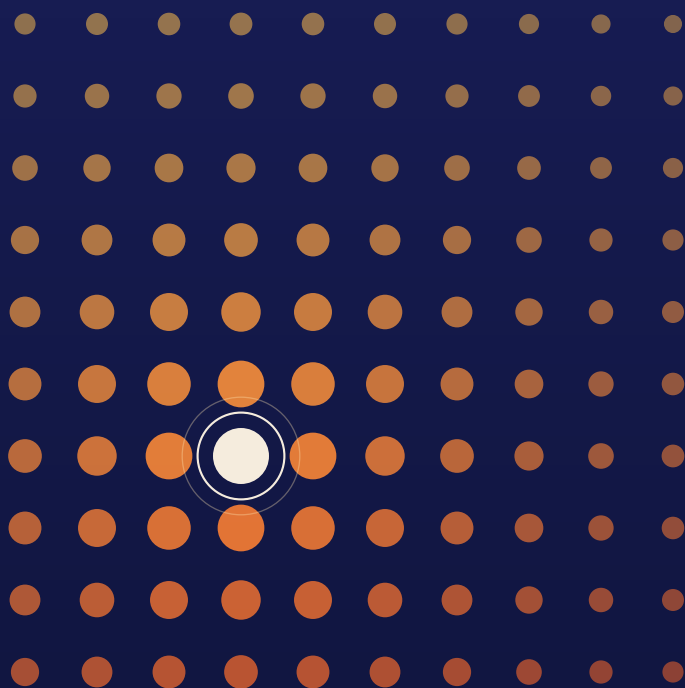


THREE HUNDRED SELECTED STORIES



The Hundred- Story Trilogy

VOLUME I

GAJENDRA THAKUR

Stories 1–100

The Hundred-Story Trilogy (Volume I)

The Hundred-Story Trilogy

Volume I

Three Hundred Selected Stories by Gajendra Thakur

Gajendra Thakur

Translated from the original Maithili into English by the author himself

The Hundred-Story Trilogy (Volume I)

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Gajendra Thakur's three hundred selected stories form a vivid mirror of the many shapes of life in Mithila, Vajji and Anga: folk life, human relationships, changing times, village and town, sorrow and joy, tradition and modernity, nature and society, women and men, childhood, old age, life away from home, memory, struggle and hope.

Across these three volumes, the simplicity of the people's language, the depth of life, and the cultural pulse of Mithila, Vajji and Anga dwell together.

A story lives as long as people and language live.

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The Flowerpot by the Window

On the second floor of the old District Education Office building, Shashibhushan Babu's desk stood beside a window. Outside the window were two ashoka trees, beyond them the road, and across the road a small tea stall. In thirty-five years the building had been painted four times, officers had changed who knew how many times, files had gone from thick to thin, and computers had arrived alongside paper; yet his desk had remained almost exactly where it was. On the window ledge stood a small earthen flowerpot, too, with two or three sprigs of periwinkle that managed to carry some blossom or other in every season.

By now, no one in the office clearly remembered who had put the flowerpot there. Shashibhushan Babu used to say that long ago a woman clerk—Meera Devi—had left it behind on the day she was transferred. Others said that Ramvriksh, the cleaner, had brought it from some fair. Once, perhaps, when the district magistrate of the time had instructed that something green be kept by the window, someone had placed it there. Whatever the truth, for many years now it was Shashibhushan Babu who had been watering it.

That Monday, five days remained before his retirement. On the table lay his pension papers, service book, leave account and a copy of his retirement order, all together. Neeraj, the new clerk, was typing rapidly at the computer when he said, "Babuji, all these old files will be scanned now. Once the cupboards are empty, the room will feel so much more open."

Shashibhushan Babu smiled. "An open room is a good thing."

Neeraj perhaps did not hear the reply at all. Small earphones sat in his ears. Every now and then he leaned towards the screen, then glanced at his phone. Shashibhushan Babu liked his speed. He did not consider many things from his own time worth preserving. Carbon paper, copy registers, the dispatch book, red tape—he felt no reverence for any of them. Yet sometimes he wondered: when everything became fast, where was a human being to keep the slowness within himself?

At one in the afternoon, Mahendra the peon set down his tea. "There'll be a feast on Friday, won't there, Babuji?"

“A feast?” Shashibhushan Babu started, as though the question concerned someone else.

“Your farewell. Everyone was saying so.”

“I don’t know. We’ll see what happens.”

Mahendra looked at the soil in the flowerpot. “It’s gone dry.”

Shashibhushan Babu poured the water left in his glass into the pot. He remembered how Malati used to say at home that one must never give a plant leftover tea; one must give it clean water. It had been seven years since Malati had passed away, but many of her sentences still hung in the corners of the house like rules for living.

On Tuesday came word that the office would be inspected. Files began to be straightened, dust was wiped away, broken chairs were pushed to the back. While checking his service book, Shashibhushan Babu found an old application. The paper had yellowed. Some student had written asking for a scholarship—Name: Manoj Kumar Mandal. In one corner, in Shashibhushan Babu’s own handwriting, were the words: “Have the income certificate attached.” The date was twenty-two years old.

He stared at the paper for a long time. Who was Manoj? He could not remember the face. Perhaps a thin boy; perhaps he had come with his father; perhaps he had been crying, perhaps not. In thirty-five years thousands of names had passed before him. Some people received scholarships and some did not; some became teachers, some went away to earn a living, some he would not even have been able to recognise. In his service book, his own life was recorded clearly year by year; but the people for whom he had spent all those days moving papers had grown blurred in his memory.

The inspector did not come on Wednesday. Word arrived that the programme had changed. But because of all the preparation, the office was unusually clean. The windowpanes had been wiped, and the road outside looked clearer than before. The owner of the tea stall was teaching his son how to keep accounts. Shashibhushan Babu watched the scene for a while.

That day Neeraj asked, “Babu, what will you do after retirement?”

It was an ordinary question, and he ought to have had an answer ready. Most people, when asked, said they would go on pilgrimage, live with their grandchildren, look after the fields, read books. Shashibhushan Babu said, “I haven’t thought about it yet.”

“You’ll have so much time!” Neeraj laughed. “If I get even one day off, I feel as if I’ve got my life back.”

Shashibhushan Babu laughed too. But that evening, after returning home, he kept looking at the clock for a long time. Seven o’clock, eight, nine. There truly was a great deal of time; but the amount of time and its usefulness were not the same thing. For the first time, the thought became clear to him.

On Thursday his daughter Nidhi called. She lived in Bengaluru. “Babu, we’ll video-call on Friday. You’ll cut a cake at the office, won’t you? Send me pictures.”

“We’ll see,” he said.

“Make some plans for yourself. Come here and stay for a few months.”

“Yes, we’ll see.”

When the call ended, the house fell silent again. The woman who cooked for him had left in the evening. Shashibhushan Babu remained seated on the veranda. On the empty chair in front of him he sometimes put a newspaper, sometimes clothes. When Malati was alive, she used to sit there cutting betel nut. In seven years Shashibhushan Babu had thought many times of removing the chair, but he never did.

When he reached the office on Friday, there was an unusual bustle. An urgent letter had come from the district office: details concerning teacher appointments in several schools had to be sent that very day. Everyone was absorbed in their own screens and files. Shashibhushan Babu too opened the old registers and began matching the figures. Ten o’clock passed, then noon, then two.

In the afternoon Mahendra said softly, “Babuji, we were supposed to bring a cake. But Sahib said the report should go first.”

“Send the report first,” Shashibhushan Babu said. Saying it caused him no pain. On the contrary, it brought a familiar calm. Countless times in thirty-five years, work had come before ceremony. Why should the last day be different?

The report went at half past four. The officer came out of his room and said, “Oh! Today is Shashi Babu’s last day!” Five or seven people gathered at once. Sweets were ordered on someone’s phone. Rasgullas arrived in a plastic box. The officer gave a two-minute speech—“honest, disciplined, experienced...” Shashibhushan Babu listened. The words were not wrong, yet they seemed to him not the life of a person but the summary of a service book.

Neeraj draped a gamchha over his shoulders. Mahendra took photographs. Everyone applauded. Shashibhushan Babu stood and tried to say, “I... all of you...” but his throat went dry. He drank some water, then said, “We have worked together for many years. If I have ever made any mistake...” The rest of the sentences came by themselves. On such occasions, almost everyone says much the same thing.

At five twenty, people returned to their work. Some had buses to catch; some had reports to correct. Shashibhushan Babu opened the drawer and took out his belongings—an old pen, a small calculator, Malati’s photograph, which he had kept inside, two clips, a handkerchief. He himself was surprised

to see how little there was. Thirty-five years of presence fitted into one small bag.

He rose to close the window. The flowerpot was still there. The soil was faintly damp. The periwinkle bore three flowers—two pink, one almost white. Shashibhushan Babu had just reached out when Neeraj said from behind him, “Babuji, take this pot with you. You’re the one who has always looked after it.”

Shashibhushan Babu stopped his hand. “No. Let it stay here.”

“Why? The cleaner may throw it away on Monday. There’s a plan to put a second computer monitor on the windowsill.”

For a few moments Shashibhushan Babu looked at the pot. Then he said, “In that case, give it to me.”

Neeraj wrapped the pot in newspaper and placed it in his hands, separate from the bag. As he went down the stairs, Shashibhushan Babu was afraid for the first time that his hand might slip. Mahendra walked out with him. Evening was settling over the road. Smoke from the tea stall drifted upwards. Shashibhushan Babu looked back at the building once. The window on the second floor was still open. Inside, Neeraj’s face glimmered in the light of the screen.

When he reached home, Nidhi video-called. She looked at the photographs, the gamchha, the box of rasgullas. “You didn’t cut a cake?” she asked, laughing.

“There was a lot of work,” Shashibhushan Babu said.

“All right. Now rest.”

He said, “Yes.” When the call ended, he placed the flowerpot on the veranda beside Malati’s empty chair. After a while he felt that was not the right place, so he moved it near the window. Too little sunlight would reach it there. He brought it back to the veranda. In the end he thought—tomorrow I’ll see.

The next morning his eyes opened at half past five, as they did every day. He bathed, shaved, and put on a clean kurta. While making tea in the kitchen, he took out his tiffin box and set it on the table. After straining the tea, his eyes fell on the box and he went still. A few moments later, a faint smile came to him. He put the box back in the cupboard.

At seven o’clock, the bell of some distant school could be heard. The sound came thinned by the air, yet it was distinct. Shashibhushan Babu stepped onto the veranda. One periwinkle blossom had fallen in the night. He bent, picked it up, and looked at it for a while in his palm. Then he touched the soil in the pot. It was still damp.

He brought a small lota of water from inside. Before watering the plant, he stopped—the soil was damp; it needed no water yet. Holding the lota, he sat down on the veranda steps. A milkman passed along the road; two children

ran by with schoolbags hanging from their shoulders; an empty rickshaw went past. Suddenly Shashibhushan Babu felt like calling the office to ask whether Neeraj had put the copy of the report in the right place.

He went inside, picked up his mobile, and found the office number on the screen. His thumb reached the call icon. It stayed there for a few moments. Then he put the phone down on the table. Outside, the sound of the bell had stopped.

Returning to the veranda, he lifted the flowerpot and placed it on Malati's empty chair. Then he sat facing it. The sun was climbing. On a periwinkle leaf, an old drop of water shone—a drop he had not given it.

The Leave Application

Prabha Mishra's leave application had been lying in her bag for three days. On the first day she had written three days' leave on it. On the second, she struck out "three" and made it "two." On the third morning, after reaching school, she drew a small line through "two" and wrote "one." In the space for the reason she had first written: "Because of my mother's illness." Later, "illness" had seemed too weighty a word, so she crossed it out and wrote, "Urgent work at home."

Prabha taught science at a girls' high school in Madhubani. She was forty-six, but in the eyes of her students she always seemed almost the same age—plain cotton sari with a white border, a small bindi on her forehead, a watch on her wrist, and the attendance register in her hand as she appeared at the classroom door five minutes before the lesson began. At school she was regarded as a dependable teacher. If another teacher was absent, Prabha took her period; if a list was needed for the science laboratory, Prabha prepared it; if the examination papers would not tally, Prabha sat late and set the count right.

That week the half-yearly examination answer books were being marked. Two teachers were away for training, one was at home because her child had a fever, and every day the principal said, "Just manage these four days. After that, everything will be all right." No one was quite sure from which day those four days were to be counted.

On Monday evening Prabha's younger brother Amit had called. "Didi, Ma's fever has come down, but she is very weak. The doctor says it would be better if someone stayed with her for a few days. I have to return to Patna tomorrow. Can you come?"

Prabha had answered at once, "Yes, I'll see." "I'll see" was the kind of reply that could mean yes or no, depending on the circumstances. After the call ended, she opened a bundle of answer books and sat down to mark them. Her red pen kept moving until half past eleven at night. Once, in between, Amit sent another message: "You don't need a ticket. Just come by bus." Prabha read the message and laid the phone face down.

On Tuesday she wrote the first application. Three days. The moment she wrote it, three days seemed far too much. Her mother was over the fever, not admitted to any hospital, facing no emergency. Examinations were under way at school. Prabha put the application into her bag and went as far as the principal's office. Two parents were sitting inside. She stood outside for five minutes; then the bell rang, and she returned to her class without submitting the application.

By Wednesday, the application had become one for two days. During the lunch break her colleague Meenakshi asked, "You've been very quiet since yesterday. Is everything all right at home?" Prabha said, "Yes. Ma is a little weak." Meenakshi immediately said, "Then go and see her. The answer books aren't going to run away." Prabha smiled. "It isn't anything that serious. My brother went and saw her."

Meenakshi opened her mouth as though to say something, then did not. Both went back to marking papers. One blade of the fan in the room was slightly bent. As it revolved, it made a faint "tick" on every turn. Counting that "tick," Prabha reached Question Fifteen.

On Thursday morning the application became one for a single day. After assembly, the principal was walking towards her office. Prabha followed her. When they reached the door, she said, "Madam, I have a leave application."

The principal turned. "For when?"

"Tomorrow."

"Tomorrow? Oh, Prabhaji, the science practical list has to be prepared tomorrow, doesn't it?"

"Yes. I'll prepare it today."

"Something urgent?"

Prabha paused for a moment. What she was supposed to say was—my mother is ill. But the word "ill" seemed to summon an image of a hospital bed, oxygen, doctors rushing about. Her mother was only weak; she was speaking on the phone and taking her medicines. Prabha said, "There's some work at home."

The principal took the application, looked at the date, and signed it without a second question. "All right. Leave the list today. And I need the marks sheet for the question papers on Monday."

That was all. Prabha kept looking at the blue signature on the application. For three days she had carried that sheet in her bag and weighed it against herself; before the principal it had not lasted even ten seconds. She felt a little relief, followed at once by a strange emptiness. The permission that had seemed so difficult to her was, for another person, merely an ordinary signature.

That day Prabha was the last to leave the school. She finished the laboratory list, handed two bundles of answer books to Meenakshi, and put the marks register in the cupboard. At the gate the watchman said, "You won't be coming tomorrow, Madam?" Prabha replied, "I have one day's leave." The watchman nodded casually, as though one day were no particular part of the world.

When she reached home, she began packing clothes, fruit and medicines for her mother. Her own home was a small rented house ten minutes from the school. Her husband Arun had died suddenly of a heart attack two years earlier. At that time the school had granted her seven days' leave, but on the fifth day she had returned to school of her own accord. For a long time people kept telling her, "If you keep your mind on work, the grief will lessen." Prabha too had accepted the sentence, because no other sentence occurred to her.

Two or three of Arun's things still remained in their old places in the house. His raincoat behind the door, his spectacle case on the book rack, and, in the upper recess of the kitchen, the steel cup from which he used to drink his evening tea. Prabha neither removed these things nor really looked at them. When she cleaned the house, her hands simply went around them of their own accord.

At twenty past five on Friday morning, Prabha's eyes opened. As on a school day, she sat up at once. She bathed, put on a sari, tied her hair, and fastened her watch. As she lifted her bag, she remembered that she was not going to school today. For a few moments she stood by the door. Then she set down the bag with her books and papers and picked up a small cloth holdall.

The bus was going towards Jhanjharpur. September sunlight was caught in the clouds. On both sides of the road the paddy fields were green, with water glinting here and there between them. Prabha sat by the window. Messages kept arriving in the school group on her phone—someone's question-paper marks would not add up; who had the laboratory key; the principal was asking the time of Monday's meeting. Prabha read every message. She felt like replying to the first two, but did not.

Her mother lived in a small rented house. The old ancestral home had become unfit to live in after a flood, so a few years earlier Amit had rented her a room near the market. When Prabha arrived, her mother was sitting on the cot, propped against a pillow. Her face was thin, with faint shadows beneath her eyes. But the moment she saw Prabha she said, "Why did you bring so much fruit? I'm hardly ill."

Prabha laughed. "Then why did you call me?"

“When did I call you? Amit makes a drama out of everything on his own.” Her mother pulled the bag towards herself and began looking through it. “Apples are so expensive. Why did you bring four?”

At noon Prabha made khichdi. Her mother said twice that there was too little salt, then ate half a bowl. After giving her the medicine, Prabha changed the bedsheet, dusted the mesh on the window, and arranged the packets of medicine according to their dates. She found pleasure in doing all of it. The work had a clear sequence—do this, then that; this thing here, that thing there. Like school.

In the evening her mother sat on a chair on the veranda. Rain began. The sound of water filled the tin roof. When the electricity went out, Prabha lit a candle. Her mother asked, “Is the inverter at your house working properly?”

“Yes.”

“Aren’t you afraid alone at night?”

“Afraid of whom?” Prabha said. “There are people all around.”

Her mother fell silent. A little later she asked, “Do you sleep well?”

“Yes.”

The rain grew harder on the tin roof. Prabha watched the candle flame. Her mother had laid her thin hands on her knees. Five minutes later Prabha said on her own, “Sometimes it takes a while.”

Her mother said, “Hm.” Nothing more.

After that “hm,” Prabha understood that the matter was finished. Yet she did not get up. Outside, there was the sound of water running along the road. After a while her mother suddenly asked, “You spend the whole day at school among so many people. Do you ever talk to anyone?”

Prabha laughed. “I’m talking all day. I teach the children, in the staff room...”

Her mother did not interrupt. She only kept looking at her. Prabha’s laughter faded by itself. She understood that by “talking,” her mother did not mean teaching a lesson or giving instructions.

After a long while Prabha said, “Arun’s cup is still up there.”

Her mother did not look away.

“Sometimes I think I should remove it. Then I think—why should I? Sometimes, in the evening, when I hear a scooter stop at the door, for one moment...” Prabha left the sentence unfinished. Outside, someone’s motorcycle really did pass along the road. Its sound receded into the distance.

Her mother asked softly, “Have you ever told anyone this?”

Prabha shook her head. “What would I say? Everyone knows, don’t they?”

“Knowing and listening are not the same thing.”

Prabha watched the wax melting down the candle. There were no tears in her eyes. Instead, a great weariness suddenly came over her, almost like sleep.

She leaned her back against the chair. "I used to think school was what made me tired," she said.

Her mother asked nothing.

Very softly, Prabha said again, "Perhaps I get more tired from being silent all the time."

Her mother reached out and laid a hand on Prabha's palm. Her hand was no longer hot; the fever had passed. The two of them sat that way for some time. The rain slowly weakened. Less than half the candle remained.

That night Prabha slept in the room beside her mother's. For the first time in many days, she put down her phone without setting an alarm. Sleep did not come immediately, but while waiting for it she did not look at the clock. Once she got up, drank some water, then looked into the darkness through the window. A dog barked far away. She could not clearly recall Arun's face; she remembered only the way he laughed, the hand that lifted his cup of tea, and the small sound of the key striking the lock when he opened the door. This time she did not try to push the memory away.

In the morning her mother looked somewhat better. She insisted on making the tea herself. Prabha tried to stop her, but her mother said, "Don't turn me into an invalid." They drank tea together. As Prabha was leaving, her mother said, "Call me when you reach school." Prabha replied, "I'm not going to school today. Today is my leave." At that, both of them burst out laughing.

On the bus back, for the first time Prabha did not open the school group. She put the phone inside her bag. Rainwater from the night had gathered along the roadside. The leaves of the paddy looked washed clean. When the bus stopped near a small station, children in school uniforms climbed aboard. A little girl stood beside Prabha. Prabha offered to hold the girl's bag in her lap. The child thanked her and turned to look out of the window. No conversation passed between them. Prabha did not find the silence heavy.

When Prabha reached school on Monday, all the work was exactly where she had left it. The science list needed only two corrections. Holding out a bundle of answer books, Meenakshi asked, "How is your mother?"

"She's better now," Prabha said.

"Then that's good." Meenakshi returned to her papers.

At ten o'clock the principal sent for Prabha. "Here—your leave application. I've attached it to the attendance register. And a training letter has come from the district office for Monday and Tuesday; you may have to go."

Saying, "All right," Prabha took the application. Beneath the blue signature, "CL-1" had been written in red ink. So many days of hesitation, her mother's thin hand, rain on the tin roof, Arun's cup, the darkness of the night

—all seemed to have been folded into that small “CL-I,” yet the paper bore no trace of any of them.

She started to leave, then stopped at the door. “Madam?”

The principal raised her spectacles. “Yes?”

Prabha was silent for a few moments. Then she said, “Next week I need two more days’ leave.”

The principal asked the dates. Prabha told her.

“Has your mother’s condition worsened again?”

Prabha looked at the blank reverse of the application. Outside, the bell rang. The veranda filled with the sound of the girls’ footsteps. Quietly she said, “No. Ma is well now.”

The principal looked at Prabha for a few moments, then glanced at the calendar on her desk. “Then leave the application with me.”

Back in the staff room, Prabha took out a fresh sheet of paper. She wrote the date at the top. After writing “To,” she paused for a moment. The fan was turning; that same old bent blade made a faint “tick” with every revolution. This time Prabha did not count the sound. The nib of her pen did not rest on the paper for long. She began writing the next line.

The Letter That Arrived Late

Sharda Devi found the letter at the bottom of an old iron trunk. She had not opened the trunk in search of any letter. After the monsoon, damp had spread through the room at the back of the house, and the carpenter had said the trunk would have to be moved a little away from the wall. So Sharda was sorting clothes, old receipts, wedding photographs and useless papers when a thin blue envelope slipped out from between two old account books.

A fine layer of dust lay on the envelope. The paper had yellowed at the corners, but the name was still clearly legible: “Shri Harinarayan Jha, Village—Belahi, District—Darbhanga.” Below, in smaller letters, was written: “Personal.” The post-office stamp was only partly visible, yet the year was clear: 2006.

Sharda kept looking at that year for a long time. Twenty years. It seemed to her that twenty years was not a number written on paper but something like the dust gathered inside a house—something that, at the mere touch of a hand, could release an old smell.

She carried the envelope to the veranda. Harinarayan Babu was sitting there with the newspaper open. His spectacles had slipped down his nose. Sharda said, “Look at this.”

At first Harinarayan Babu did not lift his eyes from the paper. “What is it?”
“A letter.”

“Who writes letters nowadays?” He laughed.

“Not a letter from now. One from twenty years ago.”

This time he folded the newspaper. He took the envelope, read the name, examined the postmark, turned it over and looked at the back. There was no sender’s name. Only the line of old gum, still unbroken.

“Where did you find it?”

“In the trunk. Between two account books.”

Harinarayan Babu looked at the envelope again. His brows contracted slightly. “Why was it never opened?”

Sharda did not answer. It was hard to tell whether the question had been addressed to her or to the household of twenty years ago.

The old papers in the trunk had generally been Harinarayan Babu's responsibility. Bank passbooks, receipts for seed and fertiliser, land records, the children's certificates—he kept them all in separate cloth pouches. Sharda took them out only when they were needed. But this envelope had not been in any pouch. Why had it been pressed between two account books? She could not remember.

Harinarayan Babu touched one corner of the envelope with his fingernail. "Shall I open it?"

Sharda was about to say, quite naturally, "Open it," but the words did not come out. Instead she asked, "Shouldn't we first think who it might be from?"

"My name is on it."

"Your name is on it, yes. But who wrote the letter?"

Harinarayan Babu was silent for a few moments. In the courtyard the leaves of the guava tree moved in the wind. Far away, some devotional song played very softly over the temple loudspeaker.

"Manoj?" Sharda said quietly.

Harinarayan Babu placed the envelope on the table.

2006 was the year their elder son Manoj had left home for Delhi. Even now Sharda used the words "left home" carefully in her own mind, because Manoj had not run away in the night. He had bought a ticket, packed a bag, and caught the morning bus in front of everyone. Yet after what had happened in the house during the three days before his departure, to say merely that he had "gone for work" always seemed incomplete to Sharda.

Manoj had been working for a private company in Patna. He wanted to marry a girl of his own choice. She was from Madhubani and was educated, but by the family's old calculations of clan and marriage, the match was not considered acceptable. Harinarayan Babu had refused outright. Manoj first tried to explain, then argued, then raised his voice. On the third day Harinarayan Babu had said, "If your own decision is so dear to you, then take responsibility for it yourself as well."

Sharda still remembered that sentence word for word. After it, Manoj had said very quietly, "All right."

For six months Manoj did not come home. Even his phone calls were infrequent. Sharda would try his number from a neighbour's phone. Sometimes he answered, sometimes he did not. Then one day word came that Manoj had found a job in Delhi. Two years later he married. Harinarayan Babu went to the wedding, though his mouth remained almost entirely closed throughout. Slowly, visits began again. A grandson was born. There were celebrations. When illness came, Manoj rushed home. Life, in its own way, began tying the broken ends together.

Now Manoj lived in Gurugram and came once or twice a year. Harinarayan Babu asked about his grandson's studies, argued with him about the share market, and had him bring blood-pressure medicines. The old dispute over the marriage had not been mentioned for many years.

Sharda looked at the envelope. "What if it is from Manoj?"

Harinarayan Babu said, "So what? He may have written it twenty years ago. We'll read it."

"Should we ask him first?"

"Why should I ask him about a letter addressed to me?"

In that answer Sharda caught a faint glimpse of the old Harinarayan—the same man who, once he had made a decision, built walls around it. But at once she felt the comparison was unfair. Whether Harinarayan had changed in twenty years could not be answered in a single sentence.

Until lunch, the letter remained on the table. They talked of ordinary things—the dal needed more salt, the gas cylinder had to be booked, their younger daughter Rekha would video-call tomorrow. Yet every now and then both of them glanced at the envelope.

After lunch Harinarayan Babu went to his room for a nap. Sharda washed the dishes and returned to sort the remaining things in the trunk. One account book contained the expenses for 2005–06: wheat, urea, Manoj's bus fare to Patna, Rekha's college fees. On one page, in Sharda's own handwriting, was a small entry: "Manoj Delhi—1000." She could not remember when she had sent those thousand rupees. Perhaps through someone. Perhaps without telling Harinarayan.

The letter had been wedged inside that very account book. Sharda thought for a long time: was it possible that she herself had put the letter there and forgotten? Perhaps the postman had delivered it, and she, afraid of Harinarayan's anger, had first kept it aside herself? She remembered nothing. Memory sometimes leaves a blank precisely where a person remains certain that something must once have been there.

At evening tea, Harinarayan Babu picked up the envelope again. "Bring the scissors."

Sharda took two steps towards the kitchen, then stopped. "Open it by hand. The paper might get cut."

Harinarayan Babu smiled. "Is it an old letter or a government document?"

"It is old. That is why."

He tried to slip his thumb under the edge of the envelope. The paper was no longer crisp; after years of damp air it had softened. One corner tore a little. Sharda said involuntarily, "Wait."

Harinarayan Babu stopped. "What now?"

Sharda searched for an answer. "What if it contains something from that time that no longer exists?"

"If the thing no longer exists, does what was written change?"

"No. But perhaps reading it will change something."

Harinarayan Babu leaned back in his chair. "Sharda, what can a piece of paper from twenty years ago change in me now?"

Sharda looked at him. His hair was almost entirely white, there was a thin sheen of moisture at the corners of his eyes, and two fingers of his right hand were slightly bent from arthritis. She had spent forty-five years with this man. In forty-five years, how many things had actually been spoken, how many understood by guesswork, and how many left untouched simply because there would be another day to live together—there was no accounting for any of it.

Softly she asked, "When Manoj went away, did you stay awake at night?"

Harinarayan Babu looked startled. "When?"

"During those six months."

"Why are you asking that now?"

"No reason."

Harinarayan Babu looked out of the window. "I slept less."

It was the first time Sharda had heard that answer. Back then she had assumed Harinarayan stood firm by his decision, that he was angry with Manoj, that he felt no regret. On many nights she had risen and seen him sitting on the veranda, but she had never asked. She had thought that asking might start the quarrel all over again.

"I used to think nothing had happened to you at all," Sharda said.

"You never asked."

The words were spoken in an ordinary tone, not as an accusation. Even so, Sharda felt as though some closed window from twenty years ago had opened for an instant.

She said in turn, "You never told me either."

Harinarayan Babu nodded. "Yes."

They both fell silent. The tea on the table was growing cold. Through the torn corner of the envelope a thin white edge of the paper inside could be seen.

After a while Harinarayan Babu said, "If Manoj did write it, perhaps if I had read it then, something might have been different."

Sharda asked, "Better or worse?"

"Who knows."

"Then what will we learn by reading it now?"

Harinarayan Babu gave a faint laugh. "What he wrote then."

"Not what we would have done then."

"No."

Evening fell. Sharda switched on the light. Under the yellow glow the envelope looked older still. Harinarayan Babu picked it up once more, but this time he made no attempt to open it.

After dinner Manoj called. He usually telephoned on Sundays, but this was Saturday. His wife had perhaps gone to the market; his son was at coaching class. Manoj asked the usual questions—were they taking their medicines, had the mason looked at the roof, he might be able to come for Dashami next month.

Twice Sharda wanted to say, “We have found a letter of yours from twenty years ago.” But each time some small domestic question slipped into the middle of the conversation. At last Manoj said, “All right, Ma. Give the phone to Babuji.”

Harinarayan Babu took the phone. “Hm, tell me.” His voice carried the same familiar mixture of sternness and affection that had formed over the years between father and son. Five minutes later the two of them had talked about cricket, medicines and train tickets, and he put the phone down.

Sharda asked, “You didn’t tell him?”

“Neither did you.”

They looked at each other and laughed. It was a very small laugh, but for the first time since the old dispute it seemed to Sharda that they were laughing together at their own silences from those days.

Before going to bed, Harinarayan Babu was about to put the letter on top of the cupboard. Sharda said, “You’ll forget it there again.”

“Then where shall I keep it?”

Sharda looked towards the trunk, then said, “Let it stay here on the table.”

The next morning, when Sharda got up, Harinarayan Babu was drinking tea on the veranda. The envelope lay before him. The corner was torn exactly as much as it had been the day before.

“Did you open it?” Sharda asked.

“No.”

“Why?”

Harinarayan Babu placed his cup on the table. “I thought I’d wait until you woke up.”

Sharda sat down opposite him. There was night dew on the guava leaves. A milkman went past along the lane on his bicycle. Inside the house the clock struck seven.

Harinarayan Babu held the envelope out to her. “You open it.”

Sharda extended her hand but did not take it. “Your name is on it.”

“We’ll both read it.”

For a few moments their hands remained on either side of the envelope. It suddenly seemed to Sharda that whatever lay inside the letter was twenty years

old, but this moment belonged to now. Twenty years ago, each of them had borne many things alone. At least now, before this small piece of paper, they were not alone.

She took the envelope and placed her thumb against the torn corner. The paper could have opened very easily.

Just then there was the sound of milk boiling over in the kitchen and spilling onto the stove. Sharda sprang up. "The milk!"

She ran inside. Behind her Harinarayan Babu called, "Turn off the gas first. The letter isn't going anywhere."

Sharda turned off the gas and began wiping the stove. A laugh came to her without warning. On the veranda Harinarayan Babu coughed. Outside, the milkman rang his bell again.

A little later Sharda made two fresh cups of tea and came out. The letter was still lying on the table, not half-opened—only one corner torn. She placed a cup before Harinarayan Babu and sat down herself.

They drank their tea. The letter remained between them. This time, neither of them was in any hurry to open it.

Story 4

After the Rain Stopped

On the third day after the floodwater began to recede, Ramlochan Yadav went out towards his field. For nine days the fields, the paths, the bamboo thickets and the pond behind the house had all merged into water of the same colour. Now the water had gone down, but the land had still not fully recovered its old shape. Where green rows of paddy had stood, there were sticky mud, debris and leaves of water hyacinth caught in the slush.

The earthen ridge between Ramlochan's northern field and Bindeshwar Mishra's southern field had been washed away for nearly thirty cubits. Only two traces of the boundary remained—at one place a bamboo stake half-sunk into the earth, at another a small rise covered with grass. Everywhere else the flood had levelled the two fields so completely that it seemed there had never been a boundary between them.

Ramlochan stood for a while with the spade in his hand. Two years earlier he and Bindeshwar had had a serious quarrel over this very ridge. The surveyor's tape had once fallen a little to one side, then on the second measurement a little to the other. The dispute had begun over two cubits of land and had travelled through old accounts, old bitterness, all the way to the conduct of their children. At the end Bindeshwar had said, "Keep what is yours. I do not want even a finger's breadth of your land." Ramlochan had replied, "Nor do I want anyone's charity."

After that day, members of the two households still spoke to one another, but conversation between Ramlochan and Bindeshwar had shrunk to necessary words alone—"Your cow has come loose," "Have the drain cleared," "The postman left your letter." At times even a greeting ended with nothing more than a nod.

Today Ramlochan had decided he would first rebuild the ridge from his own side. If they called the surveyor after the flood and waited for a fresh measurement, the time for sowing would pass. He drove the spade into the earth. The mud was soft on the surface and heavy underneath. With every spadeful he lifted, his breath grew quicker.

After five or seven spadefuls a voice came from behind him. "If you go on like that, you won't finish even ten cubits by evening."

Ramlochan turned. Bindeshwar was approaching with a spade over his shoulder and a bamboo basket in one hand. His dhoti was folded up to his knees, his feet caked with mud.

Ramlochan only said, "The soil is heavy."

"Leave the sludge on top and cut from below. The lower soil will hold."

"I'm seeing."

Bindeshwar set down the basket. For a few moments both men looked at the broken ridge. The question was whether they should begin the work together or each start from his own side. Neither felt like putting the question into words. Without saying anything, Bindeshwar began working with his spade at the far end of the broken stretch.

For half an hour there was only the thud of spades, the scrape of the basket over earth, and the distant cries of egrets. After the flood the village itself sounded different. In one house a fan was running to dry a wall; somewhere sheets of tin were being hammered into place; elsewhere people were opening sacks of wet paddy and spreading the grain in the sun.

From time to time Ramlochan glanced towards Bindeshwar. Three days earlier, when the water had stood chest-high, this same man had gone with him at two in the morning as far as the main road. Ramlochan's wife, Phoolmati, had suddenly begun breathing hard. She had long suffered from asthma, but that night her medicine had run out. The mobile network kept disappearing. Ramlochan had repeatedly tried to call his son, who lived in Pune, but the call would not go through.

Bindeshwar had probably heard about it from his granddaughter. Without asking anything, he had come carrying a large torch, a plastic bag and a bamboo staff. "Come," was all he had said.

Together they had waded through water above their waists towards the main road. At one place the current was strong. When Ramlochan's foot slipped, Bindeshwar caught him by the arm. A relief vehicle was standing on the road; from there they obtained an asthma inhaler and two tablets. On the way back neither of them mentioned the old dispute over the ridge even once.

Phoolmati was well now. Yesterday morning she had said, "Thank Bindeshwar Babu properly at least once." Ramlochan had replied then, "Yes, I will."

Now the weight of that thank-you felt heavier than the earth he was lifting with his spade.

Bindeshwar asked, "Is Phoolmati Bhabhi breathing all right now?"

"She is fine. She took the medicine last night."

"Is there any inhaler left?"

"Yes."

“The market must have opened by now. Get another one. You can’t trust a flood.”

Ramlochan said, “Yes.” A few moments later the words “That night...” reached his lips, but he drove the spade into the mud instead. The sentence remained unfinished. Bindeshwar may have heard it, or he may not have.

By noon the ridge had begun to take shape. Each man had understood the rhythm of the other’s work. Ramlochan cut the earth, Bindeshwar carried it up in the basket; after a while, without a word, they exchanged jobs. In earlier days they had done such work together many times—digging drains, lifting pump pipes, planting bamboo poles for a wedding. Perhaps for the first time since the quarrel, their bodies were remembering one another’s pace.

Bindeshwar wiped his head with his gamchha. “The ridge won’t come up on the old line here.”

Ramlochan grew alert at once. “Why?”

“Look at the stake. The water has pushed it half into the ground. The old channel is gone too.”

Inside Ramlochan, the voices from two years ago awoke with alarming speed—the tape, the surveyor, two cubits of land. He said, “Then let us measure it.”

Bindeshwar gave a slight laugh. “With what? The measuring tape at home was soaked and rotted. The surveyor will be making the rounds of the whole block now.”

“Then?”

“We join the surviving ends of the old ridge. The line through the middle will find itself.”

Ramlochan looked at the bamboo stake. It seemed to him that this method could produce a difference of a cubit or two. Two years ago they had spent an entire day arguing over exactly that much.

He asked, “Does that seem right to you?”

With both hands resting on the handle of his spade, Bindeshwar said, “Both our paddy crops have washed away. What will two cubits of earth give anyone now?”

The sentence was spoken in the most ordinary way. Ramlochan could, if he wished, have taken it as sarcasm. He could also have heard in it an answer to the old quarrel. But Bindeshwar’s face was tired; there was swelling under his eyes. Perhaps he had not slept properly through the night.

Ramlochan asked, “What about the back wall of your house?”

“It has sunk a little. The mason will look at it tomorrow.”

“The wheat in the store?”

“Half survived. Half is gone.”

“Has your name been entered on the government list?”

“They say it will be.” Bindeshwar smiled. “The list moves more slowly than the flood.”

Ramlochan too gave a small laugh. He could not remember whether this was the first time since their quarrel that the two of them had laughed at the same thing.

At noon Phoolmati came to the field carrying a bucket of water and two brass tumblers. The moment Ramlochan saw her, he remembered again—the thank-you. Handing Bindeshwar a tumbler, Phoolmati said, “If you had not been there that night, we would have been in terrible difficulty.”

While drinking the water, Bindeshwar said, “What is there in that? If people in a village do not come to one another’s aid, then who will?”

Phoolmati said simply, “Even so, you did us a kindness.”

“Leave the word kindness, Bhabhi.” Bindeshwar lowered the tumbler. “Ramlochan has run with me to hospitals, police stations and the block office more times than I can count. If we start keeping accounts of such things, nothing will work.”

Ramlochan kept looking at the earth. He remembered that seven years earlier, when Bindeshwar’s younger son had been in a motorcycle accident, he had spent the night with them at the hospital. He had almost forgotten it.

Phoolmati went back. After a while Ramlochan said, “That night...”

This time Bindeshwar looked at him.

Again the sentence began to stick in Ramlochan’s throat. He could have said, “Thank you.” He could have said, “What I said two years ago was not right.” Both sentences were perfectly clear in his mind, yet the moment they came close to his lips they sounded too formal.

At last he said, “The current at that bend was very strong that night.”

Bindeshwar looked at him for a moment, then said, “Yes. The earth under the road is probably still cut away. Don’t let the children go there.”

Ramlochan nodded. The conversation had returned to earth, water and children. He felt a little disappointed, and at the same time relieved.

Towards evening the ridge was almost finished. In the middle stretch Bindeshwar drove in a bamboo stake to align the boundary. Where he placed it, Ramlochan could clearly see that, compared with their old estimate, it had shifted slightly into Bindeshwar’s field—which meant Ramlochan’s portion would grow a little larger.

Ramlochan said, “The stake has gone a little onto your side.”

Looking down at the ground, Bindeshwar said, “After all this wind and water, who knows where the old line was?”

“It could be as much as two cubits.”

“Then let it be.”

Ramlochan wanted to pull up the stake and move it a little towards his own field. His hand even went out to it. But Bindeshwar had meanwhile walked away to bring another basket of earth. Ramlochan stood holding the stake for a few moments. Finally he moved it half a cubit towards his own side—not all the way to the old position, only half a cubit.

Bindeshwar returned. His eyes went to the stake. He said nothing. He emptied the basket and began pressing the soil firm with his foot.

Ramlochan asked, “Is it all right here?”

Still levelling the edge of the ridge with his foot, Bindeshwar said, “It is all right.”

That was all.

The sun showed faintly through the clouds. Yellow light fell on the floodwater still pooled in small hollows. Two egrets came down at the far end of the field.

When the work was over, the two men went to wash their spades in what water remained in the drainage channel. The handle of Bindeshwar’s spade was loose. Ramlochan took it from him and struck it twice against the ground. “Hammer a nail into this when you get home. Otherwise it will split tomorrow.”

Bindeshwar said, “We have to come back here tomorrow?”

“Five cubits at the northern end are still left.”

“Morning?”

“Morning.”

They put their spades on their shoulders. There was only one narrow path back towards the village, so they walked in the same direction. In earlier times Ramlochan would have dropped a little behind at such moments, or Bindeshwar would have quickened his pace and gone ahead. Today they walked at nearly the same speed.

At one place the path was still badly waterlogged. Bindeshwar’s foot sank. Instinctively, Ramlochan caught him by the arm. Pulling his foot free, Bindeshwar only said, “This place is still bad.”

Letting go of his arm, Ramlochan said, “Yes, let us go a little to the side.”

Near the first house in the village, they had to turn towards their separate courtyards. Bindeshwar stopped. “Tell Phoolmati Bhabhi not to miss her evening medicine.”

“I will.” Ramlochan paused, then said, “And you... if the mason doesn’t come for the wall, tell me. I’ll phone the younger mason.”

Each man walked towards his own courtyard. No thank-you had been spoken. No apology either. Whether the old quarrel had ended, or had merely grown tired and fallen silent for a few days, neither man knew clearly.

After darkness fell that evening, Ramlochan looked towards the fields from the veranda. The new ridge appeared from a distance as a thin, slightly crooked line. On this side lay his field; on that side, Bindeshwar's. But as the darkness deepened, the line slowly dissolved into the earth.

Ramlochan was about to go inside when he remembered that in the morning, along with his spade, he should take a hammer as well. A nail still had to be driven into the handle of Bindeshwar's spade.

The Evening Bus

When Niranjan Jha boarded the bus, there were still two hours to go before evening. At Darbhanga bus stand, dust, the smell of diesel and the voices of people were so thoroughly mingled that a man speaking on his mobile had to raise his own voice to hear himself. Niranjan placed his small suitcase on the overhead rack and sat down by the window.

He was going to the village after four years. In between, he had come as far as Darbhanga twice—once for a wedding, once on company business—but on both occasions he had spent the night in a hotel and returned the next day. The family had accepted this under the phrase “there was no time.” Niranjan too had learned the convenience of that phrase.

All day, congratulatory messages had been arriving on his phone. The company had given him a new position; his salary had gone up, his team had grown larger, and a new designation had been added before his name. In the office group, his photograph had appeared with the words, “Best wishes for the next phase.” Since getting off the train, Niranjan had opened that post three times.

And yet there was no particular exhilaration inside him. He took the absence of it for fatigue.

The bus began to fill. A woman with two children sat in the front. Two college students at the back were arguing loudly about cricket. Moving through the aisle and urging people farther in, the conductor called out, “Benipur, Bahera, the turning for the villages ahead.”

Just before the bus started, an elderly man climbed aboard slowly. He wore a white kurta and grey pyjamas, carried a faded canvas bag over one shoulder, and had thick-framed spectacles on his eyes. As soon as he mounted the steps, he paused once, held the rail and steadied his breathing.

At first Niranjan saw only that the man was old. Then, when he moved a little farther along the aisle, Niranjan caught sight of the old scar on the left side of his forehead and rose to his feet.

“Sir?”

The old man looked at him over the top of his spectacles. It took two moments. “Niranjan?”

Niranjan was astonished. Fifteen years had passed since he had left school. He laughed. "You still recognized me?"

Rameshwar Sir adjusted the strap of his bag on his shoulder and said, "There is a little less hair on your head. The face is the same."

Niranjan urged him to take his seat. At first Sir refused—"I'll sit here on the aisle"—but the conductor said, "Sir, sit by the window. You'll get some air." So he sat down, and Niranjan shifted into the seat beside him.

The bus moved off. The crowd at the stand fell behind, the rows of shops thinned, and soon ponds, small bazaars and paddy fields appeared on both sides of the road.

Rameshwar Sir asked, "Where are you living now?"

"Gurugram. I'm with a private company."

"For a long time?"

"Eight years."

"Everyone at home is well?"

Niranjan answered, "Yes, everyone is fine."

Sir thought for a moment and asked, "Did your Babuji get his hearing aid repaired? The last time I met him, he said he could not hear properly on one side."

Niranjan was silent for a moment. He did not know about this. He had spoken to Babuji twice on the phone the previous month, but both conversations had been about the farm accounts and some bank papers.

"Perhaps... it still hasn't been repaired," he said.

Rameshwar Sir began looking out of the window. "At this age, small things demand time."

There was no reproach in the sentence, yet Niranjan lowered the screen of his phone.

After a while Sir asked, "Work is going well?"

Niranjan had answered this question many times. He said easily, "Yes. I was promoted today, in fact. A larger division will be under me now."

"Good." Pleasure came over Sir's face. "Congratulations."

That was all. Niranjan felt slightly awkward. All day in the city, people had asked about the post, the salary, the shares and the new responsibilities. Sir turned back towards the fields, as though the information were complete.

A few moments later he suddenly said, "In Class Eight, you once made a water-driven wheel for the science exhibition. Do you remember?"

Niranjan laughed. "It never even worked."

"Not the first time. The next day you cut a new channel and made it again."

"How do you remember all this?"

"I don't remember everything." Rameshwar Sir laughed. "Who can make a list of what one has forgotten?"

The bus stopped at a small crossroads. The moment the conductor opened the door, a middle-aged man came running from a tea stall. "Rameshwar Sir!"

Sir opened the window. The man held up two paper cups. "Tea?"

"Less sugar."

"For you, it is always ready with less sugar even before you say so."

The shopkeeper's name was Shambhu. Sir told Niranjan, "He was a student of mine. In Class Seven he forgot his mathematics notebook for three months in a row."

Laughing from outside, Shambhu said, "Sir, now I keep accounts better than you do. Not one customer can escape after eating on credit."

Sir began taking money out of his bag. Shambhu tried to stop him, but as he took the cup Sir said, "Run your shop. The age for paying guru-dakshina passed long ago."

As the bus began to move, Shambhu ran alongside the window and called, "Sir, Neha's form has been filled in. She chose the subject you suggested."

Sir merely raised a hand. The bus moved on.

Niranjan asked, "Neha?"

"His daughter. She has passed Class Twelve. She wants to study further."

"You still keep track of everyone's studies?"

Rameshwar Sir took a small sip of tea. "Not everyone's. Whoever comes to ask, I tell them whatever I understand."

Niranjan opened his phone. The company director's message was at the top: "You deserve this position." He typed a thank-you and sent it. Then he switched off the screen.

The road ahead was bad. The bus slowed, swerving around potholes. At one bend, three schoolchildren got on. The moment one of the boys saw Rameshwar Sir, he pulled his bag into his lap and made space for him, although Sir was already seated. Everyone laughed at the boy's confusion.

Sir asked, "Whose son are you?"

The boy gave his father's name.

"He too was my student," Sir said at once. "When he wrote, the ink used to smear all over his right hand."

The boy looked at his own hand in amazement, as though the trait might be hereditary.

Niranjan laughed again, but this time a strange thought rose within him. Rameshwar Sir's life seemed to be spread along this road in small signs—the tea stall, the conductor, the child's father, some Neha's application form. His name was written on no plaque, yet the moment people saw him, they opened some old page of their own lives.

Niranjan thought about his own life. In the Gurugram office, his name was printed on the glass cabin. His photograph was on the company website. But if

he were no longer there five years from now, where and in what places would any trace of him remain? The question had never occurred to him before.

He was immediately irritated with himself. He disliked such sentimental comparisons. Work was work; a school belonged to another world. Success, he told himself, had its own measure for each person.

Rameshwar Sir, as though he had heard none of Niranjan's thoughts, opened his bag, took out a small box and swallowed some medicine. Niranjan gave him water.

"Your health is all right?"

"One may call it all right. My knee has begun to act according to its own wishes, and I am to have an eye operation next month."

"Will you go alone?"

"To the hospital? No. My younger son will come. He is in Pune."

Niranjan asked, "Why don't you live with him?"

Sir smiled. "I stayed there for two months. They looked after me very well. But if I got up in the morning there, whom would I ask whether the water in the pond had risen or fallen? Here one finds people willing to ask such useless things."

Niranjan remembered his mother. On the phone she too asked almost the same questions every time—"How hot is it there?" "Has it rained there?" Niranjan usually said, "Yes, yes, everything is fine," and moved the conversation on.

The bus stopped again. This time a woman climbed aboard carrying a bag of medicines. The moment she saw Rameshwar Sir, she bowed to him. Sir asked, "Has your mother's fever gone down?"

"She is better now. The reports were normal too."

"Good."

The woman went and sat at the back. Niranjan asked, "Was she also your student?"

"No. Her brother was."

"And you even remember that her mother had a fever?"

Adjusting his spectacles, Sir said, "I met her at the medicine shop last week. She told me."

The answer was utterly ordinary. Niranjan felt his question had been a little foolish.

The evening light had softened now. Long shadows lay across the paddy fields. Smoke rose from a courtyard somewhere in the distance. Niranjan remembered those childhood afternoons when, at this hour, he used to race his bicycle home from school because he was impatient to get back and play cricket.

"Sir," he asked, "do you remember everyone from my batch?"

“Many of them.”

“Who became successful?” The question had barely left his mouth when Niranjan himself was startled by it.

Rameshwar Sir looked at him. “In what sense?”

Niranjan searched for an answer. “I mean... who did well in life?”

Sir was silent for a while. A rattling vibration came from the roof of the bus. At last he said, “How would I know the answer to that question?”

Niranjan laughed. “You were our teacher. Surely you must have some idea.”

“At school I knew the marks. Who gave me the answer sheets of their lives to examine?”

Having said this, Sir turned to the window. The matter was closed.

The answer felt incomplete to Niranjan, but there was relief in it too. He had feared Sir might offer some sermon—that money was not everything, that he must not forget the village, that he must serve his parents. Nothing of the kind was said.

After they had gone a little farther, Rameshwar Sir spoke on his own. “There was Rakesh in your batch, wasn’t there?”

“Yes.”

“He does electrical work now. Last year he repaired all the school fans without taking any labour charge. I scolded him for it—why had he not taken his wages?”

Niranjan smiled.

“Sushma?” Sir asked.

“She became a doctor, I think. In Patna.”

“Yes. She came once for a health camp. She tested my blood sugar and said, ‘Sir, fewer sweets.’”

“And Manoj?”

Rameshwar Sir’s face changed slightly. “He is no more. He died of an illness three years ago.”

Niranjan fell silent. Manoj had sat on the bench behind him at school. Niranjan could remember his laughter clearly; he could not connect it with death.

Sir said softly, “His daughter is in Class Nine now.”

For a while neither of them spoke.

Niranjan’s phone vibrated again. This time it was the property broker. Negotiations were under way for two kathas of land behind the old village house. Niranjan was making this trip mainly to have Babuji sign the papers. The buyer had said he would meet them that night.

He declined the call. A message from the broker appeared at once: “What time will you reach?”

Niranjan did not reply.

Rameshwar Sir asked, "Where will you get down?"

"At first I had thought of getting down at the bazaar. I have to meet someone there." Niranjan paused. "But perhaps I'll go as far as the village turning."

"The bus goes that far."

"And you?"

"One stop before that."

The bus was growing dark inside. The conductor switched on the lights. In the yellow glow, every face looked a little tired, a little unfamiliar.

Rameshwar Sir took an old sheet of paper from his bag and examined something on it. Niranjan happened to glance at it—it was some sort of school list, torn at the edges.

"What is that?"

"An old list of the library books. The headmaster said many books appear to be missing. I told him to compare it with the old list first. That's why I had taken it with me."

Niranjan laughed. "Even after retirement, the school hasn't let you go."

Sir laughed too. "The school has let me go. The people haven't."

The bus stopped where Rameshwar Sir was to get off. Niranjan stood and brought down his bag. Sir reached the steps, then turned back.

"Will you stay at home for two days?"

"I had been thinking of returning tomorrow itself."

"All right. If you have time, go by the school once. That old science room is still there. The window has been changed, but I think the table is the same."

Niranjan said, "I'll see."

Sir got down. Two young men by the roadside stepped forward to take his bag. Sir called one of them by name. The bus moved off.

Niranjan kept looking back through the window until the white kurta had dwindled into the darkness.

He returned to his seat and opened his phone. The company's congratulatory message was still at the top. Beneath it were three missed calls from his mother.

Niranjan called her.

"Where have you reached?" his mother's voice asked.

"The bus is not far from the village turning."

"But you had said you would get down at the bazaar?"

"No. I'm coming straight home."

His mother was silent for a moment, then asked, "Shall I put the rice on?"

Niranjan had been about to say, "I've already eaten." Whenever he returned from the city, he said this whether he had eaten or not. Then he looked out of the window; lights had come on in scattered houses beyond the fields.

“Yes,” he said. “Put it on. Tell Babuji I’m coming.”

“If only he can hear me,” his mother laughed. “The hearing aid is broken again.”

Niranjan’s hand tightened slightly around the phone. “We’ll see to it tomorrow. I’ll take it to town and get it repaired.”

His mother said, “First reach home.”

The call ended.

The broker’s message came again. Niranjan read it but did not reply. The papers were in his bag; the sale had not been cancelled. Only the meeting that night no longer seemed necessary.

The bus reached the village turning and stopped. Niranjan took down his suitcase and stood by the road. His house was not visible from there, but from that direction came smoke and the familiar smell of cow-dung cakes.

An auto-rickshaw driver asked, “Where to?”

Niranjan gave the name of the village. The driver quoted the fare. Niranjan put his suitcase inside, then suddenly asked, “Does the old high school fall on the way?”

“A little out of the way.”

“That’s all right. Go there first.”

The driver turned the auto. Niranjan did not know whether he would find the school gate open or closed, whether the old table was still there, or whether he would simply look at the building from outside and then go home. His promotion was still real, the land papers were still in his bag, and the train for the next day was still booked. Nothing had changed dramatically.

And yet, in the darkness of the road, watching the small headlamp of the auto turn towards the school, he felt for the first time that perhaps success did not mean arriving at one particular place. Sometimes it might also mean understanding who had remained along the road, and who still remembered your name.

He did not allow the thought to form itself into a complete sentence. The phone rang again. This time it was Babuji. Niranjan smiled, answered, and spoke loudly, “Yes, Babuji, can you hear me? I’m on my way.”

Story 6

The Empty Bed

On the fourth morning after the wedding, Kaushalya Devi went into Anupama's room with a broom for the first time. For three days there had been so many people in the house that, even when the room was empty, it had never felt empty. Someone's sari would be lying there, someone's bag, someone's child would be jumping on the bed. Today the veranda was clear, the bamboo poles of the wedding pavilion had been taken down and stacked to one side of the courtyard, dried flower petals had mingled with the dust, and the door of the room stood half open.

The sheet on the bed was the same one Anupama had left there on the morning of her departure—the one with blue flowers. One corner was crumpled, the pillow lay askew, and a red thread had caught at the foot of the bed. Standing at the door, Kaushalya said aloud, “Anu, could you not even leave the sheet pulled straight?”

Once the sentence was complete, her own voice sounded slightly unfamiliar to her. The room did not answer.

She went inside, stretched the sheet smooth, straightened the pillow, then for no reason set it askew again. “You liked it this way,” she said softly.

Sweeping should have taken five minutes, but she spent twenty. She picked up a hairpin left on the table and placed it in a little box. She wiped the dust from the window frame. From beneath the bed came a scrap of paper—a receipt from a box of sweets bought for a guest. Instead of throwing it away, she placed it on a corner of the table, then laughed at herself, picked it up again and put it in the rubbish.

From outside, Maheshwar Babu called, “The tea is getting cold.”

Kaushalya said, “I'm coming.” But she did not leave at once. She stood for a few moments with a hand resting on the footboard of the bed.

Anupama's wedding had taken place in Janakpur. The groom, Abhishek, worked in a bank; the family was good, the household well ordered, everyone courteous. These were precisely the things Kaushalya herself had wanted for the last two years. When the match was settled, no one had been happier than she. For three months her days had been consumed by lists—saris, utensils, the

wooden trunk, books, sheets, spices: what would go with Anupama, what would not.

At the farewell, Anupama had wept a great deal. Kaushalya had wept too, though in between she had been preoccupied with whether a bottle of water had been put in the car, where the bag of medicines was, and whether the jar of pickle had been handed to Abhishek's mother. Even after the car vanished around the bend and people led her back inside, her first worry had been: "Anu's phone charger hasn't been left behind, has it?"

The charger had not been left behind.

On the first night Anupama called three times. On the second day, twice. On the third day, only once, and that too at night. By the morning of the fourth day there had been no call.

Kaushalya sat on the veranda with her cup of tea. Maheshwar Babu had opened the newspaper. His spectacles had slipped a little down his nose.

"Has Anu called?" Kaushalya asked.

"She called last night, didn't she?"

"She called me last night too. I mean today."

Maheshwar Babu looked up from the newspaper. "It is only half past eight in the morning."

Kaushalya fell silent. She felt that Maheshwar Babu had not understood the question. It was not a question of time.

At half past nine the phone rang. Anupama's voice was brisk. In the background many women could be heard talking.

"Ma, where did you put my green shawl?"

Kaushalya stood up at once. "It was in the upper shelf of your cupboard."

"I couldn't find it there."

"Did you look in the blue trunk?"

"The trunk is here, but the shawl isn't. I thought perhaps it was left at home."

Holding the phone between her ear and shoulder, Kaushalya went into Anupama's room. She opened the cupboard. Half of it was empty now. On the upper shelf were two old salwar suits, the college bag, some files and a white box. No green shawl.

"It isn't here," Kaushalya said.

"All right, I'll find it. Yesterday the didis had put some clothes in another room. I'll look again."

"Have you eaten?"

"Yes."

"What did you eat?"

"Ma, I'll tell you later. Everyone is going to the market. I have to go too."

"All right."

“Are you all well?”

Kaushalya looked at the bed. “Yes, we are well.”

The call ended.

For a few moments Kaushalya stood with the mobile still in her hand. Then she said to the bed, “What was such a hurry? You could have talked for another two minutes.”

She smiled at herself. “What am I saying to you? You are wood and mattress.”

Then she remembered—she had spoken to an inanimate thing as though it were a person. As if correcting Anupama’s grammar, she corrected her own words: “It is wood and mattress.” The tiny correction made her laugh.

That afternoon, Lalita Kaki from next door came over. In her hand was the large brass platter she had borrowed for the wedding. As she returned it, she said, “The house must feel deserted now.”

Kaushalya answered at once, “Why deserted? I am here, and he is here. The house is the same.”

Maheshwar Babu heard from outside and laughed. “It is enough that I have been included in the count.”

Lalita Kaki laughed too. Kaushalya felt her own answer had sounded a little harsh. She changed the subject.

In the evening, while putting away the utensils, Kaushalya took out two small bowls and then returned one to the shelf. Anupama used to eat curd in a small bowl. Maheshwar Babu ate very little curd.

At half past ten that night Maheshwar Babu said, “Close the window of that room. Mosquitoes will come in.”

Kaushalya said, “Let it stay open. The smell will go out.”

“What smell?”

“There were so many people here for the wedding. If the room stays shut it will turn damp.”

Maheshwar Babu said nothing.

Once during the night Kaushalya awoke. She thought she had heard the bed creak in the back room. Whenever Anupama turned in her sleep at night, one slat of the bed used to sound. Kaushalya had heard that creak for years. She rose and went as far as the door.

A cat had come in through the window and was sitting on the bed. Kaushalya gently shooed it away. The cat climbed onto the window and leapt outside.

“Because of you my sleep was broken,” she said to the bed. “Are you satisfied now?”

As she spoke, she felt moisture in her eyes. She wiped them with the end of her sari as though a speck of dust had fallen there.

By the second week the house had almost returned to its old rhythm. Maheshwar Babu went for his morning walk, Kaushalya performed her worship and cooked, the milkman came on time, the newspaper dropped beside the door. Only a few small tasks had lost their purpose. There was no tiffin to prepare for Anupama, no old college water bottle to wash, no need in the evening to ask, "What time will you be back?"

Kaushalya had once thought all this would save time. Time was saved. But she did not know where one was supposed to keep saved time.

She continued to go into Anupama's room at least once a day. Sometimes to close the window, sometimes to open it, sometimes merely to straighten the pillowcase for no reason.

One day Maheshwar Babu said, "Shall I put my old books on the shelves in that room?"

Kaushalya answered immediately, "No."

Maheshwar Babu looked at her for a moment. "All right."

The "no" had come out so quickly that Kaushalya herself felt uncomfortable. She added, "Not yet. The dust hasn't been properly cleaned."

Maheshwar Babu said, "All right," again. This time his voice was ordinary, but all day Kaushalya wondered whether she had postponed the books because of the dust or because she was afraid the room would become something else.

That evening Anupama sent a photograph. Five women of Abhishek's family were standing on the roof. Anupama stood among them in a green sari, smiling. Behind her were the pink wall of the new house and a clothesline.

Kaushalya enlarged the photograph. There was little tiredness in Anupama's face. She looked at ease.

First a feeling of happiness rose inside Kaushalya. Immediately after it came a very slight, almost ashamed sorrow—how had she become at ease so quickly? Kaushalya was ashamed of the feeling itself. Did she want her daughter to be unhappy there?

That night she sat beside the bed and said, "Did you see? You are smiling so much. Good. You should smile."

After a few moments she added, "But what mountain comes crashing down if you make a phone call?"

The bed remained silent.

Kaushalya laid her palm on the sheet. It was cold. She remembered how, when Anupama was little and burning with fever at night, she used to sit beside her head on this bed and keep changing the wet cloth on her forehead. During the Class Ten board examinations, Anupama would study until two in the morning, and Kaushalya would come in twice with milk. On her first day of college, Anupama had sat here and cried that she would not make a single friend. Three months later the same girl had brought so many friends home

that Kaushalya had come out of the kitchen and said, “Is this a house or a hostel?”

Not all the memories had the same colour. There had been quarrels with Anupama too—clothes flung across the bed, returning home late, never putting down the phone, sulking whenever marriage was discussed. Kaushalya had said countless times, “One day, when you go to your own home, then you will understand.”

Now the words “your own home” in that sentence stung her. Had this house, then, never been Anupama’s own?

In the third week Anupama said that her old books could be given to Pinki. Pinki was Lalita Kaki’s granddaughter and was studying in Class Twelve.

“All of them?” Kaushalya asked.

“All the competitive-exam books. I don’t need them now.”

“Keep some.”

“Why? If Pinki studies from them, they’ll be useful.”

Kaushalya agreed.

The next day Pinki came with two bags. Kaushalya took books out of the cupboard. Anupama had written her name in every one of them—sometimes in neat letters, sometimes in haste. When Kaushalya opened a biology book, a dried gulmohar leaf fell from between its pages.

Pinki asked, “Mausi, shall I keep this?”

Kaushalya picked up the leaf and looked at it. “Throw it away.”

Pinki was about to throw it when Kaushalya said, “Wait.” Then she put the leaf back between the pages. “Let it stay as it was.”

After Pinki carried the books away, two shelves of the cupboard stood entirely empty. The bed began to look larger than before.

That day Kaushalya removed the sheet for the first time. She put the blue-flowered sheet with the clothes to be washed, shifted the mattress into the sun, and beat the pillow free of dust. Beneath the mattress she found a thin sheet of paper.

It was a list in Anupama’s handwriting: “Saris 6, slippers, medicines, certificates, needle-thread, pickle, oil, small scissors, charger...” At the bottom, on another line, she had written: “Ma’s green shawl?” There was a question mark after it, and then the words had been crossed out.

Kaushalya remembered her green shawl. It was old, its border worn, but Anupama borrowed it from time to time. While packing for the wedding, Kaushalya had offered it to her; Anupama had said, “No, it looks good on you.”

Kaushalya moved her hand to fold the list and throw it in the rubbish, then instead put it in the drawer of the table. This time she did not laugh at herself.

That night Anupama's phone call lasted a little longer.

"Ma, did Pinki take my books?"

"Yes."

"Good. She studies well."

After a while Kaushalya asked, "Are you able to sleep there?"

Anupama laughed. "Not the first two nights. All the sounds felt unfamiliar. It is all right now."

The words escaped Kaushalya's mouth: "Your bed is lying empty here."

There was silence for a few moments at the other end of the phone.

Anupama said softly, "I'll come at Dashami, Ma."

"I was only saying it. Why should I make you worry?"

"I'm not worrying."

"All right. Is everything well there?"

"Yes, everything is well."

The conversation moved back to cooking, bank timings and the expected arrival of some relative. After the call ended, Kaushalya sat for a long time. It seemed to her that she had been asking her daughter for proof that she too felt the same emptiness. Kaushalya did not like giving that feeling a name.

Two days later, in the afternoon, Maheshwar Babu went into Anupama's room with the newspaper. Sunlight fell near the window. He sat on the bed and began to read. When Kaushalya came in with water and saw him there, she stopped for a moment.

Maheshwar Babu asked, "May I sit here, or is the place reserved?"

Kaushalya looked at him. His voice was teasing, but there was caution in his eyes.

"Sit," she said. "The bed won't break."

Maheshwar Babu reopened the newspaper. After a while he lay down there and fell asleep.

Kaushalya stood at the door and watched him. At first she felt a small irritation—Maheshwar Babu's head on Anupama's pillow! Then she noticed that, in sleep, he had stretched one hand out towards the empty side, as though from old habit he were leaving space for someone.

Silently she brought a thin cotton towel and spread it over his feet.

In the evening Maheshwar Babu said, "That room gets good sunlight."

Kaushalya replied, "Yes."

"We'll see about the bookshelf later."

"We'll see."

It was the first time that "no" had not come out at once.

The next morning Kaushalya spread the washed blue-flowered sheet on the bed again. She put a fresh cover on the pillow. She placed Anupama's old

college bag on the upper shelf of the cupboard. She removed the empty box from the table.

When she opened the window, the outside sunlight fell across half the bed. Fine grains of dust began floating in the brightness.

Kaushalya sat at the foot of the bed. For the first time in many days, there was nothing in the room that needed doing.

Softly she said, "It is good that you are able to sleep there."

After a moment she smiled at herself. "I should have said that to her, not to you."

The bed gave no answer.

From outside Maheshwar Babu asked, "Will there be tea, or shall I make it?"

Instead of replying at once, as she usually did, "I'm coming," Kaushalya looked out of the window. On the neighbour's roof, Pinki was reading one of Anupama's old books. In the courtyard, a labourer was carrying away the last bamboo pole left from the wedding.

"Make it," Kaushalya called back. "I'll come a little later."

Maheshwar Babu may have been surprised, but he said nothing.

Kaushalya remained seated with her hand resting on the bed. The room was still empty. Anupama was still far away. Dashami was still many days off. None of that had changed.

The square of sunlight that had entered through the window kept moving slowly across the blue-flowered sheet. Kaushalya watched it until, from the kitchen, came the faint sound of tea beginning to boil.

Pension Day

In the third month after his retirement, Bhuvaneshwar Babu was going to the bank himself for the first time to collect his pension. For the first two months the amount had appeared in his account, but this month even after the fifth had passed, the passbook showed no new entry. He did not trust the messages that came to his mobile. He believed that only figures printed on paper were truly real.

By seven in the morning he had bathed and dressed in a white kurta, light-grey pyjamas and his old black shoes. They were the same shoes he had worn to the office through the last five years of his service. The leather had softened, but after a polish they still looked respectable.

His wife, Vimala Devi, came out of the kitchen and asked, "The bank opens at eleven. Why are you ready already?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu looked at the clock. "There will be a queue. On pension days there are many people."

"Today is the seventh."

"So what? The later it gets, the greater the crowd."

Vimala Devi said nothing. She placed his cup of tea before him. As he drank, Bhuvaneshwar Babu opened his old leather file. Inside were the pension-sanction letter, copies of his Aadhaar and PAN cards, the bank passbook, two photographs, a copy of his life certificate, and an old black pen.

Vimala Devi looked at the file and smiled. "Has the bank asked for all this?"

"It might."

"The photographs too?"

"Who knows when a rule may change?"

He carefully tucked the photographs back inside. During his years in office, he had never accepted anything without documentary proof. Three colours of files used to lie on his desk - red, green and blue. Whenever an application was incomplete, he would write in red ink across the front: "Required documents not enclosed." The shape of those words had become so familiar that even three months after retirement, his fingers sometimes seemed to write them in the air.

At eight-twenty he left the house. The bank was in the bazaar, about two kos away. He could have found a rickshaw, but he preferred to walk. During his service years he had gone on a motorcycle. His son Neeraj had now taken the motorcycle with him to Patna. Neeraj had said, "Babuji, what do you need the motorcycle for now? Where do you go?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu had laughed then. But for three months the words "Where do you go?" had remained lodged in his mind.

It was ten past nine when he reached the bazaar. The bank shutter was closed. Five people were already sitting on the veranda: two elderly men, an elderly woman, a middle-aged man, and a young man who had probably accompanied someone.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu stood beside a pillar. There was space to sit, but he remained standing. Out of old office habit, waiting for the bank to open felt almost like conducting an inspection.

One of the elderly men, with a white gamchha tied around his head, asked, "You too, pension?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu paused slightly before saying, "Yes."

"New?"

"New?"

The old man laughed. "New among pensioners. One can tell from the face."

The others sitting on the veranda laughed too. Bhuvaneshwar Babu smiled faintly, but he did not like the expression "new among pensioners." During his service people had called him "Babu Saheb," some "Bhuvaneshwarji," some "Barka Babu." In the word "pensioner," it seemed as though age had been written where a name should have been.

He asked, "How long have you been coming?"

"Eighteen years," the old man said. "I was a khalasi in the Railways. Now half my pension goes on medicine, half on the household. But I like bank day."

"Why?"

"My daughter-in-law says, Babuji, give it to me, I'll withdraw it for you. But I say no. The pension comes to me, so I will go to the bank." He laughed again. "At least once a month my kurta gets ironed."

The remark seemed rather light to Bhuvaneshwar Babu. Yet the old man's kurta truly was neatly ironed, and the gamchha looked freshly washed.

The elderly woman, who had been sitting quietly on the iron bench, said, "He comes to show his kurta. We come to see people's faces."

Everyone laughed again. The woman introduced herself as Janaki Devi. Her husband had been a primary-school teacher and had died five years earlier. She received a family pension.

Looking at Bhuvaneshwar Babu, Janaki Devi asked, "Which department?"

"Land Records Office."

"Oh, then you are a man of papers."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu replied instinctively, "Can work be done without papers?"

Janaki Devi took a folded sheet from her bag. "See this. The bank people had told me to submit a life certificate. My grandson did it online. Even so, I keep this paper. When there is paper in hand, the mind stands firmer."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu took the paper and examined it. Everything was in order. Without thinking, he said, "The place for the signature is blank here."

Janaki Devi put on her spectacles and looked. "I give my thumb impression there."

"Right -" Bhuvaneshwar Babu stopped. "Then it is all right."

Janaki Devi said, "My thumb has been doing my work longer than my name has."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu handed the paper back. Unbidden, he remembered how many elderly women's names he had written beside their thumb impressions during his service. At the time the sight had seemed part of a rule, not part of a human life.

By half past nine there were fifteen people on the veranda. Some were pensioners, some farmers, some had come to open accounts. The bank guard arrived and lifted one side of the shutter, then began sweeping inside. People started forming a line.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu moved forward at once and secured the seventh place. Janaki Devi stood behind him. The railway pensioner was in front.

"Will there be tokens?" someone asked.

The guard said, "The machine is broken. Stay in the queue."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu's brows tightened. A system without tokens? He thought the branch manager ought to be told. Then he remembered: he did not know the branch manager, and the branch manager did not know him either.

At five past ten the bank opened. The queue moved inside. The fans started, computers came alive, and employees took their places behind the glass counters.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu held his passbook tightly. His mobile still showed no message about the pension being credited.

The railway pensioner turned back and asked, "The first pension makes one afraid, doesn't it?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu said, "Afraid of what? All my papers are in order."

"Even when the papers are in order, one feels afraid. I did too."

"Why?"

The old man thought for a moment. "I did not understand then. Now I do. In the days of a job, money may have been little, but one knew what would happen next month. On the first pension day, it feels as though next month will no longer arrive by itself - one will have to wait for it."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu did not fully understand what he meant. The pension was credited automatically. What was there to wait for?

The computers at the counters were slow. Each person took five or seven minutes. The queue advanced in fits and starts.

Behind Bhuvaneshwar Babu now stood a thin old man named Rahman Ansari. He kept patting his pockets. Suddenly he asked Bhuvaneshwar Babu, "Brother, where do I write the account number on this withdrawal slip?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu took the slip. "Here."

"My eyesight is poor. Would you fill it in for me?"

For a moment Bhuvaneshwar Babu was silent. During his service people used to crowd around his desk asking him to fill forms, and he would usually say, "There is a form-writer sitting outside. Get it filled there." Today he bent over the slip.

"Name?"

"Rahman Ansari."

"Amount?"

"Three thousand."

"Why withdraw so little?"

Rahman Ansari laughed. "Let the rest stay in the account. If it stays at home, my grandson will say, Dada, I want this, I want that. If it stays in the bank, I can say - there isn't any."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu laughed too. He filled in the slip. At the end, indicating the proper place, he said, "Sign here."

"I do sign, but the letters change every time."

"What if they change?"

"The bank people say the signature doesn't match." Rahman Ansari showed him his hand. "The hand has grown old. How can the signature remain young?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu handed the slip back and looked at the man's hand. His fingers trembled.

The queue moved two places forward.

Behind the glass, a young woman employee looked at an old man's passbook and said, "Dada, your life certificate has not been updated." The old man became anxious. The grandson who had come with him took out his phone and began showing something on it.

A faint tightness entered Bhuvaneshwar Babu's chest. He opened his file again and checked his life certificate. The seal was clear. The date was correct.

From behind him Janaki Devi said, "Your papers must have been checked four times already."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu turned. "Caution is good."

"It is," she smiled. "But paper does not get frightened. We do."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu gave no reply.

After that the queue did not move at all for nearly twenty minutes. The server had gone down. The employees began making phone calls. The guard kept asking people to remain calm.

There were too few chairs inside the bank. Elderly people sat near the floor by the wall, leaned against window frames, or stood wherever they could. Bhuvaneshwar Babu remained standing at first, but the railway pensioner shifted aside on his bench and said, "Babu, sit down. In a pension queue, rank is not taken into account."

The sentence pricked Bhuvaneshwar Babu a little, but his legs had begun to ache. He sat down.

The railway pensioner's name was Shambhunath Paswan. He took a small box from his pocket and began cutting betel nut.

"What do you do at home?" Shambhunath asked.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu replied easily, "Nothing in particular yet. I put some papers in order. I read the news."

"Grandchildren?"

"One granddaughter, in Patna."

"You must see her on the phone."

"Yes."

"I have three grandsons at home. They make such a racket that sometimes I come to the bank in search of peace."

Janaki Devi laughed. "He is lying. Nobody listens to him at home, so he comes to the bank to talk."

Shambhunath laughed. "Both things are true."

After a while Rahman Ansari too sat nearby. For no particular reason, conversation began among the four of them - the price of medicines, the electricity bill, potatoes in the bazaar, grandchildren's studies, the old railway line, schoolteachers, new bank rules.

At first Bhuvaneshwar Babu only listened. Then, now and again, he began to answer.

Janaki Devi said, "My son says, Ma, why do you go to the bank? You have an ATM card. I tell him, the card will give me money, but it will not give me people's voices."

Rahman Ansari said, "I am afraid of the ATM. A machine will give money, but it will not ask - is everyone at home well?"

Shambhunath smiled. "The bank people don't ask that either."

"Not the bank people. The people in the queue ask," Janaki Devi said.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu quietly watched them.

The server was still down. It was half past eleven. Bhuvaneshwar Babu thought how many people he would have scolded if such disorder had occurred in his office. People used to wait before his desk; from inside he would call, "Next." Someone would enter carrying a file. One person's papers incomplete, another's copy blurred, another's name wrong. The authority to decide - however small - had rested in his hands.

During the first week after retirement many people had phoned. "Babu Saheb, where can I get a copy of this khatiyani?" "Which cupboard is that file in?" "Do you have such-and-such employee's number?" He told everyone what they needed. In the second week the calls became fewer. By the third, they had nearly stopped.

One day he himself phoned an old colleague, Manoj, and asked, "Everything all right at the office?" Manoj said, "Yes, Babuji, it is going on slowly." Then, five minutes later, he added, "Someone has come in; I'll talk later."

"It is going on slowly." He had been thinking about those words ever since. The office was continuing without him. Perhaps more slowly, perhaps at exactly the same pace.

In the meantime an employee announced that the server was back. The queue formed again. Bhuvaneshwar Babu stood up.

His turn was now third.

Shambhunath Paswan's work was completed first. Taking the passbook in his hand, he looked at the printed amount, then put the book in his bag without counting anything.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu asked, "Won't you check the amount?"

"I checked."

"It is correct?"

"It is what usually comes. If they send extra, will the government itself call me?"

Laughing, he walked out.

Then Bhuvaneshwar Babu's turn came. He went to the glass counter. The young woman employee took his passbook and typed in the account number.

"Name?"

"Bhuvaneshwar Jha."

"Pension?"

"Yes."

After looking at the computer screen, she said, "The amount was credited on the sixth."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu immediately said, "No message came on my mobile."

"Is the mobile number updated?"

"Yes."

"Sometimes the message doesn't come. I'll print the passbook."

The printer rattled. A new line appeared. Bhuvaneshwar Babu took the passbook through the opening in the glass. The amount was correct. Exactly the same as the previous month.

The tightness he had carried inside him since morning loosened in an instant. Yet the relief was not as great as he had expected.

The young employee looked towards the next customer and said, "Next."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu moved aside. Standing near the counter, he suddenly remembered that during his service he too had said "Next" hundreds of times a day. What was happening inside the person who moved away with a file in hand - had he ever once wondered?

Behind him, Rahman Ansari came forward with his withdrawal slip. The employee looked at it and said, "The signature does not match."

Rahman Ansari became flustered. "Sister, my hand trembles."

"Sign again."

He did. The employee checked the screen once more.

Without thinking, Bhuvaneshwar Babu returned to the counter. "His hand trembles. Look at the old signature - the main strokes are the same."

The young woman looked at him. "Are you with him?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu was about to say "No," but Rahman Ansari immediately said, "Yes, he is with me."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu fell silent.

The employee checked a few more things, consulted a senior colleague, and then accepted the slip.

When Rahman Ansari came outside with the money, he searched for Bhuvaneshwar Babu and said, "If you had not been there, I would have had to stand in the queue again."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu said, "I did nothing. The rules allowed it."

"Even so." Counting his three thousand rupees, Rahman Ansari said, "Sometimes it is enough simply to have beside you someone who understands the rules."

It was an ordinary sentence. But Bhuvaneshwar Babu remained silent for a few moments.

At the tea stall outside the bank, Shambhunath Paswan was already standing. Janaki Devi too was sitting with tea.

"New pensioner!" Shambhunath called from a distance. "Did you get the money?"

This time the word "new" did not annoy Bhuvaneshwar Babu. He said, "I did."

"Then the tea is on you."

Janaki Devi immediately objected, "With the first pension people take sweets home, and you will drink his tea?"

Shambhunath said, "The people at home will eat the sweets. I will drink the tea."

Everyone laughed. Bhuvaneshwar Babu paid for four cups of tea.

As they drank, no one asked what post he had held in the Land Records Office, how many files had gone out bearing his signature, or over whom he had exercised authority. Someone merely asked, "Where is your home?" "Where does your son live?" "Do your knees hurt?" "What date will you come next month?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu kept answering.

When the tea was finished, Shambhunath said, "We usually meet around the seventh. Whether the pension comes earlier or later, I come anyway."

"Why?" Bhuvaneshwar Babu asked again, although by now the answer was beginning to become clear.

Shambhunath shrugged. "The days at home are very long."

Janaki Devi added, "And here the queue is never very short."

Everyone laughed again.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu walked home. The sun had grown strong. The file was tucked under his arm, the passbook inside it. The amount was safe in the account. All the fears of the morning - that the pension might have stopped, that some paper might be wrong, that the bank might send him running from place to place - had proved groundless.

Yet as he walked, he understood that the tightness in his chest since morning had not been about the amount alone.

For three months the shape of his day had seemed to be shrinking. Earlier there had been a fixed time to leave home, people waiting for him, files arriving on the desk, telephones ringing. Now even after he had read the entire newspaper in the morning, the clock had not yet reached ten. Vimala Devi remained occupied with her own work. His son said on the phone, "Rest, Babuji."

Slowly the word "rest" had begun to sound to him like "no one needs you."

He stopped in front of a stationery shop on the way. Out of old habit his eyes went to the red pens. Then, for no particular reason, he bought an ordinary blue one. The shopkeeper returned five rupees in change.

When he reached home, Vimala Devi asked, "Did the pension come?"

"Yes."

"Then why so late?"

Taking off his shoes, Bhuvaneshwar Babu said, "The server was down."

After a moment he added, "I met some people."

Vimala Devi asked, "What people?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu began listing names: "Shambhunath Paswan, from the Railways; Janaki Devi, the schoolmaster's wife; Rahman Ansari..."

Vimala Devi looked at him in surprise. "You got acquainted with everyone?"
"There was time in the queue."

After lunch, Bhuvaneshwar Babu went to put the old file back in the cupboard. The red pen was inside it. He took it out and placed it in the desk drawer. The new blue pen remained in his pocket.

At three o'clock there was a call at the door. Sonu, a boy from the neighbourhood, had come holding an application form.

"Babuji, this is the scholarship form. Father is away. Will you fill it in for me?"

The first words that rose to Bhuvaneshwar Babu's lips were, "Get it filled at the cyber shop." But before the sentence could be completed, he remembered the bank withdrawal slip.

He said, "Sit. Let me read it first."

Sonu pulled up a chair and sat down. Bhuvaneshwar Babu opened the application. The paper was simple: name, date of birth, school, bank account, income certificate. He read each line aloud, and Sonu answered.

Halfway through, Bhuvaneshwar Babu opened the drawer to look for the red pen. His hand went to it, then stopped. He took the blue pen from his pocket instead.

When the form was complete, Sonu said, "Thank you, Babuji."

"Attach all the papers."

"Yes."

Sonu left.

From inside, Vimala Devi asked, "Have you opened the office again?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu laughed. "No."

He looked at the table where the completed form had been. There was nothing there now.

"It was only one paper," he said.

In the evening Neeraj called. At the end of the conversation, as was his habit, the son said, "Rest, Babuji. You don't have to worry about work any more."

This time Bhuvaneshwar Babu did not become irritated as he usually did. He only said, "I am not worried about work."

Neeraj began saying something else at the other end. Bhuvaneshwar Babu kept looking out of the window. Sonu was running down the lane, carrying the same application in his hand.

After putting down the phone, Bhuvaneshwar Babu opened the passbook once more. The pension entry for the sixth was printed there clearly. He looked at it once and closed the book.

Whether there would be any need to go to the bank on the seventh of the following month, he did not yet know. The amount might arrive beforehand. A message might come on the mobile too.

Even so, in his mind Bhuvaneshwar Babu counted forward to the seventh.

Then he opened the drawer and placed the blue pen beside the red one. The two pens lay there quietly.

Two Letters

Sudhanshu Babu always kept the umbrellas hanging behind the door. One black, one blue, one light grey. The black umbrella was his, the blue one belonged to his wife, Malati Devi, and the grey umbrella belonged to no one—at least, no one in the house called it their own.

The grey umbrella had hung there for six years. Its cloth had faded in places, fine rust marks had appeared on two of its metal ribs, and the wooden handle had grown smooth. Just below the handle, two letters scratched with a small knife were still visible: “R. C.”

Ramakant Chaudhary.

Sudhanshu Babu read the full name in his mind, but did not say it aloud.

Clouds had gathered since morning that day. It was September rain—neither a full downpour nor a complete pause. Water stood between the courtyard bricks, the tulsi platform was wet, and heavy drops fell now and then from the edge of the roof.

Malati Devi asked, “Is it necessary to go to college today?”

Folding the newspaper, Sudhanshu Babu said, “I have a class. Second period.”

“Will students come on a day like this?”

“Some will certainly come.”

He rose and began getting ready. A year and a half remained before the end of his service in the Maithili Department. Once, failing to reach college on a rainy day had seemed to him a breach of discipline. That conviction had loosened a little now, yet sitting at home still did not come naturally to him.

At a quarter to nine he came to the door. He tried to open his black umbrella. It opened halfway, then one rib slipped loose from inside. He forced it again. The cloth sagged crookedly to one side.

Watching from behind, Malati Devi said, “I told you yesterday to get it repaired.”

“I forgot.”

“Then take the blue one.”

Sudhanshu Babu reached for the blue umbrella, but Malati Devi said, “Its catch is loose too. If there is wind, it will turn inside out.”

Their eyes went to the grey umbrella at the same time.

Without saying anything, Malati Devi went inside. Sudhanshu Babu stood there for a few moments. The drops in the courtyard had begun to fall more heavily.

He took down the grey umbrella. There was no dust on it; Malati Devi wiped it from time to time. The moment the handle came into his hand, there rose the mingled smell of old leather and damp wood. Sudhanshu Babu felt he had known that smell somewhere before.

From inside Malati Devi called, "Does it open or not?"

Sudhanshu Babu opened it in the courtyard. The umbrella trembled once, then spread fully. There was a small hole in one corner of the cloth, but it would serve.

"It is all right," he said.

Malati Devi came to the door. Her eyes fell on the letters on the handle, then on Sudhanshu Babu's face. "You have taken it out after a long time."

"Mine is broken."

"I did not say anything."

"Nor did I."

After those words both felt a little awkward. Malati Devi went back inside. Sudhanshu Babu opened the umbrella and stepped into the lane.

Ramakant had been dead for six years. Very few people at the college now remained who remembered him as "Ramakant Sir." Some of the newly appointed teachers had heard the name; some had not. Two books written by him were still in the department's old cupboard, but dust settled quickly now on their spines.

Sudhanshu Babu and Ramakant had been appointed in the same year. They sat in the same room, drank tea at the same tea stall, and often walked together to the station after college. In thirty years of acquaintance there had been so much between them that it was difficult to tell it like a story, from a clear beginning to a clear end. Their friendship had formed slowly, and its ending too had not come suddenly on any one day.

Yet in his mind Sudhanshu Babu had marked one day.

That day too, it had rained.

Water had collected at the bend in the lane. Sudhanshu Babu walked with the rim of the umbrella lowered slightly. Two schoolchildren were splashing barefoot through the water. One child looked at the grey umbrella and said, "Babu, that umbrella is very old."

Sudhanshu Babu smiled involuntarily. "Yes. It is old."

The child ran on.

On the main road he found a rickshaw and got in. The rickshaw-puller reached to fold the umbrella and place it behind the seat. Sudhanshu Babu said at once, "I'll keep it."

The rickshaw-puller withdrew his hand.

By the time he reached college the rain had eased a little. Ramvilas, the peon, stood beneath the awning by the main gate. Shaking the umbrella, Sudhanshu Babu went in. Ramvilas stared at it.

"That looks like Ramakant Sir's umbrella."

Sudhanshu Babu's hand stopped for a moment. "You still remember?"

Ramvilas laughed. "He had scratched letters on that handle. He used to say all umbrellas in a college are the same colour; if there is no name, people exchange them."

Sudhanshu Babu looked at the handle. The letters "R. C." were very small.

Ramvilas said, "Once he took my umbrella home too. The next day he came saying, 'Ramvilas, your umbrella is healthier than I am.'"

He laughed. Sudhanshu Babu laughed a little too, then immediately walked towards the department.

In the room, Praveen, a young assistant professor, was already seated with his laptop open, writing something. Sudhanshu Babu placed the umbrella in a corner. Praveen looked up and said, "Sir, very few students have come today."

"We shall teach however many have come."

Looking at the umbrella, Praveen said, "That is a beautiful old design. You do not get handles like that now."

Sudhanshu Babu merely said, "Hmm."

The class began at ten past ten. There were fourteen students. The subject was memory and the present in modern Maithili fiction. It was an old unit in the syllabus, one Sudhanshu Babu had taught for many years. As he wrote on the blackboard, "Memory changes the present," the chalk broke in his hand.

He took another piece of chalk.

A girl asked, "Sir, is memory true, or do we change it later?"

Sudhanshu Babu paused before answering. Usually, when asked such a question, he gave an example at once. Today the words did not come quickly.

"Both," he said at last. "The event is one thing, but the form in which we keep it in the mind can change with time."

The student asked again, "Then which one is the truth?"

There was a little laughter in the room. Sudhanshu Babu smiled too. "That is a good question for a storyteller, and a difficult one for an examination."

Everyone began to write.

He turned towards the blackboard, but before his eyes there suddenly appeared that rainy day from six years earlier.

Ramakant had come to his house that afternoon. It was the same grey umbrella. The cloth had looked almost new then.

For three months the two of them had barely spoken. The cause was so slight that now, even to state it fully in his own mind embarrassed Sudhanshu Babu. On a college selection committee, Ramakant had supported a young candidate, while Sudhanshu Babu had pressed particularly for one of his former research students. The younger candidate had been appointed.

Sudhanshu Babu had never openly said that he was hurt. He had merely stopped going for tea with Ramakant, stopped walking with him to the station, and limited himself in the department to whatever conversation was necessary.

At first Ramakant had tried two or three times to laugh the matter away. Then he too had fallen silent.

On that rainy afternoon Ramakant had appeared unexpectedly at the house. Malati Devi made tea. Sudhanshu Babu sat on the veranda. The lower part of Ramakant's pyjamas was wet.

"There is a lot of water on the road," he said.

Sudhanshu Babu replied, "That happens in the rains."

Ramakant was silent for a few moments. Then he took a paper from his pocket and said, "I have to go to Patna tomorrow."

"Why?"

"I have to see a doctor."

Sudhanshu Babu did not take the paper. "There are no doctors here?"

Ramakant gave a faint laugh. "There are. One of those doctors has sent me to Patna."

Malati Devi set down the tea and went inside.

Holding the cup, Ramakant watched the steam for a long time. Then he said, "Can you come with me?"

For years Sudhanshu Babu kept that sentence in his memory in a form that made Ramakant's question seem merely polite: "Can you come with me?"—like an ordinary invitation to which it was easy to say no.

That day Sudhanshu Babu had answered at once, "I don't have time just now."

That was all.

Ramakant nodded. "All right."

After a while he got up to leave. The rain was very heavy by then. From inside, Malati Devi said, "Stay a little longer in this."

Ramakant said, "I'll get a rickshaw."

The umbrella remained hanging in a corner of the veranda. No one noticed.

The next morning Sudhanshu Babu saw it. He thought of taking it to college, then did not. "He will come and take it," he told Malati Devi.

Ramakant went to Patna. Two weeks later came the news that he had a serious blood disorder. Treatment began. Sudhanshu Babu telephoned twice. The first conversation was brief; the second time Ramakant's son answered.

"Babuji is asleep," the son said.

Sudhanshu Babu said, "When he wakes, tell him I had called."

He kept thinking that he would call again.

Three months later Ramakant was gone.

The class bell rang. The students began to rise. Sudhanshu Babu looked at the sentence on the blackboard—"Memory changes the present." He wiped the board clean with the duster.

On her way out, the girl said, "Sir, the answer to the question is still incomplete."

"Which question?"

"Which one is the truth?"

Sudhanshu Babu smiled slightly. "Next class."

By afternoon the rain had grown heavy again. The sound of drops filled the roof of the department. While eating, Praveen asked, "Sir, Ramakant Sir was an old friend of yours?"

"Yes."

"I once read an article of his. The language was very simple."

"He wrote simply."

"What was he like personally?"

Before answering, Sudhanshu Babu looked at the umbrella. "Very talkative."

Praveen laughed. "The opposite of you."

"In some ways."

Praveen opened his lunch box again and continued eating. The conversation ended.

Sudhanshu Babu suddenly remembered that Ramakant had not been a talkative man. Not, at least, in his last ten years. He had simply talked more in front of Sudhanshu Babu. Sudhanshu Babu understood the difference only now.

College ended at three. The rain showed no sign of stopping. Students stood along the veranda. Some had motorcycles, some umbrellas; some were calling home to ask for a vehicle.

Sudhanshu Babu opened the grey umbrella. As he reached the gate, a voice called from behind, "Sir!"

He turned. Vishal, a first-year student, came running with a book held over his head. "May I walk with you as far as the bus stand? I didn't bring an umbrella."

Sudhanshu Babu was instinctively about to say, "I am in a hurry." The sentence reached his throat, but did not come out.

He lifted one side of the umbrella. "Come."

They walked together. The umbrella was a little small for two people. Sudhanshu Babu's right shoulder was getting wet, and Vishal's left arm too.

Along the way Vishal kept talking about the college—the hostel roof leaked, no new books had come to the library, he wanted to stage a Maithili play. Sudhanshu Babu answered now and then with a "Hmm."

Near the bus stand Vishal said, "Sir, you got wet."

"So did you."

"The umbrella is small."

For the first time Sudhanshu Babu looked at the umbrella as a whole. "It did not seem this small before."

Vishal did not understand. His bus arrived. He bowed and got on.

Sudhanshu Babu went and stood beneath the awning of a tea stall. The rain fell across the road like a curtain. Visibility had shortened.

Suddenly he remembered one part of that last meeting which, for six years, he had never remembered completely.

Before saying, "Can you come with me?" Ramakant had been silent for a long time. He had put down his teacup and rested both hands on his knees. His eyes had not been on Sudhanshu Babu but on the rain in the courtyard.

And after asking the question, when he heard Sudhanshu Babu say, "I don't have time just now," he had not immediately said, "All right."

There had been a moment between the two.

A very small moment.

In that moment Ramakant had looked straight at Sudhanshu Babu. Directly. As though he wanted to say something. Then he had looked away.

Sudhanshu Babu understood clearly now that the moment had not vanished from his memory; he himself had repeatedly cut it away. He had kept reducing the event so that his own answer too might seem like a smaller offence.

The tea seller asked, "Tea?"

Sudhanshu Babu started. "Yes."

As he held the tea, his other hand remained around the grey umbrella's handle. His thumb moved again and again over the letters "R. C."

He thought—if he had gone to Patna that day, what would have changed? The illness would still have been there. Perhaps death would still have come.

Whether the friendship would have become what it had once been, he did not know that either.

It was also true that Ramakant himself had not telephoned him during those three months. They had both been adults; the silence had belonged to both of them.

And yet a sentence does not remain merely a sentence. "I don't have time just now."

Sudhanshu Babu finished his tea. The rain had eased a little.

When he reached home, Malati Devi came to the door with a towel. "Your shoulder is completely wet."

"A student walked with me."

Malati Devi took the umbrella. "The hole has grown. Shall I have it stitched?"

Sudhanshu Babu was about to say, "Leave it. What use is it now?" But after a moment's thought he said, "Yes. Have it stitched."

Folding the umbrella, Malati Devi asked, "Will you hang it in the same place again?"

Sudhanshu Babu looked behind the door. There were three hooks there. For six years the grey umbrella had hung separately on the middle hook, like some object in the house meant not for use but only for remembrance.

He said, "Take the black one down. We'll have that repaired. Keep this one in front."

Malati Devi looked at him. "In front?"

"Yes. The umbrella that works should be in front."

Malati Devi said nothing. She opened the wet umbrella and left it in the veranda to dry.

After dinner Sudhanshu Babu took out his old diary. Ramakant's home number was still written there, though the number might have changed. His wife, Sharda Devi, lived in Patna with their son.

Sudhanshu Babu picked up his mobile. Ramakant's son Amit's number was in his contacts. In six years they had spoken only twice—once after the shraddha, once about a copy of a book.

He opened the number and stared at the screen for a long time.

From beside him Malati Devi asked, "Will you call?"

"I don't know."

"Then why have you been looking at the number so long?"

Sudhanshu Babu did not switch off the phone. "I'll ask how Sharda Bhabhi is."

Malati Devi simply said, "Ask," and got up to take her medicine.

Sudhanshu Babu moved his thumb towards the call button, then stopped. It was ten o'clock. "It has become late," he said to himself.

He placed the phone on the table.

In the veranda the grey umbrella stood open. Its cloth was drying. Through the small hole, the yellow light of the bulb fell on the floor like a single point.

Sudhanshu Babu went as far as the door. He looked at the umbrella. Then he picked up the phone again.

He did not call. He merely wrote Amit a short message: "It has been a long time. How is Sharda Bhabhi?"

No reply came immediately after the message was sent. Sudhanshu Babu put the mobile in his pocket; the umbrella was still open in the veranda.

At night the rain began again. Amid the sound of the drops, the mobile chimed once. Sudhanshu Babu reached towards his pocket, then paused for a moment. In the veranda, the old umbrella was slowly drying.

The Day the Key Was Handed Over

When Ramcharit Kaka reached the school, the clock showed six forty-seven. The main gate was still closed, the bricks of the veranda looked dark with the night's dew, and water rested on the leaves of the peepal tree in the middle of the grounds.

He took out the small bunch of keys tied at his waist. There were eleven keys on the ring. Five of the eleven were no longer used—the old storeroom, a broken cupboard, the first room of the laboratory, and two locks that had been replaced years ago. Even so, all five keys were still on the ring.

As he opened the gate, the familiar scrape of iron sounded. Without thinking, Ramcharit Kaka ran his hand along the upper bar of the gate. From tomorrow, someone else would do this.

It was his last day at the school.

Thirty-eight years earlier, he had come to this same school as an attendant. At that time there had been two permanent rooms; the rest were under tiled roofs. Now there were eight rooms, an office, a library, a kitchen, toilets and a large iron gate. Only the peepal tree had been there then too.

The first thing Ramcharit Kaka opened was the headmaster's office. He drew the window curtain to one side, blew away the dust that had settled on the table overnight, filled the water jug and set it in place. Then he opened the teachers' room, the classrooms and the library.

He did everything in the same order in which he had done it for decades. He no longer had to think about the order. His feet knew the route by themselves.

At seven twenty, Phulo Devi, the cook, arrived. The moment she saw him she said, "Kaka, today is your last day, isn't it?"

Ramcharit Kaka smiled. "That is what the paper says."

"Then today you won't give the keys to me. You'll give them to the headmaster."

"I'll give the keys to the key-holder. You look after the khichdi."

Phulo Devi laughed. "And who is the key-holder from tomorrow?"

Ramcharit Kaka was silent for a moment. "Whoever has been appointed."

In fact, no new attendant had yet been appointed. An order had come from the block office that, temporarily, the cook and one teacher would open and close the school. Ramcharit Kaka had heard this three times already. Even so, it seemed to him that keys required one definite hand.

By half past seven, the children began to arrive. Some came running, some dragged their schoolbags, some were unwilling to let go of their mothers' fingers. Standing near the gate, Ramcharit Kaka would lift someone's bag, tell another, "Brush the mud off your shoes before you go in," and another, "Don't run. You'll fall."

Ravi from the lower class shouted from a distance, "Kaka, will we get sweets today?"

"Why?"

"Master Sahib said you are leaving."

"Where am I going?" Ramcharit Kaka asked.

Ravi stopped short. He could not think of an answer.

Ramcharit Kaka placed a hand on his head and said, "Go to class. The bell will ring."

With five minutes to go before eight, he went to the iron wheel used as a bell. An electric bell had been installed at the school two years earlier, but it was often out of order. The old iron wheel and hammer still hung by a pillar of the veranda.

Ramcharit Kaka struck it three times—clang... clang... clang...

The children began forming lines in the field.

As he listened to the sound, he remembered his first year, when the bell had actually been a piece cut from a railway track. The headmaster then, Lakshminarayan Babu, had told him, "Time is the school's first teacher. The bell must never be wrong."

Lakshminarayan Babu had died many years ago. The old brass plaque bearing his name lay in the library.

The prayer began. Ramcharit Kaka stood at the far end of the veranda. The children's voices rose together, then sometimes moved ahead of one another, sometimes behind. He heard this every day, but today the voices seemed slightly different. Perhaps it was not the voices that had changed, but the listener.

After the prayer, acting headmaster Sudhir Jha announced over the microphone, "Today is Ramcharitji's last day of service. We shall have a small programme at noon."

The children applauded.

Ramcharit Kaka immediately looked down. He was not accustomed to hearing applause. When the bell rang, classes began; when people clapped, he did not know what he was supposed to do.

When Sudhir Jha stepped down from the platform, he said, “Kaka, all the teachers will be here at twelve. I have informed the BEO Sahib as well; if he gets time, he may come.”

Ramcharit Kaka only said, “All right.”

He went into the office. The attendance register lay on the table. The teachers came one by one to sign it. There was a separate staff register for Ramcharit Kaka, and on almost the last line of its last page the space for today’s date was still blank.

He took his spectacles from his pocket. He looked at his name on the page — “Ramcharit Paswan, Attendant.”

The signatures from the previous months did not look alike. Sometimes there was a curve like an R, sometimes “Ra” was clear, sometimes only a line. His hand had grown old, and so had his signature.

He left today’s space blank for now.

“Kaka, won’t you mark your attendance?” mathematics teacher Manoj Kumar asked.

“I will. The day has only just begun.”

Manoj laughed. “Rules even on the last day?”

Ramcharit Kaka said, “Does time run faster on the last day?”

Manoj seemed about to say something, then smiled and went to his class.

After the first bell, Ramcharit Kaka placed the post on the headmaster’s table. Two envelopes, one registered letter, and the statement of rice for the midday meal.

Then he took a screwdriver and went to tighten the loose latch on the door of Class Three. It had been loose for three days. Yesterday he had thought, “What is it to me now?” But when he saw it that morning, his hand had picked up the screwdriver by itself.

As he tightened the latch, Rani from Class Three asked, “Kaka, you won’t come tomorrow?”

“No.”

“Then who will repair the latch?”

Turning the screwdriver, Ramcharit Kaka said, “There are plenty of people who can repair a latch.”

“And the bell?”

“The bell too.”

Rani did not look satisfied. “But like you?”

Ramcharit Kaka did not answer. He tightened the final screw, opened and closed the door to test it. The latch worked properly.

Some Class Ten students came to the office to submit examination forms. Ramcharit Kaka went on matching the files. He did not know every student’s name, but their faces had long been familiar. He remembered stories such as

whose father had studied with him, whose grandfather had donated bricks when the school's first building was being constructed.

Tea was made at ten. Five cups were placed in the teachers' room. Ramcharit Kaka usually drank his own tea on the veranda. Today Sudhir Jha said, "Kaka, sit inside."

"I'm fine here."

"Sit today."

Ramcharit Kaka sat on an empty chair inside. The moment he sat down, he felt slightly uncomfortable. For years he had entered this room to serve tea; he had rarely sat there.

Nirmala Devi, the history teacher, said, "Kaka, now you will rest."

Ramcharit Kaka smiled. "At what time does rest begin?"

Everyone laughed. Nirmala Devi too. But Ramcharit Kaka had not asked the question as a joke.

As he left home that morning, his wife, Sita Devi, had said, "From tomorrow you can sleep late."

Ramcharit Kaka had said, "Yes." But once his eyes opened at five in the morning, he did not know how one went back to sleep.

At school, his clock ran by the bells—prayer at eight, the second bell at nine forty, recess at half past ten, lunch at twelve, dismissal at two. At home, time had no such pieces.

As soon as the tea was finished, he stood up.

"Sit, Kaka," Sudhir Jha said.

"I'll go and check the kitchen water."

In fact, there was enough water. He had only been looking for a reason to stand up.

Near the kitchen, Phulo Devi was washing rice. She asked, "Will you wear a garland at the programme?"

"A garland looks good on a tree."

"If you show too much stubbornness today, I'll put it on you by force."

Ramcharit Kaka laughed.

At eleven, a call came saying that the Block Education Officer would not be able to come. Sudhir Jha's face fell a little. He said, "Never mind, we shall hold the programme ourselves."

At eleven forty-five, sudden word came that an inspection team from the block office was at a nearby school and might come here too. The teachers began checking the registers, attendance, the meal register and the grant papers.

The small programme planned for twelve was postponed until "after the inspection."

Ramcharit Kaka said nothing. He rang the bell for the midday meal.

The children stood in line for khichdi. Ramcharit Kaka straightened the bowls of the smaller children, picked up a fallen spoon for someone, told someone else not to break the line.

Ravi asked again, "Sweets?"

Ramcharit Kaka said, "Eat the khichdi. Sweets later."

"When?"

"When they come."

Ravi was satisfied with the answer. For a child, "later" is a very large stretch of time.

By one o'clock, the inspection team had not come. Sudhir Jha remained busy on the phone. The teachers went back to their classes. The two marigold garlands bought for the programme lay wrapped in paper near the office window.

Ramcharit Kaka looked at them once, then began drinking water.

He did not feel bad—he told himself this twice. The work of the school had to go on. Inspection was important. A programme was only a programme.

Even so, when at half past one Phulo Devi silently picked up one garland to look at it and then put it back, Ramcharit Kaka walked out towards the field for a few moments.

The peepal tree's shadow had grown short. Two Class Seven students were playing ball in the field. Beyond them, the fields were white with sunlight.

Ramcharit Kaka placed a hand on the trunk of the peepal tree. The trunk had grown thick. In thirty-eight years, how many children had come and gone, teachers had changed, buildings had changed, nameboards had changed. He thought—if the peepal tree retired too, where would it have to go?

The thought made him laugh at himself.

With ten minutes to go before two, Sudhir Jha said, "Kaka, it seems the inspection people won't come now. We'll stop everyone for five minutes after dismissal."

Ramcharit Kaka said, "The children's buses will leave."

"Then the teachers will stay."

Ramcharit Kaka again said, "All right."

Five minutes to two. He went to the bell. He raised the hammer in his hand.

After this bell, the children would go home. Tomorrow, at this time, he would be at home.

It suddenly occurred to him how many times in thirty-eight years he had rung this final bell, and yet never listened to its sound all the way to the end. The moment he struck it he usually moved to the next task—open the gate, let the children out, check the rooms, close the windows.

Today he struck once and stood still.

Clang...

The sound crossed the veranda and travelled towards the field, returned from the building walls, then slowly weakened.

The second strike.

Clang...

The third.

Clang...

The children's voices rose at once. Chairs scraped, schoolbags closed, doors opened. The school filled with sound.

Ramcharit Kaka lowered the hammer. It seemed to him that the sound of the bell had not ended; it had mingled with the children's voices.

A crowd formed at the gate. Someone said, "Namaskar, Kaka," someone ran out without looking, someone waved a hand. Ravi remembered again — "We didn't get the sweets!"

From the kitchen Phulo Devi called, "Come tomorrow and eat them!"

Laughing, Ramcharit Kaka said to Ravi, "Did you hear? Tomorrow you will eat them, not me."

Ravi did not understand what that meant. He ran off.

After the children had left, the teachers gathered in the office. Sudhir Jha took out the garland.

Just then the phone rang again. The block office wanted some information immediately. Three teachers began searching through papers.

The programme stopped for another five minutes.

Ramcharit Kaka looked at the clock on the wall. Two thirty-five. In his daily routine, the school had to be empty by two fifteen, the windows and doors checked by two thirty, and by two forty he would set out for home.

Slowly, he went out to inspect the classrooms.

On the board in Class One, some child had written in chalk, "Today is Saturday." The vowel mark in "Today" leaned a little crookedly. Ramcharit Kaka picked up the duster, then did not erase the writing.

One window in Class Two was open; he closed it.

The latch in Class Three, which he had repaired that morning, was fine.

A pencil lay on the floor in Class Four. He picked it up and placed it on the teacher's table.

At the back of Class Five, an old map had peeled halfway from the wall. He pressed it with his hand, but without glue it would not stay. The thought came — tomorrow I'll bring some glue and...

He stopped the thought midway.

Tomorrow he would no longer be the attendant.

When he returned to the office, the information requested by the block had been prepared. Sudhir Jha stood with the garland. "Kaka, now just two minutes."

Ramcharit Kaka let them put the garland around his neck. Everyone clapped. Nirmala Devi gave him a gamchha. Manoj Kumar gave him a small diary. Sudhir Jha said, "The school family is grateful for thirty-eight years of service."

The sentence was correct, respectful, but very short.

Ramcharit Kaka was asked to say something.

He stood before them. He looked at the faces of the teachers. Some were very old acquaintances, some new. On the wall behind the office was written the year the school had been established.

He wanted to say—thirty-eight years is a long time. He wanted to say—he had been twenty-two on his first day. He wanted to say—he had enrolled his own son at this school, and later the boy had left for the city. He wanted to say—even when his wife was ill, he had rung the bell before going home. He wanted to say—on the day Lakshminarayan Babu died, the school bell had remained silent for half the day.

But all that came out of his mouth was, "Open the school on time. It is not good if the children have to wait outside."

Everyone smiled.

Ramcharit Kaka added, "And in the rains, water comes in through the Class Three window. Keep an eye on that."

Sudhir Jha said, "Don't worry, Kaka."

Photographs were taken. One teacher held up a mobile. Ramcharit Kaka stood in the middle wearing the garland. Once the photograph had been taken, he felt as though the work were over.

He removed the garland and wrapped it in paper. He tucked the gamchha under his arm. The diary went into his bag.

Then he opened the staff register.

Today's blank space was still waiting for him.

He put on his spectacles and slowly signed—Ramcharit Paswan. The final "n" trembled slightly.

He wrote the date. There was no box for the time.

As he closed the register, he felt strange. Tomorrow, on this page, there would be no blank space opposite his name; there would simply be the next date's line, which no one would fill.

He took out the bunch of keys.

Sudhir Jha said, "Kaka, until a new arrangement is made, why don't you keep the key to the main gate with you? We may need you sometimes."

Ramcharit Kaka's hand paused for a moment.

It would have been very easy to say, "All right."

Instead, he separated the main gate key from the ring and placed it in Sudhir Jha's palm. "If you need me, you people can call."

He placed the remaining keys on the table as well. Eleven small pieces of metal clinked together.

His waist suddenly felt light.

He picked up his bag.

"Shall someone drop you?" Manoj asked.

"My house is right here. Have my feet forgotten the road?"

Everyone laughed. Ramcharit Kaka said namaskar and went out.

When he reached the gate, habit made him turn and look back—windows closed? Office door? Kitchen? Bell? Everything was in order.

His hand moved to close the gate, then stopped. He no longer had the key.

Sudhir Jha came up from behind and closed the gate.

"See you tomorrow, Kaka," he said casually.

Just as casually Ramcharit Kaka said, "Yes."

After ten steps, it occurred to him—why would he come to the school tomorrow?

The village road was bending towards evening. Shops were open, bicycles passed, a cow grazed beside the drain. Ramcharit Kaka had walked this road home every day. Today's road was the same, but the time felt different.

Earlier, on his way home, he would think about the next day's work—the rice would arrive, there was an inspection, the flag rope had to be changed, the holiday notice had to be pasted up. Today the next day was empty.

He thought, tomorrow morning I'll get up at five. Then?

Tea.

Then?

Sweep the courtyard.

Then?

No answer came.

Near the village pond, his old friend Jaynarayan was sitting. From a distance he called, "Ramcharit! So now you've joined our group!"

"What group?"

"The group of people with no work." Jaynarayan laughed.

Ramcharit Kaka laughed too, but the words caught slightly inside him.

Jaynarayan said, "From tomorrow morning, sit here with us. We'll play cards."

Ramcharit Kaka said, "We'll see."

"What is there to see now? You don't have to go ring the bell."

Ramcharit Kaka looked at the water of the pond. The evening light was breaking across it.

“Yes,” he said. “I don’t have to go ring the bell.”

When he reached home, Sita Devi saw the garland at the door. “Good, they gave you a garland too,” she said happily.

Ramcharit Kaka showed her the gamchha and the diary.

Sita Devi examined everything with delight. “Did they take a photograph?”

“Yes.”

“Did you give a speech?”

“I said two things.”

“What?”

“Water comes in through the window.”

Sita Devi stared at him, then burst out laughing. “After thirty-eight years, that was your speech?”

Ramcharit Kaka laughed too.

After dinner, he opened the new diary. The first page was completely blank. He wrote his name, then the date. After that, nothing occurred to him.

From old habit, his hand went to his waist. There were no keys.

He took his hand away and began looking out of the window. The school building could not be seen from there, but the upper part of the peepal tree was visible.

From the bed Sita Devi said, “Tomorrow you can get up at your ease.”

Ramcharit Kaka said, “Yes.”

At four fifty-eight in the morning, his eyes opened.

The house was silent. It was still dark outside. Lying in bed, he went on estimating five o’clock, five ten, five twenty. He did not look at the clock.

At six he got up. He swept the courtyard. He filled water from the tap. Tea was made.

At six forty his body began getting ready by itself—the gamchha on his shoulder, slippers straight, the impulse to look for his bag. He stopped midway.

Sita Devi understood. She said nothing.

At seven, two children were going past the house towards school. One stopped and said, “Kaka, aren’t you coming?”

Ramcharit Kaka said, “Now it is all your responsibility.”

The child laughed and ran on.

At seven fifty-five Ramcharit Kaka was sitting on the veranda. He could not hear the school bell clearly; it was too far away. But at exactly eight, some metallic sound came faintly through the air, broken by the distance. Once, then again.

Ramcharit Kaka raised his head.

The sound was irregular. Perhaps Phulo Devi was ringing it, perhaps some teacher. There was too long a pause between the first strike and the second.

From inside Sita Devi asked, “What happened?”

“Nothing.”

Ramcharit Kaka kept listening. The third strike came.

He did not get up.

A little later he sat on the veranda with the new diary. Beneath the date on the first page he wrote: “The bell rang at eight.”

Then he held the pen still for a long time.

Below it he wrote: “I was at home.”

He kept looking at the two sentences.

The children’s voices faded along the road. The house became quiet again. Ramcharit Kaka did not close the diary. The page remained open.

After some time, he noticed a loose door in the courtyard. He got up and began looking for a screwdriver.

Two Cups of Tea

It was an evening in Chaitra. The last patch of sunlight in the courtyard had caught beside the tulsi platform, and the fragrance of tea leaves was drifting slowly out through the kitchen window.

Devaki Devi lifted the lid of the kettle and looked inside once, then lowered the flame. Three cups stood on the table.

For three months, three cups of tea had not been made together in the house.

Two cups were still made, but not at the same time. Harinath Babu's cup was usually placed on the small table in the veranda, while Devaki drank hers sitting on the low stool in the kitchen.

No one had sat down one day and devised this arrangement. It had formed gradually, the way fine dust gathers by itself in the corner of a wall.

That day the third cup was for Tarakant Babu.

Tarakant Babu was an old colleague of Harinath's. The two had taught in the same college for thirty years—Harinath taught history, Tarakant economics. After retirement they met less often, but now and then he would come by on the pretext of a wedding, a shraddha, an illness, or some pension-related paperwork.

Today he had come with an invitation to the wedding of his younger daughter, Rashmi.

The red-lettered card lay on the table in the sitting room. With his spectacles low on his nose, Tarakant Babu was explaining the wedding date once again.

"The eighteenth of Vaishakh. Wednesday. The wedding party will arrive at eight at night. You both must come during the day."

Harinath Babu stroked a corner of the card with one finger. "During the day?"

"Yes. I regard Bhabhi as my own sister. If she isn't there, the family will never let me hear the end of it."

Devaki heard this from the kitchen but gave no reply.

Raising his voice, Tarakant Babu called, "Bhabhi, you heard me, didn't you?"

“I heard.”

That was all.

Harinath Babu looked once towards the doorway, then back at the card.

Tarakant Babu may have noticed the small pause, but at once he moved on to other wedding matters—the confectioner, lodging for the wedding party, relatives arriving by train, and the nuisance of having the roof repaired before the rains.

Devaki strained the tea into three cups. She put no sugar in the first cup. Two small spoonfuls in the second. Half a spoonful in the third.

She did not think while doing it about which cup belonged to whom. Her hands knew on their own.

The first cup—Harinath’s.

The second—the guest’s.

The third—her own.

Harinath Babu had been diagnosed with diabetes five years earlier. The doctor had told him to cut down on sugar, and since then Devaki had made his tea without it.

Three months of silence had not changed that rule.

The silence had changed many things—where they sat, when they ate, the small remarks once exchanged before sleep, the way the newspaper pages were divided in the morning—but not the amount of sugar in his tea.

Devaki carried the tray into the sitting room.

Tarakant Babu looked up from the card. “Oh, Bhabhi, tea too! The doctor has told me to drink less.”

“He told you to drink less, not to give it up,” Devaki said.

Tarakant Babu laughed. “I like that interpretation.”

Devaki placed the tray on the table. Usually she would slide the first cup towards Harinath. Today, with all three cups there together, her hand paused for a moment.

Without sliding any cup towards anyone, she sat down.

Tarakant Babu pushed the wedding card towards Harinath again. “This address is new. I sold the old house.”

“You sold it?” Harinath was startled.

“Yes. My son said, what will two old people do in such a large house? I too thought—one cannot spend one’s life holding on to walls.”

Harinath Babu’s finger became still on the edge of the card.

Devaki kept watching the steam from her cup.

Tarakant Babu continued the story on his own. “At first my heart would not agree. Babuji had lived in that house, the children were born there. But Rashmi said, ‘Selling a house does not mean selling memory.’”

Harinath said nothing.

Three months earlier Mrinal had telephoned from Hyderabad.

Mrinal was their only daughter. She had married two years before. Now she was pregnant, and the doctor had given the first week of May as the expected time.

That night on the phone Mrinal had said again and again, "Ma, come here now. Stay at least two months. Babu should come too."

From that very moment Devaki had wanted to go. Her daughter was going to become a mother for the first time. She wanted to be beside her, just as her own mother had stayed in Darbhanga for a month when Devaki had given birth for the first time.

Harinath had been listening on speakerphone.

Mrinal said again, "Babu, please look at the tickets."

Without looking at Devaki, Harinath said, "I am not going anywhere. If your mother wants to go, she may."

The sentence was short. His tone was not especially harsh either.

But Devaki could not find her own name anywhere in that sentence.

"Your mother."

As though she were not Harinath's companion in life, only the person connected to him through Mrinal.

After the call ended, Devaki had asked, "Are you telling me to go?"

Folding the newspaper, Harinath had said, "If you want to go, go. Why should you stay because of me?"

Devaki had asked nothing more that night.

The next morning she placed Harinath's tea in the veranda. She drank her own in the kitchen.

The third day too.

Then the arrangement became a rule of the house.

The Hyderabad tickets were never booked. Mrinal asked twice. Devaki said, "There is some work at home."

Mrinal perhaps did not understand, but she did not press very hard.

Tarakant Babu was now describing the measurements of the veranda in his new house. "It is small, but enough for two people."

Harinath tried to laugh. "Where will your books go in a small house?"

"I gave half to the college library. Rashmi took away the other half."

"You gave the books away?"

"I did. What else would I have done? After I die, the children will sell them by the kilo."

Tarakant Babu laughed, but Harinath did not.

Devaki looked at his face.

The hair on Harinath's head had grown very thin. The white around his ears had increased. None of this had changed in three months, yet for some reason Devaki suddenly saw it today.

Tarakant Babu reached for his cup when his mobile rang.

He looked at the screen. "It's from home."

The moment he answered, his face changed.

"What? Now? ... All right, I'm coming."

He put the phone away and stood up. "Bhabhi, forgive me. The confectioner has arrived and there is no man at home. I have to go now."

Devaki said, "At least drink your tea."

"Next time I'll drink two cups," Tarakant Babu said with a laugh.

The words slipped from Devaki's mouth: "Tea made once does not remain for another time."

For a moment Tarakant Babu looked at her, then said easily, "Then I'll drink it at the wedding."

Harinath Babu picked up the card and went with him as far as the gate.

Devaki remained in the sitting room.

There were three cups on the table.

One without sugar.

One with two spoonfuls of sugar—for the guest.

One with half a spoonful—her own.

Outside came the sound of Tarakant Babu's motorcycle starting, then fading at the bend in the lane.

Harinath returned to the sitting room.

Devaki thought of getting up, but did not.

Harinath too did not immediately sit in his usual chair. He stood by the table, looking at the three cups.

"The tea is getting cold," Devaki said.

In three months, this was the first sentence she had spoken to Harinath that was not merely some necessary household information.

Perhaps Harinath understood this. Very softly he said, "Yes."

He picked up the cup on the right side of the table.

Devaki said at once, "Not that one."

Harinath's hand stopped in mid-air.

"That one has sugar," Devaki said. "Yours is this."

She slid the cup on the left towards him.

Harinath looked at the cup, then at Devaki.

Devaki lowered her eyes.

For a few moments only the ticking of the clock could be heard in the sitting room.

Harinath sat down. He lifted the cup and took a sip.

"It hasn't gone cold," he said.

Devaki lifted her own cup.

The guest's cup was still full in the middle of the table.

There was more steam rising from that cup than from the other two, because no one had touched it.

Harinath asked, "Had Tarakant told you earlier that he had sold the house?"

"No."

"To you... to you formally?"

Harinath began with the intimate "to you," then stopped and shifted to the more formal form of address.

Devaki's fingers tightened slightly around the handle of her cup.

"He hadn't told me either."

Silence again.

But this silence was not like the silence of the previous three months.

In the earlier silence, each of them would turn their face in a different direction. Today they were sitting at the same table, with the third cup between them.

Harinath ran a finger around the rim of his cup. "Will we go to Rashmi's wedding?"

Before answering, Devaki took a sip of tea.

"The invitation is for both of us."

"Yes."

After that "yes," Harinath seemed to want to say something more, but the sentence would not form.

Devaki thought he might bring up Hyderabad.

He did not.

Outside, a child rang a bicycle bell while passing through the lane.

Devaki looked at the cup made for the guest. The sugar was settling at the bottom.

"Shall I throw this away?" Harinath asked.

Devaki said, "Leave it."

"It will go cold."

"Let it."

Harinath fell silent.

After a while he took his spectacles from his pocket and began reading the wedding card again.

Devaki kept looking at the red border of the card lying on the table.

"The eighteenth of Vaishakh," Harinath said.

"Yes."

"Mrinal's date is in the first week of May, isn't it?"

Devaki put down her cup.

"The doctor said the seventh of May."

Harinath lowered the card.

"After the eighteenth of Vaishakh..." He left the sentence unfinished.

Devaki looked at him.

Harinath began looking out of the window.

"After that, what?" Devaki asked.

Harinath's lips moved slightly. "Nothing."

Devaki picked up her cup again.

The old anger in her had not vanished all at once. On the contrary, the sentence—"If your mother wants to go, she may"—rang clearly again.

But today, beside that sentence, another unfinished sentence had appeared: "After the eighteenth of Vaishakh..."

The two sentences did not cancel each other out.

They had merely begun to live in the same house.

At dinner that night Devaki served the dal. Harinath took a little less rice than usual.

"Have you taken your medicine?" Devaki asked.

The moment she asked, she herself was surprised. For three months she had continued to place the medicine box on the table, but she had not asked.

Harinath said, "Not yet."

"Take it after dinner."

"Yes."

After that small exchange they again ate quietly.

At night Devaki looked through Mrinal's old messages.

In one message there was a photograph of blue baby clothes. Mrinal had written, "Ma, is this nice?"

Devaki had replied, "It is nice."

Another message: "Have the tickets been booked?"

The reply beneath it was: "Not yet."

Devaki switched off the phone and placed it beside the pillow.

In the other room Harinath was opening the cupboard. She heard the wooden panel slide.

Devaki continued listening to the sound.

After a while came the sound of something heavy being set down.

She did not get up to see.

In the morning, when Devaki went to the kitchen, the old brown suitcase was lying in the veranda beside the sitting room.

That suitcase had been used ten years earlier on a journey to Kashi. Afterwards it had been kept on top of the cupboard.

A thick layer of dust lay over it, but across the middle a broad handprint had been wiped clean.

Harinath was watering the tulsi in the courtyard.

Devaki looked at the suitcase, then at him.

She asked nothing.

In the kitchen she put the tea on.

Out of habit she took out two cups.

She put no sugar in one. Half a spoonful in the other.

For a moment she thought of placing the first cup on the small table in the veranda, as she had been doing for three months.

Then she remembered yesterday's third cup—the guest's cup, which no hand had touched until the end.

She placed both cups on the same tray.

She carried them into the sitting room and set both on the same table.

Harinath was returning from the tulsi platform.

He looked at the table.

Devaki sat down.

Harinath stood for a few moments, then pulled out the chair opposite and sat.

Before lifting a cup, he asked, "This one is without sugar?"

Devaki said, "Since when have I begun putting sugar in your tea?"

A very faint smile came over Harinath's face. At once he lowered his eyes to the cup.

Devaki too lifted her own cup.

The old suitcase lay in the veranda.

There was still dust on it.

Neither of them said anything about cleaning it.

Across the Road

Shivakant Babu's house stood beside the main road. The road was not very wide, but by evening the sound of bicycles, motorcycles, milk vans, and people returning from the market lingered for a long time.

The old veranda opened towards the road. On it stood a bamboo chair and a small table, and on the wall hung a clock that ran five minutes fast.

Shivakant Babu had been living alone for three years.

His wife, Saroja Devi, had died on a winter night. Since then very few things in the house had changed. The spice tins in the kitchen remained in the same order, the brass lamp in the shrine hung from the same hook, and on the small table to the left of the bed still lay Saroja's spectacle case.

The spectacles were not inside it. During her last month, whenever she went to the hospital, Saroja had worn them. The case had remained empty.

Shivakant Babu had thought many times of putting the case away, but had never done so.

He had retired from the district post office. While he was working, his days had moved by the accounting of hours and minutes. Now time was long, but had fewer marks within it.

The newspaper in the morning. The market at ten. Rice at noon. Sometimes a nap at three. The veranda in the evening.

Night was not the most difficult time. The difficult part was that short stretch of evening when the day had ended but night had not yet taken on its shape.

At that time Shivakant Babu would sit in the chair on the veranda.

Across the road stood a two-storeyed house. A metal gate below, a small courtyard inside, and upstairs, facing the road, a square window.

A pale yellow curtain hung at the window.

Every evening, at almost the same time, a light came on behind it.

At first Shivakant Babu had not paid attention to this. One day after rain, when the electricity returned late, the window suddenly turned yellow in the darkness across the road. It was then that he realized he had been seeing that light almost every evening.

After that, without intending to, he began to learn its time.

At around six forty-five, two or four children returning from school could be seen on the road. Before seven, the milkman would pass ringing the bell on his bicycle. A little after that, the light across the road would come on.

Once the light came on, Shivakant Babu would often fold the newspaper.

Sometimes he switched on the radio. Sometimes he went into the kitchen and warmed the dal. Sometimes he simply remained in the chair.

He did not know the people in that house very well.

Now and then a middle-aged man could be seen by the gate, perhaps the son of the household. Sometimes a young woman brought out a scooter. And behind the upstairs curtain, from time to time, there appeared the outline of an elderly woman.

Shivakant Babu had assumed that the elderly woman was the mother of the family.

He did not know her name.

Once, at the grocery shop, he had heard the shopkeeper call someone "Uma Kaki." Shivakant Babu had thought it must be the elderly woman from that house. Then the detail had not stayed in his mind.

He had not felt any need for that acquaintance either.

The light was simply a light.

Like the peepal tree at the turn in the road. Like the whistle of a distant train that came at eight each night. Like the wall clock that had been running since Saroja's time.

Some things make a place for themselves in a life without ever being properly introduced.

Shivakant Babu's daughter, Swati, lived in Gurugram. She telephoned two or three times a week.

"Babu, don't sit outside in the evening. There are too many mosquitoes."

"The veranda is not outside. It is part of the house."

"Have the mosquitoes been told that?"

Swati would laugh. Shivakant Babu would laugh too.

After the call ended, the veranda would become quiet again.

Once Swati insisted strongly that he come to Gurugram for two months.

Shivakant Babu said, "Who will look after the house here?"

"A house can manage on its own for two months."

"The plants?"

"We'll tell the gardener."

"The shrine?"

Swati was silent for a moment, then said, "The gods can come to Gurugram with you for two months too."

Shivakant Babu laughed, but he did not go.

He felt he could not leave his house.

What exactly there was in the house that held him back, he had never thought through clearly.

One Wednesday evening the air was warmer than usual. The sun had been strong all day, but clouds were gathering in the west.

Shivakant Babu sat on the veranda reading an old editorial in the newspaper. He read the same paragraph twice and realized that not once had he really been paying attention.

The milkman went past.

The temple bell rang.

The wall clock reached five minutes past seven.

Shivakant Babu folded the newspaper.

He looked across the road.

The window was dark.

At first it did not seem especially significant. He thought the light might simply be late coming on.

He leaned back in the chair.

Ten minutes later he looked again.

Darkness.

Even the curtain in the upstairs window was barely visible.

The gate below was closed. There was no light in the courtyard either.

Shivakant Babu got up and went inside. He switched on the radio. The news was playing. The volume was ordinary, yet it seemed very loud to him. He turned it down.

In the kitchen he lifted the lid from the pot of dal.

Then, without heating it, he covered it again.

He returned to the veranda.

The window was still dark.

He looked at the switchboard in his own house. There was electricity. The veranda bulb was on. The streetlights were on too.

"Everyone must have gone out," he said to himself.

Even after saying the sentence, the matter did not end.

He wondered why he had begun wanting to know.

A light had not come on in someone else's house. What was there in that?

People continued to come and go along the road. Three young men were laughing at the paan shop. A child ran after a ball. A motorcycle horn sounded.

Everything was moving as usual.

Only that window was dark.

Shivakant Babu kept tapping his fingers on the arm of the chair.

Suddenly he remembered the last days of Saroja's illness. After returning home from the hospital, Saroja spoke very little at night. But when sleep would not come, she would switch on the small light in the bedroom.

Sometimes Shivakant Babu would say irritably, "I can't sleep with the light on."

Without answering, Saroja would switch it off.

Why this tiny memory had returned after so many years, Shivakant Babu did not know.

He rose and went as far as the gate.

The thought of crossing the road came to him.

Then he stopped.

If he went to that house, what would he ask?

"Why didn't your light come on?"

What would people think of such a question?

He stood at the gate for a while, then went back inside.

Eight o'clock came. The window remained dark.

Shivakant Babu ate very little dinner.

He picked up the phone. Swati's name was on the screen. He thought of calling her.

Then he put the phone down.

It seemed strange to telephone his daughter merely for this reason.

"The light in the house across the road didn't come on, so I felt like hearing your voice"—he could not say such a sentence.

At night the rain began.

Drops kept striking the window glass. Shivakant Babu lay in bed, but sleep came late.

In the morning the road looked washed clean.

He set out for the market. While crossing the road, he involuntarily looked towards the gate of that house.

The gate was closed.

At the grocery shop he bought oil, soap and tea leaves. Raju, the shopkeeper, was putting the things into a bag.

Trying to sound casual, Shivakant Babu asked, "Where has everyone in Mishraji's house across the road gone?"

Without looking up, Raju said, "Uma Kaki has gone to Darbhanga. She had an eye examination. Her son went with her. She'll probably return in two days."

Shivakant Babu said, "Oh."

That was all.

Raju asked, "Did you need something from them?"

"No. I was only asking."

He picked up the bag.

Walking home, he felt a slight relief.

Then he felt almost ashamed of the relief.

Uma Kaki—the name was clear now.

He thought that in three years he had exchanged greetings with the elderly woman only twice. Then why had her absence changed the taste of his dinner the previous night?

No answer came at once.

The second evening the window remained dark too.

This time Shivakant Babu knew why. Even so, he kept looking across the road again and again.

He tried to read the entire newspaper. He played old songs on the radio. He lit the lamp in the shrine.

But the evening was long.

Then a simple thing became clear to him.

He had no use for that light, yet that light was present in his evenings.

He did not talk to anyone there, but merely knowing that life was going on in someone else's house was also a form of company.

He had continued to think that he lived entirely by his own strength. His own time, his own house, his own food, his own illness.

But so many unnamed people had taken places in his routine—the milkman, Raju's shop, the temple bell, the yellow light across the road.

That night Swati telephoned.

"Babu, what are you doing?"

"Sitting on the veranda."

"Again?"

"Yes."

After a pause Shivakant Babu asked, "Does the light in your veranda come on in the evening?"

Swati laughed. "Why?"

"Just asking."

"It does. Anshu studies there."

"All right."

Swati seemed about to say something more, but Shivakant Babu changed the subject.

On the third evening he switched on his own veranda bulb earlier than usual.

The daylight had not entirely faded yet.

The bulb's yellow glow was barely visible in the remaining light of day.

Shivakant Babu remained sitting in his chair.

He wondered what his veranda looked like from across the road.

The question had never occurred to him before.

On the fourth afternoon a car stopped at the gate of the house across the road. Shivakant Babu saw it from his window. A man got out and began unloading luggage. Then Uma Devi stepped out from the back in a white sari. She wore dark glasses.

Shivakant Babu let the curtain fall.

He did not like admitting that he was waiting for evening. Even so, he sat on the veranda five minutes earlier than usual.

The milkman went past.

The temple bell rang.

Darkness thickened along the road.

The window across the road was still dark.

Shivakant Babu turned a page of the newspaper.

Then the window glowed yellow.

He did not keep looking at it for long. He looked once, then lowered his eyes to the newspaper.

But his shoulders relaxed a little.

The next morning he was going to the market. As he crossed the road, he saw Uma Devi sitting on a chair near the gate. She was not wearing the dark glasses; there was a slight swelling around her eyes.

Shivakant Babu greeted her.

Uma Devi raised a hand in reply.

Shivakant Babu took two steps forward, then stopped.

“Are your eyes better now?”

Uma Devi smiled. “The doctor says I’ll begin to see clearly in a few days.”

“Good.”

Then both were silent.

Shivakant Babu had just begun to move on when Uma Devi said, “The light in your veranda came on very early the day before yesterday.”

Shivakant Babu stopped.

Quite naturally, Uma Devi said, “I was returning in the car. I saw it from a distance. I knew you were at home.”

Having said this, she lightly pressed the corner of her eye with the end of her sari.

For a few moments Shivakant Babu did not answer.

Then he said, “Yes, I was at home.”

He walked on towards the market.

That evening Shivakant Babu sat on the veranda. Across the road, the light came on at its usual time.

After a while he rose and went into the kitchen.

This time, unlike before, he did not switch off the veranda light.

The dal kept warming.
The radio played the news softly.
Outside, the traffic on the road thinned.
The road between the two houses was exactly as wide as it had always been.
As Shivakant Babu ladled dal into his bowl, he looked once towards the
open doorway.
The veranda light was still burning.
He let it burn.

Notice of Name Removal

It had been eight months since Raghunath Mishra died.

His bamboo chair was still on the veranda, though now clothes were often dried on it. His walking stick still stood beside the household shrine. At first no one had dared to move it. Later there seemed no reason to move it either.

Death changes many things first, and then, slowly, a few objects remain as though nothing has changed at all.

Shailendra did not pay attention to this.

He was a clerk in an insurance office in Darbhanga. He left home at half past nine in the morning and returned by seven in the evening.

When his father was alive, the moment he heard the door open he would ask from the veranda, "Late again today?"

Shailendra would usually say, "It is an office, Babu. It doesn't run by looking at the clock."

Raghunath Babu would laugh. "The clock doesn't run. You do."

Sometimes Shailendra laughed at the remark; sometimes it irritated him.

Now, when he came home in the evening and opened the door, no one asked.

For the first few months that silence had been very distinct. Now it too had dissolved into routine.

One Sunday morning, while shaking out the ration bag, Shailendra's wife Malati said, "Babuji's name is still on the card."

Shailendra did not look up from the newspaper. "Let it stay if it is there."

"The shopkeeper says we should have it updated next time. The members of the family have changed."

Shailendra turned the page.

Malati was silent for a while. Then she said, "The death certificate is in the file. There is a copy of his Aadhaar too. We only have to submit an application."

"Next week."

"You said next week last month too."

"Where do I get leave from the office?"

Malati did not answer. It was Sunday, a holiday—they both knew that.

In the courtyard, Shailendra's mother, Kamala Devi, was sitting in the sun sorting paddy. It was difficult to tell whether she could hear the conversation.

After a while she came inside and said, "If the name has to be removed, remove it. A person does not remain alive because his name remains on paper."

For the first time Shailendra looked up from the newspaper.

Kamala Devi carried the plate of paddy towards the kitchen.

The application was not prepared that day either.

Three days later the ration shopkeeper telephoned.

"Shailendra Babu, get the list updated. If a deceased member remains in the system, there can be trouble later."

Shailendra said, "All right," and ended the call.

Three insurance-claim files lay on the desk in front of him at the office. One of them contained a photocopy of a death certificate.

Without thinking, he read the date on it.

Then suddenly he remembered his father's certificate.

That evening, after returning home, he opened the old iron cupboard.

On the upper shelf was the blue file containing the family's papers.

The first page was a land-revenue receipt. The second, an old electricity bill. The third held a copy of his mother's Aadhaar. Behind it was his father's death certificate.

The paper was clean. The name was printed in bold letters—Raghunath Mishra.

Year of birth, date of death, place.

Shailendra stood for a few moments with the paper in his hand.

On the day of the cremation so many people had surrounded him that he had not had a moment in which to be alone.

At the ghat there had been wood, the priest's instructions, phone calls, vehicles, relatives, the evening meal—one task had followed another.

Until the thirteenth day the house had remained full of voices.

On the first morning after everyone had left, Kamala Devi had asked, "Shall I make two cups of tea or three?"

Immediately she herself had fallen silent.

Shailendra had walked out of the kitchen then.

In eight months even that moment had grown blurred.

The death certificate now seemed more solid than all those days surrounding the death.

He put the paper back in the file.

Malati asked, "Shall I prepare the application?"

"Tomorrow."

The next day, on his way to work, he put the blue file into his bag.

After lunch he took half a day's leave.

The supply office was at the rear of the block building.

Around twenty people sat or stood along the veranda. Several notices about schemes and eligibility had been pasted to the wall. The corners of some pages had curled.

People were submitting applications at one window.

Shailendra took a token. Number thirty-seven.

The screen showed thirty-one.

He sat down on a wooden bench.

Beside him, a newly married young woman was filling out an application to have her name added to the card of her new family. An elderly woman with her kept asking, "There won't be any problem if your name is removed from your mother's family card?"

The young woman laughed and said, "My name can't remain in two places, Ma."

In front of them a young man was saying to someone on his mobile, "I live outside, but I need to ask whether my name should remain here or not."

An old man was showing papers and saying that his year of birth had been entered incorrectly.

Everyone had come to put their place in the list right.

There was a name in Shailendra's bag too. But his was not a name to be added or corrected. It was to be removed.

He took out the application form.

At the top it read: Change in Family Details.

In the first box he wrote his own name as the head of the household.

In the second he entered the card number.

In the third section were the options: Add Member / Remove Member / Other Correction.

His pen stopped.

After a few moments he marked "Remove Member."

Below it was written: Name of Member to Be Removed.

He wrote "Raghunath Mishra."

The letters came out clearer than usual.

The next box asked for the relationship.

Shailendra wrote "Father."

Reason.

There the pen stopped again.

The space on the form was small.

There was room enough for the single word "Death."

Shailendra wrote the first letters, then lifted his pen.

Why, he himself did not understand.

Beside him, the young woman was showing her form to the elderly woman and saying, "Look, I wrote 'husband' here."

The older woman said, "Write everything properly, otherwise you'll have to run around again later."

Shailendra looked back at his form.

He completed the word: "Death."

Token thirty-seven was called.

Behind the counter sat an employee of about thirty. An empty tea glass stood beside the computer.

"What work?"

Shailendra handed over the form.

The employee read it. "Removing a member?"

"Yes."

"Deceased?"

"Yes."

"Certificate?"

Shailendra gave him the photocopy of the death certificate.

The employee typed the card number into the system.

The monitor was not fully turned towards Shailendra, but the names could be seen.

Kamala Devi. Shailendra Mishra. Malati Mishra. Saurabh Mishra. Raghunath Mishra.

His father's name was at the bottom.

The employee asked, "Date of death?"

Shailendra looked at the certificate even though he remembered the date.

He told him the date.

The employee kept typing.

Then he paused the mouse and asked, "Remove?"

Shailendra understood that it was only a confirmation required by the system.

Even so, the word sounded different in his ears.

"Yes."

There was a very soft click.

The screen went blank for a moment, then the list returned.

This time there were four names.

Raghunath Mishra was not there.

Shailendra kept looking at the screen.

The employee reached for the printer. "Take the receipt. The update will show in seven to ten days."

The paper came out.

Shailendra took the receipt.

People were waiting behind him at the counter.
He moved aside.
By then the sunlight on the veranda had shifted to one side.
The young woman's work had been completed. She was going down the steps with the elderly woman.
The old man was still arguing about the correction of his birth year.
Shailendra sat down on the bench again.
He was in no hurry to go anywhere.
The receipt said: Request Accepted. Process to Remove Member Initiated.
Below it: Raghunath Mishra. Reason: Death.
Shailendra thought that his hand had not trembled when he lit the funeral pyre at the ghat.
The priest had said, "Offer the water." He had offered it.
He had taken the ashes to the Ganga.
The pind-daan had been performed on the thirteenth day.
Through all those acts he had felt that there was something he had to do.
Here there was nothing left for him to do.
There had been one click, and the list had become shorter.
He did not fold the receipt. He placed it straight inside the blue file.
It was evening by the time he reached home.
Malati opened the door. "Done?"
"Yes."
"Did you get the receipt?"
"Yes."
"Good. We'll check with the shopkeeper next month."
Shailendra took off his shoes and went towards the veranda.
Two dhotis were drying on the bamboo chair.
He lifted them, hung them on the line, and cleared the chair.
Earlier he himself rarely sat in that chair.
That evening he sat down.
Kamala Devi was pouring water over the tulsi plant in the courtyard.
She asked, "The name was removed?"
"Yes, Ma."
Kamala Devi set down the small water pot.
For a few moments she was silent.
Then she said, "That is right."
Having said only that, she went inside.
Shailendra felt like asking—how was it right?
But he did not ask.
Dinner was rice, dal and potato curry.

As Malati served the rice, she said, "Next month the ration will come for one member less."

Then immediately she fell silent.

Kamala Devi was mixing dal into her plate.

She did not raise her head.

Shailendra too said nothing.

After dinner he opened the blue file again.

The receipt lay behind the death certificate.

Two pieces of paper.

One said that Raghunath Mishra had died.

The other said that the request to remove Raghunath Mishra's name had been accepted.

Shailendra had seen the first paper many times.

The second he was seeing for the first time.

It seemed to him that the second paper was harsher.

The death certificate recorded an event.

The receipt arranged an absence.

He closed the file.

Two weeks later Malati returned with the ration.

Whether the bag was a little lighter than before, Shailendra did not weigh.

Showing him the card on her mobile, Malati said, "There are four names now."

Shailendra took the screen. Four names—Kamala Devi at the top, then Shailendra, Malati, Saurabh. That was all.

He handed the phone back to Malati.

Much later that night Shailendra went out to the veranda.

The bamboo chair was empty; he did not sit down.

The walking stick stood beside the wall.

Shailendra picked it up.

The handle was smooth; years of contact with his father's palm had darkened the wood.

He took two steps into the courtyard with the stick, then stopped.

From inside Kamala Devi asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing."

He put the stick back in the same place, then sat in the chair.

A bicycle passed outside the door. Its bell rang.

Inside the house Malati was putting away utensils, Saurabh was studying in his room, and Kamala Devi coughed.

Shailendra remained seated in the darkness of the veranda.

Suddenly he remembered his father's old sentence—"The clock doesn't run. You do."

This time he did not try, as he once would have, to find an answer to it in his mind.

He kept running his palm over the bamboo arm of the chair.

After a while Malati called from inside, "Shall I switch off the light?"

Shailendra said, "Not yet."

The veranda light remained on. Beside the wall, the shadow of the walking stick stretched long across the floor.

His name was no longer on the list.

A few things in the house were still in their places.

The Last Page of the Notebook

Sudha Mishra sat alone in an empty classroom at the school.

The afternoon dismissal had taken place long ago. There were no children's voices in the veranda now, only the dry swish-swish of Ramdulari's broom.

Outside the window the peepal leaves moved. Sunlight had crept halfway across the sill.

On the desk lay two piles of Class Seven notebooks.

One pile had been checked. The other remained.

Sudha Devi uncapped her red pen.

She had been teaching for thirty years. Checking notebooks was no longer merely work for her; it had become almost a habit.

Underline a misspelling. Put a question mark beside an incomplete answer. A small tick for neat handwriting.

If someone wrote very well, she would write "Good."

She rarely wrote "Very good." She believed too much praise made children overconfident.

She believed this firmly.

She disliked the language of approximation. She wanted things to be definite.

She picked up the next notebook.

On the cover, in blue ink, was written: "Pallavi Kumari, Class Seven, Roll No. 23."

The corners of the notebook were worn. In two places, pages had been stitched back together with needle and thread.

Sudha Devi opened the first page.

Title: "My Village."

Below it was an old comment in her own red ink: "Complete the sentence."

Second page: "A Rainy Day."

In the margin: "Submitted late."

Third page: "Mother."

Half a page had been written. At the bottom, in red: "Incomplete."

Sudha Devi continued turning pages without pausing.

"Handwriting unclear."

“Write again.”

“Answer incomplete.”

“Do your work on time.”

She had seen sentences of her own like these thousands of times before. There was nothing unusual today.

But as she reached the end of the notebook, her hand stopped.

After the last written lesson there were two blank pages.

Then, on the page just before the back cover, something had been written in tiny pencil letters.

There was no title above it.

The first line read: “We should finish all our work.”

Sudha Devi pulled the notebook closer.

The second line: “Being late is a bad thing.”

The third: “Crying does not finish work.”

The fourth: “Someone who does not do the work always has many excuses.”

Sudha Devi put the red pen down on the desk.

That fourth sentence was hers.

Exactly as she said it.

She had said in class countless times, “Someone who does not do the work always has many excuses.”

How many times?

She could not count.

The writing continued down the page: “I write slowly.”

“I reach home late.”

“I feed my little brother, so my homework gets done late.”

“When Ma goes to the fields, I look after my brother.”

“When my brother cries, I have to stop studying.”

“I should learn to write faster.”

“I should not cry.”

“Madam says, be strong.”

Sudha Devi’s eyes stopped on that line.

Had she said, “Be strong”?

Yes.

Last month Pallavi had begun to cry in class.

Her notebook had not been submitted. Sudha Devi had asked the reason. Pallavi had remained silent.

Then Sudha Devi had said, “Why cry over such a small thing? Be strong. I want the notebook complete tomorrow.”

The sentence had seemed entirely proper to her that day.

Now, on the page, it had taken on another shape.

“Be strong.”

As though a child were issuing an order to herself.
Sudha Devi leaned back in her chair.
The sound of sweeping in the veranda had stopped.
Ramdulari must have gone to another room, she thought.
The school suddenly seemed very quiet.
She tried to remember Pallavi's face.
A thin body. Two plaits. The left plait usually loose.
She sat at the edge of the fourth bench.
Even when she knew an answer, she rarely raised her hand.
If someone asked for a pencil, she had the habit of breaking her own pencil in half and giving one piece away.
Had Sudha Devi noticed these things before?
She had seen them. But seeing and paying attention were not the same thing.
She read the page again.
Lower down, the pencil writing grew fainter.
"Ma says if I study, my life will become better."
"I want to study."
"Sometimes I feel sleepy."
"Feeling sleepy is not a bad thing, but then the homework remains unfinished."
"Unfinished is bad."
This time Sudha Devi's eyes went to her own red comment—"Incomplete."
On the third page of the notebook.
When she had written that single word, she had seen nothing particular in it.
Now it seemed as though the word had not been written on the notebook at all, but on the child's forehead.
Sudha Devi looked out of the window.
The sunlight on the peepal leaves was fading.
She remembered herself in Class Seven.
Her name then had been Sudha Kumari.
There were five brothers and sisters at home. She was the eldest daughter.
Her mother was ill for long stretches of time.
Before leaving for school in the morning, blowing the cooking fire, tying her little sister's hair, filling two glasses of water—these were all part of her share of the household.
She used to reach school late.
The old headmaster, Nandkishore Babu, would look at the clock and say, "Time is equal for everyone."

That sentence had remained inside Sudha Kumari for a long time like a thorn.

One day she had arrived late. Her mother's fever had not gone down all night.

She remembered being made to stand in the veranda.

The class continued inside.

She kept copying the lesson into her notebook outside.

That day she had taken a vow within herself: she would not be late.

And indeed she began to be late less often.

She learned to finish many things on time.

Her examination marks were good. She completed her training. She found a job.

People said, Sudha is disciplined.

She liked hearing it too.

Gradually discipline ceased to be merely one of her qualities. It became her identity.

She had never questioned that identity.

Outside the window two students ran past. Perhaps they had come back from the playground to fetch their ball.

One said to the other, "Hurry. Madam is still here."

Both lowered their voices.

Sudha Devi heard them.

She tried to smile faintly, but the smile did not fully form.

Pallavi's last page was still open.

At the very bottom was one small line: "I am not bad."

It had been crossed out in pencil.

Below the crossed-out line she had written again: "I will improve."

Sudha Devi stared for a long time at the sentence that had been struck through.

"I am not bad."

Crossed out.

"I will improve."

Left standing.

She picked up the red pen.

She wanted to write something.

"Good."

"Very good."

"You have written what you feel."

No sentence seemed right.

She put the pen down again.

Just then there was a voice at the door.

“Madam?”

Sudha Devi looked up.

Pallavi stood there.

In her hands was a small steel container.

“What is it?”

“Ma told me to give this to Ramdulari Kaki. She wasn’t at home. I thought she might be at school.”

“She is at the back. Give it to her.”

Pallavi turned to go.

Sudha Devi said, “Pallavi.”

She stopped.

“Your notebook is here.”

Pallavi’s face changed slightly. She looked at the desk.

“Yes, Madam.”

“What you wrote on the last page...”

Pallavi’s hands tightened around the steel container.

“That... I was practising.”

“Practising what?”

“Just... writing.”

Sudha Devi was silent for a few moments before answering.

“Your mother goes to the fields?”

“Yes.”

“Every day?”

“In the season. Right now there is paddy work.”

“How old is your little brother?”

“Four.”

“You look after him?”

“When Ma is late.”

“And then your homework?”

Pallavi gave a slight shrug.

“I do it at night.”

“You feel sleepy?”

Pallavi looked first at the notebook, then at Sudha Devi’s face.

She could not tell whether this question came before a scolding or instead of one.

“Sometimes.”

Sudha Devi felt like saying: divide your time properly.

Then she felt like saying: the work must be completed.

Both sentences came as far as her tongue, but neither came out.

She asked only, “Do you tell your brother stories?”

For the first time Pallavi’s eyes brightened a little.

"Yes. He listens to the same story again and again."

"Which one?"

"The Bird and the Pond."

"You made it up?"

"Yes."

"Have you written it down?"

"No."

Sudha Devi closed the last page of the notebook.

"Bring it written."

Pallavi immediately asked, "Tomorrow?"

That "tomorrow?" sounded like a request for a deadline.

Sudha Devi heard it.

"Whenever it is done."

Pallavi was silent.

"Even if it is unfinished, bring it."

This time Pallavi truly looked at her face.

"Even unfinished?"

"Yes."

"Yes, Madam."

She went towards the back carrying the container.

For a while Sudha Devi kept looking towards the doorway.

Then she opened the notebook again.

On the last page, "I am not bad" had been crossed out.

She took the red pen in her hand.

Once again she felt the urge to write something beside the crossed-out sentence.

This time too, she wrote nothing.

She placed the notebook on top of the checked pile.

On the way home, Sudha Devi stopped at the vegetable stall.

She bought okra, potatoes and coriander.

The shopkeeper said, "Madam, very late today?"

Sudha Devi looked at the time.

Half past five.

"Yes. I was checking notebooks."

When she reached home, her younger sister telephoned.

Her sister now lived in Purnea.

They spoke about two or three household matters.

Suddenly Sudha Devi asked, "Do you remember Nandkishore Babu?"

Her sister laughed. "The one who made you stand in the veranda for being late?"

Sudha Devi fell silent.

“How do you remember that?”

“You came home and cried so much. Ma said, ‘If the teacher scolds you, it is for your own good.’”

“I cried?”

“A lot.”

Sudha Devi still held the phone in her hand. Evening was descending outside the window.

She remembered that day, but she did not remember her own crying.

After a few moments she said, “All right, we’ll talk again,” and ended the call.

She went into the kitchen.

As she cut the okra, one line kept returning to her mind: “I am not bad.”

That night she opened her old trunk.

Inside were certificates, training papers, two of her mother’s old saris, and a few notebooks.

She had not looked at those notebooks for many years.

On one thin notebook was written: “Sudha Kumari, Class Seven.”

She did not smile.

She turned the pages.

The handwriting was not neat. Ink had spread in many places.

On one page was a teacher’s comment: “Submitted late. Learn discipline.”

Sudha Devi touched the sentence with a finger.

Below it, in her childhood handwriting, was half an essay.

Title: “My Mother.”

The essay stopped midway.

The page after it was blank.

Why she had never completed it, she could not remember.

Perhaps her mother had been ill.

Perhaps she had not had time.

Perhaps she simply had not felt like it.

All three were possible.

Sudha Devi did not close the notebook.

She left it open on the table.

The next day in class she was checking homework.

Pallavi held out her notebook.

Sudha Devi turned the pages in the usual way.

The work was half finished.

Earlier she would have written “Incomplete” in red.

Her pen went to the page.

She made a small tick.

Then she wrote in the margin: “Add the rest whenever it is done.”

She handed the notebook back.
Pallavi read the comment.
She said nothing.
The class continued.
Two days later Pallavi brought a separate sheet of paper.
At the top was the title: "The Bird and the Pond."
The story was not complete.
Its final sentence stopped in the middle: "Then the bird thought that..."
Sudha Devi read it.
"What comes next?"
Pallavi said, "I haven't thought of it yet."
Sudha Devi looked at her for a few moments.
Then she did not fold the sheet. She placed it straight inside the notebook.
"All right."
Pallavi went back to her seat.
The bell rang.
The children rose and ran outside.
Sudha Devi continued gathering the notebooks from the desk.
Pallavi's old notebook was still in her bag.
That evening, as she left the school, Sudha Devi looked at the time.
Ten past five.
She would be late reaching home.
She did not look at the clock again.
She came down from the veranda and walked slowly towards the gate.

The Dried Mango Branch

When Malati stepped into the courtyard, she looked first not at the house but at the mango tree. On the right-hand side, where a thick branch used to be, there was now the fresh round scar of a cut.

She stopped.

Prabhakar came out from inside. "You've arrived?"

Instead of answering, Malati looked up and asked, "You cut the branch?"

"Four days ago."

"Without telling me?"

Prabhakar paused a little. "It split halfway in the storm. One part fell on the tiled roof. I called Jitan and had it cut."

Malati's eyes went to the roof. Two tiles were new.

"The registry is tomorrow," Prabhakar added. "I thought this danger should be removed first."

Malati put her bag down in the veranda. Inside the house there was the smell of closed rooms, dust and old wood. Since their mother died, the house had rarely been opened.

The matter of selling the house had arisen gradually. At first Prabhakar would talk about repairing the roof, the electricity bill and the worry of an empty house; Malati would say on the phone, "See to it." In the end, Suresh Chaudhary from the village had shown interest in buying the house to open a small clinic.

Malati had signed the consent paper. At the time she had felt no objection. Standing in the courtyard today, it seemed to her that signing a paper and leaving a house were not the same thing.

Prabhakar brought two cups of tea. "There wasn't much sugar. I used what was in the house."

Malati took the cup. Their mother never made tea this weak. She wanted to say it, but did not.

"Where is the branch?"

"Behind the house, by the wall. Once the wood dries, Sharda Kaki will take it."

Malati did not get up at once. The steam from the cup slowly faded.

“You could have made one phone call.”

Prabhakar said, “The storm came at night. In the morning the roof began to leak. Jitan happened to be available that day. I thought this wasn’t a question of making a decision; it was a question of safety.”

Malati set the cup on the table. “For you, everything becomes a decision very quickly.”

Prabhakar did not answer.

Both understood that they were not speaking only about the branch.

“Look through the things inside first,” Prabhakar said. “Set aside whatever you want.”

There was no bed in their parents’ room. On his previous visit Prabhakar had given it to Ramsevak from the village. On the phone Malati had said then, “You did right.” Today, looking at the empty space, she felt that the bed should still have been there.

In the cupboard were two old blankets, some papers and their mother’s small iron box. Inside the box were buttons, needles, two old coins, a broken chain and a ball of red thread.

“Take this box,” Prabhakar said.

“You don’t want it?”

“What would I do with it?”

“Then what will I do with it?”

For a moment they both laughed. In the closed house, that small laugh sounded very clear.

In the next room were two bamboo stools. Malati said, “Don’t sell these two.”

“All right.”

“You take one.”

“Where will I keep it?”

“On your balcony.”

“There are already three chairs on my balcony.”

Malati ran her hand over the frayed cane weave of the stool. Their mother used to sit on it in the evening and cut vegetables. Memory wants to save an object immediately; the question of where the object will go comes later.

In an old trunk they found a photograph. Prabhakar was twelve in it, Malati seven or eight, and their father sat on a charpoy beneath the mango tree. A swing hung from one branch.

Malati brought the photograph close to her eyes. “The swing was on this same branch that was cut, wasn’t it?”

Prabhakar took the photograph. “No. It was on the left side.”

“I remember it.”

"The old kitchen is on this side in the photograph. By that reckoning, the swing was on the left."

Malati looked again. Prabhakar was right. The branch that had been cut was not the branch that held the swing.

She took the photograph back. "But Babu used to put the charpoy on this side."

Prabhakar said nothing.

Around noon Jitan arrived. He carried two roof tiles and a small hammer.

"I'll replace the tiles where the branch fell," he said.

Malati asked, "Had the branch gone very bad?"

Jitan looked up at the cut scar. "It was hollow inside. Once half of it split, it was difficult to leave it there."

"Could it have been cut earlier?"

Jitan did not laugh. "It is better to cut a dry branch in time. But I do it when the people of the house tell me."

Prabhakar continued untying an old rope in the veranda.

Malati asked, "Since when had Ma been saying it should be cut?"

Prabhakar's hands stopped. "For two years."

Malati remembered an old phone call. Ma had said, "One branch of the tree is drying. Prabhakar says we should have it cut." Malati had replied, "Let it stay for now. I'll come and see."

She had not been able to come.

"Then why didn't you cut it?"

"Ma said Malati would come and see."

"And after that?"

"After that something or other kept happening every time. You didn't come. Ma kept waiting. Even after she was gone, cutting it did not feel easy to me."

A part of the anger inside Malati suddenly changed direction.

"And four days ago it suddenly felt easy?"

Prabhakar looked at the roof. "The branch had broken halfway. By then there were fewer choices."

This time Malati did not answer.

Jitan replaced the tiles and left. When the sound of his hammer stopped, the house became quiet again.

Sharda Kaki from next door had sent lunch. A little later she herself came over too.

"The registry really is tomorrow?"

"Yes, Kaki," Prabhakar said.

Kaki's eyes went to the cut scar on the tree. "So the branch was finally cut."

Malati asked, "You remembered it too?"

“Until last monsoon your mother kept saying, ‘Let Malati come. She loves this tree very much.’”

Malati’s hand became still.

Sharda Kaki immediately moved on to talking about an old pickle jar, but her first sentence remained in the veranda.

After Kaki left, Malati said, “Ma kept it because of me.”

Prabhakar said, “Not because of you. She kept waiting for you.”

“What’s the difference?”

“A great deal.”

Malati was silent.

While gathering the plates, Prabhakar said, “Ma understood everything. Even so, she kept waiting.”

In Malati’s mind, phone calls from the last several years began to rise one after another—the leaking roof, the broken pump, the electricity bill, the leaning wall, the drying branch.

Every time she had said, “See to it.”

Prabhakar had kept seeing to it.

“Had you already been thinking of selling the house?” Malati asked.

“Six months after Ma died.”

“Why did you tell me only later?”

“At first I was only thinking about it myself.”

“It wasn’t a decision that belonged only to you.”

In a calm voice Prabhakar said, “If you want to keep the house, we can still stop.”

Malati grew uncomfortable. She could not keep the house. She found it difficult even to come twice a year; she did not want to manage repairs, taxes, security, the garden—anything. She only wanted the house to remain.

“That isn’t what I’m saying,” she said softly.

“I understand.”

There was no taunt in that “I understand.” That was why it hurt Malati more.

After lunch Malati went alone behind the house. Pieces of the cut branch lay by the wall. The wood inside the thicker sections was brown and hollow.

She picked up a thin piece.

The wood was lighter than she had expected.

She remembered how, in childhood, Babu used to keep dry mango twigs separate for the kitchen fire. He did not like cutting green branches.

She could not be certain whether the memory was truly this clear or whether her mind was making it so now.

Memory is not always clear like a photograph. Sometimes it fills in the empty places by itself.

Malati walked a little way holding the piece of wood. Then she put it back beside the wall.

In the evening the belongings were divided. Malati kept their mother's iron box. Of the two stools, one was left for Sharda Kaki and Prabhakar agreed to put the other in his car.

Prabhakar set aside Babu's thick sweater.

Malati said, "It won't fit you."

"It isn't for wearing."

Malati asked nothing. She put the photograph in her purse.

That night they spread bedding in the veranda and slept there. In the darkness, the gap left by the cut branch could not be seen clearly.

After a while Malati asked, "Does selling the house make you feel bad?"

Prabhakar answered after a long pause. "Yes."

"Then why such a hurry?"

"Seeing the empty house makes me feel worse."

Malati was silent.

Prabhakar said, "Whenever I came, I would first open the front door, then all the rooms. In the evening I would close everything again. Sometimes it felt as though I wasn't opening the house; I was only checking that no one was there."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"What would I have said?"

After a while Prabhakar himself added, "Weariness and attachment can live together."

Malati did not answer.

All night the wind moved through the leaves of the mango tree. Inside the house, the tied bundles lay still.

In the morning Suresh Chaudhary arrived early with the file.

Sitting in the veranda and looking through the papers, he said, "The front room will become the waiting room. The two inner rooms will be for examination. We'll leave the old wall cupboard as it is."

Prabhakar asked, "And the courtyard?"

"It will remain open. Patients can sit outside. We won't cover the earth with cement."

Malati watched him without saying anything.

Suresh Babu began talking about old memories of the house—how as a child he had sat in this very veranda with their father, how he had once come during examinations to drink water, how their mother had once given him pickle.

Malati knew barely half of these things.

It occurred to her that the memory of a house does not belong only to the family. Many people carry away their own small portion of it.

Before leaving for the registry, Malati looked once more through every room—their mother's room, the kitchen, the veranda, the courtyard.

At the end she ran her hand over the inner bolt of the door. In childhood, the bolt had been beyond her reach.

Prabhakar stood at the gate. "Shall we go?"

"Yes."

Malati opened her purse and checked—the photograph, their mother's iron box, her papers. Everything was there.

Prabhakar closed the door of the house and turned the old brass key. The lock gave a single metallic click.

Malati asked, "The key?"

"After the registry, I'll give it to Suresh Babu."

For a few moments the key shone in Prabhakar's palm, then disappeared into his pocket.

The two of them stepped out through the gate.

As they walked along the road, Malati placed a hand on her purse. The hard edge of the iron box pressed against her fingers.

She did not look back.

The Unemployed Afternoon

Aniruddh never reached the crossroads before one in the afternoon. If he arrived after one, it seemed to him that he was not going there to sit at the tea stall at all; he was out on some necessary errand and had merely stopped for five or ten minutes along the way.

Those five or ten minutes usually lasted three hours.

Lakhan's tea stall stood exactly at the corner where the road to the bus stand, the lane into the market, and the road to the block office branched off in three directions. It had a tin roof, two bamboo posts in front, a coal stove inside, and biscuits in old glass jars. Three long benches stood outside.

Aniruddh usually sat at the right end of the middle bench. From there he could see the road clearly, while from the road his face remained half-hidden behind one of the posts.

Whether he had chosen that place deliberately, even he did not know.

He was twenty-eight. He had completed a postgraduate degree. Twice he had taken the teacher eligibility examination, once a bank examination, three railway examinations, once the secretariat assistant examination, and many other recruitment tests large and small. In some he had cleared the written stage, in some he had missed by two or four marks, and the results of some were still pending.

His shoulder bag always contained two or three admit cards, photocopies of certificates, a black pen, and a folded newspaper. Because of the bag, anyone seeing him assumed that he was on his way somewhere.

When he left home, his mother would ask, "Where are you going?"

"To see if there is any news about forms."

Sometimes he said, "I have some work at the cyber café."

Sometimes only, "As far as the crossroads."

His mother no longer asked many questions. Aniruddh should have felt relieved that her questions had become fewer, but instead her silence made him more uncomfortable.

Babuji ran a small grocery shop in front of the house. Earlier he had farmed too; after the pain in his knees worsened, he had given the fields out on sharecropping. No one in the house kept an account of what had been spent on

Aniruddh's education. But inside Aniruddh, that account was always being made and remade.

Babuji never said, "Sit at the shop."

For that very reason, sitting at the shop was even more difficult for Aniruddh.

The moment Lakhan saw him, he would put tea on.

"Less sugar?"

"Yes."

Aniruddh even liked that small question. At least here he had one definite preference.

People at the stall changed through the afternoon. Bus drivers, the clerk from the fertiliser shop, an employee from the panchayat office, a farmer wandering through the market, a rickshaw-puller, sometimes two college boys. Everyone came, drank tea, and went off in their own direction.

Only Aniruddh usually remained where he was.

He opened the newspaper and read recruitment advertisements. Then he read advertisements he had already read. Salary, age limit, last date to apply—he knew almost all of it by heart. Sometimes he opened old question papers on his phone, solved two questions, then began looking at the road.

There was no clock on the wall of the stall. Even so, he knew the time. At two the small school bus passed. At half past two the milkman returned on his motorcycle with empty cans hanging from it. At three the first employees from the block office began to appear at the crossroads.

Aniruddh would get up before four. As soon as he reached home, his mother would ask if he wanted tea, and he would say, "I've already had some."

One day his mother said softly, "Tea outside every day is not good for the stomach."

Aniruddh understood that she was not speaking about tea.

"I only drink one cup."

"I wasn't asking how many cups you drink."

His mother continued sorting rice. Aniruddh said nothing.

That day, for the second time, his bag felt heavier than usual.

The next afternoon he was again at Lakhan's stall.

It was September heat. The rainy season was almost over, though muddy water still stood in some of the potholes in the road. The air was damp. Lakhan's ten-year-old daughter, Nidhi, returned early from school. Her teacher had not come, so school had closed at midday.

Nidhi put her schoolbag in the back room of the stall and came straight to sit at the counter.

"Babu, give me a notebook."

"There's one in your bag."

“Not that shop notebook. A new one.”

Lakhan pulled out a thin five-rupee notebook from beneath the biscuit jars.

“What will you write?”

“Homework.”

Sticking the tip of her tongue out, she began writing the heading on the first page: “The People Around Me and Their Work.”

Lakhan laughed as he put milk on the stove. “Write about me first.”

Nidhi wrote: “My Babu makes tea.”

“Only tea?” Lakhan called from behind her. “I sell biscuits too.”

Nidhi added, “and sells biscuits.”

Just then Raghu came for tea. The moment Nidhi saw him, she asked, “Raghu Kaka, what do you do?”

“I cut your Babu’s ears.”

Nidhi burst out laughing.

“Tell me properly.”

“I shave beards and cut hair.”

Nidhi wrote it down. Then she looked across the road at Munna, the tempo driver, and wrote his name too.

Aniruddh had the newspaper open, but he was not reading a single line. He liked Nidhi’s exercise. In a child’s notebook the world was very clear—one person, one occupation.

Suddenly Nidhi turned towards him.

“Aniruddh Bhaiya, what do you do?”

The question was so simple that at first Aniruddh could not understand why no answer came out.

He folded the newspaper.

“Me?”

“Yes. I have to write five people. I’ve got four. You’re the fifth.”

Raghu had already walked away drinking his tea. Munna had started his tempo. Lakhan had turned back towards the stove to watch the milk. No one was looking at Aniruddh.

Even so, it seemed to him that every sound in the stall had suddenly grown quieter.

“I study,” he said.

Nidhi stopped her pen. “Which class?”

This time Lakhan turned around and looked at his daughter as though to scold her.

“Don’t ask so many questions.”

“It’s homework,” Nidhi said naturally.

Aniruddh tried to laugh. “Not a class. I study for job examinations.”

Nidhi began to write in the notebook, then stopped.

"Then what should I write for work?"

This time Aniruddh gave no answer.

Lakhan said quickly, "Write—he studies."

"But Madam said to write the work people do."

Lakhan banged the lid of the pot down harder than necessary. "Go take the tea inside first."

Nidhi closed the notebook and went into the back room.

For some time Aniruddh kept rubbing his thumb over one place on the newspaper. There was an advertisement there: "Vacancies: 48." The paper grew pale where his thumb rubbed it.

Lakhan placed the tea in front of him.

"She's a child," he said.

Aniruddh picked up the cup. "Yes."

"Don't take it to heart."

"What would I take to heart?"

Lakhan said nothing.

The tea had less sugar that day too, but Aniruddh could not taste it.

At a quarter past two he got up. Lakhan was surprised.

"So early today?"

"There is some work at home."

The moment he said it, the sentence sounded strange even to Aniruddh.

When he reached home, Babuji was sitting inside the shop with an old ledger open. One arm of his spectacles was tied with thread. He was adding up the accounts for oil, soap, dal and biscuits.

"Back already?"

"Yes."

Babuji bent over the ledger again.

Aniruddh started to go inside, then stopped.

"Shall I add up these accounts?"

Babuji looked up. The question appeared on his face as though Aniruddh had spoken in some distant language.

"You study."

"I will study. Give it to me."

"What if you make a mistake?"

Something pricked inside Aniruddh, but he understood that Babuji was joking.

"Then I'll strike it out and write it again."

Babuji pushed the ledger towards him.

The work could have taken five minutes. Aniruddh spent fifteen. Not because addition and subtraction were difficult, but because behind every

number he could see the thing it represented—three kilos of sugar, seven bars of soap, two packets of salt. Everything had been sold. Everything had some use.

“That’s all?”

“That’s all,” Babuji said. “No need to interrupt your studies for so little.”

Aniruddh closed the ledger.

“When did the studying stop?”

He said it so softly that he did not know whether Babuji heard.

That night Aniruddh sat at his study table for a long time. The book was open, but Nidhi’s notebook kept returning to his mind: “The People Around Me and Their Work.”

In his mind he wrote many words after his own name—student, candidate, unemployed, competitive-exam aspirant, waiting.

No word seemed to contain him completely.

“Unemployed” was the word that frightened him most.

It seemed to him that the word crossed out every examination he had taken, every night he had studied, the money the family had spent, his mother’s silence, Babuji’s ledger—and made one empty box out of all of it.

But that night, for the first time, he also understood how many names he had given his afternoons in order to avoid that word—cyber café, forms, news, preparation, just going as far as the crossroads.

In truth, most afternoons were only afternoons.

The next day at one, his mother asked, “Where are you going?”

Aniruddh stopped with the bag on his shoulder.

The first words on his tongue were, “To look for forms.”

He did not say them.

“I’m going to sit at Lakhan’s stall. Then at two I’ll go to the library.”

His mother looked at him. There was neither relief nor worry on her face, only ordinary acceptance.

“Bring half a kilo of mustard oil on your way back.”

“All right.”

Aniruddh went out. He was surprised that this was all there was to it.

Nidhi was sitting at the stall again. The notebook lay open.

“Bhaiya, yesterday’s fifth person is still left.”

Aniruddh sat down on the bench.

“Still?”

“You didn’t give an answer.”

Lakhan said from between them, “Write somebody else’s name.”

Nidhi shook her head. “Madam said people around us.”

Aniruddh pulled the notebook towards himself. Four lines were written there—Babu makes tea, Raghu Kaka cuts hair, Munna Kaka drives a tempo, Sarita Didi stitches clothes. The fifth line was blank.

He picked up Nidhi's pen.

For a few moments he looked at the empty line.

Then he wrote: "Aniruddh Bhaiya is looking for a job at present."

Nidhi read it.

"Is that work too?"

Aniruddh rolled the pen between his fingers.

"I don't know."

Nidhi looked at him, then pulled the notebook back towards herself.

"Then Madam will cross it out."

"Let her."

Nidhi laughed. "Then we'll write it again."

Aniruddh laughed too.

Lakhan set down his tea. "Less sugar."

"Yes."

The two o'clock school bus could be seen approaching from a distance. Aniruddh did not drink his tea in a hurry.

He was supposed to go to the library, but even after the bus had passed he remained seated for another minute or two.

Then he lifted his bag.

"Don't forget the oil," he said aloud to himself.

Lakhan asked, "What?"

"Nothing."

He began crossing the road. A motorcycle passed in the middle, so he had to stop. The sun was still harsh. He still had no job. The result of his next examination had still not come.

Behind him Nidhi was writing something in her notebook. Aniruddh did not turn to see whether she had left his fifth line exactly as it was for her teacher, or changed it.

He crossed the road and took the path towards the library.

No Call Came

On Sunday morning, Gopal Babu made tea a little earlier than usual. At seven forty-five he turned off the gas, covered the cup, and placed his mobile on the window ledge, where two bars of network usually remained steady.

His son Neeraj usually called at around eight thirty. Sometimes at eight twenty, sometimes at eight forty, but on Sunday morning the call would come—over the past three years, Gopal Babu's week had settled into a rhythm around that certainty.

Neeraj lived in Bengaluru. His wife and two-year-old daughter were there with him. Gopal Babu lived alone in his old house in Madhubani. His wife Shailaja had died four years earlier. From that year onward, Neeraj had made the Sunday call regular. At first he used to call twice a day; then work increased, the child was born, the family moved house, the office was farther away. In the end, one long conversation on Sunday morning became fixed.

Gopal Babu was satisfied with this arrangement. At least that was what he always told himself.

At eight twenty he swept the veranda. At eight twenty-five he watered the tulsi. At eight twenty-eight he reheated the tea. At eight thirty he sat down in the chair.

The mobile remained silent.

He looked at the screen. Battery: eighty-eight percent. Network: two bars. Volume: full.

At eight forty Gopal Babu lifted his cup. The tea had gone slightly cold.

"He must be tied up with work," he said softly.

No one needed to answer, but saying the sentence made him feel better.

At five past nine, Sonu, Ramvilas's grandson from next door, came to the gate.

"Dada, can I borrow the spade?"

"Why?"

"I have to clear the drain behind the house."

Gopal Babu glanced towards the inner room where the mobile lay on the window ledge.

"Take it. But if the phone rings, will you hear it?"

Sonu laughed. "Your phone?"

"Yes."

"I'll be digging the drain. How will I hear it?"

Gopal Babu laughed too. "All right. Take it."

Sonu went away with the spade. The gate closed. The house became silent again.

At nine fifteen Gopal Babu opened Neeraj's name on the screen. The green phone symbol was just below it. His finger reached towards it, then stopped.

Last Sunday Neeraj had said, "Babu, this week is a little difficult. There is a new presentation."

"Then I won't call now," Gopal Babu said to himself. "He'll call on his own."

By ten there had still been no call.

He ate breakfast. Opened the newspaper. Read the first page and moved to the second, but read the same report three times. Then he folded the newspaper.

The day went on. At noon an unknown number called. Gopal Babu's heart quickened for a moment. He answered. It was a recorded voice from an insurance company. He cut the call.

In the afternoon he put the mobile in his pocket and went up to the roof. The drain needed cleaning before the rains. He had been thinking about it for two months. Some dry leaves had collected there. He reached out to remove them, then felt as if the mobile had vibrated in his pocket. He took it out and looked. No call.

He cleaned half the drain and came downstairs.

By evening Neeraj still had not called.

That night Gopal Babu considered calling him himself. At seven fifty-five he took the mobile in his hand. Then thought—the child might be sleeping. At eight ten he thought—they might be having dinner. At nine he thought—if I call now, Neeraj will understand that I have spent the whole day doing nothing but waiting.

That last thought made him slightly uncomfortable.

"I haven't spent the whole day only waiting," he said to himself.

Then he began counting the day's tasks—sweeping, watering the tulsi, breakfast, the newspaper, half the roof drain. The list was short.

On Monday morning no call came.

Gopal Babu rose at five. If Neeraj missed Sunday, he sometimes called on Monday morning. Because of that possibility, Gopal Babu kept the mobile in the kitchen while making tea.

Nothing by six thirty.

He took out his shopping bag. On the list were oil, salt, matches and soap. At the gate he looked at the mobile. One bar of network. He went back inside, put the phone on charge, and sat down without going to the market.

Half an hour later he became angry with himself.

"The phone can keep charging. What am I supposed to do?"

He picked up the bag and went to the market.

There he met Banwari Sah.

"Gopal Babu, will you take a mango sapling? The nursery man has come."

"Not now."

"You said 'not now' last year too."

Gopal Babu smiled. "There is an old tree at home."

"How much fruit does the old tree give?"

"Two or four."

"Then plant a new one."

Gopal Babu did not answer. He bought the oil and salt and returned home.

There were no missed calls on the mobile.

On Monday afternoon, for the first time, he considered calling Neeraj's wife, Anamika. Then the thought made him even more uneasy. If Neeraj was busy, why worry Anamika? And if something had happened, surely they themselves would call.

"Why should anything have happened?" he said aloud.

The house clock went on ticking.

On Tuesday, Sonu came to return the spade. The wooden handle had split slightly in the middle.

"Dada, I didn't break it," Sonu said quickly.

Gopal Babu examined the handle. "It was old."

"Shall I have a new handle fitted?"

"Leave it."

Sonu paused. "Did you finish cleaning the drain yesterday?"

Gopal Babu looked up.

"No."

"If it rains, the water will collect on the roof again."

"Yes."

Sonu left. Gopal Babu placed the spade in the veranda. For some time he ran his fingers over the split in the handle.

Then he placed the mobile on the window ledge and climbed to the roof.

He cleared out the leaves gathered in the drain. Scraped away the moss. At one place a brick joint had loosened, so he opened an old small bag of cement and mixed mortar. Nearly an hour and a half passed as he worked. Twice he thought he heard the phone ringing below, but he did not go down.

When he finally came downstairs and checked the mobile, there had been no call.

The surprising thing was that this time he did not feel greatly disappointed. His body was tired, cement dust clung to his hands, and on the roof the path for the rainwater now lay visibly clear.

That afternoon he went to the carpenter to get a new handle fitted to the spade. On the way he saw Banwari Sah with the nursery man again.

"If not mango, will you take guava?" Banwari asked.

Gopal Babu stopped.

"How much for the guava?"

"Eighty."

"Too much."

"Give seventy."

Gopal Babu looked at the sapling. Two new leaves had emerged.

"Sixty."

"Take it."

He did not put the sapling in the bag. He carried it home in his hand.

Behind the house was an empty corner from Shailaja's time where coriander and green chillies had once grown. After Shailaja died, weeds had slowly filled the patch. Gopal Babu worked the soil with a hand hoe, cleared the grass, and planted the small guava tree.

As he poured water around it, he remembered something Shailaja used to say: "If you plant a tree, you create the work of looking after it."

At that moment the mobile rang inside the house.

Gopal Babu straightened at once.

The sound was clear. Once. Twice. Three times.

He put the hand hoe down on the ground and started towards the house. Then he noticed that only half the water around the sapling's roots had been poured. There was still some water left in the bucket.

He stopped. Poured the remaining water around the roots. Set the bucket upright. Washed the soil from his hands at the tap. By then the phone had fallen silent.

When he went inside and looked at the screen, there were three missed calls from Neeraj.

Relief and a small flare of anger rose in his chest at the same time. He had waited three days, and now, when Neeraj finally called, he had not answered.

He did not call back at once. First he dried his hands with a towel. Cleaned his spectacles. Sat down in the chair. Then he dialled.

Neeraj answered on the first ring.

"Babu! Where were you?"

Gopal Babu paused a moment before replying.

"I was behind the house."

"Why didn't you answer? I called three times—"

"There was soil on my hands."

There was a brief silence at the other end.

"Are you all right?"

"I'm all right."

"I feel terrible. On Sunday I was out with the office people. I left my phone at the hotel. I got it back last night. All the numbers were in the cloud, but the password—"

Neeraj began explaining in detail. Gopal Babu listened. All the possibilities he had built over three days—meeting, illness, accident, forgetfulness, neglect—collapsed into one ordinary mistake.

"All right," he said.

"Are you angry?"

"No."

"Really?"

"What is there to be angry about?"

Neeraj was silent again. "You must have waited on Sunday."

Gopal Babu looked through the window towards the back of the house. The guava sapling stood slightly crooked.

"For a while," he said.

"I never imagined the phone would get left at the hotel."

"These things happen."

"You could have called me."

Gopal Babu smiled at the sentence, though Neeraj could not see him.

"Yes. I could have."

Neeraj put the little girl on the phone. She said something indistinct. Gopal Babu asked "What?" two or three times, then laughed without understanding. Anamika came on the line too. Altogether they spoke for about eleven minutes.

After the call ended, Gopal Babu looked at the screen for a while. He was happy. Relieved too. But mixed into the relief was a little embarrassment at the waiting of the previous three days.

He went outside. Beside the guava sapling he drove a thin bamboo stake into the ground and tied the plant to it loosely with a strip of cloth.

On Wednesday morning he went to Banwari Sah's shop and looked at two lemon saplings. He did not buy them.

On Thursday he finished repairing the loose brick joint on the roof.

On Friday Sonu came, and Gopal Babu showed him the spade with its new handle. Sonu lifted it and said, "This time I won't borrow it."

"Why?"

“If it breaks again, the blame will fall on me.”

They both laughed.

On Saturday, while cleaning the cupboard, Gopal Babu found an old diary. Shailaja had used it to keep household accounts. The pages listed rice, oil, milk, medicines and things for worship, but every now and then there was a separate line: “Sowed fenugreek,” “Cleaned the roof,” “Neeraj’s letter arrived,” “Gopal’s cough is better.”

Gopal Babu did not close the diary. He left it on the table.

Sunday came again.

At seven forty-five in the morning he made tea, but did not place the mobile on the window ledge. The phone, charged overnight, remained on the table.

At eight he went behind the house. Dust had settled on two leaves of the guava sapling. He watered it. A little grass had come up in the empty patch; he pulled it out.

At eight twenty-seven the phone rang inside the house. Gopal Babu heard it. At that moment he was shaping a small circular ridge of earth around the guava sapling. The ridge was half finished. The phone rang again.

He stopped his hands, looked towards the house, then scooped up the last two handfuls of soil and finished the ridge. He washed his hands at the tap. The phone was ringing for the third time when he reached the veranda. He answered.

“Yes, Neeraj.”

“Babu, what were you doing?”

Gopal Babu looked out through the window. The guava sapling shone with the morning water.

“I had some work to do,” he said. “Now tell me.”

A Small Award

Shashikant Mishra received the news of the award over the phone while he was sitting in the veranda, cutting an old newspaper into small slips.

The secretary of the City Literary Council said, "Mishraji, this year the Council has decided to confer its annual literary honour on you."

At first Shashikant Babu said, "What?" He thought the network had broken.

The secretary repeated, "The honour. This Sunday. At Town Hall. Five o'clock."

"Me?"

"Yes, you. For your long contribution to literature."

Shashikant Babu remained silent for a few moments. In front of him was the rusted iron lattice of the veranda, and in one corner a spider was spinning a new web.

"All right," he said at last.

After the call ended, it occurred to him that on receiving such news people usually telephoned someone. He kept the mobile in his hand. His daughter Neelima was in Delhi. His son Vivek was in Pune. Both numbers were on the screen.

He called Neelima first. She did not answer immediately.

Vivek was in a meeting; he sent a short message: "Babu, I'll call later."

Shashikant Babu placed the mobile on the table. The newspaper slips he had cut were blown to the floor by the breeze. He bent and gathered them all.

About twenty minutes later Neelima called.

"Babu, is everything all right?"

"Everything is fine. The Council is giving me an honour this year."

The other end of the line brightened at once. "Really! That's wonderful. Finally."

The word "finally" stayed in Shashikant Babu's ears a little longer than the others.

"What date?"

"Sunday."

“I won’t be able to come, Babu. The child’s examinations are on. But have someone make a video. Wear a good kurta.”

Shashikant Babu laughed. “I still know how to wear a kurta.”

Neelima laughed too. Then she asked, “What will they give with the award?”

“I don’t know.”

“Prize money?”

“I didn’t ask that either.”

Neelima seemed about to say something more, but a child’s voice came from behind her. “Babu, I’ll call again in the evening.”

She did not call in the evening. Shashikant Babu did not remind her either.

That night he opened the cupboard and looked through his kurtas. There was a white khadi kurta whose collar had yellowed slightly. There was also a pale sky-blue kurta Neelima had given him on his last birthday. Its fold lines were still straight.

He took out the sky-blue kurta and hung it over the back of a chair.

Then, from the upper shelf of the cupboard, he took out his three books of poetry. The first, “The Last Line of Sunlight,” 1998. The second, “The Voice from Across the River,” 2007. The third, “The Remaining Light,” 2016.

After the third book was published, he had written very little.

It was not that words no longer came. They did come, but before they could settle on paper, they turned into some other task—electricity bills, medicines, the bank, roof repairs, someone’s wedding, someone’s death, someone’s phone call.

When his wife Meera was alive, she would ask after dinner, “Did you write anything today?”

Shashikant Babu would often say, “I’ve written it in my mind.”

Meera would laugh and say, “Books written in the mind aren’t sold in the market.”

It had been five years since Meera died.

On the night he received the news of the award, Shashikant Babu opened his old diary after a long time. The last written date was a year and a half old. There were four lines, a word crossed out after the third, and then blank pages.

He picked up a pen.

For a while he looked at the page.

Then he closed the diary.

Over the next two days calls kept coming. The Council secretary told him the order of the programme. A local journalist asked for a photograph. An acquaintance from the library said, “You should have received this long ago.”

Shashikant Babu kept saying, “Yes,” “Thank you,” “You are kind.”

On Saturday, while shaving, he looked more carefully than usual at his face in the mirror. The front of his hair had turned completely white. There were faint pouches beneath his eyes.

Suddenly he wondered whether the announcement would describe him as a “senior poet” or an “elderly poet.”

He did not like the word “elderly.”

On Sunday he was ready by four. Sky-blue kurta, grey pyjamas, black jacket. He also wore the old watch Meera had bought, the one he did not wear every day.

Pramod from next door took him to Town Hall on his motorcycle.

“Call me when you are returning,” Pramod said. “I’ll come and get you.”

“I don’t know how long the programme will last.”

“Just call.”

Two strips of coloured cloth were tied outside Town Hall. Inside there were about seventy chairs. Five chairs stood on the stage, a bouquet in the middle, and the name of the Council and title of the programme on the curtain behind.

Shashikant Babu’s name was spelled correctly on the poster. This gave him an unnecessary sense of relief.

The secretary came hurrying over and took his hand. “You’ve come! Come, sit in front.”

Three people were already seated in the front row: a retired headmaster, a local businessman who was the chief guest, and a young professor whom Shashikant Babu recognized by face but not by name.

All three rose and greeted him.

The young professor said, “I studied your poetry in college.”

Shashikant Babu’s face brightened. “Which poem?”

The professor hesitated. “That one... about the river. Very good.”

“The Voice from Across the River?”

“Yes, yes, that one.”

Someone immediately called him away to look after the stage arrangements. The conversation ended there.

The programme began at twenty past five. A ceremonial lamp was lit. There was a welcome song. In his speech, the Council president called Shashikant Babu “a poet rooted in the fragrance of Mithila’s soil.” The secretary read his literary introduction—year of birth, education, government service, three poetry collections, publication in many journals and magazines.

Shashikant Babu listened attentively. The introduction was accurate.

But while listening, he had a strange sensation—as though the person sitting on the stage was not himself but a short paragraph written about him.

The chief guest said, “Such senior writers are the heritage of society.”

Everyone applauded at the word “heritage.”

Shashikant Babu smiled too.

The young professor gave a five-minute address. He spoke about modern Maithili poetry, folk memory, regional sensibility, and the responsibility of the new generation. He tried to quote two lines from one of Shashikant Babu’s poems, but altered the words slightly.

In his mind Shashikant Babu immediately repeated the correct lines. Outwardly he said nothing.

Then a shawl was draped over him. He was given a memento. An envelope. A flower garland. Photographs.

The photographer said, “Sir, lift the certificate a little higher.”

He lifted it.

“Smile.”

He smiled.

“Now look towards the chief guest.”

He looked.

There was applause again.

He was given five minutes for a vote of thanks. He had brought no written speech. First he thanked the Council, then recalled the first time one of his poems had been published, and then, without naming Meera, said that a writer does not write alone; many people in the household carry the weight of the sentences he never speaks.

His voice grew slightly heavy at that sentence. He changed the subject at once.

“An honour is not the end of writing, perhaps only a small halt somewhere in the middle,” he said.

The moment he said it, he felt a little embarrassed. To speak of a “halt in the middle,” where exactly was his writing now?

By the time the programme ended it was seven. People became occupied with tea, samosas and photographs. Someone posted a photograph of the certificate on Facebook. Someone else took a selfie with him.

An elderly reader came up and said, “You won’t recognize me, but I bought your first book.”

Shashikant Babu became interested. “Do you still have it?”

“A lot of books were lost when we moved house. Probably not.”

They both laughed a little.

The envelope contained five thousand one hundred rupees. Shashikant Babu did not count it; the secretary told him the amount himself.

By seven twenty the chairs had begun to empty. The organizers grew busy with arrangements for the meal that followed. He telephoned Pramod.

Pramod answered, but said that his child had a high fever and he was on his way to the hospital.

“Take an auto,” Pramod said.

“All right. Look after the child.”

There were two autos outside Town Hall, but both were full. He waited for a third. Ten minutes. Fifteen.

Evening had settled on the road. Shashikant Babu thought his house was only about two kilometres away; he could walk slowly.

The shawl, memento and certificate bag were in one hand. He had no walking stick in the other—he had not brought one.

He began walking.

The lights of Town Hall fell behind. Shops were still open along the main road, but after one turn the road became sparse.

Shashikant Babu walked slowly. The hard folder of the certificate kept striking his arm. The garland was sticking slightly out of the bag.

At one place he stopped and pushed the garland completely inside.

The words from the programme began returning to him—“heritage,” “senior,” “long contribution,” “fragrance of the soil.”

They were all good words. None of them was wrong.

Even so, he felt that together they had made a clean glass box around him. Inside it his old books were safely kept; outside, the present evening was going on.

He smiled at himself. “Why does a man begin thinking so complicatedly after receiving an award?”

A small tea cart at the roadside was still open. He stopped.

The teenage boy at the cart did not recognize him. “Tea?”

“Yes, less sugar.”

He sat on a small plastic stool. He placed the bag beside him.

A girl was with the boy, perhaps his sister, writing something in a notebook while still wearing her school uniform.

The girl's eyes fell on the flower garland visible from the bag. “Are you returning from someone's wedding?” she asked naturally.

Shashikant Babu laughed. “No.”

“Then?”

The boy scolded his sister. “Why do you ask everything?”

Shashikant Babu said, “I received an honour.”

The girl stopped writing. “For what work?”

“I used to write poetry.”

The girl asked again, “Used to? You don't write now?”

The question was so ordinary that Shashikant Babu did not answer immediately.

The boy set the tea before him. "Here."

Shashikant Babu held the cup. The warmth touched his fingers.

The girl bent over her notebook again. For her, the question had probably ended.

For Shashikant Babu, it had not.

"Even now... sometimes," he said after a delay.

The girl looked up. "Our teacher says rhyme isn't necessary for writing poetry."

"It isn't."

"Then how is poetry different from prose?"

Shashikant Babu remained holding the cup. On the stage his life had been introduced in a speech; here an unknown child had asked him a question that could not be answered in five minutes.

"That's a good question," he said. "I'll think about it and tell you."

The girl laughed. "I'll go to school tomorrow."

"Then I'll have to tell you now."

He thought for a moment. "Prose is like a road—you keep walking, and it takes you somewhere. Poetry... sometimes it isn't a road, but a way of standing in one place and looking."

After saying it, he was not entirely satisfied with the sentence.

The girl said, "Like a photograph?"

"No, not a photograph."

"Then?"

Shashikant Babu laughed. "See, I'm still thinking."

The boy laughed too.

After finishing his tea, he stood up. While paying, the girl asked, "Your name?"

"Shashikant Mishra."

"I'll search."

"Where?"

"On the phone."

Shashikant Babu picked up his bag. "I don't know how much of my poetry is on the phone."

"What if I don't find it?"

"Then you won't."

He started walking. After ten steps, the girl called from behind, "What you write now—where will that be published?"

Shashikant Babu turned.

He did not know the answer.

"Let me write it first," he said.

The road towards home was almost empty now. Between the electric poles there were patches of darkness.

As he walked, Shashikant Babu suddenly wanted to remember the sentence from the ceremony he had liked most.

The president's speech? The young professor's remarks? The chief guest's "heritage"?

None of them.

Again a small question sounded in his ears—"Used to? You don't write now?"

It pricked a little, and pleased him a little too.

When he reached home, he first removed the shawl. He placed the memento on the table. He propped the certificate against the wall; he did not feel like hammering in a nail.

Then he changed out of the sky-blue kurta and put on an old one.

There was leftover rice in the kitchen. Before reheating it, he came and sat in the veranda.

The diary lay on the table—the same one whose last date was a year and a half old.

He opened it. Four lines, a crossed-out word, a blank page.

He picked up the pen.

He wrote one sentence, then crossed it out. He wrote another, then crossed out half of it.

He stopped.

The award envelope lay at the other corner of the table. Five thousand one hundred rupees. The shawl was on the chair. His name shone on the memento.

Shashikant Babu looked at all of it once, then turned back to the diary.

This time he did not try to complete a poem. He simply wrote the date at the top of the page.

Below the date he wrote: "Today a child asked—don't you write now?"

He read the sentence.

Then beneath it, after a very long time, he wrote a new line.

He did not think the line was entirely good.

He did not cross it out.

The New Neighbours

Saraswati Devi first learned that new neighbours were moving in not from the sound of a truck, but from the creak of the iron gate.

The house next door had been closed for five years. The owner's family had moved to Patna, and the small two-room house had remained silent with the rain, the sun and the dust.

Every morning Saraswati Devi sat in a bamboo chair on her veranda and drank tea. The gate of the neighbouring house was to her right.

That day the gate opened three times, closed twice, and then remained open.

A small goods vehicle drove in.

First came down the frame of a bed, then two plastic chairs, a gas stove, five cardboard boxes, a small bookcase and three flowerpots.

Saraswati Devi continued drinking her tea.

She was not looking for the sake of looking, yet everything was visible.

A young man was telling the driver, "Put this box in the inner room."

A young woman stood at the doorway reading the words written on the boxes—Kitchen, Books, Clothes.

The woman's hair was tied up, and every now and then she tucked a loose strand behind her ear.

Saraswati Devi's first thought was: how could anyone set up a home with so few things?

In her own house there were two old trunks, four cots, three cupboards, and who knew how many small and large things that had not been used for years.

Even so, all those things were part of the house.

By afternoon the goods vehicle had left.

In the evening the young man met her at the gate.

"Namaste, Kaki," he said.

Saraswati Devi was slightly startled.

"Live long," she replied.

"I'm Abhinav. This is my wife, Neelima. I work at the bank. I've been newly posted here."

Neelima stood two steps behind. She too greeted Saraswati Devi.

Saraswati Devi asked, "For how long?"

Abhinav laughed. "The bank knows that."

There was a lightness in the answer that Saraswati Devi did not like.

How could some other institution know how long a home was for?

She said only, "All right."

The next morning, at ten past seven, a scooter started.

The sound was not very loud, but after five years of silence it seemed very loud to Saraswati Devi.

She looked at the clock. Seven ten.

The scooter went out through the gate. Abhinav was driving; Neelima sat behind him.

At seven twelve the lane was quiet again.

The third day was almost the same.

On the fourth day the scooter did not start.

Saraswati Devi had finished her tea on the veranda, but involuntarily she looked at the clock—seven fifteen.

The gate next door was closed.

At seven twenty Abhinav came out on foot. He was carrying a helmet.

Though she wanted to, Saraswati Devi did not ask anything.

In the afternoon Neelima appeared at the gate.

"Kaki, where can I get curry leaves here?"

Saraswati Devi said, "You'll get them in the market, but why go there now?"

She rose, went to a corner of the courtyard, and broke off a few sprigs from the curry-leaf plant.

Neelima held out her hand. "So much?"

"Dry it and keep it."

"I only need two or three leaves."

"Go to the market for two or three leaves?"

Neelima laughed.

Saraswati Devi found nothing impolite in her laughter.

The following week Neelima brought a small bowl of semolina halwa.

"For the curry leaves the other day," she said.

Saraswati Devi did not want halwa. She was supposed to eat less sweet food.

Even so, she took the bowl.

"I take very little sugar," she said only that much.

"This has very little too," Neelima said.

The halwa was indeed not very sweet.

That evening Saraswati Devi did not send the bowl back empty. She put two nimkis in it.

Abhinav returned the bowl.

“Kaki, Neelima said your nimki is very good.”

Saraswati Devi said, “The oil was a little old.”

“I couldn’t tell.”

“What would you know?”

Abhinav laughed.

Saraswati Devi smiled too, but after he left she felt a little displeased with herself.

Why had she smiled?

After a few days she realized that the sound of the scooter no longer felt like noise.

The seven-ten sound had become a small marker in her morning.

If the scooter left at seven five, she thought: early today.

If it had not left by seven twenty, she assumed: perhaps a holiday.

Immediately she would scold herself.

“What need have I to know?”

Even so, her eyes would go towards the gate.

One day there was a violent downpour.

In the afternoon the wind suddenly grew strong, and clothes drying on Neelima’s roof began to blow about and catch against the railing.

The neighbouring house was locked.

Saraswati Devi watched from the veranda, then stopped midway as she turned to go inside.

She brought out her old bamboo ladder.

One leg was slightly loose.

When she was working, she used to do such things herself; now her son repeatedly told her on the phone, “Ma, don’t climb ladders.”

She set the ladder in place.

First rung. Second.

Just then Rambabu, the vegetable seller, saw her from the lane.

“Kaki, what are you doing?”

“The clothes are blowing away.”

Rambabu climbed up and brought the clothes down.

Saraswati Devi spread them out on her own veranda.

When Neelima returned in the evening, she asked shyly, “Kaki, these clothes?”

“The wind was taking them away.”

“Did you climb up?”

“Not me. Rambabu.”

Gathering the clothes, Neelima said, “If you hadn’t been here, half my clothes would have been lying in the lane.”

Saraswati Devi gave no reply.

At nine that night the electricity went out.
The lane went dark.
Saraswati Devi lit a lantern and placed it on the veranda.
After a while Neelima called from inside her gate, "Kaki, may we sit on your veranda?"
"Come."
Abhinav came too.
The three of them sat in the dark veranda.
First they talked about mosquitoes, then the electricity department, then the drain in the lane.
After a while Neelima asked, "Do you live here alone?"
Saraswati Devi said, "Alone is a very large word. I am in the house."
Abhinav fell a little silent.
"Your son?"
"In Surat. My daughter is in Janakpur."
"Do they come?"
"They come."
Saraswati Devi did not say that her son had not been able to come the previous Diwali, and that her daughter had come only for two days.
That was not necessary.
When the electricity returned, Abhinav and Neelima got up and left.
The veranda became empty again, but for some time that night it did not feel empty to Saraswati Devi.
Two weeks later, the pain in Saraswati Devi's knee increased.
She had left the prescription for her medicines on the table, but did not feel like going to the market.
In the evening Neelima returned carrying a bag of vegetables. Saraswati Devi asked without planning to, "Coming from the market?"
"Yes."
Saraswati Devi looked at the prescription for a few moments.
Then she said, "Will you go again tomorrow?"
"What do you need?"
"Nothing. There were some medicines."
Neelima took the prescription. "I'll bring them now."
"Tomorrow."
"The shop is open. Five minutes."
"Abhinav will be waiting."
"He's at home. He'll come too."
Saraswati Devi could not stop her.
Twenty minutes later Abhinav came with the medicines and the bill.
"Kaki, one of these is to be taken after dinner at night."

"I can read."

"All right," Abhinav said with a smile.

Saraswati Devi counted out the money and gave it to him.

Abhinav returned four rupees.

Those four rupees lay on the table for a long time.

A few days later Saraswati Devi told her daughter on the phone, "People have moved into the house next door."

Her daughter asked, "Who?"

"A bank boy and his wife."

"Good people?"

Saraswati Devi said, "People always seem good at first."

After ending the call, her own reply seemed a little harsh to her.

The next morning she was sweeping fallen leaves beneath the curry-leaf plant when Neelima came over.

"Kaki, shall we grow coriander here?"

"Now?"

"The patch is empty."

"Grow it in your own courtyard."

"It doesn't get enough sun there."

Saraswati Devi looked at the soil.

"Coriander won't last very long here."

"However long it lasts."

Whether Neelima had said this only about the plant or about something else, Saraswati Devi could not tell.

She said, "Do you have seeds?"

"Yes."

Together they prepared a small bed.

Neelima scattered the seeds; Saraswati Devi covered them with a thin layer of soil.

From that day, every morning before opening her own gate, Neelima came to look at the coriander.

On the fourth day tender shoots appeared, thin as green threads.

"Look!" Neelima said like a child.

Saraswati Devi bent to see. "Don't call it coriander yet. Let two leaves come out first."

"You test everything."

"If I don't test the plant, shall I test you?"

They both laughed.

This time Saraswati Devi was not displeased with her own laughter.

Katik was approaching.

The evenings were growing shorter.

Sometimes Abhinav returned late from the bank. Neelima would sit on the veranda talking to her mother on the phone.

Saraswati Devi could not hear the words clearly, only the tone.

Sometimes Neelima laughed; sometimes she remained silent for a long time.

One evening the silence lasted longer.

Saraswati Devi wanted to ask, Is everything all right?

She did not ask.

The next day Neelima herself said, "Ma was ill."

"And now?"

"She's better."

"Will you go?"

"Abhinav can't get leave. I'm thinking of going alone."

Saraswati Devi said, "For one's mother, one can travel alone."

Neelima looked at her.

"Do you say the same thing to your daughter?"

The question was simple.

Saraswati Devi looked towards the curry-leaf plant.

"Sometimes I say the opposite."

Neelima asked nothing more.

Three days later she went to see her mother and returned after two days.

On her way back she brought peda from Janakpur.

Saraswati Devi took one piece.

"Too much sugar," she said.

"I knew you would say that."

"Then why did you bring it?"

"Because you'll eat it."

Saraswati Devi ate half a piece.

The coriander had grown somewhat thick now.

One morning Saraswati Devi was looking at the dew on its leaves when Abhinav came over.

He was dressed as on an ordinary day, but there was no scooter key in his hand.

"Kaki, I wanted to tell you something."

Saraswati Devi straightened. "Tell me."

"I've been transferred."

For a moment Saraswati Devi understood that she had heard the words, but their meaning arrived a little later.

"Where?"

"Muzaffarpur."

"When?"

“Next week.”

Saraswati Devi looked at the coriander leaves.

“So soon?”

Abhinav did not laugh. “The bank knows.”

Saraswati Devi remembered the same answer from the first day.

This time it did not sound light.

“Neelima?”

“She’s packing.”

Saraswati Devi said, “Cut the coriander. Otherwise it will spoil.”

Abhinav looked at her for a few moments, then said, “Yes.”

That day there was no sound of the scooter.

The next day the cardboard boxes appeared again.

Kitchen. Books. Clothes.

Saraswati Devi sat on the veranda drinking tea.

Five months earlier she had watched these boxes going inside; now she watched them coming out.

Neelima was bent over one box sealing it with tape.

In the middle of the work she stood up and came to Saraswati Devi.

“Kaki, will you keep this coriander?”

Saraswati Devi said, “It’s my soil.”

Neelima did not laugh.

“I thought I’d leave some of the flowerpots.”

“Why? Take them.”

“There may not be enough room in the vehicle.”

“Room can be made for plants.”

Neelima was silent for a few moments. “All right.”

Saraswati Devi immediately felt she had spoken a little too harshly.

But she could not call the words back.

On the day of the transfer, the goods vehicle arrived at ten.

This time there were a few more things. A bamboo basket, two new flowerpots, a small table, and the old brass-coloured tin Saraswati Devi had given Neelima, in which she kept spices.

Saraswati Devi saw the tin.

Neelima said, “I’m taking this.”

“It’s yours.”

“You gave it to me.”

“Once I gave it, it became yours.”

Before closing the gate, Abhinav handed the key to the house-owner’s nephew.

Then both of them came to take leave of Saraswati Devi.

When Neelima bent down, Saraswati Devi placed a hand on her head.

There was something she wanted to say.
“Call when you reach.” The sentence came to her mind.
But she said, “Keep drinking water on the way.”
Neelima laughed. “All right.”
Abhinav said, “Kaki, come to Muzaffarpur.”
“First settle the house properly.”
“It will settle.”
Saraswati Devi did not ask: for how long?
The vehicle drove away.
The gate was closed again.
In the afternoon the veranda of the neighbouring house stood empty.
Three round marks left by the flowerpots remained on the floor.
Saraswati Devi went back into her own house.
At seven ten in the evening she suddenly felt like looking at the clock.
Then she remembered—seven ten was the morning time when the scooter used to leave.
She laughed a little at herself.
At night Neelima called. “Kaki, we’ve reached.”
“All right.”
“Cut the coriander.”
“Plant some new coriander there.”
“I will.”
The call ended.
The next morning Saraswati Devi sat on the veranda with her tea. The lane was quiet. Seven ten came. No scooter started.
Saraswati Devi put the cup on the table and went towards the curry-leaf plant.
Beside it, the small coriander bed was wet with dew. She bent and pulled out two handfuls of weeds. The leaves had grown somewhat dense.
Whether it was time to cut them or whether they should be left a few more days, she did not decide. She only loosened the soil a little.
Then a breeze came from the direction of the closed gate next door. The gate did not open.
Saraswati Devi straightened, brushed the soil from her hands, and returned to the veranda. The tea was still a little warm.

The Creak of the Chair

Ramlochan Yadav went to the panchayat building on the pretext that he needed a copy of an old drainage scheme.

In truth, there was no immediate need for the copy.

That paper was already kept in the iron trunk at his house.

Even so, in the morning he bathed, put on a white kurta, slung his old leather bag over his shoulder, and set out.

His wife asked, "Where?"

He said, "As far as the panchayat office."

His wife asked no second question.

Until four months ago, that answer had meant meetings, papers, applications, crowds of people.

Now it meant only that Ramlochan was going out of the house.

The gate of the panchayat building was half open.

Two old benches had been placed in the sun on the veranda.

From inside came the rough sound of a broom.

Raghunandan, the watchman, saw him and stopped sweeping.

"Ramlochan Babu, so early?"

Earlier he used to call him "Mukhiya-ji."

This was not the first time Ramlochan had noticed the difference.

Even so, today's form of address lingered in his ears a little longer.

"I came to look for a paper."

"Which paper?"

Ramlochan made as if to open his bag, then closed it again.

"The drainage one."

Raghunandan nodded. "It should be in the old cupboard. The key is inside."

Ramlochan crossed the veranda.

The chair stood in the left-hand corner by the door.

Dark brown, heavy, wooden, with armrests.

The end of the right arm had been worn smooth.

There was a long crack down the middle of the back, held in place by nails driven into it twice over the years.

He had sat in that chair for ten years.
 After the new mukhiya took charge, she brought in a new metal chair.
 The old chair had been moved against the wall.
 Ramlochan walked towards it.
 He placed a hand on the armrest.
 There was not much dust.
 Raghunandan had probably wiped it the day before.
 He sat down slowly.
 The chair went, "Kirr."
 Ramlochan's body went still for a moment.
 It was the same sound.
 The first time he had sat in this chair after becoming mukhiya, it had made the same sound.
 That day the veranda had been full of people.
 Someone had garlanded him, someone had brought sweets, someone had tried to push an application forward before the others.
 He had sat down, and the chair had creaked.
 At the time he had felt as though the old chair were protesting while accepting his weight.
 Two weeks later he had stopped hearing the sound.
 The chair still creaked, but Ramlochan no longer heard it.
 Now, four months later, the same sound was clear again.
 From the doorway Raghunandan asked, "Shall I have tea made?"
 Out of habit Ramlochan said, "Tell them two cups."
 Then at once he remembered that what he said here was no longer an order.
 He added, "If you feel like having one too."
 Raghunandan laughed. "I always feel like having tea."
 He went outside.
 Ramlochan looked towards the desk.
 The new mukhiya had a new desk.
 A corner of the old desk had swollen with damp, and during the rains papers could not be kept there.
 Now that desk was in the storeroom.
 A new list for the gram panchayat hung on the wall.
 The names were printed in clear letters.
 Ramlochan did not look for his own name.
 There was no reason for his name to be on that list anymore.
 Even so, his eyes travelled from top to bottom.
 The election result had come four months earlier.
 The defeat had not been very large—one hundred and twenty-seven votes.

For the first two days he told everyone the number.
“Only one hundred and twenty-seven.”
As though calling the number small would make the defeat smaller too.
From the third day he began saying, “It is the people’s decision.”
A week later he said, “I have got some rest now.”
After a month he stopped saying that sentence.
Rest had very quickly turned into long days.
When he woke in the morning, no one was waiting at the gate.
The phone rang no more than two or three times a day.
Earlier his wife used to complain that meals went cold.
Now the food stayed warm, and Ramlochan sat down to eat on time.
After a few days his wife had asked, “Do you really like so much silence?”
Ramlochan had said, “What’s wrong with silence?”
His wife had not answered.
The chair gave another faint creak.
Ramlochan straightened slightly.
How many times, sitting in this chair, had he told people, “Sit down.”
Many people would remain standing until he himself invited them to sit.
In the first year this had embarrassed him.
In the second year it became a habit.
By the fifth year he no longer noticed it at all.
Once a farmer, Bhola Paswan, had come carrying an application.
Ramlochan was speaking on the phone.
Bhola stood for almost ten minutes.
When Ramlochan ended the call, he asked, “Yes, tell me.”
Bhola held out the paper.
On his way home that day, Ramlochan had suddenly remembered that he
had never once said, “Sit down.”
He had remembered it, and then the memory had served no purpose.
Today the scene appeared very clearly.
Bhola standing with a blue gamchha over his shoulder.
Mud on his slippers.
The paper folded in his hand.
And Ramlochan himself laughing into the phone.
Ramlochan ran a finger along the armrest.
The smooth wood of the chair was cold.
Raghunandan returned carrying tea.
Two glass tumblers.
He placed one on the desk and kept one in his own hand.
Earlier he used to drink his tea outside.
Ramlochan noticed that too.

"Sit," he said.

Raghunandan pulled a bench closer and sat down.

Without hesitation.

They began drinking tea.

Raghunandan asked, "Shall I look for the paper?"

"Leave it."

"Then?"

Ramlochan watched the steam rising from his glass. "What will they do with this chair?"

Raghunandan looked at it.

"The new Madam says a list of old items will be made. Things that are usable will be kept; the rest will be auctioned."

"This isn't usable?"

Raghunandan did not laugh. "It creaks when someone sits on it."

Ramlochan did not laugh either.

"It creaked before too."

"Then why wasn't it changed?"

The question was very simple.

Ramlochan searched for an answer.

"I got used to it."

Raghunandan kept drinking his tea.

After a while a bicycle bell sounded outside.

A man came in—Bhola Paswan.

Ramlochan recognized him at once.

Instead of the blue gamchha, he now had a white towel over his shoulder.

The hair on his head had grown very thin.

Bhola looked first at Raghunandan, then at Ramlochan.

"Ramlochan Babu."

"Come, Bhola."

For a moment Bhola remained standing in the old way.

The words "Tell me" almost came out of Ramlochan's mouth.

He stopped them.

He gestured towards the bench. "Sit down."

Bhola sat.

"What work?" Ramlochan asked.

Bhola laughed. "Not with you. I had to ask Raghunandan about a birth certificate."

Something very small shifted inside Ramlochan.

As though one step of a staircase had suddenly dropped lower without his noticing.

He placed the glass on the desk.

“Yes, yes. Of course.”

Raghunandan took the papers from Bhola.

The two began talking about the date on the certificate, the name, and the Aadhaar copy.

Ramlochan listened.

Only four months earlier, a conversation like this would have begun with him, in front of him.

Now the conversation was flowing past him.

There was no insult in it.

No one had ignored him.

Even so, it seemed to him that his size in the room had become a little smaller.

After handing over the papers, Bhola stood up.

Ramlochan asked, “Everything all right at home?”

“All right. My little granddaughter has started school.”

“Which class?”

“Second.”

“Make sure she studies properly.”

The moment the sentence came out, Ramlochan’s own voice sounded old to him.

Bhola smiled. “She studies. She understands more than I do.”

He left.

For a few moments Ramlochan kept looking towards the doorway.

Raghunandan gathered the files.

“Ramlochan Babu, if you want, you could buy this chair at the auction.”

Ramlochan looked at him.

“Take it home?”

“Yes. It’s an old thing. It won’t fetch much.”

Ramlochan’s first thought was that it would look good on the veranda at home.

Then he remembered the veranda.

There were already four chairs there.

One bamboo chair, two plastic chairs, and one his wife used while sewing.

Space could be made for this heavy chair.

He placed his hand on the armrest once more.

How many people had stood before this armrest.

How many applications had been placed upon it and signed.

How many times had he leaned over it while making phone calls.

How many times had the chair creaked while he did not hear it.

“Will you take it?” Raghunandan asked again.

Ramlochan said, “Let it stay for now.”

"The auction notice will come."

"Let it come."

Raghunandan nodded.

Ramlochan stood up.

The chair creaked loudly once.

He turned and looked back.

The empty chair stood still.

For a moment he felt something strange—he could not decide whether the sound had come because his body rose, or because the chair had become empty.

He slung the bag over his shoulder.

Raghunandan asked, "The drainage paper?"

Ramlochan laughed.

"It's at home."

Raghunandan laughed too. "Then why did you come here?"

Ramlochan moved towards the door.

"To see."

"What?"

He did not stop.

"The chair."

As he came down from the veranda, the sunlight had grown a little stronger.

Two children were riding bicycles along the road.

One saw Ramlochan and greeted him.

The other did not; he was busy keeping his bicycle balanced.

Ramlochan blessed the first child.

He paid no attention to the second.

A little farther on, Bhola Paswan was standing by a tea stall.

Bhola called, "Ramlochan Babu, tea?"

Ramlochan's first impulse was to say, "I've just had some at the panchayat office."

Instead, he crossed the road towards the stall.

Bhola shifted along the bench to make space.

Ramlochan sat beside him.

The bench did not creak.

The shopkeeper asked, "Sugar?"

Ramlochan said, "Less."

Bhola began talking about his granddaughter's school.

Ramlochan listened.

In the middle of it, his phone rang.

The screen showed the name of an old supporter.

He looked at the phone, but did not answer immediately.

Bhola was saying that his granddaughter could write her own name in English, but wanted to write her grandfather's name in Maithili.

Ramlochan smiled.

The phone stopped ringing.

"If she can write your name, that's plenty," he said.

The tea arrived.

Ramlochan took the glass in his hand.

The veranda of the panchayat building could be seen some distance away from there.

The doorway was open.

The chair inside was not visible.

Only the dark rectangle of the doorway could be seen.

Ramlochan took a sip from the glass.

At that moment he remembered the creak of the chair again.

But this time the sound seemed very far away.

Bhola asked something.

Ramlochan turned towards him.

"What did you say?"

Bhola repeated it.

Ramlochan began listening carefully.

Seven in the Morning

Raghunath Jha's eyes opened at five forty-five in the morning.

The alarm had been set for six.

He reached out and switched it off before it could ring.

The habit was thirty-five years old.

On school days the alarm hardly ever woke him; it merely told him that it was now time to leave the bed.

He sat up.

The room was still slightly dark.

Outside the window came the first cawing of a crow.

His wife, Kamala Devi, was still asleep.

Raghunath put on his slippers quietly.

At the tap in the courtyard, his hands moved by themselves through the same sequence they had followed every day.

First the face, then the eyes, then two splashes of water over the head.

He placed the towel over his shoulder.

A freshly ironed pale blue shirt hung from a nail in the veranda.

The previous evening Kamala Devi had asked, 'Why have you taken this shirt out now?'

Raghunath had said, 'No reason. Just like that.'

In truth, he himself had not understood why.

Yesterday had been his last day at school.

At the farewell he had been given a flower garland, a watch, and a large sheet of paper on which the children had written together: 'Master Saheb, keep coming back.'

Raghunath had folded the paper, put it into his shoulder bag, and brought it home.

After dinner he had not even opened the bag.

Only now, in the morning, did he remember for the first time that there was no need to get ready for school.

Even so, he took down the shirt and put it on.

While fastening the buttons, his hand stopped at the second button.

He looked towards the mirror.

'Where am I going?'
 He did not say the question aloud.
 He did not fasten the remaining buttons.
 After a while he took the shirt off and hung it back on the nail.
 Over his old striped vest he put on an ordinary kurta.
 That small change filled him with a strange emptiness.
 As though the day had been given another name.
 At ten past six Kamala Devi woke up.
 On her way to the kitchen she saw him sitting in the veranda.
 'So early?'
 'My sleep broke.'
 'Now you can sleep at ease.'
 Raghunath smiled.
 'We'll see.'
 Kamala Devi began lighting the stove.
 Raghunath sat on the low wooden platform in the veranda and looked at the clock.
 Six sixteen.
 By this time he would ordinarily be pressing the bicycle tyres to check them.
 He would check whether the attendance register, red pen, two pieces of chalk, and the midday-meal list were all in the bag.
 Today the bag lay in a corner of the room.
 He got up and went inside.
 He opened the buckle of the bag.
 From inside he took out half a piece of chalk.
 Chalk dust had drawn a white streak over the black lining of the bag.
 Raghunath turned the chalk in his hand.
 Then put it back in the same place.
 The greeting sheet he had received along with the garland was inside too.
 He felt like opening it, but did not.
 He closed the bag again.
 Six twenty-eight.
 Kamala Devi brought tea.
 'Today the tea won't go cold,' she said.
 Raghunath looked at her questioningly.
 'There's no hurry for school now.'
 He gave a faint laugh.
 'Yes.'
 The tea was in his hand, but he looked at the clock again.
 Six thirty-two.

The school was about a mile and a half from the house.
 On his bicycle he usually left at six thirty-five.
 Rain, fog, winter—the time hardly changed.
 Today six thirty-five came.
 Raghunath's feet moved involuntarily towards the slippers beneath the platform.
 Then he looked at the cup of tea in his hand.
 He did not put the slippers on.
 From the kitchen Kamala Devi called, 'Is the sugar all right?'
 'It's all right.'
 He began drinking the tea slowly.
 Six forty.
 Two children ran past through the lane with schoolbags on their backs.
 One child shouted from outside the door, 'Master Saheb!'

Raghunath stood up instinctively.
 The child folded his hands in greeting and moved on.
 Raghunath remained standing for a few moments.
 Then sat down again.
 A little tea remained in the cup.
 He drank it in a single swallow.
 At six forty-five the village milkman came by bicycle.
 'Master Saheb, no school today?'
 The question was entirely ordinary.
 Raghunath paused a little before answering.
 'Not anymore.'
 The milkman stopped his bicycle.
 'Oh! Yesterday was your last day, wasn't it?'
 'Yes.'
 'You served a long time.'
 A smile came to Raghunath's face, but no answer formed.
 The milkman rode on.
 'Not anymore.'
 For a while the two words seemed to remain in the veranda.
 Raghunath thought: he had never practised giving that answer.
 Six fifty-two.
 He stepped down into the courtyard.
 The soil near the tulsi platform was slightly dry.
 He poured water from a lota.
 Then he pulled out two weeds that had sprung up beneath the small pomegranate tree.
 One of the weeds had a deep root.

He kept tugging at it.
The root broke.
Half of it came away in his hand.
'It will grow again,' he said to himself.
He looked at the clock.
Six fifty-six.
He returned towards the veranda.
The bicycle leaned against the wall.
There was no dust on the handlebar; he himself had wiped it with a cloth the night before.
He pressed the bicycle bell.
Tring-tring.
The sound was familiar.
For years that sound at the turn in the lane had told the children that Master Saheb was coming.
Raghunath did not ring the bell again.
Six fifty-eight.
From the direction of the school, the blurred sound of children began to reach him.
Paddy fields lay between the village and the school.
The voices did not travel clearly, but now and then, in the morning air, a collective murmur floated across.
Raghunath stood beside a pillar of the veranda.
A few seconds before seven, he felt a faint tightness in his chest.
He did not know why.
Then, from a distance, the school bell rang.
Once.
A second time.
Then several short strokes in succession.
The very bell he had heard for thirty-five years.
For many years he had rung it himself whenever the attendant was absent.
Many times he had been annoyed when it rang late.
Many times children had run towards their classrooms as soon as it sounded.
Today the bell rang.
Raghunath went nowhere.
For one moment his feet moved towards the bicycle.
Then stopped.
The bell fell silent.
The air became ordinary again.
Raghunath remained standing with one hand on the pillar.

He could not tell whether what he felt was sorrow or relief.
The two feelings had dissolved into each other.
As though a heavy bag had been lifted from his shoulder, but the shoulder was still searching for its weight.
Kamala Devi came into the veranda.
'Did you hear the bell?'
Raghunath looked at her.
'Yes.'
Kamala Devi said nothing.
She picked up the empty cup from the platform.
Raghunath asked, 'Is it seven?'
Kamala Devi looked at the clock.
'Seven two.'
Raghunath nodded.
Two minutes.
On school days two minutes had meant: prayer has begun, reach the class before attendance, some child has come late again.
Today those two minutes had no task.
He began walking in the courtyard.
At five past seven, for the first time, he noticed a small square of sunlight on the eastern wall.
He was not ordinarily at home at this hour.
The light was climbing slowly upward.
An old crack in the wall ran through it.
Raghunath had perhaps never seen that crack so clearly—
He stopped the word in his mind.
He laughed at himself.
He thought: after living in this house for so many years, why had he never noticed that crack?
Then the answer came on its own—where was he ever at home at seven?
Kamala Devi was kneading flour.
Raghunath stood at the kitchen doorway.
'Is there anything to do?'
Kamala Devi looked at him in surprise.
'Now?'
'Yes.'
'Cut the vegetables.'
Raghunath sat on a low stool.
He began peeling potatoes.
The peel came off the first potato much too thick.
Kamala Devi saw it, but said nothing.

With the second potato Raghunath's hand became more careful.
Seven twelve.

Again the collective recitation of children came faintly from afar.
Raghunath's hand stopped.

Something like the rhythm of 'two twos are four' reached him, broken by the air.

He began cutting the potatoes again.

Kamala Devi asked, 'Is your mind going there?'

Raghunath answered, 'My mind is right here.'

After saying it, he understood that it was not a complete answer.

Kamala Devi too perhaps—

The same word returned to his mind.

Raghunath smiled.

Kamala Devi asked, 'What happened?'

'Nothing.'

He pushed the plate of cut potatoes towards her.

At seven twenty he brought the bicycle out.

Kamala Devi asked, 'Where?'

The first answer that wanted to come from Raghunath's mouth was:
'School.'

He stopped it at once.

'As far as the market.'

'What will you bring?'

Raghunath thought a little.

'Nothing. I'll just ride around and come back.'

Kamala Devi smiled.

'Then go.'

Raghunath mounted the bicycle.

At the turn in the lane, his hands automatically began turning the handlebar left, towards the road to the school.

He turned halfway and stopped.

Straight ahead was the road to the market.

To the left, the school.

He stood still on the bicycle for a few moments.

A farmer passed with a bullock cart.

'Master Saheb, forgotten the road?'

Raghunath laughed.

'A little.'

The farmer too laughed and moved on.

Raghunath straightened the handlebar and rode towards the market.

At that hour the market was only half open.

Four men were sitting at the tea stall.
The moment they saw him, one of them shifted to make room.
'Come, Master Saheb. Now you've got all the time in the world.'
Raghunath stopped the bicycle.
He could sit there.
Earlier, sitting at a tea stall at this hour had seemed impossible to him.
'It's school time,' he would have said, and ridden on.
Today he looked at the clock.
Seven twenty-eight.
At the school, prayer would be over.
The first class would be beginning.
He leaned the bicycle against the front of the stall and sat down on the bench.
Without asking, the shopkeeper put tea on for him.
'Less sugar,' Raghunath said.
'I know.'
At those words Raghunath fell silent.
Suddenly he realized that people outside the school knew some of his habits too.
It was a very small thing.
Even so, he liked it.
The tea came.
The men on the bench continued talking about crops, roads and electricity bills.
No one spoke about his farewell.
No one counted his thirty-five years of service.
No one asked what he would do now.
At first Raghunath thought someone would ask.
Then, after a little while, he was glad no one did.
He held the glass of tea in both hands and kept looking at the road.
At seven forty a school bus passed.
Children's faces were visible through the windows.
Raghunath raised a hand without thinking.
Whether anyone saw him, he did not know.
His hand remained in the air for a little while.
Then came down.
He finished the last sip of tea and rose.
On the way home he did not take the road past the school.
Even so, once, in the air, he heard the bell from very far away.
Perhaps the second period.

The moment he heard the word 'perhaps' in his own mind, Raghunath smiled.

He thought: what need is there for me to know now?

When he reached home, Kamala Devi was sweeping the courtyard.

'What did you find in the market?'

Leaning the bicycle against the wall, Raghunath said, 'Tea.'

Kamala Devi laughed.

'You went all the way to the market for that?'

'Yes.'

'There wasn't tea at home?'

Raghunath thought a moment and said, 'Tea at home was different.'

Kamala Devi continued sweeping.

Raghunath sat down on the platform in the veranda.

The clock now showed eight five.

For the first time, he took off the watch and placed it on the platform.

He did not do very much for the rest of the day.

He tied up old newspapers.

Repaired the handle of a broken bucket.

After lunch he slept for a while.

When he woke, for a moment he could not tell whether he had taken leave from school and fallen asleep, or whether he truly did not have to go to school anymore.

Once he understood the distinction, he lay looking at the ceiling.

His heart grew a little heavy.

Then the call of the vegetable seller came from outside.

He got up.

In the evening two former students came to see him.

Both worked in the city now.

One had brought a box of sweets.

They touched his feet.

Raghunath tried to stop them, but it was too late.

As they talked, the students recalled old incidents from the school.

Raghunath laughed.

After they left, the veranda became quiet again.

Putting the box of sweets inside, Kamala Devi said, 'People remember.'

Raghunath said, 'People remember their own things.'

That night he went to bed early.

The alarm clock was on the table.

He switched off the alarm for six.

Then, after thinking for a moment, he did not set one for five forty-five either.

Kamala Devi asked, 'Will you sleep late tomorrow?'
Raghunath said, 'We'll see.'
The next day his eyes opened again at five forty-five.
There was no alarm.
For a few moments he remained lying in bed.
Unlike the previous day, he did not get up at once.
Outside the window the morning was slowly growing bright.
Kamala Devi was asleep.
Raghunath closed his eyes again.
Sleep did not return.
At ten past six he got up.
Today he did not even look towards the blue shirt.
He put on an ordinary kurta.
Tea was made.
He took the cup and came to the veranda.
The bicycle leaned against the wall.
The bag lay in the room.
At six forty-five the children ran through the lane again.
One called, 'Master Saheb!'
Raghunath raised his hand.
He did not stand up.
At six fifty-eight he stepped down from the platform into the courtyard.
On the eastern wall the same square patch of sunlight was beginning to
form again.
He watched it.
Seven o'clock came.
The distant school bell rang.
For one moment Raghunath's feet shifted towards the door.
He stopped. The cup of tea was in his hand. The bell kept ringing. He
looked at the sunlight on the wall.
Was it a little higher than yesterday, or did it only seem so? He did not
know.
From inside Kamala Devi called, 'Your tea will go cold.'
Raghunath raised the cup to his lips.
The bell stopped.
He went back and sat on the platform.
The clock was inside the house; Raghunath did not get up to look at it.

Two Tickets

At the ticket window of the Madhubani bus stand, Mahesh first looked at Ramvilas Chaudhary's face and then at the two five-hundred-rupee notes in his hand.

"Patna?" he asked.

"Yes. The six o'clock bus in the morning."

"How many seats?"

Ramvilas said, "Two. Side by side."

Mahesh ran his eyes over the computer screen. "Eleven and twelve are vacant."

"All right."

The tickets were printed. As Mahesh handed over both slips, he smiled slightly. "Is someone travelling with you this time?"

Ramvilas folded the tickets. "We'll see."

The answer was not new to Mahesh. For the past year and a half, whenever Ramvilas travelled to Patna, he had bought two tickets. Yet when the bus departed, he was usually seen travelling alone.

People interpreted this habit in different ways. Some said he was an old man and wanted the seat beside him empty. Others said his knees hurt, so he bought a second seat to stretch his legs.

Ramvilas explained himself to no one.

He was a retired postal employee, sixty-four years old. His wife, Nirmala, had died five years earlier. His daughter Kavita was a schoolteacher in Begusarai. His son lived in Delhi.

He was going to Patna for an eye examination. Three months earlier the doctor had told him, "Don't postpone the next check-up."

When he returned home, his neighbour Manoj saw the tickets and asked, "Kaka, who is the second ticket for?"

Putting his spectacle case into his bag, Ramvilas said, "For no one yet."

"Then why did you buy it?"

"The seat may remain empty."

Manoj laughed. "Full fare just for an empty seat?"

Ramvilas laughed too, but gave no answer.

The next morning the bus stand was wrapped in fog like cotton. Steam from the tea seller's kettle rose together with the bus exhaust.

Ramvilas arrived at five forty-five. In his bag were one change of clothes, his medicines, an old umbrella and the tickets.

The driver was inspecting the engine at the front of the bus. The conductor, holding the seat list, was calling out numbers rather than names — “One to ten in front, eleven to twenty in the middle.”

Ramvilas sat in seat eleven. He left seat twelve empty.

Tearing the tickets, the conductor asked, “Where is the passenger for twelve?”

“Not here yet.”

“The bus leaves in five minutes.”

“Let it leave.”

The conductor looked at him but said nothing.

One by one all the seats filled. Only twelve remained empty. Outside, several people who had failed to get tickets were asking about the next bus.

Ramvilas kept watching the faces outside through the window. He looked less at the road than at the ticket window and the bus door.

Two minutes before six, a woman came running. She carried a child of about four in her arms, a bundle of clothes under one arm, and an old bag in her hand.

“Patna?” she asked, panting.

The conductor said, “The seats are full.”

The woman looked towards the ticket window. From inside, Mahesh called out, “The next bus is at eight-thirty.”

“Bhaiya, I have to reach Patna Medical. The child's examination is at ten.”

The conductor softened a little. “One seat is showing vacant on the list, but the ticket has already been sold.”

Ramvilas took out the ticket for seat twelve and looked out through the glass.

The woman said, “I'll travel standing.”

The conductor shook his head. “It's a long journey, and you have a child. It's against the rules too.”

Ramvilas rose and went to the door. “This ticket is yours.”

The woman stared at him. “Mine?”

“Seat twelve.”

“But the money—”

“The bus is about to leave. Get on first.”

Still hesitant, she boarded the bus. The child was half-drooping with sleep. Ramvilas put his own bag overhead and made room for her to sit in seat twelve.

The bus pulled away.

For some distance the woman said nothing. Then, stroking the child's head, she asked, "Do you know me?"

"No."

"Then why had you already bought the ticket?"

Ramvilas looked outside at the harvested paddy fields. "The answer to that question is a little long."

"There is plenty of time before Patna," the woman said.

Ramvilas smiled faintly.

Thirteen years earlier, his daughter Kavita had been going to Patna to sit the written examination for a teaching appointment. It was her first such examination, and the family was in very difficult circumstances then.

When they reached the ticket window, Ramvilas discovered that he was thirty-seven rupees short of the fare. He was certain he had left home with the full amount. Where the money had fallen on the way, he never found out.

He told the ticket clerk, "Hold one seat for me. I'll borrow the money from someone and come back."

The clerk said, "The bus leaves in five minutes."

Ramvilas searched the crowd for a familiar face. There was no one. Kavita said nothing, but the fear of missing the examination was clear in her eyes.

At that moment an elderly woman standing behind them asked for two tickets at the window.

Ramvilas assumed someone was travelling with her. But the woman placed one of the tickets in Kavita's hand.

"Take it."

Ramvilas was flustered. "No, I'll pay the—"

The woman said, "When you have the money, don't let someone else's journey be interrupted."

Ramvilas asked her name. The woman said only, "If we keep accounts by name, the work becomes difficult."

She went and sat in another corner of the bus. When they reached Patna, she disappeared somewhere in the crowd. Ramvilas never saw her again.

Kavita was appointed through that examination. Later, Ramvilas tried many times to find the unknown woman, but he never found a clue.

"Since then," Ramvilas told the woman in seat twelve, "whenever I make a long journey and can afford it, I buy two tickets."

The woman remained silent for a long time.

"Do you find someone every time?"

"No."

"Then the second ticket?"

"Sometimes it remains empty."

“Money wasted?”

Ramvilas thought for a moment. “An empty seat and wasted money are not the same thing.”

The bus stopped at a small roadside dhaba. Ramvilas bought tea. The woman asked for milk for the child, but she did not have a small note. When Ramvilas tried to offer money, she stopped him.

“The ticket was enough. I’ll buy the milk.”

She took coins from a small pocket inside her bag.

Ramvilas smiled. “All right.”

When they reached Patna, he learned that the woman’s name was Rekha Devi. The child’s name was Anshu.

Before leaving for the hospital, Rekha said, “Give me your address. I’ll send you the ticket money.”

Ramvilas took a pen from his pocket. Rekha thought he was going to write his address.

Instead, on the back of the ticket he wrote just one line: “When you get the chance, don’t let someone else’s journey be interrupted.”

He placed the ticket in Rekha’s hand.

Rekha read it and smiled slightly, then lowered her eyes. “But this isn’t an address.”

“I didn’t get an address that day either.”

Rekha took the child’s hand and walked towards the hospital.

Ramvilas stopped a rickshaw for the eye hospital.

As he sat down in the rickshaw, it occurred to him that seat twelve had not remained empty today.

For the evening journey home, he bought only one ticket.

The next month, when Ramvilas came to the ticket window again, Mahesh asked, “How many this time?”

Ramvilas held out a five-hundred-rupee note. “Two. Side by side.”

Mahesh smiled again. “Someone travelling with you this time?”

Ramvilas looked at the faces in the crowd. “No one yet.”

The Bangle Box

Three days before she died, Malati Devi had placed a blue velvet box in Sumitra's hands. The box was light, but at that moment Sumitra was in no state to judge its weight.

Her mother had said only, "Open it seven days before Nandini's wedding."

Sumitra had asked, "What is inside?"

Malati Devi had smiled and said, "You'll know seven days before."

Twelve years had passed since then.

Nandini was now twenty-five, and her wedding was exactly the following Monday. The house was full of sacks of rice and dal, turmeric, invitation cards, relatives' phone calls, and bundles of clothes, all mingling into one another.

The blue box had remained wrapped in cloth on the upper shelf of Sumitra's cupboard.

During those twelve years Sumitra had taken it in her hands many times. There was no clear metallic clink from inside. Even so, she had always believed that this was her mother's bangle box, and therefore there must be bangles inside.

Their father, Rameshwar Jha, never asked about the box. Whenever the expenses of the wedding were discussed, he said only, "We will not take a loan. We will do only as much as we can afford."

Sumitra found the sentence a little harsh. It seemed to her that her father was more concerned with accounts than with the excitement of his daughter's wedding.

On the morning seven days before the wedding, Sumitra brought the box down from the cupboard. Nandini, their father and their maternal cousin Reena were in the room.

A red thread was tied around the box. The knot had grown hard with age.

Nandini laughed. "Didi, you really didn't open it all these years?"

"Ma said seven days before."

"You really are very obedient."

Sumitra cut the thread with scissors.

The lid opened.

There were no bangles inside.

No cotton either. Only many tiny folded slips of paper, one round brass token, and a narrow strip of old newspaper.

At first Nandini laughed, as though she thought it was a joke. Then she saw Sumitra's face and fell silent.

Sumitra opened one slip. At the top was written: "Harilal Jewellers — Deposit 250." The date was twelve years old.

A second: "Deposit 300."

A third: "Deposit 200."

There were twenty-three such receipts altogether. Sometimes the amount was two hundred, sometimes five hundred, sometimes only one hundred and fifty.

The brass token bore the raised number 47. On the back, in very small letters, was the name "Harilal."

Nandini asked, "What is all this?"

Sumitra could not answer.

Their father, Rameshwar Jha, was sitting near the door. There was no surprise on his face.

Sumitra immediately looked at him. "You know about this?"

Her father was silent for a while. Then he said, "Take the box to Harilal."

"Where are the bangles?"

"Go to Harilal."

Something grew hot inside Sumitra. A box preserved for twelve years, her mother's final instruction, and now only receipts.

"Why can't you tell me now?"

Her father lowered his eyes. "Some things become smaller when they are told. They are understood properly only when seen."

Sumitra did not like the answer.

That afternoon she took Nandini with her to the old market. Harilal Jewellers was now run by Harilal's son Manoj, but the elderly Harilal still sat on a wooden platform in front.

Sumitra placed the brass token before him.

Harilal took it in his hand and adjusted his spectacles. "Forty-seven."

He looked carefully at Sumitra. "Are you Malati's daughter?"

"Yes."

"The wedding has come at last?"

Nandini smiled. "Mine."

Harilal rose slowly. He opened an iron cupboard at the back. From among many packets he took out a small bundle wrapped in red cloth. In faded ink it was marked: "47 — Malati / Rameshwar."

Sumitra's eyes stopped on the second name.

Harilal opened the bundle. Inside were two simple gold bangles—neither very thick nor very thin. The workmanship was plain, with a small leaf-like engraving along the edges.

Nandini remained speechless.

Sumitra asked, “When were these made?”

Harilal took out an old ledger from behind him. “They were not made all at once. First came the deposits.”

He opened a page. The amounts matched the receipts. Beside the first seven entries was written “Malati.”

From the eighth entry onward, the name changed to “Rameshwar.”

The date was two months after Malati Devi’s death.

Sumitra placed a finger on the page. “Even after that?”

Harilal said, “Yes. Your father kept bringing whatever he could every month or two. Sometimes three hundred, sometimes one hundred. Two years passed when nothing came for as long as six months. Then one day he deposited one thousand.”

Nandini asked softly, “When were the bangles completed?”

“Three years ago.”

“Then why didn’t he take them home?”

Harilal laughed. “Rameshwar Babu said that if he kept them at home, some emergency might remind him of them before the daughter’s wedding. Let them stay here, he said. Seven days before the wedding, send the daughter with the token from the box.”

Sumitra fell silent.

Several scenes from the past years came to her all at once—her father postponing the purchase of new sandals, repairing the old radio and using it again, removing two unnecessary dishes from the wedding menu, and saying again and again, “We will not take a loan.”

Sumitra had taken all these things as small proofs of miserliness.

Harilal held the bangles against Nandini’s wrist to judge the size. “Malati had left the original measurement. Later Rameshwar Babu said Nandini had slim wrists like her mother. Keep them slightly loose.”

Nandini put on the bangles. They fit perfectly.

Sumitra’s throat tightened, but she could not cry.

“Is any money still due?” she asked.

Harilal closed the ledger. “No. The final instalment was completed last Phagun.”

“Last Phagun?”

“Yes. Rameshwar Babu brought it himself.”

On the way home, Nandini did not put the bangles back in the box for a long time. She kept them on her wrists and looked out of the bus window.

Sumitra said, "Babu never told us anything."

Nandini replied, "Ma didn't tell us everything either."

"Both of them were very good at keeping secrets."

Nandini laughed. "But they kept the accounts clear."

When they reached home, their father was bargaining with the flower seller in the veranda.

"This many marigold garlands are too much," he was saying. "Cut it by half. If you cover the entrance with flowers, people forget the people inside."

Earlier, a sentence like this would have irritated Sumitra. Today she listened in silence.

Nandini went to her father. The bangles were on her wrists.

For a moment he looked at them, then turned his face back towards the flower seller. "Do they fit?"

Nandini said, "Perfectly."

Her father only said, "Hmm."

Sumitra placed the twenty-three receipts and the brass token before him.

Rameshwar Jha said, "Don't throw these away. Malati kept the first receipt with her own hands."

"I won't throw them away."

After a few moments Sumitra asked, "Even after the bangles were ready three years ago, why didn't you bring them home?"

Her father smiled faintly. "The box was to be opened seven days before."

For the first time Sumitra understood that her mother's instruction had not been preserved by her mother alone.

On the morning of the wedding, Nandini was getting ready. Sumitra adjusted the bangles on her wrists.

Nandini asked softly, "Didi, should these be called Ma's bangles or Babu's?"

Closing the clasp, Sumitra said, "The box was Ma's. The instalments belonged to both of them. The bangles are yours."

Nandini smiled.

Late that night, after the wedding crowd had thinned, Sumitra opened the blue box again. There were no bangles in it now. She arranged the twenty-three receipts in order of date. The brass token lay on top. The first seven receipts bore her mother's name; the rest her father's.

Before closing the lid, Sumitra looked at the box for a while. This time the box was empty, yet inside it lay twelve years of two signatures side by side.

One Rupee Short

Girish Sah's grocery shop in the middle of Barhi market was not large enough for anyone to call it an establishment, but it was certainly old enough for three generations of customers to have rested their elbows on the same wooden counter.

Girish Sah was known for one habit: he allowed no looseness in accounts, not even by a paisa.

He often said, "A shop runs on trust, but trust stands on the feet of accounts."

At the left corner of the counter stood a small brass bowl holding one-, two- and five-rupee coins. Girish called it the change bowl.

That Monday morning the bowl was almost empty.

For the past two days there had been a shortage of coins in the market. Customers offered twenty instead of ten, fifty instead of twenty, and Girish kept saying, "We'll settle the one rupee later. I'm writing down the name."

Under the counter was a thin red ledger. On its cover was written: Change Due.

Many people did not even know the ledger existed. Whenever Girish owed a customer one or two rupees in change, he wrote down the name; whenever a customer bought on credit, that too was entered in the same ledger with a different mark.

Around noon, after school had let out, a boy of about twelve named Amar came to the shop.

One button of his shirt was missing, his schoolbag was old, and a thin line of sweat lay across his forehead. In his hand were two folded ten-rupee notes and a few coins.

"Girish Kaka," Amar said, "give me one thick notebook and a blue pen."

Girish took down a notebook hanging above. "How many pages?"

"The one Master Sahib told us to get—one hundred and sixty pages."

"This is eighteen rupees. The pen is eight. Twenty-six altogether."

Amar opened his fist. On the counter he placed two ten-rupee notes, one five-rupee coin, and a few smaller coins.

Girish counted them. Then counted again.

“Twenty-five.”

Amar counted the coins too. “Ma gave me twenty-five only.”

“Then you’re one rupee short.”

Amar looked at the notebook and the pen. “Can I give it tomorrow?”

Girish’s hand moved by habit towards the red ledger beneath the counter, but he stopped himself.

He knew the condition of Amar’s household. The boy’s father worked as a labourer in Punjab and had not come home for three months. His mother, Phulkali Devi, did sewing in other people’s houses.

Girish could easily have written down the one rupee. But at that hour five or six customers were standing in the shop.

One customer laughed and said, “What’s one rupee worth accounting for, Girishji? He’s a child.”

At those words, something in Girish hardened in the opposite direction.

He thought: once people begin treating a shopkeeper’s accounts as trivial, then slowly five rupees, ten rupees, fifty rupees—everything becomes nothing.

In a calm voice he said, “Child or adult, the price of an item is the price of the item.”

Amar’s face reddened slightly.

“Then leave the pen,” he said.

“The notebook alone is eighteen. Seven rupees will remain.”

For a moment Amar turned the pen in his hand. Its cap was blue, with a thin silver-coloured band around the middle.

“I need the pen,” he said softly. “I’ll take the notebook tomorrow.”

Girish was surprised. “What will you do with the pen without the notebook?”

“There are a few pages left at the back of my old notebook.”

“Then take the pen. Seventeen rupees will remain.”

Amar took the pen, but looked once more at the notebook.

Girish returned seventeen rupees to him. There was no one-rupee coin in the change bowl, so he made up the amount with five- and two-rupee coins.

Amar put the money in his schoolbag and left.

The crowd of customers began moving again.

Girish forgot the matter—at least that was how it seemed to him.

At three in the afternoon Phulkali Devi herself came to the shop.

She carried an old cloth bag. “Half a kilo of rice, a quarter kilo of dal, and fifty grams of turmeric.”

Girish weighed out the goods.

As Phulkali paid, she asked, “Did Amar come?”

“Yes. He took the pen.”

Phulkali paused for a moment. “The notebook?”

“He was one rupee short. He said he’d take it tomorrow.”

A tiny flash of surprise appeared in Phulkali’s eyes, but she said nothing.

She picked up the bag and said, “All right.”

Hearing that “all right” made Girish slightly uneasy.

He thought Phulkali could have said, “Write down the one rupee.”

But she did not.

As she stepped out of the shop, Phulkali tightened the knot of her bag. Girish involuntarily looked at her hands. There were old needle marks on her fingers.

At five in the evening, schoolteacher Ramesh Jha came to the shop.

“Do you have the one-hundred-and-sixty-page notebooks?”

“Yes.”

“Give me two. The children have started a new project.”

While handing over the notebooks, Girish asked, “A project?”

“They have to write the history of the old village pond. Every child needs a separate notebook.”

“Amar too?”

“Yes. He was especially excited. He said he would ask his maternal grandfather for old stories about the pond.”

Girish said only, “Hmm.”

Ramesh Jha left.

One notebook remained in the opened packet on the counter. Girish put it back on the shelf.

Evening deepened.

Girish had a fixed rule for closing the shop: first bring in the goods from the platform, then count the cash, then check the main ledger, and finally the change ledger.

That night, while matching the cash, he found a difference of three rupees.

He counted again. This time the difference was two rupees.

On the third count, the accounts matched.

He breathed in relief.

Then he opened the red Change Due ledger.

On the first page many old names had been crossed out. Beside some was written “to give,” beside others “to receive.”

He began entering the day’s new items—Shambhu Sah: two rupees to give; Rita Devi: one rupee to receive; Mukhtar Ansari: three rupees to give.

As he turned the page, his eyes stopped on an old entry.

“Phulkali Devi — 1 rupee to give.”

The date was five days old.

Girish frowned.

He remembered the incident.

Five days earlier Phulkali had bought half a kilo of flour and a bar of soap. The total was forty-nine rupees. She had given him a fifty-rupee note. The change bowl had been empty. Girish had said, "Take the one rupee later. I'm writing down your name."

Phulkali had laughed. "Come all the way to the shop again for one rupee?"

Girish had replied, "An account is an account."

And he really had written down her name.

For a long time Girish stared at that single line.

The sound of Amar's coins on the counter that afternoon returned to his mind.

"You're one rupee short."

He heard his own voice clearly.

Then the line in the red ledger: Phulkali Devi — 1 rupee to give.

Girish slowly sat down on the chair.

By the logic of accounts, Amar's purchase had not been incomplete. One rupee belonging to his household was already lying in this shop.

The shopkeeper owed the boy's family.

The first excuse that came to Girish's mind was that Amar did not know about it; Phulkali had not mentioned it either; the entry belonged to a different day.

But the excuse looked less clear than the red ink in the ledger.

He ran a finger along the corner of the page.

Then he took down a one-hundred-and-sixty-page notebook from the shelf.

He closed the shop, pulled the shutter halfway down, tucked the notebook under his arm, and set off towards Phulkali's house.

Her house was a ten-minute walk from Barhi market.

Twice on the way Girish thought: Amar will come tomorrow; I can give it then.

But it seemed to him that waiting until tomorrow would not delay the account—it would delay his own mind.

A small lamp was burning in front of Phulkali's house.

Amar lay on his stomach in the veranda, writing in his old notebook. The blue pen was in his hand.

On the last pages of the old notebook, he was searching for spaces between earlier writing and squeezing new lines into them.

The moment he saw Girish, he sat up. "Kaka?"

Phulkali came out from inside. "At this hour?"

Girish held the notebook out towards Amar. "This is yours."

Amar did not take it immediately. "I'll give the rupee tomorrow."

"You don't owe any rupee."

Phulkali looked at Girish's face.

Girish told them about the entry in the red ledger.

At first Phulkali tried to remember, then smiled faintly. "That one rupee? I had forgotten it completely."

"I hadn't forgotten," Girish said. "The ledger hadn't forgotten."

Amar still had not taken the notebook.

"So... this is from Ma's one rupee?"

"Yes. Your twenty-five, and the one I owed. Twenty-six complete."

A satisfaction came over Amar's face as though he had not been given a free notebook, but had found the correct place of his own account.

He took the notebook. "So I wasn't one rupee short?"

Girish's answer did not come at once.

Then he said, "No. I was the one who was one rupee short."

Phulkali burst out laughing. "A shopkeeper can be short too?"

Girish laughed as well. "If the ledger says so, one has to accept it."

Amar opened the new notebook. The first page was perfectly white.

With the blue pen he wrote the date at the top. Then the title: "The Pond of Our Village."

Girish stood watching for a few moments.

Phulkali asked, "Will you have tea?"

"No, I've left the shop half open."

"Then go. Otherwise someone may carry off the goods and the accounts will be thrown out again."

All three laughed.

Girish returned to the shop.

He raised the shutter, went inside, and opened the red ledger again.

He drew a straight line through the entry: "Phulkali Devi — 1 rupee to give."

Then, after thinking for a moment, he wrote below it: "Account complete."

His pen stopped.

After "Account complete," he added a small full stop.

The change bowl at the corner of the counter was still almost empty.

Girish looked at it and smiled.

For the first time he understood that an empty memory was more dangerous than an empty bowl.

The ledger was closed. The day's accounts were truly complete now.

Photo Studio

Jyoti Photo Studio at Benta Chowk in Darbhanga had been there for thirty years. The blue signboard outside had faded in many places, but 'Passport Photos in Ten Minutes' could still be read in thick white letters.

Inside, the owner, Pankaj Jha, still kept the wooden counter from his father's time. Beneath the counter glass were dozens of small photographs—someone's school identity card, someone's job application, someone's pension papers, someone's passport.

In the age of mobile phones, the work of the studio had changed. Fewer large wedding albums were made now; more photographs were taken for Aadhaar cards, examinations, bank documents and passports.

Pankaj used to say that people generally came to a studio not for their face, but for some piece of paper.

At around half past ten that Thursday, an elderly couple came in.

The man's name was Aniruddh Jha. His wife was Shail Devi. Both were past seventy.

Aniruddh carried a brown cloth bag; Shail Devi held a small purse.

Pankaj pulled two chairs forward. 'Please sit. What would you like?'

Aniruddh said, 'Passport-size photographs. Separately.'

'How many copies?'

'Four each.'

Opening the computer, Pankaj asked, 'For passports?'

'No.'

'Visa?'

Shail Devi laughed. 'Where are you sending the two of us at this age?'

Pankaj smiled too. 'Then pension papers?'

Aniruddh said, 'Not for papers.'

Pankaj stopped asking questions. A photographer did not have the right to know every reason.

He pulled down the white backdrop at the rear. Aniruddh was seated first on the stool.

'Head a little straighter.'

Aniruddh straightened his head.

‘Keep the glasses on?’ Pankaj asked.

Aniruddh looked at Shail Devi.

Shail said, ‘Keep them. Without the glasses, you don’t look like yourself.’

Pankaj lowered the light slightly. ‘There is glare on the lenses. I’ll change the angle.’

There was a small old scar above Aniruddh’s right eyebrow. Pankaj noticed it on the screen.

‘Shall I soften this scar a little?’

Before Aniruddh could answer, Shail Devi said, ‘No.’

‘All right.’

‘It has been with him for forty-five years,’ Shail said. ‘Let it remain in the photograph too.’

Aniruddh smiled. ‘I fell off a bicycle. The story won’t be written in the photograph.’

‘If the scar stays, the story will be remembered,’ Shail replied.

Pankaj raised the camera. ‘Try to look natural. Not too serious.’

For a moment Aniruddh’s face grew stiff, then relaxed. The shutter clicked.

Pankaj turned the screen towards them. ‘Have a look.’

Aniruddh looked. ‘Fine.’

Shail Devi leaned slightly forward. ‘The eyes are right. Keep this one.’

Now Shail Devi sat down. She straightened the end of her sari. The vermilion in the parting of her hair was very faint.

Pankaj asked, ‘Shall I fix this stray section of hair?’

‘As much as can be done by hand. Not by computer,’ Shail said.

Pankaj laughed. ‘All right.’

From behind, Aniruddh said, ‘The mole on the left cheek must stay.’

Shail turned at once. ‘Where will the mole go?’

‘These photographers make a great many things disappear.’

Pankaj said, ‘Nothing disappears here unless someone asks for it.’

The shutter clicked.

Shail looked at the screen.

‘The lines beneath my eyes show too much,’ she said.

Pankaj asked, ‘Shall I soften them a little?’

Shail was silent for two moments. Then she shook her head slightly. ‘No. Let them stay.’

Aniruddh said softly, ‘Let the photograph show the face that exists today.’

Hearing this, Pankaj looked again at the image on the screen.

Many customers said: remove the mark, brighten the complexion, fill in the hair, reduce the darkness under the eyes.

These two were worried about the opposite—that something might be removed.

Pankaj arranged four copies of each photograph. 'It will take twenty minutes.'

Aniruddh looked at his watch. 'We'll have tea and come back.'

They both went out.

While preparing the printer, Pankaj said to Deepak, 'Take out the photo paper.'

Deepak was in college and helped at the studio in the afternoons.

He looked at the elderly couple's pictures on the screen. 'Passport?'

'No.'

'Then?'

'They said it isn't for papers.'

Deepak laughed. 'What else is a passport-size photo for, apart from papers?'

Closing the printer tray, Pankaj said, 'Wait twenty minutes. I haven't understood either.'

The photographs came out of the printer.

Pankaj lifted each sheet and examined it in the light.

The lenses of Aniruddh's spectacles were clear. So was the scar above his eyebrow.

Shail Devi's mole, the fine lines beneath her eyes, the greying part of her hair—all remained in their places.

Technically, Pankaj did not find the photographs especially beautiful. But both faces looked as though they had not come to be made into photographs; they had come to have their presence recorded.

Twenty minutes later the couple returned.

Aniruddh carried two earthen tea cups. One was empty; a little tea remained in the other.

Shail Devi said, 'The tea across from your shop is still far too sweet.'

Pankaj cut the photographs into four-copy sets.

'Shall I write the names on the back?'

Aniruddh said at once, 'Yes.'

Shail added, 'And today's date with the name.'

Pankaj looked at her. 'The date?'

'Yes. The full date.'

Pankaj took a fine pen. On the back of the first set he wrote: 'Aniruddh Jha — 19 September 2026.'

On the second set: 'Shail Devi — 19 September 2026.'

Deepak was watching from behind the counter. His curiosity had grown.

Pankaj placed the two sets in separate white envelopes.

He held Aniruddh's envelope out towards Aniruddh.

Shail Devi extended her hand. 'Give that to me.'

Pankaj paused.

Then Aniruddh took the envelope containing Shail Devi's photographs. Deepak's eyes widened a little.

Pankaj smiled. 'Now I understand. Photographs of each other.'

Aniruddh said, 'Yes.'

'Some special occasion?'

Shail Devi sat down again. 'Call it special, or call it ordinary.'

Aniruddh opened the brown bag. From it he took out an old plastic album.

The corners of the album were worn.

He opened the first page.

A black-and-white wedding photograph. Aniruddh thin, his hair thick; Shail Devi's face round and full of shyness.

On the second page was a group photograph with the children. On the third, a school function. On the fourth, a Chhath ghat.

In almost every photograph they were together, or among several other people.

Aniruddh said, 'After our marriage, very few photographs of us were taken separately.'

Shail Devi said, 'There are thousands of photographs on the mobile. But whose hand the phone will be in, who will know the password, which photograph is where—I don't understand any of that.'

Pankaj asked softly, 'So this is why?'

Shail Devi pointed to an empty sleeve in the album.

'Last month my cousin died,' she said. 'Her family kept searching for one clear, recent photograph of her alone. In every photograph someone or other was with her. In the end they cropped her face out of a fifteen-year-old group photograph.'

Pankaj fell silent.

Shail continued, 'I didn't like that. And it wasn't only about a photograph after death.'

Aniruddh looked at her.

Shail said, 'I thought—if I go first, which face of mine will this man look at? The one from our wedding? The one from forty years ago?'

Aniruddh smiled gently. 'In that photograph she wasn't even looking at me. She was looking at the camera.'

'And in your old photograph you look so serious, as if you're angry with someone.'

Deepak could not suppress his laughter.

Aniruddh laughed too.

Shail Devi tapped the envelope in her hand. 'I want the face I have today. The face I see every day now. With the glasses. With the scar.'

Putting Shail Devi's envelope into his pocket, Aniruddh said, 'And I want this one with the lines under the eyes.'

Pankaj understood that the photographs were not being made for death, but to preserve the present form of life.

He asked, 'Won't you take one photograph together?'

Aniruddh said, 'We have plenty together.'

Shail added, 'We have very few separately. One day, when one of us is left, that person should have the other's face alone.'

For a few moments there was silence near the counter.

Outside, a tempo horn sounded. A student waiting to have a photograph taken peered into the shop.

Aniruddh took out his wallet.

Pankaj told him the charge.

Shail Devi took one of the four photographs and slipped it into the transparent pocket of her purse.

Aniruddh's face was immediately visible in the small rectangle.

Aniruddh placed one photograph of Shail Devi inside his old diary.

The remaining photographs would stay in the album at home.

They both stood up.

At the door, Shail Devi turned and asked, 'You wrote the date clearly on the photographs, didn't you?'

'Yes.'

'The date is important. Later people keep guessing the age.'

Pankaj said, 'It is written clearly.'

They left.

Deepak immediately asked, 'Bhaiya, have customers like that ever come before?'

Pankaj said, 'No.'

'Wasn't it a little sad?'

Pankaj turned towards the computer. 'Did it seem sad to you?'

Deepak thought. 'At first. Not afterwards.'

Pankaj did not reply.

Throughout the afternoon many people came. One student for an admit-card photograph, one woman for a bank account, two young men for job applications.

As he photographed each of them, Pankaj kept remembering Aniruddh and Shail Devi's words.

In the evening, while closing the shop, he looked at the old photographs kept beneath the counter glass.

In one corner was a photograph of his own parents.

It was about eighteen years old. His father's hair was half black then; his mother did not wear glasses.

Pankaj took the photograph out.

His father was now seventy-five. His mother seventy-two. Both lived at home, only two kilometres from the studio.

Pankaj photographed dozens of faces every day. He did not have a photograph of his own parents as they looked today.

There must have been many pictures on the mobile, of course. At someone's birthday, during worship, with the grandchildren. But a separate, direct portrait, without decoration—he did not know whether there was one.

That night at dinner Pankaj asked his mother, 'Are you free on Sunday?'

Serving dal, his mother asked, 'Why?'

'We'll go to the studio.'

His father looked up from the newspaper. 'Work even on Sunday?'

'Not work.'

'Then?'

Pankaj said, 'I'll photograph both of you.'

His father laughed. 'After so many years, you finally remembered?'

Pankaj laughed too. 'Yes. A little late.'

On Sunday morning Jyoti Photo Studio opened half an hour earlier than usual.

When Deepak arrived, he saw Pankaj's father seated on the stool in front of the white backdrop.

His mother stood near the counter adjusting her sari.

Deepak began to pick up the camera, but Pankaj said, 'Father alone first.'

His father asked, 'Not both together?'

Straightening the backdrop, Pankaj said, 'Together afterwards. Separately first.'

He set the camera.

His father began to remove his glasses.

Pankaj stopped him. 'Keep them on. Without the glasses, you don't look like yourself.'

His mother laughed from behind.

Pankaj raised the camera to his eye.

Through the glass, his father's present face was clear—white hair, spectacles, and all the lines on his forehead.

He clicked the shutter.

The Red Sweater

A little inside Station Road in Madhubani stood the small workshop of the Mithila Women's Weavers' Cooperative. As winter began, the place filled at once with the smell of wool, iron cupboards, measuring tapes, cardboard boxes and skeins of many colours.

Usha Devi was responsible for inspection at the cooperative. On her table that day lay a pile of twenty-seven sweaters. By evening they all had to be sent to different customers and to the shops of two schools.

She opened each sweater in turn, checked the stitching, counted the buttons, and measured chest and length with a tape.

"Number forty-two—correct."

Manju put a tick in the register.

"Forty-three?"

"Correct."

"Forty-four?"

Usha Devi snipped off a loose thread from inside the cuff. "Now it is correct."

A little before noon, her hand stopped on a deep red sweater. The colour was different from all the others—not bright vermilion, not maroon, but a deep red somewhere between the two. There were four black buttons in front, a simple round neck, and a small paper tag marked 47 inside the right chest.

Usha Devi measured the chest first. Correct.

She measured the length. Correct.

The right sleeve—twenty inches.

When she measured the left sleeve, her eyebrows rose.

Fourteen inches.

She placed the tape again.

Fourteen.

"Manju."

"Yes?"

"Look at the order slip for number forty-seven."

Manju took out the carbon copy kept inside the register. "Chest thirty-two, length twenty-two, sleeve twenty."

“Both sleeves?”

Manju gave a small laugh. “The slip only has one line for sleeve.”

Usha Devi spread the sweater over the table. The right sleeve was full length; the left was plainly shorter.

“Who made this?”

From a machine in the corner, Geeta Mandal, wrapped in a grey shawl, looked up. “I did.”

“Come here.”

Geeta stopped the machine and came to the table.

Usha Devi laid the measuring tape along the left sleeve. “Look at this.”

Geeta glanced once. “Yes.”

“What do you mean, yes? It is six inches short.”

“It isn’t short.”

“Manju, read the slip.”

Manju read again, “Sleeve twenty.”

Geeta said quietly, “The right one.”

Usha Devi looked at her. “The slip says nothing about right and left.”

Geeta straightened the left cuff with her fingers. “Even so, the measurement is not wrong.”

Two women sitting at machines in the workshop stopped and began looking over. Usha Devi disliked a crowd gathering at such moments. In an even voice she said, “If it is wrong, we will call it wrong. Is there any red wool left?”

Manju looked towards the cupboard. “A little. The whole sleeve can be made again, though the dye lot may be slightly different.”

Usha Devi turned to Geeta. “Unravel the left sleeve and remake it. The vehicle will come at four.”

Geeta immediately picked up the sweater.

Usha Devi assumed she was taking it to unravel, but Geeta carried it not to her machine, but to the top of the wooden cupboard by the window.

“Open it up.”

Geeta said, “Wait until three.”

“Why?”

“The person whose sweater it is will come.”

“And when the customer comes, we are going to show them a wrong sweater?”

“First we will have him try it on.”

Usha Devi’s voice hardened. “Geeta, the cooperative does not run on guesswork. The measurement is on the slip. The sleeve is six inches shorter than that. If something like this goes out, people will say the Mithila Women’s Weavers’ Cooperative supplies faulty goods.”

Geeta remained silent for a moment before answering. Then she said, "It will not be opened before three."

Usha Devi felt both anger and surprise. Geeta had been with the cooperative for nine years. She was not argumentative. She rarely made mistakes, and when she did, she was usually the first to admit them.

"How are you so certain?" Usha Devi asked.

Geeta said only, "I took the measurement."

"Then why isn't it on the slip?"

This time Geeta looked at Manju. Manju immediately lowered her eyes.

Usha Devi noticed.

"Manju?"

Manju hesitated. "There was a lot of crowd that day."

"Which day?"

"The day we went to take measurements near the Saurath health camp. Seventeen orders came at once."

Usha Devi pulled the register towards herself. Against number forty-seven was written: Sulekha Devi. Beneath the customer's name: Chandan Kumar, age thirteen. A phone number. That was all.

"Was anything special written down?"

Manju turned the slip over. The back was blank.

Geeta said, "I remember."

Usha Devi looked at the red sweater. She believed in the necessity of rules. An institution cannot run on memory—she had said this sentence many times in meetings.

"Everyone remembers differently," she said. "Paper says the same thing every time."

Geeta answered quietly, "Sometimes paper does not record the whole thing."

Usha Devi said nothing.

She began inspecting the next sweater, but the red remained at the edge of her vision.

One o'clock came. The women opened their lunch boxes and began eating. Usha Devi ate her rotis sitting at the table. Manju sat opposite on a stool with a box of dal.

"Do you remember the day at Saurath?" Usha Devi suddenly asked.

Manju paused while tearing a roti. "A little."

"Number forty-seven?"

"Not by name."

"How does Geeta remember anything?"

Manju scratched her head. "She was taking measurements. I was writing the slips. There were too many people. The health camp, vaccination, eye

examination—all in the same field. Some people placed sweater orders. Some were from schools too.”

“The red colour?”

Manju thought for a moment. “One child insisted on red. I remember that.”

“Anything else?”

“That’s all.”

Usha Devi finished eating. Then she took number forty-seven’s slip in her hand again. It had three lines: chest, length, sleeve.

For years she had been getting the same form printed. Child, old person, man, woman—the same three lines for everyone. Below them, colour. Then advance payment.

For the first time that day, the slip seemed very small to her.

At ten past two, the driver called. “Didi, not four. I’ll reach by half past three.”

Usha Devi looked at the clock.

The red sweater was still on top of the cupboard.

“Geeta,” she said, “if the customer doesn’t come, we’ll open it at two forty-five.”

Without stopping her machine, Geeta said, “They said three.”

“The vehicle will come at half past three.”

“This one isn’t going in the vehicle.”

“Then?”

“They will collect it themselves.”

Usha Devi fell silent for a moment. The slip indeed said “Self collection,” something she had not noticed earlier.

At two fifty-five a cycle-rickshaw bell rang outside.

Manju looked towards the door.

A woman entered first, about forty, a black shawl over her shoulders and a cloth bag in her hand. Behind her came a thin boy of thirteen or fourteen, wearing an old navy-blue sweater.

“Sulekha Devi?” Geeta asked, rising from her machine.

The woman smiled. “Yes. We’re not late, are we?”

“No.”

The boy came inside and looked around. His eyes went straight to the red sweater on top of the cupboard.

“Is that the one?” he asked.

Geeta smiled. “Yes, Chandan.”

Usha Devi looked at the boy. Then her gaze stopped on the left side of his old navy sweater.

The right sleeve reached normally to his wrist. The left sleeve had been folded into a thick cuff a little below the elbow and fastened inside with a small safety pin.

Usha Devi's hand involuntarily rested on the measuring tape lying on the table.

Geeta took down the red sweater. "Try it on."

Chandan removed his old sweater. He needed no help. His left arm had ended a little below the elbow since birth. He had folded up the left sleeve of his shirt as well.

Usha Devi looked once at Geeta.

Geeta said nothing.

Chandan put on the red sweater—first his right hand through the full sleeve, then the left side. The short sleeve ended neatly in a cuff at the end of his left arm. No cloth hung loose. Nothing needed folding. No pin was required.

The boy walked to the small mirror hanging on the wall in front.

He looked first at the right side, then the left. Then he straightened both shoulders.

"Is it all right?" Sulekha Devi asked.

Chandan did not answer for a few moments. He touched the left cuff with his fingers.

"This is the first sweater whose sleeve I don't have to fold," he said.

Geeta smiled. "So the measurement was right?"

Still looking at himself in the mirror, Chandan said, "Very right."

The workshop fell completely silent.

Usha Devi remembered what she herself had said only a short while earlier: the measurement is on the slip.

She picked up the slip.

"Sulekha Devi," she asked, "did you tell us this that day?"

"Yes," Sulekha Devi said. "There was a lot of crowd. I said the left sleeve should be measured separately. Geeta Didi herself took the measurement. I thought it had been written on the slip."

Manju said softly, "I missed it."

Sulekha Devi looked at her. "It doesn't matter. The sweater has turned out right."

Usha Devi said at once, "It does matter. If Geeta hadn't been here today, I would have opened it and made it wrong again."

Geeta laughed. "Then Chandan would have had to fold the sleeve again."

Chandan laughed too.

Sulekha Devi took the remaining payment from her bag. Usha Devi made out the receipt. As she handed it over, she looked once more at the red sweater.

Its two sleeves no longer looked unequal to her. Each was complete in its own place.

Chandan put the old navy sweater into the bag. He removed the safety pin and gave it to his mother.

“Keep this,” he said.

Sulekha Devi held the pin in her hand. “Why?”

Looking at the red sleeve, Chandan said, “I don’t need it for this anymore.”

The two of them left the workshop. The rickshaw was still waiting outside. As the deep red colour passed through the doorway into the sunlight, it appeared a little brighter.

The vehicle arrived at half past three. The remaining sweaters were packed into cardboard boxes and sent away.

As the workshop began to empty, Usha Devi stopped Manju.

“How many of the old order slips are left?”

“Two bundles.”

“Don’t throw them away. But from tomorrow we’ll add one line by hand.”

“What?”

Usha Devi took a blank slip. Beneath chest, length and sleeve, she drew a fourth line with her pen.

She wrote: “Special measurement / information given.”

Manju read it. “Will we include this in the next printing?”

“Yes.”

Geeta was covering her machine. Usha Devi looked at her.

“Geeta.”

“Yes?”

“Today you were more correct than the form.”

Geeta adjusted the shawl on her shoulder. “Now the form will become correct too.”

Usha Devi fixed the blank slip in the register together with the old tag marked 47 from the red sweater.

The tag still carried only a number.

But beneath it, a new line had already been drawn.

The Key

Almost all of Kamala Devi's belongings had been packed.

Two iron trunks, three cardboard boxes, the covered case of a sewing machine, four bundles of books, and the kitchen utensils in separate sacks.

Only one bamboo stool remained in the veranda, the one on which she had sat for fourteen years to drink tea in the evenings.

Harimohan Babu, the landlord, was now sitting on that stool.

Kamala stood before him holding a ring of keys.

"This is the main gate." She separated the first large key.

"This is the front room."

"This is the kitchen."

"This is the back door."

Harimohan Babu received them one by one into his palm.

There were four keys.

Kamala shook the ring again. One small brass-coloured key was tied with blue thread.

She paused slightly.

Harimohan Babu's eyes fell on it.

"That one too?" he asked.

Kamala turned the key between her fingers. "Yes. Usha Didi gave me this one."

Usha Devi had been Harimohan Babu's wife. She had died six years ago.

Harimohan Babu looked at the blue thread. "Which lock in my house does that open?"

Kamala did not answer at once.

Outside the veranda, the tempo driver was tightening the ropes. The new tenant's family was due to arrive by evening.

"The small room at the front," Kamala said softly.

Harimohan Babu raised his eyebrows. "The one whose door opens into the lane?"

"Yes."

"I thought that had been locked for years."

Kamala lowered her eyes. "It wasn't locked."

Harimohan Babu stood up.

Along the left side of the courtyard ran a narrow passage. At the end of it was a wooden door, barely two hand-spans wide, with a rusted little awning above and a padlock.

Harimohan Babu rarely went that way. His rooms were in the other part of the house.

Kamala inserted the blue-threaded key into the lock.

She turned it once.

The lock opened.

When the door was pushed inward, what came out was not the damp smell of a shut room, but the smell of chalk and old paper.

Harimohan Babu looked inside.

The room was not large. Along one wall were three low shelves. On them were books from Class Three through Class Ten, notebooks, old question papers, two dictionaries, a geometry box, and a globe from which half the colour had peeled away.

Four thin mats were folded on the floor.

A small blackboard hung on the wall. Written on it in chalk was: "Today, five o'clock — Mathematics practice."

The date was today's.

Harimohan Babu looked at Kamala's face.

"Classes were held here?"

"They are held here," Kamala said.

"Who teaches?"

Kamala smiled faintly. "Whoever knows something."

Harimohan Babu did not understand the answer.

Kamala took a thick notebook from one of the shelves. On the cover was written: "Evening Study."

The first page was very old. Its date was from fourteen years earlier.

Below it were five names: Rinku, Pinki, Sabita, Renu, Aarti.

Harimohan Babu placed a finger on the first name. "Rinku... isn't she Phulo Devi's daughter?"

"Yes."

"She works at a bank now."

"The same one."

On the following pages the names kept changing.

Beside some was written "Passed Class Ten," beside some "ITI," beside some "Nursing form," and beside others only a mark of attendance.

The handwriting changed from time to time.

Some pages were in Usha Devi's clear, rounded hand.

Some were Kamala's.

Many pages from the last year were in the quick, slightly slanted handwriting of a teenage girl named Rinki.

Harimohan Babu did not close the notebook.

"When did this begin?"

Kamala leaned against the doorframe.

"When I first came here, the front room had old sacks of paddy and a broken chair in it. One day Usha Didi saw Phulo Devi's daughter doing her homework on the veranda steps. There wasn't enough light in her house at night."

"Usha Didi had the room cleared. At first two girls sat here. Then four. Then people in the lane came to know."

Harimohan Babu kept listening.

"Didi used to say, better than letting a room stand empty is letting someone's book open inside it."

Kamala wiped the dust from a shelf with her finger.

"I was an assistant teacher at the school. Giving an hour in the evening wasn't difficult. Later the older girls began teaching the younger ones."

"After Usha died?" Harimohan Babu's voice grew softer.

"It remained closed for two days. On the third day the children came to the door at five o'clock."

Kamala laughed a little. "I opened the lock."

Harimohan Babu looked at the bulb on the wall. It was a new LED bulb.

"Electricity?"

"From the house meter."

Kamala quickly added, "I used to add a little to my rent for it. It had been that way since Usha Didi's time."

Harimohan Babu looked at her. "You never added anything to the rent."

Kamala fell silent.

"I paid the bill," Harimohan Babu said.

Kamala looked at him in surprise.

"You knew?"

Harimohan Babu looked at today's date on the blackboard.

"Not everything."

He turned the pages of the notebook.

"For a month after Usha died, I kept hearing children's voices from this side in the evenings. At first I thought they were playing in the lane."

He paused.

"One day the bulb fused."

Kamala said at once, "Yes. In the morning I found a box with a new bulb outside the door. I thought someone from Rinku's house had left it."

Harimohan Babu did not smile. He only said, "I left it."

For a long time Kamala said nothing.

Outside the room, the tempo driver called, "Maasi, where shall I put this box of books?"

Kamala called back, "At the back, on top of the trunk."

Then she turned to Harimohan Babu.

"Why did you never come inside?"

"It was Usha's work. Later it was yours."

"The house is yours."

"Every room belongs to the house. Not every task belongs to the owner."

Kamala placed the blue-threaded key on her palm.

"Now take this. The new tenants will come. I am moving two kilometres away to the government quarters."

Harimohan Babu did not take the key.

"Does anyone come at five?"

"Rinki is coming today. She is in Class Eleven. For three years she has been doing mathematics with the younger children."

"Rinki's house?"

"At the last turn in the lane. Her mother works in other people's homes."

Harimohan Babu brought the stool in from outside and placed it inside the room.

"Don't leave before five."

Kamala laughed. "The tempo driver won't wait for me."

"Let the luggage go. You can leave by rickshaw half an hour later."

For the first time that day, Kamala sat again on the stool.

The tempo left with the luggage. The veranda became empty.

The room that had been cleaned for the new tenant stood open. On the wall remained a pale square where Kamala's old calendar had hung.

At four fifty-five, the sound of slippers came from the lane.

Rinki arrived with three notebooks tucked under one arm. Two little girls followed her.

Seeing Kamala without her belongings, she stopped.

"Madam, have you already left?"

"Half," Kamala said.

Rinki did not understand.

Harimohan Babu stood at the doorway of the small room.

Kamala held out the blue-threaded key towards Rinki.

Rinki stepped back. "Me?"

"Yes."

"But this is a key to the house."

For the first time Harimohan Babu smiled faintly.

"I have received four keys to the house. This is the fifth."

Rinki took the key.

“I should keep it?”

Kamala said, “As long as someone younger than you keeps coming here at five.”

Rinki tied the key by its blue thread to the ribbon of her notebook.

One of the little girls went inside and began wiping the old writing from the blackboard.

The other opened a mat.

Kamala stood up and put her bag over her shoulder.

Harimohan Babu walked with her as far as the main gate.

“There will be less space in the quarters,” he said. “You could have left these books here.”

Kamala said, “Half the books are still here.”

Both turned and looked back.

The door of the little room stood open. Inside, Rinki sat with a notebook open. The two little girls were in front of her.

The old date on the blackboard had been erased.

Rinki was writing a new date.

Kamala stepped out through the gate.

Harimohan Babu closed the main gate, but left the small door into the lane open.

Ten Minutes

At ten minutes past five in the evening, the clock at Darbhanga Junction showed five ten.

Lalita Devi stood near the stairs on Platform One and looked once more at her paper.

On the back, in blue ink, were written: "Platform 3, S-4, Seat 52."

She looked up at the electronic display. The letters were changing. An announcement came, but half the words dissolved into the iron roof, the voices of people, and the whistle of an engine.

Lalita Devi asked the tea seller beside her, "The train to Patna is on Platform Three?"

Without looking up, the tea seller said, "Yes, Three. Ten minutes left."

"Ten minutes?"

"Look at the clock."

Lalita Devi looked at the clock again.

In her hand was an old cloth bag containing a plastic file. Inside the file were the original residential certificate, a copy of the date-of-birth document, and two photographs.

Renu had told her three times on the phone, "Mausi, only the original residential certificate. I have everything else."

When leaving home, Lalita Devi had put the other papers in along with the certificate.

In matters like these, she did not trust the words "only this much."

She moved towards the stairs.

Just then a young man came quickly from behind and said, "Platform Three?"

Lalita Devi turned.

He carried a brown envelope in one hand and a black bag over his shoulder. Fine beads of sweat stood on his forehead.

"I'm going there too," Lalita said.

The young man looked at the clock. "The train leaves in ten minutes."

"Why is everyone repeating that to me?"

The young man laughed for the first time. "Perhaps because you walk slowly."

"Not slowly. My knee hurts."

His smile vanished at once. "Give me the bag."

"No, I'll carry it."

"You have to climb the stairs."

Lalita tightened her grip on the bag. "There are documents in it."

"I have documents in my hand too."

For a moment each looked at what the other was carrying.

Lalita handed him the bag.

"Name?" the young man asked.

"Of the bag?"

"Yours."

"Lalita Devi."

"I'm Shashank."

"Full name later. Platform Three first."

They began climbing the stairs.

The footbridge above was crowded. A family stood in the middle of the way with four bags. Two children clung to the railing and looked down at the engine.

Shashank went ahead, making a path. Lalita followed behind.

Halfway up the stairs, Lalita stopped to catch her breath.

"You go," she said. "I'll come."

Shashank stopped. "I also have to hand over a document. There is only one train."

"Then do your work first."

"The person I have to give it to has switched off the phone."

"Mine isn't connecting either."

They looked at each other again.

Shashank said, "Why do all phones stop working at railway stations at the same time?"

Lalita said, "People run. Perhaps the phones get tired."

Shashank burst out laughing.

As he laughed, his grip loosened and the brown envelope slipped between his fingers.

It fell near the railing.

Before Shashank could bend, a child's foot moved towards it.

Lalita did not carry a walking stick, but her right hand darted out and picked up the envelope.

"Laugh less when you're carrying documents," she said.

Shashank took the envelope. "Now the account is even. I carried your bag; you picked up my envelope."

"The account is not even yet."

Another announcement came: the train bound for Patna would depart from Platform Three at its scheduled time.

Shashank looked at the clock.

Five thirteen.

"Seven minutes," he said.

"Now you've started counting too?"

They crossed the bridge.

The crowd was denser on Platform Three. The train stood there. The coach numbers were visible at intervals along its length.

Lalita took a folded paper from the small pocket inside her blouse.

"S-4," she read. "Seat fifty-two."

Shashank did not look surprised, but immediately said, "I have to go towards the sleeper coaches too."

"What seat is your person on?"

"I don't know the seat."

"Then how will you find him?"

"I know the name."

"You'll find a coach by a name?"

"It would be easier if the phone connected."

Lalita held out her paper to him. "First find S-4. Once we reach there, you look for your person and I'll look for my girl."

"All right."

S-1 was behind them. They moved forward along the coaches.

Peanuts, water, tea, books, voices—everything moved together on the platform.

Lalita could not walk quickly. Shashank would go two steps ahead from time to time, then stop and let her catch up.

As they reached S-3, the train gave a slight jerk.

Lalita stopped short. "Has it started?"

"No. They must have coupled the engine."

"Are you sure?"

"No."

"Then why did you say it with such confidence?"

"You were frightened."

"I wasn't frightened. I only asked."

Shashank smiled.

S-4 was in front of them.

The clock showed five sixteen.

"Four minutes," Shashank said.

"Be quiet."

They climbed into the coach.

Inside, people were arranging their sheets, bottles and bags. Seat 52 was by the window.

The seat was empty.

Lalita stopped.

"Renu?" she called.

An elderly woman sitting opposite the window said, "That girl has gone to get water."

Shashank's face changed at once.

"What name did you say?"

Lalita looked at him. "Renu."

"Renu Kumari?"

"Yes."

"Belahi Girls' High School?"

Lalita narrowed her eyes. "How do you know her?"

Shashank raised the brown envelope.

"I've come from the school."

Lalita said nothing for a few moments.

"What's in that?"

"Her character certificate and the marksheet attested by the headmaster. The seal was put on this afternoon. Renu called at four to ask whether someone could bring them to the station."

Lalita opened her bag and took out the plastic file.

"She called me and said the original residential certificate had been left at home."

Shashank looked at the file, then at his own envelope.

"She told me she had everything else."

"She told me the same."

They did not laugh together.

The same realization came to both of them at once.

Everything else Renu needed was, in fact, lying in two different places.

One document at home.

One at the school.

And each of them had assumed the other document was already with her.

A whistle sounded outside.

The elderly woman said, "The train is about to leave."

Lalita turned towards the door. "Where has Renu gone?"

Just then a thin girl came hurrying down the aisle carrying two bottles of water.

“Mausi!”

Renu saw Lalita first, then Shashank.

“Shashank Sir?”

“Not Sir,” Shashank said. “Clerk.”

Renu laughed between breaths.

“Both of you?”

Lalita handed her the file. “Your ‘everything else’ was lying in quite a few places.”

Shashank gave her the brown envelope. “Open this and check it now.”

Renu sat down on the seat and opened both.

“Original residential certificate.”

“Yes.”

“Character certificate.”

“Yes.”

“Marksheet.”

“Yes.”

Renu suddenly fell silent.

“I need all three for verification in Patna tomorrow,” she said softly.

Lalita said, “You told me about only one.”

“I thought the school papers wouldn’t be ready by evening.”

Shashank said, “And I thought the document from home was already in your bag.”

Renu pressed both sets of papers to her chest.

A second whistle sounded outside.

The guard raised the green flag.

Shashank said, “Now we’re getting off.”

Lalita turned too.

Renu caught her hand. “Mausi—”

“Nothing. Call when you reach.”

Shashank stepped down from the coach. Lalita followed.

The train began to move slowly.

Renu came and stood at the doorway.

“I got both sets of papers!” she called, as though seeking confirmation once again.

Lalita raised her hand.

Shashank did too.

S-4 moved slowly ahead.

Then S-5, S-6.

At last the red guard’s coach receded into the distance.

The crowd on the platform suddenly seemed a little thinner.

Lalita took a deep breath.

Shashank still had her bag hanging from his shoulder.

Lalita said, "My bag."

Shashank started. "Oh."

He took it off and gave it to her.

"Now the account is even," Shashank said.

Taking the bag, Lalita said, "No."

"What's left now?"

"You carried my bag. I picked up your envelope. You showed the way. I gave you the seat number. If we start settling accounts, ten minutes will pass."

Shashank looked at the clock.

Five twenty.

At that very moment, the minute hand of the station's large clock reached the four.

For a few moments both of them looked at it.

Lalita said, "Ten minutes is a very short time."

Shashank did not reply.

As they walked towards the bridge stairs, he looked at his empty hand, where the brown envelope had been only a short while earlier.

Lalita felt the light weight of her bag.

Both of them were walking slowly now.

Behind them, an announcement for the next train began on the platform.

The Last Customer

On the old wooden sign outside Ramsevak Thakur's shop, faded blue letters read: "Ramsevak Hair Cutting."

The blue paint had worn away long ago in many places. Half the "r" in "Hair" had peeled off, and a black rain stain marked the final "g" of "Cutting."

That day, a sheet of white paper had been pasted beneath the sign: "Last Day Today."

Ramsevak had not written it. Bhola, who ran the paan shop next door, had written it that morning with a thick sketch pen.

Ramsevak read it and said, "Why such big letters?"

Bhola laughed. "So people will understand."

"Those who need to understand will understand even without the paper."

Even so, he did not remove it.

The shop was thirty-nine years old. On one wall hung a large mirror. Beneath it was a narrow wooden shelf holding combs, scissors, a razor, brushes, a tin of powder, and small bottles.

In the middle stood a heavy iron barber's chair whose red cushion had worn through in several places. There was a ceiling fan, but its regulator acknowledged only two speeds: very fast and almost off.

Ramsevak's nephew Nandu had been packing things since morning.

"Kaka, shall we keep this old machine?" Nandu asked.

Ramsevak lifted his head and looked. It was a black electric clipper with a cord, now seldom used.

"No. Take whatever still works."

"Who will use a machine like this in my shop?"

"Then throw it away."

Winding the cord around the machine, Nandu said, "If I throw it away, you'll say again—it was from my time."

Ramsevak smiled. "Not everything from my time is worth preserving."

Nandu had his own new shop on Station Road: a glass door, two swivel chairs, bright lights, music controlled by a mobile phone. Its name was "New Look."

Ramsevak had been there twice. He liked the shop, though he found it too shiny.

“Shall I put this chair there?” Nandu asked, tapping the old iron chair.

“There isn’t room.”

“I’ll make room.”

“No. The landlord will keep it here. He said he’ll decide about the old things later.”

In fact, this row of the old market was to be demolished from the following week. The landlord had given all the tenants notice three months earlier. Ramsevak could have opened a small shop somewhere else if he wished, but he had chosen not to.

“Thirty-nine years is enough,” he told everyone.

People did not believe him.

“If a barber stops working, what will he do?”

Ramsevak would say, “People will go on growing their hair. I’ll keep watching.”

By afternoon the number of customers was greater than on an ordinary day. Some came for a haircut, some for a shave, some simply to talk.

Some came even though they did not need a haircut.

Nagendra Babu, a retired postmaster, arrived at ten. His hair had been cut only the previous week.

“Even it out a little near the ears,” he said.

Ramsevak looked. “It’s already even.”

“Still. A little.”

Ramsevak moved the scissors twice.

Nagendra Babu looked in the mirror. “Now it’s right.”

As he paid, he said, “Don’t consider this the last.”

Ramsevak put the money in the drawer. “The hair will grow again, Babu. Only the shop won’t be here.”

At noon Bhola from the paan shop brought tea. Nandu continued separating empty boxes, old towels and spare bottles.

“Kaka, shall I pack everything?” Nandu asked.

“Not everything.”

“What’s left?”

Ramsevak set aside a black comb, a pair of round-tipped scissors, a small spray bottle and a white cloth on the shelf.

Nandu looked at them. “Who are these for?”

“Leave them.”

“Is your last customer still to come?”

Ramsevak looked at the clock. “There is time yet.”

Towards five in the evening people began coming again. Someone took a photograph. Someone shook Ramsevak's hand. At six forty-five, Sahdev Jha, a retired school headmaster, arrived.

"I am the last customer," he announced as soon as he reached the door.

Bhola from outside called, "It isn't seven yet."

Sitting in the chair, Sahdev Babu said, "Then cut mine slowly."

His haircut took twenty minutes. Then his beard was trimmed. At the end Ramsevak brushed the back of his neck.

Sahdev Babu stood up, looked at his head in the mirror and said, "I am the last customer of a thirty-nine-year-old shop. Write that down."

Bhola laughed. Nandu did too.

Ramsevak only said, "Seventy rupees."

"You charge even the last customer?"

"I charged the first one too."

Sahdev Babu put down seventy rupees and went out. The people standing outside teased him:

"Your name has entered history."

At seven fifteen the last ordinary customer left.

Nandu swept the floor. Small clumps of hair gathered to one side. Ramsevak washed the razor and put it in its box. He closed the powder tin. The bottles were wrapped in paper.

At seven forty-five Ramsevak pulled the shutter halfway down.

Bhola asked from outside, "That's it?"

"Not yet."

"Then what?"

Ramsevak did not answer.

Nandu looked again at the comb, scissors, spray bottle and white cloth still lying out.

"These four are still outside."

"Yes."

"Someone is coming?"

"Yes."

"Who?"

"You'll see when he comes."

At eight five most shutters in the market had come down. The paan shop was still open, though there were few customers. A vegetable seller was beginning to turn his cart homeward.

Nandu looked at his phone. "Kaka, I have to go."

"Go."

"You'll be alone?"

"I'll close the shop."

Nandu went as far as the doorway, then stopped. "The customer who's coming—shall I cut his hair?"

Ramsevak said, "Sit."

Nandu sat again on the plastic stool.

At eight twelve, two pairs of feet stopped outside the half-lowered shutter.

A woman bent and looked in. With her was a boy of about twelve.

Seeing the shutter, the woman said, "Montu, the shop has closed. Come."

The boy immediately began to turn away.

Ramsevak called from inside, "Bindu! Here."

The woman bent again. "Kaka? I thought everything was closed."

"His chair is empty."

The boy looked through the half-open doorway. The shop did not have its usual crowd. The radio was off. The fan was off. Only one tube light was burning.

Ramsevak raised the shutter a little.

Montu came slowly inside.

He did not sit in the chair at once. First he looked at the comb on the shelf.

Then the scissors. Then the spray bottle.

"Machine?" he asked.

"No," Ramsevak said.

"Radio?"

"No."

"Fan?"

"Slow, if you feel hot."

Montu sat in the chair.

Nandu remained silently on the stool.

Bindu said, "Kaka, even if you didn't do it today—tomorrow somewhere else—"

Montu immediately said, "No."

Bindu fell silent.

Ramsevak fastened the white cloth around his neck.

"Remember the order?" Ramsevak asked.

Montu looked at him in the mirror.

"Right side first."

"Then?"

"Left."

"Then?"

"Back."

"The top?"

Montu paused. "Last."

Ramsevak picked up the scissors.

Montu had first come to this shop about two years earlier. By then his mother Bindu had already tried three shops. In a crowd Montu would not remain seated in the chair. At the whirring sound of a clipper he would cover his ears and get up. Some people scolded him; others advised holding him down firmly.

On the first day Ramsevak had simply let him sit in the chair for five minutes. He had not cut his hair.

The second time he called them after the shop had closed.

Radio off. Fan slow. No machine. First he let Montu touch the comb. Then, from a distance, he made the scissors go “snip-snip” twice so the boy could hear the sound.

That day only the hair on the right side was cut.

The third time, the rest.

After a few months Montu began having his entire haircut done in one visit.

But the time remained the same—after the shop had emptied.

Nandu had not known any of this before.

He watched Montu in the mirror. Ramsevak moved the scissors very slowly. The comb once through the hair, the scissors twice. Then a pause.

Montu kept counting the four small scratches on the arm of the chair with his finger.

“One.”

The comb.

“Two.”

The scissors.

“Three.”

The scissors again.

“Four.”

Ramsevak stopped. “Right side done.”

Montu gave a slight nod.

Nandu instinctively took his phone from his pocket, then immediately put it back.

The left side began.

Bindu stood near the door. Seventy rupees were already folded in her hand.

In the middle of the haircut a motorcycle passed outside, sounding its horn loudly. Montu’s shoulders tightened.

Ramsevak stopped the scissors.

After a few moments Montu sat straight again.

“Now,” he said.

Ramsevak resumed.

At eight forty-two the haircut was finished.

Ramsevak did not brush the back of Montu's neck. Montu disliked the brush. Instead, he removed the loose hair gently with a small towel.

"Mirror?" Ramsevak asked.

Montu first looked into the mirror in front of him. Then Ramsevak handed him the smaller mirror for the back.

Montu looked at the right, the left and the back.

"Fine."

At that one word, Bindu let out her breath.

She held out seventy rupees.

Ramsevak took the money.

Bindu was surprised. "Today is the last day. I thought—"

Ramsevak put the money in the drawer. "The rate doesn't change on the last day."

Bindu laughed.

Montu climbed down from the chair. At the doorway he turned back.

"Next time?"

Ramsevak remained silent for a few moments.

For the first time Nandu looked at Ramsevak as though he too needed the answer to that question.

Ramsevak picked up the black comb and the round-tipped scissors from the shelf. He wrapped both in the white cloth.

Then he placed the bundle in Nandu's hand.

Nandu stared. "For me?"

Ramsevak said, "Your shop closes at eight on Sundays?"

"Yes."

"One Sunday a month, at eight ten, keep the radio off."

Nandu looked at Montu.

Ramsevak continued, "No machine. Right side first, then left, then the back. The top last."

Montu kept looking at Nandu.

Nandu slowly repeated, "Right first. Then left. Then back. The top last."

Montu asked, "Fan?"

"Slow," Nandu said.

"Brush?"

Nandu looked at Ramsevak.

Ramsevak said, "No brush."

Nandu repeated, "No brush."

Montu thought for a moment. "Fine."

Bindu wiped her now-empty hand on the end of her sari.

"Come, Montu."

They went out.

The market was almost closed. Bhola at the paan shop was still watching from a distance.

He shouted, "Kaka, now truly the last?"

Ramsevak did not answer.

Nandu stood holding the small bundle wrapped in white cloth.

Ramsevak picked up the small spray bottle left on the shelf, poured the water into the drain outside, and put the bottle in his bag.

Then he opened the drawer.

The day's notes and coins lay inside. Sahdev Babu's seventy rupees were on top, Montu's seventy beneath them.

Ramsevak did not separate the two.

He closed the drawer.

For a moment he stood before the mirror. The chair was empty.

Nandu asked, "Shall we take down the sign?"

Ramsevak looked outside. The old wooden sign hung slightly crooked in the darkness. Beneath it the white sheet of paper was still pasted:

"Last Day Today."

Ramsevak said, "The landlord will take it down tomorrow."

He switched off the light.

The shutter came down slowly.

Outside, darkness settled over the shop, but the small bundle of white cloth in Nandu's hand remained clearly visible.

The Broken Clock

The first time Madhavi took the old clock down into her hands, it seemed to her less a clock than some ancient stubbornness of the house.

A square wooden body. Varnish peeled away at the corners. A thin crack along the right side of the glass. Inside, two brass-coloured hands moved in the opposite direction from those of an ordinary clock.

Even the numerals were arranged in reverse order.

Twelve at the top, but one on the left and eleven on the right.

Madhavi laughed. "See? This is my broken clock."

Standing on a chair, Aniruddh took the clock from her.

"Broken?"

"Yes. It runs, but backwards."

"Then it isn't broken. It should be called mad."

"Babu says the same thing."

The room smelled of dust. Four thin bands of Magh sunlight fell through the window bars. For the past three months there had been talk of whitewashing the house after the wedding, but whitewashing was not the real reason the room was being cleared.

After Madhavi's marriage, her father was thinking of renting out the front room, and so the old belongings were being sorted.

This room had once belonged to Madhavi's grandmother, Janakdulari Devi.

Janakdulari Devi had been dead eleven years.

The bed had already been removed. The iron trunk had been shifted to the back storeroom. On the wall only two hooks, an old nail, and the clock remained.

Madhavi said, "Babu says to throw it away. I told him I'd have it repaired."

Aniruddh held the clock to his ear.

Tick.

Tick.

Tick.

The sound was clear.

For a few moments he stood silent, watching his own shadow fall across the opposite wall.

“The mechanism works.”

“It tells time backwards.”

“A watch repairer will look at it.”

Madhavi ran a finger over the back of the clock. On the wood were very old letters written in white chalk: “J.D.”

“Nani’s name.”

“Janakdulari Devi?”

“Yes.”

Aniruddh wrapped the clock in a cloth.

Madhavi added, “Have it made straight. The numerals too. After the wedding we’ll put it in the new house.”

“Where?”

“In the study.”

Aniruddh smiled. “The study is already ready?”

“The room is decided. The books will go later.”

“And me?”

“You’ll get whatever space remains after the books.”

They both laughed.

Aniruddh did not put the clock in the storage box of his motorcycle. The box was too small. He placed it in a bag, hung the bag from the handlebar, and rode slowly towards the market.

Badri Sah’s watch shop on Station Road in Madhubani was still there, though two letters had fallen from the word “Repairing” on the sign outside: “Badri Watch Repairing.”

The shop was very small.

One glass cabinet.

Clocks on three walls.

On the table lay tiny screwdrivers, tweezers, a lens, a bottle of oil, and hands of different sizes.

Badri Sah was over seventy now. His son Pravin did most of the work, but Badri Sah still opened up the old wall clocks himself.

Aniruddh placed the clock on the table.

“This has to be made straight.”

Badri Sah pushed his spectacles higher.

“Doesn’t it run?”

“It runs. It runs backwards.”

Badri Sah looked at the face of the clock.

His hand stopped midway.

“Where did you bring this from?”

Aniruddh gave the name of the village.
 “Whose house?”
 Aniruddh gave the name of Madhavi’s father.
 Badri Sah looked at the clock again.
 “Janakdulari Devi’s?”
 Aniruddh was startled.
 “You knew her?”
 Badri Sah did not answer. He turned the clock over and saw the “J.D.” on the wooden back.
 “I made this.”
 “You?”
 “Not made. Modified.”
 He called to Pravin, “Give me that old large screwdriver.”
 Pravin handed it to him and, glancing at the clock, laughed.
 “That’s the backwards clock.”
 Badri Sah looked at him. “Backwards is an easy word.”
 Four screws came out.
 When the rear cover was removed, the metal mechanism inside became visible.
 Badri Sah fitted the lens to his eye.
 “The spring is fine.”
 He turned one wheel gently with a finger.
 “The teeth are fine.”
 Then he said, “There is nothing wrong with this clock even now.”
 Aniruddh asked, “Then why do the hands move backwards?”
 “Because that is how it was meant to move.”
 Aniruddh fell silent.
 Badri Sah pushed his chair back.
 “Before making it straight, there is something we need to see.”
 He told Pravin to mind the shop and stood up.
 “Come.”
 “Where?”
 “To their house.”
 Aniruddh thought Badri Sah was joking, but the old man took a key from the cabinet and stepped outside.
 “Bring the clock.”
 They went on foot. The house was not very far.
 Badri Sah spoke little on the way.
 Only once did he ask, “Is Janakdulari Devi’s room still as it was?”
 “Almost empty.”
 “The mirror?”

“What mirror?”

This time Badri Sah looked at Aniruddh.

“Then half the story is still there.”

When they reached the house, Madhavi’s father, Shyamkant Jha, was sitting in the veranda warming himself in the sun.

Seeing Badri Sah, he stood up at once.

“Arre, Badriji?”

“After a long time.”

Shyamkant’s eyes fell on the clock in Aniruddh’s hands.

“So it has reached your shop?”

Madhavi came out from inside.

“So quickly?”

Aniruddh said, “The clock went with me to be repaired. It has brought me back to study history.”

Madhavi looked at Badri Sah.

“You know this clock?”

“A little.”

Badri Sah went into the room.

He looked at the empty wall.

Then he pointed towards the corner opposite the window.

“Was there a cupboard here?”

Shyamkant said, “Yes. Nani’s wooden cupboard. We put it in the small storeroom last year.”

“And a mirror on it?”

Shyamkant fell silent.

Madhavi looked at his face.

“Babu?”

Shyamkant said softly, “Yes. A small square mirror.”

“Where is it?”

“With the cupboard.”

They all went to the small storeroom.

There, a tin trunk, two bamboo baskets, an old low wooden seat and the cupboard stood pressed close together.

On the cupboard door, beneath the dust, was a square mirror.

Badri Sah said, “Bring it out.”

Aniruddh and Shyamkant shifted the cupboard.

The mirror showed clearly in the window light.

Badri Sah handed the clock to Madhavi.

“Hold it against that wall.”

Madhavi held the clock near the old hook but did not hang it.

“Now look in the mirror.”

Madhavi turned towards the mirror.
 For a moment she said nothing.
 In the mirror, the numerals on the clock were in their proper order.
 One on the right.
 Eleven on the left.
 The hands appeared to move in the ordinary direction of a clock.
 Aniruddh took out his mobile and checked the time.
 In the mirror, the clock was only one minute behind the mobile.
 Madhavi looked again at the actual clock.
 There the hands moved backwards.
 Then at the mirror.
 There the time was completely ordinary.
 "This..."
 Badri Sah said, "It was made for the mirror."
 Shyamkant stood holding the veranda doorframe.
 Madhavi turned to her father.
 "Why?"
 The answer came not from Badri Sah but from Shyamkant.
 "At one time the right side of your grandmother's body became very weak."
 He did not say the word "paralysis." His voice remained entirely matter-of-fact.
 "The bed was here. She could turn to the left, but it was difficult for her to look to the right. The clock was on the wall behind her head."
 Slowly Madhavi began to understand the arrangement of the room.
 Where the bed must have been.
 Where the cupboard stood.
 At what angle the mirror faced.
 Shyamkant continued, "At first she kept asking the time again and again. When is the medicine? When is the radio programme? Has it become time for you to come home from school?"
 Badri Sah smiled faintly.
 "One day she called for me."
 A trace of the old day came alive in his voice.
 "She said, 'Badri, can you make a clock that runs straight in the mirror?'"
 Aniruddh asked, "And you made one?"
 "At first I said, 'Buy a new clock.' She said, 'What will a new clock do? I need the time in the mirror.'"
 Madhavi's fingers rested motionless on the wooden case.

Badri Sah said, "I removed the old mechanism and fitted one that ran in the reverse direction. I changed the numeral strip too. Such parts were not easy to get in the market then. Twice I had to bring parts from Patna."

"So Nani kept reading the time?" Madhavi asked.

Shyamkant said, "Yes."

"Why don't I remember?"

"You were living in a hostel then. You came during holidays. To you it was simply the clock in Nani's room."

Madhavi kept looking at the mirror.

A blurred memory returned to her.

Nani sitting on the bed.

The radio news about to begin.

Nani glancing once into the mirror and saying, "It is five o'clock."

At the time Madhavi had thought her grandmother somehow knew the time by herself.

There had been no clock inside that memory.

Only Nani's certain voice.

Aniruddh asked, "Then it wouldn't be right to make it straight?"

Badri Sah said, "I can."

He took the clock in his hands.

"A normal mechanism can be fitted. The numeral strip can be changed. Two hours."

Madhavi did not answer immediately.

Shyamkant said, "But who will look at it through a mirror now?"

It was a practical question.

The clock's old use had ended.

Madhavi looked at the cracked glass.

"Can the glass be replaced?"

"Yes."

"The wood cleaned?"

"Yes."

"The mechanism?"

"This one still runs."

"Then don't change it."

Shyamkant looked at his daughter.

"You'll keep a backwards clock in your new house?"

Madhavi did not laugh.

"The new house will have a mirror too."

Aniruddh said, "The mirror has reached the study before the books."

Madhavi glared at him, but this time she could not hold back a smile.

Badri Sah wrapped the clock again in the cloth.

"I'll only replace the glass. Clean it. Oil it."

"And write one thing on the back."

"What?"

Madhavi thought for a moment.

"Do not straighten it?" Aniruddh suggested.

Madhavi shook her head.

"No. Why leave an order for someone who doesn't understand?"

Badri Sah waited.

Madhavi said, "Only write the date when you changed it, if you remember."

Badri Sah's face grew a little serious.

"I remember the date."

"After so many years?"

"Not every date. Some work remembers its own date."

The next evening Aniruddh brought the clock back.

The glass was new.

The wood was clean, but its old scratches had been left as they were.

On the back, Badri Sah had written in small letters:

"Modified for the mirror — 17 July 2001.

Glass replaced — 19 September 2026."

Madhavi looked at the writing for a long time.

Then she hung the clock not in the room but in the veranda.

Shyamkant asked, "Here?"

"For now."

The clock went on turning backwards.

Anyone looking directly at it in the veranda would think it was wrong.

After dinner that night, Madhavi brought the mirror from the small storeroom. Not the entire cupboard—only the old square mirror.

Aniruddh had brought tools for removing the screws.

Together they fixed the mirror to the wall opposite the clock in the veranda.

Shyamkant sat in a chair and watched everything.

When the work was finished, Aniruddh looked at his mobile.

Eight eighteen.

Madhavi looked into the mirror.

The clock too showed eight eighteen.

Shyamkant looked directly at the clock.

Then at the mirror.

Then at the clock again.

For a long time he said nothing.

At last he rose to go inside.

At the doorway, without turning, he said, "Your nani used to listen to the nine o'clock news."

Madhavi looked at the clock in the mirror.

It was now eight nineteen.

She did not go to look for the radio in the veranda.

She simply pulled a chair in front of the mirror and sat down.

Aniruddh sat beside her.

On the wall itself, the clock went on running backwards.

In the mirror, time moved steadily forward.

The Sweet Box

Seema Devi was more concerned about the box than about the taste of the sweets.

“Take an ordinary cardboard box,” her daughter Mrinal said. “We’ll eat the sweets, not the box.”

Seema Devi kept looking at the glossy boxes arranged behind the shop’s glass display. Red, golden, blue, deep green. Some had raised flowers, some fine latticework. In the middle was a rigid cream-coloured box with a golden border and a small clasp that looked like brass.

“How much is this one?”

The shopkeeper, Naresh Sah, said, “The sweets are separate. The box is on deposit. Leave three hundred rupees; return the box clean and you get the three hundred back.”

Mrinal burst out laughing. “There. The matter is settled. Take an ordinary box.”

Seema Devi gave her a look. “Everything seems simple to you.”

The next day Anup’s family was coming from Samastipur to meet Mrinal.

Seema Devi did not like the phrase ‘coming to see her’; Mrinal had been teaching in a school for seven years, earned her own salary, and made her own decisions. Even so, in family conversation people still said, ‘They are coming to see the girl.’

Mrinal had already made herself clear: no display, no expensive decoration, no piles of gifts. Tea, savouries, a little sweet. That was all.

Seema Devi agreed with her. But agreement and the fear lodged inside the heart are not the same thing.

“What do people notice first?” she asked quietly. “The house, the utensils, the serving, the box. They remember the taste of the sweets later.”

Mrinal said, “Anyone who has come to inspect the box need not inspect me.”

Naresh Sah suppressed a smile. “Didi, many people take this box on deposit. The occasion ends, the box comes back. Nobody is taking it home to build a cupboard.”

Seema Devi looked once more at the cream-coloured box. "Pack one kilo of kaju barfi and half a kilo of peda in this."

Mrinal shook her head but said nothing.

Naresh Sah placed the box on the counter and wrote a small '17' with a black marker on its underside. Then he wrote 17 on a narrow slip of paper and handed it to Seema Devi.

"Return the box with this slip. Within seven days."

Seema Devi put the slip in her purse.

On the way home Mrinal said, "Ma, what if someone turns the box over tomorrow and reads the number?"

"Will people eat the sweets or turn the box over?"

"Hard to say."

Seema Devi laughed. "You find jokes only at my expense."

From morning the next day, the house was in a stir. Seema Devi changed the tablecloth twice. The first had a faint stain in one corner; the second was clean but faded. In the end she put the first one back and placed a flower vase over the stain.

Mrinal wore a simple blue cotton sari. Seema Devi said once, "You could wear the silk one."

"Is this a school function or an exhibition?"

"All right, all right."

At three in the afternoon Anup arrived with his father, Devkinandan Jha, his mother Usha Devi, and his younger sister Pooja. Anup did not work in a bank; he was in the accounts department of a private publishing firm in Patna. Mrinal had already laughed at the fact that both families had asked so plainly about professions during the very first phone conversation.

The meeting remained easy. Anup spoke little, but when Mrinal brought up the school library, he listened attentively. Pooja went as far as the kitchen and asked Seema Devi, "Aunty, I don't take sugar in tea." Seema Devi immediately made a separate cup.

Opening the sweet box on the table, Devkinandan Babu said, "I don't usually eat much kaju barfi, but today I'll have one."

A small wave of satisfaction rose inside Seema Devi. The cream-coloured box really did look beautiful. When the lid opened, the sweets sat in even rows. With its golden border, even the ordinary sitting room appeared a little more orderly, a little more prosperous.

Mrinal looked once at her mother's face. She said nothing.

The conversation went on for about an hour and a half. No decision was made then and there. As they were leaving, Usha Devi held Mrinal's hand and said, "We'll talk again on the phone. There is no need to hurry."

Seema Devi felt lighter. She liked that sentence: neither yes nor no, but respect.

As he was stepping outside, Devkinandan Babu turned back. "I'm taking the box with us. The children at home will see the sweets."

Seema Devi paused for a moment. She remembered the deposit slip. Then she quickly said, "Yes, yes, of course."

Mrinal smiled from behind the doorway.

The car left.

Seema Devi let out her breath. "See? They liked the box."

Mrinal said, "The sweets or the box?"

"Both."

"And now the three hundred?"

Seema Devi took the slip from her purse and looked at it. "The box will come back. They seem like decent people."

Mrinal laughed. "Ma, is this a marriage decision or box management?"

By six in the evening there had been no phone call. Seema Devi checked her mobile three times.

At seven, a message from Anup came to Mrinal: "Reached home. It was good meeting everyone. We'll talk calmly tomorrow."

Seema Devi read the message, then read it again.

At half past seven the sound of a motorcycle stopping came at the door.

Outside was not Anup but Devkinandan Babu. In his hand was the same cream-coloured sweet box.

Seema Devi's heart gave one hard thump.

"So soon?" she asked, opening the door.

Devkinandan Babu held out the box. "I came to return this."

Seema Devi's hand slowed involuntarily.

The box was almost empty. Two pedas remained inside.

"Did something go wrong?" escaped Seema Devi's mouth.

Devkinandan Babu looked startled. "Wrong?"

"No, I mean... you brought the box back so quickly..."

Mrinal came out from inside. One look at her mother's face and she understood.

Devkinandan Babu laughed. "Oh. You thought I had come to return the sweets?"

Embarrassed, Seema Devi said, "No, no, I..."

"I understand."

He turned the box over and showed her the underside. The number 17 was written there in black marker.

"The moment I saw this number, I recognized Naresh Sah's box."

Seema Devi was silent.

Devkinandan Babu took a folded slip from the pocket of his kurta, opened it, and placed it on the table. It read: "Deposit Box No. 23." The date was two months old.

"For my younger sister's granddaughter's birthday, I too took a box from the same shop. Three hundred rupees was worth saving, so I returned it the very next day."

Mrinal smiled.

Seema Devi still did not quite understand. "Then why bring the box all the way here at this hour?"

Devkinandan Babu said, "Naresh Sah closes his shop at eight. I thought, why should the box lie at our house until tomorrow? Your three hundred rupees would remain tied up. I was passing this way, so I brought it back."

Seema Devi's face grew warm. "For three hundred rupees, so much trouble..."

"Is three hundred rupees a small amount?" Devkinandan Babu asked in an easy voice. "It isn't small for me either."

For a few moments no one spoke.

Then Devkinandan Babu opened the lid and pointed to the two remaining pedas inside.

"We couldn't eat these two on the way. You keep them."

Seema Devi said, "No, no, take them for the children."

"There is plenty at home. And one more thing."

He ran a finger along the golden edge of the cream-coloured box. "Tomorrow, when we talk at home, we should also talk about expenses. If the marriage goes ahead, I would prefer that money not be wasted on decoration, packaging, boxes and such things. Let the food be good. Let what is worn be comfortable. As for what people will say—the accounting for that never ends."

For the first time Seema Devi looked directly at his face.

"Why are you saying this?"

Devkinandan Babu smiled again. "Because today I saw number seventeen in your house, and two months ago number twenty-three was in mine. It seems both families rent an expensive-looking box out of the same fear."

Mrinal burst out laughing.

Seema Devi could not hold back either.

"You will not tell Mrinal this," she said.

Mrinal was standing right in front of them. "Too late, Ma."

All three laughed.

Devkinandan Babu stood up. "Come, let us return the box to Naresh Sah. His closing time is near."

Seema Devi took the slip from her purse.

Mrinal said, "I'm coming too."

The three of them crossed the lane and reached the sweet shop. Naresh Sah had already lowered the shutter halfway.

“Ah, number seventeen back so soon?” he said with a laugh.

Devkinandan Babu replied, “How many days should a man keep someone else’s box at home?”

Naresh Sah inspected the box. He saw the two pedas inside.

“These?”

Seema Devi said, “They do not come with the box.”

Naresh Sah took the two pedas out onto a small paper plate, put the box away inside, and returned three hundred rupees to Seema Devi.

Seema Devi did not count the notes. She put them into her purse.

On the way back Mrinal broke one peda into three pieces.

“What is this?” Seema Devi asked.

“The box has gone back to the shop,” Mrinal said. “I’m dividing these two pedas among the three of us.”

Devkinandan Babu took his piece.

Seema Devi took hers too.

The streetlights had come on. The cream-coloured box remained inside the shop, waiting for some next occasion, but this time its golden border no longer seemed important to Seema Devi.

The Small Advertisement

Nilesh Jha read the small-advertisements column in the newspaper for the fifth time.

The thought of writing “Work Wanted” had occurred to him before, but each time he had folded the paper again.

For six months he had been applying in different places. Schools, insurance offices, computer shops, the accounts section of a private hospital—wherever he heard there was a vacancy, he arrived with his résumé. The answer was usually the same: “We’ll call.”

The calls rarely came.

That Wednesday he had one hundred and seventy-eight rupees in his pocket.

As his mother left for the market that morning, she had said, “If you need anything for vegetables, tell me.”

Nilesh had replied, “No, I have money.”

In truth, saying “I have money” was easier than telling his mother the arithmetic of his pocket.

He had graduated from university. He could type in Hindi and English on a computer, write Maithili neatly, fill online forms, scan documents and combine PDFs. But none of these skills had yet given him the name of a job.

At noon he reached the office of Mithila Samachar on Station Road.

At a small table in front of the office, a young man named Rakesh was writing down advertisements.

“How many lines?” Rakesh asked.

Nilesh said, “Three.”

“Commercial?”

“No. Small.”

Rakesh pushed his spectacles up onto his forehead. “What do you want written?”

Nilesh took a sheet of paper from his pocket.

He had written:

“Applications, scholarship, pension, bank and school forms filled. Clear applications/letters written. Fee from Rs 50. Home service extra.”

Rakesh read it. "Mobile number?"

Nilesh wrote it down.

Rakesh said, "The zero in this '50' is a little faint."

Nilesh ran the pen over it again.

"Now?"

"Fine."

The three-line advertisement cost one hundred and twenty rupees.

As he took the receipt, Nilesh wondered for a moment whether spending one hundred and twenty rupees on an advertisement was wise.

But the money had already crossed the counter.

When he returned home, fifty-eight rupees remained in his pocket.

His mother asked, "Did you eat anything?"

"Yes."

He lied.

The next morning the newspaper fell at the door as soon as seven struck.

Usually Nilesh looked first at the employment news. That day he opened the small-advertisements page directly.

His advertisement was at the bottom right.

The mobile number was correct.

The wording was almost correct.

But the fee had been printed as: "from Rs 5."

For a long time Nilesh stared at the blank space after the five where the zero should have been.

He folded the newspaper and immediately called Rakesh.

"Brother, the advertisement has been printed wrong."

"What's wrong?"

"Five instead of fifty."

There was the sound of paper being turned at the other end.

Rakesh was silent.

Then he said, "Yes. The zero got left out."

"Now what?"

"We'll print a correction free in the next issue."

"The next issue is Saturday."

"Yes."

Nilesh said, "And if someone comes before then with five rupees?"

Rakesh gave a small laugh. "You can tell them it's a printing mistake."

The call ended.

Nilesh threw the newspaper on the table.

His mother called from the kitchen, "What happened?"

"Nothing."

The first call came at seven minutes past eight.

“Nilesh Babu?”

“Yes.”

“Do you fill pension forms?”

“Yes.”

“How much do you charge?”

Nilesh looked at the newspaper.

“What kind of form is it?”

“Old-age pension. Four pages.”

He wanted to say fifty.

What came out of his mouth was, “Whatever is printed in the newspaper.”

“Five rupees?”

“Yes.”

After the call ended, Nilesh ran a hand over his forehead.

By nine o'clock an elderly woman arrived.

Her name was Phoolkumari Devi.

In a plastic bag she carried a photocopy of her Aadhaar card, a bank passbook, a ration card, and a folded form.

Standing at the doorway, she asked, “Is this where forms are filled?”

Nilesh pulled a chair forward on the veranda.

“Sit.”

Taking out the papers, Phoolkumari Devi said, “My son is in Delhi. At the panchayat they told me to fill it myself.”

The first line of the form was: Name of Applicant.

Nilesh asked, “The same name that's on the Aadhaar card?”

“Yes.”

He began writing.

At the date of birth, Phoolkumari Devi hesitated.

“Where is that written?”

Nilesh checked the Aadhaar card.

He filled in the bank account number.

He asked about annual income.

At the section about her husband, Phoolkumari Devi said softly, “He has been gone seven years.”

Without looking up, Nilesh wrote “Late.”

It took eleven minutes to fill the form.

At the end he showed her where a thumb impression was required instead of a signature, and which photocopies had to be attached.

Phoolkumari Devi took out a five-rupee coin.

Placing it on the table, she said, “The newspaper said five.”

Nilesh looked at the coin.

“Yes.”

He took the five rupees.
 Phoolkumari Devi gathered her papers and left.
 His mother had watched everything from inside the doorway.
 She said, "Eleven minutes for five rupees?"
 Nilesch said, "It's a printing mistake."
 "Then why didn't you say fifty?"
 "The newspaper says five."
 His mother said nothing.
 At twenty past ten the second customer came.
 Mahendra Paswan, a mason.
 He needed to renew his labour registration online.
 "An OTP will come on your mobile," Nilesch said.
 Mahendra took out an old phone.
 The screen was cracked.
 The network kept disappearing.
 It took twenty-seven minutes to finish the work.
 Mahendra gave him five rupees.
 Then he asked, "Where can I get photocopies?"
 Nilesch pointed out the shop at the turn in the road.
 Mahendra said, "He charges twenty there. You charge five."
 Nilesch did not smile.
 By noon he had had four customers.
 Twenty rupees in all.
 Serving rice, his mother asked, "At this rate, when will the one hundred and twenty rupees for the advertisement come back?"
 "In six days, if four people come every day."
 "And your time?"
 Nilesch had no answer.
 After eating, he cut out the advertisement and placed it on the table.
 With a red pen he wrote a "o" after the "5."
 On the paper, the fee was once again fifty.
 At three o'clock a teenage girl came.
 Her name was Ruchi Kumari.
 She had brought a scholarship form.
 "Babuji is in the field," she said. "Ma told me to ask first whether you'll fill it for five."
 Nilesch looked at the advertisement with the red zero.
 "I will."
 Ruchi sat down.
 The form required the school's code.
 Ruchi did not know it.

Nilesh opened the school's website.
The website would not load.
He searched for the headmaster's number.
The call did not connect.
Then he found the code in an old notice PDF.
Ruchi watched the screen in silence.
When the form was complete, she took out five rupees.
Not one five-rupee coin—two rupees, two rupees, one rupee.
Nilesh took the money.
Ruchi picked up the papers, then asked, "Will you do this work every day?"
"I don't know."
"My younger sister will have a form next month too."
She left.
By evening nine customers had come.
Forty-five rupees.
That night Nilesh took out a notebook and wrote down the account.
First customer — 11 minutes.
Second — 27 minutes.
Third — 8 minutes.
Fourth — 13 minutes.
Ruchi — 31 minutes.
Total time: three hours fifty-four minutes.
Total earnings: forty-five rupees.
Below the calculation he wrote: "Loss."
Then, after a while, he wrote another word: "Demand."
Both words remained on the same page.
The next morning someone knocked at the door before seven.
It was Mahendra Paswan.
He had brought two other labourers with him.
"These two need their renewals done too."
Nilesh looked at the clock.
"Now?"
Mahendra said, "We have to reach the worksite by eight."
Nilesh opened the table.
By the time all three forms were finished it was five past eight.
As he left, Mahendra placed fifteen rupees on the table.
Then he paused and added another ten.
Nilesh said, "This is extra."
Mahendra said, "Yesterday you saved me half an hour. Doesn't that count in those five rupees?"
"No, what is printed—"

“What is printed belongs to the newspaper. I have settled my own account.”
He left.

At ten, Javed, who ran the photocopy shop at the turn in the road, came over.

“Your customers are coming to me for photocopies,” he said.

Nilesh thought it was a complaint.

Javed said, “There’s an empty corner in my shop. If you want, sit there for two hours in the evening. People can get forms filled and copies made in one place.”

“Rent?”

“First see whether the work runs. My customers will increase too.”

Nilesh looked at his face.

“Computer?”

“There’s an old one. The internet is slow, but it works.”

At noon Nilesh went to the Mithila Samachar office.

As soon as Rakesh saw him, he said, “Shall I put in the correction today? ‘50’ instead of ‘5’?”

Nilesh took the clipped advertisement from his pocket.

The zero he had added in red pen was still there.

Rakesh took the paper.

“Fifty?”

Nilesh was silent for a few moments.

Then he drew a line through the red zero.

“No.”

“Then?”

Nilesh asked for a fresh sheet of paper.

He wrote:

“Applications, scholarship, pension, bank and school forms filled. Simple forms Rs 5. Long/online work from Rs 20. Fee not compulsory for those unable to pay.”

Rakesh kept reading.

“This has become too long,” he said. “It’ll take four lines.”

“How much?”

“One hundred and sixty.”

Nilesh laughed.

“Last time the advertisement was printed wrong because of your mistake.”

Rakesh said at once, “The correction is free.”

“This isn’t a correction. It’s a new advertisement.”

Rakesh looked at him.

Then he pulled over the old receipt and wrote on the back: “Four lines — zero.”

"This settles the mistake," he said.

Nilesh did not pick up the paper.

"On one condition."

"What?"

"This time read the figures aloud once."

Rakesh laughed.

"Simple forms five. Longer ones twenty."

"Fine."

The new advertisement appeared in Saturday's issue.

Four lines.

One line longer than the first advertisement.

But its space in the newspaper was still very small.

At five that evening Nilesh was sitting in a corner of Javed's shop.

Three forms lay on the table.

An elderly man had brought a bank nomination form.

A woman had her daughter's school-admission form.

A young man had opened employment registration on his mobile.

Changing paper in the printer, Javed asked, "Have you stopped looking for a job?"

Nilesh did not answer at once.

There were still two copies of his résumé in his pocket.

He took one out and put it in the table drawer.

"I haven't stopped," he said. "But for now, this work comes first."

The small newspaper clipping lay on the table.

The first advertisement.

The one in which the zero after fifty had been missing.

Nilesh did not throw it away.

He folded the paper and placed it on top of his résumé.

The Blue Pen

“Whose signature is this?”

Vinod Jha, the clerk in the school office, asked with his finger resting at the bottom of the form.

Mamta stood before him. In her hand was a transparent file containing, in order, the scholarship-renewal certificate, a photocopy of the bank passbook, the caste certificate, and the previous year’s marksheet.

She bent to look. At the lower right of the form, in blue ink, was written: “Phoolkumari Devi.”

“My mother’s,” Mamta said.

Vinod Babu pushed his spectacles a little higher. “Your mother signs her name?”

“She does now.”

“Now?”

Mamta understood that the question would not end there.

Vinod Babu took an old admission form from the file. A document from five years earlier.

In the box for the guardian’s signature was a black-ink thumbprint. Beneath it, in someone else’s hand, was written: “Phoolkumari Devi, Mother.”

He took out another paper. An old bank verification document. There too was a thumbprint.

“A thumbprint here,” he said. “A thumbprint here too. But this time there is a full signature.”

“Yes.”

“Did someone else write it for her?”

Mamta’s face flushed at once. “No. Ma wrote it herself.”

Vinod Babu did not make his voice harsh. “Look, I have to verify it. These are scholarship papers. The signature differs from the earlier record. Bring your mother once tomorrow.”

Mamta remained silent for a few moments.

“She should leave the fieldwork and come?”

“It will take ten minutes.”

“For ten minutes, half her day will be spoiled.”

Vinod Babu put the papers back in the file. "I understand. But I am not authorized to approve it without verification."

Mamta took the file.

As she stepped out through the doorway, her eyes fell once more on the blue signature on the form.

The previous night, Phoolkumari Devi had taken five minutes over that signature.

First she had written "Phool." Then paused.

Then "kumari."

While writing "ri," the line had climbed a little upward. "Devi" had come out comparatively straight.

After writing it, she had looked at Mamta's face. "Is it right?"

Mamta had laughed. "Why are you looking at me? It's your name."

Phoolkumari had laughed too.

Then the nib had left a tiny blue dot beneath the signature. Mamta had tried to wipe it with a cloth, but her mother had stopped her.

"Leave it. People will know I wrote it myself."

They had both laughed at that.

Now the little blue dot did not seem funny to Mamta.

When she reached home, Phoolkumari was spreading a mat in the courtyard to dry paddy.

Mamta put the file on the wooden bench on the veranda.

"What happened?" her mother asked.

"We have to go to the school tomorrow."

"Why?"

"To show them your signature."

Phoolkumari's hands stopped at the corner of the mat. "Show them?"

"The old papers have your thumbprint, remember? They say this signature could have been written by someone else."

Phoolkumari kept looking at Mamta's face.

"You told them?"

"I told them you wrote it yourself."

"They didn't believe you?"

"They say they have to verify it."

Phoolkumari slowly let go of the mat. "All right. I'll go."

Mamta wanted to say, "No, I'll talk to them again"—but there was no shame on her mother's face. There was a little irritation, and behind it the same stubborn resolve Mamta had seen during the first days of the literacy class.

Six months earlier, an evening literacy class had begun in the back room of the panchayat building.

Phoolkumari had not gone the first day.

Nor the second.

On the third day, their neighbour Lalita had taken her by the hand and led her there.

“What use are letters to me at this age?” Phoolkumari had said.

Lalita had replied, “How old are letters?”

During the first week, Phoolkumari learned only to recognize her own name.

Then to write it.

Saraswati Didi had given everyone pencils. Phoolkumari wrote with a pencil for two days. On the third day, after returning home, she asked Mamta, “Do you have a blue pen?”

Mamta had taken three pens from her bag. One black, two blue.

“Which one?”

Phoolkumari chose the cheap blue pen. The five-rupee one.

“Pencil keeps getting erased,” she had said. “If I write with a pen, it will remain.”

From that day, the blue pen was hers.

Mamta would often tease her, “Ma, the ink will run out.”

Phoolkumari would say, “Then I’ll refill it. A name doesn’t run out, does it?”

The next day, before going to the school, Phoolkumari bathed, put on a pale green sari, and placed her old literacy-class notebook in her bag.

Mamta asked, “Why the notebook?”

“If they say I can’t write, I’ll show them.”

“They’ll simply ask you to write there.”

Phoolkumari put a hand inside her bag and felt for the blue pen. “Then I’ll write.”

By the time they reached the school, the morning prayer was over. Students were moving along the veranda towards their classrooms.

Mamta went into the office with her mother.

Seeing Phoolkumari, Vinod Babu pulled a chair forward. “Sit.”

Phoolkumari did not sit. “I’m fine here.”

Vinod Babu took out the previous day’s form. “Did you make this signature?”

“Yes.”

“Earlier you used a thumbprint?”

“Yes.”

“And now you sign?”

“Now I have learned to write my name.”

Vinod Babu pushed a blank sheet of paper towards her. "Write it once here."

Phoolkumari took the blue pen from her bag.

One side of the cap bore a small tooth mark. While practising, whenever she paused to think, she tended to bite the cap.

She placed the pen on the paper.

First she wrote "Phoolkumari."

"Phool" came out a little large.

"Ku" sat close together.

"Mari" was straighter this time than it had been the previous day.

Then: "Devi."

She lifted the pen.

Vinod Babu placed yesterday's signature and today's side by side and looked at them.

"They aren't exactly the same," he said.

Mamta spoke at once. "It's written by hand—how can it come out exactly the same?"

Phoolkumari looked at Mamta. "You keep quiet."

Then she looked at the papers in front of Vinod Babu.

"I'm not a machine, Babu," she said calmly. "Yesterday my hand was trembling a little. Today it came out better."

A faint smile appeared on Vinod Babu's face, but he immediately turned back to the file.

"My problem is not with your handwriting," he said. "The change has to be entered in the record. Otherwise it will raise a question during audit."

Phoolkumari took the notebook out of her bag.

"Enter it from this."

Vinod Babu took the notebook.

On the first page were large, crooked letters:

Phu

Phu

Phool

On the second page:

Phoolku

Phoolkumari

A few pages later came the full name.

In one place the "ku" in "Phoolkumari" was missing.

In another, the "v" in "Devi" had turned out almost reversed.

Then, page by page, the letters grew steadier.

On the final five pages, different dates were written. Beneath each: "Phoolkumari Devi."

Some signatures were large, some small.

But one thing was the same in all of them: the first stroke of the “Ph” leaned slightly to the left.

Vinod Babu looked through the notebook for a long time.

“How long have you been learning?”

“Six months.”

“Where are the classes held?”

“At the panchayat building.”

“Teacher?”

“Saraswati Devi. Everyone calls her Saraswati Didi.”

Vinod Babu searched for something on the computer. Then he took out a register.

“For this, a declaration has to be written: previously thumbprint, now signature adopted.”

Phoolkumari asked, “Should I write the declaration?”

“I’ll write it. Can you read?”

Phoolkumari paused. “Not everything. Slowly.”

Vinod Babu wrote one line: “I, Phoolkumari Devi, shall use my signature from this date onward.”

He turned the paper and placed it before her.

Phoolkumari began reading word by word.

“I... Phool...kumari... Devi...”

“From this,” Vinod Babu prompted gently.

“From this date... onward... my... signature...”

At the last word she stopped.

Mamta was about to help, but her mother stopped her with one hand.

Phoolkumari joined the letters slowly. “U-se... use... shall use.”

“Yes,” Vinod Babu said.

Phoolkumari picked up the blue pen.

This time the signature came out a little differently from the first two. The “D” in “Devi” was more open.

Vinod Babu looked at all three signatures.

Then he looked at the photocopy of the old thumbprint.

At the top of the file he wrote a brief note: “Guardian adopted signature after becoming literate; personally verified.”

Beneath it, he signed his own name.

Mamta noticed that Vinod Babu’s own signature was not exactly identical to the one on the previous page either.

She said nothing.

Vinod Babu stamped the scholarship form with the verification seal.

“Now the work is done.”

Mamta let out her breath.

Phoolkumari was not looking at the form. She was looking at her notebook.

“Do you need to keep this notebook?” she asked.

“No, it belongs to you.”

She immediately put it back in her bag.

At the doorway she turned once more.

“Babu, the bank has my thumbprint too.”

“You can update your signature there as well.”

“On the ration card?”

“The name need not be changed there, but wherever necessary, you can register your new signature.”

Phoolkumari nodded.

Mamta laughed. “Now will we go round every office?”

“Wherever my thumbprint sits alone, my name will sit there too.”

Vinod Babu laughed.

Leaving the school, the two of them took the road through the market.

The afternoon sun had grown sharp. Phoolkumari pulled the bag a little higher on her shoulder.

Mamta said, “Give me the pen. I have to write my history notes.”

Phoolkumari took out the blue pen.

She looked at it for a few moments.

Then she put it back in the bag.

“You have two pens at home.”

“What’s so special about this pen?” Mamta teased.

Walking on, Phoolkumari said, “Nothing.”

Two steps later she spoke again: “But this one is mine.”

Mamta said nothing.

That evening, at the literacy class, Saraswati Didi opened the attendance register.

Earlier, beside Phoolkumari’s name, a small box used to carry her thumbprint.

For six months now, a little space beside that mark had been left for her to practise her new signature.

That day Saraswati Didi pushed the register towards her.

Phoolkumari took out the blue pen.

The box for the thumbprint remained empty.

Beside it, she wrote her name:

Phoolkumari Devi.

The Wooden Horse

Dharmanath Mistri was sweeping the dust in front of his shop when Sushila arrived with a wooden horse tied to the rear carrier of her bicycle.

At first glance, the horse looked less like a horse and more like a tired bundle of old paint.

Here and there on its body, layers of blue, green and red showed through. Half of the right ear was broken. The front rocking board was split along one side. The handle was loose and trembled when touched.

Sushila parked the bicycle and said, "Mistriji, can this be repaired?"

Dharmanath leaned the broom against the wall.

"It can be repaired. The question is whether it is worth repairing."

Sushila laughed. "It is worth it to me."

Dharmanath lifted the horse.

It was heavier than he expected.

"How old is it?"

"No one has an exact count."

"From your house?"

"No."

"Then?"

"From the centre."

Dharmanath looked at her.

"Which centre?"

"The anganwadi in Ward Seven."

Dharmanath looked at the horse again.

The anganwadi stood about half a kos from his shop. After the road was widened, the old building had been left a little behind the main road, and he rarely had reason to go that way now.

Sushila said, "Tomorrow is vaccination day. The children will come. That is why I brought it today."

Dharmanath pressed the broken rocking board with his finger.

"By tomorrow morning?"

"Before ten."

"It needs a new board. The handle has to be tightened. The ear too must be joined."

"Do whatever is necessary. But do not strip off all the paint."

Dharmanath raised his eyebrows.

"Not the paint?"

"No. The children know it in this form."

"With the paint peeled like this?"

"Yes."

Dharmanath found the request a little strange.

He had his own rule for repairing old wooden things. If the surface was badly worn, first scrape away the old paint, open the joints and tighten them again, then give the object a fresh coat. That made it look new. Customers were usually happiest that way.

Sushila was saying, "Just mend what is broken. Let whatever is old remain as old as it is."

"The ear?"

"Join the ear."

"Paint?"

"Match only the new part. Not the whole thing."

Dharmanath nodded.

"All right."

Sushila took a small paper from her bag.

"Payment will come from the centre's maintenance account. Make a bill."

"I will."

"Write the name: Anganwadi Centre Number Twenty-seven."

Dharmanath opened his old ledger.

"Repair of wooden horse."

He smiled as he wrote it.

It had been a long time since the words "wooden horse" had appeared in his ledger. Most of his work now involved doors, cots, windows, cupboards, bedsteads, plywood racks, and small repairs to modular kitchens.

After Sushila left, Dharmanath placed the horse on the worktable.

The rocking board had to come off first.

He picked up a screwdriver.

One screw turned. The second was stuck.

He applied oil.

Five minutes later he tried again.

The screw slowly came loose.

When the board came away, the wood beneath it was clearly visible for the first time.

Dharmanath's fingers stopped.

There were three thin bands of colour in the wood: yellow at the bottom, green above it, and then the present blue.

In a few places children had scratched marks with their nails or some pointed object.

“M.”

“Ru.”

A little star.

A round face.

In one place, only two straight lines.

Dharmanath smiled.

Marks like these appear on children’s things by themselves.

He measured the old board and took out a thin strip of new sheesham wood.

As he began sawing, he remembered his father.

Jagdish Mistri used to hold down the end of a piece of wood with his left foot while sawing.

Dharmanath had never liked that method; he preferred clamps. His father would say, “Wood is understood through the hand, not through iron.”

Dharmanath would reply, “If the hand gets cut, the wood will not pay for the treatment.”

The two of them had laughed over that argument many times.

Jagdish Mistri had been dead twenty-two years.

The shop was the same, though a new tin awning now stood in front, an electric saw had come inside, and the old hammers were used less often.

Dharmanath cut the new board and rounded its edges.

Then he wiped the underside of the old horse with a dry cloth.

Black grime had collected in one corner.

He rubbed it lightly with sandpaper.

When the dirt came away, a small triangle appeared in the wood.

Dharmanath’s hand stopped.

Inside the triangle were two very small cuts—one long, one thin.

He pulled a chair over and sat down.

The mark was extremely simple. No name. No year.

But Dharmanath recognized it.

Jagdish Mistri used to cut this same mark beneath the smaller things he made.

A triangle. Two lines inside.

His lazy way, he used to say, of writing “J” and “Mi.”

Dharmanath turned the horse over and looked again.

The mark was unmistakably the same.

He went to the back of the shop, where old ledgers were kept in a tin trunk.

When he opened the trunk, the smell of paper rose from it.
 Ledgers from 2011 to 2016 lay on top. Older ones were beneath them.
 Dharmanath did not know the exact year.
 He took out three ledgers.
 1994.
 1991.
 1989.
 His father's handwriting was small and slanted.
 "Mohan Yadav — two cots."
 "School — repair of four benches."
 "Saraswati Puja stage boards."
 Dharmanath kept turning the pages.
 Near the bottom of one page was written: "Children's Centre — small
 tables 2, low stools 6, horse 1."
 The amount was written beside it.
 Dharmanath looked at the date.
 17 July 1991.
 For a long time he kept his finger on the line.
 It seemed to Dharmanath that the "Children's Centre" must be today's
 anganwadi. It would have had another name then.
 Beside the amount, his father had put a small circle. Dharmanath knew
 what that circle meant: payment received.
 No story. No note. Only one line.
 Dharmanath suddenly remembered seeing four or five wooden horses in
 one corner of the shop when he was a boy. His father had said, "For children."
 This must have been one of them.
 Dharmanath closed the ledger.
 He did not go home for lunch. When his wife Vimala called, he said, "A job
 is stuck."
 "How big a job?"
 Dharmanath looked at the horse.
 "Small."
 Vimala laughed. "Small jobs take the most time."
 "You are right."
 He ended the call.
 While fitting the new board, Dharmanath used the old screw holes. New
 holes might weaken the wood.
 He opened the handle and replaced the nail inside.
 For the right ear he chose a piece of old sal wood, not bright new timber. It
 would be easier to match the colour.

After shaping and joining the ear, he spent a long time smoothing the edges so the new part would not feel different to the hand.

Then came the question of paint again.

Painting the whole horse would have been easy.

But Sushila had forbidden it.

Dharmanath opened three small tins. Into the blue he mixed a little green until it resembled the old faded shade.

He painted only the new board and the ear.

The rest of the body remained as it was.

The repair was therefore not hidden, yet neither did it shout for attention.

By evening the horse stood again.

Dharmanath placed it on the floor and gave it a gentle push.

It rocked forward and back.

There was a little rasping sound.

He tightened it once more.

The second time there was no sound.

Before closing the shop, he looked once more at the triangular mark beneath the belly.

The sandpaper had cleared the dirt around it, but the mark itself remained untouched.

Dharmanath did not paint over it.

The next day Sushila arrived at twenty past nine.

Two women and three children were with her.

At the sight of the horse, one child ran forward.

"I'll sit first!"

Another immediately said, "You sat yesterday."

"Yesterday it was broken."

"Then the day before."

Sushila stopped them both. "Don't run inside the shop."

Dharmanath kept smiling.

Sushila shook the horse with her hand.

"The handle doesn't move now."

"New nail."

"The board?"

"New."

She bent and looked beneath it. "The colour matches too."

Dharmanath said, "I didn't repaint the whole thing."

"Good."

One of the women asked, "How much?"

Dharmanath opened the ledger.

"Four hundred and twenty."

Sushila signed the payment paper without bargaining.

"Give me a receipt."

Dharmanath wrote out the receipt.

Then, suddenly, he asked, "How long has this centre been here?"

Sushila thought for a moment. "Since before I was born."

"Had you seen this horse before?"

Sushila laughed. "I sat on it myself."

Dharmanath looked at her.

"Really?"

"My mother says I wouldn't leave the horse when it was time to go home. There's an old photograph at the centre too."

The woman beside her said, "Sushila is in the photograph hanging on the wall."

"How old is it?"

"Twenty-five or twenty-six years."

Dharmanath was silent for a few moments.

Then he turned the horse over and showed them the underside.

"Do you see this mark?"

Sushila bent down.

"The triangle?"

"It was my father's mark."

"Your father?"

"Jagdish Mistri."

Sushila's expression changed. "Oh! I've seen the name Jagdish in the centre's old register. There are some old papers about the building's stools and tables."

Dharmanath said, "It's in our ledger too—1991. One horse."

The youngest of the three children was not listening to Dharmanath at all. His whole attention was on the horse.

He asked, "Can I sit on it?"

Dharmanath set the horse upright.

"Gently at first."

The child climbed on.

The horse rocked.

He laughed.

The second child immediately said, "Now my turn."

Sushila looked at the clock. "We have to reach the centre. The vaccination team will arrive."

The women tried to lift the horse.

Dharmanath said, "I'll take it there."

"You?"

“Nothing will happen if the shop stays closed for ten minutes.”

He put the horse on the small cart attached to his bicycle and took it to the centre.

The anganwadi building stood a little way in from the road. Letters, fruits, animals and numbers were painted on its walls. A small heap of shoes and slippers lay on the veranda.

Photographs hung on the wall inside.

Sushila took one down and showed it to Dharmanath.

The photograph had faded. Five children sat on the floor. In the middle was the same wooden horse.

The horse was yellow then.

One little girl held its handle.

Sushila pointed with her finger. “That is me.”

Dharmanath looked at the photograph.

The shape of the horse was the same. The right ear was whole. The rocking board was thick. The paint shone.

In a corner of the wall behind it, a small wooden stool could also be seen.

Dharmanath felt that the stool too might have been made by his father.

He did not ask.

A worker put the horse back in its old place inside the veranda.

Soon children began to arrive.

One mother came holding a child’s hand. A grandmother came with her granddaughter. Someone carried a vaccination card. Someone else asked where to queue for a nutrition packet.

The horse was immediately surrounded.

Sushila established an order. “One at a time.”

Dharmanath stood near the doorway and watched.

While rocking, one child ran a finger over an old scratched star on the horse’s body.

“Who made this?” he asked.

Sushila looked at Dharmanath.

The answer reached Dharmanath’s lips: “My father.”

But he paused.

Then he said, “A carpenter made it a long time ago.”

The child asked another question. “Whose horse is it?”

This time Dharmanath did not answer at once.

He looked at Sushila.

Sushila smiled and said, “Whoever’s turn it is.”

Satisfied, the child began rocking again.

Dharmanath stepped outside.

On his way back to the shop, the 1991 page of his ledger kept returning to his mind.

One line: Children's Centre, one horse.

That was all.

More than three decades had gone unwritten after that one line, while children had continued adding their own small marks to the horse.

Back at the shop, Dharmanath opened the ledger.

Beside today's entry was written: "Anganwadi Centre Number Twenty-seven — repair of wooden horse — Rs 420."

He picked up his pen.

He felt like adding something.

Should he write: "Made by Father"?

Should he write: "1991"?

He thought for a few moments.

Then he added only two small words: "Running again."

He closed the ledger.

The Sewing Machine

Shivnath Thakur was wiping the dust from the old signboard outside his shop when Naveen Jha arrived holding a pink card.

The faded letters on the board read: “Shivnath Tailors · Stitching to Measure · Established 1986.”

“Kaka,” Naveen said, holding out the card, “the Traders’ Association is honouring you on Sunday evening.”

Shivnath pushed his spectacles up his nose. “Me?”

“Forty years. In the same place. Everyone said it wouldn’t be right to let a man like you pass without recognition.”

Shivnath opened the card. Inside was printed: “In honour of four decades of outstanding tailoring service.”

He read it, smiled faintly, and then looked inside the shop.

Behind the wooden table, an old black sewing machine sat under its cover. Its golden floral decoration had worn away long ago. The iron treadle was no longer shiny; years of use had polished it smooth.

Naveen pointed towards the machine. “We’ll put this on the stage too. It’ll look excellent in the photographs.”

Shivnath said at once, “The machine will not go on the stage.”

Naveen laughed. “Too heavy? Four men can carry it.”

“It isn’t heavy.”

“Then?”

Shivnath folded the card and placed it on the counter. “The machine is not mine.”

Naveen’s laughter stopped.

He looked at the machine again.

A forty-year-old shop. Shivnath Thakur. Shivnath Tailors. Half the market had worn wedding kurtas, trousers, coats and school uniforms that had come from here. If the machine was not Shivnath’s, whose was it?

“Is it rented?” Naveen asked.

“No.”

“Then explain it later.” Shivnath slipped the card into his pocket. “Right now this pair of trousers has to be delivered by evening.”

Naveen decided it must be one of the old man's peculiar notions and left. The shop was small, but its identity in the market was old and established. At the front stood the platform where measurements were taken. On the left was the long table for cutting cloth. On the right were drawers for thread, buttons, zippers and tailor's chalk. At the back there used to be a half-height wooden partition. Five years earlier, when it rotted, it had been removed. The sewing machine had stood behind that partition. Old customers had never paid much attention to the fact that Shivnath was usually visible at the front table—with the measuring tape around his neck, chalk in his hand, and the click of scissors beside him. From behind came the steady burr and beat of the machine. People assumed that a tailor must, naturally, be operating a sewing machine. There had never seemed any reason to think more deeply about it. That evening when Shivnath reached home, Savitri was shelling peas in the courtyard. Her hair had turned completely white, but her fingers were still quick as they sorted the peas. Shivnath handed her the pink card. Savitri read it, then said, "That's good." "Good?" "Yes. If you sit in the same place for forty years, you ought to receive something for it." Shivnath laughed. "Who was sitting?" Savitri dropped another handful of peas into the bowl. "Don't start again." "They want to take the machine onto the stage." This time Savitri's hands stopped. "The machine?" "Yes." "Why?" "They say it will look good in the photographs." Savitri looked at the card again. "Take a photograph of the machine. What is that to me?" Shivnath remained silent for a few moments. "I told them the machine isn't mine." Savitri looked up at him. "Leave all this now. What will people say?" "For forty years people said whatever they said." "What is the use now?" Shivnath did not answer.

The next day a young man came to the shop to take photographs. The Traders' Association was preparing a poster.

"Kaka, sit beside the machine," he said.

Shivnath picked up the scissors. "Take the photograph with the scissors."

"But the sewing machine is the symbol."

"The symbol is fine. I would be sitting in the wrong place."

The photographer did not understand. In the end he photographed Shivnath cutting cloth.

On the poster appeared: "Shivnath Thakur: Four Decades of Trust."

The sewing machine could be seen blurred in the background.

On Friday, an old customer, Sahdev Mishra, saw the poster and came into the shop.

"Congratulations, Shivnathji! You stitched my wedding coat. It's still in my wardrobe."

Shivnath smiled. "I took the measurements."

"And the stitching was yours too."

Folding his measuring tape, Shivnath said, "Listen to that part on Sunday."

Sahdev laughed. "Have you prepared the speech already?"

"Not a speech. An account."

Shivnath's granddaughter Neera had come home from college that day. She was taking photographs of the shop on her mobile phone.

"Baba, how old is this machine?"

"One year younger than the shop."

"So thirty-nine years?"

"About that."

Neera lifted the machine cover. There was no dust. A faint smell of oil remained. A short length of blue thread was caught near the needle.

"Does it still work?"

"It does."

"Do you use it?"

Shivnath looked at Neera.

"I can sew a straight seam for about two handspans. After that I'll ruin the cloth."

Neera burst out laughing. Then her laughter slowly faded.

"Then...?"

Shivnath put the cover back over the machine. "Go home and ask your grandmother."

That evening Neera sat beside Savitri.

"Dadi, who used to sew all the clothes from the shop?"

Savitri did not answer immediately.

“Baba took the measurements,” Neera said. “He did the cutting. The machine?”

Savitri smiled softly. “A machine doesn’t run by itself.”

“You?”

“For many years.”

“How many?”

“Since before your father was little.”

Neera fell silent.

Savitri began to tell her slowly.

Before marriage, she had learned sewing at her parents’ home.

A year after their marriage, Shivnath had rented a small shop. He was good at taking measurements, cutting cloth and dealing with customers; his hand on the machine was heavy.

“In the first month he ruined two kurtas,” Savitri said, laughing. “One sleeve here, the other somewhere else.”

“So you started going to the shop?”

“Not to the front. I sat at the back.”

“Why?”

Savitri looked towards the empty pea basket, as if the old partition were standing there.

“In those days there was a small child, the house, the kitchen. Many of the customers were men. It was easier to sit behind and sew. Slowly, that simply became the way things were.”

“And only Baba’s name was on the signboard?”

“The shop was in his name. No one ever asked.”

“You didn’t either?”

Savitri thought for a moment. “Not at first. Later it became a habit.”

On Saturday Shivnath went to Rahim, the sign painter in the market.

“I need a small board painted.”

Rahim took out a sheet of paper. “What should I write?”

Shivnath gave him two names.

Rahim looked up. “In this order?”

“Yes. Savitri first.”

“Are you changing the name of the shop?”

“Not the name. I’m correcting the account.”

Rahim asked nothing more.

On Sunday evening the plastic chairs in the market community hall were full.

Traders, customers, neighbours, and a few old acquaintances had gathered.

On the stage stood a flower garland, a certificate of honour, and a small brass lamp.

The sewing machine was not there.

Naveen leaned close to Shivnath and whispered, "You didn't bring it after all?"

"It will come."

"With whom?"

"With the person who ran it."

Again Naveen did not understand.

The programme began.

Two speakers talked about Shivnath's punctuality, his measurements, his ability to save cloth, and his honesty.

Sahdev Mishra said into the microphone, "He stitched my wedding coat."

Seated in front, Shivnath shifted slightly in his chair. Neera was watching his face.

Then the president of the association began reading the citation:

"For four decades of outstanding tailoring skill..."

Shivnath raised his hand.

"One minute."

Every eye turned towards him.

He went slowly onto the stage.

"I will accept the honour," he said, "but that line is wrong."

The president looked flustered. "What is wrong?"

"The tailoring skill is not mine."

A low murmur ran through the hall.

Shivnath took the microphone.

"I took the measurements. I cut the cloth. I listened to the customers' complaints. I counted the money. But the machine..."

He looked towards the doorway.

Neera rose and went outside.

A few moments later she returned with Savitri. Behind Savitri, Nandu and Rahim were carrying the old sewing machine.

Everyone turned to look.

Savitri's discomfort was plain on her face.

Shivnath said, "In these forty years, for every time I sat at that machine, she sat there ten times over."

No one laughed.

"There was a partition at the back of the shop. On this side of the partition was my name. On the other side was her work."

Sahdev Mishra sat straighter in his chair.

Shivnath continued, "Kurtas, trousers, school uniforms, blouses, pillow covers—the clean seams all of you believed came from Shivnath's hands were, in large part, Savitri's work."

Savitri said quietly, "What need was there to say so much?"
 Holding the microphone, Shivnath looked at her.
 "After forty years, there was a need."
 The president looked at the citation.
 "Then we will change the certificate."
 Shivnath said, "Change the paper. But first do one thing."
 Rahim unwrapped a small board from newspaper.
 On a blue background, in white letters, it read:
 "Savitri-Shivnath Tailoring House"
 Below, in smaller letters:
 "Measurement · Cutting · Stitching"
 For a moment the hall was silent. Then came applause.
 Savitri kept looking at the board.
 "Why is my name first?" she asked Shivnath softly.
 "The machine ran first. The scissors came after."
 This time Savitri laughed.
 Naveen placed the sewing machine to one side of the stage. The
 photographer got ready again.
 "Now, Shivnath Kaka, shall you sit beside the machine?"
 Shivnath said, "Will you still seat the wrong person there?"
 A chair was given to Savitri.
 She sat beside the machine. Shivnath stood next to her holding his scissors
 and measuring tape.
 Neera stood behind them holding the signboard.
 The photograph was taken.
 For a moment the flash lit the black body of the old machine.
 On Monday the shop opened again.
 The old "Shivnath Tailors" board was taken down and placed against the
 inside wall. Behind it, a faded rectangular mark remained—the pale outline of
 four decades of dust.
 The new board was hung outside.
 The first customer was an elderly woman who had come to have the sleeves
 of a blouse loosened.
 She read the board and paused.
 "Oh! Savitri's name comes first!"
 From behind the counter Shivnath said, "It has reached its proper place
 rather late."
 Savitri was seated at the machine in the back.
 "Do you still sew?" the elderly woman asked.
 "A little," Savitri said. "Now Neera will learn."
 Neera pulled a stool to the right side of the machine and sat down.

Savitri placed her hands over the cloth.

“Needle down first. Then press the treadle gently.”

The machine began to run—burr... burr... tak.

At the front table Shivnath spread out a piece of cloth, took out the measuring tape, and drew the first line with chalk.

The shop began to work as it always had.

There was only one difference: outside, the signboard now carried two names, and inside, for the first time, the sound of the machine was no longer hidden behind only one of them.

A Pair of Shoes

The women's college hostel was undergoing its year-end inspection.

The superintendent, Madhu Jha, was newly appointed. She had taken charge three months earlier, and this was the first time she was having a complete inventory made of the old storeroom, kitchen, study room, and the students' shared cupboards.

For two days Vimala Didi had been with her, reading out entries, taking out objects, and wiping away dust.

Vimala had worked as an attendant in the hostel for twenty-five years. Without consulting any register, she remembered whose bed had a loose leg, which window leaked during the rains, and which student did not drink milk at night.

After the thirtieth item, Madhu opened an old wooden cupboard.

On the upper shelf lay three umbrellas, a torn bag, two steel boxes, and a pair of black shoes.

Madhu stopped when she saw the shoes.

"Whose are these?"

Vimala bent to look. "Leave them where they are."

"Whose are they?"

"No one's."

Madhu read the line written in the inventory: "Black closed shoes, one pair, owner unknown."

"The rule says that property with an unknown owner is to be removed after six months," Madhu said. "These look much older than that."

The shoes were indeed old, though they did not look like something fit to be thrown away. The leather had softened in many places. A new black rubber piece had been fitted to the heel of the right shoe; the lace on the left was a slightly different shade. Even the inner soles were not the same colour.

Vimala said, "They are old, but they are not bad."

"The owner?"

"There is no name."

Madhu closed the register and looked at her. "There is no name, and there is no owner, are not the same thing."

Vimala smiled faintly. "With this pair, they are."

Madhu did not understand.

That evening a notice was pinned to the board:

"If the old black shoes kept in the hostel's shared cupboard are anyone's personal property, please contact the superintendent's office with proof by Friday. Thereafter they will be removed according to the rules."

A few students stopped to read the notice. Some laughed; some looked at one another. No one came to the office.

On Wednesday Madhu asked Vimala, "See? They belong to no one."

Vimala replied, "That is what I told you from the beginning."

"Then why object to removing them?"

"Wait until Friday."

At about seven on Thursday evening, quick footsteps sounded along the last veranda of the hostel. Nisha Jha, a third-year student, appeared at the office door carrying a transparent file.

"Ma'am, may I ask you something?"

"Ask."

Nisha hesitated. "The black shoes... have they been removed?"

Madhu pushed up her spectacles. "Are they yours?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I need them until Saturday."

"Why?"

"I have a scholarship interview in Darbhanga. The notice says: simple dress, closed shoes. I only have sandals. I called home, but they cannot send new shoes so quickly."

Madhu sat straighter in her chair. "How can I give you property whose owner is unknown?"

Nisha looked at Vimala, who was standing near the doorway holding a register.

Vimala said, "The owner is not unknown. The owner's house is simply very large."

Madhu frowned. "Another riddle?"

Nisha said softly, "Ma'am, these are not private shoes."

"Then why has the register said 'owner unknown' all these years?"

Vimala did not answer at once. She went to the cupboard and took out a small tin box that had been kept behind the shoes.

Inside the box were half a tin of black shoe polish, a small brush, two spare laces, and a thin notebook.

Madhu opened the notebook.

The first page was marked with the year 2014.

Below it were dates:

“12 August — taken.”

“12 August evening — returned.”

“3 November — taken.”

“4 November — returned.”

The next page was 2015. Then 2016. Some years had two entries, some five. There were almost no names anywhere.

“What is this?”

Vimala said, “The record of the shoes going out.”

“To whom?”

“Whoever needed them.”

Nisha stood silently.

Vimala pulled up a chair and sat down.

“Many years ago there was a student named Sulochana. In her final year she had to go to Patna for a job interview. For the first time in her life, she bought a pair of closed black shoes. She got the job. When she left the hostel, she did not take the shoes with her.”

“Why?” Madhu asked.

“She said, ‘There will be little occasion to wear them at home. Someone else here may need them next.’ I told her to write her name on them. She refused. She said, ‘If I write my name, people will think they are borrowed. Let them belong to everyone.’”

Madhu looked at the shoes.

Vimala continued, “In the first year two students wore them. Once a lace broke; the student brought them back with a new lace. Another time the heel wore down; someone had it repaired. Once the polish ran out, another student put in a new tin. Slowly a rule formed: take them, return them clean; if something breaks, get it repaired.”

Madhu slipped her hand inside the left shoe. Along the edge of the sole were tiny stitches.

“This too?”

“The sole came loose one day before someone’s interview. She had it stitched before returning them.”

Nisha said softly, “I had heard about them from senior students. That’s why I came to ask.”

Madhu kept turning the pages of the notebook.

On one page, in red ink, there was only one sentence:

“Returning them is essential.”

“Getting the job isn’t essential?” Madhu asked.

Vimala laughed. “How would we enter that in the register?”

Madhu laughed too.

Then she became serious again. "But the rules?"

Vimala said, "If the rules require a name, write the hostel's name."

"Why wasn't that done before?"

"No one asked before. The former superintendent understood the matter. The old line in the register simply remained."

Madhu thought for a few moments. Then she turned to Nisha.

"Size?"

"Six."

Vimala said at once, "The shoes are six too."

Madhu opened the notebook and wrote a new line:

"Friday evening — Nisha Jha, for interview."

Nisha looked surprised. "You'll write my name?"

"This time we will. The item may be shared; the responsibility will not be unknown."

Nisha nodded.

Vimala handed her the shoes. "Try them on."

Nisha put them on at one side of the office. The left shoe was a little tight. She walked two steps, then turned back.

"They're fine."

"If they hurt your feet, don't stuff them with paper and keep walking," Vimala said. "There's a thin insole in the box."

Nisha laughed. "Didi, you remember every solution."

"The shoes are old. The mistake need not be new."

On Saturday morning Nisha left at half past six. The shoes had been polished. She wore a simple salwar-kurta and carried her file and a cloth bag.

Madhu watched from the veranda. At first Nisha's steps were a little cautious; by the time she reached the gate, they had become natural.

Twice during the day Madhu opened the cupboard and looked at the empty space.

By afternoon she found her own behaviour ridiculous.

"It is only a pair of shoes," she told herself.

But when Nisha had still not returned by seven in the evening, Madhu looked at the veranda clock three times.

At twenty past seven the gate opened. Nisha came in.

She carried the same transparent file in one hand and a paper bag containing the shoes under her arm. On her feet were her old sandals.

"The interview?" Madhu asked.

"It's done."

"How did it go?"

"The result will come later."

She placed the bag on the table.

“Why did you take the shoes off already?”

“There was water on the road after I got off the bus. I thought it better not to wear them through the wet street.”

Vimala opened the bag. The shoes were clean.

Beside her name in the notebook, Nisha wrote: “Returned.”

Then she took a small packet from her pocket.

“What is this?”

“New laces. The old ones are still usable, but one end is beginning to fray. Keep these.”

Madhu kept looking at her.

“I do not yet know whether I’ll get the scholarship,” Nisha said, “but the shoes have come back.”

Vimala looked at Madhu.

The red line in the notebook had proved true again.

On Monday the hostel had its annual inspection.

Reading down the inventory, the inspector stopped at item forty-seven.

“Black closed shoes, one pair — owner unknown?”

Madhu said, “That is an old entry. It was awaiting correction.”

“Has the owner been found?”

“No.”

The inspector’s pen stopped.

Madhu opened the next register. A new entry had already been made:

“Shared interview material — black shoes, size 6, one pair.”

In the owner column was written: “Hostel — shared use.”

The inspector looked up slightly. “Shared shoes?”

Madhu opened the tin box and showed him the notebook.

The inspector read two or three pages. He said nothing. Then, in the old inventory, he drew a line through “owner unknown” and wrote: “Transferred to shared materials.”

The inspection moved on.

That afternoon Madhu took down her old notice from the board—the one warning that the shoes would be removed.

In its place she pinned a smaller new notice:

“Black shoes, size 6 — available for interviews/formal requirements. Enter your name at the office. Return them clean after use. If the laces, sole or heel break, have them repaired if possible.”

Below it, Vimala added one line in her own handwriting:

“Returning them is essential.”

Madhu read the line and laughed.

That evening a first-year student reading the notice asked, “Ma’am, whose are these shoes, after all?”

Madhu thought for a moment before answering.

“The register says they belong to the hostel.”

The student asked again, “And actually?”

Madhu looked towards the cupboard. Inside, the black shoes rested with their new laces. The leather was old, but the pair was ready again.

“Actually,” she said, “they belong to whoever needs them, and after that, to the next person who does.”

The student read the notice once more.

The cupboard was closed. Inside it was a pair of shoes that belonged privately to no one, yet was useless to no one.

The Lost Wallet

Raghuvir Mandal's bicycle-repair shop at the bus stand opened before anyone else's in the morning.

To call it a shop was generous: a small tin roof, a wooden table, an air pump, two spanners, and a few old tyres hanging at the back.

The buses began drawing crowds from seven, but Raghuvir arrived by half past six. At that hour the stand was only half awake: the tea seller blew into his stove, the sweeper worked with his broom, and drivers lifted engine covers to inspect them.

That Tuesday the ground was damp from the night's rain. Raghuvir was clearing water from in front of his shop when something brown glinted beneath the iron bench in the waiting area.

At first he thought it was a scrap of paper. When he bent and picked it up, it turned out to be a leather wallet.

The wallet was not wet. It must have survived the night beneath the bench.

Raghuvir looked around.

Only an elderly man sat in the waiting area with a newspaper open. Two drivers stood at the tea stall. No one seemed to be searching for a wallet.

Raghuvir weighed it in his hand. Something inside made it heavy.

He called to Munna, the tea seller. "Did you see anyone drop a wallet here?"

Munna shook his head. "No. Open it. There may be an identity card."

Raghuvir did not like opening another man's wallet. But finding its owner without looking inside would also be difficult.

He undid the button.

There was money inside: two five-hundred-rupee notes, three two-hundred-rupee notes, and some smaller notes. An old identity card was tucked into one compartment.

Raghuvir took out the identity card first.

"Devendra Sah — Conductor."

Below it were the name of a private bus service and the route: Madhubani-Fulparas.

As soon as Raghuvir read the name, he could picture the face. Devendra was the thin, dark conductor who spun his ticket-punch between his fingers while speaking.

Raghuvir often travelled to the weekly market on that bus on Wednesdays.

As he put the identity card back, his eyes fell on another compartment.

There was more paper there than money.

Small slips: the back of a cut ticket, the corner of a notebook page, the blank part of a medicine receipt. All folded.

One slip opened and fell out.

On it was written: "Shanti Devi — 8."

Raghuvir picked it up. Another said: "Karim Miyan — 5."

A third: "Ramchandra Master — 12."

Names and amounts. Nothing else.

Raghuvir frowned.

"Looks like a list of debts," Munna said, having come up behind him.

Raghuvir was about to close the wallet at once when familiar letters on the corner of one slip stopped him.

"Raghuvir Mandal — 6."

He read it twice.

Munna laughed. "Arre, your name is there too! Do you owe him money?"

Raghuvir said nothing.

He could not remember owing Devendra anything. On Devendra's bus he always paid cash for his ticket.

He had gone to the market the previous Wednesday too, but who remembers eight days later exactly how much fare he paid and how much change he received?

Raghuvir folded the slip again and returned it to the same compartment.

"I'll deposit the wallet at the office," he said.

The small bus-stand office was at the far end of the platform. Inside, Ramkishor Babu was writing out the timetable.

Raghuvir placed the wallet on the table. "Found it under the bench. The identity card says Devendra Sah."

Ramkishor Babu pushed his spectacles up. "The Madhubani-Fulparas conductor?"

"Yes."

"His bus comes at seven twenty-five. Leave it here. I'll give it to him."

Raghuvir withdrew his hand, then paused.

"Should we write a receipt?"

Ramkishor Babu smiled. "I'll write one. How much money is in it?"

Raghuvir said, "I didn't count it."

Ramkishor Babu reached to open the wallet, then stopped. "Then we'll count it in front of the owner. Fine."

Raghuvir returned to his shop.

By seven the bus stand was fully awake. Schoolchildren, men and women going to the market, baskets, bags, milk cans, bus horns — everything mingled together.

Raghuvir was pumping air into the rear tyre of a bicycle, but his mind kept returning to the slip: "Raghuvir Mandal — 6."

Six rupees.

Such a small amount was easy to forget.

But why had Devendra written down his name?

The seven twenty-five bus arrived five minutes late.

As soon as it stopped, the conductor did not call out as he usually did, "Fulparas, Ghoghardiha, move inside."

Devendra got down first and began looking at the ground.

He checked the first step of the bus, beside the wheel, then bent to look beneath the benches on the platform.

The driver told him, "Ask at the office."

Worry was plain on Devendra's face.

Raghuvir stopped pumping.

Devendra hurried towards the office.

A few moments later Ramkishor Babu's voice came from inside. "First tell me what the wallet looks like."

Devendra said, "Brown. The stitching is open at the right corner. Inside there is an identity card, money, and many slips."

Ramkishor Babu brought out the wallet.

Devendra seemed to get his breath back all at once.

After taking the wallet, he did not count the notes first.

He opened the paper compartment first.

He began moving the slips one by one with his finger.

Ramkishor Babu laughed. "Money later, slips first?"

Devendra said, "If the money is short or extra, I can work that out. If these slips were lost, I would forget whom I owe and how much."

Standing near the doorway, Raghuvir caught on that sentence.

He went inside.

"Whom you owe how much?"

Devendra recognized him at once. "Raghuvir Bhai, you?"

Ramkishor Babu said, "He is the one who found the wallet."

Devendra immediately folded both hands. "You have done me a great favour."

Raghuvir cut him off. "First tell me this: the people whose names are on those slips — do they owe you, or do you owe them?"

Devendra was silent for a moment, then understood that Raghuvir had seen the slips.

He smiled.

"I owe them."

The question remained on Raghuvir's face.

Devendra took out one slip: "Shanti Devi — 8."

"Yesterday evening she gave me a fifty-rupee note. The fare was forty-two. I had no change. I wrote eight on the back of the ticket, and also wrote her name for myself. Next time I see her, I'll return the eight."

Another slip: "Karim Miyan — 5."

"This is three days old. He doesn't travel every day, so I kept a separate slip."

Ramkishor Babu said, "But it is written on the ticket too, isn't it?"

Devendra nodded. "It is. But people throw tickets away, they get wet, or they forget. My memory will not be equally good every time either. So whenever I cannot return someone's change immediately, I write down the name."

Raghuvir said slowly, "So this is not a list of money people owe you..."

"It is a debt," Devendra said, "but in the opposite direction."

Ramkishor Babu laughed.

Raghuvir laughed too, but he remembered his own slip.

He asked, "Is there someone named Raghuvir Mandal too?"

Without searching, Devendra said, "Six rupees."

Raghuvir's smile vanished.

"You remember?"

"The Wednesday market run. You gave fifty. The fare was forty-four. I had only two two-rupee coins left. I told you I'd give the rest next Wednesday."

Raghuvir scratched his head.

Now he faintly remembered. The bus had been crowded; Devendra had said something while handing him the ticket. In his hurry to get down, Raghuvir had merely waved his hand.

"I had forgotten," Raghuvir said.

Devendra opened the coin compartment.

He took out three two-rupee coins and placed them on Raghuvir's palm.

Raghuvir drew his hand back. "Leave it for now. What are six rupees?"

Devendra placed the coins in his palm again. "Six may be small. The account is not."

Raghuvir was about to say something, but Devendra continued, "You returned my whole wallet. Why should I keep your six?"

Ramkishor Babu closed the receipt book lying on the table. "Both accounts are being settled in the same place."

Devendra began sorting the slips again.

Raghuvir noticed that some had red lines drawn through them.

"Why are these crossed out?"

"When I return someone's money, I cross the name out. In the evening, when I get home, I throw the slip away."

Devendra found the slip marked "Raghuvir Mandal — 6."

In front of Raghuvir, he drew a straight red line through it.

"Now it's settled."

At that moment a woman called from the bus door, "Devendra! You remember my eight rupees from yesterday, don't you?"

Without turning, Devendra said, "Shanti Devi, I remember. I'm coming."

He took eight rupees from the wallet.

Raghuvir smiled. "And if the slip had not been there?"

Fastening the wallet firmly, Devendra said, "Then someone's five, someone's eight, someone's twelve would dissolve into my memory. Small amounts are forgotten first."

"People forget too," Raghuvir said.

"That is why I write them down."

Devendra ran back to the bus. He put eight rupees in Shanti Devi's hand, punched a ticket, then stood by the door urging passengers farther inside.

Raghuvir returned to his shop.

The three two-rupee coins were still in his palm.

Munna the tea seller asked, "What happened? Was your name in his debt list?"

Raghuvir placed the coins on the table and coiled the air-pump hose.

"It was in a debt list," he said.

Munna widened his eyes. "You had to pay?"

Raghuvir laughed. "No. I had money to receive."

Before Munna could understand, the bus horn sounded.

Devendra raised a hand from the doorway towards Raghuvir. The wallet was safe in the inside pocket of his shirt.

The bus slowly left the stand.

Raghuvir picked up the six rupees from the table. It occurred to him that he had neither saved nor earned that amount; someone had simply remembered it on his behalf.

He dropped all three coins into the small box where he kept change.

They made three tin-tin sounds in the box.

At noon, when a schoolboy came to have air put into his bicycle tyre and paid with a five-rupee coin, Raghuvir did not have one rupee in change.

He turned the box over and looked. It contained only two-rupee coins.
The boy said, "I'll take it tomorrow."
Raghuvir tore a small piece from a sheet of paper on the table.
He asked the boy's name and wrote: "Sonu — 1."
The boy laughed. "You're writing my name for one rupee?"
Raghuvir folded the slip and placed it beneath the change box.
"The money is small," he said. "Remembering is not."

The Rented Room

Behind Sharda Devi's old two-storey house in Kadirabad, Darbhanga, there was a small room.

It was eight cubits long and six wide, with a green window, two wooden shelves set into the wall, an iron cot in one corner, and a hook behind the door.

Among girl students, the room in that house was well known. The rent was not very low, but by the standards of the market it was not high either.

Kiran Jha had been living there for eleven months.

She had come to Darbhanga from a village near Jhanjharpur and was preparing for teacher recruitment. Mornings in the library, afternoons at coaching, evenings studying in her room — eleven months had passed in that rhythm.

On the last Monday of Bhadra, she received her appointment letter.

She had to report on Saturday for training at a district school. Hostel accommodation was also available, so she had to give up the rented room.

Kiran had already paid the full month's rent on the first of the month. But she would have to leave on Thursday morning. Four days would still remain before the month ended.

She was not desperately short of money, but ahead lay the journey to the new place, the hostel deposit, and the cost of a few necessary things.

That evening she went to Sharda Devi.

Sharda Devi was sitting on the veranda, sorting paddy. Kiran said, "Mausi, I'll leave the room on Thursday."

Sharda Devi stopped her hands. "So soon?"

Kiran told her about the appointment letter.

Sharda Devi's face lit up. "That is good news. When are you leaving?"

"Thursday morning. Four days early."

Kiran paused. "What about those four days...?"

Sharda Devi placed the basket of paddy beside her. "I'll look at the register and tell you. We'll settle the account tomorrow evening."

The answer was perfectly ordinary, yet a small uncertainty rose in Kiran's mind.

“I’ll look at the register and tell you” — what exactly did that mean? Would she get the money for four days back or not?

She returned to her room.

Outside the window, the leaves of the mango tree moved in the rainy-season wind. Her appointment letter lay on the table, but Kiran’s attention kept returning to the rent calculation.

Four days were not much. Even so, she had already paid for the whole month.

She thought there was nothing wrong in asking.

She began packing. She divided her books into three piles: those she would take with her, those she would send home, and those she would give to the small library at the coaching centre.

While taking old papers down from the shelf, she remembered her first day.

Eleven months earlier she had reached Darbhanga in the evening. It had been agreed that the room would be available from the following day, because the previous tenant’s month ran until that night.

But the previous tenant had left two days early.

Sharda Devi had given Kiran the key that very night.

Kiran had asked, “What about the money for tonight?”

Sharda Devi had said, “Tonight is already accounted for.”

At the time Kiran had assumed it was simply the landlady’s ordinary generosity.

The memory returned now, though its meaning was still not clear.

The next morning, while Kiran was wrapping utensils in old newspaper, two young women came into the back courtyard.

One held an admit card. The other seemed to be her sister.

“Mausi, can we get a room for one night?” the first young woman asked.

Sharda Devi said, “Everything is occupied right now.”

“On the veranda?”

“Not on the veranda at night. There is Saraswati Niwas in the lane ahead. Ask there.”

The two young women left.

Kiran watched from the window. She was a little surprised. If Sharda Devi had wanted, she could have charged them for the veranda or the empty room upstairs. But she never turned the house into a daily-rate lodging house.

That afternoon Sharda Devi came into Kiran’s room.

“We’ll settle the account tomorrow evening. We’ll look at the key then too.”

“All right.”

Sharda Devi looked towards the corner of the wall. "Don't remove that hook. It was there before you came."

Kiran laughed. "I was wondering how it got so crooked."

"It is very old."

Sharda Devi left.

By Wednesday evening Kiran had packed everything: one shoulder bag, one suitcase, and two boxes of books.

At half past seven she went to the front room to settle the account.

That room was like Sharda Devi's small office: a table, an iron chest, a file of electricity bills, a bundle of rent receipts, and a thick register.

The register had a blue cover, its corners worn white.

Sharda Devi put on her spectacles and opened it.

Kiran sat opposite her.

The first pages carried the names of former tenants of the house. Dates, monthly rent, deposits, and key numbers were all written neatly.

Turning the pages, Sharda Devi came to Kiran's name.

"Kiran Jha. Arrived on the twenty-seventh of Ashwin. Regular rent: all months complete. Electricity: paid."

Kiran's attention went to a narrow column on the right-hand side of the register.

At the top of that column was written: "+ Days."

There were numbers beside several names.

"Rita — +2."

"Najma — +1."

"Pooja — +3."

"Sarita — +1."

Beside some names was zero.

At first Kiran thought these might be extra days charged for vacating the room late.

She asked, "What are these plus days?"

Sharda Devi looked at her over the top of her spectacles. "First let us settle your account."

She picked up the calculator.

"Monthly rent: twenty-one hundred. At thirty days, one day comes to seventy. Four days: two hundred and eighty."

Sharda Devi opened the chest and took out three hundred rupees.

Kiran immediately said, "I have twenty rupees in change."

"No. Listen first."

Sharda Devi placed the three hundred rupees on the table and turned the register towards Kiran.

“These + days are days for which a tenant has already paid, but leaves before the room is due to be vacated.”

Kiran fell silent.

Sharda Devi put her finger on Rita’s name. “Rita left two days early. I told her to take the money for those two days. She said no — if some girl comes to sit an examination and gets stranded for a night or two, let her stay during those days.”

“So this is an account of donations?” Kiran asked.

Sharda Devi shook her head. “Call it a donation and the matter becomes heavy. It is simply an account of days whose rent has already been paid.”

She pointed to another name. “Najma left one day. Pooja left three. If someone wants all her money back, I return it. Someone feels like leaving one day, someone two. I do not keep even a single day without asking.”

Kiran kept looking at the register.

“And someone actually stays during these days?”

“Yes. Mostly girls who come to sit examinations. I check the admit card. Not more than one or two nights. Only when a room is vacant and there are days in the account.”

“You don’t take money?”

“How can I take rent twice for the same night?”

The sentence was so simple that Kiran had no immediate reply.

She remembered her own first night.

“When I first came... you told me, ‘Tonight is already accounted for.’”

Sharda Devi smiled.

She turned back to an older page of the register.

“Look.”

On that page was written: “Manjari Karn — +1.”

Below it, in smaller letters: “Used by: Kiran Jha, teacher-exam preparation, 1 night.”

Kiran’s finger touched the paper almost without her realizing it.

“So my first night...”

“Was Manjari’s unused day.”

“Did she know me?”

“No.”

“Then why the name?”

“The name is for the account. Nothing more.”

Kiran read the register again.

Some lines had names of people who had used the days. Some were still blank.

Sharda Devi said, "Not every day gets used. If the time passes and no one comes, the day is finished. I do not carry that money into another month. Only the exact number of days the room was truly vacant."

Kiran liked that rule. There was no invisible charity box in the arrangement, no burden of favour upon anyone. Only a small accounting of time.

Sharda Devi pushed the three hundred rupees towards her again.

"Your four days. Two hundred and eighty. Give me twenty back."

Kiran looked at the notes.

She remembered the hostel deposit. The travel expense too.

She did not want to make an impulsive, emotional decision.

"May I take the money for three days?"

"Of course."

"Leave one day in the account."

Sharda Devi picked up her pen. "Certain?"

"Yes. One day. I need the money for the other three."

Without praise, without widening her smile, Sharda Devi wrote in the register: "Kiran Jha — +1."

Then she counted out two hundred and ten rupees and placed them on the table.

"This is for three days."

Kiran took the money.

She was glad she had taken back the three days she needed. She had left one day simply because one day was what she could afford to leave.

Just then a voice came from the outer gate.

"Mausi?"

Sharda Devi rose.

A middle-aged woman stood there with her daughter. The girl held a transparent file against her chest.

"Her examination is tomorrow morning," the woman said. "The train arrived very late. The rooms near the station are asking so much... if there is anything for one night..."

Sharda Devi first looked at the girl. "Do you have the admit card?"

The girl opened the file and showed her the paper.

Sharda Devi came back inside and looked at the register.

Kiran was still sitting in the chair.

Looking not at Kiran but at the register, Sharda Devi said, "There is one night."

Kiran felt a small jolt in her heart.

She had imagined that the one day she was leaving might someday be of use to someone.

She had not imagined that the very day would be standing at the door so soon.

The girl's mother asked, "How much?"

Sharda Devi said, "The rent for tonight has already been paid."

The woman looked startled. "By whom?"

Closing the register, Sharda Devi said, "By the room."

Kiran could not keep from smiling.

Sharda Devi looked at her but said nothing.

Kiran stood up. "I'll give you the key tomorrow morning."

"All right. Give it by seven so the room can be cleaned."

Early the next morning Kiran rose.

The cot was bare. The shelves were empty. Beside the window there was only a square of sunlight.

She swept the floor, wiped the table, and looked once more at the crooked hook behind the door.

She carried the suitcase outside and finally stood in the middle of the room.

In eleven months this small place had witnessed her studies, fever, rain, failed practice tests, and her appointment letter.

Kiran pulled the door shut.

Handing the key to Sharda Devi, she said, "The hook is still as it was."

Sharda Devi laughed. "Its account is not in the register."

In the courtyard, the student from the previous night — Sonam — sat reading her books. Her examination was at ten.

She greeted Kiran. Neither of them yet knew the other's name.

Kiran returned the greeting.

As she crossed the gate, it occurred to her that Manjari Karn too had probably never known her.

The rickshaw arrived.

Kiran loaded her luggage and sat down.

Sharda Devi went back inside and opened the blue register.

Opposite the line "Kiran Jha — +1," she wrote in small letters: "Used by: Sonam, teacher examination, 1 night."

Then she added the date.

After that day, Kiran's account stood at zero.

The room was rented again, but the rent for one night had not been charged twice.

The Nameless Parcel

On the eastern side of the old pond in Benipatti, the yellow gate of Arun Jha's house could be recognized from a distance.

The paint had faded somewhat, but bus drivers and conductors still called that turn "the Yellow Gate."

Six weeks earlier, Arun's mother, Kaushalya Devi, had died. Since then the gate remained closed for most of the day.

When Kaushalya Devi was alive, she would place a bamboo stool just inside the gate at eight every morning and sit there.

Arun had often said, "Ma, sit inside on the veranda. Too much dust blows here."

Kaushalya Devi would reply, "There is a breeze here."

Arun had assumed that was the only reason.

That Tuesday, at about two in the afternoon, a horn sounded three times loudly at the gate.

Mamta came out from the kitchen.

An old blue-and-white bus stood on the road. For a while, the cloud of dust behind it hung in the air.

The conductor's assistant was lowering a large brown bundle from the roof.

"Kaki's house?" he asked, looking towards the gate.

Mamta was silent for a moment.

"Kaki is no longer here," she said softly.

The man's hands stopped. "Oh."

Then someone called from inside the bus, "Give it there. The house is the same."

The helper placed the bundle inside the gate.

"Who sent it?" Mamta asked.

"I don't know."

"The fare?"

"Paid."

"By whom?"

The man turned towards the bus. "It was put aboard at the stand. We were told: Kaki's house, Yellow Gate."

With that he ran back and climbed onto the bus.
The bus pulled away.
Mamta stood looking at the bundle.
In thick blue pen on the brown paper was written: "Kaki's house, Yellow Gate, near the old pond, Benipatti."
The sender's space was blank.
There was no phone number either.
Mamta called Arun from inside.
Arun had returned from the circle office and had just sat down to drink tea.
He came out and turned the bundle over.
"No name?"
"No."
"No postal slip?"
"It came by bus."
Neelima too left her studies and came outside. She was in the final year of her undergraduate degree.
"Even Dadi's name isn't written," she said. "Only Kaki's house."
Arun frowned. "Should we open it?"
Mamta said, "The address is our house. If there are papers inside, perhaps we'll understand."
The bundle was not very heavy, but many things seemed to shift and rustle inside.
Arun brought scissors.
The string on top was cut.
When the brown paper was removed, an old plastic fertilizer sack appeared beneath it. It had been washed clean. Its mouth was tied firmly with cord.
Neelima tried to laugh. "This is exactly how Dadi used to tie things. She never threw anything away."
No one answered.
The cord was opened.
There were no gifts inside.
Instead there were twelve small bundles—some wrapped in newspaper, some in cloth, some in old medicine cartons.
A different name was written on each.
"Ramdulari Devi — Barha Tola."
"Najma Khatoon — behind the mosque."
"Amresh Paswan — beyond the canal."
"Sonu — Mahendra Sah's grandson."
"Lalita Mishra — North Orchard."
Arun read the names one by one.
"These are all local people," Mamta said.

“Then why was the parcel sent to our house?”

Neelima reached into the sack. At the bottom lay a folded sheet of paper. She opened it.

Four lines were written on it:

“Heard that Kaki is no more. These things were still lying at the stand. They do not belong to one person, so no sender’s name has been written. Give each bundle to the person whose name is on it. Two bundles have incomplete names—the rest will be found in Kaki’s notebook.”

There was no signature below.

Arun read the note again.

“Kaki’s notebook?”

Mamta immediately looked towards Kaushalya Devi’s room.

For six weeks the room had remained almost exactly as it was: the cot, the iron trunk, the small picture of God, the wall clock, and the wooden shelf beside the window.

Kaushalya Devi kept many papers: old electricity bills, seed receipts, medicine wrappers, temple-donation slips—all in separate folds.

Arun could not remember any notebook.

“Let’s deliver the bundles with clear names first,” Mamta said. “We’ll look for the other two later.”

Neelima picked up Ramdulari Devi’s bundle.

“Shouldn’t we open it?”

Arun said, “No. Whoever it belongs to will open it.”

Ramdulari Devi lived two houses away.

The moment she saw the bundle, her face brightened.

“It has come now?”

Neelima looked surprised. “You knew about it?”

“My son had new lenses fitted for my spectacles in Darbhanga and sent them. He called three weeks ago and said he had given them to a busman.”

“Why didn’t you go and collect them?”

“Where would I go? He said it would reach Kaki’s house.”

Holding the bundle, Ramdulari Devi suddenly fell silent.

“I had forgotten that Kaushalya is now...”

The sentence remained unfinished.

Neelima returned home.

The second bundle was Najma Khatoon’s. Inside it was a small belt for her sewing machine, sent by her brother from Madhubani.

The third bundle, for Amresh Paswan, contained two plastic covers for certificates.

The fourth was Sonu’s mathematics practice book.

The fifth was the cuff of Lalita Mishra's blood-pressure monitor, which had been sent for repair.

By evening seven bundles had been delivered.

Almost everyone gave the same answer: "It had been given to the busman," "It was supposed to be dropped at Kaki's house," "Kaki would deliver it."

Arun could not believe that all this had been going on for so long.

"When did Ma do all this?"

Mamta looked at him. "When you were at the tehsil, I was in the kitchen, and Neelima was at college."

"But all day?"

"Not all day. At bus time."

Suddenly Neelima remembered a very old sound: two short horns on the road, then the knock of Dadi rising from her stool.

As a child she had thought Dadi hurried outside simply to watch the bus.

Sometimes Dadi would come inside carrying a small bundle wrapped in newspaper.

"Whose is it?" Neelima would ask.

"Someone's from the western hamlet."

Then Dadi would call some child and send it on.

No one in the household had ever discussed it.

Before darkness fell, five bundles remained.

Three had clear names. Two carried only clues.

On one was written: "Shambhu's mother, who lives behind the old school."

On the other: "The girl who comes to learn sewing on Wednesdays."

Arun did not laugh.

"This isn't an address. It's a riddle."

Mamta said, "For Kaushalya Ma, it would have been an address."

Neelima remembered the line in the note: it will be found in Kaki's notebook.

All three went into the room.

The iron trunk was opened.

Saris lay on top, then an old towel, a box of coins, another box of puja things.

No notebook.

They searched the shelf.

Electricity bills, medicine slips, ration papers.

Under the cot was a small tin box.

Inside were balls of wool, two old pairs of spectacles, a comb, needle and thread.

Neelima was disappointed.

"How did the person who wrote that note know there was a notebook?"

Arun said, "That means the people at the stand knew Ma well."

Mamta was wiping the window frame when she suddenly stopped.

"What is this?"

Between the wall below the window and the cot, a thin notebook had slipped down.

Nothing was written on the cover.

When they opened the first page, there was a date at the top.

Below it, three columns had been drawn by hand: "For whom," "What," "Delivered or not."

The first entry was seven years old.

"Mahendra Sah — medicine — delivered."

"Razia — school papers — delivered."

"Bindeshwar — key — delivered."

Page after page was filled with such small entries.

Many lines had a round mark beside them. Many had dates. Some said: "House locked," "Try again tomorrow," "Grandson collected."

Neelima slowly turned the pages.

It was not an account book.

No money was recorded in it. It was a memory of things that had reached their destination.

Here and there the names of buses appeared too: "Mithila," "Jai Ma," "Sugauna route," "Afternoon blue bus."

Arun asked, "All these years?"

Mamta said, "Ma still sat at the gate after I came here as a bride. There weren't even so many mobile phones then."

The handwriting on the final pages trembled slightly.

An entry from two months before her death read: "Ramdulari — spectacles — to arrive."

Below it: "Najma — machine belt — to arrive."

And then the two incomplete clues.

"Shambhu's mother — name: Devaki Devi."

"Wednesday sewing girl — Ruby Kumari, tenant in the red house to the west."

The addresses of the last two bundles had been found.

Arun sat for a long time holding the notebook.

"Ma never told me."

Mamta replied, "What was there to tell? People gave her things and she delivered them."

"It was a responsibility."

"Yes."

Neelima said, "And everyone trusted her."

That night the final two bundles were delivered.

Devaki Devi's bundle contained batteries for a hearing aid. Ruby's held two special sewing-machine presser feet sent by her instructor from Darbhanga.

When they returned home, the fertilizer sack lay empty.

But one object still remained at the bottom, something no one had noticed earlier.

An old cloth bag printed with yellow and green flowers.

Neelima picked it up.

"This is Dadi's."

Arun recognized it immediately. Whenever Kaushalya Devi went to the market, she carried that bag. Five years earlier Mamta had patched one corner with blue thread.

There was nothing inside it except half a broken pencil.

Mamta ran her finger over the patch.

"How did this reach the stand?"

Arun said, "We'll go and ask tomorrow."

The next morning Arun and Neelima went to the bus stand.

The counter for the afternoon blue bus was not a proper office: a tin awning beside a tea stall, one table, two benches.

A man of about sixty named Raghunandan sat at the counter.

Arun placed the bag on the table.

"Did you send that parcel?"

Raghunandan understood as soon as he saw the bag.

"Did it reach?"

"Yes. But why was there no sender's name?"

Raghunandan laughed. "Whose name should I have written?"

"The person who collected everything."

"I collected it, but the things weren't mine. Half came with different drivers, some were left by passengers, two came through another bus operator. Everyone said the same thing: drop it at Kaki's house."

"Did Ma come here?"

"Sometimes. Mostly we sent things with the bus."

"And the bag?"

Raghunandan looked at the patch.

"The last time she came."

Arun fell silent.

Raghunandan continued, "About two months ago. There were three bundles. Kaki said, 'Put them in the bag. My hands tremble.' I did. Then she sat on the bench for a while. When the bus was about to leave, she got up and went. The bag remained here."

"No one returned it?"

"I thought I would send it the next day with the busman. Then I heard she was ill. Then..."

The sentence stopped there.

Raghunandan scratched the corner of the table.

"The parcels kept accumulating. At first I thought the house was in mourning, so whom should I give them to? Then the old route storeroom had to be cleared. So I put everything into one sack and sent it."

Neelima asked, "How long had Dadi been doing this?"

Raghunandan leaned back in his chair.

"It's hard to say exactly how many years. Almost since this route began. Earlier the bus ran only twice a day. Many village homes had no road access. Someone would send medicine from town, someone papers, someone a key, someone a small machine part. If we wrote full addresses, the bus staff would have to go from house to house."

"So the Yellow Gate?"

"So Kaki."

"Why?"

Raghunandan answered at once.

"She did not forget names."

Then he thought for a moment and added, "And she never handed anything to the wrong person."

Neelima remembered the round marks in Dadi's notebook.

"Did she charge anything?"

Raghunandan made a face as though the question were odd.

"Kaki? No. The bus charged a fare if one had been fixed. Kaki's work was only to see that it reached the person."

Arun said softly, "We knew nothing about this."

Raghunandan looked at him.

"People inside a house often know less about what happens outside its gate."

He said it without sermon or reproach, as though stating an ordinary fact.

On the wall behind the counter hung several lengths of string from an old nail. Perhaps parcels had once been suspended there.

Arun picked up the cloth bag.

As they were about to leave, Raghunandan called, "One thing."

"Yes?"

"If small parcels come now, where should we drop them?"

Arun was about to answer, but Neelima spoke first.

"At the Yellow Gate."

Arun looked at his daughter.

Neelima added, "Call first. The name will be written clearly."

Raghunandan laughed. "Times have changed now."

Neelima laughed too. "So has the notebook."

After returning home, she placed Kaushalya Devi's thin notebook on the table.

The old pages remained exactly as they were.

On the final blank page, Neelima wrote the date.

Arun asked, "What are you writing?"

"Nothing yet. Only beginning."

She drew three columns: "For whom," "What," "Delivered or not."

Mamta watched from a distance and smiled.

Two days later, at noon, two short horn blasts sounded on the road again.

Neelima was reading a book on the veranda.

Without thinking, she got up and went towards the gate.

The blue bus stopped for a moment.

The helper held out a small bundle wrapped in newspaper through the window.

"Mahendra Sah — medicine."

Neelima took the bundle.

"Did he phone?"

"Yes. The number is at the counter."

The bus moved on.

Neelima came inside. She opened the notebook and made the first new entry: "Mahendra Sah — medicine."

She left the "Delivered or not" box blank.

In the evening Mahendra Sah's grandson came and collected the bundle.

Neelima placed a round mark in the box.

Arun was sitting in a chair on the veranda at the time.

The gate stood open.

The yellow panels moved slightly in the breeze.

For the first time Arun understood that the nameless parcel had not really been some secret gift from anyone.

It was the remainder of a route—a route along which people had entrusted one another with names even more than with objects.

Kaushalya Devi's cloth bag now hung from a nail beside the window.

There was nothing inside it.

Looking at the empty bag, Neelima did not see absence. She saw space.

Behind the Photograph

On the eastern wall of the sitting room in Vijaykant Jha's house, in the old quarter of Madhubani town, a broad black wooden frame had hung for fifty years.

Inside it was a black-and-white photograph: five adults, two children, and, in the middle, Gauri Devi in a white sari.

The photograph had no official name in the household. Everyone simply called it "the picture of everyone."

The family story was that it had been taken in 1971, when all four of Gauri Devi's children had gathered at the ancestral home at the same time.

Vijaykant had heard this since childhood.

"After that, everyone could never be together again," his mother, Sudha Devi, used to say.

And so the photograph seemed to carry more weight than an ordinary family picture.

Today was the first day of clearing out the house.

Vijaykant and his younger sister Meera had both arrived with their families.

Sudha Devi had died six months earlier. No one now lived in the ancestral house regularly.

The decision to sell it had come only after much thought.

The old bed, the brass water pot, two trunks, the bookcase—decisions about these were being made easily enough.

But discussion stalled at the photograph in the sitting room.

Meera said, "I'll take this."

Vijaykant immediately asked, "Why?"

"Ma used to say never throw it away."

"Who is talking about throwing it away? It can stay at my house too."

Meera looked at the frame.

"Where is there space in your house?"

Vijaykant laughed a little. "Space is made for a photograph."

His daughter Neha was closing a cardboard box and listening to them.

She said, "Let the original stay with one of you. I'll have a good scan made so everyone can have a copy."

Meera thought that reasonable.

"The frame has to be opened first," Neha added. "There is a haze trapped under the glass."

The wood at one lower corner of the frame was also beginning to split.

Vijaykant said, "Naresh Babu on Station Road still does old photographs. He can clean it."

That afternoon Neha and Meera took the picture to Naresh Photo Service.

The shop had become half photo studio and half mobile-print shop.

Behind the glass were passport photographs, enlarged wedding prints, and samples of restored old pictures.

Naresh Thakur was past seventy, but he still sat behind the counter himself.

Meera set the frame before him.

"We want this cleaned. Change the glass, and save the frame if it can be saved."

Naresh looked once at the picture from a distance.

"Very old."

"1971," Meera said at once.

Naresh pushed his spectacles up and looked again.

"Are you certain of the date?"

Meera smiled. "It's the most famous date in our family."

Naresh turned the frame over.

Thick brown paper had been pasted across the back, fixed around the edges with small nails.

"This paper will have to be cut," he said.

"Cut it."

With a small knife he lifted the edge of the paper.

A thin layer of dust rose.

When the backing board came free, Neha took out her phone to photograph it, but Naresh stopped her hand.

"One minute."

On the inside of the board, four separate numbers had been written in pencil:

127/B.

48/D.

301/A.

72/C.

Beside them were two small arrows in red pencil and one circled mark.

Meera asked, "What are these?"

Naresh did not answer.

He carefully lifted the photograph out of the frame.

On the back of the photographic paper were two faint stamps: "Sharda Art Studio, Madhubani" and "Re-touch."

Naresh's expression changed.

"This is work from Sharda Studio."

Neha asked, "Where was that studio?"

"Two lanes west of here. There is a cloth shop there now."

Meera said, "Did my grandfather have photographs taken there?"

"Many people did. But these numbers..."

Naresh placed a white light in front of the photograph.

He took out a lens and examined each face in turn.

Neha laughed. "What are you looking at like a detective?"

Naresh did not laugh.

"Not everyone in this picture sat before the camera at the same time."

Meera did not understand.

"What do you mean?"

"This is a composite photograph."

The sound of the shop's fan suddenly seemed much louder.

Neha was curious first. "The photographs were combined?"

"Yes. By the old method. Faces and bodies from different negatives were brought together into one frame."

Meera reached towards the photograph, then stopped.

"No. They were all photographed together. Everyone at home says so."

Naresh said softly, "Look."

He pointed towards the feet of the man standing at the left.

"Here the shadow falls to the right."

Then he showed the space beneath another woman's chair.

"Here the shadow is almost straight."

Then the edge of Gauri Devi's shoulder.

"This part has been retouched by hand. Behind the child too."

Neha looked very closely.

What had always seemed to her a single natural moment now began to show its fine joins.

The light on one child's kurta was slightly different from everyone else's.

The man on the right was looking half an inch above the camera.

Meera sat down on a chair.

"Then everyone wasn't together in 1971?"

Naresh shrugged.

"The photograph tells us only that one picture was made from four sources. I know nothing about what happened in the family."

Meera remained silent for a long time.

Neha understood that her mother's shock was not really about the photograph being false. It was about a very old sentence in the family breaking apart.

"Ma called this 'the picture of everyone,'" Meera said softly.

"She wasn't wrong about that either," Neha said.

Meera looked at her.

"But they weren't together."

"They are all in the photograph."

"That is a different thing."

Naresh turned the backing board over again and again.

"If the original job register survived, these numbers would explain it."

Neha asked, "Where would the register be?"

Naresh thought for a moment.

"The owner of Sharda Studio was Shashibhushan Lal. His son Arvind lives on Rajnagar Road now. I've heard he preserved a lot of old material."

Meera stood up at once.

"Give us the address."

Naresh said, "Leave the frame here first. It is not wise to carry the photograph around while it is open."

Neha photographed all four numbers clearly on her phone.

That evening they told Vijaykant what they had learned.

His first reaction was disbelief.

"Naresh Babu may have misunderstood."

Neha showed him the photograph on her phone.

"There are four numbers."

Vijaykant zoomed in on the digital photograph of the original.

"That could mean four copies were made."

Meera said, "Naresh Babu showed us the shadows."

"Family history doesn't change because of shadows."

The sentence came out a little harsh.

Meera fell silent.

That night, while clearing an old cupboard, Neha found a small album.

Its pages were black, and each photograph was held at the corners by paper triangles.

She turned the pages one by one.

At one place she stopped abruptly.

There was a separate photograph of Vijaykant's maternal uncle, Shyamohan, the man who stood on the right side of the group picture.

He was standing alone in some park in Calcutta.

The same striped bush shirt.

The same angle of the face.

Neha removed the photograph. On the back, in blue ink, was written: "Calcutta, 1969."

She hurried to Vijaykant.

"Look at this."

Vijaykant held the photograph and stared at it for a long time.

The Shyamohan in the group picture and the Shyamohan in the album were the same photograph—only the background had been changed.

There was little room left now for argument.

Meera asked quietly, "Will you still say they were all together in 1971?"

Vijaykant did not answer.

The next morning all three went to Arvind Lal's house.

It was an old single-storey house a little inside Rajnagar Road. Two closed enlargers and an iron cupboard stood on the veranda.

Arvind Lal was close to eighty.

As soon as he heard Naresh's name, he invited them inside.

Neha showed him the numbers on her phone.

Arvind first changed his spectacles.

"127/B... 48/D..."

He repeated the numbers slowly.

"This is my father's old numbering system."

Meera asked, "Do the registers still exist?"

Arvind laughed.

"In this house, the things that ought to have been thrown away are the things that have survived best."

From the bottom of the cupboard he took out three thick registers wrapped in cloth.

The first covered 1960 to 1967.

The second, 1968 to 1974.

The pages had yellowed; there were old termite marks along the edges.

Arvind began searching the serial numbers.

48/D appeared first.

"Shyamohan Jha — Calcutta — copy."

Neha looked at Vijaykant.

127/B — "Sarojini — Sitamarhi."

72/C — "Ramlochan — Janakpur."

301/A — "Gauri Devi with two children — home."

All four sources had different dates.

Meera sat gripping the edge of the chair.

"Is there an entry for the group picture?"

Arvind turned the pages forward.

About three months later they found a line:

“Gauri Devi Jha — four negatives combined into one family photograph — 12 × 16 — two copies.”

Beside it was his father’s small signature.

That was all.

No secret message.

No property, name, or dispute.

Just an ordinary studio order.

Meera kept reading the line.

“Two copies?”

Arvind said, “Yes. One probably for the house. The other may have gone to one of the children.”

Vijaykant asked, “Do you remember anything about this job?”

Arvind shook his head.

“I was in college then. I used to sit in the shop with my father in the evenings. I don’t remember every customer.”

He paused.

“But composite family pictures were not unusual then. Families lived in different towns. Marriage, jobs, illness—it was difficult to gather everyone at one time. People brought separate photographs and asked us to make them into one.”

Neha asked, “Was the aim to make it look as though everyone had actually sat together?”

“That was usually what people wanted.”

Arvind looked again at the register.

“My father would match scale, direction of the eyes, chairs, background. Some errors always remained—shadows, light on clothing, height.”

Vijaykant was very quiet.

Meera suddenly asked, “Did Gauri Devi herself have this photograph made?”

“The register names her as the customer.”

At that answer Meera sat a little straighter.

On the drive home no one said much.

The afternoon sun lay across the roads of Madhubani.

Neha kept comparing the four source photographs on her phone.

Back at the house they opened the album again.

They had found Shyamohan’s picture.

Soon they found Sarojini Mami’s too: seated alone on a veranda in Sitamarhi. In the group picture her face, sari, and the position of her hands were exactly the same.

They never found Ramlochan Mama’s source photograph.

The picture of Gauri Devi with the two children was inside a small envelope.

Now the construction of the group photograph was clear.

Vijaykant said slowly, "I remember Ma saying once that when this picture was made, Shyamohan was in Calcutta."

Meera looked at him immediately.

"Then why didn't you say so before?"

"Because I thought Ma was mixing up the date. Later we ourselves turned it into the story that everyone had gathered."

Meera was silent for a while.

"Did Ma ever say it was photographed with everyone together?"

Vijaykant thought.

"No. She only called it 'the picture of everyone.'"

Neha smiled.

"Then who told the lie?"

Brother and sister looked at one another.

Neither had an answer.

Perhaps the story had formed simply because it was more convenient for the family.

One photograph, one date, one gathering—that made memory neat and orderly.

Four towns, four photographs, four different times—that was a slightly harder story.

That evening Neha spread all the source photographs from the black album across the table.

The group picture was open on her phone in the middle.

She saw that in Gauri Devi's original photograph there had actually been empty space beside her.

When the group picture was made, Sarojini had been placed into that empty space.

Ramlochan on the other side.

Shyamohan a little higher and farther back.

Meera said softly, "Perhaps Dadi didn't like empty spaces in photographs."

For the first time a faint smile appeared on Vijaykant's face.

"Perhaps."

Neha said, "If everyone had been together, there would have been no need to make the photograph."

At that, both fell silent.

The value of the picture had not suddenly diminished.

Its meaning had changed.

It was no longer proof of a final gathering.

It was a solution created because gathering had not been possible.
The next day Naresh called from the shop.
“The photograph is clean. Shall I fit a new backing board?”
Meera said, “One minute. Don’t throw away the old board from the back.”
All three went to the shop.
Naresh had cleaned the photograph and placed it on thin acid-free paper.
The image was clearer than before.
The corners of Gauri Devi’s eyes, Shyamohan’s bush shirt, Sarojini’s sari—all showed distinctly.
Meera said, “I want the old backing board.”
Naresh gave it to her.
Neha laid transparent paper over the four pencilled numbers and copied them.
Then she took out a small sheet of paper.
Vijaykant asked, “What will you write?”
Neha said, “The truth.”
Meera grew slightly cautious. “Not too much explanation. The next generation will invent another story.”
Everyone laughed.
In the end they wrote three lines:
“This is not a photograph of a single moment.”
“Four separate photographs were combined, at Gauri Devi’s request, to make one family portrait.”
“The original studio reference numbers are preserved behind it.”
Neha added today’s date.
Naresh fixed the note safely inside the new backing, without letting it touch the photograph.
The four numbers from the old board were preserved inside as well.
Meera asked, “Who will take the frame?”
Vijaykant paused before answering.
“You take the original.”
Meera was surprised.
“And you?”
“I’ll take the scan. More than the wall now, I want these four source photographs.”
Neha laughed. “Yesterday you were arguing over the original.”
Vijaykant said, “Yesterday I wanted one moment. Today I’ve found four times.”
Meera took the frame in her hands.
As she left the shop, she looked once at the back of the photograph.
The new backing board was clean.

Inside it the four numbers from the old board were hidden, but now not like a concealed truth—like preserved evidence.

On the day the house was sold, the sitting-room wall stood empty.

The frame went with Meera.

Vijaykant had the four source photographs scanned separately and made a small album.

First page: Shyamohan — Calcutta.

Second: Sarojini — Sitamarhi.

Third: Gauri Devi with the children — Madhubani.

Ramlochan's source photograph had still not been found. Its place was left blank.

On the final page he placed a copy of the group photograph.

Neha asked, "Shall we fill this empty place?"

Vijaykant shook his head.

"No. If the photograph hasn't been found yet, let its place remain empty."

After a pause he added, "Dadi filled an empty space once. Now we'll keep this one visible."

A few weeks later Meera hung the photograph in her new house.

When a visitor asked, "When were they all photographed together?"

Meera no longer answered immediately, "1971."

She would look at the frame, smile, and say, "They weren't photographed together. They were made into one picture together."

And if the listener truly wanted to know, she would tell the story of the four towns.

The photograph was no longer the family's simplest memory.

But it had become the family's truest one.

Because what it preserved behind it was not the story of everyone once being together, but the desire not to leave one another's place empty even while living far apart.

Two Lamps

The narrow lane running east from Madhubani's old bus stand was officially called 'Ward Seven, Sub-lane Three.' But everyone nearby simply called it Peepal Lane.

An old peepal tree stood midway down the lane, and just beyond it the road divided in two.

The path to the left was paved. The one to the right was unpaved, with a narrow open drain running through the middle, and farther on stood a small cluster of five houses.

Nayan's house was the second from the end of that right-hand path.

Eight days before Diwali, the streetlight on the pole at the turn went out.

For the first two nights people thought the bulb had burnt out. On the third night an electrician came, inspected the pole, shook the wire, and said, 'The upper joint has burnt. It can't be repaired without the municipality's vehicle.'

The vehicle had still not come.

By day the turn looked perfectly ordinary. At night the shops lit the paved road on the left, but the right-hand path vanished into darkness.

Twice the milkman had taken the wrong turn. Once Nayan's cousin had called and asked, 'I've reached the peepal tree. Which way now?'

Nayan had laughed and said, 'Turn where you can't see anything.'

But his mother, Renu Devi, had not liked the joke.

'Darkness should not be identified by more darkness,' she had said.

Nayan had kept the sentence in his mind.

On the morning of Diwali, the market was spread with stalls of clay lamps, coloured paper, sweets and flowers.

Nayan's mother gave him ten rupees.

'Bring two lamps,' she said, 'and if there is any money left, buy two handfuls of cotton too.'

Nayan asked, 'Only two?'

'We have less oil this year. If we decorate with too many lamps, they will all go out halfway through the night.'

Nayan closed his fist around the money and went to the market.

Near Peepal Chowk, an elderly potter woman sat on a mat with lamps arranged before her.

Her name was Mangala Devi. Everyone called her Mangala Kaki.

There were three kinds of lamps on the mat: plain round ones, ones whose rims had been pinched into flower shapes, and small four-spouted lamps coloured with red ochre.

Nayan pointed to the plain round lamps.

'How much?'

'Three rupees for two.'

Nayan handed over his ten-rupee note.

As Mangala Devi put two lamps into a small paper bag, she asked, 'Only two for Diwali?'

'Yes.'

'One by the tulsi plant and one at the threshold?'

Nayan shook his head.

'One at home. One at the turn.'

Mangala Devi's hand stopped.

'At the turn?'

'The light in our lane is broken.'

Kaki laughed. 'Will one lamp light the whole lane?'

'Not the whole lane. It only has to show the turn.'

Mangala Devi looked at his face for a moment. Then she placed two small wicks in the bag as well.

'Money for these wicks?' Nayan asked.

'No. They come with the lamps.'

'Ma told me to buy cotton.'

'Then buy cotton. These two wicks are from me.'

With the remaining seven rupees, Nayan bought cotton and a little oil and returned home.

Renu Devi looked into the bag and said, 'Good. We'll light both lamps this evening.'

Nayan said, 'I'm taking one outside.'

'Where?'

'To the turn by the peepal tree.'

Renu Devi looked at him. 'Why?'

'People can't see the right-hand path.'

'Who will notice one lamp among all the firecrackers?'

'Firecrackers don't burst all the time.'

Renu Devi said nothing.

She poured mustard oil into a small brass bowl.

'We won't divide it unequally,' she said. 'Half for the lamp at home, half for the lamp at the turn. It wouldn't be right to light our own lamp and leave the other one empty.'

Nayan smiled.

Evening was falling.

Rangoli, alpana and lamps began appearing at the thresholds of the houses in the lane. Some homes had strings of electric lights, some candles in the windows.

Nayan placed the first lamp on the threshold of his house. His mother straightened the wick, and Nayan struck a match.

A small flame rose.

He put the second lamp on an old metal plate and walked towards the turn by the peepal tree.

Renu Devi called after him, 'Don't put it beside the drain.'

'I won't.'

At the turn, one brick was missing from the corner of an old wall. Nayan placed the lamp in that hollow.

It was about two handspans above the ground, sheltered from the wind.

He lit the lamp.

For a few moments the flame trembled, then steadied.

Nayan stepped back five paces.

There was plenty of light on the paved road to the left. The right-hand path was still dark, but with the lamp burning in the corner of the wall, its entrance could now be seen clearly.

Nayan's neighbour, Ajay Kaka, passed carrying a box of firecrackers.

'Who put this here?'

'I did.'

'For worship?'

'No. For the road.'

Ajay Kaka laughed at first. Then he looked towards the right-hand turn.

'Good. At least no one will fall into the drain.'

He went on.

A little later two children came running with sparklers. One bent towards the lamp.

Nayan immediately said, 'Don't touch it. This isn't decoration.'

'Then what is it?'

'It shows the road.'

The children laughed and ran away.

By eight the wind had grown stronger.

From the house Nayan kept looking again and again towards the turn.

Once the flame grew very small. He ran out with the oil bottle.

There was still oil in the lamp, but the wick had drooped into it. Nayan lifted the wick a little with a twig.

Mangala Devi's stall was still open in the market then.

Most of her lamps had sold during the day, though about three dozen remained on the mat.

Her daughter-in-law Sulekha had brought her lunch in the afternoon and told her, 'Come home before nine tonight.'

Mangala Devi had thought she would pack up at eight, but at the last moment people kept stopping to buy more lamps.

At half past eight she packed the remaining lamps into a sack.

The main road was the easier way to the bus stand, but that night it was crowded with firecrackers, motorcycles and people.

A sweet seller told her, 'Kaki, cut through Peepal Lane. It comes straight out near the bus stand.'

Mangala Devi had taken that path two or three times by day, never at night.

She entered the lane with the sack tucked under her arm rather than balanced on her head.

The first stretch was bright. Lamps and electric strings outside the houses made the road easy to see.

Near the peepal tree the light suddenly diminished.

Ahead, the road divided in two.

Mangala Devi stopped.

On the paved path to the left she could see a white light in the distance. On the right, in the corner of a wall, burned a small lamp.

Behind that lamp, the edge of the right-hand path, the drain, and the raised bricks could be seen clearly.

Mangala Devi remembered the boy from that morning.

'One at home. One at the turn.'

She smiled softly.

The shortcut to the bus stand was on the right.

When she reached the lamp, she found Nayan standing against the wall, adjusting the wick.

Nayan recognized her.

'Kaki! Your stall was open till now?'

'I've just closed it.'

Mangala Devi looked at the lamp.

'Is this the second one?'

'Yes.'

'Did it light the whole lane?'

Nayan laughed. 'No. But you can see the turn.'

Mangala Devi laughed too.

'Tonight, that was enough for me.'

She hitched the sack a little higher under her arm and took the right-hand path.

Nayan watched until she reached the small exit leading towards the bus stand.

When he returned home, his mother asked, 'Who were you talking to?'

'The Kaki who sells lamps.'

'She came here?'

'Yes. She saw the turn.'

Renu Devi checked the oil in the first lamp at the threshold. Its flame was steady.

'And the second?'

'A little less.'

From the oil left in the bowl she poured one spoonful into Nayan's hand-held bottle.

'Take it.'

Nayan asked, 'What about the lamp at home?'

'It won't burn all night. It doesn't have to. It can burn as long as the oil lasts.'

Nayan went and added the oil at the turn.

At nine, Ajay Kaka stopped beside the lamp on his way home.

In his hand was a small bottle half full of mustard oil.

He said nothing. He simply poured a little oil into the lamp.

Ten minutes later, Veena Kaki from the neighbourhood came and left a new wick; the old one had grown very short.

Nayan saw both things from the window at home.

He wanted to go outside, but his mother stopped him.

'The lamp is no longer yours alone.'

'I bought it.'

'You bought it. But now everyone is putting oil into it.'

At half past ten, the first lamp at the threshold went out.

Nayan picked up the matches to relight it.

Renu Devi said, 'Leave it.'

'It's Diwali.'

'The house can be seen. The door can be seen. We are inside.'

She pointed towards the window.

The second lamp at the turn was still burning.

'The road there still needs to be seen.'

Nayan put the matches back.

The next morning he went to the turn.

The lamp had gone out. The oil was finished. Its rim was blackened.

But beside it lay three things: a small bottle with a little oil in it, two new wicks, and a flat piece of brick.

On the brick, in chalk, someone had written: 'Here until the light is repaired.'

The handwriting was Ajay Kaka's.

Nayan picked up the brick.

At that moment Mangala Devi was walking from the bus stand towards the market, again carrying an empty sack under her arm.

Nayan showed her the brick.

Mangala Devi read it and smiled.

'How many lamps do you need now?'

Nayan said, 'One.'

'For the house?'

'No. For the turn. Yesterday's home lamp is still there.'

Before even spreading out her mat, Mangala Devi took a plain lamp from her bag.

Nayan said at once, 'I'll pay.'

'You will.'

'How much?'

'Two were three rupees. One is one and a half.'

Nayan took a two-rupee coin from his pocket.

Mangala Devi began looking for a half-rupee coin, then laughed.

'Where will I find a half-rupee coin now?'

Nayan laughed too.

'Then keep two rupees.'

'The account will be wrong.'

Nayan remembered the two lamps from the previous day.

'Then take fifty paise less next time.'

Mangala Devi placed the lamp in his hand. 'All right. The account will remain.'

Three days later the municipal vehicle came.

The wire on the pole was replaced. That evening the streetlight came on again.

The turn was brighter than before.

Ajay Kaka bent to remove the piece of brick.

Nayan said, 'Leave it.'

'The light has been repaired.'

'Yes.'

'Then what use is the lamp?'

Nayan thought for a moment.

'The light may break again.'

Ajay Kaka laughed. 'That's a good answer.'

The brick remained where it was.

Before the next Diwali, the streetlight at the turn failed twice more.

Both times, by evening, someone or other placed a lamp in the corner of the wall.

Sometimes Ajay Kaka, sometimes Veena Kaki, sometimes Nayan.

Whenever Mangala Devi came to sell lamps at Peepal Chowk, she would glance towards the turn in the afternoon.

The following Diwali, Nayan came to her mat.

'Two lamps,' he said.

Without asking, Mangala Devi took out two plain lamps.

Then she smiled and asked, 'One for home, one for the turn?'

Nayan nodded.

This time, along with the wicks, Mangala Devi added a pinch of cotton wrapped in a small piece of paper.

Nayan asked, 'How much for this?'

'Let it remain in the account.'

'Whose account?'

Mangala Devi looked towards the turn.

'The account where everyone adds oil.'

Nayan carried the lamps away.

That evening the first lamp was lit at the threshold of his house.

The second was lit at the turn by the peepal tree.

This time the electric streetlight on the pole was working, so the second lamp was scarcely needed for illumination.

Even so, people noticed it as they passed the turn.

For by then it was no longer merely a remedy for darkness.

It had become a small sign that a public road does not belong to any one household.

As the night deepened, the lamp at the threshold went out first.

The lamp at the turn burned a little longer.

Someone had added oil again.

The Last Row

Madhav had received the invitation card three days earlier.

Suresh Babu himself had come to Madhav's small electrical shop. In one hand he carried a card with a red border; in the other, a sheet showing the temporary decorations.

"Anjali's wedding is this Sunday," Suresh Babu said. "The card is for you, but there is also a job. The old wiring in the house will not carry so many strings of lights and lamps. Please have a look."

Madhav opened the card and read it. At the top were Anjali's name and the groom's; below, the time; and at the end: "With family, you are cordially invited."

He smiled. "Did you give me the invitation first, or the work first?"

Suresh Babu laughed too. "You are one of our own. The work account is separate, the invitation separate. We won't mix the two."

Madhav wrote down the estimate: wire, two MCBs, three temporary points, and the electrician's labour.

Suresh Babu did not bargain. He only said, "Don't forget to eat at the wedding."

On Sunday morning at nine, Madhav arrived with his assistant Bipin.

Above the courtyard, coloured light strings, bamboo poles, microphone cables, fans and the thick cable running towards the kitchen all passed between and across one another.

Within half an hour Madhav understood that until evening his work would not merely be to join wires, but to keep the wires from interfering with one another.

By noon he had divided the main supply into three lines: kitchen separate, wedding pavilion separate, outdoor lighting separate.

Madhav had also brought a clean kurta in his bag. His thought was that once the work settled in the evening, even if there was no time to bathe, he could at least change his shirt and sit down to eat.

From four o'clock onward calls began arriving about the wedding party's bus.

At five, the flower decorator added two extra strings of lights.

At twenty past five, the sound man plugged his amplifier into the same board that ran the kitchen motor.

Madhav pulled out the plug and shifted it to another line. "Nothing else goes on this board now."

The sound man said, "Only for two minutes."

"In two minutes a wire does not understand that there is a wedding."

By half past six the house was glowing.

From a distance Suresh Babu raised his hand as if asking: Everything all right?

Madhav gave him a thumbs-up.

Just then Suresh Babu's maternal uncle came over.

"Arre, Madhav! You're here too? Suresh was saying you are an old acquaintance."

"I'm an acquaintance, and an electrician too," Madhav said with a laugh.

The uncle knew nothing about the invitation card. He assumed Madhav had come only for the electrical work.

"He has hired the right man," he said. "All these wires make me nervous."

At seven, the first dining row sat down.

Vegetables, dal, pulao, curd and sweets began appearing on the leaf plates.

Madhav stood near the distribution board by the outer gate, checking the heat of the line.

Bipin asked, "Guruji, shall I go and eat?"

"You go first. I'll come in ten minutes."

Bipin went towards the row at the back where the workers were eating.

Madhav thought of taking the clean kurta out of his bag, but just then a fan in the wedding pavilion stopped.

The fan itself was not faulty. Its plug had been pressed behind a flower curtain and had slipped halfway out.

Madhav fixed it.

By the time he came back, it was eight.

The second dining row was getting up.

Suresh Babu's wife saw him from a distance.

"Madhav Bhai, have you eaten?"

"Not yet."

"Sit now. It will get more crowded later."

Madhav went to wash his hands.

He took the clean kurta out of his bag.

There was greasy black insulation tape on his shirt. He thought he should change.

Just then a voice came from inside the house:

"Madhavji! The light in the bride's room is flickering."

The kurta went back into the bag.

The fault in the bride's room was small: a cheap multi-plug was loose.

But the room was full of women, decoration wires and mobile chargers, so the job took time.

When Madhav came out, the wedding party had arrived.

After nine the dining rows were running continuously.

For the first time Madhav sat down in an empty place.

Two unfamiliar guests sat beside him.

The young man placing leaf plates looked at Madhav, then at the dust on his clothes, and asked, "Who are you with?"

Madhav did not understand the question. "With the family."

The young man asked again, "Are you a guest or one of the workers? The workers' row will be at the back."

Madhav's hand went instinctively to his pocket, where the folded invitation card lay.

He could have taken it out.

At that moment the microphone suddenly went dead.

Three people near the pavilion called his name at once.

Madhav got up.

Ten minutes later the microphone was working again.

But other people had taken the places in that dining row.

At half past ten Bipin found him.

"I've eaten. You?"

"Electricity has been eating me so far."

Bipin laughed. "The workers' row is being laid now."

Madhav went there.

Behind the kitchen, beside a bamboo enclosure, the generator operator, two young men from the flower decorator, the men carrying utensils, Bipin, and the other workers sat down together.

Madhav had barely put his hand to the leaf plate and sat when every light at the outer gate went out at once.

Someone shouted, "The wedding party is taking photographs—everything is dark outside!"

Madhav got up again.

This time the fault was not in the generator. It was in a wet wire the flower decorator had added later.

While removing it, Madhav felt a slight shock in his finger.

He did not swear. He only asked the flower decorator, "Why did you reconnect the wire I told you not to use?"

The decorator lowered his eyes.

At a quarter past eleven the outdoor lights became steady again.

The wedding rituals had begun in the pavilion.

The dining rows had thinned out.

Madhav returned behind the kitchen.

Most of the workers had already eaten and left.

A cook was gathering the remaining rice into a large pot.

"Food?" Madhav asked.

The cook recognized him. "You sat down twice and got up again. The vegetables are finished. There is dal, rice and a little pickle."

"That will do."

Madhav did not ask for a brass plate.

The cook served rice and dal on an old steel plate.

Madhav ate standing beside the kitchen wall.

He did not feel bad while eating. He was hungry, the rice was warm, and there was enough salt in the dal.

But the corner of the folded invitation in his pocket kept pressing against his stomach.

The next morning Madhav returned to collect the wires and settle the account.

The flowers from the night before had wilted in the courtyard.

The chairs were piled to one side.

Suresh Babu was on the veranda settling accounts with the caterer.

"There cannot have been four hundred and twenty-six dining places," Suresh Babu was saying. "My count is four hundred and eight. The workers were separate."

The caterer opened his ledger. "Workers: eighteen. Four hundred and eight plus eighteen is four hundred and twenty-six."

Suresh Babu said, "Why did you count Madhav among the workers? He was my guest."

A relative sitting nearby immediately said, "Guest? He ran around with wires all night. I never saw him in the guest rows."

The caterer ran a finger down the page. "My man said two meals for the electricians. One assistant ate. One plate went out late at night."

Madhav was standing on the veranda steps listening to all of it.

Seeing him, Suresh Babu fell silent.

"Arre, come. First, your account."

Madhav handed over his paper.

The amount for materials and labour was exactly what had been agreed three days earlier.

Without bargaining, Suresh Babu counted the money.

Then he took out an extra five-hundred-rupee note and held it out.

"Keep this. You had to run around a great deal last night."

Madhav did not take the note.

"I have received exactly what we agreed."

"Think of it as a tip."

"I did not do a tip's work. I did an electrician's work."

Suresh Babu looked slightly uncomfortable.

He asked quietly, "Did you at least get a proper meal?"

Madhav said, "The rice and dal were good."

The answer was so ordinary that Suresh Babu became even more uncomfortable.

As Madhav put the money into his pocket, the folded invitation card fell to the ground.

There was a black stain from insulation tape on its red border.

Suresh Babu picked it up.

He recognized the card he himself had given.

"You kept this in your pocket all night?"

"Yes. I thought I would change into my kurta in the evening and sit down to eat. I never got the chance."

Suresh Babu looked for a while at the line: "With family, you are cordially invited."

"You could have sat in the first dining row."

Madhav smiled. "I sat down twice."

"Then?"

"Once the microphone took me away. The second time, the lights at the gate."

Suresh Babu opened his mouth to say something, then closed it again.

The caterer was still sitting there with the ledger open.

He asked, "Should I enter Madhavji's meal under guests or under workers?"

For one moment there was no sound on the veranda.

Madhav signed the receipt for his wages.

Then he took the invitation card from Suresh Babu and folded the receipt inside it.

"Write it wherever your account balances," he said quietly. "I have received all the money due to me."

Madhav lifted his bag.

Bipin was outside tying up the remaining wires.

The two of them set off.

In daylight the strings of lights at the gate looked colourless.

The wires that had thrown the same coloured light over guests and workers alike the previous night were now being coiled into Madhav's bag.

In his pocket lay two papers together: an invitation and a wage receipt.

All night, people had kept giving him first one meaning and then the other.

Four Cubits of Cloth

On the first Monday before school reopened, a sheet of paper came into Rama Devi's hands.

Neha took it out of her schoolbag and gave it to her. At the top was the school's name; below it, a list of books, notebooks and uniform materials for the new class.

Rama Devi first looked at the number of books, then stopped her finger at the line about the uniform.

"For two uniforms: four cubits of blue cloth," she read softly. "For two shirts: two cubits of white."

Neha said, "Teacher said to give the cloth for stitching this week."

Rama Devi folded the paper and placed it beside the stove.

It was the beginning of the month, but ration, school fees and medicine for her younger son Manu were already in the accounts. She had set money aside for the uniform, but shoes also had to come out of that same amount.

That afternoon she took Neha with her to the market.

At Badri Cloth Store, two rolls of the school's blue fabric were kept in the same cupboard. The colour was almost identical—a deep blue that caught a slightly pale sheen in sunlight.

Badri Sah opened the first roll.

"Forty-four inches wide. Eighty-six rupees a cubit."

Rama Devi raised her eyebrows slightly. "The other one?"

Badri Sah opened the second roll.

"Thirty-six inches. The cloth is fine, but the width is less. Seventy-two rupees a cubit."

Rama Devi rubbed both fabrics between her fingers. There did not seem much difference in thickness. The colour too matched the school sample.

"The list says four cubits," she said, taking out the paper. "Give me four cubits of the cheaper one."

Badri Sah said again, "It is narrower. It would be better to ask the tailor about the measurements first."

Rama Devi had already done the arithmetic.

Four cubits at seventy-two came to two hundred and eighty-eight rupees.

Four cubits at eighty-six came to three hundred and forty-four.

That left a difference of fifty-six rupees.

With fifty-six rupees she could buy half a strip of Manu's medicine and two notebooks for Neha.

"The school has said four cubits," she replied. "Surely the tailor does not know more than the school."

Badri Sah said nothing.

He measured out four cubits and cut the cloth.

On the receipt he wrote: "36 inches wide."

Rama Devi folded the receipt and tucked it inside the cloth.

Neha glanced once at the forty-four-inch roll, but said nothing.

In another lane of the market was Vimala Sewing House.

Vimala Devi had been stitching school uniforms for twenty years. Measuring tape, scissors and old paper patterns hung on the wall.

As soon as she opened the cloth, Vimala asked, "Two uniforms?"

"Yes. Four cubits, according to the school list."

Vimala lifted one edge, measured the width, then looked at Neha.

"Take Neha's measurements first," Rama Devi said. "Cut after that."

Vimala measured her shoulders, waist, uniform length and sleeves.

Then she spread the cloth on the table and placed two paper patterns over it.

One pattern fitted.

The second would not fit fully beside it.

Vimala turned it around. Even then its edge ran beyond the cloth.

"Two uniforms will not come out of four cubits of this cloth," Vimala said.

Rama Devi immediately took out the list.

"It says clearly here: four cubits."

"The length is four cubits," Vimala said, "but the width is thirty-six inches."

"Cloth is cloth."

Vimala did not laugh.

Nor did she pick up the scissors and start cutting.

She simply left the fabric spread on the table.

"I can make one," she said. "For the second you will need another cubit. There may be a little left over, but not enough for a full uniform."

Rama Devi's voice hardened. "Another cubit? Then why does the school write four cubits?"

"The school must be assuming wider cloth."

"Is every mother supposed to understand all this?"

Instead of answering, Vimala picked up another bundle lying near the doorway. Shakuntala Devi's name was written on it.

“This is also for a girl in Neha’s class,” Vimala said. “Four cubits too.”

Rama Devi watched as she opened the bundle. The fabric was plainly wider.

Vimala placed the same two paper patterns on it.

This time they both fitted side by side, with a gap of about two fingers left between them.

Rama Devi was silent for a few moments.

“How much does that cloth cost?”

“I don’t know. But it is forty-four inches wide.”

Rama Devi folded her own cloth again.

She remembered Badri Sah’s words: ‘The width is less.’

At the time the sentence had sounded like a minor detail added after the price.

Now it stood in the middle of the entire calculation.

Neha asked softly, “Ma, shall we return the cloth?”

“Let us see.”

The two of them went back to Badri Cloth Store.

Badri Sah looked at the receipt.

“The cloth hasn’t been cut?”

“No. Only spread out on the tailor’s table.”

He checked the fabric.

There were two faint chalk marks from Vimala along one edge. Badri Sah brushed them away with his palm.

“It can be returned,” he said.

The tightness inside Rama Devi eased a little. She had feared the shopkeeper would say that cut cloth could not be taken back.

“Give me four cubits of the wider one,” she said.

Badri Sah began making a new bill.

“Four at eighty-six: three hundred and forty-four. You paid two hundred and eighty-eight. Fifty-six more.”

Rama Devi paused while taking out the money.

“What if I had taken five cubits of the cheaper one?”

“Three hundred and sixty.”

Rama Devi looked at him. “Then the cheaper cloth would have cost more in all?”

Badri Sah smiled.

“For two uniforms, yes. If you were making one, it would have been cheaper.”

Neha laughed. “The price per cubit is lower, but you need more cloth.”

Rama Devi paid the additional fifty-six rupees.

It felt as though there was no saving left, yet compared with buying a fifth cubit she had still saved sixteen rupees.

This saving did not look like the first calculation.
 Just then Sarita Devi entered the shop holding the same school list.
 “Give me four cubits of blue cloth,” she said.
 Badri Sah asked, “Thirty-six inches or forty-four?”
 Sarita Devi looked startled. “Where does the list say that?”
 The three of them looked at one another.
 Badri Sah took the school’s old sample from behind the cupboard.
 “For three days I have been explaining this to everyone. Some hear the price and take the narrower cloth; some take the wider. Then the tailor sends them back.”
 “Then tell the school,” Rama Devi said.
 Badri Sah shrugged. “I am a shopkeeper. I do not write the school’s list.”
 “Do the mothers write it?” Sarita Devi asked.
 No one had an answer.
 The following Wednesday there was a parents’ meeting at the school.
 The announced subjects were book distribution and the midday meal, but the uniform list came up first.
 The headmistress, Sharda Jha, placed the printed list on the table.
 “These quantities have been used for many years. Why is there a problem now?”
 Someone at the back said, “There are two widths in the market now.”
 Another voice said, “The tailor is asking for one cubit more.”
 A third said, “The shopkeeper gives the narrow one because it is cheaper.”
 Badri Sah was not at the meeting. Neither was Vimala.
 It was easy for all blame to travel towards people who were absent.
 Rama Devi had been sitting quietly at first. Then she stood up.
 “The shopkeeper did tell me the width,” she said. “I counted the price; I did not understand the width. The tailor did not cut it—she showed me first. It is not one person’s fault. The list gives only half the measurement.”
 The room became a little quieter.
 The headmistress asked, “Half the measurement?”
 Before Rama Devi could answer, Neha stood up beside her mother.
 The children had been seated at the back for the parents’ meeting.
 “Teacher,” she said hesitantly, “when we measure a rectangle in mathematics, we need both length and width, don’t we?”
 Some people laughed.
 Sharda Jha did not.
 She looked at the list.
 Neha opened her notebook and drew two rectangles—both the same length, but one wide and one narrow.

“Both can be four cubits long,” she said, “but they do not contain the same amount of cloth.”

Sharda Jha pulled the notebook towards herself.

Mahendra Babu, the school’s former storekeeper, was sitting at the back.

He said, “Earlier the rolls that came were usually forty-four inches wide. The list must have been made then.”

“How many years ago?” the headmistress asked.

Mahendra Babu laughed. “Before my time.”

This time the room laughed.

Sharda Jha ran her pen across the list.

“The width will be added in the next printing. For now, put it on the noticeboard.”

A teacher asked, “Four cubits if the width is forty-four inches? And five cubits if it is thirty-six?”

Rama Devi said, “Ask the tailor for the exact quantities. Do not guess again.”

Sharda Jha nodded.

“Right. We will ask Vimala Devi and the other tailors and write the correct measures.”

The meeting moved back to books and meals, but Neha circled the two rectangles in her notebook.

Two days later, at Vimala Sewing House, the forty-four-inch cloth was spread across the table.

This time the two patterns fitted side by side.

Before lifting the scissors, Vimala said to Rama Devi, “See. The full four cubits are here.”

“And the width?” Rama Devi asked.

Vimala smiled. “Now that is full too.”

After giving her measurements, Neha sat in a corner and began doing her homework.

Vimala cut the cloth.

The strip left over was very small—just enough for the inside facing of a pocket and the underside of a collar.

Rama Devi picked up the little piece.

“Is this the saving?”

Vimala said, “This is leftover cloth. Saving is something else.”

Rama Devi laughed. “I understand that now.”

A week later Neha went to school with two new uniforms.

A new line had been written by hand on the noticeboard:

“For two uniforms, buy cloth according to its width: if the width is 44 inches, 4 cubits. For any other width, ask the tailor for the required amount.”

Below the line someone had drawn, in pencil, two small rectangles—one wide, one narrow.

Neha smiled when she saw them.

That evening Rama Devi was putting the school list back into the cupboard.

At first she had seen only the words ‘four cubits’ on that sheet.

Now she understood that a measurement was not merely what the tape showed in one direction.

She took out the receipts.

The first said: “36 inches.”

The second said: “44 inches.”

She folded them together and placed them inside the school list.

If next year someone found that ‘four cubits’ seemed too much or too little, the reason would be there inside the paper as well.

Shared Shade

On the footpath east of Madhubani's old bus stand, Ramsagar's cart was number seventeen and Nasima Khatoon's cart was number eighteen.

After a municipal survey, the ground allotted to each had been measured and marked with a red rectangle. Ramsagar's rectangle was six cubits long and four cubits wide; Nasima's was almost the same. Between them, a narrow strip a cubit and a half wide had been left for pedestrians.

Ramsagar sold bael sherbet, sattu and lemon water. Nasima kept cucumbers, lemons and a few fruits according to the season.

By the second week of Jyeshtha, the afternoon heat had become so fierce that it was difficult to hold the iron handle of a cart without a cloth.

Nasima kept laying a wet sack over the cucumbers she had arranged in the morning.

Ramsagar watched his slab of ice melt away by half the day.

Each cart had its own small umbrella, but once the round shade covered the cart, the vendor himself remained half in the sun. If a customer stood there, the shade had to be divided yet again.

One Monday, four municipal employees arrived in the market carrying folded green mesh, bamboo poles and a receipt book.

The young man walking in front called out, "Heat-relief scheme. One shade net for every two registered vendors."

Ramsagar took out his card. "Seventeen."

Nasima showed hers. "Eighteen."

The employee looked at both cards together. "Fine. You two are a pair."

Taking the green net into her hands, Nasima asked, "Only one net?"

"One for two carts. Eight by six. Hang it between you. A photograph will be uploaded. It says shared use."

Ramsagar laughed. "Even shade comes in pairs now?"

The employee laughed too. "The net is large. It will cover both of you."

They were also given two bamboo poles, but the poles were short. The employees advised them to use two old posts so that the net could be stretched properly.

There was an electricity pole behind the carts, but it stood outside Ramsagar's red boundary.

Behind Nasima's cart was the tin post of a tea stall, but it stood almost two cubits beyond her rectangle.

Ramsagar said, "Let us tie the bamboo to our own carts and raise the net above them."

Together they tied the ropes.

The green net stretched from one cart to the other.

Its shade also fell over the narrow pedestrian strip between them.

For the first time, both of them sat fully in the shade at noon.

Nasima removed the wet sack from the cucumbers. "They have given us something useful."

Ramsagar looked at the ice box. "Today it will last half an hour longer."

Two customers stood in the narrow strip between the carts and drank sherbet.

An elderly woman rested for a while beside Nasima's cart.

Under the green light filtering through the shade net, the colours of the market seemed altered.

At half past twelve, two municipal workers arrived on a motorcycle.

One carried a measuring tape; the other held a mobile phone.

First they read the cart numbers, then looked at the red lines, then raised their eyes to the net.

"Whose rope is this?"

Ramsagar said, "Mine and Nasima Sister's. The municipality gave us the net."

Standing on the pedestrian strip, the worker said, "Nothing may be hung over the pedestrian passage."

Nasima looked surprised. "There is nothing below. People are walking through."

"The overhead extension is also outside your allotted boundary."

Ramsagar pointed to a corner of the green net. "Your own people gave this to us today."

The worker said, "That is from the relief section. We inspect vending boundaries."

"But they gave one net for two carts. The carts are in separate rectangles. If one net has to cover both, it has to cross the space between."

Pulling out the measuring tape, the worker said, "My papers say that no bamboo, rope, awning, net or goods may extend beyond the allotted line."

He took a photograph with his phone.

Nasima asked quietly, "Then where are we supposed to hang a shared net?"

The worker replied, "Ask the relief section. I am here to record violations."

The second employee wrote on a narrow slip: "17/18 — net beyond boundary."

Below it was an instruction to remove it within twenty-four hours.

Ramsagar held the slip and looked at it for a while.

The municipal seal was printed at the top.

That evening, the two of them took the net down.

Nasima said, "Back to our own little umbrellas."

Folding the net, Ramsagar said, "Something given for two people cannot be used by even one."

The next morning the heat was harsher.

Ramsagar thought of a solution.

Instead of spreading the net fully, he folded it in half and tied it only within one allotted rectangle at a time.

"You keep it from ten to twelve," he told Nasima. "I'll take it from twelve to two. Then you again from two to four."

Nasima laughed. "Will the shade move according to the clock?"

"The papers watch the clock. The sun does not."

They began sliding the net back and forth by turns.

When it covered Nasima's cart, Ramsagar's ice melted faster.

When it covered Ramsagar's cart, Nasima's cucumbers began to soften.

At one in the afternoon the number of customers increased.

At that time it was Ramsagar's turn to have the net.

Nasima tilted her small umbrella to cover the cucumbers and stood herself in the sun.

Ramsagar said, "Move the net towards your side."

"No. It is your turn."

"I can buy more ice. If the cucumbers soften, customers will not buy them."

Nasima said nothing.

They shifted the net a little towards her.

Just then the relief team from the first day appeared at the eastern end of the market.

The young man took out his mobile phone from a distance and prepared to take a picture.

He stopped beside carts seventeen and eighteen.

"Why is the net only half spread?"

Ramsagar took out the notice. "If we spread it fully, it crosses the boundary."

The young man read the notice. His face changed.

"But under the scheme we have to show shared use. In the photograph both carts should be under the shade."

Nasima said, "If we hang it that way, there will be another photograph for this notice."

The young man was silent for a few moments.

Then he said, "My mobile form has three options: in use, not in use, damaged."

Ramsagar asked, "There is no fourth option — 'If used, it breaks the rules?'"

The young man did not smile. "No."

He entered something on his phone.

Nasima asked, "What did you write?"

"Shared use not verified."

"But the net is here."

"The net is here. But both of you are not under the shade together."

Ramsagar placed the second slip behind the first one.

The relief team left.

Sales were low that day.

Ramsagar bought ice twice.

Five kilos of Nasima's cucumbers remained unsold till evening; she took two kilos home.

The next day, both of them went to the municipal office.

A teenager named Bipin watched Ramsagar's cart, while Nasima's elder daughter watched hers.

The vending section was on the first floor of the office.

Ramsagar showed the notice about the net extending beyond the boundary.

The clerk opened a file and said, "No structure may extend beyond the marked line. This is an old instruction."

Nasima handed him the second slip. "This says we must use the shared net."

The clerk read it. "This is from the climate-relief cell. They sit downstairs in the new building."

Ramsagar asked, "Aren't both papers from the municipality?"

"They are. The sections are different."

"Then which one are we supposed to obey?"

The clerk pushed his chair back. "Ask for written clarification."

"From whom?"

"Submit an application to both sections."

They bought plain paper from the photocopy shop downstairs.

Ramsagar wrote the application; Nasima signed her name.

The first section stamped it as received.

The second section said, "Bring the vending section's remarks first."

Ramsagar went upstairs again.

It was one in the afternoon.

Their two carts were operating in the market without their owners.

At last an assistant wrote in pencil at the corner of the application: "Joint site inspection required."

"When?" Nasima asked.

"A team will be formed. You will receive a phone call."

They returned to the market.

Ramsagar's ice was almost gone.

Nasima's daughter had been wetting cloth again and again to keep the cucumbers covered.

The green government net lay folded beneath the cart.

No call came for three days.

Nor on the fourth.

On the fifth day Ramsagar brought an old bamboo mat from home.

He tied it at an angle entirely within his red rectangle.

Nasima had her old blue umbrella reinforced.

The green government net remained folded.

At noon the narrow strip between the carts was once again in full sun.

Customers stood only briefly, moving from one cart to the other.

Nasima said, "The shared shade exists on paper now."

Ramsagar replied, "On paper it will not cross the boundary."

At the end of that week, a new municipal poster was pasted on the wall of the bus stand:

"Protect Yourself from the Heat: Shade, Water, Rest."

Below the slogan was a photograph from the relief scheme showing two vendors smiling beneath a single green net.

Ramsagar looked at the poster, then at their folded net.

Nasima took the two notices out of her purse.

One said: "Remove net beyond boundary."

The other said: "Shared use not verified."

The same municipal emblem was printed at the top of both.

Nasima folded the slips again and put them back in her purse. "We'll see when the phone call comes."

Ramsagar kept stirring the sattu mixture.

The afternoon sun fell directly on the cubit-and-a-half strip between them.

The government net lay safely folded beneath the cart; according to the paperwork, it crossed no boundary and gave shade to no one.

A Day's Leave

On the last day of the month, Sudha Jha took notes out of a small steel box and placed them on the dining table.

“Malti, three thousand four hundred and fifty for this month.”

Malti Devi wiped her hands and looked at the notes.

Her monthly wage was three thousand six hundred.

“Why is it one hundred and fifty less?”

Sudha looked towards the calendar hanging on the wall.

“You did not come one day. The tenth.”

Malti recognized the date at once. The tenth had been a Tuesday. That day there was a parents’ meeting at her younger daughter Sonam’s school.

“But I told you about that leave beforehand. You had said, ‘Don’t come on Tuesday; come on Sunday for the festival cleaning.’”

Sudha paused.

“I gave you leave, that is true. But did I ever say the leave would be paid?”

Malti’s hands were still wet. She wiped them on the end of her sari.

“I was here for five hours on Sunday.”

“That was festival cleaning.”

“And Tuesday?”

“That was your leave.”

Both statements were true. But once the two truths were separated from each other, the account changed.

Malti had worked in this house for seven years.

She came at seven every morning, washed utensils, swept and mopped, helped with the first kitchen work, gathered the clothes, and left by half past eight. After that she had three other houses to go to.

Sudha too had known her for seven years.

During illness she had sometimes given Malti money for medicines, clothes during festivals, and even old practice books when Sonam had examinations.

Perhaps for that reason, neither woman raised her voice in the argument.

Sudha counted the notes again.

“I keep the account from the calendar. If you do not come on a day, that day is deducted.”

Malti went over to the calendar on the wall.

In the box for the tenth, Sudha had written in blue pen: "Malti absent — school."

The sixteenth was a Sunday. In that box, in red ink, she had written: "Festival cleaning — Malti, 7 a.m."

Both notes were in Sudha's handwriting.

Malti placed her finger first on the tenth, then on the sixteenth.

"Aren't these two halves of the same thing?"

Sudha said, "Sunday is not a regular working day."

"That is exactly what I am asking. It was not a regular day, yet I came. Where is that counted?"

Before Sudha could answer, the pressure cooker whistled in the kitchen.

She went to turn off the gas.

For a few moments the discussion remained suspended there.

Malti remembered that Sunday clearly.

Three days before the tenth, while washing utensils, she had said, "Didi, Sonam has a school meeting on Tuesday. I need one day's leave."

At the time Sudha had been making a cleaning list for before Diwali.

"Tuesday is fine. But can you come a little early on Sunday? The upper cupboards and windows have to be done."

Malti had said, "Sunday is my day off."

Sudha had laughed and said, "Then swap the day. Go to the school peacefully on Tuesday and give me Sunday instead."

The phrase "swap the day" had remained in Malti's ears.

In Sudha's mind, perhaps, "Tuesday leave" and "Sunday extra cleaning" had later become two separate things.

On Sunday Malti had stayed from seven until twenty past twelve.

Apart from the usual utensils and mopping, she had cleaned the window mesh, fans, upper cupboards, brass items in the prayer room, and the veranda wall.

Sudha had given her tea in between.

At nine she had said, "A lot of work has been done today."

Malti had replied, "I'm making up for Tuesday."

Sudha had answered only "Yes" or perhaps "All right." Neither woman now remembered clearly which.

The one hundred and fifty rupees at month's end rested on that blurred word.

Sudha returned from the kitchen.

Malti asked, "Did you pay me separately for Sunday's work?"

Sudha thought.

"No. Festival work like this happens sometimes within the monthly wage."

“Then why should Tuesday’s leave be deducted?”

“Because you did not come that day.”

Malti looked at the calendar again.

“And I came on Sunday, when I was not supposed to come. That is not added. One day I did not come, so that is counted; another day I was not supposed to come but did come, and that is not counted.”

For the first time Sudha looked not at the notes on the table but at Malti’s face.

Just then Sudha’s daughter Rashmi came home from school.

She put her bag on a chair and asked, “What happened?”

Sudha said, “Nothing. It’s an account matter.”

Drinking water, Rashmi read the calendar on the wall.

“The tenth and the sixteenth?”

Sudha looked at her. “What do you remember?”

Rashmi said, “Malti Kaki was here on Sunday. My science chart was by the window, so I kept moving it out of her way.”

Malti smiled. “I remember that too.”

Rashmi pointed to the narrow strip of paper attached by a magnet below the calendar.

“Ma, you had made a list that day.”

It was the Diwali cleaning list.

Sudha took down the strip.

At the top was written: “Sunday: Malti — windows/cupboards; in exchange for Tuesday.”

The words “in exchange for Tuesday” were very small.

Sudha had probably written them herself while making the list, and later copied only “festival cleaning” onto the calendar.

Malti remained silent.

Sudha looked at the paper for a long time.

Then she added one hundred and fifty rupees to the pile of three thousand four hundred and fifty.

“The account is complete.”

Malti did not pick up the notes immediately.

“I need the money, but next time let it be clear beforehand. Leave is one thing; swapping a day is another.”

Sudha nodded.

She took out the wage register.

Until then, it had recorded only the date and “came/did not come.”

On a new page Sudha made three small columns: “Regular day,” “Approved leave,” “Substitute day.”

Malti read them.

“And extra work?”

Sudha drew a fourth column: “Extra work.”

Rashmi laughed. “Now the calendar will become huge.”

Malti said, “Let the calendar grow. The deduction should not shrink the truth.”

All three laughed a little, though inside the laughter lay a month’s worth of small, unwritten rules.

Malti tied the money into the end of her sari and left.

That evening Sudha’s husband Arun returned home.

He saw the wage register lying open on the table.

“Why are there four different columns?”

Sudha told him what had happened.

Arun said casually, “So much accounting for one day’s leave?”

Sudha looked at the calendar on the wall: on the tenth, “Malti absent”; on the sixteenth, “Festival cleaning.”

“The leave was for one day,” she said, “but the account involved two.”

The next month there was another meeting at Sonam’s school.

Three days beforehand Malti said, “Didi, I need Wednesday.”

Sudha opened the register.

“Leave, or a substitute day?”

Malti thought for a moment.

“This time leave. No substitute day.”

Sudha wrote Wednesday’s date in the “Approved leave” column.

On the wall calendar too, she wrote the same words: “Approved leave.”

One day had one name only.

This time there was no room in the account for it to acquire a second meaning.

The Tin Trunk as Collateral

At the southern turn of Sakri market stood Nasim Ansari's bicycle-repair shop.

The shop was so small that if two bicycles were standing inside, Nasim had to turn his body sideways to reach his toolbox.

Yet for four months the thing taking up the most space inside had not been a bicycle, but an old green tin trunk.

Its paint had flaked away in patches. One corner was dented inward, a long scratch ran across the middle of the lid, and on the front, in white chalk, was written: "Govind — 370."

Nasim had retraced those words three times. Rain and dust had faded the first writing.

On the first Thursday of every month, Karim the scrap dealer made his round of the market with his handcart.

That day too he stopped in front of the shop.

Karim tapped the trunk with a finger. "Still lying here?"

"Still here."

"Sell it. It is empty tin. It won't weigh less than five kilos. I'll give you two hundred and eighty."

Tightening a nut with a spanner, Nasim said, "It is collateral."

Karim laughed. "Collateral for four months? Only if the man ever comes back."

Nasim did not answer.

Four months earlier, Govind Sada had come to the shop for the first time one afternoon.

The rear wheel of his bicycle had gone out of true, the chain was slipping off the teeth, and the brake cable was half frayed through.

Govind worked as a mason's helper. Every day he rode the bicycle to a warehouse under construction nearly seven kos from Sakri.

"Can it be repaired today?" he had asked.

Nasim spun the wheel and examined it.

"The axle will have to be changed, two spokes, the chain joint, the brake cable. It will be ready by evening."

“How much?”

Nasim added it up. “Six hundred and twenty.”

Govind’s face changed at once.

He had two hundred and fifty rupees in his pocket.

“I’ll give the remaining three hundred and seventy tomorrow,” he said.

Nasim had never seen him before.

“And if you don’t come tomorrow?”

Still holding the bicycle handle, Govind thought for a while.

“If I leave the bicycle, I won’t earn wages tomorrow. If I take the bicycle, why should you trust me?”

Nasim said nothing.

When Govind returned in the evening to collect the repaired bicycle, he had an old green tin trunk with him.

He had carried it on his head. A torn sack hung behind him.

He put the trunk down in front of the shop and opened the lid.

There was nothing inside.

“I took all the clothes out and put them in the sack,” he said. “Keep this. When I pay the three hundred and seventy, I’ll take it back.”

Nasim burst out laughing.

“This tin trunk is security for three hundred and seventy rupees?”

Govind smiled a little too.

“I don’t know what a scrap dealer would pay for it. But this is all I have that I can leave behind.”

Nasim pressed down on the lid.

The lock worked, though Govind did not lock it. Putting a lock on an empty thing seemed ridiculous to him.

Nasim wrote in chalk across the front: “Govind — 370.”

Govind rode away on the repaired bicycle.

Three days passed.

Seven days.

Govind did not return.

On the tenth day Nasim went to the lane in Sakri where Govind lived in one room with two other labourers.

The door stood open. The landlord was sweeping inside.

“They all left yesterday,” the landlord said. “The contractor’s work shifted towards Sitamarhi.”

“Govind too?”

“He went with them.”

Nasim returned.

During the first month the trunk stood against the wall inside the shop. Nasim kept old inner tubes on top of it.

In the second month there was pump rubber.

In the third, two broken bells and a cracked bicycle seat.

Slowly the trunk began to look less like collateral and more like a permanent fixture of the shop.

Nasim's son Danish said twice, "Abba, sell it. It is taking up space."

Nasim replied, "There is money outstanding against it. It would not be right to sell it without knowing what happened to the man."

Danish read the chalk writing on the front.

"Three hundred and seventy due. The scrap dealer will give two hundred and eighty. You would still make a loss."

"An account is not only that much," Nasim said.

But even as he said it, he himself could not have explained what the other part of the account was.

One rainy night water dripped through the roof of the shop.

A round stain formed on the lid of the trunk.

The next morning Nasim wiped it and put the trunk out in the sun.

Karim the scrap dealer saw it again that day.

"I won't give two hundred and eighty now. The rust is increasing."

"How much?"

"Two hundred and sixty."

Nasim pulled the trunk back inside.

By the end of the fourth month even Nasim had begun to wonder: if Govind never returned, how long should he keep this tin trunk?

There was no written paper for the collateral. No phone number. No address.

He opened the last page of his main ledger.

"Govind — 370 — tin trunk as collateral."

The date was four months old.

Nasim decided that when Karim came the following Thursday, he would ask once more.

He closed the ledger.

He resolved not to sell the trunk before the next Thursday.

The next Thursday Karim did not come.

But at about two in the afternoon Govind himself appeared.

At first Nasim did not recognize him.

Govind's beard had grown, his body was thinner, and he had a blue plastic sack tucked under his arm.

Behind him stood a woman and a girl of about eight. Both were carrying things.

Govind peered into the shop.

His first question was, "Is the trunk still here?"

Nasim put the spanner down on the table.

"It is."

Govind's face relaxed, as though he had been asking after a person's wellbeing.

He took folded notes from his pocket.

Three hundred-rupee notes, one fifty, one twenty.

"Three hundred and seventy."

Nasim counted the money.

"After four months."

Govind lowered his head.

"In between, I could not even gather the fare to come back. From Sitamarhi we went to Sheohar, then Muzaffarpur. Now I have found work on this side again."

Nasim removed the tubes lying on top of the trunk.

The green tin was fully visible again.

The woman stepped forward at once.

"This is the one."

The girl touched the dented corner.

"Ma, this mark is still here."

Nasim smiled.

"There was nothing inside. It wasn't hard to recognize."

The woman said, "We recognize it because it was empty. If it had been full, the things inside would have changed."

It took Nasim a moment to understand the sentence.

Govind opened the lid.

There truly was nothing inside: no clothes, no papers, no money.

Only a scrap of old newspaper stuck to the bottom and dust in one corner.

Nasim asked, "You came back all this way for an empty trunk like this?"

Govind did not laugh.

"The bicycle was for work. I sold it in Muzaffarpur. We needed bus fare and food for two days."

"You sold the bicycle?"

"Yes."

Nasim looked at the trunk almost involuntarily.

"You sold the bicycle, but came back to save the tin trunk?"

This time Govind's wife answered.

"A bicycle can be replaced. Replacing this trunk would not make things better."

She put the blue sack down on the ground.

It had been stitched in two places along the top.

“This tore in Sitamarhi. We got another sack in Sheohar. In Muzaffarpur the corners of the child’s notebooks got bent. If we had had the trunk, everything would have stayed together.”

Govind ran a hand along the inside of the trunk.

“Wherever we get a room, this is the first thing we put against the wall. Clothes and papers go inside. The stove tin goes on top, the child’s schoolbag, sometimes plates. Then the room begins to feel like a room.”

The girl interrupted, “I sit on it to study.”

Her mother looked at her.

“You used to sit on it. For four months you have been studying on a sack.”

The girl laughed.

Nasim noticed a strip of blue paint on one side of the trunk, a splash of white lime on another, and a half-erased “12” in black on the back.

Govind followed his gaze.

“Room number twelve, in Darbhanga. The blue paint is from the Pandaul site. This dent happened while unloading it from a truck.”

“How many places has this thing travelled?” Nasim asked.

Govind began counting, then stopped halfway.

“What is the use of counting places? We have changed rooms more often.”

His wife said, “We bought it second-hand in Begusarai after our marriage. It has been with us ever since. Sacks changed, buckets changed, mats changed. This did not.”

There was no mystery in what she said.

No letter, jewellery or old photograph emerged from inside the trunk.

Yet for the first time Nasim understood that the empty object which had occupied a corner of his shop for four months was not actually empty.

Its usefulness was scattered across place after place.

Govind looked at his wife.

“Shall we pack everything into it here?”

“Yes. Carrying the sacks to the bus stand is difficult.”

Nasim gave them an old cloth.

The woman wiped the dust from inside the trunk.

Then the sacks were opened.

Three sets of clothes, two aluminium plates, a steel tumbler, four of the girl’s notebooks, a thin book, papers wrapped in plastic, packets of medicine, a small stove pump—one by one they settled into the trunk.

Nasim watched.

Things that had looked scattered between two torn sacks and one plastic bag fitted, within five minutes, into a single square tin trunk.

The girl put her schoolbag on top at the end.

The lid would not close.

Her mother took the schoolbag off and said, "You'll carry this under your arm."

The lid pressed shut.

Govind locked it.

Nasim wiped a damp cloth over the chalk words "Govind — 370."

The letters did not disappear completely the first time.

Govind said, "Leave it. I'll wash it when we reach home."

Nasim did not wipe it again.

He opened the ledger and drew a straight line beside Govind's name.

"Settled."

Govind did not ask for a receipt.

Even so, Nasim wrote on a small piece of paper: "Balance — zero."

The woman placed the paper on top of the locked trunk, then laughed.

"Now this paper will go inside too—but after we get onto the bus."

The three of them left the shop with their belongings.

Govind and his wife took one handle each.

The girl walked behind them with the schoolbag on her back.

At the turn in the road they found a handcart.

For thirty rupees they agreed on transport to the bus stand.

The tin trunk went onto the cart first. The blue sack was placed on top of it.

Karim the scrap dealer happened to be approaching from a distance.

When he saw the green trunk on the handcart, he stopped beside Nasim's shop.

"Oh, the man who left the collateral came back?"

"Yes."

"I had offered two hundred and sixty."

Nasim closed the ledger.

"He paid three hundred and seventy."

Karim laughed.

"For an empty tin trunk?"

Nasim looked towards the road.

At the bus stand Govind was checking the lock on the trunk once more.

The girl, tired, had sat down on top of it.

Karim shifted the weighing weights on his cart.

A little later the bus arrived.

The helper first lifted the tin trunk onto the roof, then the sack.

The ropes were tightened.

When the bus moved away, the green trunk remained steady on the roof while the sacks behind it swayed lightly.

Nasim went back inside the shop.

Where the trunk had stood for four months, a clean square remained in the dust.

Half a Sack

It was the last week of Agahan.

The paddy from the western field at Ratanpur had been cut, threshed, and spread in the threshing yard for the past three days.

As soon as the sun came up, Ramlochan Yadav began turning the paddy with his two sons.

The night dew had dampened the top layer slightly, but the grain underneath was warm and dry.

The field belonged to Shashibhushan Jha.

Ramlochan cultivated it on a sharecropping arrangement.

The cost of seed, fertilizer, irrigation and harvesting had been shared equally by both sides.

The understanding had been clear from the beginning: the harvest would be divided half and half.

Because that understanding was clear, there had been no serious dispute for the past three years.

At ten o'clock Shashibhushan Jha arrived.

With him came his grandson Aditya, two empty bullock carts, and Tulsi Sah with his old balance scale and brass weights.

In the village, it was usually Tulsi who did the weighing of paddy.

Looking at the threshing yard from a distance, Shashibhushan said, "The yield is good this year."

Ramlochan dusted his hands and replied, "Better than last year. But the eastern corner held too much water."

"Even there the grain looks full."

"Yes, the grain survived."

The conversation was easy.

The difficulty had not yet appeared anywhere.

The sacks began to be filled and weighed.

The first weighed forty-one kilos two hundred grams.

Tulsi Sah marked it with chalk: "1."

The second weighed forty kilos eight hundred grams.

He marked it: "2."

The rule they adopted was simple: odd-numbered sacks would go on Shashibhushan's cart, even-numbered sacks into Ramlochan's pile.

Next time, the order would be reversed so that lighter and heavier sacks fell to both sides by turns.

Tulsi Sah said, "If we divide by weight rather than by number, we'll total it at the end."

Shashibhushan agreed.

Ramlochan did too.

Until noon the needle of the balance kept rising and falling.

Aditya recorded every weight in a notebook.

Ramlochan's son stitched the mouths of the sacks.

At one point Tulsi Sah joked, "It is easy to say half and half. Making it half takes the whole day."

No one laughed, but no one took offence either.

After noon, grey clouds appeared in the eastern sky.

Looking up, Ramlochan said, "It may rain tonight."

Shashibhushan signalled to the cart drivers to hurry.

"Then let us take everything away today."

The number of sacks grew.

At one point Aditya added the figures and said, "So far both sides are about nine hundred and ninety-six kilos—almost equal."

Tulsi Sah looked at his notebook.

"Not almost. One side is nine hundred and ninety-six kilos four hundred grams; the other is nine hundred and ninety-six kilos two hundred."

Aditya smiled. "Do we really have to write two hundred grams too?"

Tulsi Sah said, "Leave out the small things in an account and they become large at the end."

Hearing that, Ramlochan looked for a moment at Tulsi's balance.

Before evening, the main heap was almost finished.

At the end, a small pile of paddy remained on the bamboo mat.

It was not enough to fill a whole sack.

Ramlochan's younger son Pappu held open a sack while Tulsi Sah filled it.

It came a little over half full.

The weight was thirty-two kilos six hundred grams.

Aditya wrote in the notebook: "Final — 32.6."

Shashibhushan said casually, "Divide it equally: sixteen kilos three hundred each."

Ramlochan did not answer at once.

He opened the sack, took out a handful of paddy, and rubbed the grains between his fingers.

"This is from the eastern edge."

“So?” Shashibhushan asked.

“It is a little damp.”

Shashibhushan took a handful too.

“It is paddy. Water is not dripping from it.”

Ramlochan said, “When it dries, the weight will fall.”

“Both shares will be equally damp. What difference does half and half make?”

Ramlochan looked at the sack.

“The difference is this: your share will go home on the cart today. Mine will remain here. I do not have space at home to store so many sacks; I will sell mine to the mill tomorrow. The mill will deduct for moisture.”

Shashibhushan’s face changed slightly.

“The paddy stored at my house will dry too.”

“It will. But you are not going to sell it now.”

Aditya stopped writing.

Steadying the beam of the scale, Tulsi Sah asked, “Then what do you want, Ramlochan?”

“Let us dry this half sack first. Tomorrow we will weigh it and divide it.”

Shashibhushan immediately said, “All the other sacks are leaving today. For half a sack, another cart tomorrow, another guard, another weighing?”

Ramlochan said, “The cart is yours, the guarding mine. But how do we decide the share of dry grain from the weight of wet grain?”

“Both of you will get equal amounts.”

“Equal today. What about tomorrow?”

For a moment everyone was silent.

The clouds had grown darker.

Tulsi Sah opened the sack and poured the paddy back onto the mat.

“First let us see how damp it is.”

He had no instrument.

He bit down on a few grains, then nodded.

“It is wetter than the upper pile. It came from the eastern edge, so that is natural.”

Shashibhushan said, “Then let us deduct three kilos. Call it twenty-nine kilos six hundred. Divide that.”

Ramlochan did not laugh.

“Why three kilos? Why not two? Why not five?”

Shashibhushan’s voice hardened slightly.

“Are we going to open a laboratory for every matter?”

Ramlochan remained calm.

“No. But whatever weight disappears—whose share should it disappear from on a guess?”

Aditya quietly closed the notebook.

It seemed to him that the dispute was about thirty-two kilos, but the matter was becoming larger than thirty-two kilos.

Shashibhushan looked around the threshing yard.

Then suddenly he asked, "Were all the other sacks equally wet or dry?"

Before Tulsi Sah could reply, Ramlochan said, "No. The middle of the heap was dry. Some sacks from the edges were a little heavier."

"Then why did you not say so earlier?"

"The sacks were going alternately to both sides. I thought the difference would be shared."

Aditya opened the notebook again.

"Shall we check by the order?"

He began reading weights from the first page.

"Forty-one point two, forty point eight, forty-two point one, forty-one point seven..."

Tulsi Sah stopped him.

"Weight alone will not tell us. We did not mark which sacks came from the edge."

Ramlochan's elder son Bhola said, "The sacks with black mud stains must be from the eastern pile."

Everyone began checking the sacks on the cart and in Ramlochan's pile.

Some bore black stains; others did not.

They counted.

Shashibhushan's share had eleven stained sacks.

Ramlochan's had thirteen.

Aditya said at once, "Then Ramlochan Kaka got more of the damp sacks."

Shashibhushan stopped him.

"A stain does not prove the weight was from moisture."

Ramlochan agreed.

"You are right. A stain is not proof."

That agreement did not reduce the dispute; it made it more difficult.

Tulsi Sah sat down beside the scale.

"You called me here to divide half a sack. Now it seems even reweighing the whole threshing yard would not settle everything."

Lightning flashed inside the clouds, though the thunder was still far away.

Pulling his towel tighter over his shoulder, Shashibhushan said, "Do one thing. Let Ramlochan keep the half sack. Tomorrow when he sells it to the mill, he can give me half the money according to the weight he gets there."

Ramlochan immediately shook his head.

“The mill will deduct for price and for moisture. Then the share of half a sack of grain will become money. And if the market price rises or falls tomorrow?”

“Then you suggest something.”

Ramlochan fell silent.

His wife Kaushalya arrived from a distance carrying tea.

Hearing the argument, she set the cups down on the ground.

“So much over half a sack?” she asked.

Ramlochan said, “Not over half a sack. Over what we mean by half.”

Kaushalya said nothing.

She looked at the paddy on the mat, then at the clouds.

Drinking his tea, Tulsi Sah said, “There is one solution. Leave this paddy spread on the mat here. Stretch a tarpaulin over it. Tomorrow, when the sun comes out, dry it, weigh it, and then divide it. Ramlochan will guard it; Shashibhushan will provide the tarpaulin. Whatever the weight loses by tomorrow, both sides will see it together.”

Shashibhushan asked, “Tulsi, will you come again?”

“I will. But the weighing fee for a second day will be separate.”

For the first time, a faint smile appeared on Ramlochan’s face.

“Then the cost of fairness is half and half too.”

Shashibhushan smiled as well.

“On that point there is no dispute.”

Aditya wrote the final line in the notebook:

“32.6 kilos — decision tomorrow.”

The tarpaulin was stretched.

The carts left.

In the threshing yard remained half a sack of paddy, one mat, and Ramlochan’s family.

It did rain a little that night.

For a long time drops pattered on the tarpaulin.

Ramlochan got up twice to check the edges.

The next morning the sky was clear.

The paddy was spread out.

Until noon, Kaushalya and Bhola kept turning it by turns.

Tulsi Sah arrived at two.

Shashibhushan and Aditya came too.

The paddy was filled into the sack again.

The weight was twenty-eight kilos nine hundred grams.

Aditya was startled.

“It has lost three kilos seven hundred grams!”

Tulsi Sah said, "Not all of that is water. Some dust, some husk, a few grains left on the mat. But you can see the difference."

Shashibhushan looked at the grain.

"If we had taken sixteen kilos three hundred each yesterday, today that would have been about fourteen and a half kilos each."

Ramlochan said, "For both sides."

"Yes. For both sides."

Tulsi Sah divided twenty-eight kilos nine hundred grams by two.

Fourteen kilos four hundred and fifty grams each.

There was no fifty-gram brass weight.

The smallest weight was one hundred grams.

Tulsi Sah laughed.

"Now shall we get stuck over fifty grams?"

Aditya laughed too.

Ramlochan took a handful of paddy and placed it on one pan of the scale.

The beam tipped slightly.

Shashibhushan placed a handful on the other.

The beam came almost level again.

Tulsi Sah said, "Enough. That is it."

Two small sacks were tied.

As Shashibhushan was placing his sack on the cart, Aditya asked quietly, "Dada, yesterday the forty-six sacks we divided all had different amounts of moisture. What about that?"

Shashibhushan stopped.

Ramlochan heard him too.

For a few moments no one answered.

Wrapping the balance beam in cloth, Tulsi Sah said, "For all those sacks, we left fairness to the trust that they were being given alternately."

Aditya asked, "And is trust more accurate than weighing?"

Tulsi Sah replied, "Not more or less accurate. Without trust, we would have to divide all that grain grain by grain again."

Shashibhushan climbed onto the cart.

"Yesterday's half sack taught me that equal shares are not made by the balance alone."

Ramlochan said, "Nor by trust alone. When a difference becomes visible, it must be questioned."

The cart moved away.

Ramlochan lifted his sack of fourteen kilos four hundred and fifty grams and started towards home.

A few grains were still scattered over the mat in the threshing yard.

Kaushalya swept them into one place.

They amounted to barely more than a handful.
She called to Ramlochan, "Whose share is this?"
Ramlochan turned back.
Then he laughed and said, "This time, the chickens'."
Kaushalya scattered the grains before the chickens in the courtyard.
The balance had gone.
For the first time, no needle moved in the threshing yard.

The Other Door

From half past seven in the morning, two signboards stood in front of the main entrance of Asha Health Centre.

The first, in blue letters, said: “Regular Patients — Main Entrance.”

The second, in green, said: “Free Health Camp — Other Door.”

An arrow on the green board pointed towards a narrow lane along the right side of the building.

The lane curved around to the rear courtyard, where a temporary registration table, three benches and two medicine boxes had been set up.

It was the centre’s foundation day.

The local traders’ association had paid for the medicines, four doctors had agreed to conduct free examinations until two in the afternoon, and an advertisement had appeared in the newspaper: “Health for All.”

Neelam Jha arrived at seven as a volunteer.

She was an undergraduate student and the niece of Dr Prabhakar, the owner of the health centre.

Her job was to distribute camp slips, keep the queue orderly, and guide elderly patients to the correct room.

The first time Neelam read the board saying “Other Door,” she paused.

“Why from the back?” she asked the manager, Arun Babu.

Counting a bundle of papers, Arun Babu said, “The crowds must remain separate. The regular patients already have appointments in the main waiting room.”

“But the doctors are the same?”

“The doctors are the same. Registration is separate.”

“Water?”

“There is an earthen pot at the back.”

Neelam looked through the glass of the main hall.

Cool air moved inside, a digital queue number glowed on the wall, and a water cooler stood in one corner.

In the rear courtyard, half the shade came from a bamboo canopy.

Arun Babu understood her look.

“It is a one-day camp. Everyone will be examined and everyone will get medicine. That is what matters.”

By eight, people began arriving.

Sita Devi from Ratanpur came first. She had pain in her knees. Reading the green sign, she turned into the lane on the right.

Then came an elderly couple: the husband complaining of breathlessness, the wife needing an eye examination.

Neelam wrote serial numbers on the slips: 1, 2, 3...

By half past eight, the rear courtyard was full.

Twelve people could sit on the three benches. The rest stood along the wall.

Meanwhile regular patients kept arriving through the main entrance.

Some had prior appointments, some had come to show test reports.

At the main registration desk they received white slips; the camp patients received green ones.

Both kinds of slip bore the same name of the health centre.

The difference was only the colour and the box for the fee.

On the green slip, that box was blank.

At nine, the first doctor arrived: Dr Neha Mishra.

She entered through the main door, put down her bag, then went to the room assigned to the camp at the back.

The first ten patients were examined.

Blood pressure was measured. Some were sent to the laboratory in the main building for blood-sugar tests.

Neelam noticed that to reach the laboratory, a camp patient had to come out again through the same narrow lane and then enter the small corridor beside the main entrance.

“Why not go straight through the inside door?” Sita Devi asked.

Neelam searched for an answer.

An assistant said, “That is the regular section.”

Sita Devi said nothing.

Leaning on her walking stick, she took the lane again.

At ten the sun grew strong.

The shade of the canopy at the back began to shrink.

Neelam thought of bringing two plastic chairs from the main waiting room, but Arun Babu stopped her.

“Those chairs are for patients with appointments.”

“Elderly people are standing here.”

“Bring stools from the storeroom.”

There were five stools in the storeroom.

One had a shaky leg.

Neelam wiped them and set them out.

By eleven, the camp numbers had crossed seventy.
 At that time only seven patients were sitting in the main waiting room.
 Neelam looked once more through the glass.
 Cool air. Empty chairs. Chilled water.
 At the back, an elderly woman was wiping her face with a towel.
 "Daughter, where is the water?"
 Neelam pointed towards the earthen pot.
 The water was finished.
 She filled two bottles from the main hall and brought them out.
 Arun Babu said nothing, though his face suggested that this was an exception, not the rule.
 At half past eleven the sky suddenly turned grey.
 Wind rose.
 The two signboards in front of the main entrance began rocking back and forth.
 Ramdin, who handled cleaning and small chores, ran over and picked them both up.
 "It is going to rain," he said. "I'll keep them inside."
 Ten minutes later a few drops fell and then stopped.
 Meanwhile Neelam had taken a patient to the laboratory.
 Ramdin began mopping the main floor.
 The job of putting the boards back outside fell to Rohit, a new volunteer.
 He switched their positions.
 The blue board now pointed towards the lane on the right: "Regular Patients — Main Entrance."
 The green board pointed directly towards the glass doors: "Free Health Camp — Other Door."
 The words "Other Door" now stood directly in front of the main entrance.
 The arrow pointed straight inside.
 Rohit did not notice the mistake.
 His job was only to stand the boards up again.
 For the first five minutes, nothing happened.
 Then Saroja Devi from Bharwara read the green board and walked in through the main entrance.
 She had the old advertisement for the free camp in her hand.
 At the main registration desk she asked, "The free examination is here?"
 Swati, who was sitting at the main desk, looked at the board for a moment.
 Outside, the green arrow pointed inward.
 "Do you have a slip?"
 "No."
 Swati looked for Neelam but could not see her.

Then she took out a green slip and wrote Saroja Devi's name on it.

Saroja Devi sat down in the glass-walled waiting room.

Four more people came in behind her.

Within ten minutes, eleven patients with green slips were sitting in the main hall.

Some drank water from the cooler. Some watched the digital queue display.

At that moment Manoj Agrawal, a cloth merchant from town, arrived for his regular check-up.

His appointment was for twelve.

Following the arrow on the blue sign, he turned into the lane on the right.

He reached the rear courtyard and looked for the registration desk.

"My appointment is at twelve," he said.

Volunteer Bablu looked at the white slip in his hand.

"You are a regular patient?"

"Yes."

"Then... the board points this way."

Manoj Agrawal looked around: bamboo canopy, stools, medicine boxes, a crowd holding green slips.

"Where is Dr Neha?"

"Inside, in the other room."

"Why have I been sent here?"

Before Bablu could answer, another regular patient, Jagdish Babu, a retired bank manager, came through the lane.

He too was holding a white slip.

The two men looked at each other.

Jagdish Babu said, "Is the main entrance closed?"

"No."

"Then why were we sent here?"

Bablu explained about the board.

Jagdish Babu became irritated.

"I paid and took an appointment, and now I am supposed to stand here in the sun?"

At that very moment Sita Devi, returning from the laboratory, heard the sentence.

She said nothing.

She only tightened her grip on her walking stick.

At five past twelve, Neelam returned to the main hall.

She stopped when she saw the scene.

People with green slips were inside the glass waiting room.

People with white slips were in the rear courtyard.

Arun Babu arrived too.

“What has happened here?”

Rohit ran outside.

The moment he saw the boards, his face fell.

“I switched their places.”

Arun Babu said at once, “Put them right! Quickly!”

Neelam asked, “First, where do we send the patients who are already here?”

“Send everyone to the section they belong to.”

“But the doctors are already seeing slips from both sides.”

“The crowds have become mixed.”

The crowds had indeed become mixed, but the examinations had not stopped.

Swati had already sent three patients with green slips to the doctor according to their numbers.

At the back, Bablu had already measured Manoj Agrawal’s blood pressure.

No machine had failed.

No paper had been lost.

People had merely reached the correct work through the wrong door.

Arun Babu came into the main hall.

“Camp patients, please go to the back. Regular patients, sit here.”

Saroja Devi stood up.

She was holding a small bottle of water, half full.

She asked Neelam, “Had I been sitting in the wrong place?”

Neelam said, “The board was wrong.”

“But the chair was fine.”

Neelam had no answer.

Returning towards the rear courtyard, Sita Devi passed Manoj Agrawal, who was now going towards an empty chair in the main waiting room.

Sita Devi asked softly, “Was the sun too strong there?”

Manoj looked at her.

There was no mockery in the question, only a direct inquiry.

He said, “Yes. A little.”

Sita Devi nodded.

“For me too.”

They went their separate ways.

The boards were put back in their old positions.

Green arrow to the right.

Blue arrow straight ahead.

But traces of the half-hour’s confusion remained.

Two green slips had been left on chairs in the main hall.

A white slip lay pressed beneath something on the rear table.

During the short lunch break, Dr Neha Mishra asked Arun Babu, “Why are two entrances necessary?”

Arun Babu said, “For orderly management.”

“For half an hour just now, everything ran in reverse. What broke?”

“The regular patients were inconvenienced.”

“And the camp patients?”

Arun Babu did not answer.

Neelam was beside them counting slips.

She did not raise her head.

After a while Arun Babu said, “The main waiting room has limited space. Paying patients come with appointments. We have to provide them comfort.”

Dr Neha asked, “And the camp patients do not give time?”

“They do not pay a fee.”

As soon as the sentence came out, Arun Babu fell silent.

The counting of slips in Neelam’s hands stopped at that point.

Dr Neha said nothing.

She closed her lunch box and walked towards the rear courtyard.

By one in the afternoon, the sun was even stronger.

Dr Neha asked for ten chairs from the main hall to be sent to the back.

The extra twenty bottles kept beside the water cooler were sent there too.

Arun Babu did not object.

With fewer chairs in the main hall, two regular patients had to stand.

Ten minutes later, empty chairs became available again.

The camp ended at two.

A total of one hundred and twenty-seven patients had been examined.

The regular department had continued running as well.

In the evening the staff were adding up the registration slips.

A representative of the traders’ association arrived.

He wanted a photograph for the newspaper.

“A photograph with a crowd will look good,” he said.

The photographer suggested that everyone stand together in front of the main glass entrance.

Arun Babu moved the blue signboard for the main entrance slightly aside so that the name of the health centre would be clearly visible in the photograph.

Neelam picked up the green board too.

“Where should I put this?”

“Outside the photograph,” Arun Babu said.

The photographer arranged patients, doctors, volunteers and organizers together.

Some held green slips, some white; in the photograph the colours of the slips were not visible.

The next day the photograph appeared in the newspaper.

The caption read: "Equal healthcare for patients of all sections at Asha Health Centre."

Neelam cut out the newspaper item and pinned it to the office noticeboard.

Beside it hung the preparation list for the next month's camp.

The third line on the list said: "Place the Free Health Camp signboard in front of the other door on time."

Neelam stood for a long time looking at the two pieces of paper together.

Then, with her pen, she made a small question mark beside that line on the preparation list.

She did not tear the paper.

She did not erase the rule.

Only the question mark remained beside the line—exactly where, for half an hour the previous day, the difference between the two doors had disappeared.

Five Chairs

Just before the rains began, five red plastic chairs were placed in a straight line in the school courtyard.

The chairs were not new.

Two had fine cracks in their backrests; the right leg of one splayed slightly outward.

But a white towel had been draped over each chair, and a small paper label was pinned on top.

The first said: "Chairperson."

The second: "Chief Guest."

The remaining three: "Honoured Guest."

Straightening the chairs, headmaster Ramakant Jha said, "Keep all five in front. They should show clearly in the photograph."

Secretary Nandkishor stood holding the attendance register.

"More than sixty people have been told to come. Where will they sit?"

Ramakant looked towards two long benches beside the veranda.

"There are benches. There are mats too. It is a village meeting; people will manage."

The public meeting that day was to decide whether the school's old storeroom should be turned into a community reading room.

The storeroom had been almost empty for five years.

Apart from a broken table, old maps and bundles of leftover examination paper, there was little inside.

Village students wanted a place where they could study in the evenings.

Some people had proposed keeping newspapers, old books and magazines for competitive examinations there.

But there were many questions.

Who would keep the key?

Who would pay for the electricity?

Would books be allowed to go home?

Would the room be only for students, or for the whole village?

The invitation said three in the afternoon.

People began arriving from half past two.

Sangeeta, a Class Ten student, came first.
 She carried an application signed by seven students.
 Then Phulo Devi arrived.
 Her son was in Class Twelve, and five people lived in a single room at home.
 By three, both benches were full.
 Children, parents, shopkeepers, teachers and several elderly people sat on the mats.
 The five red chairs were still empty.
 Nandkishor looked at the clock.
 "Has the chairperson called?"
 Ramakant said, "He is on the way."
 "The chief guest?"
 "He has left the block office."
 "And the other three?"
 Ramakant looked at the labels on the chairs.
 "They will come."
 At a quarter past three, the wind changed.
 The leaves of the peepal tree in front of the school suddenly flashed pale on their undersides.
 The sky to the east grew black.
 Looking out from the veranda, Phulo Devi said, "The rain has reached us."
 Someone laughed.
 "The reading room is about to face its first examination."
 The laughter did not last long.
 First five large drops struck the dusty courtyard.
 Then came a sound as if a thousand pebbles had fallen at once on the school's tin roof.
 People sitting on the mats got up and ran towards the veranda.
 Nandkishor tucked the attendance register under his arm.
 The children began folding the mats.
 Ramakant's first glance went to the five red chairs.
 "Bring these inside! Quickly!"
 Two students lifted them.
 The veranda was already crowded.
 When the five chairs were brought in, they occupied almost half the front space.
 Sangeeta pressed her application to her chest and edged towards the wall.
 Phulo Devi stood by the doorframe.
 An elderly man, Jagdish Kaka, who had been sitting on a bench because of pain in his knees, had to stand in the crowd.
 Four children squeezed onto his bench.

Nandkishor said, "Shall we give one chair to Kaka?"

Ramakant immediately looked at all five labels.

"No. These are for the front. The honoured guests may arrive at any moment."

Jagdish Kaka heard him but said nothing.

He remained standing, holding the window frame.

The rain grew heavier.

Within fifteen minutes the courtyard was shining with water.

Water reached the first step, then flowed away.

Watching the crowd on the veranda, Sangeeta said softly, "How will so many people sit in the reading room?"

Her classmate Neeraj said, "Let it be made first."

A phone rang.

It was the chairperson's driver.

Water had risen over the small bridge on the road; the car was taking another route.

Five minutes later a second call came.

The chief guest had not yet left the block headquarters.

He would start when the rain eased.

Nandkishor looked at the five chairs.

"Shall we begin the meeting?"

Ramakant thought for a moment.

"Ten more minutes."

In the left corner of the veranda the roof began to leak.

First one drop, then a steady stream.

Two of the red chairs stood directly beneath it.

Ramakant himself ran over.

"Move these two this way!"

People shifted again.

All five chairs were now placed in a row in the driest middle section of the veranda.

A wall was behind Phulo Devi; chair backs were in front of her.

She shifted half a step to the right.

The lower edge of her sari was already wet.

A teenager said quietly to his friend, "The chairs must not get wet."

His friend did not laugh.

There was little room for laughter in the crowd.

At a quarter to four, assistant teacher Arun opened the old storeroom and dragged out a wooden table.

As soon as the door opened, the stale smell inside reached the veranda.

Sangeeta peered in.

“Sir, is this where the reading room will be?”

Arun said, “If everyone agrees.”

“There is space.”

“There is space. Making the rules for using it will be the difficult part.”

The proposal was made to place the papers on the table and begin the meeting.

Nandkishor said, “If the chairperson does not arrive, let us choose a temporary chairperson.”

A voice from the back said, “First let people sit down.”

Ramakant looked around.

There was no space on the benches.

Half the mats were wet.

The five red chairs were empty.

For a moment his eyes rested on them.

Then he said, “If the honoured guests arrive, people will have to get up again. Let everyone stand for a little while.”

This time Jagdish Kaka spoke.

“I have already had enough practice getting up.”

A small smile appeared on several faces, but it was swallowed at once by the noise of the rain.

The meeting began.

Sangeeta read the application.

“We want a place to study from five to eight in the evening after school hours. Not everyone has a separate place at home.”

Phulo Devi said, “If the electricity bill rises, we will contribute what we can every month. But do not keep the room locked against the children.”

Shopkeeper Shambhu asked, “Will books be allowed to go home, or must they be read here?”

Arun said, “Let the reading room begin first. A register can be made for the books.”

Still holding the window frame, Jagdish Kaka said, “Instead of throwing newspapers away after one day, they can be kept here. I buy two newspapers every day.”

A woman said, “If the key stays only at the school, it will be locked again on holidays.”

From the other side came a suggestion: one key with the headmaster, another with the secretary of the women’s group.

Gradually the discussion became clearer.

The five empty chairs remained in front of everyone.

By four, the rain had eased a little.

The phone rang again.

The chairperson's car had been unable to cross the bridge and had turned back.

The chief guest sent a message from his office: because of the weather, he would not be able to attend the programme.

Of the remaining three, one phone was switched off, one person was out of town, and from the third person's house came the message: "We will see when the rain stops."

Nandkishor read the messages and fell silent.

Ramakant looked at the five chairs.

"Now?" Jagdish Kaka asked.

Before Ramakant could answer, Nandkishor removed the label from one chair.

"We are no longer waiting for the honoured guests."

He pushed the chair towards Jagdish Kaka.

Kaka did not sit.

"Why?"

"More than half the meeting is over now. I can remain standing."

Nandkishor pushed a second chair towards Phulo Devi.

She too refused at first.

"I am fine."

Ramakant said, "Sit. Why should it remain empty?"

Phulo Devi sat down hesitantly.

Her wet sari left a dark mark on the red seat.

One by one, the labels were removed from all five chairs.

Two chairs went to elderly people, one to Phulo Devi, one to Nandkishor, and on the fifth they spread out the proposed list of books.

The veranda did not suddenly become larger, but the line of people loosened.

Neeraj asked, "How many chairs will there be in the reading room?"

Arun replied, "There are ten old tables and chairs on the inventory. We can repair them."

Looking at the five red chairs, Shambhu asked, "Will these five ever remain empty too?"

No one answered.

Ramakant remained bent over the book list.

The meeting ended at five.

The resolution was written down:

The storeroom would be cleaned.

Two old cupboards would be repaired.

The reading room would remain open from five to eight in the evening.

There would be no fee for students.

A voluntary monthly contribution box would be kept for electricity expenses.

Two copies of the key would be made.

The rain had almost stopped.

Small streams of water ran across the courtyard.

People began leaving for home.

Some carried their slippers in their hands.

Some wrapped their book bags in cloth.

Phulo Devi stood up.

The mark from her wet sari remained on the red chair.

She tried to wipe it with the towel.

Nandkishor stopped her.

“Leave it. It will dry.”

Ramakant counted the five chairs again.

“All here?”

“All five.”

Two students carried them into the storeroom.

Sangeeta followed.

Inside, the chairs were stacked one over another beside the broken table and the dust-covered cupboard.

She asked, “Sir, when do we start cleaning?”

Arun said, “From Sunday.”

“We’ll come.”

Coming down from the veranda, Jagdish Kaka said, “Those chairs had quite a busy day.”

Shambhu laughed.

“Less sitting, more protecting.”

Ramakant smiled too, but said nothing.

Before closing the attendance register, Nandkishor began writing a short account of the meeting on the last page.

“Members present — sixty-two.”

“Honoured guests absent due to weather.”

“Decision — community reading room to be established.”

He was about to write something under “Seating arrangement,” then his pen paused.

Outside, Phulo Devi was crossing a small stream of water on her way home.

Jagdish Kaka was probing the depth ahead of his feet with his walking stick.

Sangeeta and Neeraj had opened the storeroom window to let the stale air out.

In one corner of the room, the five red chairs were stacked one over another.

Four were almost dry.

One still bore the faint mark of a wet sari.

At last Nandkishor wrote: "Meeting concluded."

He left the space for "Seating arrangement" blank.

The Washerman's Mark

As soon as Prabha Devi opened the bundle of clothes, she counted the saris first.

One, two, three, four, five.

She counted again.

One, two, three, four, five.

Standing on the veranda, Bhola Rajak had set his bamboo basket down on the ground.

His fourteen-year-old son Chhotan was with him, crossing the returned clothes off in a notebook.

Prabha Devi opened the fifth sari once more.

A yellow cotton one with a black border.

One with red flowers.

One with a fine green stripe.

Two old everyday saris.

The purple Banarasi was not there.

"One sari is missing."

Bhola immediately looked at the notebook.

"You gave seventeen pieces in all."

"Not seventeen. Eighteen."

"The notebook says seventeen."

Prabha Devi's voice hardened.

"So whatever is written in the notebook becomes the truth?"

Chhotan's pen stopped.

Three days later, Prabha Devi's younger sister's daughter was to be married.

The house was already full of turmeric preparations, oil, invitation cards, sweet boxes and the coming and going of relatives.

The purple Banarasi sari had been given to Prabha Devi by her mother.

She wore it very rarely.

She had planned to wear it at this wedding, and clearly remembered putting it with the other clothes to be ironed.

"Bhola, I placed that sari there with my own hands."

Bhola opened the notebook and held the page before her.

“Look: five saris, four blouses, three kurtas, two dhotis, two sheets, one shawl. Seventeen in all.”

“There were six saris.”

“I wrote five.”

“Then you wrote it wrong.”

“I counted them on your veranda when I collected them.”

At that moment Prabha Devi’s neighbour Shashikala came in through the gate.

“What happened?”

Without lowering her voice, Prabha Devi said, “An expensive sari has not come back.”

Shashikala looked at Bhola.

“Which sari?”

“A purple Banarasi. With gold zari.”

The atmosphere on the veranda changed at once.

Chhotan did not close the notebook, but his finger froze on the page.

Bhola said, “If that sari had come to me, it would have a mark.”

“Where will you look for a mark on a sari that is missing?” Prabha Devi said.

“We use one mark for all clothes in a particular batch. Your household’s old mark is different; each new batch has its own mark.”

He picked up the yellow cotton sari and turned over the inner edge.

Near the fall were two tiny blue dots and, beside them, a thin crooked line.

“This is the mark for this batch.”

Prabha Devi was losing patience.

“What does showing me a mark on a sari that is here prove about the one that is missing?”

Before Bhola could answer, two more people had stopped at the gate.

In a wedding house, even a small voice travels quickly outside.

Someone asked, “How much did it cost?”

Prabha Devi said, “Leave the price. My mother gave it to me.”

After that sentence, the matter was no longer merely about a piece of cloth.

Bhola ran a hand through the inside of his basket to show it was empty.

“I have none of your clothes left with me.”

“Then where did the sari go?”

“I do not know.”

“If you do not know, who will?”

Bhola was silent for a few moments.

Then he said, “All I know is that I took seventeen pieces and returned seventeen.”

Shashikala said softly, “Look once more in the house.”

Prabha Devi turned towards her.

"There is a wedding in this house. Would I not know where I kept my mother's sari?"

Shashikala fell silent.

Someone standing outside the gate said, "Expensive clothes should be entered separately."

Another voice said, "I never give silk to a washerman at all."

Bhola did not look in that direction.

He closed the notebook.

"Prabha Didi, if you wish, come and search my house. The baskets, bamboo racks, clothes room—everything."

"I am not going to search anyone's house."

"Then what should I do?"

Prabha Devi did not answer at once.

Anger, the rush of the wedding, and her mother's sari all stood together on her face.

At last she said, "Find the sari first. We will talk after that."

Bhola lifted the basket.

Chhotan tucked the notebook under his arm.

They began walking towards the gate.

At the gate Bhola turned once.

"I will check the clothes room again by this evening."

Prabha Devi said nothing.

By noon that day the story had crossed two lanes.

One relative had been planning to send clothes to Bhola for ironing, but said, "Not now. Let the wedding pass."

A woman from the neighbourhood took her own bundle to another ironer.

That evening Bhola really did search his small clothes room twice.

His wife Nirmala took down the hanging clothes and counted them.

Chhotan emptied the sacks and checked them.

The purple Banarasi was nowhere.

"Was the notebook right?" Nirmala asked.

"Seventeen."

"Then?"

Bhola opened the notebook and looked at the page again.

"Then seventeen."

Nirmala watched his face.

"People do not read the page."

Bhola said, "People read the story."

The next morning Prabha Devi sat down to separate the clothes for the wedding.

She needed the golden blouse she meant to wear with the purple sari.

The blouse was not in the upper shelf of the cupboard.

She took out a box from the lower shelf.

It was not there either.

Then she remembered that the fall of the sari had come loose at one place the previous week.

She had thought she would keep the sari aside and get the fall stitched by the seamstress before giving it to the washerman.

The thought came like lightning, but she did not want to accept it immediately.

Beside the kitchen was a small room where the sewing box, old curtains, extra pillows and wedding decorations were kept.

Prabha Devi went straight there.

On top of a wooden chest lay a white cloth bag.

Its mouth was half open.

Her hand trembled slightly.

Inside was the golden blouse.

Beneath it, folded, lay the purple Banarasi sari.

For a long time Prabha Devi did not lift it.

Her daughter Neha, standing behind her, asked, "Ma?"

Prabha Devi slowly picked up the sari.

One corner of the fall was indeed loose.

That was why she had kept the cloth aside.

"How did this come here?" Neha asked.

Prabha Devi did not answer.

She opened the sari and looked at the inner edge.

Near the old part of the fall was a small black-ink mark: one dot, one straight line, then half a circle.

She remembered the two blue dots Bhola had shown her the day before.

Neha brought one of the returned cotton saris.

Inside it the two blue dots and crooked line were clear.

The two marks were different.

Prabha Devi remembered that the old black mark was from the washing done the previous Phagun.

Bhola changed the mark with every batch so that old clothes from the same household would not get mixed with a new batch.

The purple sari had no mark from the current batch at all.

Neha said nothing.

Prabha Devi herself said, "When I made the bundle, I put in five saris."

“But when you were counting?”

“In my mind I counted this one too.”

Neha folded the sari again.

“Then Bhola Kaka was right.”

In Prabha Devi’s mind returned the veranda of the previous day, the people standing outside the gate, Shashikala’s silence, and the voice saying ‘expensive cloth.’

She did not put the sari back into the bag.

Holding it in her hands, she went straight to Bhola’s house.

Bhola was heating a coal iron in the courtyard.

When he saw Prabha Devi, he did not get up.

He simply rested his hand on the lid of the iron and waited.

Prabha Devi opened the sari in front of him.

“I found it.”

Bhola looked at the mark.

“This is an old mark.”

“Yes.”

“It did not come in this batch.”

“Yes.”

Bhola said nothing more.

For Prabha Devi, his silence was harder than a scolding.

“It was my mistake.”

Turning the coal in the iron, Bhola said, “All right.”

Prabha Devi opened her purse.

“For the trouble you went through—”

Bhola immediately raised a hand.

“Not money.”

“Then?”

“Nothing.”

Prabha Devi was about to breathe in relief when Bhola spoke again.

“There is one thing.”

“Say it.”

“Where the accusation was made yesterday, the correction should be made there too.”

Prabha Devi looked at him.

Bhola did not raise his voice.

“If you tell me in my house that a mistake was made, my house will know. The lane will not.”

Prabha Devi closed her purse.

“All right.”

That evening there were people again on the veranda of the wedding house.

This time Prabha Devi herself spoke loudly enough for Shashikala, the neighbours, two relatives, and even the paan seller outside the gate to hear.

“The purple sari was here in the house. I had put it aside and forgotten. Bhola took only seventeen pieces. The accusation was my mistake.”

Someone said, “At least it was found—that is the main thing.”

Someone laughed. “These things happen in a wedding house.”

Only Shashikala looked towards Bhola, who was standing near the gate delivering a bundle.

Bhola said nothing.

The correction was made, but the matter did not end there.

Two days later, the same neighbour who had taken her bundle to another ironer came to Bhola.

“Next time I’ll give it to you again. That day I got a little frightened.”

Bhola said, “All right.”

“Write expensive clothes separately.”

“I already do.”

The woman gave a slightly awkward laugh.

“Yes, yes. Now I understand.”

On the wedding day Prabha Devi wore the same purple Banarasi sari.

Neha had stitched the fall the previous night.

Bhola had ironed the sari too.

This time Prabha Devi had handed it to him herself, and instead of counting aloud she had checked every item against the notebook.

Bhola put a new small mark for that batch on the inner edge.

The wedding passed.

The lane returned to its usual rhythm.

A week later a new customer came to Bhola with five pieces of clothing: two shirts, a pyjama, a sheet and a silk sari.

Separating the sari, he said, “Take a little care with this. I heard that last week—”

He did not finish the sentence.

Bhola looked at him once, then opened the notebook.

“Five in all.”

“Yes, five.”

Bhola made a very small blue mark on the inner edge of the cloth.

The mark was so small that it could not be seen from a distance.

But the other mark that had been made in the lane required no one to turn a piece of cloth inside out in order to see it.

Hours of Wages

At the gate of a four-storey building under construction on the outskirts of Laheriasarai, a round clock hung on the wall.

A fine dust of cement always settled on its glass, but the black hands could be seen clearly from a distance.

Directly beneath the clock stood the watchman Kailash's table.

For safety, he entered in a thick notebook the time of every worker who crossed the gate: name, time of entry, time of exit.

That notebook was not used to calculate wages.

Its purpose was to show how many people were inside the building and whom to look for in case of an accident or inspection.

The attendance for wages was recorded inside, beside the tool store.

Before eight in the morning the workers crossed the gate, then formed a line in front of the small storeroom.

One needed a spade, another a mortar pan, another a chisel and hammer; those going to the upper floors needed safety belts and ropes.

Naresh Lal, the store clerk, counted out the tools and at that same moment wrote the time beside each name on the attendance sheet.

"Seven fifty-eight?" Budhan Paswan asked one day.

Naresh Lal looked not at the clock but at the line and said, "You crossed the gate at seven fifty-eight. Attendance was marked at eight five. Spade number five and mortar pan eighteen."

Budhan did not pay much attention to it then.

Seven minutes did not seem like anything important.

He had been working at that construction site for seven months.

The work was regular: measuring sand and cement, mixing mortar, sending filled pans upward, bringing empty pans back down.

In the evening the process ran in reverse.

When the five o'clock bell rang, the work teams cleaned their tools, scraped hardened mortar from the pans, coiled ropes, and returned everything to the store after it had been counted.

On the attendance sheet, the exit time was written as five o'clock because "work ended at five."

But the workers usually crossed the gate at five ten, five twelve, sometimes five fifteen.

That difference too did not seem important to anyone.

After all, people were merely returning tools before going home.

On the last Saturday of the month, wages were being distributed.

On Naresh Lal's table lay a blue ledger, a bundle of attendance sheets and envelopes of cash.

When Budhan's turn came, the clerk looked at the ledger.

Four hundred and twenty-five rupees had been deducted.

Budhan thought there must be some outstanding advance.

"What is the deduction for?"

"Short time."

"Which day?"

"Not a day. The minutes have been added together. Five hours and forty minutes short over the month."

Budhan did not laugh.

"I did not miss even half a day."

Naresh Lal pulled out the sheets.

"Look here: eight five to five. Here: eight seven to five. Here: eight three to five."

"When did I cross the gate?"

"The gate register is not the wage register."

"Then when do wages begin?"

Naresh Lal looked towards the tool room.

"When you receive your tools and work begins."

"Standing in the line is not work?"

The clerk became slightly uncomfortable.

People were waiting behind Budhan.

"The rule is the same for everyone."

Budhan took the envelope and moved aside.

Karim Miyan had three hundred and ten rupees deducted.

Sarita Devi, two hundred and sixty.

Rampukar, around four hundred.

No one had been absent for half a day, yet everyone had "short minutes."

Karim Miyan said, "A minute is small until it turns into money."

That evening, after collecting their wages, everyone came out.

Kailash kept writing exit times in the gate register.

Budhan found his own name.

That day: entry, 7:52. Exit, 5:13.

He remembered the attendance sheet: 8:05 to 5:00.

Thirteen minutes in the morning.

Thirteen minutes in the evening.

"Kailash Kaka," he asked, "do you fill this register every day?"

"When I am on the gate, yes. If it is the other shift, Shambhu writes it."

"Are the old pages still here?"

"Six months are bound together. They may be asked for during a safety inspection."

Budhan said nothing.

On Monday he deliberately crossed the gate at seven fifty.

Kailash wrote: 7:50.

There were already eleven people in front of the tool room.

Naresh Lal was issuing equipment alone.

One spade had a loose tooth and had to be replaced.

The buckle of one safety belt jammed.

When Budhan's turn came, the clock showed eight four.

The attendance sheet recorded 8:04.

He took his spade.

"I have been inside for fourteen minutes."

Naresh Lal said, "But you received the tool only now."

"You are the one issuing the tools."

Naresh Lal did not answer.

The line behind him kept growing.

At noon Budhan told Karim Miyan, Sarita and Rampukar what he had noticed.

On an empty cement sack Rampukar drew two lines with a piece of charcoal: "Gate / Attendance."

"Shall we start writing down the times from tomorrow?"

Karim Miyan said, "They are already written at the gate."

"Then we only have to look at the sheets."

For the next three days everyone remembered their times.

Gate 7:48, attendance 8:02.

Gate 7:55, attendance 8:07.

Gate 7:51, attendance 8:01.

In the evening the sheets closed at five.

The gate times were 5:11, 5:09, 5:14.

Sometimes the gap was smaller, sometimes larger.

But the direction was always the same: in the morning the wage sheet began late; in the evening it stopped early.

Sarita said, "We arrive on time and become late while standing in the attendance line?"

Karim Miyan did not laugh.

"Do we make the line, or does the store?"

On the fourth evening one mortar pan was reported missing.
 Everyone was held back.
 At last the pan was found in a corner of the third floor.
 By the time they crossed the gate, it was five twenty-two.
 On the attendance sheet, the exit time for that day was still 5:00.
 Rampukar said, "During those twenty-two minutes, was I on my way home?"

Naresh Lal said, "Searching for the pan is a separate matter."
 "Whose pan was it?"
 "The construction company's."
 "Who searched for it?"
 The clerk fell silent.

At the end of that week, five workers went to the contractor, Vinod Sah.
 Vinod Sah was sitting on a plastic chair looking at building plans.
 Budhan placed the gate register and the attendance sheets for two or three dates in front of him.

"This is the safety register," Vinod Sah said.
 "Yes. But the people are the same," Budhan replied.
 On one date: gate 7:52, attendance 8:05, exit sheet 5:00, gate 5:13.
 On another: 7:50, 8:04; then 5:00, 5:11.

Vinod Sah said, "How can anyone work before receiving tools?"
 Sarita asked, "Whose arrangement is the line for receiving tools?"
 "The construction site's."
 "Then whose time is the time spent in that line?"
 Vinod Sah looked at the papers again.

Karim Miyan said, "In the evening too, washing, counting and returning the tools are required by the construction site."
 "That is necessary for safety."
 "Then why is necessary time outside wage time?"
 The discussion did not turn into a quarrel.
 No one raised a voice.

The papers were lying in front of them, and because of the papers everyone had to keep his sentences short.
 Vinod Sah called Naresh Lal.
 "Since when has attendance been recorded like this?"
 "As I was instructed: entry when the tools are issued, exit at five."
 "Only one person distributes tools in the morning?"
 "Yes."
 "How many workers?"
 "Sometimes twenty, sometimes thirty."
 After a few moments Vinod Sah said, "Recheck this month's account."

Rampukar began copying dates from the gate register.

Kailash opened the old pages.

The attendance sheets were placed beside them.

In just the first three days, Budhan's total difference came to thirty-eight minutes.

In ten days, more than two hours.

When all twenty-six days were added up, of Budhan's five hours and forty minutes of 'short time,' four hours and fifty-seven minutes turned out to be time spent waiting for tools or returning and cleaning them.

The rest was genuine lateness: one day because the bus was late, another because he left early for the hospital.

Everyone's figures were different.

But the list ran to four pages.

When the figures for all seventeen regular workers were added, a few minutes at a time had become many dozens of hours.

Looking at the calculations, Vinod Sah said, "So much time was not visible in the main structure of the work."

Budhan replied, "When the structure is being built, the line is not visible."

This time Vinod Sah did not smile.

Two days later, the portion of the deductions created by this process was returned to the workers.

Where there had been genuine lateness, those deductions remained.

No one shouted slogans of victory.

People counted the money, put it in their pockets, and went back up to work.

The following Monday there was a new arrangement in front of the tool store.

The entry time in Kailash's gate register would now count as the start of attendance.

In the evening, the time of crossing the gate would be the exit time.

A second person was also assigned to the store so that the line would remain shorter.

At the top of the new sheet, Naresh Lal wrote in red ink: "According to gate time."

Budhan read it.

"And the old sheets?"

Naresh Lal let out a small breath.

"All the bundles from the old months are in the storeroom."

Beside the gate, two old bundles really were lying tied with string.

On top was written: "Month Closed."

It was eight o'clock.

All the workers were inside.

The tool line was still moving.

But this time the minutes on the clock did not have to stand in the queue before they could reach the wage sheet.

The Red Seal

Shakuntala Devi held a blue paper folder in her hand.

One corner of the folder had swollen a little from rainwater, but she had wrapped the papers inside it three times in cloth: a copy of her Aadhaar card, a copy of the bank passbook, her husband Shambhunath's death certificate, an income certificate, two photographs, and the application form.

Her turn came at the window of the block service counter.

The young man seated behind the desk turned the papers over one by one.

"Everything is here," he said.

Shakuntala Devi's face brightened slightly.

The young man stopped his finger on the last page.

"There is no red seal."

Shakuntala Devi leaned forward a little so that she could hear properly.

"Which seal?"

"The red seal for local verification. It is written in the list."

He pointed to the notice hanging beside him.

At the top, in large letters, it said: "District Destitute Pension Assistance: Required Documents."

At the end of the seventh line, in small letters, were the words: "Local verification — with red seal."

Shakuntala Devi could not read.

The young man read the line aloud to her.

"Where do I get it?"

"From the village office."

"I have brought the income certificate from there."

"The seal is still required separately."

Behind her, the next person at the window cleared his throat, ready to push his papers forward.

Shakuntala Devi gathered up the blue folder.

"It cannot be submitted today?"

The young man shook his head.

"Bring it with the seal."

There were only three direct vehicles a day from the block office to her village.

The afternoon one had already left.

She walked as far as the market and caught a shared vehicle in the evening.

By the time she reached home, darkness had fallen.

The next morning she went to the village office.

Secretary Naresh Jha first looked at the income certificate, then at the application.

"I have already signed the verification here," he said.

"They want a red seal."

"Red?"

Naresh Jha picked up the round office seal kept at the corner of the desk.

He opened the ink pad.

The ink inside was blue.

"This is the seal of my office."

"Then where will I get the red one?"

"Changing the colour does not change the authority of a seal."

Shakuntala Devi remained silent.

Naresh Jha searched for the information booklet, but he did not have the new pension list.

He said, "Bring me a copy of that list. I will look at it."

A copy of the list could be bought for five rupees from a photocopy shop outside the block office.

The next day Shakuntala Devi took the vehicle again.

This time there was less crowd at the pension window.

She asked for a copy of the list hanging beside it.

The young man said, "You will get it outside."

At the photocopy shop outside, the owner took out the page.

"Five rupees."

Shakuntala Devi gave him a ten-rupee note.

As he returned the change, the shopkeeper asked, "For the red seal?"

She looked surprised.

"How did you know?"

"A lot of people have been taking this page this month."

"Where is the seal put?"

The shopkeeper shrugged.

"Some say the panchayat, some say the circle office. My work is only to make copies."

Shakuntala Devi folded the page and put it in the blue folder.

She did not try to submit the application again that day.

First she had to take the list to the village office.

On the way back, she had to break a fifty-rupee note for the fare.
 Counting the coins left in her pocket, for the first time she wondered how much she had already spent simply in applying for the pension.
 After reaching home, she took out an old medicine envelope.
 On its back, she had her granddaughter Payal write:
 “First trip — forty.”
 “Second trip — forty.”
 “Photocopy — five.”
 Payal asked, “Why are you keeping this account?”
 Shakuntala Devi said, “I want to see how much the pension eats before it even begins.”
 The next day Naresh Jha read the photocopied list.
 “It really does say ‘red seal’ here,” he said.
 “Then?”
 Naresh Jha looked again at his blue office seal.
 “I can buy red ink and stamp it, but what if the rule does not require my seal at all?”
 “The block office says it does.”
 “Then ask them whose seal.”
 Weariness settled over Shakuntala Devi’s face.
 “I asked them. They said the village office.”
 Naresh Jha thought for a while.
 At last he signed beside the verification line once more and stamped it with the blue office seal.
 “This is my valid seal. Red ink is not my rule.”
 “Will they accept it?”
 “They should.”
 “And if they do not?”
 Naresh Jha did not answer.
 For the third time Shakuntala Devi reached the block office.
 That day the first young man was not at the window.
 A middle-aged woman was seated there.
 Her nameplate said: Reeta Kumari.
 Reeta examined the papers.
 Her finger stopped on the blue seal.
 “A red seal is required.”
 Shakuntala Devi was ready this time.
 “This is the actual seal of the village office. Their ink is blue.”
 “The list says red.”
 “Whose red?”
 Reeta looked at the page.

"I am telling you what the instructions say."

"Whose seal do the instructions say?"

Reeta became slightly uncomfortable.

She took a thin file from the cupboard behind her, but the queue was growing.

"There is no time now. The assistant officer will be here next Tuesday. Ask him."

"Take the application today. I will get the seal added later."

"We cannot accept an incomplete application."

"Are my papers complete or not?"

Reeta said, "Without the red seal, they are not complete."

Shakuntala Devi gathered the blue folder again.

Outside, she took out the medicine envelope.

This time Payal was not with her.

Shakuntala Devi could write numbers herself, though not letters.

Below the earlier "40," she wrote another "40."

Then she wrote ten rupees for tea.

She did not particularly want tea, but she had eaten nothing since morning and there was time before the next vehicle.

At the tea stall, an elderly man asked, "Paperwork?"

Shakuntala Devi said, "Seal work."

The old man laughed.

"Work involving a seal is never only about the seal."

Shakuntala Devi did not laugh at that sentence.

On Tuesday she went again.

Eight people were standing outside the assistant officer's room.

It took an hour to get inside.

The officer looked at the page, the list, and the blue seal from the village office.

"This is blue."

Shakuntala Devi asked, "Should I change the colour?"

The officer looked at her.

There was no mockery in the question.

"No. Changing the colour will not solve it."

"Then whose red seal?"

The officer rang the bell.

A clerk came in from outside.

"Where does the red seal for the pension application come from?" the officer asked.

The clerk answered at once, "After local verification."

"By whom?"

The clerk paused.

“The village office... perhaps.”

Shakuntala Devi heard the uncertainty in the answer.

The officer said, “Bring the old circular.”

The clerk left and returned much later carrying two thick bundles.

One bundle held more dust than paper; the other, more paper than dust.

Just then a young records assistant entered the room.

Her name was Sujata.

She placed the bundles on the table and began searching through the pages.

“Which year?”

The clerk told her, “The first year after the new scheme began.”

Sujata checked the index and opened a page from the middle.

“Here is the list of attachments required from the applicant,” she said.

Everyone leaned closer.

The line was read item by item: identity, bank details, death certificate, income, residence, photograph.

There was no mention of a red seal.

The clerk said, “Look at the next page.”

The next page was headed: “Office Procedure.”

Sujata put her finger on the relevant line and read:

“After receipt of a complete application, the receiving counter will register the application number, affix the red receipt seal, and send it to the verification section.”

For a few moments there was no sound in the room.

Shakuntala Devi did not understand every word.

She asked only, “Was I supposed to get the seal, or were you?”

Sujata looked at her.

“The office was.”

Reeta was called in.

She arrived carrying the list that had been posted outside.

The officer placed the two pages side by side.

On the locally typed checklist, the phrase “local verification” and the next office instruction, “red seal,” had been joined into the same line.

Sujata said, “It looks as though when the list was typed, the page break was joined incorrectly.”

Reeta said quietly, “We have all been checking from this list.”

The officer asked, “How many applications were sent back?”

No one answered.

Shakuntala Devi took out the medicine envelope.

“I have come four times.”

The officer looked at the paper in her hand.

“What is that?”

“Expenses.”

“How much?”

Shakuntala Devi could not add the figures herself.

Sujata took the envelope.

She added the fares, photocopying, tea, and one shared-vehicle journey.

“Two hundred and thirty-five rupees.”

Shakuntala Devi said, “I also lost one day’s weeding in the field. That is not written here.”

The room fell silent again.

The officer handed the application to Reeta.

“Receive it.”

Reeta picked up a round stamp from the right-hand corner of her desk.

She opened a red ink pad.

For the first time Shakuntala Devi saw the seal.

It had been lying from the first day inside the same window from which she had repeatedly been sent away.

Reeta pressed the stamp into the ink, placed it on the application, and pushed down firmly once.

Thump.

“Received.”

An application number was written down.

Sujata handed Shakuntala Devi a receipt.

“Keep this safely. Your application has been submitted.”

Shakuntala Devi put the receipt into the blue folder.

Then she put the medicine envelope inside as well.

“Is there any fee for this?” she asked.

“No,” Reeta said.

Shakuntala Devi looked at her for a few moments.

“Not here,” she said.

Reeta did not reply.

Outside, the old list was being taken down from the noticeboard.

Sujata crossed out the seventh line in red pen and carried the page towards the copying section to prepare a corrected version.

Shakuntala Devi walked down the stairs.

This time she was no longer carrying the search for that red seal in her hands.

Before catching the vehicle home, she stopped in the market for five minutes.

She bought two notebooks for Payal.

The shopkeeper asked, “Did the pension work get done?”

“They accepted the application.”

“Did you find the red seal?”

Shakuntala Devi gave a faint smile.

“I found it. It was on their own desk.”

When she reached home, Payal opened the medicine envelope.

She looked at the numbers and asked, “Is the account closed now?”

Placing the blue folder on top of the cupboard, Shakuntala Devi said, “No.

When the first pension comes, we will see how much is left.”

Payal took a red pen and drew a line beneath the figures on the envelope.

Above the line were the numbers for the journey expenses.

Below it, there was still empty space.

The Shared Ridge

It was the last week of Bhadau.

After three days of rain, the sun had come out properly for the first time.

In the fields towards Bisfi, the paddy leaves were shining, and here and there the doob grass, motha and soft growth on the ridges looked like green strips.

Gopal Yadav was cutting grass on the southern ridge of his field with a sickle.

His cow had been tied in the cowshed for the past two days.

Because of the wet paths, it had not been able to go out to graze.

Gopal thought that if he cut the grass from the ridge and took it home, there would be fodder until evening.

He had cut three swathes when Raghunandan Mishra called out from the field to the east:

“Gopal Bhaiya, stop your hand there.”

Gopal stopped the sickle in mid-air.

“Why?”

Raghunandan stepped carefully between the rows of paddy and came up to the ridge.

The lower edge of his dhoti was smeared with mud.

“That grass is on my side.”

At first Gopal thought Raghunandan was joking.

“Does grass also look which side it is growing on?”

There was no smile on Raghunandan’s face.

“The ridge falls within my holding in the land record.”

Gopal tightened his grip on the sickle.

“The ridge is on the boundary. Half mine, half yours.”

“Have you looked at the papers?”

“I have papers at home too.”

For a few moments both were silent.

A small heap of cut grass lay between them.

Raghunandan bent down and lifted a handful of doob grass.

“Last year too you cut from here.”

Gopal said, "Last year you did not say anything."

"If I said nothing, did the right change?"

This time Gopal's voice hardened.

"If we are going to talk about rights, let us measure the ridge half and half."

Raghunandan looked straight at him.

"Let us measure it."

By noon the matter had travelled from the fields into the village.

It was the kind of village where, if two people raised their voices over a field ridge, by evening five people had produced old maps, seven had produced old quarrels, and ten had produced their own opinions.

Over tea at Ramphal Sah's shop, someone said, "It is only grass. Divide it."

Another said, "Whoever has the ridge in his holding owns the grass."

A third held that "Doob belongs to no one; whoever has the cow gets the grass."

Ramphal Sah laughed.

"Then call the cows to the panchayat."

The shop burst into laughter, but neither Gopal nor Raghunandan laughed.

The next morning a surveyor was called.

Kamlesh Paswan arrived with an old measuring tape, two bamboo pegs and a small red cloth bag.

Gopal had brought a copy of his khatiyā.

Raghunandan had brought his jamabandi papers too.

Kamlesh examined both sets of papers, then went towards the ridge.

The ridge was not straight.

In some places it was a cubit and a half wide; elsewhere less than a cubit.

At one point an old rat hole had collapsed.

At another, thick reed-like grass roots were holding the earth together.

Kamlesh said, "A boundary line looks straight on paper. In a field, soil breathes."

Gopal said, "Measure it straight."

Raghunandan added, "And write down where each person's part ends."

Kamlesh stretched the tape.

It took two hours.

At last small bamboo pegs were driven into the ground at three places.

According to the line, most of the ridge did indeed fall on Raghunandan's side of the recorded holding.

Gopal's face fell.

Raghunandan immediately said, "Then the matter of the grass is clear."

Brushing soil from the peg, Kamlesh said, "The boundary is clear. I am not deciding the grass."

"The ridge is mine, so the grass is mine," Raghunandan said.

Gopal replied, "Fine. Then maintaining the ridge is yours too."

Raghunandan paused.

"Where did maintenance come from?"

"Whoever owns the ridge owns its soil, its grass, and its repairs."

Kamlesh looked from one to the other but said nothing.

That afternoon Raghunandan had the grass cut from the part of the ridge he considered his.

His grandson Sonu wielded the sickle.

The grass was cut close to the ground so that tender new shoots would come quickly.

Gopal kept spreading fertilizer in his own field at a distance.

He did not go near them even once.

Three days later it was time for water to be released into the canal.

From the village's small irrigation channel, the water first reached the eastern corner of Gopal's field.

Then, through two small openings made along the top of the ridge, it was let by turns into the two fields.

For years this sequence had been supervised by old Ramcharit Mahato.

Ramcharit was nearly eighty.

His eyesight was dim, but he could still understand the movement of water from the trembling of leaves.

That evening he came towards the fields, leaning on his stick.

Gopal was opening the small gate of the channel.

Raghunandan arrived too, carrying a spade.

Ramcharit asked, "Who takes the first water?"

Gopal said, "It is my turn."

Raghunandan immediately said, "Last time you took the first turn too, but at midnight the water entered my side as well."

Gopal raised his eyes.

"It did not enter. It seeped through the ridge."

Ramcharit planted his stick on the ridge and stood as if listening.

"Seeped?"

"Yes."

Raghunandan said, "It is fine now."

The water slowly reached the edge of the field from the channel.

Gopal opened his small inlet.

The water spread between the rows of paddy.

For the first half hour everything was fine.

Then, on the part of the ridge where the grass had been cut close to the roots, the soil began to shine wet.

Ramcharit noticed it from a distance.

“Put a spade there.”

Raghunandan said, “It is nothing.”

Ramcharit said again, “Put a spade there.”

This time a thin stream emerged from behind the ridge.

First as thick as one finger.

Then two.

Raghunandan ran over and pressed the earth down with the spade.

Instead of stopping the water in his own field, Gopal stood watching the leak.

Within moments, a small section of the ridge collapsed inward with a soft crumbling sound.

Water rushed towards Raghunandan’s field.

“Shut it!” Raghunandan shouted.

Gopal ran towards the mouth of the channel.

Ramcharit sat on the ridge and began pressing the wet earth with his hands.

Within ten minutes the water was stopped.

But one strip of Gopal’s field had already drained halfway, while too much water had collected in the lower corner of Raghunandan’s.

Sonu brought sacks and straw from home.

People from both families began filling soil.

Without saying anything, Gopal cut earth from a dry corner of his own field and brought it over.

Raghunandan looked at him for a moment.

Then he took hold of the sack.

By nightfall the ridge was standing again.

Ramcharit’s feet were caked with mud.

He asked, “Was the grass cut close to the ground?”

Raghunandan did not answer.

Sonu said, “I cut it. Dada told me to cut low so it would grow again quickly.”

Ramcharit ran his hand over the mound of earth.

“The roots were holding the soil.”

Raghunandan’s face tightened.

“Then should we not cut the grass?”

“Cut it. But do not scalp the ridge.”

Gopal was quietly washing his spade.

Ramcharit looked at him.

“You were wrong too.”

Gopal looked surprised.

“What did I do?”

“Three days ago you said, ‘Whoever owns the ridge owns the repairs.’”

Gopal opened his mouth to answer, then closed it.

Ramcharit said, “A boundary exists on paper. Water does not read paper.”

The next morning Ramcharit opened an old wooden trunk in his house.

Inside were not land documents but an old irrigation register—pages from notebooks, some in blue ink, some in pencil, some with only dates and names.

Ramcharit’s father used to record turns for the irrigation channel.

Later Ramcharit himself had begun writing them.

He carried the notebook to Gopal’s veranda.

Raghunandan was called too.

The pages had turned yellow.

In one place it said:

“Bhadau Shukla 5 — Gopal’s father first turn. Mishraji second turn. Soil on the middle ridge from both households.”

On another page:

“Agahan 12 — Mishraji first turn. Yadavji second turn. Southern opening of ridge closed by Yadavji.”

There were more pages.

The years changed, the names changed, but one thing appeared again and again: soil for the ridge from both households; one would open the ridge inlet and the other would close it.

Raghunandan pulled the notebook towards himself.

“This is not a document of ownership.”

Ramcharit said, “No.”

Gopal said without smiling, “Then it is a document of use.”

Ramcharit nodded.

“And of responsibility.”

Raghunandan turned the pages.

On one old entry was his father’s signature.

“Ridge private boundary. Water-control shared.”

Four words.

Raghunandan kept his finger on that line for a long time.

Gopal said, “The surveyor was not wrong.”

“No.”

“Most of the ridge lies in your holding.”

“Yes.”

“But the work of holding back the water belongs to both of us.”

Raghunandan replied, “Yes.”

Ramcharit closed the notebook.
That afternoon both men went to the fields again.
The section repaired the previous day was still soft.
Gopal brought two baskets of sticky clay from his field.
Raghnandan brought straw and old sacks.
Together they packed the ridge.
When Sonu began cutting the remaining grass with the sickle,
Raghnandan stopped him.
“Cut from the top. Leave the roots.”
Gopal said, “And half for my cow.”
Sonu looked at both men.
For the first time, a faint smile appeared on Raghnandan’s face.
“Half the grass? Shall we call the surveyor again?”
Gopal smiled too.
“No. The measuring tape does not work on grass.”
The grass was divided into two heaps, but not measured.
One heap received a little more, the other a little less.
No one counted again.
A week later it was time to irrigate once more.
This time the first water belonged to Raghnandan’s field.
Gopal himself came to press earth over the southern opening of the ridge.
Raghnandan opened the irrigation channel.
The water reached the ridge and seemed to pause, as if looking in two
directions, then flowed along the intended path.
Ramcharit sat at a distance on a bamboo stool.
The old irrigation register was not in his lap.
The notebook was at home.
This time no one needed it.
On his way back in the evening, Gopal saw fresh doob beginning to grow
on the ridge.
He did not take out his sickle.
Raghnandan looked at it too.
Neither man said anything.
The ridge was still a boundary.
But more important than the grass growing on that boundary was the soil
that kept the water of the two fields from overwhelming one another—and, at
the same time, bound both men to the same responsibility.

A Plate of Rice

A little away from the bus stand, beside the old post office, stood Janak Bhojanalaya.

The name was grand; the establishment was small.

Inside were eight tables and sixteen benches, a glass case at the front holding onions and lemons, and two stoves in the kitchen at the back.

The owner, Jagdish Sah, rose at five every morning.

By seven, after the rice had been washed, the lentils sorted and the vegetables arranged for cutting, the first pot would be on the fire.

His wife, Kamala Devi, managed the kitchen.

Before leaving for school, their son Neeraj filled the water drum.

Their daughter Poonam, on her way to college, counted the change in the cash box.

The midday plate cost sixty rupees.

Rice, dal, one vegetable and pickle.

For five rupees more, an egg; for ten more, fish curry.

The customers included bus conductors, rickshaw pullers, painters, daily-wage labourers, nearby small shopkeepers, and now and then an office clerk.

Under the front counter Jagdish kept a thick notebook.

On its cover, in blue ink, was written: "Due."

Inside were names and amounts.

"Ramesh the painter — 180."

"Salim the conductor — 120."

"Bachchu the mason — 300."

"Devu the rickshaw puller — 60."

Against some names was a red line; against others, a mark showing part payment.

Jagdish was not the sort of man who would go to someone's house in the evening for a single rupee of debt.

His rule was simple: "Pay when you can, but your name will remain written down."

The difficulty was that over the past two months, "when you can" had moved farther and farther away.

One Monday morning, as rice merchant Murli Sah unloaded a sack, he said, "The last two sacks have not been fully paid for."

Jagdish said, "I'll pay this evening."

"Not this evening. Give me half now. I too have to settle payment at the wholesale market."

Jagdish opened the cash box.

There were one thousand three hundred and seventy rupees inside.

He owed Murli two thousand eight hundred.

"Take one thousand. The rest tomorrow."

Murli Sah did not glare at him.

He only said, "I have a notebook too, Jagdishji."

The sentence pricked Jagdish slightly.

Murli unloaded the rice and left.

Jagdish took out his own dues notebook and began adding.

The total was four thousand nine hundred and twenty rupees.

He added again.

The amount was the same.

As she salted the vegetables, Kamala Devi asked, "What are you looking at?"

"People eat now and pay later."

"Everyone pays."

"They do, but my rice sacks want cash now."

Kamala said nothing.

By noon Jagdish had made up his mind.

On a piece of cardboard he wrote in large letters: "NO CREDIT FROM TODAY."

Below it, in smaller letters: "Please do not mind the inconvenience."

The board was hung above the counter.

The first customer to read it laughed.

"Kaka, is this written for me?"

It was Devu the rickshaw puller, who had sixty rupees outstanding.

Jagdish said, "It is for everyone."

Devu searched his pockets.

He found thirty rupees.

"Will I get half a plate?"

Jagdish tried to laugh, but no laugh came.

"If I give half the rice and charge half the price, the dal and vegetable account will go wrong."

Devu looked at the board for a while.

"Then I'll have tea and biscuits."

He left.

For a moment Jagdish felt like calling after him, "Sit down. Pay tomorrow."

But the board was hanging above his head.

Between twelve and two, all the tables were usually full.

That day two tables remained empty.

Ramesh the painter came as far as the entrance, read the board, and did not come inside.

Salim the conductor gave a hundred-rupee note, ate a sixty-rupee plate, and asked for the remaining forty to be adjusted against his old debt.

Jagdish said, "No new credit."

Salim smiled.

"This isn't new. I'm reducing the old account."

Jagdish opened the red notebook and deducted forty.

At the end of the day the cash box held two hundred rupees more than on an ordinary day.

Jagdish felt satisfied.

But one pot of rice was left in the kitchen.

Kamala Devi said, "Fewer people came today."

"They will understand from tomorrow."

"What about the leftover rice?"

"Take it home. We'll all eat it tonight."

That was what usually happened.

Whatever was left became the family's evening meal.

Sometimes dal was cooked separately at home, but most often the household ate from the food prepared at the bhojanalaya.

Jagdish had never treated this as a separate question in the shop accounts.

The bhojanalaya was his, the house was his.

One stove, one rice.

For three days the board remained hanging.

No new debt was added.

Five hundred and seventy rupees of old debt also came back.

Jagdish grew more encouraged.

On the fourth day he gave Murli Sah another thousand.

Murli said, "You are on the right path."

Jagdish felt pleased inside.

That evening Poonam returned from college and sat at the counter.

She studied accountancy, so her father sometimes asked her to count the cash.

Poonam asked, "Have you entered this week's purchases?"

"Everything."

"Rice?"

“Two sacks.”

“Dal?”

“Forty-five kilos.”

“Oil?”

“Thirty-six litres.”

Poonam opened an old register in which daily sales were recorded.

She added the total plates sold over five days, keeping fish, eggs and tea separate.

Then she subtracted the purchases.

After a while her brow tightened.

“Babu, the account still does not match.”

Jagdish looked towards the board.

“Credit is closed.”

“Credit is closed, but the shortage is not.”

“How much?”

“About five hundred in five days.”

Jagdish immediately pulled the notebook towards himself.

“How can that be? I count the cash myself.”

Poonam said, “I’m not saying cash is being stolen. I am comparing stock cost with sales.”

Kamala Devi had been listening from the kitchen.

She came out.

“Perhaps we used more oil.”

Poonam shook her head.

“Oil can vary a little. Five hundred is not that small.”

Jagdish grew uneasy.

He began to suspect that some employee might be taking supplies home.

In the kitchen there were only Kamala and one cook, Ramcharit.

Ramcharit had been with them for fifteen years.

Even the thought of suspecting him made Jagdish uncomfortable.

Poonam took a pencil and began asking questions.

“How many plates were prepared yesterday?”

“About seventy.”

“Sold?”

“The register says fifty-six.”

“The remaining fourteen?”

“Some rice was left, and the staff ate some.”

“Do you record the staff plates?”

“Those are part of their wages.”

“Then where is their number recorded?”

Jagdish was silent.

Poonam asked again, "And what you take home?"

Kamala Devi said, "Whose account would that go into? It is our own house."

Poonam smiled slightly.

"The house is ours, but the rice comes from Murli Sah's sacks."

Jagdish remembered Murli's sentence: "I have a notebook too."

Poonam began estimating the previous five days.

There were four people at home: Jagdish, Kamala, Poonam and Neeraj.

Ramcharit and one helper ate at the bhojanalaya.

Sometimes Jagdish also ate a full plate at noon; sometimes only rice and dal.

"Four evening plates at home, over five days, makes twenty," Poonam said.

"At sixty rupees each that would be twelve hundred, but at cost it is roughly four hundred and fifty to five hundred."

Kamala Devi laughed.

"So now even eating our own food has become credit?"

Poonam laughed too.

"Not credit. But it is outside the ledger."

Jagdish kept looking at the board: "NO CREDIT."

For the first time it occurred to him that the board was meant for people outside, while the shortage could also be coming from inside.

That night the family ate leftover rice from the bhojanalaya with potato and pointed gourd, and dal.

Kamala Devi served the plates.

Usually Jagdish ate without thinking.

Today, before the first mouthful, he asked, "Will Poonam record these four plates?"

Neeraj laughed.

"Babu, shall I become a customer of the hotel from tomorrow?"

Jagdish laughed too.

"Not a customer. But rice does not come out of thin air."

The next morning Poonam made a new page in the register.

Three columns: "Cash," "Credit," "Home/Staff."

The word "Home" looked strange to Jagdish.

"What is the use of this?"

"At least we will know how much is prepared, how much is sold, how much we eat, and how much is left."

"And credit?"

Poonam shrugged.

"Credit is one difficulty. Things outside the ledger are another."

That afternoon Devu the rickshaw puller came again.

He had sixty rupees in his hand.
 "Kaka, the earlier sixty later. Today is cash."
 Jagdish served him a plate.
 Devu sat down.
 A little later Ramesh the painter stood outside.
 He had forty rupees.
 He read the board and began to turn away.
 Jagdish called, "Ramesh!"
 Ramesh stopped.
 Jagdish thought for a moment.
 In the old way he could have said, "Sit down, pay later."
 But that sentence would reopen the same unlimited notebook.
 He said, "Give forty. I'll write twenty as due. But no more than one new plate of credit at a time."
 Ramesh looked at the board.
 "It says credit is closed."
 Jagdish looked up.
 The board really was still hanging there.
 He climbed onto a stool, took it down, and on the blank reverse wrote a new sentence:
 "Nothing Without Entry in the Ledger."
 Ramesh read it and laughed.
 "That sounds even stricter."
 "Not stricter. Clearer."
 Jagdish entered Ramesh's twenty rupees under credit.
 Then he looked at the "Home/Staff" column on the new page Poonam had made.
 At noon Jagdish himself ate one plate of rice.
 When he finished, Poonam lifted her pencil.
 "Babu — one?"
 Jagdish said, "Write it."
 "Which column?"
 "Home."
 Kamala Devi smiled from behind them.
 By evening the new page showed twelve cash plates, two on credit, three for staff, and five for home.
 At night the cash matched.
 The stock estimate too came a little closer than the day before.
 Jagdish was not surprised.
 Cash had not suddenly increased.
 The debt to Murli Sah had not disappeared.

The customers' difficulties had not been solved either.

Only a few things that had previously been nameless had acquired names.

A week later, while unloading rice, Murli Sah read the new board.

"Nothing Without Entry in the Ledger," he read aloud. "Like my notebook."

Jagdish laughed.

"Yes. Now I understand."

Murli asked, "Credit has started again?"

"Within limits."

"And the household?"

Jagdish looked surprised.

"Who told you about the household?"

Murli Sah laughed.

"Who needs to tell a person who runs a small shop? The house eats first; the account wakes up later."

Jagdish did not answer.

Before closing the bhojanalaya that night, Poonam wrote the final line for the day.

"Home — four plates."

Jagdish looked at the page.

Once he had thought that 'due' meant only the money that people outside owed him.

Now cash, credit, staff and home were all on the same sheet.

He closed the ledger.

From the kitchen Kamala Devi called, "There is rice left. Shall we take it home?"

Jagdish said, "Take it."

Then, after a pause, he added, "Four plates are written down, aren't they?"

Poonam smiled.

"Yes."

Jagdish switched off the light.

In the darkness the new board above the counter could no longer be read, but in the ledger every plate from the day was now visible.

The Rented Cart

Every morning at half past five, Sarita Devi reached Bhola Sah's courtyard.

Calling it a courtyard was perhaps too generous.

It was the open space between three rooms where, at night, eight handcarts stood one behind another, their noses almost touching.

One had new wheels, another a bent handle, another old stains of turmeric, coriander or fish on its plank.

Sarita's cart was number five.

A small white "5" was painted on its right wheel.

Bhola Sah would take down the ledger hanging from a nail in the wall, write the name against the date, and collect the day's rent of seventy rupees.

The rule was said to be very simple: "If you take a cart, seventy rupees for the day."

There was no column in the ledger for what time the cart was taken or what time it was returned.

Sarita usually brought it back between six and seven in the evening.

Sometimes, if the vegetables sold early, she returned it at three.

Bhola Sah never asked who owned the remaining hours of the day.

Sarita had never asked either.

On that Wednesday in Ashadh, the sky had already sunk low by morning.

Sarita took out cart number five and headed towards the wholesale market.

She bought one sack of potatoes, a basket of brinjals, okra, bitter gourds, tomatoes and coriander.

By seven, the rain began.

First a fine drizzle.

Then heavy sheets.

Sarita stretched an old blue tarpaulin over the cart.

There were three small holes in it.

She moved the tomato basket away from beneath them, but slanting rain still reached the brinjals.

By ten o'clock she had sold only eighty-eight rupees' worth of vegetables.

There were few people on the road.

Whoever came out hurried under an umbrella and did not want to stop to choose vegetables.

At eleven Sarita turned the cart around.

Not towards home, but straight to Bhola Sah's courtyard.

Bhola Sah was sitting on the veranda removing a wheel from cart number seven.

Sarita pushed number five inside.

Bhola Sah looked up.

"Back so early?"

"The road is empty."

"The vegetables?"

"More than half are left."

Bhola Sah lifted the tarpaulin and looked at the wet baskets.

"The coriander will not last till night."

Sarita took forty rupees out of her bag.

"It did not run even half a day. Keep forty."

Bhola Sah did not take the money.

"The day's rent is seventy."

"Where did the day go?"

"Into the rain."

"Then collect it from the rain."

Bhola Sah smiled, but did not extend his hand.

"The cart was reserved for you from the morning."

"I have returned it now."

"You have returned it, that is fine. But the rule for a day is the rule for a day."

The words sounded harsh to Sarita.

She was in a position to pay seventy rupees, but her mind resisted.

"I'll give it in the evening," she said, and began unloading the remaining vegetables.

Bhola Sah said nothing.

The rain continued until afternoon.

At home Sarita separated the wet coriander, wiped the tomatoes, and sold the brinjals to a neighbour at a lower price.

At four the rain stopped.

At five her younger son Sonu said, "Ma, my wooden box was left under the cart."

The box held two old scale weights and some paper bags.

Sarita said, "Come, we'll get it."

The two reached Bhola Sah's courtyard.

Cart number five was not there.

At first Sarita thought Bhola Sah had moved it farther inside.

"Where is number five?" she asked.

Bhola Sah's son Munna said, "Chhotelal took it."

"Which Chhotelal?"

"The man who roasts maize. He is going to the bus stand for the evening crowd."

For a few moments Sarita stared at Munna's face.

"For how much?"

Before Munna could answer, Bhola Sah came out.

"Thirty rupees," he said. "For three or four hours."

Sarita asked slowly, "Then how much rent did number five earn today?"

Bhola Sah understood the question, but took a moment before replying.

"Your seventy. His thirty."

"A hundred rupees from the same cart on the same day?"

"His was for the evening."

"Was the evening not included in my seventy?"

Bhola Sah frowned.

"You returned it."

"Was the rent for a day or by the hour?"

"For the day."

"Then does a day include the evening or not?"

Munna slowly slipped inside.

Bhola Sah took out the ledger.

Against Sarita's name was written "70."

Below it, beside Chhotelal's name, "30."

Sarita placed her finger on the page.

"One day. One cart. Two rents."

Bhola Sah said, "If the cart had stood idle, the thirty would not have come."

"I am already paying the rent for it to stand idle, am I not?"

After that question, for a while the only sound on the veranda was water dripping from the roof.

Bhola Sah was not a hard man.

But he did not like seeing a rule that had run for years suddenly stand before him as a question.

"Do you want me not to give it to Chhotelal?"

"No. I want my day not to be sold a second time."

Bhola Sah closed the ledger.

"Tomorrow all the renters will be here. We will talk then."

Sarita took the box and went home.

That night, more than the seventy rupees, it was the unused time of cart number five that troubled her.

She thought: if she had kept the cart standing uselessly at her own gate, Bhola Sah could not have earned the extra thirty.

She had returned it early, so the cart had been used again.

But who had received the benefit of her returning it early?

The next morning the rain had stopped.

All eight regular renters gathered in the courtyard.

Chhotelal came too, because the matter of number five could not be complete without his name.

Bhola Sah opened the ledger.

Sarita said, "Make the rule clear. If seventy rupees is the rent for the day, then the day is mine. If the rent is by hours or by shifts, there should be a separate entry for that."

Rahim, who sold fruit, said, "I often return my cart at two. Is it given to someone else later?"

Bhola Sah said, "Sometimes."

"Then why is 'sometimes' never written in my ledger?"

Parvati, another vegetable seller, laughed.

"I always thought the cart was mine until night."

Bhola Sah said, "Will you keep it at home overnight?"

"No. But what are the seventy rupees for?"

Chhotelal had been silent.

At last he said, "Thirty seemed fair to me. I needed the cart for three hours."

Sarita looked at him.

"I have no objection to your thirty. My objection is to my seventy."

Kailash, who sold eggs, pulled the ledger towards himself.

"Write the time."

Bhola Sah said, "Am I to sit writing times every day?"

Kailash replied, "If you write the money, write the time too."

For a long while they added, subtracted and argued.

The full day would be seventy rupees.

The morning shift—from five in the morning to one in the afternoon—forty.

The evening shift—from one to nine at night—thirty.

But one question remained.

If someone took the cart for the full day and returned it at noon, should the rent be seventy or forty?

Bhola Sah said, "I had reserved it for the whole day. How could I know beforehand whether an evening customer would come?"

Sarita accepted that point.

"If no one takes it in the evening, seventy. If it is rented again, count my rent as the morning forty."

Rahim asked, "Then the owner still gets seventy—forty and thirty?"

"Yes," Sarita said. "The day is not sold twice. The time is sold in two shifts."

Bhola Sah looked at the ledger for a long while.

"And if someone returns it at three?"

Parvati said, "Then the quarrel starts again."

Everyone laughed.

In the end the rental rule did not become very legalistic.

There were simply three columns: "Full Day," "Morning," "Evening."

Below them was one short line:

"If a cart taken for the full day is rented again in the evening, the first rental will be counted as the morning shift."

Bhola Sah reopened Wednesday's page.

He crossed out the "70" beside Sarita's name and wrote "40."

The "30" beside Chhotelal's name remained as it was.

Sarita received thirty rupees back.

Thirty rupees was not a very large sum.

But that day the crossed-out "70" in the ledger felt weightier than the money itself.

Sarita kept cart number five for the full day that day.

There was no rain.

Sales were good.

She returned it at six in the evening and paid seventy.

Nothing unusual happened for the next three days.

On the fourth day, by noon almost all Sarita's vegetables had sold.

Only two kilos of potatoes and some chillies remained.

Earlier, on a day like this, she would slowly wheel the cart through the lanes until evening, thinking that she had already paid for the whole day.

This time she went straight to Bhola Sah's courtyard.

"Does anyone want it for the evening?"

Bhola Sah said, "Chhotelal has asked."

Sarita pushed the cart inside.

"Then write morning."

Bhola Sah looked at the clock.

"Twelve forty-five."

"Before one."

In the ledger he wrote: "Morning — 40."

Thirty rupees remained in Sarita's hand.

At five that evening, returning home from the market, Sarita reached the bus stand.

Chhotelal was roasting maize on cart number five.

On the plank were a charcoal stove and small containers of lemon, salt and chilli.

From a distance Chhotelal called, "Your cart."

Sarita replied, "Yours for the evening."

The white "5" on the right wheel was the same.

By the end of the month Bhola Sah's ledger had changed.

Beside some names was written "Full Day," beside others "Morning," beside others "Evening."

On some days the same cart number appeared on two lines, but when those two lines were added together, the total never exceeded seventy.

At first Bhola Sah found it troublesome.

So many times to ask the time, so many times to change the shift entry.

But gradually he noticed another benefit.

Earlier, renters whose vegetables sold early would still keep wheeling the empty cart around because they had paid for the whole day.

Now they returned it sooner.

Two or three new sellers became regular evening renters.

The carts were used more, but the same stretch of time was never entered as rent twice.

One day Munna, adding the ledger, said, "Babu, the rent this month is a little higher than last month."

Bhola Sah asked, "How?"

"Earlier the carts often stood idle in the evening. Now the shifts are running."

Bhola Sah looked at the page with Sarita's name.

That month she had three mornings, twenty-three full days, and four days of rain or leave.

Munna asked, "Changing the rule did not cause a loss?"

Bhola Sah said, "The day did not become shorter. Only the entry became correct."

That evening Sarita came to return cart number five.

Showing her the ledger, Bhola Sah asked, "Going early to the wholesale market tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Chhotelal has asked for number five in the evening."

Sarita smiled.

"If my vegetables sell, the evening is his."

"And if they do not?"

“Then the full day is mine.”

Bhola Sah did not write anything yet beside “5.”

Earlier, the moment the cart was taken, the whole day was sold in the ledger.

Now the day retained the possibility of becoming two parts.

The next morning number five rolled out onto the road again.

The same four wheels, the same plank, the same white numeral.

Only the ledger had changed—and once the ledger changed, for the first time even unused time acquired a visible value.

Three Glasses of Water

In the waiting room of a small private clinic in Laheriasarai, the water dispenser stood to the right of the door.

Above the machine, in blue letters, was written: "Purified Water Free for Patients and Attendants."

Below it, in slightly smaller letters, was another line: "Twenty-Rupee Deposit for Steel Glass. Money Refunded on Return of Glass."

Seema Devi had read the first line from a distance.

She read the second only when her mother, Jagdamba Devi, asked for water.

Jagdamba Devi had been at the clinic for the past two hours: first registration, then tests, then waiting for the doctor.

Seema's ten-year-old son Neeraj was with her too.

School was closed, and there was no one at home with whom she could leave him.

"Ma, will you drink some water?" Seema asked.

Jagdamba Devi nodded.

Neeraj said at once, "Me too."

Seema searched her bag for the empty bottle.

She had filled it at home, but it had been finished halfway through the bus journey.

A young man sat beside the water counter.

In front of him were a small box of round red tokens and a receipt book.

Seema said, "We need three glasses of water."

The young man took out three red tokens.

"Sixty rupees deposit."

Seema paused.

"It says the water is free."

"The water is free. The deposit is for the glass."

"For three glasses?"

"Twenty each."

Seema opened her purse.

Inside were one hundred-rupee note, two ten-rupee notes and some coins.

Before leaving home that morning, she had calculated carefully.
The bus fare for coming had already been paid.
She needed seventy-two rupees for the journey back.
She had kept a little loose money for tea, water or some unexpected expense.

The registration fee had already been paid.

“Can we take one glass and drink from it one after another?” Seema asked.

The young man pointed to two baskets kept beside the machine.

One was marked “Washed,” the other “Used.”

“Once a glass has been used, it cannot be given again without washing. You can take one, return it, take the token, then take another.”

Seema looked at the clock.

There was no certainty when the doctor would call their number.

“Then Ma will drink first.”

She paid twenty rupees.

The young man gave her one red token and a glass.

Jagdamba Devi drank slowly.

She stopped halfway through the glass.

“Enough?” Seema asked.

“A little more later.”

All this while Neeraj kept looking towards the water machine.

“Ma, I’m very thirsty.”

Seema put the first glass into the used basket and returned the token.

“Can I get the second glass with this token?”

The young man said, “Yes, but the first deposit is still open. The glass has been returned and you have the token. The money for the token will be refunded at the accounts counter.”

Seema did not understand.

“The twenty rupees won’t be returned here?”

“No. I do not keep the money. The deposit is paid at the accounts counter.”

Seema looked at the receipt.

The receipt for the twenty rupees the young man had taken had in fact been printed from the machine at the adjacent accounts counter.

The water counter issued only the token.

“Then for the second glass I must pay another twenty?”

“If you have not yet taken the refund for the first token, yes. Otherwise, go to the accounts counter, get the refund, then come back.”

There were seven people in the queue at the accounts counter.

Seema looked at Neeraj’s face.

She took out two ten-rupee notes and paid.

Neeraj drank water and returned the glass.

A second red token came into Seema's fist.
 Seema herself had not yet had any water.
 It was hot.
 The fan was running in the waiting room, but the door opened again and again, letting the hot air from outside enter.
 Jagdamba Devi said, "You drink too."
 "I'll drink later."
 "Later you will have to stand in the queue again."
 Seema did not laugh.
 She opened her purse again.
 Breaking the hundred-rupee note, she paid a third twenty-rupee deposit.
 A third glass came into her hand.
 She drank more than half of it in one breath.
 After returning the glass, she had three red tokens in her palm.
 Sixty rupees of her money had now become tokens.
 Just then a voice called from inside:
 "Slip number one hundred and seventeen!"
 Seema's slip was one hundred and seventeen.
 Supporting her mother, she stood up.
 Neeraj picked up the bag.
 "We'll collect the money for the tokens later," Seema said.
 The young man at the water counter nodded.
 They spent fifteen minutes in the doctor's room.
 When they came out, Seema put the prescription in her bag.
 She planned to buy the medicines from the shop near home because the shop there also gave them on credit.
 The clock now showed one twenty.
 Seema had to catch the direct bus at one forty-five.
 If she missed it, the next direct bus was at four.
 In between she would have to take a tempo to the market crossing and then another bus.
 Holding the three red tokens, she went to the accounts counter.
 There were now five people in the queue.
 Ten minutes later her turn came.
 She slid the tokens beneath the glass partition.
 "Three glasses. Sixty rupees refund."
 The woman at the accounts counter looked at the tokens, then at the clock.
 "Deposit refunds after two o'clock."
 Seema thought she had perhaps heard wrongly.
 "I have returned the glasses. I have the tokens."

“Yes. But deposit refunds are made after two.”

“Why?”

“Cash reconciliation is done from one to two. During that time we issue new receipts only; no refunds.”

“I have a bus to catch.”

From behind the glass, the woman pointed to a small notice.

It really did say: “Deposit Refunds: 10-1 and 2-5.”

Seema looked at the clock.

It was one thirty-two.

“If I had come eight minutes earlier, I would have got it?”

“How would I know when you joined the queue?”

The answer belonged to the rule, not to an argument.

Even so, Seema’s face grew hot.

“I drank the water just now. I returned the glasses just now. Why must I get my money an hour later?”

“I do not make the rules.”

Jagdamba Devi sat down on a chair behind her.

Neeraj stood beside her.

Seema moved a little aside.

She opened her purse and counted again.

Fifty rupees and some coins.

The direct bus fare for three people was seventy-two.

The sixty rupees were hers, but they were not in her hand.

Jagdamba Devi asked, “How long?”

“Until two.”

“The bus?”

“One forty-five.”

Her mother said nothing.

Neeraj said, “What if I had not drunk the water?”

Seema looked at him immediately.

“Don’t say that.”

But the sentence had already been spoken.

In the waiting room, a family was buying bottled water.

The shopkeeper took twenty rupees and handed over a bottle.

No token.

No queue.

Seema looked that way for a moment.

Neeraj asked softly, “Would buying a bottle have been cheaper?”

Seema calculated.

One large bottle for all three might have cost twenty or thirty rupees.

But she did not answer.

The water was free.

At one forty, Seema went back to the accounts counter.

“I will take the sixty rupees at two, but I will miss my bus. Is there any way?”

This time the woman at the counter spoke more gently.

“Even five minutes early, I cannot reopen refunds. The cash is being counted.”

“Can I leave the tokens and send someone tomorrow?”

“The receipt is in your name. You or an authorised person.”

“I live thirty-five kilometres away.”

The woman fell silent.

Seema looked at the clock.

She decided to let the bus go.

At one forty-five, the horn of the bus sounded from the road outside.

Neeraj looked through the window.

“Our bus?”

Seema said, “Yes.”

At two the accounts counter reopened.

Seema was first in line.

Her sixty rupees were returned against the three tokens.

The woman counted the notes three times before handing them over.

“Account complete.”

Seema took the notes.

Outside, she caught a tempo.

For three people it cost thirty rupees to the market crossing.

From there, the second bus cost eighteen rupees more than the direct bus would have.

By the time they reached home, it was evening.

That night Seema opened her small expense notebook.

She recorded every journey: bus, clinic, medicine, tea—how much money had gone where.

She wrote:

“Glass deposit — 60. Refunded — 60.”

She paused.

Under it she wrote:

“Bus missed. Extra fare — 48.”

Neeraj was studying beside her.

He asked, “Then was the water free, or did it cost forty-eight rupees?”

Seema stopped her pen.

“The water was free.”

“Then the forty-eight?”

“Not the price of the water. The price of time.”

Neeraj understood some of it and some he did not.

Two weeks later Seema received a call from the clinic.

“Did you write something in the suggestion book on your last visit?”

Seema remembered.

When collecting the deposit at two, she had written one line:

“Do not suspend refunding money at a time when a returned glass has just been handed back.”

The caller was the manager.

He asked, “Was there some difficulty in returning the glass?”

“Not with the glass. With the money.”

Seema told him the whole story.

Halfway through, the manager said, “But the deposit was refunded in full?”

Seema did not interrupt him.

She let him finish the sentence.

“—so there was no monetary loss?” the manager asked.

Seema said, “Not in the deposit account. There was in the account of getting home.”

For a few moments there was silence on the phone.

Seema added, “For someone who has more money in their purse, this is only one hour. For me, in that one hour those sixty rupees were the bus fare.”

The manager said only, “All right.”

Seema did not expect anything to change.

Three months later Jagdamba Devi had to visit the same clinic again.

This time Seema brought two bottles of water from home.

When they entered the waiting room, she looked instinctively towards the water counter.

The blue sign was still there: “Water Free.”

The line below it had changed.

“Glass deposit: twenty rupees. Return the glass; refund immediately here.”

There was now a small cash box at the water counter.

The receipt machine from the accounts desk was no longer involved.

The tokens were still red.

Seema left the bottles in her bag.

Jagdamba Devi said, “Shall I drink some water?”

Seema took one glass.

She paid twenty rupees.

Her mother drank.

The glass was returned.

The twenty rupees came back there and then.

Neeraj was not with them this time.

Seema put the note back in her purse.

The whole exchange had perhaps not taken even a minute.

She read the blue sign once more.

The water had been free before as well.

The only thing that had changed was that between the returning money and the returning person, there were no longer two counters and an hour.

The Line for a Name

On the veranda of Belahi Middle School, the relief register hung from a rope against a damp wall.

It consisted of four pages.

Across the top, in large letters, was written: "Flood Camp: Members Present by Household."

Below were the household number, the name of the head of the household, and the number of members.

Manjari Devi stood beside the second page with her mother-in-law, Devaki Devi.

Devaki Devi ran her finger down the lines until she found: "Raghunath Mandal."

There were four boxes in that row.

In the first: Raghunath Mandal.

In the second: Devaki Devi.

In the third: Ramesh Mandal.

The fourth box was blank.

Devaki Devi read it again.

"Where has your name gone?"

Manjari let go of the rope holding the edge of the page.

"It should have been here."

"After Ramesh?"

"Yes."

Inside the veranda, people were receiving small packets of flattened rice, jaggery, candles and matches.

The number of people written on a family slip determined the quantity issued.

This was not a permanent assistance scheme.

It was a temporary distribution arranged jointly by the block administration, the school and the local committee for the first three days of the flood.

Raghunath Mandal's slip said three.

There were four people in the household.

Manjari had married into this family six months earlier.

Two weeks after the wedding, beside her name in her parental household register at Satlakha, someone had written in red ink: "Transferred."

Ramesh had submitted an application to add her name at her marital home in Belahi.

At the time, the village employee had said, "It will be added in the regular revision."

Ramesh had thought: what difference can two or three months make?

The difference appeared when the Kamla River rose overnight, crossed the courtyard, and reached the rooms.

The first boat had brought all four of them—Raghunath Mandal, Devaki Devi, Ramesh and Manjari—to the middle school.

The young boatman had written all four names in his register.

But the relief register had been prepared not from the boat register, but from the household register.

Manjari said to Devaki Devi, "Take the slip. I'll ask."

Naresh Babu was seated at the distribution table.

In front of him lay three ledgers, a red pen and a counting stamp.

Manjari placed the three-person slip before him.

"There are four of us in the household."

Naresh Babu looked at the slip.

"The list says three."

"My name has been left out."

"The list was made from what is in the household register."

Manjari took a transparent pouch from her bag.

Inside were a copy of her marriage registration, the transfer slip, and the receipt for the application to add her name in Belahi.

Naresh Babu examined the receipt.

"The application has been made. The name has not yet been added."

"Then am I here or not?"

Naresh Babu raised his head.

"You are here. On paper, you are not here yet."

An old man standing behind her tried to laugh at the sentence, but the laugh did not come out.

Manjari too said nothing.

Naresh Babu said, "Show it at the records table. If they make a correction, I will change the count."

The records table was at the other end of the veranda.

There Ganesh Babu was spreading old newspapers to dry damp papers.

Manjari placed the receipt before him.

"My application to add my name is under this number."

Ganesh Babu searched for the number.
 He opened a thick register.
 He found the page for Raghunath Mandal's household.
 After the three names there really was an empty line.
 At the left of that blank line, in small pencil writing, were the words: "New member — Application 178."
 The space for the name was blank.
 Manjari kept looking at that empty space.
 "My name can be written here."
 Ganesh Babu took a pen in his hand, then stopped.
 "I am not authorised to make an interim change in the permanent register. The application will be entered in the next regular revision."
 "Will the flood wait for the regular revision?"
 Ganesh Babu was silent for a few moments.
 "No."
 "Then who is this blank line for?"
 "For the application."
 "And me?"
 Ganesh Babu did not close the register.
 "I understand your difficulty. But I cannot change the permanent register now."
 By then Manjari's mother-in-law had reached the table.
 She was holding the packet issued for three people.
 Devaki Devi said, "Whatever is here, we will divide into four. Why are you running around for a name?"
 Manjari said softly, "Flattened rice can be divided into four. A name cannot."
 Devaki Devi looked at her face.
 "The name will be added later."
 "The water did not come later."
 Outside the veranda, the rain grew heavier again.
 The school field was under knee-deep water.
 Manjari looked once more at the page of the register.
 The blank line was still there, with its pencil note.
 Ganesh Babu said, "Can you show the register entry from your parental home?"
 "I have a copy."
 Manjari handed him the transfer slip.
 It carried the old household number from Satlakha and a date below it.
 Ganesh Babu read: "Name removed: Manjari Kumari. Reason: transferred after marriage."

“Your name is no longer there?”

“No.”

“Here the application exists, but the name does not.”

“Yes.”

“Then on paper you are somewhere in between.”

Manjari said, “I am not somewhere in between. I am at home.”

Ganesh Babu fell silent again.

By afternoon three more cases of the same kind had appeared.

An elderly man’s name was still attached to his old house, though the river had cut that house away and he now lived with his son.

A labourer’s family had returned from a brick kiln the previous month, but two children had not yet been added to the household register.

For one newborn, the space for the name contained only the word “infant.”

Ganesh Babu kept the papers for all these cases separately.

Manjari returned to the schoolroom where her mother-in-law was sitting.

Raghunath Mandal was dividing the flattened rice into four small piles.

Of the three pieces of jaggery issued for three people, Devaki Devi broke one again to make four shares.

Ramesh said, “I won’t eat. Let three people eat.”

Manjari immediately pushed one pile towards him.

“My name is missing. Why should your hunger be missing?”

Ramesh smiled, but kept looking at the empty side of the packet.

In the evening the boatman himself came to the school.

He had come to reconcile the numbers—how many people had been brought by boat and how many were still in the camp.

His name was Shambhu.

While checking his register, Ganesh Babu suddenly stopped.

“How many people were in the boat for Raghunath Mandal’s household?”

Shambhu turned the pages.

“Four.”

“Names?”

Shambhu read: “Raghunath Mandal, Devaki Devi, Ramesh Mandal, Manjari Devi.”

Ganesh Babu looked at Manjari.

Manjari said nothing.

Shambhu asked, “Is something wrong?”

Ganesh Babu said, “Three in the household register. Four in the boat register.”

Shambhu replied matter-of-factly, “A boat counts people, not household registers.”

This time Ganesh Babu gave a faint smile.

"That is exactly the point."

He called Naresh Babu over.

Three registers were placed on the table: the household register, the boat register and the relief register.

Naresh Babu said, "We cannot alter the permanent household register. The relief list is copied from it."

Ganesh Babu asked, "Is the relief list itself a permanent register?"

"No."

"Then can we make a separate register of the people actually present in the camp?"

Naresh Babu read the heading printed on the paper: "Members Present by Household."

"Members present..." he repeated softly.

Shambhu pushed his boat register forward.

"Everyone I brought was present."

Ganesh Babu took out a blank notebook.

On the first page he wrote: "Temporary Camp Attendance Register — Not a Revision of the Permanent Household Register."

Below it he made three columns: "Name," "Basis of Presence in Camp," "Status in Permanent Register."

The first name was Manjari Devi.

In the second column: "Boat Register — Entry 26."

In the third: "Application 178 to add name to household register — pending."

Ganesh Babu held the pen out to Manjari.

"Sign here."

Manjari signed beneath her name.

Naresh Babu crossed out the three on the old relief slip and wrote four.

Beside the corrected number he put his small signature.

Devaki Devi looked at the slip.

"Four now?"

"Four for this camp."

"And the household register?"

"That will be done in the next revision."

Devaki Devi said, "Three registers for one name."

Ganesh Babu replied, "One register moved ahead of time, another stayed behind it. For the days in between, we had to make a third."

Manjari folded the slip and put it in her bag.

The rain did not stop that night.

But as new people arrived at the camp, their names began to be entered first in the boat register and then in the temporary attendance register.

Within two days the new register contained eighteen names.

For some, the permanent list still showed an old household; for some, a child's name was pending; for others, the papers had dissolved in floodwater.

No one was treated as a permanent household member merely because of the temporary entry.

It recorded only that on a certain day a certain person was present in a certain camp, and the basis on which that presence was established.

Manjari's name remained on the first line.

On the fifth day the water began to recede.

On the tenth day Raghunath Mandal's family returned home.

There was silt in the courtyard.

The cots were put out in the sun to dry.

Two sacks of grain had spoiled.

Life returned to the small calculations of the household.

The transfer slip went back into the iron trunk.

The relief slip was put there with it.

Manjari's name was still not in the permanent household register.

Three weeks later notice came for the regular revision.

Ramesh and Manjari went to the village office.

Ganesh Babu opened the same thick register.

On Raghunath Mandal's page, after the three old names, the same blank line remained.

The pencil note "New member — Application 178" had faded slightly.

With a blue pen Ganesh Babu wrote: "Manjari Devi."

In the relationship column he wrote: "Daughter-in-law."

He entered the date.

He took Manjari's signature.

Ramesh said, "Now it is right."

Manjari kept looking at the page.

"Yes. Now it is right."

Outside, the school veranda had long since dried.

The relief table had been removed.

The Temporary Camp Attendance Register had been tied up and placed in an office cupboard.

On the first line of that register, Manjari's name had been written from the days of the flood.

Her name entered the permanent household register only after the water had receded long before.

The Crop Sample

The gate of the Barhi paddy procurement centre had opened before seven in the morning.

In the December fog, bullock carts, small tractors and handcarts were entering one after another.

On a bamboo board to the right of the gate, a sheet of paper was pinned:
“First registration, then inspection, then weighing.”

Kiran Devi had come to the centre for the third time with her fourteen sacks of paddy.

On the previous two occasions her crop had been purchased without any difficulty.

This time a new long brass sampling probe lay on the inspection table.

Its front end was narrow and pointed; at the back was a small tube.

Inspection assistant Nandkishor stopped the first sack.

He pushed the probe into the middle of the sack, twisted it slightly, then pulled it out.

A small stream of paddy fell from the tube into a brass bowl.

Kiran watched.

The second sack.

Then the third.

From each sack, roughly a quarter of a handful of grain fell into the bowl.

From time to time Nandkishor pressed the grains between his fingers.

“The moisture seems fine,” he said.

Kiran asked, “Will this paddy go back into the sack?”

Without looking up, Nandkishor replied, “No. It is the sample.”

“Then where does it go?”

“For testing.”

Kiran moved on.

At the time the matter did not seem particularly important.

All fourteen sacks passed under the probe.

Then the sacks went to the weighing table.

Each weight was written down.

Numbers were marked on the sacks in blue chalk.

She received her slip.

Putting it into her bag, she moved towards the line for payment processing.

Behind her, Harinarayan Yadav had reached the inspection table with nine sacks.

When grain from his first sack fell into the bowl, he laughed and said, "If this much comes out in testing, the birds at the centre will grow fat."

Nandkishor laughed too.

"The birds won't eat it, Kaka. It is testing grain."

"And while you go on testing, where does the grain end up?"

"In the sample bucket."

Nandkishor pointed to a blue bucket under the table.

It was half full.

Standing in the payment line, Kiran looked again at the bucket.

Not that many people had arrived yet that morning.

Still, half a bucket.

Kamala Devi, standing ahead of her, was folding her slip.

Kiran asked, "How many sacks did you bring?"

"Eleven."

"They took a sample from every sack?"

"Yes."

Kamala Devi looked at her with mild surprise.

"Why?"

"Nothing. I am just looking."

The payment itself was not going to be made immediately.

Slips were being deposited and names entered for bank payment.

Kiran went outside and sat near the tea seller.

The sun was beginning to rise through the fog.

By ten o'clock the centre courtyard was full of sacks.

When the blue bucket beside the inspection table filled, Nandkishor lifted it and carried it into the room at the back.

Kiran stood up almost without thinking.

She did not go as far as the room, but the open doorway gave a clear view inside.

Nandkishor was pouring the paddy from the bucket into a white sack.

In black letters the sack was marked: "Sample Residue."

The question rose again in Kiran's mind.

She went to the inspection table.

"Whose white sack is that?"

Nandkishor said, "The centre's."

"The paddy?"

"From the samples."

“Whose samples?”
 For the first time Nandkishor paused.
 “Everyone’s.”
 Kiran said, “Then how is the sack the centre’s?”
 Nandkishor smiled.
 “If all are the parents, is the child the centre’s?”
 People standing nearby laughed.
 Kiran smiled too.
 “I am not joking. I want to understand.”
 By then the centre’s accounts assistant, Shashibhushan, had also come over.
 He said, “The sample is taken for testing. It is a very small amount.”
 Kiran asked, “Does weighing happen first or sampling first?”
 “Sampling first. That way the quality of the grain can be judged properly.”
 “Then the sacks are weighed?”
 “Yes.”
 “Then the grain that has gone into the sample is not included in the weight on the farmer’s slip?”
 Shashibhushan was silent for a moment.
 “It is a very small amount.”
 Kiran said, “I understand that it is small. What I do not understand is whose it is.”
 Harinarayan Yadav left his sacks and came over.
 “Now I understand the question too.”
 Shashibhushan said, “Only a few grams come out of each sack. It is not right to stop the work over this.”
 Kiran replied, “Do not stop the work. Just show the account.”
 “What account?”
 “Is sampling the centre’s work or the farmer’s?”
 “It is the centre’s inspection.”
 “Then why is the paddy used for the inspection left outside the farmer’s recorded weight?”
 A few more people gathered in the courtyard.
 No one spoke loudly.
 The question was small, but the answer was not equally simple.
 The centre supervisor, Rampravesh Babu, was informed.
 He came to the inspection table carrying a thick register.
 “What happened?”
 Shashibhushan explained briefly.
 Rampravesh Babu looked at Kiran.
 “You do not want to give a sample?”
 “I will. How can the centre buy without testing?”

“Then?”

“I will give the sample, but its weight should exist in someone’s account too.”

Rampravesh Babu said, “All the farmers’ samples get mixed later. Returning each one separately is not possible.”

“I am not asking for it to be returned.”

“Then?”

Kiran did not pick up the probe lying on the table. She only pointed towards it.

“This testing tool belongs to the centre.”

“Yes.”

“The bowl belongs to the centre.”

“Yes.”

“The moisture meter belongs to the centre.”

“Yes.”

“Then why is the cost of the paddy taken out for testing silently excluded from the farmer’s weight?”

Rampravesh Babu opened the register.

It had columns for purchase weight, moisture, impurities, rate and total amount.

There was no column called “sample.”

He turned the page.

There was none there either.

Shashibhushan said quietly, “The rule says a sample has to be taken. There is no separate weight column for it.”

Harinarayan said, “So if there is no column for something, the thing does not exist?”

Rampravesh Babu did not signal him to keep quiet.

He asked Nandkishor, “About how much comes out of one sack?”

“It is not always the same. It depends on the grain and the probe. Twenty to twenty-five grams, sometimes more.”

“How many sacks have been tested today?”

Nandkishor checked the register.

“Two hundred and twelve.”

Kiran looked at the blue bucket.

Rampravesh Babu looked too.

“Weigh the white sack.”

Nandkishor went inside.

The white sack was brought out.

It was not full; a great deal of space remained at the top.

It was placed on a small scale.

The needle stopped near four kilos eight hundred grams.

No one said anything.

Rampravesh Babu said, "This belongs to all the farmers. Fine."

Kiran said, "And now it is impossible to know how much belonged to each farmer."

"Yes."

"Then when the samples were mixed, the owner's name disappeared."

Shashibhushan said, "Keeping a separate account for such a small portion would be difficult."

Kiran took out her slip.

"Do not keep separate accounts. Change the order."

"What order?"

"Weigh first. Then take the sample."

For a few moments the courtyard was silent.

Rampravesh Babu said, "Then a little less paddy than the slip shows will reach the centre's store."

"Because the centre is doing the testing."

"You mean the weight of the sample should be treated as the centre's testing expense?"

"I am only asking one thing: whose cost is the test?"

Harinarayan wiped his forehead with the end of his dhoti.

"If weighing happens first, I get a slip for my full weight. The sample taken afterward goes into the centre's inspection."

Kamala Devi too came away from the line.

"And if you return the sample to the farmer's sack, will that spoil the purpose of the test?"

Nandkishor said, "After all the samples are mixed, returning them would not be right. We would not know whose grain went into whose sack."

"Then do not return it," Kamala Devi said. "Just record the weight first."

Rampravesh Babu did not decide immediately.

He looked at the distance from the inspection table to the weighing table.

There were about twenty cubits between them.

Until then, sacks were inspected first, then weighed, then stitched.

If the order were reversed, the sacks would be weighed first, then inspected, then stitched.

Rampravesh Babu called over a warehouse employee.

"Try it with twenty sacks today."

"Now?"

"Now."

The next farmer's five sacks went first to the weighing table.

The weights were recorded.

Then the sacks came to the inspection table.
 The probe went in.
 Paddy fell into the bowl.
 The sacks went for stitching.
 Shashibhushan matched the slips with the warehouse register.
 The five sacks were complete.
 Then the next seven.
 Then eight.
 Twenty sacks were completed.
 The inspection had taken out slightly less than half a kilo of paddy in all.
 Rampravesh Babu said, "This half kilo will now be treated as the centre's inspection sample."
 Shashibhushan asked, "The warehouse account?"
 "Make a separate column: 'Inspection Sample.'"
 "There is no such column in the prescribed register."
 "Add an extra page. Do not deduct it from the purchase weight."
 Kiran said nothing.
 She only kept looking at her old slip.
 Rampravesh Babu said, "We cannot reweigh the farmers whose sacks were already inspected today."
 Kiran nodded.
 "What happened today has happened. From the next sack onward, let the order be right."
 Rampravesh Babu had the board at the gate taken down.
 The old paper said: "First registration, then inspection, then weighing."
 With a black pen he exchanged the positions of "inspection" and "weighing."
 The new line read: "First registration, then weighing, then inspection."
 The handwriting was not neat, but the order was clear.
 After noon, the centre began moving quickly again.
 Kiran was preparing to leave with her payment slip.
 At that moment Nandkishor brought out a new white sack.
 Instead of the old label "Sample Residue," this one was marked:
 "Inspection Sample — Centre."
 The date was written below.
 On the extra page, Shashibhushan made the first entry.
 "Inspection Sample: Centre's Expense."
 Harinarayan read it and said, "Now the child has found a father."
 People laughed.
 Nandkishor did too.
 Kiran said, "Not a father. It has found an expense column."

By evening, one hundred and seventy-seven sacks had been purchased under the new order.

No separate deduction for sampling was made from anyone's weighed quantity.

Inspection continued exactly as before.

The moisture meter kept showing its numbers as before.

The probe kept entering the body of each sack as before.

The only change was that the grain emerging from the probe now fell into the bowl after the farmer's weight had already been recorded.

Three days later Kiran came to the centre again.

Her neighbour's paddy was to be sold.

A new clean notice had been posted at the gate:

"Registration → Weighing → Inspection → Stitching."

Behind the inspection table stood three small white sacks in order.

Each was marked with a date and the words "Centre Inspection Sample."

Shashibhushan was filling in the new column in the register.

Kiran asked, "Was it difficult?"

"A little on the first day."

"And now?"

"Now people are getting used to it."

"The warehouse account?"

"Testing expense separate. Purchase weight separate."

Kiran looked at the probe lying on the table.

It was the same old probe.

The same bowl.

The same scale.

The paddy still came out by the handful in exactly the same way.

The only difference was that the handful now fell on the other side of the weighing.

The Small Awning

For five years, Mamta Devi had been living as a tenant in the rear portion of an old two-storey house in Laheriasarai, Darbhanga.

Along with her room, she had a small kitchen, a narrow veranda and an iron door opening into the courtyard.

There had originally been nothing directly above the door.

In summer, that meant little.

In the rains, it meant a great deal.

Water from the edge of the roof fell directly in front of the doorway, and when the wind was strong, half of it splashed inside.

For the first two monsoons Mamta managed with buckets, old sacks and a mop.

In the third year she slipped.

That day she had turned near the doorway carrying a pot of milk.

Her foot landed on a mossy brick and her body struck the wall beside her.

The pot was saved, but her elbow hurt for two weeks.

After that Mamta said to her husband Vinod, “We need some kind of cover here.”

Vinod was an electrician.

He was out all day and usually did small repairs at home on Sundays.

He measured the wall.

“It will not project more than two cubits,” he said.

“Just enough to protect the doorway.”

Shambhu, a tinsmith from the neighbouring lane, was called.

He brought an old but sturdy strip of blue sheet metal.

Two iron brackets, four screws, a narrow gutter and the sheet—that was all it took to make the awning.

Water stopped falling directly before the door and began running into the old drain on the right.

Mamta paid the cost.

At the time, the landlord, Shivkant Jha, was living in Madhubani with his younger son.

His elder daughter Kalpana came once a month to collect the rent.

The awning was installed.
One monsoon passed, then another.
For Mamta, the blue sheet gradually became like a part of the house.
In the morning the milkman would set his vessel beneath it.
The children put on their shoes there before leaving for school.
Sometimes a bag of vegetables would hang there for two minutes to keep it out of the rain.
Even so, the awning was not large.
If two people stood beneath it together, one person's shoulder remained outside.
In Jeth of the fifth year, Shivkant Jha returned to live permanently in the house.
He was close to seventy.
The upper floor was empty, so he began inspecting the paint, drains, electrical wires and cracks in the walls one by one.
One morning his eyes went to the space above Mamta's door.
He stopped.
"Whose tin sheet is this?"
Mamta was wringing clothes in the courtyard.
"I had it put up."
"With whose permission?"
The question was not loud, but it was direct.
Mamta put the clothes back in the bucket.
"Rainwater used to come inside. You were not living here then."
"Did you tell Kalpana?"
Mamta thought for a moment.
"She saw it. She did not stop us."
Shivkant went up to the wall.
Where the iron bracket had been fixed with screws, a fine line showed at the edge of the plaster.
He touched it with his finger.
"Look at this. The wall is cracked."
When Vinod returned that evening, the matter came up again.
Shivkant said, "If every tenant starts drilling into the walls as they please, how will the house survive?"
Vinod remained calm.
"There are only four screw holes. Shambhu filled around them with mortar when he fitted it."
"Four today. Tomorrow someone else will make six. A third person will fasten a pipe. There has to be one rule."
Vinod did not immediately find an answer.

The house was not his.
Nor was the wall.
Shivkant said again, "Have it removed on Sunday. I will get the plaster repaired."
Mamta looked towards the kitchen door.
"The rains are about to begin."
"I am having the roof drain cleaned. Water will not fall there."
"What about the rain that blows in with the wind?"
Shivkant was silent for a moment.
"A house cannot run forever on little awnings. It needs proper repair."
Mamta did not think the sentence was wrong.
But she also remembered that for the past two monsoons, without any proper repair, that small awning had kept the house usable.
On Sunday Shambhu came.
He put oil on the screw heads.
The first screw came out easily.
The second was stuck.
Shambhu said, "Didi, if we remove it carefully, the sheet will survive. You can use it somewhere else later."
Shivkant stood on the veranda.
"The sheet is hers. The wall is mine. Save both."
Mamta said nothing to that.
Shambhu removed two brackets, but the work was not completed by evening.
One side of the sheet was tied up temporarily with a rope.
"I'll take it down completely tomorrow morning," Shambhu said.
At ten that night, the wind changed.
First lightning flashed in the distance.
Then rain suddenly began so heavily that the house opposite blurred from sight.
Mamta had already shut the door.
Five minutes later the first splash landed on the kitchen floor.
She quickly pulled out an old sack.
Because the sheet had been tied halfway up, the roof water was not falling directly at the doorway as before, but wind-driven rain was slanting in.
Vinod went outside.
There was not knee-deep water in the courtyard, but the drain was full.
The mouth of the narrow drain that had for years caught the water on the right side of the awning was blocked with leaves.
Vinod took a short piece of bamboo and cleared them away.
The water rushed out.

Just then Shivkant's voice came from the upper veranda.

"Vinod!"

"Yes!"

"Water is coming into the rear room."

The rear room was Shivkant's storeroom.

It was built beside Mamta's kitchen, on the other side of the same outer wall.

Vinod went with a torch.

Dark wet lines were climbing the lower portion of the wall.

An old wooden chest stood in one corner.

The floor beneath it was wet.

Shivkant moved the chest aside.

"Why from here?"

Vinod inspected the outside wall.

Where Mamta's small awning had previously projected, the plaster was relatively dry.

Where the sheet had been raised that day, rain was beating against the wall.

Not runoff from the roof—the wind was driving the rain sideways.

The water was running down and collecting near the foundation.

Shivkant moved the torch beam across the wall.

On the old white plaster two colours were clearly visible: one pale, one dark.

Vinod said, "Look. Where the awning used to be, the wall is less wet."

Shivkant did not agree immediately.

"One night proves nothing."

"That is true."

"Water may also be entering through the screw holes."

"That may be true too."

For a few moments both men simply watched the rain.

It showed no sign of easing.

At last Shivkant said, "Move the chest up. Tomorrow I'll call a mason."

The next morning the courtyard was full of moss, leaves and broken flowers.

Shambhu did not come.

The rain had held up another job of his.

Shivkant called Jagdish, a mason.

Jagdish first examined the wet wall from inside, then went outside.

He bent down and inspected the first four courses of brick.

At one place the mortar had crumbled away.

At another there was a dark stain showing that water had stood there.

He examined the awning brackets too.

“The screws are not wrong, but the filling around them was not done properly,” he said.

Shivkant asked, “Should the awning be removed or not?”

Jagdish did not laugh.

He measured the edge of the sheet, the drain and the way the wall met them.

“This sheet keeps water off. But it is not a permanent solution for the house.”

Mamta stood by the doorway.

“Then?”

“We will refill the mortar at the bottom of the wall. Above, we will make an edge to throw water away from the wall. The screw holes will be sealed properly. And if the awning remains, its slope must be corrected towards the drain.”

Shivkant said, “My fear is that tomorrow every tenant will start attaching something or other.”

Putting his hammer back into his bag, Jagdish said, “Then make a rule for additions. Rain does not come after reading rules.”

Vinod smiled slightly at that sentence.

Shivkant did not.

By afternoon, the lower mortar had been opened up.

While scraping away the old damp portion, Jagdish stopped at one place.

“Look at this.”

There was an old fine crack in the brick joint.

The crack was not new.

The dust and blackness inside showed that it had been receiving water for years.

Mamta asked, “From my screws?”

Jagdish shook his head.

“The screws are above. This crack below is old.”

Shivkant stood silently beside the wall.

He knew the history of his old house better than Mamta did, but no one fully knew the history inside the wall.

That evening Shambhu arrived.

“Shall I remove it?”

Shivkant said, “Not yet.”

Shambhu looked at Vinod.

Vinod said nothing.

Shivkant pointed towards the sheet.

“First put it back properly. Fill the mortar well around the screws. Keep the mouth of the drain open. Give it a little more slope.”

Mamta asked, "And the plan to remove it?"

"We will see later."

That answer was not a victory.

Mamta had not expected one.

Two days later Shivkant brought a notebook.

On the cover he wrote: "House Repairs and Additions."

On the first page he made three headings:

"House Structure."

"Tenant's Property."

"Shared Maintenance."

Shivkant called Vinod.

"Whose property is this awning?"

"The tin sheet is mine," Vinod said.

"The wall?"

"Yours."

"The drain?"

Vinod thought for a moment.

"The house's."

"Who will clean it?"

From inside, Mamta said, "Whoever sees the leaves will remove them."

For the first time Shivkant smiled.

"How do I write that in the register?"

Mamta came outside.

"The drain belongs to the house. The leaves belong to everyone."

Shambhu burst out laughing.

Shivkant wrote: "Drain — shared cleaning."

In the line for the awning he wrote:

"Tin sheet belongs to tenant; additions only with landlord's permission; sealing around screw points and external wall repair are landlord's responsibility."

Vinod read it.

"If we leave the house?"

"You may remove the sheet. I will have the holes filled, provided ordinary removal does not damage the wall."

"If you want the awning removed?"

Shivkant paused.

"Not before the rains. And I will record the reason."

To Mamta, the notebook mattered more than the awning in that answer.

The awning projected only two cubits.

The three headings in the notebook could extend much farther.

The following week heavy rain came again.

This time the sheet was fully in place.
Water drummed on its blue surface and fell towards the drain.
The kitchen doorway remained dry.
So did the wall of the adjoining storeroom.
Shivkant came twice with a torch to inspect it.
The third time Mamta said, "Still checking?"
"The house is old. Checking is not a bad thing."
He bent down and removed two leaves from the mouth of the drain.
Mamta said nothing.
After the rain stopped, two children stood beneath the awning putting on their shoes.
Shivkant did not move them away.
He only ran his hand over the lower part of the wall.
The plaster was dry.
Then he looked up at the sheet.
The small awning still belonged to Mamta.
The wall still belonged to Shivkant.
But the rain that fell between those two things that night had made it difficult to write everything under only one person's name.

The Bar of Soap

At a women's hostel in Darbhanga, soap was distributed on the first Saturday of every month.

The rule was very old.

One student, one bar of bathing soap.

The hostel had twenty-four rooms.

Almost every room housed two students.

So for Kusum Jha, the store clerk, the arithmetic was very simple: twenty-four rooms, two students in each, forty-eight bars in all.

The monthly requisition was prepared on that basis.

The supplies arrived on that basis.

And on distribution day, twenty-four small paper packets were made, with two bars in each.

Kusum liked the arrangement.

Write the room number on the packet, take a signature, work finished.

This month too, at ten in the morning, a long table was set up on the hostel veranda.

Four boxes of soap stood on it.

Twelve bars in each box.

Four boxes—forty-eight.

Kusum opened the boxes and arranged the bars in order.

Every bar, wrapped in pink paper, was the same size.

Beside them lay the open distribution register.

The first line read: Room 1.

The last: Room 24.

The superintendent, Kaushalya Devi, sat on a chair.

She lowered her glasses slightly on her nose and looked at the register.

"Begin."

The representative from Room 1 came forward.

She took two bars.

She signed.

Room 2.

Two bars.

Signature.

Room 3.

In this way the line moved forward.

Kusum had no worry about the count.

There were exactly as many bars in the boxes as there were in the register.

Ranjana from Room 5 came.

She turned away carrying two bars in one hand.

A student standing behind her laughed.

“Taking two at once?”

Ranjana laughed too.

“There are two of us in my room.”

“Where is the other one?”

“She has a fever. She’s in bed.”

The matter ended there.

No one knew then that, a little later, those same two bars would become a subject of discussion again.

By noon, supplies had been distributed to twenty-three rooms.

Only two bars remained on the table.

Kusum turned the page of the register.

“Room twenty-four.”

Three students came forward.

The first was Prabha.

The second, Sonali.

The third, Meenakshi.

Kusum stopped her hand.

“Three of you?”

Prabha said, “Yes.”

“In this room?”

“Yes.”

Kusum looked at the register.

It contained only the number: 24.

No names.

Only the room number and a blank space for a signature.

“There are two bars.”

Prabha thought Kusum was joking.

“There are three of us.”

“The register provides for two.”

Meenakshi said softly, “I came here ten days ago.”

Kusum looked at her.

“Where were you before?”

"I am a new admission. There was no space, so a third cot was put in this room."

Kaushalya Devi rose from her chair.

"Are the supplies short?"

Putting the two bars on the table, Kusum said, "By one bar."

The voices of the students standing on the veranda grew a little quieter.

Someone said, "Someone must have received extra."

Another voice said, "Forty-eight came, didn't they?"

Kusum answered at once, "Four boxes. Twelve each. I counted them myself."

"Then where did one bar go?"

After that question, everyone's eyes began moving towards one another's hands, bags and rooms.

Ranjana was standing at the other end of the veranda.

Someone said quietly, "I saw Ranjana take two at once."

Ranjana heard it.

She immediately came forward.

"Neelima is in my room too. She has a fever."

"I only said I saw you take two."

"If the rule says two are due, does taking two become theft?"

The veranda fell silent again.

Kaushalya Devi raised her hand.

"No one's bag will be checked. No one's room will be searched."

She turned towards Kusum.

"Look at the papers first."

Kusum did not like that suggestion.

She trusted her count.

Even so, she took the storeroom key and went inside.

A little later she returned carrying three papers.

The first was the goods receipt.

Four boxes of bathing soap.

Twelve bars in each.

Total: forty-eight.

The second was the monthly requisition.

On it was Kusum's own handwriting:

" $24 \text{ rooms} \times 2 = 48$."

The third was the distribution register.

Room 1 through Room 24.

Kaushalya Devi placed all three papers together on the table.

"Bring the residents' register."

Kusum went inside again.

This time she returned with a thick register.
 That register contained names.
 Room 1—two names.
 Room 2—two names.
 And so on.
 At Room 24 there were three names.
 Prabha Kumari.
 Sonali Jha.
 Meenakshi Yadav.
 Beside Meenakshi's name, in blue ink, was written: "Admission: 10 days ago."
 Kaushalya Devi put her finger on the line.
 "How many residents in all?"
 Before answering, Kusum began counting the register.
 One, two, three...
 Some of the students also began counting silently along with her.
 At last Kusum said, "Forty-nine."
 Kaushalya Devi lifted the requisition.
 "How many bars of soap were requested?"
 "Forty-eight."
 "Why?"
 Kusum looked at the paper.
 "Twenty-four rooms... two each."
 "But how many students?"
 "Forty-nine."
 For a few moments no one spoke.
 The two bars were still lying on the table.
 Meenakshi stood beside them.
 Kaushalya Devi said slowly, "No bar of soap has gone missing."
 Ranjana looked towards Kusum.
 Kusum looked at Meenakshi's name.
 Meenakshi kept looking at the requisition lying on the table.
 There had never been any space on that paper for her name.
 Prabha said, "Then the three of us can share the two bars. It will be corrected next month."
 Meenakshi said at once, "I still have some of my old bar left. I do not need one today."
 Kaushalya Devi shook her head.
 "This is not about one bar of soap."
 She placed her finger on the requisition.
 "The point is that our calculation counts rooms, not people."

Kusum became slightly uncomfortable.

"It has been done this way for years."

"For years, perhaps every room had two students."

"Most of the time."

"Monthly supplies cannot be distributed on the strength of 'most of the time.'"

This time none of the students laughed.

Kaushalya Devi turned towards Ranjana.

"Your name being raised in the middle of this was not right."

Ranjana replied, "It was not just one person who raised it. Everyone thought someone had taken extra."

"Why did they think that?"

"Because the paper said the supplies were complete."

Kaushalya Devi said, "And the paper was incomplete."

Kusum pulled the distribution register towards herself.

It had twenty-four lines.

Twenty-four lines for forty-nine people.

For the first time, she saw the difference so clearly on paper.

"We will make a new register," she said.

Kaushalya Devi asked, "How?"

Kusum thought for a moment.

"The room number will remain, but there will be one line for each student."

"And the requisition?"

"The resident count will be checked one day before distribution."

"New admissions?"

"Added."

"Those who leave?"

"Removed."

"Three students in one room?"

This time Kusum smiled.

"Three lines."

The atmosphere on the veranda lightened slightly.

Meenakshi smiled too.

But the immediate problem on the table remained unchanged: two bars, three students.

Kaushalya Devi took out a small expense slip from the hostel office.

"One bar will be purchased today from the local cooperative shop."

Kusum asked, "Under whose name?"

Kaushalya Devi said, "Hostel supply correction. Not anyone's private donation."

Meenakshi liked that.
She did not want charity.
She only wanted the item that everyone was entitled to under the rule.
In the afternoon, an employee brought one bar of soap from the cooperative shop.

Kusum attached its receipt to the requisition.
Then she prepared the first sample page of the new distribution register.
The first column: serial number.
The second: student's name.
The third: room number.
The fourth: item.
The fifth: signature.
Kusum wrote Meenakshi's name.
Serial number 49.

Room 24.
Bathing soap — 1.
Meenakshi signed.
Passing along the veranda, Ranjana stopped.
She looked at the register.

"Where is my name?"
Kusum turned to the first page.
"Serial number 9."
Ranjana said, "And Neelima?"
"10."

"Then if I carry two bars away in one hand now?"
For the first time, Kusum smiled openly.
"There will be two marks beside two names. Then no one will suspect anything."

One day before the next month's distribution, Kaushalya Devi herself checked the residents' register.

By then one student had completed her examination and left the hostel.
Another new student had arrived.
The total was again forty-nine.
But on the requisition Kusum did not write " 24×2 ."
She wrote: "Active residents: 49."
A list of names was attached below it.
On Saturday the same long table was again set up on the veranda.
Again, bars of soap wrapped in pink paper were arranged in rows.
This time, before counting the soap, Kusum counted the lines.
From one to forty-nine.
Then she counted the bars.

From one to forty-nine.

Meenakshi now came as the representative for Room 24.

Kusum did not simply hand her three bars together.

She read all three names.

Prabha—one.

Sonali—one.

Meenakshi—one.

Meenakshi put all three bars into her bag.

Kusum marked three separate lines.

At the end, no bar remained on the table.

No one was short of a bar either.

As Superintendent Kaushalya Devi closed the register, she looked for a moment at the final page.

Something more important than the number of soap bars was written there.

Forty-nine names.

The previous month, no bar of soap had gone missing.

What had been missing was one line in the count for one student.

Outside the Accounts

It was the final night of the autumn fair.

For six days, two long rows of bamboo stalls, tarpaulins, yellow bulbs and coloured pennants had filled the field.

Now, after ten at night, the lights were going out one by one.

The last customer came to Ramlochan Sah's spice stall at nine fifty-five.

He bought half a kilo of roasted cumin, two packets of coriander and a small box of chilli powder.

After the customer left, Ramlochan closed the lid of the wooden chest.

"Sales are over now," he said.

His daughter Sushma laughed.

"That is the first time in six days you have said that on time."

"Today even the customers agreed."

Maya Devi was gathering the empty sacks kept at the back.

The colour of spices had settled into her fingers.

Niranjan took down the small signboard from the bamboo post:
"Ramlochan Spice Store."

As soon as the sign came down, the stall looked a little smaller.

Beside them was Karim Ansari's stall selling dry fruits and savoury mixtures.

He was still adding his accounts.

Karim's two assistants were tying up boxes of goods.

A young night watchman sat outside on a bench.

Ramlochan took out his blue ledger.

The sales for the six days were written on separate pages.

First day: seven thousand three hundred and fifty.

Second day: six thousand nine hundred.

Third day: eight thousand one hundred and twenty.

The amounts for the final three days had also been added.

Sushma did not take out a calculator.

She preferred adding on paper.

"Forty-six thousand two hundred and forty in all," she said.

Ramlochan turned to the expenses page.

Goods purchased — thirty-one thousand eight hundred.

Fair fee — one thousand five hundred.

Electricity — four hundred and twenty.

Transport — one thousand two hundred and sixty.

Paper, string and bags — four hundred and eighty.

Tea, water and small miscellaneous expenses — three hundred and sixty.

Ramlochan added them.

“Thirty-five thousand eight hundred and twenty.”

Sushma immediately said, “Then nine thousand four hundred and twenty remains.”

Ramlochan’s face brightened.

“Not bad this time.”

Karim Ansari heard him.

“I will not have that much left,” he said, closing his own ledger.

Ramlochan smiled.

“Your stall was larger than mine.”

“It was larger, and so were the expenses.”

Karim opened his ledger again.

“Two assistants — three thousand six hundred. Night watchman — nine hundred. Loading and unloading on the first and last days — eight hundred. Wages for two women at home who packed the savoury mixture — one thousand and twenty.”

Ramlochan laughed.

“Did you run a business or distribute wages?”

Karim laughed too.

“If the shop cannot run without someone, that person’s name enters the expenses.”

Before answering, Ramlochan looked at Maya Devi’s hands.

She was folding an empty sack.

Sushma said nothing.

An announcement came from the fair committee:

“Traders wishing to have their deposits refunded must clean their spaces and have the bamboo and tarpaulins removed by eight tomorrow morning. If rubbish remains, cleaning charges will be deducted from the deposit.”

Ramlochan raised his head.

“Eight in the morning?”

Niranjan said, “Then we won’t get home early tonight.”

“We won’t take down the tarpaulin now. There will be dew at night. We’ll do it in the morning.”

Maya Devi asked, “And the night watch?”

“Niranjan and I will take turns staying awake.”

From the next stall Karim Ansari said, "My watchman can keep an eye on both stalls if you like."

Ramlochan waved a hand.

"No, no. We have our own people."

Karim looked at him for a moment, then smiled.

"All right."

At half past ten, Maya Devi and Sushma left for home.

Maya Devi carried three small boxes of leftover spices.

She could not simply leave them as they were after reaching home.

The chilli and coriander had to be separated and wrapped again in cloth to protect them from moisture.

Ramlochan remained at the field.

Niranjan stayed awake until midnight.

At one, he lay down on the bench.

Ramlochan then sat up.

Most of the bulbs in the field had gone dark.

In the distance, the tea seller was still washing his last kettle.

Karim's watchman walked between three rows of stalls.

Every now and then he looked towards Ramlochan too.

At half past two Ramlochan's eyes closed.

At three a dog tried to enter the stall, sniffing at the sacks.

Ramlochan woke up.

He lifted the sacks higher.

At five in the morning Niranjan got up.

"Babu, did you sleep?"

"As much as necessary."

The two began taking down the tarpaulin.

The damp ropes had gone stiff.

While untying the bamboo knots, the skin beside one of Ramlochan's fingernails scraped off.

At six Karim's two assistants arrived.

Within ten minutes his tarpaulin was down and the boxes had been loaded onto a cart.

Ramlochan and Niranjan were still separating the bamboo poles.

Karim told one of his assistants, "Load two of Ramlochanji's boxes as well."

Ramlochan immediately said, "No, no. We'll manage."

The assistant stopped.

Niranjan was breathing a little heavily.

At half past six Maya Devi and Sushma returned to the field.

Maya Devi had brought a broom, an old cloth and two empty tins from home.

Ramlochan asked, "Did you take care of the leftover spices last night?"

"Yes. I opened all three boxes again. Two packets had picked up moisture, so I changed them."

"How long did it take?"

Maya Devi looked at him.

"I did not look at the clock."

Sushma said, "It was twelve ten when I went to sleep."

Ramlochan fell silent.

By seven the space was almost empty.

The tarpaulin had been folded.

The bamboo had been deposited in the committee's pile.

Torn paper, empty spice packets, bits of string, dust and leaves had been swept together.

A committee employee came over.

He inspected the ground.

"Fine. The full deposit will be returned."

Ramlochan collected the five-hundred-rupee deposit.

Sushma smiled.

"Will we add this five hundred to the profit?"

"The deposit was our own money. It is not profit."

"If we had not cleaned, it would have been deducted."

"Even so, it was our own money."

"I was only asking."

Ramlochan did not understand the tone of her question.

Before leaving the field, they stopped at the fair committee table, where priority forms for next year were being distributed.

A trader who had vacated the space according to the rules this year would have the first right to request the same location at the next fair.

Ramlochan took a form.

Name, type of stall, space number and fair fee were ordinary questions.

Near the bottom were two boxes:

"Total persons working."

"Persons employed for wages."

Ramlochan wrote "1" in the first box.

Sushma looked at the form.

"One?"

"The shop is mine."

"Were you the only person working for six days?"

Ramlochan stopped his pen.

Sushma said, "You are the owner. The question is not asking who owns it. It is asking how many people worked."

Niranjan laughed.

"Then will my name go in too?"

"Did you stand night watch?"

"Yes."

"Did you lift the sacks?"

"Yes."

"Then?"

Maya Devi leaned the broom against the wall.

"What will happen if my name is written?"

Sushma said, "Nothing. But writing only one when four worked is not right either."

Ramlochan crossed out the "1" and wrote "4."

In the second box—"Persons employed for wages"—he wrote zero.

Taking the form, the employee asked, "Four people worked, but the number employed for wages is only zero?"

Ramlochan said, "They were family."

The employee nodded matter-of-factly.

There was nothing unusual in that answer to him.

After reaching home, Ramlochan bathed first.

Maya Devi put rice on the stove.

Sushma took out the blue ledger again and placed it on the table.

While eating, Ramlochan asked, "Accounts again?"

"The final account."

"Nine thousand four hundred and twenty. We added it yesterday."

"That was the cash account."

Ramlochan put his spoon down on the plate.

"A business runs on the cash account."

"Yes."

Sushma did not argue.

She reminded him of the page in Karim Ansari's ledger where wages had been entered.

"Babu, if Niranjan Bhaiya had not lifted the sacks, how much would you have paid someone to do the loading?"

"For two rounds... four or five hundred."

"Night watch?"

Ramlochan did not answer.

Niranjan said, "Karim Chacha paid nine hundred."

Sushma looked at Maya Devi.

"Packing the packets at home?"

Maya Devi said at once, "That was work for our own household. How can its money be counted?"

"I am not saying money has to be paid."

"Then?"

"If you had not done it, would Babu have had to hire someone?"

Ramlochan said quietly, "He would."

Maya Devi lifted the lid from the rice pot.

Steam rose.

"Then write it down," she said. "But do not turn it into a debt against me."

Everyone laughed.

Ramlochan laughed too.

"If I start paying your wages, the shop will close."

Maya Devi replied, "The shop will not close. The mouth of your profit will only become smaller."

This time the laughter lasted a little longer.

Then Sushma took a blank sheet of paper.

At the top she wrote: "Cash Expenses at the Fair."

Below it she copied all the amounts from the ledger.

On a second page she wrote: "Labour Outside the Accounts."

Ramlochan frowned.

"That title is too heavy."

"Then give it a lighter one."

Niranjan said, "Household work?"

Maya Devi said, "Household work for the fair."

Sushma wrote that.

First line: sorting spices.

Second: weighing and making packets.

Third: making the name-board.

Fourth: loading the goods at dawn.

Fifth: night watch.

Sixth: cleaning and packing up on the final day.

Seventh: securing the leftover stock again at home.

Ramlochan kept looking at the list.

"Was Sushma involved in all this too?"

Maya Devi asked, "Whose handwriting was on the name-board?"

Ramlochan looked at Sushma.

Sushma laughed.

"Did you think it was printed?"

"I had not noticed."

"That is exactly what the account is about."

This time Ramlochan did not laugh.

He pulled the blue ledger towards himself.

Beside the figure nine thousand four hundred and twenty he had earlier written only: "Profit."

He did not strike out the word "Profit."

He added two words beside it: "Cash Surplus."

Then at the bottom of the page he wrote:

"Family labour: no cash expense, but labour was performed."

Sushma read it.

Ramlochan asked, "Is this right?"

"More right than before."

In the afternoon Karim Ansari came to collect some remaining sacks.

Ramlochan asked him to stay for tea.

Karim asked, "What did the final profit come to?"

Ramlochan opened the blue ledger.

"Cash surplus: nine thousand four hundred and twenty."

Karim smiled.

"Yesterday it was profit. Today it has become cash surplus?"

"The profit is still there."

"Then?"

Ramlochan showed him the second line.

Karim read:

"Family labour: no cash expense, but labour was performed."

He remained silent for a few moments.

Then he said, "In my ledger wages were written, so all our names entered automatically. In your ledger no money went out, so the names did not enter either."

Maya Devi came from inside carrying tea.

"Have the names entered now or not?"

Karim laughed.

"Now they have."

A week later was the final day to submit the priority form for next year at the fair committee office.

Ramlochan looked at the form once more.

"Total persons working — 4."

"Persons employed for wages — 0."

This time the two numbers did not seem contradictory to him.

In small letters along the blank margin of the form, he wrote:

"Family helpers — 3."

Taking the form, the employee said, "There was no need to write that separately."

Ramlochan replied, "There was for me."

The employee said nothing.

He placed the form on the pile.

After returning home, Ramlochan went to put the blue ledger in the cupboard.

For the first time, he did not close it immediately.

He opened the page again.

“Cash surplus — nine thousand four hundred and twenty.”

Below it, the list of household labour.

Both entries were on the same page.

Not a single rupee had disappeared from the cash box.

But the profit figure no longer stood alone.

The Wall's Second Birth

There were still ten days before the rains were due, yet the southern wall of Ramdulari Devi's house had already begun to give off the smell of damp earth.

Two rows of roof tiles had already been taken down.

Old bamboo, broken tiles and heaps of earth lay in the courtyard.

The mason, Chandeshwar, pressed his palm against the lower part of the wall, then brushed the crumbling earth from his fingers.

"We will replace the roofing above. But if we do not remove the plaster from this side, it will swell again in the first heavy rain."

Anupama turned towards the wall at once.

There was an old painting on it.

A large lotus occupied the centre; around it were fish, birds, bamboo sections, the sun and moon, vines and leaves, with the empty spaces filled by diagonal lines.

The colours were no longer as bright as they once had been.

In some places the ochre had faded; elsewhere the black outlines had turned grey.

Even so, the painting filled the entire wall so completely that anyone entering the veranda looked there first.

Anupama had seen this painting since childhood.

Her grandmother, Ramdulari Devi, had made it eighteen years earlier, when Anupama's maternal cousin was married.

Anupama had been five then.

She did not remember the painting being made, but she remembered the finished wall: the eyes of the fish, the round dot at the heart of the lotus, and the two small birds in the right-hand corner.

"You will remove the plaster?" Anupama asked.

Chandeshwar said, "If we leave it as it is, the earth underneath will not hold. Putting fresh colour on top will not make the wall healthy."

Anupama looked towards her grandmother.

Ramdulari Devi was taking water from an earthen pot and setting it beside the tulsi altar.

In an ordinary voice she said, "If it has to come off, let it come off."

The answer hurt Anupama more than if a piece of the painting itself had fallen.

“You made it.”

“Yes.”

“It has been here for so many years.”

“Yes.”

“And you are saying, remove it?”

Ramdulari Devi covered the mouth of the earthen pot.

“Which should be saved first, the wall or the painting?”

Anupama did not answer.

She was studying art history at college in Patna.

During the past two years she had read a great deal about museums, archives, conservation, acidity in paper and the deterioration of pigments.

As soon as she came to the village, she had photographed this wall from different angles.

She had shown the photographs to friends at college.

One professor had told her that proper documentation of old examples of domestic wall painting was very important.

Anupama felt that her grandmother did not understand the value of what she herself had created.

After dinner that night, Anupama went back to the wall.

By the light of her phone she took photographs of the whole wall, the lotus, the fish, the birds, the bamboo and the border.

With a small measuring tape she noted the dimensions.

In a notebook she sketched where the crack in the right-hand corner began.

Ramdulari Devi watched from a cot on the veranda.

“Will so many photographs make the wall heavier?” she asked with a laugh.

Anupama did not laugh.

“If I do not photograph it, nothing will remain.”

“Does everything have to remain?”

“This is an old thing.”

“Does something become worth preserving merely because it is old?”

Anupama lowered the phone.

“This is not an ordinary thing.”

Ramdulari Devi was silent for a moment.

Then she rose and came to the wall.

She put her finger on a small vine in the left-hand corner.

“Do you see this?”

“Yes.”

“It was not there at first.”

“What?”

“When I first painted this, there was a straight bamboo in this corner. Two years later the mud cracked. The crack ran through the bamboo. So I added this vine to cover it.”

Anupama went closer.

The black line of the vine was indeed slightly thicker than the rest of the painting.

Ramdulari Devi pointed to a fish on the right.

“This fish used to face the other way. One year the plaster came off in the rain, so I painted it again.”

“Then this is not the original painting?” Anupama asked without meaning to.

Ramdulari Devi smiled.

“Where will you find the original?”

Anupama fell silent.

“When I painted it the first time,” Ramdulari Devi said, “my mother had shown me an older design. I did not copy it exactly either. The wall of this house was different. The window was different. The wedding was at a different time. My hand was different.”

“But this painting has its own history.”

“It does. So take photographs. Write down the measurements. Keep whatever you want to remember. But history does not mean allowing the wall to rot.”

The next day Anupama brought transparent paper, thick paper and black pens from Madhubani.

She asked Chandeshwar to wait two days.

She did not try to make an exact replica of the whole painting.

Instead she traced the principal forms separately: the lotus, the fish, the birds, the bamboo joins, and the three patterns used in the border.

She named the photographs by date.

In her notebook she wrote down how the colours appeared at that moment.

From time to time Ramdulari Devi corrected her.

“There were four lines here, not three.”

“But now only three can be seen.”

“One has worn away.”

“Then should I write three or four?”

“Write three for what you see. Write separately what I remember.”

For the first time that day Anupama smiled.

“Two truths?”

“Two reports. Do not put the burden of truth on me.”

At noon, twelve-year-old Gudiya from the neighbouring house came over.

Looking at Anupama's sheets, she asked, "Didi, will you take the painting off and put it onto paper?"

"No. I am only keeping its traces on paper."

"Then will the wall become empty?"

Before Anupama could answer, Ramdulari Devi said, "For a few days."

Gudiya looked at the birds in the painting.

"Will these birds be in the new one?"

"We'll see," Ramdulari Devi said.

Anupama looked at her.

"In the new one?"

"If the wall is plastered again, will we leave it empty?"

Until then Anupama had thought her grandmother was in favour of erasing the old painting.

A sudden question came to her: was her grandmother unwilling to preserve the old painting, or had she already begun thinking about the new one?

On the third morning Chandeshwar began work.

The first blow did not come from a hammer but from a thin iron scraper.

The crumbling plaster at the bottom of the wall fell away in strips.

Anupama stood there.

She knew it was necessary, yet when the tail of the first fish disappeared, her throat went dry.

Ramdulari Devi sat on the veranda cleaning makhana.

"Aren't you watching?" Anupama asked.

"Will watching stop the scraper?"

"No."

"Then let it do its work."

By noon half the lotus was gone.

By evening the whole wall had returned to the colour of raw earth.

Only in one upper corner remained a faint dark stain from the old border.

Anupama opened the old photographs on her phone.

On the screen the painting was whole.

In front of her the wall was empty.

The two sights were so different that for a few moments she could not decide which one felt more real.

From behind her Ramdulari Devi said, "Rain cannot reach a photograph."

Anupama turned.

"That is both its advantage and its loss," her grandmother added.

The new plaster took three days.

The smell of fresh mud and cow dung filled the house.

Chandeshwar smoothed the surface and left it to dry.

Each day Anupama watched the damp wall slowly grow lighter.

On the fourth day Ramdulari Devi brought out small containers. Soot black, ochre, green, yellow, rice paste. Some colours were made at home, some bought in the market. Anupama asked, "I can open the photographs and show where each colour was in the old painting."

Ramdulari Devi said, "We will look at the photographs later."

"You will not make it exactly the same?"

"Why?"

Anupama searched for an answer.

"So that the old form survives."

"The old form is in the photographs. The new wall will have new work."

Ramdulari Devi held out a thin bamboo pen towards Anupama.

"Draw the first line."

Anupama stared at her.

"Me?"

"I have watched you count lines for so many days. Now make one."

"I'll make a mistake."

"A wall is not a notebook whose page you can tear out. If you make a mistake, another line will grow around it."

Anupama took the bamboo pen.

She did not have the courage to draw the first line in the middle of the wall. She chose the lower left corner and made a small leaf.

The leaf came out slightly more crooked than she had expected.

Ramdulari Devi drew two fine lines around it.

The crookedness became part of the form.

"Whose line is this now?" Anupama asked.

"Yours."

"And the other two?"

"Mine."

"Then whose leaf is it?"

Ramdulari Devi smiled again.

"The wall's."

The whole painting was not completed that day.

Only the central lotus, four fish, the sun and moon, and half the border took shape.

The next day Gudiya came and looked for the old birds.

"The birds are not here yet," Anupama said.

Gudiya's face fell.

Ramdulari Devi asked, "Which birds do you want?"

"The two that looked towards each other."

"Then make them."

Gudiya laughed first, then grew frightened.

"I cannot."

"Do you draw them on paper?"

"Yes."

"The wall will not quarrel with paper."

With a small black line Gudiya drew the body of a bird.

Her bird was larger than the old one and had a shorter tail.

Anupama opened the photograph to compare them, then closed the phone again.

By the third day the painting was almost full.

Anupama had left one corner empty.

Ramdulari Devi asked, "What will go here?"

Anupama thought for a while.

"A girl sitting with an open book."

"That was not in the old one."

"No."

"Then?"

Anupama looked into her grandmother's eyes.

There was no prohibition there.

"It will be there this time," Anupama said.

She drew a small figure: a girl seated on the ground, an open book in her lap.

Ramdulari Devi added two leaves behind her and a small bird above.

"Is that you?" Gudiya asked.

Anupama said, "Not necessarily."

Ramdulari Devi said, "Whoever reads it may think it is herself."

After the painting was finished, Anupama chose one of the old photographs to have printed.

On the back she wrote the dates: when the old wall had been documented, and when its plaster had been removed.

She photographed the new painting too, but did not have it printed immediately that day.

That evening the first light rain fell.

Water sounded on the new roofing.

The southern wall did not become damp.

The air coming through the open veranda carried the smell of earth and rice paste.

Sitting on a cot, Anupama looked at the old painting on her phone.

On the screen, the old lotus, the old birds, and the vine that had covered the crack were all still there.

Then she switched off the phone and looked at the new wall before her.

The old vine was not in the new painting.
In its place was the girl with the open book.
The old pair of birds had not returned in the same form; there was Gudiya's larger-bodied bird.
Even the lotus had a different number of petals.
Ramdulari Devi was putting away the colour containers.
Anupama asked, "Nani, if the wall has to be plastered again next time, will this disappear too?"
"It is a wall," Ramdulari Devi said. "Someday."
"Then photographs again?"
"Take them."
"And another new painting?"
Ramdulari Devi closed the lid of a colour container.
"If there is someone left who will draw a line."
Anupama said nothing.
She stood up and went to the wall.
Along the lower border was a small empty space that her eye had missed throughout the day.
She picked up the bamboo pen.
This time she did not open the photograph.

Thread in Two Shades

When the morning light fell straight in through the eastern window of the weaving room, Neera's eyes stopped at the middle of the cloth on the loom.

She had been at the loom until night.

Eighteen cubits of cloth had been woven: a muted blue, with fine white stripes running through it and a narrow band of black thread along both edges.

Until the previous evening, it had all seemed the same colour.

In the eastern light, however, the blue after the ninth cubit looked slightly deeper.

The difference was so slight that it could have been dismissed as shadow, yet clear enough that once seen, the eye kept returning to it.

Neera lifted the length of cloth and carried it into the courtyard.

"Ma!" she called.

Savitri Devi was unwinding thread beside the kitchen.

"What happened?"

"Look at this."

Neera did not place the cloth on the ground.

She spread it across two low stools so that dust would not touch it.

Savitri Devi first looked from one side, then from the other.

Then she ran her hand over the middle of the cloth, as though colour might be understood through the fingers.

"The shade has changed," she said.

Neera asked at once, "Why did we not see it yesterday?"

"Yesterday it was evening. How would this difference show under the yellow light inside?"

"But the thread was supposed to be the same colour."

Savitri Devi did not answer.

She went back into the weaving room and began looking at the empty bobbins stacked in the corner.

Neera followed.

About a month earlier, twelve bobbins of muted blue thread had come from a thread shop in Darbhanga.

The first seven bobbins had been in one cardboard box; the remaining five came in a second consignment.

The shopkeeper had written the same colour name on both: "Blue-34."

Two of the empty bobbins still had small paper slips tied to them.

One was dated "12 Jeth."

The other, "28 Jeth."

Savitri Devi placed both bobbins in the light from the window.

Neera remained silent for a few moments.

The few strands caught inside the first bobbin were a slightly greyer blue.

The thread in the second was a little bluer.

"Same number," Neera said.

"One number," Savitri Devi replied. "Two dye lots."

"The shopkeeper did not write that."

"And I did not ask."

At this answer Neera looked at her mother.

She had expected Savitri Devi to leave the mistake entirely at the shopkeeper's door.

Instead, Savitri Devi picked up the two bobbins and placed them on the table beside the register.

Neera looked again at the cloth.

"The trader is coming tomorrow."

"Yes."

"He asked for all twenty cubits in exactly the same shade."

"Yes."

"Then?"

Savitri Devi sat on a low stool.

"First let us find exactly where the change begins."

Neera brought a measuring tape.

They began measuring from the start of the cloth.

Seven cubits, eight, nine.

At nine cubits and three fingers, the faint boundary of the change in shade could be seen.

Neera placed a small piece of paper there.

"This must be where the second consignment began," she said.

Savitri Devi opened the old register hanging beside the loom.

It recorded the date, colour of thread, width of the border, total length of cloth and customer's name.

But there was no separate column for the dye lot.

Neera kept turning the pages.

"How many times might this have happened before?"

"If the difference was small, perhaps we never noticed."

“Shall we dye the whole cloth again?”

Savitri Devi raised her head.

“All of it?”

“Yes. We could dye it a deeper blue. Then both parts would become one colour.”

“Can you be certain they would become exactly the same?”

Neera stopped.

Savitri Devi said, “The dyer can tell us whether another dyeing would erase this first difference or create a second one. But I know one thing: the customer asked for Blue-34. We would be giving him another colour.”

“Then shall we cut off the first nine cubits?”

“Cutting it will not erase the problem. It will only move the place where it appears.”

Neera said irritably, “But if we give the cloth like this, he will say the quality is poor.”

Savitri Devi looked at the cloth for a while.

“If he wants one exact shade, then for him this cloth is poor.”

Neera fell silent.

She had not expected that sentence.

She had imagined that her mother might call the difference in shade beautiful simply because the cloth was handmade.

Savitri Devi added, “Not every mistake in something handmade becomes a virtue.”

For a while the courtyard held only the faint sound of air moving through the unfinished warp on the loom.

Neera asked, “Then what do we do?”

“We tell him what is there.”

“Only that?”

“Have we ever done even that properly before?”

Savitri Devi opened a blank page in the register.

At the top she wrote: “Dye Lot.”

Below it she made two entries.

The first: 12 Jeth.

The second: 28 Jeth.

Neera measured again with the tape.

“First section: nine cubits, three fingers. Second section: eight cubits, five fingers.”

“Write it.”

Neera wrote the measurements.

Savitri Devi took a small piece of black thread and tied a tiny knot at the edge of the cloth, exactly where the shade changed.

The knot was not in the usable part of the cloth; it sat only between two threads projecting beyond the border.

“What is that?” Neera asked.

“A marker. Next time, when we look at the register, we will know that the lot changed here.”

“Will we show it to the customer too?”

“Why not?”

Neera did not smile.

All she could see in her mind was the trader’s face the next day.

The trader was Madhukant Sah, who bought handwoven cloth for a shop in town.

Three months earlier he had chosen a sample in this colour.

His order was for twenty cubits.

Savitri Devi and Neera had completed the first eighteen cubits; two cubits remained to be woven that day.

Neera asked, “Which thread do we use for the remaining two cubits now?”

“The second lot.”

“Then the difference will grow longer.”

“No. The same shade will continue. But the customer’s order will still not have been fulfilled, because he wanted one shade throughout.”

“What if he refuses even the eighteen cubits?”

“Then he refuses.”

It was not easy for Savitri Devi to say that.

Neera knew it.

Three weeks of labour, the cost of the thread and the household electricity had gone into the cloth.

Even so, her mother did not close the register.

She said, “Call the shopkeeper. Ask whether any Blue-34 remains from the 12 Jeth lot.”

Neera called.

The shopkeeper searched through his papers for a long time.

At last he said that the old lot was finished.

All the current stock was from 28 Jeth or later.

“Then that is the end of it,” Neera said after putting down the phone.

“Not the end,” Savitri Devi said. “Now we make a rule.”

By noon they had woven the remaining two cubits.

The loom moved with the same rhythm as before, but Neera’s eyes kept returning to the small black knot at the edge.

In the evening she folded the cloth.

This time she did not tie on a single slip as usual.

She made two.

On the first she wrote: "Blue-34 / 12 Jeth lot / 9 cubits 3 fingers."

On the second: "Blue-34 / 28 Jeth lot / 10 cubits 5 fingers."

Between the two slips she wrote: "One length of cloth — note difference in shade."

Madhukant Sah came the next day.

As soon as he opened the cloth, he first looked at the weave, measured the border, and rubbed the thread between his fingers.

His eye did not immediately catch the colour difference.

Neera could have remained silent.

Savitri Devi said, "The dye lot changes after nine cubits."

Madhukant Sah spread out the cloth again.

There was no eastern morning light now; it was afternoon.

He found the black knot, then compared the blue on either side.

"Yes," he said. "There is a difference."

Neera's hand remained still on the register.

"I wanted one shade throughout," Madhukant Sah said.

"We know," Savitri Devi replied.

"Then I will not take the whole order."

"All right."

Madhukant Sah looked again at the first section.

"The nine-cubit section is close to the old sample. I can take that. I may look at the other section another time for a different use."

For the first time Neera let out the breath she had been holding.

Savitri Devi's expression did not change.

The original order had been for twenty cubits.

That day they were paid only for nine cubits and three fingers.

The remaining cloth stayed at home.

After Madhukant Sah left, Neera said, "If we had not told him, perhaps he would have taken the whole length."

Savitri Devi opened the register.

"Perhaps."

"We suffered a loss."

"We did."

"Then you are not upset?"

Savitri Devi looked at Neera.

"I am upset. But changing the name of a loss does not make the loss disappear."

She began writing four rules on a blank page.

First: whenever new thread of the same colour arrives, ask for the date and dye lot.

Second: if an old lot and a new lot are joined in one length of cloth, place a small marker on the edge.

Third: record in the register the measurement at the point where the colour changes.

Fourth: if the order requires one exact shade, consult the customer before beginning a new lot.

Neera read them.

“None of this makes the colour the same.”

“No.”

“Then how does it improve the quality?”

Savitri Devi placed the two empty bobbins beside the register.

“One part of quality is the colour. Another part is knowing where the colour changed.”

A few days later, two small table runners were made from the remaining cloth of the 28 Jeth lot.

Whether they sold or not was entered in the register later.

But the new rule began that very day.

The next month Blue-34 arrived again.

Neera opened the box.

At first glance the colour looked the same.

Before placing the bobbin on the loom, she searched for the paper slip.

This time the shopkeeper had written the lot number.

Neera entered the date in the register, wrote the lot number, and cut two fingers' length of thread from the remaining old bobbin.

She tied it to the corner of the page.

Beside it she tied two fingers' length from the new lot.

Savitri Devi watched from a distance.

“Same colour?” she asked.

Neera held both threads up to the light.

“Same name,” she said. “Different lot.”

Then she tied a small marker at the edge of the loom.

This time the marker had not been added after a defect was discovered.

The Orchard Path

The orchard came to Shashidhar Jha after his father's death.

His name had already been on the papers, but paper and orchard were not the same thing—he understood that within the first month.

The orchard lay half a kos east of the house.

There were mango, litchi and jackfruit trees, two jamun trees, and here and there old guava trees.

The young trees needed no introduction.

The old ones looked as though they had witnessed more days than the people of the household.

While his father was alive, Shashidhar went to the orchard only when there were too few hands at mango-picking time.

Now fruit, wages, guarding, drains and pruning all entered his accounts.

In the first week he walked through the orchard with his younger brother Neelambar and his daughter Anvita.

Anvita studied while living in the village and, during holidays, helped her father keep the accounts.

An old path ran through the middle of the orchard.

Calling it a path was itself a little generous.

In places it was two cubits wide, elsewhere one and a half.

At one point it curved right around a mango tree, then turned left near a cluster of litchi trees.

In one place it bent so sharply that anyone standing ahead would think someone had made the turn for no reason.

Neelambar stopped there.

"This path ought to be straightened," he said.

Shashidhar looked at the ground.

"What do we gain by making it straight?"

"A cart will pass easily. Bringing manure will be easier. Taking fruit out will be easier. And nearly half a kathha of land will be freed."

Anvita laughed.

"Straightening a path saves land?"

“A crooked path eats land,” Neelambar said. “Draw it on paper and you will see.”

Anvita really did take out her notebook.

She drew a rough map of the orchard—round dots for trees, a crooked line for the path.

Neelambar joined two points with a straight line.

“See? Half the distance.”

Shashidhar kept looking at the notebook.

On paper, the old line of the path looked awkward.

That evening they discussed the matter at home.

Shashidhar’s mother, Sharda Devi, sat beside the stove.

She was close to eighty, yet she still remembered which tree in the orchard had been planted in which year.

Neelambar said, “Ma, why did Babu keep the path so crooked?”

Without raising her head, Sharda Devi said, “Did Babu make the path?”

“Then?”

“The path was there before Babu.”

“Who made it?”

Sharda Devi did not laugh.

“Whoever walked it.”

Neelambar and Shashidhar looked at each other.

“We are thinking of straightening it.”

“Do it.”

The answer was so easy that Shashidhar was surprised.

“You have no objection?”

“The land is yours. You will walk the path.”

Anvita asked, “But why is it crooked?”

This time Sharda Devi thought for a moment.

“Have you ever walked it in the rains?”

“No.”

“Then leave it until the rains.”

Neelambar said, “We cannot build the path during the rains.”

“Then build it before the rains. Look afterward.”

His mother’s words sounded like a riddle to Shashidhar.

But he had little time.

Two days later, two labourers were called.

Two bamboo pegs were driven into the ground and a straight string was stretched from the western gate of the orchard to the fruit shed in the east.

The string crossed the old path at four places.

At the first crossing, some grass was scraped away.

At the second, a small rise in the earth was cut down.

At the third, the ground was levelled two cubits away from a mango tree.
 At the fourth, an old litchi root had risen above the surface.
 The labourer stopped his spade.
 “Shall I cut this root?”
 Shashidhar answered at once, “No.”
 Neelambar looked at the string.
 “We can put a little soil over it.”
 Anvita said, “Then the straight line will bend again.”
 For a few moments all three looked at the root.
 In the end the path was shifted half a cubit to the right.
 “Straight enough to be called straight,” Neelambar said with a smile.
 The new path was completed in three days.
 Parts of the old crooked path were covered with grass and leaves so that people would use the new one.
 When a fruit cart travelled along the new path for the first time, Neelambar seemed to have been right.
 Two people took it all the way to the gate without having to lift it.
 Shashidhar said, “This is better.”
 Anvita wrote in the register: “Inner path levelled — three days’ labour.”
 During all this, Sharda Devi did not go to the orchard.
 The first rain of Ashadh came at night.
 It was not heavy.
 For two hours there was a steady sound on the roof, then it stopped.
 In the morning Shashidhar went to the orchard.
 A little water had collected at the western end of the new path.
 “It is only the first rain,” he thought.
 Two days later came the second rain.
 This time it lasted from afternoon until evening.
 On the third day Anvita went to the orchard and, even from the gate, noticed that the colour of the soil had changed.
 A thin channel had formed down the middle of the new path.
 Where the rise in the ground had been cut away, water had run straight downhill.
 Near the mango tree, where the path had shifted half a cubit to the right, the water had curled towards the roots and washed the soil away.
 Two fine roots were now visible above the ground.
 Anvita called her father.
 Shashidhar came and silently bent down to touch the soil.
 Neelambar arrived too.
 “We will fill in more soil,” he said.
 Anvita looked towards the old path.

The grass there was wet, but the soil had not washed away.
 Before reaching the mango tree, the old path curved left, climbed slightly, then descended gently near the litchis.
 “This path goes straight downhill,” Anvita said.
 Neelambar asked, “So?”
 “So does the water.”
 Shashidhar raised his head.
 That evening Sharda Devi went to the orchard herself.
 She walked slowly with a stick.
 Anvita was with her.
 As soon as Sharda Devi saw the channel on the new path, she stopped.
 “There used to be a mound of earth here,” she said.
 “We had it levelled,” Shashidhar replied.
 “Why?”
 “For the cart.”
 Sharda Devi said nothing.
 She began walking along the old path.
 Near a mango tree she stopped.
 “Here your grandfather used to say, ‘The roots are high—no spade.’”
 Farther on, near the litchis:
 “In the rains the water used to run east here. That is why the path turned left.”
 Anvita asked, “Did anyone measure and build this path?”
 “No.”
 “Then how did all this take shape?”
 Sharda Devi placed the tip of her stick on the grass.
 “In Jeth people walked where the ground was dry. In the rains they walked where there was less water. When they saw roots, they went around them. When a bullock cart got stuck, it went by another side. Year after year, the path kept taking its own measure.”
 Neelambar stood a little distance away listening.
 “But what about the cart?” he asked.
 Sharda Devi replied, “Was the cart made for the path, or the path for the cart?”
 Neelambar laughed.
 “Ma, do not become so philosophical.”
 Sharda Devi smiled too.
 “I am not philosophical. My knees hurt. My feet slip on a straight slope.”
 Everyone laughed.
 But after the next rain, the matter was no longer funny.
 There was heavy rain in the night.

By morning, near the mango tree, a strip of soil a hand's breadth wide had been washed away from one side of the new path.

Standing there, Anvita looked towards the old path.

Leaves had caught there.

The small roots of the grass held the soil.

The water had turned once to the right, once to the left, and thinned out as it went.

Shashidhar said, "Close the new path."

Neelambar did not agree immediately.

"It will become difficult to take the fruit out."

"Then we need a separate solution for the fruit."

The three walked around the outer edge of the orchard.

Along the northern boundary the ground was mostly level, though there was more scrub.

Anvita said, "Why must the cart use the inner path at all?"

Neelambar replied, "The outer side is longer."

"But there are fewer tree roots."

Two days later Shashidhar had the scrub cleared along that boundary.

A new broad route for carts was made around the outer edge of the orchard —slightly longer, but level.

Grass was allowed to grow again on the newly cut straight inner path.

The traces of the old crooked path were reopened.

Anvita began that work not with a spade, but with small bamboo pegs.

Where the old path was still clear, no peg was needed.

Where the new levelling had erased the old line, Sharda Devi guided them:

"A little left here."

"Turn around the jackfruit root here."

"Leave the rise in the ground here."

Anvita drew the map again in her notebook.

This time she did not think the crooked line looked awkward.

Beside it she wrote small notes:

"Root above ground."

"Water east."

"Gentler slope."

"Old rise."

Neelambar looked at the notebook.

"We no longer save half the distance," he said.

Anvita replied, "We saved half the soil."

Neelambar said, "That calculation will be hard to prove."

"Then the rain proved it."

Shashidhar stopped both of them.

“Accounts later. Cover the roots first.”

Around the exposed mango roots they laid soil, dry leaves and a layer of grass.

At two places along the newly cut straight section, they made small cross-drains so that the water would not gather into one channel.

Sharda Devi watched the work.

Shashidhar asked, “Did Babu make all these arrangements?”

“Some Babu, some his father, and some perhaps the water made for itself.”

Anvita said at once, “The water too?”

Sharda Devi laughed.

“All right—some of it the water. There is no need to find an owner for everything.”

By the end of Sawan, the old path had become clear again.

Schoolchildren did not use it.

Nor was it a public village road.

It was the orchard’s own inner path—for inspecting fruit, touching the trees, keeping watch, and moving from one side to the other.

The cart used the outer route.

Now and then Neelambar muttered, “Three minutes longer.”

But no one suggested straightening the old path again.

In Kartik, Anvita made a clean copy of the map.

At the top she wrote: “Inner Orchard Path — where possible, do not cut across the old line.”

Below it she added four points:

“No spade towards exposed roots.”

“No straight cutting down a slope.”

“Inspect the soil after rain.”

“Carts by the outer route.”

Shashidhar read the paper.

“Whose rules are these?”

Anvita said, “Not mine. I wrote what we understood.”

Sharda Devi put on her glasses to look at the map.

She ran her finger along the crooked line.

Anvita asked, “Have I drawn it correctly?”

Sharda Devi said, “A path is never completely correct on paper.”

“Then?”

“Keep walking it and keep looking.”

Anvita folded the map and placed it in the register.

Who knew whether that page would be opened again in the next monsoon.

But the path was already there in the orchard—crooked, slightly uneven, turning around the roots of trees.

This time, its crookedness no longer looked like unfinished work waiting to be corrected, but like knowledge still waiting to be read.

The Nameless Picture

For three years, the old northern veranda of the school had stood half empty.

There had once been two Class Seven rooms there.

After a new building was constructed, one of the old rooms became a library and the wall of the other was knocked down to widen the veranda.

The broad wall was coated in white limewash, but rain and dust had left grey streaks along its lower part.

When the school reopened after the Ashadh holidays, Urmila Jha, who taught art, looked at the wall and said to Headmistress Shailaja Devi, "If the children's work were here, the place would feel alive."

Shailaja Devi measured the wall with her eyes.

"Will the colour last?"

"It is an inner veranda. It will."

"Then make it before the exhibition this year."

The school's annual exhibition was held at the end of Bhadav.

Science models, clay objects, sewing, paintings, collections of old papers—every class contributed something.

Urmila Jha asked the Class Nine students to propose designs for a mural.

Some drew flowers.

Some drew the school building.

Some drew a river.

Some drew a child reading an open book.

On a long sheet of paper, Manjari Karn had drawn only shadows: the shadow of a tree, two windows, and an empty space between them.

Renu Jha added, with a fine blue line in one corner, a small puddle left by rain.

Urmila Jha asked, "Why are both of you working on the same sheet?"

Manjari said, "I had drawn the shadows. Renu said there was too much empty space."

Renu laughed.

"When I added the puddle, she asked why there was no sky in the water."

"Then who drew the sky?"

"No one yet."

Urmila Jha looked at the sheet again.

"The two of you will paint the wall."

The girls looked at one another.

Manjari's hand was quick with line.

She could turn the branch of a tree across paper in a single breath.

Her patience broke quickly when it came to filling colour.

Renu loved mixing colours, shifting shade, keeping fine differences inside a single colour.

But before drawing the first line, she took out the measuring tape again and again.

Urmila Jha said, "That is precisely why both of you."

The next day the two sat on the veranda for an hour to decide what the wall should contain.

School had ended.

The field was empty.

Bird calls came from the trees to the east.

Manjari said, "If we paint the school, we will paint the building. If we paint the building, we will end up making another wall on this wall."

Renu said, "Then not the building."

"What?"

"What lives here."

"People?"

"People can be there, but if we paint everyone's face, half the school will still be left out."

They fell silent again.

Just then Kamala Devi, the library attendant, came out carrying two broken cane stools.

She said, "Are you talking about the picture? Paint the morning light that falls in this veranda. By noon it has shifted away."

Manjari looked at the wall.

A square of light from a window was indeed falling obliquely across the floor.

Renu took out her measuring tape.

Manjari burst out laughing.

"You are going to measure the light?"

"I'll measure it now. Tomorrow at the same time we'll see where it is."

For the next three days the two came to the veranda at the same time.

The square patch of light on the floor changed slightly each day.

The mural took shape from that moving light.

On the left side of the wall would be the shadow of a tree.

In the middle, an open field of light.

On the right, two windows.

Below, a small gathering of water in which one square window would appear upside down.

No person would be shown in full.

Only a few signs of presence:

three pairs of slippers kept in one corner,

an open book,

half of a rope swing visible at the edge,

and a broom leaning against the wall.

Urmila Jha looked at the design.

"Title?"

Manjari asked, "Of the picture?"

"Yes."

Renu said, "Light on the Veranda?"

Manjari shook her head.

"Too direct."

Kamala Devi was listening from behind them.

She said, "Give it a name later. Paint it first. The work will tell you its own name."

On the day the wall was cleaned, four Class Nine students wiped off the old dust.

A fresh thin coat of limewash was applied.

After it had dried for two days, Urmila Jha had a broad frame marked in charcoal.

Manjari drew the first line.

The main branch of the tree reached halfway across the wall.

Standing a little distance away, Renu said, "The shadow is becoming too heavy here."

Manjari stepped back and looked.

"Shall I cut it?"

Renu ran her finger along the charcoal line.

"Do not cut it. Leave openings of light between it."

Manjari left the space of two leaves open inside the branch.

The next day they mixed the colours.

Renu was making a muted green.

Manjari kept saying, "A little more yellow."

When more yellow was added, Renu said, "Now it is too much."

They kept changing the colour in a small bowl.

By noon not a single large section had been completed.

Urmila Jha asked, "Are you making colours or a picture?"

Renu replied, "With a colour that does not fit, the picture will certainly be finished quickly."

Manjari said at once, "A wrong colour."

Renu looked at her.

"All right—a wrong colour."

Three days later the shadow of the tree was complete.

On the fourth day Manjari did not come to school.

There were guests at her house.

Working alone, Renu filled the darkness inside the windows.

When Manjari came the next day, she saw a thin white line between the panes.

"What is this?"

"Light on the glass."

"It was not in my design."

Renu paused.

"Shall I remove it?"

Manjari went up to the wall and looked.

"No. It makes the window seem open."

That day Manjari changed the square reflection of the window in the water.

Renu asked, "Why did you move it from where I measured it?"

"It was right on the wall. In the water it looked too straight."

Renu took two steps back.

"All right."

The work continued in this manner.

Where one drew a line, the other changed the colour.

Where one laid colour, the other created an empty space.

Sometimes after discussion.

Sometimes without any discussion.

One day Urmila Jha asked jokingly, "How much of this picture belongs to each of you?"

Manjari said, "Shall we measure the wall and divide it?"

Renu added, "Three cubits on the left hers, three cubits on the right mine?"

"And the middle?" Urmila Jha asked.

Both answered at once, "The school's."

Everyone laughed.

The mural was finished four days before the exhibition.

On the final day only the small patch of water below remained.

Manjari wanted the shadow of a bird there.

Renu said, "If a bird is reflected in the water, there has to be a bird above."

"But the sky is not visible above."

“Then leave it.”

Manjari put the brush down.

The water remained empty.

When the painting was complete, Urmila Jha asked, “Now the title?”

Looking at the wall, Renu said, “Empty Water.”

Manjari said, “If people hear that title, they will start looking for the water.”

Kamala Devi was passing by again.

She said, “To me it looks like ‘Before Noon.’”

Both girls stopped.

Renu smiled.

“That is right.”

On a small card below the mural they wrote: “Before Noon.”

Every item in the exhibition had to be entered in a register.

The school’s old exhibition register was a thick book bound in green cloth.

The first page bore the year 1987.

Through the book were different colours of ink, different handwriting, and pages whose corners had been folded.

That year the task of filling the register had been given to Manoj Mishra, the librarian.

In order, he recorded the class, the name of the exhibit, the medium, the artist’s name and the date of the exhibition.

Manjari and Renu came to have the mural entered.

Manoj Mishra asked, “Title?”

Renu said, “Before Noon.”

“That is the title of the picture. Artist’s name?”

“Both of us.”

Manoj Mishra stopped his pen.

Opposite “Artist’s Name” there was one thin line.

After it came one small box for “Class” and another for “Serial Number.”

He said, “Write the name of the main artist first. I’ll put the second name in the remarks.”

Manjari did not answer immediately.

Renu bent over to look at the page.

“Who is the main artist?”

Manoj Mishra said casually, “The one who made the original design.”

Manjari said, “I made the first design, but where did that design remain unchanged in the finished picture?”

“Then the one who did more of the colour work.”

Renu said, “I mixed most of the colours, but Manjari changed them in half the places.”

Manoj Mishra became slightly impatient.

“Write both names on the same line.”

Manjari looked at the line.

“Whose first?”

“Either one.”

Renu said, “Then the name written first will still seem like the main one.”

“Then put them in alphabetical order.”

Manjari laughed.

“Does M come before R, or R before M?”

Manoj Mishra smiled too.

“You are making the register harder than the work itself.”

Urmila Jha entered the library just then with some exhibition papers.

Manoj Mishra explained the problem.

Urmila Jha looked at the page.

“Write both names.”

Renu said, “I have no objection to writing the names.”

“Then?”

“I object to making one of us the artist and the other a remark.”

Manjari said quietly, “Even if both names go on one line, where will we write how the work was actually made?”

Before answering, Urmila Jha began turning the older pages of the register.

On one page, opposite a clay model of a village, four names had been written in very small letters; the last name climbed out beyond the line.

On another page, opposite “Paper Bridge,” there was one name, and in the remarks was written: “Assistance: Class Eight.”

Urmila Jha said, “This problem has existed before.”

Manoj Mishra said, “Perhaps when the register was made, it assumed one exhibit meant one student.”

Renu asked, “And now?”

For a few moments no one spoke.

Urmila Jha said, “This time leave the line blank. In the remarks write: joint work; names on the next page.”

Manoj Mishra said, “Then the register will remain incomplete.”

Manjari kept looking at the thin line on the page.

“The register is incomplete already.”

Manoj Mishra looked at her.

The sentence was sharp, but Manjari’s voice was not.

Urmila Jha said, “All right. Leave it blank. But write the reason.”

The line for “Artist’s Name” remained blank.

In the remarks Manoj Mishra wrote:

“Joint mural by two students; the present register has no separate provision for recording shared roles.”

Then, at the top of the next blank page, both names were written.

Below them went a short description: design, colour, altered lines, final work—all with shared participation.

Manjari said, “Here you have divided the roles again.”

Renu looked at her.

Manoj Mishra asked, “Then what should I write?”

Both girls thought for a moment.

Renu said, “Write: the work changed hands alternately.”

Manoj Mishra smiled.

“That will be a first in this register.”

On exhibition day people stopped again and again in front of the mural.

Some looked at the shadow of the tree.

Some at the square in the water.

Some asked why there were no faces.

An elderly parent said, “This is a school. Where are the children?”

Renu replied, “Look at the slippers.”

The man saw the three pairs of slippers.

“Then the children have gone inside?”

Manjari said, “Wherever you want them to have gone.”

The man laughed.

The title of the picture was written below the wall, but the artists’ names were not.

Two or three people asked.

The students answered, “Manjari and Renu.”

One parent asked, “Why are the names not written?”

Manjari replied, “We are looking for space in the register.”

The parent thought it was a joke.

He laughed and moved on.

The day after the exhibition ended, Shailaja Devi was checking the register.

She stopped at the blank line.

“Why is this empty?”

Manoj Mishra told her the whole story.

At first Shailaja Devi said, “What was difficult about writing two names?”

Urmila Jha, who was there, showed her the older pages of the register.

“Two names are not difficult. The problem is that this box assumes one work has one artist. Group work is increasing—in science, clay, painting, everywhere.”

Shailaja Devi turned the pages.

“Should we buy a new register?”

Manoj Mishra said, "This one is not even half full."

"Then?"

Outside on the veranda, Renu and Manjari were putting away paint tins.

They did not know about the discussion.

Three days later Shailaja Devi called both of them to the office.

The exhibition register lay open on the table.

She asked, "Tell me again why you left the line blank."

Manjari looked at Renu.

Renu said, "If we chose one name, it would reduce the other person's work."

"And if both names were written?"

Manjari said, "They can be written. But the register still asks: who is the artist? Where are the roles? What if three people work together?"

Shailaja Devi was quiet for a few moments.

Then she showed them the old page with four names against the clay village.

"What each of these four did, no one knows now."

Manoj Mishra said, "It was not recorded at the time."

"We will not guess now," Shailaja Devi said.

She did not close the register.

"The history of the old work is whatever has survived. For new work, we will use a new method."

The following week the school clerk printed a thin supplementary sheet.

At the top it read: "Exhibition Record — Supplementary Sheet."

Instead of the old single box for "Artist's Name," it had two fields:

"Creators"

and

"Role / Remarks."

There was a separate place for the class to be entered collectively.

The serial-number box was removed; if needed, a number could be written beside a name.

Manoj Mishra inserted the supplementary sheet after the relevant page in the old register.

The first entry was "Before Noon."

"Creators — Manjari Karn, Renu Jha."

"Role / Remarks — Joint design, colour and revisions; roles changed hands alternately during the work."

Manoj Mishra read it out and asked, "Is this right now?"

Renu said, "Now the register is not lying."

Manjari added, "And the names have survived."

Urmila Jha asked, "Was it necessary for the names to survive?"

Manjari thought for a moment before replying.

“A picture can remain without a name. But there is no need to erase the names of the people who made the work.”

Shailaja Devi, who was standing at the door listening, said, “We will not write that sentence in the register.”

Everyone laughed.

A new small label was made beneath the mural.

This time, under the title, it read:

“Creators: Manjari Karn and Renu Jha.”

Manjari looked at the label.

“Why is my name first?”

Renu replied immediately, “M comes before R alphabetically.”

Both burst out laughing.

Urmila Jha said, “Next time we will need a separate register for disputes about alphabetical order.”

By Kartik the paint had dried and become part of the wall.

Children passing through the veranda stopped pausing in front of it; things seen every day quickly become things of the house.

But one day three Class Seven students came to the library carrying a small drainage model made of earth and bamboo.

Manoj Mishra opened the supplementary sheet.

“Creators?”

The three gave their names.

“Roles?”

One boy said, “I cut the bamboo.”

The second said, “I packed the earth.”

The third remained silent for a while.

“I broke it twice.”

Manoj Mishra laughed.

“Is that a role too?”

The boy was serious.

“If I had not broken it, the water would not have flowed.”

Under “Role / Remarks,” Manoj Mishra wrote:

“All three participated in improving the design.”

On the veranda wall, “Before Noon” remained as it was.

That same day, returning from class, Manjari and Renu saw the three new names on the supplementary sheet.

Renu said, “Our blank line has been filled.”

Manjari shook her head.

“No. That line is still blank.”

“Then?”

Manjari opened the old register and showed her.

“It is necessary for this to remain blank. Otherwise it will look as though everything was already right before.”

Renu did not put her finger on the page.

She only looked.

The old line was indeed blank.

Below it was the note.

On the next page were their two names.

After that came the new format.

Outside on the veranda, the real midday light had already moved beyond the square of brightness painted on the mural.

The painted light remained where it was.

They were not the same.

One was a mark of a moment; the other was time still moving.

The blank line in the register was like that too.

Nothing had been written there.

Yet because of that, a great deal could be read.

The Seven-Minute Voice

At the top of the first page of Saurabh's notebook, in black ink, were the words: "Seven Minutes."

Below them were seven small circles.

Beside the first circle: "Did Ma eat?"

Beside the second: "Maths Question 37."

Beside the third: "Oil for Nani's knees."

Beside the fourth: "School excursion."

Beside the fifth: "My new shoes."

Beside the sixth: "Did it rain in Patna today?"

The seventh circle was blank.

Saurabh had made the notebook himself.

No teacher had told him to do it.

It was not homework.

It was simply that his mother, Rama Devi, usually spoke to him on the phone for about seven minutes.

Rama Devi worked in the accounts section of a book-distribution warehouse in Patna.

Her evening shift ended at eight.

It took five minutes to walk from the warehouse to the bus stop, and the bus towards the village usually arrived at eight twelve.

That short stretch between eight five and eight twelve had become the most solid part of Saurabh's day.

The phone rang at eight five, six, or seven.

"Yes, tell me."

That was all Rama Devi would say.

Saurabh began with the first circle.

"Did you eat?"

"I had flattened rice and curd at the warehouse. You?"

"Nani gave me rice."

Second circle.

"How do I do the division in Maths Question Thirty-seven?"

"I do not have the notebook in front of me. Divide first by the smaller number."

"That does not work."

"Then ask Master Saheb tomorrow. I will not guess from here."

Third circle.

"Nani said the oil is finished."

"Get it tomorrow from Ramnaresh's shop. There is money in the tin."

By the time they reached the fourth circle, the first horn of the bus could usually be heard on the other end of the call.

"Quickly, tell me. The bus has come."

Then Saurabh shortened his questions.

"Can I go on the excursion?"

"Where?"

"Rajnagar."

"How much money?"

"Two hundred."

"All right. Tell Nani to give it."

The fifth circle was often left out.

Sometimes the sixth too.

The seventh had remained blank from the beginning.

After the call ended, Saurabh drew a small arrow beside any question left unanswered and carried it over to the next day's page.

Some questions travelled for three days.

"Shoes" — Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday.

"Science chart" — Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday.

"Why did Deepak take my pen?" began on Wednesday's page, but by Friday Saurabh had worked out the answer himself.

Deepak had not stolen the pen.

During play, Saurabh himself had left it on Deepak's notebook.

That question was crossed out.

Rama Devi was pleased with this system of the notebook.

One night she said, "You write your questions down, so nothing gets missed on the phone."

Saurabh looked at the notebook and smiled.

In fact, a great deal was missed.

That day, on his way home from school, he had found an old brass-coloured button half-buried in the earth.

He wanted to know whether shirts from his mother's childhood had buttons like that.

But in which circle should he write the question?

Food, studies, Nani, money, school—where did a button belong among these?

Beside the seventh blank circle he wrote: “Button.”

When the call came, there were already four necessary things to discuss first.

The bus arrived earlier than expected.

“Tomorrow,” Rama Devi said.

The next day the button gave way to Nani’s medicine.

On the third day, the school fee.

On the fourth, Rama Devi herself said in a tired voice, “The warehouse count went wrong today and my head is aching. If there is something necessary, say it.”

Saurabh erased the arrow he had drawn beside “Button.”

He pressed the button between the pages of the notebook.

In this way the seventh circle slowly became a home for different things:

the string of a half-torn kite,

a yellow bird seen beside the pond,

two lines of dialogue he had been given in the school play,

a word from one of Nani’s old stories,

and the question of whether his mother truly liked tea without sugar, or drank it that way only to save money.

Sometimes he left the seventh circle blank.

Sometimes he wrote only one word beside it:

“Nothing.”

Rama Devi came home four or five times a year.

But this time she had been unable to come for five months in a row.

A new accounting system had started at the warehouse, two employees had left, and demand for books had risen before Diwali.

On the phone Rama Devi kept saying, “I will definitely come in the last week of Kartik.”

Saurabh wrote the date at the back of the notebook.

Until then he had counted only questions.

Now he began counting days as well.

A week before she was due to return, Rama Devi asked, “What should I bring when I come?”

Saurabh had a separate list for that in his notebook:

a geometry box,

blue socks,

a storybook,

a cord for Nani’s spectacles.

He read out the list.

Before ending the call, Rama Devi laughed and asked, “Anything else?”

Saurabh looked at the seventh circle.

Beside it was written: "Many things."

"No," he said. "That is all."

Rama Devi reached home on Saturday afternoon.

When Saurabh returned from school, her iron trunk lay open in the courtyard.

Nani was taking out the clothes one by one and holding them to the sun.

Rama Devi sat on the veranda peeling potatoes.

Saurabh stood at the gate for two moments.

For so many days he had met his mother's voice every day on the phone that the sudden sight of her body sitting before him seemed slightly unfamiliar.

As soon as Rama Devi saw him, she dropped the potato and stood up.

"Why have you become so thin?"

Saurabh laughed.

"You could not see me on the phone."

Rama Devi touched his head.

"How was I supposed to see your head over the phone?"

Nani said, "Wash your hands and face first. The two of you have started your story right at the gate."

Saurabh went inside.

That evening there was plenty of talk in the house:

neighbours, the warehouse, Patna, school, fields, uncle, Diwali, new clothes.

But Saurabh's "many things" did not appear anywhere among those conversations.

After dinner he took his notebook and sat beside his mother.

"What is that?" Rama Devi asked.

"The Seven-Minute Notebook."

"Let me see."

Saurabh did not hand it over immediately.

"I will ask first."

"Ask."

He opened an old page.

"Did shirts in your childhood have brass-coloured buttons?"

For a moment Rama Devi looked at him.

"Why suddenly?"

Saurabh took the old button from between the pages.

"I found it on the road."

Rama Devi placed the button on her palm.

“Not on my shirts. But your Nana had a coat with buttons like this. I remember—”

Saurabh interrupted at once.

“Do you remember it clearly?”

Rama Devi laughed.

“Clearly? No. The memory is not clear. When Nana comes home, we will ask him.”

Saurabh opened another old page.

“I saw a yellow bird. Long beak. What is it called?”

“Am I a bird book?”

“You know everything.”

“Who told you that?”

Saurabh smiled.

Third question.

“Do you really like tea without sugar, or are you saving money?”

Rama Devi burst out laughing.

“You have kept this question for five months?”

“Three months.”

“Answer: at first I was saving money. Now tea with sugar tastes too sweet.”

Saurabh put a small mark in the notebook.

Rama Devi noticed.

“Are there so many old questions?”

“A lot.”

“Will you ask all of them today?”

“Yes.”

Ten minutes later Rama Devi leaned her back against the wall.

Twenty minutes later the pace of Saurabh’s questions slowed.

After half an hour, three pages of the notebook had been crossed through.

“Now?” Rama Devi asked.

Saurabh turned a page.

“That is all.”

“All?”

“For today.”

Rama Devi looked at the clock.

“It is only nine.”

On the phone, by nine o’clock they would both already have reached their own places.

Saurabh would have closed the notebook.

Rama Devi would have been looking for a seat on the bus.

Now time lay open.

No horn.

No "quickly, tell me."
 Even so, both fell silent.
 Nani was putting away utensils in the kitchen.
 Outside, the wind moved through the bamboo leaves.
 Rama Devi asked, "Everything all right at school?"
 "Yes."
 "No quarrel with Deepak?"
 "No."
 "Maths?"
 "Fine."
 "Then?"
 "What?"
 "Say something."
 Saurabh laughed, but said nothing.
 Rama Devi laughed too.
 "On the phone you do not let me speak during those seven minutes."
 "There is less time there."
 "Here there is more."
 Saurabh did not answer.
 For two days the same thing returned in small forms.
 In the morning Rama Devi sat with him over tea.
 "What are you thinking?"
 "Nothing."
 At noon, while putting away his books, she asked, "Have you read this story?"
 "Yes."
 "How is it?"
 "Fine."
 In the evening they walked towards the fields.
 "Is this embankment new?"
 "Yes."
 "When was it made?"
 "In Bhadav."
 Rama Devi said with mild irritation, "It was easier to talk to you on the phone."
 For the first time Saurabh looked directly at her.
 "On the phone there were questions."
 "There are no questions here?"
 "There are. But not every question is for asking."
 Rama Devi fell silent.
 That night the electricity went out.

Nani lit a lantern and placed it on the veranda.
It was hot inside the house, so all three sat outdoors.
Rama Devi had a basket of pea pods in her lap.
She was shelling them for the next day's vegetable.
Without being asked, Saurabh sat beside her and pulled over another empty plate.
For a while there was only the soft sound of pods splitting open.
One pod held five peas.
Another held two.
A third held three very small ones.
Saurabh placed one tiny pea on his palm and said, "If this is planted, will it grow into a plant?"
Rama Devi looked at the pea.
"It may. It may not. We would have to see whether it has dried out."
Saurabh set it aside.
Silence again.
After a while the sound of a distant train came.
Rama Devi said, "At night, behind my room in Patna, I hear trains like that."
Saurabh asked, "How many times?"
"I have never counted."
"Why did you never tell me before?"
Rama Devi's hands stopped.
"Where was the time on the phone to tell you about trains?"
Saurabh said nothing.
Rama Devi began shelling peas again.
"In the beginning, when I heard trains at night, they made me think of home," she said softly.
Saurabh's hands stopped too.
That sentence could not fit inside any of the circles in the Seven-Minute Notebook.
He did not ask, "Why home?"
He did not ask, "How much did you miss it?"
He did not ask, "Did you cry?"
He simply remained sitting beside her.
The distant sound of the train faded.
Nani lowered the lantern wick a little.
Rama Devi spoke again.
"One night the rain was so heavy I could not leave the warehouse. I missed the bus. I could not call you. The next day you told me you had fallen asleep."
Saurabh remembered.

That night he had watched the phone until half past nine.
In his notebook he had written: "Why no call?"
The next day Rama Devi had said only, "It was raining."
Saurabh thought of looking for that page in the notebook, then let the thought go.

"I fell asleep late," he said now.

Rama Devi looked at him.

"But you told me you had already gone to sleep."

"I did."

"Why?"

Saurabh kept breaking the stems from the pea pods.

"There were only seven minutes on the phone."

Rama Devi did not smile.

She only nodded.

A little later Saurabh went to his basket and brought out the old brass-coloured button.

By then the button no longer lived in the notebook; it stayed in his pencil box.

"Does this look like the button from Nana's coat?"

"I do not know."

"Then keep it."

"Why?"

"So there will be something from home in your room."

Rama Devi did not take the button.

"You keep it. My room is not short of things from home."

"What is there?"

"Your photograph, the tin of makhana Nani gave me, an old key from this house, and the paper boat you made last year."

Saurabh was surprised.

"You still have that boat?"

"Yes."

"It must have got wet."

"It does not rain inside my room."

Both laughed.

After a while all the pea pods were finished.

Still, neither of them got up.

The electricity had not yet returned.

There was the yellow light of the lantern on the veranda, darkness outside, and now and then the sound of crickets.

Saurabh suddenly understood that being silent was also something one could do.

On the phone, silence consumed time.

Here, silence made time.

During the next three days, Rama Devi and Saurabh did not have any great conversations.

They went to the market together.

One day, while hanging clothes to dry, Rama Devi told Saurabh about a strange habit of one of her colleagues at the warehouse.

Returning from school, Saurabh simply said—without first turning it into a question—that a crow had flown away from the playground carrying a red ribbon.

Rama Devi asked, “Where did it take it?”

“I do not know.”

“Did you follow it?”

“A little way.”

“Why?”

“To see.”

That was all.

And the conversation was complete.

Rama Devi’s leave was for seven days.

On the morning of the eighth day she had to return to Patna.

That night Saurabh opened his notebook.

For the previous seven days he had not made a single new “Seven Minutes” page.

On a blank page he wrote the date.

Below it he drew seven circles.

He left the first six blank.

Beside the seventh he wrote: “Silence.”

Then, after thinking a little, he crossed out “Silence.”

In its place he wrote: “Together.”

In the morning Rama Devi left.

Two days later, at six minutes past eight in the evening, the phone rang.

Saurabh already had the notebook open.

“Yes, tell me,” Rama Devi’s voice said.

Behind her came the sounds of vehicles at the bus stop.

Saurabh looked at the first circle.

Blank.

The second.

Blank.

The third.

Blank.

“What happened?” Rama Devi asked. “No questions today?”

“There is one.”

“Tell me.”

“Did you hear the train today?”

For a few moments there was no answer from the other end of the phone.

Saurabh did not look at the clock.

Rama Devi did not speak at once either.

Somewhere in the distance a horn sounded.

Then Rama Devi said, “Not yet. But it may come.”

Saurabh said, “All right.”

Both remained silent for a while.

In that silence were the sounds of buses, Nani’s cough on the village veranda, and one shared night stretched between two places farther than seven minutes could measure.

The horn sounded a second time.

Rama Devi said, “The bus has come.”

Saurabh replied, “Yes. Go.”

Before the call ended, Rama Devi said, “If I hear the train tomorrow, I’ll tell you.”

Saurabh drew no arrow in the seventh circle.

He left the page open.

The Earthen Bowl

When the call came from Darbhanga, Deepak was sitting beside the potter's wheel, counting the unfired bowls.

Under the thatched roof, thirty-two bowls were drying in three rows.

Some had mouths a little wider, some bodies a little fuller, some bases narrower.

All were made from the same clay, but none was an exact copy of another.

On the phone, Arunesh, the manager of a new restaurant in town, said, "I need one hundred bowls. Handmade. But all exactly the same size."

Deepak fell silent at the first order he had ever received on such a scale.

"One hundred?"

"Yes. For serving dal and vegetables. I'll send a sample tomorrow. Make them all like the sample."

After the call ended, Deepak remained for a long while with the mobile in his hand.

Ramcharan the potter kept the wheel turning.

Between his hands, a lump of clay slowly took the shape of a bowl.

Deepak said, "Dada, we have an order for a hundred bowls."

Ramcharan's fingers did not stop.

"How much time?"

"Three weeks."

"We have clay."

"But there is one condition."

Ramcharan opened the mouth of the bowl a little wider.

"Tell me."

"They want every one exactly the same size."

This time the wheel slowed.

Ramcharan placed the newly made bowl on the plank and, while washing his hands, asked, "Exactly the same?"

"His own words."

Ramcharan looked towards the thirty-two drying bowls.

"Then why did he ask for handmade?"

Deepak did not laugh.

“Handmade things are in demand in town. But on the table they want everything to look the same.”

“They want the hand, but not the mark of the hand?”

Deepak did not answer.

It was a large order.

For two months they had been postponing the repair of the old kiln.

The western side of the roof also needed replacing.

The money from a hundred bowls could pay for both.

The next day the sample arrived in a box.

It was not earthenware but a white ceramic bowl made in a mould.

Its mouth was perfectly round, the rim equally thick all around, and the base so level that it did not rock even slightly when placed on a board.

Inside the box, a sheet of paper listed the measurements: width of the mouth, height, diameter of the base.

Deepak took out a measuring tape and checked them all again.

Ramcharan held the sample for a while.

Then he ran a finger over its inner surface.

“It is beautiful,” he said.

Deepak was surprised.

“Then we can make it?”

“This one has already been made.”

“I mean—like this.”

Ramcharan set the sample on the plank.

“We can make bowls like this. We cannot make this bowl.”

Deepak understood that an argument was beginning.

“Dada, this time we will have to leave our own way aside. They have given measurements.”

“Who told you to leave the measurements aside?”

“Then?”

“Make ten first. We will see.”

That same day Deepak made his own preparations beside the wheel.

He cut a thin bamboo strip to measure the width of the mouth.

A second strip for the height.

A third for the diameter of the base.

He also brought out the old balance so that each lump of clay could be made nearly equal in weight.

Ramcharan watched from a distance.

Deepak asked, “Why did you never do all this before?”

“There was no need.”

“Now there is.”

“Then do it.”

His grandfather's easy answer irritated Deepak slightly.
He felt that Ramcharan objected inwardly but simply refused to say so.
The first lump went onto the wheel.
Deepak opened the mouth, held the bamboo strip against it, pressed slightly, measured the height, then measured the base.
The bowl came out beautiful.
Then the second.
The third.
The fourth.
While making the fifth, his finger went a little too far inward.
The mouth matched the measurement, but the body curved inward slightly.
Deepak immediately set it aside.
Ramcharan asked, "Why?"
"The shape is different."
"Is it broken?"
"No."
"Then?"
"You remember the order, don't you?"
Ramcharan said nothing.
By evening Deepak had made fifteen bowls.
He set five aside.
Ten were within his chosen measurements.
Ramcharan picked up one of the five that had been rejected.
"This one can stay at home for curd."
Deepak said, "Dada, if five out of every fifteen are rejected, we will have to make a hundred and fifty to deliver a hundred."
"Then your hand will learn."
"We have only three weeks."
Ramcharan looked at him.
"In three weeks we will see whether time teaches the hand, or the hand teaches time."
Deepak did not laugh.
For the next three days, measurement ruled the workshop.
The clay lump on the balance.
The mouth gauge at the wheel.
The height strip.
The base circle.
Serial numbers on the drying boards.
Deepak made a register with blank lines numbered from 1 to 100.

Ramcharan kept making bowls too, but the bamboo strip repeatedly caught on his work.

One bowl's mouth was half a finger narrower than the measure.

Another was slightly taller.

Deepak set three aside.

At the fourth, Ramcharan stopped his hand.

"Even for such a small difference?"

"They said exactly the same."

"Where on the measuring strip is the word 'exactly' written?"

"On the paper."

"Will the paper eat from the bowl?"

Deepak grew annoyed, but kept his voice low.

"The restaurant people will accept the goods according to that paper."

Ramcharan put his fourth bowl on a separate plank.

"Fine. This one is mine."

That evening, when Grandmother Janaki Devi saw the separate plank, she asked, "Has another shop opened?"

Deepak said, "These are outside the measurements."

Janaki Devi picked up one bowl and examined it.

"To me it looks all right inside and out."

"You are not the customer."

"That is true."

She put the bowl back.

"But will the customer eat the dal, or the bowl's measurements?"

Deepak said, "Both."

Ramcharan silently covered the clay.

The first twenty bowls dried and went into the kiln.

Deepak had been restless since morning on the day the kiln was opened.

He had watched unfired clay shrink in fire since childhood.

But this time shrinking was not merely the nature of clay; it was a risk to the order.

The bowls came out.

Their colour had deepened into terracotta.

Deepak measured the first.

The mouth was right.

The height was slightly less.

The second: mouth right, base slightly smaller.

The third: all three measurements almost right.

The fourth: the mouth a quarter of a finger too wide.

His head grew hot.

"Fire does not read measuring strips," Ramcharan said.

“Then the raw measurements will have to change.”

“Change them.”

Deepak set the five most similar bowls in one row.

From a distance they truly looked almost alike.

Ramcharan placed two of the older rejected bowls beside them.

Deepak at once reached out to remove them.

Ramcharan said, “Look at one thing.”

“What?”

“Bring water.”

Deepak was puzzled, but brought water from the earthen pitcher.

Ramcharan asked for the old brass cup used in the kitchen to measure dal.

For years Janaki Devi had used that cup to measure lentils, chickpeas and curd.

Ramcharan filled it to the brim and poured one measure into the first bowl.

Then a second.

The water stopped two fingers below the rim.

He poured two measures into the second bowl.

The water stopped one and a half fingers below.

Two measures into the third.

The water came almost to the rim.

Deepak bent closer.

Ramcharan said, “One shape, three stomachs.”

Deepak immediately picked up one of the bowls he had rejected because its body seemed slightly fuller.

Two measures of water were poured into it.

The water stopped exactly where it had stopped in the first bowl.

Deepak tested five more.

Even where the external dimensions were close, the internal capacity was not the same.

Wall thickness, the rise inside the base, and shrinkage during drying all made a difference.

“But the customer gave outside measurements,” Deepak said.

Ramcharan replied, “Have you understood what the customer needs the bowl to do?”

“For dal and vegetables.”

“If one bowl holds less dal and another more, will identical appearance save him?”

Deepak remained silent.

That night he called Arunesh.

“I want to ask one thing. How much dal will you serve in each bowl?”

There was a pause at the other end.

"I use one ladle. Around two hundred and eighty millilitres. Why?"

Deepak said, "What is the capacity of the sample bowl?"

"I have never measured it exactly."

"Please measure it tomorrow and tell me."

Arunesh laughed.

"Did I order bowls or a mathematics lesson?"

Deepak laughed a little too.

"This time, both."

The answer came the next day.

Filled to the rim, the sample held three hundred and twenty millilitres.

In use, about two hundred and eighty millilitres would be served.

Deepak wrote it down.

Ramcharan said, "Now you have the measurement."

"What about the mouth and height?"

"Those remain too. But this is the first measurement."

Deepak did not find that easy to accept.

For three days he had treated outward sameness as the centre of the work.

Now his grandfather was not overturning the entire system Deepak had made; he was only shifting its centre.

Together they devised a new method.

The raw lumps of clay would be approximately the same weight.

The mouth width would stay within a set range.

The height too would stay within a range.

But the real test of a fired bowl would be its capacity.

Deepak checked the measure of the brass cup and brought a small steel measuring vessel so that equal amounts of water could be measured precisely.

Turning it in his hand, Ramcharan asked, "Will this sit on the wheel too?"

"No. After the bowls come out of the kiln."

"Then fine."

Deepak added a new column to the register: "Capacity."

Beside it: "Mouth," "Height," "Batch," "Kiln Date."

Ramcharan looked at the register.

"Will you write all this?"

"For the first hundred."

"And the second hundred?"

"Then we will see which writing is actually useful."

Ramcharan smiled.

"That is right."

In the next batch, the rhythm at the wheel changed.

Deepak no longer used the bamboo strip only as a final judge.

He felt the thickness of the clay with his fingers, watched the rise inside the base, and then checked the measurements.

Ramcharan too sometimes asked for the measuring strip.

One day the mouth of a bowl he made came out slightly below the permitted range.

Deepak said, "This one is out."

Ramcharan asked, "Capacity?"

"It is still unfired."

"Then punishment before the test?"

Deepak did not set the bowl aside.

"We'll see after the kiln."

Ramcharan merely said, "Hmm."

Three days later that same bowl proved correct in capacity, though its mouth was slightly below the measurement.

Deepak held it for a long time, looking at it.

Ramcharan asked, "What will you do?"

"Keep it in the sample group. Arunesh can see it himself."

The earlier Deepak would not have made that decision.

A week later Arunesh came to inspect the workshop.

Meena, the restaurant cook, came with him.

Thirty fired bowls stood in a row on the plank.

From a distance they looked like members of one family.

Up close, the differences were clear.

One rim opened slightly more.

One body was rounder.

On another, the terracotta colour at the base was darker from the fire.

After looking at the first three bowls, Arunesh frowned.

"I asked for the same size."

A tightness rose inside Deepak's chest.

Ramcharan said nothing.

Deepak said, "First, let me show you one test."

Meena asked, "What?"

Deepak filled the measuring vessel with two hundred and eighty millilitres of water and poured it into the first bowl.

The water stopped about one finger below the rim.

The second bowl—the same.

The third—the same.

The fourth, fifth, sixth—almost the same in each.

Meena took the measuring vessel herself.

She picked up one bowl from the middle of the row and filled it.

"This one looks smaller from outside," she said.

Deepak replied, "The space inside is the same."

Meena tested two or three more.

Arunesh took the white sample bowl out of its box.

Two hundred and eighty millilitres of water were poured into that as well.

The water rose to almost the same height.

This time Ramcharan spoke.

"Your sample gave us a measurement for the eye. Your kitchen needs a measurement for the stomach."

Arunesh looked at him.

"But if they look too different on the table, that will not be good either," he said.

Deepak opened the register.

"That is why we have kept the outer dimensions within limits too. Not identical. Among these thirty, the variation in the mouth is less than half a finger. The height variation is also within that range. Capacity is the main standard."

Meena said, "For me the capacity is important. If one ladle of dal looks the same in every bowl, serving becomes easy."

Arunesh turned one bowl in his hand.

Along its rim was a very faint mark left by finger pressure.

"Will marks like these remain?"

Ramcharan said, "Where a hand has touched, now and then they will."

"I need cleanliness."

"You will have cleanliness. We will not erase the hand."

Deepak looked at his grandfather.

His voice was not hard, but it was clear.

Arunesh set the bowl down again.

"I will take these thirty for a trial. We'll use them in the restaurant for two days. Then we will decide about the rest."

Deepak's stomach felt slightly hollow.

The order was still not fully secure.

The thirty bowls were wrapped separately in sacks and paper and sent away.

For two days the workshop waited for the phone.

Deepak kept making new bowls, but he stopped short of the target of one hundred.

Without Arunesh's answer, making the remaining seventy would be a risk.

Ramcharan continued working at his usual pace.

Deepak asked, "Aren't you worried?"

"I am."

"It doesn't show."

"Will showing worry make the bowls dry faster?"

Deepak laughed.

The call came two evenings later.

It was not Arunesh but Meena.

“Deepakji, there is one problem.”

Deepak’s smile vanished at once.

“What?”

“When we stack the bowls one inside another, some of them stick too tightly. In the kitchen we have to stack washed bowls quickly.”

Deepak fell silent.

He had not thought of that.

“The capacity is right,” Meena added. “Serving has become much easier. But control the slope between the base and the mouth a little, so they do not jam when one is placed inside another.”

Deepak immediately opened the register.

“How much difference do you need?”

“I’ll send you a short video. Watch it.”

After the call ended, Deepak told Ramcharan.

Ramcharan suggested adding a third measurement: “nesting”—how far one bowl went into another when stacked, and where it stopped.

Deepak said, “Then that is again a measurement of form.”

“A measurement of use,” Ramcharan corrected him.

Those two words stayed in Deepak’s mind.

Now “Nesting” was added beside “Capacity” in the register.

A small bamboo gauge was made.

It did not copy the outer body exactly.

It merely checked that the bowl’s slope did not curve inward so much that it would jam inside another bowl.

Ramcharan made the gauge himself.

Deepak asked, “You don’t like moulds.”

“Not moulds for identical shape. This is a boundary for use.”

Deepak looked at him for a few moments.

He was beginning to understand that his grandfather was not opposed to measurement.

He distinguished between measurement and imitation.

The remaining bowls were now made quickly, but not in the fear that had governed the first three days.

The raw lumps were nearly equal.

The mouths stayed within the range.

The heights stayed within the range.

The slope allowed easy stacking without sticking.

After firing, capacity was checked.

A bowl that was too high or too low in capacity received a black mark on its base and was separated from the restaurant batch.

A bowl slightly different in form, but correct in capacity and nesting, remained in the batch.

Deepak's "out" pile grew smaller.

Ramcharan's movements changed slightly too.

Before picking up a lump of clay, he began glancing towards the balance, though he did not weigh every piece.

One day Deepak joked, "Dada, now you are turning into a machine."

Ramcharan replied, "When the machine develops a backache like mine, I'll accept that."

Both laughed.

On the final morning of the third week, one hundred and eight fired bowls stood ready in the workshop.

Deepak checked the capacity of every one again.

One hundred and two fell within the chosen limit.

Six were high or low.

Of the one hundred and two, two still looked a little more different in form to him.

He looked at his grandfather.

Ramcharan asked, "Stomach?"

"Right."

"Nesting?"

"Right."

"Any breakage?"

"No."

"Then?"

Deepak placed the bowls in a row.

When the two differently shaped ones stood among the others, they did not look as different as they had when held alone.

"They stay," Deepak said.

Ramcharan said nothing.

He only put a tick beside those two serial numbers in the register.

Exactly one hundred bowls were selected for the restaurant.

Two more were added as spares in case any broke on the way.

Six were set aside for the house and the local shop.

This time Arunesh came himself with a vehicle.

Before loading, he looked over the hundred bowls.

"They do not look as identical as on the first day," he said.

The old tension stirred inside Deepak, but he opened the register.

"Not identical. The measurements of use are the same."

Meena was with him.

She stacked five bowls inside one another, then took them apart.

None stuck.

Deepak was about to demonstrate the water measure, but Meena raised her hand.

“We have already tested that.”

Holding one bowl, Arunesh said, “We will have to change the paper for the next batch.”

Deepak asked, “Which paper?”

“The order sheet. It currently says ‘same size.’ Those are not the right words.”

Ramcharan stood behind them.

Arunesh said, “We will write: capacity suitable for serving 280 millilitres; mouth and height within the specified range; easy nesting in stacks; natural variations of handwork acceptable.”

Deepak involuntarily looked towards his grandfather.

Ramcharan said only, “This time the paper is not eating from the bowl. It understands the work.”

Arunesh did not understand the reference, but Deepak laughed.

After the vehicle left, the workshop felt unusually empty.

Only the six separated bowls, some raw clay and the old brass measuring cup remained on the plank.

Janaki Devi picked up one of the rejected bowls.

“This one for curd?”

Deepak checked its capacity.

“This one holds a little more.”

“Why should I get less curd?”

Ramcharan laughed.

Deepak handed the bowl to his grandmother.

In the evening he sat down to put the register away.

On the first page were his old columns: mouth, height, base.

On later pages were capacity, batch, kiln date and nesting.

He looked at the serial numbers of the first five bowls he had rejected on the first day.

Two of them, if made now, could have entered the restaurant standard.

For a moment Deepak thought of crossing out the page, then did not.

In the corner he wrote:

“First measure: form. Later measure: use.”

Ramcharan read it from behind him.

“Is that a rule?”

Deepak said, “No. A reminder.”

Ramcharan sat down beside his old wheel.
“Then make a new bowl.”
“The order is finished.”
“We are short of bowls at home.”
Deepak sat on the other side of the wheel.
He picked up a lump of clay.
The balance was in front of him.
So were the bamboo strips.
The brass cup stood on the plank.
He placed the lump on the balance, then removed a little clay.
Ramcharan asked, “Measurements even for a bowl for home?”
Deepak said, “Not capacity. Just to warm my hand.”
The wheel began to turn.
The mouth of the first bowl opened.
One side was slightly higher, the other slightly lower.
Deepak raised a finger to even it out, then stopped.
He looked at the space inside, felt the thickness of the base, and slowed the wheel a little.
Ramcharan said nothing.
Deepak placed the bowl on the plank.
It was not exactly the same as another bowl.
But looking at it, Deepak’s first question was no longer how closely its shape matched.
He did not even reach for the brass measuring cup.
It was a bowl for home.
Its use was already known.

The Star on the Roof

As soon as the first star of evening appeared, Aditi would climb to the roof.

Her science teacher had given her the exercise:

for twenty days, at the same time, look at the sky in the same direction; write in a notebook what you can see, and also what you cannot see.

Aditi liked the second part of the exercise more.

Because sometimes what was absent from the sky said a great deal too: there might be cloud, dust, too much moonlight, or clothes hung on the roof might have come in the way.

That last reason led to her first disagreement with her aunt, Manjula Devi.

Even calling it a disagreement was perhaps too strong.

Neither of them raised her voice.

But when Aditi reached the roof, the place on the western side where she usually opened her star chart was occupied by a yellow bedsheet stretched between four bamboo poles.

The sheet was not there to be washed, but to dry.

Around it, two saris, three salwar garments, children's clothes and a long white towel were taking the air.

In the middle of the roof, papads had been spread on four cotton cloths.

In one corner were two winnowing trays of wheat, which Manjula Devi was letting catch the light evening breeze.

Aditi stopped on the last step of the staircase.

Seeing her, her aunt said, "It will take a little time today. These clothes stayed half-dry under clouds all day."

Aditi looked towards the western sky.

The sun had set, but the twenty minutes of evening her teacher had specified had already begun.

"How long?" she asked.

"Let the clothes air for a while. I have to turn the papads too."

"My star will go lower by then."

Manjula Devi laughed.

"Will the star go lower, or will the earth turn?"

Aditi did not laugh.

She folded her star chart and went to the northern side of the roof.

There was a water tank there, and from behind it half the western sky was cut off.

She opened her notebook.

She wrote the date.

She wrote the time.

Then she wrote: "Western view obstructed."

After a pause, she added: "Cause: clothes."

From a distance Manjula Devi asked, "Will you write my name too?"

"No need."

"Then did the clothes hang themselves?"

Aditi looked at her.

Her aunt was smiling.

After the word "clothes," Aditi made a small pair of brackets and wrote: "household use."

Manjula Devi said nothing when she saw that.

Aditi was fifteen.

She lived in town with her parents, but that year she had come to the ancestral house for two months during the school summer holidays.

Her grandfather was no longer alive.

Her grandmother too had died the previous winter.

Now the large courtyard house was occupied by her uncle and aunt, their two young children, while Aditi's parents came and went during holidays and leave.

For Aditi, the roof was the most beloved place in the house.

At their house in town, there was little to see from the roof beyond a water tank, wires and the walls of neighbouring buildings.

Here there were trees all around, fields stretching into the distance, and as soon as night fell the sky opened so wide that for the first two days she felt as though the number of stars had increased.

She had decided to do her science teacher's exercise here.

But for Manjula Devi, the roof was not merely a place for looking at the sky.

In the mornings, paddy or wheat was spread there.

In the afternoons there were papads, badis, jars of pickle, sometimes clothes.

When the rains lingered nearby, every dry hour on the roof had a different value.

Aditi knew that value, but she did not accept it.

The next day she went up first.

Half an hour before sunset.

On the western side she laid out the star chart, her notebook and a small torch covered with red paper.

Her teacher had said that red light disturbed the eyes' adjustment to darkness less.

When Manjula Devi came up, she found Aditi spread out in the western corner.

She was carrying two baskets.

"The papads go here," she said.

Aditi looked up.

"I came first today."

"The papads have been here since yesterday."

"But right now they are in the baskets."

"They will dry only when I spread them."

Aditi was silent for a few moments.

So was Manjula Devi.

Then she carried the baskets to the eastern side.

Aditi said, "There is less sunlight there."

"What remains today will get enough."

"Then will the papads spoil?"

"No. They will only take a little longer."

Aditi felt something like victory, but she was not happy.

That evening her chart was clear.

Low in the west she saw a bright point that might have been a planet rather than a star.

She sketched its position in the notebook.

While coming down the stairs, she noticed the first trace of dew settling on the papads on the eastern side.

At that moment Manjula Devi was coming up.

She touched the papads and immediately began gathering the cloth.

Aditi asked, "Have they got wet?"

"Not wet. But the wind has turned."

"How did you know the wind had turned?"

"By the smell."

Aditi sniffed the air around her.

She could smell only earth, cloth and pickle spices.

"What smell?"

"Dampness from the pond side below."

The answer did not sound scientific to Aditi.

She asked, "Did you measure the humidity?"

Lifting the papads, Manjula Devi said, "I used my fingers."

Aditi said nothing more.

On the third day the wind had been strong since afternoon.

When Aditi went up at evening, the western side was clear for her star chart.

But five saris were flapping from a long rope across the middle of the roof.

Whenever the wind lifted a sari, the sky opened.

Then the sari fell and covered the stars again.

Aditi kept trying to catch one star.

She saw it three times; the fourth time a sari came between.

Annoyed, she reached to lower the rope.

Just then Manjula Devi's voice came from behind.

"Do not untie the knot."

Aditi stopped her hand.

"I'll lower it for five minutes."

"In five minutes the wind will throw the saris onto the floor."

"I'll hold them."

"Will you watch the sky or hold five saris?"

Aditi let go.

That night she wrote in her notebook:

"Visibility repeatedly obstructed: wind + saris."

Below that, in a little anger, she wrote:

"Stable observation difficult because the roof is shared."

She stopped at the next line.

Then she wrote:

"Need a solution."

The next morning she found Manjula Devi in the kitchen.

Her aunt was kneading flour.

Dal was cooking on the stove.

Aditi said directly, "I need the roof every evening from seven to eight."

Manjula Devi left the dough and looked at her.

"The whole roof?"

"At least the western half."

"Between seven and eight, the clothes are taken down, papads are gathered, pickle jars are brought in."

"Can't all that be done at six?"

"Why should I gather at five what has sunlight until six?"

Aditi had come prepared with an answer, but that question was not in her notebook.

"Then at eight?"

"By then the dew will settle."

"Then when am I supposed to do my work?"

Manjula Devi got up to wash her hands.

"That is my question too."

For a few moments they looked at each other.

Washing her hands from a lota, Manjula Devi said, "The roof is yours too, and mine too. But the sky decides the time—for your stars, and for my sunlight."

Aditi found the sentence half appealing and half inconvenient.

She said, "The stars appear at almost the same time every day."

"The sunlight is not the same every day."

"Then let us divide the time."

"Divide it."

"Seven to seven-thirty for me."

"Not on the days after rain."

"Why?"

"The clothes will take longer to dry."

"Then what kind of rule is a rule if it keeps changing?"

Manjula Devi smiled.

"The rules of the sky and the rules of a house are different."

Aditi was irritated again.

She left the kitchen.

At noon her uncle went to the market.

The younger children were doing their schoolwork.

Aditi went alone to the roof.

She measured it.

It was about thirty-two cubits long and twenty-four cubits wide.

There was a small drain on the western side, the stairwell on the east, and the tank to the north.

She drew a map of the roof in her notebook.

She needed an eight-cubit strip on the west.

Her aunt usually spread papads across the open middle section.

The clothesline ran north to south, cutting across the western view.

Aditi drew three possibilities.

First: run the clothesline east to west.

Second: after afternoon, shift the papads to the eastern side.

Third: keep the western strip clear from seven to seven-thirty.

She took the map to her aunt.

Manjula Devi was not looking that way; she was breaking the stems from chillies.

Aditi placed the paper before her.

"Look at this."

Manjula Devi did not wear glasses, but when reading small writing she held the paper farther away.

"Is this the tank?"

"Yes."

"So small?"

"It is small on the map."

"Where are my papads?"

"Here."

"And your star?"

Aditi put her finger on the open strip to the west.

Manjula Devi looked at the map for a while.

"If the rope is turned, the clothes will catch less wind."

"Why?"

"In this month the wind usually comes from the south-west."

Aditi immediately asked, "Usually?"

"Not every day."

"Is there any written measurement for that?"

Breaking chilli stems, Manjula Devi said, "If your grandmother were alive, you could ask her. She would say that before Ashadh the wind changes its gait three times."

"That is not a scientific measurement."

"Then measure it."

Aditi stopped.

"What?"

"The wind. Write it down every day. You write about stars—write about the wind too."

Aditi folded the paper.

That evening her aunt did not spread the papads in the west.

But the clothesline still ran in the same direction.

Aditi looked at it and said nothing.

In a new corner of her notebook she wrote:

"Wind: south-west, moderate."

From behind her Manjula Devi asked, "How do you know it is moderate?"

"According to me."

"Then that is scientific?"

Aditi laughed without meaning to.

It was the first time they had laughed together since the disagreement began.

For the next four days, the experiment continued.

At seven in the evening Aditi used the western strip.

Manjula Devi did her gathering-up in the middle and eastern parts of the roof.

If clothes still hung on the western rope, her aunt took half of them down before seven.

Aditi dealt with the rest after seven-thirty.

In return, Aditi began helping to gather the papads.

On the first day she stacked two papads on top of each other.

Manjula Devi separated them immediately.

"If you keep them like this, the steam will be trapped."

"Even after they are this dry?"

"Dry on the surface. Still a little soft inside."

Aditi held one papad to her ear, as if she might hear the dampness inside.

Her aunt laughed.

"Can you hear it?"

"No."

"Bend it with your fingers."

Aditi bent it lightly.

The papad did not break; it only curved a little.

"Now?"

"There is still moisture inside," Manjula Devi said.

Aditi could not resist the urge to write it down.

She added a small line:

"Papad: surface dry, slight moisture inside; bending test."

Manjula Devi looked at the notebook.

"Your papads have entered among the stars."

"The roof is shared."

As soon as Aditi heard herself say that, she was slightly surprised.

On the fifth day the sky was perfectly clear.

The evening wind had fallen still.

The clothes had dried in the afternoon.

The papads too had been gathered on time.

The entire western strip was empty.

Aditi sat with the red torch, star chart and notebook spread before her.

First she wrote the position of the moon.

Then she began searching for the shape of the Great Bear.

After a while Manjula Devi came up.

Her hands were empty.

Aditi asked, "No work today?"

"Today I came to look at your roof."

The sentence sounded odd to Aditi.

She shifted slightly to make room.

Manjula Devi sat on the floor, but held the chart upside down.

Aditi turned it around.

“Look at these seven stars. Four make something like a box, and three make a tail.”

Manjula Devi looked at the sky.

“The one that is tilted a little?”

“Yes.”

“I have been seeing that since childhood.”

“Did you know its name?”

“No. My mother used to call them the Seven Sisters.”

Aditi at once bent towards the notebook.

“Wait,” Manjula Devi said. “Must everything be written down?”

Aditi stopped her hand.

“I’ll write it later.”

For a while the two simply watched the sky.

Manjula Devi pointed at one star.

“Why does that one look still?”

Aditi tried to explain the Pole Star, the turning of the earth, and how direction stays fixed—the way her teacher had explained it.

Manjula Devi listened carefully.

Then she said, “So old people must have watched the stars for direction.”

“Yes.”

“I watch the roof for sunlight. You watch the sky for direction.”

“For stars.”

“Stars give direction too, don’t they?”

Aditi smiled.

“Sometimes.”

That night Aditi wrote in her notebook:

“Observation: Great Bear clear. Pole Star shown.”

Then, after a pause, she added:

“Kaki calls them the Seven Sisters.”

The next afternoon clouds suddenly gathered.

From the courtyard Manjula Devi shouted, “Aditi, the roof!”

Aditi dropped her book and ran.

Wheat was spread upstairs.

There were two sheets of clothes.

Four jars of pickle.

The wind was strengthening.

Without argument they both went to work.

Aditi lifted the wheat cloth by all four corners and dragged it inside.

Manjula Devi carried the jars towards the staircase.

The first heavy drops struck the roof just as the last winnowing tray came in.

They stood in the stairwell catching their breath.
 Aditi asked, "How did you know before it started?"
 "The south-west wind suddenly turned cold."
 "The smell?"
 "That too."
 Aditi put out her hand and caught a drop.
 Manjula Devi asked, "Will you write it in your notebook?"
 "I will."
 "My name?"
 Aditi laughed.
 "This time I will."
 The rain stopped half an hour later.
 At night the sky opened again, but the roof was wet.
 Aditi sat on the threshold of the stairwell and looked up at the sky.
 Manjula Devi walked barefoot over the wet roof, checking where water had collected.
 "Do not sit there," she said. "You will slip."
 "I'll watch from here."
 "Leave the stars for today."
 "It is a twenty-day exercise."
 Manjula Devi said nothing.
 She went inside and brought an old bamboo stool.
 "Sit on this."
 Aditi sat on the stool.
 Through breaks in the clouds, stars appeared and disappeared one after another.
 In her notebook she wrote:
 "Visibility unstable; clouds after rain."
 Below it:
 "Roof wet; stool used."
 She did not write her aunt's name.
 But in brackets she added: "assistance."
 The days passed.
 Aditi's notebook was no longer only a star notebook.
 One page contained wind, another moonlight, a third the times at which the roof was used.
 Sometimes she wrote:
 "No papads today; western strip clear from 6:55."
 Sometimes:
 "Clothes remained late; observation from north side."
 One day her aunt said, "The wind will change tomorrow. Let us see."

The next day the wind really did blow from the east.

Aditi asked, "How did you predict it?"

"I watched the clouds moving in the morning."

"Are you right every time?"

"No."

"Then why don't you write it down?"

Manjula Devi stopped while folding clothes.

"For whom would I write it?"

"For yourself."

"My work goes on without writing."

Aditi thought for a moment.

"My stars would go on just by looking too. The teacher gave me the notebook, so I write."

"Then your teacher did right. Writing lets yesterday's thing meet you today."

"Where will your yesterday's thing meet you?"

Manjula Devi did not answer.

The next morning Aditi brought a thin notebook from the market.

At the top she wrote: "Rooftop Routine."

Seeing it, Manjula Devi said, "I do not want homework."

"It is not homework. Write only when you feel like it."

"What?"

"How much sun, which way the wind came from, what was dried, when it was brought in."

"If I write all that, when will I do the work?"

"One line."

Manjula Devi put the notebook on a cupboard shelf.

For three days it remained empty.

On the fourth day Aditi saw thick handwriting on the first page:

"Strong sun in the morning. Clouds from east after noon. Badis kept out three hours longer."

Aditi said nothing.

She merely left the next page blank.

By the end of the week, both notebooks had begun to stay together on the roof.

Aditi wrote about stars.

Manjula Devi sometimes wrote one line about sunlight, sometimes two words about wind.

One night the electricity went out.

The village suddenly sank into darkness.

Apart from two or three distant houses with battery lamps, everything became dim.

Aditi ran to the roof.

The sky looked fuller than before.

She froze as soon as she looked up.

Where darkness usually seemed empty, faint stars had emerged everywhere.

Manjula Devi came up behind her.

“Your work has increased today.”

“Yes.”

“Mine has decreased. There is no light to inspect the clothes.”

Aditi handed her the red torch.

“Take this.”

Manjula Devi shone the red light on the clothes.

“This makes the clothes look red.”

“Do not look at the colour. Touch and check the moisture.”

Her aunt looked at her.

Aditi laughed at herself.

“The finger test.”

Manjula Devi laughed too.

That night they worked in separate corners of the roof.

Manjula Devi gathered the clothes.

Aditi tried to count the stars, even though her teacher had clearly told her not to count them but to recognise patterns.

After gathering the clothes, her aunt came over.

“Where are the Seven Sisters today?”

Aditi searched the sky and showed her.

“And that bright one?”

“That may be a planet. I’ll compare it with the chart tomorrow.”

“Not a star?”

“Not everything that shines is a star.”

Manjula Devi said softly, “Not everything spread on a roof is clothing either.”

Aditi understood that her aunt was joking.

But she liked the sentence.

The last week of the holidays arrived.

Aditi’s twenty-day exercise was complete, but she did not stop going to the roof.

One evening Manjula Devi asked, “Your school assignment is finished, isn’t it?”

“Yes.”

“Then why do you come every day?”

Aditi closed the notebook.

"It has become a habit."

"The stars?"

Aditi thought for a moment.

"The roof."

That evening the red glow in the west lingered for a long time.

There were no papads.

Only two sheets hung on the rope, and they were brought in by half past six.

Aditi and Manjula Devi sat in the middle of the roof.

Her aunt opened her "Rooftop Routine" notebook.

"Look. In these fifteen days, clouds came from the east after noon five times. Three times there was rain by evening."

Aditi looked at the notebook.

"You are making data."

"What is data?"

"Information about the same thing written down repeatedly."

"Then am I a scientist too?"

"A little."

"Why only a little?"

"Because the sample is small."

Manjula Devi laughed loudly.

"How large is your sample?"

"Twenty days."

"Then yours is small too."

Aditi had no answer.

Both kept laughing.

The next evening there was a new arrangement on the roof.

Her uncle fixed two small hooks so that part of the clothesline could be loosened and shifted towards the east when needed.

It was not a permanent solution.

Depending on the wind, the rope would return to its old direction.

But between seven and seven-thirty, when Aditi was observing, the eight-cubit strip on the west was usually clear.

In return, Aditi helped with the evening gathering-up.

No one wrote this arrangement as a rule and nailed it to a wall.

It continued because both of them kept watching the time.

One day Manjula Devi came up late.

Aditi was already on the roof.

The western strip was clear.

In the middle, the cloth of papads was still spread out.

The sun was setting.
Aditi could have begun her own work if she wanted.
She touched a papad.
There was still a little moisture inside.
She bent it to check.
It still flexed.
She brought the basket, but did not gather them.
Instead, she lifted the four corners of the cloth and changed the direction in which the air was reaching them.
When Manjula Devi came up, she asked, "The stars?"
"Five minutes later."
"Why?"
"These are not ready yet."
Manjula Devi touched one papad.
"You are right."
Aditi smiled.
"My finger test."
"Not mine. Yours now too."
Five minutes later the papads were gathered.
Aditi sat in the western strip.
Manjula Devi picked up the empty basket and started towards the stairs, then stopped.
"Can you see the Seven Sisters today?"
Aditi looked up.
"They will become clear in a little while."
Manjula Devi put the basket down and sat.
"Then I'll wait a little."
The sky slowly deepened.
First one star, then another, then the familiar pattern of seven emerged.
Aditi pointed out the direction with her finger.
This time Manjula Devi recognised it at once.
"There."
"Yes."
"And the Pole Star?"
Aditi joined two stars in her mind to estimate the direction, then pointed to a dim point farther away.
Manjula Devi looked at it for a long time.
"Something so dim gives direction?"
"It does."
"It is not only bright things that are useful."
Aditi said nothing.

She very much wanted to write that sentence in her notebook.
But she kept the notebook closed.
After a while Manjula Devi asked, "Will there be sun tomorrow morning?"
Aditi looked at the sky.
"I do not know."
"The clouds?"
"There are a few."
"The wind?"
Aditi raised her palm and felt it.
"South-west."
"Then your guess?"
Aditi smiled.
"I'll write it in the notebook tomorrow."
Manjula Devi smiled too.
From the courtyard below came a child's voice:
"Ma, the rice!"
Manjula Devi got up.
"Come on. Stars will not fill the stomach."
Aditi stood too.
Before going down, she looked once more at the roof.
The rope was tied loose towards the east.
The papad cloth was folded.
The western strip was empty.
The sky spread above that empty strip.
But Aditi now understood that the sky did not reveal itself only in empty space.
Sometimes its form opened between clothes, papads, wind, dew and baskets as well.
As they went down, Manjula Devi asked, "What time tomorrow?"
Aditi said, "First we'll check the papads. Then the stars."
Manjula Devi said, "And if there are clouds?"
Aditi stopped at the turn of the stairs and smiled.
"Then I'll write the clouds."

The Thin Curtain

When a new person joins a household, the first thing to change is often not a room, but the route people take through the house.

Lalita understood what that meant on the third day after her wedding.

Amresh's home was an old house built around a square courtyard.

The kitchen was on the east, two rooms on the south, the grain room on the west, and a long veranda on the north.

At one end of the veranda was Amresh's room; at the other, the room of his grandmother, Saraswati Devi.

The veranda between them was also a passage through the house.

In the morning the milkman passed that way.

The children went out to school through it.

At noon the women sat there sorting paddy.

In the evening Babuji pulled out a cot and sat there.

Late into the night someone or other crossed it to fetch water, give medicine, or check a door.

Lalita liked the room.

It had two windows: one towards the courtyard, the other towards the bamboo grove.

There was an old wooden cupboard, a low stool, a small table, and a niche built into the wall.

But the moment the door was opened, the whole veranda could see inside.

For the first two days Lalita took this simply as the nature of the house.

On the third day, while she was changing clothes inside, seven-year-old Pihu came running along the veranda, stopped at the doorway and asked, "Kaki, have you seen my ribbon?"

Startled, Lalita pulled her sari end across herself.

"No."

Pihu ran away.

A little later Amresh came in.

Lalita said quietly, "If I keep the door shut, everyone in the house thinks I am upset."

Amresh did not laugh.

“Yes.”

“If I leave it open, someone or other comes right in front of me.”

“Yes.”

“Is there no way between the two?”

Amresh looked at the doorway.

“Shall we hang a curtain?”

Lalita said nothing.

That evening Amresh brought a thick cloth curtain from the market.

It was a pale, dusty green, with small iron rings along the top.

As soon as the elder sister-in-law saw it, she said, “This will be good. There will be no need to keep the door closed all day.”

Amresh stretched a rope between two pillars of the veranda.

The curtain was hung there.

The veranda was divided into two parts.

The curtain stood about three cubits in front of the room door.

Someone inside could change clothes, sit on the cot, or talk in privacy.

From outside, only the dull green surface of the curtain could be seen.

For the first time Lalita felt at ease.

That night she said to Amresh, “It was such a small thing, yet for three days I hesitated to say it.”

Amresh replied, “The house is old. The need is new.”

Both thought that was the whole problem.

The next morning, when Saraswati Devi opened the door of her room, it was darker inside than before.

Her room had no window of its own.

It once had.

Ten years earlier, when the neighbour built a new brick house on the northern side, a wall rose directly in front of the window.

A gap of half a cubit remained between them, but more air than light came through it.

The real light for Saraswati Devi’s room came from the eastern end of the veranda.

In the morning, as the sun rose above the courtyard, a long white band of light formed across the veranda.

That band slowly shifted until it reached her doorway.

As the day advanced, even the inner wall of her room brightened from it.

The new curtain stood exactly across that path.

Saraswati Devi stood in her doorway for a while and looked.

Then she brought her low stool out from the room and placed it on the veranda.

Sitting there, she put on her glasses and began mending her tulsi-bead rosary.

On her way to the kitchen, Lalita saw her.

“Dadi, won’t you sit inside?”

“The air is good here.”

Lalita went on.

For two days she noticed nothing more.

On the third afternoon it rained.

The sky was grey, and even the veranda was dim.

Lalita went into Saraswati Devi’s room to put away a bottle of oil.

Dadi was sitting on the cot, knotting a loose thread along the edge of an old cloth.

When Lalita entered, her eyes took a few moments to adjust.

“Dadi, shall I turn on the light?”

“In daytime?”

“It is dark.”

Saraswati Devi bit off the thread with her teeth.

“It is a rainy day.”

Lalita switched on the light.

In the yellow glow the room suddenly became clear.

Then her eyes went towards the doorway.

Directly outside it, the dull green curtain was fully drawn.

“Does this curtain stop the light?”

Saraswati Devi looked at her over her glasses.

“A little.”

“A little?”

“On clear days some light comes from above too.”

“But before?”

“Before, there was no curtain.”

Lalita fell silent.

Saraswati Devi began threading the needle again.

“Let the curtain stay.”

“Your room has become dark.”

“Your room has gained privacy.”

“I’ll have the curtain removed.”

Saraswati Devi stopped the needle.

“Why?”

“It blocks the light.”

“So it must go?”

“What else?”

Saraswati Devi placed the needle on the cot.

“A new need came into the house, and a solution was found for it. That solution hurt another need. So should the first need be erased?”

Lalita did not answer.

“There are so many people in this house,” Dadi said. “Privacy for a newly married couple is not a luxury.”

Hearing her own difficulty spoken aloud by Dadi embarrassed Lalita and relieved her at the same time.

“But should you sit with the electric light on in daytime?”

“That is not right either.”

“Then?”

“Then ask the curtain.”

Lalita smiled.

“Will the curtain answer?”

“If it is cloth, it can be cut, folded or moved. If it were a wall, it would be harder.”

That evening Lalita did not remove the curtain.

But for the first time she looked at it as a problem.

The curtain stretched about seven cubits from one end of the rope to the other.

There was a gap of three fingers between its top and the eaves, and it hung four fingers above the floor.

Air could pass through those two gaps, but not light.

When Amresh returned from work, Lalita said, “The curtain is not in the right place.”

“Shall we hang it closer to the room door?”

“Then there will be less privacy.”

“Farther from Dadi’s door?”

“People walk through the veranda here. Move it too far and the passage will be blocked.”

Amresh looked at the curtain.

“What if we leave it half open during the day?”

Lalita slid it halfway and looked.

Light reached Dadi’s room, but from the courtyard Amresh’s cot could be seen directly.

“No.”

“Shall we cut away the upper half?”

“Then a standing person will be able to see inside from above.”

“From below?”

“Pihu is below already.”

Both laughed.

But no solution appeared.

The matter came up at the family meal the next day.
 Babuji said, "Move Dadi to another room."
 Saraswati Devi replied at once, "No."
 "The southern room has a window."
 "Then rearrange my medicines, trunk, shrine shelf—everything there again."
 "We will."
 "Why should I leave my own room?"
 Babuji fell silent.
 The elder sister-in-law said, "Make the curtain from thinner cloth."
 Lalita liked the idea.
 The next day she hung one of her old white cotton sheets on the rope to test it.
 The room really did become brighter.
 But in the evening, when a lamp was lit inside, the silhouettes of Lalita and Amresh were clearly visible from outside.
 Pihu and her little brother Nanhku stopped while passing through the veranda.
 "Kaki, your shadow has become huge!"
 Lalita immediately switched off the light.
 The sheet was taken down that night.
 When Saraswati Devi heard what had happened, she laughed.
 "Thin cloth is a friend of the day, not of the night."
 The sentence stayed in Lalita's mind.
 The next morning she hung the sheet again, but this time only as an experiment.
 She wanted to see exactly where the sunlight came from.
 At eight, light was on the eastern wall of the courtyard.
 At half past eight it touched the first pillar of the veranda.
 At nine the left edge of the curtain brightened.
 At nine twenty the light fell on the middle portion of the curtain.
 Lalita marked the floor with small pieces of chalk as the light moved.
 Saraswati Devi sat in the doorway watching.
 "What are you measuring?"
 "Your light."
 "Can light be measured?"
 "For today."
 By ten o'clock there were five chalk marks on the floor.
 Lalita understood that the light reaching Dadi's room did not travel in a straight line.
 As the sun climbed, its path shifted to the right.

Because the curtain covered the full width, it blocked every one of those paths.

If one section in the middle were removed, light could travel directly to Dadi's doorway for about an hour and a half.

But from that same opening, the inside of Amresh's room would also be visible.

Lalita stood in the courtyard and looked from different angles.

There was one position from which light could reach Dadi's doorway, but Amresh's cot could not be seen.

A pillar stood in between.

Lalita picked up the chalk again.

"Dadi, sit here."

"Why?"

"Look."

Saraswati Devi dragged her low stool to the chalk mark and sat.

Lalita folded the left half of the curtain and tucked it against the right.

"Light?"

"It is coming."

"Can you see inside from the courtyard?"

Saraswati Devi turned her neck and looked.

"The cot is visible."

The experiment failed again.

Lalita let the curtain fall.

That afternoon the elder sister-in-law was hanging saris on two ropes outside the veranda to dry.

One rope was in front, the other behind.

The saris were not all on the same line.

The clothes on the front rope left spaces between them, while those on the rear rope covered those spaces.

Lalita stood there watching for a while.

The kitchen inside could not be seen directly from the courtyard.

Yet light entered in broken pieces between the two ropes.

Suddenly she asked, "Bhabi, why are these two ropes at different distances?"

Her sister-in-law looked surprised.

"How would so many clothes fit on one rope?"

"No, I mean—why one in front and one behind?"

"Because that is where the pillars are. That is where we tied them."

Lalita went straight to the curtain.

Saraswati Devi was watching.

"What happened?"

"One curtain is too straight."

“Will you make the curtain crooked?”

“I’ll make two.”

That evening when Amresh returned, Lalita was sitting on the floor with two lines drawn in chalk.

One marked the place of the original curtain.

The second was about a cubit and a half behind it, closer to the door of Amresh’s room.

“What is this?”

“Two curtains.”

“If we hang both, it will become even darker.”

“Not on the same line.”

Lalita showed him with the chalk.

“The first panel from here to here. The second behind it from here to here. The gaps between them will not face each other directly.”

Amresh looked for a while.

“From the courtyard, behind the first opening there will be the second curtain.”

“Yes.”

“And the light?”

“It can find a slanting path between them from above.”

“At night?”

“At night we slide both so they overlap.”

Amresh measured the pillars.

“Not ropes. We need two thin bamboo rods. The rings can slide along them.”

From her doorway Saraswati Devi said, “Try it with cloth first. Cut bamboo later.”

The next day two old sheets were chosen for the experiment.

One green, one white.

The elder sister-in-law used the sewing machine to make both into long narrow panels.

The first panel was hung on the front rope.

It covered the left half of the veranda.

The second panel was hung a cubit and a half behind it on another rope.

It covered the right half.

Seen from the courtyard, the two together formed a staggered screen.

There was a path between them for air and light, but no straight path for the eye.

Pihu was called for the test.

“Can you see Kaka’s cot from here?”

Pihu looked from the left.

“No.”

She went to the right.

“I can see the chair from here.”

Lalita slid the second panel four fingers farther.

“Now?”

“No.”

Nanhku crouched down near the floor to look.

The elder sister-in-law lightly smacked the top of his head.

“Is this the only work you have?”

Nanhku ran away laughing.

Saraswati Devi said, “It is necessary to test with a child’s eyes. Grown people look only while standing.”

By noon the two-panel screen had been adjusted.

But the real test came the next morning.

From eight o’clock Lalita sat in Dadi’s room.

At first there was only a greyish light.

At half past eight, sunlight from the courtyard touched the veranda.

At nine, the edge of the first panel brightened.

At nine fifteen, the light found the slanting path between the two panels and touched the frame of Dadi’s doorway.

Lalita stood up.

The white strip slowly moved inward.

First the floor.

Then the leg of the cot.

Then the wall opposite.

Saraswati Devi was untangling thread with her glasses on.

She took off her glasses and looked at the wall.

“Now?” Lalita asked.

“Now the day has come inside.”

Lalita said nothing.

Saraswati Devi put her glasses back on.

The experiment seemed successful.

But in the evening another problem appeared.

Because the two panels stood on different lines, under the outside light at night one corner of the room could be seen through the slanting passage between them.

Amresh said, “A daytime solution is incomplete at night.”

Lalita slid the second panel until it came in front of the first.

The two panels overlapped by four fingers.

Inside, there was complete privacy.

“Like this at night.”

“And in the morning?”
 “Back to the chalk marks.”
 She darkened two small marks on the floor.
 The first: Day.
 The second: Night.
 Saraswati Devi watched.
 “Will the curtain tell the time too?”
 Lalita laughed.
 “Someone or other will.”
 For three days the house used the arrangement this way.
 In the morning Lalita or Amresh slid the panels to the daytime marks.
 After noon, when the sun climbed overhead, if more privacy was needed,
 one panel was moved slightly again.
 In the evening, before the lamps were lit, both panels came to the
 nighttime marks.
 No one issued an order.
 Slowly the household learned.
 Sometimes, returning from school, Pihu would notice that the curtain was
 not at the daytime mark and ask, “Kaki, has night come already?”
 Lalita would say, “No, the wind is strong.”
 Sometimes Saraswati Devi herself used the end of her walking stick to push
 a ring and move one panel two fingers.
 “Dadi, you could have called me.”
 “The curtain belongs to my light too.”
 At that sentence Lalita looked at her.
 Saraswati Devi went on untangling thread without smiling.
 A few days later, they discussed cutting the new thick green curtain.
 Amresh hesitated.
 “It is new.”
 Lalita said, “Cloth is for work, not for remaining whole.”
 The elder sister-in-law brought out the sewing machine.
 The curtain was not cut straight down the middle into two equal halves.
 According to the measurements, one panel was made slightly wider, the
 other narrower.
 The edges were doubled over and stitched.
 Separate rings were fixed along the tops.
 Amresh smoothed two thin bamboo rods and fitted them between the
 pillars—one in front, one behind.
 Saraswati Devi took two small brass-coloured bells from her old trunk.
 “What are these for?”
 “Tie one to the last ring of each panel.”

Lalita was surprised.

“They’ll make a noise.”

“Not much. If someone draws the curtain at night, the person inside will know.”

Amresh shook one bell in his hand.

The sound was very soft.

One bell was attached to the edge of each curtain panel.

Now, when a panel moved by day, there was a faint chime.

When the curtains were closed at night, two chimes came together and stopped.

Lalita liked that sound.

A week later Amresh’s maternal cousin arrived with his family.

The veranda filled with people.

Children ran about, women talked, men pulled out cots and sat.

Earlier, on such a day, Lalita would have kept the room door closed.

This time the door remained open.

The two daytime curtain panels stood in their places.

Inside, Lalita folded clothes on the table.

She could hear the voices outside and feel the air coming in, but everyone’s eyes did not reach inside.

There was light in Saraswati Devi’s room too.

Sitting beside Dadi and looking at old photographs, a cousin said, “Was there always this much light in this room?”

Saraswati Devi replied, “There was light. For a few days in between, the curtain ate it.”

Lalita heard from the other end of the veranda.

Dadi added, “Then the curtain was taught its path.”

Everyone laughed.

Lalita did too.

But that night, after the guests had gone to sleep, she said to Amresh, “Why didn’t Dadi tell us earlier that her room had become dark?”

Amresh was quiet for a while.

“Perhaps she thought the curtain would be removed.”

“She did not want it removed.”

“That is why.”

“Why did I not understand earlier either?”

“Because you needed your privacy.”

Lalita touched the bell on the curtain.

“Is it wrong to see one’s own need?”

“No.”

“And to see someone else’s need late?”

Amresh thought before answering.

“If it is late, what you do after seeing it matters more.”

Lalita said nothing to that.

She slid both panels to the nighttime marks.

Chime.

Chime.

The two edges overlapped.

The following month the monsoon clouds thickened.

For three days the sun did not appear clearly.

Saraswati Devi’s room became grey again.

The two-panel arrangement could not create sunlight.

Lalita switched on the light at noon.

“This time the curtain is not at fault,” Dadi said.

“I know.”

“Then why that face?”

“I thought the solution was complete.”

Saraswati Devi laughed.

“In a house, complete solutions are rare.”

“Then?”

“You have to keep adjusting them.”

When the rain stopped, Amresh examined the old blocked window in the northern wall.

The gap from the neighbour’s wall was small, but a little light opening could be made in the upper part.

Babuji asked a mason.

The mason said two upper bricks could be removed and a grille fitted; direct rain would not enter.

Saraswati Devi agreed.

“Because the curtain was made, we remembered the window,” she said.

A few days later the small light opening was made.

It did not bring strong sunlight, but a steady grey light began entering.

Lalita thought perhaps the curtain arrangement would no longer be so necessary.

But the curtains remained as they were.

Because their work had not been only to save Dadi’s light.

They had added a new manner of living to the movement of the house.

Before, the veranda had been only everyone’s passage.

Now, within that passage, there was also an acknowledgement that in a shared house a person could have a right to privacy.

And also that making privacy did not require erasing someone else’s air, light, passage or habit.

One Kartik morning Lalita woke a little late.
Amresh had already gone out.
The curtains were still fully closed in their nighttime position.
She looked at the clock.
The sun had risen.
Lalita got up quickly, but before she reached the doorway she heard a faint chime.
Chime.
Then another.
Saraswati Devi was using the end of her walking stick to slide the first panel towards its daytime mark.
From behind the curtain Lalita said, "Dadi, leave it. I'll do it."
"It is done."
"It is difficult for you."
"Pushing it two fingers is not difficult."
Through the slanting gap between the two panels Lalita saw her.
Saraswati Devi sat down on her low stool.
A little later the light climbed from the courtyard onto the veranda.
It touched the first bamboo rod.
It passed between the two panels.
Then it drew a thin white line across Dadi's threshold.
At that moment Pihu came running from the courtyard.
Reaching the curtain, she asked out of habit, "Kaki, may I come in?"
Lalita said, "Come."
Instead of lifting the edge of the curtain panel, Pihu began searching for the open passage between the two.
"Not through there," Lalita said. "Go around to the right."
Pihu went around to the right and came inside.
The line of light did not break.

The Measure of Shade

It was the first week of Bhadav.

The old neem tree standing at the south-west corner of the school was still green, but on the wall beneath it a long crack showed as clearly as a fresh streak of light.

The crack had existed before.

For a long time the children had taken it simply for an old line in the wall.

But this time the line had grown from beneath the window to the corner of the frame.

At eight in the morning an engineer from the buildings department arrived.

With him were the headmistress, Sudha Jha, the science teacher, Nalini Kumari, and Ramcharit Kaka, the school attendant.

The engineer first measured the crack.

Then he bent outside the wall and examined the neem roots.

Two thick roots had passed beneath the cement drain and grown towards the wall's foundation.

The drain had risen in three places.

Ramcharit Kaka said, "These bulges were not here last year."

The engineer nodded.

He tested the wall joints with a small iron probe, then inspected the classroom from inside.

"Keep this classroom empty for now," he said.

Sudha Jha asked, "What if only the roots are cut?"

The engineer looked at the neem.

"If roots this thick are cut, there will be less certainty that the tree can remain standing safely. The wall will need separate repairs too. Have the tree and the building assessed together."

He did not order the tree to be cut immediately.

But by noon his words had spread through the school.

Madhura of Class Nine first heard that the neem was going to be cut down.

She left the science room and went straight to the tree.

Five children were already gathered there.

One touched the trunk.
 Another looked upward.
 Someone said, "They are going to cut such an old tree?"
 Madhura looked at the crack in the wall.
 For the first time she noticed that the distance between tree and wall really was very small.
 There were not even four cubits between the trunk and the wall.
 At noon the neem's shade reached across half the school veranda.
 The earthen water pot was kept beneath it.
 During the midday break the children sat there with their lunch boxes.
 After examinations, the small assembly where results were announced was also held in that shade.
 Madhura said, "We will not let them cut it."
 Amar of Class Eight said at once, "We'll write a petition."
 "To whom?"
 "The headmistress."
 "She wants the tree cut too."
 No one remembered exactly who had first said that.
 But within half an hour the sentence had become a truth in the school.
 When Nalini Kumari entered Class Nine that afternoon, someone had already written on the blackboard:
 "SAVE THE NEEM."
 She erased nothing.
 Opening her notebook, she said, "Today's lesson was supposed to be temperature. But first tell me this: when you say 'save the neem,' what do you want to save?"
 Amar said, "The tree."
 "What in the tree?"
 "The tree itself."
 The class laughed.
 Amar grew annoyed.
 Nalini Kumari did not laugh.
 "The trunk?" she asked.
 "Yes."
 "The leaves?"
 "Those too."
 "The roots?"
 No one answered.
 "The shade?"
 Several voices answered together, "Yes."
 "The birds?"

“Yes.”

“The coolness around the water pot?”

Madhura was slightly startled.

She had not thought of that before.

Nalini Kumari asked again, “And the wall of Class Seven?”

This time no one said yes.

Under “SAVE THE NEEM” on the blackboard she wrote four words:

“WHAT IS TO BE SAVED?”

Madhura raised her hand.

“If the wall is really unsafe, then the classroom has to be saved too.”

“Right.”

Amar said, “Another wall can be built. A neem this large cannot grow again quickly.”

Nalini Kumari did not dismiss that either.

“That is also a valid question.”

No decision was taken that day.

The next day a horticulture officer came from the district horticulture office.

His name was Shashibhushan Mandal.

He did not tap the trunk and stop there; he walked around the tree.

He examined the soil, the raised roots, the distance between trunk and wall, and the heavy branches above.

The engineer came again.

The two spoke for a long time.

The children watched from the windows.

At last the headmistress called two representatives from every class to the veranda.

Sudha Jha said clearly, “No work will be done without hearing what you have to say. But the findings of the inspection will not be hidden either.”

The engineer showed them the crack in the wall.

“This is not merely a line in the plaster,” he said.

The horticulture officer said, “It is difficult to say that the tree will remain safe if we simply cut the roots. Strong winds come through this place. Weakening a major root on one side may increase the risk.”

Amar asked, “Can the tree be moved somewhere else?”

Shashibhushan Mandal looked at the trunk.

“A tree this large, this close to a building, with roots like these—it is not as simple in reality as it looks on paper.”

“Then it has to be cut?” Madhura asked.

There was a short silence before the answer.

"In my assessment," the engineer said, "to make the building safe, this tree will have to be removed."

"Removed means cut," Amar said.

"For a tree of this size, yes."

Some of the children's faces fell.

Ramcharit Kaka stood beside a veranda pillar.

Madhura looked at him.

He had not worked at the school for forty-nine years, but he carried forty-nine years of the school's story in his memory.

His own service had begun thirty-five years earlier.

The neem had already been large then.

After the meeting Madhura went to him.

"Kaka, how old is this neem?"

Ramcharit Kaka smiled.

"Older than my job."

"Was it this large when you first came?"

"A little thinner. But it gave shade even then."

"Who planted it?"

"I do not know."

Madhura was surprised.

"No one in the school knows?"

"If it is in an old register, look there."

"You do not remember?"

"I can tell you what I saw. When I came here, it was already here."

Madhura found the answer disappointing.

She had wanted the tree to have a beautiful beginning-story.

A name.

Someone's hand.

Ramcharit Kaka understood from her face.

"Not finding a name does not make the tree less old," he said.

Two days later the children prepared a petition.

Three pages long.

Its title was:

"Request for the Preservation of the School's Old Neem Tree."

Madhura was part of the writing group.

The petition mentioned shade, birds, old assemblies, environment and memory.

At the end Amar added:

"A felled tree cannot be joined back together."

Everyone liked that line.

Sudha Jha read the entire petition.

Then she asked, "Have you read the wall inspection report?"

No one had.

"What the horticulture officer wrote?"

No.

"Then the petition says, 'The tree is completely safe.' Where did that statement come from?"

The class representatives were silent.

Amar said, "We thought..."

"Thinking and an inspection report are not the same thing."

Sudha Jha did not return the petition.

She gave them copies of both reports.

"Read them, then give me the petition again. Wanting to save the tree is not wrong. But if you erase the findings of the inspection, who will carry the weight of the tree you save?"

That night Madhura read the reports.

Some words were difficult.

She asked her father.

He was not a mason; he worked at the post office.

He did not understand everything either.

But one sentence was clear:

"The principal roots have entered the foundation zone of the wall; unilateral cutting of roots may affect the stability of the tree."

Madhura read the line in the petition again:

"The tree is completely safe."

She crossed it out in pencil.

The next day the group met again.

Amar was dissatisfied.

"If we keep crossing things out like this, the petition will become weak."

Madhura said, "A lie does not make it strong."

"Then write: cut the tree?"

"No."

"Then what?"

Madhura could not answer.

Just then Nalini Kumari entered the classroom.

In her hands were four thermometers, a long measuring tape and a small box of white chalk.

"The temperature lesson is still pending," she said.

Amar made a face.

"At a time like this?"

"At exactly this time."

She took them all to the neem.

It was ten twenty in the morning.

"For five days beginning today," Nalini Kumari said, "we will not measure arguments for or against the neem. We will measure what the tree does."

"The tree's work?"

"Yes. If you want to save something, understand not only its form, but its function."

She put a small chalk mark on the ground.

"The edge of the trunk's shade is here right now."

The measuring tape was stretched.

The outer edge of the shade was marked.

The time—10:20—was written down.

Two thermometers were placed in sunlight, two in shade.

The location of the water pot was marked.

The veranda steps where children sat were measured too.

Madhura drew a map in her notebook.

Amar asked, "Will this save the tree?"

Nalini Kumari said, "I do not know."

"Then?"

"If the tree is not saved, at least we will know what must not disappear with it."

That sentence sounded different to Madhura from every line in the petition.

At noon they measured again.

The shade had shifted and now covered half the water pot.

At one o'clock, during the midday break, measuring was difficult.

Small children stepped on the chalk lines.

Someone asked, "Is this a game?"

Madhura would answer, "A register of shade."

"Can shade be written in a register too?"

"Today it can."

At three the shade climbed the western wall.

Inside Class Seven the temperature was lower than in the sun outside, though less air entered because the cracked corner had been closed off.

Nalini Kumari had each measurement written separately.

On the second day the sky was cloudy.

Amar asked, "Where do we measure the shade today?"

"Wherever it can be seen. If it cannot be seen, write 'not visible.'"

"Leave it blank?"

"If you leave it blank, later it will look as though you forgot to measure. If you write 'not visible,' the condition of the day remains visible."

Madhura wrote that rule at the top of her notebook.

The third day was brightly sunny.

This time the younger children began watching the measurements themselves.

Pihani of Class Five said, "Now I understand why we eat our lunch boxes here."

"Why?"

"Because at one o'clock there is complete shade here."

"Did you not understand that before?"

"I did. But I had never measured it."

The temperature of the water pot was recorded too.

There was a difference between the water in the pot kept in shade and the water in a test pot placed in the sun.

The headmistress herself came once to look at the measurements.

She saw the curved chalk lines.

"The courtyard has turned into a drawing," she said.

Ramcharit Kaka replied, "The ground is showing where the tree goes during the day."

Madhura smiled.

By the fifth day there were five lines for each time across the courtyard.

Some overlapped.

Some were separate.

Nalini Kumari asked the children to copy all the lines onto a single map.

When the lines came together, they formed a strange shape.

The trunk was only a small point.

The shade was an area spreading around it through the day.

Madhura suddenly said, "We were looking only at the trunk."

Amar asked, "And now?"

"Now it seems that much of what we want to save is not the trunk at all."

Nalini Kumari said nothing.

She let the children finish the thought themselves.

Three places were specially marked on the map.

First: the shade used during midday meals.

Second: the shade over the water pot and the line where children came to drink.

Third: the shade falling on the western classroom wall in the afternoon.

The tree's use for birds was recorded separately.

The horticulture officer was called again.

The children showed him the map.

Shashibhushan Mandal studied the page for a long time.

"This is not a map of the tree," he said.

Amar replied at once, "Of the shade."

“Yes. And of its uses too.”

Sudha Jha asked, “If removing this tree becomes certain, how can these uses be preserved?”

The question in the meeting had changed.

Before, it had been:

Should the tree be cut or not?

Now it was:

What must not be cut away along with the tree?

The existing repair plan for the school was brought out.

The cracked wall was to be rebuilt.

The drain would be remade too.

A narrow tin bicycle shelter had been proposed for the southern side of the courtyard.

Looking at the plan, Madhura asked, “Why is the shelter here?”

The headmistress said, “Because this space was already empty.”

“According to the shade measurements, the children sit here at one o’clock.”

“Then?”

“Can the bicycle shelter be shifted a little?”

The engineer looked at the measurements on the paper.

“It can be shifted. But the shelter was not designed for the children.”

Nalini Kumari asked, “Can one structure do two jobs?”

The discussion began.

A tin roof would become hot at noon.

A fully permanent roof would cost more.

Bamboo used permanently would not last long enough.

At last the engineer suggested a simple solution:

the bicycle shelter could be moved west, and an open slatted strip added along its eastern side; instead of dense sheet metal above, there would be spaced battens and a wire framework for local vines.

Shashibhushan Mandal immediately said, “Choose the vine species carefully. Do not plant beside the wall in a way that creates another root problem.”

Amar asked, “Will the place where the neem stood be left empty?”

“The old trunk area will remain open for repairing the wall,” the engineer said.

“Then there will be no sign of the tree?”

Sudha Jha looked at Madhura.

“Is a sign necessary?”

Madhura’s first impulse was to say yes.

Then she looked at the chalk lines all around.

“One sign in one place will not be enough,” she said.

“Why?”

“Because the shade was not in one place.”

Ramcharit Kaka laughed softly.

It was decided that no circular memorial would be made around the old trunk.

Instead, a “Shade Register” would be kept in the school archive, containing the map, times, temperatures, places of use, and the reasons for the repair.

The temporary chalk lines in the courtyard would be allowed to disappear with rain and footsteps.

They would not be made permanent with paint.

Amar was not satisfied with this decision.

“There should be something visible too,” he said.

Madhura agreed with him on that.

But no one could agree on what.

Ramcharit Kaka said, “If you need something visible, write the measurements on the new shelter.”

“Which measurements?”

“How much shade the children need.”

Everyone fell silent at that.

The engineer wrote down the width of the slatted strip on the paper.

“This measurement comes not from the tree’s trunk, but from the children’s use,” he said.

Madhura liked that.

The day for cutting was fixed for Sunday, when the school would be closed.

On Saturday evening the children were allowed to gather under the neem.

There was no ceremony.

No speech.

Anyone who wished could sit there for ten minutes.

Many children came.

One touched the trunk.

One picked up a leaf.

One took a photograph on a phone.

Amar thought of writing his name on the trunk, but Ramcharit Kaka stopped him.

“It has stood all these years without a name. Why give it a nameplate on its last evening?”

Amar lowered his hand.

Madhura sat on the veranda steps.

The sun was setting.

The shade slowly climbed the wall.

She did not open her notebook.
 The five days of measurements were complete.
 Ramcharit Kaka sat beside her.
 “Kaka,” Madhura asked, “are you sad?”
 “I am.”
 “Even so, you did not oppose it.”
 “If I opposed it, would the crack close?”
 “No.”
 “Would the tree remain standing safely?”
 “I do not know.”
 “Nor do I. But it was necessary to have it inspected.”
 Madhura said, “People will say the school cut down the tree.”
 Ramcharit Kaka looked towards the last line of shade on the ground.
 “They will. But you should also write what you measured before cutting it, why you measured it, and what you changed afterward.”
 “Won’t that sound like a statement written only to defend ourselves?”
 “If you write it only to defend yourselves, it will. If the next time someone plants a tree beside a wall they read this register, then it will be a lesson.”
 Madhura did not go to school on Sunday.
 She deliberately stayed away.
 Afraid she might hear the sound of the cutting from a distance, she shut the window and sat down to study.
 Until noon she could not keep her mind on the book.
 When she reached school on Monday, the south-west corner looked open.
 More sky was visible.
 So was the crack in the wall.
 The neem was gone.
 The earth where the trunk had stood had not yet been levelled; the roots still had to be removed.
 Madhura did not stand there for long.
 She went straight to the water pot.
 It was in the sun.
 For the first time, the sunlight in that place hurt her eyes.
 Amar said, “See? Now do you understand?”
 Madhura said, “Yes.”
 That day the water pot was moved inside the veranda.
 At the midday meal the children searched for different corners.
 A few Class Three children quarrelled over the thin shade on the steps.
 Nalini Kumari said nothing.
 She merely added one line to the Shade Register:
 “First day after removal: water pot moved inside; lunch seating scattered.”

Madhura asked, "Write this too?"

"This too."

The repairs began.

The weakened section of the old wall was opened.

The lower foundation was repaired.

The direction of the drain was altered slightly.

The posts of the new shelter were set outside the old root zone.

Every day the children watched the measurements.

One day Madhura noticed that the workers were bringing the eastern edge of the shelter two cubits inside the planned line.

She told the engineer.

"If it starts here, the place of the water pot will be in the sun at one o'clock."

The engineer took out the plan.

The workers were stopped.

"Your measurements have become useful," he said with a smile.

That was the first day Amar looked pleased while watching the repair work.

"So this is becoming the neem's shade?" he asked.

Madhura said, "No. It is being made from our measurements."

"What is the difference?"

"The neem's shade changed all day. This strip covers only the place where the need was greatest."

"Then it is less."

"Yes. And what is less is meant to grow as the new trees grow."

A place for planting was chosen along the north-east boundary of the school.

Before anything was planted, Shashibhushan Mandal showed the children the possible spread of a mature tree, the distance from the building, the drain and the path of overhead wires.

This time the question was not:

Which tree is beautiful?

The question was:

Where will this reach twenty years from now?

The children measured the ground with tapes.

Three separate places were chosen for local shade-giving trees.

Not a row of one species.

Not an imitation of the old form.

Madhura asked, "No neem among them?"

Shashibhushan Mandal said, "A neem can be planted, but this time at sufficient distance from the building. The issue is not opposition to neem. It is placement."

In the end, a safe distance along the northern boundary was measured for one neem too.

Madhura was silent for a while.

She liked the fact that no one needed to call the new neem the child of the old neem.

It would be its own tree.

Its own roots, its own shade, its own time.

There was no inauguration when the new shelter was completed.

At one in the afternoon the children simply sat beneath the strip on their own.

Sunlight fell through the slatted roof in thin square patches on the ground.

This was not like the neem's shade.

The neem's shade had moved with its leaves.

Here the lines were sharp.

At first Madhura found it slightly unfamiliar.

Then the wind blew.

A thin stem of the new vine tied above moved.

Its shadow drew a small crooked mark across the square lines.

Amar noticed.

"Was that in the measurement?"

Madhura laughed.

"No."

"Then is it wrong?"

"No. The measurement was a boundary, not the shape."

Amar said nothing to that.

In December the first copy of the Shade Register was bound into the school archive.

The first page did not contain a photograph of the old neem, but a map.

The second page contained a summary of the building inspection.

The third contained the five days of shade lines.

The fourth recorded what changed after the tree was removed.

The fifth recorded the measurements of the new shelter and the planting sites.

The final page was left blank.

Sudha Jha asked, "Why is this empty?"

Madhura said, "We will measure again after five years."

"What?"

"The shade of the new trees."

Ramcharit Kaka was there.

He said, "Then the register is not finished."

"No."

One winter afternoon in Magh, Madhura went to the shelter to drink water.

The winter sun was low.

At that hour the shade of the slatted shelter did not reach the water pot.

But in winter the need for it was smaller too.

Madhura suddenly remembered the measurements from those old five days.

She understood that what had been preserved was not the exact shape of the old neem's shade.

What had been preserved was the habit of measuring the need for shade.

She looked towards the north-east boundary.

The new saplings were still small.

Among them was the neem too.

No tree looked like the old neem.

Ramcharit Kaka was filling the water pot.

Madhura asked, "Kaka, how big will all these be after five years?"

"We will measure."

"You will not say beforehand?"

"If I say beforehand, it will be an estimate."

He put the lid back on the pot.

"Write the estimate separately in the register."

Madhura laughed.

She looked at the small board fixed to the shelter post.

No tree's name was written on it.

There were only three lines:

"Midday seating: 18 cubits."

"Shade for water pot: 6 cubits."

"Open strip to reduce heat on western wall: 11 cubits."

Below, in smaller letters, it said:

"Measurements to be taken again."

Madhura brushed the dust from the board with her hand.

She did not go towards the place where the old neem's trunk had stood.

She looked at the direction of the sun.

Then she looked at the new shade falling on the ground.

The Lamps of Both Homes

It was the first week of Kartik.

One day before the school holidays, the art class was in progress.

The teacher told every child to draw “the lamp of my home” on a sheet of paper.

Some children drew doorways, some courtyards, some borders of flowers and leaves.

Twelve-year-old Anvi rested her pencil in the middle of the paper and fell silent.

She did not have only one home.

Her mother, Madhavi Jha, lived in half of Nani’s house in the old quarter of town.

Her father, Nachiket Jha, lived in a new rented house behind the market, with his small bookshop on the ground floor.

Anvi spent alternate parts of the week in the two places.

The school register contained one address for her, but she had a toothbrush in two places, clothes in two places, two small piles of books, and two different windows beside which she slept at night.

“What happened?” the teacher asked, coming near her.

Anvi looked at the paper.

“I have two homes.”

Without showing surprise, the teacher said, “Then draw two.”

Anvi drew a straight line down the middle of the page.

On the left she drew a small section of the tiled roof at her mother’s house, the tulsi altar and the veranda.

On the right she drew the narrow staircase of her father’s house, the veranda above and the shutter of the bookshop below.

Her hand stopped again when she had to decide where the lamp should be.

She remembered the previous year’s festival of lamps.

It had been the first festival after her mother and father began living in separate houses.

Both had said beforehand, “We will not let you feel that anything is missing.”

The result was that the two houses had become almost copies of one another.

Her mother had made Anvi's favourite snack.

Her father had brought the same thing from the market that evening.

Her mother had bought seven earthen lamps.

Her father had bought seven too.

Her mother had given her a new kurti with a red border.

Her father had given her a shawl with a red border.

Both had asked, "Did you like it better here?"

Both times Anvi had answered, "Yes."

But that night, lying in bed, she had felt that the word "better" had turned into a rope stretched between the two houses, and she was standing in the middle of it.

This year, three days before the festival, her mother asked on the phone, "When will you come here to light the first lamp?"

Anvi said, "After the holidays begin."

"You will light the first lamp here, won't you?"

Her mother had spoken casually, as though she were only asking about the time.

Anvi could not say yes.

That same evening her father said, "This year light the first lamp on my veranda. Last year you went there first."

Anvi changed her answer there too.

"We'll see."

Now, on the drawing paper, she could not decide where the lamp belonged.

The teacher moved on.

At last Anvi drew a small empty circle near the doorway of the house on the left, and three small dots along the stairs of the house on the right.

She did not draw any flames.

The class ended.

On the way home her friend Gunjan looked at the drawing.

"Why haven't your lamps been lit?"

Folding the paper, Anvi said, "It is not time yet."

When she reached her mother's house, Nani, Sarojini Devi, was sorting makhana in the courtyard.

Madhavi was searching through a trunk on the veranda for an old brass lamp.

Anvi put down her schoolbag.

Madhavi took out the lamp and wiped it with a cloth.

"You used to like this one very much, remember?"

The lamp was small, with a broad mouth and a narrow pointed spout.

When she was little, Anvi had called it the “bird lamp.”

“Yes.”

“This year this one will be lit first.”

Anvi looked towards Nani.

Sarojini Devi went on sorting the makhana.

“Nani,” Anvi asked, “whose lamp is the first lamp?”

Sarojini Devi stopped her fingers.

“Whichever one is lit first.”

Anvi did not laugh.

“I mean, of the house?”

“A household lamp belongs to the household.”

“And if there are two homes?”

This time Sarojini Devi raised her head.

Madhavi too fell silent.

“Then there will be two lamps,” Nani said.

Madhavi said softly, “But the festival’s first lamp can be lit only once.”

Separating a bad makhana from the basket, Sarojini Devi said, “The sun sets only once. It does not become dark in every house one after another.”

Madhavi said nothing.

Anvi kept the sentence in her mind.

The next day she went to her father’s house.

Nachiket was opening bundles of new books in the shop.

On the upstairs veranda stood two boxes of earthen lamps.

“So many?” Anvi asked.

“For the stairs, veranda, shop—everywhere.”

“Last year there were seven.”

“This year the place is larger.”

Nachiket opened one box.

“I chose a separate lamp for you.”

He showed her a small round lamp with a black line painted around the rim.

Anvi turned it in her hand.

“Will this be lit first?”

“If you want.”

Anvi put the lamp back in the box.

“And if I don’t want that?”

Nachiket hesitated.

“Then another one will be lit.”

“I mean—why does the first one matter so much?”

Her father thought for a moment.

“Perhaps the first thing stays in the memory.”

"The second stays too."

"It does."

Anvi sat down on the stairs.

Inside the shop was the smell of paper and new books.

"Last year you asked whether I liked it here better than at Ma's house."

Nachiket's hands stopped on the string of the bundle.

"Did I ask that?"

"Twice."

"I don't remember."

"I do."

Her father left the string and came to sit beside her.

"Did it make you feel bad?"

Anvi did not answer at once.

"I felt that if I said it was good here, then it would make things bad there."

Nachiket was silent for a long time.

A bicycle bell rang on the road below.

The milkman passed in front of the shop.

"I won't ask this year," Nachiket said.

Anvi replied, "Only not asking is not enough."

"What else?"

"Why is the same thing done in both places?"

"What?"

"Seven lamps. Red clothes. The same snack. The same time. The same talk."

A faint look of embarrassment passed over Nachiket's face, then he smiled.

"I thought familiar things would make you comfortable."

"Ma thought the same."

"Then were both of us wrong?"

Anvi shook her head.

"Not wrong. But the two homes started becoming one."

"Shouldn't that be good?"

"No. Because they are not one."

Nachiket said nothing to that.

Anvi went upstairs.

In one corner of the veranda stood her small table.

She took out the school drawing.

House on the left, house on the right, a line between them.

An empty circle and three dots on the stairs.

Beside the empty circle on the left she wrote in pencil: "Before darkness falls."

Beside the three dots on the right she wrote: "After the shop closes."

Then she put the drawing back in her bag.

On the third day, the festival cleaning was underway at her mother's house. Madhavi was mixing rice paste for the old aripan designs. Anvi swept the veranda. The doorway frame was washed. Madhavi asked, "Shall we make a large aripan this year?" Anvi asked, "How large?" "Across the whole courtyard." "Babu made one last year too." Madhavi's hand stopped. "He did?" "I asked him, so he did." "Was it good?" The moment the question came out, Madhavi closed her mouth. Anvi looked at her. Madhavi laughed. "Comparison again." "Yes." "All right. That question is crossed out." Anvi sat beside the bowl of rice paste. "Ma, let me make one small aripan." "Make it." "Not across the whole courtyard." "Then?" Anvi pointed to the right-hand corner of the doorway. "Here. Only the size of a palm." Madhavi was surprised. "So small?" "Yes. One lamp beside it." "Only one?" "Not the first one. Just the lamp at this home's doorway." Madhavi put down the bowl of rice paste. "Does the word 'first' trouble you that much?" Anvi said, "If one becomes first, the other is automatically pushed into second place." Madhavi's eyes remained on Anvi for a few moments. "I had not thought of it that way." "I had." Madhavi dipped her palm into the rice paste, then stopped. "All right. One small aripan. You make it." "And you?" "I'll fill the border."

Anvi laughed.

From a distance Sarojini Devi said, "I'll put the dot in the middle."

All three laughed.

That evening Anvi phoned her father.

"Will there be something different at your house?"

"Different meaning?"

"Something that does not happen at Ma's house."

Nachiket said, "There is no courtyard at my place."

"Right."

"So we won't copy the aripan."

Anvi felt relieved.

"There are stairs."

"There are."

"Three turns."

"Yes."

"Three lamps at the three turns?"

Her father was silent for a while.

"From the bottom to the top?"

"Yes. After the shop closes."

"Why after?"

"Because the day changes in your house after the shop closes. At Ma's house everyone comes inside before darkness falls."

Nachiket said slowly, "All right."

"And not the same snack."

"Then what?"

"You decide."

"I have that right?"

"Yes. It is your home."

Nachiket laughed on the other end of the call.

"Then flattened rice and curd?"

Anvi laughed loudly.

"On festival night?"

"You said different."

"Not that different."

"Then makhana kheer?"

Anvi thought.

"All right."

"Will Ma make it?"

"No. You make it."

"Then it will be less a kheer and more an experiment."

"Accepted."

From morning on the festival day, calls from both homes began reaching Anvi.

First Mami asked, "Where will you be in the evening?"

"In both places."

"Which one first?"

Anvi said, "There is no first-place list."

Mami laughed, but did not ask again.

A little later her father's sister called.

"You'll do the night worship with your father, won't you?"

Anvi said, "I'll be with him at night. But I'll also be at Ma's house."

"Will you run between two houses on the same day?"

"I won't run. The times are different."

By noon Anvi understood that it was not only her parents; people around them too were accustomed to imagining a festival shut inside a single place.

She tore a page from her notebook.

At the top she wrote: "Today's Two Times."

First line:

"Before evening darkness falls: Ma's doorway."

Second line:

"After the shop closes: Babu's stairs."

She did not write exact clock times.

Her mother said, "Why not write five-thirty?"

Anvi replied, "The sun does not set by looking at a clock."

Sarojini Devi laughed.

Madhavi did too.

A little before evening, the bowl of rice paste was brought into the courtyard.

Anvi really did make an aripan no larger than a palm at the right-hand corner of the doorway.

First a small circle, four leaves around it, and Nani's dot in the centre.

Madhavi added two fine lines at the border.

"That's all?" Madhavi asked.

"That's all."

The rest of the courtyard was not empty.

That day lamps were to be placed separately near the old altar, the kitchen and the rooms.

But the lamp Anvi wanted to light with her own hand stood beside this small aripan.

Darkness began to fall slowly.

Madhavi poured the oil.

Sarojini Devi straightened the wick.

Anvi struck the match.
The flame trembled first, then steadied.
Madhavi seemed about to say something, but stopped.
Anvi understood that the word “first” had almost reached her mother’s mouth.
Instead, her mother said only, “The doorway is visible now.”
Anvi said, “Yes.”
The three remained silent for a while.
There was no comparison in that silence.
A little later Anvi ate the first part of her meal.
Madhavi said, “Keep some hunger for Babu’s place.”
“There is a kheer experiment.”
“Then certainly keep some.”
Anvi did not take a bag.
She only put on a light warm kurta and carried the folded school drawing in her hand.
Madhavi came to the door to see her off.
“I won’t phone,” she said.
“Why?”
“Let the time there belong there.”
Anvi touched her mother’s hand.
“I’ll call when I return.”
“All right.”
By the time she reached her father’s shop, the night had deepened.
The shop was still open.
Two customers were looking at books.
Nachiket saw Anvi but did not look at the clock.
“You came?” was all he said.
“Yes.”
On the first turn of the staircase, Anvi saw three empty earthen lamps.
One on the first turn, one on the second, one near the veranda above.
“No oil?”
“Waiting for you.”
“Has the shop closed?”
“Not yet.”
“Then not yet.”
Nachiket smiled.
“The instruction will be obeyed.”
Anvi went upstairs.
In the kitchen, milk had boiled over halfway.
The makhana in a pan had been roasted a little too much.

"Is this the beginning of the kheer?"

"Yes."

"If Ma saw this—"

Anvi stopped the sentence.

Nachiket said, "Comparison?"

"Yes."

"Don't."

"I was going to say that she lowers the flame first."

"That is useful information, not a competition."

Anvi laughed.

Together they wiped up the spilled milk.

Nachiket put the makhana on a lower flame.

A customer's voice came from downstairs.

He went back to the shop.

Anvi stood on the veranda and watched the road.

Far away, lamps were burning at different houses.

Some roofs glowed with strings of lights.

For one moment she wondered whether the lamp at her mother's doorway was still burning.

She took out her phone to ask for a photograph.

Then she put the phone away again.

Let the lamp there remain there.

About half an hour later Nachiket came upstairs.

"The last customer has gone."

Anvi looked towards the stairs.

"Now."

They both sat at the first turn.

Nachiket held a small bottle of oil.

Anvi poured oil into all three lamps.

Her father made the wicks.

"Which one first?" Nachiket asked without thinking.

Anvi looked at him.

Both were silent for a moment.

Her father slapped his own forehead lightly.

"First again!"

Anvi burst out laughing.

"From bottom to top."

"That is not first and second?"

"It is a path."

The lowest lamp was lit.

Then the one at the second turn.

Then the one above.

The three flames looked like three small pauses in the darkness of the staircase.

Standing below, Anvi looked upward.

“Now the staircase is visible.”

Nachiket said, “Exactly Ma’s sentence?”

Anvi was startled.

“How did you know?”

“A guess. A lamp’s work is to make things visible too.”

Anvi smiled.

Upstairs, the two ate the kheer.

It was a little thick, and some of the makhana was hard.

Nachiket asked, “How many marks?”

Anvi stopped her spoon.

“No marks.”

“Right. Question crossed out.”

“But next time roast the makhana less.”

“Useful information?”

“Yes.”

At nine that night Madhavi sent a message: “Reached?”

Anvi wrote back: “Yes.”

Madhavi asked nothing more.

Anvi opened the school drawing.

In the empty circle at the left-hand house, she drew one small flame.

On the three dots along the stairs of the right-hand house, she drew three flames.

The straight line between the two houses now looked very hard.

She picked up an eraser.

She did not erase the entire line.

She erased only a two-finger-wide space in the middle.

The two houses remained separate on the paper, but a small open passage appeared between them.

“What is that?” Nachiket asked.

“A path.”

“Joining the houses?”

Anvi shook her head.

“For me to walk through.”

Nachiket looked at the drawing again.

“Right.”

Anvi slept at her father’s house that night.

There had been no plan to return to her mother’s house the same night.

That too mattered to her: having two homes did not mean that she had to keep running back and forth on the same night.

In the morning she phoned her mother.

“Did the lamp at the doorway go out?”

Madhavi said, “When the oil ran out in the night.”

“The aripan?”

“It is still there.”

After a moment Madhavi asked, “The stair lamps?”

“All three burned.”

“The kheer?”

Anvi laughed.

“Useful information has been given to Babu.”

Madhavi laughed too.

“Good.”

For a while both were silent.

Then Madhavi said, “Next year, can we change the place of this little aripan?”

“Why?”

“If the doorway is repaired?”

Anvi remembered Nani’s words: houses do not become dark one after another.

She said, “We can change it. A tradition is not hammered into a place like a nail.”

“Which book did you read that in?”

“None.”

“Then write it down.”

Anvi ended the call and opened her notebook.

On one page she wrote: “This year’s two times.”

Below it she made two lines.

“Ma’s house — small aripan at the doorway, before darkness fell.”

“Babu’s house — three lamps on the stairs, after the shop closed.”

Then, after thinking for a long time, she added a third line:

“It is not necessary that next year be exactly the same.”

Nachiket came onto the veranda carrying tea.

“What are you writing?”

Anvi did not close the notebook.

“A festival register.”

“Rules?”

“No. Memory.”

“What is the difference?”

“A rule tells you to repeat. Memory only tells you what happened once.”

Nachiket placed the tea cup on the table.

"That too is useful information."

Anvi laughed.

School reopened after the holidays.

The art teacher asked the class to take out their unfinished work again.

Anvi spread out her paper.

One flame at the left-hand house, three flames along the stairs on the right, and a small open path in the dividing line.

Gunjan looked at it.

"Your lamps are lit now?"

"Yes."

"Which home was better?"

Anvi looked at her.

Last year that question had tied a knot in her stomach.

This time she smiled.

"They were different."

"But which was better?"

Anvi picked up her pencil.

"That question does not find a place in my picture."

She completed the four leaves of the aripan beside the left-hand doorway.

She drew a fine line beneath the three lamps on the right-hand staircase.

She left the open path in the middle exactly as it was.

The Veranda Lesson

It was an afternoon in Ashwin.

The rains had stopped, but here and there the bricks of the veranda still looked damp.

The veranda of the old headmaster's house had now become a place for reading twice a week.

His widowed sister, Surma Devi, who lived there, had said, "If books remain shut inside an empty room, what use are they?"

So on Tuesday and Friday evenings, five or seven schoolchildren came there and read aloud news, government notices, stories and small books to elderly women.

Some could not read small print even with spectacles.

Some recognised letters but tired along long lines.

Some came only to listen.

Surma Devi was always the first to spread out the low stools.

Phulkali Kaki came carrying a small winnowing tray of half-peeled makhana.

Jamuna Devi kept an old thread bag hanging from her shoulder.

Sakina Khatoon usually sat for half an hour before the evening namaz.

Among the children, Ragini read most clearly.

She was in Class Eight.

If she stumbled over a word, she did not guess immediately.

She paused and looked at the letters again.

Chetan was in Class Seven.

He did less reading and more counting of lines, writing dates, and making small marks in the margins.

That day Malati Teacher had sent a thin book from the school.

On its blue cover was written: "Fifty Years of Our Village."

The book had been printed five years earlier on the village foundation day.

Ragini ran a finger over the cover.

"Shall we read this today?"

Surma Devi said, "Read. Let us hear about our own village."

Chetan turned the pages.

The first chapter described the old pond.

The second, the founding of the school.

The third, the road, electricity and the market.

Everyone listened.

Here and there the older women made brief comments.

“This road used to be unpaved.”

“The pond had another name earlier.”

“The year is wrong here.”

Chetan kept making notes in the margin of his notebook.

Ragini opened the fourth chapter.

Its title was: “The Year of the Great Flood.”

She began to read.

“After continuous rain, three hamlets of the village were submerged. A relief centre was opened in the school building. The people of the village together arranged food, medicine and a safe place.”

Phulkali Kaki’s hand stopped over the tray of makhana.

“Read that again.”

Ragini read it again.

“The people of the village together arranged food, medicine and a safe place.”

Phulkali Kaki asked, “The people?”

Ragini looked at the book.

“That is what it says.”

“Whose hands among the people?”

Chetan started to laugh, but Surma Devi looked at him.

He fell silent.

Ragini read the next line.

It named the president of the youth committee, the secretary, two ward representatives and five men who distributed relief.

Jamuna Devi asked quietly, “Did the food cook itself?”

Ragini did not close the book.

“Perhaps further on—”

She stopped herself immediately.

“Perhaps it is written further on.”

She read two more pages.

There was mention of boats, government rice, medicine boxes and a visit by a block officer.

Nothing about who ran the kitchen, who dried the grain, or who changed the wet clothes of the children.

Phulkali Kaki put down her tray.

“I am not saying my name must be there.”

Surma Devi asked, "Then?"

"I want the sentence to be complete."

Ragini kept looking at her.

Phulkali Kaki said, "When you read 'the people arranged food,' it sounds as though the food came out of the sack and fell straight onto the plate."

Sakina Khatoon smiled.

"Rice comes out of a sack. Cooked rice does not."

A light laugh passed through the veranda.

Ragini marked the place on the page with her fingernail.

"Then what should be written?"

Instead of answering, Phulkali Kaki asked, "First find out what happened."

Chetan immediately opened his notebook.

"I'll write."

Surma Devi stopped him.

"Listen first."

Chetan's pen stopped in the air.

Phulkali Kaki began, "The first stove was lit in the back room of the school."

Jamuna Devi interrupted at once.

"Not on the first day."

"The first evening."

"No, the second day."

"You had gone to your mother's house then."

"I went on the third day."

The two looked at one another.

Ragini understood that filling the blank space in the book would not be simple.

Malati Teacher was not on the veranda that day.

Ragini asked, "Shall we write both versions?"

Surma Devi said, "Write nothing yet. First ask about the things everyone remembers in the same way."

At the top of a page Chetan wrote: "Flood Year."

Below it he wrote two questions:

"Whose hands?"

"What work?"

Jamuna Devi asked, "Who gave you those questions?"

"All of you," Chetan said.

Phulkali Kaki picked up her tray again.

"Then ask."

Chetan asked, "Who lit the stove?"

Three voices rose almost together.

“Many people.”

Chetan’s head dropped.

“Again: the people.”

Everyone laughed this time.

Surma Devi said, “Not names. Ask about the work.”

Ragini understood.

“What work was done?”

Jamuna Devi began counting on her fingers.

“Wet firewood was separated.”

Sakina Khatoon added, “Dry cow-dung cakes came from house to house.”

Phulkali Kaki said, “The rice was sorted. The wet rice was separated.”

Surma Devi said, “Thin khichdi for the children.”

Sakina said, “Food without chilli for the old people.”

Jamuna said, “The stove remained in the school for two days, then on the veranda.”

Phulkali interrupted again.

“Three days.”

This time Chetan wrote both versions separately.

“Two or three days — memories differ.”

Surma Devi looked at his notebook.

“That is right.”

Ragini asked, “If we are not certain, how can it go into a book?”

“Why must it go into the book?” Surma Devi asked.

“Then?”

“Let there be a paper beside the book.”

Phulkali Kaki said, “Do not cut the old printed words. Put the omitted work beside them.”

The next day at school, Ragini told Malati Teacher everything.

Malati Teacher turned the book over in her hands.

“This book was prepared by the history committee. The sources are listed at the end too.”

Chetan asked, “Do the sources contain the women’s names?”

Malati Teacher looked at the last two pages.

Minutes of meetings, government letters, the school register, the panchayat report, old newspapers.

“No.”

Ragini said, “Then does that mean we should not accept what they say?”

“Not at all,” Malati Teacher said. “Oral memory is also a source. But dates can slip in memory, sequences can change, and two people may remember the same event differently.”

Chetan said, “I wrote ‘two or three days.’”

Malati Teacher looked at his notebook.

"That is an honest line."

Ragini asked, "Can we make a supplement?"

Malati Teacher did not say yes immediately.

She thought for a while.

"If you make one, do not turn it into merely a list of names to be added."

"Why?"

"Because then the same problem returns. Whose name is remembered enters history; whose is not remembered is left outside again."

Ragini remembered Phulkali Kaki's sentence: the sentence should be complete.

She said, "Then write the work."

Malati Teacher drew five columns on the board.

First: "Printed sentence."

Second: "Omitted work."

Third: "Who said it."

Fourth: "Is there another basis?"

Fifth: "Doubt or disagreement."

Chetan smiled at the fifth column.

"Can 'do not know' be written in history too?"

"Where we do not know, it should be written."

That week, the reading on the veranda changed.

Earlier the children read and the elderly women listened.

Now one line was read, and then questions arose.

"The people of the village together..."

Surma Devi would say, "Stop. What work?"

"A relief centre was opened in the school..."

Jamuna Devi would ask, "Opened means what? Who opened the lock? Who cleaned the room? Where were the sacks kept?"

"Food supplies were arranged..."

Sakina Khatoon would say, "Food arriving is one thing; becoming fit to eat is another."

Ragini kept writing.

But on the second day a new difficulty arose.

Phulkali Kaki said that for the first three nights women had stayed at the school to look after the children.

Jamuna Devi said, "Not every night."

Sakina Khatoon said, "I stayed one night. After that I had goats at home."

Ragini asked, "Then how will the sentence be written?"

Surma Devi said, "Write only as much as is certain."

Chetan wrote:

“Some women stayed at the school for one or more nights to look after children and elderly people; the number is uncertain.”

Phulkali Kaki listened as he read it aloud.

“My name is not there?”

Chetan looked alarmed.

“But you said names were not necessary.”

Phulkali Kaki laughed.

“I was asking to see what you understood.”

Chetan laughed too.

“The work first.”

“Exactly.”

In the third week Ragini and Chetan went to two houses each.

They did not ask for life stories.

They simply read the marked line from the book and asked:

“What work is missing from this sentence?”

Many answers were short.

“Sewing sacks.”

“Spreading wet wheat to dry.”

“Boiling well water and cooling it.”

“Counting the names of small children.”

“Keeping the stove fire alive through the night.”

Many answers conflicted with one another.

One elderly woman said the medicines were kept in the eastern room of the school.

Another said the western room.

Chetan wrote both.

“Room uncertain.”

At one house they found a paper in an old wooden chest.

Not in Surma Devi’s house.

In Shyamkali Devi’s.

The paper contained a credit account from thirty-five years earlier.

Ten seers of rice.

Four seers of lentils.

Salt.

Mustard oil.

Two names were written below.

One was that of a male shopkeeper.

The other:

“Rampari Devi.”

Shyamkali Devi said, “Rampari was my mother-in-law.”

Ragini grew excited.

“Then we have proof!”

When Malati Teacher saw the paper, she said, “We have support for one point: Rampari Devi took supplies. But this does not prove that she ran the entire kitchen.”

Ragini felt slightly ashamed of her excitement.

Malati Teacher smiled.

“In history, do not make a small piece of paper larger than it is.”

In the fourth column of the work sheet they wrote:

“Credit slip available.”

The fifth column remained blank.

A few days later Shivrinarayan Babu, an elderly member of the committee that had prepared the history book, came to the veranda.

He had heard that the children were ‘correcting’ the book.

He sat down with the book in his hands.

“What is wrong in it?”

Ragini did not answer immediately.

Phulkali Kaki said, “Call it an error, or call it an empty space.”

Shivrinarayan Babu adjusted his spectacles.

“We wrote it from the papers available to us at the time.”

Malati Teacher said, “That may be exactly why work done outside the papers was omitted.”

Shivrinarayan Babu turned a page.

“But the committee members’ names are here.”

Jamuna Devi asked, “Did the committee members light the stoves?”

Shivrinarayan Babu fell silent.

Phulkali Kaki rescued him.

“We are not saying you knowingly left us out.”

Surma Devi added, “The work that produced papers entered the book. The work that happened day after day produced fewer papers.”

Shivrinarayan Babu slowly nodded.

“That is true.”

The next day he brought his old file.

Three pages of relief-committee minutes.

A list of received supplies.

One medical slip.

An incomplete map.

Some dates on the work sheet became clearer.

Some confusion increased.

The meeting papers said the school relief centre began on Monday.

Phulkali Kaki remembered the stove burning from Sunday.

Chetan asked, “Which is correct?”

Shivnarayan Babu said, "It is possible the stove began earlier and the place received its official name as a centre later."

Malati Teacher said, "Then the two statements do not necessarily cancel each other."

Ragini wrote in the fifth column:

"Informal work may have begun before the official opening; oral memory and the meeting register give different dates."

After hearing the line, Phulkali Kaki said, "That language is too heavy."

Chetan laughed.

"You say it, then."

Phulkali Kaki thought.

"The paper says Monday. My memory says Sunday. Keep both."

Ragini crossed out the earlier line and wrote this simpler one.

Malati Teacher said nothing.

She only smiled.

The argument over the title of the supplementary booklet lasted even longer.

Chetan wanted: "The Missing History."

To Ragini, that sounded too much like an accusation.

Surma Devi suggested: "Talk from the Veranda."

Phulkali Kaki said, "Write the work, not the talk."

At last the cover read:

"WORK NOTES."

Below, in smaller letters:

"A supplement to be read with Fifty Years of Our Village."

Five rules were printed on the first page.

"This does not replace the original book."

"Anything found in only one memory is marked separately."

"Where memories differ, both or all versions are retained."

"Work before person; available names may be added in notes."

"What is not known will not be hidden by leaving a blank."

Chetan read the fifth rule and asked, "Leave it blank?"

Ragini said, "Not blank. Write 'not known.'"

Work Notes did not stop with the flood chapter.

Another chapter of the local history said:

"The village's first library was built with community help."

On the veranda the question arose:

"What work was that help?"

Surma Devi remembered that the bindings of the old books had been torn.

Three village women had sat at night and reinforced the bindings with strips of cloth.

Sakina Khatoon said, "I was not there, but my mother supplied thread."
 No second written source was found.
 The line in Work Notes became:
 "Oral memory of repairs to old books; no second written document for this account has yet been found."
 Chetan found the word 'independent' too heavy in an earlier draft.
 He replaced it with:
 "No other paper for this has yet been found."
 Malati Teacher smiled again.
 A third marked chapter said:
 "During the drought year, the people of the village removed silt from the pond."
 This time the work of men and women was remembered separately.
 The men cut out the silt.
 The women levelled the earth along the banks, brought water, and kept small children away from the pond.
 One elderly woman said some women had also used spades.
 Another said, "I did not see that."
 Work Notes recorded:
 "Some witnesses remember women using spades; not all witnesses agree."
 Jamuna Devi listened to the sentence and said, "This time it is right."
 "Why?" Ragini asked.
 "Because it does not enlarge the story just to make us look heroic."
 Phulkali Kaki added, "And it does not make us disappear either."
 A small print run was made in the school computer room.
 Twenty-four pages.
 Ordinary paper.
 A thin dusty-green cover.
 Fifty copies in all.
 The first copy came to the veranda.
 Chetan smelled the cover.
 "The smell of new paper."
 Phulkali Kaki said, "The work is old."
 Ragini placed the original book and the supplement together on a low stool.
 "Which one shall we read first?"
 Surma Devi said, "The original."
 Ragini was surprised.
 "Not Work Notes?"
 "First hear the sentence. Only then will you understand what is missing inside it."

That evening the fourth chapter was opened again.

Ragini read:

“The people of the village together arranged food, medicine and a safe place.”

This time she stopped on her own.

Chetan opened Work Notes.

He read:

“Omitted work: separating wet and dry grain; gathering cow-dung cakes and firewood; different food for children and elderly people; staying some nights to provide care; boiling and cooling well water.”

Phulkali Kaki listened.

Chetan read the next line:

“Memories differ about the day the stove began: the paper says Monday; some memories say Sunday.”

Shivnarayan Babu was also on the veranda that day.

He said softly, “This line has not made the book smaller.”

Surma Devi said, “It has made more room beside the book.”

Ragini liked the sentence.

She thought of writing it in her notebook, then did not.

Not every sentence had to be preserved.

When the reading ended, Malati Teacher looked at the last page.

It was almost blank.

At the top only one line had been printed:

“Some work is still missing.”

Below it were twelve empty lines.

Chetan asked, “Why was this page left blank?”

Ragini said, “Because we do not know everything.”

Phulkali Kaki added, “And because the next lesson is still left.”

Two weeks later a new child came to the veranda.

Ritu of Class Six.

She was reading the original book for the first time.

When she reached the flood chapter, she read:

“The people of the village together...”

Then she stopped.

She looked at the older readers.

“Do I open Work Notes here?”

Surma Devi said, “First finish the sentence.”

Ritu read it.

Then Chetan opened the supplement.

Listening, Ritu reached the final blank page.

She asked, “Who will write on these empty lines?”

“Whoever brings something after checking it,” Ragini said.

At that moment Sakina Khatoon, who had been quiet for some time, spoke softly.

“I remember one thing.”

Everyone turned towards her.

“On the second night of the flood, two girls took medicine in a small boat to the eastern hamlet.”

Phulkali Kaki frowned.

“Two girls? I remember one.”

Jamuna Devi said, “I was not at the school that night.”

Chetan lifted his pen.

“What shall I write?”

Earlier his hand would have gone straight to the blank line.

This time he remembered the rule of the fifth column.

Ragini said, “For now, only the question.”

On the first line of the final page Chetan wrote:

“Boat carrying medicine: one girl or two? To be checked.”

Sakina Khatoon listened as the line was read aloud.

She nodded.

Phulkali Kaki picked up her tray of makhana again.

Ritu did not close the original book.

She left it open beside Work Notes.

The evening light on the veranda had grown dimmer.

There was no empty space between the two books.

Only one thin line remained for the next question.

The Name on the Toy's Underside

A little away from the Bishanpur market, in a narrow lane, stood Madhav Toy House.

The word “shop” made people first look for a glass display case, but there was little glass here and much more wood.

To the right of the doorway hung horses; to the left, coloured birds.

On the long shelf inside stood small bullock carts, fish, spinning tops, pinwheels, winged toys, rattles and elephants on wheels.

The workshop was behind the shop.

Different sounds rose there all day:

the rasp of the plane,

the whisper of a fine saw,

the turning of the lathe,

the tap-tap of a small hammer on dry wood,

and the chime of a brass bowl in which colours were mixed.

A tin roof covered the workshop.

In the rains the noise grew louder, but the work did not stop.

The shop had been named after Madhav Jha, the grandfather of the family.

Madhav Jha was no longer alive, but his name continued to travel with every toy.

A small round stamp was pressed onto the bottom of each one:

“Madhav Toy House, Bishanpur.”

Nothing more.

There was no sign of who had shaped it, who had painted it, who had fitted the wheels.

For the family, this had never been a question.

Harinarayan Jha, Madhav Jha's elder son, worked the lathe.

His younger brother Shambhunath cut the wood and brought out the form.

Harinarayan's wife, Kamala Devi, did the painting.

Shambhunath's wife, Ratna Devi, handled polishing, cords, wheels and small joints.

Sometimes one toy passed through four hands.

Sometimes one hand carried it from beginning to end.

If anyone asked, "Whose toy is this in your house?" Harinarayan's answer was always: "The house's."

Seventeen-year-old Ira used to like that answer.

She was Shambhunath's daughter.

After finishing school, she had begun sitting regularly in the workshop that year.

First she mixed colours, then learned to sand, and later began shaping the bodies of small birds and fish.

Her hand was still slow.

Harinarayan would say, "Wood does not tolerate haste."

Ira would laugh and reply, "My hand is still afraid of wood."

"Good if it is afraid. The hand that is not afraid at all makes the first mistake."

One day Ira made six small horses.

Their bodies were all to the same measurements, but the tilt of the ears differed slightly.

One horse held its head a little higher; another had a rounder back.

Kamala Devi gave them a yellow base coat.

Ratna Devi drew the black manes.

Before closing the shop that evening, Ira turned all six horses over.

The same round stamp was on the underside of each.

"Kaki," she asked Ratna Devi, "is there nowhere on these where my mark remains?"

Ratna Devi smiled.

"The crooked ears made by your hand are there."

Ira smiled too, but the question remained.

"If someone asks ten years from now who made this horse, then?"

"Why would anyone ask?"

"Suppose they do?"

Ratna Devi set one horse upright.

"Then say: Madhav Toy House."

"But Madhav Baba's hand is not in this."

"The name belongs to the house."

Ira fell silent.

The matter came up again over dinner that night.

Shambhunath said, "A workshop needs one name in order to run. If every artisan writes a separate name, what remains of the shop?"

Ira said, "Let the shop's name remain. Under it, in smaller letters, the maker's name can be there too."

Harinarayan stopped with a morsel of rice in his hand.

“And who is the maker?”
 Ira did not answer.
 Harinarayan began counting.
 “Shambhu cut the wood, I turned it on the lathe, you shaped the ears,
 Kamala painted it, Ratna fitted the wheels. Shall we write five names now?”
 Ira burst out laughing.
 Harinarayan laughed too.
 “See? The register will become bigger than the underside of the toy.”
 The matter ended there.
 Three days later, at noon, an elderly man came to the shop.
 With him was a girl of about seven.
 She held a cloth bag pressed to her chest.
 The old man introduced himself as Devkant Mishra.
 “I have an old object to show you,” he said.
 From the bag came a small wooden bullock cart.
 Most of its colour had worn away.
 One wheel was detached, the axle was split in the middle, and one horn of
 the bullock was half broken.
 On the underside, the faded round stamp could still be read:
 “Madhav Toy House, Bishanpur.”
 Harinarayan took the cart in his hands.
 “This is very old.”
 Devkant said, “About sixteen or seventeen years.”
 The girl interrupted, “It was Baba’s.”
 Devkant placed a hand on her head.
 “I bought it when my son was small. This is his daughter now. We found it
 in a trunk while cleaning the house. She refuses to let it go.”
 The girl kept looking at the broken wheel.
 “Can it be repaired?” Devkant asked.
 Harinarayan did not say yes immediately.
 He examined the broken part of the axle closely.
 With a fine pin he checked the depth of the hole.
 He turned the wheel over and looked at the curve inside it.
 Shambhunath came nearer too.
 “This is the old style of axle,” he said.
 Harinarayan said, “Looks like mine.”
 Shambhunath shook his head.
 “Your axles were never this thin.”
 “They used to be.”
 “How long ago?”
 Instead of answering, Harinarayan turned the cart again.

Kamala Devi was studying the remaining flecks of colour.

"This red had mahua gum mixed into it," she said.

Ratna Devi replied, "We all used mahua gum."

"Not every year."

"When did we stop?"

Kamala Devi thought for a moment.

"When the yellow pigment changed."

"When did the yellow change?"

Now all four looked at one another.

For the first time Ira understood that repairing an old toy was not only a matter of joining the broken parts.

One also had to recognise the old habits of the hands that had made it.

Devkant asked, "Is there any difficulty?"

Harinarayan said, "No difficulty. But if a new wheel is made, we must understand the old axle measurements properly. We will not repaint the whole toy either. We will preserve what remains and repair only what is broken."

The girl said at once, "Do not make the whole thing new."

Everyone looked at her.

Pulling the cart towards herself, she said, "Baba says it used to look like this. If you make it completely new, it will not be Baba's one anymore."

A small brightness came into Harinarayan's eyes.

"You are right."

Devkant left the cart there and was asked to return after three days.

In the workshop the cart remained on a plank.

No one touched it immediately that day.

While putting away the work that evening, Ira turned it over again.

Around the round stamp there was only blank wood.

She said softly, "If there had been someone's mark on the underside?"

Harinarayan heard her.

"Then what?"

"Then first we would know whose hand made the axle. We could look for that year in the register."

From a distance Shambhunath said, "Where is the register from sixteen years ago?"

Ira fell silent.

It was true.

The old records were incomplete.

The workshop kept order accounts:

the shopkeeper's name, quantity, money, the date the goods were sent.

But not who did what work on which toy on which day.

The next day Harinarayan decided to take the old bullock cart apart.

The wheel was removed and the surviving half of the axle separated.
 The colour inside the wood was examined.
 Shambhunath said, "This is not sheesham. It is gamhar."
 Harinarayan said at once, "Then it is not mine."
 "Why?" Ira asked.
 "At that time Shambhu used to make thin axles from gamhar more often."
 Shambhunath laughed.
 "I am still not certain."
 Kamala Devi showed them a very fine red line inside the old wheel.
 "I did not apply this colour."
 "Which one?"
 "I did not carry the colour this far inside. This bit of colour that has entered the wheel-hole—Ratna used to do that."
 Ratna Devi was surprised.
 "Me?"
 "Yes. You had a little cotton-tipped stick."
 Ratna Devi took the wheel.
 She looked at it for some time.
 "Possible," she said slowly. "But the cut of the horn is not Shambhu's."
 "Then whose?" Ira asked.
 Ratna Devi looked at Harinarayan.
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "Now do you understand? One toy does not accept one name."
 This time Ira did not argue.
 On a thin sheet of paper she made four boxes:
 Wood / Form / Colour / Joint.
 Below them she wrote:
 "What seems likely."
 Harinarayan read it.
 "What is this?"
 "Everything we are guessing before the repair."
 "You will put guesses in a register?"
 "So that later we do not call a guess a fact."
 Harinarayan said nothing.
 In the first box Ira wrote:
 "Axle: gamhar; possibly Shambhunath."
 In the second:
 "Bullock horn: unclear."
 In the third:
 "Red colour entering the inner hole: possibly Ratna Devi's old method."
 In the fourth:

“Wheel joint: Harinarayan or Shambhunath; not certain.”

Kamala Devi read the page and said, “Where is my name?”

Ira laughed.

“You yourself are saying the colour is not yours.”

Kamala Devi laughed too.

By noon the method of repair had been decided.

The new axle would be made to the old measurements, but the broken half would be preserved.

Instead of making only one new wheel and assuming the other was correct, the outer diameter of both wheels would be measured so the cart would not lean to one side.

The broken horn would not be restored to a completely new full length.

Only enough would be added to make the form legible, while the old break line remained slightly visible.

Colour would be applied only to the new join.

Ira wanted to make the axle.

Harinarayan asked, “On your first repair?”

“You keep watching.”

“If I watch, how will the hand become yours?”

Ira smiled.

“That can go into the register too.”

Harinarayan let her sit at the lathe.

A thin rod of gamhar began to spin.

Ira placed the chisel against it very slowly.

“A little outward,” Harinarayan said.

Ira shifted her hand.

“Now?”

“Now it is yours.”

The rod grew thinner.

It was compared with the old axle measurement.

The first time, it remained two fingers too thick.

Ira mounted it on the lathe again.

The second time the measurement matched.

When the axle came off, Ira scratched a small line at one end with her fingernail.

Harinarayan asked, “What is that?”

“My mark.”

“A fingernail mark will disappear in three days.”

“That is why I am thinking about something permanent.”

That evening Ira took a scrap of wood.

On it she began trying small marks:

I, Ira, I.S., a leaf, two dots, a diagonal line.

Watching her, Shambhunath said, "More practice signing than making toys?"

Ira said, "A full name will not fit underneath."

"Why is a name needed?"

Ira looked towards the old bullock cart.

"Because today we cannot tell."

Shambhunath pulled up a chair and sat.

"What would change if we could tell?"

"Repairs would be easier to understand. If the artisan is still in the workshop, we can ask. If not, we can look in the register. Which paint, which wood, which joint—we may find some clues."

"Then a name alone is not enough."

Ira paused.

Shambhunath's question pushed her proposal beyond itself.

"The date too."

"And?"

Ira wrote another word on the paper:

"Work."

Shambhunath smiled.

"Now the underside really will become a register."

"Not everything underneath. A small mark underneath. The full account in a register."

Harinarayan had been listening from a distance.

He came closer.

"The shop stamp?"

"It stays."

"The artisan's mark?"

"It stays."

"Date?"

"A small number."

"Work?"

"In the register."

Harinarayan picked up the scrap of wood.

"If five artisans work on one toy, five marks?"

Ira was stuck again.

From inside, Ratna Devi said, "Record the hands where the work changes in the register. Why put every hand's mark on the underside?"

Ira turned towards her.

Ratna Devi set down the bowl of colour.

“Put one number on the underside. Against that number in the register, write every hand.”

Harinarayan nodded at once.

“The number will eventually reach a thousand.”

“Then?”

“Without a number, the register is useless.”

Ira said, “Under the shop stamp, put the year and a serial number. In the register, against that number, write wood, form, colour, joint—and whoever did each.”

Shambhunath added, “And if one artisan makes the whole thing alone, put that name on a single line.”

For a few moments everyone was silent.

The proposal was no longer Ira’s demand to put a single name on a toy.

It was beginning to become a memory for the workshop.

On the third day the bullock cart was ready.

The new axle was inside.

The new join had been lightly coloured close to the old red.

The line of the broken horn remained visible.

The wheels turned again.

Devkant returned, with the girl.

The first thing she did after taking the cart was spin the wheel.

Then she looked at the horn.

“You can see where it broke,” she said.

Harinarayan’s face tightened slightly.

Devkant asked the girl, “Does that look bad?”

She shook her head.

“No. Now I can tell where it had broken.”

Ira watched her silently.

The girl turned the cart over.

“Was this round name underneath before too?”

“Yes,” Devkant said. “That is how we knew to come here.”

The sentence struck Ira deeply.

The old stamp had not been useless.

It had preserved the address of the house.

Its only limitation was that it carried no information about the hands inside the house.

Devkant paid.

Before leaving he asked, “If it breaks again?”

Harinarayan said, “Bring it back.”

Ira said without thinking, “This time we will write down who made the axle.”

Devkant laughed.

“Then there will be less argument next time.”

Harinarayan laughed too.

That evening a new register was opened.

At the top of the first page was written:

“UNDERSIDE REGISTER.”

Below it were five columns:

Serial Number / Date / Object / Work / Hand.

The first entry was the repair of the old bullock cart.

Ira wrote:

“72/1 — Bullock cart — Repair — Axle: Ira, under Harinarayan’s supervision; colour-joint: Ratna; horn-joint: Shambhunath; original maker not known exactly.”

Harinarayan read the last words.

“Was ‘not known exactly’ necessary?”

Ira said, “Most necessary.”

“Why?”

“What we do not know should not be placed under someone’s name.”

Harinarayan slowly nodded.

The next question was how to mark the underside.

Having a new iron stamp made would be expensive.

Shambhunath suggested burning in a number with a small heated pin.

Ratna Devi said, “Burn the mark before painting, otherwise the paint will scorch.”

Kamala Devi added, “And not so deep that it feels rough in a child’s hand.”

Ira practised on the underside of a leftover horse.

The first burn was too deep.

The second crooked.

The third clear, small and fine.

Harinarayan said, “A serial number is better than the first letter of the artisan’s name.”

Ira looked at him.

“You are still afraid of names?”

“Not afraid. I want to avoid comparison.”

“What comparison?”

“A customer will say, ‘I want only Ira’s work,’ or ‘only Harinarayan’s.’ Then the fact that one toy may contain five hands will disappear again.”

Ira thought for a while.

The concern was not unreasonable.

She said, "Let the serial number remain underneath and the names remain in the register. But if an artisan makes an entire object alone and wants to, they may add a small initial."

"If they want to?" Kamala Devi asked.

"Yes. Not compulsory."

Ratna Devi said, "Good. Some may want to preserve a name; some only the work."

The rules were written down.

First: the old round shop stamp would remain.

Second: the underside would carry a small date and serial number.

Third: the Underside Register would record names according to the work each hand did.

Fourth: a sole maker could add a small initial if they wished.

Fifth: on repaired objects, old marks would not be erased; a new repair number would be added separately.

Harinarayan smiled on reading the fifth rule.

"That little girl taught us this one."

The rules came into use the following week.

The first new toy was a fish made by Ira.

She chose the wood, shaped it, sanded it, asked Kamala Devi about the amount of colour, but applied the colour herself.

Ratna Devi only showed her how to tie the cord at the end; she did not touch the work.

Beneath the round stamp, a small mark was burned:

"26-07 / 01."

Ira looked at it for a while.

Harinarayan asked, "Initial?"

Ira still held the heated pin.

If she wished, she could burn in an "I."

After a little while she put the pin down.

"Not yet."

"Why?"

"My name is in the register."

There was a faint smile in Harinarayan's eyes.

The next day Shambhunath made a small bird entirely by himself.

The serial number was burned underneath.

He picked up the pin and burned a small "S" beside the number.

Ira saw him.

"You were the one asking why a name was needed."

Without looking up, Shambhunath said, "A mind can change."

"So quickly?"

“Wood does not tolerate haste. The mind sometimes does.”

Everyone laughed.

Within a month, three pages of the Underside Register were filled.

The old register had spoken only of quantities and money.

The new one began to show the movement inside the workshop.

Sometimes four names stood beside one horse.

Sometimes only Ratna Devi beside a spinning top.

Sometimes:

“Colour — Kamala; correction — Ira.”

Sometimes:

“Axle remade — Shambhunath.”

Ira noticed something else.

Writing down names made mistakes harder to hide, but it did not make blame simple.

One day the cords on five fish loosened within two days.

The register was checked.

Ratna Devi had tied the cords, but Ira had made the holes in the wood.

Ratna Devi said, “The holes were too large.”

Ira answered at once, “The cord was too thin.”

The two remained silent for a few moments.

Harinarayan said, “The register is not a paper for finding the guilty person. It is a paper for understanding where the work changed.”

Both the holes and the cord were changed.

There was no problem in the next batch.

That day Ira added a line in small letters at the top of the register:

“A name is not the answer; it is the place of the question.”

Harinarayan read it and said, “That sounds very much like a book.”

Ira laughed.

“Shall I erase it?”

“No. Leave it. It may be useful someday.”

One autumn evening the market was crowded.

A woman came to the shop with two small children.

She was looking at four horses.

She turned one over.

“What is this number?”

Ira said, “The date it was made and the serial number.”

“A responsibility mark for the shop?”

“No. A record of the work.”

“What does that mean?”

Ira opened the register and showed her the entry for that number.

“Kaka cut the wood, I brought out the form, Ma applied the colour, Kaki fitted the wheels.”

The woman looked slightly surprised.

“So many people in one small horse?”

From behind them Harinarayan said, “The horse is small. The hands are not.”

The woman laughed.

She bought the horse.

For the first time Ira understood that the register was not only for future repairs.

It also made invisible work visible in the present.

But she did not want to turn that into a loud advertisement for the shop.

So no large sign appeared at the door saying, “See the artisans’ names.”

The small number remained underneath.

If someone asked, the register was opened.

If no one asked, the toy went home with its colour, its shape and its play.

Two months later Devkant returned.

This time the old bullock cart was not broken.

The girl came turning it in her hands.

“The wheels run well,” she said from a distance.

Ira smiled.

Devkant chose a small fish to buy.

Out of habit the girl turned it over.

“There is a number on this.”

“Yes.”

“Whose?”

Ira opened the register.

Against that fish was written:

“Form: Ira; colour: Kamala; cord: Ratna.”

The girl read it.

Then she asked, “Whose name is on the old cart?”

Ira opened the first page.

“The names from the repair are here. We do not know exactly who made it originally.”

The girl thought for a while.

“Then is it nameless?”

Ira took the bullock cart in her hands.

The old round stamp was on the underside.

Beside it was the fine mark of the new repair number.

“Not completely nameless,” Ira said. “It has the house’s name. It has the names of the later work. Some names in between are not known to us.”

“Then?”

Ira said, “Where we do not know, that place will remain blank.”

Whether the girl was satisfied with that answer could not be read from her face.

Holding the fish in one hand and the cart in the other, she went out of the shop.

Evening was falling.

In the workshop, Harinarayan turned over the last horse of the day and burned its serial number onto the underside.

Ira watched from a distance.

Once she had thought that if her own name did not appear underneath, her work would be erased.

Now she understood that writing a name was not merely saying, “This is mine.”

Sometimes a name said:

“This hand was here.”

Sometimes:

“This work passed through here.”

Sometimes:

“Begin understanding this mistake from here.”

And sometimes a blank line said:

“Here, we do not know.”

Ira picked up a newly made horse.

On the underside were the round shop stamp, the date and the serial number.

She took the thin heated pin in her hand.

For a few moments she thought.

Then, beside the number, she burned a very small “I.”

Harinarayan saw it but said nothing.

Ira turned the horse upright.

From above, there was no sign anywhere.

The horse was simply a horse.

But if it ever returned to this workshop, its underside could be opened and its path read.

The Broken Note

It had been drizzling since noon that day.

In the western room of the house, an old harmonium stood on a low wooden platform.

Its black polish had worn away long ago, the brass along its edges had gone dull, and though the leather on the left side was slightly torn, the bellows still worked properly.

But one note in the middle would not sound.

Whenever a finger pressed it, instead of a note there came from inside only a dry puff of air:

“Phuss.”

Mrinalini pressed the key for the third time.

“Again the same,” she said.

Her younger brother Nachiketa sat with the recording app open on his phone.

He looked up and said, “Play it once more.”

Mrinalini pressed it again.

“Phuss.”

Nachiketa stopped the recording.

“This will not work.”

Janaki Devi, sitting on the cot, laughed.

“It seems to be working to me.”

“Dadi, one note is missing.”

“Not missing. It is sulking.”

Mrinalini laughed.

“How will we record a song with a sulking note?”

Janaki Devi kept looking at the rain falling outside the window.

“The way a song is sung—with whatever is there.”

It was not that simple.

Mrinalini had to return to Pune in three days.

For six months she had been away for training in sound archiving.

This time, when she came to the village, she had decided to record the five old songs that only her grandmother still remembered in full.

They were all songs connected with weddings, but they were not all of one kind.

One was sung before kanyadaan, one when the palanquin was lifted, one on a new bride's first morning, one at a brother's farewell, and one that Janaki Devi herself called "the middle song."

"Why the middle song?" Mrinalini had asked on the first day.

Janaki Devi had said, "Because people thought of it as both a beginning and an ending. The song lived in between."

Mrinalini had liked that answer very much.

She wanted to record all five songs.

The first four had been recorded over the previous two days.

The fifth remained.

And the fifth needed exactly that broken note.

The harmonium was not Janaki Devi's.

It had belonged to her elder sister-in-law, who had died many years earlier.

No one in the house played it regularly, but when the plan to record the songs was made, it had been brought down from a box in the upper hall.

The dust had been wiped away, the cloth covering changed, and oil applied to the bellows.

On the first day everything had seemed fine.

Today, just before the fifth song began, the middle Ma had fallen silent in the middle of playing.

Nachiketa said, "I called Mehta-ji in the market. He can come the day after tomorrow."

Mrinalini replied at once, "I leave the day after tomorrow."

"Stay one more day."

"Changing the ticket is not easy. It is the first session of the training."

Janaki Devi listened to both of them.

Then she asked, "Can the song not happen unless the harmonium is repaired?"

Mrinalini turned towards her.

"The song can happen, but the melody will be distorted."

"Is the melody so weak?"

"Not weak. But at one place it descends onto Ma. What will we do there?"

Janaki Devi held out her hand.

"Let me play first."

Mrinalini slid the harmonium towards the cot.

Janaki Devi worked the bellows.

Her left hand was still steady.

With the right she played Sa, Re, Ga, then the silent Ma, then Pa.

"Phuss."

She played it again.

“Phuss.”

Nachiketa said, “See?”

Janaki Devi said, “I see.”

She hummed the first line of the song.

The broken note did not occur in the first line.

Nor in the second.

At the end of the third line, the tune was supposed to descend and settle on that Ma.

Janaki Devi stopped her finger before it reached the note.

Then, skipping Ma, she descended straight to Ga.

The line of the song bent slightly.

Mrinalini said at once, “That became different.”

“Yes.”

“It is no longer the original tune.”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

Janaki Devi hummed the same line again.

This time, instead of descending to Ma, she lingered a little on the Pa above it, then came down to Ga.

“This?”

Mrinalini listened.

“A little better. But still not the original.”

Janaki Devi stopped the bellows.

“Where do you want the original—in your ear, or on paper?”

Mrinalini did not answer.

Nachiketa was opening the list of the four songs already recorded on the phone.

Janaki Devi said again, “When I first learned this song, there was no harmonium.”

“Then?”

“There was the mouth.”

“Was the melody the same even then?”

“As far as I remember.”

“Who did you learn it from?”

“From my mother. Before her—”

Janaki Devi stopped, then corrected herself.

“Before her, I do not know exactly.”

Mrinalini smiled.

Her grandmother too had learned the habit of leaving a blank where a fact was not known.

"But the melody?"

"Melodies change as they travel."

"Then what should I write in the archive?"

"Write what was sung today."

"But today the harmonium is broken."

"Write that too."

After that sentence, only the sound of rain remained in the room.

Mrinalini went to the window.

Outside, water had collected around the tulsi altar.

The water falling from the edge of the roof was not even everywhere—thick in some places, thin in others.

She remembered her instructor from the training.

He often said: before removing a background sound from a recording, ask whether it is an obstruction or part of the context.

Mrinalini had written that sentence many times in her notebook.

But now the question was not in the background.

It was inside the melody itself.

One complete note was missing.

Nachiketa asked, "Can you alter the pitch on the phone and add the note later?"

Mrinalini replied immediately, "No."

"Why? It would become clean."

"I am not making the song. I am documenting it."

Janaki Devi laughed.

"And the one who documents is so afraid of cleaning?"

Mrinalini laughed too, but the question remained inside her.

She wanted her grandmother's song to survive as completely as possible.

It seemed wrong that the form of the song should change because of a broken instrument.

After noon the rain grew heavier.

Mehta-ji called again and said that water had risen near the bridge, so it would be difficult for him to come before the day after tomorrow.

Mrinalini ended the call.

"Now it is certain."

Nachiketa asked, "What?"

"Let us leave today's recording. Dadi can simply sing without the harmonium."

Janaki Devi said, "Why without the harmonium?"

"It is broken."

"One note is broken. What crime have all the others committed?"

Nachiketa burst out laughing.

Mrinalini did not.

"Dadi, if you change the song, later people will think the melody was like this."

"Who are these people?"

"Whoever listens."

"Will they read what you write too?"

"If I keep the description with it, they may."

"Then write: 'On this day one note of the harmonium would not sound.'"

"But the listener will hear the sound first."

"Good. Then they will hear its absence in the sound too."

"But you will leave out the note."

"I will not leave it out. I will move around it."

This time Janaki Devi's voice was not joking.

She pulled the harmonium towards herself again.

"Watch."

She sang the first line.

The bellows continued.

The second line.

The third line was now approaching Ma.

She held on Pa and lengthened the note slightly.

Then, instead of dropping straight to Ga, she circled down towards Re and came back to Ga.

The tune changed in such a way that the place of the missing note did not sound empty; a small curve had formed around it.

Mrinalini was startled.

"Again."

Janaki Devi sang again.

This time the curve was slightly different.

"Again."

On the third attempt it was different again.

Mrinalini said, "You are not singing it the same way each time."

"Why should I?"

"For the recording."

"Will the song hold its breath for the recording?"

Mrinalini fell silent.

Janaki Devi said, "Where Ma used to be, I am now looking for a path. How can a path become fixed the very first time?"

Mrinalini liked that sentence, but her working habit wanted a single take.

"Let us practise five or six times first."

"Let us."

That evening the front hall of the house became a small rehearsal room.

Nachiketa shut the window to reduce the sound of rain.

Janaki Devi immediately said, "Open it."

"The noise is coming in."

"So is the heat."

The window was opened again.

Mrinalini placed the phone a little away from the harmonium, pointed more towards her grandmother's mouth.

In the first rehearsal, Dadi stopped on the third line.

"No. That turn became too large."

The second time she shortened the line.

The third time a goat bleated outside in the middle.

Nachiketa stopped the phone.

Janaki Devi said, "Does the goat have no place in the archive either?"

"Dadi!"

Everyone laughed.

On the fourth attempt Mrinalini worked the bellows herself while Janaki Devi only sang.

Then it became clear that the problem was not only the broken Ma.

When the pressure of the bellows changed, the other notes too sometimes sounded thick, sometimes thin.

Janaki Devi said, "You are pumping the bellows in fear."

"I am not afraid."

"Your hand says you are."

She showed Mrinalini how to work the bellows—long, even, without a jerk.

"The note is broken, not the breath."

Mrinalini wrote that line in her notebook.

After dinner they practised again.

This time Janaki Devi tried another way.

When the place of the broken note approached, she stopped her hand on the harmonium, let her own voice rise slightly by itself, and then caught the instrument again.

Mrinalini said, "This is very clean."

"Must it be clean?"

"For listening."

"But this is farther from my earlier melody."

Both fell silent.

After a while Janaki Devi asked, "What are you trying to preserve—the song, or its measurements?"

Mrinalini searched for an answer.

"Both."

“Both do not always fit in the same box.”

The next morning the rain had stopped.

Small pools of water lay in the courtyard.

Eastern light shone in them.

Mrinalini decided to record at seven in the morning.

At that hour fewer people in the house were talking, there was less noise from the road, and Janaki Devi’s throat was less tired.

Nachiketa folded a piece of paper beneath one side of the low platform so the harmonium would not rock.

Mrinalini first began to record a short introduction.

“Date—”

Janaki Devi stopped her.

“Write the date later. First the song.”

“Dadi, the description—”

“What?”

Mrinalini laughed.

“All right. The song first.”

The phone began recording.

The first line was steady.

The second line was steady.

On the third line Janaki Devi did not choose any one of the forms from the rehearsals.

She paused on Pa, carried her voice down with her own throat, reached Ga without touching the broken Ma, then took a small breath.

There was a strange emptiness in that breath.

Mrinalini felt that she could hear the missing note—not sounding, yet its place was audible.

The song moved on.

The fourth line.

The fifth.

The final refrain.

Janaki Devi raised her hand and stopped the bellows.

For a few moments no one spoke.

Outside, drops of leftover rain kept falling from the roof:

tap, tap.

Nachiketa said softly, “Done?”

Mrinalini stopped the phone.

“Done.”

Janaki Devi said, “Play it back.”

The three listened.

In the first two lines the harmonium sounded full.

In the third came the turn of the voice, the small breath, and then the song continued.

Janaki Devi said, "Here I descended a little too soon."

Mrinalini was startled.

"Shall we do it again?"

"Why?"

"You yourself said you descended too soon."

"I did. But the song did not break."

Nachiketa said, "One more, a cleaner version, would be good."

Janaki Devi looked at him.

"Then the first one is unclean?"

Nachiketa fell silent.

Mrinalini laughed.

"Clean."

Janaki Devi said, "Then is the first one dirty?"

"No."

"Then?"

Nachiketa gave up and smiled.

"All right, Dadi."

Even so, Mrinalini made a second recording.

The second time Janaki Devi's turn was more measured.

The breath was less audible.

The dripping outside had stopped too.

Technically, the second recording was more polished.

Mrinalini kept both.

She named the files:

"middle_song_1"

and

"middle_song_2."

Janaki Devi asked, "Why one and two?"

"First and second."

"Does the broken note sound more in the first?"

"The note is absent from both."

"But its absence?"

Mrinalini listened to both again.

In the first recording, the breath and small instability in the third line truly made the space around the missing note more distinct.

The second recording was smoother, but less open.

She renamed the files.

The first:

"middle_song_broken_note."

The second:
 “middle_song_second_take.”
 Janaki Devi said nothing.
 Two days later Mehta-ji came.
 The rain had lessened.
 He had tied a small bag of tools to the rear carrier of his bicycle.
 The harmonium was opened.
 Inside, they found dust, the dried wing of a moth, and a thin piece of metal lodged near the reed.
 Mehta-ji said, “The reed is stuck. It is not broken.”
 Nachiketa asked, “Can it be repaired?”
 “Half an hour.”
 Janaki Devi sat there watching.
 Mrinalini’s bus was in the evening.
 She had already packed her things, but stayed to see the harmonium repaired.
 Mehta-ji cleaned the reed, removed the piece of metal, checked the airflow, then closed the case.
 “Play.”
 Mrinalini pressed Ma.
 A full note came out.
 She pressed it again.
 The note was steady.
 Nachiketa picked up the phone at once.
 “Dadi, now the old one.”
 Janaki Devi said, “Which old form?”
 “The one from before.”
 “Before where?”
 “The song as you learned it.”
 Janaki Devi pulled the harmonium towards herself.
 She sang the first line.
 The second.
 On the third line, the melody now descended onto Ma.
 The full note sounded.
 For a moment Mrinalini felt as though a door had opened again.
 This melody was familiar to her—from Dadi’s humming, from weddings in childhood, from some distant blurred memory.
 The song ended.
 Nachiketa said happily, “That’s it! Now it is right.”
 With her hand still on the harmonium, Janaki Devi asked, “Was yesterday wrong?”

Nachiketa did not answer immediately.

Mrinalini stopped the phone.

“No.”

“Then how is this right?”

“This is closer to the older melody.”

“Good.”

Janaki Devi played Ma again.

The note came out clearly.

“And the path that formed yesterday?”

Mrinalini said, “That is different.”

“Will it remain?”

“It will.”

Nachiketa asked, “Why both? Choose one as the final version.”

For the first time in all these days, Mrinalini answered without thinking.

“Why choose?”

She opened all three audio files on the phone.

First: the first take with the broken note.

Second: the second take from the same day.

Third: the older familiar melody after the harmonium was repaired.

Mrinalini opened a new register.

At the top she wrote:

“The Middle Song.”

Below it, three lines.

Beside the first:

“The harmonium’s middle Ma was stuck; the singer rerouted the melody; dripping from the roof after rain is audible.”

Beside the second:

“Same day, second take; the turn is more stable.”

Beside the third:

“After the reed was cleaned; Ma sounds again in the older familiar melody.”

Janaki Devi read the register.

“‘Older familiar’ is right,” she said. “Good that you did not write ‘original.’”

Mrinalini asked, “Why such dislike for the word ‘original?’”

Janaki Devi thought for a while.

“Because the moment people say ‘original,’ they begin to think everything else is an imitation.”

“And if there really is one original?”

“Then look for it. But do not announce it before you find it.”

Mrinalini closed the register.

Before leaving for the evening bus, she went to Dadi's room.

Janaki Devi sat by the window, untangling thread.

"Dadi, I will keep all three recordings together, not in separate groups."

"Keep them."

"And I will not delete the one with the broken note."

Janaki Devi looked up.

"Delete it?"

Mrinalini laughed.

"I will not."

"What did you find in that one?"

Mrinalini thought for a few moments.

"A melody that would never have formed if the instrument had been working."

Untangling a knot in the thread, Janaki Devi said, "Then keep it for that."

"And the older melody?"

"Why would you leave that out?"

"Both?"

"Both."

"Then which one will people learn next time?"

"Whichever serves them."

"So much freedom?"

Janaki Devi laughed.

"Is a song a prisoner?"

Before leaving for the bus stand, Mrinalini went once more to the western room.

The harmonium lay closed on the low platform.

She opened the lid and pressed the middle Ma once.

The note sounded clean.

After that clean note, she remembered yesterday's small breath—the empty space that had actually been audible.

Mrinalini took out her phone.

She placed all three recordings in a single group.

She named the group:

"The Middle Song — Three Paths."

Then she wrote the final line in her notebook:

"The instrument was repaired; the first melody was not erased."

The River's Other Name

It was the last week of Bhadav.

A new district map had been hung in the school geography room.

Blue lines, black roads, small round dots, and the names of blocks in large letters.

For the first time, Nandini was looking for the name of her village on such a large map.

She found the village.

A thin blue line ran south of it.

Beside the line was written:

“Sirhani River.”

Nandini read it twice.

“Sirhani?”

Urmila, sitting beside her, asked, “What happened?”

“Is this the name of our river?”

Urmila leaned towards the map.

“What else would it be?”

Nandini did not answer.

No one at home called the river Sirhani.

At this time of year, Dadi called it Patar Dhar—the Thin Stream.

In Ashadh, Babu called it Duimunhi—the Two-Mouthed.

Harilal Kaka, who rowed the boat at the ghat, called one bend Ghumni.

Until now Nandini had assumed these were names for different parts of the river.

The geography teacher, Mridula Jha, began the lesson.

“This week every student will make a small map of their village. Mark the road, school, pond, river, embankment—whatever is important.”

On the board she wrote four things:

Place.

Direction.

Name.

Use.

“Take the name from the map. If you hear a different local form, you may record it separately in a note, but do not erase the official name.”

Nandini raised her hand.

“Ma’am, what if there is more than one local name?”

Mridula Jha paused for a moment.

“First find out whether the names are truly different names, or names for different parts of the river.”

“And what if the name changes when the season changes?”

A few children laughed.

Mridula Jha did not.

“Then write the season too. But do not turn something you have heard into a fact immediately. Record who told you, where you heard it, and when.”

At the top of her notebook Nandini wrote:

“Sirhani River?”

She put in the question mark deliberately.

That evening, after returning home, she sat beside her grandmother.

Dadi, Kamala Devi, was sitting on the veranda picking husks from makhana.

Nandini asked, “Dadi, what is the name of our river?”

Without looking up, Kamala Devi said, “Now? Patar Dhar.”

“Why now?”

Dadi raised her head.

“What do you mean?”

“A name should be one thing.”

“According to whom?”

Nandini opened her notebook.

“The school map says Sirhani River.”

Kamala Devi pushed the makhana kernels to one side.

“Yes, that will be its name on paper.”

“Then why do you call it Patar Dhar?”

“Because now it is thin.”

“In the rains?”

“Watch during the rains. The sandbank in the middle will go under, the current will split into two channels, and people will call it Duimunhi.”

“Then when do you call it Sirhani?”

Kamala Devi thought.

“When the matter is on paper. Police station, circle office, school, land measurement. In household talk, you hear it less.”

Nandini began to write.

“Patar Dhar — Bhadav?”

Dadi stopped her.

“Not every Bhadav. Watch how the water is moving.”

“Then what should I write?”

“Write only what you understand. When the rains have lessened, and the main water is moving through one narrow course.”

Nandini wrote:

“Patar Dhar — after the rains lessen; narrow main channel.”

Then she asked, “Duimunhi?”

“Ask Harilal about that. He stays at the ghat all day.”

After school the next day, Nandini and Urmila went towards the river.

To reach the ghat they had to cross paddy fields.

In some places water still shone beside the ridges.

From a distance the river truly looked thin.

Across the wide sand, the water flowed like one dark line.

Harilal Kaka had turned his boat upside down to dry.

Nandini opened her notebook.

“Kaka, what is the name of this river?”

Harilal laughed.

“Do you have an examination at school?”

“I am making a map.”

“Then write Sirhani.”

Nandini was a little surprised.

“You call it Sirhani?”

“That is what it is on paper.”

“Duimunhi?”

Harilal brushed the mud from the belly of the boat with his fingers.

“That is not the river’s name every day.”

“Dadi said in the rains.”

“Even in the rains, only above this ghat. See that sand mound over there?”

Nandini looked into the distance.

“Yes.”

“When the water rises, that mound goes half under. The current passes on both sides of it. Then this place is Duimunhi. Later it becomes one channel again.”

Nandini drew a line in her notebook.

“And Ghumni?”

This time Harilal pointed downstream.

“That bend.”

“Not the river’s name?”

“No. It is the name of the way the water moves at the bend. You need to know it when you take a boat through.”

“Should I put it on the map?”

“If your map is a boatman’s map, put it.”

Nandini fell silent.

Harilal asked, “What kind of map are you making?”

For the first time, she could not answer the question.

A map for school.

But a school map for whose use?

On the way back, Urmila said, “Did you find the answer, or did the questions increase?”

Nandini looked at her notebook.

One official name, one seasonal form, one split in the current, one boatman’s bend.

“The questions increased.”

On the third day she went to the northern bank of the river, where there were vegetable fields.

Savita Kaki was cutting grass there.

Nandini asked, “What do you call this river?”

Savita Kaki said, “Which part?”

“The one in front of us.”

“This is Sirhani.”

Nandini felt relieved.

“And Patar Dhar?”

“That is farther down.”

“Dadi calls this same river that.”

Savita Kaki laughed.

“The channel visible from your grandmother’s house is thin, so she will call it thin. Near my field the river is not so thin.”

She took Nandini up onto a field ridge.

From there, the width of the water really did look different.

In one place sand lay exposed.

In another, water reached almost to the edge of the field.

Savita Kaki said, “It is easy to ask the river’s name. If you do not ask the place, the answer will be only half.”

Nandini wrote that sentence down.

The next day in class, all the students showed their rough maps.

Some had drawn their pond large, some the road.

Some had marked a temple, some an embankment.

On her map, Nandini had written “Sirhani River” above the main line of the river.

Beside it, with three small arrows, she had written:

“Patar Dhar — in some places, after the water falls.”

“Duimunhi — near the upper sand mound, when the water rises.”

“Ghumni — boatman’s bend; movement of the current.”

Mridula Jha looked at the map.

“This is better than before.”

Nandini asked, “Then all three names are correct?”

“I will not use the word ‘correct’ yet.”

“Why?”

“Because your three notes are not the same kind of thing. One is a seasonal form of the river. One is a division of the current at a particular place. One is a boatman’s water-mark. If you call them all names of the river, you will misunderstand them again.”

Nandini was disappointed.

“Then is my title wrong?”

“Your title is a question. Let the question remain.”

In the corner of the map Mridula Jha wrote:

“Add time / place / use with a name.”

That night Nandini sat down to redraw the school map.

Putting everything on one sheet filled the river with words on every side.

The line itself became hard to see.

She did not tear the page.

She put it above her head and kept thinking.

Her younger brother Neel looked at the pile of papers and asked, “Are all these the same river?”

“Yes.”

“Then why so many maps?”

An idea came to Nandini.

From her drawing box she took out three thin transparent sheets.

At the bottom she placed the main map:

road, school, fields, the official river line, and “Sirhani River.”

On the first transparent sheet she drew only the Patar Dhar of the time after the rains had lessened.

On the second, the sand mound and the two channels when the water rose.

On the third, Harilal’s Ghumni bend, the ghat and the boat route.

At the top of each sheet, instead of a date, she wrote a time-or-use marker:

“After the rains lessen.”

“When the water rises.”

“Boatman’s place.”

Then she laid the sheets one over another.

One river appeared in four forms.

Neel kept lifting the first sheet and laying down the second.

“It looks as though the river is moving.”

“The river does move.”

“On a map?”

Nandini was quiet for a few moments.

“Less so on a map.”

The next day Mridula Jha looked at the transparent sheets.

She lifted them one by one and held them against the light.

“Where did this idea come from?”

“Writing all the names on one sheet was becoming confusing.”

“And now?”

“Now I understand that all the names are not alternatives for the same thing.”

Mridula Jha nodded.

“Write that below the map.”

Nandini wrote:

“Local names / markers are not substitutes for one another; some are linked to place, some to time, some to use.”

On Saturday, the school held a small exhibition.

The students’ maps were hung in the veranda.

Nandini’s map was placed on a table instead of being hung, because the transparent sheets had to be lifted and replaced.

Her father was the first visitor.

Reading “Sirhani River,” he said, “This time you have written it correctly.”

Nandini did not laugh.

“Look at the sheets underneath.”

Babu lifted the first.

“Patar Dhar.”

The second.

“Duimunhi.”

The third.

“Ghumni.”

He said, “Why have you written Ghumni as the river’s name?”

Nandini answered immediately, “It is not the river’s name. It is the boatman’s bend. That is why it is on a separate sheet.”

Babu smiled slightly.

“Then all this asking did some good.”

By noon many people had looked at the map.

Someone said, “Near us they call it Narkatahi.”

Nandini did not pick up her pen immediately.

She asked, “Where?”

“Near the reeds to the east.”

“All the time?”

“No, when the small channel runs that way.”

“Who do you hear calling it that?”

The person thought.

“People in our hamlet.”

On a separate slip Nandini wrote:

“Narkatahi — near the eastern reeds; when the small channel runs there; verification pending.”

Urmila was standing beside her.

She said softly, “Earlier you would have added it to the map at once.”

“Now there is still the place to ask about.”

After noon the headmaster came.

With him was an employee from the block office who had come for an inspection of the school building.

Looking at the map, he asked, “Where is the official name?”

Nandini showed him the bottom sheet.

“Sirhani River.”

“And all these others?”

“Local uses.”

The employee said, “In disaster notices one name is necessary. Several names can create confusion.”

Nandini hesitated before answering.

Mridula Jha said, “The official name has not been changed on this map. The other sheets are for understanding local markers.”

The employee looked at the sheets again.

“Then write clearly at the top: official name separate; local use separate.”

Nandini wrote the suggestion down at once.

It did not seem like opposition to her.

Instead, for the first time she understood that one name and another name could have different jobs.

In the evening the exhibition was packed away.

Mridula Jha stopped Nandini.

“Do you remember your first question?”

“Which name is right?”

“Yes.”

“And the answer now?”

Gathering the map sheets, Nandini said, “For the map, Sirhani. The other names are incomplete without place and time.”

“That is all?”

Nandini thought for a moment.

“And the name on a map cannot do every job either.”

Mridula Jha smiled.

On Monday the geography worksheet was handed out again.

Earlier the question had read:

“Write the river’s correct name.”

Mridula Jha had changed it to:

“Write the name of the river given on the district map.”

Below it she had added another line:

“If you find a local name or marker, record it separately with place / time / use.”

No one in the class paid much attention to the change.

Nandini did.

In the corner of the worksheet she drew three tiny sheets.

On one she wrote:

“Patar.”

On another:

“Duimunhi.”

On the third:

“Ghumni.”

Above them she drew one straight blue line and wrote:

“Sirhani River.”

A few days later there was heavy rain at night.

In the morning Kamala Devi looked towards the river from the veranda and said, “Now go and see whether it has become Duimunhi.”

Nandini picked up her notebook.

“First I will look as far as the sand mound.”

Dadi laughed.

“Now you will verify what I say too?”

“Everyone’s.”

“Good.”

The two set out towards the river by the path through the fields.

The sky was still grey.

From a distance the sound of the water was heavier than it had been the day before.

When they reached the sand mound, Nandini saw that the main current really was splitting into two.

She opened her notebook, but did not immediately write “Duimunhi.”

First she wrote the place.

Then the day.

Then the condition of the water.

Only after that did she write the name.

Kamala Devi said nothing.

On the way back, the school roof could be seen in the distance.

Inside, on the district map hanging on the wall, the river was still a single blue line with a single name.

Nandini no longer thought that line was wrong.

She understood only this:

paper was doing its work, and the river its own.

Two Kinds of Seed

Ashadh was drawing near, but the clouds that rose in the sky still thinned out by evening.

When Abhay returned from Darbhanga, a white sack was tied behind his bicycle.

As soon as he entered the courtyard, he opened the sack and placed it before his grandmother.

“This time we’ll sow this seed,” he said.

Janaki Devi was filling an earthen pitcher with water.

She bent to read the printing on the sack.

“Certified?”

“Yes. The people at the agricultural centre said the grains are uniform, the yield is good, and there is less disease.”

Janaki Devi did not touch the sack.

“Then what about the old seed?”

Abhay looked towards a corner of the veranda.

On a bamboo platform stood two small earthen pots.

The mouth of one was tied with a red cloth; the other was empty.

“The old seed has too many broken grains,” Abhay said. “How many times can we keep saving the same seed?”

“As long as it still does its work.”

“The new seed will do more.”

This time Janaki Devi smiled.

“Then explain it to me.”

Abhay lifted the sack.

He began reading aloud: sowing time, spacing between plants, amount of fertiliser, protection from disease.

Dadi stopped him.

“What does it say for the Dihwala field?”

Abhay fell silent.

“Which one?”

“The raised land behind the bamboo.”

Abhay laughed.

“Why would the name of a field be written on the sack?”

“Then for the Chaurwala field?”

“Dadi, the sack says the same thing for every field.”

“Are all fields the same?”

Abhay did not answer.

The household had three main fields.

A small strip near the house, where water never stood for long.

The Chaurwala field to the south, where the soil stayed wet for a long time once the rains filled it.

And the Dihwala field behind the bamboo, where the topsoil began to crack after only two days of sun.

When Babuji was alive, the field names appeared more often in conversation than on paper.

“Plough Chaurwala first.”

“Leave Dihwala for now.”

“Raise the ridge on Ghar-lagawa.”

To Abhay, all this seemed more like old habit than knowledge.

This time he had returned from a two-day camp at the agricultural centre.

His notebook was full of notes.

Seed selection, germination, spacing, nutrition.

He wanted farming to proceed by measurement, not by guesswork.

Dadi’s earthen pot seemed to him the last sign of that old guesswork.

Janaki Devi put down the pitcher and climbed up to the bamboo platform.

She untied the red cloth.

Inside was old paddy seed—some grains long, some a little short, not even all the same colour.

“This is Lalchhar,” she said.

“Even the name is one given at home.”

“Does the name work in the field, or the grain?”

“The grain.”

“Then talk about the grain.”

Abhay put his hand into the pot.

He took a few grains onto his palm and examined them.

“These are not uniform.”

“Yes.”

“Then the crop will not be uniform either.”

“Possibly.”

“Then why do you want to save it?”

Janaki Devi did not answer immediately.

She reached towards the bottom of the pot and took out a small cloth bundle.

The bundle contained four handfuls of seed.
 “Why is this separate?” Abhay asked.
 “Last year Dihwala was sown late.”
 “So?”
 “I saved seed from the plants that survived there.”
 Abhay looked again at the bundle.
 “That is not proof.”
 “I am not calling it proof.”
 “Then?”
 “I call it memory.”
 Abhay did not like that answer.
 He took out his notebook.
 “This time I will write everything down.”
 Janaki Devi said, “Write.”
 “The new seed goes into the main fields.”
 “Put it there.”
 “The old?”
 “Keep it.”
 “How much?”
 “As much as there is.”
 Abhay had expected Dadi to demand half a field again.
 But she asked for nothing.
 That confused him more.
 Two days later the first good rain came.
 The smell of wet earth filled the whole house.
 Early in the morning Abhay went to inspect the Chaurwala field.
 The soil was soft, and a thin layer of water shone over it.
 He prepared a seedbed with the new certified seed.
 The grains looked uniform.
 The sprouts too came up at almost the same time.
 Abhay went to look every morning.
 On the seventh day he took Dadi with him.
 “Look how even the plants are.”
 Janaki Devi bent to look.
 “Good.”
 Her answer seemed too small to Abhay.
 “The old seed never comes up this evenly.”
 “No.”
 “Then?”
 “Then, for now, the new seed looks good.”
 “For now?”

“Yes, for now.”

Abhay wanted to say something, but Dadi had begun studying the water in the field.

After the rain there were ten days of sun.

Chaurwala still held moisture.

Ghar-lagawa dried somewhat, but could still be worked.

The topsoil of Dihwala began hardening again.

Every evening Abhay watched the sky.

Clouds rose in the distance but did not reach the village.

On the twelfth day Dadi asked, “What will you do with Dihwala?”

“When it rains.”

“And if the rain is late?”

“Then we will plant late.”

“How large will the new-seed seedlings be by then?”

Abhay looked at his notebook.

He had not written that question down.

“I will transplant some into Ghar-lagawa,” he said. “The rest are for Chaurwala.”

“And Dihwala?”

Abhay was not angry, but his voice hardened.

“Dadi, why do you keep asking the same thing again and again?”

Janaki Devi remained calm.

“Because the field does not keep giving the same answer.”

On the third evening, a little rain fell.

Not enough to soak Dihwala completely, but enough to soften the topsoil.

Janaki Devi brought out the red-cloth bundle.

Abhay saw it.

“Now?”

“There are four handfuls. We’ll sow a small strip.”

“In so little rain?”

“That is why.”

“What if there is no more rain?”

“Then we’ll write that it did not survive.”

Abhay looked at his grandmother’s face for a moment.

He had thought saving old seed was a matter of faith for her.

Now she was ready to test it.

He picked up the spade.

A small strip was prepared in the eastern corner of Dihwala.

No one divided half the field.

No one made two equal plots.

Only as much old seed was sown as the time and soil allowed.

In his notebook Abhay wrote:
 "Dihwala, eastern corner, twelve days after first sowing."
 Janaki Devi added, "Rain — light."
 Abhay wrote it.
 "Soil?"
 "Soft on top; still dry inside."
 "That too?"
 "If you are going to write, why write only half?"
 Abhay wrote it down.
 There was no rain again the following week.
 Not every grain of the old seed germinated.
 Some places remained empty.
 Abhay showed them to Dadi.
 "See?"
 Janaki Devi counted the empty spaces.
 "Yes."
 "There are not this many gaps in the new seedbed."
 "Write that too."
 Abhay wrote the numbers in his notebook.
 That night a strong wind blew.
 By dawn the clouds had thickened, and rain fell until noon.
 The surviving shoots in the Dihwala strip stood upright again.
 A few days later the new-seed seedlings were transplanted into Chaurwala
 and Ghar-lagawa.
 The work went quickly.
 The seedlings were almost the same height, the roots clean, the joints even.
 Abhay was satisfied.
 So was Dadi.
 But Dadi did not announce her satisfaction.
 She simply kept giving water to the women doing the transplanting.
 By the middle of Sawan all three fields had turned green.
 The old-seed plants in the eastern corner of Dihwala looked different.
 Some were tall, some short.
 When Abhay went there, he first counted the empty spaces.
 Then he looked at the colour of the plants.
 "Not very uniform," he said.
 Janaki Devi had come there too.
 "Who promised they would be uniform?"
 "No one."
 "Then why are you measuring them by that standard?"
 Abhay did not laugh.

“Comparison is necessary.”

“Make the comparison. But do not ask the same question of everything.”

“What do you mean?”

Dadi pointed towards Chaurwala.

“Over there, ask how much yield it will give.”

Then she pointed towards the Dihwala strip.

“Here, first ask whether it stayed standing after being sown this late and with so little water.”

Abhay closed his notebook.

That night he opened it again.

At the top of a page he wrote:

“Name of seed.”

Below it, two lines:

New certified seed.

Lalchar.

Then he realised he was making the same old comparison again.

He did not tear the page out.

On the right he made four new columns:

Field.

Sowing time.

Water pattern.

What survived / what it gave.

The next day he showed it to Dadi.

Janaki Devi read it and asked, “Where is taste?”

Abhay smiled.

“Let the crop come first.”

“Does the story of seed not reach the stomach?”

Abhay added a fifth column:

Rice / taste.

Dadi said, “Saved seed too.”

“A sixth?”

“Yes.”

“You will make this notebook larger than the field.”

“A field is for one year. A notebook page can help next year too.”

In Bhadav the water suddenly rose.

For two days water stood in Chaurwala.

Abhay worried.

The new plants were strong by then, but he went every day to inspect the ridges.

There was no such problem in the Dihwala strip.

The water there drained away overnight.

This time Dadi said nothing.
 Abhay himself wrote in the notebook:
 "Chaurwala: standing water for two days."
 On another line:
 "Dihwala: low water retention."
 Beside it he made a small mark so he would remember later that this was a
 quality of the field, not of the seed.
 That distinction had not occurred to him before.
 In Ashwin the grain heads began to appear.
 The heads on the new seed were full and even.
 Abhay was pleased merely looking at them from a distance.
 The Lalchhar strip in Dihwala was a little later.
 The heads did not fill on the same day.
 Some bent over, some still stood straight.
 "The market people will make faces at this," Abhay said.
 "The new one is for the market."
 "Then who is this for?"
 "First let it come home."
 On harvest day the sacks of new paddy filled quickly.
 The grain was clean.
 Abhay weighed it and wrote the figure in his notebook.
 Dadi was sitting nearby.
 "Well?" she asked.
 "The new one gave a good yield."
 "Write it."
 "I have."
 "Lalchhar?"
 "Its strip was small. A direct comparison would not be fair."
 Janaki Devi smiled.
 "This time you said that yourself."
 Abhay laughed too.
 The Lalchhar was harvested two days later.
 The yield was lower, but not nothing.
 On its line Abhay wrote:
 "Late sowing, low water at the start, crop survived; yield not directly
 comparable with the new seed."
 Dadi read it.
 "You wrote a very long line."
 "I will not write half the truth."
 Janaki Devi said nothing.
 After the paddy dried, the first rice cooked at home was from the new seed.

The grains swelled and remained separate; it looked good.

Abhay ate from his plate.

"It is good."

Dadi ate too.

"Yes."

The next day rice from Lalchhar was cooked.

The colour was slightly dull and the grains were not uniform.

As soon as the lid was lifted, the aroma was different.

Abhay took the first mouthful and fell silent.

Dadi did not ask.

After a while he said on his own, "This aroma was not in the new one."

"No."

"But the new one looks better for the market."

"Yes."

"Then both go into the notebook."

"Write them."

In the taste column Abhay wrote two separate sentences.

He did not write "good" or "bad."

Against the new seed:

"Grains swell, remain separate; aroma mild."

Against Lalchhar:

"Grains uneven; aroma strong; preferred more by people at home."

The following week Harinarayan Kaka from the village came.

He had already seen Abhay's fields.

"Tell me, which seed won?"

At first Abhay wanted to laugh.

In Jeth he could have answered that question at once.

Now he could not.

He asked, "What kind of field do you have?"

Harinarayan Kaka was surprised.

"What?"

"Low land where water stands, or raised?"

"Both."

"Will you sow on time, or is there a risk of delay?"

"The rain will decide that."

"Then how can I give you one name?"

Harinarayan Kaka looked towards Dadi.

Janaki Devi was sorting paddy.

She did not raise her head.

Abhay brought his notebook.

“Look. In Chaurwala the new seed did well. In late sowing at Dihwala, Lalchhar survived. They are not directly comparable. I will write it again next year.”

“So you will keep both?”

“Yes.”

“Which one more of?”

Abhay turned the page.

“First according to the field.”

Harinarayan Kaka studied the page for a while.

“Will you give me a handful of the old one?”

This time Janaki Devi raised her head.

“We will give you seed. But with its story.”

Kaka laughed.

“The seed’s story?”

“If you do not say when it was sown, where it was sown, and how much water it received, you are giving only grain, not knowledge.”

Abhay looked at Dadi.

He did not write that sentence in the notebook.

It seemed to him that some things had to enter practice before they entered a page.

At the end of Kartik came the day to separate seed for the next year.

Abhay brought two clean containers.

He began by writing only the name on the first, then stopped.

He cut a larger strip of paper.

On the container for the new certified seed he wrote:

“Chaurwala / transplanted on time / water-retaining / good yield.”

On the Lalchhar container he wrote:

“Dihwala, eastern corner / late sowing / little water at the start / crop survived / strong aroma.”

Janaki Devi kept reading.

“And if next year it turns out the other way around?”

Abhay said, “We’ll add a new line.”

“Erase the old one?”

“No. We’ll write the year.”

He added the year above both labels.

Then he wrote the amount of saved seed.

The Lalchhar container was small.

The new-seed container was large.

The two were placed beside each other on the bamboo platform.

For the first time Abhay noticed that Dadi had never kept the old seed in opposition to the new one.

She only did not want its place to become empty.
After dinner that night, Abhay opened his notebook again.
On the first page were still his old two lines:
New certified seed.
Lalchhar.
Above them he wrote:
“Question: Which seed is good?”
He held the pen still for a while.
Then after the question he drew a small arrow and wrote:
“Where? When?”
Janaki Devi was sitting on the veranda untangling thread.
Abhay showed her the page.
She read it.
“And water?”
Abhay burst out laughing.
“That is the third question.”
He added:
“How much water?”
Dadi said, “And the eater?”
“A fourth?”
“In the end, does the notebook eat the rice or do people?”
Abhay added the fourth question too:
“For whom?”
The page was full.
The answer was still not complete.
On the bamboo platform the two containers stood quietly side by side.
To Abhay, that silence no longer felt like uncertainty.
It felt like room.

The Leaf Inside the Book

During the last week of Bhadav, the windows of the town library remained open throughout the day.

The dampness of the rains had lessened somewhat, and the sunlight was not so harsh that old paper would immediately begin to warp.

This was the time of year when the library carried out its annual inspection for moisture, dust and insects left by the monsoon.

For the first time, Mrinal was helping with that work.

She had completed Class Twelve and was continuing her studies in town, and in the evenings she came to the library.

The librarian, Shashikala Devi, assigned her three cupboards: old history, agriculture, and local society.

“Do not take out too many at once,” Shashikala Devi said.

“Ten books at a time. Dust them. Check the pages. Note insects, dampness and torn edges separately.”

Mrinal liked this work.

Books in order, pages clean, titles standing straight—these gave her a particular kind of satisfaction.

The first two days were easy.

Some pages had dust, some carried old library-stamp ink that had spread, and some bindings were loose.

On the third day she took a thick old book from the bottom shelf of the agriculture cupboard.

Its cover must once have been green, but it had now faded to a greyish brown.

As soon as she opened the book, a dried leaf fell from between the pages onto the floor.

The leaf was yellow-brown, its veins still clearly visible.

Mrinal bent and picked it up.

“Things like this should be taken out and thrown away first,” she said to herself.

Under the pressed leaf there was a faint brown stain on the page.

She was carrying the leaf towards the wastebasket when Shashikala Devi noticed.

“Which page did it fall from?”

Mrinal stopped.

“Fifty-seven.”

“Write that down first.”

“The leaf too?”

“Yes. Record what you found. Whether it is discarded or kept can be decided later.”

Mrinal found the instruction slightly unnecessary.

Even so, on the inspection sheet she wrote:

“Page 57: dried leaf; stain.”

She turned the pages again.

In the margin of page sixty-nine, two lines had been written in pencil.

The handwriting was fine and slightly slanted.

“The pond water did not fall this low this year.”

Below it, in another hand, someone had written:

“Which year? The year is not clear on the page.”

Mrinal frowned.

“This should be cleaned.”

Shashikala Devi came closer.

“Why?”

“Someone has written in the book.”

“I can see that.”

“Writing in library books is forbidden.”

“It is forbidden now.”

“Was it not forbidden earlier?”

Shashikala Devi looked at the book’s old stamp.

“The rule on paper is very old. It was not followed in exactly the same way at all times.”

Mrinal took out an eraser.

“The pencil is faint. It will come off.”

Shashikala Devi stopped her hand.

“Not yet.”

“We are cleaning the dust.”

“Dust and writing are not the same thing.”

Mrinal fell silent.

Shashikala Devi examined the stamp at the back of the book.

The accession number was very old.

The library had received the book from the private collection of a teacher in the town.

The year of donation was half erased.

"The note may have been written by the donor," Shashikala Devi said.

"Or by a reader."

Mrinal asked, "Then if we do not know whose it is, should we still keep it?"

"First we should know what it is."

That day, instead of ten books, only four were inspected.

Because Mrinal's eyes had begun to look more at the margins than at the dust.

In one book an old grocery list was trapped.

In another, half a railway ticket.

In a third, on page twelve, someone had written:

"Ask Babu about this."

On page eighty-one someone had drawn only three question marks.

Somewhere there was a round blue flower drawn by a child's pen.

Somewhere else, a telephone number.

Mrinal kept making a list of everything.

By evening, her first assumption—old books are dirty—had changed a little.

But another problem had become clear.

If every mark were preserved in the name of memory, the books themselves could be damaged.

The stain from the dried leaf was spreading.

In one book, the paper under a pressed flower had turned black.

A piece of old newspaper had begun sticking to a page.

The next day Mrinal showed all this to Shashikala Devi.

"If we keep everything, the book will not survive."

"You are right."

"Then shall we remove it?"

"Everything?"

Mrinal did not answer.

Shashikala Devi placed four things on the table:

the dried leaf, the railway ticket, the grocery list, and a thin slip of paper with two lines of verse written on it.

"Which of these is important?"

Mrinal picked up the leaf.

"This is damaging the book. It has to be removed."

"Does it have to be preserved?"

"I do not know."

"The railway ticket?"

"Perhaps it was used as a bookmark."

"The grocery list?"

"Nothing special."

"The poem?"

Mrinal read it.

The lines were ordinary.

There was neither an author's name nor a date.

"Perhaps someone used this as a bookmark too."

Shashikala Devi smiled.

"See? Something found inside an old book does not become history by itself."

"Then how do we decide?"

"That is what we have to understand."

That week Ramlochan Jha, an old member of the library, came in.

He was a retired headmaster and came twice a week to read newspapers.

Shashikala Devi showed him the pencilled note in the book.

Ramlochan Jha lowered his spectacles and examined the handwriting.

"This is not my handwriting," he said first.

Mrinal laughed.

"I had not even asked."

"When people see an old thing, their first instinct is to deny their own crime."

All three laughed.

Then Ramlochan Jha became serious.

"But the second line is interesting."

Mrinal read it aloud:

"Which year? The year is not clear on the page."

"Yes. The reader is demanding an accounting from the author."

"There is no name."

"Still, the question exists."

Mrinal asked, "If we erase this note, the book becomes clean."

Ramlochan Jha tilted the page towards the light.

"If you use an eraser, the pressure mark will remain."

Indeed, the paper beneath the pencil letters was slightly indented.

"Then it will be neither clean nor old," he said.

That sentence stayed with Mrinal.

That evening she took out three separate registers.

The first:

Condition of the book.

The second:

Separate objects found inside.

The third:

Writing in the margins.

Shashikala Devi asked, "Why three?"

"Because the three are not the same thing."

In the first register she wrote:

"Page 57: stain; leaf must be removed."

In the second:

"Dried leaf; page 57; date found."

In the third:

"Page 69; two separate pencil notes; words copied as exactly as possible."

Shashikala Devi said nothing.

Two days later the library committee met.

The main subject was repair of a leaking roof, but at the end Shashikala Devi raised the matter of the old books.

One committee member said, "A library keeps books, not piles of unnecessary paper."

Another said, "If someone has written in a book, they broke the rule. Erase it."

For the first time Mrinal spoke before the committee.

"Not everything has to be preserved."

Everyone looked at her.

"But before erasing something, we should know what we are erasing."

She showed them the stain from the dried leaf.

Then the note on page sixty-nine.

"If the leaf remains inside, it will damage the paper. It has to be removed. But if we throw it away without recording where it was, later no one will know why the stain existed."

"And the note?" a member asked.

"If it is already in an old book, do not immediately erase it. First make a photograph or copy, note the page number, and record whether it is ink or pencil."

"In every book?"

"Only where such marks are found."

The committee chair asked, "And what about people writing in books from now on?"

Mrinal had not prepared for that question.

How could old marks be preserved and new marks prevented at the same time?

Ramlochan Jha was sitting there.

He said, "Give paper beside the book."

"A bookmark?"

"No. For the reader's words."

Mrinal remembered the dried leaf.

"If loose slips are pressed inside the book again, we will have the same problem."

Shashikala Devi said, "Not inside the book."

There was silence around the table.

Slowly Mrinal began to see a method.

"A slip with the book's accession number and page number could be kept separately in a box."

"The reader writes, returns the book, and leaves the slip at the book desk?"

"Yes."

"Could another reader ask for the slips for that book?"

"Yes."

"Then the note has become separate from the book."

Ramlochan Jha said, "Separate, but not orphaned. The accession number is its thread."

The committee did not pass the rule immediately.

A three-week trial was agreed upon.

Mrinal and Shashikala Devi cut fifty small slips.

At the top were four fields:

Book number.

Page.

Date.

Reader's name — optional.

Below was an open space:

"Your comment / question."

The slips were plain grey-white.

Mrinal wanted different colours.

Shashikala Devi stopped her.

"Do not assign meanings through colour. Let the reader write what they want."

A second kind of thin envelope was made for old material found inside books.

Every envelope carried the book number, page where found, date found, and a short description of the object.

The dried leaf was removed from page fifty-seven and placed in one such envelope.

For a few days a thin blank sheet was left between the affected pages so the dampness of the stain would not increase.

The railway ticket was separated too.

There was a debate over the grocery list.

Mrinal asked, "Keep this?"

Shashikala Devi said, "First write the book number and page. Then we will look again after a month. Not everything has to be kept permanently."

Mrinal was slightly disappointed by this answer.

She had suddenly begun to feel an attachment to old objects.

Where earlier she had wanted to throw everything away, now she wanted to preserve everything.

Shashikala Devi understood the change.

"Both are easy extremes," she said.

"Erase everything, or preserve everything."

"The work in the middle is harder?"

"In the middle, you have to write down the reason."

Very few slips were filled during the first week of the trial.

People took books, read them, returned them.

Mrinal began to think the plan would remain only on paper.

On the third day, a college student filled out a slip.

The book was about local history.

For page 113, he wrote:

"The old course of the river is named here, but there is no map. Where can the map be found?"

Mrinal read the slip and showed it to Shashikala Devi.

"Should we answer?"

"The library is not an answer sheet."

"Then?"

"Keep the slip."

Two days later an elderly reader asked for the same book.

Mrinal showed him the slip.

He read page 113, then filled out another slip.

"The old course can be seen on the district archive map of 1964; the name is different."

Mrinal placed both slips in the same compartment under the same book number.

For the first time the system felt alive to her.

The slip was not an answer.

It was a path from one reader to another.

Meanwhile, inspection of the old books continued.

In one book someone had written "Not correct" in the margin thirty years earlier.

Mrinal copied the note.

Ramlochan Jha asked, "Does it say why it is not correct?"

"No."

"Then the note is incomplete."

Mrinal said, "Even so, it is a reader's mark."

"Yes. But do not turn the mark into evidence."

Because of this, a third rule was added:

Old marginal notes would be recorded as readers' statements, not as facts belonging to the book.

In another book they found a telephone number.

Mrinal picked up her mobile to photograph it, then stopped.

"Record this too?"

Shashikala Devi looked at the number.

"It may be personal. Do not copy the digits. Write only: 'telephone number written.'"

For the first time Mrinal understood that preservation did not mean reproducing everything exactly for public view.

For some things, only their existence would be recorded, not their content.

Some marginal replies would remain in the books; some only in copies.

Some pressed objects would go into separate envelopes; some would be destroyed because of insects or mould.

The decision was not the same every time.

But now the reason for the decision was written down.

Three weeks later the committee met again.

Mrinal took the box of slips with her.

Of fifty slips, seventeen had been filled.

Eight were only questions.

Five were disagreements.

Three pointed towards additional sources.

One slip said only:

"This page reminded me of my grandmother."

One committee member said, "That is not useful information."

Mrinal read the slip again.

"It is not a fact," she said.

"But it is a reader's response."

"Will you keep everything?"

Shashikala Devi answered, "As much as space and the rules allow. But categories will remain separate."

At last the new method was approved.

Marks found in old books would not immediately be erased.

First an inspection note would be made with the page reference.

Harmful pressed objects would be removed from the book.

Objects worth keeping would be placed in separately labelled envelopes.

New readers would not write in the books.

They would submit page-numbered slips at the book desk.

The slips would be kept in separate compartments according to accession number.

And useless, private or harmful material would be reviewed from time to time.

After the rules were written, Mrinal suggested the title:

“Reader-Slip Rules.”

Shashikala Devi said, “Fine. But write the first line: ‘Do not write in the book.’”

“After all this work, the same old rule again?”

“The rule may be old. Its reason is clearer now.”

Mrinal laughed.

A month later, that first book was repaired.

Its binding was tightened.

The brown stain on page fifty-seven did not disappear completely.

The stain was now recorded in the book’s damage note.

The dried leaf was in a separate envelope:

“Book 347 / Page 57 / Found in Bhadav.”

The two pencilled notes on page sixty-nine remained in the book exactly as they were.

A copy of them had also been made on a separate sheet.

Mrinal was about to return the book to the shelf when she opened page sixty-nine once more.

The first reader had written:

“The pond water did not fall this low this year.”

The second had asked:

“Which year? The year is not clear on the page.”

Mrinal felt the question was still valid.

She took out a new reader slip for the book.

She wrote the accession number.

Page 69.

The date.

Then she held the pen still for a long time.

She did not know the answer to the old note.

At last she wrote:

“If anyone has a year-by-year record of this pond’s water level, please inform the library.”

She left the name field blank.

She did not put the slip inside the book.

She placed it in the book-desk compartment beside Book 347.

Two days later someone had written in small letters on the back of that slip:

“Check the municipality’s old rainfall register.”
Mrinal saw the line.
So did Shashikala Devi.
“What will you do now?” she asked.
Mrinal said, “First we will look for it.”
“And if it is not found?”
“We will write on the slip: ‘Not found.’”
Shashikala Devi smiled.
Mrinal looked towards the shelves.
From outside, the book looked cleaner than before.
There was no new writing on its pages.
But in the small compartment at the book desk, its reading was continuing
to grow.
The old dried leaf was outside the book.
The new reader’s slip was outside the book too.
Each was safe in its own place.
And the book, between them, was open again for reading.

Shared Time on the Roof

It was the beginning of Kartik.

By seven in the morning, so many people gathered on the roof of the town's four-storey building that the courtyard below seemed empty.

The building bore the name "Sahaj Nivas," but the residents simply called it "the Four-Storey."

The roof was rectangular.

Two water tanks stood on the western side, four clotheslines on the east, five solar panels on the south, and an open strip on the north.

There was nothing in the middle.

Yet at different hours of the day, that empty middle belonged to different people.

In the morning Shyamnarayan Babu walked there.

His knees hurt.

The doctor had told him to walk twenty minutes on level ground.

The road below had vehicles, dust and stray dogs.

So he completed his twenty minutes on the roof.

By eight, Sushila Devi and Manjula Devi came up carrying clothes, sacks of makhana, papads and jars of pickle.

By ten, the sunlight shifted from behind the solar panels and fell across the open eastern side.

That was when the clothes were spread there.

At noon the roof stood deserted.

At four the children came up with a ball, skipping ropes, paper pinwheels and chalk.

After evening, two or three families came to walk.

For a long time this sequence continued like an unwritten rule.

The quarrel began after the solar panels were installed.

Earlier, the southern side of the roof had also been open.

To reduce the electricity bill, the building committee had five solar panels fitted there.

The panels stood slightly above the floor on iron frames.

A person could pass between them, but if a child's ball went underneath, it was difficult to retrieve.

The worker who cleaned the panels had said that at least one cubit of passage should be kept clear around them.

For the first two weeks everything went well.

In the third week Sushila Devi set up two new bamboo poles beside the eastern clotheslines.

"The southern space is gone," she said. "The clothes have to dry somewhere."

A new line was stretched between the bamboo poles.

Because of that line, Shyamnarayan Babu's walking circuit became smaller.

Earlier he had gone around the water tanks and made a full loop from east to south.

Now he had to bend to pass beneath the new line.

Twice his head brushed against a wet sheet.

On the third day he untied one end of the line and fastened it a little higher.

At noon Sushila Devi saw it and lowered it again.

"How am I supposed to lift the clothes that high?" she said.

The next morning Shyamnarayan Babu placed two pieces of brick beside the line.

A narrow passage formed between them.

That evening the children arranged those same bricks into a circle and made them the boundary of their game.

The following day the bricks were somewhere else again.

No one said anything.

But everyone understood that the roof had begun asking for separate marks.

The first unmistakable incident came when seven-year-old Neel crawled beneath the solar panels after his ball.

Ten-year-old Richa followed him.

Manjula Devi was upstairs gathering the clothes.

As soon as she saw them from a distance, she called out, "Do not go in there!"

Richa stopped.

Neel had already reached the ball.

When he stood up, his head narrowly missed the iron corner of a panel.

Manjula Devi caught his hand and brought him out.

"Will you split your head open for a ball?"

Neel said nothing.

By evening the matter had reached downstairs.

Neel's father, Arun, said, "If the children had a place of their own, why would they go under the panels?"

Sushila Devi immediately replied, "How can they have space? The clothesline area has been cut in half."

Shyamnarayan Babu said, "And the walking path has been cut in half too."

No one laughed.

Arun pointed towards the roof and said, "Then whose roof is it?"

The air changed as soon as the question was asked.

Every family in the Four-Storey paid a monthly maintenance charge.

On paper, the roof was a shared space.

But the word "shared" was simple only on paper.

On the roof its meaning got caught among clothes, knees, balls, sunlight, water and electricity.

The following Sunday morning a small meeting was held.

Hariprasad Chaudhary, the committee secretary, came with a notebook.

He said, "Divide the space. The dispute will end."

Arun said, "Give half the northern side to the children."

Sushila Devi said, "All the sunlight on the eastern side should be for clothes."

Shyamnarayan Babu said, "Leave a three-cubit walking path all around."

The company that serviced the solar panels had already asked for a southern service path.

Hariprasad drew a rectangular plan in his notebook.

As soon as he drew the first line, the problem began to show itself.

If half the eastern side became permanently the clothes area, there would be no sun there in the evening, while the children needed open space then.

If a three-cubit walking path were left all around, the middle would become too small for play.

If a permanent strip were set aside for the children, it would lie empty in the morning.

Rashmi sat near the mouth of the staircase, listening.

She was seventeen and studied in Class Twelve.

She had not come to speak in the meeting.

She had come with her mother, Manjula Devi, to take down clothes.

But the permanent lines being drawn in the notebook looked strange to her.

She did not come to the roof to study every day, but she did when examinations were near.

She knew that a place shaded in the morning could be in sharp sun by afternoon.

The shadow behind the solar panels too shifted like the hand of a clock.

Rashmi asked quietly, "Does the space stay the same all day?"
 Hariprasad looked up.
 "The roof?"
 "The roof stays. But the space being used?"
 Sushila Devi said, "Does space move?"
 Rashmi did not answer immediately.
 She looked towards the eastern clotheslines.
 The morning sun was now beneath them.
 The shadow of the southern solar panels stretched long towards the north.
 "The shade moves," she said.
 Arun smiled and asked, "Will shade settle the quarrel?"
 Rashmi had no immediate answer.
 The meeting ended without a decision.
 Hariprasad said they would discuss it again the following week.
 That afternoon Rashmi went back to the roof.
 She had chalk, a measuring tape and an old notebook.
 Manjula Devi asked, "What are you measuring?"
 "Not the roof. Time."
 Her mother laughed.
 "Can time be measured with a tape?"
 "I am trying to see."
 The next morning Rashmi returned at seven.
 She placed a small chalk dot at the edge of the solar-panel shadow.
 Another at ten.
 A third at one.
 A fourth at four.
 A fifth at five.
 She did not draw a complete line.
 Only small dots, with the times written in her notebook.
 On the second day she measured the shadow of the water tanks.
 On the third, the sunlight under the clotheslines.
 Neel asked, "Didi, are you making a game?"
 "Not yet. I am measuring."
 "Can I help?"
 Rashmi gave him a piece of chalk.
 "At four o'clock, make a small circle wherever your ball keeps going."
 Neel made five circles.
 "That many times?"
 "Every time."
 Rashmi wrote in her notebook:
 "Path of the ball."

Richa was skipping rope.

She said, "My rope catches on the line."

Rashmi marked that place too.

While doing his morning walk, Shyamnarayan Babu stopped.

"These dots of yours fall in my circuit."

"The dots will not remain," Rashmi said.

"Then?"

"First I am trying to understand whose work goes where, and at what time."

Shyamnarayan Babu completed his twenty minutes and went towards the stairs.

As he left, he said, "At seven I do not go along the northern side. It is slippery then."

"Why?"

"Night dew."

Rashmi opened the notebook again and wrote:

"Northern strip wet in the morning."

In four days, two pages of the notebook were full.

Rashmi understood that the dispute was not simply about a shortage of floor space.

The problem was that everyone was taking the hour of their own need to mean the whole day.

To Sushila Devi, the eastern strip seemed to be a place for clothes because she saw it that way from ten to two.

To Shyamnarayan Babu, the open strip all around seemed to be a walking path because that was how he saw it in the morning.

To the children, the empty middle in the evening seemed to be a playground.

To the solar-panel worker, the narrow southern strip was a service path.

All four things were not true at the same time.

But they were true at different times.

The following Sunday the meeting was held again.

This time Rashmi sat with her notebook.

Hariprasad said, "Now let us settle the boundaries."

Rashmi said, "Let us settle the boundaries, but not make every boundary serve the same purpose all day."

She spread out the notebook.

On the first page was a simple plan of the roof.

On the second were five times:

seven in the morning, ten, one, four, five.

On the third were the different uses.

“From seven to eight,” Rashmi said, “there are fewer clothes. A walking circuit can remain open all around.”

Shyamnarayan Babu listened silently.

“From ten to two,” she continued, “there is more sunlight in the east and the middle. No one plays then. The sunning area for clothes and grain can be larger.”

Sushila Devi bent towards the notebook.

“And at four?”

“From four to six, the central portion is for play. Whatever clothes have dried should be gathered. Whatever has not dried can stay on the eastern lines, but the new line through the middle should be removed.”

Sushila Devi frowned.

“Do the clothes dry by four every day?”

“No,” Rashmi said. “That is why the original four eastern lines remain. Only the new bamboo line through the middle goes.”

Arun asked, “The solar panels?”

“Their service path remains clear at all times.”

“And the children?”

“No ball on the southern side.”

Neel immediately said, “What if the ball goes there?”

Rashmi said, “Instead of a low rope on that side, we can tie a mesh so the ball cannot go underneath the panels.”

Hariprasad ran a finger over the notebook.

“This has become a timetable.”

“Not completely,” Rashmi said.

“What else?”

“The shade will change. The timing will change in winter. It will change in summer. So we should not paint permanent lines on the floor.”

Arun asked, “Then how will people remember?”

Rashmi took four small wooden plaques from her bag.

One said:

“WALKING.”

The second:

“SUN.”

The third:

“PLAY.”

The fourth:

“SERVICE PATH — KEEP CLEAR.”

“Whichever use applies at that time, hang that plaque near the stair entrance.”

Sushila Devi said, "While spreading clothes, am I supposed to keep changing plaques too?"

Manjula Devi spoke for the first time.

"Why should changing the plaque be one person's job? Whoever comes up first can look."

Hariprasad said, "Let us try it for a week."

No one was very enthusiastic.

But no one openly opposed it either.

On the first day the rule nearly broke in the morning itself.

When Shyamnarayan Babu came up at seven, clothes washed the night before were still hanging on the eastern lines.

He called out, "Whose are these?"

No one answered from below.

By old habit, he felt like untying the line.

But the "WALKING" plaque hung by the mouth of the staircase.

He did not touch the line.

He made his circuit slightly smaller by moving inward.

At eight Sushila Devi came up.

She saw the clothes.

"Seema left them overnight," she said.

Seema lived on the third floor.

Sushila Devi called downstairs.

"These are your clothes. It is eight."

Seema came up and gathered them.

She looked annoyed, but said nothing.

On the second day Seema came up at seven fifty-five.

Shyamnarayan Babu was making his final circuit.

He did not look at the clock.

Seema stood beside the line.

Shyamnarayan Babu saw her and stopped walking five minutes early.

"My twenty minutes are not complete," he said with a laugh.

Seema smiled.

"Yesterday I took five minutes from you."

No meeting was held over those five minutes.

On the third day the afternoon wind was strong.

Two of Sushila Devi's sheets blew from the line and fell in the middle.

At one o'clock the "SUN" plaque was hanging.

There were no children.

Rashmi picked up the sheets and put them back on the line.

At four one sheet was still damp.

Neel came up with his ball.

He looked at the sheet, then at the "PLAY" plaque.
 "Kaki, when will this come down?"
 Sushila Devi touched the cloth with her fingers.
 "Half an hour."
 Neel did not go downstairs.
 He went to the northern side and played with a paper spinner.
 Half an hour later Sushila Devi gathered the sheet.
 Neel took out the ball.
 Rashmi wrote nothing in the notebook that day.
 She understood that the half-hour of waiting had done more work than the written rule.
 On the fourth day the problem appeared in another form.
 Two workers came without notice to clean the solar panels.
 It was afternoon.
 Two mats of makhana were spread in the sunning area.
 The workers needed the southern service path.
 The makhana was not on the service path, but there was too little turning space to carry a bucket through.
 Manjula Devi folded back one corner of a mat.
 The workers passed.
 As he left, one said, "Never close off this one-cubit path."
 Hariprasad wrote that in the notebook.
 "This is not a rule of time," he said.
 Rashmi replied, "That is why its plaque says 'keep clear at all times.'"
 On the fifth day the children quarrelled not over the ball but over skipping.
 Richa said the middle strip was hers.
 Neel said the play strip belonged to everyone.
 "Then my rope will get tangled with his ball."
 Rashmi was there.
 She said, "Are we dividing the roof among four families, or among activities?"
 Both fell silent.
 "The play strip belongs to play. Even games can take turns."
 Neel put the ball down and held the skipping rope for five minutes.
 Richa jumped ten times, then handed the rope to Neel.
 No one wrote a rule for it.
 On the seventh day the meeting was held.
 Hariprasad asked, "Will the arrangement work?"
 Sushila Devi said, "In winter the sunlight comes later."
 Rashmi said, "Then the times will change."
 Shyamnarayan Babu said, "In the rains the clothes will stay up longer."

"Then the play strip will be a little smaller," Arun said.

Neel's face fell.

Looking at him, Arun added, "And once the rain stops, the roof will be more open for play."

Hariprasad crossed out the word "permanent" in the notebook.

He wrote:

"Measure again according to season."

Rashmi said, "That is the main thing about my rule."

"What?"

"The line belongs to the hour, not to the ground."

Hariprasad did not write that sentence down.

The notebook needed rules, not sentences.

Two weeks later the new bamboo clothesline through the middle was removed.

The original four eastern lines remained.

A narrow mesh was tied in front of the southern solar panels so balls could not roll underneath.

No permanent paint was put on the ground along the northern side.

Only a small peg for the four wooden plaques was fixed near the mouth of the staircase.

Sometimes "WALKING" hung there.

Sometimes "SUN."

In the evening, "PLAY."

"SERVICE PATH — KEEP CLEAR" never came down.

A month later the first heavy rain came.

All of Rashmi's chalk dots on the roof were washed away.

The little marks measuring the solar-panel shadows, the circles made by the ball, the mark for the dew-wet northern strip—all disappeared.

When Rashmi came up in the morning, the floor was washed clean.

For a moment she felt sad.

Four days of measurements had gone away not in dust, but in water.

Shyamnarayan Babu came up the stairs.

He looked at the ground.

"Your map is gone."

"Yes."

"Will you make it again?"

Before answering, Rashmi looked towards the eastern lines.

Seema was gathering her overnight clothes before eight.

Sushila Devi stood by the stair entrance, waiting for her to come down.

Below, Neel sat holding his ball.

He was not waiting for four o'clock; after the rain he was waiting for the ground to dry.

The southern service path was clear.

Manjula Devi was spreading a mat of makhana not in the middle, but in the small patch of eastern sun.

Rashmi said, "Not yet."

Shyamnarayan Babu began his circuit.

After ten minutes he stopped.

"The path comes a little farther inside today," he said.

Rainwater had collected on the northern side.

Without complaint he made his circle smaller.

Rashmi went to the mouth of the staircase.

The "WALKING" plaque hung on the peg.

Below it hung "SUN" and "PLAY."

Rashmi straightened "WALKING" with her hand.

Then she looked across the roof.

There was not a single permanent line on the ground.

Even so, everyone's path could be understood separately.

And as the day advanced, those paths would change again.

The Unfinished Play

There were still eighteen days left before the annual theatre evening.

At one side of the school's largest room stood two bamboo poles, with an old white sheet stretched between them.

Seven students sat on a mat in front, each holding their own pages.

Malati Jha looked at the clock.

"Shall we begin?"

No one answered.

In the middle of the mat lay a thick notebook with a blue cover.

The notebook belonged to Shashank.

Until three days earlier, Shashank had been the loudest voice in that room.

He changed dialogues, showed how a character should walk, then crossed out lines he had written and wrote them again.

Today he was not in school.

He was no longer even in this town.

His father's work had suddenly been transferred to another town, and within two days the family had packed up and left.

Before leaving, Shashank had handed the notebook of the play to Malati Jha.

"Five scenes are complete," he had said. "I am writing the sixth."

"The ending?" Malati Jha had asked.

Shashank had laughed.

"That is exactly where I am stuck."

At the time everyone had taken it as an ordinary remark.

No one had imagined that three days later that stuck ending would occupy such a large space in the school.

The play was called "Evening at the Threshold."

The story was not very long.

Two sisters, an old house, the threshold between inside and outside, and the choice between leaving home to study in the city or staying in the village with their ageing mother.

The play moved around that decision.

Shashank had not turned the decision into a sermon.

One sister's wish to leave was not merely ambition; the other's wish to remain was not merely sacrifice.

Their work, fears, stubbornness and affection unfolded gradually through separate lines.

Jyoti played Anaya, the elder sister.

Ritu played Meera, the younger.

Deepak played the maternal uncle, who wanted the house sold.

Apoorv played the young neighbour who repeatedly brought news between the two sisters.

Neelima played the elderly mother.

And Renu handled the work behind the stage—chairs, lamp, curtain, entrance cues, everything.

The beginning of the sixth scene had also been written.

Evening.

A lamp on the veranda.

Meera inside.

Mother on the cot.

Anaya standing at the threshold with her bag beside her.

Apoorv enters from the path outside and says that the last bus to the city will leave in half an hour.

Up to this point everything was complete.

After that came five pages of dialogue.

The mother does not stop Anaya.

Meera does not ask her to stay, but places the household accounts notebook in her hand.

Anaya puts the notebook back on the table.

The uncle says that a decision made too late ceases to be a decision.

Apoorv says he can hear the bus horn outside.

Then came the final page.

On that page Shashank's handwriting was no longer as clear as before.

Two lines had been crossed out.

One line was only half written.

The last complete sentence was:

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

After that there were only three words:

"Meera looks at her..."

That was all.

Half the page below was blank.

The next page was blank too.

Everyone sitting on the mat kept looking at those three words.

Deepak broke the silence first.

"We can write from here."

Jyoti said at once, "Who will write it?"

"All of us."

"Inside Shashank's play?"

Deepak said, "Are we performing the play, or worshipping the notebook?"

Malati Jha said nothing.

Ritu pulled the notebook towards herself.

She read, "Meera looks at her. Then Anaya leaves to catch the bus. What is difficult about that?"

Jyoti looked at her.

"You think Anaya leaves?"

"Yes."

"I do not."

"You are playing Anaya, so you want her to stay."

Jyoti smiled.

"You are playing Meera, so you want her to leave?"

Ritu did not answer.

Deepak said, "Let us write two endings. We will keep whichever works better in rehearsal."

Renu was straightening the sheet used as the stage curtain.

From behind it she said, "Better for whom?"

Deepak turned.

"For everyone."

Renu said, "If everyone liked the same thing, we would not be arguing."

Apoorv laughed.

Malati Jha closed the notebook.

"Today we rehearse only up to Scene Five," she said.

"And Scene Six?" Deepak asked.

"Tomorrow."

"Will Shashank be back tomorrow?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Tomorrow, we will still be here."

That day rehearsal ended with the fifth scene.

On her way home, Jyoti looked once more at the blue notebook in Malati Jha's hand.

The notebook was closed, but she felt as though the half-page of blank space had spread beyond it.

The next day Malati Jha telephoned Shashank.

All the students were in the room.

They could not hear Shashank's voice, but they could hear Malati Jha's replies.

"Yes, I found the notebook."

"Yes, it is complete through the fifth."

"No, we have not added anything."

After a while she said, "Do you want to tell us the ending?"

There was a long silence.

Malati Jha only listened.

Then she said, "All right."

After she ended the call, Deepak asked, "What did he say?"

Malati Jha replied, "He had not settled on the ending either."

"Then we can write it."

"He did not say that."

"Then what?"

"He said: look for it on the stage. But do not add your lines to the pages I wrote and leave them under my name."

The room fell silent again.

Jyoti said softly, "That is fair."

Deepak was still dissatisfied.

"How are we supposed to look for it on the stage and not write it?"

While loosening the curtain rope, Renu said, "First let us walk it."

Malati Jha opened the blue notebook.

"Scene Six."

Everyone took their places.

The lamp was lit.

Neelima sat on the cot.

Ritu held the household notebook.

Jyoti stood at the threshold line with the bag beside her.

Apoorv acted as though he were entering from the road outside.

The dialogue began.

Line by line, up to the place everyone remembered.

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

Jyoti turned.

Ritu looked at her.

That was all.

Three moments.

Five moments.

From behind the stage Deepak whispered, "Go on."

Jyoti asked, "What?"

"Do something."

Jyoti picked up the bag.

She took one step outside.
 Without thinking, Ritu stepped forward and caught her hand.
 Jyoti stopped.
 Malati Jha asked, "Would Meera do that?"
 Ritu let go of the hand.
 "I do not know."
 "Again."
 They played the scene again.
 The final written sentence.
 Jyoti turned back.
 This time Ritu did not stand.
 Jyoti put the bag down and sat beside the cot.
 Deepak said, "That is it. That is the ending."
 Jyoti stood up at once.
 "Why?"
 "Anaya stayed."
 "Does sitting down mean she stayed?"
 "Doesn't it?"
 "She could stand up again ten minutes later."
 Apoorv laughed.
 Deepak became irritated.
 "Then nothing is ever an ending."
 Malati Jha said, "Sometimes sitting on a stage is not a decision. It is only sitting."
 They played the scene a third time.
 This time, after turning, Jyoti remained standing at the threshold.
 Ritu put the notebook on the table.
 Neelima closed her eyes.
 Apoorv kept acting as though he were looking outside.
 No one did anything.
 From behind the stage Renu counted to five.
 Then she dropped the curtain.
 Deepak said, "But that remains unfinished."
 From behind the curtain Renu replied, "So does the notebook."
 The rehearsal did not end with that sentence.
 Everyone began arguing again.
 Apoorv wanted the sound of the bus fading into the distance in the last scene.
 Ritu wanted the mother to speak Anaya's name for the first time.
 Deepak wanted Anaya to say clearly, "I am going," or "I am staying."
 Jyoti tried saying both lines aloud.

Both sounded external to her.

"In the first five scenes Anaya never says anything this directly," she said.

Malati Jha nodded in agreement.

"Then why suddenly give her the author's command in Scene Six?"

Deepak replied, "The audience should understand."

"Understand what?"

"The ending."

Renu sat down on the mat.

"I think I understand one thing," she said.

Everyone looked at her.

Renu rarely spoke much about the acting itself.

"Every time we get stuck, we return to the same sentence."

"Which one?"

Renu opened the notebook and read:

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

"And after that, something different happens every time."

"So?" Deepak asked.

"So perhaps what we should show is not an ending, but the turning back."

"Show the audience our rehearsal?"

"Not the whole rehearsal."

Renu stood and went to the stage.

She stood on the threshold mark.

"The same sentence. Then the first time, one possibility for five breaths. Lights out. Then the same sentence again. Then a second possibility."

Apoorv asked, "How many?"

"Only as many as we genuinely found in rehearsal, and kept short."

Malati Jha asked, "And dialogue?"

Renu shook her head.

"No new dialogue. We will not invent Shashank's lines."

Jyoti smiled faintly.

"Only the body?"

"Body, distance, position."

Ritu said, "Then Meera says nothing?"

"Shashank wrote nothing for her there."

The sentence made everyone slightly uncomfortable.

Deepak said, "But this is our play too. We are performing it."

For the first time in the argument, Malati Jha spoke clearly.

"Yes. That is why the stage exercise is yours. The original text is Shashank's. They are not the same thing."

On the board she wrote two lines:

Original text.

Stage exercise.

“If they coincide, good. If they differ, record the difference.”

Deepak kept looking at the board.

“Then in the programme?”

“Original play — Shashank Mishra.”

Malati Jha wrote a second line.

“Final stage exercise — School Theatre Group.”

Ritu asked, “Will Shashank like that?”

“I will ask him again. But first we need to make our own boundary clear.”

For the next four days they rehearsed only movement in the final scene.

In the first sequence Jyoti crossed the threshold.

She turned back.

Ritu looked at her.

For a few moments they looked at one another.

Then Jyoti walked out.

Ritu did not follow.

Lights out.

In the second sequence, after turning back, Jyoti put the bag down.

But she did not sit.

Ritu too did not move from her place.

The threshold between them remained empty.

Lights out.

In the third sequence, Jyoti came to the threshold with the bag still in her hand, turned back, then placed the bag in the middle of the threshold—not towards Meera.

She did not return inside, nor did she go outside.

Ritu did not come forward to pick up the bag.

The light slowly dimmed.

Deepak liked the third sequence least.

“That is no decision at all.”

Jyoti asked, “Are the first two decisions?”

“In the first she leaves.”

“She could come back after the scene ends.”

“In the second she stays.”

“She could pick up the bag again.”

Deepak sat down holding his head.

“Your Anaya will never decide anything.”

Jyoti laughed.

“Not mine. Shashank’s.”

Then she paused and added, “And perhaps Shashank’s Anaya does not decide either.”

On the fifth day Malati Jha spoke with Shashank again by telephone.
This time the students were outside.

When they returned, she said only:

“He says the separate credit is fine. Add nothing to the original notebook.”

Deepak asked, “The three sequences?”

“He has not seen them.”

“Then permission?”

Malati Jha said, “He gave permission for stage exploration. We never asked him for permission to choose an ending.”

That made Deepak think again.

On the sixth day the programme sheet was prepared.

The title of the play at the top.

Shashank’s name below it.

Then the names of the actors.

At the very bottom, in small letters, it said:

“The original manuscript is unfinished in the middle of the final scene. After the written text ends, this performance will show three silent stage explorations developed by the group. These exploratory sequences should not be treated as text by the original author.”

Deepak read the line and said, “Is it necessary to write all this?”

Renu said, “If it was not necessary, why did we spend five days arguing?”

On the day of the theatre evening the school was noisy from morning.

Someone shook out the mat.

Someone tied the curtain to the bamboo poles.

Someone counted chairs.

Renu asked for a separate table for the blue notebook.

Apoorv asked, “Will the notebook be on stage?”

“In the final part.”

“Why?”

“Where the written text stops, it should be clear that what follows is not an accidental omission by us.”

Malati Jha said, “Do not turn the notebook into an object for display. Use it only to mark the boundary of the text.”

So the notebook was placed at one corner of the stage where the light did not fall directly upon it.

By evening every chair was filled.

Some people stood at the back.

The first five scenes went by without any major mistake.

Jyoti’s voice trembled once, but Ritu delivered the next line on time.

Deepak reversed two words in one dialogue, but the audience noticed nothing.

At Apoorv's entrance the curtain caught slightly; Renu freed it by hand.
Scene Six began.
The lamp on the veranda.
The cot.
The bag.
The threshold.
All the dialogue proceeded exactly as it was written in the notebook.
Anaya reached the threshold.
Jyoti turned back.
Ritu looked at her.
At that point Renu came forward from the side of the stage carrying the notebook.
She did not look at the audience.
Looking at the notebook, she read:
"Here the written text of the original manuscript ends."
A faint rustle passed through the hall.
Renu closed the notebook.
"Now, three brief stage explorations by the group."
The lights went out.
Then came back.
The first sequence.
Jyoti turned.
Ritu looked at her.
Jyoti walked out.
Ritu did not come as far as the threshold.
Darkness.
A few people in the audience began to applaud, but the lights came on again immediately.
Renu read the same original sentence once more:
"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."
The second sequence.
Jyoti put down the bag.
Ritu remained in her place.
The threshold between them stayed empty.
Darkness.
This time there was no applause.
For the third time Renu read the original sentence.
Jyoti turned back.
She placed the bag in the middle of the threshold.
She did not stand as though one foot belonged outside and one inside; she simply remained beside the threshold.

Ritu looked at the bag, then at Jyoti.
 No one moved.
 The light slowly faded.
 This time full darkness fell.
 For a few moments the hall remained silent.
 Then applause began.
 First from two people in the front row.
 Then from the back.
 Then from almost everyone.
 After the curtain fell, Deepak's first question was, "Which one felt like the ending?"
 Renu burst out laughing.
 "Starting again?"
 Deepak laughed too.
 "Now we'll ask the audience."
 Malati Jha stopped him.
 "The play is over. Let them take their own thoughts home."
 Behind the curtain Jyoti was picking up the bag.
 Ritu said to her, "I liked the first one best."
 "You still want Anaya to leave?"
 "Yes."
 "I like the second."
 "Staying?"
 "No. Pausing."
 Ritu thought for a moment.
 "Pausing and staying are different?"
 "Maybe."
 Ritu smiled.
 "Do not let Malati Jha hear that."
 Both laughed.
 The audience was leaving.
 Some students were discussing the first sequence.
 Some the third.
 An elderly parent came up to Malati Jha.
 "I did not understand the ending," he said.
 Malati Jha asked evenly, "Where?"
 "At the end."
 "The original text stops there."
 "Then why did you not complete it?"
 Before Malati Jha could answer, Deepak, who was standing nearby, said:

“We completed it many times. Not once were we certain the author would have written that.”

The elderly parent looked at Deepak.

“Then you left it unfinished?”

Deepak thought for a moment before replying.

“The notebook is unfinished. The stage was not empty.”

Malati Jha looked at him.

Deepak himself seemed surprised by his own sentence.

The next day chairs from the programme were being removed from the school.

Renu took the blue notebook to deposit it in the library.

Malati Jha went with her.

The librarian opened the register.

“The play notebook?”

“Yes.”

“Complete?”

Renu and Malati Jha looked at one another.

Renu said, “Complete as far as the author wrote it.”

The librarian pushed her glasses up.

Malati Jha took out three thin sheets of paper.

At the top of the three were written:

“Stage Exercise 1.”

“Stage Exercise 2.”

“Stage Exercise 3.”

There was no dialogue on the sheets.

Only movement, distance, the position of the bag, and cues for the light to fade.

The librarian asked, “Shall I attach these to the notebook?”

Renu said immediately, “No.”

Malati Jha smiled.

“In a separate envelope.”

“Why?”

“These are not Shashank’s pages.”

The librarian placed all three sheets in a separate envelope.

On it she wrote:

“School Theatre Group: Final Stage Exercises.”

Only Shashank’s name had been on the blue notebook from the beginning.

It remained that way.

One month later Shashank sent a letter to an old friend at the school.

The letter was short.

About the play he wrote only two lines.

"I received the programme sheet. I liked that you did not complete my unfinished page and leave the addition under my name."

The second line said:

"Which of the three sequences I like best, I will not say yet."

After reading the letter Deepak said, "See? He likes one of them too."

Jyoti said, "Did he say that?"

"No. But he will."

Renu folded the letter.

"Let him."

Before the term ended, the theatre group went to the library once more.

The following year's new students wanted to read the play from that notebook.

One student asked, "Why are these three pages separate after the final scene?"

Renu, who was now moving into the next class, took out the envelope.

"They are not the ending of the notebook. They were our rehearsal."

"Can we make a fourth?"

Deepak looked at the student at once.

The old Deepak might have said, "Choose one of these three first."

This time he said nothing.

Renu said, "You can."

"Add it to the notebook?"

"No. On your own page."

The student walked away holding the envelope.

The blue notebook remained on the table.

Its last written sentence was unchanged:

"Before crossing the threshold, Anaya turns back."

After that:

"Meera looks at her..."

Then blank space.

Malati Jha looked at the page once more.

There were still no new words in that blank space.

But around it, three earlier stage explorations and the path towards a new fourth possibility had already opened.

A Share of the Moon

It was the first evening of Bhadav.

The lane was so narrow that from the second-storey window of one house it seemed as though, if you stretched out your hand, you could touch the wall of the house opposite.

The real distance was a little greater, but as the houses rose upward they seemed to eat into one another's sky.

Among them were two rooftops—one to the east, one to the west.

Below them ran the lane; above them remained a narrow open gap.

At one particular hour in the evening, the moon descended into that gap.

Naina had first noticed this three years earlier.

She had been twelve then, while Ritu was gathering towels from the western roof.

"Look," Naina had said, "it is trapped between the two houses."

Ritu looked up.

"Not trapped," she said. "It is passing through here."

From that day, a small game began between them.

On evenings when the moon was visible, Naina would stand in the south-west corner of her roof.

Ritu would stand by the eastern parapet of hers.

Together they watched the moon's shape—how thin, how round, how yellow, how grey.

Naina made a notebook.

At the top she wrote:

"The Moon in the Gap."

Ritu said, "Is the gap on your roof or mine?"

"Between them."

"Then the notebook's name should be between them too."

"You write it."

On the second page Ritu wrote:

"Between the Two Rooftops."

Both names remained in the notebook.

It was not a regular ritual or a lesson.

Many days they forgot.
Many days there were clouds.
On some evenings the electricity went out and housework increased.
But whenever the moon came exactly into that narrow gap, one of them would call out:

“It has come today!”

Gradually the other people in the two houses became familiar with their game too.

Naina’s grandmother, Vimla Devi, would say, “The moon is everywhere. Why do you two like only this little piece of it?”

Naina would answer, “Because this is where we can see it from.”

When Ritu’s father, Mahendra Sah, came up to his roof, he sometimes laughed and said, “Today the moon is more on our side.”

Naina would reply at once, “The moon is not on your roof. It is above.”

Mahendra Sah would laugh.

That year, in Jeth, the town’s water supply changed.

Earlier water came twice a day, morning and evening.

Now sometimes it came for half an hour in the morning, sometimes at noon, sometimes after skipping a day.

The old water tank at Mahendra Sah’s house was small.

There were four people in the household, and Ritu’s aunt and her two children had also come upstairs for the holidays.

Twice the water ran out in the middle of cooking.

Mahendra Sah said, “We will have to get a larger tank.”

No one in the house objected.

Ritu too said, “Get one. Then we will not have to run about with buckets in the morning.”

A week later a large round black tank arrived.

Four people hauled it up to the roof with ropes.

The mason said that before making the permanent base, the empty tank would remain there for two days.

They would first check the wall beneath, the pipe distance, and the route for climbing up.

The tank was placed in exactly the south-eastern corner from which the open gap towards Naina’s roof could be seen.

That evening Naina went upstairs with her notebook.

The sky was clear.

She stood in her usual place.

There was no gap.

Directly in front of her was only the round black body of the tank.

A thin edge of sky could be seen behind it, but the moon was nowhere visible.

Naina moved two steps to the right.

From there, the higher part of the parapet stood in the way.

She moved two steps left and the neighbour's stairwell blocked the view.

"Ritu!" she called.

Ritu came onto the other roof.

"What?"

"Where is the moon?"

Ritu looked up.

From her roof the moon was clearly visible to the left of the tank.

"Here."

"I cannot see it."

Ritu looked at the tank, then towards Naina's position.

"Oh."

For a while neither of them spoke.

Naina said, "Why did you put the tank there?"

Ritu became defensive at once.

"I did not put it there."

"It belongs to your house."

"And our house needs water."

"I am not stopping your water."

"Then?"

Naina closed the notebook.

"Nothing."

That evening, for the first time, the two went downstairs without saying, "How round is it today?"

The next day the matter did not remain between the children.

Vimla Devi was gathering clothes from the roof.

Looking at the tank, she said, "What new mountain has been raised here?"

Naina's mother, Mridula, did not laugh.

"The evening light has lessened a little from that side too."

"Tell Mahendra to move it slightly."

When Mridula saw Mahendra Sah in the lane below, she mentioned it.

At first Mahendra Sah answered casually.

"It has not even been fixed yet. But the mason says the pipe will run most easily from there."

Mridula said, "Could it be moved a little to the right?"

"The stairwell is on the right."

"To the left?"

"The open place for drying clothes is on the left. And we have to see where the supporting wall runs underneath."

The matter could have ended there.

But from above Vimla Devi called out, "We had only one little opening of sky from our roof. Will you close that too?"

Mahendra Sah looked up.

"Kaki, the tank is on my roof."

"Your roof—and the sky too?"

Two neighbours stopped in the lane.

Mahendra Sah's face hardened.

"I am not taking anyone's sky. I am putting up a water tank."

Mridula understood that the matter was worsening.

She said, "Kaki, leave it for now."

Vimla Devi gathered the clothes and went inside.

That evening Naina did not go to the roof.

Ritu did, but she did not call out.

On the third day the mason brought bricks for the permanent base.

Mahendra Sah was counting them below.

Ritu said quietly, "Babu, can the tank be shifted a little?"

"Why?"

"Naina's moon has been blocked."

Mahendra Sah laughed at first, but Ritu did not.

"The moon cannot be blocked."

"It cannot be seen from there."

"She can look from somewhere else on the roof."

"From somewhere else the parapet and stairwell get in the way."

Mahendra Sah kept looking at the pile of bricks.

"And if the house runs short of water?"

"I am not asking you to remove the tank."

"Then?"

Ritu did not answer.

That afternoon Ritu went to Naina's house.

It was the first time in three days.

Naina sat at her study table with a notebook open.

The Moon in the Gap lay beside it.

Ritu opened it.

On the previous month's page was a thin half-moon, then two nights of greater roundness, then a sign for cloud.

"How large is the tank?" Naina asked.

"I do not know."

The two went upstairs.

They brought a measuring tape.

They measured the width of the tank and compared its height with the mason's bamboo pole.

Naina said, "What if the tank were not here, but a little over there?"

"Babu says we have to check the line of the wall underneath."

"Then let us check first."

"How?"

Naina saw four thin bamboo poles lying in a corner of the roof.

"The tank is too heavy to keep dragging around. Let us make its size instead."

Ritu laughed.

"A bamboo tank?"

"We will not fill it with water. We only need to see."

By noon, using four bamboo poles, old rope and two thin sticks, the two girls had made a light frame roughly equal to the tank's height and width.

It was not round, but square.

When Vimla Devi came up, she asked, "Now a second tank?"

Naina said, "This one will hold the moon, not water."

Vimla Devi laughed.

The hardness of the past three days loosened a little.

The mason returned by evening.

At first he was surprised by the bamboo frame, then understood.

With his finger he pointed to three places on the roof floor.

"There is a wall underneath here. Here too. A large tank cannot stand in this middle portion. It is a matter of load."

Naina asked, "Of these two places, which one?"

"The first is easier for the pipe. For the second the pipe will have to turn a little, but it can be done. The route to the stairs must remain clear."

Mahendra Sah came up.

He saw the scene—his daughter, Naina from next door, the mason, the square bamboo frame.

"Is there a meeting going on here?"

Ritu said quietly, "We will watch for three evenings."

"What?"

"The frame at the first place, then the second. We will see from where the moon is visible."

Mahendra Sah was tired.

"Hold up the brickwork for three days?"

The mason said, "The base can be made tomorrow too. The tank is still empty."

Mahendra Sah looked towards Naina's roof.

Vimla Devi was standing there.

“Kaki, three days for the moon?”

This time Vimla Devi answered softly.

“The tank will stand there for water for a lifetime. Spend three days looking at the moon too.”

An unwilling smile came to Mahendra Sah’s face.

“All right.”

On the first evening, the bamboo frame was placed where the tank currently stood.

Naina stood in her old position.

The moon disappeared completely behind the frame.

From her roof Ritu called, “Write it—first position, no.”

In the notebook Naina wrote:

“First position: gap closed.”

On the second evening the frame was moved to the right, leaving the necessary passage beside the stairwell.

The moon was visible in a narrow space between the frame and the stairwell, but Naina had to move away from the parapet to see it.

“Can you see it?” Ritu asked.

“Half the time.”

“Half a moon?”

“No. Half my position is bad.”

Both laughed.

On the third evening the frame was placed at the safe position on the left.

The pipe would have to be a little longer, but the stair route remained open.

The moon did not appear in the centre of the old gap; it appeared a little to the right.

Naina moved two steps.

This time the parapet was not in the way.

“Today?” Ritu called.

Naina raised her hands and made a circle.

“Whole.”

Mahendra Sah too was on the roof.

He looked towards Naina’s position, then at the bamboo frame, then at the old mouth of the pipe.

“It will take two extra cubits of pipe,” he said.

The mason said, “It will.”

“And the base?”

“There is a supporting wall below. It can stand there.”

Mahendra Sah looked at Ritu.

“You left your studies for three days for this?”

Ritu said, "I studied later."
 "What did you write in the notebook?"
 Ritu asked Naina for the notebook and showed him the three lines.
 First position — gap closed.
 Second position — visible, but passage narrow.
 Third position — view open, stair route open, pipe longer.
 Mahendra Sah read the lines three times.
 "The cost of the pipe is not written here."
 Naina became embarrassed.
 Mahendra Sah himself said, "Write it—two extra cubits of pipe."
 Naina wrote it.
 The next day the tank was moved to the third position.
 Four people did the work together.
 Even empty, the tank was not light.
 The mason made the base, turned the pipe, and left a narrow route for climbing.
 Vimla Devi watched from her roof.
 When the work was finished, she called to Mahendra Sah.
 "Yesterday I said a little too much."
 Brushing the dust from his hands, Mahendra Sah replied, "And I put too much force into the words 'my roof.'"
 Neither said anything more.
 That evening the tank was half-filled for the first time.
 Naina came to the roof.
 Ritu was already standing there.
 The moon was now a little to the right of its old place.
 The gap too was no longer exactly as before—the curved black edge of the tank showed along one side.
 Naina opened the notebook.
 Ritu asked, "What will you write?"
 Naina thought for a long time.
 "The gap changed."
 "And the moon?"
 "It did not."
 Ritu sat on her roof with her back against the parapet.
 "Babu was saying—who has a share in the moon?"
 Naina said, "No one."
 "Then why so much quarrelling?"
 Naina looked at the body of the tank in front of her.
 "Not for the moon. For the place from which we see it."
 Ritu thought for a moment.

“And whose is the place from which one sees?”

“Whoever leaves a little room for the other.”

Ritu did not laugh at the answer.

The words sounded a little too large to her; Naina too did not immediately write them in the notebook.

A few days later Vimla Devi said the old bamboo frame could be taken apart.

Naina was untying the rope when Mahendra Sah said, “Leave one bamboo pole.”

“Why?”

“I am thinking of putting up a new bar for drying clothes. Before I fix it, I will use this to see whether it blocks anyone’s path, light or gap.”

Ritu looked at her father.

“Three days again?”

“This time one evening will be enough.”

Everyone laughed.

One day in the last week of Bhadav, the moon did not enter the gap.

Its course had risen higher.

Naina stood on the roof with the notebook.

Ritu said, “Empty today.”

Naina did not draw a round mark on the page.

She wrote only the date, and beside it:

“Moon outside the gap.”

A little later both girls went back to their work on their own roofs.

The black tank stood full.

Water was flowing down into the house.

The stair route was open.

So was the narrow strip of sky between the two houses.

And no one’s name was written on that sky.

The New Courtyard

Bhadav was drawing to a close, but the walls of the rehabilitation buildings still carried the smell of fresh limewash.

Four-storey blocks stood facing one another.

Between them lay a square paved space, with stairways, drains and small planting beds around it.

On paper it was called the “central open space.”

The residents had given it no name.

They simply called it “the paved place in the middle.”

Six months earlier, the flood had submerged thirteen houses in Piprahi Tola along with homes in two other hamlets.

When the water receded, many houses were no longer fit to repair.

Under the government rehabilitation scheme, the families were allotted space in these multi-storey buildings.

On paper, everyone’s home was safer than before—a concrete roof, separate kitchen, tap, toilet and electricity.

Even so, during the first month Ramkali Devi kept saying, “We got a house, but where is the courtyard?”

At first her granddaughter Isha laughed at the question.

“Dadi, there is such a large space in the middle.”

“There is space.”

“Then?”

Ramkali Devi did not answer.

Isha was thirteen.

From the time of the flood she remembered very little clearly—only the sharp smell of the water, her mother’s hand, and her father carrying sacks up a bamboo ladder.

Her memory of the old courtyard came in fragments.

In the morning Dadi sorted paddy there.

At noon Ma dried papads.

In the evening two neighbour women dragged out a cot and sat talking.

When rain came, everything rushed indoors at once.

No strip in the courtyard had labels saying “sitting,” “play,” “grain,” or “path.”

Yet everyone understood when and where each activity belonged.

In the new building Isha’s family lived on the third floor.

Opening the door led to a veranda barely a cubit and a half wide, then the staircase.

Every morning Dadi brought a chair out onto the veranda, but if two people had to pass together, the chair had to be pulled back inside.

“Even to sit here, you have to keep calculating how much path to leave for people,” she would say.

The paved place in the middle was not empty all day.

In the morning the milkman parked his bicycle there.

At noon the children played ball.

Sometimes someone left a motorcycle there for an hour or two.

In the evening a few women sat beside the planting beds.

But no one thought of the space as their own place.

As soon as their work was done, people climbed back up their own stairways.

One day, returning from school, Isha saw two small children drawing a house with chalk on the paved ground.

Four lines, one doorway, and a round hearth inside.

Two steps away, another child accidentally stepped on the drawing.

“Move!” the little girl shouted. “This is my courtyard!”

Isha stopped.

The girl was seven-year-old Neetu, who lived on the second floor.

“Courtyard?” Isha asked.

Neetu pointed to the chalk square.

“This.”

“But this is inside the house.”

“Then this outside part.”

She added a half-circle in front of the square.

The other child stepped on it again.

Neetu caught the child’s hand and moved it aside.

Isha did not laugh.

She remembered Dadi’s question:

We got a house, but where is the courtyard?

That evening she told Ramkali Devi about Neetu’s chalk courtyard.

Dadi asked, “How large was it?”

“Two cubits.”

“Then Neetu’s courtyard was smaller than my old courtyard.”

“Much smaller.”

"But she knew where it was."
 Isha remained silent for a while after that answer.
 The next day she called Neetu, Sajid, Pinky, Rahul and her younger brother Mohan into the middle space.
 "Shall we make a courtyard?"
 Mohan immediately asked, "Whose?"
 Isha said, "That is what we are going to see."
 The children gathered chalk.
 Neetu made the first attempt.
 She began drawing a large square in the middle.
 Sajid stopped her.
 "The ball goes through here."
 Pinky said, "And my mother sits here in the evening."
 Mohan added, "The milkman parks his bicycle here too."
 Neetu stopped the chalk.
 "Then where is the courtyard?"
 Isha looked around.
 Four stairways from the four buildings descended towards the central space.
 She said, "Let one line come from each stairway."
 "And in the middle?"
 "Leave the middle empty for now."
 The children understood it as a game.
 From the eastern staircase, Neetu drew two leaves.
 From the west, Sajid drew two curved lines like a fish tail.
 From the north, Pinky joined five dots.
 From the south, Mohan made a small crescent.
 The lines grew towards one another, but a round space about a cubit wide remained empty in the centre.
 "Shall we finish it?" Rahul asked.
 Isha said, "Not yet."
 The chalk lines remained visible on the paved floor until evening.
 People paused as they came down the stairs.
 Someone said, "A rangoli?"
 Someone else, "Children's play."
 When Ramkali Devi came downstairs, her eyes stopped on the empty circle in the middle.
 "Why is this empty?"
 Isha said, "If all the lines reach there, it will become one complete picture."
 "Then make it."
 "What form should we make?"
 Dadi smiled faintly.

“Have you not found the answer to that?”

“No.”

Ramkali Devi did not rub out a single chalk line with her foot.

She only looked at the narrow gap between the eastern staircase and the drawing.

“How will people walk through here?”

Isha understood that the question was not about the empty centre of the picture.

It was about the path.

That night the children gathered again.

Isha said, “We leave four paths open.”

“Then the picture will remain broken,” Neetu said.

“It will.”

“A broken aripan?”

“An unfinished one.”

Pinky did not like the word.

“Why should an aripan be unfinished?”

Isha did not answer.

The next morning Ramkali Devi mixed a little rice paste in her old brass bowl and came downstairs.

Isha was surprised.

“You will make it?”

“If it rains, the chalk will disappear.”

“The rice paste will wash away too.”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

Dadi held the bowl out to Isha.

“One is less afraid to make something that can be washed away.”

Isha took the bowl.

But Ramkali Devi laid down one condition.

“One hand will not make the whole picture.”

“Why?”

“You asked whose courtyard it is. If one hand makes the whole thing, the answer will already be written.”

That day the children sent word to families by all four staircases: whoever could come downstairs in the evening would add only one small line.

No one would make a whole flower.

No one would erase someone else’s line.

The circle in the middle would remain empty.

The four paths would remain open.

Seventeen people came the first evening.
 Some from curiosity, some because the children insisted.
 Ramkali Devi did not make the first line.
 She gave the bowl to Neetu's mother, Renu Devi.
 Renu Devi hesitantly placed two dots.
 Then Sajid's father, Karim Mian, came.
 He did not know how to make an aripan.
 "What should I do?"
 Isha said, "Draw a straight line."
 Karim Mian laughed.
 "That I do every day in masonry work."
 He drew a short straight line.
 Beside it Pinky's grandmother joined three dots.
 Someone made a leaf, someone only a curve.
 A small child dipped a finger in the paste and left a round print.
 By dusk a picture had formed, but it had no single form.
 Lines came in from four sides, the centre remained an empty circle, and
 four paths stayed open.
 Neetu was slightly disappointed.
 "It does not look like an aripan."
 Ramkali Devi asked, "Like whose aripan?"
 Neetu could not find an answer.
 Two days later the use of the open space began to change.
 Not because of the lines, but because of the people.
 Those who had earlier gone straight upstairs after coming down now
 lingered for a while.
 Someone sat on the edge of a planting bed.
 Someone brought down a stool.
 Someone stayed to watch the children play.
 The children did not play ball in the empty central circle; they ran in the
 open outer strip because small children had begun sitting in a ring in the
 middle to play marbles.
 The next day it was the opposite.
 The middle remained empty while, in one outer corner, women cut
 vegetables and talked.
 No rule had been written.
 The uses kept changing by turn.
 On the third evening, a resident named Dinesh Babu came downstairs and
 said, "This rice paste is getting on people's feet. The cleaner is complaining."
 Isha immediately fell silent.
 Renu Devi said, "He is right. The paste should not be on the walking path."

Dinesh Babu looked towards the central design.

"And will this be made every day?"

"Not every day," Ramkali Devi said.

"Then what is the use of all this?"

Before Ramkali Devi could answer, Isha said, "Are you asking the use of the picture, or the people?"

Dinesh Babu looked at her.

Isha felt that her voice had become too sharp.

She lowered it.

"We have kept all four paths open. The paste will not come onto the paths."

Dinesh Babu said, "If it stays clean, I have no objection."

The next evening the children used less rice paste.

The lines became thinner.

The four paths were widened to two cubits.

The empty central circle was made slightly larger too.

Isha wrote no measurements in her notebook.

She simply watched how people moved.

Within a week the paved middle space acquired a small name:

"the New Courtyard."

The children began saying it first.

"Meet in the New Courtyard this evening."

"The ball is near the New Courtyard."

"Dadi is sitting in the New Courtyard."

Gradually the adults began to say it too.

Ramkali Devi heard the name, but never repeated it on her own.

One day Isha asked, "You do not like it?"

"What?"

"The New Courtyard."

"The name is good."

"Then why do you not say it?"

Looking down from the window, Ramkali Devi said, "If a name is given too early, people begin to think the work is finished."

"Is the courtyard not finished?"

"We will see."

That week heavy rain came at night.

Water drummed on the roof of the new building.

When Isha went downstairs in the morning, almost all the rice-paste lines had washed away.

Here and there only white stains remained, or the pale circles of old dots.

Without the drawing, the empty middle and the four paths were simply the same-coloured paved floor again.

Neetu stopped on her way to school.
 "It is all gone."
 Isha looked for a while too.
 "Yes."
 "Will we make it again today?"
 Isha said, "We'll see in the evening."
 Rain stopped and started throughout the day.
 By evening the sky had cleared, but the ground was still cool and damp.
 Isha did not prepare a bowl of rice paste.
 She simply went downstairs.
 Neetu was already there.
 Sajid came with a ball.
 Pinky's grandmother brought a stool.
 Karim Mian, returning from work, stopped in the middle.
 Renu Devi brought puffed rice and chickpeas in two bowls.
 Ramkali Devi slowly came down the stairs.
 No one drew a line.
 Even so, the four paths remained open on their own.
 People sat more or less where they had sat the previous week.
 The children played ball not in the centre, but in the open outer strip.
 When a small child fell, people from three households stood up at once.
 After a while Dinesh Babu came too.
 Looking down, he said, "No picture today?"
 Neetu answered sadly, "The rain washed it away."
 Dinesh Babu looked around.
 "Then the courtyard is gone?"
 For the first time Ramkali Devi laughed.
 "Does it look gone to you?"
 Dinesh Babu did not answer.
 In front of him Karim Mian was eating puffed rice.
 Pinky's grandmother was undoing Neetu's braid and tying it again.
 Mohan was running after the ball.
 Two women were talking about clearing leaves from a blocked drain.
 Suddenly Isha understood why Dadi had not repeated the new name too early.
 As they went upstairs that night, she asked, "Now tell me—is it a courtyard?"
 Ramkali Devi stopped at the turn of the staircase.
 "Today it became one, a little."
 "And tomorrow?"
 "If people do not come tomorrow, it will not become one."

Isha said, "In the old house, the courtyard was always there."

"The ground was always there."

"And the courtyard?"

Holding the railing, Ramkali Devi climbed the next step.

"That too was made by people every day. I simply had not noticed it then."

The next evening the children brought rice paste again.

This time they made no attempt to recover the old lines.

Neetu drew a small fish from the east.

Sajid made two leaves from the west.

Pinky placed five dots from the north.

Mohan drew a crooked line from the south, and everyone laughed when they saw it.

Isha again left the central circle empty.

Neetu asked, "Will we never fill the middle?"

Isha said, "It will be filled—sometimes with play, sometimes with conversation, sometimes by being left empty."

Whether Neetu fully understood the answer or not, she did not say.

She merely added one dot to the tail of her fish.

The four paths remained open again.

This time something new happened.

Families who had not added a line before came too.

Shailaja Devi from the fourth floor drew only one small curve.

Elderly Naseem Chacha from the first floor could not draw a straight line because his fingers trembled.

His line wavered, but no one corrected it.

A newly married couple who had moved into the building three weeks earlier asked, "Where should we draw ours?"

Isha pointed around.

"Wherever there seems to be space."

"Beside whose line?"

"Beside whichever one has room."

Slowly the design filled, but it was never completed.

That became its rule:

not to be complete.

A month later, during the Durga Puja holidays, the building committee decided to install two permanent iron benches in the paved central space.

Dinesh Babu brought the proposal to Ramkali Devi.

"People will have somewhere to sit. It will be good."

Ramkali Devi said, "A place to sit is needed."

Isha was in front of them.

She did not interrupt.

Dadi asked, "Where will they go?"
Dinesh Babu pointed to two places near the middle on the paper.
Isha could not hold back.
"Children run through here."
"Then we will put them at the side."
"Women cut vegetables at the side."
Dinesh Babu laughed.
"Then shall we hang the benches in the air?"
Ramkali Devi said, "Put two heavy chairs there for two days and see."
"Chairs?"
"Place two heavy chairs wherever you are thinking of putting the benches.
Watch how people move around them."
The idea seemed ordinary to Dinesh Babu, but he agreed.
At the first location, the chairs made it difficult for the milkman to turn his bicycle in the morning.
At the second, they cut across the children's running line in the evening.
At the third, beside the planting bed, Pinky's grandmother got shade and the path remained open.
In the end, the benches were installed there.
Isha told Dadi, "The four paths of the aripan even saved the bench place."
Ramkali Devi said, "Not the lines. The way people moved showed us."
At the beginning of winter, the use of the paved place changed again.
Older people began sitting in the morning sun.
At noon some families placed pickle jars at the side.
Darkness fell earlier in the evening, so the children's play grew shorter.
The aripan was no longer made every day.
Sometimes on Sundays, sometimes before a festival.
But the memory of the four paths remained.
If someone left a motorcycle in the centre overnight, the next day a child would say, "It is in the middle of the New Courtyard."
The motorcycle would be moved.
If someone wanted to leave a broken chair permanently beside the planting bed, Renu Devi would say, "Sit there if you like, but do not block the path."
This rule was not on paper.
No meeting had ever passed it.
One day at school Isha was asked to write ten lines on "My Home."
In the first two lines she described her room on the third floor.
In the third, the window.
In the fourth, the kitchen.
At the fifth line her pen stopped.
She wrote:

“In the middle of my home there is a courtyard that does not belong to any one house.”

Then she crossed it out.

The word “my” did not seem right.

She wrote again:

“In the middle of our building there is a place that becomes a courtyard in the evening.”

She liked that line.

At night she showed the notebook to Dadi.

Ramkali Devi read it and said, “And in the morning?”

“Sometimes a path, sometimes sunlight, sometimes empty.”

“Then the line is right.”

“Will you call it the New Courtyard now?”

Ramkali Devi closed the notebook.

“I will.”

“Why now?”

“Because now the weight of the name is not resting on one picture.”

Isha looked down.

That evening there were no rice-paste lines.

People were coming down the four stairways one after another.

In the paved middle space one child was playing marbles.

On the bench at the side two elderly people were sitting.

Near the planting bed Renu Devi and Shailaja Devi were talking.

The four paths were open.

The middle too was not completely filled.

Some space had to remain empty so that there would be room for the next person.

Looking down from above, Ramkali Devi said, “Look, the courtyard formed quickly today.”

Isha asked, “Without the lines?”

“The lines were for learning.”

“And the courtyard?”

Dadi said, “Now the people have learned.”

Below, Mohan stopped the ball and looked up.

“Didi! Come!”

Isha closed the notebook and began going down the stairs.

When she reached the bottom, no one had made a separate place for her.

Even so, there was room.

The Thirty-First Bed

On the gate of the night shelter built behind the bus stand, the words “Women’s Shelter—30 Beds” were painted in white.

Champa Devi did not remember those thirty beds by looking at their numbers on paper. She remembered the sounds the beds made.

The right leg of bed number one was a little loose; it went ting-ting when someone sat on it. Bed number five had the lump of an old weld in its frame. While sweeping beneath number eleven, the thin edge of the iron would brush her hand. The mattress on number twenty-seven was the heaviest of all, because the cotton inside it had gathered to one side.

At that shelter, Champa worked from seven in the evening until ten at night, and from four in the morning until six. On paper, the six hours in between did not belong to her.

The contract said: sweep and mop in the evening, clean the toilets, take out the rubbish, dry the wet floor, then do the same work again in the morning.

The paper did not say where Champa’s body was to be from ten at night until four in the morning.

On ordinary days there was no need for that question. Two lanes behind the shelter, Champa rented a small room with a tin roof. At ten at night she would lean the broom against the wall, wash her hands and feet, lock up, and go home. Before dawn, while it was still dark, she would return.

Bimla Devi, the shelter caretaker, would joke, “Your clock is better than mine.”

Champa would say, “It isn’t the clock. It’s the stomach. If I’m late, they’ll strike my name off next month.”

Bimla would laugh, but both of them knew it was not entirely a joke.

One evening in Paush, a drizzle began in the afternoon. By eight at night the wind had grown fierce. Rain rattled on the tin roof of the bus stand as though many small pebbles were falling all at once.

That night all thirty beds in the shelter were occupied.

Among the women who came in, one had spent the whole day carrying sacks at the vegetable market, one had come with a sick relative at the

hospital, one had arrived to spend the night after missing her train, and one had been making that shelter her place for the night for months.

Bimla wrote names in the register, asked for identification where possible, and told each new arrival her bed number.

“Twenty-nine.”

“Thirty.”

When the last woman had been given number thirty, Bimla drew a thin line beneath the entries in the register.

At that moment Champa was pouring water over the toilet floor.

A little after nine, her neighbour called her mobile phone.

“Didi, the bamboo holding up your roof has fallen.”

At first Champa did not understand.

“Which bamboo?”

“The one holding the tin. It has lifted in the wind. Water is getting inside. I’ve wedged a brick against the door from outside.”

Champa set down the bucket in her hand where she stood.

“The trunk inside?”

“I put it up on the bed. But it would be difficult to sleep there now.”

When the call ended, Champa stood for a few moments with the mobile phone still in her hand.

Bimla saw her face from a distance.

“Has something happened at home?”

Champa told her.

Bimla looked towards the gate. Outside, the rain was falling at a slant.

“The road will be bad too if you go now,” Bimla said.

“Yes.”

“Spend the night here.”

The words came easily enough, but afterwards both their eyes went at once to the beds.

There was someone on every one of the thirty beds.

Bimla opened the register.

“The woman in number twelve has gone out for tea, but she’ll come back. The woman in number twenty-four has left her bag on the bed. They’re all occupied.”

Champa said, “I don’t need a bed. I’ll spread a sheet in some corner.”

Bimla looked up as though reading the rules board hanging on the wall beside the gate.

“The passage has to be kept clear. The fire-exit route must not be blocked.”

“Then the storeroom?”

Both of them fell silent again.

The storeroom held an iron cupboard, brooms, mops, acidic cleaning fluid, boxes of soap, a can of phenyl, and an old broken chair.

Bimla said, "It isn't right to sleep in there."

Champa smiled. "I handle the things in that room all day. What will happen if I spend the night near them?"

"Holding them in your hands and sleeping with them beside your head are not the same thing."

By then Rampari Devi, who had bed number five, had heard them.

She sat up. "Champa, come here. The bed is wide. There's room for both of us."

Champa shook her head at once.

"No, Didi. You spend all day at the vegetable market. I won't take half your bed at night."

Rampari said, "What do I mind?"

"You may not mind. I do."

Rampari understood some of it and some she did not. She pulled the blanket over herself again.

At ten, Champa's evening shift ended on paper.

She washed her hands, wrung out the wet end of her sari, and sat on the narrow wooden bench beside the gate. During the day, the bench was used for visitors' bags.

Bimla said, "Shall I give you my chair?"

"You have to write in the register all night and watch the gate. The chair is yours."

Bimla gave her an old blanket.

Champa wrapped it around herself.

At eleven the wind grew stronger still. A thin stream of water was coming in beneath the door. Champa got up, folded a sack, and wedged it under the door.

At midnight someone went to the toilet. Champa got up again and wiped away the wet footprints.

Bimla said, "You're off duty now."

Wringing out the mop, Champa said, "If it stays wet, someone will fall."

"You're not an employee now. You're someone spending the night."

Champa laughed. "Which line of the register do I go in?"

Bimla did not answer.

At one in the morning, Champa dozed off sitting on the bench. Her legs hung halfway in the air. The blanket had slipped down to her knees.

Twice Bimla got up and adjusted the blanket. The third time she did not; she thought that if Champa woke, she would pick up the broom again.

At about half past three, a sharp smell came from the storeroom. The cap on a bottle of cleaning fluid had not been closed properly. Bimla set it upright.

Champa woke.

“What time is it?”

“Half an hour until your shift starts.”

Champa stepped down from the bench. Her legs were numb. She held the wall and stood still for a moment.

“Skip the morning work today,” Bimla said.

“If I skip it, the paper will mark me absent.”

“I’ll write that you were here all night.”

Champa looked at her.

“Being here all night and being present for the morning shift are two different boxes.”

Bimla said nothing.

At four, Champa picked up the broom.

By half past five the rain had stopped. The sky was grey. One by one, the women in the shelter began to rise. One folded her blanket, one searched for her mobile phone, one went outside for tea.

At six, just as Champa was sweeping one last time beneath the beds, a jeep stopped at the gate.

Bimla frowned. “So early?”

Three people came inside: a woman officer, a clerk, and a representative of the contracting agency.

The previous week there had been a complaint about wet blankets and a closed toilet at the night shelter. The inspection had been arranged without notice.

The officer asked first for the register.

“How many for the night?”

“Thirty,” Bimla said.

“Beds?”

“Thirty.”

“Staff?”

“Me, one night guard, and a cleaner in the evening and morning.”

The officer turned a page.

“Where does the cleaner stay at night?”

Bimla opened her mouth to give the ordinary answer—“Home”—but after that night the word stuck.

At that moment Champa was picking up a wet piece of paper from beneath bed number twelve.

Bimla said, “On ordinary days she goes home.”

“And last night?”

The contracting agency's representative spoke at once. "Her shift ends at ten."

The woman officer looked at him. "I didn't ask about her shift. I asked about the night."

There was silence for a few moments.

Bimla pointed to the bench.

"She spent the night there, sitting up. The roof of her room was damaged."

The officer went over to the bench. Directly behind it was the door to the storeroom. She looked at the bottles, the phenyl, the brooms inside.

"Here?"

Champa said, "All the beds were occupied."

"The floor?"

"We're not allowed to block the passage."

"The storeroom?"

"There are chemicals in there."

The contractor's representative said, "This was an unusual situation."

The officer said, "What do the rules provide for an unusual situation?"

No answer came.

She looked at the register again. There were thirty names on the residents' page. In the staff attendance register, Champa's evening signature was there, then a blank space for the morning signature. The six hours in between truly did not exist on paper.

The officer asked Champa, "Should your name have been entered in the residents' register?"

Champa said, "I didn't need a bed here. I needed a safe place for my body to be through the night."

"What is the difference?"

"A great deal. If I had taken a bed, there would have been one less for the person it was meant for. But if a worker has to remain here through the night, she needs a place too."

Rampari, who was folding the bedding on bed number five, called from behind, "I told her I'd give her half."

Without turning, Champa said, "Your whole bed is yours."

The officer looked once at Rampari, then wrote something in the register.

The contractor's representative asked, "What are you writing?"

The officer read it aloud. "Temporary staff rest beside cleaning-fluid storage—unsafe. No separate safe rest arrangement for staff at night."

The contractor's representative said, "But the cleaner is not night staff."

This time Champa looked at him.

The officer asked, "Was she inside the building last night?"

"Yes."

“Morning shift at four?”

“Yes.”

“Then the question is not merely one of job title.”

The inspection moved on. Blankets were opened, the toilets were examined, the fire-exit route was measured.

Champa returned to her broom.

By seven the officials had left.

Bimla was a little excited. “You’ll see. Something will happen now.”

Champa said, “Inspection papers see many things, and many things they don’t.”

“This time it has been written down.”

“Let it stay written.”

She set off for home.

The water in the lane was not up to her knees, but it reached her ankles. Half the tin roof of her room really had lifted away. Her neighbour had raised the trunk onto the bed.

For two days Champa slept on that neighbour’s veranda. On the third day the bamboo was tied back into place.

At the shelter, the days began to run as before: thirty beds, thirty numbers, the evening broom, the morning broom.

The inspection was almost forgotten.

About twenty days later, one afternoon, a small handcart stopped at the shelter gate. Champa was not on shift then.

When she came in that evening, Bimla showed her something beside the gate.

An iron folding bed stood against the wall. It smelled of fresh paint.

Champa asked, “Where did this come from?”

“From the central store.”

“For a resident?”

“No. The order says—for night staff or emergency staff rest. The number of residents remains thirty.”

Champa unfolded the bed and looked at it. It was narrow, but sturdy.

On the side of one leg, a small number had been painted in white—31.

Champa touched the number with her finger.

“The thirty-first bed in a thirty-bed shelter.”

Bimla laughed. “The inventory register won’t accept anything without a number.”

Champa said, “Then the bed has entered the count.”

Bimla looked at her. “The person was already here.”

Champa said nothing.

She folded the bed again and set it against the wall. She moved the storeroom brooms, mops, and cleaning fluids two arm's lengths away from it.

That night she did not need to sleep on bed 31.

At ten she locked up and went back to her room.

Behind her, inside the gate, stood the thirty residents' beds, each with its own number. Against the wall stood one more folding bed, which had come not from anyone's kindness, but because an omitted count had finally been noticed.

The Back Staircase

At the front entrance of Amaltas Building, two things could be seen from a distance—the brass-coloured nameplate and the lift moving up and down behind the glass.

Toward the back lane stood another iron gate, on which small letters read: “Service Route.”

Savita Devi had been reading those words for five years, but when she first came to the building for domestic work, she had not asked what they meant.

The guard had said, “Domestic workers, milk, deliveries, rubbish—all through here.”

From then on, Savita’s feet belonged to that route.

The back staircase went up seven floors. Between two floors was a small landing; in a corner of a landing there might be a pipe, somewhere an old paint bucket, somewhere a broken tub, somewhere a tied bundle of newspapers.

There was a handrail between the first and second floors. Between the second and third, the wall was bare. Near the fourth floor, a thin iron handrail appeared again, but one of its joints was loose.

The lighting was not the same everywhere either. On the ground floor and the second floor there was yellow light; on the third it was often out; on the fifth a little daylight came through a window, while at night it was almost dark.

Savita was not in the habit of counting the staircase’s faults. When someone has to climb and descend the same way every day, the body remembers even its crookedness.

She knew that the fourth step on the third floor was slightly higher. Coming down from the fifth floor, her left hand had to touch the wall. Before the seventh, she had to keep her head clear of a sagging pipe.

The building’s residents were almost entirely unaware of these details.

For them, the back staircase was simply “over there.”

Beside the lift at the front hung a fire-safety map. Red arrows ran down from every floor toward a staircase. The map was neat, its square lines clear, the word “EXIT” in bold.

Savita had never studied the map closely, because her route was remembered not behind the map's glass but inside her body.

One Monday the building committee put up a notice: "Safety Inspection Wednesday."

For two days the glass at the main entrance was polished. The fire-hose cabinet received a fresh coat of red paint. The decorative planter in front of the lift was shifted a little.

Raghavendra Babu, the building committee's secretary, sent word to every flat that the inspection would be at ten on Wednesday and the corridors should be kept clear.

Savita heard about it at Archana Jha's home on the fifth floor.

"There's an inspection tomorrow," Archana Jha said. "Move those bags and things on the back route a little to one side."

Savita asked, "Whose bags?"

"How would I know? Someone must have left them there."

As Savita came down that day, she saw three empty water cans on the sixth-floor landing, an old shoe rack on the fourth, and an iron cot leaning against the wall on the second.

She took a cloth from her work bag and wiped away the dust, but she had no authority to move other people's things.

Downstairs, the guard Kailash was sitting at his post.

Savita said, "If there's an inspection, will they inspect the back staircase too?"

Kailash laughed. "They'll inspect the main stairs, the fire hose, the wiring and pipes. The back one is the service route."

"Does fire burn differently on the service route?"

Kailash laughed, then fell silent.

At ten on Wednesday the inspection took place. Two officers came. Raghavendra Babu, the treasurer, the caretaker, and two residents accompanied them.

Savita was washing dishes on the fourth floor at the time. She heard them moving along the main corridor—"Exit clear," "Lights fine," "Hose date," "Door width."

At around eleven, the inspection ended.

By one in the afternoon, the building had returned to its usual state.

The main entrance was quiet. Many residents were at work. A few elderly people were at home. Two children had returned from school. Women doing domestic work were on different floors. Delivery workers moved up and down. In the back lane, a young man collecting rubbish pushed his cart.

At that moment, Malati Devi on the fifth floor heard the sound of something falling near the back staircase.

A large sack of rice had rolled down half a step between the fourth and fifth floors and come to rest.

Naseem, the young man carrying the sack upstairs, had saved himself by catching hold of the wall.

Malati Devi came out.

“What happened?”

Catching his breath, Naseem said, “If there’d been a handrail, my hand would have found it. I can lift the sack again.”

He tried to lift the sack. Savita was coming up from below just then. Together they put it on the landing.

Malati Devi said, “Why didn’t you bring it up in the main lift?”

Naseem did not answer.

Savita said, “Goods come by the back route.”

Malati Devi paused. “Even something this heavy?”

Naseem smiled. “Even when the goods are light, it’s the same route.”

No complaint was filed about this small incident. Naseem delivered the sack. Savita returned to her work.

But Malati Devi remembered the red arrows from the inspection.

That evening she asked Raghavendra Babu, “Was the back staircase inspected today?”

Raghavendra Babu said, “It isn’t the main exit.”

“But at noon half the building moves along that route.”

“Half the building?”

“I mean the people.”

Raghavendra Babu grew a little uneasy. “How many people?”

Malati Devi had no answer.

That question led to an unusual exercise the next day.

Raghavendra Babu took out the guard’s register. The residents’ names were not recorded in it; the names and times of outside visitors were. Many domestic workers had permanent identity cards, so their daily entries were not made consistently.

“Then I don’t know exactly how many people are in the building at one in the afternoon,” the treasurer said.

Kailash said, “We have the number of residents.”

Savita was wringing out a mop near the gate. She said, “The number of residents and the number of people actually inside the building at that time are not the same thing.”

Every eye turned toward her.

Raghavendra Babu asked, “Then how do we find out?”

Savita said, “Count them one day.”

“Whom?”

“Every body that is inside.”

The following Monday the building committee chose three times—seven in the morning, one in the afternoon, and eight at night.

It was not a census; there was no list of names either. Only the kinds of people present in the building at each time and their approximate numbers—residents, children, elderly people, domestic workers, delivery workers, repair workers, guards.

At seven in the morning there were more residents. Milk-delivery workers and rubbish collectors were there too.

At one in the afternoon the result was different.

Many residents with jobs were out. In the building were sixteen women doing domestic work, three meal-delivery workers, two repair workers, one rubbish collector, two guards, seven elderly people, four small children, and a few residents working from home.

Raghavendra Babu added the numbers on the sheet.

“That many people?”

Kailash said, “Today is a quiet day. On Tuesdays the ironing man comes too.”

At eight at night the picture changed again.

For the first time, Raghavendra Babu understood that the building’s “people” were not the same group all day long.

The next step was to measure the routes.

Savita, Kailash, Malati Devi, and the committee members went upstairs in two groups. One group took the main staircase, the other the back one.

The first problem with the back staircase appeared on the ground floor itself. The iron gate stayed open during the day, but after evening it was latched from inside so that “outsiders” could not enter from the back.

Kailash said, “When there’s a need, I open it.”

Savita asked, “Does need ask permission before it arrives?”

Kailash said nothing.

The second problem was the cot on the second floor. It was actually an old piece of furniture discarded by a resident, which the guards sometimes used for sitting.

The third problem was a dead light.

The fourth was the handrail, present only in broken sections.

The fifth was the three empty water cans kept between the fifth and sixth floors.

The sixth was the broken edge of a step. A fresh layer of cement had been put on it, but in the dark the difference in colour could not be seen.

Raghavendra Babu kept writing everything down.

By the time they reached the seventh floor, Malati Devi was panting.

She said, "I sometimes climb the main stairs as far as the fifth floor. Why does this route feel so different?"

Savita replied, "Your body has not memorised the measure of this route."

No one laughed at that sentence.

The committee met that same evening.

The first proposal was to remove the "Staff Only" sign from the back staircase.

Savita did not agree with the proposal.

"Will removing the sign make the light come on?"

Everyone was silent.

She continued, "I don't need the privilege of walking through the main door as proof of respect. The route I use every day because of my work should be safe."

Malati Devi said, "And so should the route that everyone may have to use in an emergency."

Then the discussion moved away from names and toward the work that had to be done.

It was decided that both staircases would undergo separate safety inspections. The question of whom each was meant for could come later; first there would be lighting, handrails, steps, clear landings, and a way to open the doors.

Every light on the back staircase was replaced within the week. The fifth-floor window was cleaned.

The gaps between the separate sections of handrail were filled in.

Private belongings kept on the landings were removed.

The broken edge of the step was levelled and given a pale white marking so that the change in level would be visible in the dark.

The latch on the back gate was altered so that it could be opened from inside without a key, while entry from outside remained under the guard's watch.

This point caused the greatest argument.

One resident said, "We need safety, but what if someone gets in from the back?"

Kailash replied, "We'll watch from outside. Why should people on the inside have to find us in order to get out?"

There was no joking in his voice this time.

Two weeks later there was another safety inspection.

This time the inspector himself said, "We'll inspect both staircases."

Without saying anything, Raghavendra Babu opened the back gate.

Savita was coming down from the seventh floor at that moment. She had an empty bucket in her hand.

On the third floor, her hand fell naturally on the new handrail.

She did not stop.

When she reached downstairs, she saw that a new sheet had been put up behind the glass beside the old fire-safety map.

The sheet did not contain the building's numbers at the three different times. There were no names either.

There were only two lines—Main Staircase, Back Staircase. Beside each were the same four words: "Lighting · Handrail · Clear · Open."

Savita read the sheet.

Kailash asked, "All right?"

Savita said, "We'll keep watching."

"What?"

"If a light goes out, then we check again."

Kailash laughed. "Isn't the inspection over?"

Savita lifted the bucket.

"How can the inspection of a route used every day ever be over?"

She turned toward the back staircase.

This time, at the turn on the second floor, she did not need to feel her way along the wall.

The Night Slip

At the east gate of the district hospital, the main visitors' register closed as soon as the clock struck eight at night.

The closing of the register did not mean the gate was closed. A hospital is never completely closed at night.

Someone came carrying medicine, someone a patient's clothes, someone in response to a call for blood, someone from a distant village after hearing news. Sometimes a person came only to find out which ward their relative was in.

The employee at the main registration desk left at eight. After that, the gate depended on the security guards and the attendants running in and out.

Devanath was one of those night attendants.

His work was not to write things down. He carried supplies to the wards, returned empty wheelchairs, cleared the way for the night medicine trolley, sometimes took sheets as far as the mortuary—whatever work appeared before him.

But five years on the night shift had taught him another task: remembering when people arrived.

At first he kept it all in his head.

"The man with the red gamchha at five past ten."

"The woman with the glass box at ten twenty-seven."

"The one with two children before eleven."

By dawn, the number of such markers would have grown, and Devanath's mind would be as crowded as the hospital corridors.

One night two families began quarrelling outside the same ward door. Both said they had arrived first. The nurse asked, "Who was sent in first?"

Devanath remembered the faces, but not the time.

After that day, he began cutting little slips.

The slips were not made from new paper. Sheets left printed on one side in the daytime office, old lists, spoiled printouts—the blank sides that remained—Devanath cut them into squares and kept them in a tin box.

Date at the top. Serial number on the left. Time in the middle. Ward on the right.

A name only when two people arrived at the same time for the same patient.

He did not make a habit of writing telephone numbers.

“Why not that much?” the security guard Brijnandan once asked him.

Devanath said, “I need to count people through the night, not find their homes.”

Brijnandan laughed.

Slowly, the slips became part of the night’s work.

A visitor arrived. Devanath looked at the clock. Wrote the serial number. Wrote the ward. If the person was sent inside, he made a small mark in the corner of the slip. If told to wait, he drew an empty circle.

At dawn the slips were left on the registration desk.

Lalita Devi, who worked during the day, did not transfer every slip into the main register. If a permanent entry pass had been made for someone, she copied the name. She counted the remaining slips and wrote—“Night visitors: 17”—then put the slips into an old paper envelope.

“How many days do we keep these papers?” Devanath once asked.

Lalita Devi said, “Until the cupboard says enough.”

It was not a rule, but much of the hospital’s work ran on habit before it ran on rules.

The real use of the slips became clear when someone said at dawn, “I have been sitting here since eleven last night.”

Devanath would look in the box.

“Serial twelve—11:18.”

Someone would say, “The person who came after me was sent in first.”

The slip would be checked. Sometimes that had indeed happened, because permission had come at once from one ward and not from another.

The slip made no decision. It merely kept the order from disappearing into the dark.

In the last week of Sawan, an inspection team came from the district office.

All day the medicine store, fire exits, wards and accounts were inspected. Around the change of the evening shift, the inspectors reached the east gate.

The registration desk was being closed. Lalita Devi was putting the register into the cupboard.

The chief inspector’s eye fell on the tin box.

“What is this?”

Devanath opened the box.

Half-cut sheets, serial numbers, times, sometimes a ward number, sometimes a name.

The inspector picked up one slip.

“Is this part of the official register?”

No one answered.

Lalita Devi said, "For convenience at night..."

"On whose orders?"

Silence again.

The inspector looked at another slip. "This has a patient's ward and a visitor's name on it. Why is it in an open box?"

For the first time, Devanath looked at his slips through another pair of eyes.

The sheets that had seemed like order to him all night looked, in daylight, exactly like loose papers—someone's name, someone's ward, someone's time of arrival.

The inspector said, "Stop this from today. If a record is needed, make an approved register. No private papers."

Brijnandan glanced quietly at Devanath.

Devanath merely put the lid back on the box.

That night, for the first time in five years, no slips were made.

At ten ten, a young man arrived—Ward 6.

At ten sixteen, an elderly woman—Ward 3.

At ten twenty-five, two sisters—Ward 9.

Devanath looked at the clock, but his hand, after moving automatically toward his pocket, stopped.

"Serial number?" Brijnandan asked jokingly.

Devanath said, "Now the order is in my head."

"Will the inspector inspect your head?"

"A head doesn't sit in an open tin box."

Neither of them laughed.

For three nights, nothing much happened.

On the fourth night, at about half past ten, Nirmala Devi came to the east gate. She carried a cloth bag and a folded sheet of paper.

Her sister was admitted in Ward 5. During the day, the doctor had said that the old prescription from home should be shown to the night nurse, so it could be matched with the papers for the morning examination.

Nirmala Devi had taken the bus at half past nine.

Brijnandan stopped her at the gate.

"Night visiting hours are over."

Nirmala Devi showed him the folded paper. "I was told inside that it was important to deliver this."

Brijnandan tried to telephone the ward. The phone rang, but no one answered.

When Devanath reached them, Nirmala Devi said, "I have been here since around twenty or twenty-five past ten."

Brijnandan said, "It is only half past ten now. It must have been five or seven minutes."

Nirmala Devi immediately looked at the clock. "As soon as I got off the bus, I telephoned home. That was at ten twenty-two. It took two minutes to reach the gate."

Brijnandan's voice did not harden, but he did not give up his point. "In between, I was moving an ambulance. I don't remember exactly when you came."

Devanath's hand went toward his pocket again.

The pocket was empty.

At last the ward answered. Nirmala Devi's paper was sent inside. She was not.

The matter could have ended there.

But in the morning the ward in-charge asked, "When did the paper reach us last night?"

Brijnandan said, "Around ten forty."

Nirmala Devi, who had returned in the morning, said, "I was at the gate at ten twenty-four."

There was no entry for her in the main register at the registration desk, because she had never actually gone inside.

In the ward, the time when the paper arrived had been written down—10:47.

The time she reached the gate was written nowhere.

It was easy to conclude that someone was lying.

But Devanath could see that it was possible no one was lying.

One person remembered the time she got off the bus. Another remembered the interval in which he had been moving an ambulance. The ward had only the time the paper reached someone's hand.

There were three times. None was complete.

On the fourth day after the inspection team's order, the superintendent held a small meeting.

The chief inspector was present again.

Devanath was called as well.

The old tin box of slips was not on the table. Since the day of the inspection, it had been kept in a locked cupboard.

The superintendent asked, "Why did you start making the slips?"

Devanath said, "At night, the time when someone came used to disappear."

"And why the names?"

"When two people came at the same time for the same patient."

The inspector said, "But it was not right to write names on loose papers left in the open."

"It was not right," Devanath admitted.

The room was quiet for a moment.

The superintendent turned a pencil in his fingers for a while. Then he asked, "Did stopping the slips solve the problem?"

Lalita Devi said, "The papers ended. The problem did not."

The chief inspector looked at her.

Lalita Devi said slowly, "From eight at night until six in the morning, the main register is closed. During those hours, people who come to the main gate are formally recorded only if permission is given for them to go inside. Anyone who waits and then leaves never appears in the record."

The superintendent asked, "So should we write down full details for every visitor?"

Devanath answered at once, "No. We only need to know what time someone came, which ward they came for, and whether they went inside or waited."

The inspector added, "Names too should be kept to a minimum. If they are not necessary, do not write them. No telephone numbers. No loose papers left in the open."

No large decision was written at the end of the meeting.

Only a thin sample sheet for a new register was made.

Four columns—serial number, arrival time, ward/purpose, status.

Three small status marks—inside, waiting, returned.

If a name was necessary, there would be one final narrow column for it.

At night the register would remain inside the gate in a locked drawer.

In the morning Lalita Devi would match it with the main register. For anyone whose entry was formally recorded, the night serial number would be added in the margin of the main register. For anyone who waited and then left, only the count would remain in the day's tally.

Loose slips would be made only when a queue number had to be given—without names. At dawn they would be counted and destroyed.

Devanath read the sheet.

"Whose job is this register?"

The superintendent said, "Whoever is at the gate at night."

"Then this becomes extra work for me?"

A light laugh went around the room.

Devanath did not laugh.

The superintendent understood. "It will be added to the shift duty list. If it requires time, write that down too. Work cannot be done without time."

Devanath looked at the sheet again.

For the first time, he felt that his five years of unauthorised slips had not merely been given a legitimate name; the burden of the work had also been written into someone's responsibility.

The new register arrived three days later.

On the first night, an elderly man came at nine thirteen. Ward 2. He was not sent inside; the nurse said he should return in the morning.

Devanath filled in the first line.

Serial 1. 9:13. Ward 2. Returned.

The old man asked, "Will writing this mean I get to go in first in the morning?"

Devanath said, "No."

"Then what is the use?"

Devanath placed a finger on the page of the register.

"The fact that you came here tonight will not disappear by morning."

The old man looked at him for a moment, then nodded and left.

The night went on.

Serial 2. Serial 3. Serial 4.

At ten forty-eight Nirmala Devi came again. This time she had clothes for her sister.

Devanath wrote down the time.

Nirmala Devi smiled and asked, "Slips again?"

Devanath turned the register around to show her.

"Not slips. The night register."

Nirmala Devi asked, "Will you write my name?"

Writing the ward number, Devanath said, "There is no need yet."

He tore off a small queue slip kept beside the register. It bore only one number—7.

Nirmala Devi took the slip.

"How long will this survive?"

"Until morning."

"Then?"

"After that, what needs to remain will stay in the register. The paper that does not need to remain will not."

Nirmala Devi folded the number seven into her palm.

Outside the gate, the night was as dense as ever. Inside the hospital, people kept coming and going as before.

Devanath placed his pen on the next line.

This time he did not need to bind anyone's face into his memory.

Two Buttons

On the western side of town, as evening fell in the back courtyard of an old wedding hall, two bundles of white kurtas were opened. At the front gate, strings of lights, electric garlands and an arch of flowers were being arranged; in the back courtyard, plates, glasses, drums of water and the serving staff's clothes were being counted.

Raghu, the contractor's assistant, was handing a kurta to each young man and writing down his name. His register had three columns—name, place of work, and whether the kurta was returned.

"Check the clothes properly," Raghu kept saying. "If there is a tear, a stain, or a broken button when it comes back, it will be deducted from your wages."

People took the clothes in hand, held them to their chests to judge the size, and changed at once. The wedding feast was about to begin. No one had the leisure to inspect every seam, every button, every edge of a kurta.

The kurta Suresh received had two buttons of different colours on the left cuff. The upper button was milky white, the lower one slightly yellowed. Suresh laughed and said, "This kurta has a history of its own."

Without looking up, Raghu said, "Not history. Clothes. Return it tonight."

Suresh was new to this work. He had come from the village to the city and unloaded sacks in a warehouse by day; at night, whenever he found the chance, he cleared plates at wedding feasts. His younger sister's school fee was due that very week, so the wages from this one night mattered to him.

He put on the kurta. The two differently coloured buttons on the left cuff caught his eye again. The thread of one button was a little loose. He thought of telling Raghu, but at that moment a shout came from the main kitchen—"Five men for water, over here!"—and everyone ran.

By nine at night the wedding hall was full. At first Suresh handed out glasses of water, then he cleared empty plates, and later he was stationed at the sweets table. The sleeve of the kurta kept brushing against the edge of the table. Once the loose cuff button caught on the corner of a plate. Suresh stopped his hand and carefully freed it. The button survived, but the thread loosened further.

He could not stop work then to look for needle and thread. He folded the cuff back and went on clearing plates.

At half past one, the first wave of guests began to thin. At two, sweeping and wiping began. At half past two, Raghu sat by the gate and opened the register for the return of the kurtas.

One by one, the men took off the clothes and handed them back. Raghu stretched each white kurta beneath the light, counted the buttons, checked for stains, then marked the name.

Suresh's turn came. Raghu held the kurta out. The moment his eyes fell on the left cuff, his brow tightened.

"One button is loose, one half broken. Forty rupees will be deducted."

Suresh started. "It was already like this. Look—the two buttons are not even the same colour."

Raghu said, "The condition in which it is returned is what gets recorded. Did you say anything when you took it?"

"Where was the time? But I did not break it."

Raghu rested his pen on the register and looked at him for a few moments. "If I accept your word, everyone else will also say it was already like that. How will the accounts work then?"

Suresh fell silent. He had no answer. He understood only this much: the cost of something that had come into his hands already damaged was being taken from his wages.

In the back room, Kamla Devi did the sewing. Her work was to mend the wedding hall's curtains, tablecloths and the servers' kurtas. At the end of the night she took home the pile of kurtas and brought them back repaired before the next engagement.

Raghu tossed Suresh's kurta into a separate pile. "This one goes to Kamla Didi."

Kamla Devi picked up the garment and examined the cuff. The moment she saw the two differently coloured buttons, her hand stopped.

"This again?"

Raghu asked, "What?"

"Nothing," she said, but she set the kurta apart in her lap.

Before dawn broke, after reaching home, Kamla Devi opened the bundle of repairs. She spread the kurta before her again. Inside the left cuff were two tiny knots of fine blue thread. Kamla Devi remembered—one knot she had made three weeks earlier, the other after the previous wedding.

She had her own method. When the same garment came back again and again, she left a small mark of coloured thread near an inner seam so she would know that work had been done there before. It was not a register; it was merely an aid to her memory.

She counted the thread knots. The buttons on the left cuff had already been replaced twice. This time the thread was loose again.

Kamla Devi opened the cuff and examined the cloth. The fault lay less in the button than in the old cuff band. Where the button was sewn, the cloth had become thin from the inside. A new button, sewn on tightly, lasted a few nights; then the thread pulled out together with the cloth.

She thought—how many workers' wages have the buttons on this kurta already eaten?

The next afternoon the wedding hall was preparing for another engagement. Kamla Devi brought in the repaired clothes, but she did not put that kurta into Raghu's pile.

"Look at this first," she said.

Raghu was busy. "Didi, people will start arriving again at five this evening. Everything is all right, isn't it?"

Kamla Devi turned the cuff inside out and showed him the blue knots. "I have changed the buttons here twice before. Now, for the third time, it has come loose again. The cloth has worn thin. Whoever wears it will not be at fault."

Raghu took the cuff in his hand. "Then change it."

"I will. But whose money will be deducted?"

Raghu said nothing.

Kamla Devi asked again, "Whose wages were cut the last two times?"

"I don't remember."

"In the register?"

Raghu opened the register. It contained only the names and a mark for 'clothes returned'. There was nothing about which number kurta it was, what condition it had been in when issued, or whose hands it had passed through before.

"See?" Kamla Devi said. "The garment comes back, the fault comes back, but the account catches only the worker's name."

Raghu grew uncomfortable. "Didi, do you know how many people there are? Fifty or sixty servers. If we write the story of every garment, the feast will be over before we finish."

Kamla Devi did not laugh. She looked at the lower inside edge of the kurta. "Don't write a story. Write a number."

With red thread she stitched a small '17' inside.

"What is that?"

"A garment number. From now on this is number seventeen. Four things in the register—whose hands it went into, any old defect when it was issued, any new defect when it was returned, and the date of repair. That's all."

Raghu shook his head. "You would need a person just to write all that."

Kamla Devi said, "And how many people does it take to deduct the price of the same button three times?"

At that moment Neeraj, the owner's younger brother, came in. He looked after the accounts and arranged temporary workers on wedding days. Raghu told him what they had been discussing. At first Neeraj laughed. "Change the whole system for two buttons?"

Kamla Devi put the kurta in his hands. "Not for two buttons. For money that has been deducted twice. So that we know before it is deducted a third time."

Neeraj examined the cuff. The cloth really had grown thin. He asked, "How can we prove that a deduction was made earlier for this same kurta?"

Kamla Devi showed him the blue knots. "They do not prove the deduction. They prove the repairs. The register of deductions ought to be with you."

For a while after that, the room was silent.

Neeraj asked Raghu for the old pages recording deductions. They contained brief entries on different dates—'button—20', 'cuff—40', 'stain—30'—but not which kurta they referred to. Beside one worker's name was 'button—20' from three weeks earlier; beside another was 'cuff—40' from the previous week. Whether both entries concerned this same kurta could not be known for certain.

Suresh had not yet been paid the forty rupees in question. Neeraj said, "Stop the deduction this time. First identify the garments."

Raghu did not agree at once. "Then what if someone really breaks a button tonight?"

"Then record the new defect," Neeraj said. "But also record the old defect when the garment is issued. No deduction without both."

Before five that evening, Kamla Devi and Raghu began stitching small cloth labels inside all the kurtas. Numbers from 1 to 48 were written on them. Some kurtas already had stains, some had frayed sleeve edges, some had buttons of different colours, and some were entirely sound.

At first Raghu remained irritated. But after ten or fifteen kurtas his hand found the rhythm. He made a small register—'number / condition at issue / condition at return / repair'. The worker's name was entered separately in the first column.

Kamla Devi strengthened the left cuff of kurta number seventeen by adding cloth from the inside. Then she sewed on two new buttons—deliberately not of the same colour. One milky white, one yellow.

Raghu asked, "You had two buttons of the same colour. Why make these different?"

Kamla Devi said, "If we erase the history, it will return as a fault again. Now that there is a register, these two buttons will remind me why the register was made."

That night kurta number seventeen went to a young man named Mahesh. For the first time, as Raghu handed out the garment, he said, "The left cuff has been repaired. The two buttons are different colours. This old condition is written in the register."

Mahesh looked at the kurta. "So when I return it, that won't be put on me?"

"Not the old defect. If there is a new one, we will see."

Mahesh laughed. "This is the first time I've heard the account when taking the clothes too."

The wedding feast ended. Kurta number seventeen came back in good order. Raghu wrote in the register—"no new defect."

Two weeks later there was another wedding. This time 41 of the 48 kurtas were issued. Four were recorded as already stained at the time of issue, two were already under repair, and one was set aside as unfit for use.

At the end of the night, a fresh oil stain was found on one young man's kurta. Raghu did not immediately declare him at fault. They checked the issue entry—the garment had had no stain. The young man himself admitted that a pan had splashed near the kitchen. The cleaning cost was written down; the worker was spoken to; if a deduction was made, its reason was entered in the register.

Kamla Devi watched from a distance. The arrangement had not become just in a single night. Temporary workers still earned little, still stood until late, still feared losing work. But at least an old stain on a kurta no longer climbed onto a new man's body as an accusation.

At the end of the month Suresh came again asking for work. Raghu recognised his name. "That day the forty rupees were not deducted," he said.

Suresh smiled. "I got my money. But what happened to the two buttons?"

Raghu pulled kurta number seventeen from the bundle. The milky-white and yellow buttons were still on the left cuff. '17' was written on the strip inside.

"Here it is," Raghu said. "Now it has a name of its own."

Kamla Devi, who was sewing a torn tablecloth in the corner, looked up.

"Not a name," she said. "A number. The names belong to all those who wear it. The number does this much—it keeps the same fault from being placed again and again on a new name."

Suresh looked at the two buttons on the cuff. He remembered the night when he had fallen silent at the mention of forty rupees.

This time, before handing him the kurta, Raghu opened the register.

“Number seventeen. Left cuff repaired earlier. Two buttons of different colours. No new defect.”

Suresh said, “Write—sound when issued.”

Raghu wrote it down.

At the front gate of the wedding hall, the arch of flowers was shining again. In the back courtyard, the white kurtas kept passing from hand to hand. But now it was not only the garments that returned; their previous condition returned with them as well.

The two buttons were of different colours, but this time they were not a sign of error. They were a sign that when an object’s history is written down, the burden of an old fault need not be placed again and again upon a worker’s body.

Rent for a Closed Window

The only window in the rented room had once looked out on the sky.

The sky was not very large. In front lay the landlord's courtyard, beyond it a tulsi altar, and above that, between two houses, a thin strip of blue. But for Sunayana, that was enough.

Sunayana did sewing. Inside the room were a small table, a hand-operated sewing machine, two boxes of thread, a packet of needles, and a notebook in which she wrote down clothing measurements.

In the morning, when light from the window fell on the table, she could thread a needle without a lamp. By afternoon the light reached the back wall. Toward evening its colour turned first yellow, then grey.

The room was both her home and her place of work.

The landlord, Shambhunath, lived with his family in the front part of the house. Sunayana had been renting a room toward the rear courtyard for two years.

The rent was not very low, but the market was nearby. Customers could leave a blouse, petticoat, or a child's kurta with her and return two days later.

Her relations with Shambhunath were not quarrelsome. On the first of each month, Sunayana paid the rent. Shambhunath wrote out a receipt.

One day before the rains, bricks were unloaded in the courtyard.

Sunayana asked, "Where will the bricks go?"

Shambhunath said, "I'm going to build a small storeroom at the back. The rice, oil tins, old cot—everything is clogging up the house."

Sunayana looked toward the window.

"Here?"

"A little way from the window. Don't worry."

On the first day, the foundation was dug. On the second, two courses of brick rose. On the third, the wall reached the lower edge of Sunayana's window.

That afternoon, while threading a needle, Sunayana missed the eye twice.

She laughed. She thought the fault was in her eyes.

On the fourth day, the wall rose halfway up the window.

On the fifth day, the blue strip of sky disappeared.

The window was open, but three arm-lengths away stood a bare brick wall without any opening. A little light trickled down from above. The air no longer came straight in; it struck the wall and turned upward.

For the first time, Sunayana lit the lamp during the day.

At half past twelve in the afternoon.

That felt strange to her. A lamp belonged to the night. In daylight, its flame announced that the room had changed.

That evening, Shambhunath was crossing the courtyard carrying a tin of kerosene.

Sunayana said, "Babu, the wall has come very close."

Shambhunath stopped.

"Let the roof go on. I'll leave a grille at the top."

"In front of the window?"

"It's a storeroom. No one will live there. Air will come in from above."

Sunayana said nothing.

That night she took out the rent receipt and looked at it. The paper said only—"one room." There was no mention of the window. No mention of light. Air, shade, heat—nothing.

The next day Sunayana opened the last page of her measurement notebook. At the top she wrote—"The Room's Day."

At seven in the morning she placed a needle on the table. She sat facing the window, not with her back to it.

She could thread white cotton through the needle without a lamp.

At eight as well.

At nine, for the first time, she had to bring it close to her eyes.

At ten, threading red cotton became difficult.

At eleven, she had to light the lamp.

She wrote—"Lamp from eleven o'clock."

On the second line, she hung a washed handkerchief near the window. Earlier, a handkerchief like that would dry by noon. That day, even at four in the afternoon, the corners were still damp.

She wrote—"Handkerchief: damp until four."

The third matter was oil. Every evening Sunayana filled the lamp with a small bowlful of oil. Now she had to light it from the afternoon itself. In three days, one extra bowlful of oil had been used.

She added the expense in the notebook.

Shambhunath's wife, Malati, saw this and asked, "What accounts are you writing?"

Sunayana said, "How much daytime is left in the room now?"

Malati did not understand.

"Day lasts all day."

Sunayana pointed to the lamp.

"In my room, night begins at eleven."

Malati did not laugh.

She went and stood by the window. The roof had still not been put on the wall. A thin light remained above.

"Was it not like this before?"

"No."

"Shambhu said he would leave a grille at the top."

"The grille will be above. My table is below."

Malati was silent for a while. Then she said, "I'll tell him."

Two days later, a tin roof went up over the storeroom. A space one arm high had been left at the top for a grille, but that grille was above Sunayana's window.

The room became greyer still during the day.

This time Sunayana did not quarrel with Shambhunath. She held out the notebook.

"Look at this."

Shambhunath looked at the first page.

"What is this?"

"First week. Lamp at eleven. Second week—ten forty-five. After the roof went on—ten o'clock."

"Do you measure light by looking at a clock?"

"The needle measures it."

Shambhunath frowned.

Sunayana put the red thread and the needle in his hand.

"Sit here and thread it."

Shambhunath sat at the table. He held the needle. He brought the thread to its eye. He missed once. He missed a second time.

"My eyesight is weak," he said.

"My work is done with my eyes."

Sunayana showed him the second page.

"This is how long the handkerchief takes to dry. This is the expense for oil. I am not saying you should remove the storeroom. I am asking—whether the room I rented two years ago is still the same room now."

Shambhunath's face hardened slightly.

"The four walls are the same. The roof is the same. The door is the same."

"Then was the rent only for four walls?"

Hearing this, Malati, who was winnowing spices in the courtyard, stopped her hands.

Shambhunath said, "Are you asking for the rent to be reduced?"

Sunayana said, "First we need to understand what has happened."

"I built the storeroom on my own land."

"I am not talking about the land. I am talking about the daytime inside my room."

Shambhunath got up and left.

No decision was made that night.

For the next three days, Shambhunath spoke very little to Sunayana. The date for the rent was drawing near. In Sunayana's notebook, the cost of oil kept rising.

One evening Malati said, "Will you look for another room?"

Sunayana shook her head.

"I can look. But a room this close to the market is expensive. And I have settled this place with my own hands. Customers know the way here now."

"Shambhu is afraid that once the rent is reduced, it will never go back up."

"I am afraid too—that once the window's light is gone, the room's price will remain the same."

Malati said softly, "Then write down both fears."

Sunayana laughed at that.

The next day Malati brought an old notebook. Shambhunath sat down too.

Malati said, "The storeroom will not be removed. Sunayana is not leaving the house for now. So find the middle ground."

Shambhunath said, "There is a grille at the top."

Sunayana said, "The light from that grille does not reach the table."

Malati asked, "Could three courses of brick at the top of the wall be removed and the grille brought lower?"

Shambhunath answered at once, "There will be rice stored there. Water will get in."

Sunayana asked, "Is it necessary to remove the bricks?"

All three went to look at the storeroom.

No sacks of rice had yet arrived. On one side stood the old cot, two empty oil drums, and a box. The wall directly in front of the window was thick. There was a grille above, but under the roof the inside was dark.

Sunayana saw that there was no need to store any sack directly opposite the window. That part could remain as a passage.

"Does this wall need to be completely closed?" she asked.

Shambhunath said, "For security."

Malati looked up toward the grille.

"Bring the grille lower and put iron bars outside. Add a small awning above for the rain."

Shambhunath remained silent.

"The expense?"

Sunayana said, "I will not pay it. The storeroom is not mine."

Shambhunath did not like that.

“Then why should I do it?”

Sunayana opened her notebook.

“Because you do not charge rent for four walls. You charge rent for a room fit to live in. As long as the light has been reduced, I will pay a smaller part of the rent. When the grille is brought down and working light returns, I will pay the old rent.”

Shambhunath narrowed his eyes.

“How much less?”

Sunayana had come prepared.

She showed him the cost of the oil.

“The oil costs this much. The loss of working time is separate. But I will not calculate every paisa. Five percent less from the monthly rent, until the window’s light is put right.”

Shambhunath objected at once, “Five percent is too much.”

“Then you tell me.”

“Two.”

“Four.”

“Three.”

Malati intervened. “Write three, but write the date of the work too. From the day the grille is brought lower, the old rent.”

Sunayana looked at Shambhunath.

After a long while, Shambhunath nodded.

In the notebook they wrote—“The storeroom wall has reduced the room’s natural light. Until the correction is made, monthly rent reduced by three percent. Correction: in the upper part of the storeroom wall opposite the window, an open iron grille strip to be brought down lower, with a rain-shielding awning above. Old rent after the work is completed.”

Sunayana added another line—“Whether the correction has worked will be accepted by both sides by seeing, in daylight, whether there is enough working light to thread a needle.”

Shambhunath read it and smiled.

“So the needle is the judge?”

“No,” Sunayana said, “it is the tool of my work.”

For the first time, the amount written on the next rent receipt was slightly lower.

In the margin of that paper, Shambhunath wrote in small letters—“temporary light reduction.”

Sunayana folded the receipt and placed it in her notebook.

The work on the grille did not happen at once. A mason was found two weeks later. Meanwhile, Sunayana continued lighting the lamp during the day.

One day a customer, Kamala Devi, asked, "Why is the lamp burning in daytime?"

Sunayana said, "The window is open, but the day is a little closed."

Kamala Devi did not understand, but she laughed.

Two weeks later, in the section of the storeroom directly opposite the window, a narrow grilled strip was made from high up down toward the window level. A small sloping awning was fitted outside so rainwater would not enter directly. The iron bars were strengthened from within.

On the second day after the work was finished, Shambhunath himself sat at Sunayana's table.

It was half past ten.

Sunayana had not lit the lamp.

She placed the red thread and needle before him.

This time Shambhunath threaded it on the first attempt.

"Now?"

Sunayana said, "Now a little of the day has come inside again."

She hung the handkerchief too. It dried after noon.

The oil expense returned to what it had been before.

The next month, the rent returned to its old amount.

While writing the receipt, Shambhunath asked, "Will you write this in the notebook too?"

"I will."

"What?"

"Three-percent reduction ended."

Both of them laughed.

Sunayana then said, "And one more thing."

"What now?"

"Next time, before raising any wall, we will put a chair in front of the window and sit there once."

Shambhunath said, "Shall I bring the needle too?"

"If it is needed."

The rains came. The storeroom filled with sacks of rice. Rain drummed on the awning over the grilled strip, but no water came inside. The full sky did not return to Sunayana's window. The blue strip was thinner than before.

But the light reached the table.

One evening, while turning the pages of her old notebook, Sunayana came to the page titled "The Room's Day." Lamp at eleven, ten forty-five, ten o'clock—all the times were written there. Beneath them were the oil expense,

the time the handkerchief took to dry, the three-percent reduction, and the date the grille was made.

She did not tear out the page.

Beside it she also kept the receipt whose margin bore the small words —“temporary light reduction.”

The room’s four walls were the same. The roof was the same. The door was the same.

But Sunayana now knew that the rent of a home is not merely a count of bricks.

Sometimes its reckoning begins with just enough light to thread a needle.

The Brick Mark

Two slanting lines marked the corner of a wet brick.

Kaushalya recognized the mark from a distance.

Last year Raghuni had drawn those same two lines on the damp body of each brick with a small piece of wood. A brick would come out of the clay, the mould would open, Kaushalya would set it in a row in the sun, and Raghuni would score two slanting lines into one corner.

“So that our batch can be distinguished when they are counted,” he would say.

To Kaushalya, the mark had never been a name. It was only a small sign of work—a way of recognizing their row among the thousand or two thousand bricks made in a day.

This year Raghuni was not there.

In Phagun a fever came on; within two days his body had grown terribly weak. There was the village medicine shop, the block hospital, a borrowed vehicle—everything was tried. In the first week of Chait, Raghuni died.

Kaushalya had thought the kiln would now remain only a memory. But by Jeth the grain at home was finished, her younger daughter’s school fee was still unpaid, and the accounts from the previous season had not been settled. The clerk, Navalkishor, sent word twice: “Come and settle the account. Raghuni’s old debt is still outstanding.”

Kaushalya came to the kiln after the third message.

The kiln was as it had always been—red dust, the smell of soot, rows of unbaked bricks, puddles of water here and there, and smoke rising in the distance. Only for her had something changed. Every place where Raghuni’s body had been present the year before now seemed empty.

Under the clerk’s thatched shelter, two thick ledgers lay on an old wooden table. Navalkishor pushed his spectacles up his nose and opened a page.

“Two lines,” he said. “Raghuni’s mark. Look—an advance of eighteen thousand four hundred. It could not all be recovered by the end of last season.”

Kaushalya looked at the page. In the space for the name was written ‘Raghuni-Kaushalya’. Beside it were two slanting lines. Below were figures,

dates, deductions, then more figures. On some lines there were only numbers—no thumbprint, no signature.

“When was all this money taken?” Kaushalya asked.

Navalkishor ran a fingernail along the page. “If it is in the account, it must have been taken.”

“I remember what I took. Five thousand in Jeth. Two thousand in Sawan for medicine. When were these three thousand taken?”

“Raghuni must have taken it.”

“When?”

“The date is written.”

“You wrote the date. Where is Raghuni’s print?”

Navalkishor grew a little uncomfortable. “We do not take a print every time here. The mark itself is proof.”

“These two lines?”

“Yes.”

Kaushalya lifted her eyes from the page.

Just then a child came running in from outside and said, “Munshi-ji, please count Ramesar’s row.”

Navalkishor got up. Kaushalya too went outside.

The sun was fierce. Long rows of newly moulded wet bricks had been laid out. Ramesar and his wife, Panmati, were cutting clay and filling the moulds. Their two children were smoothing the earth around the raw bricks.

Kaushalya’s gaze caught on one brick.

At its corner were two slanting lines.

Kaushalya looked at another brick. Two lines there as well. On a third too. The entire row bore the same mark.

She went over to Ramesar.

“Who puts this mark on them?”

Ramesar brushed the clay from his hands and said, “Munshi-ji gave us the old piece of wood. He said this would be the mark for this batch.”

“The old piece of wood?”

Panmati picked up a small piece lying beside the raw bricks. Along one edge were two raised ridges. Pressed into the clay, they left the same sign.

Kaushalya took the piece of wood in her hand.

It was not the piece Raghuni had made. Someone must have made another after the earlier one broke. But the mark was the same.

Navalkishor was counting the row. “One thousand seven hundred and forty,” he wrote in the child’s notebook. “Two lines—Ramesar.”

Kaushalya heard him.

“Munshi-ji,” she said, “the two lines you just counted—whose are they?”

“Ramesar’s.”

"And in the ledger inside, whose are the two lines?"

Navalkishor looked at her. "In the old account, Raghuni's."

"Then how can the same mark sometimes be Ramesar and sometimes Raghuni?"

"The batch changes. The mark is only for identification."

Kaushalya said nothing. She handed the wooden piece back to Panmati.

She stayed at the kiln until noon. The clerk opened the ledger again.

"Look, the account has to be settled. If you work this season, it will gradually be deducted."

"Against which mark?" Kaushalya asked.

Navalkishor started.

"If I work, what mark will I get?"

"We'll give you a new one."

"The two lines belong to Ramesar now."

"Yes, this season."

"Then why does Raghuni's debt rest on those two lines?"

Navalkishor said nothing.

Kaushalya wiped the sweat from her forehead with the end of her sari.

"When bricks are being counted, the mark belongs to this season's team.

When money is being deducted, the same mark belongs to a dead man from last season. Why should one mark have two meanings?"

"That is how the accounts have always been kept."

"The accounts have always been kept that way—or the marks?"

Two labourers sitting nearby almost laughed, but when they saw Navalkishor's face they fell silent.

By evening the matter had spread through the kiln. It was nothing new to anyone that a family's account could continue with the family. What was new was that Kaushalya had seized upon the meaning of the mark.

She returned the next morning. This time she carried an old school notebook.

She sat beside the clerk's table and made two columns on the first page. On the left she wrote: "Work mark." On the right: "Money taken."

Navalkishor frowned. "What is this?"

"An attempt to understand your ledger."

In the left-hand column she wrote—

Two lines — previous season: Raghuni–Kaushalya.

Two lines — this season: Ramesar–Panmati.

Then in the right-hand column she wrote—

Five thousand — Kaushalya present.

Two thousand — for medicine.

Three thousand — no proof.

She put question marks before all the figures that followed.

"Erase the question marks," Navalkishor said.

"Show me the proof and I will erase them."

"You don't trust my ledger?"

"For me to trust a ledger, its meaning has to remain the same."

Navalkishor struck the table with his palm. "The kiln is not a court."

Kaushalya replied in an even voice, "Nor am I a court. I am only asking—are the two lines a person, or are they a batch?"

The owner, Jagmohan, happened to be at the kiln that day as well. He usually came in the evenings, but a trader was due to select a shipment of bricks. Navalkishor told him what had happened.

Jagmohan called Kaushalya over.

"Do you not have to pay the old debt?"

"I will pay what is mine. What Raghuni took, if there is proof, is a separate matter. But two lines are not a birthmark on my forehead."

Jagmohan tried to laugh. "Who said anything about a birthmark?"

"Then why are those lines on the new team's bricks?"

The owner's face grew somewhat serious. He looked at Navalkishor.

Navalkishor said, "The old mark was available, so I gave it to them. What difference does that make?"

Kaushalya answered at once, "Only this much: the people making the bricks have changed, but the person owing the debt has not. If the mark can change whenever it is convenient, how can it be proof of a debt?"

At that moment a man from the trader's party arrived while examining a row of bricks. The colour of one batch seemed slightly different to him.

"Who made these?" he asked.

Navalkishor pointed towards a distant row. "Two lines."

"What does two lines mean?"

Navalkishor paused for a moment. "Ramesar's team."

Kaushalya remained silent.

The trader's man asked, "Didn't the previous batch also have two lines?"

"That was last season."

"Then is the season written on the page?"

Navalkishor began turning the pages of the ledger. Some had dates; some did not.

For the first time, Jagmohan examined the ledger closely.

"Why is the same mark used again and again?"

"There are only so many marks," Navalkishor said. "Two lines, three dots, a circle, two crossed lines—that is about all. When a team changes, the marks are reused."

“Then add the date or batch number,” the trader’s man said matter-of-factly. “Otherwise, if a bad batch turns up, how will you know whom to hold responsible?”

Kaushalya watched the owner’s face. The issue had moved now from a labourer’s debt to the quality of an owner’s goods. The question that had seemed light in her voice had suddenly acquired weight in its commercial form.

She did not find it funny. Nor did it make her sad. It only made an old truth clear again—the same fact does not weigh the same in everyone’s hands.

That afternoon Jagmohan told Navalkishor to prepare four new pages.

First—season/batch number.

Second—production mark and the names of the current team.

Third—advance or money paid, with date.

Fourth—the recipient’s signature or thumbprint.

Navalkishor said, “Who will write all this?”

Jagmohan replied, “You will. That is why you are the clerk.”

The workers nearby laughed again. This time even Navalkishor smiled a little, though his smile showed more weariness at the extra work than defeat.

Kaushalya said, “And the old debt?”

Jagmohan pulled Raghuni’s page towards him on the table. “Where there is a print, we will examine it. Where there are only figures, Navalkishor will explain the basis. Figures in Raghuni’s name will not automatically be added to Kaushalya’s new wages.”

Navalkishor immediately said, “Malik—”

“If the ledger is clear, it is better for me as well.”

Kaushalya did not feel as though she had won anything at that moment. Raghuni had not returned. The shortages at home had not ended. The genuine advances of five thousand and two thousand were still in the account. She still needed to work.

But one thing had changed—the two slanting lines were no longer stuck to her body.

She agreed to work at the kiln that season. Her new team consisted of herself and Dhanmanti, her nephew’s wife. They were given a new mark—a small crescent. Beside it the batch number was written: “Jeth-3.”

Taking the wooden marker in her hand, Kaushalya said, “If you give this mark to someone else next season, write the new season on the page.”

Navalkishor said, “So now you’ll become the clerk?”

“No. I’ll only make bricks. The clerk will do the clerk’s work properly.”

Navalkishor laughed. “Your tongue has started running a great deal.”

“Earlier my hands had more work to do in the clay.”

Days passed. The rows of crescent-marked bricks grew longer. Each morning Kaushalya soaked the clay, filled the mould, smoothed the corners, and pressed in the little wooden marker. The sign was small, but now beside it there was a date, a batch number, and a current team.

Ramesar's two-line bricks dried as well. Often, as Kaushalya passed those rows, she would see the mark. For a moment she would remember Raghuni's hands. Then she would see Ramesar's bent back and Panmati's clay-smeared palms.

Slowly she understood: a mark could remain a memory, but it could not remain ownership.

At the end of the month the first new accounting was done. Navalkishor opened the production ledger.

"Jeth-3, crescent, Kaushalya-Dhanmanti—eighteen thousand two hundred bricks."

Then he opened the advance ledger.

"Kaushalya—two thousand, for school fees. Thumbprint."

Kaushalya listened as the entry was read out, then gave her print.

"The old account?" she asked.

Navalkishor opened another page. "Five thousand and two thousand—those two are accepted. No basis was found for the remaining three entries. The owner has struck them out."

Kaushalya remained silent for a few moments.

"What was genuinely Raghuni's will remain written?"

"It will. In his name. It will not enter your new wages automatically."

Kaushalya nodded. She did not hear complete justice in that answer. She heard only one clear line: this figure on this page belonged to this person, on this date. Another figure on another page belonged to another matter. Perhaps clear accounting began there.

Before the rains, a new storehouse was built at the kiln. Leftover bricks from different seasons were used in its lower wall.

One day Kaushalya stopped there to drink water. In the wall she saw a brick marked with two slanting lines. Beside it was another bearing a crescent.

The two marks were set into the same wall.

Kaushalya touched the brick with the two lines. She remembered Raghuni—squinting in the sun, brushing clay from his hands, saying, "So that our batch can be distinguished."

Her eyes filled with tears, but the mark no longer looked to her like a figure in a debt account.

It was only a sign of work from the previous season.

On another brick in the wall was the crescent—this season's.

Kaushalya did not touch it.

She knew that next year the crescent might pass into the hands of some other team.

The mark would remain on the brick.

But in the ledger, the date, the batch, and the person had to remain separate.

Otherwise, a small line in clay can slowly become such a shackle that an entire lifetime may be too little to break it.

The Pocket Ledger

Turning out the pockets before washing clothes was the first rule of the laundry.

Jhunia Devi's hands were quick at this work, but quickness did not mean haste. She checked the left shirt pocket first, then the right, then the small inner pocket. Before putting her hand into a trouser pocket, she shook the garment so that the point of a pen or a key would not cut her thumb.

Kusum Laundry was not a very large place. At the front stood the counter where clothes were received, behind it the washing room, to one side a long ironing board, and against the wall a small iron cupboard.

Above the cupboard, in bold letters, was written—

“Write down whatever you find.”

The rule had been made two years earlier.

Before that, coins found in pockets were sometimes left on the counter, keys were tied to the clothes with thread, slips of paper went through the wash with the garments, and sometimes people forgot which object belonged to whom.

Once a customer said there had been a five-hundred-rupee note in his trouser pocket. The clothes came back; the note did not.

For three days Ramakant Babu, the owner of the laundry, questioned everyone. No one admitted anything. There was proof on neither side. In the end, an equal amount was deducted from the wages of the four people who had sorted clothes that day.

That day Jhunia had said, “If we are to be responsible for whatever we find, then we should write it down too. Otherwise the pocket is the customer's and the blame is ours.”

That was when the register began.

Its columns were simple—garment number, pocket, object found, quantity or identifying mark, time found, who found it, and into whose keeping it was placed.

If cash was found, the number of notes and the total amount were recorded. If keys were found: “brass—one,” “iron—two.” For coins, the total

amount. A bus ticket, a shop receipt, a medicine wrapper, a child's glass marble—everything was written down.

Within a few days the rule became everyone's habit.

Along with Jhuniah, Sudha, Parveen, and Jagdish sorted the clothes. Each pair of eyes noticed different things. Sudha looked first at the stitching, Parveen at stains, Jagdish at buttons, Jhuniah at pockets.

"Write down whatever you find" was no longer merely the owner's instruction to them. It became a wall of protection around them.

One evening three hundred-rupee notes came out of the inner pocket of a yellow shirt. Jhuniah entered them in the register, showed them to Sudha, placed all three notes in a small envelope, and wrote the garment number on it.

Two days later the customer came to collect his clothes and said, "There was some money in the pocket."

Ramakant Babu, seated at the counter, opened the register.

"Three hundred?"

The customer thought for a moment, then said, "Yes, it must have been three hundred."

The envelope was brought out. The three notes were returned.

Jhuniah watched from a distance. It seemed to her that the paper was small, but its voice was large.

Another time a customer began speaking loudly because he could not find the key that had been in his coat. The register said: "Right pocket, one iron key, blue thread, envelope II."

The cupboard was opened. The key was found.

That day Ramakant Babu rested his hand on the register and said, "This is how people come to trust us."

Jhuniah said inwardly, "And how we protect ourselves as well."

The trouble began with that same paper of trust.

It was a humid afternoon in Sawan. Few people were coming in from outside to leave clothes. Inside, the heat from the irons was intense. The fan was running, but all its air did was circle the smell of hot metal through the room.

Sudha placed a pair of grey trousers in front of Jhuniah.

"Check the pockets."

Jhuniah took two coins from the left pocket. The right pocket was empty. In the back pocket was a sheet of paper folded four times.

It was unopened, but the folds lay in such a way that two lines inside could be seen at the edge.

Jhuniah carried it over to the register.

Sudha was doing the entries in the register at that time.

“What should I write?” Sudha asked.

“One sheet of paper.”

Sudha picked it up. “There are many kinds of paper. Tomorrow someone may say it was a five-hundred-rupee voucher and that you wrote only ‘paper.’”

She opened one fold.

Jhuniah said at once, “Don’t open it.”

But one fold had already been opened.

At the top was a name— “Ma.”

The first line below read: “I won’t be able to send money this month.”

Sudha stopped.

“Now what?”

Jhuniah folded the paper again.

“One sheet of paper, folded four times, ‘Ma’ written at the top.”

Sudha said, “The rule says—write down whatever you find.”

“What we found is a piece of paper. Not what is inside it.”

At this Ramakant Babu spoke from behind them. “Write it all down. Then there will be no dispute tomorrow.”

Sudha read two lines and copied them into the register: “Ma—I won’t be able to send money this month; lost my job at the hotel...”

Jhuniah looked at her hand.

“Why so much?”

Ramakant Babu said, “For identification. There is a great deal of suspicion in our work. The clearer the record, the better.”

Jhuniah fell silent.

The paper was put into the envelope for garment number 418.

Until evening, the matter seemed finished.

The next day a young man came to collect the grey trousers. His name was Ravi. Garment number 418 was written on the laundry receipt.

Ravi was not a regular customer. For the past two months he had been working nights at a nearby eatery and studying during the day for competitive examinations. Sometimes he brought the clothes himself; sometimes his maternal cousin Dinesh, with whom he lived, dropped them off.

That day Dinesh was with Ravi.

Sudha was counting the clothes at the counter. Ramakant Babu looked at the register.

“There was a paper in one pair of trousers.”

Ravi held out his hand at once. “Yes, give it to me.”

Ramakant Babu asked for the envelope. While looking for it, Sudha read the entry in the register—

“Ma—I won’t be able to send money this month; lost my job at the hotel...”

Dinesh turned to look at Ravi.

"You lost your job?"

Ravi's hand, which had been reaching for the envelope, stopped midway.

For a few moments the only sound in the laundry was the fan.

Ravi asked softly, "Why did you read this?"

Ramakant Babu said, "We have a rule that we record whatever is found in a pocket."

"Then write that a paper was found. Why write what was written on the paper?"

"For identification."

Ravi did not look at Dinesh.

"For identification, should what I wrote to my mother remain in everyone's register?"

Sudha said, "I wrote it according to the rule."

Ravi looked at her, but his voice was not harsh.

"I am not blaming you. I am only asking—do you need an account of what was in my pocket, or an account of my life?"

After he said this, Jhunias rose from beside the ironing board and came to the counter.

"I said the same thing yesterday."

Ramakant Babu grew a little uncomfortable. "Look, this register protects us from accusations of theft. Without details, later someone may say there were five thousand rupees inside the paper, or that it was some important document."

Ravi took the envelope containing his paper.

"If there were five thousand rupees, then five thousand rupees is a separate object. If it was a document, write 'document.' Why the sentences?"

Dinesh remained silent. He could see that his very presence had become an embarrassment for Ravi.

Ravi picked up his clothes and walked out.

Dinesh followed him.

The register remained open on the counter.

In that line, something Ravi had never chosen to tell was now part of the laundry's permanent writing.

Sudha capped her pen.

"Did I do wrong?"

Jhunias said, "You followed the rule. Now the question is about the rule."

Ramakant Babu said, "If we remove the rule, the accusations will return."

"Don't remove the rule," Jhunias said. "Set a boundary to the account."

That night, after the washing stopped, all four workers sat around the counter.

Jagdish kept turning the pages of the old register.

“Look how much is written here. ‘Doctor’s prescription—medicine three times a day.’ ‘Loan account—seven thousand.’ ‘School-fee receipt.’ While saving people’s belongings, we have been collecting their private matters.”

Parveen placed her thumb on one line.

“Here it says, ‘paper with mobile-phone number.’ The whole number is written too.”

Ramakant Babu pulled the register toward himself.

Before this, all those entries had looked like carefulness to him. That night, for the first time, he saw the other face of that carefulness.

“Then what should be written?”

Jhunia took a blank sheet of paper.

At the top she wrote four words: “Object, number, value, identifying mark.”

“If cash is found, the total amount and the number of notes. If it is a key, the number and an outward identifying mark. Coins, ring, pen—whatever the object is. If a private paper is found, ‘private paper—one.’ That is all.”

Sudha asked, “What if the paper itself is an identity card?”

Parveen said, “A name that is clearly visible on the outside can be used for identification without reading anything else. But not what is written inside.”

Jagdish said, “And if a paper is folded, don’t open it.”

Ramakant Babu asked another question. “What if the customer says there was cash inside the paper?”

Jhunia said, “We do not open the paper. If there is cash hidden inside a fold, then we simply will not know. But write a rule for customers as well—do not leave cash or important objects in pockets. Our responsibility is to keep safe what we find, not to read people’s minds.”

The discussion went on for a long time.

In the end they did not make a new register. Five new columns were added to the old one—garment number, pocket, category of object, number/amount, envelope number.

A short rule was written below them—

“The text of private papers will not be copied.”

Ramakant Babu said, “Cash will require two signatures.”

Sudha added, “And a private paper goes at once into a small sealed envelope.”

Parveen laughed. “Make sure you say ‘sealed,’ or Jagdish will open it again.”

Jagdish said, “I only look to make sure the paper doesn’t dissolve in the wash.”

The laughter was brief, but it loosened some of the tension of the night.

One question still remained—Ravi’s sentence in the old register.

“What do we do with this?” Sudha asked.

Ramakant Babu said, “It would not be right to tear a page out of the register.”

Jhunia said, “Don’t tear it. Cover the sentence, and write above it: ‘Private text removed under the new rule’—with the date and two signatures.”

Ramakant Babu thought for a while.

Then a thin strip of paper was cut and pasted over Ravi’s private sentence. Above it they wrote: “Private text removed—date...”

Sudha and Ramakant Babu signed it.

Jhunia said, “And if someone asks later what was written there?”

“The answer will be: private matter. That is all,” Ramakant Babu said.

The new rule took effect the very next day.

Its first test came with a blue shirt. In the pocket they found two five-rupee coins, a small key, and a folded paper.

Sudha picked up the paper as she would have before, but this time she did not open it.

In the register she wrote—

“Garment 431. Right pocket. Cash—10. Key—I. Private paper—I. Envelope—7.”

Jhunia added the second signature.

The paper was sealed in envelope number seven.

In the evening the customer came. After taking his clothes, he said, “Did I leave a slip of paper in my pocket?”

Sudha checked the register. “One private paper. Envelope seven.”

The envelope was returned.

The customer opened the paper, looked at it, then folded it at once and put it in his pocket.

No one asked what was written on it.

Two weeks later another suspicion of theft arose.

A customer said there had been two thousand rupees in the pocket of his kurta. The register said: “Cash—two thousand; four five-hundred-rupee notes; envelope 19; Jhunia/Parveen.”

The envelope was opened. All four notes were safe.

The customer counted the money and said, “Correct.”

Ramakant Babu looked at Jhunia.

The register was still protecting them.

The only difference was that now no one’s private sentences were needed for that protection.

A month later Ravi came to the laundry again. This time he was alone. He carried three shirts and two pairs of trousers.

Sudha was a little hesitant as she counted the clothes.

Ravi himself said, "I have come back."

Ramakant Babu came out.

"That day..." he began.

Ravi did not stop him.

Ramakant Babu said, "The rule has changed."

He showed him the register—the column for private papers, the envelope number, and the sentence written below.

Ravi read: "The text of private papers will not be copied."

He did not close the register. For a few moments he kept looking through the older pages.

"My entry?"

Ramakant Babu opened the old page. A thin strip had been pasted over the sentence: "Private text removed under the new rule."

Ravi did not touch the strip with his hand.

"All right."

Jhunia called from behind them, "The paper was not torn out, but your words are no longer out in the open either."

Ravi looked at her. "And if I leave something in a pocket this time?"

Jhunia laughed. "The object will come back. The story will remain yours."

Ravi smiled a little too.

He handed over the clothes.

Jhunia checked the first pair of trousers. One coin. The other pocket was empty. In the back pocket of the second pair was a folded slip.

Sudha picked up the slip, but did not open it.

"Garment 487," she wrote. "Private paper—one. Envelope—12."

Ravi watched all this from the other side of the counter.

He did not say what was written on the slip.

No one asked.

On the old wall of the laundry, the bold words were still there: "Write down whatever you find."

One day Jhunia added another line beneath them in smaller letters—

"Not what is written on it."

From that day on, the pocket ledger kept account of objects, not minds.

The Evening Chair

The green iron chair at the door of the pharmacy had a small sign tied to it —“For Customers.”

The sign was white, the letters properly bold. It could be read even from a distance.

Govind saw it many times in the course of the day.

His place of work was exactly two arm’s lengths behind that chair.

The shop opened at half past eight in the morning. Govind first opened the grille door, stood by the steps, cleared the way for the vehicle bringing medicine cartons, and kept watch over the people coming in and going out.

His shift lasted until nine at night.

The chair remained there all day.

Often empty.

Govind’s feet were not empty of work all day.

Inside the shop were two medicine counters. A glass cabinet stood between them. To the right was a small blood-pressure machine. Outside, to the left of the steps, stood the green chair.

At first there had been no sign on the chair.

Two months earlier, an elderly customer had been left standing for a long time. After that, the shop owner, Umesh Babu, had said, “Keep one chair permanently for customers.”

Seema, who worked at the medicine counter, wrote the words on thick paper and tied the sign to the chair.

Everyone had thought it a good idea that day.

Govind too had said, “Good. The elderly will be able to rest.”

The next afternoon the shop was empty. The sun outside was fierce. After carrying five cartons of medicine inside, Govind sat on the chair for two moments.

Umesh Babu saw him from inside.

“Govind, that is for customers.”

Govind stood up at once.

“Yes, Babu.”

“There is a seat for you in the back room. You can go there during your break.”

There was a seat in the back room, but the door could not be seen from there. Govind had a half-hour break. For the rest of the time, his place was at the door.

From that day on, Govind no longer needed to read the sign.

Even when the chair stood empty, he did not touch it.

Sometimes he shifted the weight of his right foot onto his left. Sometimes he raised his heel. Sometimes he rested a palm against the doorframe and let it take a little of his body's weight.

In the afternoon no one noticed any of this.

After five in the evening, before the clinic opposite closed, the crowd would grow.

That was when the green chair truly became busy.

One day Sharda Devi came and sat down. She had an old cloth bag in her hand and a doctor's prescription.

Seema said, “It will take ten minutes to prepare the medicine.”

Sharda Devi sat on the chair.

Govind stood beside the doorway.

Ten minutes passed. Then fifteen. One box of medicine could not be found inside, so Seema was opening another cabinet.

Sharda Devi looked at Govind.

Govind bent one knee once, then straightened it again.

“Do your feet hurt?” Sharda Devi asked.

Govind laughed. “My work is to stand, Maai.”

“Is your work to stand, or to keep watch?”

Govind did not answer.

Sharda Devi asked again, “How long have you been standing?”

“Since morning.”

“In between?”

“There is a break.”

Sharda Devi read the sign.

Just then Seema held out her medicine.

“Yours is ready.”

Sharda Devi rose. She tucked the bag under her arm. Taking hold of the back of the chair, she pushed it two arm's lengths towards Govind.

“My work here is done. Now you sit for two minutes.”

Govind's hand went instinctively to the back of the chair, then stopped.

“No, Maai. This is for customers.”

Sharda Devi looked at the sign, then at the bag of medicine in her hand.

“Now that I have the medicine in my hand, am I no longer a customer?”

Govind laughed, but he did not sit.

From behind the medicine counter Umesh Babu said, "Maai, you sit. His rules are different."

"I don't need to sit now."

Sharda Devi left the chair where it was and walked out.

Govind moved it back to its old place.

The shop closed that evening, but Seema remembered the small incident.

The next afternoon the chair stood empty for three hours.

Govind did not sit on it even once during those three hours.

In the evening Sirchan Babu arrived, leaning on a stick. His medicine should have been ready, but one name the doctor had written was unclear. Seema was trying to telephone and ask.

Sirchan Babu sat on the chair.

Five minutes later the answer came.

He stood up, but did not leave.

"Govind, no one is sitting now. Sit down."

Govind gave the same answer again—"This is for customers."

Sirchan Babu read the sign.

"You work here, so you are not a customer. But were your knees made differently from a customer's knees?"

This time Umesh Babu said nothing.

Govind still did not sit.

Sirchan Babu placed his empty medicine bag on the chair.

"Until someone else comes, this bag is the customer. Sit and guard the bag."

Seema laughed. Govind grew embarrassed.

At last he sat on one edge of the chair for two minutes.

His eyes remained on the doorway.

A young man came in. Govind stood up at once.

The young man did not ask for the chair. He went straight to the medicine counter.

Sirchan Babu picked up his bag and said, "See? The chair was empty, and the work did not stop."

This time Umesh Babu said, "Two minutes one day, then half an hour every day. A rule is a rule."

Govind remained silent.

Without stopping her work on the prescription, Seema said only, "One must also remember what question a rule was made to answer."

Umesh Babu heard her, but did not reply.

Nothing changed for three days.

In the evenings the green chair passed among elderly customers. In the daytime it remained empty. Govind remained standing.

On the evening of the fourth day, it rained.

People crowded beneath the awning at the doorway. The chair came to stand in the middle of the passage.

At that moment a woman arrived, pushing her elderly father in a wheelchair.

The way through the doorway had become narrow because of the chair and the people.

Govind immediately picked up the green chair and put it against the wall, moved people aside, and cleared the middle passage.

The wheelchair went inside.

Umesh Babu said, "This is why we cannot keep more chairs at the door. The way gets blocked."

Sharda Devi had come again that evening for medicine. She saw everything.

"A chair that blocks the way is wrong," she said. "The need to sit is not wrong."

Umesh Babu remained silent.

Seema took out a measuring tape to measure the width of the doorway.

"A passage three arm's lengths wide can be kept clear in the middle at all times," she said. "There is empty space along this side of the wall."

"If we leave a chair there, it will be stolen at night," Umesh Babu said.

"Don't leave one there," Seema said. "A seat that folds against the wall could be made."

For the first time Govind spoke in the middle of the discussion—"Folded up in the daytime, opened when needed. The way would stay clear too."

Umesh Babu looked at him.

"You are having a great many ideas."

Govind fell silent.

Sharda Devi said, "Ideas come easily when the feet hurt."

This time Umesh Babu neither laughed nor grew annoyed.

After the shop closed that night, Seema drew a straight chalk line down the middle of the doorway.

"This is the passage," she said.

On the left wall she drew two small rectangles.

"These are the places for the seats."

Umesh Babu took the measuring tape and measured again. A wheelchair could pass. So could a trolley carrying cartons.

"How much will the blacksmith charge?" he asked.

Govind named a local blacksmith.

The next afternoon the blacksmith came. Two small seats were made by cutting an old thick plank. They were fixed to the wall with iron hinges. When not in use, they could be folded up flat against the wall.

Umesh Babu said, "Write that one is for customers and one for the guard."

Seema took out a sheet of paper, then stopped.

"The same problem again."

"What?"

"What if the customer's seat is empty and Govind is tired? What if Govind's seat is empty and two elderly customers arrive?"

Umesh Babu looked at the paper.

"Then what should we write?"

Seema said, "Nothing."

Govind said at once, "If there is no sign, people will quarrel."

Sharda Devi, who happened to have come again for medicine, heard this.

"Keep a sign," she said.

Everyone looked at her.

"Write—'Open a seat when needed. Fold it back when you get up.'"

Sirchan Babu too happened to come that evening. He said, "And keep the middle passage clear."

Seema wrote two lines.

"Open a seat when needed. Fold it back when you get up.
Keep the middle passage clear."

Umesh Babu read the notice.

"Nothing about employees or customers?"

"No," Seema said.

Govind kept reading the notice.

The new arrangement began the next day.

In the morning the doorway was clear. Both seats were folded against the wall.

At ten an elderly man came. He opened one seat and sat. When he received his medicine, he got up and folded it back.

At half past one in the afternoon there were no customers in the shop. Govind opened one seat.

He sat.

For three minutes.

His eyes remained on the doorway. A medicine delivery vehicle arrived; he stood up at once, folded the seat, and cleared the way.

Umesh Babu watched from inside.

He said nothing.

In the evening there was a crowd. Both seats were open. Sharda Devi sat on one, Sirchan Babu on the other.

Govind stood.

Sharda Devi's medicine was ready first. She got up.

This time she did not push the chair towards Govind. The seat was fixed to the wall.

She said only, "It is empty."

Govind looked at the crowd. A pregnant woman was standing near the medicine counter.

Govind gestured towards the seat with his hand.

The woman sat down.

Sharda Devi smiled.

"You did right."

At seven the crowd thinned a little. The pregnant woman had left. So had Sirchan Babu.

One seat was empty.

Govind sat.

Umesh Babu came outside and looked at the chalk line through the doorway. Old rainwater had erased half of it.

"Draw the chalk line again," he told Seema.

Then he looked at Govind.

"Keep an eye on the passage."

"I will," Govind said.

"And if the crowd grows?"

"We'll see what is needed."

Umesh Babu nodded and went back inside.

The old green chair now stood inside beside the blood-pressure machine. Its "For Customers" sign had been removed.

The two small holes left by the sign remained in the back of the chair.

After a few days, two dots of rust appeared around the holes.

On the wall by the doorway, the two folding seats kept opening and closing again and again through the day.

Sometimes a customer sat there. Sometimes Govind. Sometimes Seema, for two moments, to set down a carton of medicine. Sometimes a child waiting for his grandmother's medicine.

The question of whom the chair belonged to slowly became pointless.

In the evening, only this was looked at—who was tired, who was waiting, and whether the middle passage was clear.

The Fifth Bucket

It was the last week of Jeth. For three days, no water had come through the municipal tap.

The black tank on the roof of Sharda Sadan had fallen to less than half.

The building had four flats—two upstairs, two downstairs. Near the gate, behind the pump room, there was also a small room where the caretaker, Basudev, lived with his wife Sita and their twelve-year-old daughter Rupa.

On paper, that room was the “service room.”

It was a place to live, but in the count of residents it had no number.

At six in the morning, Basudev checked the motor switch, then opened the lid of the roof tank and peered inside.

“We’ll have to call for the tanker again today,” he said as he came down.

The water rule at Sharda Sadan had been made the previous summer. When the tank ran low, the taps of the four flats were opened for fixed periods. Twelve minutes for the first flat, twelve for the second, twelve for the third, twelve for the fourth.

Besides those four periods, one red bucket was allowed to be filled twice for washing the stairs, the entrance, and the common toilet.

Painted on the bucket in white were the words—“Common Work.”

Everyone called it the fifth bucket.

It belonged to no household.

It belonged to the building.

Basudev’s morning work was to fill that bucket, wash the entrance, wipe the dust from the stairs, pour water near the rubbish bin, and clean the common toilet.

Sita had said many times, “Why is the red so bright? From far away it looks as though the building’s water is in my hands.”

Basudev would laugh.

“Not ours. The work’s.”

He had given that answer so many times that little by little it had settled inside him too.

Each of the four flats had its own blue container for storing water. In Basudev’s room there was a small earthen pot and two old brass lotas.

On ordinary days, they fetched drinking and cooking water from the public tap in the lane.

That tap ran between five and six in the morning.

For three days, it too had been dry.

On the first day, Sita brought two pitchers from another lane.

On the second, she fetched water from the temple tap half a mile away.

On the third day, there was a queue at the temple tap too.

Rupa went carrying two small containers, but returned an hour and a half later empty-handed.

"The water ran out," she said.

Sita had half a lota of water left by the stove to wash the rice.

At that moment Basudev was wiping the entrance. The red bucket was half full.

Sita saw him from a distance.

"Give me two lotas from that."

Basudev stopped his hand.

"This is for the common work."

"Are our mouths less important than the common work?"

Basudev said nothing.

Sita herself went to the bucket. She filled two lotas. One she set aside for the rice, the other for Rupa to drink.

Just then Shashibhushan Babu saw them from the balcony of the second flat upstairs.

"Basudev!"

His voice was sharp.

Basudev looked up.

"Yes?"

"Why is the water from that red bucket going into your room?"

Sita stood still, the lota in her hand.

Shashibhushan Babu came down the stairs. In his hand was the small notebook in which the water account was kept.

"The rule is the same for everyone," he said. "The tank is low. What is meant for common cleaning must not go into a household."

Sita did not set the lota down.

"Is my home outside this building?"

"I didn't say that."

"Then where is water written for us?"

Shashibhushan Babu opened the notebook. There were four lines—Flat 1, Flat 2, Flat 3, Flat 4. Beneath them it said—Common work: two buckets.

Basudev too looked at the notebook.

His name was not on that page.

Nor Sita's.

Nor Rupa's.

But two buckets had been written down for Basudev's broom, mop, stairs and toilet.

Sita said quietly, "The water in my hands has been counted. My throat has not."

Shashibhushan Babu closed the notebook.

"Arguing won't make more water now. In the evening we'll all sit together and look at the account."

"The account is already here," Sita said. "Four homes, two buckets. Three bodies missing in between."

Carrying the lota, she went back toward the room.

With the water left in the red bucket, Basudev wiped half the entrance. He left the other half.

That day a thin layer of dust remained on the upper two steps of the staircase.

At noon the tanker came. The driver first asked for cash. The people in the four flats paid their shares. Basudev collected the money and gave it to the driver, held the pipe while the tank was filled, and shut the motor before it overflowed.

Rupa stood in the shade and watched.

The tank filled, but the rule did not change.

At seven that evening, the people from all four flats gathered in the small veranda by the entrance.

Shashibhushan Babu opened the notebook again.

"First understand this," he said. "The problem is that there is too little water. If we make rules out of emotion, there will be another quarrel."

Kiran Devi, who lived in the first downstairs flat, said, "Fine. But the count has to be complete."

"There are four flats."

"How many people?"

For a few moments, the question was followed by silence.

Eleven people lived in the four flats together.

Three lived behind the pump room.

Fourteen in all.

On paper, the water had four doors. In the building, there were fourteen bodies.

Naresh, from the fourth flat upstairs, said, "So now we divide it into fourteen shares? Children, old people, everyone equally?"

Kiran Devi said, "Before dividing anything, separate the work this time."

She pointed toward the red bucket.

“Whose two buckets are these?”

“For cleaning,” Shashibhushan Babu said.

“Whose body does the cleaning?”

“Basudev’s.”

“Then the building gives water to his labour, but not to his life?”

Basudev grew uncomfortable. Hearing so many words spoken on his behalf felt good to him, but heavy too.

He said, “I don’t want pity. I want a place in the rule.”

Sita stood at the doorway of the room.

“And the common cleaning must not stop either,” she said. “The dirt belongs to everyone.”

At that, everyone looked toward her.

Shashibhushan Babu opened the notebook again.

“Then what is the solution?”

Basudev had not thought it through beforehand. But while wiping only half the entrance that morning, one thing had become clear to him.

“Keep two accounts separate,” he said.

“Which two?”

“Water for bodies, and water for the building’s work.”

“Go on.”

“The minimum needed for drinking, cooking and essential washing should be according to the number of people. We three are included in that. Water for wiping the stairs, the common toilet, the drain—that is a separate share for the work. If there is a shortage, the water for the work can be reduced, not the count of people.”

Naresh said, “But if cleaning is reduced, the building will become dirty.”

Sita replied at once, “Instead of washing the whole veranda every day, sweep it daily and wipe it with water every other day. Don’t reduce the water for the toilet. Wash the drain only when needed.”

Kiran Devi added, “Treat washing the balconies as private work. No common water for that.”

Meera, from the third flat upstairs, said, “And washing cars is completely stopped for now.”

Naresh fell silent. The car was his.

Rupa had been listening from a corner of the doorway.

She went inside and brought out an old sheet of paper.

“Babu, shall I write everyone’s names?”

Basudev said, “Names aren’t necessary. Write the numbers.”

Rupa made two headings on the paper.

“Bodies.”

“Work.”

Under Bodies, she made fourteen little dots.
 Under Work, she made three lines—not drinking; common toilet;
 stairs/veranda; drain.
 Shashibhushan Babu laughed.
 “Drinking isn’t ‘work’?”
 Rupa said, “Drinking is under bodies.”
 For the first time, no one in the veranda laughed.
 Everyone kept looking at her sheet of paper.
 For the next half hour, they argued over quantities.
 How much was the minimum?
 Should cooking and drinking be counted separately or together?
 How much for an infant?
 When should clothes be washed?
 The cleaning of the toilet could not be reduced.
 The stairs did not have to be washed with water every day.
 In the end, the decision was not a perfect calculation.
 It was an order of priority.
 First, the minimum for drinking and cooking.
 After that, the common toilet.
 Then essential household use.
 Then the stairs and veranda.
 Washing cars, decorative washing of courtyards, hosing dust away—
 stopped on days of shortage.
 And most important of all—the three bodies behind the pump room were
 now part of the count.
 Shashibhushan Babu drew a straight line through the old page’s words
 “four flats.”
 Beneath it he wrote—“Residents: 14.”
 Then—“Common work: measured separately.”
 The red bucket would remain red.
 But its meaning had changed.
 The next morning Basudev filled the bucket.
 Rupa asked, “Is this still the fifth bucket?”
 Basudev said, “Yes. But not of a fifth household.”
 “Then whose?”
 “Of the work that belongs to everyone.”
 Rupa lifted her small drinking lota.
 “And this?”
 “Yours. Because you are in the count.”
 Rupa burst out laughing.
 “Fourteenth.”

“Yes, fourteenth.”

The public tap did not run that day either.

But Rupa did not go to the temple carrying empty containers.

The tank water had already been measured out. Sita washed the rice. Rupa drank. Basudev cleaned the common toilet.

The stairs were only swept.

At noon, one resident said, “No mopping today?”

Basudev said, “That is the order on shortage days.”

The man looked at the steps. There was dust, but no filth.

“All right.”

Two days later, the municipal tap ran for half an hour. The building breathed easier.

Then the question arose—now that the crisis was over, would the old rule return, or the new one?

Shashibhushan Babu said, “Now that the water has come, will fourteen bodies become twelve again?”

No one answered.

The old page was not torn out.

It remained in the register—four flats, two buckets.

On the next page—fourteen residents, common work separate.

The difference between those two pages was not only a difference in numbers.

The first page counted the building’s doors.

The second counted the bodies living between those doors.

When Sawan came, the tank began to stay full. The red bucket was spoken of less often.

But Rupa drew a small line beneath its white lettering.

“Common Work” was still written there.

Below the line, in pencil, she wrote—“The people who do the work are counted too.”

Basudev saw it.

“Who told you to write that?”

“No one.”

“What if they erase it?”

Rupa shrugged.

“Let them. It will still be in the register.”

In the evening light, the red bucket lay upside down in the corner of the staircase.

It was empty.

But because of that empty bucket, three bodies were no longer empty spaces on paper.

The Discarded Identity Card

When the evening siren sounded at the packing factory in the Sonbarsa industrial belt, Chanda Devi picked up her cloth bag from beneath her table.

That day the siren sounded a little different from other days.

Work ended at five as usual, but for Chanda and the twelve others with her, the contract itself was ending that evening.

For three months they had counted soap boxes, folded paper, tied cartons and placed them on trolleys.

After three months, the factory's colours, smells and sounds had settled into their bodies.

The identity card she had received at the gate on the first day bore Chanda's small photograph, her name, her worker number and a red stripe.

The red stripe meant—contract worker.

The permanent workers' cards had blue stripes.

At the midday meal break, the difference in colour did not seem to mean much.

At the gate, its meaning was clear.

At ten past five, Kailash, the contractor's clerk, began collecting the red identity cards one by one.

With a small metal punch, he made a round hole in the right-hand corner of each card.

The moment the hole was punched, the card was considered inactive.

The punched identity cards kept dropping into a blue box beside the exit room.

Chanda handed over her card.

Kailash punched it.

The card fell into the box.

Without meaning to, Chanda looked inside.

Thirteen small photographs lay one over another.

Some faces were upside down, some upright.

Kailash said, "Come to the accounts office tomorrow at eleven for your final wages."

Chanda asked, "What shall we show at the gate?"

Kailash laughed.

“Say your name. Everyone knows.”

Ramavatar, standing behind her, said, “But you’ve thrown the identity cards into the scrap box.”

“The cards became scrap, not the people,” Kailash said.

Someone laughed softly.

At the time, the remark passed like a joke.

The next day Chanda reached the gate at five minutes to eleven.

Ramavatar, Sahdev, Reshma, Pavitri and the others were with her.

Rahim Mian, the guard, was standing at the gate.

He recognised Chanda’s face.

For three months, the two had met at that same gate almost every day.

Chanda said, “We’ve been called to the accounts office for our final wages.”

Rahim Mian folded his hands and, with a trace of embarrassment, asked, “Identity card?”

Chanda smiled.

“Yesterday, right in front of you, it was punched and dropped into the box.”

Rahim Mian turned the pages of the register.

Against Chanda’s name, in red ink, was written—contract ended.

“I can’t let you in on the strength of this register,” he said.

Ramavatar grew irritated.

“We worked inside until yesterday, and today we can’t go in to collect our own wages?”

Rahim Mian kept his voice low.

“I didn’t make the rule. You need an active identity card or a visitor’s pass.”

Reshma said, “Then give us a visitor’s pass.”

“The person you are going to meet has to authorise it from inside.”

“The accounts office.”

Rahim Mian picked up the telephone.

He dialled the accounts office.

It rang three times.

No one answered.

He dialled again.

This time someone picked up.

Rahim Mian explained the situation.

He listened for a while.

Then he said, “All right, but authorisation by name for each person?”

An answer came from the other end.

Rahim Mian put down the telephone.

“The accounts office says: come with the contractor's clerk. He will identify you.”

Kailash had not yet arrived.

Chanda looked at the clock.

Twenty past eleven.

Final wages at the accounts office were to be paid from twelve.

Everyone stood in the small patch of shade outside the gate.

Meanwhile, permanent workers kept showing their identity cards and going in.

The gate opened as soon as a blue stripe appeared.

The people of the red stripe stood outside, but none of them had a red stripe in hand any longer.

At five minutes to twelve, Kailash arrived on a motorcycle.

He stopped when he saw the crowd.

“Why haven't you gone inside?”

Ramavatar replied, “Because you threw all our identities into the scrap box yesterday.”

Kailash looked a little uneasy.

He went over to Rahim Mian.

“These were all my workers.”

Rahim Mian said, “Were—that I know. But for today's entry, the register needs a basis.”

“I'm telling you.”

“And if you aren't here tomorrow?”

Kailash fell silent.

He wrote the names of all thirteen on a sheet of paper and signed it.

Rahim Mian went to the security officer's room.

He returned ten minutes later.

“For this once, you may go in as a group. But enter everyone's name in the gate register.”

All thirteen went inside.

Another queue formed outside the accounts office.

Naval Kishore, the accounts clerk, called the names one by one.

“Worker number?”

Chanda said, “317.”

“Identity card?”

Chanda looked at Naval Babu.

“It was punched and thrown into the scrap box.”

Naval Babu frowned.

“Without the number, it is difficult to find the record.”

“I just told you the number—317.”

“Any proof?”

Chanda held out her service letter recording the end of the contract.

It carried her name and the period of work, but not her worker number.

Naval Babu kept turning the pages of the register.

At last he found the name.

“Give your thumb impression.”

Chanda gave her impression.

Her wages were counted out.

She asked, “What if I hadn’t remembered my worker number?”

Naval Babu said, “Then I would have searched by name.”

“And if two people had the same name?”

Naval Babu paused.

“Then I would have asked the contractor.”

Chanda folded the service letter and put it into her bag.

“My identity card had the number on it.”

“Yes.”

“And that identity card was punched and thrown away yesterday.”

Naval Babu said nothing.

By one in the afternoon, not everyone had received their wages.

Two people’s names had been entered in the register with different spellings by mistake.

One worker number had been duplicated.

One woman, Kamli, did not remember her number.

Kailash went out for lunch.

Kamli’s wages remained on hold.

She sat on the veranda outside the accounts office, inside the gate.

At two, Kailash returned.

He identified Kamli.

She received her wages.

As they left through the gate, Rahim Mian wrote the time beside each name.

Chanda watched.

“A name is needed to enter, a name is needed to leave, a number is needed for wages,” she said, “but the paper that had both the name and the number was thrown away first.”

Rahim Mian did not laugh.

“The gate rule says—when the contract ends, the identity card becomes inactive.”

“The accounts office rule says—when the contract ends, come back for final wages.”

“Yes.”

“The two rules don’t speak to each other.”

Rahim Mian closed the register.

“That is true.”

Three weeks later, another contract ended.

This time there were twenty-four workers.

In the evening, when identity cards were being collected, Kailash again took out the punch.

But a new stack lay on Rahim Mian’s table at the gate.

Small slips of white paper.

At the top was printed—“Settlement Slip.”

Below were five boxes—worker number, name, contractor, date, accounts office.

On the right, in red letters, was written—“Gate to accounts office only; valid for one day; surrender on exit.”

Kailash took the first identity card.

He wrote the worker number on the slip.

He wrote the name.

He punched the identity card.

The punched card fell into the scrap box.

The slip went into the worker’s hand.

Rahim Mian entered the serial number of that slip in his gate register.

The next day the workers came to the gate.

None of them had an active identity card.

But no one had to depend on the guard’s memory to prove, “I was working here until yesterday.”

The slip carried the name.

It carried the worker number.

It stated the room they were to go to.

The time of entry was written at the gate.

At the accounts office, the slip was checked, the number matched with the register, the thumb impression taken, and the wages paid.

On the way out, the slip was surrendered at the gate.

At the end of the day, the collected slips and the settlement entries in the accounts register were matched against each other.

A few months later, Chanda was passing through the industrial belt on some other errand.

She saw the gate of the old factory.

The blue scrap box was still there.

A worker was handing his red identity card to Kailash.

There came the small sound of the punch.

Click.

The card fell into the box.
At once, a white settlement slip went into the worker's hand.
Chanda stopped and watched for a moment.
Rahim Mian recognised her.
He raised a hand from inside the gate.
Chanda raised hers too.
In the blue box, an old identity card could become scrap.
But the final dues attached to the work recorded on that card did not
become scrap.
The work could come to an end.
The accounting still had to be completed.

Half a Signature

The rains had withdrawn, but the roof of the town's old grain warehouse was still leaking.

The warehouse no longer stored grain; it was now a storehouse for the municipal council's tools and old tables and chairs.

A twenty-day contract had been awarded to repair that roof.

The contractor, Harihar Sah, had engaged twelve daily-wage labourers and four craftsmen.

Jagarnath the mason was one of the four.

He laid bricks, mixed lime, straightened the edges of tin sheets, and by evening scraped the mortar stuck to his palms with his fingernails before going home.

His wage was seven hundred and twenty rupees a day.

On Saturday evening, the accounts for all seven days were settled together.

An old table stood on the front veranda of the warehouse.

Cash lay on one side of the table, a thick register on the other, with a red stamp and neatly cut small slips between them.

The young man who distributed the money was named Nandu.

Nandu was the contractor's nephew and was only just learning the work of keeping accounts.

He called out names rapidly, turned the register around, pointed with a finger to the signature box, and counted out the money.

On the first Saturday Jagarnath wrote his full name: "Jagarnath Paswan."

On the second Saturday too.

On the third Saturday, when he reached the register, his finger stopped.

That week, work had been done on six of the seven days.

On one day, heavy rain had made it impossible to climb onto the roof.

Jagarnath had already added up his wages in his head.

For six days: four thousand three hundred and twenty rupees.

Nandu placed four thousand two hundred rupees on the table.

"Why is one hundred and twenty short?" Jagarnath asked.

Nandu looked at the register.

"Tool loss."

"Which tool?"

"It is written here."

"I can see what is written. Which tool?"

Nandu turned to the next page, then came back to the first.

"The deduction has come from above."

Jagarnath turned the register towards himself.

He was not a very fast reader.

He could read figures well.

He understood words connected with work too.

Small print took him time to read.

Opposite his name in the register, separate boxes had been filled for days, rate, total wages, deduction, and amount payable.

In the deduction box it said: "Tool loss 120."

At the end of that same line was an empty space for his signature.

"I bring my own tools from home," Jagarnath said.

"The contractor's ropes and hammers are issued to everyone," Nandu said.

"Did anything break in my hands?"

"I don't know. Sign first, then ask Harihar Babu."

The queue behind them was growing.

Someone was anxious to catch a bus.

Someone wanted to get to the market.

Someone was counting the money needed for medicine they had been told to buy at home.

"Jagarnath da, just sign," Sadanand called from behind. "I'm getting late too."

Jagarnath picked up the pen.

He began to write his name.

"Jag..."

He stopped there.

Nandu looked up.

"What happened?"

"Give me my slip first."

"You get the slip after taking the money."

"Does the slip show this one hundred and twenty?"

"It should."

"Not 'should'. Show me."

Nandu began searching through the small slips for his name.

He found Jagarnath's slip.

It showed six days, the rate, total wages, and amount payable.

Against deduction there was only "120".

There was no reason.

Jagarnath took the slip in his hand.
 "It does not say 'tool loss' here."
 Nandu grew a little irritated.
 "It's written in the register, isn't it?"
 "The register will stay with you. What will stay with me?"
 For a few moments, silence spread across the veranda.
 Jagarnath looked at the half-written name before him.
 The ink was drying.
 Nandu looked at it too.
 "What do we do with this?"
 "Nothing yet. I'll finish it after I understand what I'm signing."
 For the first time, Nandu did not laugh.
 He turned the register back towards himself.
 "Money cannot be paid against an incomplete signature."
 Jagarnath said quietly, "Then what is understood from a complete signature?"
 "That you received the money."
 "Only that?"
 "What else?"
 "Then why is my signature under the box for the deduction?"
 Nandu had no answer.
 He called the contractor, Harihar Sah.
 Harihar Sah was counting new tin sheets behind the roof.
 He came over, looked at the register, and saw Jagarnath's half-written name.
 "What new method is this?"
 Jagarnath held out the slip.
 "Explain to me which tool my one hundred and twenty rupees were deducted for."
 Harihar Sah looked at the register.
 "Two hammers went missing that day."
 "Which day?"
 "Tuesday."
 "On Tuesday I was on the roof all day. The hammers were with the team on the ground."
 "Then the loss must have been shared among everyone. There were twelve people; a little from each."
 Jagarnath looked at the register again.
 Sadanand's line also said "Tool loss 120".
 So did Paras's.

The same was written against Rehana, who worked mortar along the edge of the tin sheets.

Jagarnath asked, "How much did the two hammers cost?"

Harihar Sah said, "That account is separate."

"If you took one hundred and twenty from each of us, that is one thousand four hundred and forty from twelve people."

The people standing behind now began wanting to see their own lines in the register.

Nandu put his hand over it.

"Don't all bend over it at once."

Rehana said, "Give me my slip first."

Sadanand said, "Mine too."

The queue that ten minutes earlier had been impatient to hurry home now stopped around the table.

Harihar Sah's voice hardened.

"Everyone will get their money. Why so much argument over one register?"

Jagarnath said, "The argument is not over the register. It is over what is being accepted beneath my name."

Harihar Sah placed a finger on the half-written "Jag..."

"Finish it."

"Show me the full account first."

"You don't trust me?"

Jagarnath thought for a moment.

"A register is not made for trust. It is made so that even if trust breaks, the facts can still be seen."

At those words, Nandu looked fully at Jagarnath for the first time.

Harihar Sah pulled up a chair and sat down.

"All right. Two hammers were missing. The burden was divided among everyone."

Rehana asked, "Why should the burden fall on me for tools I never even touched?"

"They were the team's tools."

"Then were they counted out in front of the team?"

No answer came.

Jagarnath turned his slip over.

The back was blank.

He said to Nandu, "Write here: two hammers missing; one hundred and twenty charged to each of twelve workers."

Nandu looked at Harihar Sah.

Harihar Sah said, "There is no need to write so much."

"Then what is the need for my signature?" Jagarnath asked.

Silence again.

Just then Anamika Jha, a junior engineer with the municipal council, came onto the veranda.

She had come to record the evening measurement of the work.

Seeing the crowd, she asked, "Are wages being distributed, or is this a meeting?"

Harihar Sah tried to make the matter sound small.

"Nothing much. One worker is stuck over a deduction."

Anamika looked at the register.

"Is the reason for the deduction written?"

"It says tool loss."

"Is there a register showing whose responsibility the tools were, when they went missing, and what they cost?"

Harihar Sah's expression changed slightly.

"It will be in the warehouse account."

"And on the worker's slip?"

Nandu showed her Jagarnath's slip.

Anamika said, "There is no reason written here."

Harihar Sah said at once, "Engineer madam, this is an account between me and the workers."

Anamika replied evenly, "The account is yours. But I measure this work. From tomorrow, I can require the count of tools issued and returned to be written down before work begins as well."

She did not close the register.

She only looked at Jagarnath's half-signature.

"Why isn't this complete?"

Jagarnath said, "I am reading."

Anamika did not smile.

She only said, "Read it through."

Then she went to the back to take the work measurements.

Those two words remained on the veranda: "Read it through."

It was not the first time Jagarnath had been reading.

But it was the first time the time he needed to read had not been treated as smaller than the queue's delay, the owner's impatience, or the speed of paying wages.

Nandu took out all the workers' slips and laid them on the table.

On Jagarnath's slip the reason was written: "Tool loss - two hammers."

Jagarnath asked, "Cost?"

Harihar Sah said, "We'll look at the purchase receipt tomorrow."

"Then how can there be a deduction today?"

Harihar Sah closed his eyes and sat for a moment.

Then he said to Nandu, "Don't hold back this one hundred and twenty today. Pay the full wage. We'll examine the tool account separately."

Nandu counted out four thousand three hundred and twenty.

Jagarnath did not take the money into his hand.

First, the deduction box on the slip was struck through and a zero was written in it.

Nandu put his initials beside the correction.

Only then did Jagarnath turn the register towards himself.

The half-written "Jag..." was still there.

Nandu asked, "Shall you complete the name now?"

Jagarnath smiled a little.

"If I complete it after that half-name, it will look as though I wrote it all at once."

"Then?"

Anamika was returning in the distance.

Jagarnath said, "Beside the unfinished part, write small: 'Stopped while reading the account.' Then I'll sign in full in a new box."

Harihar Sah said at once, "That will spoil the register."

For the first time, Nandu did not obey him.

In small letters beside it he wrote: "First entry incomplete; signature after correction of the entry."

He added the date.

Harihar Sah watched.

Jagarnath wrote his full name in the next empty space.

This time, slowly.

"Jagarnath Paswan."

Then he counted the money.

Rehana read her slip.

Sadanand read his.

Paras, who could not read, said to Nandu, "Read my slip aloud to me."

Nandu read it.

First the name.

Then the days.

Then the rate.

Then the total wages.

Then the deduction.

Then the amount payable.

That evening, for the first time, distributing the wages took half an hour longer.

Someone missed a bus.

Sadanand grumbled.

But by the next Saturday, things had changed a little.
The slips were placed on the table before the money.
On every slip, if the deduction box was empty, a "o" had been written in it.
Where there was a deduction, the reason was written somewhat more clearly, not in just two words.

"Advance - 500, dated..."

"Absent days - 1."

"Tool loss" appeared on no one's line.

A separate small register had been started for the warehouse tools.

In the morning, whichever team took ropes, hammers, chisels, or a ladder had the count recorded.

In the evening, the count was taken again when the tools were returned.

A week later, a chisel really did go missing.

This time Harihar Sah did not immediately order a deduction from wages.

First the tool register was checked.

The chisel had been issued in the name of another team.

The next day it was found in the earth beside a drain.

Nandu laughed and said, "If we'd deducted as before, would it have been one hundred and twenty from everyone again?"

Harihar Sah stared at him.

Then he himself burst out laughing.

"Keep quiet."

On the nineteenth day of the job, the final edge of the roof was being secured.

Jagarnath had an old chisel in his hand.

The number 7 had been painted in white on its handle.

That evening Nandu wrote in the tool register: "7 returned."

Jagarnath said, "See? Now even the tool has a name of its own."

Nandu said, "Because of you, I've ended up with two extra registers."

"Not because of me. What used to be wrongly mixed together in one register can now be seen separately."

On the twentieth day, the final wages were distributed.

The table on the veranda was still the same.

So was the red stamp.

But a new rule had been posted on a sheet of paper:

"Read or have the slip read to you first. Understand the reason for any deduction. Only then take the wages and give your signature or thumbprint."

Paras could not read the whole notice.

He had Jagarnath read it to him.

Then he said, "Why wasn't this the rule before?"

Jagarnath did not answer.

He looked at the register.

The page from the third week was still in the middle of it.

The unfinished "Jag..." looked like a small ink stain.

Beside it was Nandu's brief note.

That page had not been torn out.

The ink had not been erased.

There had also been a proposal to start a new register, but Nandu had refused.

"This page will stay," he had said. "Otherwise it will look as though the rule had always been like this."

Jagarnath said nothing to that.

He folded his final slip and put it in the inside pocket of his kurta.

He took the full wages in his hand.

He wrote his full name.

As he went out through the gate, he touched his pocket once.

The slip was inside.

The name was complete.

But what remained with him most strongly was the half-written name.

Because sometimes the right to write the whole truth begins at the point where a person can stop in time.

The Locked Chest

On the western side of the district bus stand stood a small room, on whose door faded blue letters read—Lost Property.

Inside the door were two iron cupboards, a table, three sacks and an old wooden chest. Iron bands ran across the top of the chest, and there were two locks on it.

Throughout the year, whatever was found on a bus, in the waiting hall, near the ticket window or around the tea stalls was first entered in the register and then placed in a cupboard or in the chest.

Malti had not been given a key to the chest.

She was a temporary assistant. On paper, her work was to wipe the objects clean, tie serial-number slips to them, lift the sacks, and place the articles on the table when the committee sat.

The key remained with Ramanath, the permanent clerk.

Malti had no key, but she remembered the faces of the objects.

She knew where the umbrella with the red handle had been found. She remembered under which bus the child's single shoe with the yellow strap had lain. She even remembered the small name scratched on the lunchbox with the broken handle.

Sometimes Ramanath would laugh and say, "There is more stuff in your head than in the chest."

Malti would reply, "The chest stays shut. The head stays open."

In the last week of Paush came the day for preparing the year-end inventory.

Since morning, a thin strip of sunlight had fallen outside the room. The table was pulled out for the committee. Devkinandan came from the accounts office. Harishankar, the store assistant, came. Chandramohan, the stand in-charge, sat down with his thick register.

Ramanath opened the first lock.

The second lock stuck a little. Malti brought a small bottle of oil. After two drops, the key turned.

The lid rose.

The smell of old cloth, iron rust and damp shut-in paper came out all at once.

Chandramohan said, "Make a list of the things whose time has expired. Keep what can be sold separate from what is useless."

Devkinandan straightened his sheet of paper.

"Call out the serial numbers."

Ramanath lifted the objects one by one.

One hundred twenty-seven—blue umbrella, three ribs broken.

One hundred twenty-eight—old sweater, left sleeve torn.

One hundred twenty-nine—steel lunchbox, without lid.

One hundred thirty—child's white shoe, only one.

Devkinandan kept making three columns—sale, donation, scrap.

Malti cut slips and placed them with the objects.

After a while Ramanath lifted a grimy cloth bag from the bottom of the chest.

The bag was heavy.

As soon as it was placed on the table, iron clinked inside.

"One hundred forty-one," Ramanath read. "Found under the rear seat of bus number thirty-two. Date—eight months ago."

Harishankar opened the knot.

Inside were a mason's trowel, a small hammer, a plumb line, two chisels, an iron measuring tape and a thin wooden strip.

"Tools," Devkinandan said. "For sale."

Malti reached to lift the bag, but at that moment a small piece of paper slipped from an inner fold of the cloth.

Ramanath picked it up.

It was an old identity card. The edges were worn, the photograph faded. At the top was the name of a construction contractor. Below was the worker's name—Ramvriksh Sada.

On the back, a village address had been written in blue ink.

Devkinandan looked at the identity card and pointed towards the pile of tools.

"The card is expired. Look at the date. Three years old."

Malti asked, "The card is old; should we assume the address is old too?"

Devkinandan said, "The rule applies to the article. Eight months have passed. The owner did not come."

Malti left the bag of tools on the table.

"How much is the card worth?"

"Worth?"

"At auction."

Devkinandan laughed. "What value can a piece of paper have?"

Malti picked up the trowel. Its edge was worn, but the handle was smooth.
“And this?”

Harishankar said, “It is iron. It will fetch something.”

Malti said quietly, “The paper may have no selling value. But it may have value in getting the things back.”

For a few moments there was silence at the table.

Chandramohan said, “We have not sat here to change the rules. Continue the inventory.”

The work resumed.

One hundred forty-two—wooden toy.

One hundred forty-three—old spectacle case.

One hundred forty-four—half a notebook, no name.

Malti’s eyes kept returning to the bag of tools.

Tea came at noon. The committee moved back from the table for a while.

Malti was dusting the inside of the chest. At the bottom she found a small photograph stuck there.

There were five people in the photograph. No names. On the back were only the words: “Sawan, first day of work on the bridge.”

She gave the photograph to Ramanath.

Ramanath asked, “Which serial number does this belong to?”

They could not tell. It had probably fallen from some paper or wallet.

Devkinandan said, “Scrap.”

For the first time Malti spoke sharply. “Sell the photograph?”

“Not sell it. Throw it away.”

“Why?”

“No owner. No value. No identification.”

Malti looked at the five faces in the photograph.

“No identification—that is true. But does that make it only paper?”

Chandramohan looked at her.

“Malti, your job is to help with the inventory.”

“I am helping.”

She placed the photograph at one corner of the table.

By afternoon the committee had made three piles.

Articles fit for sale.

Clothes fit for donation.

Scrap.

The bag of tools was in the first pile.

The old identity card was at the edge of the scrap pile.

The photograph was there too.

For two minutes Malti stood looking at the two piles.

Then she picked up the identity card and placed it on top of the bag of tools.

Devkinandan said at once, "Why are you separating it?"

"These two were found together."

"So?"

"So until we are certain the card is useless, the owner of the tools is not unknown."

Devkinandan tapped his pen on the paper.

"No one came in eight months."

Malti asked, "Did anyone send word?"

No answer came.

Ramanath turned the pages of the register. He found the entry for serial number 141.

"Found—bus thirty-two, rear seat. Bag. Tools inside. That is all."

"The paper was not recorded?" Malti asked.

"It may not have been noticed then."

"The address was not recorded?"

"No."

Malti read the address on the back of the identity card. The village was thirty or thirty-five kos from the bus stand, but bus number thirty-two went in that direction.

Ramanath understood it too.

He said, "Narayan, the old conductor on number thirty-two, is still on the same route."

Chandramohan grew a little uneasy.

"I cannot put bus employees to a private search."

Malti said, "Not a private search. One notice can be sent by post."

Devkinandan laughed. "And under which account will the postage be paid?"

This time Ramanath spoke.

"The lost-property branch has a postage account."

Devkinandan fell silent.

Chandramohan ran a finger along the empty margin of the register.

"All right. One notice. We will not hold up the sale list because of this. Keep the bag's serial number separate. Seven days."

Malti said nothing.

She merely lifted the bag of tools from the sale pile and placed it under the table.

The photograph was still at the edge of the scrap pile.

Malti did not pick it up.

She knew that not every object could be returned.

By evening the inventory was complete.

Lines were drawn on the table sheet—article, status, route of disposal.

In the first line Devkinandan wrote—sale/donation.

In the second Ramanath added—identifiable paper/address clue: notice first.

Malti asked what the third line would be called.

Chandramohan said, “Scrap.”

Malti looked towards the photograph.

“Not all scrap is the same.”

“Then what should we write?”

Malti thought for a moment.

“Personal tokens—not for sale.”

Devkinandan frowned.

“Photographs, letters, private papers?”

“Yes. When their time is over, whatever the rule says may be done. But not in the auction pile.”

Chandramohan did not approve it at once.

He said, “We need written orders from above for that.”

Malti nodded.

“Then for now write—decision pending.”

Ramanath wrote those words in the register.

Three days later the letter was sent.

On the sixth day no one came.

On the seventh afternoon bus number thirty-two entered the stand.

Malti was outside gathering the sacks.

A thin man got down from the bus. A gamchha lay over his shoulder and there was mud on his feet. He did not go straight to the lost-property room. He first made inquiries at the information desk.

A little later Ramanath brought him over.

“Name?”

“Ramvriksh Sada.”

“What was in the bag?”

Without pausing to think, Ramvriksh said, “One trowel, a small hammer, two chisels, a plumb line, a tape, a thin strip. Red thread was tied below the hammer handle. Two nails are driven into the trowel handle.”

Ramanath opened the bag.

There really was a fine knot of red thread below the hammer handle.

There were two nails in the trowel handle.

Chandramohan showed him the identity card.

Ramvriksh did not smile.

He held the card in his hand and looked at it for a long time.

“This is from an old job,” he said. “The contract has changed now.”

“The address?”

“The village is the same.”

“Why did you not come for eight months?”

Ramvriksh’s face tightened a little.

“I did not think I had left it on the bus. I thought it had stayed at the building where I was working. I searched twice. Then I borrowed new tools and took another job. I paid more in interest on that loan than the price of this bag.”

Malti remained silent.

Chandramohan carried out the formal verification: name, address, description of the bag.

Ramvriksh gave his thumb impression.

The bag went into his hands.

He took the identity card as well.

As he was leaving, he asked Malti, “Did you send the letter?”

Malti said, “It went from the bus stand.”

Ramvriksh asked nothing more.

He pressed the handle of the trowel, as though checking an old companion.

Then he disappeared into the crowd at the bus stand.

That evening Chandramohan called Ramanath.

“Make a new set of categories.”

Ramanath asked, “Three?”

“Three.”

First—ordinary articles: after the prescribed period, sale, donation or disposal according to the rules.

Second—articles with identifiable papers or address clues: make a reasonable attempt to return them before disposal.

Third—private letters, photographs or such personal tokens as should not be turned into market goods: keep separately in a sealed envelope; decision according to written rules.

Malti was listening.

She asked, “Why are the tools in the second category?”

Chandramohan said, “Not because they are tools. Because of the address clue.”

Malti nodded.

“Right.”

That small “right” mattered.

For she did not want pity to take the place of a rule.

If some tools were found tomorrow without a name or address, they could not be held forever merely because their owner might be poor.

But if a clue for returning something lay inside the chest, looking at that clue ought to be part of the work.

A week later a reply came from above. The instruction was approved that private identity papers and personal photographs should not be put in the ordinary auction pile; a separate method of disposal would be written.

Ramanath opened a new disposal register.

On the first page he wrote three headings.

That day Malti wiped the inside of the chest again.

The chest was almost empty.

Only a child's single shoe remained in one corner.

No name. No address. No mate.

Malti took it in her hand.

After a few moments she put it back in the chest.

Its fate too would be decided on the next disposal day.

Not every object could be saved.

Nor was it necessary that every object be sold.

The difference was not only one of value.

The difference was whether an object still showed a road by which it might reach someone.

In the evening Ramanath closed the lid of the chest.

The first lock clicked shut.

The second lock clicked shut.

From outside Malti looked at the faded blue words—Lost Property.

It seemed to her that the chest had been closed before and was still closed now.

But between its inside and the world outside, a new line had opened.

Light for Rent

As evening fell, a night market sprang up opposite the town's old grain warehouse.

By day there were trucks and sacks there; after five in the evening came folding iron carts, cloth awnings, bamboo poles and coils of wire.

The market ran until eleven at night.

The municipal council had installed four bright lamps along the passage through the middle of the market.

There were also small individual electricity connection points for the carts.

Any vendor who used a lamp, fan or other small appliance on a cart had to pay the same electricity charge night after night.

The amount was not very large.

But it was the same.

For the past two months, that word—"same"—had been troubling Saroja Devi.

Her cart sold glass bangles, inexpensive earrings, combs, ribbons and hair ties for girls.

She reached the market at half past six in the evening, because she could come only after finishing the day's work at home.

Her cart had just one nine-watt bulb.

After ten, when customers thinned out, she switched it off and packed her goods by the light from the central passage.

Beside her, Naseem's tea cart operated from five until eleven.

He needed two bulbs, a fan and a small electric water-heating appliance.

On the other side, coloured string lights glowed on Lalan Sah's toy cart from evening until closing.

All three carts paid the same nightly electricity charge.

At first Saroja said nothing about it.

She thought—the amount is small; why invite trouble?

But in the last week of Bhadau, the council posted a new rate.

The old twelve rupees became eighteen rupees a night.

The notice gave the reason as: "Increase in electricity tariff and maintenance costs."

Bhola, the market watchman, read the notice aloud.
 Naseem said, "Eighteen is fine. The fan runs, the lights run."
 Lalan Sah said, "Fine for me too."
 Saroja asked, "Why is it fine for me too?"
 Bhola laughed.
 "Doesn't your bulb run on electricity?"
 "It does."
 "Then the charge is for electricity too."
 Saroja did not reply.
 That night she made a new line at the back of her old account book.
 "Light switched on—6:42."
 At five minutes past ten she wrote: "Light switched off—10:05."
 The next night she wrote it again.
 And the third night too.
 She was not preparing any learned calculation.
 She was merely putting down on paper what her own eyes had seen.
 After eight nights, the lines had filled a page.
 Sometimes three hours and twenty minutes.
 Sometimes two hours and fifty-five minutes.
 One rainy night no customers came, and the bulb burned for only an hour.
 Yet on all eight nights she paid eighteen rupees each time.
 On the ninth night, Saroja showed the book to Bhola when he came to collect the electricity charge.
 Bhola laughed at first.
 "Who's going to count all these minutes?"
 Saroja said, "I am counting them."
 "The council doesn't calculate by the minute."
 "I'm not making the council's bill. I'm asking—why should a bulb that burned for three hours and one that burned for six cost the same?"
 Bhola kept the register tucked under his arm.
 "That's the rule."
 "And the reason for the rule?"
 Bhola pointed at the board again.
 "Electricity tariff and maintenance."
 Saroja said, "Two things are written there. Electricity is one thing, maintenance another. Shouldn't their accounts be separate too?"
 Bhola had no answer to that question.
 He entered eighteen in the register, took the money and moved on.
 The matter might have ended there.
 But the next night Naseem asked to see Saroja's notebook.
 "Let me see. Do you really write down the minutes?"

Saroja handed it to him.
 Naseem turned the pages.
 “Mine never runs for less than six hours.”
 Lalan Sah overheard.
 “Then you should pay more.”
 Naseem laughed.
 “If I pay more, do your coloured lights get to shine for free?”
 Lalan Sah’s face tightened.
 Saroja said at once, “I’m not asking to increase anyone’s payment.”
 “Then what?”
 “I want to understand how eighteen is arrived at.”
 Questions like that spread quickly through a market.
 Within two days someone had decided that electricity would now be counted minute by minute.
 Someone said, “Saroja Devi will put a clock on every cart.”
 Someone said, “Customers will run away while we’re busy switching lights off.”
 Someone said, “Anyone with a fan will pay double.”
 Saroja argued with none of them.
 She kept writing down only the use of her own bulb.
 Three days later the market supervisor, Raghunath Mishra, summoned her.
 Raghunath Mishra was a man of sixty.
 He had overseen the market’s arrangements since its first year.
 Half the market called him “Mishraji”; the other half simply “Babu”.
 He placed Saroja’s notebook on the table and asked, “Are you the one spreading this?”
 Saroja said, “I wrote the notebook. I did not spread the rumours.”
 Raghunath Mishra had also called Naseem and Lalan Sah.
 Naseem sat half on a chair; Lalan stood.
 Raghunath Mishra said, “Look, maintaining connection points, replacing wires, repairing broken lights, the main panel, the safety breakers—all of that costs money. It isn’t only your nine-watt bulb.”
 Saroja nodded.
 “I’m not objecting to any of that.”
 “Then what is the problem?”
 “How much of the cost is for all that, and how much is for the electricity I actually use—why are both in the same line?”
 Raghunath Mishra was silent for a moment.
 Lalan Sah said, “By that logic, customers see my coloured lights and the whole market benefits from the brightness. Others benefit too.”

Naseem replied at once, "And customers who drink my tea and water linger at other carts too."

Raghunath Mishra raised a hand.

"Don't turn the market into a village council."

Saroja smiled.

"Can an account be made without one?"

Raghunath Mishra looked at her, then opened the notebook.

"What do you want?"

Saroja did not answer at once.

"I'm not asking for a charge by the minute."

Naseem looked startled.

"Then why did you write all this down?"

"So it can be seen that the usage is not the same."

"Then?"

"First see what all is included in this one equal charge."

Raghunath Mishra leaned back against the chair.

The discussion did not end that day, but for the first time eighteen rupees ceased to be a complete truth.

The next evening Chhotan Jha, the council electrician, came to the market.

People in the market saw him connecting wires often; they rarely heard him talk about accounts.

Raghunath Mishra called him to the table and asked, "What is inside this eighteen rupees?"

Chhotan Jha said, "I don't know the rate. I look after the wiring."

"Then tell us the cost of the wiring."

Chhotan Jha laughed.

"You can't count the cost of the wire by the night."

"Why not?"

"The main cable was installed once. There is one panel. The safety breaker watches the total load. A bulb burning for three hours does not make the wire three hours old."

Saroja said, "That is why I say the two things are different."

Chhotan Jha looked at her.

Raghunath Mishra explained the whole matter.

After thinking a little, Chhotan Jha said, "Without individual meters, measuring exact units is difficult."

Lalan Sah said, "Install them."

Chhotan Jha laughed.

"When you hear the price of an individual meter, you'll sell your coloured lights."

A few people laughed.

Saroja did not.

She asked, "Then only by the hour?"

"Hours still don't give the full account. Nine watts and sixty watts are not the same. A fan is different. A water heater is different."

Naseem looked toward his cart.

"Then mine is much more?"

Chhotan Jha said, "Your electricity consumption is higher. But the cable, panel and repairs are shared by everyone."

Raghunath Mishra tapped a finger on the table.

"Then calculating eighteen is not merely difficult; it is impossible."

Chhotan Jha said, "Exact calculation is expensive. Fair calculation is a different matter."

It was hard to tell whether Raghunath Mishra disliked that sentence or liked it very much.

He said, "Tomorrow, make a sample from ten carts."

Ten carts were chosen.

Saroja's one bulb.

Naseem's two bulbs, fan and water heater.

Lalan's three strings of coloured lights.

Two clothing carts with two bulbs each.

A fruit seller who used only the light from the central passage.

A toy repairer who ran a small fan.

A spice cart that switched its light off at nine.

A cobbler who lit an extra lamp when he had a customer.

And a sweets cart whose lighting was very bright.

Chhotan Jha noted the rated load of the appliances.

Saroja supplied her record of times.

For two nights Bhola made the rounds every half hour to see which lights were on.

On the third night Bhola grew irritated.

"Am I supposed to guard the market or count bulbs?"

Raghunath Mishra said, "That is exactly why this is an experiment."

On the fourth night it rained.

Half the market remained empty.

Naseem's fan did not run.

Lalan lit only half his coloured lights.

Saroja switched her bulb off at eight.

But all four lamps in the central passage burned the whole night.

The market's main safety lights could not be switched off.

The fifth night was very crowded.

The sweets seller added an extra light.
Naseem repeatedly ran the water-heating appliance.
At 8:40 p.m. the main safety breaker tripped.
The entire market went dark at once.
For a few moments only the glow of mobile phones flickered.
Lalan Sah shouted, "There is a child with my customer—nobody move a cart!"

Chhotan Jha ran to the panel.
Five minutes later the lights in the central passage came back on.
The cart connections were restored gradually.
This time Chhotan Jha stopped Naseem's water heater.
"The load limit was exceeded."
Naseem said, "I pay for it."
Chhotan Jha replied, "You pay, but the capacity of the wire does not increase when it sees your money."

That night Saroja wrote a new word beside the time in her notebook: "Blackout—8:40 to 8:45."

The next day they prepared a sample calculation.
The first proposal was: the more hours connected, the more the charge.
Chhotan Jha rejected it.
"The load differs."

The second proposal was: appliance load multiplied by time.
Raghunath Mishra rejected it.
"We would need a separate person just to keep this account."
The third proposal was the old method: the same charge for everyone.
Saroja closed the notebook.

"Then were these five nights of work useless?"
Raghunath Mishra said, "Not useless. We learned at least this much: precision can itself become an expense."

Naseem said, "Then a middle path?"
Instead of answering, Raghunath Mishra looked toward Saroja.
"You started this. Now you tell us."
Saroja closed the notebook and placed it on the table.
"I don't want an account by the minute."
Lalan Sah said, "You said that before too."

"Yes. Now I understand why."
Chhotan Jha pulled his chair closer.
Saroja said, "The problem isn't whether eighteen is too little or too much. The problem is that even if I don't switch on my bulb, I still have to pay for a private connection."

Raghunath Mishra raised an eyebrow.

“And the central lighting?”

“That belongs to everyone. Let everyone pay for it. But charge me for my cart’s connection only when I take it.”

Silence fell around the table.

Naseem said slowly, “Then everyone who takes a connection pays the same?”

Saroja said, “Up to a fixed limit. If you cross the limit, the connection should not run at all.”

Chhotan Jha lifted his head at once.

“That makes sense.”

Naseem asked, “And my water-heating appliance?”

Chhotan Jha looked at him.

“It is too heavy for the market’s ordinary connection. Paying more does not make the wire thicker.”

Naseem seemed about to say something, then fell silent.

Raghunath Mishra said, “Then that appliance is banned?”

Chhotan Jha said, “Banned on the market connection. You already use gas for making tea.”

Naseem made a face.

“The electric appliance was convenient.”

Saroja said, “Convenience and entitlement are not the same thing.”

Naseem looked at her for a moment, then laughed.

“Today you are making a great many rules.”

“I’m not making rules. I’m looking at limits.”

Chhotan Jha pulled a sheet of paper toward him.

The market’s electrical panel had a separate small breaker for each cart connection.

Until then, all the breakers had been switched on together at five in the evening.

Chhotan Jha said, “There is no need to switch all of them on. Open only the breaker for a vendor who wants a private connection.”

Bhola asked, “Am I supposed to stand beside the panel all day?”

“Switch it on once and turn it off at closing.”

“What if someone wants a connection midway through the evening?”

“Enter it in the register, then switch it on.”

Raghunath Mishra said, “And the payment?”

Chhotan Jha replied, “If someone takes a private connection, charge the private-connection fee. If not, no fee.”

“Whether it is used for three hours or six?”

“Within that limit, the same. We are not metering units; we are making a safe connection available.”

Saroja nodded slowly.

She did not see perfect justice in that answer.

But for the first time the thing she was paying for had a clear name.

Raghunath Mishra said, "And the four lamps in the middle?"

"They are not private connections. Put their cost under the market's common arrangements."

The fruit seller, who had been standing behind them listening to the meeting, said at once, "Then I won't pay the private electricity charge?"

"Not if you do not take a connection on your own cart."

He was delighted.

Lalan Sah asked, "Can I connect all three strings of coloured lights?"

Chhotan Jha said, "As long as they remain within the prescribed limit. Cross it and the safety breaker will trip by itself."

Lalan Sah asked, "How will I know the limit?"

"Register the name and load of the appliance beforehand. Ask before adding a new appliance."

Naseem looked again at his appliance.

"Will mine be written down as prohibited?"

Chhotan Jha said, "Not on the market's ordinary line. It is not an insult; it is the limit of the wire."

This time Naseem did not argue.

The next problem was trust.

What if someone did not pay for a private connection and quietly attached a wire anyway?

Bhola said, "There are fifty carts at night. Are we supposed to keep inspecting every wire?"

Chhotan Jha opened the panel.

"If the breaker for a number is off, that cart's connection is dead. Attaching a wire will do nothing."

Bhola asked, "What if someone switches the breaker on himself?"

"The panel is locked."

Raghunath Mishra tapped a finger on the table.

"Then the register will record who takes a private connection, not their minutes."

Saroja said, "Yes."

"And the cost of the common lighting?"

"Write it separately. Show it to everyone."

Raghunath Mishra smiled.

"Your notebook has made my register longer."

Saroja said, "If the lines increase, the arguments will decrease."

Chhotan Jha laughed.

The new arrangement could not be put into effect in a single day.

First, the numbers on the main panel had to be matched with the cart numbers.

Three connections turned out to be crossed.

When the breaker for cart seventeen was opened, electricity reached cart eighteen.

Bhola said, "Until now we switched them all on together, so no one ever noticed."

Chhotan Jha checked the wiring for two evenings.

Then each connection point received a small number plate.

The register got two separate columns: "Common Market" and "Private Connection".

The charge for common market lighting appeared as a separate line on the cart-rent receipt.

The names of those taking private connections were entered in the nightly register.

The time at which a breaker was switched on was also recorded, but the charge was not calculated by the minute.

The time was written only to show that the connection had actually been opened.

On the first trial night Saroja did not take a private connection.

She moved her cart a little closer to one of the lamps in the central passage.

The light was not quite sufficient.

Green bangles showed clearly, but deep blue and black looked almost alike.

A customer asked for blue bangles and picked up black ones.

Saroja smiled.

"Wait. Today I don't have my own light."

She carried the bangles beneath the central light.

The customer chose the correct colour.

By the end of the evening Saroja understood that a private connection was not merely a luxury.

The second night she went to Bhola.

"Cart fourteen—switch on the connection."

Bhola entered it in the register.

He unlocked the panel.

He raised breaker number fourteen.

Saroja's bulb came on.

That night she paid the full private-connection charge.

On the third night it rained.

Half the market remained empty.

Saroja did not take a private connection.

The fourth night was crowded with customers.
 She took the connection.
 On the fifth night, work at home delayed her and she arrived at eight.
 She asked Bhola, "Even now, the full charge?"
 Bhola said, "Yes. The connection is charged for being available for the night, not by the hour."
 Saroja made a face.
 "Then injustice again?"
 Bhola laughed.
 "Take out your notebook."
 Saroja laughed too.
 She did not take the connection.
 She worked for an hour and a half under the common light and went home.
 Because that choice now existed, some vendors changed their old habits.
 The fruit seller had never taken a private connection; now the electricity charge disappeared from his receipt.
 A bookseller began taking a connection only on Saturdays and Sundays, when the crowd was larger.
 Lalan Sah took one every day because the coloured lights were part of his cart's identity.
 Naseem also took one every day, but the electric water heater was gone.
 He went back to using a small gas stove.
 The first week he grumbled about it.
 The second week he said, "At least the breaker doesn't trip now."
 Chhotan Jha replied, "That too is part of the account."
 In the middle of the month a new difficulty appeared.
 On days when they did not take a connection, some people began drawing a thin wire from a neighbour's connection.
 Raghunath Mishra was annoyed.
 Saroja said, "There is an empty space in the rule."
 "What are we supposed to do—guard every cart?"
 Chhotan Jha said, "If sharing is completely banned, even helping a neighbour becomes an offence."
 Naseem said, "Then allow shared connections."
 Lalan Sah asked, "Who pays?"
 Saroja replied, "Whoever's numbered breaker is switched on."
 "Whether the other person pays half is between the two of them."
 Raghunath Mishra thought about it.
 "But the load limit?"

Chhotan Jha said, "The limit on one connection remains the same. If two carts share it, they must stay within that same limit."

A line was added to the new rule: one private connection may be shared with a neighbouring cart, but the safety limit must not be exceeded, and responsibility remains with the original connection holder.

That led some vendors to pair up.

Saroja did not make such a pair.

Sometimes she needed her own bulb; sometimes she did not.

At the end of the month Raghunath Mishra spread all the registers on the table.

There had been fewer nights with private connections than before.

Total private electricity consumption had also fallen.

But that was not the main thing.

For the first time the council receipt had two separate lines: common market lighting and private cart connection.

Raghunath Mishra said, "The total of the two lines is not very far from the old average."

Saroja asked, "Then the council has not suffered a loss?"

"Not yet. We will look again after three months."

"And if there is a loss?"

"The rate will change, but the reasons will remain separately visible."

Naseem asked, "I take a connection every day. I still pay more than Saroja."

Saroja said, "You take it on more nights."

"But on one night I use it for six hours; sometimes you use yours for three."

Saroja fell silent.

That question had not been settled.

She said, "Yes. That difference still remains."

Raghunath Mishra said, "Without individual meters, an exact account of it is difficult."

Naseem smiled.

"Then Saroja Devi has won only half a victory?"

Saroja laughed.

"Was I fighting a war?"

"You wrote down minutes for eight nights."

"The minutes showed me that usage was not equal. But that does not mean justice exists only in a clock."

Chhotan Jha said, "And justice for the wire?"

Saroja said, "You look after that."

The meeting ended in laughter.

That night Saroja opened her old notebook.

The first eight pages were filled with switch-on and switch-off times.

On the pages after that, some days said “connection taken” and some “not taken”.

On the last line she wrote: “Minutes opened the question; choice opened the way.”

Then she paused.

She crossed out the word “way” and wrote “space”.

She did not like grand sentences.

She put the notebook back in her bag.

At half past six in the evening the market was opening.

All four lamps in the central passage were already lit.

Saroja went to Bhola.

“Switch on fourteen today.”

Bhola entered her name in the register.

He opened the panel and raised breaker number fourteen.

Saroja’s bulb came on.

Light fell across the bangles.

Beside her, the fruit seller arranged his cart without a private connection.

Naseem’s light was on, and so was the small blue flame of his gas stove.

Lalan’s coloured string lights still shone brighter than everything else.

No one was counting anyone else’s minutes.

At 10:15 p.m., Saroja saw no customers.

She switched off the bulb.

Bhola did not turn off the panel then; under the rule, all breakers would be switched off at the end of the night.

As she tied up her bag, Saroja thought for a moment that even today she would pay for a five-hour private connection though her bulb had burned for less than four hours.

It did not seem perfectly equal to her.

But if tomorrow she did not want a private connection, she would not have to pay for one.

It was a small difference.

For now, it was enough for her.

When the market was closing, Bhola was locking the panel.

Saroja watched from a distance.

Earlier, every numbered connection had been switched on together.

Now some were on and some remained off.

The four lamps in the middle still burned the same for everyone.

Private light was now rented, but at least it had its own door.

The Small Lock

On the eastern side of the town stood a five-storey building called “Madhavi Apartments.”

The building was not very new, but neither was it so old that the paint on its walls had forgotten its first colour.

The main gate gleamed.

The mirror inside the lift was wiped twice a day.

To the right of the gate was a small glass-doored room for keeping parcels and deliveries.

To the left was the service entrance, through which domestic workers, the milkman, the waste collector, and repair workers went inside.

Just inside the service entrance, twelve small iron lockers were fixed along the wall.

Each locker stood a little above knee height.

Numbers had been painted above them in white—1 through 12.

The women who worked in the flats kept their small belongings in those lockers.

Someone’s old slippers.

Someone’s raincoat.

Someone’s spare scarf.

Someone’s tea leaves.

Someone’s house key.

Someone’s wages for the day.

Someone’s child’s school notice.

The building had installed those lockers two years earlier.

Before that, the women used to leave their bags in a corner of the staircase or beneath the guard’s desk.

Once, two bags had been exchanged by mistake.

After that, the residents’ committee had said in a meeting, “Belongings should be kept in an orderly way.”

Twelve lockers were installed.

The lockers belonged to the building.

The women had put their own locks on them.

The locks were small.
Most were brass or cheap steel.
One had a red thread tied around it.
Another had a dab of red paint.
Another had no mark at all.
Muniya Devi's locker was number seven.
Her lock was blue, though half the paint had worn away.
Her son had once bought that lock for the chain of an old bicycle.
The bicycle chain broke; the lock survived.
Muniya put it on the locker instead.
Muniya worked in four flats in the building.
She arrived at half past six in the morning.
First, sweeping and mopping on the third floor.
Then the preliminary kitchen work on the fifth.
Then dishes on the second floor.
Finally, cleaning the room of an elderly couple on the first.
At about one in the afternoon, she left the building.
In the evening she returned for an hour and a half in one flat.
The locker by the service entrance was her small place in the middle of the day.
She left her rainwear there in the morning.
When she went home in the afternoon, she left her work slippers in the locker.
Sometimes, if she could not take her wages home at once, she put the money in an old tin inside the locker and took it out in the evening.
She did not need a very large locker.
What she needed was for the key to be in her own hand when the locker was opened.
Ashok Babu, the building manager, rarely spoke about those lockers.
He had many responsibilities.
The pump.
The lift.
Parcels and deliveries.
Monthly dues.
Security at the gate.
The water tank on the roof.
The shared electricity account.
And the residents' complaints.
Ashok Babu was not stern by nature.
But he liked order.
He trusted what was written in a register.

There was a separate register for the key to the parcel room.
There was another register for opening the roof gate.
Emergency keys to the residents' private storerooms were kept in a sealed box.

The rules for opening that box were posted on the wall.

Flat number.

Reason for opening.

Time.

Resident present, or written permission from the resident.

Manager's signature.

And then the time the key was returned.

Muniya had seen that register many times.

Once, the lock of Suchitra Didi's storeroom on the fifth floor had jammed from the inside.

Before opening the sealed key box, Ashok Babu had called her on the phone.

Muniya had been mopping nearby at the time.

She had seen that even taking out a key was recorded like an event.

Muniya had liked that.

Opening someone's lock was not treated as an ordinary thing.

One Monday, a small commotion arose in the building.

A newly married couple lived on the fourth floor.

The woman's name was Rashmi.

That afternoon, one earring from a small pair of gold earrings belonging to Rashmi could not be found.

Rashmi first searched her room.

She lifted the pillows.

She shook out the sheet.

She checked the bathroom.

She opened the drawer of the dressing table.

She turned the laundry basket upside down.

One earring was in the box.

The other was not.

She called her husband.

Her husband said, "It will be somewhere in the house."

Rashmi searched again.

The earring was small.

There was not much gold in it.

But her mother had given it to her at the time of her wedding.

For that reason, its value was not merely its market value.

Two people had come to work in Rashmi's home that morning.

Muniya, for sweeping and mopping.
 Reena, for the dishes.
 The milkman had come only as far as the door.
 A parcel had also arrived, but the delivery person had not gone inside.
 At four in the afternoon, Rashmi went to the management office.
 Ashok Babu was looking through a register.
 Rashmi said, "I am not accusing anyone."
 Ashok Babu nodded.
 "I understand."
 "But the earring was in the house."
 "Until what time did you see it?"
 "I cannot say the exact time."
 "Who all came into the house today?"
 Rashmi gave the names.
 Ashok Babu checked the visitors' register.
 "Muniya and Reena come every day."
 "Yes. I am saying that I am not naming anyone."
 "All right. Search the house once more first."
 "I have already searched three times."
 Ashok Babu thought for a moment.
 Then he called Suresh, the guard at the gate.
 Suresh came.
 "Is the camera at the service entrance working?"
 "Yes, Babu."
 "Check the afternoon footage."
 The camera showed people coming and going.
 But not what happened inside the flats.
 Muniya had entered at half past six.
 At ten minutes past eight she had left the fourth floor and gone to the fifth.
 Reena had arrived around nine.
 She too had done her work in the usual order and left.
 Nothing unusual appeared.
 Rashmi said, "The camera cannot show what happened inside the house."
 Ashok Babu said, "That is true."
 Just then Devesh Babu, the committee secretary, arrived as well.
 Rashmi's husband had called him.
 Devesh Babu listened to the matter.
 For a while, everyone remained silent.
 Then, looking towards the service entrance, Devesh Babu said, "Could the lockers there be checked once?"
 Ashok Babu also looked in that direction.

Rashmi immediately said, "I did not say that everyone's lockers should be opened."

Devesh Babu said, "Is there any other way?"

Rashmi fell silent.

Ashok Babu stood up.

The twelve lockers stood in a row by the service entrance.

At that evening hour, two women were opening their lockers and taking out their things.

One locker was empty.

The owners of three lockers were working in the building at that moment.

Ashok Babu ran a hand over the lockers.

"Is there a second key for these?"

Suresh said, "A master key was made a long time ago."

"Where is it?"

Suresh pointed to the upper drawer in the guardroom.

There were three keys on one ring.

A thin strip of paper was tied to one of them—"belongings lockers."

Ashok Babu took the key in his hand.

Devesh Babu said, "Let us open them all and check. Then the matter will be over."

Rashmi said again, "I do not like the idea that everyone's belongings should be opened because of me."

A little uneasy, Devesh Babu said, "But if we do not open them, the suspicion will remain."

Ashok Babu said, "We will open each locker in front of its owner."

The matter stopped there for the moment.

It was decided that as many locker owners as could come would be called at six that evening.

The remaining lockers would be checked the next morning.

Suresh took out the list of names.

Locker number seven—Muniya Devi.

Muniya was outside the building at that time.

Suresh called her.

"Muniya Didi, please come a little before six this evening."

"Why?"

Suresh paused for a moment.

"We have to look at the locker."

"Whose?"

"Everyone's."

"Why?"

"Something has gone missing."

Muniya understood that there was something more inside the word “something.”

She said, “I will be coming at quarter to six anyway.”

“All right.”

After the call ended, Muniya thought of her blue lock.

There was nothing stolen inside her locker.

That was not what frightened her.

But there were things in the locker that she did not want opened out in front of everyone.

There were three thousand rupees in an old cloth pouch.

She had kept the money for her daughter’s examination fee the following week.

In an envelope was a notice from the landlord raising the rent, about which she planned to ask her brother’s advice.

A small bottle of pain oil.

Two old photographs.

A key.

And a clean sari, kept there in case she was suddenly needed for some ritual work in one of the homes and had to change.

None of those things was a crime.

Even so, she did not want them spread out before everyone.

At quarter to six, Muniya reached the building.

Five women were already standing by the service entrance.

Reena.

Jyoti.

Sakina.

Parvati.

Kamla.

Suresh had placed the register on the desk.

The master key lay beside it.

Muniya asked, “What has gone missing?”

Suresh said quietly, “An earring from the fourth floor.”

Reena immediately said, “Was my name mentioned too?”

“No one’s name was mentioned.”

“Then why all the lockers?”

Suresh searched for an answer.

Kamla said, “Open them. There is nothing in mine.”

Jyoti said, “Nothing in mine either.”

Sakina remained silent.

Muniya looked at the lockers.

Then at the master key lying on the guard’s desk.

She asked, "When was this key used before?"
 Suresh said, "Many times. If someone forgets her own key."
 "Where is it written down?"
 "What?"
 "Whose locker was opened, and when."
 Suresh laughed a little.
 "There is hardly going to be a register for such small lockers."
 Muniya said nothing.
 Ashok Babu arrived.
 Devesh Babu was with him.
 Rashmi stood a little distance away as well.
 Ashok Babu said, "Look, let us not make this into a big matter. One thing has gone missing. The lockers will be opened in front of everyone and checked. If nothing is found, the matter ends."
 Muniya asked, "Whose locker first?"
 Ashok Babu looked at the list.
 "Number one."
 Number one belonged to Parvati.
 Parvati took out her key.
 "Shall I open it myself?"
 Ashok Babu said, "Yes. You open it first."
 Parvati opened the lock.
 Inside were a cloth bag, slippers, a bottle of oil, and two steel containers.
 Devesh Babu stepped slightly forward.
 Parvati took out the bag and placed it on the table.
 Muniya watched.
 Ashok Babu said, "Show the containers too."
 Parvati opened the first container.
 Roasted gram.
 The other held satttu.
 Devesh Babu immediately said, "Enough. All right."
 Parvati put everything back inside.
 She locked the locker again.
 The second locker was Jyoti's.
 Taking out her key, Jyoti said, "There are only clothes in mine."
 She opened it.
 Two garments, a small pouch, a broken comb.
 Ashok Babu looked towards the pouch.
 Jyoti opened it herself.
 There were coins inside.

Then Muniya asked, "Where will it be written that this checking is taking place?"

Devesh Babu said, "What is there to write?"

"That the locker was opened."

"It is being opened in front of everyone."

"At what time?"

Devesh Babu grew a little irritated.

"Muniya, why are you making this difficult?"

Muniya looked at him.

"I am not making it difficult. I am asking."

Ashok Babu intervened. "What do you want?"

Muniya gestured towards the parcel room by the service entrance.

"When we take the key to that room, we write it in a register."

Ashok Babu said, "That is a different matter."

"Why is it different?"

"The residents' parcels are kept there."

"Our belongings are kept here."

Ashok Babu fell silent.

Muniya continued, "When the master key to the private storerooms upstairs is taken out, the reason is written down."

Devesh Babu said, "Those are the flat owners' property."

Muniya placed a hand on her locker.

"This locker belongs to the building. Whose are the things inside it?"

No answer came at once.

Rashmi, who had been standing at a distance, came a little closer.

She said, "The things inside are theirs."

Devesh Babu looked at her.

Rashmi said, "I want my earring. But the answer to this question is clear."

Ashok Babu lifted the master key.

Then he placed it back on the table.

"All right. I will make a register."

Devesh Babu said, "Now?"

"Yes, now."

Ashok Babu brought a blank sheet of paper from his office.

At the top he wrote—"Interim Register for Opening Belongings Lockers."

Below it he made columns.

Locker number.

Owner's name.

Reason for opening.

Time.

Owner present—yes/no.

Which key was used.
Time closed after inspection.
Owner's signature or thumb impression.
Manager/witness signature.
Devesh Babu looked at the page.
"Is all this necessary?"
Ashok Babu said, "If we are going to write it, why write only half of it?"
Muniya said nothing.
Jyoti's locker was closed again.
Ashok Babu entered it in the register.
Parvati's locker had already been opened.
Its entry was filled in afterwards.
Parvati put her thumb impression.
Ashok Babu did not guess the time.
Suresh checked the camera and said, "Six seven."
That exact time was written down.
Then Reena opened her locker.
Inside Reena's was a thin bag containing two saris, a small umbrella, a tin of betel nut, and a paper envelope.
Devesh Babu looked towards the envelope.
Reena placed her hand over it.
"This is a private paper."
Devesh Babu said, "The earring could be inside an envelope too."
Reena's face tightened.
Before Muniya could say anything, Rashmi spoke.
"Shake the envelope. If there is no sound of metal, there is no need to open it."
Ashok Babu said, "Right."
Reena shook the envelope.
There was no sound.
It was not opened.
The register recorded—"Visual inspection; sealed private paper not opened."
Devesh Babu smiled slightly.
"Now the register is making decisions too?"
Ashok Babu said, "The register is only recording what happened."
One by one, the lockers were opened.
One locker held rainwear.
Another, a packet of henna.
Another, a household ration slip.
Another, a child's lunchbox.

Another, coins.
Another, a spare blouse.
Another, a small hearing aid.
The earring was nowhere.
At six thirty-four, it was number seven's turn.
Muniya put the key into the blue lock.
Before opening it, she asked, "I am opening it myself. Will my name still go into the register?"
Ashok Babu said, "Yes. The reason is the same."
Muniya opened the lock.
The door stuck a little.
She lifted it and pulled.
The old tin, the sari, the paper envelope, and the cloth pouch inside came into view.
Ashok Babu asked, "The pouch?"
Muniya took it out.
"There is money in it."
Devesh Babu started to say something, then stopped.
Ashok Babu said, "We are looking for an earring, not counting money."
Muniya opened the mouth of the pouch only enough for the notes inside to be visible and for it to be clear that there was no earring.
Then she closed it again.
The envelope was not opened.
The sari was lifted.
Beneath it were the bottle of pain oil and two photographs.
For a moment, Muniya's hand paused over the photographs.
Ashok Babu immediately looked away.
"That is enough."
Muniya put the things back inside.
She fastened the blue lock.
The time was entered in the register.
Muniya did not usually sign her name in one flowing hand.
She wrote it letter by letter.
"Mu—ni—ya."
No thumb impression was taken after that.
Her written name was considered enough.
Locker number eight belonged to Sakina.
Sakina had remained silent until then.
She took out her key, then stopped.
"There is medicine in my locker."
Ashok Babu said, "Open it."

“I will not open the medicine box.”

“What if the small earring is in there?”

Sakina said plainly, “It is not. But if there is to be an inspection, it will be in front of me and not before I have read the paper.”

She picked up the register.

She read it slowly.

Then she opened the lock.

The medicine box was not transparent.

Ashok Babu said, “Lift the box.”

Sakina lifted it.

“Does it need to be opened?”

Rashmi spoke again. “No.”

This time Devesh Babu did not object.

The remaining lockers were opened as well.

The earring was not found.

At seven five, the last line on the page was filled in.

Ten of the twelve lockers had been opened.

The owners of two lockers were not available that day.

Ashok Babu said, “Tomorrow morning, in front of them.”

Devesh Babu asked, “Can we not open them now with the master key?”

Ashok Babu did not fold the page.

He kept it flat.

“If we have just adopted the rule that a locker is to be opened in front of its owner, why break it for two lockers now?”

Devesh Babu remained silent.

In a tired voice Rashmi said, “I am sorry everyone has had to go through this trouble.”

Reena said, “Your belonging is missing. It has to be searched for.”

After a moment, Muniya added, “Searching and opening someone’s belongings—both are necessary matters. There should simply be an account of both.”

Rashmi nodded.

The earring was not found that night.

The next morning, the two remaining lockers were opened in front of their owners.

Nothing was found there either.

The suspicion about the earring did not end.

But the suspicion over the lockers was emptied out.

Ashok Babu checked the camera timings again.

A repairman had come to Rashmi’s flat two days earlier, but whether the earring had still been there at that time was not clear.

Rashmi continued searching her home.

Three days passed.

The building's daily work returned to its usual rhythm.

Muniya came in the morning.

She opened the blue lock.

She put away her rainwear.

She took out her work slippers.

Then she closed the lock again.

But now a new, thin register lay on the desk by the service entrance.

Ashok Babu gave the interim page a permanent form.

At the top he wrote—"Private Belongings Locker Access Register."

The word "employee" was not used.

Nor was the word "resident."

The rules occupied four lines.

If the owner opens the locker with her own key, it is ordinary use; no register entry is required.

If management uses the master key, the reason, time, and witness must be recorded.

If a locker is opened for inspection, the owner must be present unless there is an emergency.

A sealed private paper or container may be opened only after a clear reason has been recorded.

Devesh Babu read the rules.

He said, "Has this not become too formal?"

Ashok Babu replied, "The key was already formal. Only the paper was missing."

Devesh Babu laughed.

"All right."

After that, Ashok Babu also took out the register for the private storerooms upstairs.

Both registers were kept in the same cupboard.

The only difference was their size.

The upstairs register was thick.

The service-locker register was thin.

A week later, news came of Rashmi's earring.

It was not in her flat. It was found in the sari box at her parents' home.

When Rashmi visited her parents for the first time after the wedding, she opened an old sari and saw the earring.

She remembered that the previous week she had worn the same pair at a family function.

On returning, she had removed one and put it into her purse; the other had caught in a fold of the sari.

When she returned to Madhavi Apartments, Rashmi went straight to the management office.

Ashok Babu was checking the pump account.

Rashmi quietly placed a small box on the table.

"You found it?"

"Yes."

"Where?"

"At my parents' home."

Ashok Babu looked at her for a moment.

Then he said, "Good."

Rashmi said, "Should we tell everyone?"

"We must tell those whose lockers were opened."

That evening, Ashok Babu posted a small notice by the service entrance.

"The missing earring has been found. No related item was found during the inspection of the belongings lockers."

Below it was the date.

And the signature.

Muniya read the notice.

So did Reena.

Sakina stood reading it for a little longer.

Reena said, "So all that drama was for nothing?"

Opening her lock, Muniya said, "For the earring, yes."

"And the register?"

Muniya put her rainwear inside the locker.

"That perhaps was not for nothing."

Reena said nothing.

Two weeks later, one morning, Sakina forgot her locker key at home.

She needed the work sari kept inside.

Earlier, in such a situation, Suresh would have taken out the master key and simply opened the locker.

That day Suresh took out the key.

Then he stopped.

He opened the register on the desk.

"Sakina Didi, look at the time."

Sakina looked at the clock.

"Seven twenty-three."

Suresh wrote it down.

"Reason—owner forgot her own key."

Sakina laughed.

“For this too?”

Suresh said, “A rule is a rule every time.”

Ashok Babu was listening from a distance.

He said nothing.

Sakina’s locker was opened with the master key.

She took out the sari.

The locker was closed again.

Suresh recorded the time the key was returned.

Sakina wrote her name.

At that moment, Muniya was opening her own blue lock.

The lock was as small as before.

The blue paint had worn away a little more.

The master key was still on the same ring.

The difference was that now the sound of its turning was no longer alone.

A line in the register opened with it.

Two Minutes Late

For Nawal, who delivered evening meals, two minutes was a very small amount of time.

On a clock, two minutes could pass in the blink of an eye.

But in the accounts of the “Door-Platter” meal service, those two minutes had a value of their own.

If a delivery ran more than two minutes beyond the appointed time, twenty rupees were deducted from the delivery fee.

Nawal did not argue against this rule.

He knew that delays happened for many reasons.

Sometimes the box came out of the kitchen late.

Sometimes rain blocked the road.

Sometimes the customer’s house number was written incompletely.

And sometimes a building gate consumed more time in paperwork than the meal itself.

On the western side of the town stood an eight-storey building called “Sahaj Niwas.”

Nawal delivered food there two or three times a week on average.

The gate was wide, but the way inside was narrow.

To the right stood the guard’s desk.

A thick register lay on the desk.

Beside the register was a brass-coloured bell.

Above, on the wall, hung a round clock.

A fine crack ran across the clock’s glass.

The guard, Ganesh Yadav, read the time through that crack.

Ganeshji’s duty was to record the names of those who came, their time of arrival, whom they were visiting, and the time they left.

The building rule required meal-delivery workers to leave their motorcycles outside.

They had to show identification at the gate.

They could enter only after permission came from the customer.

After eight at night, a service worker was not allowed to ride the lift alone.

A resident had to accompany the worker, or the food had to be handed over downstairs.

The building's security committee had made this rule.

Nawal knew the rule.

So whenever an order for Sahaj Niwas appeared, he allowed an extra five or seven minutes in his mind.

That Tuesday evening, he had three boxes in his bag.

The first two were on the way.

The third was for Room 604 on the sixth floor of Sahaj Niwas.

The customer's name was Mrinalini Jha.

The meal-service slip gave the scheduled delivery time as 8:18 p.m.

Nawal left the kitchen at 7:49.

He delivered the first meal at 7:56.

The second at 8:05.

The third address was about two kilometres away.

He did not keep looking at the clock on his mobile phone.

He disliked checking the time while riding.

After crossing one junction, he stopped his motorcycle by the roadside and looked at the phone screen.

8:12.

Six minutes remained.

He reached the gate of Sahaj Niwas at eight fifteen and a few seconds.

His phone showed 8:15.

Nawal parked the motorcycle outside.

He slung the bag over his shoulder.

Ganeshji turned the register towards himself.

"Whom are you going to?"

"Six-oh-four. Mrinalini Jha."

"Name?"

"Nawal Kumar."

Ganeshji looked at the wall clock.

It showed 8:17.

In the register he wrote—8:17.

Nawal raised his eyes to the clock.

"My clock says fifteen."

Ganeshji laughed.

"My clock belongs to the building."

Nawal smiled a little too.

"My clock belongs to the food."

Ganeshji rang the customer's room.

There was no answer the first time.

The second time, Mrinalini's voice came through.

"Who is it?"

"Food."

"Send it up."

Ganeshji said, "After eight, the rule is that you must come down or send someone with him."

There was a brief silence at the other end.

"I'm washing my hands. Two minutes."

Ganeshji put down the receiver.

Nawal remained standing beside the desk.

The smell of hot spices drifted from his bag.

The wall clock reached 8:18.

Nawal's phone showed 8:16.

He opened the order on the screen.

It said—"Scheduled arrival: 8:18."

A small circle below was slowly filling in.

Nawal asked Ganeshji, "Will it count as delivered downstairs?"

Ganeshji said, "When the customer takes it."

"I have reached the gate."

"In my rules that is arrival, not receipt of food."

Having each said his piece, the two fell silent.

A few moments later, the numbers on the lift display began to descend from above.

8.

7.

6.

Then it stopped at 6.

Nawal looked at the wall clock.

8:19.

His phone showed 8:17.

The lift moved again.

According to the building clock, Mrinalini came downstairs at 8:20.

Her mobile phone was in her hand.

She said, "It's very late."

Nawal handed her the box.

"I reached the gate at fifteen."

Mrinalini looked at her phone screen.

Her phone showed 8:19.

"I have only just received the message saying you've arrived."

Nawal showed her his screen.

It showed 8:18.

Mrinalini's screen showed 8:19.

Ganeshji's wall clock showed 8:21.

All three were standing in the same place.

All three times were different.

Mrinalini said, "The food is getting cold."

Nawal said, "If I'm marked two minutes late, twenty rupees will be deducted."

Mrinalini replied, "How am I to know how long you have been at the gate?"

Ganeshji tapped the register.

"It says here—seventeen."

Nawal said, "My phone says fifteen."

Mrinalini showed her screen.

"My message came at nineteen."

Which time was true was a question no clock could answer at that moment.

Mrinalini took the food and went upstairs.

Nawal marked it "delivered."

At once, a small red line appeared on the screen—"2 minutes late."

For Nawal, that line was worth twenty rupees.

For Ganeshji, that line concerned something outside the building.

For Mrinalini, it confirmed the time she had spent waiting.

Nawal left for his next order.

When he returned to the kitchen at half past ten that night, the accounts were checked.

He had made eight deliveries that day.

Seven were on time.

One was two minutes late.

Twenty rupees were deducted.

Nawal told Saroj, who supervised the kitchen, "At Sahaj Niwas I was on time."

Saroj looked at the slip.

"The customer received it around nineteen or twenty."

"I reached the gate at fifteen."

"Proof?"

Nawal opened the location history on his phone.

It showed that he had stopped in front of the building at 8:15:42.

Saroj did not look at the register.

"The service is complete when the food reaches the customer."

Nawal said, "The building does not allow me to go inside."

Saroj thought for a moment.

"Then the customer can come downstairs."

“That took four minutes.”
 “You could call beforehand.”
 “While riding a motorcycle?”
 Saroj fell silent.
 She did not immediately return the twenty rupees.
 “Tomorrow I’ll understand the building’s rule.”
 The next day Saroj went to Sahaj Niwas.
 It was afternoon.
 Ganeshji was writing in the register.
 Saroj asked for the entry recording Nawal’s arrival.
 Ganeshji opened the page.
 “Eight seventeen.”
 Saroj looked at her own watch.
 The building clock was one minute and fifty-six seconds ahead of hers.
 She smiled.
 “This clock is fast.”
 Ganeshji said, “How far ahead?”
 “Almost two minutes.”
 “Could be.”
 “Then the time in the register?”
 “I write what I see on the wall.”
 “Whose responsibility is it to set the clock right?”
 Ganeshji scratched his head.
 “When the repairman comes.”
 Saroj asked, “Why can’t food-delivery workers go inside at night?”
 Ganeshji showed her the notice of rules.
 “After eight, a service worker cannot go upstairs alone.”
 “It takes time for the customer to come down.”
 “My responsibility is security.”
 “And the meal service’s time?”
 “That is your rule.”
 Ganeshji did not say this rudely.
 It was as though someone had hung the keys to two separate cupboards on two separate hooks.
 Saroj met the building manager, Basant Chaudhary.
 Basant Babu listened to the rule.
 “Security cannot be reduced.”
 “I am not saying it should be.”
 “Then what is the problem?”
 Saroj handed him a sheet on which three times were written.
 8:15:42 — Nawal’s location history.

8:17 — the gate register.

8:19 — the customer notification.

Below that, the customer's receipt time, around 8:20.

Basant Babu looked at the paper.

"These are not the same time."

Saroj said, "They are not the same event either."

Basant Babu looked up.

"What do you mean?"

"First—reaching the building. Second—entry in the gate register. Third—the food reaching the customer's hand."

"That is only natural."

"The penalty treats them as one time."

Basant Babu looked at the paper again.

This time he saw more than minutes in its lines.

"Do you want us to send the food-delivery workers straight upstairs?"

"No."

"Then how is the customer's waiting time to be reduced?"

"I don't know the answer to that yet."

Saroj admitted it.

The matter did not end there.

Three days later, Mrinalini herself came to the manager's office.

She had come to give notice of the monthly residents' meeting.

Quite casually, Basant Babu asked, "Was the food very late that day?"

Mrinalini said, "It felt late to me."

"The guard says the young man had arrived earlier."

"It took me time to come downstairs."

"When did you receive the notification?"

Mrinalini checked the old message on her phone.

"Eight nineteen."

"He was near the building at fifteen minutes and twenty-two seconds past eight."

Mrinalini looked startled.

"Then where did the four minutes go?"

It was the first time the question had come from the customer's mouth.

Ganeshji was called.

He came with the register.

"I wrote seventeen."

Mrinalini heard about the wall clock.

"Then your seventeen was really fifteen?"

Ganeshji said, "I wrote what the clock showed."

Basant Babu said, "There was not one single person's mistake."

Mrinalini asked, "Then whose were the four minutes?"

Basant Babu did not answer.

The matter was raised at the residents' meeting that day.

Someone said the delivery workers should not be sent upstairs.

Someone asked how elderly people were supposed to come downstairs.

Someone said customers should already be waiting at the gate.

Someone said the service should decide when food counted as delivered.

Ganeshji had placed the register on the table.

Saroj had also been invited.

Nawal had been called as well, but he was out on a delivery.

When the meeting began, the first argument was about the clock.

One resident compared his watch with the building clock.

The difference was two minutes and five seconds.

Another found a difference of two minutes and nine seconds.

Someone said, "First fix the clock."

Basant Babu immediately told them to have the clock taken down for repair.

But Saroj said, "Even if the clock is correct, the three times will not become one."

Everyone looked at her.

She opened the paper with the three lines again.

"Reaching the gate from the road is one event."

"Receiving permission in the register is another."

"The food reaching the customer's hand is the third."

"Even if every clock shows the same second, these three will still remain separate."

Mrinalini nodded slowly.

An elderly resident, Harinarayan Mishra, said, "It takes me ten minutes to get downstairs. Does that make the delivery worker guilty?"

A young resident said, "But the service says 'to the door.'"

Saroj replied, "Our service would go to the door if the building allowed it."

Basant Babu said, "The building will not abandon its security rule."

Ganeshji added, "Nor its register."

Mrinalini said, "And my waiting time is not false either."

At that one sentence the meeting grew a little quieter.

All three sides were defending their own clocks, yet none of the three was lying.

The problem was not the truth of the clocks, but placing the responsibility of one clock upon another.

Basant Babu said, "Then where do we consider the handover to take place?"

Everyone began speaking again.

Outside the main gate?

At the guard's desk?

Near the lift?

At the room door?

Saroj said, "Make the first handover point the place a delivery worker can reach without any additional permission from the building."

Ganeshji looked in front of the desk.

To the left of it, under the awning, there was about six feet of empty space.

Two flowerpots had stood there before.

Even in the rain the spot stayed dry.

It did not block the way to the lift.

It was inside the gate, but before the boundary of the residents' area.

Basant Babu said, "Here?"

Ganeshji got up and went there.

"Standing here, the register is visible."

Mrinalini said, "The customer can come down here."

Harinarayan Mishra said, "And if I cannot come down?"

Basant Babu said, "For you, with permission, the guard can send it upstairs with someone, as under the old rule."

Saroj said, "In that situation, record the time separately."

The meeting did not make a permanent rule at once.

A one-week trial was agreed upon.

A white line was painted beneath the awning.

A small table was placed inside it.

On the wall they wrote—"Food Handover Point."

Below it were two lines.

"Gate arrival."

"Customer receipt."

Two new columns were also added to Ganeshji's register.

The old "arrival" entry was not removed.

Beside it they added "handover notification."

The meal service added to its own rules: in buildings where service workers are not allowed upstairs, arrival at the designated handover point will count as the time limit.

The customer's mobile screen would separately record the receipt time.

No time was erased.

They simply wrote which event each time referred to.

On the first evening of the trial, Nawal reached Sahaj Niwas again.

This time the order was for Room 302.

The scheduled time was 7:42.

At the gate, Nawal's phone showed 7:39.

The newly corrected building clock also showed 7:39.
 Ganeshji laughed.
 “Today the two agree.”
 Nawal said, “Let us see how long the friendship lasts.”
 Ganeshji wrote 7:39 in the register.
 He rang the customer.
 “The food is at the handover point.”
 The customer came down three minutes later.
 The receipt time was recorded as 7:42.
 Both times were correct.
 The next day, food for an elderly resident went upstairs with the guard.
 Gate arrival: 8:11.
 Upstairs receipt: 8:17.
 The six minutes in between were recorded as the building’s process.
 No deduction was made from Nawal’s delivery fee.
 Nor did the customer’s waiting time disappear from the register.
 On the third day, one customer did not come downstairs for five minutes.
 Under the service rule, the food had reached the handover point on time.
 Later the customer complained that the food had become a little cold.
 The complaint was not dismissed.
 It was recorded in a separate column—“receipt delay.”
 Seeing this, Mrinalini said, “Now the customer will be trapped in the register too.”
 Ganeshji smiled.
 “The register is not meant to trap anyone. It is meant to separate the times.”
 Mrinalini asked, “Then what about my four minutes that day?”
 Ganeshji opened the old page.
 “That day there was only one column.”
 “And now?”
 “Now there are two.”
 A week later the residents’ meeting met again.
 The trial page recorded a total of twenty-seven meals.
 In thirteen cases, the customer came downstairs within two minutes.
 In eight, it took three to five minutes.
 In four, the food had to be taken upstairs with the guard for an elderly or unwell resident.
 In two, permission from the customer came late.
 No security rule had been broken.
 The meal service’s two-minute penalty applied only when the delivery worker reached the handover point after the scheduled time.

Saroj returned Nawal's old twenty rupees.
 Looking at the money, Nawal said, "All those meetings for this?"
 Saroj said, "Not for your twenty rupees."
 "Then?"
 "To make it clear whose next twenty rupees it will be."
 Nawal put the money in his pocket.
 He did not dance with joy.
 Twenty rupees was not a small sum for him, but the whole matter had grown larger than he was.
 That evening he again had an order for Sahaj Niwas.
 This time it was for Mrinalini Jha.
 Nawal reached the gate at 8:16.
 The scheduled time was 8:18.
 Ganeshji wrote 8:16 in the register.
 The box was placed at the handover point.
 The bell was rung.
 From upstairs Mrinalini said, "I'm coming."
 Nawal adjusted the strap of his bag.
 His next order was far away.
 He said to Ganeshji, "May I go?"
 Ganeshji said, "You have completed your time."
 Nawal left.
 Mrinalini came downstairs three minutes later.
 Ganeshji handed her the box.
 "Eight nineteen," he said.
 Mrinalini looked at her mobile phone.
 "Mine also says nineteen."
 Ganeshji looked at the building clock.
 It too showed 8:19.
 By coincidence, all three clocks agreed at that moment.
 Mrinalini laughed.
 "So today there is no quarrel."
 Ganeshji wrote the receipt time in the register.
 "The quarrel was not in the clocks."
 Mrinalini asked, "Then where was it?"
 Ganeshji placed the tip of his pen between the two lines.
 "Here. In between."
 Mrinalini took the box and walked towards the lift.
 By then Nawal had already gone out through the gate.
 The register carried two times for the same meal.
 Two minutes was still two minutes.

But now it was no longer automatically one person's fault.

The Weighing of Wet Paddy

In the first week of Agahan, the paddy fields looked not like gold, but like wet yellow.

It had rained three days earlier.

The soil was still soft beneath the feet when one stepped on the field bund.

Once the harvesting began, the stalks of paddy were cut with toothed sickles, small bundles were made, and by noon a yellow heap had risen along one side of the field.

Phulmati Devi was not the oldest in that group, but whenever the matter of accounts arose, everyone looked toward her.

She was not very quick at writing.

She could write her name, village, numbers and dates.

The rest of an account she understood through grain, measures, sacks and days.

The owner of that field was Ramlochan Jha.

In the village people did not call him a harsh man.

Nor was his name commonly associated with complaints of withholding wages.

Before harvesting began, he told all the labourers plainly, "The wage for a day is eighteen kilos of paddy. It will be weighed out in the evening."

Phulmati said nothing that day.

It had been eighteen kilos the previous year too.

She still remembered one sack from the previous year.

After reaching home, that sack had been spread out in the courtyard for two days.

On the third day, when the grain was put back into the sack, the sack felt lighter.

Her younger son Chandan had said, "Mother, perhaps they gave you less at the weighing."

Phulmati had scolded her son then.

"Do not blame anyone without seeing."

The matter had ended there.

But the memory of the sack having grown lighter had not ended.

This year, on the evening of the first day of harvesting, a scale was set up on the threshing ground.

Not the old iron balance with two pans.

It was a square, battery-powered weighing machine.

The clerk, Devkant, placed each sack on it, read the number, and wrote the weight beside the name in the ledger.

The first labourer's sack showed 18.10.

Devkant took out a little paddy.

It became 18.00.

The second sack was 17.85.

He added another handful of paddy.

18.00.

The numbers kept becoming equal.

Then came Phulmati's turn.

When her sack was lifted, it felt cold from underneath.

She put her hand inside.

There was moisture among the grains in the middle.

Devkant said, "Take your hand out. It will disturb the weighing."

Phulmati withdrew her hand.

The machine showed 18.20.

Devkant removed two handfuls and looked again.

18.00.

"Take it."

Phulmati did not lift the sack.

She asked, "Write the date on this."

Devkant looked at her.

"Why?"

"Just write it—the date of today."

"The date is in the ledger."

"On the sack too."

Devkant laughed.

"Is the paddy going to run away somewhere?"

Phulmati smiled a little too.

"Not the paddy. The matter runs away."

A little way off, Ramlochan was having his own share piled up.

Hearing the voices, he came over.

"What happened?"

Devkant said, "Phulmati wants the date written on the sack."

Ramlochan said, "Write it. What is there in that?"

Devkant picked up the blue chalk lying on the threshing-ground table.

On the sack he wrote—"Agahan 5."

Phulmati said again, "Write 'wet' too."

This time Devkant's hand stopped.

"What?"

"Wet paddy."

"All the paddy is wet."

"Then what harm is there in writing it?"

Ramlochan looked at her more closely.

"Do you suspect something?"

Phulmati immediately shook her head.

"Not suspicion. Condition."

"What is the difference?"

"Suspicion is about a person. Condition is about the paddy."

For a few moments, amid the noise of the threshing ground, those words sounded distinct.

Ramlochan said, "Write it, Devkant."

Under the date, Devkant wrote in small letters—"Wet."

Phulmati lifted the sack.

That night she did not take the paddy home.

All the labourers' sacks were kept in the veranda of the threshing ground.

At dawn the labourers returned to the field.

The sun came out well on the second day.

Ramlochan's household began spreading the owner's paddy thinly over the cleared middle of the threshing ground.

The grain was turned again and again with a long bamboo rake with teeth.

The labourers' sacks remained closed in the veranda.

When Phulmati came at noon to drink water, she saw that her sack had become even damper at the bottom.

She dragged the sack outside.

Devkant said, "Do not open it now. Everyone's sacks will get mixed up."

Phulmati pointed to the date written on the sack.

"My sack is marked."

"Even so."

"If it stays shut inside, how will it dry?"

Before Devkant could answer, Ramlochan came over.

He said, "Take the wage sacks home. I cannot take responsibility for drying them here."

The statement was not unreasonable.

The threshing ground belonged to the owner.

The wages had already been paid.

Phulmati put the sack back inside.

"I will take it in the evening."

The harvesting went on as usual that day.
 After noon the clouds gathered again.
 It did not rain, but the air grew more humid.
 The evening paddy was wetter than on the first day.
 Again, the scale kept being brought to 18.00.
 On her second sack Phulmati had this written as well—"Agahan 6,
 evening, wet."
 This time Devkant wrote it without asking.
 Ramsagar from the group laughed and said, "From tomorrow we should
 have a birth register written on the sacks too."
 Phulmati said, "I will not write it on your sack."
 Ramsagar hoisted his sack onto his shoulder.
 "I received eighteen kilos. That is enough."
 Phulmati said nothing.
 On the third day the harvesting continued for only half the day.
 After noon the labourers began taking home the sacks from the previous
 two days.
 Phulmati put the first sack back on the scale.
 Devkant immediately said, "Why weigh it again now?"
 The machine showed 17.25.
 Phulmati put the second sack on it.
 17.60.
 Ramsagar was standing nearby.
 He immediately said, "See! It was short."
 Phulmati stopped him.
 "No. Earlier it was eighteen."
 "Then now?"
 "It dried."
 Ramsagar pressed the sack with his hand.
 "Then did I receive eighteen, or seventeen?"
 Phulmati did not answer.
 The question was no longer hers alone.
 Devkant opened the ledger.
 "It is clearly written here—eighteen."
 Phulmati said, "At that time it was eighteen."
 "Then the account is correct."
 "I am saying the account is not false."
 Devkant's voice softened.
 "Then what is the dispute about?"
 Phulmati pointed toward the owner's paddy spread out to dry.
 "When will that paddy be weighed?"

Ramlochan answered, "After it has dried completely."

"Why?"

"Wet paddy cannot be stored in the granary."

"And will it be sold after drying too?"

"Yes."

Phulmati placed her hand on the word "Wet" written on her sack.

"Then my eighteen is wet. Your account is dry."

Ramlochan said, "Your wage was said to be eighteen kilos. I gave you eighteen."

"That is correct."

"Then?"

"Was the meaning of eighteen also stated?"

Ramlochan fell silent.

Phulmati spoke again, "Wet eighteen or dry eighteen?"

Ramsagar interrupted, "It should be dry."

Phulmati looked at him.

"Listen first."

There was calculation, not displeasure, on Ramlochan's face.

He said, "If I give everyone eighteen kilos dry, the wage will increase."

Phulmati said, "Will it increase, or become clear?"

Devkant closed the ledger.

"Why was this not raised earlier?"

Phulmati looked at the date on the sack.

"Last year I did not understand."

"And now you understand?"

"Now the sack wrote it down."

Ramlochan laughed a little.

"A sack does not write."

Phulmati laughed too.

"True. The weighing wrote it."

Work resumed half an hour late that day.

No decision was reached.

The labourers took their sacks home.

Phulmati spread both sacks separately in the courtyard at home.

The date on the first sack could still be read.

On the second, the chalk had faded a little.

Chandan asked, "Why is 'wet' written here?"

Phulmati said, "So that we remember a number alone is not the whole matter."

Chandan did not quite understand the answer.

He pressed a grain between his teeth.

“It is still soft.”

“Let it dry.”

When Phulmati reached the threshing ground the next morning, she saw a man sitting amid Ramlochan’s spread-out paddy with a small instrument.

He was a representative of a local paddy buyer.

He took handfuls of grain from different places, put them into a small box, and looked at the number on the instrument.

Ramlochan asked, “How much?”

The man said, “Still too high. Dry it again until evening.”

“The vehicle will come tomorrow.”

“Then separate the thin upper layer.”

Phulmati stood some distance away listening.

She did not go closer.

The labourers’ work was in the field.

When she came at noon to drink water, she saw the small instrument lying on the table.

Devkant was there.

Phulmati asked, “Does this measure the water in the paddy?”

Devkant said, “Moisture.”

“Was my sack measured yesterday?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Who will go to so much trouble for wage paddy?”

Phulmati set the water cup down.

“So water has no value in a small sack, but it has value in a large heap?”

Devkant did not become irritated.

He picked up the instrument.

“It is not possible to measure every sack. The instrument belongs to the buyer. He measures for his own purchase.”

“I am not asking for the instrument.”

“Then what?”

“One rule.”

“What rule?”

“If the weighing is wet, weigh both shares wet. If it is dry, weigh both shares dry.”

Devkant said, “The owner’s share is large. It is first made into a heap, then dried, then weighed. The labourers need their wages every day.”

“They do need them every day.”

“Then how can both be weighed at the same time?”

Phulmati thought for a moment.

“When the heap is divided, weigh and record the owner’s share wet too.”

Devkant frowned.

“Weigh the whole heap every day?”

“When the paddy from that day is taken out, the wage share is separated from it, is it not?”

“Yes.”

“Then count the owner’s remaining share at the same time too. Later write the dry weight in a separate ledger.”

Devkant did not answer immediately.

Phulmati picked up the water cup.

“I have to go back to the field now.”

She left.

That evening Devkant told Ramlochan about it.

At first Ramlochan laughed.

“If we keep weighing my paddy every day, it will be midnight.”

Devkant said, “She is not asking for every sack to be weighed one by one. She says the condition of the heap from which the wages are taken should be recorded.”

“Will writing the condition make the weights equal?”

“No.”

“Then what is the benefit?”

Devkant opened a blank page of the ledger.

“The benefit may be that later a wet figure and a dry figure will not be treated as though they were the same thing.”

Ramlochan looked at the page.

“You have taken a liking to the idea?”

Devkant said, “I need a line to write in. Liking can come later.”

Ramlochan smiled.

“That is why clerks are dangerous.”

“Only when the line is left blank.”

Both of them laughed.

But there was still no decision.

The fifth day was the last large field of the harvest.

Everyone reached the field before sunrise.

The paddy was heavy.

Dew still clung to the lower part of the stalks.

By noon three heaps had formed on the threshing ground.

One heap was of the drier paddy cut in the morning.

The second was from noon.

The third was paddy from the lower part of the field and was wetter.

Ordinarily Devkant would have mixed all three together.

That day Phulmati said, “Let them stay separate.”

Ramsagar asked, "Another experiment?"

Phulmati said, "Not an experiment. What the eyes can see."

Ramlochan was there too.

He said, "All right. Let all three remain separate."

When wages were distributed in the evening, the first four sacks were filled from the morning heap.

The next four from the noon heap.

The last four from the damp heap.

Every sack was 18.00.

Ramsagar pressed his sack and said, "Mine is wetter."

Budhni Devi, the labourer beside him, said, "The number is the same."

"Will you eat the water?"

Budhni said, "We will dry the paddy."

"When it dries, it will become less."

Phulmati said nothing.

This time she did not need to raise the question.

Ramlochan had small slips placed beside the three heaps.

"Morning."

"Noon."

"Lower field—damp."

Devkant also made three entries in the ledger.

He asked, "Shall we keep the owner's share separate according to these three heaps today as well?"

Ramlochan thought for a moment and said, "Keep it separate."

The decision caused no great upheaval.

Only three extra tarpaulins were needed on the threshing ground.

Ramlochan's younger brother became annoyed.

"If we keep everything separate like this, the work will go on all night."

Ramlochan said, "Let us see for one day."

The labourers' sacks went away.

The owner's three heaps were spread separately.

The next day the sun was strong.

By noon the grain in all three heaps had begun to rattle almost alike.

The paddy buyer's representative came again.

He took samples from all three.

The morning heap became suitable first.

The noon heap a little later.

The paddy from the lower field needed more sun.

For the first time Ramlochan noticed that the wage sacks from all three heaps had been exactly 18.00 the previous evening, but the three kinds of paddy had not been in the same condition.

He did not call Phulmati.

First he said to Devkant, "Can we get yesterday's labourers' sacks again?"

Devkant laughed.

"Half of them have reached home."

"Then how do we compare?"

"The two sacks in the veranda belong to Ramsagar and Budhni. Both will take them today."

Ramlochan said, "Weigh them."

Ramsagar's sack, filled from the damp heap, showed 16.90.

Budhni's, filled from the morning heap, showed 17.40.

Ramsagar immediately said, "See!"

Ramlochan looked at him.

"Yesterday both were eighteen."

"Then why is mine half a kilo less?"

Devkant said, "Your paddy was wetter."

Ramsagar looked at Phulmati.

Phulmati said, "Now we understand that within eighteen, the share of water can also be different."

Ramlochan placed a hand on the ledger.

"Then what do we do? Dry every sack before giving it? Will the labourers wait three days?"

Budhni said, "I cannot. We need paddy at home."

Ramsagar too said, "I have to take mine today."

Phulmati said, "I do not want to wait either."

Ramlochan asked, "Then your one rule?"

Phulmati looked at the three heaps on the threshing ground.

"Decide the weighing point beforehand."

"Say it."

"Before the harvesting begins, write whether the wage is based on fresh wet weight or dry weight."

Ramlochan said, "For this year, take it as fresh weight."

"Then in the first account, treat the owner's share from that day as fresh weight too."

"I will weigh it again later for sale."

"Do so. But that should be a second account."

Devkant drew the ledger toward himself.

Phulmati continued, "In the first ledger write the total fresh paddy, how much of it went as wages, and how much remained as the owner's share. Along with the date and condition."

Ramlochan asked, "Weigh the whole fresh heap?"

Devkant interrupted, "It is not as though every bit goes into the granary in sacks. I can write a total for every ten sacks. At the end of the day it can be added up."

Ramlochan looked at him.

"You had the solution ready already?"

Devkant said, "It came when I looked at the ledger."

Ramsagar said, "I want eighteen kilos dry."

Phulmati turned toward him.

"You can say that before next year."

"This year?"

"This year we will make clear the meaning of what was already settled. If we change the rate midway, there will be another dispute."

Ramsagar fell silent.

Phulmati had not taken the owner's side.

She was accepting the limit of what she herself had said.

Perhaps for that reason, Ramlochan listened fully for the first time.

He said, "This year the wage will be by fresh weight. But the date and 'wet' will be written on the sacks. And the day's first weighing of the total paddy will also be recorded in that same condition."

Devkant added, "The later dry weight in a separate ledger."

"Yes."

Budhni asked, "And if one day the paddy is very wet?"

Before Ramlochan could answer, Phulmati said, "Then that day the matter will be settled again beforehand."

Ramlochan said, "Very wet paddy will not be given as wages. It will first be spread in the shade once."

Ramsagar asked, "What is the measure of 'very'?"

Everyone laughed.

Ramlochan too.

"Now you want the instrument?"

Ramsagar said, "No, but tomorrow Phulmati Didi will say a word alone is not the whole matter."

Phulmati smiled.

"You are learning."

That evening Devkant made a new page.

At the top he wrote—"Harvest Paddy—First Weighing."

Below it were five fields.

Date.

Field/heap.

Condition.

Wage paddy.

Owner's remaining paddy.

At the top of a second page he wrote—"Dry/Sale Weight."

Ramlochan said, "With so many ledgers we will become less farmers and more clerks."

Devkant said, "The two figures were already there. Now only their names have been separated."

Phulmati was standing there.

She read the ledger.

The word "condition" seemed a little difficult to her.

She said, "In this field write 'wet/dry' clearly."

Devkant did not strike out "condition."

In brackets he added—"wet/dry."

Phulmati nodded.

The next day was the first test of the new rule.

The field was small.

The paddy reached the threshing ground all at once.

By evening a total of twenty-four sacks had been filled.

Devkant first counted all the sacks.

Two sacks at a time were checked on the scale, but in the end every sack was recorded at its own actual weight.

Four sacks were separated for wages.

The remaining twenty were the owner's share.

In the ledger the first weight of all of them was recorded as wet.

Phulmati's sack was stopped at 18.00.

Devkant picked up the chalk.

"Date?"

Phulmati said, "Write it."

"Wet?"

"Write it."

He wrote it.

This time it was not only the labourer's name that was written on the sack.

The same date and "Wet" were also written in chalk on the owner's first five sacks.

Ramlochan's brother again asked, "Why all this on the owner's sacks?"

Ramlochan answered, "So that tomorrow, after seeing the dry weight, I do not say that yesterday there had been only this much."

His brother said nothing.

At dawn the owner's sacks were opened and the paddy spread out.

The labourers took their sacks home.

Two days later the dried paddy was weighed again.

Devkant wrote the new figures in the second ledger.

Those figures made it appear that the owner's paddy had diminished. Ramlochan joked, "Look, my paddy has been stolen." Devkant said, "The water went." At that time Phulmati had come to bind the remaining straw in the field. She heard them. "Write the thief's name in the ledger." Ramlochan laughed. "Water?" "Yes. But do not send it to jail." Laughter rose across the threshing ground. The matter became light, but the account no longer felt heavy. On the final day of harvesting the labourers' wages were being distributed. Ramsagar took his sack and picked up the chalk himself. He wrote—"Agahan 12, evening, wet." The letters were crooked. Phulmati looked at them. "The 'jh' in 'saanjh' is backwards." Ramsagar said, "Will the paddy understand?" Phulmati laughed. "Not the paddy. You have to understand." Budhni had only the date written on her sack. Devkant asked, "Not 'wet'?" Budhni said, "Write it. Otherwise my daughter-in-law at home will ask why the sack became lighter." The sun was setting. On one side of the threshing ground the owner's remaining paddy lay spread out. On the other, the labourers were lifting their sacks onto their shoulders. The scale stood in between. Before closing the ledger, Ramlochan looked back and forth at the first and second pages. The first page held the wet weights. The second held the dry ones. Both were correct. Both were different. Phulmati lifted her last sack onto her shoulder. The chalk writing brushed her cheek and left a small white streak of dust. Devkant said, "Phulmati, what is written on the sack will wash away in the rain." Phulmati looked toward the ledger. "That is why it is written there too."

She walked away.
There was a date on the sack.
Beside the date was one small word—“Wet.”
Eighteen kilos was still written as eighteen.
The difference was that now the number also carried the moment at which
it had been measured.

The Empty Plate

On the outskirts of Madhubani, the kitchen behind the wedding pavilion had been hot since evening.

In front were coloured lights, garlands of flowers, and the sound of music.

At the back were three large hearths, two gas stoves, twelve cauldrons, and blue drums of water.

Malti Devi stood in the middle of the kitchen.

A large ladle was in her hand.

Her sari-end was tied firmly over her head.

She kept an eye on both the fire and the clock.

There were seventeen people in her team that day.

Four cooks.

Six servers.

Three dishwashers.

Two water carriers.

One person to tend the wood and coal.

And Malti herself.

The catering sheet listed five hundred guests.

Malti had asked, "Where is the number of the people who are working?"

Naresh Babu, who was overseeing the arrangements, had laughed.

"You are all in the kitchen. How could there be any shortage of food?"

Malti asked again, "Where is the count?"

"We'll eat at the end."

The answer was not new to her.

She had heard that sentence many times at wedding feasts.

"We'll eat at the end."

Meaning, after all the guests had eaten.

Meaning, whatever remained.

Meaning, no one would count beforehand how much would remain.

Malti did not argue.

She closed the spice box and turned back towards the cauldrons.

At seven in the evening, the first line of guests reached the food tables.

In front, there were separate counters for chaat, sweets, rice, dal, vegetables, puris, and curd.

Behind them, work in the kitchen quickened.

“Two cauldrons of dal to the front.”

“Fifty more puris.”

“Open the third pot of rice.”

“The curd is running low.”

The calls rose again and again.

Malti watched the people in her team.

Ganesh was frying puris.

Jamuna Devi was tending the vegetable cauldron.

Chhotu was filling the water drums.

Ramesh was washing dishes.

Phulkumari was carrying plates to the servers.

No one had sat down.

It was eight at night.

Malti said to Ganesh, “Eat something now.”

Ganesh looked towards the fire under the hearth.

“Who will fry the puris now?”

“Jamuna will watch them for ten minutes.”

From a distance Jamuna said, “If I leave the vegetables, they’ll burn.”

Ganesh laughed.

“We’ll eat at the end.”

Malti looked at his face.

The same sentence again.

This time from a worker’s mouth.

Habits do not belong only to owners.

Sometimes the rule of deprivation makes a home in the worker’s mouth as well.

By half past eight, the number of guests had risen.

Two buses had arrived outside at the same time.

Naresh Babu came running in.

“Malti ji, make sure the rice does not run short.”

“How many more people?”

“About a hundred and fifty.”

Malti calculated at once.

“That takes us beyond the five hundred we were told.”

“That happens at weddings.”

“It does.”

She went back to work.

By ten, the first rush had thinned.

Malti picked up an empty plate.
 "Ganesh, eat now."
 Ganesh went to wash his hands.
 Just then Naresh Babu came running in again.
 "Don't eat yet. Two vehicles from the groom's side are still on the way."
 Ganesh wiped his hands and returned to the hearth.
 The plate remained in Malti's hand.
 She turned it upside down and set it to one side.
 At eleven, the last group from the groom's side arrived.
 By then the dough for puris was running low.
 One cauldron of vegetables was empty.
 Three cans of curd were finished.
 There was still dal.
 There was rice too.
 Among the sweets, only boondi remained.
 Naresh Babu said, "Manage with whatever is left."
 Malti replied, "We will."
 Up to that point, no one in her team had eaten a full meal.
 Chhotu saw two puris fall to the ground.
 He picked them up and set them aside.
 Malti saw him.
 "Don't eat those."
 Chhotu said, "I won't throw them away."
 "Don't throw them away. But that is not your meal."
 Chhotu fell silent.
 By midnight, the number of guests had dwindled.
 Malti said, "Now everyone wash your hands."
 Nine of the seventeen gathered to one side first.
 Phulkumari handed out plates.
 There was dal.
 There was rice.
 There was boondi.
 At the bottom of the vegetable cauldron there was gravy, but very few pieces.
 The puris were finished.
 The curd was finished.
 The salad was finished.
 Ganesh took rice on his plate.
 He took dal.
 He took one ladle of vegetable gravy.
 He laughed.

"So this is my wedding feast."
 Malti did not laugh.
 Jamuna Devi stood holding an empty plate.
 She served Chhotu first.
 Then Ramesh.
 When she went to put rice on her own plate, the pot was empty.
 Phulkumari said, "There are still two handfuls."
 Jamuna stopped her hand.
 "Leave it. I'll drink water."
 Malti held out her own plate to her.
 "Take mine."
 Jamuna shook her head.
 "You have been standing all day too."
 Naresh Babu arrived in the middle of this small dispute.
 There was a box of sweets in his hand.
 "This is left. Share it."
 Malti looked at the box.
 "How many?"
 "Ten or twelve pieces."
 "There are seventeen of us."
 "Then take half each."
 Naresh Babu said it quite naturally.
 He thought he had offered a solution.
 Malti did not take the box.
 "The problem is not the sweets."
 Naresh Babu stopped.
 "Then what is it?"
 "Where was our people's food counted?"
 "But this much food was made. The number of guests increased."
 "The guests increased. But the seventeen of us were here from the beginning."
 Naresh Babu was silent for a moment.
 "If we set food aside for you, someone will say the cooks hid food for themselves."
 Malti said, "Not hidden separately. Counted beforehand."
 "Why make a distinction?"
 "Not a distinction. A count."
 Before Naresh Babu could answer, a shout came from the front.
 "We're running short of tea!"
 He ran off again.
 By half past one, the wedding pavilion was nearly empty.

There was a heap of dishes in the kitchen.
 After drinking water, Jamuna began sorting the dishes again.
 Malti looked at her empty plate.
 Before the plate could go into the pile for washing, she picked it up.
 She hung it from a hook.
 Ganesh asked, "Why are you doing that?"
 Malti said, "It will be shown in tomorrow's account."
 "Can an empty plate be part of an account too?"
 "If someone was responsible for filling it, then yes."
 The work ended at three in the morning.
 The wage register lay before Naresh Babu.
 Seventeen names.
 Seventeen signatures or thumbprints.
 Malti placed a hand on the register.
 "Write one thing."
 Naresh Babu was tired.
 "What now?"
 "At the next feast: kitchen workers' meals—seventeen."
 "Today's matter in the register for the next feast?"
 "We learn from today."
 Naresh Babu lifted his pen, then stopped.
 "Who will pay for the food?"
 Malti said, "It belongs in the wedding feast account of whoever is holding the wedding."
 "Then the contract cost will rise."
 "Seventeen people work all day. Why should the cost of their food be outside the contract?"
 Naresh Babu leaned back in his chair.
 "How much food should be set aside?"
 "As much as is needed for seventeen people."
 "Who will measure the quantity?"
 "The person who measures for five hundred can measure for seventeen as well."
 "And if someone eats once early and then eats again?"
 Ganesh was listening from a distance.
 He burst out laughing.
 "So I'll be watched more closely than the guests."
 Malti glared at him.
 Ganesh fell silent.
 Naresh Babu smiled a little too.
 The tension eased.

Malti said, "There is no need to write names. Write the total number."

"And when will they eat?"

"That too must be thought through."

Naresh Babu said, "If everyone sits at once, the work will stop."

"Not everyone at once."

"Then?"

"In three batches."

Malti picked up a piece of chalk from the floor.

She drew three lines on the kitchen wall.

First—the cooks and water carriers who can be relieved in rotation.

Second—half the servers.

Third—the people remaining.

"In every batch, two or three people will stay at the hearths and serving stations."

Naresh Babu looked at the wall.

"Will all this be possible in the middle of a wedding?"

"If it is written down beforehand."

"And where will the separate food be kept?"

Malti pointed towards one corner of the kitchen.

Two medium-sized covered cauldrons stood empty there.

"In these."

Naresh Babu said at once, "Then people will say—the cooks took out the best vegetables for themselves first."

Malti replied, "Then take a counted portion from whatever is cooked for the guests. Do not cook separately."

"When should it be taken out?"

"Just before serving begins."

"In whose presence?"

Malti thought for a moment.

"In the presence of the person keeping the arrangements register."

For the first time, Naresh Babu was listening with full attention.

Malti continued, "A label will go on the cauldron—'Workers' meal, number seventeen.' And the time on the lid."

"And if the food for the guests runs short?"

"Then make fresh food as you did today when the guest count rose. Taking back the workers' share is not the solution."

Naresh Babu gave no direct answer.

In the blank margin of the register he wrote—

"Workers' meal—number beforehand."

Malti looked at it.

“Not ‘kitchen workers’. Write ‘working people’. There are lighting workers, cleaners, gatekeepers too.”

Naresh Babu stopped his pen.

That had not occurred to him before.

“They are all from different contracts.”

“Hunger is not on a separate contract.”

Naresh Babu wrote again—

“Working people—total number.”

This time Malti said nothing.

The air before dawn was entering the kitchen.

The empty plate hanging from the hook swayed gently.

Two weeks later there was another wedding in the same family.

This time it was the bride’s cousin.

The venue was different.

Naresh Babu was again in charge of the arrangements.

Malti’s team was called again.

Before work began, Naresh Babu arrived carrying a thin register.

“Let’s count today.”

Malti did not laugh.

Seriously, she began counting not names but numbers.

Kitchen—eighteen.

Servers—twelve.

Dishes—five.

Water—three.

Cleaning—four.

Lights and wiring—two.

Gate and vehicle parking—three.

Total: forty-seven.

Naresh Babu was startled.

“So many?”

Malti said, “Five hundred guests are counted. Why not forty-seven working people?”

Naresh Babu wrote 47 in the register.

Then he asked, “The same food for all of them?”

Malti said, “The main meal being served to the guests.”

The young man handling the lights was listening from a distance.

He said, “My shift will run late.”

Malti asked, “Can you eat in the first batch?”

“I’ll have to watch the wiring until half past seven.”

“Then the second.”

The gatekeeper said, “I cannot leave my post.”

Naresh Babu said, "Your plate will be covered and sent to the gate."

Malti looked at him.

What until yesterday had been only a kitchen arrangement was now spreading across the whole workplace.

At noon, the quantities for the main meal were measured.

Naresh Babu was present himself.

Malti said, "Before the guests are served, take out the share for the working people."

An assistant asked, "Won't that be called stealing?"

Naresh Babu replied, "It is written in the register."

Malti said nothing.

It struck her that justice often needs not a moral speech first, but a line on paper.

At seven in the evening, five minutes before the first serving began, two medium cauldrons were set aside.

One held rice.

One held the measured share of dal and vegetables.

Raw dough for the puris was weighed separately.

A small pot of curd.

Pieces counted out from the sweet box according to the number.

A label was attached—

"Workers' meal—47."

Below it, the time—

"6:55 p.m."

Malti read the label.

"No one's name."

Naresh Babu said, "The number is enough."

Ten people sat in the first batch.

Ganesh was still at the hearth.

Jamuna Devi was in the first batch.

When she sat down with her plate, Malti looked at her.

Malti remembered the empty plate from the previous wedding.

Jamuna took rice.

She took dal.

She took vegetables.

Laughing, she said, "Not just gravy today."

Malti said, "Eat slowly."

"How much time?"

"Twelve minutes."

"Slowly in twelve minutes?"

Both of them laughed.

After twelve minutes, the first batch got up.
 The second batch sat down.
 The work did not stop.
 There was a crowd at the serving tables, but half the servers remained there.
 The hearths were burning in the kitchen.
 Water was being filled.
 Dishes were being washed.
 And of the forty-seven people, some were eating in turn.
 At nine, a problem arose.
 The number of people from the groom's side again exceeded the estimate.
 Naresh Babu came quickly.
 "Malti ji, the vegetables will run short."
 Malti looked at the cauldrons.
 "Put on a fresh cauldron."
 "How long?"
 "Thirty-five minutes."
 "What do we serve immediately?"
 "There is dal and rice. There is another vegetable dish for now."
 Naresh Babu looked towards the covered cauldron where the workers' food was kept.
 His gaze rested there for a moment.
 Malti saw it.
 She said nothing.
 Naresh Babu himself looked away.
 "Put on a fresh cauldron."
 It was a small moment.
 There was no speech.
 There was no argument.
 But the arrangement made after the previous wedding was tested in that moment.
 The workers' meal did not become the first reserve for making up a shortage for the guests.
 By ten, the new vegetables were ready.
 The crowd slowly thinned.
 In the third batch, a covered plate was sent to the gatekeeper.
 When the young lighting worker returned after checking the wires, his portion was still being kept warm.
 The four women cleaners sat down late.
 One of them, Rekha Devi, asked, "Will the cost of this food be deducted from our wages?"
 Naresh Babu was there.

He replied at once, "No."
 Rekha asked again, "What if the contractor deducts it?"
 Naresh Babu opened the register.
 "It is written here—host's feast expense."
 Rekha looked at the register.
 She could not read all the letters.
 Malti read the line aloud to her.
 Rekha nodded.
 "All right."
 She began to eat.
 At half past eleven, Malti took her own plate.
 This time she was not the last.
 Ganesh was sitting opposite her.
 He said, "Malti Didi, where is the empty plate now?"
 Malti looked towards the hook in the kitchen.
 There was no plate hanging there.
 She said, "There is nothing wrong with a plate being empty."
 Ganesh did not understand.
 "Then?"
 "An empty plate should not mean that no one ever counted its share."
 Ganesh went on eating, mixing his dal into the rice.
 After the night ended, Naresh Babu checked the register.
 Working people—47.
 Meals taken—46.
 One gatekeeper had gone home midway.
 His covered plate remained.
 Naresh Babu asked, "What about this one plate?"
 Malti said, "Now this is truly leftover food."
 "Give it to someone?"
 "If it is safe, it can be given wherever the rules permit. But first write—one person did not take the meal."
 Naresh Babu wrote it down.
 "Is so much accounting necessary?"
 Malti said, "If you do not write it, next time the difference between 47 and 46 will again be put on someone's head."
 Naresh Babu laughed.
 "You'll put everything into the register."
 Malti smiled too.
 "Not everything. Only what keeps disappearing."
 By dawn, the washing of dishes was finished.

The plates set aside for forty-seven people were washed and stacked upside down in one pile.

One plate still stood apart from that pile.

The plate that had been covered for the gatekeeper and left unused.

Malti removed its cover.

The food had passed the time for which it could be kept safely.

She set it aside according to the rules.

The plate was washed.

It became empty.

Malti put it with the other plates.

This time, the plate was not empty because the food had run out.

It was empty only because the person meant to use it had left.

Its number was still recorded in the register.

The plate was empty.

The count was not.

The Three-Rupee Receipt

On the eastern side of Darbhanga's district bus stand stood a public toilet.

Above the doorway, blue letters on a white strip read: "Usage fee: 3 rupees."

The strip was new.

The table below it was old.

At one corner of the table lay a serial-numbered receipt book, at the other a small iron cash box, and in the middle an empty plate for counting coins.

Saroj Devi's shift ran from five in the morning until two in the afternoon.

She issued receipts, took money, mopped the floor, and if the tap stopped working, she also opened the lid of the tank inside.

On paper, her post was "attendant."

In the course of a day, four or five different jobs fitted inside that one word.

Before the first morning bus arrived, she wiped the table and opened the receipt book.

She entered the serial number of the first receipt in the register.

That day, the number was 4821.

Opening the cash box, she untied sixty rupees in change from a knot in the end of her sari.

Two ten-rupee notes, four five-rupee coins, and the rest in twos and ones.

Those sixty rupees were her own.

The contractor did not provide change.

"You can take it back out at the end of the day," Ramesh Babu from the accounts room used to say.

It was easy to say.

In the rush, which coin was hers and which belonged to the contractor was a calculation Saroj kept in her head.

At twenty past five, the first bus arrived.

The first passenger handed her three one-rupee coins.

Saroj tore off a receipt and held it out.

The passenger waved his hand.

"Don't need it."

Saroj set the receipt down on the table.

The next man gave her a five-rupee coin.

Saroj returned two rupees and offered him the receipt.

“Keep it.”

“The money?”

“The receipt.”

That receipt too remained lying on the table.

Within half an hour, eleven receipts had collected there.

A gust of air sent two of them to the floor.

Saroj bent and picked them up.

One had stuck beside a wet shoe.

She set it aside to dry.

By seven, the crowd had grown.

Afraid of missing their buses, people put coins on the table, ran inside, came out, and hurried back toward the buses.

“Take the receipt.”

“Don’t need it.”

“Take the receipt.”

“What will I do with a piece of paper?”

“You’re supposed to take it.”

“My bus will leave.”

Some people took the receipt and threw it down beside the doorway.

Some left it on the table.

Some did not even look toward Saroj’s outstretched hand.

At first, Saroj used to tear off a receipt for everyone.

Then one day, after seeing a sack of cleaning rubbish full of paper, the first contractor had told her, “Why tear a receipt for someone who won’t take it? Save the paper.”

From that day, Saroj had formed a habit.

If a user clearly said, “I don’t need it,” she took the money but did not tear off a receipt.

To her, the rule seemed like a way of saving paper.

No one had given her a written order.

No one had stopped her either.

And the work went on.

At two that Tuesday afternoon, when her shift ended, Saroj counted the money.

The total was eight hundred eighty-seven rupees.

She separated her own sixty rupees in change.

That left eight hundred twenty-seven.

At three rupees each, that accounted for two hundred seventy-five users, with two rupees left over.

Saroj counted again.

A coin had lodged in a groove in the table.
 When she took it out, the total came to eight hundred twenty-eight.
 Exactly two hundred seventy-six users.
 The last receipt torn from the book bore the number 5068.
 From 4821 through 5068, there were two hundred forty-eight receipts in all.
 That meant the money of twenty-eight users had been taken without any receipt being recorded.

Saroj wrote in her notebook: "Receipt not taken—28."
 She handed the money and the receipt book over in the accounts room.
 Ramesh Babu counted the cash first.
 Then he looked at the receipt numbers.
 "Twenty-eight extra?"
 "Yes. Twenty-eight people didn't take receipts."
 "Then why didn't you tear off the receipts?"
 Saroj paused.
 "They don't take them. The old contractor had said to save paper."
 Ramesh Babu scratched his head.
 "The paper was saved, but where did the account go?"
 Saroj showed him her notebook.
 "It's written here."
 Ramesh Babu looked at the line in the notebook.
 "You wrote 28. How am I to know whether it was 28, or 18, or 38?"
 Saroj did not answer.
 Ramesh Babu counted the money again.
 "Today extra money is being deposited, so no one will accuse you of stealing."
 He paused for a moment.
 "But if the arrangement stays like this, tomorrow the money could come up short. Then whose word will we believe?"
 Saroj's face hardened.
 "I do not take money out."
 "I am not saying that you do."
 "But the suspicion is the same."
 Ramesh Babu was silent for a few moments.
 "The suspicion is not about the person. It is about this arrangement. But when the arrangement is weak, the suspicion will fall on the person all the same."
 The words lodged in Saroj's mind.
 Even after she returned home that day, the receipt numbers remained with her—4821, 5068, twenty-eight.

That night, while she was cooking, her daughter asked, “Ma, are you counting coins?”

Saroj realized she had been moving her lips silently.

“No.”

“Then what?”

“Paper.”

The next day Saroj brought a small iron spike from home.

It had once been used for impaling old bills.

She placed a small block of wood at the right corner of the table and fixed the spike into it.

On a piece of paper she wrote: “Receipts not taken.”

The first passenger of the morning paid three rupees.

Saroj tore off a receipt.

“Here.”

“Don’t need it.”

Saroj impaled the receipt on the spike.

The second person did not take his either.

The second receipt went on top of the first.

By seven o’clock, twelve receipts were on the spike.

At eight, twenty-nine.

At ten, forty-seven.

Loose receipts no longer blew about on the table.

Saroj now tore off a receipt for every user, whether the person took it or not.

At the end of the shift, the serial count and the cash matched.

“Not taken”—seventy-one.

Ramesh Babu looked at the spike.

“What is this?”

“You had said the method was bad. This is the witness for those twenty-eight.”

“Today it isn’t twenty-eight. It’s seventy-one.”

“Then seventy-one.”

Ramesh Babu counted the receipts.

“Seventy-one indeed.”

Saroj said, “Now will anyone say I made up the number I wrote?”

Ramesh Babu smiled.

“Fewer people will say it now.”

The spike became part of the routine.

Three days later, Shanti Devi of the second shift fixed a spike to her table as well.

She said, “My receipts used to go straight into the sweeping.”

Saroj said, "The receipts went into the sweeping, but the suspicion stayed on my head."

Both women laughed.

For a week, the accounts remained clear.

At the end of each day, the last torn receipt number, the cash, and the spike—all three matched.

Saroj thought the problem had been solved.

But the problem was not as flat as a sheet of paper.

At noon on Saturday, the bus stand became unusually crowded.

Three buses arrived at once.

A line formed in front of the table.

A young man paid three rupees.

He did not take the receipt.

Saroj impaled his receipt on the spike.

A boy standing behind him glanced at the spike.

Saroj got up for two moments to check the water inside.

When she came back, the boy had one of the receipts from the spike in his hand.

"Where did you take that from?"

The boy started.

"It was lying right here."

"It was not lying there. It was on the spike."

"I thought it was waste paper."

He was trying to give the receipt to the person with him so that three rupees could be saved.

Saroj took the receipt back.

The elderly man with the boy said, "Let it go. It's only a matter of three rupees."

Saroj said, "It is a matter of three rupees, and that is why the account of three rupees will be spoiled."

The elderly man paid three rupees.

Saroj tore off a new receipt.

She marked the old one with a cancelling stroke of her pen and impaled it on the spike again.

From that day, the spike was moved behind the table.

But another difficulty appeared two days later.

Water from the tap dripped onto a receipt.

The paper softened and began to disintegrate.

Half the serial number was erased.

Saroj dried it.

Ramesh Babu saw it in the evening.

“Is this number 5783 or 5788?”

“5783.”

“You remember it.”

“Yes.”

“And I?”

Saroj was silent.

The testimony of the spike too had come to depend on a person’s memory.

The following week, an inspection team from the municipal body arrived.

Two officers inspected the toilet’s cleanliness, water, and fee board.

The third officer’s eye fell on the spike.

“What are all these?”

Ramesh Babu said proudly, “Receipts belonging to users who do not take them. For transparent accounting.”

The officer pulled out a receipt and looked at it.

“Where in the rules is this spike mentioned?”

“It is not in the rules. It is a local arrangement.”

“Fine. But what if the wind carries off five receipts?”

“It is kept behind the table now.”

“What if someone removes one?”

“We keep watch.”

“What if water falls on them?”

Saroj remembered the wet receipt.

The officer put the receipt back.

“This is a useful aid. But an employee’s honesty should not have to hang only from this spike.”

For the first time during the inspection, Saroj spoke.

“Then what should it hang on?”

The officer looked at her.

“That is something all of you will have to decide together.”

The inspection team left.

Gathering up the papers, Ramesh Babu said, “More work again.”

Saroj said, “My work has already increased. Now the paper work will increase for you.”

Ramesh Babu did not laugh.

The next day, a new complication arose at the change of the afternoon shift.

Saroj’s shift ended at two o’clock.

Shanti Devi arrived at two.

There was only one receipt book.

There was only one cash box as well.

At five past two, while Saroj was counting the money, a passenger placed three rupees on the table and went inside.

Saroj tore off a receipt.

Shanti asked, "Does that belong to your shift or mine?"

Saroj looked at the clock.

"Five past two."

"Then mine."

"But I took the money."

"And you tore the receipt."

The two women looked at each other.

Three rupees was a small amount.

The question was not small.

That day the accounts balanced, but the boundary between the shifts did not.

The next day Saroj made a sheet of paper.

At the top she wrote: "Shift Handover."

Below it, five lines.

"Opening receipt number."

"Closing receipt number."

"Cash."

"Change float."

"Signatures of both attendants."

Ramesh Babu looked at the sheet.

"If we write this much, the paperwork will grow."

"Do the lines belong to the users or to the accounts?"

"To both."

"Then reconcile five minutes before the shift changes."

"And the users?"

"The woman from the next shift will manage the table while the woman from the first shift counts the box."

Ramesh Babu turned the sheet this way and that.

"Why list the change separately?"

Saroj untied the knot in her sari.

She put sixty rupees on the table.

"Does this belong to the contractor?"

"No."

"Whose is it?"

"Mine."

Ramesh Babu was startled.

"You put your own money in the cash box?"

"How else do I take a three-rupee fee without change? People give ten-rupee notes, twenty-rupee notes."

"Why didn't you tell me before?"

"It had always been working, that is why."

"It had always been working"—those four words silenced both of them.

The spike had been working in the same way.

So had the habit of not tearing receipts.

So had the shift without reconciliation.

Where there was no system, workers kept filling the gaps with their own small arrangements.

Ramesh Babu counted the sixty rupees.

"From tomorrow, the contractor will provide the change."

"How much?"

"Ninety."

"Will it be written in the register?"

Ramesh Babu looked at Saroj.

"Yes, it will be written."

The new trial began the following Monday.

In the morning, a change pouch containing ninety rupees came from the accounts room.

The pouch bore the number C-3.

The register recorded: "Opening change: 90 rupees."

The opening number in the receipt book was 6121.

Saroj signed.

Ramesh Babu signed.

The rule was clear.

Whether or not the user took the receipt, a receipt would be torn off.

Receipts not taken would remain on the spike, but their number would be for information only.

The basic revenue calculation would come from the opening and closing serial numbers.

Ninety rupees in change would be separated from the cash.

The remaining money would be matched against the number of receipts.

At the change of shift, both attendants would check the numbers and the money together.

The spike was no longer the sole basis of proof.

Everything went smoothly until the afternoon on the first day.

Five minutes before two, Shanti arrived.

Saroj placed the receipt book in front of her.

Last receipt torn—6394.

Total receipts—two hundred seventy-four.

Expected amount—eight hundred twenty-two rupees.
Total in the cash box—nine hundred twelve.
Ninety set aside as change.
Balance—eight hundred twenty-two.
Shanti smiled.
“It matches.”
There were sixty-two receipts on the spike.
Saroj asked, “Do we count these?”
Shanti said, “Write ‘Not taken—62.’ But we won’t reconcile the money from that.”
Saroj entered it on the line.
Both women signed.
The first day’s trial was successful.
On the second day, a new problem appeared.
A passenger gave her twenty rupees.
Saroj returned seventeen.
The passenger left.
Ten minutes later Saroj noticed that a two-rupee coin was missing from the change pouch.
She strained her memory.
Could she have returned nineteen instead of seventeen?
Her heart gave a jolt.
Earlier, something like this would have thrown the entire day’s account out of balance at the end.
This time she immediately wrote in the register: “Possible change error: 2 rupees, 8:35.”
She told Ramesh Babu.
At ten o’clock, the same passenger returned to the bus stand.
From a distance he called, “Didi, you gave me two rupees too much.”
He placed the coin on the table.
Saroj did not strike out the line in the register.
Beside it she wrote: “Returned, 10:02.”
Ramesh Babu saw it.
“You wrote down even such a small thing?”
Saroj said, “If I had not, by evening those two rupees would have become a question about someone’s character.”
Ramesh Babu gave no answer.
On the third day, the same municipal officer returned for an inspection.
He first looked at the fee board.
Then the register.
Then the change pouch.

Then the spike.
“The spike is still here?”
Saroj said, “Yes. It shows that people still do not take their receipts.”
“But the accounting?”
Ramesh Babu showed him the new register.
The officer read the opening number.
He read the closing number.
He checked the cash.
He saw that the change was separate.
He saw the two signatures at shift handover.
“Who made this?”
Ramesh Babu pointed toward Saroj.
Saroj said, “First I made the spike. The paper came later.”
The officer said, “There was nothing wrong with the spike.”
Saroj replied, “But it was incomplete.”
The officer nodded.
After a week’s trial, the new system was made permanent.
The accounts room had a printed register prepared.
It had separate boxes for the opening and closing receipt numbers.
A separate one for the change float.
A separate one for cash deposited.
Space for two signatures at shift handover.
There was also a small box for the number of “Receipts not taken.”
Beneath that box, in fine print, it said: “For information; not the basis of
revenue reconciliation.”
Saroj read that line twice.
She liked it.
The spike was not removed.
But its responsibility had changed.
Now it was a record of people’s habit.
It was no longer the only testimony to an attendant’s honesty.
On the last Friday of the month, the morning rush was heavy again.
A middle-aged passenger put three coins on the table.
Saroj tore off a receipt and held it out.
“Don’t need it.”
Saroj offered it once more.
“Take it, if you want.”
“No. I’ll throw it away.”
Saroj impaled the receipt on the spike.
The passenger went inside.
At two in the afternoon, the shift changed.

Opening number—7401.
Closing number—7613.
A total of two hundred thirteen receipts.
Six hundred thirty-nine rupees.
The box contained seven hundred twenty-nine including change.
Ninety was set aside.
Balance—six hundred thirty-nine.
Shanti said, “It matches.”
Saroj counted the spike.
Fifty-one receipts.
In the register she wrote: “Not taken—51.”
Both women signed.
Saroj began removing the receipts from the spike and putting them into the day’s envelope.
One receipt slipped from her hand and fell to the floor.
Earlier, when a receipt fell like that, she would become anxious at once.
This time she bent down calmly.
She picked up the receipt.
She put it in the envelope.
On the table, the last line of the register had already been filled in.
“It matches.”

The Last Light

The clock at the town bus stand showed twenty past ten at night.

The last bus, the one scheduled for ten fifteen, had already passed through the gate.

Its red rear light flashed once at the distant bend and vanished.

The crowd on the platforms thinned at once.

The voices in front of the shops subsided.

The public-address system fell silent.

But the bus stand was not empty.

Kamli Devi stood on the third platform with a broom in her hand.

She did not do the main cleaning through the day; she did it after the last bus.

It was hard to sweep while the crowd was still there.

Scraps of paper, tea cartons, betel wrappers, water bottles and dust all revealed themselves at once after the buses were gone.

Near the gate, Shyama Devi's little tea stall was still open.

She was putting out the stove.

Two kettles had been turned upside down to dry.

She was measuring the leftover milk and pouring it into a small pot.

A passenger sat on the stone bench.

The jeep for his next village had not yet arrived.

Raghunath, the night watchman, was bent over the register.

He wrote down the time of the last bus.

"10:15 — departure."

Just below that line stood an old rule.

"Switch off the main lights ten minutes after the last bus departs."

Raghunath looked at the clock.

Ten twenty-five.

He went towards the switch box.

Kamli stopped sweeping and said, "Raghu-bhaiya, five minutes more."

Raghunath stopped his hand.

"The rule says ten minutes."

"What sort of rule sends my eyes home along with the bus?"

Raghunath did not laugh.
 He had not made the rule.
 He merely operated the switches.
 "Orders from above say to save electricity."
 Kamli said, "Save it. But how am I to sweep in the dark?"
 Raghunath said, "The gate light will remain on."
 Kamli looked towards the third platform.
 The single yellow light at the gate could not cast enough light that far.
 Raghunath pressed two switches.
 Six of the eight tube lights on the platforms went out at once.
 The light beneath the roof thinned.
 The shape of the bus stand changed in that very instant.
 The paper that had looked white before now turned grey.
 The patches of water that had shone before now merged with the colour of the floor.
 Kamli swept more slowly.
 From her stall Shyama called out, "Leave one light on here."
 Raghunath said, "The stall has to close anyway."
 Shyama replied, "The work of closing does not finish by itself when the light goes out."
 Raghunath said nothing more.
 The passenger on the bench switched on the light of his mobile phone.
 Kamli watched its streak of light move across the floor.
 She stopped sweeping.
 "Look, the man is sitting with his own light. Shall I tie a mobile phone to my broom too?"
 Embarrassed, the passenger lowered his phone.
 Raghunath switched one light back on.
 "Only one."
 Kamli said, "One will do for today's work."
 Raghunath wrote nothing in the register.
 He only looked at the time.
 At ten thirty-seven, Kamli leaned her broom against the wall.
 At ten forty, Shyama pulled down the tin shutter.
 The passenger's jeep arrived at ten forty-five.
 That day, apart from the gate light, all the main lights were switched off at ten forty-six.
 The next day, Naresh Babu, who was in charge of the electrical room, asked Raghunath, "Why were they on thirteen minutes longer yesterday?"
 Raghunath said, "The cleaning was still going on."
 "You know the rule?"

"I know it."

"Then?"

Raghunath did not answer directly.

"I had left one light on."

Naresh Babu looked at the electricity register.

Only two things were written there.

Main lights on — 5:42 p.m.

Main lights off — 10:46 p.m.

He asked, "The last bus?"

"10:15."

"Then that is thirty-one minutes extra."

Raghunath said, "Not all the lights."

Naresh Babu looked again at the register.

There was no separate box in it for "all" and "one."

He said, "In the account, the main lights are simply the main lights."

Raghunath remained silent.

At noon Kamli went to the office to collect cleaning supplies.

Naresh Babu was sitting there.

He had already heard about the previous night.

He stopped Kamli.

"You have a complaint about the lights?"

Kamli said, "Not a complaint. My eyes need light."

"The electricity bill is rising."

"I do not know by how much."

"Then how can the rule be changed without an account?"

Kamli turned the new bamboo handle of her broom in her hand.

"Write down my account too."

"What account?"

"How long the work continues."

Naresh Babu smiled faintly.

"The working hours are in the contract."

"The contract says till ten at night."

"Your shift ends at ten?"

"On paper."

"In reality?"

Kamli said, "As long as the last bus is late, the rubbish is late."

For the first time Naresh Babu looked at her closely.

Kamli added, "If I sweep in the daytime, five people will dirty it again. Only after the last bus do I get the whole floor at once."

Naresh Babu said, "Proof of that?"

Kamli smiled.

"You want proof from a broom?"
 Naresh Babu smiled too.
 "If you want an account, you need paper."
 Kamli said, "Then make the paper."
 The matter ended there that day.
 For three days the old rule continued.
 Ten minutes after the last bus, the lights were reduced.
 Sometimes Raghunath left one light on.
 Sometimes, afraid of Naresh Babu, he did not.
 Kamli changed the pace of her work according to the light.
 While the light remained, she cleaned the third platform.
 Once it went out, she moved to the area near the gate.
 The rear corner she left for the next morning.
 Shyama lit the small bulb in her own stall herself.
 The electricity for that bulb went through her separate meter.
 But the five-step stretch from the stall to the public tap remained dark.
 One night, while filling water, she stumbled over an empty bucket.
 The bucket rolled away with a clatter.
 Nothing happened.
 Shyama picked it up.
 She said nothing to Raghunath.
 The next night an elderly passenger asked the way to the toilet.
 From the gate Raghunath pointed with his hand.
 The old man walked in the wrong direction through the dark.
 Kamli stopped him and showed him the right way.
 The old man asked, "Why is there no light?"
 Kamli replied, "The bus has gone."
 The old man paused.
 "But I am still walking."
 The words stayed with Kamli all night.
 The next afternoon the bus stand had its monthly cleanliness inspection.
 Seema Jha, a junior officer from the municipal transport office, arrived.
 She inspected the floor, the toilets, the tap, the rubbish bins and the exit route.
 Kamli followed behind her.
 At the back of the third platform, Seema Jha noticed a thin line of dust.
 "Is the cleaning poor here?"
 Kamli said, "At night the light is switched off too soon."
 Naresh Babu was there as well.
 He immediately said, "It is the electricity-saving rule."
 Seema Jha asked, "At what time?"

"Ten minutes after the last bus."
 "When does the cleaning end?"
 Naresh Babu gave the time written in the contract.
 Kamli gave the actual time.
 The two times were different.
 Seema Jha wrote something on the paper.
 "Is anyone asking to keep the lights on all night?"
 Kamli shook her head.
 "No."
 "Then what do you need?"
 Kamli did not answer at once.
 Raghunath stood some distance away.
 Shyama's stall was closed, but she was inside washing the milk pot.
 Kamli said, "When the bus leaves, the bus's work ends. Not all the work of the bus stand."
 Seema Jha looked up from the paper.
 "Then until what time?"
 Kamli paused again.
 "How can I say that from one day?"
 Seema Jha looked at Naresh Babu.
 "Write it down for a week and see."
 Naresh Babu asked, "What should we write?"
 Seema Jha said, "The finishing time of every task that continues after the bus has gone."
 She drew five lines on the paper.
 Last bus departure.
 Cleaning finished.
 Stall closed.
 Last waiting passenger out.
 Main lights reduced.
 "And security?"
 Raghunath asked.
 Seema Jha said, "The gate security light is separate, isn't it?"
 "Yes."
 "That will remain on all night."
 Naresh Babu said, "If all the platform lights stay on, the bill will rise."
 Seema Jha replied, "Who said all the lights?"
 She looked up at the roof.
 The eight tube lights were controlled by three separate switches.
 Two were for the gate route.
 Three were for the middle section of the platforms.

Three were for the rear section.

Under the old practice, all three switches were turned on together in the evening.

At night, two switches were turned off together.

Seema Jha said, "First write down the times. Then we will see how much light is needed, and where."

The one-week trial began the following Monday.

Raghunath was given a new, thin register.

On the first night, the last bus left at 10:12.

Kamli finished cleaning at 10:34.

Shyama closed her stall at 10:29.

The last passenger left at 10:18.

The main lights were reduced at 10:36.

On the second night the bus left at 10:20.

That day a passenger from one of the buses had vomited.

Kamli had to wash the floor.

The cleaning ended at 10:52.

Shyama closed at 10:31.

The last passenger left at 10:26.

The lights were reduced at 10:54.

The third night was rainy.

The last bus left at 10:17.

Water was blowing onto the platform.

Kamli was drying the floor.

Shyama had pulled the tin shutter halfway down and was putting things away inside.

A student whose bus had left was waiting while calling his uncle.

Raghunath kept writing the times in the register.

The student left on a motorcycle at 10:46.

Shyama closed at 10:42.

Kamli finished sweeping and mopping at 10:58.

The lights were reduced at 11:00.

Naresh Babu looked at the register the next morning.

"For an hour?"

Raghunath said, "It rained last night."

"Forty-three minutes after the last bus."

"Yes."

"All the lights?"

"No."

This time Raghunath had written the details separately.

"Middle section — three lights. Gate — two. Rear — off."

Naresh Babu turned the register towards himself and looked at it.
 "Who added this box?"
 "I did."
 "Why?"
 "If I had not written it, all the lights would again be treated as the same."
 Naresh Babu said nothing.
 On the fourth night the cleaning finished early.
 Bus 10:14.
 Cleaning 10:28.
 Stall 10:25.
 Last passenger 10:19.
 Middle lights off at 10:30.
 On the fifth night a new problem arose.
 The last bus left at 10:16.
 Kamli had almost finished her work.
 Just then, at 10:38, an outstation bus that was running late entered the bus stand.
 That bus was to halt there for the night.
 Its passengers got down.
 Two families began looking for vehicles outside the gate.
 A woman went to the toilet with her child.
 Shyama half-opened her nearly closed stall again and gave them hot water.
 Kamli had to sweep the platform again.
 Raghunath looked at the first line in the register.
 "Last bus departure — 10:16."
 Below it he added a new line.
 "Late arrival — 10:38."
 Naresh Babu saw that line the next day.
 "That wasn't in the rule."
 Raghunath said, "The bus did not come after reading the rule."
 Naresh Babu laughed.
 "So now the bus is at fault too?"
 Raghunath said, "No one is at fault. The times were different."
 That night's cleaning ended at 11:02.
 Shyama closed at 10:58.
 The last passenger left at 11:06.
 The work lights were reduced at 11:08.
 On the sixth night the bus left on time.
 Kamli's work ended at 10:32.
 Shyama at 10:27.
 There were no passengers.

Work lights 10:34.
 The seventh night was completely quiet.
 Bus 10:13.
 Cleaning 10:30.
 Stall 10:26.
 Last passenger 10:15.
 Work lights 10:32.
 On the morning of the eighth day, all the times were totalled.
 Seema Jha came again.
 Naresh Babu brought the thick electricity register.
 Raghunath brought the thin night register.
 Kamli stood some distance away with her broom.
 Shyama too had been called.
 Seema Jha first read the times for the seven days.
 "On average, how long did the cleaning continue after the last bus?"
 Naresh Babu took out a calculator.
 Kamli said, "Whatever the calculator says."
 Naresh Babu added the figures.
 "About thirty-two minutes."
 "The stall?"
 "About twenty to twenty-five."
 "The last passenger?"
 "Not the same every day."
 Seema Jha said, "And the electricity?"
 Naresh Babu said, "If all eight lights had stayed on, it would have been more."
 "Did they?"
 "No. Three or five."
 "Then the difference?"
 Naresh Babu looked at his calculation.
 "Not as much as it had seemed before."
 Kamli asked, "How much?"
 Naresh Babu told her the figure.
 Kamli understood some of it and some she did not.
 She understood only this much: the matter was not impossible.
 Seema Jha got up to inspect the switch box.
 None of the three switches had a label above it.
 One had a soot mark.
 The second had a white scratch.
 A red thread was tied around the third.
 Raghunath said, "I know which is which."

Seema Jha said, "And when Raghunath is on leave?"
 Everyone fell silent.
 That day three small labels were made.
 "Gate/Exit."
 "Work Route."
 "Rear Platform."
 Naresh Babu asked, "Which is the work route?"
 Seema Jha said, "The route from the gate to the toilet, the tap, the stall and the broom store."
 Kamli interjected, "Half of the third platform too."
 Seema Jha asked, "Why?"
 "The rubbish bin is there."
 The label was changed.
 "Work Route/Rubbish Bin."
 A new two-week trial was fixed.
 The rule was simple.
 Five minutes after the last bus left, the extra lights on the rear platform would be switched off.
 The work-route lights would remain on until the recorded work was finished.
 The gate/exit security lights would remain on all night.
 If a bus arrived late, Raghunath or the watchman on duty could switch the work-route lights back on.
 The time of every switch change would be written in the register.
 On the line for the last task, the person concerned would put a short signature or thumb impression.
 Kamli said, "Do I have to sign every day?"
 Seema Jha said, "If the lights depend on the time your work ends, it is better that your time be recorded by your own hand."
 Kamli knew how to write her name.
 She could write "Kamli."
 On the first trial night she wrote 10:41.
 Beside it she wrote "Kamli."
 The letters were a little crooked.
 Raghunath said, "Shall I write the time for you?"
 Kamli said, "No. I have learned to read the clock."
 Shyama wrote her time too.
 Her letters were small.
 Over the two weeks, the new rule revealed a few inconveniences as well.
 One night Kamli wrote that her work was finished.

Five minutes later she remembered that a bucket had been left outside the broom store.

She went back inside.

By then the work-route lights had been switched off.

She said to Raghunath, "Turn them on again."

Raghunath did.

A second time was added to the register.

Kamli said, "I signed too soon."

Raghunath replied, "That is what the register is for. Strike out the mistake and write the new time."

He drew a thin line through the old time.

Beside it he wrote 10:47.

The next night Shyama closed her stall and left.

Kamli's work was still going on.

Shyama came back.

"The milk can is still inside."

She unlocked the stall.

Raghunath looked at the register.

Shyama laughed.

"Write my time again too?"

Kamli said, "The milk counts as work as well."

All three laughed.

But the time was written down.

On the third night, an employee from the electrical room said, "So much writing just for the lights?"

Naresh Babu was there.

He replied, "Earlier there was only one line, but that one line was measuring the wrong thing."

The employee asked, "Wrong?"

Naresh Babu said, "The bus's work. Not the bus stand's."

Kamli was listening from a distance.

She said nothing.

After two weeks, the electricity charges were compared.

The extra use was far less than keeping the lights on all night as before.

It was slightly more than under the old rule.

Naresh Babu said, "So electricity is saved and the work gets done too."

Seema Jha said, "It is not ideal. But it is workable."

Raghunath asked, "Permanent?"

Seema Jha said, "For three months first. Then we will review it."

The rule board was written again.

The old line was not erased.

A thin line was drawn through it.
 Below it came the new lines.
 "Reduce the extra lights after the last bus."
 "Keep the work-route lights on until the last recorded task is complete."
 "Gate/exit security lights remain on all night."
 "For a late arrival or necessary work, the work lights may be switched on again."
 Kamli read the board.
 Her eyes stopped at "last recorded task."
 She said to Raghunath, "So now the bus is not named?"
 Raghunath said, "The bus is named above. The work is named below."
 Kamli said, "Good."
 A month passed.
 The rule gradually became ordinary.
 At first people talked whenever the lights changed.
 Now Raghunath wrote down the time and changed the switches.
 Kamli filled in her line.
 Shyama filled in hers.
 Sometimes Raghunath wrote down the time of the last passenger.
 Sometimes a passenger whose last bus had gone sat there for five minutes.
 Sometimes for half an hour.
 Sometimes a bus arrived late.
 Sometimes nothing happened.
 In the last week of the three months, an inspection team came from the transport office.
 This time Seema Jha was not with them.
 It was another officer.
 He read the rule board.
 He looked at the electricity register.
 "Why does it say 'last task' here?"
 Naresh Babu did not tell the whole story.
 He took out the old seven-day trial register.
 The officer looked through the times.
 "Did electricity use increase?"
 "A little."
 "Lights all night?"
 "No."
 "Any security complaints?"
 "None in the last three months."
 "Cleaning?"
 Kamli's contract-inspection scores were shown to him.

The old note about dust on the third platform had not been repeated later.
 The officer closed the register.
 "All right."
 That was all he said.
 The rule remained in place.
 One winter night the bus stand emptied early again.
 The last bus left at 10:11.
 The wind was sharp.
 Shyama closed her stall at 10:25.
 One passenger left at 10:27.
 Kamli kept sweeping the floor.
 The extra lights on the rear platform had already been switched off.
 The three work-route lights were still burning.
 One light was not directly above Kamli, but a little ahead.
 As she swept, she moved into its circle of light.
 Then out of it.
 Then into the next circle.
 Raghunath sat near the gate with the register open.
 At ten thirty-eight, Kamli emptied the rubbish bin.
 At ten forty, she washed the broom.
 At ten forty-two, she locked the store.
 She came towards the gate.
 Raghunath turned the register towards her.
 Kamli wrote the time.
 "10:42."
 Below it, "Kamli."
 Raghunath asked, "Everything done?"
 Kamli looked back once.
 The third platform was empty.
 The tap was closed.
 The rubbish bin was covered.
 The broom was inside.
 Shyama's shutter was down.
 "Yes."
 Raghunath pressed the work-route switch.
 The three lights went out at once.
 The two security lights at the gate were still burning.
 Kamli tightened her shawl over her head.
 As she crossed the gate, she said, "Now switch these off."
 Raghunath said, "These stay on all night."
 Kamli stopped outside the gate and looked back.

The bus stand was not completely dark.
Nor was it fully lit.
The light for the work that had ended had gone out.
The light for the route that was still open remained.
Kamli set off for home.
In the register, the line for the night's last task had been filled in.
"10:42 — Kamli."

Outside the Count

The floodwater had receded, but its height still remained marked on the walls.

In some houses there was a brown line up to the waist, on some doorways up to the chest.

On some walls the mud had dried and cracked.

On others there were marks from new brooms.

In the town's last ward, sand had collected here and there along the lanes.

Shoes sank into that sand.

Pull a foot free, and a wet print remained behind.

That morning, the enumeration team went through the whole ward for the first time.

There were four people in the team.

Junior engineer Prabhakar Jha examined walls, roofs, and foundations.

Clerk Harinarayan carried the register.

Local worker Sunita identified people's homes.

And the newly appointed enumerator, Mrinalini, walked with a bundle of papers and two pencils.

The printed form in Mrinalini's hand had, as its first field, house number.

Second—owner's name.

Third—damage to the roof.

Fourth—damage to the wall.

Fifth—habitable or not.

At the bottom, in small type, there were two lines for remarks.

The form was small.

The ward was large.

The first house had no door.

A bamboo screen leaned to one side.

Sunita said, "This is Ramlochan Sahu's house."

Harinarayan wrote, "1. Ramlochan Sahu."

Prabhakar measured the wall.

"A serious crack on the right side."

Mrinalini looked at the roof.

Half the tiles had fallen.

Ramlochan Sahu was separating wheat from a soaked sack in the courtyard. He said, "Look at the back room too."

The team went to the back.

There was mud on the room's floor.

A waterline ran three feet up the wall.

A small iron stove lay overturned in one corner.

Near the doorway, two children's wet books had been spread out in the sun.

Mrinalini asked, "Who used to live in this room?"

Ramlochan said, "A tenant."

"Name?"

"Ramesh Mandal."

"How many people?"

"He, his wife, two children."

"Where are they now?"

"On the school veranda."

Harinarayan looked up from the register.

"The owner's name has been written. Next."

Mrinalini looked at the form.

There was no field for Ramesh Mandal's name.

On the first remarks line she wrote, "Back room: Ramesh Mandal family, 4."

Harinarayan said, "If you put this much in the remarks, the space will run out."

Mrinalini smiled.

"There is space for now."

Half the front wall of the second house had fallen.

The owner lived away.

An elderly woman was washing utensils at the doorway.

Sunita said, "This is Kamala Devi. The owner's sister."

Harinarayan asked, "The owner's name?"

"Shivnarayan Chaudhary."

"Where is he?"

"Surat."

"Who lived in the house?" Mrinalini asked.

Kamala Devi shaded her eyes with her palm.

"I did. And two boys in the front room."

"Two boys?"

"They work in a sweet shop. Their village is in another district."

"Names?"

"One is Shambhu. The other, Mukesh or Mahesh... I don't know exactly."

A voice came from inside the doorway: "Mukesh."

A thin young man came out.

"I am Mukesh Paswan."

"The other?"

"Shambhu Yadav. He is drying his tools just now."

"Tools?"

"Not the shop's. My own bicycle-repair tools. I do another job at night."

Mukesh went inside and brought out a rusted spanner, a screwdriver, and a small hammer wrapped in cloth.

"All of these were submerged in the water."

Harinarayan said, "This survey is for recording damage to the house."

Mukesh fell silent.

He wrapped the tools in the cloth again.

Mrinalini asked, "Do you live in this house?"

"Yes."

"For how long?"

"Eight months."

On the second remarks line Mrinalini wrote, "Rented room: Mukesh Paswan, Shambhu Yadav; 2 residents."

The space was full.

When they reached the third house, Harinarayan laughed.

"Where will you write the remarks now?"

Mrinalini did not answer.

The owner's register listed the third house under the name of Manorama Devi.

The house had four rooms.

In one, Manorama Devi lived with her granddaughter.

In the second lived Naseema Khatoon, who did sewing work.

In the third lived Kailash and Phulo, a couple who carried bricks.

The fourth room had been empty before the flood.

On the night the water rose, five neighbours had taken shelter in the empty room.

Mrinalini began asking each name.

Harinarayan said quietly, "Those who took shelter are not residents of this house."

"Right."

"Then don't write them."

"We'll record the permanent residents separately."

Mrinalini took a blank sheet from her bag.

At the top she wrote, "House 3 — Residents there."

First line—Manorama Devi, granddaughter Rinku.

Second—Naseema Khatoon, daughter Gulnaz.

Third—Kailash Sada, Phulo Devi, one child.

Below that she wrote separately, "Temporary shelter on the night of the flood: 5; not included in this resident count."

Prabhakar returned after measuring the wall.

He saw the blank sheet.

"What form is this?"

"None."

"Then?"

"I am writing down how many families were living inside the house."

Prabhakar was silent for a few moments.

"Compensation will not be decided from this paper."

"I am not writing a decision."

"People will think that if their names are written, they will get money."

Mrinalini nodded.

"That is why we will tell everyone this is only an enumeration."

Manorama Devi had been listening from a distance.

She said, "I understand that writing my name does not mean I will get money. But if my name itself is not written, who will know where I am?"

No one answered.

The team moved on.

Lane after lane.

Door after door.

The number of houses on the forms kept growing.

So did Mrinalini's blank sheets.

House 4—one owner-family.

House 5—owner away; three tenant families.

House 6—shop below, owner upstairs; watchman's room at the back.

House 7—one widow, one student tenant.

House 8—two brothers as owners, but separate kitchens; with an elderly uncle.

House 9—four seasonal labourers in one room.

House 10—closed.

"Closed" was easy to write.

Mrinalini looked through the crack in the doorway.

An overturned bucket on the floor.

A clothesline on the wall.

An earthen stove in the corner.

Sunita asked the neighbour.

"Who used to live here?"

"Three sisters. They work as cleaners at the hospital."

"Where have they gone?"

“To a relative’s house after the water rose.”
 “The owner?”
 “In Darbhanga town.”
 Harinarayan searched for the owner’s name in his register.
 “Jagdish Mishra.”
 Mrinalini wrote, “House 10: three sisters residing; names to be verified.”
 Harinarayan said, “What is the use of writing it without names?”
 “At least we will not say the house was empty.”
 By noon, twenty-six houses had been counted.
 The team sat on the school veranda.
 A relief kitchen was operating there.
 Steam rose from the rice.
 People stood in line holding plates.
 Mrinalini spread her papers on the ground.
 Harinarayan opened the main register.
 “Twenty-six houses.”
 Prabhakar said, “Eight severe, eleven moderate, seven light.”
 Mrinalini counted her lines.
 “Thirty-two families.”
 Harinarayan looked startled.
 “Thirty-two in twenty-six houses?”
 “Yes.”
 “People?”
 “One hundred and four. Some names still need verification.”
 Sunita said, “And we haven’t even covered half the ward yet.”
 Prabhakar kept drinking water.
 Mrinalini lifted the main form.
 “On these twenty-six pages, how many signs are there of those one hundred and four people?”
 Harinarayan replied, “The form is not for counting people.”
 “Right.”
 “It is a structural-damage form.”
 “Right.”
 “Then why are we trying to read both things together?”
 Mrinalini folded the paper.
 “Because in the relief room, people ask the questions, not walls.”
 Prabhakar smiled faintly.
 “Don’t say that sentence in front of an officer.”
 “Why?”
 “He will say—even walls, after all, are for people.”
 Everyone laughed.

The laughter was brief.
 The line for rice moved forward.
 At that moment a child came and stood near Mrinalini's papers.
 He had a soaked school identity card in his hand.
 The photograph inside the plastic had blurred.
 The child asked, "Is my name written?"
 Mrinalini asked, "What's your name?"
 "Sonu."
 "Full name?"
 "Sonu Kumar."
 "Home?"
 The child pointed toward the main road.
 "The one with the red door."
 Sunita understood.
 "House five."
 Mrinalini looked at the blank sheet.
 House five listed three tenant families, but not the child's name.
 Only the names of the heads of families and the number of members.
 Mrinalini said, "Your family has been counted."
 The child asked again, "Me?"
 Mrinalini paused for a moment.
 "Yes, you too."
 The child walked away.
 At the top of the blank sheet, Mrinalini added a new heading: "Number of family members."
 Not everyone's names.
 The number clearly.
 After noon, the team went to the lower part of the ward.
 The water had receded later there.
 The mud was still wet.
 A piece of plastic was caught on a bamboo pole.
 "12" had been written in white chalk on the door of one house.
 Prabhakar said, "House twelve."
 Sunita stopped him.
 "No, twelve is the old municipal number. In our count this will now be twenty-seven."
 Harinarayan laughed.
 "One house, two numbers."
 Mrinalini said, "And now we'll see how many counts are inside it."
 The owner of the house was Vasudev Mahato.
 He was shovelling mud out of his courtyard.

Prabhakar asked, "How high did the water rise?"
 Vasudev put his hand on the wall.
 "Up to here."
 "The roof?"
 "Fine."
 "The foundation?"
 "Settled a little at the back."
 Harinarayan wrote the owner's name.
 Mrinalini asked, "Who lived there?"
 Vasudev began counting.
 "Me, my wife, my younger son."
 "And?"
 "Sarita in the front room."
 "Sarita?"
 "She does domestic work. With two daughters."
 "And?"
 Vasudev looked toward the back.
 "Ramvriksh used to live near the storehouse."
 "Used to?"
 "I haven't seen him since the night of the flood."
 Mrinalini was not startled.
 "Where did he go?"
 "He is sometimes seen at the school. Perhaps in the relief camp."
 "Family?"
 "Alone."
 "Work?"
 "With a mason."
 Mrinalini wrote.
 House 27.
 Owner-family—3.
 Tenant Sarita Devi—3.
 Resident Ramvriksh Sada—I, present location pending verification.
 Total—7.
 Vasudev looked at the paper.
 "Ramvriksh too has been written down?"
 "Yes."
 "He has no papers or anything."
 "We are not distributing identity cards right now."
 "Then?"
 "We are writing down who used to live here."
 Vasudev rested the mud-filled shovel on the ground.

"That's right. His trunk is still there."
 A thin tin trunk lay near the storehouse.
 Mud had caked onto the lock.
 On top of the trunk, the letters "Ra" could be seen in white paint.
 Mrinalini did not open the trunk.
 She only wrote, "Evidence of residence available."
 Harinarayan was watching from a distance.
 "Now even a trunk will become a witness?"
 Mrinalini said, "Even if there is no name, at least there is some sign."
 By the end of the day, thirty-seven houses had been counted.
 The main register contained the names of thirty-seven owners.
 Mrinalini's separate sheets listed sixty-one families.
 A total of one hundred and seventy-three people.
 The names or present locations of eleven people still awaited verification.
 Seven families were in houses whose owners did not live in the ward.
 Nine families were tenants.
 Four groups were labourers sharing a single room.
 Two elderly people were listed as part of an owner's family but kept separate
 kitchens.
 Harinarayan counted the figures again.
 "Thirty-seven houses. Sixty-one families."
 He scratched his head.
 "If this register goes up to the office, it will raise a lot of questions."
 Mrinalini said, "If it doesn't, the people will become fewer."
 Prabhakar gathered the papers.
 "Tomorrow there is a review at the block office. We'll see there."
 The next day, nine teams sat in the review room.
 A map hung on the wall.
 Tea on the table.
 The smell of wet shoes.
 Block officer Anil Kumar asked each team for its figures in turn.
 "Ward one?"
 "Forty-two structures."
 "Ward two?"
 "Forty-nine."
 "Ward three?"
 "Thirty-seven," Prabhakar said.
 Anil Kumar wrote it down.
 "Severe?"
 "Twelve."
 "Moderate?"

“Sixteen.”

“Light?”

“Nine.”

Then Prabhakar said, “There is one additional list.”

Anil Kumar looked up.

“What list?”

Mrinalini placed the bundle of blank sheets in front of him.

“Of the people who were living there.”

The room fell silent.

Anil Kumar read the first page.

“This is not on the form.”

“No.”

“Why was it made?”

“Because in thirty-seven houses we found sixty-one families.”

Two people in the room looked at each other.

Anil Kumar read the papers again.

“This cannot become a compensation-eligibility list.”

“I haven’t written that it is.”

“Was that explained to the people?”

“Everyone who asked was told that this is only a resident count. No promise of money or eligibility.”

Anil Kumar looked toward Harinarayan.

“You were present?”

“Yes.”

“Were people confused?”

Harinarayan thought for a moment.

“Some people asked. But Mrinalini kept explaining it clearly.”

Anil Kumar’s finger stopped on one line of the paper.

“‘Evidence of residence available’—what is this?”

Mrinalini told him about Ramvriksh’s trunk.

“The person was not found. The owner says he lived there. His trunk is still there. It is marked as pending verification.”

Anil Kumar turned the page.

“Three sisters, names pending verification.”

“Information from a neighbour.”

“So the list is not fully reliable.”

“That is why it says pending verification.”

The room fell silent again.

Rekha Devi, supervisor of another team, said, “In my ward too, one house has five tenant families. The main form carried only the owner’s name.”

A member of a third team said, "I have a group of brick-kiln labourers. There is no owner's house, only huts. Which category do I put them in?"

Anil Kumar leaned back in his chair.

"We are mixing two things right now—structural damage and affected people."

Prabhakar said, "That is what it seems to me as well."

"But the form sent from above is for structures."

Mrinalini said, "Then let the structural form remain as it is. A separate supplementary register can be made."

"On what basis?"

"Information about residents. The level of verification can be marked separately."

Anil Kumar did not agree at once.

He picked up his tea.

After a sip, he looked at the papers again.

"If a separate register is made, three things must be clear."

Mrinalini picked up her pencil.

"First—this is not an approval of compensation."

She wrote it down.

"Second—this register will not decide the rights of either the house owner or the resident."

She wrote that down.

"Third—one person must not be counted in two places."

"Right."

Rekha Devi said, "One fourth point—people who took temporary shelter should not be mixed with permanent residents."

"Right."

Harinarayan said, "And if a name cannot be found?"

Anil Kumar said, "Write the number, write the source, write pending verification. Do not turn an estimate into a confirmed fact."

Mrinalini wrote four headings.

In the room, the old printed form lay beside the blank sheets.

Anil Kumar said, "By this evening, make a one-page supplementary format. Tomorrow all teams will try it."

Mrinalini asked, "Will it be sent upward?"

"First we'll look at the figures."

"And compensation?"

Anil Kumar answered plainly.

"That is a separate decision under the rules. This register does not promise it."

"Right."

“But we need to know the number of affected people.”

That sentence was not written on the paper.

But everyone heard it.

That evening four people kept working on the layout of the supplementary page.

At the top, the heading: “Damaged Site: Resident Details.”

First field—house number.

Second—name or identification of family/group.

Third—number of members.

Fourth—basis of residence: owner/tenant/service room/shared/other.

Fifth—present location.

Sixth—source of information.

Seventh—verified/pending verification.

At the bottom, in bold, they wrote, “These details do not in themselves create a right to compensation.”

Harinarayan read it.

“Will people understand the word ‘in themselves?’”

Sunita said, “In the field we will say it plainly.”

Mrinalini added another line below: “Having a name recorded is not a promise of receiving money.”

Harinarayan laughed.

“They will understand that.”

On the third day, the team went back into the ward.

This time they had the supplementary page along with the main form.

At house one, Ramlochan Sahu was outside.

Ramesh Mandal had also returned from the relief school.

Mrinalini said, “Yesterday I wrote your name in the remarks. Today there is a separate resident register.”

Ramesh asked, “Will I get anything from this?”

“I am not promising anything right now.”

“Then why the name?”

“So that it is not recorded that only the owner of this house was affected.”

Ramesh looked at Mrinalini for a few moments.

Then he said, “All right. Write four people.”

“You, your wife, two children?”

“Yes.”

“Where are you now?”

“School veranda. We probably won’t sleep here tonight.”

“Why?”

Ramlochan said from the side, “The back wall is still wet. It isn’t fit to live in.”

Prabhakar nodded.

“That is also written on the main form.”

Mrinalini wrote the present location on the supplementary page.

Owner and tenant now appeared on separate lines beneath the same house number.

Ramlochan looked at the paper.

“Now it shows that I wasn’t living in the house alone.”

Ramesh smiled.

“You weren’t living alone before the flood either.”

Ramlochan laughed too.

The matter ended there.

The three sisters had returned to house ten.

Their names were Sangita, Rekha, and Pramila.

All three worked as cleaners at the hospital.

Pramila said, “Our belongings were lost in the water, but the house is not ours.”

Mrinalini said, “Ownership of the house is one field. Residents are another.”

“Money?”

“No promise.”

“All right.”

Sangita opened her wet iron trunk.

Inside were clothes, an old hospital identity card, a small image of a deity, and strips of medicine.

She said, “Do all these have to be written down?”

“No. Only that you lived here, the number of members, and your present location.”

Sangita closed the trunk.

“Then that’s fine.”

Ramvriksh was found at house twenty-seven.

He was living under a tarpaulin in one corner of the school grounds.

Sunita brought him along.

As soon as Ramvriksh saw his tin trunk, he touched the lock.

“I thought the water had carried it away.”

Vasudev said, “I lifted it and put it on bricks.”

Ramvriksh said nothing.

Mrinalini asked, “How long have you been living here?”

“Two years.”

“Rent?”

“Not cash. I watch the storehouse at night, and get the room in return.”

Mrinalini looked at the field for basis of residence.

“Service room.”

Ramvriksh asked, “So I’m not a tenant?”

“We’re writing the arrangement as you describe it. Is ‘service room’ right?”

“Right.”

“Where are you now?”

“School grounds.”

“Members?”

“One.”

Mrinalini marked him as verified.

Yesterday’s “pending verification” was crossed out.

Ramvriksh asked, “How much damage did you write for my home?”

Prabhakar said, “The rear part of this house is in the moderate-damage category.”

“My room?”

Prabhakar looked at the paper.

“Not fit to live in until it dries and is inspected.”

Ramvriksh nodded.

He tried to open the lock on his trunk.

The lock was jammed with mud.

Vasudev went to fetch oil.

The team moved on.

For four days the supplementary register was filled in.

Ward one: forty-two structures, seventy families.

Ward two: forty-nine structures, seventy-four families.

Ward three: thirty-seven structures, sixty-one families.

Ward four: seventy-two structures, seventy-nine families.

In some wards the difference was small.

In some it was large.

Especially in lanes where rooms were rented out, labourers lived behind shops, or several kitchens operated within one courtyard.

At the block office, two figures were written beside the map.

“Damaged structures: 200.”

“Recorded affected families/groups: 284.”

Below them: “Preliminary; verification continuing.”

In red ink Anil Kumar wrote, “Not a compensation list.”

No one objected.

Because now the two numbers each had their own meaning.

A week later, an inspection team came from the district.

They examined the main forms.

The supplementary register too.

One officer asked, "On whose orders were these additional details collected?"

Anil Kumar said, "The need arose in the field."

"It isn't on the state form."

"The original form has not been changed."

"Then what is this used for?"

"To reconcile numbers for relief sites, temporary shelter, water, sanitation, and family contact."

The officer turned the pages.

"Compensation?"

"Separate rules."

"List of those eligible for assistance?"

"Separate verification."

"Then fine. Keep the heading clear."

Mrinalini was listening from a distance.

The matter ended there.

No grand order came.

No applause.

The supplementary register simply became one new page in the bundle of registers.

Two weeks after the flood, the water had dried completely.

The sand in the lanes was swept to the sides.

Some houses had begun to receive a coat of limewash.

Some doorways were still crooked.

On her final verification round, Mrinalini went to house five.

The red door was half open.

Sonu was outside drying his notebook.

The moment he saw Mrinalini, he asked, "Is my name written?"

Mrinalini laughed.

"Your family is written down. Four members."

"Me?"

"You too, among those four."

Sonu was not satisfied.

"Which one of the four am I?"

Mrinalini looked at the line bearing the head of the family's name.

"This register doesn't list every member by name."

Sonu made a face.

Mrinalini took a small slip of paper from her pocket.

"Tell me your full name."

"Sonu Kumar Paswan."

On her personal work list she wrote, "House 5: child Sonu Kumar Paswan—member verification from school list."

"Now?" Sonu asked.

"Now your name will appear in the verification."

"Money?"

Mrinalini burst out laughing.

"You too with the same question?"

Sonu laughed as well.

"Everyone asks."

"My answer is the same—no promise."

Sonu turned the notebook over in the sun.

Mrinalini moved on.

In the ward's last lane, the wall of one house had been replastered.

The old waterline was hidden beneath the limewash.

The municipal chalk number still remained near the doorway.

"37."

Five people in the owner's family lived in that house.

Two tenant students lived in the back room.

Under a small lean-to, a woman who did sewing work lived with her daughter.

The main form said, "House 37. Owner: Devkinandan Jha. Moderate damage."

The supplementary page had three lines.

Owner-family—5.

Tenant students—2.

Service/work-room residents—2.

Total—9.

Mrinalini clipped the two pages together.

Harinarayan stood beside her.

He said, "So all thirty-seven houses are complete now?"

"Yes."

"Anything still pending verification?"

"The present locations of two families. The names have been confirmed."

Harinarayan closed the main register.

"On the first day I thought one name for one house was enough."

Mrinalini said, "Perhaps it was enough for a structure."

"Not for people."

Mrinalini did not answer.

A relief vehicle passed outside the lane.

A thin layer of dust rose.

The chalked "37" on the wall blurred, then came into view again.

Mrinalini looked at the last line of her supplementary page.

“Total residents — 9.”

There were two counts for the same place.

Both were correct.

Both were different.

The flood had left its line on the wall.

The register was now leaving a line for the people who had lived within it as well.



A story lives as long as people and language live.

Gajendra Thakur's three hundred selected stories form a vivid mirror of the many shapes of life in Mithila, Vajji and Anga: folk life, human relationships, changing times, village and town, sorrow and joy, tradition and modernity, nature and society, women and men, childhood, old age, life away from home, memory, struggle and hope.

Across these three volumes, the simplicity of the people's language, the depth of life, and the cultural pulse of Mithila, Vajji and Anga dwell together.

INSIDE VOLUME I

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The Broken Clock · The Star on the Roof · The Last Light*



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THE
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Three Hundred Selected Stories

STORIES 101 – 200

GAJENDRA THAKUR

THE HUNDRED-STORY TRILOGY

VOLUME II

Three Hundred Selected Stories

GAJENDRA THAKUR

The Hundred-Story Trilogy · Volume II

Gajendra Thakur

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Gajendra Thakur

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STORY 101

Beyond the Embankment

Fourteen years had passed since New Bahuara was settled.

On government maps it was called “Rehabilitation Sector-3,” but people themselves called it New Bahuara.

Old Bahuara lay beyond the embankment.

In the rains, when the reservoir filled, it was hard even to look toward the old village.

In winter, as the water receded, a raised patch of earth appeared in the distance like an island, but the old path to it no longer existed.

The village shrine, too, had stood there.

Outsiders hearing “village shrine” imagined a large temple.

Old Bahuara had no such temple.

There was an old pakar tree, a mud platform beneath it, a small piece of black stone at the centre, and a single lamp burning at dusk.

That was all the shrine was.

There was no permanent priest.

The turn for lighting the lamp passed from house to house.

If one household ran short of oil, a neighbour supplied it.

If the family of a house was away, the next household lit the lamp, but in the register the turn remained recorded in the absent household’s name.

Devkali Devi remembered this better than anyone.

She was seventy-two.

In New Bahuara her house stood at the end of the third row.

In front were two flowerpots, a tulsi altar, and an old wooden seat beneath the bamboo.

Most evenings Devkali sat there, looking toward the embankment.

Her grandson Chandan would ask, “Grandmother, what do you see over there?”

Devkali would say, “What can no longer be seen.”

The answer never satisfied Chandan.

He had been born in New Bahuara itself.

Old Bahuara was a story to him.

One day a notice came from the panchayat.

A meeting would be held to decide how to use the public open ground in the middle of the rehabilitation settlement, lying vacant for years.

Sometimes children played gulli there, sometimes paddy was spread to dry, and sometimes rainwater pooled there during the monsoon.

At the meeting Raghunandan Jha proposed, "Let us build the village shrine."

A few people agreed at once.

"The old shrine has gone under water," someone said. "A new village is incomplete without a shrine."

From the second row Lalan Mahato said, "If it is built, it should be in the middle. Why in front of the first row?"

Raghunandan replied, "This is the middle."

"The patch in front of your house is the middle?"

Laughter rose, then died almost at once.

Some said the old shrine had stood near the Mahato quarter.

Others said its approach ran through the Brahmin quarter.

One elderly man claimed that the first lamp at the shrine had always been lit by members of his lineage.

At this Devkali spoke in the meeting for the first time.

"No. That is not right."

Every eye turned toward her.

Devkali said softly, "The first lamp belonged to no single lineage. There was a turn."

Raghunandan smiled. "Auntie, who can remember something that old?"

Devkali did not answer.

She rose and went home.

Chandan followed behind her.

At home Devkali brought down an old trunk kept atop the grain bin.

Inside were old marriage papers, two yellowing photographs, a copy of a field survey, and a thin register wrapped in cloth.

On its cover, in lampblack, were written the words: "Lamp Turns."

Chandan read it and stared in surprise.

"This belongs to the shrine?"

"Yes, to the shrine."

"How did it come to you?"

"Your grandfather kept the turn-list for five years. The day we left the village, all the papers were wet. He wrapped this book in that cloth and brought it with him."

Chandan turned the pages.

There were names.

No amounts of money.

The first page listed the names of forty-two households in order.

Against each name there was only a small mark—whether the lamp had been lit or not.

In one place it said, "Oil given by Sukni."
 Elsewhere: "Household away—the next turn lit the lamp."
 Between the names of two households, one line read: "Rain. Path closed.
 Lamp in the morning."
 Chandan said, "There is no sign here that any lineage had the first right."
 Devkali looked at him.
 "Ownership of the shrine did not lie in the lamp; it lay in the turn."
 The next day Chandan carried the register to the meeting.
 Devkali did not go.
 She said, "Show them the book. The rest is for all of you to decide."
 The register passed from hand to hand at the meeting.
 Raghunandan read the first page.
 His lineage stood seventh in the order.
 Lalan Mahato's grandfather was twelfth.
 Sukni of the Musahar quarter was fourteenth, with three notes beside her
 name recording oil supplied for other households.
 No donation amount appeared beside any name.
 No honorific.
 No "chief."
 Chandan said, "We can match the old turns with the numbers of the new
 houses."
 The meeting did not reach an answer at once.
 Of the forty-two families, eight no longer lived in New Bahuara.
 Some had moved to the city.
 In one family only a daughter survived, and she lived in another village.
 And New Bahuara now had seven families absent from the old village
 register—new households created by marriage, division of families, and later
 settlement.
 Raghunandan said, "Then how can the old register work now?"
 Chandan said, "The old register shows us the rule, not a final list of names."
 At that, a few people fell silent.
 Madhubala Devi, who had married into the new settlement, asked, "Will
 my household have a turn or not?"
 No one had an immediate answer.
 Lalan Mahato said, "If new households are not added, this shrine will be a
 memory, not a village."
 This time Raghunandan did not object.
 For three days Chandan and two school students matched the old names
 with the new house numbers.
 They prepared a file.
 First column—the name in the old register.
 Second—the present family.

Third—the new house number.

Fourth—blank if the old family was no longer there.

Fifth—newly added family.

Devkali looked over the file.

She asked, “Why have you not struck out the names that are vacant?”

Chandan said, “They will remain for remembrance.”

“And the turns?”

“The turns will belong to the living households.”

Devkali nodded.

Then another dispute arose: should a masonry temple be built on the open ground, or only a platform?

Raghunandan wanted a proper structure.

His argument was that the new village needed a “proper shrine.”

Devkali asked, “What does proper mean?”

“A roof, a door, an idol, an enclosure.”

“Did the old one have an enclosure?”

“No.”

“A door?”

“No door either.”

“Then why should the first thing in the new one be an enclosure?”

Raghunandan said nothing.

In the end it was decided that a low platform would be built in the middle of the open ground.

Around it would be an earthen ledge where people could sit.

No plaque bearing any household’s name would be put up.

There would be no donors’ list.

There would be a small place for the lamp.

The rest of the ground would remain the panchayat’s public open space.

On the first day of construction, someone proposed bringing earth from the old village for the platform.

Devkali refused again.

“Let that soil remain there.”

“Then how will the memory come here?” Chandan asked.

Devkali said, “Memory does not arrive in sacks.”

The platform was made from the soil of New Bahuara.

A new Lamp-Turn Register was prepared.

At the top of the first page they wrote: “Old order preserved in remembrance; present turns belong to all living households.”

The old forty-two names were copied onto a separate page.

After that, turns were assigned to all forty-nine households of New Bahuara.

The first turn fell to Madhubala Devi’s house.

No one had deliberately put her name first.

The list had been arranged by house number, and hers happened to be the smallest.

Madhubala felt awkward.

“But I never even saw Old Bahuara.”

Devkali said, “Does that make your turn any less?”

At dusk Madhubala came with her daughter Rani.

Rani poured oil into the lamp.

Madhubala lit the wick.

No conch shell was blown that day.

There was no inauguration.

Raghunandan came too, but gave no speech.

Lalan Mahato sat at one corner of the platform.

Chandan made the first mark in the new register.

Devkali sat a little way off on her wooden seat.

The flame of the lamp was very small.

Whenever the wind rose, Rani cupped her palm around it.

After a while Chandan went over to Devkali.

“Grandmother, is this the same shrine now?”

Devkali looked toward the black line of the embankment.

“No. Not the one from there.”

Chandan was puzzled.

“Then what is this?”

Devkali pointed to the register.

“Its place is over there.”

After a moment’s silence, she added—

“Here, our turn goes on.”

STORY 102

Vacant Post

The morning's first key was kept in the knot at the end of Jamuna Devi's sari.

It was the key to the Bellahi Health Centre.

The centre's gate opened by her hand a little before eight each morning.

Jamuna swept the veranda, opened the windows of two rooms, and wiped the wooden chair in the doctor's room with a cloth.

For five years that chair had stood almost always empty.

On the wall hung a brass-coloured sign that read: "Doctor."

Beneath it, the white strip meant for a name remained blank.

The building was not new.

Built nine years earlier, the centre stood between four villages and three hamlets.

For its first two years, a doctor had come three days a week.

Then he was transferred.

No one was posted in his place.

On paper the post was sanctioned; the building existed, there was a cupboard for medicines, an examination table, even an electric fan.

Only the doctor was missing.

On Tuesdays and Fridays, health assistant Savita Kumari came for the scheduled work of vaccinations, blood-pressure checks, and antenatal examinations.

She did whatever lay within her authority.

All other patients had to be sent to the block hospital.

It was eighteen kilometres away.

No bus went there directly.

First one took a shared vehicle to the crossroads, then another conveyance onward.

Besides the fare for the journey there and back, most people lost a day's wages.

Jamuna entered none of this arithmetic in any register.

But she remembered people's faces.

On Monday Sita Sada of Nadiyari hamlet had come complaining that her son's ear hurt.

Jamuna had told her, "There is no doctor today, sister."

Sita had asked, "Tomorrow?"

"Not tomorrow either."

“The day after?”

Jamuna had been unable to answer.

That day Sita had taken her son and set off toward the crossroads.

On Wednesday Ramlochan Mandal came with a swollen hand.

On Thursday Munni Khatoon came because her elderly mother-in-law was having difficulty breathing.

On Saturday Haricharan Paswan, who carried bricks for a living, came with pain in his lower back.

Jamuna had to point them all in the same direction.

Slowly, she acquired a strange habit.

Whenever someone came looking for a doctor and had to turn back, she tied a small knot at one end of an old length of rope.

The rope had originally been bought for hanging a curtain.

The curtain was never put up.

The rope lay in a corner of the storeroom.

Jamuna herself no longer remembered what had made her tie the first knot.

Perhaps it was the day an elderly farmer had changed vehicles twice to reach the hospital and had not managed to return until evening.

The knot had no official meaning.

No date.

No name.

No seal.

Only one person turned away.

Within a few months the knots had grown so dense along the rope that it was difficult to straighten.

Jamuna hung it from a nail at the back of the doctor's room.

One day Savita noticed it.

“What is this knotted rope?”

Jamuna said, “A road.”

Savita laughed.

“A road like this?”

“One knot for each person sent from here to there.”

Savita's laughter stopped.

She took the rope in her hands.

“How many knots are there?”

“I haven't counted.”

“Why don't you count them?”

Jamuna said, “Will counting fill the post?”

For a while neither of them spoke.

At the beginning of winter that year, word came that an inspection team from the district was due to visit.

As soon as the notice arrived, the building's broken doorframe was painted.

A fresh coat of limewash went onto the veranda wall.

The bottles in the medicine cupboard were arranged neatly.

Jamuna was told that the doctor's room must be kept especially clean.

At ten on the morning of the inspection, a young doctor arrived on a motorcycle.

Jamuna had never seen him before.

Savita said softly, "He is from the Sonapur centre. He will sit here today."

Jamuna nodded. "Yes, I understand."

The young doctor was courteous.

He sat in the chair, saw patients, listened to the complaints of two feverish children, and checked an elderly person's blood pressure.

Word spread that a doctor had arrived.

By noon the veranda was full.

Sita came again from Nadiyari hamlet, bringing her son.

The boy's ear was well now, but she had come to show the doctor her own headache.

She smiled when she saw him.

"Will you be staying here now?"

The doctor was silent for a moment.

Then he said, "I am here today for the inspection. My post is at Sonapur."

Sita's smile stopped where it was.

She made no reply.

She folded her prescription and tucked it into the end of her sari.

At around two o'clock, three motorcars stopped at the gate.

The inspection team had arrived.

The building was examined.

The cupboard was opened.

The fan was switched on.

In the doctor's room someone asked, "What is the patient load?"

The Sonapur doctor looked toward Savita.

Savita gave the figure.

An officer on the team noticed the blank name strip on the wall.

"Permanent post?"

Savita said, "Vacant for five years."

The officer turned a page.

"Has a proposal been sent?"

"Several times."

"I'll note it."

He said, "All right," and moved on to the next room.

Jamuna stood beside the door.

Her eyes went to the nail at the back.

The rope was not there.

While the building was being cleaned, an employee from the block office had had it put away in the storeroom. "This useless thing should not be left out in front."

The inspection ended.

The motorcars drove away.

The Sonapur doctor, too, left at three.

That evening Jamuna opened the storeroom.

The rope lay in the dust.

She picked it up and shook the dust from it.

The knots were exactly as they had been.

The next day the doctor's chair was empty again.

Sita did not come that morning.

Nor did Ramlochan.

But in the afternoon Phulo, an adolescent girl from Chamartoli, came with her little brother.

The boy had an old wound on his arm, and she wanted a doctor to look at it.

Jamuna told her the same thing again.

Phulo asked, "But he was here yesterday, wasn't he?"

Jamuna said, "Yesterday there was an inspection."

Phulo looked first at the chair, then at Jamuna.

"When will there be another inspection?"

The question brought both laughter and anger to Jamuna, but she did not laugh.

Phulo took her brother and went back.

Jamuna tied a new knot in the rope.

This time, after tying it, she did not hang the rope from the nail.

She wound it around a pillar of the veranda.

When Savita came on Tuesday, she saw the knotted rope in full view of everyone.

"Jamuna Didi, here now?"

"Why hide it from the people it is for?"

Savita did not answer.

Sita came in the afternoon.

She had never heard the story of the rope.

Jamuna explained it to her.

Touching one of the knots, Sita asked, "Which knot is from the time I brought my son?"

"I don't know."

"Then all these belong to all of us?"

"Yes, to everyone."

Sita said, "Count them."

That day the knots were counted for the first time.

One hundred and eighty-seven.

Savita said, "That cannot be the full number. You are not at the centre every day."

Jamuna said, "Then this is the minimum."

Sita repeated the word "minimum."

She liked the word because there was no exaggeration in it.

The following week people began telling their own experiences.

Someone said two days' wages had been lost.

Someone said that when no vehicle could be found, the patient had been taken on a bicycle.

Someone said that by the time they reached the block hospital, the queue had already closed.

Jamuna did not add every story to the rope.

She tied a knot only for those who came to the centre, found no doctor, and had to turn back.

The rule of the knots remained simple.

One turning back = one knot.

Name, caste, religion, age—the rope asked none of these things.

But how many times a person had been forced to turn back—that it recorded silently.

In the month of Magh, a public hearing was announced at the block headquarters.

The villagers decided that the matter of the health centre should be raised there.

Some spoke of writing an application.

Others of forming a delegation.

Sita said, "Applications have gone before."

Phulo, who was now in the tenth class at school, unwound the rope from the pillar and took it in her hands.

"This will go too."

Jamuna said at once, "It is not government property. Take it."

On the day of the public hearing, five women, four men, Phulo, and Jamuna went to the headquarters.

Savita did not go; that day she had vaccination work.

The rope would not fit inside Phulo's bag.

She carried it wound around the outside.

On the veranda at the headquarters, people stood waiting with different problems.

For one it was a pension, for another a land survey, for someone else the piped-water scheme.

When Bellahi's turn came, the officer asked, "Written application?"

Sita placed a copy of an earlier application before him.

Then Phulo laid the rope on the table.

The officer stared in surprise.

“Why is this rope on the table?”

Phulo looked toward Jamuna.

Jamuna said, “The distance of a vacant post.”

The officer did not understand.

Sita explained, “Each time a patient comes to the Bellahi centre, finds no doctor, and has to go elsewhere, we tie one knot.”

“How is this proof?”

Jamuna said calmly, “We have not brought it here calling it proof. This is our count. The proof that the post is vacant will be in your office.”

A few people on the veranda turned to look.

The officer lifted part of the rope in his hand.

“How many knots?”

Phulo said, “Two hundred and fourteen as of this morning.”

“Over how many days?”

“Less than six months.”

The officer wrote something down.

Jamuna watched his pen.

She was afraid another sheet of paper would be created and the matter would remain on the paper.

She said, “Until a permanent doctor comes, assign someone here for two fixed days each week. Not only on inspection days.”

Sita added at once, “And write the days on the wall.”

Phulo said, “And if the doctor does not come, that day will get a knot too.”

For the first time the officer smiled, but the people sitting before him did not.

His smile died of its own accord.

The officer said that a permanent appointment was not in his hands, but an interim arrangement could be made at block level.

No one trusted the promise at once.

They gathered up the rope again.

Three days passed.

Four days passed.

On the fifth day a two-page order arrived from the block office.

A visiting doctor’s duty at Bellahi was assigned for Mondays and Thursdays.

Two doctors’ names were listed at the bottom of the order.

Jamuna could not read the paper; Phulo read it aloud to her.

Sita asked, “How long will this continue?”

No one had an answer.

On Monday morning Jamuna opened the gate before eight, as always.

She swept the veranda.
She wiped the chair.
A copy of the new order was pinned to the wall.
Nine o'clock came.
The doctor did not.
Half past nine.

The rope was wound around the pillar.
Phulo arrived alone, without her brother.
She said, "Didi, a knot?"
Jamuna looked at the rope.
"Wait until ten."

Just before ten, the sound of a motorcycle was heard.
Dr Manish Kumar from the block hospital entered through the gate.
He had a small bag in one hand and a bottle of water in the other.
He apologised and said he had had a flat tyre on the way.
Jamuna simply opened the door for him.
The doctor sat in the chair.
The first patient was not Sita.

The first patient was Haricharan Paswan, who had come again about the pain in his lower back.

Jamuna went to the veranda pillar.
With a finger she touched the last knot in the rope.
Phulo asked, "Shall we untie it today?"
Jamuna did not nod.
"We will not untie the knots."
"Then what will we do?"
"The distance already travelled cannot be erased."
She pointed to the free end of the rope.
"Now we will see how many new knots appear."

The strip meant for the permanent doctor's name was still blank on the wall.

But beneath that blank strip, Monday and Thursday were written in clear letters.

Jamuna looked toward the chair.
Today the chair was not empty.
She left the rope around the pillar.

STORY 103

The Voice of the Land

The path from the Sada hamlet of Hariharpur to the main road was six cubits wide.

On paper, it had no name.

In the village everyone called it “the Middle Path.”

At dawn, women going to sell milk; by day, labourers bound for the fields; in the evening, children returning from school—all came and went along that path.

During the rains, when the pond overflowed, the path became even more important.

The low ground behind the hamlet would then lie knee-deep in water.

The Middle Path crossed the higher ground and led out to the main road.

One day in the month of Jeth, a pile of bricks appeared at the mouth of the path.

At first people assumed that someone was going to build a house.

The next day bamboo stakes were driven into the ground.

On the third day, mortar began to be mixed.

On the fourth, the mason stretched a line for raising a straight wall.

The owner of the land was Dhaneshwar Sah.

He had bought the adjoining field two years earlier.

After having a fresh survey carried out, he had been told that more than half of the Middle Path fell within his cadastral plot.

Dhaneshwar would say—

“I am enclosing my own land. I am not taking anyone else’s.”

The people of the hamlet would say—

“This land is a road.”

Dhaneshwar would reply—

“Show me the map.”

He had the map.

The hamlet had memory.

On the first day the wall rose only two cubits.

On the second day the women sat down in front of the bricks.

No one threw a brick.

No one spoiled the mortar.

They simply remained seated there.

The mason stopped work.

Dhaneshwar's younger brother Umakant said—

"It is not right to stop the work like this."

Jasoda Sada of the hamlet replied—

"If the path is stopped, our work will stop too."

Word reached the panchayat.

The village head said that before the quarrel grew worse, a hearing would be held at the spot itself.

The next morning the land surveyor, the panchayat secretary, people from both sides, and elderly residents from the surrounding area gathered there.

The surveyor unfolded the new map.

Its blue lines, red figures, and cadastral plot numbers were clear.

There was no separate marking for the Middle Path.

A photocopy of the old map had also been brought.

Its lines were faint.

The paper was torn in one place.

At the very point where the path curved, the colour on the map had also been rubbed away.

Dhaneshwar said—

"What more than this do you need?"

Jasoda said—

"Our feet."

A few people in the crowd laughed.

Jasoda did not.

The surveyor measured the land.

Four cubits of the path fell inside the line marked for the wall.

Only two cubits remained outside it.

Two people could pass one another through two cubits of space, but a bicycle, a load, or a cot carrying a sick person—none could pass with ease.

The panchayat secretary asked—

"Does anyone have any old evidence?"

No one did.

Then a frail voice came from the back of the crowd—

"Will no one ask about the well?"

Everyone turned.

Kusumi Sada stood there, leaning on a bamboo staff.

She was eighty-four.

Her hearing had weakened somewhat, but she spoke clearly.

Jasoda ran to bring a low wooden seat for her.

Kusumi did not sit.

She said—

"First I will look at the ground."

Slowly she walked up to the mason's line.

Then she left the line and went to the bend in the path.

There she began scratching the earth with the tip of her staff.

Dhaneshwar said—

“Grandmother, where is the well here now?”

Without looking at him, Kusumi replied—

“It is not here now. But it was.”

The surveyor asked—

“How long ago?”

Kusumi said—

“When I came to this village as a bride, its parapet stood as high as my waist.”

Someone exclaimed—

“That must have been sixty years ago!”

Kusumi said—

“Fifty-eight.”

Laughter rose again.

This time Kusumi smiled too.

“Two months after my first daughter was born, I filled a water-pot at this well for the first time. My daughter is fifty-seven now.”

The surveyor became more attentive.

He asked—

“What does the well have to do with the path?”

With her staff Kusumi drew a circle on the earth.

“The path was not straight before. It bent here to go around the well’s parapet.”

The new map showed no path, but the path on the ground did in fact make a slight curve at that very place.

The mason’s line was straight.

The path was not.

Dhaneshwar said—

“Even if there was an old well here, that does not make the land public.”

Kusumi looked at him.

“You are right. Not merely because of the well.”

For the first time, she sat on the low seat.

She held her staff between her knees.

“There was a survey. I saw it.”

The surveyor asked—

“Which survey?”

“When the northern stream changed its course. The field boundaries were marked out again.”

“How many years ago?”

Kusumi closed her eyes for a moment.

“The winter after the great flood. One year before Ramdev’s wedding. That wedding was the first time a Petromax lamp came to the village.”

Old Rameshar Yadav, standing in the crowd, said—

“Nineteen seventy-nine. Ramdev was married in eighty.”

Kusumi nodded.

“Yes, seventy-nine.”

The surveyor asked—

“Were you here when the survey was done?”

“All day.”

“Why?”

Kusumi narrowed her eyes slightly.

“I was working as a labourer. I held the stakes for the surveyors and stretched their measuring rope. They had hired me to carry water and mind the pegs.”

The present surveyor fell silent.

The measuring tape in his hand slackened a little.

Kusumi continued—

“That day the dispute was over this very thing. The owner of the eastern field said the path had entered his land. The owner of the western field said his boundary ridge had been cut. The survey was halted.”

Dhaneshwar’s father had been a boy then.

His uncle, Ramlakhan Sah, was present in the crowd.

Looking at him, Kusumi asked—

“Ramlakhan, were you there or not?”

Ramlakhan Sah remained silent for a long time.

Then he said—

“I was little. I had come with Father.”

Dhaneshwar turned towards him.

Ramlakhan lowered his eyes.

Kusumi said—

“It was decided that three cubits would be left from each field. The path would be six cubits wide. Because this was not merely a path to the fields. It carried people towards the well, the pond, the market, and the main road—towards all four directions.”

The panchayat secretary asked—

“Was this decision written down?”

Kusumi said—

“I could neither read nor write. I do not know whether it was written. But after the land was measured, boundary markers were set in the ground.”

The surveyor asked at once—

“Where are those markers?”

Kusumi stood up.

"They may not all have survived."

From the bend in the path, she walked seven paces east.

Then she stopped.

"There was one here."

A shallow trench had now been dug there for the foundation of the new brick wall.

A labourer's spade was brought.

After two or three spadefuls of earth were removed, fragments of old brick appeared.

Dhaneshwar said—

"Bricks can be found anywhere."

Kusumi replied—

"That is not the marker."

She walked another five paces south.

There was a thicket there.

It was cleared away.

The corner of a blackened stone showed beneath the earth.

The surveyor scraped the soil away with his hands.

An old boundary stone, about a cubit and a half long, emerged.

There were two chisel marks on its top.

One ran east-west.

The other north-south.

The crowd suddenly fell silent.

Kusumi was looking not at the stone, but at the path.

She said—

"The western side of this stone was the path. The eastern side was the field."

Dhaneshwar bent down and examined the stone.

His uncle Ramlakhan said softly—

"There was a stone like this at the corner of Father's field."

The surveyor unfolded the new map again.

He placed the old map beside it.

The measuring tape was stretched out.

The distance from the stone to the present boundary ridge was taken.

Then the other edge was measured.

The measurements matched.

The old width of six cubits for the path matched as well.

What the new map made appear to lie within a single cadastral plot in fact fell on the other side of the old boundary stone.

Dhaneshwar was silent.

Jasoda's eyes brightened, but she said nothing.

The surveyor asked Kusumi—

"Do you remember any other sign?"

Kusumi said—

“The well’s parapet.”

The earth was dug again at the bend in the path.

Not very deep.

About a foot below the surface, two old stones were found laid in a curve.

Black earth and lime still clung between them.

Ramlakhan Sah exclaimed—

“This must be part of that very well’s parapet.”

Kusumi looked at him.

“Your mother used to draw water from this well.”

Ramlakhan’s face changed.

“Yes.”

Having said that much, he fell silent.

The panchayat secretary began writing something on a sheet of paper.

Kusumi did not stop his hand.

But she said—

“Do not believe what I say merely because I am old.”

The surveyor looked up.

Kusumi said—

“Measure it. If what I have said is found in the earth, then believe it.”

After that one sentence, the nature of the hearing changed.

Until then, the two sides had been cutting across one another’s words.

Now everyone began looking at the earth, the bend, the stones, and the distances.

The surveyor compared the position of the stone with the faded line on the old map.

The circular mark in that faded place now seemed meaningful.

It might have marked the well.

The torn part of the map lay exactly along the old edge of the path.

A decision could not be made on conjecture.

So the surveyor asked that another old boundary marker be found.

This time Kusumi went west.

She stopped behind a house.

“There was a neem tree here. The tree was cut down, but the root should remain.”

The owner of the house gave his consent.

When the earth was opened, a thick neem root was found.

To the east of the root, a small stone had been set into the ground.

It bore the same kind of chisel marks.

The surveyor stretched out a long measuring tape.

A line was drawn between the two old stones.

That line ran alongside the edge of the Middle Path.

No one laughed now.
 At last Dhaneshwar said—
 “The papers for the land I bought show the boundary on this side.”
 The surveyor replied—
 “Your papers remain valid for examination. They will be checked separately.
 But at this spot both the old boundary and long-established usage are visible.”
 Dhaneshwar’s voice was no longer harsh.
 “And my loss?”
 The village head said—
 “Where the land is yours, your right over it will remain. But the path cannot
 be enclosed as though it were a field.”
 Sweat stood on Dhaneshwar’s forehead.
 He wiped it with his gamchha.
 “I will accept whatever the survey establishes.”
 No one in the hamlet applauded.
 Perhaps everyone was tired.
 Everyone understood that the decision was not yet complete.
 The surveyor began measuring again.
 Kusumi sat on the low seat and watched.
 At times she pointed towards a stone.
 At times she indicated the direction of an old boundary ridge.
 At times she said—
 “Pigeon peas used to grow here.”
 The surveyor would reply—
 “Not the crop. Tell me the boundary.”
 Laughing, Kusumi said—
 “I remember the boundary by the crop.”
 By noon the measurements were complete.
 The six-cubit path emerged almost along its old course.
 At one place it measured five cubits and eight fingerbreadths.
 At another, six cubits and two fingerbreadths.
 At the bend around the old well, it was wider still.
 The mason’s line for the wall was removed.
 The mason began shifting the pile of bricks two cubits east.
 Dhaneshwar himself drove bamboo stakes along the new line.
 Jasoda sat down beside Kusumi.
 “Grandmother, how did you remember so much?”
 Kusumi rested her chin on her staff.
 “When people have no papers, they have to remember places and events.”
 Jasoda fell silent.
 Kusumi added—

“But memory by itself can often deceive as well. That is why I said—dig the earth, measure it.”

By evening the foundation for the wall had been laid along the new line.

The Middle Path remained open.

The first boy to pass through with a bicycle glanced at the newly exposed top of the boundary stone.

He asked—

“What is this?”

Jasoda said—

“A boundary.”

The boy asked again—

“And this path?”

Kusumi, who had risen to return home, answered—

“A path.”

The boy stood waiting, hoping to hear something more.

But Kusumi walked away.

Her staff touched the earth first.

Then her foot came down.

Along the open path, the two sounds moved forward in turn.

STORY 104

Half a Samosa

The clock at the old town bus stand showed half past ten.

But in Jibachh's stomach, noon had arrived long before.

Baso sat beside him on the stone bench.

Again and again, both their eyes strayed towards Nandu Sah's frying pan.

Samosas hissed in the oil.

Jibachh shook out the pocket of his kurta.

Three rupees came out.

Baso untied the knot in his gamchha.

There were seven rupees in it.

Jibachh searched his other pocket once more.

He found a two-rupee coin.

Twelve rupees altogether.

Nandu Sah said—

“One samosa costs twelve.”

Baso looked at Jibachh.

Jibachh looked at Baso.

Then both looked again at the frying pan.

Jibachh asked—

“Twenty-four for two?”

Turning the tongs in his hand, Nandu Sah said—

“Mathematics has not changed yet.”

Baso burst out laughing.

Jibachh did not.

When one is hungry, mathematics becomes a very personal thing.

The two had been at the bus stand since early morning, hoping to find a day's work.

Yesterday Jibachh had found half a day's work carrying bricks.

Baso had returned empty-handed.

The day before that, Baso had earned and Jibachh had not.

That was why the accounting between them was simple.

Whoever found work also bought tea for the other.

Whoever did not find work remembered it for the next time.

There was no ledger.

No written debt.

Only memory.

And both their memories were remarkably sharp, especially where food was concerned.

Jibachh said—

“Let’s buy just one.”

Baso replied—

“Half each.”

Nandu Sah placed one samosa on a sheet of paper.

It was so hot that a round stain of oil immediately began spreading across the paper.

Jibachh said—

“Cut it through the middle.”

Nandu Sah gripped the samosa with the tongs.

With a small knife he tried to cut it exactly in half.

A samosa does not split exactly down the middle.

It has a will of its own.

The crust broke more on one side.

The potato filling fell towards the other.

In the end, two pieces lay on the paper.

One was tall and thin.

The other was lower, but plump and full.

The two friends fell silent.

Nandu Sah turned his tongs back towards the frying pan.

“Take them.”

Jibachh picked up the taller piece.

Baso took the fuller one.

For the space of two breaths, there was peace.

Then Jibachh said—

“Yours is bigger.”

Baso answered at once—

“Mine? Look at yours.”

“Yours has more potato.”

“Yours has more crust.”

“A samosa is made of potato.”

“Then eat plain potato. Why eat a samosa?”

Jibachh thought about that for a moment.

The argument was not weak.

But neither was hunger.

He put his piece back on the paper.

“Measure them.”

Baso put his down too.

Nandu Sah turned away and began straining tea.

He had understood that the matter was moving beyond the ordinary jurisdiction of a tea stall.

Jibachh placed the two pieces in a straight line.

His piece was taller.

Baso's was wider.

Baso said—

“See? The tip of yours goes farther.”

Jibachh said—

“Does the tip fill your stomach?”

“Without a tip, would a samosa remain a samosa?”

“And without potato?”

Both fell silent again.

In front of Nandu Sah's stall sat Phulo, the vegetable seller.

Laughing, she asked—

“What is this—a village council?”

Jibachh said—

“We want justice.”

Phulo pointed towards her weighing scales.

“Weigh them.”

The suggestion was so obvious that the two friends stared at each other.

How had such a simple solution occurred to no one earlier?

The two pieces were placed on separate sheets of paper.

Phulo wiped the two pans of her balance.

Jibachh's piece went into one pan.

Baso's into the other.

The pointer swung once to the right.

Then to the left.

Then trembled around the centre.

Phulo narrowed her eyes and looked closely.

“They're almost equal.”

Jibachh immediately said—

“Almost is not justice.”

Baso agreed—

“Exactly.”

Putting away her scales, Phulo said—

“Then go to a goldsmith. Have your samosa weighed there.”

The people sitting at the stall burst out laughing.

Jibachh and Baso did not.

The matter was serious.

Meanwhile, their eyes fell on the little mound of potato filling that had spilled onto the paper.

Pointing at it, Jibachh asked—

“Whose share is this?”

Baso said—

“Whichever piece it fell out of.”

“And how will we know that?”

“Ask the man who cut it.”

Both turned towards Nandu Sah.

Passing a glass of tea to a customer, Nandu Sah said—

“I cut a samosa. I did not draw up its genealogy.”

Laughter rose again in front of the stall.

This time Baso’s lips twitched.

Jibachh too could not suppress a smile.

But the dispute was not over.

The bus-stand clock showed ten forty-five.

Their samosa was beginning to grow cold.

Baso said—

“Let’s do one thing. We’ll exchange pieces.”

Jibachh immediately pulled his own piece back.

“Why exchange?”

“You think mine is bigger. I think yours is bigger. If we exchange, both of us will be satisfied.”

Jibachh shook his head.

“No. If yours really is bigger, I’ll end up taking more.”

“And if yours is bigger, I’ll end up taking more.”

They became trapped in each other’s reasoning.

At that moment Moti, who repaired bicycles, came over wiping his hands.

“What happened here?”

From a distance Phulo called out to him—

“Two friends are dividing a country inside one samosa.”

Moti looked at the two pieces.

“Cut each of them in half again.”

Jibachh’s eyes lit up.

Moti explained—

“Cut your piece into two, and his piece into two. Then combine one of yours with one of his to make one share. The remaining two pieces make the other share.”

Baso brightened.

“Now that is intelligence.”

Nandu Sah picked up the knife again.

At that very moment Jibachh stopped him.

“Wait.”

Everyone looked at him.

“How will the first piece be cut into two equal halves?”

Moti's mouth remained open.

Baso said softly—

"Another dispute."

Nandu Sah threw the knife down.

"From now on, samosas at my shop will be sold whole. The half-samosa service is closed."

A bus arrived at the stand.

Dust rose.

Some passengers got off.

Others climbed aboard.

The two friends remained standing there with their respective pieces in their hands.

A neatly dressed passenger asked Nandu Sah for two samosas.

He had been listening to the dispute.

Laughing, he said—

"I'll buy one more for you. You can each eat a whole samosa."

In a courteous voice Jibachh said—

"No, babu, thank you."

Baso added—

"The price of the samosa is not our problem."

The passenger raised his eyebrows.

Jibachh said—

"It is a question of equality."

For a few moments the passenger looked at both their faces.

Then, carrying his two samosas, he walked towards the bus.

Baso said quietly—

"He thought the two of us were mad."

Jibachh said—

"He is free to think so."

"But his samosas were hot."

"Don't talk about that."

They put their cold pieces back on the paper once more.

This time Nandu Sah himself came forward.

"Listen. Shall I separate the filling and divide it equally?"

Jibachh considered the proposal.

So did Baso.

Jibachh asked—

"And the crust?"

Nandu Sah closed his eyes.

Baso said—

"The crispness of the crust has a value of its own."

Nandu Sah opened his eyes.

“You two are less hungry than you are economists.”

Phulo bent over her basket of vegetables, laughing and laughing.

Tightening a nut on a bicycle, Moti said—

“Toss a coin.”

Jibachh said—

“A coin won’t tell us whether the shares are equal.”

Baso supported him.

“A coin will only decide who eats the larger share.”

Moti gave up and went away.

The clock struck eleven.

Neither of them had found work yet.

Now, between one argument and the next, hunger began sending messages from their stomachs.

Baso picked up his piece.

“Shall I take one bite?”

Jibachh was startled.

“Then the evidence will be destroyed.”

Baso put the piece back down.

“You’re right.”

The two remained seated, preserving the evidence in the face of hunger.

After a while Ramsevak, a mason’s foreman, came along that way.

He knew both of them.

“Jibachh! Baso! I need two labourers to unload bricks. Will you come?”

Both stood up at once.

Jibachh asked—

“How much will you pay?”

Ramsevak named the amount.

Baso immediately asked—

“The same for both of us?”

Ramsevak laughed, showing his teeth.

“The same for both. The work is the same too.”

Jibachh looked at Baso.

Baso looked at Jibachh.

The same thought came to both of them.

The samosa.

Ramsevak grew impatient.

“Come on, the vehicle is waiting.”

Jibachh picked up his piece.

Baso picked up his.

The two started walking.

After ten steps Baso stopped.

“Jibachh.”

“What?”

“If I eat my piece now, the dispute will end without a verdict.”

Jibachh stopped too.

Ramsevak struck his forehead with his palm.

“Eat the samosa and come on!”

Suddenly Jibachh burst out laughing.

Baso did too.

For the first time in all that while, both laughed freely.

Jibachh said—

“All right. No verdict today.”

Baso asked—

“Then what about justice?”

“Tomorrow we’ll get our wages. We’ll buy two samosas. Then we’ll compare them.”

With complete seriousness Baso said—

“Two samosas won’t be exactly the same size either.”

Jibachh burst out laughing again.

As they walked, each took a bite from his own piece.

It had gone cold.

But hunger had not diminished its taste.

After the first bite Jibachh said—

“Yours had more potato.”

With his mouth full Baso replied—

“Your crust was crisper.”

Ramsevak turned around and said—

“Starting again?”

Both answered together—

“No, now we are only stating facts.”

All afternoon they unloaded bricks.

From time to time the question of the samosa returned.

Jibachh would say—

“Weight is what matters.”

Baso would say—

“Who will weigh the share of taste?”

As work tired them out, the dispute grew smaller.

In the evening Ramsevak paid their wages.

Both counted their notes and coins.

The amounts were equal.

Jibachh said—

“Come on. Let’s go to Nandu’s.”

Baso understood.

They returned to the bus stand.

Nandu Sah saw them from a distance.

“What now?”

Jibachh placed the price of two samosas on the paper.

“Two.”

Nandu Sah took out two hot samosas.

One was a little longer.

The other was a little thicker.

He placed them on the paper between the two friends.

For a few moments there was silence.

Nandu Sah became wary.

Jibachh looked at the longer samosa.

Baso looked at the thicker one.

Then they looked at each other.

Nandu Sah slowly slid the knife farther away.

Baso said—

“First, one thing has to be settled.”

With a serious face Jibachh asked—

“Tell me. What?”

Baso pointed at the thicker samosa.

“Which one is bigger?”

Nandu Sah slammed the lid onto the frying pan so hard that Phulo burst out laughing again over her vegetable basket.

STORY 105

The Veranda University

East of the market, beside the old post office, stood a long veranda.

The room behind it had remained locked for years.

Once, Bisesar Babu had run a seed shop there.

Now the paint had peeled from the gate and half the lettering on the board had faded away, but the veranda remained.

Four young men gathered on that veranda every afternoon.

Nawal, Ramakant, Sadan and Parmanand.

Each had studied a different subject.

Their unemployment was the one subject they shared.

Nawal had studied history.

Ramakant, economics.

Sadan, science.

Parmanand, Maithili.

None of them had a job.

All four had plenty of time.

And so they had taken upon themselves the burden of setting the world right.

The first hour went to the national economy.

The second to village politics.

By the third, the discussion had travelled through rain, farming, cricket, education, marriage, bus fares, the river, the price of milk, and even the new thatch on Harinath's roof next door.

One day Bisesar Babu came to look at the old signboard of his shop.

Seeing the four of them deep in debate, he asked—

“What has opened here?”

Without pausing, Nawal replied—

“A university.”

Bisesar Babu looked towards the gate.

“Where is the signboard?”

Sadan slapped his palm against a broken brick and said—

“Invisible, owing to a shortage of funds.”

From that day on, the market had a name for the place: the Veranda University.

Aunt Malti's tea stall stood directly opposite.

She was their most regular listener.

Not that she had much desire to listen.
 Their debates simply fell into her ears whenever she brought them tea.
 With a piece of chalk, Aunt Malti drew little strokes on one of the veranda pillars beside each of their names.

One stroke for one cup of tea.

The strokes multiplied.

So did the debt.

One night rain blew into the veranda and soaked the pillar.

By morning, half the strokes had vanished.

Nawal said delightedly—

“Half the national debt has been written off.”

Setting water on the stove, Aunt Malti replied—

“The pillar may forget. I don’t.”

The university observed five minutes of silence after that answer.

Then Parmanand moved a proposal that memory be granted the status of an account book.

Aunt Malti said—

“Before you grant it any status, add yesterday’s three cups.”

The debate changed direction again.

That afternoon the postman stopped by the veranda.

“Ramakant Mishra?”

All four looked at him at once.

Ramakant raised a hand.

The postman handed him a thick envelope.

It bore the name of a district cooperative society.

Nawal’s eyes lit up.

“Open it.”

Ramakant turned the envelope over in his hands.

“What’s the hurry?”

Sadan said—

“Unless the envelope intends to answer for itself, there is some hurry.”

Ramakant opened it slowly.

It was an interview letter.

He was to report in town at ten the next morning.

Parmanand sprang to his feet.

“The university’s first student is going for an interview.”

Ramakant folded the letter and slipped it into his pocket.

“Leave it. I’ve seen plenty of interviews like this.”

Nawal looked at him closely.

“How many have you seen?”

Ramakant fell silent.

“This is your first, isn’t it?”

Ramakant kept tracing a line in the dust beyond the veranda.
 After a while he said—
 “There’s no point in going.”
 Sadan asked—
 “Why do you say that?”
 “They probably decide on someone beforehand.”
 “On what basis are you saying that?”
 “That’s how it happens everywhere.”
 Nawal did not laugh.
 Quietly, he asked—
 “How much is the bus fare?”
 Ramakant’s finger stopped in the dust.
 Silence settled over the veranda.
 Parmanand searched his pocket.
 Three coins came out.
 From Sadan’s pocket emerged a crumpled note.
 Nawal’s wallet held an old admit card, two tickets, and twenty-seven rupees.
 Ramakant had eighteen rupees.
 Together, the four had seventy-nine rupees.
 Once they added the fare to town and back, morning tea and the cost of changing buses twice, they were short of money.
 Aunt Malti had been watching everything from across the way.
 She came over with tea.
 “Shall I enter today’s four cups?”
 Nawal looked at the pillar.
 “Suspend the accounts for today.”
 Aunt Malti set the cups down.
 “Drink your tea. The debt will still be here tomorrow.”
 Ramakant did not even touch his cup.
 “I’m not going.”
 Aunt Malti looked at him.
 “You received a letter?”
 “Yes. Today.”
 “Then go.”
 “I don’t have the money.”
 Aunt Malti turned her face towards the smoke from the stove.
 “You should have said that first. The workings of the world may be difficult to understand, but understanding your own pocket shouldn’t be this hard.”
 Parmanand burst out laughing.
 Even Ramakant could not suppress a smile.
 But they were still short of money.
 The afternoon was waning.

In the market, chairs, bamboo poles and tarpaulins were being unloaded for an evening wedding.

A handcart overturned.

A heap of chairs spilled beside the mud.

Raghuvir, the tent contractor, looked around for help.

“If I can get four men, everything will be inside in an hour. I’ll pay wages.”

The four scholars of the veranda looked at one another.

Nawal rose first.

“The economics laboratory.”

Sadan stood up too.

“Science department present.”

Parmanand gathered up the end of his dhoti.

“If the Maithili department refuses to lend a hand, it will disgrace the language.”

Ramakant straightened the interview letter in his pocket.

“I am the head of the economics department.”

Raghuvir had no idea what they were talking about.

He merely pointed to the chairs.

“All of these—inside.”

Work began.

For the first ten minutes, the four continued to debate.

Should they carry two chairs at a time or three?

Should they wipe off the mud before taking them in, or carry them inside first and wipe them there?

Nawal said—

“First, a system.”

From a distance Raghuvir shouted—

“First, the chairs!”

After that single sentence, the university suspended theory for a while.

The four worked in silence.

Mud clung to the chair legs.

The tarpaulin was heavy.

Bundles of bamboo pressed into their shoulders.

Ramakant’s kurta was soaked with sweat.

Sadan’s slipper stuck in the mud.

Parmanand stumbled over a chair and sat down on it.

Laughing, Nawal said—

“The thing meant for sitting has made you sit.”

Parmanand got up and dusted himself off.

“This is practical education.”

One hour became two.

When the work was finished, Raghuvir paid each of them sixty rupees.

For a few moments, the four simply stared at the notes lying in their palms. The seventy-nine rupees of the afternoon suddenly seemed like a large fortune.

Ramakant said—

“Don’t all of you put in your full share. This is because of me—”

Nawal cut him off.

“At this university, the fee is equal for everyone.”

Sadan asked—

“And the profit?”

Parmanand replied—

“The profit will be debated next semester.”

When they reached Aunt Malti, the first thing they asked for was the account on the pillar.

She brought out a page from an old ledger.

An amount was written against each of their names.

Nawal clutched his head.

“So the pillar was only the outside account?”

“Yes. The outside one.”

“And the original ledger is inside?”

“The original ledger is kept inside.”

“That’s unfair.”

“Did it take you any time to drink the tea?”

Nawal fell silent.

Ramakant placed some of his share before her.

“Deduct what I owe for tea.”

Aunt Malti pushed the money back.

“Not today. First set aside your travel expenses.”

“But—”

“My shop isn’t running away.”

This time no one laughed.

The four sat on the veranda and counted the money again.

Bus fare, separately.

Money for one meal in town, separately.

Twenty rupees for an emergency, separately.

With what remained, Ramakant repaid half his debt.

Aunt Malti tried hard to stop him, but he would not listen.

“If they ask me in the interview what liability means, I’ll need an example.”

Aunt Malti laughed.

By evening, the next problem had appeared.

Two buttons were missing from Ramakant’s only good kurta.

Parmanand brought his own kurta.

Too broad at the shoulders.

Sadan's kurta was brought.

Too short.

Nawal brought a pale blue kurta from home.

Ramakant put it on.

Almost right.

Aunt Malti looked over from a distance.

"Why only almost? I'll sew on the buttons."

She took out needle and thread and fixed two buttons in two minutes.

Parmanand announced—

"The university now has a clothing department as well."

Tucking the needle into a piece of cloth, Aunt Malti replied—

"I am the vice-chancellor of that department."

That evening the four rose earlier than usual.

Ramakant kept looking at the letter again and again.

As they left, Nawal said—

"Keep all your answers short tomorrow."

Sadan said—

"Say only as much as they ask."

Parmanand added—

"And don't tell them your plan for reforming the world."

For the first time, Ramakant laughed freely.

"If you three aren't there, I'll speak less."

The next morning, all three went to the bus stand to see him off.

Aunt Malti wrapped four pieces of sattu-pakwan in paper for him.

"Food in town will be expensive."

Ramakant tried to pay her.

She drew back her hand.

"This isn't tea. It won't go into the account."

The bus pulled away.

Ramakant waved from the window.

The three returned to the veranda.

His empty place was conspicuous.

Nawal tried to begin a debate.

"Today's subject—"

Parmanand stopped him.

"Not today."

Sadan looked at the pillar.

During the previous day's rain, water had dripped from one corner of the roof.

An earthen bowl was kept there to catch it.

Sadan said—

"We've been talking about rainwater management for a year."

Nawal looked up.

"Yes. For a very long time."

Parmanand asked—

"Where can we get a ladder?"

Bisesar Babu sent an old bamboo ladder from his house.

The three began repairing the loose roof tiles.

It was a small job.

The debate started again.

Should the tile be moved right or left?

Should they apply the mud first or afterwards?

From below, Bisesar Babu called—

"Shut the university and do the work."

All three burst out laughing.

Ramakant returned after noon.

He was tired, but there was a brightness in his eyes.

All three asked at once—

"Well? What happened inside?"

Ramakant sat down on the veranda step.

"The interview happened."

"And then?"

"The result will come later."

Disappointed, Nawal said—

"You went all that way just to tell us that?"

Ramakant took a folded piece of paper from his pocket.

"The society reimbursed half my travel expenses."

Parmanand leapt up.

"Then the university is in profit!"

Laughing, Ramakant placed the money on Aunt Malti's ledger.

"Tea debt first."

Aunt Malti counted the money and entered the amount.

"Only seven cups remain now."

Nawal drew seven chalk strokes on the pillar.

Sadan asked—

"What's today's subject?"

Ramakant looked up.

The corner of the roof that had dripped the previous day was dry.

He said—

"Tea first. The world afterwards."

Aunt Malti set down four cups of tea.

Four new strokes appeared on the pillar.

Parmanand counted them and said—

"The debt has gone up again."

Nawal lifted his cup.
“The cost of knowledge.”
From inside, Aunt Malti called back—
“Not knowledge. Tea.”
Laughter spread across the veranda.
The university was open again.

STORY 106

Love on Credit

In the very heart of Belahi market stood Ramdev Sah's small shop.

At the front were tins of rice, lentils, salt, oil and spices, arranged in neat rows.

At the back, Ramdev Sah sat on a wooden platform.

To his right lay a thick credit ledger.

Its binding had been rubbed so bare that it was difficult to tell what colour it had once been.

At first the ledger had contained three columns.

The first — date.

The second — goods.

The third — price.

A year earlier Ramdev Sah had added a fourth column.

Its heading was: "What Was Said."

The reason was simple.

Many customers in the village would later say, "I never took that much salt."

Someone's memory would say: two pavs.

The ledger would say: half a seer.

Arguments followed.

So Ramdev Sah made a rule.

Whoever bought on credit would have the main thing he said recorded as well.

Ramdev Sah's eyesight was no longer as sharp as it had once been.

So most entries were made by his daughter Kusum.

Kusum's handwriting was small but clear.

She listened to what a customer said and wrote down as much as seemed necessary.

Sometimes, a little more than necessary.

That "little more" began with Madhav.

Madhav worked beneath a bicycle-repair shed west of the market.

When the owner had plenty of work, Madhav earned wages.

When work was scarce, his day went empty.

One evening Madhav came to the shop.

He asked for two pavs of rice, one pav of masoor lentils, and a handful of salt.

Kusum weighed the goods and asked—

“Money?”

Madhav turned his pocket inside out.

“There’s only air in it.”

Kusum opened the ledger.

“When will you pay?”

“Friday.”

Kusum wrote: Friday.

Madhav bent over to look at the ledger.

“Will you write down the air too?”

Kusum wrote: Air in pocket.

Madhav started.

“What did you write?”

“What was said.”

“Everything anyone says gets written?”

“Whatever is said while taking credit.”

Madhav laughed.

“Then from now on I’ll think before I speak.”

Kusum wrote that down too.

Ramdev Sah, sitting on the platform, had heard everything.

He pushed his spectacles up and looked toward the ledger.

“Kusum, write accounts, not drama.”

Kusum replied—

“Babu, you were the one who added the ‘What Was Said’ column.”

Ramdev Sah said nothing.

Madhav took his goods and left.

He did not come on Friday.

Nor on Saturday.

On Sunday evening he arrived with two rupees.

Kusum opened the ledger.

“Friday is written here.”

Madhav said—

“There was no work on Friday.”

“You gave the name of a day, not the name of the work.”

Madhav scratched his head.

“Will that be written too?”

“It is connected with the debt.”

Kusum wrote: No work on Friday.

Madhav placed two rupees on the ledger.

“The rest?”

“After the next job.”

Kusum wrote that down as well.

From that day on, Madhav's account began to fill with more sentences than numbers.

One day he came for half a pav of oil.

Kusum asked—

“So little?”

“To keep the debt small.”

She wrote: Less oil so the debt stays small.

The next day Madhav asked for jaggery.

“For yourself?”

“Mother drinks a decoction.”

Kusum weighed out the jaggery.

“You can pay for this later.”

Madhav said at once—

“Write it as debt, not charity.”

Kusum's pen stopped.

Ramdev Sah looked at him too.

Madhav said quietly—

“Whatever I take for Mother's medicine, I'll pay for it.”

Kusum wrote in the ledger: Not charity; he will pay.

Madhav read it and shook his head.

“Did you really need to write the whole thing?”

“The whole thing was said.”

This time Madhav did not laugh.

Two weeks later his debt had fallen to five rupees and twelve annas.

Then, suddenly, it rose again.

The reason was rain.

For three days hardly any bicycles came to the shed where Madhav worked.

He earned no wages.

But the stove at home still had to burn.

He took rice, oil and matches on credit.

Kusum added up the account.

“Now it is nine rupees and four annas.”

Madhav let out a long breath.

“What is getting fatter — the ledger or my debt?”

“Both.”

Kusum wrote: Ledger and debt, both getting fat.

Madhav burst out laughing.

“Your pen is never going to spare me.”

“Pay the money and the pen will spare you.”

“The words too?”

Kusum did not answer.

Instead, she placed a small dot in the blank space.

One rainy evening the wind rose hard.
 People in the market began packing up their shops.
 Rainwater started dripping through the rear roof of Ramdev Sah's shop.
 Two sacks of rice had to be moved before they were soaked.
 Ramdev Sah tried to drag one of them.

Kusum stopped him.
 "Don't lift it yourself."

Just then Madhav came running in.
 He was on his way home from the bicycle shed with his bag of tools.
 Seeing water inside the shop, he put the bag down.
 "The sacks first."

He lifted both sacks onto a high platform inside.

Then he climbed onto the bamboo framework and tied the torn tarpaulin with rope.

The wind whipped his shirt about him.
 Kusum stood below, holding the rope.
 Ramdev Sah moved goods out of the way while shielding the lamp.
 Half an hour later the dripping had slowed.
 Madhav climbed down.

A strand of wire from the tarpaulin had scratched his hand.

Ramdev Sah said—
 "We'll deduct today's labour from your debt."

Madhav asked—
 "How much?"
 "Two rupees."
 "One rupee and eight annas is enough."

Ramdev Sah frowned.
 "You are cutting your own wages?"

Madhav said—
 "I won't take four annas merely because I happened to be passing by."

Kusum opened the ledger.

"Shall I write that too?"

Madhav laughed.
 "By now you write everything anyway."

Kusum deducted one rupee and eight annas from the account.

In the 'What Was Said' column she wrote: Four annas — merely for happening to pass by.

For the first time Ramdev Sah laughed aloud.

"No moneylender in the world would keep an account like this."

Kusum said—
 "This shop does."

The rains passed.

Madhav's work picked up again.

He kept paying in instalments — one rupee, two rupees, sometimes eight annas.

Kusum drew a thin line through the old balance.

Then she wrote the new one.

She never struck out the words in the fourth column.

One day Madhav asked—

"The amount gets crossed out. Why not the words?"

Kusum said—

"Money gets paid off."

"And words?"

"Words have already been spoken."

Madhav fell silent.

After that he joked less often.

Kusum noticed, but asked nothing.

Two days later Madhav came again.

He bought only a bar of soap.

He paid cash.

Kusum did not open the ledger.

Madhav remained standing there.

"What else do you want?"

Kusum asked.

"Nothing just now."

"Then why aren't you leaving?"

"The ledger didn't open."

"You paid cash."

Madhav nodded.

"Yes. Cash."

Kusum began straightening an empty soap box.

Madhav said—

"Don't the words of people who pay cash get written down?"

Kusum smiled.

"It's a credit ledger."

"So if I want my words written, I have to borrow?"

Kusum looked at him.

"Taking a debt deliberately is not wise."

"You could write that down too."

Kusum kept the ledger closed.

Madhav left.

Ramdev Sah looked at his daughter over the top of his spectacles.

"That cash-paying customer stood here a long time."

Kusum straightened the box once more.

“He was choosing soap.”

“There was only one kind of soap.”

Kusum did not answer.

The corner of Ramdev Sah’s mouth lifted faintly.

A few days later there was a small dispute in the shop.

Bihari Kaka insisted that he had taken four seers of flour, not five.

Ramdev Sah found the old page.

There was Kusum’s note: “Give five seers. The granddaughters are coming.”

Bihari Kaka fell silent for a moment.

Then he slapped his forehead and said—

“Yes, the granddaughters came that day.”

The dispute ended.

Closing the ledger, Ramdev Sah said—

“Your ‘What Was Said’ is useful after all.”

Kusum answered matter-of-factly—

“It was your rule.”

“I made a rule. You turned it into a book.”

Madhav was standing outside the shop just then.

He had heard everything.

He came in.

“My section must be the biggest book of all.”

Ramdev Sah said—

“Your section has fewer numbers and more words.”

Madhav looked at the ledger.

“The numbers are going down.”

Ramdev Sah said—

“That is good.”

Kusum turned the page.

Madhav’s balance stood at three rupees and eight annas.

The following month the owner of the bicycle shed went to the city.

Madhav received three weeks of unpaid wages all at once.

That evening he came straight to Ramdev Sah’s shop.

In his hand were folded notes and coins.

“Add it up.”

Kusum opened the ledger.

“Three rupees and eight annas.”

Madhav placed the full amount before her.

Kusum counted it.

The amount was exact.

Beside the balance she wrote in bold letters: “Zero.”

Madhav looked at that word for a long time.

Ramdev Sah said—

"Now you are free."

Madhav asked—

"From everything?"

Ramdev Sah laughed.

"From the debt to my shop."

Madhav's eyes went to the fourth column of the ledger.

His old sentences were still there.

Air in pocket.

No work on Friday.

Not charity; he will pay.

Ledger and debt, both getting fat.

Four annas — merely for happening to pass by.

Madhav asked softly—

"Won't all this be erased?"

Kusum was putting the cap back on her pen.

"Why should it be?"

"The debt is paid."

"The money debt."

Madhav lifted his eyes from the ledger and looked at her.

There was the faintest smile on Kusum's face.

Ramdev Sah cleared his throat.

"No tearing pages."

Madhav laughed.

"I'm not asking for the page."

Ramdev Sah rose and took a new ledger down from the upper shelf.

The old one was almost full.

The new binding was green.

He placed it before Kusum.

"Start this one tomorrow."

Kusum opened the first page.

She ruled four columns.

The first column on the new page — date.

The second — goods.

The third — price.

The fourth — What Was Said.

Madhav asked with a smile—

"Where will you write my name in the new ledger?"

Kusum uncapped her pen.

"When you borrow."

"And if I pay cash?"

"Then the ledger will be spared."

"And the words?"

Kusum held the pen poised above the page.
“You don’t need a ledger in order to speak.”
Closing the rice tin, Ramdev Sah said—
“That rule was not made by me.”
Madhav replied—
“It is a good rule.”
Kusum closed the new ledger.
The old ledger remained beside it.
A pen lay between the two bindings.
Outside the shop, evening was falling.
Madhav turned to leave.
At the doorway he looked back.
“May I come tomorrow?”
Kusum asked—
“What will you take?”
Madhav said—
“I haven’t decided yet.”
Kusum replied—
“Then come with your pocket full.”
Madhav laughed.
“With money?”
Kusum rested her hand on the old ledger.
“Having thought about what you’ll say.”
Ramdev Sah sat smiling on the wooden platform.
Madhav stepped outside.
Kusum lit the lamp.
The first page of the new ledger remained blank.
The fourth column of the old ledger had not closed.

STORY 107

One Free Cup of Tea

On the old road leading towards Saharsa there was a little turn called Belwa Chowk.

The word “chowk” made it sound grand; the place itself was small.

On one side stood a bicycle-repair shack, on the other a seed shop, and between them Budhan’s tea stall.

At daybreak Budhan Sah’s first task was to light the stove.

Then he set water to heat in a brass pot.

Two handfuls of tea leaves, three firm bruises to the ginger, a measured quantity of milk—his hands performed every step without thought.

But there was one ritual that made newcomers stop and stare.

When the first pot was ready, Budhan poured out one cup of tea and set it aside.

The cup was placed on a wooden ledge at the left-hand corner of the stall.

Above the ledge, in small letters written with charcoal, was a single word: “STRANGER.”

The cup had no price.

Nor did it have a fixed owner.

Budhan called it “the first honest opinion of the day.”

The old regulars at the chowk called it “the stranger’s tea.”

Every day Bhola, the rickshaw-puller, would ask—

“Budhan bhai, may I be a stranger today?”

Without even looking at him, Budhan would reply—

“Your credit fills three pages. Who is going to believe you are a stranger?”

Bhola would laugh.

“Then tear out the pages.”

“Will tearing out the pages change your face?”

“I’ll cover my face with a gamchha.”

“And how will you cover your voice?”

At that the men on the bench would burst out laughing.

There was one rule governing the stranger’s tea.

Whoever came to Budhan’s stall for the first time—someone Budhan had never seen before—could drink that cup without paying.

But in return the person had to say one thing.

The tea had to be described exactly as it tasted.

Good, if it was good.

Weak, if it was weak.

Too sweet, if it was too sweet.

Too little milk, if there was too little milk.

Budhan would say—

“People who pay often feel shy about speaking plainly. Someone who drinks free owes me no courtesy.”

The rule had not been born of charity.

Budhan was particularly insistent about that point.

“I am no benefactor,” he would say. “I am testing the taste.”

Bhola would immediately add—

“A taste test in which the examinee gets a scholarship in the form of tea.”

Budhan would scold him—

“You have to turn everything into a university.”

Eighteen years earlier, when the stall had first opened, Budhan’s tea had been badly made.

Everyone at the chowk admitted this now, though no one had admitted it then.

In the first week his maternal uncle had said, “Wonderful! You won’t find tea like this even in the city.”

A cousin had said, “Give me two more cups.”

A neighbour had said, “The fragrance of the ginger is extraordinary.”

Encouraged, Budhan had made the tea stronger and stronger with each passing day.

On the seventh day a traveller waiting for a bus had come in.

After the first sip, the traveller fell silent.

Budhan had asked—

“How is it?”

The traveller had asked in return—

“Shall I tell you the truth?”

“Yes. Tell me the truth.”

“This is not tea. It is medicine.”

Budhan’s face had fallen.

After a second sip, the traveller had added—

“Use half as many leaves, don’t let the milk catch after it boils, and don’t grind the ginger—just crush it.”

That was the first day Budhan had begun to doubt his maternal uncle.

The next morning he made the tea exactly as the traveller had advised.

By noon, the pot had been emptied three times.

Budhan had never asked the traveller’s name.

The bus came, the man boarded it, and he was never seen again.

From the following day onward, Budhan began reserving the first cup for a stranger.

“People who know you give you affection,” he would say. “A stranger gives you correction.”

The regulars at the chowk took turns making jokes about that sentence.

Bhola would say—

“Then at home, treat your wife as a stranger and listen to what she says.”

Budhan would reply—

“Matters at home are hotter than tea. I don’t need your advice there.”

The years changed.

New faces continued to arrive at the chowk.

Some found the cup too sweet.

Some found it not hot enough.

Some thought the smell of milk was too strong.

Once a carpenter arriving from the Nepal side had said—

“The tea is good, but the cup is not clean.”

That evening Budhan had boiled every cup in water.

A student had said—

“The tea is fine, but the bench is crooked.”

Two days later one leg of the bench had been replaced.

An elderly woman had said—

“There is nothing wrong with the tea, but the smoke gets into my eyes.”

Budhan had fitted a bamboo flue above the stove.

Thus the stranger’s cup gradually became not merely a test of the tea but a test of the entire stall.

Budhan refused to admit it.

He would say—

“I ask about the tea.”

Bhola would reply—

“People end up telling you about your whole life.”

Once a newcomer had said—

“The tea is very good, but you stare too much.”

From that day on, while a stranger took the first sip, Budhan kept his eyes on the pot.

Among the old regulars, the cup inspired a peculiar longing.

Not because they wanted to save the price.

Each of them wanted, just once, to become a stranger again.

Once Bhola arrived wearing an old cap, an empty spectacle-frame over his eyes and a gamchha wrapped across his face.

Budhan asked—

“Where are you from?”

Pinching his nose, Bhola answered—

“Purnea.”

Budhan said—

“In Purnea too, is the slipper on your left foot smaller than the one on your right?”

Everyone roared with laughter.

Bhola pulled down the gamchha.

“One day you will have to give me a free cup.”

“When I forget you.”

“Then I shall have to wait.”

“A very long time.”

The game at Belwa Chowk went on.

But one week in Sawan, the game stopped.

Repairs began on the main road.

Large vehicles were diverted along another route.

The buses stopped coming.

No strangers arrived.

On the first day the cup remained on the ledge for two hours.

A thin skin formed over the tea.

In the end Budhan did not throw the tea into the drain.

He drank it himself.

Bhola said—

“So today you have become the stranger?”

Budhan grimaced.

“I am drinking my own tea.”

“Then tell the truth. How was it?”

Budhan said nothing.

Everyone sitting near the counter burst out laughing again.

On the second day the cup was set out again.

No newcomer came.

Nor on the third day.

On the fourth day there were only five old regulars in the stall.

The stranger's ledge looked oddly empty even with the cup upon it.

Budhan filled the cup and set it down.

Bhola said—

“That tea looks sad now.”

Ramphal, the seed-shop owner, said—

“Tea does not have a face.”

Bhola replied—

“Does your sack of seed have one?”

Ramphal fell silent.

Budhan spoke less than usual that day.

The closed road meant more than the absence of strangers.

Daily sales had fallen by half.

The milkman brought the usual quantity, but milk remained in the pot.

The biscuit tin, once empty by evening, now stayed full.
 Every shop at the chowk had the same worry.
 How long would the repairs continue?
 No one had a clear answer.
 Early on the fifth morning Bhola arrived with a proposal.
 "I'll send my wife's sister's husband."
 Budhan asked—
 "Does he know me?"
 "No. He has never seen you."
 "But you know him."
 "So what?"
 "If you send him, he is not a stranger. He is your emissary."
 Bhola scratched his head.
 "Your rules are very strict."
 "The free tea is cheap. The rule is expensive."
 By noon no new face had appeared.
 The heat grew.
 Budhan inverted a small brass bowl over the cup so that dust would not settle on it.
 Ramphal said—
 "Now the tea has a roof as well."
 Budhan replied—
 "You will understand the day your seed gets wet."
 Just then, someone appeared in the distance, pushing a bicycle.
 Every head turned in the same direction.
 Bhola whispered—
 "A stranger."
 Budhan looked.
 As the man came nearer, his face became familiar.
 He turned out to be the milkman's maternal cousin.
 Everyone was disappointed.
 The man could not understand why every face fell when they saw him.
 Evening was approaching.
 The cup was growing cold again.
 Budhan removed the little bowl.
 "Shall I drink it again today?"
 Bhola said—
 "Only if you promise to tell the truth."
 For the first time that day, Budhan laughed.
 Just then a young woman came walking from the broken stretch of road.
 A cloth bag hung from her shoulder.
 She carried a folded sheet of paper in one hand.

Mud clung to her slippers.
Reaching the chowk, she looked around.
“When will I get a bus?”
Ramphal said—
“Not this week.”
Her face fell.
“Then how can I get to Sonbarsa?”
Bhola glanced at his rickshaw.
“Not that far by rickshaw.”
Budhan said—
“Sit down first.”
The young woman asked—
“Can I get some water?”
“Water, yes. Tea too.”
“How much for the tea?”
Budhan lifted the cup from the ledge.
“Nothing for you.”
She looked surprised.
“Why me?”
Bhola broke in—
“Because you are a stranger.”
She looked at him.
“Is that an insult or an honour?”
Laughter rose through the stall again.
Budhan explained the rule.
The young woman listened carefully.
“So the tea is free, but an opinion is compulsory?”
“Yes. For you, there is no charge.”
“And if the opinion is unfavourable?”
“Then it matters even more.”
“And if it is favourable?”
“That is acceptable too.”
She took the cup.
The tea was no longer as hot as it had been at first.
She slowly took a sip.
Everyone watched her face.
She took a second sip.
Remembering his old rule, Budhan turned his eyes toward the pot.
The young woman said—
“The tea is good.”
Bhola was immediately disappointed.
“Is that all?”

She laughed.

"Am I sitting for your examination?"

"I am used to hearing something new."

She turned the cup slowly in her hands.

"There is one thing."

Budhan straightened.

"Tell me."

"By the time you gave me this tea, it had already gone cold."

Budhan nodded.

"The road is closed. The stranger came late."

"Then why do you fill the cup beforehand and leave it waiting for the stranger?"

Budhan was silent.

She said—

"Keep the cup empty."

"Empty?"

"When a stranger arrives, pour in fresh tea."

Bhola slapped one palm with the other.

"In eighteen years, why did this occur to no one?"

Ramphal said—

"It had occurred to me."

Bhola asked—

"When?"

Ramphal replied—

"Just now."

Budhan looked at the cup on the ledge.

It was true: every day he had been setting aside the tea, not the drinker.

If the stranger came late, the tea grew cold.

Many times he reheated it, and the taste changed.

The purpose of the rule was an honest opinion, not cold tea.

Budhan laughed.

"You are right."

The young woman asked—

"So did my opinion pass?"

"Your opinion passed. I failed."

Bhola clapped.

"The stranger's university is open today."

Budhan glared at him.

"From tomorrow, the cup will remain empty."

"But still free?"

"Still free."

"Fresh?"

“Fresh.”

“And me?”

“Not you.”

Bhola became solemn.

“The injustice continues.”

The young woman asked how she could get to Sonbarsa.

Ramphal told her that shared transport could be found two kos farther ahead, near the roadworks.

Bhola offered to take her bag on his rickshaw and drop her there.

She asked the fare.

Bhola said—

“I will charge you.”

Everyone in the stall laughed at once.

Budhan said—

“Do not rely on this man’s charity. He keeps his accounts straight.”

Bhola replied—

“Tea is free. The rickshaw is not.”

Before leaving, the young woman returned the cup.

“What if I come back tomorrow?”

Budhan said—

“Then you will have to pay.”

“In one day I will cease to be a stranger?”

“For me, yes.”

She smiled.

“Then the free tea is expensive.”

“Why expensive?”

“Because from the second visit onward, you will count me as one of your own.”

Budhan was silent for a moment.

“That is a good price.”

The young woman left with Bhola.

In the evening Budhan wiped the ledge clean.

Below the old charcoal word “STRANGER,” he wrote a new line—

“Cup empty, tea fresh.”

Ramphal read it and said—

“Was it necessary to write so much?”

Budhan replied—

“If the rule stays written down, Bhola will not come in disguise again.”

From a distance Bhola shouted—

“I can hear you!”

The next morning Budhan lit the stove.

The pot went on the fire.

The first batch was ready.
 By old habit his hand moved to fill the cup.
 He stopped.
 He placed a clean, empty cup on the ledge.
 Bhola arrived and examined it carefully.
 "Where is the stranger's tea today?"
 Budhan lifted the lid of the pot.
 Steam rose out.
 "In this pot."
 "Not in the cup?"
 "When the stranger comes, then it will be in the cup."
 Bhola sat down on the bench.
 "And when will I become a stranger?"
 Handing him his tea, Budhan said—
 "When I forget both your debt and your words."
 Bhola took the cup and laughed.
 "Then I shall grow old paying for tea."
 Budhan said—
 "That is the difficulty with one's own people."
 The empty cup shone on the ledge.
 The tea in the pot was fresh.
 And the chowk awoke once more, waiting for its first new face.

STORY 108

The Old Man and the Radio

There was a village on the Madhepura side called Bardaha.

A paved road ran through the middle of the village, but Maheshwar Jha's house stood two fields in from the road.

An old mango tree stood to the south of the courtyard.

Beneath the mango tree was a bamboo cot.

Every evening a small radio was placed on the right-hand corner of the cot.

The cover at the back of the radio had broken long ago.

Maheshwar Kaka had tied it in place with a strip of cloth.

A red thread was knotted around the volume knob.

Now that his eyesight had weakened, the red thread told him which way to turn it.

At seven every evening Maheshwar Kaka could miss a meal, but never the radio.

That was when the local broadcast came on.

News was followed by songs.

After the songs came letters from listeners.

And at the end came the voice of the announcer, Shivnath Mishra.

Shivnath Mishra would say—

“It is time for us to take leave now. The cold is increasing; our elderly listeners should keep themselves warmly clothed.”

Maheshwar Kaka would pull the shawl more snugly around his shoulders.

Then his grandson Nilu, sitting inside the house, would smile.

“Baba, did he say that to you?”

Without taking his eyes off the radio, Maheshwar Kaka would reply—

“Who else is old in this courtyard, if not me?”

Nilu would say—

“The whole district is listening.”

“Let the district listen. The words were spoken to me.”

“Does he know you?”

“Very well indeed.”

“Have you ever met him?”

“Does one know a person only by meeting him? Not by his voice?”

After that answer, argument became difficult.

Nilu had tried two or three times already.

Maheshwar Kaka won every time, because he had no need to admit defeat.

His conviction had begun almost twelve years earlier.
 At that time the little culvert west of Bardaha had broken down.
 During the rains, schoolchildren had to wade through knee-deep water.
 The villagers submitted a petition.
 The paper travelled from office to office.
 The culvert remained as it was.
 Maheshwar Kaka sent a letter from the post office.
 It was addressed to All India Radio's "Listeners' Voice" programme.
 Three weeks later, one evening, Shivnath Mishra's voice came over the radio

"Maheshwar Jha of Bardaha writes that the culvert west of his village is broken, causing hardship to the schoolchildren."

That day Maheshwar Kaka had almost sprung off the cot.

"Did you hear that?"

Everyone in the house had come running.

"He said my name!"

The radio had gone on—

"We hope this matter reaches the department concerned."

To Maheshwar Kaka, the meaning of those two lines was perfectly clear.

Shivnath Mishra had come to know him.

The culvert was rebuilt four months later.

Which petition had brought it about, whose pressure had worked, when the funds had arrived—there were different stories in the village about all of that.

Maheshwar Kaka's story was the shortest.

"Shivnath Babu spoke about it, and then it was done."

Nilu had been small then.

Now he was sixteen.

He tried to reason it out.

"Baba, just because he read your name once, does that mean he will know you for the rest of his life?"

Maheshwar Kaka would say—

"Your name was entered in the school register once. Does that mean your teacher no longer knows you?"

"The teacher sees me."

"Shivnath Babu hears."

"The radio speaks only one way."

"Words may travel one way, but attention can travel both ways."

Instead of trying to understand that sentence, Nilu scratched his head.

Maheshwar Kaka's conviction had become part of his daily routine.

Before the evening programme, he cleaned the radio.

He pulled the antenna up half a cubit.

When the batteries weakened, the sound trembled.

Kaka would put his ear close to the set and say—
“Shivnath Babu’s throat is giving out.”

Nilu would say—

“The battery is dying.”

“Everything looks like a machine to you.”

Once the broadcast said—

“Listeners returning from work in the fields, do not forget to wash your hands and face.”

That day Maheshwar Kaka had in fact come straight from the fields and sat down on the cot without washing.

He immediately got up.

“See?”

Nilu doubled over laughing.

“That was a general remark.”

“Was the mud on my hands general too?”

The next day the announcer said—

“The fog will thicken tonight.”

Maheshwar Kaka called to his grandson—

“Nilu, bring the bicycle inside. Shivnath Babu is saying so.”

Nilu said—

“It is a weather bulletin.”

“And who is the bulletin for?”

“Everyone.”

“Am I not part of everyone?”

Nilu had no answer to that.

Meena Devi, the daughter-in-law of the house, enjoyed these arguments.

Sometimes she would deliberately ask—

“Babuji, what will Shivnath Babu say today?”

Maheshwar Kaka would answer gravely—

“Yesterday he said there would be sunshine. Today he will certainly say that the paddy should be spread out to dry.”

If the agricultural advice really did mention paddy, Kaka remained triumphant all day.

If it did not, he would say—

“Not everything can be said on the radio.”

The story travelled as far as the village tea stall.

In the afternoons people teased Maheshwar Kaka.

“Kaka, Shivnath Babu did not take my name yesterday, did he?”

“He will when you have some work worth mentioning.”

“My goat is lost.”

“First look for the goat. The radio is not the police.”

Everyone would laugh.

Maheshwar Kaka laughed too.

He defended his conviction not with anger, but with humour.

One day Nilu decided there ought to be proof.

He explained his plan—

“Baba, if he knows you, then do not listen to the radio for two days. Let us see whether he asks about you.”

Maheshwar Kaka looked at him as though Nilu had made an exceptionally foolish proposal.

“If I do not listen, how will I hear him ask? I shall not hear the answer.”

“Listen on the third day.”

“Remain absent for two days without reason? Is that good manners?”

The experiment ended before it began.

But a few weeks later, two days of absence happened of their own accord, without any plan of Nilu’s.

On the first day, the radio fell silent.

Turn the knob, tap the casing, straighten the antenna—nothing worked.

Maheshwar Kaka turned it this way and that.

“Where has Shivnath Babu gone?”

Nilu opened the battery compartment.

“These two batteries are finished.”

“Bring new ones tomorrow.”

“The market is the day after tomorrow.”

That evening Maheshwar Kaka sat on the cot without the radio.

Seven o’clock came.

The mango leaves kept stirring.

From some distant house came the faint sound of a song.

Kaka strained his ears.

The sound was too far away.

He could not make out the words.

He rose at once.

He drew the shawl over his shoulders.

“Where are you going?” Meena Devi asked.

“To Ramlochan’s.”

“At this hour?”

“His radio works.”

Ramlochan’s house was half a kos away.

Maheshwar Kaka walked there through the darkness without a torch.

By the time he arrived, half the programme was over.

Ramlochan pulled out a low stool for him at the doorway.

“Sit down, Kaka.”

Maheshwar Kaka’s first question was—

“Did Shivnath Babu ask anything?”

Ramlochan stared.

“Ask what?”

“Nothing at all?”

That evening Shivnath Mishra merely introduced the songs, read two letters, gave the weather report, and signed off.

Maheshwar Kaka spoke less than usual on the way home.

The next day Ramlochan himself brought his radio to Maheshwar Kaka’s house.

“Kaka, the market is the day after tomorrow. Keep my radio for two days.”

Maheshwar Kaka refused.

“What will you listen to at night?”

“I will listen at the tea stall.”

“You will listen at the tea stall while I keep something from your house? No.”

Ramlochan laughed.

“Shivnath Babu will be offended.”

Maheshwar Kaka was silent for a moment.

Then he took the radio.

“I will return it tomorrow.”

That evening the programme began.

The reception was clear.

But it was not Shivnath Mishra’s voice.

A young new announcer was speaking.

Maheshwar Kaka sat up straight.

The songs passed.

The news passed.

The listeners’ letters began.

The new voice read the letters as well.

Maheshwar Kaka asked softly—

“Nilu, is the time right?”

“Yes.”

“Is this the same programme?”

“The same.”

At the end the new announcer said—

“Our senior colleague Shivnath Mishra is on leave for a few days. His greetings to all his listener-friends.”

Maheshwar Kaka’s face brightened again.

“Did you hear that? He said friends.”

Nilu said—

“All the listeners are friends.”

“Am I not among them all?”

Nilu lost again.

For the next three days Shivrath Mishra did not return.

Maheshwar Kaka listened to the programme, but every now and then he looked at the radio grille as though a familiar seat beyond it were empty.

On the fourth day he went to the post office.

The postmaster asked—

“Kaka, has the culvert broken again?”

“The culvert is fine.”

“Then who is the letter for?”

“All India Radio.”

“A complaint?”

“No complaint.”

“A request?”

“Not that either.”

Maheshwar Kaka wrote a short letter.

His hand trembled; the letters stood stiff and upright.

He wrote—

“Shivrath Babu is on leave. Please tell him that the evening cot in Bardaha is not empty. Let him rest and return at ease.”

He wrote his name.

He wrote the village.

Nothing more.

Nilu knew nothing about the letter.

Maheshwar Kaka himself dropped it into the postbox.

One week passed.

Then two.

Shivrath Mishra returned.

That evening Maheshwar Kaka ran a finger over the grille of the radio.

“Now it is all right.”

The programme went on as usual.

There was no special announcement.

Maheshwar Kaka’s letter was not read out.

Nilu did not know about the letter, so he could not understand the reason for Kaka’s expectancy.

In the third week the postman brought a small envelope.

It was from the All India Radio station.

Maheshwar Kaka spent five minutes looking for his spectacles.

Nilu came running.

“Shall I read it?”

“I shall read it myself.”

Kaka read it slowly, on his own.

Inside was a printed note of thanks.

At the bottom, one line had been added by hand—

“Greetings to Maheshwarji of Bardaha. I received the news about the cot. — Shivnath”

Maheshwar Kaka said nothing for a long time.

Nilu made no attempt to snatch the letter.

He had already read it himself.

At last Kaka said—

“Now tell me.”

Nilu smiled.

“Now he really does know you.”

Maheshwar Kaka shook his head.

“Not from now.”

“Then since when?”

“From before.”

“The proof has come only now.”

“You were the one who needed proof.”

Nilu fell silent.

That evening Kaka placed the envelope beneath the radio.

The evening broadcast began.

In his usual voice Shivnath Mishra gave the weather, introduced the songs, and read letters from two villages.

He did not mention Maheshwar Kaka’s name.

At the end he said—

“In many relationships in life, people never see one another’s faces; it is the voice that makes a path between them. Good night to all our listener-friends.”

Nilu immediately looked at his grandfather.

Maheshwar Kaka was adjusting his shawl.

“See?”

Nilu laughed.

“That was said to everyone again.”

Maheshwar Kaka lowered the volume of the radio.

“Yes, to everyone.”

He paused for a moment.

“But one needs the sense to hear one’s own share in what is said to everyone.”

Nilu sat down at the other corner of the cot.

For the first time, when the programme ended that day, he did not go straight inside.

A faint crackle remained in the radio.

Night dew was falling from the mango leaves.

Maheshwar Kaka folded the envelope and tucked it safely beneath the cloth strap at the back of the radio.

Nilu asked—

“Baba, what if one day Shivnath Babu leaves the service?”

Maheshwar Kaka said—

“Then another voice will come.”

“Will that voice know you too?”

Kaka laughed.

“Let me listen to it first. Acquaintance can come later.”

The next evening, at seven, two people sat on the cot.

One was an old man who believed that the people on the far side of the radio knew him.

And the other was a boy who could no longer say with certainty that this belief was entirely wrong.

STORY 109

A Shared Umbrella

By the time the Sakri market was breaking up, the sky had stooped so low that it seemed the clouds might brush the bamboo stalls.

There had been sunshine until noon.

So most people had come without umbrellas.

Lakhan Mandal had come carrying the little tin box of his old shoe-repair trade.

He had spent two hours in a corner of the market stitching sandals, replacing straps, and hammering a heel onto a pair of shoes.

The earnings were not much, but they covered his fare home and the price of vegetables for the evening.

Before the market had fully closed, the first heavy drop fell.

Lakhan lifted the tin box and looked up at the sky.

The second drop was twice as large as the first.

By the third, people were running.

Lakhan opened the old umbrella tied behind his box.

The cloth spread out, but the iron runner in the middle would not stay locked at the top.

Lakhan pushed the runner upward with his hand.

The umbrella opened.

He took his hand away.

The umbrella half-closed again.

"Your umbrella does not want to go home with its owner either?" came a voice beside him.

Lakhan looked around.

A thin young man stood there with a small cloth bag slung over one shoulder.

Lakhan did not yet know his name.

Inside the bag were two cotton towels, a cheap set of children's clothes, and a cake of soap wrapped in paper.

Lakhan said—

"The umbrella wants to go. It merely needs two people."

The young man laughed.

"Two people?"

"One to hold the handle, the other to keep this runner pushed up. Only then will His Majesty remain open."

The rain was now falling in thick sheets.

The young man stood under the market awning, but water dripping through its holes was soaking his shoulder.

Lakhan asked—

“Where are you going?”

“As far as Peepal Turn. Then on to Bhittha.”

“I am going as far as Peepal Turn too. Then to Kusaha.”

“So half the road is the same?”

“The road is the same. The umbrella can be half-and-half.”

The young man gripped the runner.

Lakhan held the handle.

The umbrella immediately opened all the way.

The two looked at each other.

Lakhan said—

“See? It does not need friendship. It needs labour.”

The young man burst out laughing.

“And the wages?”

“Half a dry shoulder.”

They left the muddy market and stepped onto the road.

The umbrella was small.

The two men were not.

Within the first ten paces the problem became clear.

Lakhan’s right shoulder was dry, his left wet.

The young man’s left shoulder was dry, his right wet.

The young man said—

“You are tilting the umbrella more toward yourself.”

Lakhan protested at once—

“The handle is in my hand, but the runner is in yours. Cheating can happen from two directions.”

The young man tried to centre the runner.

The umbrella swung to the right.

Lakhan said—

“That is not justice. That is a storm.”

They laughed again.

After fifty paces they made a rule.

For ten paces, the umbrella would lean two finger-widths more toward Lakhan.

For the next ten, two finger-widths more toward the young man.

On the twentieth pace, equality.

The rule worked for five minutes.

Then both forgot the count.

“How many paces has it been?” the young man asked.

"I was relying on your counting."

"And I on yours."

"Then we are even."

Water had collected along the roadside.

An ox cart went past and splashed water up to both their feet.

The young man looked down and said—

"From now on, let the umbrella accounts apply only to the upper half of the body."

Lakhan said—

"Agreed. The lower half belongs to nature."

For the first time, they asked each other's names.

"I am Lakhan."

"I am Salim."

"Where are you from?"

"Bhittha. You?"

"Kusaha."

After a moment Lakhan said—

"We have walked together all this while and only now asked each other's names."

Salim said—

"Saving the umbrella came first. Introductions could wait."

"That is true."

Salim worked carrying loads in the market.

Whoever had a sack, a basket, a crate—if the price was right, he would lift it.

The work was never certain.

Sometimes there was work all day.

Sometimes he waited until noon.

Lakhan stitched shoes and sandals.

His earnings too were like the rain.

Sometimes a downpour.

Sometimes not even a drop.

Salim asked—

"Good earnings today?"

Lakhan lifted the tin box slightly and said—

"The box is heavy. The pocket is light."

Salim patted his bag.

"Mine is the opposite. The bag is light; the shoulder is heavy."

They laughed again.

The rain was so fierce that the road ahead had turned hazy.

Water no longer pattered on the umbrella cloth; it drummed.

At one place, an unpaved track branched off from the metalled road.

There was a deep pothole.
 Lakhan moved left.
 Salim moved right.
 The umbrella pulled between them.
 “Stop!”
 They both said it at once.
 The runner slipped from Salim’s hand.
 The umbrella instantly half-collapsed over both their heads.
 Within two seconds they were soaked through.
 From under the folded cloth Lakhan said—
 “Justice is complete now.”
 From beneath the closed umbrella Salim replied—
 “Yes. Now neither of us can complain.”
 They stood there in the mud, laughing.
 The umbrella was opened again.
 This time Salim, gripping the runner, said—
 “This runner has become so slippery that the hand gets tired.”
 Lakhan said—
 “I will tie a wire around it when I get home.”
 Salim opened his bag.
 A thin, strong cord was tied to one corner of a towel.
 “Will this cord do?”
 “Isn’t that part of your goods?”
 “It is for tying the towel. But the towel is not going to run away.”
 They stopped by the roadside.
 Lakhan pushed the runner up.
 Salim looped the cord beneath it and tied it around the shaft.
 The first knot loosened.
 With the second, the umbrella stood crooked.
 With the third, the runner stayed in place.
 Salim let go.
 The umbrella remained open.
 They looked at it as though it had passed a difficult examination.
 Lakhan said—
 “Your job is over now.”
 Salim dusted his hands.
 “And my wages?”
 “I gave you half a dry shoulder.”
 Salim looked at his soaked shirt.
 “We shall have to reopen that wage account.”
 One person could now manage the umbrella alone.
 Even so, they kept walking together.

After a while Lakhan said—

“You can walk faster if you want. There is no need to hold the runner now.”

Salim said—

“What will I gain by walking faster? Peepal Turn will still be where it is.”

Lakhan said nothing.

He centred the umbrella.

A little bridge came along the way.

There was no water over the bridge, but the fields on both sides were flooded.

The wind was strong there.

It tried to turn the umbrella inside out.

Lakhan gripped the handle hard.

Instinctively, Salim reached up and caught one of the metal ribs at the edge.

The umbrella survived.

Lakhan said—

“You have your job again.”

Salim said—

“There are no permanent appointments under this umbrella.”

“The job is temporary. The soaking is permanent.”

They laughed again as they crossed the bridge.

Peepal Turn was now half a mile away.

The rain had eased a little.

Small streams still ran along the road.

Now and then the two fell silent too.

But the silence was not heavy.

Rain spoke on the umbrella above them.

Their shoes sank into the mud.

Sometimes Lakhan shifted the handle into his right hand.

Sometimes Salim carried the tin box for a while.

Once Salim said—

“Give it to me. I will carry the box.”

Lakhan said—

“You already have a bag on your shoulder.”

“The bag is light.”

“The box is heavy.”

“That is why I am asking for it.”

Lakhan handed him the box.

Salim put it on his shoulder.

With Lakhan’s hand free, it became easier to keep the umbrella centred.

After some distance Lakhan said—

“Give it back now. It is heavy.”

Salim said—

"I told you earlier—the shoulder was heavy."

"The box cannot be the reason for that."

"Let this be the reason for a little while."

At Peepal Turn stood an old peepal tree.

Beneath it was an earthen platform.

The road split there in two.

Left to Bhittha.

Right to Kusaha.

They stopped.

The rain had thinned to almost a mist.

Salim returned the tin box to Lakhan.

Lakhan held out the umbrella handle toward Salim.

"Take it. Carry it as far as Bhittha."

Salim was surprised.

"How will you get to Kusaha?"

"The rain has eased."

"It is just as light on my side."

"There are clothes in your bag."

"There are tools in your box."

"The tools are iron."

"The clothes will dry."

For a few moments they kept offering the umbrella to one another.

At last Salim said—

"Let the umbrella decide for itself."

He let go of the shaft so that it stood straight.

There was no wind.

The umbrella leaned toward neither man.

Lakhan said—

"It is clever. It has stayed in the middle."

Salim looked at his bamboo-coloured cord, still holding the runner in place.

"The cord is mine."

"The umbrella is mine."

"Then we have half a right each."

"Shall we cut the umbrella in two?"

"No. If it rains again, it will need two people."

Lakhan laughed.

"Are you coming to the market next Tuesday?"

"If I get work."

"I will be there."

"Get the umbrella repaired."

"Then I shall not need you."

Salim replied at once—

“Not for the umbrella. I have to get my cord back.”

“Cut it off now.”

“No. Next Tuesday.”

They agreed that the cord would remain on the umbrella until then.

Salim turned toward Bhittha.

Lakhan toward Kusaha.

After ten paces Salim turned and called out—

“Keep the umbrella in the middle!”

Lakhan turned too.

“Whose half is the rain now?”

Salim waved a hand.

“All of it is yours now!”

The following Tuesday the sky was clear.

The sun was out.

Dust rose in the market.

Lakhan sat in his usual place with the tin box open.

The umbrella was folded and tied behind the box.

Beneath the runner, Salim’s cord was still there.

Around noon, after unloading sacks, Salim came over.

From a distance he called—

“Is the cord safe?”

Lakhan opened the umbrella.

A new thin wire now held the runner so that it stayed up on its own.

He untied the cord and handed it to Salim.

“The umbrella is repaired.”

Salim put the cord back in his bag.

“Good. Now one person can manage it.”

Lakhan said—

“Yes. It is fixed.”

For a few moments neither spoke.

Then Lakhan asked—

“Will you walk as far as Peepal Turn?”

Salim looked up at the sky.

“Where is the rain?”

“There is no rain.”

“Then the umbrella?”

Lakhan folded it and put it over his shoulder.

“The umbrella is no longer the excuse. The road is still the same.”

Salim smiled.

He took hold of one side of Lakhan’s tin box.

The two walked out of the market together.

This time the umbrella was closed.
Both their shoulders were dry.
And the road was no longer divided into halves.

STORY 110

The Five-Rupee King

By noon, the scent of fresh greens had settled into Gopi's right hand.

Since morning he had been sitting with his mother on the veranda.

His mother, Malati, was tying into bundles the greens cut from the little patch behind the house.

Gopi shook the leaves clean, evened the stalks, and arranged the bundles in rows.

He was nine years old.

But that day he had done more work than his age ought to require—at least that was his own opinion.

When the last bundle too had been sold, Malati untied the knot in the corner of her sari.

A few coins jingled.

Gopi's ears pricked up.

Malati placed a five-rupee coin on his palm.

"These are your wages."

Gopi looked first at his mother.

Then at the coin.

Then at his mother again.

"All mine?"

"All yours."

"I don't have to give it back?"

"No, you don't have to give it back."

"I don't have to give it to anyone?"

"Not if you don't want to."

Gopi closed his fist around the coin.

The moment his fist closed, his shoulders rose a little.

At the other end of the veranda his little sister, Jhunki, was playing with an earthen lid.

Gopi called to her.

"Hey, Jhunki!"

Jhunki raised her head.

"What?"

Gopi opened his fist.

The coin flashed in the sunlight.

"Look."

Jhunki came closer.
 “Five rupees.”
 Gopi’s eyes widened.
 “How did you know?”
 “It has a five written on it.”
 Gopi was slightly disappointed.
 He had wanted Jhunki to be astonished the moment she heard the news of his wealth.
 But Jhunki began to turn back to her earthen lid.
 Gopi said—
 “I’m rich now.”
 Jhunki stopped.
 “With five rupees?”
 “With my own five rupees.”
 Jhunki looked at the coin again.
 “Then are you a king?”
 The thought had not occurred to Gopi until then.
 But it was a good thought.
 “Yes. I am the king now.”
 He sat down on the old low stool in the middle of the veranda.
 “I am the king.”
 Jhunki abandoned her game as well.
 “What am I?”
 Gopi thought for two moments.
 “You are the guard.”
 “I am the queen.”
 “Guard of the royal treasury.”
 “Queen.”
 “All right. Queen-guard.”
 Jhunki accepted the arrangement.
 Gopi turned an old brass bowl upside down in the middle of the stool.
 The coin was placed beneath it.
 “This is the royal treasury.”
 Jhunki immediately put her palm over the bowl.
 “No one is to touch it.”
 Malati, gathering the discarded stalks of greens, watched the two of them with a smile.
 “Your Majesty, will you eat, or will you spend the whole day staring at the treasury?”
 Gopi rubbed his stomach.
 “A king eats.”
 “Then wash your hands.”

“Does a king wash his hands?”

“The king in my house does.”

Gopi went quietly towards the well.

Even after lunch, his sense of wealth did not diminish.

Again and again he went to the stool.

He lifted the bowl.

Looked at the coin.

Then put the bowl back.

Along one edge of the coin was a small crescent-shaped scratch.

Gopi stared at it until he knew it by heart.

“This is my royal mark.”

Jhunki asked—

“The scratch?”

“The royal mark.”

“A scratch.”

“I’ll banish you from the court.”

“Then who will guard the bowl?”

Gopi fell silent.

Running a kingdom was not simple.

In the afternoon Sito Kaki came by.

She wanted a bundle of bathua greens.

Malati said—

“The last bundle is ten rupees.”

Sito Kaki handed her a twenty-rupee note.

Malati untied the knot in her sari.

She needed two five-rupee coins.

There was only one five-rupee coin in the knot.

She looked at Gopi.

Gopi understood that a crisis had reached the royal court.

Malati said with a laugh—

“Your Majesty, may the kingdom lend us five rupees?”

Gopi immediately placed his hand over the bowl.

“The royal treasury will become empty.”

Sito Kaki laughed.

“Such a tiny kingdom?”

Gopi remained grave.

“The treasury of a small kingdom is still a treasury.”

Malati said—

“If you don’t want to, let it be. I’ll take Sito Didi’s five rupees to her this evening.”

Gopi listened to his mother’s voice.

There was no compulsion in it.

The bowl was still safe under his hand.
 He thought for a moment.
 Then he lifted the bowl.
 "I'll lend it."
 "At what interest?" Sito Kaki asked.
 Gopi did not quite know what interest meant.
 But a king had to answer every question.
 Gopi said clearly—
 "One piece of news by evening."
 "What news?"
 "News of where my coin went."
 Sito Kaki took the coin.
 Gopi pointed out the crescent-shaped scratch on her palm.
 "Look at this mark."
 "Yes, I've seen it."
 "This very coin must come back."
 Sito Kaki said—
 "Your Majesty, money moves. It does not sit still."
 Gopi looked at the empty belly of the bowl.
 He did not like that statement.
 Sito Kaki left.
 Jhunki immediately announced—
 "The king has become poor."
 "I've lent it."
 "The bowl is empty."
 "The royal treasury has gone out."
 "Empty."
 Gopi turned the bowl right side up.
 The empty bowl looked even emptier.
 He turned it upside down again.
 "Now it doesn't show."
 Just then Nanhku from next door peeped onto the veranda.
 Jhunki immediately said—
 "The king is poor."
 Gopi sat a little straighter on the stool.
 "The royal treasury is travelling."
 Nanhku asked—
 "Will there be a royal feast?"
 "When the treasury returns, the matter will be considered."
 "May I become a minister right now?"
 "The minister's post is not vacant."
 Jhunki frowned.

“Who is the minister?”

Gopi hesitated for a moment.

“The kingdom is small at present, so the king is also the minister.”

Nanhku went away laughing.

Jhunki said softly—

“The queen-guard does more work.”

Gopi heard the objection, but there was no official file anywhere in the court from which he could produce an answer.

A couple of hours later Harkhu the milkman passed through the lane.

Two brass milk cans hung from the crossbar of his bicycle.

Gopi and Jhunki were sitting on the veranda.

Harkhu laughed and called—

“Long live the king!”

Gopi was startled.

“How did you know?”

Harkhu stopped his bicycle.

“Sito Didi told me.”

Gopi’s chest swelled again a little.

News of the kingdom had crossed the lane.

Harkhu took a coin out of his shirt pocket.

“Is this the royal coin?”

Gopi jumped down from the stool.

Along the edge of the coin was the crescent-shaped scratch.

“That is my royal coin!”

“At the moment it is in my pocket.”

Gopi’s face fell.

Harkhu laughed.

“Sito Didi paid me five rupees she owed for milk.”

Gopi stared at the coin as though it had sent news from some distant country.

“Will you return it now?”

“Why should I return it? Did your mother borrow five rupees from me?”

Gopi stopped.

The matter was difficult.

Harkhu put the coin back into his pocket.

“Don’t worry. The royal coin is making its rounds.”

He rode away.

Jhunki said—

“King of two houses.”

Gopi said—

“Not two houses. The whole lane.”

This time there was less worry and more pride in his voice.

Towards evening his father, Ramsevak, returned from his little bicycle-repair shop.

There was grease on his palms.

Reaching the veranda, he asked—

“I hear a king has arisen in this house.”

Gopi sat very straight on the stool.

“Yes. The kingdom is running.”

Ramsevak folded his hands.

“Your Majesty, your subject is tired. May he have some water first?”

Jhunki collapsed with laughter.

Gopi ran and brought a lota full of water.

Ramsevak drank and said—

“The king’s service is excellent.”

Gopi immediately asked—

“Did you see my five rupees?”

Ramsevak raised his eyebrows.

“Which five?”

“The one with a crescent-shaped scratch on the edge.”

Ramsevak searched his pocket.

He took out a five-rupee coin.

Gopi pounced on it to inspect it.

There was no scratch.

“Not this one.”

“Will there be a royal inspection of my shop as well?”

“Harkhu Kaka had it.”

Ramsevak laughed.

“He came at noon to have air put in a tyre.”

Gopi’s eyes lit up.

“Then what happened?”

“He gave me twenty rupees. The charge was fifteen. I returned five.”

Gopi stood up.

“Which five?”

“Whichever came into my hand.”

“The scratched one?”

Ramsevak scratched his head.

“I don’t keep the genealogy of coins.”

Jhunki began laughing again.

Gopi was not amused.

“Whom did you give it to?”

Ramsevak thought.

“The postman came by. I had tightened his bicycle bell.”

“To him?”

"Possibly."

Gopi stepped out of the veranda.

He looked down the lane.

The postman was nowhere in sight.

It seemed to Gopi that the royal coin had now taken the government road.

Malati, blowing on the cooking fire, said—

"Gopi, think about your supper. Your five rupees are my responsibility."

Gopi said—

"I don't want another five."

"Why not another coin?"

"I want the one with my mark."

Malati laughed.

"Does Your Majesty own the money or the scratch?"

Gopi did not answer.

Just then a bicycle bell rang in the lane.

It was the postman.

His bag was already empty.

He turned towards the house.

"Malati sister, is there any bathua left?"

Malati said—

"One small bundle."

"Give it to me. They asked for it at home."

Malati picked up the bundle.

"Ten rupees."

The postman searched his pocket.

He took out a five-rupee note, two two-rupee coins, and one five-rupee coin.

Gopi's eyes went straight to the five-rupee coin.

He came slowly closer.

"May I see?"

The postman asked—

"See what?"

"That five."

"A royal inspection?" Ramsevak called from behind.

The postman laughed and placed the coin on Gopi's palm.

Along its edge was the little crescent-shaped scratch.

Gopi's face lit up as if the sun had returned after dusk.

"This is it!"

Malati took the rest of the money from the postman.

The postman left with the bundle of bathua.

Gopi closed his fist tightly around the coin.

"It came back."

Ramsevak asked—

“Where all did it go?”
 Gopi began counting.
 “From my hand to Ma.”
 “From Ma to Sito Kaki.”
 “From Sito Kaki to Harkhu Kaka.”
 “From Harkhu Kaka to Babuji’s shop.”
 “From there to the postman.”
 “From the postman back home.”
 Jhunki asked—
 “Then is this five-rupee coin rich?”
 Gopi said—
 “No. A coin isn’t rich.”
 “Then are you?”
 Gopi sat down again on the stool.
 He lifted the brass bowl.
 He put the coin underneath it.
 Then, after thinking for a moment, he removed the bowl.
 The coin lay openly on the stool.
 “I am the king.”
 “Why?” Jhunki asked.
 Gopi ran a finger over the coin.
 “Because my royal treasury went all around the lane and still recognised me when it came back.”
 Ramsevak burst out laughing.
 “Did the coin recognise you, or did you recognise the coin?”
 Gopi thought for a moment.
 “We recognised each other.”
 After supper that night, the coin did not go under his pillow again.
 It remained on the stool beside the brass bowl.
 At dawn Sito Kaki came to the doorway and called—
 “Your Majesty!”
 Gopi woke and came running.
 “What is it, Kaki?”
 Sito Kaki said with a laugh—
 “Do you have change for five?”
 Gopi looked at the coin lying on the stool.
 Jhunki too was looking at him.
 Gopi picked up the coin.
 “Yes. I have one.”
 Sito Kaki held out her palm.
 Before giving her the coin, Gopi looked once at the crescent-shaped scratch.
 Then he smiled.

“I want news by evening.”

STORY III

The Aroma of Rice

The first dusk of evening was slowly descending upon that old lane in Darbhanga.

Madhav sat by the window of his small rented room.

Letters covered the open book before him, but again and again his eyes strayed from the page towards the courtyard next door.

In the neighbouring house, Kamla Kaki's hearth was burning.

The crackle of dried mango leaves and little sticks came drifting with the air.

A little while later the lid of the pot trembled softly.

Then the aroma of cooked rice crossed the narrow lane and reached Madhav's window.

His hand stopped upon the page.

He closed his eyes.

His village was in that fragrance.

There was the earthen veranda.

There was his mother's old brass pot.

There was his sister drying rain-soaked clothes.

And there was his father's voice, returning from the fields at dusk: "Is the rice ready?"

Madhav opened his eyes.

Before him was the same room once more.

A cot.

A low wooden board.

Two books.

A half-filled sack of rice against the wall.

And in the corner, a small kerosene stove that had not been lit for three days.

Madhav drew water from the earthen jar and drank a lotaful.

Then he opened his book again.

Next door, the lid was lifted.

The aroma of rice grew richer.

Madhav smiled at the thought.

"Mother must still fill the kitchen with smoke when she drains the rice water," he thought.

That night too, his supper was flattened rice and salt.

There was nothing wrong with flattened rice.

At home as well he ate it often.

But eating flattened rice for a fifth consecutive night in the city was not the same as choosing to eat it at home.

Madhav was the son of a poor household, but hunger was no stranger to him.

He knew how to keep accounts with hunger.

College fees, room rent, the price of books, pens, paper, and the fare home - among all these, the cost of food quietly had to find its own place.

Rice arrived from home.

Sometimes two seers, sometimes five.

Rice was not the problem.

Fire was.

Kerosene was expensive.

Buying firewood cost no less.

Madhav had worked it out: if he cooked rice every night, the money for his journey home during the last seven days of the month would disappear.

So most evenings he managed with flattened rice, sattu, curd when he could get it, and otherwise salt with green chillies.

The sack of rice remained in the corner.

And every day the aroma rising from the neighbouring hearth reminded him that a sack could be full while a cooking pot remained empty.

At first Kamla Kaki had paid no attention to this.

Her own days were full.

Sweeping the courtyard at dawn.

Sewing until afternoon.

Seeing to her granddaughter's lessons in the evening.

Cooking rice and lentils at night.

Then one day she noticed something curious.

As long as the water in her pot simmered, the sound of pages turning came from Madhav's room.

The moment the first aroma of rice rose, the pages stopped turning.

The first day Kamla Kaki took it for a coincidence.

The second day it happened again.

The third day as well.

On the fourth day, before lifting the lid, Kamla Kaki looked towards the window.

Madhav was reading.

The lid rose.

Steam escaped.

Madhav lifted his head from the book.

He leaned a little towards the window.

Kamla Kaki immediately looked away.
 She felt like laughing, and she felt sorrow too.
 After dinner that night, she went to Madhav's door.
 "Baua, do you have a great deal to study?"
 Madhav stood up.
 "Yes, Kaki. The examination is near."
 Kamla Kaki let her eyes travel around the room.
 She saw the sack of rice.
 She saw the kerosene stove in the corner.
 There was no fresh trace of soot above it.
 "Do you cook the rice, or merely stand guard over it?"
 Madhav could not help laughing.
 "I don't get much time, Kaki."
 "Does rice require time, or fire?"
 For a moment Madhav's laughter caught in his throat.
 He understood that Kaki had understood.
 But Kamla Kaki asked nothing more.
 She merely said, "All right. Study."
 The next evening, when Madhav returned from college, Kamla Kaki had set two pots in the courtyard.
 One was her own large pot.
 The other was small and empty.
 Madhav stopped when he saw the little pot.
 "Whose is this?"
 "Yours."
 "Mine?"
 "Yes, Baua."
 "Why this?"
 Kamla Kaki pushed a stick deeper into the hearth.
 "After my rice comes off the fire, half the heat dies for nothing."
 Madhav was silent.
 "Your rice is yours, your water is yours, and this old pot is mine. Save the embers from dying."
 Madhav's ears grew warm.
 "No, Kaki. This won't be right."
 "What is wrong about it?"
 "Your firewood -"
 "How is the wood mine? It belongs to the tree."
 Madhav did not smile.
 Kamla Kaki went on, "If you insist on keeping accounts, sweep away the ash. My knees hurt. Take the fire in exchange for that labour."
 Now Madhav laughed.

"Sweep the ash?"

"Yes. A fair bargain."

The bargain was so strange that refusing it was difficult.

Madhav opened his sack.

He took out a bowlful of rice.

He washed it.

He poured water into the small pot.

After Kamla Kaki's rice came off, he set his pot over the fading embers.

They both waited.

Five minutes.

Ten minutes.

Fifteen minutes.

Kamla Kaki lifted the lid and pressed a grain between her fingers.

It was still hard at the centre.

"Half the fire has died," she said.

Madhav laughed.

"Even rice sets examinations for poor students."

Kamla Kaki added two thin sticks to the fire.

A little later the rice was cooked.

That day Madhav ate rice from his own store.

Only with salt and two green chillies.

But the moment he put the first mouthful into his mouth, it seemed to him that the walls of the room had moved a little farther back.

The place had somehow grown larger.

The next day the arrangement changed.

Kamla Kaki did not wait for her own rice to come entirely off the fire.

When only the last breath of cooking remained in her pot, she moved it to the edge and placed Madhav's little pot in the centre of the flame.

The two pots took turns on the same hearth.

Madhav swept away the ash.

Kamla Kaki tended the wood.

Her granddaughter Rani saw the two pots and gave them names.

"This is the big house, and this is the little house."

Madhav asked again, "Why so?"

"Three people's rice is in the big house; one person's rice is in the little house."

"Is the house of one person necessarily small?"

Rani thought and said, "No. The pot is small."

Kamla Kaki laughed.

"Don't argue with this child."

A week later Madhav saw some dry twigs on his way and picked them up.

When he returned from college there were five or seven twigs tucked under his arm.

Kamla Kaki saw them and immediately asked, "What is this now?"

"My share."

"Share of what?"

"The fire."

"I make you sweep the ash."

"The wages for sweeping ash are not that high."

Kamla Kaki took the twigs.

"All right. Is the account even now?"

"For today."

"Will the account open again tomorrow?"

"If the hearth burns."

And so a new kind of accounting grew between them.

There were no rupees in it.

On one side were twigs.

On the other, leftover heat.

On one side, sweeping the ash.

On the other, a corner of the hearth for the little pot.

And at the very centre of it all was the aroma of rice.

Madhav no longer closed his book when the fragrance arrived.

He kept reading and simply understood: it was time to wash the rice.

Sometimes Kamla Kaki called out, "Baua, have you put in the water?"

"Yes."

"Not too much?"

"Measured it today."

"If you measure water to cook rice, the taste will run away."

"What branch of learning is that?"

"The science of the kitchen."

"Is there an examination in it?"

"Every day."

One evening it rained heavily.

Madhav was held up in a college class.

He had no umbrella.

When the rain eased a little, he reached his room drenched through.

It was very late.

Kamla Kaki's courtyard was dark.

Madhav thought: today's fire is gone.

He reached for the flattened rice.

Just then a voice came from the neighbouring courtyard -

"Will you go on studying this late, or will you eat rice too?"

Kamla Kaki stood at the door.

"You haven't gone to sleep?"

"If I were asleep, how would I be calling you?"

Madhav went into the courtyard.

The mouth of the hearth was full of ash.

Kamla Kaki shifted a little of it aside with the iron tongs.

A red point glowed within.

"I saved the embers," she said.

Madhav said nothing.

He simply sat down and blew upon them.

The red point first grew redder.

Then it became a small flame.

Kamla Kaki handed him two dry twigs.

"Wash the rice quickly."

The rice cooked late that night.

But Madhav felt that, for the first time, the distance between the village and the city had grown shorter.

A few days later his younger brother came from home carrying a bundle of rice.

Inside the bundle, their mother had tied two handfuls of new rice separately in a piece of cloth.

His brother said, "Mother said this is from the new harvest. You are to eat it first."

Madhav opened the cloth.

He took the grains into his hand.

Even the uncooked rice carried a faint fragrance.

That evening Madhav put that new-harvest rice into the little pot.

Kamla Kaki moved her own pot to the side.

Madhav's pot came into the centre of the fire.

The water began to bubble.

The lid trembled.

When the lid was lifted, the fragrance was so rich that Rani came running from the other end of the courtyard.

"What rice is this today?"

Madhav laughed.

"Rice from home."

Kamla Kaki stood still for a moment.

She leaned her face towards the steam.

"I've never smelled this fragrance before."

"I used to smell it every day."

Kamla Kaki looked at him.

Madhav understood: he was speaking not of rice, but of memory.

When the rice was cooked, for the first time Madhav served a bowl from his little pot and placed it before Kamla Kaki.

Kamla Kaki raised her eyebrows.

"What is this now?"

"The account for the embers."

"Is my fire that expensive?"

"This is not the price of the rice."

"Then what?"

"Of the fragrance."

Kamla Kaki laughed.

She took one mouthful from the bowl.

She chewed slowly.

"Does your mother use less water?"

"Yes, Kaki."

"That is why the grains remain separate."

"You understood?"

"Rice is not difficult to understand."

Madhav asked again, "And people?"

Kamla Kaki looked at him.

"To understand people, one has to lift the lid."

Madhav laughed again.

Two days later there was a holiday.

Madhav was going to the village.

In the morning he put his room in order.

He tied up his books.

He folded the rice sack.

He washed the little pot and left it in Kamla Kaki's courtyard.

Kamla Kaki said, "The pot will stay here. You'll need it again after the holiday."

Madhav said softly, "Keep it."

"And the twigs?"

"I'll bring them when I return."

"Will the account remain open?"

"As long as there is fire."

Madhav walked out of the lane.

Kamla Kaki sat down to sweep the hearth.

When the ash was cleared away, two round marks remained on the earthen surface - one left by the large pot, the other by the small one.

She swept the ash from around the larger mark; over the smaller one she passed her palm, but did not erase it.

STORY 112

The Grammar of a Love Letter

The afternoon sunlight had crept halfway across Ramanand Jha's veranda and stopped.

Ramanand Jha sat on a woven cot, cutting the edge of an old newspaper into a small slip of paper.

On that slip he meant to write down everything that had to be brought from the evening market.

The first word was - oil.

Salt.

Matches.

Eye medicine.

After those four items, his pen stopped.

He scratched his head.

"There was something else."

Just then a voice came from near the gate.

"Guruji, are you in?"

Ramanand Jha pushed his spectacles up on his nose.

"Come in, Deepak."

Deepak entered the veranda.

He held a folded sheet of paper in his hand.

First he stood before the cot.

Then he looked around for somewhere to sit.

Ramanand Jha pointed towards the low wooden stool beside him.

"Sit down. This is not an examination."

Deepak did not sit.

He gripped the paper more tightly.

Ramanand Jha looked at his hand.

"An application?"

Deepak shook his head.

"Not an application."

"A petition?"

"Not that either."

"An account of a debt?"

"Not that."

"Then why does the paper look so frightened?"

Deepak's ears turned red.

He said softly, "A love letter."

The little shopping slip on which Ramanand Jha had been writing 'salt' slipped from his hand.

"Say that again. What did you say?"

"A love letter."

"Why bring it to me?"

Deepak answered at once, "It isn't for you."

Ramanand Jha stared at him for two moments.

Then he burst out laughing.

"That should have been made clear at the beginning."

Deepak laughed too.

His embarrassment eased a little.

He sat down on the stool.

"Guruji, please correct it once for me."

Ramanand Jha held out his hand.

Deepak gave him the paper.

There were three pages.

Across the top, in large letters, was written - "Most Beloved Sugni Ji."

The moment Ramanand Jha read the first line, he took off his spectacles.

"Who is Sugni?"

"She works in the library."

"Do the two of you speak to each other?"

"Sometimes."

"How many times?"

Deepak thought.

"Four times."

"Three pages of love after four conversations?"

Deepak blushed again.

"But it has been in my heart for a long time."

"Days in the heart do not enter the count."

Ramanand Jha bent over the paper again.

The first sentence was - "You are the moon of my life."

He picked up a pencil.

"There is nothing wrong with the grammar."

Deepak's face brightened.

"Then shall I leave it?"

"First tell me how often Sugni rises over your life at night."

Deepak fell silent.

Ramanand Jha said, "Have you seen the moon?"

"Yes."

"Yesterday?"

"Not yesterday."

"And the day before?"

"Not then either."

"Sugni?"

"Yesterday, in the library."

"Then you see Sugni more often than you see the moon."

Deepak laughed.

Ramanand Jha said, "I will check the grammar. I do not rent out moons and stars."

Deepak took the pencil.

He drew a line through the first sentence.

The second sentence was - "I cannot live without you."

Ramanand Jha read it.

"This too is grammatically correct."

Deepak grew hopeful.

"Then this one survives?"

"What did you eat this morning?"

"Two rotis and potatoes."

"Was Sugni there?"

"No, not this morning."

"Then you are living."

Deepak lifted the pencil.

He struck out the second sentence as well.

"Guruji, at this rate the letter will become blank."

"Blank paper is better than a lie."

Deepak looked mournfully at all three pages.

Ramanand Jha read the next sentence - "My heart chants your name day and night."

"What were you doing while you wrote this?"

"I was truing a bicycle wheel."

"And chanting Sugni's name?"

Deepak laughed and said, "No. I was cursing Rambabu's crooked wheel."

Ramanand Jha held the paper out to him.

"Strike out that line yourself."

Deepak did so.

Half of the first of the three pages was now covered with pencil lines.

Deepak sat with his head in his hands.

"Falling in love wasn't difficult. Writing it is."

Ramanand Jha said, "I never taught the grammar of love."

"Then what did you teach?"

"Write what you have seen. Do not write what you have not seen."

"Where is that in grammar?"

"It was in my school."

Outside the veranda, a crow landed and dipped its beak into a bowl of water kept in a corner of the courtyard.

Deepak opened the paper again.

"Then what should I write?"

Ramanand Jha picked up an empty matchbox.

"What was the first thing about Sugni that you liked?"

Deepak did not answer at once.

He looked out beyond the veranda.

Then he said, "One day it was raining outside the library."

"Go on."

"A child had come to return a book."

"Go on."

"His book had got wet."

"Go on."

"Sugni did not scold him."

Ramanand Jha remained silent.

Deepak continued on his own.

"She opened the book and slipped pieces of old newspaper between the pages, one by one."

"Hmm."

"The child was crying."

"What did she do then?"

"She told him there would be no fine, but that next time he should bring the book wrapped in cloth."

Ramanand Jha handed him the pencil.

"Write that."

Deepak was startled.

"A wet book in a love letter?"

"It is better than the moon."

Deepak took out a fresh sheet.

He wrote, "Sugni Ji, the first time I liked something about you was the day you did not scold the child who brought back a wet book."

Ramanand Jha read it.

"Something about you' is vague here."

Deepak asked, "What should I write?"

"Write what it was that you liked."

Deepak wrote again, "That day, I liked your patience."

Ramanand Jha nodded.

"Now the sentence belongs to you."

A small smile appeared on Deepak's face.

He began the next sentence.

"Since then, whenever I go to the library, I feel like talking to you."

Ramanand Jha read it.

"This sentence is fine."

Deepak looked surprised.

"Nothing to strike out?"

"Not yet."

Deepak grew bolder.

He wrote, "I love you."

Ramanand Jha held his pencil still.

"The grammar is correct."

Deepak stared at him, scarcely breathing.

"And is it true?"

Ramanand Jha handed the pencil back to him.

"That question is not for me."

Deepak read the sentence again.

He did not strike it out.

Ramanand Jha pointed to the next blank space on the page.

"Now write about the answer you want from her."

Deepak wrote, "Awaiting your sweet reply."

Ramanand Jha frowned.

"Why must the answer be sweet?"

Deepak stopped his pencil.

"It is a love letter."

"The answer is hers."

Deepak was silent for a few moments.

Then he struck out the word 'sweet'.

The sentence became - "Awaiting your reply."

Ramanand Jha asked again, "Is she obliged to reply?"

Deepak said softly, "No. She is not obliged."

"Then write that too."

Deepak wrinkled his nose.

"If I am this polite, won't the love become smaller?"

Ramanand Jha laughed.

"If politeness makes it smaller, where was the love?"

Deepak wrote again, "If you should not wish to reply, I will understand that too."

Ramanand Jha read it.

"Should' does not sit properly here."

Deepak circled the word with his pencil.

Twice he wrote a replacement and erased it.

At last he wrote, "If you do not wish to reply, I will understand that too."

Ramanand Jha nodded.

"Now the meaning is clear."

Deepak gathered the original three pages and put them to one side.
 The new letter was now only a little more than half a page long.
 Deepak kept looking at it.
 "Guruji, one thing."
 "Hmm?"
 "From three pages to so little?"
 "The falsehoods have been reduced."
 "And the love?"
 "That is not measured by paper."
 A breeze entered the veranda.
 The old newspaper shopping slip fluttered to Deepak's feet.
 He picked it up.
 It read - oil, salt, matches, eye medicine.
 Deepak asked, "Does your list need correcting too?"
 Ramanand Jha said, "There is no love in this list. That makes it less difficult."
 They both laughed.
 At the end of the letter Deepak wrote, "Name - Deepak."
 Ramanand Jha said, "Only your name?"
 "What else?"
 "On the first page you had written, 'Yours forever and ever.'"
 Deepak looked at the old page.
 "That got struck out."
 "Why did you strike it out?"
 "You told me not to write what is not certain."
 Ramanand Jha smiled.
 "This time you remembered my lesson."
 Deepak began folding the letter.
 Ramanand Jha stopped him.
 "Read it aloud once."
 "Aloud, here?"
 "In front of me. Sugni is not here."
 Deepak read it.
 His voice trembled on the first line.
 On the second, it steadied.
 At "I love you", his voice dropped very low.
 At the final line he laughed at himself.
 Ramanand Jha asked, "Why are you laughing?"
 "I am reading a letter, but it feels as though I am speaking."
 "Then the letter has survived."
 Deepak folded the paper carefully.
 He put it in his pocket.

He rose and bowed respectfully.

At the gate he turned back.

“Guruji, your fee?”

Ramanand Jha picked up the shopping slip with ‘salt’ on it.

“There is a fee?”

“Yes, there should be.”

“On your way back from the market, bring me a packet of matches.”

Deepak laughed.

“Only that much?”

“Grammar is not expensive.”

“And love?”

“I do not know its price.”

Deepak left.

For three days he did not return.

Ramanand Jha went to the market twice.

He bought the matches himself.

On the fourth evening, someone called again at the gate.

Deepak had come.

This time his hands were empty.

Ramanand Jha asked, “The matches?”

Deepak took a packet from his pocket.

“Here they are.”

“It took four days?”

“I paid the fee late.”

Ramanand Jha pushed his spectacles up.

“The answer?”

Deepak put his hand into his pocket.

He drew out a small folded slip.

Ramanand Jha held out his hand.

Deepak hesitated for a moment.

Then he gave him the slip.

There were only two lines on it -

“On Sunday, after the library closes, wait for five minutes

In return for three pages, this much is enough for now.”

Ramanand Jha read it twice.

Then he picked up his pencil.

Deepak snatched the slip back at once.

“No, Guruji.”

“What happened?”

“Do not correct anything on this.”

Ramanand Jha put on a grave expression.

“There is a full stop at the end of the second line, but not the first.”

Deepak folded the slip and put it back in his pocket.

“Let it be.”

“And the grammar?”

“Right now, five minutes matter more.”

Ramanand Jha looked at him for a few moments.

Then he set the pencil down on the newspaper slip.

“All right. I will not touch it.”

Deepak moved towards the gate.

Ramanand Jha called after him, “Be there on time on Sunday.”

Deepak turned and laughed.

“Is that sentence correct?”

“Correct - and true.”

Deepak left.

Ramanand Jha looked again at his market list.

Oil was still the first item.

Salt.

Matches.

Eye medicine.

He put a small tick beside ‘matches’.

Then, in the empty space, he wrote - “Sunday - five minutes.”

He thought for a moment, and did not strike it out.

STORY 113

The Philosopher Betel-Seller

At Pipar Chowk, Badri Sah's paan shop was so small that if two customers stood there together, a third had to accept the dust of the road.

Above the shop, on a strip of tin, red letters proclaimed -

“Badri Paan Emporium.”

A first-time visitor, reading the word 'Emporium', would peer inside.

Inside were a tin of chopped areca nut, a tin of fennel seeds, two little bottles of cardamom, a bowl of catechu, a bowl of lime, and a damp cloth filled with betel leaves.

Badri Sah used to say -

“The bigger the name, the smaller the stock looks.”

The people of the crossroads called him a philosopher more often than a paan seller.

It was not because Badri Sah had read any great books.

The only book in his house was an old almanac, half of whose pages had been eaten by rats.

The reason was that whoever stood at his shop for five minutes went away with his worry a little lighter.

Badri Sah's own claim was modest.

“I do not mend lives.”

He would say this while spreading catechu over a betel leaf.

“I cool your head for five minutes. After that, your head is yours, and your worry is yours.”

One day Nandu the barber came running.

“Badri Kaka, I am leaving home.”

Badri Sah turned over a betel leaf.

“Whose home?”

“Mine.”

“Then where will you go after leaving it?”

Nandu fell silent.

“To my in-laws' house.”

“And your in-laws will ask - for how many days?”

Nandu fell silent again.

Badri Sah touched the leaf with the tip of the lime.

“First tell me, what was the quarrel about?”

“My rice was served late.”

"How late?"

"Half an hour."

"And for how many days are you planning to leave your home?"

Nandu stroked his moustache.

"The arithmetic does not seem to match."

Badri Sah folded the paan and placed it in his hand.

"Pay for this paan, go home, and sit quietly for half an hour. After that, if you still feel like leaving home, come back. Then we shall decide where your ticket should be booked."

Nandu returned in the evening.

"No ticket is needed."

"Did you get your rice?"

"Rice and vegetables both."

"Then philosophy has succeeded."

"Not philosophy. Hunger succeeded."

Both burst out laughing.

The very next day Saraswati Devi, the flower seller, set her basket down on the ground.

"Badri Bhai, this world is full of injustice."

Badri Sah asked while washing a betel leaf -

"What injustice today?"

"That flower seller opposite steals my customers."

"How?"

"She charges two rupees less."

"How much can you reduce your price?"

"Not even by one rupee."

"Then how will you win a quarrel over two rupees?"

Saraswati Devi frowned.

"So I should accept defeat?"

"I am not talking about victory or defeat. I am asking what your flowers have that hers do not."

Saraswati Devi answered at once -

"I pick mine at dawn. Some of hers are left over from yesterday."

"Then stop talking about the price. Say that."

"To the customers?"

"No, to your flowers. The customers will hear."

Saraswati Devi did not take a paan.

"Saved the price."

"Not the philosophy fee. Bring me a garland tomorrow."

On the third day, a small marigold garland hung at Badri Sah's shop.

People at the crossroads began jokingly calling the place a 'university'.

Badri Sah objected.

"At a university, students are examined. Here, the customers examine me."
Mangal Mistri's examinations were the hardest.

Whenever he came for paan, he brought some enormous question about the world.

"How can a human being remain happy?"

Badri Sah would ask -

"Where is your hammer?"

"At the shop."

"And the half-finished stool?"

"That is at the shop too."

"Then finish the stool first. Ask about happiness in the evening."

Mangal Mistri would take offence.

"You never answer serious questions."

"Serious questions are very heavy. The plank of my shop cannot bear that much weight."

Once, two members of the panchayat stopped speaking to each other.

They came to Badri Sah separately, at different times.

The first said -

"He insulted me."

Badri Sah asked -

"In how many words?"

"Three words."

"And how many words did you say in return?"

"That question is not necessary."

"Then cardamom in your paan is not necessary either."

"Why?"

"If the account remains incomplete, the taste will remain incomplete too."

The first member admitted reluctantly -

"Seven or eight words."

Badri Sah put in the cardamom.

When the second member came, the story was reversed, but the number of words was almost the same.

Badri Sah gave both men the same advice -

"Tomorrow, sit together for five minutes. Whoever mentions the old quarrel during the first five minutes will pay for both paans."

The next day both arrived.

For five minutes neither opened his mouth.

In the sixth minute, the first member asked -

"Could you give me a little more fennel?"

The other said -

"Me too."

Badri Sah said proudly -

"See? For five minutes the problem disappeared."

"And from the sixth minute?"

"The sixth minute is not my responsibility."

That sentence became famous at the crossroads.

Whenever someone looked deeply troubled, another would say -

"Go and deposit five minutes with Badri."

Badri Sah's real method was only one thing, though he never stated it plainly to anyone.

When someone described a problem, he did not answer at once.

First he chose a betel leaf.

He trimmed the central rib.

He shook off the water.

He opened the tin of lime.

He mixed the catechu.

Meanwhile, as the speaker repeated the story, he would often understand for himself how much of it was truly necessary and how much was merely heat.

If he still did not understand, Badri Sah asked one small question.

"Right now, at this very moment, what can you do?"

That question was half of his philosophy.

The other half was -

"What you cannot do right now, set aside for five minutes."

But one day neither of those sentences was enough for Badri Sah's own problem.

It was a Bhado afternoon.

Clouds were gathering in the sky.

Badri Sah was sprinkling water over the betel leaves when his landlord, Raghunath Babu, arrived.

"Badri, I have something to tell you."

"Tell me. I am listening."

"From next month, I need this room for my son."

Badri Sah's hand stopped over the betel leaves.

"This shop?"

"Yes, this one."

"How many years have I been here?"

"Seventeen."

"Then where is seventeen years' worth of things supposed to go in one month?"

Raghunath Babu spread his hands helplessly.

"I have needs in my own household too."

Badri Sah said nothing.

Raghunath Babu left.

That day Nandu the barber came by.

“Kaka, one sweet paan.”

Instead of lime, Badri Sah applied catechu twice.

Nandu stared.

“The philosopher’s hand is trembling?”

Badri Sah told him what had happened.

Nandu said at once -

“Why worry? Take half of my barber shop.”

Badri Sah measured it with his eyes.

“Half my customers will fit into your half. Where will the other half stand?”

Hearing this, Saraswati Devi said -

“Beside my flower cart there is room in the evening -”

Badri Sah interrupted her.

“Room.”

“Yes, there is room.”

“And in the morning?”

“In the morning there will be flowers.”

“Then shall I sell paan only at night?”

Mangal Mistri arrived.

“Make the shop on wheels. Wherever the customers are, there will be paan.”

Badri Sah looked at him.

“Did you finish the stool?”

Mangal Mistri fell silent.

“The stool first.”

Everyone burst out laughing together.

Badri Sah did not laugh.

By evening five people had offered five solutions.

Not one of them survived for more than five minutes.

Then the same two panchayat members arrived together.

“Badri, today you deposit five minutes.”

Badri Sah gave a faint, distracted smile.

“My problem is not a five-minute problem.”

“Neither was ours.”

The second member stood before the counter.

“What is it that you always ask us?”

Badri Sah did not answer.

The first member said -

“Right now, at this very moment, what can you do?”

For the first time Badri Sah heard his own sentence from someone else’s mouth.

He looked around him.

The betel leaves lay beneath the damp cloth.

The tins were on the plank.

The customers stood before him.
 There was no answer yet for one month from now.
 There were these five minutes now.
 “What can I do now?”

He said softly.
 “Right now, I can make one paan.”
 “Then make it.”

Badri Sah picked up a betel leaf.
 This time his hand did not tremble.
 He made a paan for the first member.
 He made one for the second.
 He gave Nandu some fennel.

Saraswati Devi's garland had dried; he entered a new garland against her account.

He asked Mangal Mistri -
 “The stool?”
 “Tomorrow.”

“If it remains unfinished tomorrow, there will be no philosophy for you.”
 This time Badri Sah himself laughed.

For the next eight days, people from the crossroads looked at different places for him.

One veranda was too small.
 One rent was too high.
 One place had no water.
 Another fell dark as soon as evening came.
 On the ninth day, Saraswati Devi brought news.

In the lane behind the peepal tree, in front of an old grain warehouse, there was an empty room four cubits wide.

The owner lived away, but his brother kept the key.
 Badri Sah went to see it.
 The room was old.
 Limewash flaked from the wall.
 The door was crooked.
 The roof was low.

But two people could stand in front of it.
 A third would have to endure less road dust.
 The rent was a little higher than at the old shop.
 Badri Sah calculated for a long time.

Then he said -
 “Not every question in life finds its answer in five minutes.”
 Nandu said -
 “Why did you never say that before?”

“Because I had not understood it myself before.”

“So your philosophy has changed?”

“No. In five minutes the question becomes smaller. A smaller question gives you the strength to lift it. The answer still has to be found afterwards.”

On the day the new shop opened, half the people of Pipar Chowk turned up.

Mangal Mistri straightened the old counter.

Nandu hung the signboard overhead.

Saraswati Devi hung a fresh marigold garland.

The signboard once again read -

“Badri Paan Emporium.”

Under it, on his own initiative, Nandu pasted a small piece of paper -

“Life's problems - five minutes.”

The moment Badri Sah saw it, he reached out to tear it down.

The second panchayat member caught his hand.

“Let it stay. It is an advertisement.”

Badri Sah said -

“People will believe it.”

Mangal Mistri laughed.

“Let them believe it for five minutes.”

The people of the crossroads roared with laughter.

The first customer was a teenage boy.

With a very grave face he said -

“Kaka, I have a great problem in my life.”

Badri Sah picked up a betel leaf.

“How great?”

“My examination is tomorrow, and I have studied nothing.”

Badri Sah put the leaf back into the tin.

“Paan will not cure this problem.”

“Then what should I do?”

“Can you reach home in five minutes?”

“Yes, in five minutes.”

“Philosophy finished. Run.”

The boy ran.

Nandu clapped.

Badri Sah leaned his elbows on the counter.

“See? In the new shop, philosophy works faster than before.”

The peepal tree remained in front of the old shop.

But the evening breeze turned through the lane and reached the new shop as well.

Badri Sah adjusted the damp cloth over the betel leaves.

Three customers stood before him, each carrying his own worry.

He looked at them and said -

“One at a time. Life is very large, but my counter is still small.”

STORY 114

The Rented Dog

There was a new bamboo gate in front of Mahendra's house.

The gate was new; the house was old.

The bamboo was not new either.

Mahendra had split three old bamboo poles, joined two pieces across them, tied everything with rope, and given it the form of a gate.

His wife, Sushila, took one look at it on the first day and said -

"Will this gate stop a thief?"

Mahendra tightened the rope and replied -

"A thief will first think there must be something valuable inside."

"What is inside?"

"Why should we tell the thief that?"

Sushila laughed.

There was very little in the house worth stealing.

One brass lota.

Two plates.

A sewing machine, which was Mahendra's livelihood.

And three bundles of cloth in a corner of the room, left by customers to be stitched.

More than his own belongings, Mahendra worried about those bundles.

"If those clothes disappear, people will find another tailor."

He said this one night while oiling the machine.

"If the machine disappears, where will I find another livelihood?"

It was this fear that had produced the bamboo gate.

But on the third night no one opened the gate. Someone merely reached over it and lifted away the brass bowl kept on the veranda.

In the morning Sushila saw the empty place.

"Did the gate stop the thief?"

Mahendra looked at the bamboo posts.

"The gate did its job. The thief came over the top."

"Then build the gate all the way up to the roof."

There was irritation in Sushila's voice, but laughter too.

From that day, talk of getting a dog began.

Not every house in the village had one, but wherever there was a dog, its barking could be heard far into the night.

Sushila kept saying -

"If we had a dog, the veranda would not feel empty."

Mahendra asked around in the market.

When he heard the price of a puppy, he felt his pocket.

Back home he said -

"If we buy a dog now, we shall have to give up dal for two weeks."

"We are not giving up dal."

"Then give up the dog."

"And give up the customers' clothes?"

Both fell silent.

That evening their neighbour Abdul Chacha was walking down the lane with his dog, Kalu.

The name Kalu suggested a black dog.

This Kalu was brown.

His first owner had given him the name; the colour had been beyond anyone's control.

One of Kalu's ears stood upright. The other folded halfway down.

He did not bark the moment he saw someone.

First he sniffed.

Then he decided whether barking was worth the effort.

Abdul Chacha stopped by the gate.

"Mahendra, why has everyone in your house been talking about dogs since yesterday?"

Sushila called from inside -

"Chacha, walls are supposed to have ears; yours are bigger than the walls'."

Abdul Chacha laughed.

"Not my ears - Kalu's. He heard it."

Mahendra came outside.

"We need a dog. We don't have the money."

Abdul Chacha patted Kalu's back.

"Then don't buy one."

"What else can we do?"

"Rent one."

Mahendra assumed Chacha was joking.

"Dogs are available for rent too?"

"Houses are rented. Bullock carts are rented. Cots are rented. Why not a dog?"

Sushila came outside.

"How much rent?"

Abdul Chacha put on a grave face.

"No rupees."

"Then what is the rent?"

“Kalu will sleep on your veranda at night. In the morning he will return to my courtyard. In exchange, bathe him once a week.”

Mahendra looked at Kalu.

Kalu was sniffing the ground.

“Will he agree?”

Abdul Chacha said -

“Kalu obeys me less than he obeys his sack.”

He fetched an old jute sack from his courtyard.

One corner had been torn by Kalu's teeth.

“Wherever I spread this sack, Kalu goes there in the evening and lies down.”

Sushila asked in wonder -

“Are we renting the dog, or the sack?”

“I haven't been able to decide that myself yet.”

On the first night Abdul Chacha spread the sack on Mahendra's veranda.

Kalu sniffed it five times.

Once he looked back towards his old courtyard.

Then he curled up and lay down.

Mahendra was delighted.

“See? The guard has arrived.”

Sushila poured some rice water into a bowl.

Kalu got up, drank it, and returned to the sack.

Mahendra said -

“If we feed him too, the rent will become expensive.”

Sushila replied -

“I used to throw the rice water away. Now it has become wages.”

In the first watch of the night Kalu barked once.

Mahendra sprang from his bed.

“He's here!”

He grabbed a bamboo staff and ran outside.

Abdul Chacha was standing on the other side of the gate.

“It's me.”

“Chacha! At this hour?”

“I left my sickle on your veranda.”

Mahendra looked at Kalu.

“He barks even at his owner.”

Abdul Chacha laughed.

“First rule of a rented guard - no kinship while on duty.”

In the second watch of the night there was barking again.

This time Sushila got up.

Outside, a cat was nudging the lid of an earthen pot.

Kalu sat on the sack and watched it.

Sushila whispered -

“Why doesn't he chase the cat?”

Mahendra said -

“The rent is for barking. Chasing must have a separate rate.”

Trying not to laugh, both went back inside.

In the morning Abdul Chacha came.

“How was the night?”

Mahendra said -

“Two warnings. One for you, one for a cat.”

“Then the arrangement is working well.”

Kalu did not get up from the sack.

Abdul Chacha said -

“Come, home.”

Kalu opened his eyes, then closed them again.

Chacha picked up the sack.

Kalu immediately rose and followed him.

Mahendra's son, Chhotu, burst out laughing at the sight.

“Babu, don't rent the dog. Rent the sack. It will be cheaper.”

For three nights the arrangement worked perfectly.

On the fourth night Mahendra gave Kalu two rotis.

Sushila asked -

“There was rice water. Why rotis?”

“A contented guard will do his work well.”

Kalu ate the two rotis and slept so soundly that in the night a goat pushed through the gate and ate the tulsi plant from its pot.

In the morning Sushila saw the bare tulsi stalk.

“This guard's contentment is very expensive.”

When Abdul Chacha heard, he said -

“No feast before night duty. I learned that today too.”

After that, Kalu received less rice water in the evening and more in the morning.

Gradually Kalu learned the timetable of both houses.

As the sun went down, he looked for the sack in Abdul Chacha's courtyard.

The moment he saw the sack being lifted, he set off for Mahendra's house.

In the morning, when the sack was lifted again, he followed Chacha back.

The children in the lane gave the arrangement a name -

“Half-Day Kalu.”

Chhotu corrected them -

“Night-Time Kalu.”

Abdul Chacha said -

“Rented Kalu.”

Kalu had no objection to any of the names.

He recognised the sack better than names.

A week later came bath day.
Mahendra took Kalu to the well.
The moment the first lota of water fell on him, Kalu bolted.
Mahendra held on to the rope.
Kalu ran three circles around him.
The rope wound itself around Mahendra's legs.
Chhotu kept clapping.
From a distance Abdul Chacha called out -
"Collecting rent is hard work!"
In the end Kalu was bathed.
But Mahendra was half-bathed too.
Sushila brought two towels.
One for Kalu.
One for Mahendra.
"The bargain is even."
She said it with satisfaction.
Mahendra asked -
"By what calculation?"
"The dog is half wet, and the owner is half wet."
"Chacha is the owner."
"At night, you are."
At that answer Abdul Chacha laughed so hard that he began to cough.
The days went by.
Nothing else disappeared from Mahendra's house.
Mahendra gave Kalu the credit.
Sushila would say -
"Only that one bowl was ever stolen. Who knows whether the thief would
have come again at all?"
Mahendra said -
"The advantage of guarding is that even what does not happen is credited to
the guard."
One night a strong wind blew.
The rope of the gate came loose.
At midnight there was a 'khat' sound.
Kalu got up and barked.
Mahendra ran outside.
The gate had sagged inward.
There was no one there.
He began tightening the rope again.
Kalu sat beside him.
Mahendra stroked his head.

“Because of you I woke up. Otherwise by morning the gate would have been lying on the ground.”

Kalu yawned.

Mahendra understood that he had no great enthusiasm for being thanked.

The next day Chhotu stitched a collar for Kalu from a piece of old red cloth.

Mahendra strengthened its edges on the sewing machine.

With charcoal, Chhotu wrote a single word on it -

“NIGHT.”

Abdul Chacha read it and said -

“What will his name be in the daytime?”

Chhotu thought.

“Kalu by day, Night by night.”

“Two jobs, two names.”

“One wage - rice water.”

Sushila said it.

A month later Mahendra's tailoring work picked up a little.

He asked again about the price of a puppy.

This time he had the money in his pocket.

Back home he told Sushila -

“Now we can buy a dog of our own.”

Chhotu overheard and came running.

“Will Kalu be sent away?”

“Not sent away. He belongs to Chacha.”

“At night he belongs to us.”

Mahendra fell silent.

In the evening Abdul Chacha arrived carrying the sack.

Mahendra told him.

Chacha put the sack down on the ground.

“Buy one. Your own dog is your own.”

Chhotu sat holding Kalu around the neck.

“Then where will he sleep at night?”

Abdul Chacha said -

“Ask Kalu.”

Everyone looked at Kalu.

Kalu sniffed the sack first.

Then he walked towards Mahendra's veranda.

Chhotu declared triumphantly -

“We have our answer.”

The puppy was not bought.

Mahendra used that money to replace a weak post on the veranda and to buy a new belt for the sewing machine.

Some money was left over.

Sushila said -

“We didn’t buy Kalu, and the house improved.”

Abdul Chacha replied -

“That’s the profit from rent.”

“We pay the rent in rice water and baths.”

“And what did I get?”

Mahendra asked.

Chacha pointed to Kalu’s bright red collar.

“By day my dog is now clean and smart. At night he has a job. I have less trouble bathing him. You get a guard. Kalu gets two homes.”

Sushila said -

“Then who loses?”

Abdul Chacha made a great show of thinking for a long time.

“The cat. Now it must think twice before nudging a lid.”

That night Kalu lay curled on the sack.

Inside, Mahendra kept the sewing machine running.

Outside, the wind moved against the gate.

After a while Kalu barked once.

Mahendra did not stop the machine.

He had learned to recognise that bark.

Abdul Chacha was passing through the lane.

His voice came from outside -

“No kinship while on guard duty!”

From inside, Mahendra laughed and called back -

“Rent fully recovered!”

STORY 115

The Empty-Pocket Feast

The afternoon had begun to gather up its light.

Beneath the peepal tree at the crossroads four friends had gathered - Lalan, Phekan, Jamil and Bhola.

In Lalan's hand was a short letter that had come from the post office.

The letter said that he had passed his training examination.

He did not have a job yet.

But by the reckoning of the four friends, passing the examination meant that half the door to a job had opened.

Phekan read the letter a second time and said -

"News like this calls for a feast."

Lalan turned the pocket of his kurta inside out.

An old button fell out.

Two bits of thread fell out as well.

There was not the faintest trace of money.

Jamil turned out his pocket too.

An old bus ticket emerged from it.

Bhola searched his pocket.

He found a single fennel seed.

Phekan said with great pride -

"My pocket contains property."

The other three looked at him.

Phekan produced a small stone.

"What sort of property is that?"

"It got into my slipper yesterday. I took it out and put it in my pocket. Then I forgot about it."

Jamil said -

"So the total wealth of four friends comes to one button, one ticket, one fennel seed and one stone."

Bhola added -

"Quite enough for a feast to celebrate passing an examination."

All four burst out laughing.

Lalan folded the letter and put it back in his pocket.

Lalan said -

"Not a single paisa will be spent today."

Jamil added another rule -

“And we will not ask anyone for anything free.”

Bhola said -

“Whatever we receive in return for work is allowed.”

Phekan put on a solemn face and asked -

“Does laughter count as labour?”

“No. Laughter has a separate wage.”

“Then my contribution is zero again.”

Their laughter broke out together once more.

It was decided: there would be a celebration, the expense would remain zero, and there would be no trickery or deceit.

The four set off towards the market.

The first shop belonged to a sweet-maker.

Oil was bubbling in the pan.

Hot kachoris were puffing themselves into roundness.

Phekan began to walk more slowly.

His neck turned towards the shop of its own accord.

Jamil caught his hand and pulled him along.

“The rule.”

Phekan said -

“I am only looking at the aroma.”

Bhola, dragging his eyes away from the guavas, asked -

“Can an aroma be looked at?”

“When your pocket is empty, all the senses start doing one another’s work.”

The sweet-maker overheard him.

Laughing, he asked -

“Four kachoris?”

Lalan said -

“Today the first course is aroma.”

The sweet-maker looked at his pan.

“Will that course fill your stomachs?”

Phekan replied -

“For now it is the turn of the eyes and the nose. The stomach’s turn will come later.”

The sweet-maker roared with laughter.

The four moved on.

At the next bend stood Ramdev’s fruit stall.

One slat of a bamboo basket suddenly broke.

Guavas began rolling into the road.

Ramdev struggled, trying to hold the basket with one hand and catch the guavas with the other.

Without saying a word, all four ran to help.

Lalan stopped the guavas that were rolling towards the drain.

Jamil pulled two out from beneath a handcart.
 Bhola spread out his gamchha and gathered the smaller guavas into it.
 Phekan tied the broken slat of the basket with a short piece of string.
 Within five minutes the road was clear.
 Ramdev breathed in relief.
 He picked up four guavas and held them out to the friends.
 Lalan immediately drew his hand back.
 "No, Kaka."
 "Why won't you take them?"
 "We are having a feast today, but we will not eat anything obtained by asking or as charity."
 Ramdev frowned.
 "Who said charity? Half my guavas would have gone into the drain. You saved them. These are your wages."
 Jamil whispered in Lalan's ear -
 "Did the rules forbid wages?"
 The four looked at one another.
 Phekan said gravely -
 "The committee will consider the matter."
 Bhola delivered the decision at once -
 "Anything earned by labour is allowed at the feast."
 Ramdev gave them four guavas.
 Phekan asked -
 "Salt?"
 Ramdev laughed and said -
 "Shall I break another basket for that?"
 They all laughed and moved on.
 Now they had four guavas in their hands.
 Phekan sniffed one and said -
 "The first course is confirmed."
 As they crossed the square, they saw a handcart stuck in the mud.
 The cart-puller was pushing it alone.
 On the cart were sacks of roasted gram and puffed rice.
 The four stopped again.
 Jamil said -
 "Our feast demands a great deal of labour."
 All four put their shoulders to the cart.
 The wheel did not turn on the first push.
 On the second, Phekan slipped and nearly sat down in the mud.
 Bhola kept laughing.
 Phekan got up and said -
 "Laugh later. Your Majesties, push."

On the third attempt the wheel came free of the mud.

The cart-puller's name was Nandu.

Wiping his forehead with his gamchha, he said -

"If you had not been here, I would have been stuck for another half-hour."

He placed a handful of roasted gram on a piece of paper.

Lalan was about to refuse again.

Phekan caught his hand.

"The committee has already ruled on this."

Nandu asked -

"What committee?"

Jamil said -

"The Empty-Pocket Feast Committee."

Nandu looked at their pockets.

"When pockets are empty, committees form quickly."

Along with the gram he added a pinch of salt.

Phekan brightened.

"Now the guavas have become civilised."

At the far end of the market was an old pond.

The four thought of sitting on its steps.

But two municipal sanitation workers were lifting heavy bamboo baskets nearby.

The handle of one basket had torn.

Without a word, Bhola stepped forward.

"How far?"

One of the workers said -

"Up to that cart."

Together, the four carried the two baskets to the cart.

The workers thanked them.

There was no question of receiving anything in return.

The four came back and sat on the steps.

Jamil said -

"What did that service add to the feast?"

Rubbing his back, Phekan replied -

"Hunger."

This time their laughter went on for a long while.

There was a public tap beside the pond.

Bhola wiped the guavas with the corner of his gamchha.

Jamil spread the gram out on the paper.

The pinch of salt was divided into four portions.

Phekan began looking for a knife to cut the guavas.

No one had one.

Lalan said -

"A shortage of equipment at the royal feast."

Bhola broke a guava into four pieces with his hands.

The first guava was shared among the four.

So was the second.

Then Phekan objected.

"If four guavas are divided among four people like this, each of us will merely get one guava."

Jamil asked solemnly -

"What do you propose?"

"If we combine all four guavas and call it a feast, it remains a feast. If we call it one guava each, it becomes ordinary eating."

By the authority vested in the one who had passed the examination, Lalan delivered his ruling -

"Today each guava will have four names - opening course, main course, interlude and finale."

Phekan was satisfied.

The gram kept circulating among them.

No one took a whole fistful.

They picked it up grain by grain.

When Nandu's salt touched the guava, Phekan closed his eyes and said -

"In the city this dish would cost at least ten rupees."

Bhola asked -

"Why ten rupees?"

"Because we don't have ten rupees."

The sun was sinking.

Evening light lay across the water of the pond.

The feast was not large.

Four guavas, a handful of roasted gram, a pinch of salt and unlimited water from the tap.

But the conversation of the four friends showed no sign of ending.

Jamil asked Lalan -

"You have passed the examination. When you receive your first earnings, what will you do?"

Without thinking, Lalan replied -

"A feast for the four of us."

Phekan objected at once.

"No. Then this feast will never be made a second time."

"Then what?"

"With your first earnings, buy a pair of slippers for your mother."

Lalan fell silent.

Her old slippers at home really were worn through.

To lighten the mood, Bhola said -

“And what about us?”

Phekan replied -

“By then our pockets will be empty again. We will find a way.”

The evening deepened.

The four rose.

A few gram husks remained on the paper.

Jamil gathered them and dropped them into a rubbish basket.

Bhola turned off the tap.

Lalan carefully put the letter back into his pocket.

Phekan searched his own pocket.

The stone was still there.

He took it out and was about to leave it on the pond steps, then stopped.

“This too is a member of today's feast.”

Jamil asked -

“What did the stone eat?”

“The emptiness of my pocket.”

The four laughed again.

On their way back they passed the sweet-maker's shop once more.

Only a few kachoris were left now.

From a distance the sweet-maker called -

“Did the feast happen?”

Lalan said -

“The feast certainly happened.”

“What was on the menu?”

Phekan began to count -

“Four guavas, one handful of gram, one pinch of salt, unlimited water.”

The sweet-maker laughed loudly.

“And you call that a feast?”

Jamil said -

“The remaining ingredients were four people.”

For a moment the sweet-maker was silent.

Then he turned back towards his pan.

The four moved on.

When they reached the peepal tree, Phekan stopped.

“One account is still unfinished.”

“Which account?”

“The total cost of the feast.”

Lalan turned out his empty pocket once more.

The button fell to the ground again.

Jamil produced the old bus ticket.

Bhola searched for the fennel seed, but it had disappeared.

“Looks as if I ate that during the feast too.”

Phekan held up the stone.

“Total expense - zero.”

Picking up his button, Lalan asked -

“And the total earnings?”

The four looked at one another.

This time Phekan gave no answer.

He merely patted Lalan on the back.

The four took the roads to their respective homes.

Nothing remained beneath the peepal tree - no leaf, no plate, no account.

Only, for a little while, the sound of their laughter lingered there.

STORY 116

The Broken Umbrella Association

The evening rain arrived before the market had closed.

At first two or three heavy drops fell.

Then the sky opened so completely that people at the crossroads ran beneath the shop awnings.

Three men reached the front of Batesar Sah's closed paan shop at the same time.

The first was Shivnath, the tailor.

He had a green umbrella in his hand.

Its cloth was almost intact, but two of its ribs were bent in the middle.

The second was Karim, the bicycle repairman.

The ribs of his umbrella were strong, but its cloth was torn in three places.

The third was Jagdish, who worked weighing sacks in the market.

More than half the cloth of his umbrella was gone.

But its central shaft and handle were still so solid that they could have served as a walking stick.

All three tried to open their umbrellas.

The green umbrella leaned to one side.

As soon as Karim's umbrella opened, three streams of water began pouring onto his head.

When Jagdish's umbrella opened, the sky could be seen clearly through it.

Looking at it, Shivnath said -

"That is not an umbrella. It is a window."

Jagdish replied -

"At least a window has a complete frame."

Karim burst out laughing.

The rain grew heavier.

There was little room beneath the awning.

The three stood with their feet drawn close together.

Water began collecting on the road in front of them.

Shivnath tried to straighten the bent rib of his umbrella.

The rib bent again.

Karim said -

"Your cloth has survived, but the bones are tired."

Shivnath looked at Karim's umbrella.

"Your bones have survived, but the skin is gone."

Jagdish tapped his umbrella shaft against the ground.
 "My soul has survived."
 The three laughed again.
 After a while the laughter stopped.
 The rain did not.
 Shvinnath's house was a kos and a half from the crossroads.
 Karim's house lay beyond the little bridge over the river.
 Jagdish's house stood on the road between the other two.
 All three needed to get home.
 None of them wanted to spend the night beneath the awning.
 Karim searched his bag.
 He found a piece of thin wire.
 It was leftover wire used for fastening a bicycle brake.
 Shvinnath took a little packet of needle and thread from his shirt pocket.
 Jagdish asked -
 "You carry a needle even in the rain?"
 Shvinnath said -
 "If a tailor goes about without a needle, what will people take him for?"
 Karim examined the inside of his own umbrella.
 Then he took the green umbrella in his hands.
 "Shall I take out two ribs?"
 Shvinnath was startled.
 "You will cut up your umbrella to save mine?"
 "What is left of my umbrella now, anyway?"
 Jagdish immediately held out his shaft.
 "This central rod may be useful."
 Shvinnath looked at his umbrella and asked -
 "And what will be left for you?"
 Jagdish said -
 "A souvenir."
 Karim spread all three umbrellas on the ground.
 Now and then spray from the edge of the awning splashed onto them.
 The three bent over the umbrellas.
 Two or three people in the market began watching from a distance.
 A boy asked -
 "Uncle, are all three umbrellas being repaired?"
 Karim said -
 "No. Three patients are going to make one healthy man."
 The boy remained standing there.
 Shvinnath carefully began removing the cloth from the green umbrella.
 The old stitching was tight.
 With the point of his needle he loosened the knots.

Karim removed the strong ribs from his umbrella.
The upper joint of Jagdish's shaft proved to be the best of all.
Karim said -
"He is richer than both of us."
Jagdish puffed out his chest.
"I knew it all along."
Shivnath said -
"Half the cloth is gone, yet the pride is whole."
The work began.
Karim fastened two ribs with wire.
Shivnath stretched the green cloth over the new frame.
At one corner the cloth fell short.
Jagdish cut a blue piece from his torn umbrella and handed it over.
Shivnath stitched the piece into the green cloth.
The umbrella was now green, with one blue corner.
Karim stepped back and looked at it.
"It looks royal."
Jagdish said -
"If the king is poor, these are the colours he wears."
The central shaft was fitted back into place.
The first time they opened it, one rib sprang out.
All three stepped back.
The boy laughed.
The second time Karim tightened the wire further.
Shivnath wound thread around the knot.
Jagdish held the shaft steady.
The umbrella opened fully.
This time it was crooked, but it remained open.
All three looked upward.
No water came through the cloth.
One drop fell from the corner of the blue patch.
Shivnath pressed the spot with his finger.
"One more stitch here."
The stitch was added.
All three moved beneath the umbrella.
The first problem became clear at once.
The umbrella was large for one person, but small for three.
Jagdish said -
"Now we need to form an association."
Karim asked -
"Why an association?"
"Because one umbrella cannot be run by three owners without rules."

Shivnath said -

“First rule - I shall walk in the middle.”

“Why should you be in the middle?”

“The cloth is mine.”

Karim immediately said -

“The ribs are mine. I should be in the middle.”

Jagdish seized the handle.

“The handle is mine, so the umbrella stays in my hand.”

For a few moments the three stared at one another.

Then the umbrella was closed.

The rain was still falling.

The boy laughed again.

Shivnath said -

“All right. The umbrella belongs to no one.”

Karim asked -

“Then?”

“It belongs to the association.”

Jagdish immediately made a rule -

“Whoever holds it will not walk in the middle.”

Karim said -

“What sort of justice is that?”

“His hand will already be raised. Walking at the side will be difficult enough.”

The rule was accepted.

Jagdish held the umbrella.

Shivnath walked on the right.

Karim on the left.

For the first ten steps everything went well.

On the eleventh, Shivnath shifted right to avoid a drain.

The umbrella moved right with him.

Karim's armpit was drenched.

He cried -

“Bias in the association!”

Jagdish brought the umbrella back to the middle.

At the next bend Karim moved left to avoid a pothole.

This time Shivnath's back was soaked.

Shivnath said -

“Has the government of the association changed?”

The three went on laughing.

On the way they came to the awning of a medicine shop.

They stopped there and inspected the umbrella.

The blue patch was sound.

The wire was sound.

The shaft was sound.

Only the three owners were wet.

Karim said -

“The umbrella is a success. The owners are still in training.”

Jagdish proposed -

“The handle should change hands every two steps.”

Shivnath said -

“At two steps each, will we reach home or reach dawn?”

In the end they settled on twenty steps apiece.

Jagdish began counting.

At twenty the umbrella passed to Karim.

At the next twenty it passed to Shivnath.

Now the three began walking at the same pace.

No one had the freedom to hurry ahead.

No one had the freedom to fall behind either.

Jagdish's house came first.

He stopped at his door.

Karim was holding the umbrella then.

Jagdish asked -

“And now, what about my share?”

Still holding the shaft, Karim said -

“Shall we take the rod out?”

The three fell silent.

Then Jagdish laughed.

“No. We are not breaking up the association.”

He brought an old sack from inside the house.

He wiped the wet cloth of the umbrella.

Then he said -

“If it rains tomorrow, come and take it from my house.”

Shivnath asked -

“And if I need it first?”

Jagdish thought for a moment.

“Then whistle.”

Karim said -

“Will we hear a whistle from a kos and a half away?”

“Then come running.”

Shivnath said -

“The rules of the association are still incomplete.”

The three laughed again.

Karim and Shivnath went on with the umbrella.

Now there were only two people.

All at once the umbrella seemed very large.

Karim said -

"One member fewer, and the convenience has increased."

Shivnath said -

"Do not tell Jagdish that."

Karim's house lay beyond the bridge.

When Karim was handing the umbrella to Shivnath there, his hand paused.

"What if a rib comes loose tomorrow?"

"I will bring it to you."

"And if the cloth tears?"

"I will sew it."

"The shaft?"

Both said together -

"Jagdish!"

The rain had eased a little.

Shivnath walked on alone with the umbrella.

Now he could remain completely dry beneath it.

But after five steps he stopped.

He looked at the blue patch.

Then at the handle.

Then at the knot of wire.

The umbrella was in his hand, but it was not wholly his.

For no particular reason, he smiled.

The next morning the sky was clear.

The three met again at the crossroads.

Shivnath had brought the umbrella with him.

Jagdish looked up at the blue sky.

"Where is the rain today?"

Shivnath said -

"This is the first meeting of the association."

Karim asked -

"The subject?"

Shivnath opened the umbrella.

"The account of the repairs."

The three sat not beneath the umbrella, but around it.

Shivnath said -

"The cloth - mine."

Karim -

"The ribs - mine."

Jagdish -

"The shaft - mine."

After a moment Karim asked -

“Then whose umbrella is it?”

Jagdish answered -

“Whoever the rain is falling on.”

Shivnath nodded.

“And if the rain is falling on all three?”

Karim lifted the umbrella.

“Twenty steps each.”

The three laughed.

It did not rain that day.

Even so, the green-and-blue umbrella remained hanging at the crossroads until evening.

People kept asking -

“Whose umbrella is that?”

The three gave the same answer in different words -

“Not mine.”

“Not his.”

“The association’s.”

And when the rain came again, before opening the umbrella they did not count anyone’s share.

They only looked to see whose armpit would get wet first.

STORY 117

The Forgetful Lover

Nandu had enormous faith in his memory.

So much faith that he considered writing anything down on paper almost an insult.

One day Madhuri had asked with a laugh -

“Do you remember my birthday?”

Nandu had answered at once -

“The seventeenth.”

Madhuri had raised an eyebrow.

“Did you say the seventeenth?”

“The seventeenth.”

“Say it again.”

“The seventeenth. Will the date change if I say it three times?”

Madhuri had burst out laughing.

“No. I only wanted to see how confident you were.”

Nandu had taken that laughter for agreement.

The truth was that Madhuri had said -

“The twenty-seventh.”

At that very moment a cart loaded with sacks of paddy had rattled past along the road.

Nandu had heard half the word.

The other half he had supplied from his own confidence.

From then on, the date had settled in his mind like a stone - the seventeenth.

He worked at a bicycle-repair shop in the market.

All day, among bells, wires, screws and air pumps, his hands grew black with grease.

Madhuri was learning sewing in the adjoining lane.

They usually met in the evening at the bend near the pond.

Their conversations were never long.

“A lot of work today?”

“Yes, a lot.”

“Everyone at home well?”

“Everyone at home is well.”

“Shall we meet tomorrow?”

“If you don’t forget the date.”

Madhuri always said that last sentence jokingly.

Nandu took it as a challenge.

The seventeenth was drawing near.

Three weeks in advance, Nandu began saving.

Tea once a day instead of twice.

Half his usual roasted gram.

On two evenings he walked home instead of taking a bicycle ride.

Five rupees here, two rupees there - he kept putting coins aside.

He did not want to buy a grand gift.

A grand gift was beyond both his pocket and his nature.

Madhuri had once said -

“I like things that can be put to use.”

Nandu thought for a long time.

In the end he bought a small, thick-covered notebook from the stationery shop.

Madhuri was learning sewing; she could use it to note measurements, thread and cloth accounts.

The shopkeeper asked -

“A gift?”

Nandu gave a brief answer -

“For keeping accounts.”

The shopkeeper looked at him.

“Can an account book be a gift?”

Nandu replied -

“When the pocket is small, every object changes its name.”

The shopkeeper laughed.

Nandu wrapped the notebook in old newspaper.

Then he thought - only a notebook for a birthday?

That evening he bought two jalebis as well.

He felt tempted to make it three.

After hearing the price, he returned to two.

On the evening of the seventeenth, he tried to finish work early.

The shop owner asked -

“Why such a hurry?”

As he pumped air into a tyre, Nandu said -

“Today is an important date.”

The owner smiled.

“Is the date important, or the person?”

Nandu did not answer.

He thought the owner was growing old.

He tucked the notebook under his arm, placed the jalebis in a leaf bowl and set off towards Madhuri's lane.

Twice on the way he opened the bowl to check.
 The jalebis were safe.
 He felt like opening it a third time, but restrained himself.
 When he reached Madhuri's courtyard, there was no sign of celebration.
 No lamps.
 No aroma of festive food.
 No new clothes.
 Madhuri's mother was sitting in the courtyard, sorting lentils.
 Madhuri sat on the veranda sewing buttons onto a half-finished kurti.
 Nandu stopped at the gate.
 Madhuri looked up.
 "So you've come?"
 Nandu became solemn.
 "Yes, I have."
 "Why are you making such a face?"
 "First close your eyes."
 Madhuri stopped her needle.
 "Why should I close my eyes?"
 "Just close them."
 Madhuri's mother kept sorting lentils and watching them both.
 Madhuri closed her eyes.
 Nandu placed the newspaper parcel in front of her.
 Then, very softly, he said -
 "Many, many happy returns of your birthday."
 Madhuri opened her eyes.
 First she looked at Nandu.
 Then at the parcel.
 Then at her mother.
 Then at the sky.
 Seeing where she was looking, Nandu asked -
 "What happened?"
 Madhuri said -
 "What date is it today?"
 Nandu smiled.
 He was prepared for this question.
 "The seventeenth."
 "Certain?"
 "Absolutely certain."
 Madhuri stuck the needle into the cloth.
 "My birthday is on the twenty-seventh."
 For a moment the leaf bowl of jalebis grew heavy in Nandu's hand.
 "Did you say the twenty-seventh?"

"The twenty-seventh."

"Say it again."

"The twenty-seventh. Will the date change if I say it three times?"

Madhuri's mother laughed so loudly that two lentils fell from her lap.

Nandu forgot his reply.

Madhuri too struggled to contain her laughter.

At last Nandu said -

"You told me the seventeenth before."

"I told you the twenty-seventh."

"No, the seventeenth."

"Yes, the twenty-seventh."

"I remember it perfectly."

"You remember it perfectly wrong."

Nandu immediately collected himself.

"Wrong?"

Madhuri smiled.

"Yes, wrong."

Nandu sat down at the edge of the courtyard.

All at once he remembered his savings, the evenings he had walked home,
the half-portions of roasted gram.

Madhuri picked up the parcel.

"Shall I open it?"

Nandu said gloomily -

"Ten days from now."

"Will the newspaper hold the birthday back for ten days?"

"The date is wrong."

"What fault is that of the gift?"

Madhuri's mother added -

"Or of the jalebis?"

All three looked at the jalebis.

Nandu said slowly -

"Jalebis cannot read dates."

Madhuri's mother laughed again.

The two jalebis were divided into three portions.

Nandu was exceedingly careful while dividing them.

Madhuri asked -

"Where was all this care when you were remembering the date?"

Looking at the jalebi, Nandu replied -

"The sweet was in front of my eyes."

"Wasn't I?"

"You were. But you were talking."

"So?"

“Words move when people speak.”
 Madhuri’s mother said -
 “And your ears remain still?”
 Nandu conceded defeat.
 The jalebis were finished.
 Madhuri opened the parcel.
 When she saw the thick-covered notebook, her laughter softened.
 She opened the first page.
 It was blank.
 “You haven’t written anything?”
 Looking at the page, Nandu said -
 “I thought you should write the first page.”
 Madhuri took a pencil from her sewing box.
 On the first page she wrote -
 “Seventeenth - Nandu’s memory.”
 Underneath it -
 “Twenty-seventh - my birthday.”
 Nandu looked at the page and turned his face away.
 “Will that remain there for ten years?”
 “The cover is thick.”
 “Tear out the page.”
 “I will never tear out this page.”
 Nandu got to his feet.
 Madhuri asked -
 “Will you come again ten days from now?”
 As he rose, Nandu said -
 “We’ll see.”
 “Write down the date.”
 “No. I won’t write it down.”
 “Then what will you do?”
 Nandu tapped his temple.
 “This time it is sitting here.”
 Madhuri’s mother said -
 “The seventeenth was sitting there too.”
 Nandu left without replying.
 The next ten days felt unusually long to him.
 Now and then the shop owner would ask -
 “Is the important date coming again?”
 Amid the clinking of screws, Nandu would say -
 “There was only one date. I reached the wrong bend first.”
 The owner repeated -
 “The wrong bend.”

Nandu narrowed his eyes.

“Has everyone heard about it?”

Tightening a screw, the owner said -

“Secrets grow wings in a market.”

This time Nandu bought no gift.

No sweets.

No flowers.

He decided that since the birthday had already been celebrated once, there would be no second expense.

But on the morning of the twenty-seventh, he woke very early.

He asked no one to confirm the date.

He looked at the wall calendar three times.

27.

He touched the number with his finger.

Then laughed at himself.

In the evening he reached Madhuri's courtyard.

His hands were empty.

Madhuri was already standing at the gate.

She looked at Nandu's hands.

“Nothing in your hands?”

“Already given.”

“Jalebis?”

“Already eaten.”

“Birthday wishes?”

Nandu was silent for a moment.

Then he said -

“Today is the twenty-seventh.”

Madhuri waited.

Nandu continued -

“And today is your birthday.”

Madhuri asked -

“Certain?”

Nandu nodded.

“This time even the calendar is on my side.”

Madhuri laughed.

She went inside and brought out the same thick-covered notebook.

She opened the first page.

The two lines were still there.

Seventeenth - Nandu's memory.

Twenty-seventh - my birthday.

Madhuri wrote a third line -

“Twenty-seventh - Nandu on time the second time.”

The moment Nandu read it, he protested -
 "Why the second time? The first time I was ten days early."

"What kind of time was that?"

"Advance."

"Then will you come in advance next year too?"

Nandu made a grave show of thinking.

"This time I have learned from experience."

"What did experience teach you?"

"Remembering a birthday is not difficult."

"Then what is difficult?"

"Remembering the date is difficult."

From inside, Madhuri's mother called -

"Both of you come in. The kheer is getting cold."

At the word kheer, Nandu stopped short.

"Kheer?"

Madhuri said -

"It's a birthday."

Nandu asked softly -

"Really?"

Madhuri stared at him.

Nandu immediately folded his hands.

"Just checking."

That evening Nandu ate two bowls of kheer.

The first was for the birthday.

The second was not punishment for his mistake on the seventeenth, but its reward.

On his way home, he thought of buying a calendar.

Then abandoned the idea.

It seemed to him that the first page of the thick-covered notebook was more trustworthy than any calendar.

The next day Madhuri wrote one more line in small letters in the corner of that page -

"Next year, ask first."

When Nandu read it, he objected -

"So much verification in love?"

Madhuri said -

"Let the love be right. Just get the date right."

This time Nandu did not argue.

He closed the notebook.

Then he asked Madhuri -

"What day of the week will the twenty-seventh fall on next year?"

Madhuri glared at him.

Nandu laughed.

“All right. I’m writing it down from now.”

STORY 118

The Barber Who Charged Nothing

Mangal the barber's shop stood at the turn beneath the peepal tree.

To call it a shop was itself an act of generosity.

Three reed screens, a tin awning, an old mirror, and in the middle a heavy chair painted blue.

The chair's right arm was a little loose.

Mangal used to say -

"The chair is loose, not my hand."

He laughed harder at that line than anyone else.

That afternoon Dhiru arrived at the shop.

His hair had puffed out so wildly that it looked as though, for the past two months, a comb had done no more than salute it from a distance.

The moment Mangal saw him, he laid his scissors on the table.

"Come, prince."

Dhiru looked into the mirror and touched his head.

"The prince's crown has grown a little too large."

"Not a crown. Neglect."

"There's a feast at home tomorrow. Cut it short."

Mangal slapped the chair.

"Sit."

Dhiru felt his pocket.

"Tell me the price first."

Mangal's eyebrows rose.

"For you?"

"Yes, for me. I've come from the city. I'll pay."

"Did friendship go out on rent the moment you came back from the city?"

Dhiru laughed.

"If you cut it for free, you'll only cut half."

Mangal's face turned serious at once.

"Don't say that again."

"Why ever not?"

"Cutting without payment is one thing. Cutting badly is an insult to me."

Dhiru sat in the chair.

Mangal wrapped an old, freshly washed gamchha around his neck.

"How short?"

"Just enough for me to look human."

“What do you look like now?”

“A thicket.”

“Even a thicket has a design.”

Dhiru watched him in the mirror.

“Master barber, are you cutting hair or surveying a field?”

Parting the hair down the middle with his comb, Mangal said -

“Your head is harder than a field.”

“Why so difficult?”

“Two whorls.”

“Are the whorls in my hair or in my fate?”

“In both. But I’ll manage the ones in the hair.”

This was where Mangal’s pride began.

If anyone in the village asked, “Who cut your hair?” and the answer was “Mangal,” he remained pleased for two days.

If anyone said, “It’s all right,” he slept badly that night.

“All right” sounded almost like abuse to him.

He wanted people to say -

“The man who cut this knew the head.”

Mangal lifted the hair above Dhiru’s right ear.

There was a small old scar there.

“Still there.”

Dhiru laughed.

“Because of you.”

“Because of me?”

“I was eight. You had made a bamboo sword by the pond. I was the king. The sword struck me.”

Mangal stopped his scissors.

“Liar. You fell on your own.”

“A king does not fall. The commander is at fault.”

“The commander is a barber now. Keep quiet.”

The scissors began again.

Snip-snip.

Snip-snip.

After a while Dhiru asked -

“Why so slowly?”

“Shall I hurry over your head?”

“The hair will grow again.”

“But what is cut today will be discussed tomorrow.”

“You have great faith in your art.”

“Not faith. Experience.”

“The difference?”

“Faith can exist before you’ve cut anything. Experience comes from cutting and cutting.”

Just then Rambabu came hurrying into the shop.

“Mangal! I’m in a hurry. Cut my hair short in ten minutes. I’ll pay double.”

Mangal had Dhiru’s left-side hair caught in the comb.

“It’ll take half an hour.”

Rambabu looked at the chair.

“That’s only Dhiru. Get him up. Take me first.”

Dhiru made as if to rise.

“I can wait.”

Mangal pressed his shoulder down.

“Sit.”

Rambabu said -

“Double payment.”

Mangal replied calmly -

“There is one chair. Three heads won’t make a second chair grow.”

“Will he pay?”

“No. He won’t.”

Rambabu stared at Dhiru in surprise.

“He won’t?”

“He’s a friend.”

“Then cut mine first. I’m a paying customer.”

Mangal looked at Rambabu’s reflection in the mirror.

“Money does not change the order of heads.”

Rambabu pulled a face and left.

Dhiru said quietly -

“You let double payment walk away.”

“Leave your head half cut and take another man’s money? Then people will say Mangal’s art looks at the price.”

“You worry a great deal about what people will say.”

“Not people. What my scissors will say.”

Dhiru laughed.

“Do scissors speak?”

“When they see a badly cut head, they say - shame.”

Mangal went back to work.

He did not cut the right side too short.

The left side he cut a little shorter.

The moment Dhiru saw it in the mirror, he started.

“Hey! The two sides aren’t equal.”

Mangal’s expression became that of a scholar who has just been told there is an error in his book.

“Equal length does not give every head an equal shape.”

“Is that the barber’s defence?”

“Quiet. There is a scar above this ear. On that side the whorl rises the other way. If I leave both sides the same length, the scar will show and the hair will stand up.”

Dhiru tried to turn his neck.

Mangal straightened his head again.

“Don’t move.”

“I want to see.”

“Look at the end. You don’t put a singer on trial after hearing half a song.”

Two children stopped outside the shop.

One whispered to the other -

“Mangal Kaka is giving a lecture again.”

Without turning, Mangal said -

“Listen. It’s free.”

The children burst out laughing.

An old woman was passing nearby, holding her grandson’s hand.

She stopped and called -

“Mangal barber, cut Monu’s hair this evening.”

Mangal answered at once -

“Bring him, Kaki. This time I won’t cut his ear.”

The old woman laughed.

“You didn’t cut his ear last time either. Why do you praise yourself?”

“Other people take too long to do it.”

Dhiru said -

“You hear that? The disease is old.”

Mangal tapped his head with the comb.

“Customer, quiet.”

“I’m a non-paying customer.”

“All the more reason to be quiet.”

The scissors started again.

Every so often Mangal took two steps back to inspect Dhiru’s head.

Sometimes from the right.

Sometimes from the left.

Once he even stepped outside the shop and looked from beneath the peepal tree.

Dhiru shouted -

“Where have you gone?”

“I’m looking at the shape from a distance.”

“Am I a statue?”

“Still unfinished.”

Dhiru could not hold back his laughter.

Mangal came in again.

He sprinkled a little water on the hair.
 It settled.
 Then he ruffled it with his hand.
 The whorl on the right rose, but the scar above the ear remained covered.
 Mangal said triumphantly -
 "See?"
 "See what?"
 "This."
 "What about it?"
 "Art."
 "All I can see is hair."
 "Your vision is ordinary."
 Dhiru tried to free one hand from beneath the gamchha.
 "Give me the scissors once. I'll make your vision extraordinary."
 Laughing, Mangal stepped back.
 "Hands inside."
 He trimmed the hair at the back of the neck with great care.
 He cleaned the edge with a razor.
 Then he lifted the hair at the front with a small comb.
 "How much here?"
 Dhiru said -
 "Whatever looks right to you."
 Mangal stopped.
 "Wisdom at last."
 "No. I'm tired."
 Mangal laughed again.
 When the work was finished, he removed the gamchha and brushed Dhiru's shoulders clean.
 Then he handed him the mirror.
 "Look."
 Dhiru looked straight ahead.
 Then to the right.
 Then to the left.
 Mangal held a second, smaller mirror behind him.
 "The back too."
 Dhiru remained silent for a long while.
 On Mangal's face, pride slowly began to turn into anxiety.
 "What are you thinking?"
 Dhiru lowered the mirror.
 "Nothing. Just looking."
 "What does 'nothing' mean?"
 "The hair is good."

Mangal wrinkled his nose.

“Good?”

“Yes, good.”

“Only good?”

Dhiru had decided to tease him a little.

“All right.”

Mangal almost snatched the mirror from his hand.

“Get up. Sit down again.”

“Why again?”

“‘All right’ does not leave my shop.”

Dhiru doubled over laughing.

“Come on, I was joking!”

“Joke when the hair grows back.”

Mangal snipped two or three more hairs near his temple.

Then stepped back and inspected him.

“Now say.”

Dhiru put on a solemn face.

“Magnificent.”

Mangal was satisfied.

“That word has weight.”

Dhiru took a note from his pocket.

Mangal drew his hand back.

“Keep it.”

“You did the work.”

“I cut a friend’s hair.”

“Did the scissors work for free?”

“My scissors don’t ask me for wages.”

“Oil, water, time?”

“There is still the account of those mangoes we stole together by the pond.”

“You ate half the mangoes yourself.”

“Then should I cut only half your hair?”

Both laughed again.

Dhiru put the note back in his pocket.

As he was leaving the shop, his eyes fell on the loose arm of the chair.

Dhiru knew carpentry work.

He bent down and examined the joint.

“What’s happened here?”

“Leave it. It works.”

“How many more days will you keep giving that speech - the chair is loose, not my hand?”

Dhiru took a small screwdriver from his bag.

Mangal stared.

“You always carry that in your bag?”
 “I’m a carpenter’s son. Why shouldn’t I take pride in my craft like you?”
 In two minutes the arm was tight.
 Mangal kept pretending to stop him.
 “This is payment.”
 Dhiru straightened and said -
 “No. I tightened a friend’s chair.”
 Mangal looked at him for a moment.
 Then smiled.
 “All right, then the account is not even.”
 “Why not?”
 “Half an hour to cut your hair. Two minutes to tighten the arm.”
 “Your art is expensive?”
 “You were the one who said ‘magnificent’ had weight.”
 Dhiru started away.
 When he reached the peepal tree, he ran his hand over his head again.
 The whorl on the right really was lying flat.
 The scar did not show.
 He turned and shouted -
 “Mangal!”
 “What are you shouting from back there?”
 “It’s a little above all right.”
 Mangal pretended to pick up the broom from inside the shop.
 “Get out of here!”
 The next morning Rambabu came again.
 This time he was in no hurry.
 As he sat in the chair, he asked -
 “You cut Dhiru’s hair?”
 Mangal picked up the comb.
 “Why do you ask?”
 “It looks good.”
 Mangal’s face lit up.
 But at once he became serious again.
 “Good?”
 Rambabu did not understand.
 “Yes, very good.”
 “Say magnificent.”
 “Say what?”
 “Nothing. Keep your head straight.”
 Just then the old woman from the previous day arrived with Monu.
 “Mangal barber, don’t cut the child’s hair too short.”
 Mangal looked at Monu’s head.

“First let me understand this whorl.”

Dhiru happened to be passing along the road.

He heard this and laughed from a distance.

The moment Mangal saw him, he called -

“Hey, non-paying customer! Don’t stop here. You lower the shop’s prestige.”

Dhiru called back -

“I’m going. But Monu, be careful! This barber cuts less hair and gives more philosophy.”

Holding his grandmother’s hand, Monu asked -

“Dadi, does philosophy cost extra?”

The old woman replied -

“From Mangal barber? He gives it without being asked.”

The shop filled with laughter.

Mangal opened his scissors.

Snip-snip.

“Laugh, laugh. But don’t move your head.”

STORY 119

Grandmother's Mobile Phone

Dhanwanti Dadi had owned the device for two years, but by her reckoning it was still new.

"It simply refuses to make sense to me," she would say.

Her granddaughter Anima laughed.

"Why should the device understand you, Dadi? You understand it."

Dadi pushed her spectacles higher and peered at the screen.

Round icons were scattered across it.

One held a camera, another a bell, another a green circle.

To Dadi, all the icons were like distant relatives from the same family - their faces looked familiar, but their names would not stay in her memory.

Anima spent three days teaching her.

"Press this green icon and you can talk."

"And the red one?"

"That ends the call."

"Then if I press the red one first, there will be no bother at all."

Anima doubled over with laughter.

On the fourth day, Dadi pressed the camera icon instead of the green one.

She was startled to see her own face on the screen.

"Who put my face inside this little box?"

The whole house burst into laughter again.

The device was difficult for her; the family was not.

Who had taken offence, who had left a sentence unfinished, who said "I am fine" while not being fine at all - Dhanwanti Dadi understood all of that without pressing a single icon.

She had three children.

Her eldest son, Raghunath, lived in the village itself.

Her younger son, Devkinandan, worked in Muzaffarpur.

Her daughter Malati was married into a family near Madhubani.

The grandchildren studied or earned their living in different places.

Earlier, everyone came home and then brought news.

Now the news arrived by telephone first; the people came later.

Dadi's device had become the family's new chaupal.

The first call in the morning was usually Malati's.

"Ma, did you sleep well?"

"I did."

"Has Raghu Bhai gone to the fields?"

"Yes."

"Did Devki call?"

"He called yesterday."

By then Malati's questions about her two brothers had already outnumbered the questions about herself.

Dadi kept count in her mind.

In the afternoon, Devkinandan would call.

"Ma, did you take your medicine on time?"

"I did."

"Is Malati coming?"

"She said next month."

"What is Raghu Bhai doing?"

Dadi counted again in her mind.

In the evening Raghunath would sit in the courtyard.

He did not call, because his mother was right there in front of him.

But even he would ask -

"Did Malati call?"

"Yes."

"What did Devki say?"

Dadi would then smile as she sliced betel nut.

"Why do all of you ask me for news of one another?"

Wiping his face with his gamchha, Raghunath would say -

"Just asking."

Devki would say -

"I don't get the time, Ma."

Malati would say -

"They must be busy."

To Dadi, "just asking," "no time," and "busy" were three names for the same illness.

It was not a serious illness.

But it was an old one.

Six months earlier, Devki had arrived late for Babuji's death anniversary.

Raghunath had said something.

Devki had answered.

Malati had stepped between them.

The matter itself had not been large.

The voices had grown large.

After that the three siblings still spoke, but less often directly to one another.

Dadi had become the bridge between them.

She did not object to being a bridge.

But it amused her that all of them knew how to operate the device, yet their hands somehow grew heavy when it came to pressing one another's numbers.

One day Anima added photographs beside every family member's name on Dadi's phone.

"Now you won't need to read the names."

Dadi looked at the screen.

In Raghunath's photograph his eyes were half closed.

In Devkinandan's photograph half an ear had been cut off.

In Malati's photograph a red wedding curtain showed in the background.

Dadi said -

"I don't need this device to recognise these three."

"It will make things easier."

"Ease is what you people need."

Anima did not understand.

Dadi did not explain.

A small brass bowl always stood beside Dadi's cot.

Inside it lay six small pieces of betel nut.

One day Anima asked -

"What are these for?"

"For counting."

"Counting what?"

"Not who called."

"Then what?"

"Who called and then asked about whom."

Anima thought Dadi was joking.

But Dadi truly kept count.

If Malati called and asked about Raghunath, one piece of betel nut moved to the right.

If Devki called and asked about Malati, a second piece joined it.

If Raghunath asked about Devki's son Sonu's examination, a third piece moved across.

By evening a little map would have formed inside the bowl.

Anima laughed.

"Dadi, the phone keeps a record of calls."

"What does it tell you?"

"Who called, how many times, and how long the call lasted."

Dadi picked up one piece of betel nut.

"Does it tell you that Malati asked your father's name three times?"

Anima fell silent.

"Does it tell you that Devki first asked about my medicine, and then about Raghu's knee pain?"

Anima looked at the device.

Dadi smiled.

"This little box counts numbers. I count the breath behind the names."

Anima liked the sentence.

She immediately thought of writing it down.

But the moment Dadi's eyes fell on her, she put the device aside.

"Not everything is meant to be written down," Dadi said.

A week later a small thing happened in the house.

The charging cable of Dadi's phone became loose.

The device worked until noon.

Then the screen went dark.

Dadi pressed it three times.

No green icon, no red icon, not even her own face.

"Dead?" she asked.

Anima had gone to college.

Raghunath was in the fields.

Dadi placed the device on the cot.

"Rest."

At half past two Malati tried calling.

The phone was off.

At three she tried again.

The phone was still off.

Malati first called Anima.

Anima was in class and did not answer.

Malati paused for a moment.

Then she pressed Raghunath's number.

It was the first time in six months that she had called him directly without any pretext.

Standing on the ridge of a field, Raghunath pressed the green icon.

"Yes, Malati?"

For two moments there was silence at both ends.

"Ma's phone is off."

"I'm in the field. I'm going home now."

"See if she's all right."

"She'll be fine. The cable must be loose."

"Call me when you reach."

"I will."

The call ended.

Malati remained sitting with the phone in her hand for a while.

A little later she pressed Devki's number.

"Did you get through to Ma?"

Devki said -

"I tried twice. It's switched off. I'll call Raghu Bhai."

Malati said -
 "I just spoke to him."
 Devki was silent for a moment.
 "What did he say?"
 "He's on his way home from the fields."
 "All right. Let me know."
 Malati smiled.
 "Why should I? You can ask Raghu Bhai yourself."
 Devki's laugh was faint at first, then clear.
 "You're right."
 Dadi knew nothing of any of this.
 She was shelling peas in the courtyard.
 Raghunath arrived out of breath.
 "Ma!"
 Dadi looked up.
 "What happened?"
 "Your phone is switched off."
 "So?"
 "Everyone is worried."
 Dadi dropped another pea into the bowl.
 "The device stopped. I didn't."
 Raghunath laughed.
 The cable really was loose.
 He pressed the old connection into place and plugged the phone in.
 Ten minutes later the screen lit up again.
 At once the phone rang.
 It was Devki.
 Raghunath held the phone out to Dadi.
 Dadi drew her hand back.
 "You talk first."
 "Me?"
 "Press the green one. That's as much as I know too."
 Smiling, Raghunath put the phone to his ear.
 "Yes, Devki."
 Dadi went on shelling peas.
 The two brothers first spoke about the phone cable.
 Then about their mother's medicine.
 Then about water in the fields.
 Then about Sonu's examination.
 The call lasted five minutes.
 Dadi did not look at the call duration.
 She listened to the weight in their voices.

After many days, each brother waited for the other to finish his sentence.
In the evening Malati called.
This time Dadi pressed the correct icon on the first attempt.
“Ma, are you all right?”
“I was all right from the beginning.”
“And the phone?”
“That has come back to life too.”
Malati laughed.
Dadi asked -
“Did you speak to Raghu?”
“Yes.”
“To Devki?”
“Yes.”
Dadi looked at the bowl.
That day there had been no need to move a single piece of betel nut.
“What is it, Ma?”
“Nothing.”
Dadi put a piece of betel nut into her mouth.
“My phone did very good work today.”
Malati said -
“By being switched off?”
“Yes.”
They both laughed.
When Anima returned at night, she replaced the charging cable.
The new cable gleamed.
Then she sat down to teach Dadi again.
“Look, this is contact, this is message, this is video -”
Dadi raised a hand.
“One lesson a day.”
“What did you learn today?”
Dadi picked up the phone.
She tried to open the screen.
She pressed the wrong icon.
Her own face appeared on the screen again.
Dadi smiled at her image.
“I learned that this little box can connect everyone.”
Anima looked pleased.
Dadi went on -
“But sometimes it must also know how to stay quiet.”
Anima laughed.
The next morning the phone rang again.
Dadi searched for the green icon.

By mistake she pressed the volume-down button.

She shouted -

“Whoever you are, speak loudly!”

Devki was laughing at the other end.

“Ma, it’s me.”

Dadi breathed easier.

“Good. Did you speak to Raghu yesterday?”

Devki said -

“This morning. He called me himself.”

Dadi looked at the betel-nut bowl.

It was empty.

She set the phone aside.

“Then why are you asking me? Tell me your own news.”

STORY 120

One Plate of Pakoras

The rain had stopped, but the tin roof at Harinagar Chowk was still counting drops.

In front of Ramcharit's tea stall, water had gathered into little pools.

Stepping across those pools one by one, five friends came inside.

Jamal first.

Nawal behind him.

Then Bhola.

Chandan entered while shaking the water from his slippers.

Raghuvir came last, the hem of his dhoti wet up to the knees.

The five friends had a rule: after the Wednesday market ended, they would sit for half an hour at Ramcharit's stall.

Whether someone's trade had gone well or badly, the rule did not change.

Ramcharit set down five glasses of tea.

The smell of gram-flour batter rose from the pan of hot oil.

Bhola flared his nostrils.

"Ramcharit, that smell is designed to ruin friendships."

Ramcharit smiled.

"If friendship is that weak, what fault is it of the pakoras?"

Nawal looked towards the pan.

"Give us one plate."

"Only one?" Jamal asked.

"One first. Let the stomachs convene their meeting."

Ramcharit lifted hot pakoras from the oil and placed them on an old brass-coloured plate.

He sprinkled salt and chilli over them.

Beside them he set a small bowl of coriander chutney.

The plate came to the middle of the table.

Chandan counted at once.

"Eleven."

Ramcharit glared at him.

"Eat the pakoras. Don't conduct a census."

Bhola laughed.

"Five men and eleven pakoras. This isn't arithmetic, it's a crisis."

Raghuvir picked up the first pakora.

"This is how a crisis is reduced."

Each of them took one.
 The bowl of chutney went round five times.
 The pairing of cool air after rain and hot pakoras was such that all five fell silent for a few moments.
 From a distance Ramcharit said -
 "See? Gram flour accomplishes more than philosophy."
 Jamal picked up a second pakora.
 "So far, equality prevails."
 The second round was completed as well.
 Ten pakoras were gone.
 One remained on the plate.
 It was nicely round.
 Its edge was crisp and well browned.
 A drop of chutney clung beside it.
 All five looked at it.
 No one reached out a hand.
 Ramcharit went on washing cups, smiling to himself.
 Bhola said -
 "Friendship will break over this one."
 Jamal replied -
 "If it breaks, it will break cheaply. One pakora isn't worth even five annas."
 Chandan said -
 "It isn't a question of price. It's a question of justice."
 Nawal stopped him.
 "Your school has opened again."
 Chandan grew serious.
 "All right. Whoever is hungriest should eat it."
 The five looked at one another.
 No one wished to admit to being hungry.
 Raghuvir placed a hand on his stomach and said -
 "Two have filled me up."
 Bhola said at once -
 "Me too."
 Jamal looked at Bhola's stomach.
 "Your stomach and your word have been old enemies."
 Laughter broke out.
 Nawal said -
 "Let's try another method. It goes to whoever earned the least today."
 Bhola shook his head.
 "Then this won't be friendship; it'll be a market audit."
 Chandan offered another proposal -
 "Whoever is oldest should get it."

Raghuvir started.

"I'm seven months older than you, not so ancient that I need a charity pakora."

Ramcharit laughed again.

"The plate is growing cold; justice is growing hot."

Jamal put down his glass.

"Let's do one thing."

"What?"

"This pakora will be eaten by the one who carries the greatest debt of friendship."

Bhola frowned.

"The one who owes the debt, or the one who gave the favour?"

Jamal fell into thought.

"Now that is a difficult question."

Chandan said at once -

"The one who gave has the right."

Raghuvir laughed.

"Then everyone will open his account book."

Nawal pulled the plate towards himself, but did not take the pakora.

"I'll begin."

He looked at Jamal.

"This pakora belongs to Jamal."

Jamal was startled.

"Why mine?"

"Two years ago the belt of my sewing machine snapped at night."

"So?"

"I had to deliver twenty school uniforms in the morning."

"So?"

"You shut your bicycle shop and spent half the night repairing the belt."

Jamal brushed it aside with a wave.

"That wasn't a debt. The following week you stitched the torn pocket of my kurta."

Nawal said -

"Stitching a pocket took five minutes. Saving the machine took three hours."

"Hours aren't counted in friendship."

"Then the pakora is yours."

Jamal pushed the plate towards Bhola.

"Not mine. Bhola will eat it."

Bhola immediately drew back his hand.

"Why has my name come into this?"

Jamal said -

"The time I had fever, for three mornings he left his own vegetables and went to open the lock of my shop."

Bhola wrinkled his nose.

"I opened the lock. I didn't repair bicycles."

"And who told the customers that Jamal wasn't dead, only down with fever?"

Everyone laughed.

Bhola smiled too.

"All right, but the pakora belongs to Chandan."

Chandan adjusted his spectacles.

"What crime have I committed now?"

Bhola said -

"My daughter Muniya couldn't understand multiplication."

"I taught her for a week."

"Two months."

"Half an hour in the evenings."

"And the fee?"

Chandan fell silent.

Bhola smiled.

"When I asked about payment, you said: first let Muniya recite the table of five without stumbling; then we'll talk."

Jamal asked -

"Did Muniya manage it?"

Bhola puffed out his chest.

"Now she can recite the table of seven too."

Chandan pushed the plate towards Raghuvir.

"Then this is Raghuvir's."

Raghuvir drew his head back.

"I present my defence in advance."

"Defence later," Chandan said.

"Last winter my father was in hospital."

Raghuvir's smile softened.

Chandan continued -

"At two in the morning we needed medicine."

"I live near the market, so I went."

"The shop was closed."

"I had another one opened."

"And you cycled three kos."

Raghuvir said quietly -

"You taught my brother's son before his examination. The account is square."

Chandan smiled.

"You have an old disease: you insist on balancing everything in friendship."

Raghuvir pushed the plate towards Nawal.

"Then Nawal will eat it."

Nawal laughed.

"I've already named Jamal."

Raghuvir said -

"When it's my turn to name someone, that's my right."

"Why?"

Raghuvir wrung the wet edge of his dhoti.

"Last monsoon my younger son's schoolbag tore."

Nawal said -

"That was sewing, not friendship."

"At ten at night?"

"He needed the bag in the morning."

"The fee?"

"Would I charge a child for mending his schoolbag?"

With a look of triumph, Raghuvir said -

"Then the pakora is Nawal's."

The plate had come back to Nawal.

For a moment all five were silent.

Then Jamal burst out laughing.

"What has happened here?"

Bhola traced a circle with his finger.

"Nawal to Jamal, Jamal to Bhola, Bhola to Chandan, Chandan to Raghuvir,
Raghuvir back to Nawal."

Chandan said -

"The circle of debts is complete."

Ramcharit left the cups and came over.

"In all this time the pakora has earned a degree."

Nawal made as if to pick it up.

Then he stopped his hand.

"Shall we cut it into five pieces?"

Jamal objected at once.

"Is this a pakora or a plot of land?"

Bhola said -

"If we cut it, more pieces will remain on the plate than get into the
chutney."

Raghuvir asked -

"Then what do we do?"

Chandan assumed a solemn expression.

"We need a ruling from the Friendship Commission."

Just then Ramcharit's eight-year-old daughter Gudiya came out from inside.

She carried five empty glasses in her hands.

She saw the lone pakora on the plate.

Then she looked at the five friends.

"Is no one going to eat that?"

All five answered together -

"A decision is in progress."

Gudiya thought for a moment.

"May I eat it?"

Everyone fell silent.

Ramcharit looked at his daughter.

"Ask first."

Gudiya asked again -

"May I?"

Jamal was the first to push the plate towards her.

"Yes, from my side."

Bhola said -

"From mine too."

Nawal, Chandan and Raghuvir agreed as well.

Gudiya picked up the pakora.

She dipped it in the chutney.

And ate it in two bites.

The five friends watched her.

Gudiya asked -

"Were you arguing all this time over that?"

Ramcharit burst out laughing.

The five friends laughed too.

Nawal said -

"Not arguing. Settling the accounts of friendship."

Gudiya picked up the empty plate.

"While you settle accounts, pakoras go cold."

She went back inside.

Jamal slapped his palm on the table.

"An eight-year-old girl turns out to be the wisest among us."

Bhola said -

"Not wise. Hungry."

Raghuvir smiled.

"And hunger keeps no accounts of friendship."

Chandan glared at him.

"Don't you start philosophising now."

Laughter rose again.

Ramcharit asked -
"Shall I bring another plate?"
The five looked at one another.
Nawal said -
"Bring it."
Jamal immediately added -
"But this time put only ten on the plate."
Ramcharit raised an eyebrow.
"And if there are eleven?"
Bhola said -
"The eleventh is Gudiya's share."
From inside came Gudiya's voice -
"Tell me beforehand!"
The shop filled with laughter again.
The second plate arrived.
Ramcharit had deliberately put eleven pakoras on it.
The five counted them.
This time no one argued.
The eleventh pakora was set aside at one edge of the plate.
Nawal called -
"Gudiya!"
From inside came the reply -
"Has the decision been made already?"
Jamal said -
"This time the decision was made in advance."
Gudiya came running.
She picked up the pakora.
As Ramcharit refilled the five friends' glasses, he said -
"Good. Friendship has been saved."
Blowing on his tea, Bhola said -
"Friendship was never in danger."
Chandan asked -
"Then what was in danger?"
Bhola looked at the empty plate.
"The eleventh pakora."
The five friends laughed once more.

STORY 121

A Pair of Slippers

From early Sunday morning in Bhadau, clouds had ringed the sky.

The rain had stopped, but the outer platform of the Shiva temple was still wet.

Near the gate, slippers lay in such a crowd that from a distance they looked like a mass of dark leaves.

Nandkishore had come to worship with his wife Vimla, their daughter Gudiya, and their young son Pintu.

They were travelling from the Saharsa side to his sister's house, and the temple lay on their way.

From the other direction, Rambilas Mandal had reached the temple with his wife Sita, his mother Kaushalya, and his son Sonu.

The two families had never seen each other before.

Outside the gate stood a long bench for shoes and slippers.

But the rain-soaked crowd was in a hurry, and everyone set down their footwear wherever they found space.

Nandkishore's slippers were black rubber.

Near the right strap there was a small repair stitched with blue thread.

Rambilas's slippers too were black rubber.

On the left sole was a small round mark made when he had once been lifting a sack of rice.

As she put down the slippers, Vimla said, "On the way back, everyone look carefully before putting on your own. There is a huge crowd."

Nandkishore laughed. "No one but me would ever take a liking to my slippers."

Pintu immediately said, "Then do you like them?"

Vimla burst out laughing.

Nandkishore pulled a face.

Meanwhile, Rambilas placed his slippers beside Nandkishore's.

Rambilas's mother Kaushalya carefully slid her old slippers with the red edging beneath the bench.

"If these disappear, I shall walk home barefoot," she said.

Sita said, "Who would take your slippers?"

Kaushalya laughed. "Someone very clever."

The temple bell rang.

Both families became absorbed in their own worship.

Outside, a light rain began again.
 People pressed closer beneath the awning.
 The mud in front of the slipper bench deepened.
 A few pairs were nudged by people's feet and slid into one another.
 As soon as the rain eased, the crowd surged outside once more.
 In his hurry, Nandkishore picked up a black pair of slippers.
 He did not notice the blue thread.
 In fact, the blue thread had been pressed beneath the wet strap.
 The pair he put on belonged to Rambilas.
 Rambilas too saw a black pair and slipped his feet into them.
 He had put on Nandkishore's slippers.
 The two pairs were almost the same size.
 So for the first few steps neither man suspected anything.
 Nandkishore's family took the road south.
 Rambilas's family headed north towards the bus stop.
 Pintu walked while looking back at the temple bell.

Gudiya caught his hand and said, "Look ahead, or you will end up sitting in the mud."

Nandkishore had gone barely ten or fifteen steps when something hard began to trouble his right foot.

He stopped.

"How did this strap become so stiff today?"

Vimla said, "The slippers are still wet. Come along."

They went on.

A little farther ahead, in front of a tea stall, Nandkishore stopped again.

He took off the slipper and looked at it.

"Where has my blue thread gone?"

Gudiya bent down at once.

"Babu, these are not your slippers."

Nandkishore turned one over and looked at the sole.

There was a small round mark.

Vimla said quietly, "You said, didn't you, that no one would ever like your slippers?"

Pintu said, "But you seem to have liked someone else's."

All four burst out laughing.

Nandkishore picked up the slippers in his hand.

"Come on, back to the temple."

By then, to the north, Rambilas too had slowed his pace.

His left slipper felt loose.

As they neared the bus stop, Sita said, "Why are you dragging your feet like that?"

Rambilas replied, "It feels as if my slippers grew larger overnight."

Sonu bent down to look.
 “Babu, the round mark on your sole is not there.”
 Rambilas took off the slippers.
 Near the right strap, the blue thread was peeping out.
 Sita put a hand to her forehead.
 Kaushalya laughed and said, “Whether you found the deity in the temple or not, your slippers are searching for their owner.”
 Rambilas too turned his family back towards the temple.
 By the gate, the crowd had thinned.
 Beside the bench, two barefoot pairs of feet arrived almost at the same moment, each waiting for the other.
 Nandkishore was carrying the slippers with the round mark.
 Rambilas held the pair with the blue thread.
 Each man looked at what the other was holding.
 Then each looked down at his own bare feet.
 For a moment there was silence.
 Pintu laughed first.
 Sonu burst out laughing too.
 Rambilas asked, “Was this round mark all set to travel to your house?”
 Nandkishore replied, “And this blue thread had set off to catch your bus.”
 They exchanged the slippers.
 Nandkishore breathed with relief when he saw the blue thread on his strap.
 Rambilas looked at the round mark on his sole.
 “Now I recognise the sign.”
 Vimla said, “The signs were there before too. Hurry had simply shut your eyes.”
 Sita said, “In a hurry, people mistake even their own things for someone else’s, and someone else’s for their own.”
 Kaushalya sat down on the platform.
 “First look for my red-edged pair. I hope those too have not gone off on pilgrimage somewhere.”
 Everyone laughed again.
 Kaushalya’s slippers were safe beneath the bench.
 She put them on and was greatly pleased.
 Just then the rain came down hard again.
 Both families were trapped beneath the temple’s outer tin awning.
 The rain was so dense that the peepal tree ahead looked blurred.
 Nandkishore shifted his family to one side.
 Rambilas too gathered his people a little closer.
 Pintu and Sonu stood in the middle.
 The two boys kept looking at each other’s feet.
 Sonu asked, “Are your babu’s slippers all right now?”

Pintu said, "Yes. But he walked straighter in someone else's."

Nandkishore heard him.

"Pintu!"

Everyone laughed again.

There was no sign of the rain stopping.

Kaushalya took a dry gamchha from her bag and laid it over her head.

Vimla asked, "Where are you all going?"

Sita said, "To the bus stop. We have to catch the bus towards Parasauni."

Nandkishore looked surprised.

"Parasauni? We too are going that way. My sister lives in Kharihani."

Rambilas said, "Then half our road is the same."

Gudiya asked, "Will we get the bus from here?"

Rambilas shook his head.

"Not today. They are filling the potholes on the road. The buses are being diverted past the old grain warehouse."

Nandkishore stopped short.

"I had no idea."

Vimla looked at him.

"If you had not put on someone else's slippers, we would have been standing at the old bus stop."

Nandkishore said, "So the slipper mistake was not a mistake, but information?"

Rambilas laughed.

"Do not give the slippers that much importance. They will become proud."

The rain thinned a little.

The two families set off together towards the grain warehouse.

Now Nandkishore kept glancing down at his feet from time to time.

Rambilas asked, "Still suspicious?"

"No. Now owner and slippers have both recognised each other."

At one point on the road there was a narrow bamboo footbridge over a drain.

Kaushalya walked slowly.

Vimla took her by the arm.

Sita carried Gudiya's bag.

Pintu and Sonu went ahead, searching for dry bricks in the mud to step on.

When they reached the warehouse, two buses were standing there.

One was bound for Kharihani, the other for Parasauni.

That was where the paths of the two families had to separate.

Kaushalya asked Vimla, "Tell me your name once more."

"Vimla."

"I am Kaushalya."

"I will not forget that name now."

Kaushalya looked down at her slippers.

"I may forget slippers, but not a name."

Sita and Vimla repeated the names of their villages to each other.

The Tuesday market lay between the two villages.

"We shall keep meeting at the market," Sita said.

Nandkishore shook hands with Rambilas.

"Next time there will be no need to exchange slippers."

Rambilas said, "First make the identifying mark bigger."

The bus whistle sounded.

The two families climbed into separate buses.

From the window Pintu waved to Sonu.

Sonu lifted one of his slippers and waved it in the air.

Rambilas pulled his hand down.

"Put it on your foot. Otherwise we shall have to go looking for another family."

A month later came the Tuesday market.

Nandkishore had come with his family to buy vegetables.

Gudiya suddenly spotted Sonu on the other side of the road.

"There is the slipper boy!" she shouted with a laugh.

Sonu ran over.

Rambilas and Sita came behind him.

Nandkishore held out one of his slippers to show them.

This time, beside the blue thread, a little knot of red thread had also been tied.

Rambilas showed his slippers too.

Above the round mark was a knot of green thread.

Vimla asked, "Why green?"

Sita replied, "So that next time they do not reach your house."

Kaushalya, who had come with them to the market, said softly, "And if they did reach it once, what harm came of it?"

For a moment everyone fell silent.

Then they all burst out laughing.

That day the two families went around the market together.

No one's slippers were exchanged.

At dusk, as they prepared to return home, Nandkishore put on his slippers marked with the red knot.

Rambilas put on his pair marked with the green knot.

The two pairs were different.

But this time their owners knew one another by name.

STORY 122

The Richest Man in the House

On an Ashadh Monday morning, Jagdish Jha sat on his verandah stitching the torn binding of a book.

His house stood two lanes in from the main road, yet it was only a ten-minute walk from the bus stand.

For that reason, many people coming to town from the villages knew the way to his house.

Jagdish did not earn much.

He stitched and rebound old books, panjis, and account ledgers.

When work came, the day went well; when it did not, the needle and thread lay silent on the table in the verandah.

His wife Malti ran the household with careful measuring and counting.

There were two rooms, a small kitchen, and a narrow verandah in front.

The house had four brass plates, yet some nights eight people ate there.

It was Malti, not Jagdish, who understood that arithmetic.

That morning, before leaving for school, Muniya came with a question.

“Babu, who is the richest person in our neighbourhood?”

Jagdish had the needle clenched between his teeth.

“Why are you asking?”

From the kitchen Malti called, “If it is wealth you need for an essay, look outside. You will not find it in this house.”

Muniya burst out laughing.

She had first thought of Ramautar Sahu.

Ramautar had a two-storeyed house, a grain warehouse, and a gleaming motorcar in the courtyard.

Jagdish said, “Then you have your name. Now write.”

Muniya sat down on the verandah.

She wrote the first line: “The richest person in our neighbourhood is Ramautar Sahu.”

Just then there was a call at the gate.

“Is Jagdish Babu at home?”

A thin young man stood there with a bag on his shoulder.

Jagdish went out.

The young man said his name was Ravindra.

He came from the village of one of Jagdish's distant maternal cousins.

His clerical examination was the next day, and there would be no bus back until evening.

The cousin had told him, "Ask for Jagdish's house. You will find a place to spend the night."

Jagdish scratched his head.

Malti had been listening from the verandah.

She called, "First put your bag inside. If the exam is tomorrow, why are you talking about going back tonight?"

Ravindra said awkwardly, "It will trouble you."

Malti replied, "We will calculate the trouble tonight. For now, wash your hands and face."

Muniya looked at her essay.

Then she wrote the second line: "Ramautar Sahu's house is very large."

By midday, Ravindra had explained two mathematics problems to Muniya.

Malti would not let him cut vegetables, but when it was time to fetch water, she told him to take hold of a bucket.

There was a rule in the house.

Whoever stayed the night took on one household task according to their ability.

Someone fetched water, someone taught the child, someone brought salt from the market.

Malti used to say, "Be a guest, not a statue."

Jagdish laughed at this rule, but never objected to it.

After midday, the gate rattled again.

This time there was a woman of about fifty-five and her nephew.

The woman was named Janki Devi.

She had come to the district hospital to have her eyes examined.

The examination was to be the next morning.

The nephew who had accompanied her wanted to return to the village at dawn because cattle were tethered at home.

The question arose of where Janki Devi would stay.

Ravindra immediately began rolling up his mat.

"I will sleep on the verandah."

Malti stopped him.

"No one's name has been written on the mat yet."

Janki Devi said, "I can sleep on the floor as well."

Jagdish said, "This house has no shortage of floor. Only level floor is in short supply."

Everyone laughed at once.

In one corner of the verandah, two old cane mats were rolled up.

The edge of one was tied with red thread.

The other had two knots of yellow thread in the middle.

Those threads had been left by different guests.

Someone had seen the edge fraying and tied it; someone else had seen a cane strip coming loose in the middle and repaired it.

Malti used to say, "Even our mats are known to people."

Muniya wanted to write a third line, but stopped.

She could not remember any mat in Ramautar Sahu's house.

Before evening, clouds gathered.

Three books on Jagdish's worktable were still unfinished.

He was sharpening his needle when two boys from the lane came running.

"Kaka, the bus stand is flooded."

"What has that got to do with me?"

"Two people are asking for your house."

Jagdish narrowed his eyes.

"Who put a signboard for my house at the bus stand?"

The boys ran off laughing.

A little later, an old man and a teenager arrived.

The old man did not know Jagdish.

He knew only the name of Shambhu Master of Pipra village.

Two years earlier, Shambhu Master had spent one night at Jagdish's house.

He had told them, "If you miss the bus, go to Jagdish's house."

Jagdish looked at Malti.

Malti looked at the old man's wet dhoti.

"Come inside first."

Jagdish whispered, "Today's accounts?"

Malti whispered back, "There is less rice in the accounts, not fewer people."

The question of dinner now truly became a large one.

There was about one and a half pav of rice in the house.

There was one bowl of lentils.

For vegetables, only two potatoes and one ridge gourd remained.

Ravindra took half a pav of flattened rice from his bag.

"Mother had packed it for the road."

Before leaving, Janki Devi's nephew had left behind a small packet of jaggery.

The old man's bag held roasted gram.

Malti placed everything on the verandah.

"Now count the wealth of this house."

Jagdish said, "One and a half pav of rice, half a pav of flattened rice, one packet of jaggery, and a handful of gram."

Malti said, "And seven pairs of hands."

Ravindra laughed.

Janki Devi began cutting the ridge gourd.

The old man cleaned the gram.

The boy went to find dry twigs for the stove.
 Jagdish went to fetch water.
 Muniya began washing the plates.
 Four plates were too few for seven people.
 Malti made two leaf plates.
 Ravindra said, "I will eat from a bowl."
 Jagdish said, "A candidate must have a plate, or his letters will come out round."

Laughing, Ravindra stopped insisting on giving up his plate.
 In the end, the rice was thin and the dal was thin too, but the verandah remained full.

From time to time, the clouds sounded over the roof.
 After dinner, the arithmetic of sleeping began.
 There were two mats, one low cot, one bedstead, and half a dry verandah.
 Janki Devi slept on the low cot.
 The old man on the bedstead.
 Ravindra and the boy on the mats.
 Muniya went inside with her mother.
 Jagdish stood on the verandah holding his pillow.
 Malti asked, "Where is your place?"
 Jagdish said, "I am a rich man. I will buy myself a place in my own house."
 Ravindra immediately started to rise.
 "Shall I move?"
 "No, you have an examination. I will sleep beside the binding table."
 Malti glared at him.
 "There is glue on the worktable. In the morning we will find a book stuck to your head."

In the end, Jagdish and the boy lay crosswise and crooked on a single mat in the dry part of the verandah.

At midnight, one of Jagdish's feet slipped out.
 Two drops of rain fell on his heel.
 He drew his foot back in.
 Half asleep, the boy said, "Kaka, do not come into my share."
 Jagdish laughed quietly.
 Janki Devi was the first to rise in the morning.
 She sat by the stove and heated water for Malti.
 The old man noticed a loose latch on the broken window.
 He took a small tool from his bag and tightened it.
 Ravindra looked at Muniya's essay.
 "Only three lines?"
 Muniya said, "It is difficult to write about rich people."
 Ravindra handed the paper back.

"Write what you have seen."

Muniya said nothing.

She folded the paper and put it in her schoolbag.

Ravindra left for his examination.

Janki Devi went towards the hospital.

The old man and the boy set off for the bus stand.

All at once the house felt empty.

Sweeping the verandah, Jagdish said, "See? Air is entering my house again."

Malti said, "Until ten o'clock."

Jagdish stopped.

"Who is coming at ten?"

"Your cousin's husband sent word yesterday."

Jagdish put a hand to his head.

"Muniya, change the essay. Write about the poorest owner of this house."

Laughing, Muniya left for school.

That day in language class, the teacher asked them to read their essays.

Muniya opened the first sheet.

The three lines naming Ramautar Sahu seemed pale to her.

She turned the paper over.

On the back was the new essay she had written during the night.

Its title was: "The Richest Man in Our House."

The teacher raised his eyebrows.

Muniya began to read.

"My father, Jagdish Jha, earns little."

Two children in the class laughed.

Muniya went on reading.

"There are four plates in his house, but the number of people who will eat is never fixed in advance."

"There are two mats, but threads from many villages are tied to them."

"A guest who comes here does not only eat."

"Someone fetches water, someone tightens a latch, someone teaches the child."

"Some nights Babu has to search for a place to sleep in his own house."

The classroom was silent now.

Muniya read the final line.

"I think that when so many people come and go through a house, its wealth must be counted in a different way."

For a few moments, the teacher looked at the paper.

Then he asked, "Has your father read this?"

"Not yet."

"Let him read it."

In the evening, Muniya placed the paper in Jagdish's hand.

Jagdish read the entire essay.

"I am this 'richest man'?"

Muniya nodded.

Jagdish looked at Malti.

"Did you hear that? I have become rich now."

Setting a pot on the stove, Malti said, "Then tomorrow bring two pav of rice from the market out of your wealth."

Jagdish folded the paper and handed it back to Muniya.

"There is one error."

Muniya became alert.

"Where?"

"Not four plates. Janki Devi's nephew cracked one while washing it."

From inside, Malti called, "He did not crack it. It was cracked already."

Jagdish smiled.

"Look, a dispute over my property has already begun."

Just then the gate rattled.

Jagdish, Malti, and Muniya looked at one another.

A voice came from outside, "Is this Jagdish Babu's house?"

Jagdish asked softly, "Do you need to spend the night, or only drink some water?"

The man outside laughed.

"I missed the bus."

Malti lifted the lid of the pot and looked at the quantity of rice.

Then she said to Muniya, "Consider your essay not yet submitted."

Jagdish went to open the gate.

The mat with the red thread was unrolled once again on the verandah.

STORY 123

Savings of Laughter

One evening in Bhadon, Ramlochan Mishra sat before his old wooden trunk.

The lid leaned crookedly to one side, but the lock still worked.

His wife, Surji, was sorting mung beans in the courtyard.

Their granddaughter Sarita came to the doorway carrying her books and exercise books.

She was in Class Eight.

“Grandfather, may I ask you something?”

Turning the key in the lock, Ramlochan said, “If the question is short, ask it. The answer will be long.”

Sarita laughed.

“Teacher has asked us to write an essay on the savings in our household.”

Surji stopped sorting the mung beans.

“Savings in our house?”

“Yes. What Grandfather and Grandmother have saved, where they keep it, and why they save.”

Ramlochan opened the trunk.

Sarita leaned forward eagerly.

Inside were clothes, old receipts, two brass keys, a torn umbrella, and a thick ledger.

Sarita’s eyes settled on the ledger.

“Is that from the co-operative branch?”

Ramlochan said, “Not the co-operative branch’s. The household’s.”

Sarita lifted it out.

On the cover, in faded ink, was written: “Expenses.”

She slowly turned the next page.

There were accounts from many years ago.

Rice, salt, oil, medicine, roofing, farming, marriage, travel.

In many places Surji’s handwriting had added a little sentence after the amount.

Sarita read: “The roof leaked again - rain, an uninvited guest.”

She laughed.

On another page it said: “New spectacles - the old eyes still free of charge.”

On a third: “Cot repaired - Ramlochan’s snoring puts too much weight on it.”

Sarita laughed harder.

"Is this an expense ledger or a book of jokes?"

Surji said, "We wrote down the expenses and lightened the heart along with them."

Ramlochan adjusted his spectacles.

"The money was spent; the sentences survived."

Sarita opened her exercise book.

"Then how much money did you two save?"

The courtyard fell silent for a moment.

Ramlochan looked at Surji.

Surji resumed sorting the beans.

"Money?"

"Yes. That's all I need."

Ramlochan said softly, "Not much."

Sarita asked again, "How much?"

A smile came to Ramlochan's lips.

"The money did not remain, but there is plenty of laughter saved up."

Sarita's pen stopped.

"Will Teacher accept that answer?"

Surji said, "Make Teacher laugh first. Then he will accept it."

Instead of writing the opening line of her essay, Sarita began turning the ledger again.

One page recorded hospital expenses.

The amount was written in large figures.

Beside it Surji had written: "Ramlochan ate khichdi for three days and called it a royal feast."

Ramlochan objected.

"I didn't call it a royal feast. I called it a feast fit for a maharaja."

Surji said, "And after taking the medicine you pulled a face for half an hour."

Laughing, Sarita put her finger on the page.

"Who used to write all these things?"

"Whoever picked up the pen first."

"And when you quarrelled?"

Surji tossed aside a hard bit from the mung beans.

"The expense of a quarrel wasn't entered separately."

Ramlochan said, "But its interest is high."

Just then a bicycle bell rang in the lane.

Naresh, a young man from the co-operative savings group, arrived on his bicycle.

He went from neighbourhood to neighbourhood explaining the new savings accounts to elderly people.

Stopping at the gate, he asked, "Is Ramlochan Kaka at home?"

Ramlochan said, "I am at home. My wealth is out wandering."

Naresh laughed and came inside.

He took several printed sheets from his bag.

"Kaka, there is no minimum deposit requirement now. An account can be opened even with a very small amount."

Ramlochan took the paper.

"My small amount is so small that you would need a magnifying glass to find it."

Surji said from the side, "Have tea first. Then listen to his tale of poverty."

Naresh sat down on the low wooden seat.

Sarita asked at once, "Bhaiya, does saving mean only money?"

Naresh glanced at her exercise book.

"In an account, yes - money."

Ramlochan said, "At home, many other things too."

Naresh smiled.

"The branch doesn't pay interest on those."

Going toward the hearth, Surji said, "At home, laughter pays its own interest."

Naresh looked at Sarita.

"Put that in your essay."

Ramlochan said, "Teacher will strike my name out as well."

While the tea was being made, Naresh continued explaining how to open the account.

Identity proof, nominee details, small deposits, withdrawals.

Ramlochan listened attentively.

Surji asked questions from time to time.

"What if only ten rupees remain at the end of a month?"

"You can deposit even that."

"Five?"

"Five too."

"One?"

Naresh laughed.

"The day I turn up at the branch with one rupee, they will throw me out."

Ramlochan said at once, "There, you see? The entry limit for the poor begins at one rupee."

The veranda filled with laughter.

Then Naresh grew serious again.

"Kaka, jokes apart, it is good to keep a little money aside for medicines or an emergency."

Ramlochan nodded.

"There is sense in that."

Surji set down the tea and said, "He doesn't laugh so quickly when something is sensible."

Naresh asked, "Did you save earlier?"

Ramlochan looked toward the old ledger.

"We did."

He showed him the hospital page.

"It went that year."

Then the page for their daughter's wedding.

"That year too."

Then the page for replacing the roof.

"That year as well."

Naresh fell silent.

Ramlochan closed the ledger.

"Savings were made, then spent; made again, then spent again. In life's ledger, the balance does not remain in the same place forever."

Surji said, "But this time something can be begun again."

Ramlochan looked at her.

"You will begin it?"

"I have a plan."

"That word frightens me as soon as I hear it."

From a corner of the courtyard Surji brought a small brass tin.

It had once held spices.

A yellow turmeric stain still marked the lid.

"From now on, on any day you come back from the market without drinking unnecessary tea, two rupees go into this."

Ramlochan protested.

"Who said tea is unnecessary?"

"On the days you come home and ask for tea again, the tea you had in the market was unnecessary."

Naresh could not hold back his laughter.

Ramlochan said, "And your savings?"

Surji answered at once, "On any day I do not eat an unnecessary piece of jaggery, two rupees."

Ramlochan raised his eyebrows.

"Jaggery is never unnecessary."

"Then the savings scheme is cancelled."

The two looked at each other.

Sarita broke in, "Make one rule: whoever calls the other's thing 'unnecessary' must deposit one rupee."

For a moment there was silence.

Then all three adults burst out laughing together.

Naresh said, "That account will fill quickly."

The account-opening form was filled in that very day.

Ramlochan named Surji as his nominee.

Naresh asked, "Kaki, whose name will you put on your account?"

Surji looked at Ramlochan.

"This man's - if he improves before I do."

Ramlochan asked, "Can a condition be written into the nomination?"

Naresh laughed again.

Sarita wrote something in her exercise book.

Three days later Ramlochan and Surji went to the co-operative branch.

Their first deposit was twenty-five rupees.

Naresh entered it in the passbook.

Ramlochan looked at the figure.

"So little?"

Surji said, "The first letter is small too; the book comes later."

This time Ramlochan did not joke.

He placed the passbook carefully in the trunk.

The brass tin remained in a corner of the kitchen.

In one week eleven rupees gathered in it.

Seven rupees were penalties for Ramlochan's use of the word "unnecessary."

Four rupees came from the two pieces of jaggery Surji had managed not to eat.

Hearing the account, Ramlochan said, "The tax on me is higher."

Surji replied, "Your income is higher - income from talking."

When Sarita returned from school, she would shake the tin.

She liked the sound of the coins.

She also kept reading the old expense ledger.

One day she found a very old page.

The date was from almost thirty years earlier.

It said: "First savings: twenty-two rupees."

Beside it, in Ramlochan's handwriting: "Surji said the world won't change with this much."

Under that, in Surji's handwriting: "Ramlochan said, not the world - the habit will change."

Sarita ran to them with the page.

"You said exactly the same thing before!"

Ramlochan looked at the page.

"Was I really that wise?"

Surji said, "You were, but we could not keep the savings going."

Ramlochan was silent for a while.

Then he said, "This time we shall see whether the wisdom lasts."

The month ended.

The brass tin held sixty-seven rupees.

Surji counted the money.

Ramlochan counted it twice more.

"Sixty-seven?"

"Yes. That's all."

"I thought we had saved more laughter than that."

Surji said, "We would need a bigger tin to count that."

Sarita finished her essay.

She gave it the title: "My Grandparents' Savings."

In the first part she wrote about the co-operative account and the brass tin.

In the second she wrote about the sentences in the margins of the old expense ledger.

Her final line was: "They have begun saving money again, but the laughter had already been saved."

The next day Teacher read the essay and asked, "Is this really what happens in your house, or is it a made-up story?"

Sarita replied, "It happens in our house."

"Then tell your grandparents to keep saving."

That evening Sarita delivered the message.

With a serious face Ramlochan asked, "Does Teacher work for the co-operative branch?"

Surji burst out laughing.

Then she opened the brass tin and dropped two rupees inside.

Ramlochan asked, "Whose penalty is that?"

"I just laughed unnecessarily."

Ramlochan immediately dropped in another two rupees.

"My share too."

Sarita said, "There was no penalty in the rule for laughing."

Ramlochan closed the lid of the tin.

"The rule has changed."

Surji said, "No. This is a voluntary deposit."

Ramlochan placed the old expense ledger and the new savings passbook together in the same trunk.

The brass tin found a place between them.

Closing the lid, he said, "Now the accounts are clear."

Sarita asked, "How much have you saved?"

Ramlochan looked at Surji.

There was laughter in the corners of Surji's eyes.

She said, "For the amount of money, look in the passbook."

Ramlochan added, "No machine has yet been invented to count the rest of the savings."

The trunk closed, and all three laughed again in the courtyard.

STORY 124

The Key

On an Aghan morning, the sunlight had not yet reached the courtyard.

Madhav Jha had gathered his old iron trunk, two sacks of books and a bamboo cot near the doorway.

Today he would leave this house.

Seven years earlier, when he had come here as a tenant, all he owned was one box, two changes of clothes and his appointment letter for the job.

Now his belongings had grown.

There was a wife.

There was a five-year-old daughter.

There were two photographs hanging on the wall.

And beneath the window stood an old wooden chest that was not his.

The chest had been in the room from the very beginning.

The wood was no longer black as if freshly polished; years of sun and rain had turned it a dull brown-grey.

Brass strips covered all four corners.

A broad lock hung in the middle.

There was a long scratch across the lid.

On his first day Madhav had asked, "Will this be moved?"

The landlord, Shashidhar Babu, had replied, "No. Let it stay."

"Is there anything inside?"

With a faint smile Shashidhar Babu had said, "Nothing of any use to you."

Madhav had not asked again.

Slowly the chest became one of the useful things in the room.

At first a lantern was kept on it.

Later, books and ledgers.

After his marriage, his wife Sumitra dried spices on it.

When their daughter was born, her little clothes were sometimes spread over it.

The chest remained shut.

Dust gathered on the lock.

Madhav kept the house keys with him.

They were on a round iron ring.

There were two keys on the ring.

One was thin and shiny.

The other was thick, brass-coloured and of an old-fashioned shape.

The thin key opened the outer door.

Madhav did not know what the thick key was for.

The first time he asked Shashidhar Babu, "The second key?"

Shashidhar Babu had said, "Let it remain on the ring."

"Which lock does it open?"

"Something old belonging to this house."

Madhav had laughed.

"Can old things be locked away too?"

Shashidhar Babu had answered, "Sometimes."

In seven years the heavy key had jingled in Madhav's palm many times.

He had never taken it off the ring.

Sometimes he thought it might belong to the old storeroom in the courtyard.

Sometimes he imagined it opened the locked room above the stairs.

One day even Meera, his daughter, had asked, "Babu, what is this big key for?"

Madhav had replied, "For whichever lock it finds."

For three days Meera searched the house for a lock.

Then she forgot about it.

Today was the day the ring had to be returned.

Outside, the bullock-cart driver was calling, "Babu, is the luggage ready?"

Madhav answered, "Half an hour."

Sumitra was sweeping inside.

She said, "Take out the peg from the wall."

"Does the peg belong to the house or to us?"

"You hammered it in."

"Then it is ours."

"Justice becomes very sharp when it is time to pull something out of a wall."

Madhav smiled.

The peg was removed.

A small hole remained in the wall.

He mixed a little mud and filled it.

Sumitra said, "Why clean it so carefully?"

"It was clean when I came."

"So?"

"If I am returning it, I should return it clean."

Sumitra said nothing.

She wiped the window frame as well.

The chest still stood beneath the window.

One of its legs was shorter than the others.

Two years earlier Madhav had cut a thin piece of neem wood and wedged it beneath the short leg.

One rainy night the roof had leaked.

Before covering his own books, Madhav had thrown a sack over the chest.

The next day Shashidhar Babu had seen it and asked, "Did your books get wet?"

"Two of them did."

"You should have saved them first."

Madhav had replied, "Books can be dried. This wood is old."

That day Shashidhar Babu had looked at the chest for a long time.

That was all.

For seven years the rent had been paid on time.

Twice it had been late.

Whenever that happened, Madhav had informed him beforehand.

Shashidhar Babu merely changed the date in his rent ledger.

There had never been a quarrel over accounts.

But they had argued plenty over the small matters of the house.

Where the tulsi platform in the courtyard should be extended.

Where clothes might be spread on the roof.

Why Meera had drawn a flower on the wall with charcoal.

For three days Shashidhar Babu had criticised that flower.

On the fourth day he drew a frame around it.

From then on Meera called him 'Picture-Baba'.

None of these things appeared in any ledger.

At nine in the morning Shashidhar Babu came into the courtyard.

He was carrying his rent ledger.

"Has everything been taken out?"

Madhav said, "Almost."

"What does 'almost' mean?"

"One peg was left. I have taken that out too."

Shashidhar Babu looked at the wall.

The hole had been filled.

"You will hand the house over cleaner than it was for the new tenant."

"That will benefit you."

"And the loss?"

"Mine. Leaving becomes difficult."

For a few moments neither of them spoke.

Then Madhav took the key ring from his waist.

Seven years of rubbing had polished the iron ring smooth.

He placed it in Shashidhar Babu's palm.

"Here."

Shashidhar Babu lifted the ring.

The two keys jingled.

He held up the thin, shiny one.

“This is for the door.”
 “Yes, for the door.”
 “And this?”
 He lifted the thick old key.
 Madhav laughed.
 “You never answered that mystery in seven years.”
 “Did you search for the answer for seven years?”
 “For the first week.”
 “And after that?”
 “Work increased.”
 “So the mystery lost?”
 “It lost to bread.”
 Shashidhar Babu laughed aloud.
 Then he slipped the thin key off the ring.
 He left the old thick key on it.
 He held the ring back towards Madhav.
 Madhav did not take it.
 “Why?”
 “It is yours.”
 “I have no lock for it.”
 “You do. You just have not seen it yet.”
 Shashidhar Babu went over to the window.
 He ran a hand over the old chest.
 A thin line of dust marked his palm.
 He said, “Lift it once.”
 Madhav did not understand.
 “Lift what?”
 “The chest.”
 “But it is yours.”
 “Until now.”
 Sumitra stopped sweeping.
 Meera came and stood at the doorway.
 Shashidhar Babu called to the bullock-cart driver.
 “Come here. This goes too.”
 Madhav immediately protested, “No, no. Not this.”
 “Why not take it?”
 “It belongs to the old house.”
 “Let it stay here.”
 “It has stayed seven years.”
 “My new house is small.”
 “The chest is not small, but it is useful.”
 “I cannot take a gift.”

Shashidhar Babu frowned.

“For seven years you kept books, spices, clothes and your child’s dolls on my chest. When one leg broke, you fitted a piece of wood under it. When the roof leaked, you covered it with a sack. And now you say you have no connection with it?”

Madhav had no answer.

Shashidhar Babu placed the heavy key in his palm.

“Try it.”

Madhav looked at the lock.

For the first time he noticed how old-fashioned its shape was.

The key was made in the same fashion.

He slowly inserted it into the keyhole.

It slid in on the first attempt.

Madhav’s hand stopped.

Meera whispered, “Babu!”

Madhav turned the key.

The lock gave a deep sound from within.

The old lid rose with a creak.

A mingled smell of old wood, dried neem leaves and cotton drifted out.

The chest was almost empty.

In one corner lay a folded piece of old white cloth.

In another were two thin strips of wood.

That was all that remained inside.

Disappointed, Meera asked, “Where is the treasure?”

Shashidhar Babu said, “Empty space is the greatest treasure. Fill it with whatever you like.”

Madhav looked at him.

“This key was with me from the very first day?”

“Yes. From the first day.”

“You never told me?”

“You asked. I put you off.”

“Why?”

Shashidhar Babu rested a hand on the lid.

“I wanted to see whether you would spend your time looking for the lock that matched the key, or whether you would settle into the house and make a home.”

Madhav’s eyebrows rose slightly.

“Was this a test?”

“No, not a test.”

Shashidhar Babu answered at once, “If it had been a test, I would have told you. It was only a foolish curiosity of mine.”

Sumitra laughed.

“At least you admit it.”

Shashidhar Babu laughed too.

“This chest belonged to my wife when she was alive. After she died, I locked it. Whatever was inside, my daughters divided among themselves. The chest remained.”

He patted the wooden lid.

“To me it was a memory. In your home it became a useful thing again.”

Madhav remained silent.

Shashidhar Babu said, “When a memory does nothing but gather dust, sometimes it needs a new home.”

The bullock-cart driver asked, “Shall I load it?”

Madhav looked at Shashidhar Babu.

“You truly want to give it to me?”

“The key is in your palm.”

This time Madhav closed his fist around the ring.

“Load it.”

Four men lifted the chest together.

The neem-wood wedge slipped out.

Shashidhar Babu bent and picked it up.

“Take this too.”

Madhav said, “But this piece of neem came from this house.”

“Now it is a leg of the chest.”

The wedge was placed inside the chest as well.

The lid was closed.

Madhav did not lock it.

Shashidhar Babu asked, “Why did you not turn the key?”

Madhav smiled.

“I will open it for the first time in the new house.”

“There is nothing inside now.”

“That is why.”

The bullock cart began to move.

Meera kept looking back and waving to ‘Picture-Baba’.

Shashidhar Babu stood by the courtyard gate.

The key jingled again at Madhav’s waist.

This time it was no useless old key.

By evening, after they reached the new house, the chest was placed beneath a window.

Sumitra asked, “What shall we put in it?”

Madhav said, “Nothing yet.”

Meera came carrying her drawing book.

“May I keep this in it?”

Madhav opened the lid.

“The first thing will be yours.”

Meera placed the book inside.

The neem-wood wedge lay beside it.

Sumitra folded the old white cloth and laid it over the drawing book.

Madhav put the key into the lock once more.

He thought for a moment.

Then he withdrew it and slipped it back onto the ring.

The lock remained open.

Sumitra asked, “Won’t you lock it?”

Madhav shook his head.

“It stayed locked for seven years. Let it remain open for a while now.”

Evening was settling beyond the window.

Inside the chest, the first drawing book lay quietly.

The key jingled once more at Madhav’s waist.

STORY 125

Ten Minutes

The clock at Darbhanga station showed ten fifty.

The train standing beside the platform was due to leave ten minutes later.

Avinash stood beside his tin trunk, looking towards the gate.

Small beads of sweat had appeared on his forehead, though the Aghan air was cold.

A cloth bag rested on top of the trunk.

Inside the bag were two pairs of clothes, a gamchha and an empty file.

A certificate that belonged in that file had still not arrived.

Guruji had told him, "I'll get it to you before the train leaves."

The certificate was needed for accommodation at the training centre.

In the school's old register, one digit of Avinash's date of birth had been entered incorrectly, and Guruji had spent until the previous evening getting it corrected.

Avinash had said, "I can come to the school myself in the morning."

Guruji had stopped him.

"You go to the station. I'll bring the certificate."

Avinash was still relying on that promise.

He looked at the clock again.

Nine minutes.

Just then, an elderly woman came up beside him, dragging a small metal-bound trunk.

The trunk was not large, but its iron bands made it heavy.

In her other hand she carried a small cloth bundle.

The knot of the bundle had loosened.

As she tried to set it beside the bench, the bundle slipped from her hand.

A brass lota rolled out and went towards the track.

Avinash ran and caught it.

"Mother, here you are."

Taking the lota, the old woman said, "Your feet are quick, son."

"The lota was quick."

The old woman laughed.

"What is your name?"

"Avinash."

"I am Kaushalya Devi."

She began tying the knot of her bundle again.

Avinash pushed her trunk beneath the bench.

Kaushalya said, "I could have done that."

"Two jobs can be done in the ten minutes before the train leaves."

"Not ten. Eight now."

Avinash looked at the clock again.

It really was eight minutes.

Kaushalya asked, "Is this your train?"

"Yes, this one."

"Mine too."

"How far are you going?"

"Beyond Laheriasarai. My daughter will get me off there."

Avinash told her his destination.

He was going to the training centre for the first time.

Kaushalya nodded.

"So your trunk is packed with your future?"

Avinash smiled.

"Only half of it, for now."

"Why half?"

"One certificate is still to come."

"Who is bringing it?"

"My Guruji."

Kaushalya looked towards the gate.

"I am waiting for someone too."

Avinash asked, "Who?"

"My son."

Kaushalya had left home early that morning.

Her son had said that he would first go to the dispensary to have a new dosage written for her medicine, then pack some food from home and reach the station.

Kaushalya had told him, "A train does not wait for anyone's mother or son."

Her son had replied, "I'll reach before the train does."

Now the station clock was putting that sentence to the test.

Both of them looked towards the gate once more.

No one.

Seven minutes.

From inside the train came the rising noise of passengers searching for seats.

A porter called out from a distance.

Avinash gripped the trunk to lift it.

At that moment one of its old clasps came loose.

The lid sprang half open.

Avinash pressed it shut at once.

"This too, now?" he muttered to himself.

Kaushalya said, "Let me see."

"It's nothing. I'll tie it with some cord."

"Do you have any?"

Avinash searched his bag.

He found nothing.

Kaushalya opened her bundle.

Inside it were a small medicine box, thread, a needle and two safety pins.

"I am going to my daughter's house, but I carry half the household in this bundle."

She took out a thick length of red thread.

Avinash kept the clasp pressed down.

Kaushalya wound the thread twice between the trunk's handle and the metal loop of the lock.

Then she secured the knot with a safety pin.

"Now try it."

Avinash shook the trunk.

The lid stayed shut.

"This is stronger than the clasp."

Kaushalya said, "The clasp was iron. The cleverness is in the thread."

Avinash laughed.

Six minutes.

Avinash asked, "What is your son bringing?"

"Medicine and a tiffin."

"You already have medicine here."

"That is the old one. A new dosage has been prescribed."

"And the food?"

"He said, 'Mother, don't eat the pakoras at the station.' If he doesn't come, then pakoras it will be."

Avinash said, "Guruji also told me, 'Don't board without the certificate.' What if he doesn't come?"

Kaushalya looked at him.

"What will you do then?"

"I'll board. If I miss the first day of training, the certificate can reach later."

"Quite right."

"And you?"

"I am not missing the train either. My son can run as far as the next station."

They both smiled again.

Five minutes remained.

The station bell rang.

More passengers began boarding the train.

Avinash lifted Kaushalya's trunk.

"You board first."

Kaushalya said, "And if your Guruji arrives?"

"I'll keep watching the gate."

"Your trunk?"

"It can stay here."

"What if someone else picks it up?"

Avinash thought for a moment.

Kaushalya said, "I'll sit beside my trunk. Leave yours with me too."

"You should board."

"If my son comes, he'll look for me here."

Because each had someone to wait for, both remained standing on the platform.

Four minutes.

A child was leaning his head out of a train window.

Kaushalya called to him, "Put your head inside. Dust will get in your eyes."

The child withdrew at once.

Avinash asked, "Do you order everyone around like that?"

"Anyone who listens."

"My Guruji is the same."

"Then your Guruji is all right."

Avinash smiled.

Three minutes.

Two people came running in through the gate.

One was a young man; the other, a vendor carrying a bundle of paan.

Avinash stepped slightly forward.

Neither of them was his Guruji.

Kaushalya too shook her head.

"Not my son either."

The engine driver's whistle sounded in the distance.

Avinash's face grew a little tense.

He placed the cloth bag on top of the trunk.

"I'll board when two minutes remain."

Kaushalya said, "Wait until one minute remains."

"Why?"

"Give the person you are waiting for his full chance."

Avinash looked at the clock.

Two minutes.

"Do you trust your son that much?"

"He is often late, but he does not abandon what he has promised."

Avinash laughed.

"My Guruji is the same."

Kaushalya smiled and asked, "He is late, and you still trust him?"

Avinash said, "Because when he comes, he never leaves a job half done."

"My son is the same."

"Then both of them suffer from the disease of running."

"And we suffer from waiting."

Their laughter rose together once more.

Kaushalya looked at him.

"What is your Guruji's name?"

Avinash was just about to answer.

Then a voice came from outside the gate: "Mother!"

Kaushalya's face lit up.

"He's here!"

A middle-aged man was running towards them with two containers tucked under one arm and a white envelope in his hand.

One end of his dhoti had been hitched up to his knee.

He reached Kaushalya, trying to catch his breath.

"Mother, I'm late."

Kaushalya said, "The clock told me that already."

The man handed her the medicine box.

Then he held out the tiffin.

"Eat on the way."

At that moment his eyes fell on Avinash.

"Why, Avinash!"

Avinash froze.

"Guruji!"

Kaushalya looked at Avinash.

Then at her son.

Then she burst out laughing.

"This is your Guruji?"

Avinash said, "Yes, he is."

The man looked equally surprised.

"You two know each other?"

Kaushalya pointed towards her trunk.

"Your student lifted my trunk."

Avinash showed him the red thread around his own trunk.

"And your mother tied up mine."

Guruji laughed loudly.

"I was late, and you two divided the work between yourselves before I got here."

One minute.

Guruji handed the white envelope to Avinash.

"Your certificate. Don't let it get wet."

Kaushalya said at once, "Put it in my bundle. There is medicine in there, not water."

Avinash placed the envelope inside her bundle.

Guruji lifted his mother's trunk.

Avinash picked up his own.

They both ran towards the same carriage door.

Guruji helped his mother aboard first.

Then he pushed Avinash's trunk inside.

The whistle blew.

The train began to move slowly.

Running beside the window, Guruji called, "Avinash, look after my mother!"

Kaushalya answered at once, "Let your student look after his trunk. I'll look after him."

Avinash called from the window, "Guruji, the certificate is in your mother's bundle now."

Guruji slapped a hand to his forehead.

"Then both of you look after each other!"

The train gathered speed.

The gate fell behind.

Kaushalya kept waving from the window.

Avinash checked the red thread around his trunk once more.

"Mother, will this knot last all the way to the training centre?"

Kaushalya said, "The knot will last. You open it at the right time."

"And the certificate?"

"Safe in my bundle."

She opened the tiffin.

Inside were two rotis, potato curry and a piece of jaggery.

"Did your Guruji tell me I should eat alone?"

Avinash laughed.

"No, not like that."

"Then half is yours."

"I have chura with me."

"Then I'll have the chura, and you have the roti."

Ten minutes earlier, the two of them had not even known each other's names.

Now one person's certificate was in the other's bundle, and the other's food lay open before the first.

Outside the train window, the fields seemed to run backwards.

Kaushalya said, "Your Guruji is late."

Avinash replied, "But he does not abandon what he has promised."

They both laughed together.

STORY 126

The Last Customer

Jayaram the barber was giving the shop its final sweep of the evening.

He had already lowered the shutter halfway.

Outside, the sounds of the market had thinned.

The brass bowl before the mirror lay upside down to dry.

He washed the razor and wiped it with a cloth.

A white stain of the day's shaving lather remained on the arm of the chair.

He rubbed that off with his finger too.

He was in a hurry to reach home.

His wife Kamala had told him that their younger son Niranjan's fever had risen again today.

But even when closing the shop he never hurried.

Forty years ago, his father had placed the first chair in this shop.

The chair had changed.

The mirror had changed.

The tin roof had changed.

But his father's old wooden comb still hung on the wall.

Jayaram reached out to lower the shutter completely.

Just then a voice came from outside—"Barber, could you give me a shave?"

Jayaram stopped.

Under the shutter he could see a pair of feet coated in dust and mud.

He raised the shutter again.

A lean, thin man stood outside.

The armpits of his kurta were damp.

The legs of his pyjama were dark with mud.

A small cloth bag was tucked under his arm.

His beard had grown for four or five days.

The man asked, "Am I very late?"

Jayaram looked at the clock.

"It is late, but a beard does not ask the time. Sit down."

The man came in.

Before sitting in the chair, he set the bag down.

Then he felt his pockets.

First the right.

Then the left.

Then the upper pocket of his kurta.

His face fell a little.

"May I tell you something?"

Jayaram unfolded the towel. "Tell me."

"I have no money with me just now."

Jayaram's hand paused for a moment.

The man hurried on, "Either my wallet fell out of the bag on the way, or I left it in my room at the inn. I cannot tell."

Jayaram said nothing.

The man began to rise.

"Then leave it. I'll see tomorrow."

Jayaram laid the towel over his shoulders.

"Stay seated."

"But the money—"

"I am shaving a beard, not settling accounts."

The man looked at him uncertainly.

Jayaram began working up the lather.

"Will you tell me your name?"

"Shashikant."

"Your native village?"

"For now, the inn. My home is toward Supaul."

"Work?"

Shashikant smiled a little.

"I look at papers."

Jayaram smiled too.

"Then you do harder work than I do. I look at beards, not papers."

As he applied the lather, he asked, "Are you new to the market?"

"Yes. I'll be here until tomorrow."

"Then stop worrying about repaying me. Who knows when we will meet again?"

Shashikant met his eyes in the mirror.

"That is precisely why I am worried."

Jayaram drew the razor.

"Does worrying fill a pocket?"

"Not even by one coin."

"Then keep your cheek still."

Both laughed.

Outside the shop, the tea seller was packing up his earthen cups.

Two bicycles went past on the road.

Jayaram cleared the first side of the beard.

Shashikant asked, "The shop looks old."

"From my father's time."

"Is it yours?"

Jayaram went quiet for a moment while rinsing the razor in water.

"The walls are mine. Half the land is mine; the other half rests on a loan."

Shashikant watched him in the mirror.

Jayaram changed the subject.

"Lift your chin."

But Shashikant asked, "Has the loan become heavy?"

Jayaram's brow tightened slightly.

"Do you examine papers, or people's heads too?"

"I have a habit of asking questions."

"Then I do not shave the beard of questions."

Again a smile came to both faces.

Jayaram cleared the lather under his chin.

Then, in a very casual voice, he said, "During Kamala's treatment I fell three instalments behind. The bank has sent a notice. If the account is not brought in order by the day after tomorrow, my share of the shop will go into the mortgage file."

Shashikant was silent for a while.

"Did you go to the bank?"

"I did."

"What did they say?"

"One file needs proof of the treatment, another an account of income, and a third the old deposit receipts. I have gathered everything. But the man handling my file said the decision would come from above."

"Do you keep all the papers together?"

"I'll take them again tomorrow."

"Then keep the papers complete."

Jayaram laughed.

"Did you come here for a shave or a loan?"

"Both need an edge."

"For that line, the shave is no longer free. It will cost two rupees extra."

Shashikant laughed openly for the first time.

"I have zero. Add two to zero and?"

"You are the man who looks at papers. You tell me."

"Still zero."

"Then that is that."

Jayaram made a second pass with the razor.

He ran a hand over the cheek to check.

A small rough patch remained in one place.

He lathered it again.

Shashikant said, "Since I have no money, you may make one pass less."

Jayaram turned serious.

"Should a beard be only half well done because there is less money?"

“That argument will not do.”

“Then be quiet.”

He cleaned that small patch too.

Then he wrung out a cloth soaked in warm water and laid it over Shashikant’s cheeks.

Shashikant closed his eyes.

For a few moments the shop was silent.

Outside, the clink of the tea seller’s last earthen cups could still be heard.

Jayaram removed the cloth.

“Now look.”

Shashikant looked in the mirror.

“Completely clean.”

“The beard was mine, the face yours. Credit half and half.”

Shashikant stood.

He tucked the bag under his arm.

Then once more he felt his pocket, as though money might appear by miracle.

Nothing.

“Write down my name. Shashikant Jha.”

Jayaram moved toward the shutter.

“I do not keep debts by writing down names.”

“Then when shall I repay you?”

“When you get a chance to do some small thing like this for someone else, free of charge.”

Shashikant stopped.

“Is that how an account is closed?”

“In my shop it is.”

Shashikant bowed his head.

“I agree to that accounting.”

He stepped outside.

Jayaram lowered the shutter.

When he reached home, Kamala asked, “Why are you late?”

As Jayaram washed his hands, he said, “The last customer.”

“Did you get paid?”

“Not a single coin.”

Kamala looked at him.

“Then what did you get?”

“A beard.”

Kamala smiled.

“The bank will take the shop, and you will go on shaving people for free.”

Placing a damp cloth on his son's forehead, Jayaram said, "Whether the bank takes the shop or not, I'll know tomorrow. Today I came home after cleaning one face."

In the morning Jayaram tied up the file.

The prescription for treatment.

The old deposit receipts.

The little ledger of the shop's income.

The land papers.

He tied them all in a red cloth and went to the bank.

Five people were already sitting in the bank's veranda.

One about a loan instalment.

One about a farmer card.

One to ask about his deposited money.

Jayaram sat with the bundle in his lap.

The wall clock struck ten.

An employee came out and said, "Jayaram the barber?"

Jayaram stood.

"Yes, I am Jayaram."

"Come inside. The regional loan officer will see your file."

Jayaram's stomach tightened.

He thought, "The bigger the word 'regional,' the bigger the trouble."

He entered the room.

Three men sat behind the desk.

In the middle, wearing a white kurta, was a familiar face.

Clean-shaven.

Smooth-cheeked.

Shashikant.

Jayaram stopped in the doorway.

Shashikant too was silent for a moment.

Then, in a very ordinary voice, he said, "Now we shall look at the file. Yesterday we looked at the beard."

The branch manager sitting beside him looked back and forth between Jayaram and Shashikant.

"You two know each other?"

Shashikant replied, "We met for the first time yesterday evening. That acquaintance will give him no advantage in the decision. The file will be examined under the rules."

Jayaram's shoulders loosened slightly.

He opened the red cloth.

He placed the papers on the desk.

Shashikant began reading them one by one.

From time to time he asked the branch manager questions.

“Why was the period of interrupted payment due to medical treatment not recorded?”

The manager checked the register.

“An application had been received, but the supporting proof was marked incomplete.”

Jayaram immediately held out the prescription.

“I had submitted this then as well.”

Shashikant looked at the date on the paper.

“This bears the receipt stamp.”

The manager turned the file again.

One page was folded double and caught in the middle.

He opened it.

That very page recorded the period of treatment.

Shashikant said nothing.

He merely straightened the page and laid it on the desk.

Then he examined the income ledger.

“Three instalments are overdue, but before that twenty-four instalments were paid on time.”

The manager nodded.

“That is on record.”

“Can the rescheduling provision be applied?”

The manager opened a booklet of rules.

He read for some time.

“Yes, if the period of medical treatment is accepted as certified.”

Shashikant pointed to the page.

“The proof was in the file. It was merely trapped inside a folded page.”

Jayaram blurted out, “Then the shop—?”

Shashikant stopped him.

“The shop is not going anywhere for now. The instalments will be rescheduled. The first payment will be next month.”

Jayaram gripped the back of the chair.

His fingers were trembling.

The branch manager said, “You will have to sign the new repayment schedule.”

Jayaram nodded.

A few moments later he looked at Shashikant.

“Yesterday’s shave—”

Shashikant interrupted at once. “Yesterday you gave me a shave. Today the file saved itself.”

“But you found the page.”

“The page was in the file. I merely opened the fold.”

Jayaram’s eyes grew moist.

He tried to laugh.
 "Then what is the charge for opening a fold?"
 Shashikant laughed too.
 "Add two to zero."
 Jayaram laughed aloud.
 The employee at the side understood nothing, but smiled anyway.
 The signatures were completed.
 Jayaram received the new instalment schedule.
 He tied the file again in the red cloth.
 As he was leaving, Shashikant stopped him.
 "One thing."
 "Tell me. I'm listening carefully."
 "I found my wallet at the inn."
 "Good."
 Shashikant put a hand into his pocket to take out money.
 Jayaram immediately caught his wrist.
 "Yesterday's account is closed."
 "But I—"
 "You told me: when you get the chance, do a small thing for someone else for free."
 Shashikant nodded.
 "Did I do that today?"
 Jayaram looked at the file.
 Shashikant turned serious.
 "I did nothing for free today. I applied the rules."
 Jayaram thought for a moment.
 "Then the account is still outstanding."
 "Let it remain outstanding."
 "When will you settle it?"
 "When I find a task that is not written in the rules."
 The two of them stood in the veranda and laughed.
 That evening Jayaram kept his shop open.
 His father's old wooden comb still hung on the wall.
 He placed the new instalment schedule safely in the chest, not behind the mirror.
 As he was lowering the shutter, a young man came running up.
 "Barber, am I too late? Can I get a shave?"
 Jayaram looked at the clock.
 "It is late."
 The young man felt his pocket and said, "I'm short of money."
 Jayaram spread the towel over the chair.
 "Sit first. A beard does not ask the time."

STORY 127

The Broken Watch

On a monsoon evening, the clouds had descended so low over the market that even while daylight remained, the tin roofs seemed to lie under darkness.

Amresh reached Dinanath's little shop with Madhavi's old wristwatch tucked beneath his arm.

Behind the glass at the front of the shop hung five or seven watches.

The hands of some were moving.

Some had stopped.

The inner workings of others had been opened out and laid on pieces of cloth.

Dinanath, a thick magnifying lens fitted over one eye, was tightening a screw in a pocket watch.

Amresh sat down.

Without raising his head, Dinanath asked, "Whose time has gone wrong?"

Amresh placed the watch before him.

"This time, don't mend the time. Mend the watch."

Dinanath looked up.

"Are those two different things?"

"One learns that only after coming to your shop."

Dinanath laughed.

The watch was old.

A thin round case.

A slanting scratch across the glass.

The leather strap was frayed at the edge.

The hour hand stood a little beyond five.

The minute hand rested on the first small mark after three.

Five sixteen.

Amresh had seen that time many times.

Whenever Madhavi wore the watch, its hands remained there.

At first Amresh had assumed the watch was broken.

Two or three times he had even told Madhavi, "Have it repaired."

Each time Madhavi had smiled and turned the conversation elsewhere.

Yesterday the strap had finally torn through.

Taking off the watch and placing it in Amresh's palm, she had said, "If you go to the market, bring a strap for it."

Amresh had asked, "Only the strap?"

Madhavi had not replied.
 Amresh had taken that silence for permission.
 He had thought to himself: the strap would be replaced, the glass polished,
 the fault inside corrected, and the watch would run again.
 It would become a small gift.
 Dinanath turned the watch over.
 He ran a fingernail along the edge of the back cover.
 He held it to his ear.
 Then he tested the little winding crown.
 His eyebrows rose slightly.
 “Who told you this was broken?”
 Amresh said, “It doesn’t run.”
 “It doesn’t run, but it isn’t broken.”
 “What sort of reckoning is that?”
 Dinanath pointed to the crown.
 “It has been deliberately pulled out.”
 Amresh bent closer.
 With the point of a needle, Dinanath lifted a very fine blue thread from
 beneath the crown.
 “Look here. The thread has been wedged in so the crown cannot be pushed
 back in.”
 Amresh kept looking at the thread.
 It was so fine that an ordinary glance could scarcely have noticed it.
 “So the watch was stopped?”
 “Yes, deliberately.”
 “At exactly what time?”
 Dinanath looked at the hands.
 “Five sixteen.”
 The words slipped involuntarily from Amresh’s mouth: “Five sixteen...”
 Dinanath looked at him.
 “Does that time mean something to you?”
 Amresh did not answer.
 The first raindrop fell outside the shop.
 A single tap on the tin.
 Then another.
 Dinanath asked, “Shall I start it?”
 Amresh answered at once, “No.”
 A faint smile came into Dinanath’s eyes.
 “Then what shall I repair?”
 “Change the strap.”
 “The glass?”
 “Leave the scratch.”

“The dust?”

“Wipe it off.”

“The time?”

Looking at the watch, Amresh said, “Let it stay where it is.”

Dinanath asked nothing more.

He removed the old strap.

For the replacement, he set four straps before Amresh.

Black, dark brown, light brown, and bluish.

Amresh chose the dark brown one.

Madhavi’s old strap had been almost the same colour.

Dinanath said, “A new thing should not be so new that it hides the old story.”

Amresh looked at him.

“Do all of you become philosophers from repairing watches?”

“No. People leave their watches here, and with them they leave their stories.”

“You don’t know this story.”

“Which is why I did not push the crown back in.”

By then the rain had grown heavy.

Amresh wrapped the watch in cloth and set off for home.

All the way, five sixteen kept circling in his mind.

He tried to remember many dates.

Madhavi’s birthday.

His own birthday.

The first time they had met by the river.

The first time they had gone to a book fair together.

The first letter he had given her.

No event clearly joined itself to five sixteen.

Their love had not begun by looking at the hands of a clock.

They had studied at the same high school, but their conversations began later.

Amresh had once taken some old question papers to Madhavi’s younger brother.

Through that pretext, conversation grew.

Conversation became waiting.

Waiting became belonging.

Belonging became discomfort within their households.

Madhavi’s father, Raghunath Jha, bore no hostility towards Amresh.

But where his daughter was concerned, his mind was full of large calculations.

Amresh’s income was small.

His elderly mother lived at home.

His younger brother was still studying.

Raghunath Babu had said, "Affection is one matter. Running a household is another."

Madhavi would argue.

Amresh spoke little.

For many months he never went beyond the outer veranda of Raghunath Babu's house.

Whenever he had some reason to visit, he called from the gate.

Madhavi would come outside.

Sometimes Raghunath Babu himself sat in the veranda and exchanged a few words with him.

But the inner courtyard seemed another frontier altogether.

Where five sixteen belonged among all this, Amresh could not understand.

The next day, when Madhavi returned from school, Amresh gave her the watch with its new strap.

Madhavi looked first at the strap.

She touched the leather with her finger.

Then she looked at the hands.

Five sixteen.

Her eyes rested on Amresh.

"You didn't start it?"

Amresh said, "Dinanath Kaka told me the watch had never been broken."

Madhavi fell silent.

"There was blue thread under the crown."

A smile appeared on Madhavi's lips.

"Is the thread still there?"

"Yes, it is."

"Then it is all right."

Amresh asked, "Why five sixteen?"

Madhavi did not answer at once.

She fastened the watch around her wrist.

The new strap looked slightly out of place beside the old case, but not awkward.

She looked out of the window.

After yesterday's rain, the mango leaves were shining.

Madhavi asked, "Where is that old black umbrella of yours?"

Amresh laughed.

"Is the answer about the watch hidden in the umbrella?"

"A little."

"The umbrella is at home."

"Do you remember the day one of its ribs pushed out?"

Amresh thought.

Rain.

The black umbrella.

The tip of one rib had pierced through the cloth.

That day he had gone to Raghunath Babu's house to return a book.

The rain had shown no sign of stopping even by evening.

Amresh had made it from the gate to the veranda, yet even after closing the umbrella he was wet.

Raghunath Babu had been sitting in the veranda.

Madhavi had brought tea from inside.

Putting the book forward, Amresh had said, "I'll go now."

Looking outside, Raghunath Babu had said, "In this rain?"

"Home is not far."

"If distance is small, that does not mean fever is far away."

Amresh had remained standing.

Raghunath Babu had then looked towards the inner doorway.

There was a wooden peg on the wall.

He had said, "Why are you holding the umbrella outside? Come in. Hang it on that peg."

At the time, Amresh had taken the sentence as an ordinary one.

He had shaken the umbrella, stepped inside, and hung it on the peg.

For the first time.

He had crossed the threshold from the veranda into the house.

The umbrella hung on the peg.

Raghunath Babu had said to Madhavi, "Bring one more cup of tea. He isn't leaving yet."

At that moment Madhavi had looked at her wrist.

Amresh's memory slowly opened.

He asked, "That very day?"

Madhavi nodded.

"Five sixteen?"

"Yes. That very evening."

"But that was only about hanging an umbrella."

"For you."

"For you?"

Madhavi laughed softly.

"For me, it was the first time Babu did not look at you as though you were an outsider."

Amresh fell silent.

Madhavi continued, "It is not as if Babu said yes to the marriage that day."

"He said yes three months later."

"Yes. But that yes, three months later, had begun earlier—on that single peg."

Amresh looked at the watch on Madhavi's wrist.

"So you stopped the watch?"

"I went inside after setting down the tea. I pulled out the crown and broke a blue thread from my shawl to wedge beneath it."

"You never told anyone?"

"Whom would I have told?"

"You could have told me."

"You would have taken the watch to be repaired."

They both burst out laughing together.

Amresh said, "True."

"And today you did take it."

"But now I have learnt."

Madhavi ran a finger over the scratch on the glass.

"Why didn't you have the scratch removed?"

"Dinanath Kaka asked me about that too."

"And what did you tell him?"

"I told him to leave it."

Madhavi looked at Amresh.

"So much wisdom in a single day?"

"It is a watch-repairer's shop. Something or other is bound to get repaired."

Madhavi laughed again.

Two days later it rained again.

Amresh reached Raghunath Babu's house.

This time they were to discuss the date of the wedding.

He had tied a strip of cloth around the old rib of the black umbrella and secured it.

He opened the gate and went inside.

Raghunath Babu sat in the veranda looking through a panji.

Amresh folded the umbrella and began to put it in a corner.

Raghunath Babu looked up.

"Why there? The peg inside is empty."

Without saying anything, Amresh carried the umbrella inside.

Madhavi was standing on the osara.

The watch on her wrist still showed five sixteen.

The wall clock inside struck six two.

Raghunath Babu said, "Madhavi, make tea. Today the discussion will be a long one."

As she went inside, Madhavi looked once at the watch on her wrist.

This time she did not touch its crown.

STORY 128

The Box of Sweets

It was evening in Madhubani market.

Shailaja stood outside a sweet shop, looking through the glass at the boxes arranged within.

From behind her, Devkant said, "Let us take plain peda. It will taste good and cost less too."

Shailaja shook her head. "We are going to Nirmala's house for the first time on such happy news. Plain peda will taste good, but it will look ordinary."

"Do sweets go into the mouth or into the eyes?"

"Into both."

Devkant laughed.

The shopkeeper brought out a square box of saffron makhana paak.

It was wrapped in deep red paper, stamped with gold along the edges, with a small lotus motif in the centre.

Shailaja fell silent for a moment when she heard the price.

Devkant looked at her.

"That much?"

The shopkeeper said, "The makhana is from the new harvest, and the ghee is pure as well."

Shailaja opened her little purse.

She counted the money again.

Devkant said quietly, "We still have to pay for the bamboo for the roof this month."

"Yes, I remember the account."

"Then why buy something so expensive?"

"Last time, at her brother-in-law's wedding, Nirmala said right in front of me, 'The gifts Shailaja brings always show her taste.'"

Devkant raised an eyebrow. "Was that praise or a challenge?"

"Take it as both."

The box was bought.

There was no card on the red wrapping on which to write a name.

When they reached home, Shailaja's thirteen-year-old daughter Ira wrote on a small piece of paper, "For Nirmala Mami — Ira."

She was about to stick it on top.

Shailaja stopped her. "Not on top. It will make it look ordinary."

Ira fixed the slip inside the lid, along the edge, with a little glue.

“Now open it and see?”

“Now it looks good.”

The shop’s golden ribbon had come loose on the way.

Ira took purple thread from the sewing box at home and tied it around all four sides.

Devkant said, “Will the purple thread lower its prestige or raise it?”

Shailaja glared at him.

Ira laughed.

That night Shailaja and Devkant reached Nirmala’s house.

News had arrived of Nirmala’s son Aniruddh’s appointment to a job.

People were coming and going in the house.

Taking the box in her hands, Nirmala said, “Oh, what was the need for all this?”

Shailaja replied, “The occasion calls for it.”

Nirmala weighed the box lightly on her fingers.

She looked at the red paper, the golden print and the lotus motif.

“It is very beautiful.”

Shailaja said casually, “Nothing special.”

Devkant cleared his throat.

Ira suppressed a laugh.

On the way home Devkant said, “Nothing special?”

Shailaja said, “One does not announce the price of a gift aloud.”

“But one adds it up completely in one’s mind.”

“Please be quiet.”

The box was not opened at Nirmala’s house that night.

There was already plenty of food.

Aniruddh said, “We will open it tomorrow.”

His younger sister Rama held the box to her nose and sniffed.

“I can smell saffron.”

Nirmala laughed. “Do not eat sweets with your nose.”

“Just one piece?”

“There are guests here now.”

Bhuvaneshwar said, “And after the guests leave?”

Nirmala lifted the box and placed it on a cupboard inside. “We shall see then.”

Bhuvaneshwar glanced once at his wife.

He understood that some other calculation was hidden inside the words ‘we shall see’.

In the morning Nirmala remembered that she had to visit Sukumari Devi, the sister of her elder sister-in-law.

It was the muh-dekhai ceremony for Sukumari Devi’s granddaughter.

Nirmala's husband Bhuvaneshwar said, "We can buy something on the way."

Nirmala opened the purse for household expenses.

Two days earlier, a trip to town for Aniruddh's papers had cost a great deal.

The coming and going of people at home had also increased.

Nirmala tied the purse shut again.

Her eyes went to the red box lying in the corner.

Bhuvaneshwar understood the look.

"No, not that one."

Nirmala said, "What do you mean, not that one?"

"What you received last night should not be passed on the next morning."

"Am I throwing the sweets away?"

"No, but—"

"Should I go to Sukumari Didi's house empty-handed?"

Bhuvaneshwar fell silent.

Nirmala picked up the box.

She looked at the purple thread.

"This thread looks a little too domestic."

"Sweets are eaten at home."

"A gift is eaten first by the eyes."

At that sentence Bhuvaneshwar laughed. "Where did you hear that?"

Nirmala did not answer.

From an old trunk she took out silver-coloured paper.

She wrapped it over the red paper.

She did not remove the purple thread; she tied green thread over it.

Bhuvaneshwar said, "So, another layer over prestige."

"This is neatness."

"Did the name change?"

"Where is there a name?"

There was no name on the outside of the lid.

Nirmala was reassured.

When she reached Sukumari Devi's house, she offered the box with great respect.

"Didi, this is for the child."

Sukumari Devi said, "More sweets in my house! Two trays came only yesterday."

Nirmala laughed. "There are children in the house. They will finish them."

"I heard the news about your son. It is very good."

Nirmala filled with pride.

After a while she returned home.

Sukumari Devi put the box in a corner.

Running a finger over the silver paper, she said, "Look at the wrapping people use these days. There may be less sweet inside, but the paper is heavy."

Mihira laughed. "Nani, open it and see."

"You have already eaten sweets three times since yesterday."

"These will be different."

"Every box looks different to you children; inside, the sugar is the same."

At noon her granddaughter Mihira asked again, "Nani, shall we open it?"

Sukumari Devi said, "Not now. The guests have left so many sweets that they will not be finished for three days."

In the evening she remembered Shailaja.

Shailaja's son Nachiketa was to leave for town the following week.

Sukumari Devi thought, "The boy is leaving home; let him take something sweet with him."

The next morning she reached Shailaja's house.

Shailaja was sorting paddy in the courtyard.

"Mausi! So early?"

"I felt like seeing you."

Sukumari Devi held out the silver-coloured box. "Keep this for Nachiketa."

Shailaja immediately drew back her hands. "What was the need for all this?"

From the osara Devkant called out, "The occasion calls for it."

Shailaja looked at him.

Devkant turned his face away.

The box came into the house.

Ira placed it on the table.

"Ma, this box is rather heavy."

"There are sweets inside. Of course it will be heavy."

Ira lifted one corner of the silver paper.

Red paper showed underneath.

"Ma."

"What did you see?"

"It is red underneath."

"There are many red boxes."

Ira untied the green thread.

She removed the silver paper.

On the red paper was a golden lotus.

Shailaja stopped sorting the paddy and stood up.

She remembered the price from that first evening—the box bought by postponing the bamboo for the roof, the red paper, the golden lotus, and Ira's purple thread.

For a moment she felt like wrapping the silver paper around it again and sending it to someone else without opening it.

But the thought itself made her laugh.

Devkant came in from the osara.

Ira said softly, "This is..."

Shailaja cut in at once, "It must be from the same shop."

Ira saw the piece of purple thread caught beneath the red paper.

"And this purple thread?"

Devkant's lips trembled.

Shailaja glared at him. "There is nothing to laugh about."

Ira opened the box.

The lid rose slowly.

Inside, along the edge, the little slip of paper was still stuck.

"For Nirmala Mami — Ira."

For a moment there was no sound in the house.

Then Devkant laughed so loudly that the brass lota on the osara rang.

Ira too doubled over with laughter.

At first Shailaja tried to remain serious.

Then her eyes went to the box's three layers—the purple thread, the green thread, the silver paper.

A smile came to her face as well.

"Three houses."

Devkant said, "And the same prestige."

"Two prestiges," Shailaja corrected him. "Mausi was not part of this game."

"True."

Ira counted the sweets.

Twelve pieces.

All exactly as they had been.

"Not even one is missing."

Devkant said, "Prestige does not make one hungry."

This time Shailaja laughed and lightly slapped his arm.

The matter remained within the house until noon.

In the evening Nirmala herself came.

She carried a small plate; she had brought some savoury snacks made at home to mark the news of Aniruddh's appointment.

Ira brought three pieces of makhana paak from inside.

Nirmala picked up one piece.

She bit into it and put it in her mouth.

For a moment her eyes went to the box.

The silver paper had been removed, but the red lotus was plainly visible.

Nirmala began chewing more slowly.

Shailaja asked casually, "How does it taste?"

"It tastes very good."

"We received it only yesterday."

Nirmala looked at Shailaja.

Ira ran inside, or else her laughter would have escaped.
 On the osara Devkant folded the newspaper up to cover his face.
 Nirmala asked softly, "From where?"
 "Sukumari Mausi brought it."
 Nirmala's hand stopped in mid-air.
 Then she too burst out laughing.
 "I thought that once the red paper was covered, the story would change too."
 Shailaja said, "I thought that if an expensive box went from my house, people would see my taste."
 Nirmala said, "They did see your taste. Three times."
 The two women went on laughing.
 Devkant said, "And where will the box go now?"
 Shailaja immediately opened the lid and emptied the remaining sweets onto a plate.
 "Nowhere now."
 Ira picked up the empty box.
 "Give it to me."
 "What will you do with it?"
 "I will keep the threads from my sewing box in it."
 Nirmala picked up the remaining piece of purple thread. "Keep this too."
 Shailaja gave her the green thread as well.
 Ira put both threads inside the empty box.
 As she closed the lid, she again saw her old little slip of paper—"For Nirmala Mami — Ira."
 She did not remove it.
 Devkant asked, "Why are you leaving that there?"
 Ira said, "If the box ever sets out somewhere again, it should not forget the way."
 This time everyone burst out laughing together.

STORY 129

A Small Advertisement

Niranjan Thakur emptied every coin from his pocket onto the desk in the little newspaper office.

Two twelve-rupee notes, one five-rupee note, and small change.

Twenty-nine rupees in all.

The clerk seated on the other side of the desk counted it again.

“Only this much?”

Niranjan tried to smile. “Will this much buy a small advertisement?”

The clerk read the lines written on the paper.

“Work wanted. I can keep accounts and ledgers, make copies, and write letters. Niranjan Thakur, Old Post Office Lane.”

He began counting the words.

“At this size, you are two rupees short.”

Niranjan felt through his pockets again.

An old railway ticket, a brass-coloured button, and an empty corner of cloth.

There was not a trace of cash left in his pockets.

“Cut two words.”

“Which words shall I cut?”

Niranjan looked at the line.

“Remove ‘letter-writing’.”

The clerk shook his head. “That is one word.”

“Remove ‘Old’.”

“Then the address may become incomplete.”

Niranjan thought for a while.

“In ‘Work wanted’, remove ‘wanted’.”

The clerk laughed. “Then the advertisement will sound like an order — ‘Work.’”

Niranjan laughed too.

In the end, “copies” was removed and “letter-writing” was shortened to “letters”.

Twenty-nine rupees was enough.

The clerk tore off a receipt and handed it to him.

“It will appear the day after tomorrow.”

Niranjan folded the receipt and tucked it inside his kurta.

When he stepped out of the office, his pocket was lighter, but his pace was a little quicker.

He had been looking for work for three months.

Balancing a ledger at one shop, accounts at another warehouse; applications somewhere, waiting somewhere else.

The answer was not exactly the same everywhere, but its meaning was nearly always the same.

“There is no place at present.”

His house stood at the last turn of Old Post Office Lane.

Two rooms, a small verandah, and a tulsi altar beside the doorway.

His mother sat on the verandah shelling peas.

The moment she saw Niranjana, she asked, “Did you get it printed?”

“Yes, I did.”

“How much is left?”

Niranjana spread both palms before her.

His mother looked at the empty hands and said nothing.

A pea rolled away to the corner of the verandah.

She rose, fetched it, and put it back.

“I will not go to the market tomorrow,” Niranjana said. “We will manage with whatever is in the house.”

His mother separated the pea pods and said, “Once an advertisement is printed, people do not come all the way to the house carrying work. Do not stop going out.”

“I will not.”

The day after tomorrow, early in the morning, Niranjana did not go to the square to buy the newspaper.

He had no money to buy it.

He stood beside the paan shop and read the public copy hanging there.

The first page, the second page, market prices, notices, obituaries.

Then, very low down, inside a black border, was his advertisement.

It was so small that if the eye missed it once, one had to search for it again.

“Work—accounts and ledgers, letters. Niranjana Thakur, Post Office Lane.”

Seeing his own name in print felt strange.

As though the paper had more faith in him than he had in himself.

That day there were two knocks at the door.

The first was the milkman.

The second was a neighbour’s child looking for a ball.

By evening there was no word of any work.

The next morning Niranjana made the rounds of three places.

A medicine shop, a grain warehouse, and a cloth shop.

At all three, the ledgers were already full and there was already someone to write in them.

On the way home, he felt a little angry with his advertisement.

It seemed as though twenty-nine rupees had become trapped in twelve words on a sheet of paper.

His mother understood the moment she saw his face.

"The newspaper is not at fault," she said.

"Did I blame it?"

"Your face did."

Niranjan laughed.

After noon, a bicycle bell rang at the door.

Once.

Then twice in quick succession.

Niranjan went outside.

At the gate, a thin, dark-complexioned young man was propping up a bicycle.

A dusty bag hung from his shoulder, and sweat shone on his forehead.

He looked at Niranjan for two moments.

"You are Niranjan?"

Niranjan was about to answer when he recognised the voice.

"Harinath?"

Both laughed at once.

Harinath left the bicycle and embraced him.

"Your moustache has finally become a real moustache."

Niranjan said, "And half your hair has gone on leave."

His mother came out from inside.

Harinath immediately bent to touch her feet.

"After so many years?" she asked.

Harinath's laughter softened a little.

"The fault is mine, Ma."

They all sat on the verandah.

Niranjan brought water.

Harinath put a hand into his bag.

Niranjan thought he must have brought sweets.

Instead, Harinath took out an old cloth pouch.

Its knot was tied with red thread.

He placed it in front of Niranjan.

"What is in this pouch?"

"An old account of yours."

Niranjan opened the pouch.

There were notes and coins inside.

Old and new, both kinds.

"Why this money?"

Harinath looked into his eyes.

“Two hundred and seventy-five.”
 Niranjan’s hand went still.
 The number brought back a day from long ago.
 Their final year at school.
 The last date for paying Harinath’s admission fee for industrial training.
 Harinath’s father had been ill.
 There had been no cash at home.
 Niranjan had given him the two hundred and seventy-five rupees he had saved.
 He had meant to buy an old dictionary with that money.
 The dictionary was never bought.
 Harinath got his admission.
 After that, life carried the two of them onto different roads.
 Harinath went away for training.
 Niranjan’s family left their old house and moved into this lane.
 A few letters came, and then the letters stopped.
 The matter of the debt slowly faded from memory.
 Niranjan pushed the pouch back towards Harinath.
 “I had forgotten this.”
 “I had not.”
 “Then why so many years?”
 Harinath looked a little embarrassed.
 “At first I had no money.”
 Harinath paused.
 “When I had money, I did not have your address.”
 Then, with a faint laugh, he added, “When I found the address, I did not have the courage.”
 Niranjan stared at him. “Courage to return money?”
 “When a debt is not repaid on time, the shame grows larger than the amount.”
 His mother carried the empty pea basket inside, as though leaving the two friends space to talk.
 Niranjan asked, “How did you find my address?”
 Harinath took a folded newspaper from his kurta pocket.
 The small advertisement inside the black border had been circled in red ink.
 “I read it at a tea shop.”
 Niranjan looked at the advertisement.
 “Have you brought news of work?”
 Harinath shook his head.
 “Not yet.”
 “Then the advertisement is half successful.”
 “Why half successful?”

"I have not found work."

Harinath placed the pouch back on his palm.

"But you found an old account."

Niranjan laughed.

He opened the pouch and counted the money again.

Two hundred and seventy-five.

Exactly that much.

Harinath also took a grubby old slip from the pouch.

It was the old fee receipt from the training centre.

On the back, in faded ink, was written: "Niranjan—275."

Niranjan recognised the handwriting.

"You have kept this all these years?"

Harinath said, "It was less an account-paper than a marker for finding you."

Niranjan handed the slip back to him.

"Then you keep it."

"Where is the interest?" he joked.

Harinath replied at once, "The interest was very expensive."

"How so?"

"We did not meet for all these years. If that is not interest, what is?"

Niranjan's laughter softened.

He kept the pouch with him.

"All right. Principal accepted."

"And the interest?"

"For interest, do not lose touch again."

Harinath raised a hand in agreement.

A little later, the two went out for a walk as far as the turn of the lane.

Harinath now worked repairing irrigation machines in a nearby town.

It was not his own shop; he worked for someone else for wages.

"I do not have work to give you," he said plainly.

"I did not ask."

"Your face did."

Niranjan laughed.

They stopped for tea at the turn.

Niranjan put a hand into his pocket, then looked at Harinath.

"Tea is on me now."

"With the money from the old debt?"

"Once money has come back, it no longer keeps its old name."

Harinath said, "That is a good principle."

The tea seller set down two glasses.

Harinath opened the same copy of the newspaper again.

"Will you advertise again?"

"Yes. I have already arranged it."

“Bigger this time?”

Niranjan read his little advertisement.

“No. It will stay small.”

“Why keep it small?”

“A big advertisement does not guarantee work.”

Harinath took out a red pen.

“Add one word—‘immediately’.”

Niranjan snatched the pencil from him.

“One word costs money.”

The two friends laughed again.

That evening Niranjan reached the newspaper office.

The same clerk sat at the desk.

He recognised Niranjan.

“Did you find work?”

Niranjan placed twenty-nine rupees before him.

“No. There is no news of work.”

The clerk raised his eyebrows.

“Then again?”

Niranjan placed a new sheet of paper beside the old receipt.

“The advertisement did not search only for work.”

“What else did it find?”

Outside the doorway, Harinath stood holding his bicycle.

Niranjan looked towards him.

“An account eight years old.”

The clerk did not understand, but he smiled.

He began counting the words in the advertisement again.

This time Niranjan did not ask him to cut a single word.

STORY 130

The Blue Pen

In the pale light of dawn, Mithilesh Jha opened his admit card once again.

He looked at his name once more.

The roll number was there.

The examination centre.

The time.

He had already checked everything three times the previous day.

Even so, his finger kept folding the corner of the paper.

Across the courtyard, Raghav Jha was filling a lota with water.

He looked at Mithilesh and smiled.

“Is the admit card still there?”

Mithilesh folded the paper.

“The paper is still there. My heartbeat is increasing.”

Raghav set down the lota and came over to him.

“Which chapter did you leave out last night?”

“None.”

“Then which chapter is this fear written in?”

Mithilesh tried to smile.

“That chapter is outside the book.”

Raghav went inside.

He returned carrying a small wooden box.

As soon as he opened its lid, the smell of old paper drifted out.

Inside lay two certificates, a brass pin, and a deep-blue pen.

There was a crescent-shaped scratch on one part of the pen's body.

Mithilesh recognized it at once.

“This is your lucky pen.”

Raghav picked it up.

“Today it is yours.”

Mithilesh drew back his hand.

“No. You took this to your first selection examination.”

“So?”

“So it should stay with you.”

Raghav placed the pen on Mithilesh's admit card.

“If there is luck in this pen, it will serve you today. If there isn't, at least I will learn to let go of my attachment to it.”

Mithilesh laughed.

“A lucky pen, and advice for free as well?”

“The fee for the advice comes later.”

Mithilesh took the pen in his hand.

Its thin brass-coloured clip was slightly bent.

His fingernail caught on the crescent-shaped scratch.

That scratch was an old mark known to both friends.

Five years earlier, while returning from the library, Raghav's bicycle had fallen.

The pen had scraped against a piece of gravel on the road.

That evening, the two of them had sat on the veranda and rubbed oil over the scratch.

The scratch had not disappeared.

Raghav had said, “Let it remain. Things that keep moving always carry something written on their bodies.”

Today Mithilesh remembered that very sentence.

“Is there ink in it?”

Raghav paused for a moment.

“There should be.”

“Should be?”

“I've kept it in the box for a long time.”

Mithilesh put the cap back on.

“Lucky things are not tested before an examination.”

“Where is that rule written?”

“In the chapter outside the book.”

Both of them laughed.

The examination centre was in the old training building at Laheriasarai.

A crowd of candidates had gathered outside the gate.

Some held bundles of papers.

Some had formulas moving silently on their lips.

Some stood with their eyes closed.

Mithilesh touched his admit card once again.

The blue pen was in the upper pocket of his kurta.

Raghav had come as far as the gate.

“Going in?”

“Yes, going in.”

“Spend the first five minutes reading the questions.”

“Will you stay outside?”

“Not here. I'll go and have tea. I am not going to stand guard over your fear.”

Mithilesh laughed again.

As he went through the gate, his steps already felt lighter.

Long desks stood in rows inside the examination hall.

Mithilesh's seat was by the window.

Outside, the leaves of an ashoka tree were stirring.

The invigilator distributed the answer books.

"No name. Only the roll number."

Mithilesh uncapped the blue pen.

He set the nib to the paper.

A tiny blue dot appeared.

He wrote the first digit of his roll number.

Halfway through the second digit, the line stopped.

Mithilesh tried again.

Not a single mark appeared.

He rubbed the nib against a corner of the paper.

A thin line appeared and immediately ran dry.

His heart gave a sudden thud.

All around him, the soft rustle of pens moving across paper had begun.

The invigilator was distributing the question papers.

Mithilesh opened the pen and looked at the nib.

A blue stain came onto his finger.

Still the pen would not write.

For a moment, it seemed to him that Raghav's luck had been left outside the door.

Then his eyes fell upon the body of the pen.

The crescent-shaped scratch.

That old mark from the fall.

Mithilesh's breathing steadied a little.

He knew the story of this pen's luck.

Before his first selection examination, Raghav had failed three practice tests.

On all those nights, it had been Mithilesh who made him work through the arithmetic problems again.

One night, in frustration, Raghav had even flung the pen onto the table.

Mithilesh had picked it up and said, "Quarrelling with the pen won't solve the problem."

Later, that same Raghav began calling this pen lucky.

In truth, the pen was not expensive.

Raghav had bought it from a stationery shop beside an old-book shop.

In the first month, its nib had to be cleaned twice.

Once, its brass clip had come loose.

Mithilesh himself had tightened its tiny screw with the point of a needle.

Even so, from the day the result came out, Raghav began keeping it separately in the box.

The name "lucky" had first been given to it jokingly by Raghav's younger sister.

The name stuck.

Gradually, the ordinary history of the pen turned into a small story in people's minds.

Mithilesh knew all of this.

Yet here in the examination hall, merely seeing that blue body made his friend's confidence feel close at hand.

For the first time, Mithilesh could not laugh at that thought.

The invigilator reached his desk.

"Any difficulty?"

Mithilesh showed him the pen.

"The pen has stopped."

The invigilator took an ordinary black pen from his bag and handed it to him.

"Here. The examination isn't running away."

Mithilesh thanked him.

He did not place the blue pen on top of the answer book; he set it in the right-hand corner of the desk.

With the black pen, he completed his roll number.

He opened the question paper.

At the very first question, his heart began beating fast again.

He read the second.

Then the third as well.

At the fourth question, his finger stopped.

It was the same kind of arithmetic problem in which he had repeatedly made mistakes three months earlier.

On his practice sheet, Raghav had drawn a circle and written: "First the quantity, then the rate."

Mithilesh wrote two small words in the left-hand corner of the paper.

"Quantity. Rate."

And he began the calculation.

The first answer was completed.

Then the second.

In the middle of the examination, the blue pen rolled off the desk once.

Mithilesh picked it up but did not put it into his pocket.

He placed it back in the corner.

By then he no longer needed the pen to write.

Its mere presence was enough.

In the final half-hour, Mithilesh read through his answers again.

He corrected two calculations.

He crossed out one line and rewrote it.

The final bell rang.

The answer books were collected.

When Mithilesh came outside, the blue pen was in his pocket and there was a blue stain on his finger.

Raghav was not standing in front of the gate.

He was sitting at the tea stall opposite, holding a clay cup.

As soon as Mithilesh reached him, Raghav stood up.

“How did it go?”

Mithilesh placed the blue pen in front of him.

Raghav's smile vanished.

“Why are you giving this back?”

“Your lucky pen wrote one digit and then went off to rest.”

“What are you saying?”

Raghav opened the pen.

He rubbed it on a piece of paper.

This time too, no mark appeared.

He pressed harder.

A single blue dot.

Raghav clutched his head.

“I didn't test it.”

“Neither did I.”

“Then the examination?”

“With a black pen.”

Raghav was silent for a few moments.

“Weren't you frightened?”

Mithilesh picked up the clay cup.

“At first, yes.”

“And then?”

Mithilesh ran his finger over the scratch on the pen.

“Then I saw this mark.”

Raghav looked at the scratch.

“The bicycle one?”

“Yes. Go inside.”

“What did that do?”

“It reminded me that your luck too had fallen three times in practice tests.”

Raghav stared at him for a moment, then laughed so loudly that even the tea seller looked over.

“Was today the day to say that?”

“The pen said it today.”

Together they took the pen to the old pen-repairer in the market.

The elderly craftsman removed the nib and put it into a small glass bowl.

Inside it was a thin crust of dried blue ink.

“Has it not been used for a long time?”

Raghav said, “It was kept in a box.”

The craftsman made a faint sound through his nose.

“The tube of a pen dries if it is kept away. Keep using it.”

Mithilesh looked at Raghav.

Raghav said, “Yes, yes, now I’ll pay for the advice too.”

The craftsman did not understand.

The two friends laughed again.

Three weeks later, the result list was posted on the office notice board.

Mithilesh first searched for his roll number from the top.

It was not there.

He began looking again from the bottom.

Raghav was reading the list from behind his shoulder.

Suddenly his finger stopped at a line in the middle.

“Look here.”

Mithilesh read it.

It was his roll number.

He said nothing.

Neither did Raghav.

For that moment, the noise of the crowd seemed far away.

Mithilesh put his hand into his pocket.

The blue pen was not there.

After it had been repaired, he had returned it to Raghav.

Raghav took the pen from his own pocket.

“In case you need to sign something?”

Mithilesh looked at the pen.

“Test it first.”

Raghav did not write on an empty corner of the notice board; he ran the pen across his own palm.

A deep blue line appeared.

“It works now.”

Mithilesh laughed.

“Good. Your luck is safe again.”

Raghav held out the pen to him.

“Keep it.”

Mithilesh shook his head.

“No. On the day of the examination, it wrote one digit. I wrote the rest.”

Raghav put the pen back into his pocket.

“So it is no longer lucky?”

Mithilesh looked once more at his roll number on the notice board.

“Why not? It wrote one digit correctly.”

Raghav laughed.

The two of them walked out of the crowd.

By then, the blue stain from examination day was no longer on Mithilesh's finger.

But the crescent-shaped scratch on the pen remained clear in his memory.

STORY 131

The Wooden Horse

In the morning, the sunlight had reached only halfway across the courtyard.

Bholanath the carpenter sat beneath the veranda, turning three pieces of jackfruit wood over in his hands.

One piece was suitable for the horse's body.

The neck could be shaped from the second.

The third piece was thin, but it would not yield all four wheels.

His son Santosh stood leaning against a pillar of the veranda, watching the work.

"Is it going to be for me?"

Bholanath did not look up.

"The wood is asking whether it should become something for you or something for the stove."

Santosh laughed.

"Tell the wood I am not a stove."

The corner of Bholanath's mouth moved.

The chisel began to work.

Thin curls of wood fell one after another.

By noon, the horse's back had taken shape.

Its neck was slightly crooked.

Santosh said, "It is looking at me."

"A horse looks towards the road."

"Then shall we give it a road?"

"First it needs feet."

Bholanath began cutting four round wheels.

Three of the wheels were made of jackfruit wood.

For the fourth, the wood fell short.

He cut a round piece from an old neem plank.

The neem wheel was a little darker than the other three.

Santosh asked, "Why aren't all four the same colour?"

Bholanath said, "To run, a wheel needs roundness, not colour."

By evening, all four wheels of the horse were turning.

Bholanath cut a thin strip of brass and fitted it at the front of the axle.

The horse's tail was made from a small tuft of red thread.

Instead of painting it, he gave the wood a thin coat of mustard oil.

The wood's own colour came alive.

Santosh picked up the horse and ran off with it.

“Slowly.”

“It’s a horse, not a goat.”

“It may be a horse, but I made all four of its wheels.”

Santosh tied a string to it and pulled it around the courtyard.

At every turn, the neem wheel made a soft “tak.”

Santosh liked the sound.

That night the horse lay beside his pillow.

For the first time that night, Bholanath shivered.

At first Santosh thought he must simply be tired.

The next day the fever rose.

On the third day Bholanath could not lift his chisel.

The doctor at the village health centre wrote out a two-page prescription.

Some of the medicines were available at the centre.

Two had to be bought outside.

Bholanath folded the prescription and placed it beside the cot.

“I’ll get them tomorrow.”

Santosh asked, “How much do they cost?”

“What business is that of yours?”

“They teach arithmetic at my school too.”

Bholanath did not laugh.

“One hundred and seventy-six.”

There was not that much cash in the house.

He had made two benches for someone, but payment would come only after the paddy from that man’s field was sold.

The paddy was still in the granary.

Bholanath said, “It can wait two days.”

Santosh looked at the prescription.

Then he looked at the wooden horse lying beside the pillow.

The Bargachhiya market was held on Fridays.

Early in the morning Santosh wrapped the horse in a cloth and put it inside his bag.

His mother Gauri thought he was going to school.

He left the school road and turned towards the market.

The market had not fully awakened yet.

Vegetable sellers were arranging their baskets.

The woman who sold earthen pots was dusting them.

In one corner Habib Mian was opening his travelling toy stall.

Bamboo whistles, clay birds, wooden spinning tops and cloth balls hung there.

Santosh stood at a distance.

Habib Mian noticed him.

“What have you come to sell?”
 Santosh took the horse out of his bag.
 Habib Mian first examined the horse's back.
 Then he spun its wheels.
 The neem wheel made a “tak.”
 “Why is this one wheel a different colour?”
 “The jackfruit wood ran out.”
 “Who made it?”
 “My father.”
 “How much do you want for it?”
 Santosh's throat went dry.
 He had worked out the amount during the night.
 “Two hundred.”
 Habib Mian laughed.
 “For that much I could buy three spinning tops.”
 “Three spinning tops are not a horse.”
 Habib Mian spun the wheel again.
 “One hundred and twenty.”
 Santosh moved the horse back towards his bag.
 “Then I don't want to sell it.”
 “One hundred and fifty.”
 Santosh remained silent.
 “One hundred and seventy.”
 Santosh remembered the price of the medicines.
 One hundred and seventy-six.
 “One hundred and eighty.”
 Habib Mian looked at him for a few moments.
 Then he ran a finger along the underside of the horse's belly.
 Bholanath had cut three thin diagonal lines there with his chisel.
 They were his maker's mark.
 Habib Mian said, “One hundred and eighty. But not the bag.”
 Santosh laughed for the first time.
 “The bag isn't for sale.”
 Eighteen ten-rupee notes came into his palm.
 The horse moved onto Habib Mian's cloth.
 The neem wheel made another “tak.”
 Santosh went straight from the market to the medicine shop.
 He bought the two packets of medicine.
 Four rupees remained.
 He put the four rupees into his pocket and went home.
 Bholanath lay on the cot with his eyes closed.
 Santosh placed the medicine beside his pillow.

Bholanath opened his eyes.

“Where did this come from?”

“From the market.”

“How much did the medicine cost?”

“One hundred and seventy-six.”

“The money?”

Santosh was silent for a few moments.

Bholanath's eyes went to the place where the horse used to lie at night.

The place was empty.

He looked at Santosh again.

“The horse?”

“It went to see the market.”

Bholanath's eyes narrowed slightly.

“You sold it?”

Santosh nodded.

“For how much?”

“One hundred and eighty.”

Bholanath asked at once, “You didn't lower the price, did you?”

Santosh was surprised.

“No. He first offered one hundred and twenty.”

A faint smile came to Bholanath's fevered face.

“Good. Never lower the price of your work.”

Santosh took the four rupees from his pocket and placed them on the cot.

“These were left over.”

Bholanath said, “Keep them.”

“Why these four rupees?”

“The price of the horse's string.”

Santosh put the four rupees back into his pocket.

A week later, the fever began to subside.

Ten days later Bholanath could sit beneath the veranda again.

He took the chisel in his hand, but on the first day he only examined its edge.

On the second day he levelled one leg of a bench.

On the third he made a small wooden disc.

Santosh asked, “Will you make a horse?”

Bholanath said, “I can.”

“Not another one yet.”

“Why not another one yet?”

“That first horse must still be seeing the market.”

Bholanath said nothing.

Meanwhile, a month passed.

The rains came.

Then the sun returned.
 The smell of jackfruit wood began to settle beneath the veranda once again.
 One afternoon Habib Mian arrived carrying his wooden chest.
 One corner of the chest had split.
 An iron hinge was loose.
 "Brother Bholanath, save this for me."
 Bholanath turned the chest over and examined it.
 "It will take two days."
 "The next market is tomorrow."
 "Then I'll do it by tonight."
 Habib Mian opened the chest.
 Inside were whistles, spinning tops, small drums and cloth balls.
 As he moved the things aside, a wooden horse rolled out.
 The dark neem wheel struck the ground with a "tak."
 Santosh was writing his lesson in another corner of the veranda.
 His pen stopped.
 Bholanath picked up the horse.
 There were three diagonal lines beneath its belly.
 The red-thread tail had now turned grey with dust.
 One axle was slightly loose.
 Bholanath asked only, "Didn't it sell?"
 Habib Mian laughed.
 "Twice, two different people picked it up. They saw three wheels of one colour and one of another, and put it back."
 Santosh came closer slowly.
 "Does it still make the 'tak' sound?"
 Habib Mian recognized him.
 "Ah, your horse!"
 "It's yours now."
 Habib Mian showed him the loose wheel.
 "Tighten this too. Then I'll sell it."
 Bholanath nodded.
 By evening, the corner of the chest had been replaced.
 A new wooden strip had been fitted.
 The hinge was tight again.
 Bholanath drove a thin bamboo peg into the horse's axle.
 The neem wheel began to turn smoothly again.
 Habib Mian returned before nightfall.
 "How much?"
 Bholanath told him the amount.
 Habib Mian searched his pouch.
 He was short of cash.

“Half now, half at the next market?”

Bholanath said, “That will do.”

Habib Mian lifted the chest.

The horse was resting on top.

He took two steps, then stopped again.

“Wait. Let me say something.”

“Go ahead.”

“This horse has been making the rounds of three markets with me. People look at it, but no one buys it.”

Bholanath remained silent.

“Make me four spinning tops. I’ll take them to the next market. I leave this horse here. Accounts even?”

Bholanath looked at Santosh.

Santosh was looking not at the horse, but at Habib Mian.

“What size should the four tops be?”

Habib Mian showed the measure with his fingers.

“About this size. Two with red thread, two with green.”

Bholanath calculated silently.

“Even.”

Habib Mian placed the horse beneath the veranda.

“Then it is yours again.”

Bholanath said, “No. It is part of the account.”

“Call it the account, then.”

He left.

Santosh did not pick up the horse for a long time.

Bholanath kept putting away his chisels.

At last Santosh asked, “May I have it?”

Bholanath said, “First see whether the axle is tight.”

Santosh tied on the string.

The horse moved across the courtyard.

The three jackfruit-wood wheels turned silently.

The neem wheel made a “tak.”

Santosh stopped.

“The sound is still there.”

Bholanath said, “Neem keeps its own colour, and its own sound.”

Over the next two days Bholanath made four spinning tops.

Santosh tied red and green thread to them.

On market day Habib Mian took the tops away.

He counted the account once more.

Neither man spoke of doing the other a favour.

The wooden horse remained beneath the veranda.

Santosh no longer kept it beside his pillow.

It found a place on top of Bholanath's toolbox.

When small children from the neighbourhood came, Santosh would bring the horse down for them.

When the play was over, he wiped it with a cloth and put it back on top.

One evening Bholanath asked, "What did your horse learn at the market?"

Santosh said as he wound up the string, "Not to lower its price."

Bholanath laughed.

"Anything else?"

Santosh pushed the horse forward once.

The neem wheel made a "tak."

"Not to forget the way home."

Bholanath said nothing.

He began measuring round pieces of wood for four new wheels.

In the evening beneath the veranda, the old horse stood still.

But on its one dark wheel, the dust of the market still clung like a faint line.

STORY 132

The Sewing Machine

The thin morning sunlight passed through the lattice of the window and made a square of light on the sewing table.

Leela had spread a piece of blue cloth in that light and was working.

A fine chalk line ran along the edge of the cloth.

The foot pedal moved in a steady rhythm.

Now and then the belt slipped a little.

Then Leela stopped her foot, lifted the belt back into place with her hand, and the needle began moving again.

Her husband, Harinarayan, stood at the doorway watching all this.

“You kept it running so late last night too.”

Leela did not take her eyes off the cloth.

“I have two kurtas to deliver tomorrow.”

“Doesn’t your foot hurt?”

“A foot’s work is to move; a mouth’s work is to ask questions.”

Harinarayan laughed.

In a wooden box beneath the table lay the head of another old sewing machine.

That machine had not run for a year.

Its shuttle was broken.

Its wheel jammed.

The old machine head had come from Leela’s parental home with the thought that “some part might come in useful someday.”

Harinarayan had cleaned it several times.

But not a single useful part had ever come out of it.

That morning Harinarayan looked once at the box.

Then he went out without saying anything.

It was Harinarayan’s birthday that day.

He did not like any grand celebration of his birthday.

What Leela liked even less was the way he always brushed everything aside by saying, “I don’t want anything.”

This time Leela had made up her mind.

A gamchha with a red border.

Two bowls of kheer.

Two friends in the evening.

That much celebration would be enough.

But there was little cash in the house tin.

Two customers from the previous week had postponed payment.

One had said he would pay after the paddy was sold.

There was a wedding in the other's house; payment would come later.

Leela counted the outstanding dues and smiled.

"If it were my birthday, I could celebrate by writing my name in chalk."

But she had already decided to buy the gamchha for Harinarayan.

Before noon, she stopped sewing.

She wrapped the unfinished piece of the blue kurta in cloth and put it aside.

She detached the machine head from the table.

The wooden table stood empty.

The workplace suddenly looked unfamiliar.

Leela called her neighbour Renuka.

"Will you come with me for a while?"

Renuka looked at the machine head.

"Where?"

"To the women's cooperative."

Renuka raised her eyebrows.

"How many days will it remain pledged?"

"Five or seven days. I'll redeem it as soon as the next payment comes."

Renuka said nothing.

Together they wrapped the machine head in cloth.

At the cooperative, an article offered as security was not weighed; it was inspected.

Half of the golden vine pattern was still visible on the black body of the machine.

The woman keeping the register turned the wheel to test it.

"Does it run?"

Leela said, "It was running until this morning."

"Seven hundred."

Leela thought for a moment.

"Seven hundred is acceptable."

A receipt was made out.

The machine went into the inner room.

Seven hundred rupees came into Leela's hands.

From that money she bought a gamchha for forty-five rupees.

She bought half a seer of milk, rice, jaggery, and cardamom.

The total expense came to one hundred and ten rupees.

She folded the remaining five hundred and ninety rupees and put them in an old red purse.

"This is the machine's money," she told Renuka.

"Then what about the birthday?"

"Is one hundred and ten rupees too little for a birthday?"

Renuka laughed.

At that same time, Harinarayan was at Badri the mechanic's shop at the other end of the market.

Badri sold sewing-machine motors, belts, pedals, and old parts.

Leela's old, broken machine head lay on the table.

Badri turned its wheel.

The wheel made half a turn and jammed.

"This won't run."

Harinarayan said, "Did I bring it to make it run?"

"Then why did you bring the machine?"

"For parts."

Badri turned the machine over and examined it.

"Six hundred and twenty."

Harinarayan did not agree at once.

"Seven hundred."

"Six hundred and twenty."

"Six hundred and fifty."

Badri shrugged.

"Six hundred and twenty, and I'll give you the motor belt at half price."

Harinarayan thought.

"All right. At that price."

The old machine was sold.

Six hundred and twenty rupees came into his hands.

He placed five hundred rupees back in Badri's hand.

"Advance for a new motor."

Badri wrote his name in the register.

"The motor will be here by tomorrow evening."

"Not tomorrow. Five days later."

"Why a delay of five days?"

"I have to arrange the rest of the money."

Badri wrote out a receipt.

Harinarayan folded it and put it in the inside pocket of his shirt.

One hundred and twenty rupees remained in his outer pocket.

He started home.

As soon as he reached home that evening, the first thing Harinarayan saw was the empty sewing table.

He stopped at the doorway.

The unfinished blue kurta lay on the table.

The chalk was there.

The scissors were there.

The machine was not.

“Leela?”

A voice came from inside, “Wash your hands and face. Don’t ask yet.”

“Where is the machine?”

“Hands and face first.”

“Has the machine gone to wash its hands and face?”

Leela came out laughing.

In her hands was the gamchha with the red border.

“Happy birthday.”

Harinarayan took the gamchha, but his eyes remained on the empty table.

“Did this gamchha cost the machine?”

“The gamchha cost forty-five.”

“Then the machine?”

Leela took out the red purse.

And the pledge receipt.

“A guest for seven days.”

Harinarayan read the receipt.

Then he looked at Leela’s face.

Then at the receipt again.

“You pledged the machine?”

“I’ll redeem it.”

“When?”

“As soon as the two customers pay.”

Harinarayan sat down on the cot.

For a few moments he said nothing.

Leela thought he would be angry.

But suddenly Harinarayan began to laugh.

Leela glared at him.

“What is so funny?”

Harinarayan took another receipt from the inside pocket of his shirt.

Leela read it.

‘Motor - advance: five hundred.’

She turned the receipt over and read it again.

“Whose motor is this?”

“Your machine’s.”

Leela looked at the empty table.

Then at the receipt.

“A motor for a machine that isn’t in the house?”

Harinarayan laughed again.

“That is exactly the question I am asking now.”

Leela laid the receipt on the table.

“Where did you get five hundred?”

Harinarayan pointed with his eyes toward the empty box beneath the table.

Leela looked there too.

The head of the old broken machine was gone.

"You sold it?"

"If we call that a machine, machines themselves will be offended. It had been sleeping in the box for a year."

"How much did you get?"

"Six hundred and twenty."

"Five hundred into the motor?"

"One hundred and twenty is still in my pocket."

Leela fell silent for a moment.

Then she opened the red purse.

She placed five hundred and ninety rupees on the table.

"Five hundred and ninety."

Harinarayan added his one hundred and twenty.

Together they counted the money.

Seven hundred and ten.

Leela looked at the pledge receipt.

"It will take seven hundred and ten to redeem the machine."

Harinarayan said, "Then the birthday accounts balance."

Leela glared at him.

"The kheer hasn't even been made yet."

"Kheer later. First the machine."

It was almost closing time at the cooperative.

The two of them walked quickly.

Leela had draped the new red-bordered gamchha over Harinarayan's shoulder.

From time to time he wiped his sweat with it.

"The gift is useful," he said.

"We'll know once the machine comes back."

When they reached the cooperative, the gate was half closed.

The woman who kept the register was gathering the papers from outside.

Leela handed her the receipt.

"So soon?"

"The empty table didn't look right at home."

The woman smiled.

Seven hundred and ten rupees were counted out.

The machine came out again, wrapped in cloth.

Harinarayan lifted it.

Leela said, "Careful. This is the post-birthday machine."

Harinarayan said, "And the debt is from before the birthday."

Back home, the machine was seated on the table again.

Leela fitted the belt.

She turned the wheel.
 The needle went up and down twice.
 The unfinished blue kurta was still there.
 Harinarayan hung the gamchha on a peg.
 “Will there be kheer or not?”
 Leela looked at the clock.
 “The two friends will be here soon.”
 “Don’t tell them the story of the machine.”
 “Why not tell the story?”
 “The kheer will grow cold.”
 Leela laughed.
 That night four bowls of kheer were made.
 Two friends came.
 They saw the gamchha.
 They wished him a happy birthday.
 No one knew about the empty box.
 Leela put the motor receipt in the spice tin.
 The pledge receipt went into the machine’s small drawer.
 Five days later Badri the mechanic arrived with the motor.
 He fixed it to the right corner of the wooden table.
 A new belt was fitted.
 The wire ran up to the hook on the wall.
 Leela paid the remaining amount from the sewing payments she had received over the previous three days.
 Badri turned the wheel by hand.
 Then he switched on the motor.
 For the first time, the machine ran without the pedal.
 Leela immediately slowed it down.
 “Not so fast.”
 Harinarayan said, “Until yesterday your foot was hurting.”
 “My foot will rest. My hands won’t.”
 Badri laughed.
 “The machine survived, and so did the motor.”
 Leela said, “One old machine is gone.”
 Harinarayan added, “And one pledge has made a round trip.”
 Badri understood nothing.
 He gathered his tools and left.
 That evening Leela finished the remaining stitching on the blue kurta.
 The soft hum of the motor filled the veranda.
 Harinarayan sat on the cot, folding the red-bordered gamchha.
 After a while a thin drop of oil appeared beneath the motor.

Leela took the gamchha down from the peg and was about to place it under the motor.

Harinarayan caught it at once.

“This is my birthday gift.”

Leela stopped her hand.

“Does motor oil not observe birthdays, then?”

Harinarayan put the gamchha back on his shoulder.

He placed a piece of old cloth beneath the motor.

Leela opened the machine drawer.

The pledge receipt lay inside.

She brought the motor's advance receipt from the spice tin as well.

She folded both receipts together and placed them beneath the needle box.

Harinarayan asked, “Why keep all this?”

Leela turned the wheel gently.

“If we ever forget the accounts, we'll look at them.”

“Which account do we need to remember?”

Leela pressed the motor switch.

The needle began to move.

“The account of two machines and one birthday in a single day.”

Harinarayan laughed.

The red-bordered gamchha remained on his shoulder.

The old box beneath the table was empty.

On the table, the sewing machine was running.

STORY 133

A Pair of Shoes

In the lane east of Madhubani station, the morning dew was still glistening along the edges of the bricks.

Naval bent down and tied the laces of his black shoes.

On the front of the right shoe was a crescent-shaped stain of blue ink.

Three years earlier, an inkpot had fallen in the printing shop; the stain had appeared then and had not gone away despite much scrubbing.

His sister Mrinal sat on the veranda, straightening the corners of her admission slip again and again.

“By what time do you have to reach there?” Naval asked.

“If the fee is deposited before eleven, the admission will be confirmed.”

Mrinal folded the paper and put it into her bag.

“We still need eight hundred and fifty rupees.”

Naval tied a second knot in the lace and said, “It will be arranged.”

“From where?”

“There is money due from the printing shop.”

The answer came in such an ordinary tone that Mrinal did not ask again.

That was Naval's nature.

He spoke little, but remembered the date of every task that had to be done.

He had also remembered the last date of Mrinal's admission for three weeks.

The two left home.

Their mother, Saraswati Devi, came to the doorway and said, “Go straight to the college.”

Naval laughed. “I also have to stop at the printing shop.”

At Station Chowk, Mrinal's path separated from his.

Naval did not go to the printing shop that day.

He went behind the old bus stand, to Rahim, the shoe-repairer who sat beside Shambhu the barber's shop.

On a small bamboo rack in front of Rahim hung old shoes, slippers, and straps.

“What needs repairing?” Rahim asked.

Naval took off his shoes.

“Not repairing. I want to sell them.”

Rahim looked first at the shoes, then at Naval's feet.

“This is your only good pair of shoes.”

“I need money now.”

Before taking the right shoe in his hand, Rahim wiped his palm.
He pressed the sole.

He examined the stitching at the heel.

He scratched at the blue stain with his nail.

"The stain won't come off."

Naval said, "I'm not asking a price for the stain."

Rahim did not smile.

"It needs a new strap. Two nails will have to be driven into the heel again.
Seven hundred."

"Eight hundred and fifty."

"What will I earn at that price?"

Naval remained silent.

Rahim looked at his feet.

The soles of his socks were already growing dirty in the dust.

"Eight hundred."

"I need eight hundred and fifty."

"Is it for something important?"

For the first time Naval looked Rahim in the eye.

"My sister's admission."

Rahim looked at the shoes again.

"All right. But there will be no receipt."

"I don't need any paper."

Rahim took from his cash box one five-hundred-rupee note, one two-hundred, one hundred, and one fifty.

Naval did not count the money.

The shoes were placed on the rack.

Rahim pushed an old pair of rubber slippers toward him.

"Wear these. Return them by evening."

"Rent?"

"If I charge rent for these, why is my name Rahim?"

The slippers were an inch too large for Naval's feet.

As he walked, they made a flap-flap sound behind his heels.

With that sound accompanying him, Naval reached the college.

Mrinal was standing in the queue at the fee counter.

"Did you get the money due?" she asked.

Naval put eight hundred and fifty rupees into her hand.

Mrinal breathed in relief, but at once her eyes fell on his feet.

"Where are your shoes?"

"Ink spilled on them at the printing shop. I've left them with Rahim."

"What happened then?"

"What else? Go on, the line is moving."

Only three students remained ahead of Mrinal.

She wanted to say something, but Naval gestured with his hand - the work first.

The admission was completed.

On the way home, the receipt was in Mrinal's bag, but her eyes kept returning to Naval's oversized slippers.

Two days later Naval returned those slippers to Rahim and began going to the printing shop in the old rubber flip-flops from home.

Mrinal asked, "Your shoes still aren't ready?"

Naval said, "The ink was stubborn."

"Does Rahim repair shoes or wash ink?"

Naval laughed.

"Your curiosity has grown a great deal."

Mrinal left the matter there, but the matter did not leave her.

A week later the scholarship list was posted at the college.

Mrinal saw her name in the third row.

She read the list twice.

Then it was checked against the office records.

She was told that the first instalment of five thousand rupees would be deposited in her account.

When she returned home, she did not tell her mother straightaway.

First she went to the printing shop.

Naval was counting sheets of wedding invitations at a small table behind the machine.

He was wearing the same flip-flops.

The strap of the right one was tied with waxed string.

"Your shoes are still with Rahim?" Mrinal asked.

Without looking up, Naval said, "Yes."

"In eight days the ink stain must have left the village and run away."

This time Naval's hand stopped.

He straightened the stack of sheets.

"Have classes started at your college, or an investigation?"

Mrinal did not answer.

She went straight to Rahim's shop.

Rahim knew her.

"Naval's sister?"

"Yes. I've come for his shoes."

Rahim had waxed thread in his hand.

"He sold them."

Mrinal's suspicion was confirmed, but hearing it made her face grow hot.

"How much did he sell them for?"

Rahim said, "Ask him that."

"I want the shoes."

Rahim pointed toward the rack.

On the upper shelf lay a polished pair of black shoes.

The blue crescent was still there on the front of the right shoe.

The strap was new.

The stitching at the heel had also been redone.

Mrinal reached up and took them down.

Her finger passed over the blue stain.

"What price have you put on them?"

"Twelve hundred."

"You bought them for eight hundred and fifty."

Rahim raised his eyebrows.

"You really are sharp at investigations."

"Three hundred and fifty so quickly?"

"Strap, heel, polish - and I have a stomach too."

Mrinal put the shoes back on the rack.

"I'll come in three days."

Rahim said, "What if they are sold by then?"

Mrinal looked once more at the blue stain.

"Keep them for now."

"Without an advance?"

She took a twenty-rupee note from her bag.

"This is all I have."

Before taking the note, Rahim asked, "Was the admission completed?"

"Yes."

"Then these shoes have already done their work."

Mrinal said, "No. They still have one job left."

Three days later the first scholarship instalment arrived.

Mrinal did not withdraw all the money from the bank.

She set aside what she would need for college books, travel, and the next fee.

She withdrew twelve hundred rupees and went straight to Rahim.

Rahim had wrapped the shoes in cloth and kept them aside.

"I thought you wouldn't come."

"I thought you would sell them."

"A twenty-rupee advance is a very strong bond."

Mrinal laughed.

She told him to deduct twenty from the twelve hundred.

Rahim laughed too.

"You've learned business."

The shoes would not fit into Mrinal's bag.

She put them in a paper bag and carried them home.

On the way, when the bag began to tear, she took the shoes out and carried them in her hand.

The blue stain looked even clearer in the sunlight.
 At home she placed the shoes beneath the cot.
 Naval returned in the evening.
 The waxed string on his flip-flop had loosened again.
 He sat at the doorway and began tying the strap.
 From inside, Mrinal said, "Rahim has given up on the ink."
 Naval's hand stopped.
 "What did you say?"
 Mrinal brought out the shoes.
 The blue crescent on the right shoe faced him.
 Naval said nothing for a long while.
 Then, before taking the shoes, he asked, "How much did you pay?"
 "Twelve hundred."
 "Twelve hundred!"
 "New strap, heel, polish - and Rahim's stomach."
 Naval could not keep from smiling despite himself.
 "Who told you?"
 "Your flip-flops."
 "Where did you get the money?"
 Mrinal placed the scholarship notice in his hand together with the admission receipt.
 "Scholarship."
 Naval read the paper.
 Then he looked at the shoes.
 "This money is for your studies."
 "On the day of my admission, these shoes also went for my studies."
 "I can walk in slippers."
 "I've also worked out the money for my books. This comes after that."
 Naval read the paper again.
 "Your first expense was on shoes?"
 Mrinal nodded.
 "My first bringing-back."
 Their mother had been listening from inside.
 She came out and took the shoes in her hands.
 The moment she saw the blue stain, she understood.
 "This stain has become a member of the family."
 Naval said, "Because of this stain, I got a lower price."
 Mrinal replied, "Because of this stain, I recognized them."
 The next day was Mrinal's first class.
 Naval went with her as far as the bus stand.
 He was wearing the black shoes again.
 The new strap was still stiff, so the lace kept tightening as he walked.

There was time before the bus arrived.

Mrinal took the bag from her shoulder and placed it on the bench.

"Is it hurting your foot?" she asked.

"It's a new strap. It will yield in two days."

"Rahim took twelve hundred. It ought to yield."

Naval laughed.

He stretched his right foot forward.

The morning sunlight fell on the blue crescent.

The bus appeared at the turn.

Mrinal lifted her bag.

Naval said, "Keep the rest of the scholarship money carefully."

Walking toward the bus, Mrinal said, "I've written the account."

"Where did you write it?"

She put a hand on the receipt inside her bag.

"One line for the college. One line for the shoes."

The bus stopped.

Mrinal climbed aboard.

She sat by the window and looked down.

Naval was still standing there.

From that distance, the blue stain on the front of his right shoe could not be seen.

But Mrinal knew - it was still there.

STORY 134

The Lost Purse

In Laheriasarai, Darbhanga, the evening rain had stopped, but the sky was still trembling in the potholes of the road.

Raghuvir was shaking the water from the canopy of his rickshaw.

The day's earnings had not been much.

At noon, his driving permit had been withheld at the transport inspection post, so he was driving a rented rickshaw.

His own rickshaw stood in the veranda at home; the red reflector at the back was broken, and the brake cable still had to be replaced.

The inspecting officer had said, "Get it repaired, pay the fine, and come on Monday with the papers."

That sentence had scratched at Raghuvir's mind all day.

He felt that even a single day's stoppage was a heavy punishment for a poor man.

At around seven in the evening, a middle-aged passenger in a white kurta boarded at Tower Chowk.

He had a thin bag of papers in his hand and a few drops of rain on his head.

"Take me to the old quarters behind the District Magistrate's office," he said.

Raghuvir put his weight on the pedals without replying.

On the way, the passenger searched inside his bag twice.

Once he said, "These papers eat up a person's whole day."

Raghuvir replied before he could stop himself, "It isn't the papers' day that goes. It's the person's day."

The passenger looked at him, but said nothing.

At the gate of the quarters, he paid the fare.

When he found himself five rupees short, he searched his bag again.

Raghuvir said, "Let it be. Next time."

"Will there be a next time?"

"In this city, the roads keep circling back to the same places."

The passenger gave a faint smile and went inside.

Raghuvir turned back toward the station.

After dropping two more passengers, he stopped the rickshaw beneath the awning of a tea stall.

When he lifted a corner of the seat cushion, he found a black leather purse pressed underneath.

The purse was heavy.

For a moment, he looked around before doing anything else.

After the rain, the road had grown sparse.

The shopkeeper was putting away his stove.

Before opening the purse, Raghuvir turned it over in his palm for a few moments.

His daughter Anushka's school fee had to be paid the next day.

The box of medicine for his mother was also almost empty.

His pocket held three hundred and twenty-seven rupees, the earnings of the entire day.

When he opened the purse, the first compartment held not a thick bundle of cash, but four five-hundred-rupee notes and some smaller change.

The second compartment held an identity card.

The moment Raghuvir saw the photograph, his hand stopped.

It was the same officer who had withheld his driving permit that afternoon.

Name - Ashok Kumar Jha.

First surprise rose inside Raghuvir, then a hot thought.

"Papers on Monday," the officer had said.

Now the officer's own papers were in Raghuvir's hand.

The shopkeeper asked, "What did you find?"

Raghuvir closed the purse.

"Someone's belonging."

"Is there a name and address?"

"The identity card has an address too."

"Then give it back tomorrow."

Raghuvir said nothing.

Keeping the purse with him until the next day suddenly felt heavy.

He turned the rented rickshaw around and headed toward the old quarters.

The gate was closed.

A boy sat on the veranda inside with a book in his hands.

Raghuvir called out.

The boy went inside, and a few moments later the same passenger came out.

This time he had changed out of his kurta and was wearing a plain vest.

Raghuvir held out the purse.

"It was left in the rickshaw."

At the sight of the purse, Ashok Jha stood stunned for a moment.

He immediately opened the compartments and checked the identity card, the keys, and the notes.

"I hadn't even realized yet that it was missing."

"I found it just now."

Ashok Jha asked someone inside to bring a chair.

Raghuvir shook his head.

"I have to go back toward the station."

The officer studied his face carefully.

"I feel as though I've seen you somewhere."

Raghuvir's left hand moved instinctively toward the pocket of his shirt, where the inspection receipt lay folded.

He did not take it out.

"At the checkpoint this afternoon."

Ashok Jha's brows rose slightly.

"Oh - the rickshaw with the broken red reflector?"

"Yes, during the afternoon inspection."

"Your driving permit was withheld?"

"Yes. Until Monday."

For a few moments, only the drip of rain was heard on the veranda.

Holding the purse in his hand, Ashok Jha said, "You could have -"

Raghuvir cut him short.

"The purse is yours."

The officer did not finish the sentence.

Raghuvir added, "The driving permit is a separate account."

Ashok Jha slowly nodded.

"Come on Monday with proof of the repairs."

"Whatever the rule requires, I'll do it."

Raghuvir turned to leave.

When he reached the gate, the officer called from behind, "Wait."

He took a five-hundred-rupee note from the purse and held it out.

"Keep this."

Raghuvir looked at the note.

"The fare was five rupees short."

At first, Ashok Jha did not understand.

Raghuvir said, "Those five rupees can be paid next time. Not five hundred."

The boy sitting on the veranda burst out laughing.

Ashok Jha too suppressed a smile.

The note went back into the purse.

Raghuvir returned toward the station.

When he reached home that night, Anushka was sitting with her school admission book open.

"Babu, tomorrow is the last day to pay the fee," she said.

Raghuvir placed the three hundred and twenty-seven rupees from his pocket on the table.

His wife Nirmala counted them and said, "This won't be enough."

"I'll borrow two hundred from Haricharan in the morning."

Nirmala asked, "What happened with the driving permit today?"

Raghuvir took out the inspection receipt and handed it to her.

“Monday.”

Anushka began to read the paper.

“Red reflector, brake cable, fine...”

She looked at her father.

“Why did everything have to be done at once?”

A tired smile came to Raghuvir’s lips.

“Because the rickshaw too decided that there should be only one day for emptying its owner’s pocket.”

Nirmala did not laugh.

She asked, “How much will you have to pay the owner of the rented rickshaw?”

“One hundred and fifty a day.”

For some time, the household accounts continued.

Raghuvir did not mention the purse.

It seemed improper to him to connect that incident with the financial trouble at home.

In the morning, he borrowed two hundred rupees from Haricharan.

Anushka’s fee was paid.

During the day, the mechanic replaced the red reflector, tightened the brake cable, and also fixed the loose screw of the rear bell.

The mechanic joked, “Now you’ll escape the government’s eye.”

Raghuvir replied, “Not the eye. It has to pass the inspection.”

On Monday morning, there was a long queue outside the transport office.

Raghuvir stood there with the repair receipt, the fine receipt, and the inspection slip in his bag.

A few rickshaw drivers knew him.

One of them said, “Ashok Babu is strict. He won’t release anything without complete papers.”

Another asked, “Will your work get done?”

Raghuvir said, “I have every paper they asked for.”

He did not mention the purse here either.

At around ten, his turn came.

Inside the room, Ashok Jha sat behind a desk.

Two assistants were examining files.

When Raghuvir entered, the officer recognized him for a moment, but no special expression appeared on his face.

“Receipt.”

Raghuvir handed over the papers.

“Reflector replaced?”

“Yes. I had it replaced yesterday.”

“Brakes?”

“New cable. Tension checked.”

Ashok Jha told an assistant, "Go outside and inspect the vehicle."

For a moment, a question rose in Raghuvir's mind - an inspection even after he had returned the purse?

Immediately, his own words came back to him: the driving permit was a separate account.

He went outside without a word.

The assistant examined the reflector, pressed the brake, and noted down the number.

Then the two returned inside.

Ashok Jha marked the fine receipt.

"The inspection is complete."

He took the driving permit from a drawer and held it out to Raghuvir.

"Don't delay repairs in future."

Raghuvir took the document in his hand.

"I won't delay again."

That was all.

No thanks, no special concession, no waiver of the fine.

Raghuvir stepped outside and was putting the papers back into his bag on the veranda when he heard a voice behind him.

"Raghuvirji."

He turned.

Ashok Jha was standing at the doorway.

There was a five-rupee coin in his hand.

"The fare left over from that day."

Raghuvir laughed.

"Didn't I say next time?"

The officer placed the coin in his palm.

"Consider this the next time."

Raghuvir put the coin in his pocket.

Then Ashok Jha said quietly, "I didn't tell anyone in the office about the purse."

"Why not in the office?"

"If I had, people would have thought your driving permit was returned because of that."

Raghuvir looked at him for a few moments.

"You did right."

Ashok Jha asked, "You didn't tell anyone either?"

"Not even at home."

"Why not at home?"

Raghuvir adjusted the strap of his bag on his shoulder.

"What wasn't mine - its story wasn't part of my earnings either."

Ashok Jha searched for an answer, but Raghuvir had already started down the stairs.

Outside, his own rickshaw stood waiting.

The new red reflector shone in the sunlight.

His first passenger was an elderly woman who wanted to go to the market.

She sat down and asked the fare.

Raghuvir told her the amount.

She took coins from her bundle and found herself five rupees short.

“Son, I’ll give you the five rupees later.”

Raghuvir put his foot on the pedal.

“Next time.”

The rickshaw moved slowly onto the road.

In his pocket, the five-rupee coin Ashok Jha had given him made a soft sound.

Raghuvir did not put his hand in to touch it.

At the turn ahead, the glint of the new red reflector appeared for a moment in the mirror behind him, and then the road straightened out.

STORY 135

The Rented Room

In that narrow lane of Laheriasarai, the morning sun arrived late.

The houses on either side stood so close that from one roof you could see the clothes hanging on the next.

Suman Mandal had been living for three years in the outer room of Harimohan Thakur's house.

The room was small - one cot, one table, two wooden planks, and an earthen water pitcher by the window.

But for Suman, that room was his first place of his own in the city.

He studied at a teacher-training institute and, in the evenings, tutored two children to pay for his food and rent.

His home was toward Araria.

His mother often wrote in her letters - "Look after your studies first."

Suman would reply - "Everything is fine here."

That sentence was the cheapest reassurance he could give her.

One evening in Sawan, Harimohan Babu sat on the veranda looking through his ledger.

Suman came to pay the rent.

He counted out thirteen hundred rupees and placed them on the table.

Harimohan Babu counted the money, tore off a receipt, then removed his spectacles and said -

"From next month, you'll have to pay fifteen hundred."

Suman thought he had heard wrong.

"An increase of two hundred?"

"Yes," Harimohan Babu answered briefly.

Suman asked, "Why is it going up?"

Harimohan Babu closed the ledger.

"Household expenses have gone up."

That was all he said.

Suman's eyes went to the broken bucket in one corner of the veranda, where rainwater was dripping from the roof.

Three months earlier he had mentioned that leak.

Harimohan Babu had then said - "We'll look at it after the rains."

The rain was not letting up, but the rent was going up.

Suman said nothing.

The following month he paid fifteen hundred.

To find the extra two hundred, he took on a new pupil for evening tuition.
Now on Wednesdays and Saturdays his dinner came late.
The second month, too, fifteen hundred went out.
In the third month, a letter came from home.

His younger sister had been admitted to school; money was needed for her uniform and notebooks.

Suman sent seven hundred rupees home from his savings.

That same week, the institute put up a notice announcing the last date for the examination fee.

One thousand rupees.

Suman read that line again and again.

There were three weeks until the deadline.

He began calculating.

He could take on more evening tuition, but the examination was near.

He could cut down on food, but only the previous month he had run a fever for two days.

Asking for money from home was something he could not accept.

That night, sitting in his room, he opened the old tin box.

It held receipts, postage stamps, two extra pens, and money kept for emergencies.

Three hundred and sixty rupees came out.

On the blank backs of old receipts he wrote the calculation -

"Fee - 1000."

"In hand - 360."

"Balance - 640."

Then he heard Harimohan Babu cough at the door.

"Why is the lamp burning so late?"

Suman closed the box.

"The examination is near."

"Have you paid the fee?"

Suman was silent for a moment.

"I will."

Harimohan Babu did not come inside.

From the doorway he said - "Don't miss the deadline."

Then he walked away.

On the first day of the fourth month, Suman paid fifteen hundred.

As he took the receipt, he asked -

"Babu, if I leave the room, how many days in advance do I need to tell you?"

Harimohan Babu's pen paused for a moment.

"Tell me before the month ends."

"I'll leave when this month is over."

Harimohan Babu looked at him.

“Have you found another room?”

“Yes. Behind the institute.”

Harimohan Babu asked, “How much is the rent?”

Suman said, “Twelve hundred.”

Harimohan Babu lowered his eyes to the ledger again.

He said only, “All right.”

Suman waited for him to say something more - that the rent would not be increased, that he should stay, or at least to offer some excuse about the leaking roof.

Nothing else was said that time.

That night Suman’s mind was made up.

There was no question of paying a fifth month’s rent; on the last day of the month, he packed his belongings.

The cot would not fit on one rickshaw, so he left it at Harimohan Babu’s house; the new room already had a cot belonging to the landlord.

The table, the planks, the clothes, and the tin box were taken away.

Harimohan Babu stood on the veranda.

“Here are the five hundred you gave as a security deposit.”

Suman was surprised.

“I hammered nails into the wall. Deduct it.”

“There is no charge for nails.”

“One pane in the window was already cracked, but people will say I broke it.”

“I remember. It was cracked before you came.”

After taking the five hundred, Suman held out the key.

Harimohan Babu placed the key in his palm and said -

“Do well in the examination.”

The resentment stored inside Suman stung all the more at that ordinary sentence.

He merely said, “Yes,” and walked out.

The new room was near the institute, but the lane was filled with noise all day.

The rent was twelve hundred, yet in the very first month the landlady took three hundred in advance for electricity.

Suman calculated silently - he had thought leaving the old room would save money, but moving had expenses of its own.

The last date for the examination fee was now four days away.

There were seven hundred and ten rupees in the tin box.

He decided he would submit an application to the institute accounts office, asking permission to pay the remaining money two weeks later.

At noon the next day, he reached the accounts office with the application in hand.

An elderly clerk sat inside, turning the pages of a ledger.

Suman gave his name and roll number.

The clerk checked the ledger, then looked at his application.

"What are you asking extra time for?"

"For the examination fee."

"Your fee has already been paid."

Suman laughed, as though he had failed to understand the words.

"I haven't paid it."

The clerk checked the ledger again.

"Name - Suman Mandal?"

Suman answered the first question with "Yes."

"Roll number one hundred and twenty-seven?"

Again Suman said, "Yes."

"One thousand rupees. Paid the day before yesterday."

The application in Suman's hand went slack.

"Who paid it?"

The clerk opened the receipt book beside him.

"Harimohan Thakur."

For several moments Suman stared at that name.

On the receipt, the payer's name had been written as his own - "Suman Mandal."

Below it, in small letters inside brackets, was written only - "Amount received from: Harimohan Thakur."

Suman's first feeling was not gratitude.

It was anger.

He folded the application, put it in his pocket, and went straight to the old lane.

Harimohan Babu was not on the veranda.

A ledger lay open on the old charpoy in the courtyard.

After a while he came out from inside, carrying a small bundle of string.

Without offering a greeting, Suman asked -

"Why did you pay my fee?"

Harimohan Babu stopped at the tone of his voice.

"You found out?"

"Answer me."

Harimohan Babu sat down on the charpoy.

Pointing to it, he said, "Sit."

"I'll stand."

"Then stand."

For a few moments neither spoke.

Then Harimohan Babu turned the ledger toward himself and showed him five lines.

On one side of every line was written thirteen hundred.

On the other side, two hundred.

In small red letters - "Suman - fee."

Suman bent over the ledger.

Five lines.

Two hundred each.

One thousand.

His voice softened, but his anger had not gone.

"So the rent hadn't really been increased?"

"The two hundred I added for you, I kept aside each month."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Harimohan Babu closed the ledger.

"That night I didn't see your box. But I kept hearing your calculations. Letters came from home - sometimes for your sister, sometimes for medicine, sometimes for seed. Whatever remained, you sent home. The examination fee kept being pushed back."

"It was my money."

Harimohan Babu agreed. "Yes. It was your money."

"Then you should have asked me."

Harimohan Babu did not argue at once.

"I should have."

Suman had not been prepared for that answer.

Harimohan Babu continued -

"I thought that if you believed the extra two hundred was rent, you wouldn't spend it. When the deadline came near, I would return it. But you left the room. I didn't understand that the raised rent would hurt you that much."

Suman looked toward the corner where the roof used to leak.

A new tin sheet had now been fitted there.

"I thought you wouldn't repair the roof, only raise the rent."

Harimohan Babu gave a faint smile.

"The roof was repaired late. That was my fault too."

"And the fact that I left the room?"

"I cannot decide the price of that mistake."

The first crack appeared in Suman's anger, but he was in no hurry to soften.

"You could have told me before paying the fee."

"I could have."

"Then why didn't you?"

"I was afraid you would send the money home again."

"If I had sent it home, that would have been my decision."

Harimohan Babu nodded.

"I understand that now."

He opened the bundle of string.

Inside were copies of Suman's five old rent receipts.

Each showed thirteen hundred as rent, with a separate mark for two hundred.

"Keep these. If you ever think I swallowed your money, the account will be in front of you."

Suman did not take the copies.

"I understand the account."

Harimohan Babu did not insist.

Suman turned to leave, then stopped.

"The rent in the new room is twelve hundred."

Harimohan Babu said, "Good."

"But she took three hundred extra for electricity."

For the first time Harimohan Babu laughed openly.

"Accounts never stop following you anywhere."

A smile came to Suman's lips too, but he suppressed it at once.

"Don't laugh yet."

"All right, I'm not laughing."

Another brief silence spread between them.

Suman walked out.

The examination came.

Whether he wrote it well or not, he did not speak to Harimohan Babu about it again.

Two months later, the result was announced.

Suman had passed.

That evening in the new room, he opened the tin box.

The old receipts lay on one side, the institute's receipt on the other.

He took out two new envelopes.

On one he wrote - "Rent."

On the other - "Next Fee."

He looked for a while at the receipt lying between them.

Then he did not put it into the envelope marked "Next Fee."

He placed the receipt with the old rent receipts.

As he closed the box, from the roof of some house in the lane came the sound of dripping water.

Suman reached out and shifted the bucket in the corner of his room into the proper place.

STORY 136

The Nameless Parcel

In the old neighbourhood on the eastern side of Madhubani, the evening sunlight had shrunk as far as the veranda pillars.

Just inside the doorway, beside the tulsi altar, lay a parcel wrapped in thick brown paper.

On top, in a clear hand, was written: “House of Shivkant Mishra, Pipra Lane.”

The space for the sender’s name was blank.

Shivkant Mishra picked up the parcel, first testing its weight and then examining the knot in the cord.

“Who left it here?”

His wife Malti, seated on the veranda, shook her head.

“It was already lying there when I noticed it.”

By the time their elder son Devesh returned from the shop, everyone in the house had gathered around the parcel.

Devesh’s wife Archana wiped her hands after leaving the stove and came outside.

Their granddaughter Rita tried to read the blue stamp on one corner of the parcel.

Only the words “Darbhanga Goods Depot” were clear; half the date was buried in a fold of the paper.

“Open it,” Rita said.

Instead of cutting the cord, Shivkant began to work the knot loose.

It was an unusual knot—a cord wound three times, with a small reversed loop in the middle.

After considerable effort, the paper came open.

Inside were four small bundles.

The first contained two rubber rings for the hand-pump.

The second held a geometry set and a thick exercise book for Rita.

The third contained a cord for Malti’s spectacles and two soft nose pads.

The fourth held a thick, hard-bound ledger for Devesh’s shop.

There was not a single written line inside the parcel.

For a few moments, no one spoke.

Then Archana slowly looked towards an inner pillar.

A small household list had been written there in charcoal: “Pump rings, Rita’s instruments, Mother’s spectacle cord, shop ledger.”

All four objects in the parcel were on that very list.

The list had been there for a month, because each time some larger expense intervened and these small things were postponed until the next market day.

Holding the ledger, Devesh said, "How could someone outside know all four things at once?"

Malti immediately named their married daughter, Sushma.

"She came during the festival last year. She must have seen the list."

Rita said, "If Auntie had done this, why would she leave off her name?"

Shivkant turned the parcel paper over again.

There was no note, no price, no shop stamp.

Just then the younger son, Nandkishore, came in.

Everyone at home called him Nandu.

An old gamchha hung from his shoulder, dust covered his feet, and his eyes carried the heaviness of half-sleep.

"What's this crowd for?" he asked.

Excitedly, Rita set all four bundles before him.

Nandu looked at them once and said only, "Good. At least the pump will leak less now."

Devesh stared at him.

"You're not surprised?"

"Should rubber rings be surprising?" Nandu laughed.

With that, he went towards the inner room.

No one in the house trusted Nandu much with any serious responsibility.

He had left his bachelor's examination unfinished twice, taken up and abandoned two or three small jobs, and for the past six months his habit of sleeping until well into the day had irritated everyone.

As soon as evening fell, he often left the house and returned towards dawn.

When asked, he said, "I have work near the goods depot."

Once, in irritation, Devesh had said, "It is difficult even to call it a job when there is neither a post nor a monthly salary."

After that day, Nandu had almost stopped talking at home about his earnings.

The word "good-for-nothing" was heard less often in front of him, and more often in his absence.

The day after the parcel arrived, the search for the secret sender began.

Sushma said plainly that she had not sent it.

Devesh's in-laws denied it as well.

Shivkant asked two of his former pupils, because one of them lived in Darbhanga.

Both laughed and said they knew nothing about any parcel.

Rita wrote a list of possible names on a sheet of paper and began crossing them out one by one.

The names dwindled; the mystery grew.

On the third day, something occurred to Malti.

“Who took the measurements for the pump rings?”

Archana said, “Nandu.”

“And the spectacle cord?”

“Rita mentioned it, but Nandu was the one who checked the size.”

Devesh said at once, “That does not mean he sent it.”

The sentence came too quickly, as though even linking Nandu’s name with such a possibility made him uncomfortable.

Shivkant said nothing.

He gathered up the parcel cord and placed it in his old file.

A week later, a second parcel arrived.

This time it contained only one thing—a light woollen shawl for Malti.

Four days earlier, when the nights had turned colder, Malti had been sewing the torn corner of her old shawl and had said it was not right to spend money on a new one just then.

There was no reason for anyone except the five people in the house to have heard that remark.

The second parcel, too, bore the blue stamp of the Darbhanga Goods Depot.

The cord was different, but the knot was the same—three turns and a reversed loop.

This time Devesh did not laugh.

“Someone inside the house is carrying our talk outside.”

Archana’s face tightened slightly.

“Passing talk outside and sending things are not the same thing.”

Devesh realised that his words had sounded like suspicion directed at his wife.

“I wasn’t talking about you.”

“Then about whom?”

No one had an answer.

Nandu was not at home that night.

When he returned at dawn, Malti was sitting on the veranda wrapped in the shawl.

He touched its edge and asked, “Is it warm?”

Malti said, “It is.”

Then her eyes fell on her son’s hand.

There were two fresh blisters on his right palm; one had burst and darkened.

“How did your palm get scraped?”

“A rope rubbed it.”

“What rope?”

“The rope for tying sacks.”

Nandu hung up his gamchha and went inside.

Malti watched him go for a long time.

That very day, Shivkant decided to go to the Darbhanga Goods Depot.

Devesh wanted to accompany him, but Shivkant refused.

“Open the shop. I’ll only ask around and come back.”

After noon he took a bus to Darbhanga.

The goods depot stood behind the main road under a long tin roof.

On one side were piles of boxes, sacks and bamboo baskets; on the other stood a weighing scale and a table where receipts were written.

Shivkant showed the papers from both parcels.

The elderly clerk at the table recognised the stamp, but there was no firm record that disclosed the sender’s name.

“No name was entered. The charge had already been paid.”

“Who paid it?”

The clerk turned over a stack of old papers and shook his head.

“A great many people come here every day.”

Disappointed, Shivkant was about to leave.

Just then came the sound of a sack being dragged from behind the roofed shed.

A young man was straightening two sacks and setting them on a wooden platform.

An old gamchha hung from his shoulder.

Shivkant’s feet stopped where they were.

Nandu had not seen him.

He gathered the torn edge of a sack, threaded thick blue cord through a large needle, wound it three times and tightened a small reversed loop in the middle.

The very same knot.

From behind, the elderly clerk called out, “Nandu, enter the charges for yesterday’s two parcels in the ledger.”

Nandu turned.

The moment he saw his father, his hand froze in mid-air. For a few moments, the two simply looked at each other.

Shivkant slowly opened his file and took out the cord from the first parcel.

“Where did you learn this knot?”

Nandu lowered his eyes. “Here, at the goods depot.”

“And the parcels sent home?”

Nandu did not hurry to answer. Behind him sacks were being unloaded from the roof of a bus, and a fine layer of dust rose in the air. “I sent them.”

Shivkant’s first question was not about the money. “Why no name?”

Nandu sat down on a sack. “If I had written my name, the questions would have reached home before the things did—where did the money come from, is the work permanent, why did you spend on this?”

He looked at the blisters on his palm. "The argument would have arrived before the parcel."

Shivkant remained silent. Nandu went on, "I handle sacks, boxes and parcels here from eight at night until three in the morning. I'm paid by the day. There isn't work every day."

"Why didn't you tell us at home?"

"I did say I had work at the goods depot."

This time Shivkant looked away. He remembered that the answer had indeed been heard, but it had not been believed.

Nandu said, "Mother's shawl was cheap at the shop. I saw Rita's instruments while unloading goods. I had the size for the pump rings. Devesh's ledger cost half as much wholesale."

"What do you keep for yourself?"

Nandu did not laugh. "I eat at home. My gamchha is still good."

Shivkant wanted to say something, but amid the noise of the goods depot he could not choose the words.

He asked only, "You come home at dawn and sleep until late in the day?"

"After the night shift."

That short answer made Shivkant see afresh many mornings from the past six months, when he had inwardly resented Nandu for sleeping late.

On the bus home, father and son sat on the same seat; midway Nandu, overcome by sleep, rested his head against the wooden window frame.

For the first time, Shivkant did not wake him.

When they reached home, Devesh began firing questions.

Shivkant placed the parcel cord on the table. "We found the sender."

Rita asked at once, "Who?"

Shivkant looked at Nandu. Nandu was taking off his slippers.

Devesh's eyes fell on his palm. All the questions that had been ready only moments earlier vanished.

Malti simply drew one end of the shawl over her son's shoulder. "When you come home at dawn, go straight to sleep."

Nandu said, "I'll eat first." Archana brought a plate from inside.

There was no apology, no grand declaration.

Over dinner, Devesh kept asking about the daily wages at the goods depot, and Nandu kept giving short answers.

Their old friction did not disappear in one night, but the next morning Devesh did not wake Nandu when he opened the shop.

That day Rita took out her sheet of possible senders again.

Beneath all the crossed-out names, she wrote one name without crossing it out: "Uncle Nandu."

After it, in brackets, she added: "Night shift, goods depot."

When Nandu woke in the afternoon, the paper was lying beside his cot.

He read it, picked up a pencil and crossed out the heading “Secret Donor.”
Above it he wrote: “Things the Household Still Needed.”

Rita watched, but said nothing.

Nandu placed the pencil beside the old list on the pillar.

All four earlier items on the list had already been crossed out.

Below them, in a new line written in Malti’s hand, were the words: “A new gamchha for Nandu.”

STORY 137

Behind the Photograph

When the western room of the old house in Saharsa was opened, the smell of dust came first. Then the lid of the iron trunk creaked.

Udayan Jha opened the window shutters. When the thin evening light fell inside, the shapes of the old clothes, brass, papers and wooden objects became distinct from one another.

The house was to be repaired the following month. For three days they had been talking about sorting out the things that were no longer in use.

His sister Swarnalata brought a thick sack from the veranda. "Broken things go in this. What we keep goes separately."

Udayan laughed. "There are more broken things in Baba's room, and less courage to throw them away."

Inside the trunk lay folded old dhotis, two brass plates, a copper lota, a few letters and a wooden frame.

Within the frame was a grey photograph. Its edges had turned yellow.

In the middle sat an elderly man with a moustache. A teenage boy stood to his right and a girl to his left.

The girl had the end of her sari over her head, but her face did not seem to resemble anyone in the family.

Swarnalata took the photograph in her hand. "Could this be Great-grandfather Jagdish Narayan?"

"It looks like him."

"And on the right—Baba as a child?"

Udayan shook his head. "The ages do not match. Baba had not even been born then."

Just then Udayan's son Aniruddh came in from behind them.

He had been given the job of selling off the old things. An antique dealer from town was due the next day.

Looking at the photograph, he said, "The frame is teak. We could sell it separately."

Swarnalata said at once, "First let us find out who these people are."

"Who is going to remember the names of everyone in all the old photographs in this house?" Aniruddh said. "And what will we do with the frame?"

Udayan did not answer. He placed the photograph against the wall.

The next afternoon the antique dealer, Mohan Sah, arrived.

He weighed the brass objects in his hands, examined the joints of the wooden box and tested the metal of the copper lota.

When he lifted the photograph, he found the paper at the back of the frame loose.

“May I open this?” he asked.

Udayan said, “Open it to inspect the frame, but do not damage the photograph.”

Mohan carefully removed the thin wooden backing. The edge of the paper inside was folded.

As soon as the photograph came out, Swarnalata said, “Wait.”

On the back was a line in blue ink. The writing had faded, but it was still legible:

“Kaushalya is to be regarded not as a daughter, but as one of this household —the debt of that day can never be repaid.”

Below it were only two initials: “J. Na.”

For a while no one in the room spoke.

Mohan Sah put the photograph on the table. His interest lay in the frame, not in the family’s silence.

Swarnalata asked softly, “Who was Kaushalya?”

The name seemed familiar to Udayan, but his memory stopped there.

“Grandmother sometimes used to speak of a Kaushalya Mausi... or am I remembering it wrong?”

Aniruddh read the line on the back again. “Not a daughter, one of the household... could she have been someone who worked for the family?”

Swarnalata looked at him. “Do not put a role before a name before we know.”

Mohan Sah quoted a price. The money he offered for the frame was very little.

Aniruddh was no longer in favour of selling it immediately. He put the photograph back into the frame. “This is not going anywhere yet.”

That evening, after dinner, Udayan opened the old letters.

Most were connected with weddings, upanayan ceremonies, illnesses and accounts of the fields.

Kaushalya’s name did not appear clearly anywhere.

But in one letter the words “Sister Kaushalya” were written. The date was about sixty-two years old.

The letter was addressed to Shashibhushan, the younger brother of Jagdish Narayan.

Only three lines could still be read:

“Sister Kaushalya is now in Madhepur. Tell her that the child survived. I shall remember my debt to her.”

Swarnalata sat for a long time with the letter in her hand. “Which child?”

Udayan's eyes went to the photograph of his own father hanging on the wall.

His father, Harinarayan, had been the only surviving son of the household.

All that was ever said in the family about his birth was that the night he was born had been very difficult.

The next day the brother and sister went to their aunt Vimala Devi.

Vimala Devi was eighty-four. Her hearing had weakened, but her memory for old names was clear.

At the name Kaushalya, the winnowing tray in her hands came to a halt.

"Kaushalya Di?" she asked. "Who told you about her?"

Udayan showed her the photograph.

The old woman first looked at the front, then at the line on the back.

Her eyes did not fill with tears; only the crease between her brows deepened.

"This has come out after a very long time."

Swarnalata moved closer to her. "Who was she?"

Vimala Devi set the winnowing tray down and said, "When my mother gave birth to Harinarayan Bhaiya, the floodwater had reached the courtyard that night."

"The dai was late in arriving. Kaushalya Di came by boat from the hamlet across the water."

"She had experience with childbirth. She stayed in this house for three days. My mother's life was saved, and the child survived."

"And then?" Udayan asked.

"After that the people of the house began to call her sister."

"Her mother had earlier worked pounding paddy for this household. But Jagdish Kaka accepted Kaushalya Di as a sister."

"She came and went as though she were a daughter of the house."

Aniruddh, who had come with them, asked, "Then why was her name no longer heard later?"

Vimala Devi looked at him. "A name does not disappear in a single day."

"First the place where she sat became separate. Then invitations to weddings grew fewer. Then the new generation stopped asking."

"The line of caste that the old people had sometimes crossed was made dark again by those who came after them."

She fell silent for a few moments.

"Kaushalya Di had a son—Rameshwar. He settled near Madhepur."

"I had heard that his daughter still lives there."

Swarnalata asked, "Her name?"

"Sumitra."

Getting to Madhepur was not difficult, yet Udayan did not go for three days.

He felt that seeking out an old relationship was not merely a matter of finding an address.

To arrive one day at someone's door with a photograph in hand when one's own family had gradually forgotten that person did not seem easy.

On the fourth day Swarnalata herself said, "Let us go."

"Whether a relationship is renewed or not is her right. But if we learn the name and then remain silent, that will be forgetting her a second time."

The house in Madhepur was built of a mixture of mud and brick.

There was a tulsi platform in front and, to one side, a small room used for sewing work.

Sumitra Devi was about sixty.

When Swarnalata mentioned Kaushalya's name, Sumitra first seated the guests inside and then asked, "How do you know her?"

Udayan placed the photograph before her.

Sumitra took it in her hands very slowly.

The moment she saw the girl in the picture, she moved away from the back of the chair and sat upright. "This is Nani."

Aniruddh's eyes remained fixed on the photograph.

Sumitra went inside and returned with a small wooden box.

Inside were two old letters, a piece of cloth and a small brass key.

One of the letters had been written by Jagdish Narayan.

It mentioned neither land, nor money, nor any share in the house.

It was simply an invitation, written after the rains when the house had been repaired, asking Kaushalya—addressed as "sister"—to come and see the new harvest.

Sumitra said, "Nani kept this letter with great care."

"She used to say that a big house had once called her one of its own."

"Later she went there less often, but she never threw this letter away."

Udayan's throat went dry. "We knew nothing of this."

Sumitra said simply, "If you did not know, whom should we blame? My mother too spoke very little about that house."

Swarnalata asked, "Have you ever been to Saharsa?"

"I have passed through while changing trains. I have never been to that house."

"Would you come now?"

Sumitra did not answer at once.

She read the line written on the back of the photograph. Her thumb stopped over the words "one of this household."

"First let me keep this photograph with me for one day."

Without thinking, Udayan said, "It is also a photograph of your Nani. Keep it."

Sumitra shook her head. "No."

"The photograph should remain in the house where what is written on it was forgotten."

“Then those written words will be seen every day.”

A week later Sumitra came to Saharsa with her daughter.

It was the first day of repairs on the house. The western room was being emptied.

Mohan Sah had come again to take away wooden objects.

Seeing the old frame, he asked, “You still will not sell this?”

Aniruddh laughed. “The price of this frame has changed.”

Mohan Sah looked at the wood. “The teak is still the same.”

“The price of the wood is the same,” Aniruddh said. “Not the value of the thing.”

Udayan hung the photograph on a new nail inside the veranda.

The writing on the back now faced the wall and could not be seen.

Swarnalata said, “The line is hidden again.”

Aniruddh copied the same sentence onto a small piece of paper and fixed it below the frame.

At the edge he added a name: “Kaushalya Devi, sister of the family.”

Sumitra read the inscription.

She did not ask for anything else to be added before the name.

She simply sat down on the old bench in the veranda where, according to Aunt Vimala, Kaushalya used to sit many years ago.

The repairs to the house began that day with the breaking of a wall.

But Udayan felt that the first repair had taken place not in the wall, but in the family’s memory.

In the evening the trunk was closed again.

The brass plates, the copper lota and some wooden objects went into the pile to be sold.

The photograph remained in the veranda.

Its price was entered in no ledger.

STORY 138

Two Lamps

The day before Diwali, the market at Bisfi was filled with earthen lamps.

Before evening fell, the sellers were lowering their prices, because there was little profit in keeping unsold lamps until the next day and a greater chance of their breaking.

Ten-year-old Nitin was helping Mangru the potter lift his sacks in the market.

Mangru gave him three rupees for the work and, as he was leaving, told him twice, "Go straight home. The crowd will grow."

Nitin stood by a heap of lamps, the coins clenched in his fist.

At his house, not many lamps were lit for Diwali.

His mother, Malati, used to say, "One lamp by the tulsi plant, one at the door—that is enough. Even the oil must be measured."

This year there was not enough oil in the house for two lamps to burn through the night.

Even so, Nitin chose two lamps.

The first was round, flat and entirely plain.

The second had a small bulge on one side, as though the potter's thumbprint had remained in the clay while it was being made.

Nitin kept turning that second lamp over in his hands.

Mangru asked, "Why two? Your mother told you to buy only one."

"One is for the house."

"And the other?"

Nitin pointed towards the river. "For the watchman at the cremation ground."

Mangru opened his mouth to laugh, then stopped. "Who gives him a lamp?"

"I will."

"Do not go there in the evening."

"I will give it before it gets dark."

Mangru gave him two lamps for the three rupees.

He also put in two small cotton wicks. "Take oil from home."

Nitin came home with the lamps tucked under his arm.

Malati was sitting in the veranda, winnowing chura.

An old paddy sack hung on the wall of the house to keep out the cold wind.

In a corner, a little mustard oil remained in a small brass container.

Nitin placed the two lamps before her.

Malati looked first at one lamp, then at the other. "Two?"

"One for the door. I'll give the other at the ghat."

Malati's hands stopped moving. "Which ghat?"

"The cremation ghat. The watchman's hut was dark when I saw it last week. The tea-seller Kaka said his lantern had broken."

Malati was silent for a few moments. "When did you go there?"

"In the daytime. Coming back from school. The shorter road passes that way."

Malati began winnowing the chura again. "Come back before dark."

Nitin understood that he had been given permission.

He looked at the oil container. "For the second lamp?"

Malati lifted the container.

When the oil moved inside, the bottom could be seen.

She poured half into the first lamp and half into the second. "If the lamp at home goes out, I will not fill it again."

"It won't go out."

"A lamp does not obey promises when there is wind."

Nitin smiled.

He wrapped the second lamp in a piece of old newspaper, kept the wick separate and poured its share of oil into a small bottle.

His father, Raghunath, had been doing night work for three months.

Nitin had been told that he had found work guarding a warehouse across the river.

He left before evening and returned at dawn.

During the day he was usually asleep.

Nitin did not like this work because evening meals with his father had stopped.

But he understood that without night work, the sack of rice at home would empty too quickly.

That day Raghunath had left earlier than usual.

Nitin had asked, "Work even on Diwali night?"

Raghunath had replied, "Where work is done at night, guarding is even more necessary on a festival night."

Nitin had not paid much attention to the answer then.

In the evening sky, smoke and a light mist were becoming the same colour.

Nitin took the shorter road towards the river.

A few lamps had already begun to glow at the doors of village houses.

Children were saving their boxes of sparklers.

Here there was the smell of milk, there of jaggery sweets, and elsewhere of mustard oil drifting on the air.

The cremation ghat lay a little away from the main road.

There were stacks of bamboo, old patches of ash, two neem trees and a small tin-roofed shed.

Budhan, who sold tea near the ghat, was packing up his cart.

Nitin greeted him.

"Why are you here?" Budhan asked.

Nitin showed him the newspaper bundle. "A lamp for the watchman Kaka."

Budhan's eyebrows rose slightly. "Do you know him?"

"No. But he lives in darkness."

Budhan looked at the bundle, then at Nitin. "He is here today. He has gone down near the wood shed. But go back quickly."

Nitin began descending the steps of the ghat.

Down below, before darkness fully settled, the river water looked grey.

In the distance a thin line of smoke was rising from one place.

He lowered his eyes.

More than death, it was the silence of the place that seemed strange to him.

Nowhere else in the village was it ever so quiet.

Near the tin shed, a man with his back turned was moving bamboo poles.

He wore an old grey shirt and had a gamchha wrapped around his head.

From a distance Nitin called, "Kaka!"

The man stopped but did not turn around.

Nitin came closer. "Kaka, I've brought a lamp for you."

This time the man turned slowly, but one end of the gamchha was still drawn over part of his face.

In the evening dimness his face could not be seen clearly.

"Who told you I needed a lamp?" The voice had been made deliberately heavy.

"No one. Your lantern is broken."

The man glanced towards Budhan's cart. "He talks too much."

Nitin opened the paper.

He took out the lamp with the clay bulge on its side and placed it beneath the shed.

"This is the second one. The first will burn at home."

"Why is the second one here?"

"Festivals happen in every home. Doesn't the place where the watchman stays count as a home?"

The man did not answer.

Nitin opened the little bottle of oil.

The wind had grown a little stronger.

Using his body as a shield, he poured the oil into the lamp and straightened the wick.

He did not have any matches.

"Do you have a light?"

The man searched his shirt pocket.

As he took out a matchbox, his right hand came into the last strip of daylight.

There was an old cut mark on the tip of his middle finger.

Nitin's eyes stopped on the mark.

He knew a scar like that.

A year earlier, Raghunath had cut his finger while cutting roofing tin.

After the wound healed, the fingertip had remained slightly bent.

Nitin raised his head.

The man struck a match.

The wind put out the first one.

The second match caught.

He brought it to the wick.

The light rose from below onto his face.

Very softly, the word slipped from Nitin's mouth—"Babu?"

Raghunath's hand went still.

The match had almost burned down to his fingers when he shook it away.

The wick of the lamp was burning now.

For a while, father and son stood silently looking at each other.

"Why did you come here?" Raghunath's voice was his own now.

"To give a lamp to the watchman Kaka."

Raghunath lowered his eyes. "Did you tell your mother?"

"Yes. I told Ma."

"She didn't stop you?"

Instead of answering, Nitin asked, "The warehouse?"

Raghunath rested a hand on one of the bamboo poles of the shed. "The warehouse work ended three months ago. The old keeper of the ghat fell ill. The people who manage the ghat were looking for someone to keep watch at night. I got the work. I could not bring myself to tell you."

"Why did you hide it from me?"

Raghunath looked towards the river. "I thought about what the children at school might say. I thought you might feel ashamed when you heard what your father does."

Nitin looked at the earthen lamp.

The thumb-shaped bulge looked like a small hill in the glow.

"I came to give a lamp to the watchman," he said. "The watchman turned out to be you. What is there to be ashamed of in that?"

Raghunath did not laugh.

But some of the hardness left his face.

"There is enough oil left for the lamp at home?"

"It was divided half and half."

"Your mother?"

“She divided it herself.”

Raghunath closed his eyes for a moment, as though he had found some large answer in that small fact.

Then he said, “Go home now. It is dark.”

Nitin walked two steps and turned back. “Babu, you must not take this lamp home. It stays here.”

“Why should it stay here?”

“I bought it for the watchman.”

This time Raghunath smiled faintly. “All right. The watchman will keep it here.”

Nitin climbed the steps and reached Budhan’s cart.

Budhan tried to read his face but asked nothing.

He only said, “Can you see the road?”

“The road is perfectly clear.”

As Nitin walked back towards the village, he kept seeing lamps at houses far and near.

The sound of firecrackers split the air from time to time.

His father’s night meals, his tired face at dawn, the smell of smoke settled in his shirt—all of it suddenly made sense in a new way.

When he reached home, Malati was adjusting the wick of the lamp at the door.

“Did you give it?” she asked.

“Yes, I did.”

“Did you meet the watchman?”

Nitin looked at Malati’s face.

Now he understood that she already knew the answer to the question.

“I met him,” he said. “The lamp is burning too.”

Malati’s hand paused for a moment.

Then she added the last drop of oil to the lamp at the door.

She asked nothing.

When the night had deepened a little, Nitin looked from the veranda towards the river.

The cremation ghat could not be seen clearly from there.

Trees, houses and darkness lay between.

But far away, a very small light seemed to be flickering—or perhaps it only looked that way; he could not be certain.

The lamp at the door would sometimes bend in the wind, then straighten again.

Nitin sat beside it.

He no longer needed to wonder where his father worked at night.

STORY 139

The Saree on Credit

When the sari was unfolded in the cloth shop at Laheriasarai, its red border gleamed across the glass counter like evening light.

Shailbala touched the fine pattern along the border with her finger, then immediately drew her hand back.

She had already seen the price tag: four thousand two hundred rupees.

"Put it away," she said. "I don't want anything this expensive."

Instead of folding the cloth, the shopkeeper spread it out again.

"How is it expensive, Didi? It is your niece's wedding. Pay in four instalments."

Shailbala's daughter Rupa was with her.

She watched her mother's eyes more than she watched the sari.

Three days earlier, her mother had taken out her old green sari.

The border was a little worn, but the cloth was still good.

Her younger sister Manju had said over the telephone, "Didi, everyone will be there this time. Come wearing something nice."

After that one sentence, the old green sari had been folded and returned to the trunk.

"How much is each instalment?" Rupa asked.

"One thousand and fifty a month. Four months. That's all."

Shailbala looked at the price tag again.

Her husband, Nandkishor, ran a small bicycle-repair shop on Station Road.

His monthly income was never the same.

There were more punctures during the rains and fewer in winter.

Rupa was in the final year of her bachelor's degree, and the school fees of their younger son Chandan were another expense.

"Let me ask at home first—"

Rupa said softly, "Ma, there are only three days left. Babu will only say that the old sari is fine."

Shailbala smiled. "Of course he will."

The shopkeeper folded the red sari and wrapped it in paper.

"Nandkishorji is an old customer. I'll put it down in his name. The first instalment next month."

Shailbala wanted to object, but by then the paper parcel had reached Rupa's hands.

When they reached home, Nandkishor looked at the parcel and remained silent for a few moments.

When he heard the price, his brows tightened; then he looked at Shailbala's face and they relaxed.

"Four thousand two hundred?"

"In four instalments," Shailbala said.

"Instalments do not reduce the price."

Rupa spoke in between. "A niece gets married only once."

Nandkishor did not laugh.

Coiling the hose he used for filling bicycle tyres, he said, "A wedding may happen only once, but the instalment will come four times."

On the day of the wedding, the marriage hall at Sakri was packed with people.

There were not enough chairs on the veranda.

Music sounded inside, while vehicles made a din outside.

Shailbala was wearing the red sari.

Rupa kept adjusting her pallu again and again.

Manju waved from a distance, but just then the bride's maternal uncle became anxious about a missing garland.

Five minutes later the generator stopped.

Then there were too few plates in the dining line.

Somebody's child was crying, somebody's shoes had gone missing, and somebody was in a hurry to leave in a vehicle.

Twice Shailbala thought that someone would say something about the sari.

Manju would ask where she had bought it.

Her elder sister-in-law would look at the pattern on the border and guess its price.

But the night passed.

No one noticed.

On the way home, Rupa said, "Ma, it looked very beautiful on you."

Shailbala kept looking out of the window into the darkness.

"Apart from you, who even saw it?"

Rupa laughed.

The matter ended there.

The following month, on the day the first instalment was due, road digging began in front of Nandkishor's shop.

For three days, cyclists could not get inside.

His earnings fell.

Instead of one thousand and fifty rupees, five hundred was paid.

The shopkeeper wrote in the account ledger: five hundred received; monthly interest on the balance.

"Interest?" Nandkishor asked.

“If an instalment is broken, that is the rule. If you like, pay the full amount next month.”

Nandkishor said nothing.

He folded the slip and put it in his pocket.

The next month Chandan developed a fever.

There were medicine expenses.

Then came Rupa’s examination fee.

The sari lay folded in the trunk, but its account remained open in the ledger.

Shailbala thought of wearing it a second time to an invitation in the month of Shravan.

Then she changed her mind.

“Why wear something so expensive again and again and wear it out?”

Nandkishor said, “An expensive sari does not become cheaper by being worn.”

At those words Shailbala fell silent.

She thought Nandkishor was taunting her.

In truth, Nandkishor was merely stating the arithmetic.

Four months became six.

Six months became ten.

From time to time five hundred, seven hundred, or three hundred rupees were paid.

The interest kept growing in small figures.

Nandkishor understood ledgers, but at the end of each month, whatever remained after oil, rice, medicines and fees was what could be paid.

Halfway through the first year, Shailbala herself went to the shop one day to pay an instalment.

She had three hundred rupees in her hand.

At that very moment a newly married woman and her mother were buying a nine-thousand-rupee sari in cash.

The shopkeeper gave equal attention to both customers, yet Shailbala’s three hundred rupees suddenly seemed extraordinarily small to her.

As he entered the amount in the ledger, she asked, “When will this account finally end?”

The shopkeeper turned the page and said, “The sooner the principal comes down, the sooner it will end. I cannot change the rules.”

“It feels as though the sari is lying at home while the interest is roaming outside.”

This time the shopkeeper looked directly at her.

“Selling cloth is my work. Whether to buy on credit or not is the household’s decision. But I’ll say one thing: if you never wear the cloth, then both the interest and the cloth are wasted.”

Shailbala did not reply.

She took the receipt for three hundred rupees and stepped out.

In the market, fruit, spices, earthenware—everything stood at its own price.

For the first time she understood that the price of the red sari had not stopped at four thousand two hundred rupees; its price was changing with every month of waiting.

That evening she opened the trunk and took out the sari.

For a moment she felt like wearing it the next day.

Then she placed the little receipt on the pallu.

Against the red cloth, the white slip looked startlingly bright.

The sari was folded again.

When a full year had passed, Shailbala took the sari out and aired it in the sun.

The red was unchanged.

A faint crease had formed along the fold of the border.

She shook the sari out and folded it again.

“Why don’t you wear it?” Rupa asked.

“After the debt is paid off.”

Rupa said nothing.

For the first time she understood that the cloth was not being kept in the trunk; it was being kept in the household accounts.

In the second year Rupa began temporary bookkeeping work at a local cooperative society.

After spending her days looking at figures for deposits, withdrawals, interest and instalments, her eyes grew used to them.

One evening she asked Babu for all the old slips.

Nandkishor laughed. “An audit after all this time?”

“Not an audit. I want to understand.”

Rupa arranged all the slips by date.

The original price was four thousand two hundred.

The payments made were separate.

The interest on broken instalments was separate.

In some months interest had even been added on interest, according to the written rules of the shopkeeper.

There had been no cheating; the rule had been printed in small letters on the back of the first slip.

No one in the household had had the time to read those small letters that day.

“How much is left now?” Shailbala asked.

Rupa added the figures.

“One thousand eight hundred and thirty-five.”

Shailbala said in surprise, “After paying so much, still?”

Rupa spread the slips out before her.

"We have already paid more in interest than the original price."

After dinner that night, all four of them sat together.

Rupa proposed that for three months they should hold back some household expenses and clear the remaining amount in one payment.

Chandan offered to stop his extra tuition.

Shailbala refused at once.

"Studies will not stop for the sake of a sari."

In the end, Nandkishor sold the old air pump from his shop, Rupa added the savings from her first two months, and Shailbala pawned one of her two old silver anklets.

Three months later, in red ink, the ledger was marked: "Account closed."

Shailbala sat for a long time with that slip in her hand.

There was less happiness than exhaustion.

Three years later, the niece came to her parents' home with a thick photo album made from the photographs of her wedding.

All the women of the house sat on the veranda turning the pages.

Someone retold the story of the generator failing, someone the shortage of plates, someone the dancing of the groom's friend.

On one page Shailbala appeared.

But half her body was hidden behind another woman.

Only one corner of the red sari's pallu could be seen.

The niece narrowed her eyes and asked, "Mausi, were you wearing red at this wedding?"

Manju said at once, "Red? I don't remember. I thought you were wearing green."

Laughter rose on the veranda.

Shailbala laughed too.

She said nothing.

That evening, after returning home, she opened the trunk.

The red sari lay folded just as before.

In three years it had been worn no more than four times.

She took it out and spread it on the cot.

The pattern on the border still shone, but along with that shine Shailbala now saw the figures on all those slips.

The next morning, as Nandkishor was getting ready to open the shop, Shailbala came into the courtyard wearing the same red sari.

Nandkishor asked in surprise, "Is there some invitation today?"

"No, no invitation."

"Then this sari?"

Shailbala adjusted the pallu on her shoulder.

"It is a sari. I will wear it."

She went out to the market to buy salt, oil and greens.
No one on the way paid any attention to her sari.
This time, neither did she care.

STORY 140

Five Dhurs of Land

In the pale morning mist, a red cord stretched between two corners of five dhurs of land.

At one end of the cord Raghunath Jha held a bamboo stake; at the other stood his younger brother, Jaynath.

Between them, the surveyor Harinarayan had stretched out his brass measuring tape and was reading the figures.

This small plot adjoining the main road was so tiny that if two bullock carts stood there together, half of it would be covered; yet for three months it had become the largest question in the household for the two brothers.

“Take it straight from here,” Raghunath said.

“Father’s old bamboo stake stood on this line.”

Jaynath replied at once, “The stake was moved three times. Look at the measurement on the eastern side in the papers.”

The surveyor wound up the tape and opened it again.

“The paper gives its measurement, but the land lies in its own fashion. Both of you stay calm; then the measurement will be clear.”

Calm had ended three months earlier.

After their father died, the house and fields had been divided long ago, but these five dhurs beside the main road had remained recorded as ‘joint’ property.

At the time, no one had cared about it.

On one side there was an old drain, on the other a thorny thicket, and dust and earth in between.

Villagers placed a foot on it while turning their bicycles; children played marbles there in the evenings.

When land prices rose, it was no longer the size of the five dhurs that caught the eye, but its frontage—directly on the main road.

Raghunath’s son Deepak wanted to open a small tea-and-pakora stall.

By his calculation, a tin roof, two benches and one stove would fit comfortably on the five dhurs.

Jaynath had a different idea.

It was difficult to bring a vehicle from the entrance of his house to the road; he wanted to keep half of the five dhurs open so that the approach could be widened.

The first dispute was only over two cubits of land.

Then old accounts entered those two cubits.

Who had contributed how much to Father's treatment, who had received more land at the time of a wedding, who had sold the fruit from which mango tree—all the old questions came and sat upon those five dhurs.

Raghunath had collected twenty bricks on his veranda.

One day Jaynath saw them and asked, "What are these for?"

"To mark the boundary."

"Has the survey been completed?"

"The survey is already there in the papers."

The next morning Jaynath had all the bricks removed.

Raghunath put them back.

On the third day, two bamboo poles were planted instead of the bricks.

By night the poles were found uprooted.

No one said openly who had uprooted them, but greetings ceased between the two households.

The two brothers drew water from the same well.

The well lay more on Raghunath's side of the courtyard, but the old partition deed recorded joint use by both families.

When Jaynath's daughter-in-law came in the morning with a bucket, Raghunath's wife Kamala would go inside.

The two women who had once talked while drawing water—about vegetable seeds, a child's fever, invitations and family occasions—now heard only the creak of the rope.

The panchayat met.

The mukhiya examined the papers, heard the surveyor's first measurement, and then said, "Divide the five dhurs into two equal parts. Let both of you receive equal frontage on the road."

Raghunath was ready to agree, but Jaynath objected that the corner near the drain lay lower.

"Two and a half dhurs and two and a half dhurs may be equal on paper, but not in use."

Jaynath argued that the width at the front should be equal.

Raghunath insisted that the total area should be equal.

The surveyor drew two maps.

In each, one side or the other lost a cubit somewhere.

Deepak tried to mediate.

"Kaka, I will make the shop a little smaller. You leave a passage for the entrance."

Jaynath looked at him affectionately, but his reply remained firm.

"If I leave half today, tomorrow the papers will show the whole thing as yours."

Deepak fell silent.

From that day he spoke less at home about the tea stall.

In Magh, Raghunath obtained a copy of the old khatiyān from the Block Office.

Jaynath got a copy of the map from the district record office.

The lines on the two documents did not match exactly.

In one map the drain ran straight; in the other it was slanting.

The dispute over five dhurs was no longer one line; it had become the difference between two papers.

"We will go to court," Raghunath said one evening.

Kamala, stirring dal on the stove, asked, "For five dhurs?"

"Not for five dhurs. For my share."

Kamala went on stirring the dal.

"I do not understand whether a share belongs to the land or to the mind."

Raghunath looked at her but said nothing.

At the beginning of Phagun, small marks in white lime began appearing along the main road.

At first people thought electricity poles were going to be installed.

Two days later a survey team arrived.

Employees in yellow caps stretched tapes from the middle of the road towards both sides.

When Raghunath reached there, one of them was driving a small red stake into the middle of the five dhurs.

"What is this survey?" Raghunath asked.

Looking at his paper, the employee said, "The main road is to be widened. The notification has already been issued. This is the proposed edge."

Raghunath's gaze moved from the stake to his pile of bricks.

"My land?"

"Whatever lies inside this line will go into the road."

Jaynath too came running when he heard the news.

For the first time, the two brothers asked the same question in one voice: "How much?"

The employee stretched the tape again.

He went as far as the drain, crossed the thicket, and wrote down the figure.

"Almost the entire five dhurs. The final measurement will be according to the notification."

For a few moments no one spoke.

The line the brothers had failed to draw for three months had been given an entirely different meaning by a government red stake in a single minute.

The question was no longer where the two and a half dhurs would fall; the question was whether anything at all would remain of the five dhurs.

Jaynath brought the map he had kept ready.

The employee looked at it.

“This concerns a private partition. The widening line will not change because of it.”

Raghunath asked, “Compensation?”

“The process will follow the title papers, records and measurements. Since the land stands in joint names, the application too must be made accordingly.”

“Joint?”

The two brothers looked at each other.

They had quarrelled over that word for three months.

Now, without that same word, the application could not move forward without both their signatures.

The following week the two went to the Block Office.

They had to sit on the same bench.

The clerk told them that because it was a joint holding, he needed both men’s identity papers, bank details, old land-revenue receipts and signatures of consent.

One receipt was at Raghunath’s house; the copy of the map was with Jaynath.

Neither could complete the file without the other’s papers.

The bus was crowded on the way back.

The two stood apart.

As they got down, a slip fell from Jaynath’s file.

Raghunath picked it up and handed it to him.

“Your receipt.”

Jaynath took the slip.

“Keep it with you. We will need it again tomorrow.”

Raghunath put the slip in his own file.

That was all that was said, but after three months, for the first time, something had passed from one brother’s hand to the other without an argument.

By Chaitra, the road-widening work had begun.

First the thicket was cut down.

Then the old drain was filled and marks were made for a new drainage channel.

The labourers moved Raghunath’s stack of bricks to one side.

The bamboo poles planted by Jaynath had already been removed.

Deepak put the two old benches he had bought for his tea stall behind the house.

“The shop will not be built here,” he said simply.

Something tightened inside Raghunath.

“We will look for another place.”

Jaynath had been listening.

He said, "There are three dhurs vacant near the bend by my pond. It is away from the main road, but people going to the market pass that way. If you like, go and see it."

Raghunath did not answer at once.

Deepak looked at Jaynath.

"Kaka, the rent?"

Jaynath did not smile.

"First get the shop running. We will settle the account later."

Raghunath's eyes rested on his brother for a moment.

Three months earlier, had he heard that sentence, he would have searched it at once for a hidden meaning—what scheme lay inside 'we will settle the account later'.

Now he merely said, "All right. We will see it tomorrow."

In the first week of Jeth, the earth-cutting machine arrived.

The top layer of the five dhurs was stripped away.

The red stake was pulled out and thrown aside.

The trace of the old drain disappeared.

In a single day, the land on which two maps, three surveys, twenty bricks and countless arguments had accumulated was levelled and absorbed into the foundation of the road.

That evening Kamala met Jaynath's daughter-in-law at the well.

After a long time, the two of them began pulling the same rope again.

When the bucket came up, Jaynath's daughter-in-law said, "Didi, Deepak's shop roof will go up tomorrow."

Kamala asked, "At that bend by the pond?"

"Yes. Father has had the bamboo cut."

The two women looked at each other and smiled.

Their talk moved once again to water, spices and leaves for the roof.

Before the rains, the new surface of the main road was laid.

The five dhurs now remained only on the map; on the ground there was a black tarred road and a paved drain beside it.

The compensation money was divided equally between the two brothers.

The amount was less than what they had imagined the old five dhurs to be worth, but neither felt like adding up the money already spent on court preparations, surveyors and travel.

One evening Raghunath and Jaynath stood beside the new road.

Vehicles sped past.

Pointing with his stick beyond the drain, Jaynath said, "By my calculation, the boundary was somewhere here."

Raghunath asked, "Yours or mine?"

Jaynath was silent for a moment.

"What is the use of saying now?"

In the distance, at the bend by the pond, smoke was rising from the stove of Deepak's small shop.

Four men were drinking tea on two benches.

Raghunath looked at the white edge-line painted on the road.

It ran straight past both houses, obeying neither the eastern map nor the western stake.

Jaynath said, "Come, let us have tea at Deepak's."

Raghunath crossed the small bridge over the drain with his stick.

"Come."

The two brothers walked together along the road where, a few months earlier, there had been five dhurs of land.

STORY 141

The Host

Morning sunlight had not yet reached the eastern wall of the courtyard, but in Raghunath Chaudhary's house the clatter of brass and bell-metal utensils had already begun. Two large cooking pots borrowed from the neighbours, three broad trays, seven buckets, and bundles of leaf plates lay in a row on the veranda. Beside the hearth was a pile of dried mango wood, and bamboo poles had been planted as far as the cowshed to stretch a cloth canopy overhead.

Raghunath was a respected man in the village. Whether there was a panchayat dispute, a marriage to mediate, or boats to arrange during a flood, people came to him. The household income did not match that standing. Three bighas of land, one old cow, and the small earnings of two sons kept the family going. But in people's memory his father's feasts were still alive—five vegetable dishes, curd, sweets, paan, and milk at the end.

This time Raghunath had arranged a village feast to mark the completion of his new veranda. The invitation travelled far by word of mouth. When the expenses were added up for the first time, his wife Malati silently pushed the sheet of paper towards him.

"Where is there this much money in the house?" Raghunath added the figures again. The total did not change.

"We'll borrow it from Ramautar Sahu," he said.

Malati kept looking at his face. "What will remain after the paddy is sold is meant for seed for the transplanting and for the younger one's studies."

"I won't touch that," Raghunath said. "The debt will be for three months. We'll repay it little by little."

Sitting at the back of his shop, Ramautar Sahu wrote the amount on a blue page of his ledger. Eighteen thousand. Three months. Interest separate. Raghunath did not put down a thumbprint; he signed his name. The line beneath that name seemed longer to him than it did on ordinary days.

Shopping in the market became its own small test of honour and embarrassment. The sweet-seller opened two kinds of boxes—laddus and pedas. After hearing the prices, Raghunath ordered only laddus.

"Chaudharyji, only one kind of sweet at your feast?" the shopkeeper asked. "One good sweet is not too little," Raghunath said. "People compare." "Will people's comparisons repay the debt?"

The shopkeeper laughed and fell silent. Raghunath ordered one hundred and eighty laddus. Then he calculated the rice, lentils, curd, and spices. On

hearing the price of paneer, he struck it off the list. Instead, he increased the quantities of pumpkin and chickpea curry. By the time he returned home, the list in his pocket had been folded four times, but the total still had not come down.

Malati looked at the list and said only, "Let the meal fill people's stomachs, not burden us with display."

Raghunath nodded in agreement. But he knew that guests came carrying not only their appetites but their expectations as well. Expectations had no scale on which to be weighed, yet afterwards they were what weighed most heavily.

At noon on the day of the feast, the first sitting began. Salt, lemon, fried potatoes, pumpkin curry, lentils, and rice were served on banana leaves. Raghunath had already told the four teenage boys, "Ask before you serve. Whoever wants something must not be left short; whoever doesn't want it must not have food thrown onto his leaf."

Everything went smoothly in the first sitting. A problem arose in the second. The basket of sweets contained a counted number of laddus. By Raghunath's calculation, there was one for every guest, with twelve kept separately at the end for the cook and the servers.

After eating his laddu, Deenbandhu Jha rested a hand on the corner of his leaf and said, "Give me one more." The boy serving looked towards Raghunath. Raghunath smiled and said, "Once all the sittings are done, if any remain, certainly." Deenbandhu twisted his smile. "Do even the laddus at a feast in your house run according to a ledger?"

Two men sitting nearby laughed. The boy moved on.

By the third sitting, half the pot of curd was gone. From inside, Malati signalled that the women's sitting still remained. Raghunath told the server, "Let the curd reach every leaf once. Then go round a second time."

That sentence too travelled through the sitting in another form.

"It's been measured out in advance," someone said softly.

"A big name—Chaudhary—but half a bowl of curd," came another voice.

Raghunath heard it. At that moment, he moved a small boy aside and bent down himself to lift the used leaves. He did not answer.

By evening, five sittings had finished. In the last sat the field labourers, the cooks, the teenage servers, and those who had arrived late. Everyone received curd. Three laddus remained. Malati said, "Give one each to the three little children."

Raghunath handed the basket to her.

At night, the piles of leaf plates were gathered under the canopy. The borrowed utensils were washed and set aside. Raghunath sat beside a pillar of the veranda, adding up the expenses: rice, lentils, vegetables, curd, spices, oil, leaves, cook, bamboo, cloth, firewood. Some amounts had gone above the estimate.

The cook, Ramphal, sat in front with his three assistants. Their wages were still due. Malati said softly, "Ramautar's payment can wait two days. These people live on the day's earnings." Without answering, Raghunath took cash from the box and placed it in Ramphal's palm. Ramphal counted it and said, "There's a hundred rupees extra."

"The share for those three boys," Raghunath said.

"But they were serving too."

"Exactly."

Ramphal divided the money among them. At that moment the courtyard was almost empty. The feast that had filled the whole day with noise, smoke, and rushing about had now become a few washed utensils, the folded canopy in a corner of the veranda, and a sheet of expenses.

Malati asked, "Did it come within eighteen thousand?" "No." "How much over?" Before answering, Raghunath folded the paper. "Two thousand seven hundred." Malati exhaled. "Then?"

"Ramautar will add the first interest. Next week I'll sell my share of the fish from the pond."

Malati was silent for a few moments. Then, in a very ordinary voice, she asked, "Were people pleased?"

Raghunath's hand stopped on the paper. "They ate and left."

"I asked whether they were pleased."

This time he gave no answer.

The next morning, Raghunath set out towards Ramautar's shop. At the tea stall in the square sat four of the previous day's guests. The conversation stopped for a moment when they saw him, but before he reached the shopfront it had begun again.

"I thought we'd see the old splendour at Chaudharyji's feast," came Deenbandhu's voice. "Splendour?" another man laughed. "Ask for a second laddu and first the counting of the whole village has to be completed!" "And the curd too—measured and measured." "A big reputation, a small hand." Laughter rose.

Raghunath's pace slowed for a moment. He could have gone inside and told them that what they called 'measuring' had been done so that even the labourers in the last sitting would not rise from empty leaves. He could have told them that the laddus had been bought with money borrowed from the moneylender. He could have told them that his own family had eaten only after the final sitting was over late at night.

But he said nothing.

At Ramautar's shop, the blue ledger was opened. The moneylender wrote the first month's interest beside the amount.

"Was the feast good?" the moneylender asked. "It was done." "Were there many people?" "Almost everyone who was invited."

Ramautar tucked the pen behind his ear and said, "In matters of prestige, one doesn't count the expense."

Raghunath looked at the blue page. "It has to be counted. If we don't count it, how will we repay it?"

The moneylender laughed, but Raghunath did not.

Over the next three weeks, talk of the feast gradually faded. But whenever Raghunath's name came up at some village gathering, someone or other retold the story of the curd and laddus. In the retelling, one laddu became half, the curd shrank from a bowl to a spoonful, and five vegetable dishes became two. It was as though the feast had not been eaten but merely heard about.

At home, another story was unfolding. Malati began setting aside five or ten rupees from the milk she sold in the mornings. The elder son started giving a part of whatever wages remained when he returned from the market. Raghunath sold his share of the fish from the pond and reduced the principal for the first time. The amount in the blue ledger grew smaller, but slowly.

One evening, Deenbandhu himself came to the veranda. In his hand was an invitation to his grandson's sacred-thread ceremony.

"Now I need your experience," he said. "How many should I plan each sitting for? You write down fewer people, and more turn up." Raghunath opened the invitation and looked at the date.

Deenbandhu went on speaking by himself. "I'm thinking of two kinds of sweets. Curd separately. But the expense is climbing too high. And afterwards people talk as well." For the first time, Raghunath looked at him closely. He remembered the laughter at the tea stall, but the memory did not enter his voice.

"First write down how much money you have," Raghunath said. "Then write down how many people you can truly feed with it. The difference between those two numbers is not called a feast. It is called debt."

Deenbandhu laughed. "You've become completely calculating."

Raghunath too gave a faint smile. "The calculation becomes clear from the day after the feast."

Deenbandhu left.

Malati brought from inside the small slip on which the blue-ledger account had been worked out. "This month's amount is ready."

Raghunath looked at the figures on the paper. From the direction of the distant square came the sound of people laughing. It was difficult to tell whether they were talking about his feast or about something else.

He rose and set out towards Ramautar's shop. In a corner of the veranda, one brass plate from the day of the feast still lay set aside to be returned to a neighbour. The plate was empty and shining.

But in the blue ledger, the feast was not over yet.

STORY 142

New Mobile Phone

It was a cold January morning.

In a rented room in a narrow lane of Laheriasarai, Aniruddha was pressing down the back cover of his old mobile phone.

One corner of the cover kept lifting; he would fold a thin scrap of paper, wedge it inside, and only then would the device remain switched on.

The screen showed the time, and that was about the only thing it could be relied upon to do.

Aniruddha was in the final year of his B.A.

His father ran a small bicycle-repair shop in the village, and his mother delivered milk to two households morning and evening.

Aniruddha's expenses in the city were measured out carefully - rent, food, college fees, and examination fees.

Anything outside those four lines was regarded as a luxury.

Even so, in the college veranda his old phone had now become more of a marker than a tool for study.

His friends sent photographs of notes on their newer phones, formed groups, and read invitations to programmes.

None of that worked on Aniruddha's device.

One day, after the history class, Deepak turned the phone over in his hand and said, "Does this thing work, or does it only tell the time?"

Everyone laughed.

Aniruddha laughed too, but his laughter came half a moment late.

That evening, after returning to his room, he read again the money-order receipt his father had sent.

The amount was five thousand four hundred rupees.

On the back was a short note in his father's handwriting: "Pay the examination fee and the remaining college dues first."

There were still twelve days before the last date for paying the examination fee.

Aniruddha worked out the figures.

He was due three thousand rupees for a month's work from two tuitions.

A local printing shop also owed him one thousand eight hundred rupees for two hours of evening work counting sheets of paper.

If all the money arrived on time, he could gather the examination fee again.

The next day he went to a shop in the market.

Shining phones stood in rows inside a glass cabinet.

The shopkeeper took out a black handset and placed it in his palm.

Aniruddha asked, "How much?"

"Eight thousand two hundred."

Aniruddha's fingers went still.

"Four thousand eight hundred now, and the rest in two instalments," the shopkeeper said.

For a long time he stared at the smooth back of the phone.

He remembered Deepak's laughter; that moment in the veranda when everyone else seemed to have something gleaming in their hands while his own palm held a scratched, loose-backed device.

"Pack it," he said.

From that day, something changed in the veranda.

Deepak whistled when he saw the phone.

Ritesh said, "Now Aniruddha Babu has become a complete city gentleman."

For the first time, when the group wanted a photograph, they asked Aniruddha to use his phone.

He refused two or three times, then took the photograph himself.

For three days there was a slight new confidence in the way he walked.

People who had earlier turned to Deepak or Ritesh when they wanted notes now also looked at photographs of pages on Aniruddha's phone.

One classmate told him, "It looks good in your hand."

The sentence was small, but Aniruddha kept remembering it for a long time that night.

He put his old phone away in a box.

His father's number, his mother's number, and the numbers of the tuition families - he transferred them all to the new phone.

As he closed the loose cover of the old one, it seemed to him for a moment that he was putting away not merely a machine but his old self as well.

But the new shine brought new expenses with it.

A protective case, a thin sheet of glass for the screen, a data recharge.

The shopkeeper had said that without these things the phone's value would go down.

Aniruddha did not add up two or three such expenses.

Together, the small amounts crossed four hundred rupees.

The examination fee was quietly moving farther away.

At night the blue light of the phone fell across the wall of his room.

He opened his books, but again and again the screen lit up.

A message, a photograph, a small joke.

He felt that he was no longer outside the group.

Four days later, when he went to the first tuition, the child's mother said, "There has been a lot of expense for a wedding this month. Take your money five days later."

The owner of the printing shop said, "A government bill is stuck. Wait a week."

A small fear rose inside Aniruddha, but he covered it with arithmetic.

Even five days later, there would still be two days before the final date.

Meanwhile, the family of the second tuition student left for the village.

That payment was pushed into the following month.

For the first time, Aniruddha opened the box of the new phone and looked at the printed price on the back.

Eight thousand two hundred rupees was written there clearly.

He had seen the figure before, but that night it carried a different weight.

On the college notice board, the last date for submitting the examination form was written in red ink.

Until five o'clock the next day.

The fee was four thousand six hundred rupees.

Aniruddha had eight hundred and seventy-five rupees.

He thought of borrowing from Deepak.

Then he remembered the laughter in the veranda - this time the reason for it would not be his old phone but his debt.

He stopped himself from asking.

That evening he went back to the same shop to sell the new phone.

The shopkeeper turned it over and examined it.

"Once it has been opened, it is used," he said. "Four thousand."

"It hasn't even been twelve days."

"The market doesn't count days."

Even selling it for four thousand would not cover the fee, and the remaining instalments would still have to be paid.

Aniruddha put the box back into his bag.

That night he kept thinking of calling his mother.

He could have told his father that the money had gone into some other expense.

But the moment he would have to name that "other expense," he could not gather the courage to hear his own voice say it.

On the final day he sat in the veranda outside the college office until four twenty in the evening.

No miracle occurred.

The printing-shop money did not arrive.

There was no news from the tuition household either.

At five o'clock the window closed.

The employee inside gathered up the register.

Aniruddha stood up.

The new phone was in his pocket.

For the first time that day, its weight felt heavy.

The next morning he went back outside the office.

The window was open, but the queue there was now for certificates, not examination forms.

Standing to one side, Aniruddha quietly asked the clerk, "Can it be submitted late?"

The clerk turned the pages of the register and said, "The date has passed. The list has been sent to the university. You will have to take the supplementary examination at the next opportunity."

"Not even one paper this time?"

"If there is no form, in whose name would we issue it?"

The answer was not harsh; it was simply the rule.

That hurt Aniruddha more than harshness would have.

If someone had scolded him, he could at least have divided the blame in his mind.

Here there was no one else with whom to divide it.

On the first day of the examination, the college gate was crowded.

Students stood with admit cards in their hands, searching for their rooms.

Aniruddha came too.

Somewhere inside him lingered the hope that perhaps his name might somehow have appeared on the list.

But his roll number was not there.

The office clerk asked, "The fee receipt?"

Aniruddha was silent.

"If the form was never submitted, how could an admit card be made?"

He said nothing.

He went outside and sat beneath a neem tree.

At exactly nine o'clock the bell rang.

The veranda slowly emptied.

The friends who until the previous day had been admiring his new phone all went into the examination rooms.

The phone vibrated.

It was a message from Deepak: "Which room are you in?"

Aniruddha did not reply.

A second message came: "I don't see your name on the list."

He switched off the screen.

An hour later, his father called.

Aniruddha let the phone ring for a long time, then answered.

"Did the examination go well?" his father asked.

Aniruddha's throat went dry.

He could have lied.

He needed only one sentence.

But sunlight was falling through the neem leaves onto his knees, and the sound of the bell seemed to ring inside him again.

"I didn't go inside, Babuji."

There was silence at the other end for a few moments.

"Are you ill?"

"No, I'm not ill."

His father asked again, "Then what happened?"

Aniruddha told him everything.

The money order, the new phone, the delayed tuition money, the closed window - everything.

His father did not interrupt him even once.

At the end, he asked only, "Do you still have the phone?"

Aniruddha said, "Yes, I still have it."

"Then keep it. Selling it won't bring today's examination back. First find out from the office when the next opportunity is."

Aniruddha had expected a scolding.

Not being scolded did not lessen his shame; instead, it made it clearer.

When the examination ended that day, Deepak came outside.

He stopped when he saw Aniruddha sitting under the neem tree.

Deepak asked softly, "What happened, yaar?"

"I didn't pay the fee."

Deepak first looked at Aniruddha's hand, where the new phone lay, and then at his own admit card.

The smile disappeared from his face by itself.

"I thought..." He left the sentence unfinished.

Aniruddha said, "I too had thought a great many things."

The following week he sold the new phone.

He received four thousand two hundred rupees.

After paying off the remaining instalments, he put the money left over into a separate envelope.

He went to the office, wrote down the date of the supplementary examination, and wrote in large letters on the envelope: "EXAMINATION FEE."

The old mobile phone returned to his pocket.

Its back cover still lifted at one corner.

Aniruddha folded a thin scrap of paper and wedged it inside again.

One day in the veranda Deepak laughed and said, "The old companion again?"

Aniruddha smiled too.

"It tells the time," he said. "For now, that's enough for me."

STORY 143

The Dowry Fan

It was an afternoon in Jeth.

The bricks in the courtyard had grown hot, and the blades of the grey pedestal fan on the veranda were turning soundlessly.

As Madhu cleaned its grille with a duster, she noticed a thin piece of paper stuck beneath the base.

In red ink it read, "Madhu - Wedding."

Some of the ink had faded, but the writing was still legible.

Madhu began peeling the paper away with her finger when her mother-in-law, Shanti Devi, called from inside, "Let it be. Why are you taking it off?"

"The paper has grown old."

"Old it may be, but it is still a mark. A mark of the things your father gave at the time of your wedding."

Madhu stopped her hand.

The fan turned again and sent a current of air towards her.

On the day of the wedding, the fan had not been the largest of the gifts.

Among a trunk, two brass plates, a bundle of bedding, a small cupboard and some utensils, it had looked quite ordinary.

But members of the wedding party had paused again and again beside the pile of things to look.

Some eyes went to the cupboard, others to the fan.

Madhu's father, Ramakant Mishra, had repeatedly said that day, "All this is for my daughter. There is no list, no account."

The groom's father, Jagmohan Jha, too had said before everyone, "We have asked for nothing."

Everyone liked both statements.

One side displayed its means, the other its freedom from demands.

The fan stood silently in between.

Three months after the wedding, the heat intensified.

At night the fan ran in Madhu and Sudhanshu's room.

One night its speed slowed; the next day the blades turned, but the air weakened.

Sudhanshu brought an electrician from the market.

The electrician opened the base and examined it for a while.

"A small part needs replacing. If you have the purchase receipt, the shopkeeper may even replace it without charge. The warranty should be for one year."

Shanti Devi immediately said, "The receipt must be with Madhu's father. He brought all these things just like that on the wedding day."

Madhu remained silent.

She felt that more than the fan's broken part was about to be opened.

That evening she told her father.

Ramakant laughed at first.

"The receipt? It must be somewhere. I'll look for it."

The next day his younger son, Nawal, arrived with an old envelope.

Inside was the sales receipt for the fan.

The price was four thousand eight hundred rupees.

Below it was the account of three instalments - the first paid fifteen days before the wedding, the second two months after it, and the third still blank.

Nawal said, "Babuji said to show this to the shopkeeper. He'll pay the remaining instalment this month."

Shanti Devi kept looking at the receipt.

Sudhanshu read it too.

When Jagmohan Jha returned from the fields that evening, the paper reached his hands.

His eyes went straight to the blank third line.

"This fan hasn't even been fully paid for yet?"

Madhu said, "Babuji bought it in instalments. He'll pay the rest."

Jagmohan's brows drew together.

"Why in instalments? I had said there was no need to give anything."

Sudhanshu tried to lighten the matter.

"The fan works. It only needs a small part replaced."

"This isn't about the part," Jagmohan said.

"People will think he took on debt to send his daughter off and we kept counting the goods."

For the first time Madhu felt anger, not embarrassment, on her father's behalf.

"Why should what people think be tied to Babuji's instalments?"

Jagmohan did not answer.

He folded the receipt and placed it on the table.

The very next day Ramakant came himself.

Nawal had perhaps gone home and told him everything.

He carried a small cloth bag.

Inside were a new receipt showing the balance fully paid and a fifty-rupee bill for the replacement part.

"The shopkeeper changed the part," he said. "The fan will be running properly by evening."

Jagmohan looked at the receipt.

"Why was it necessary for you to pay the remaining amount immediately?"

Ramakant's tone changed.

"It was mine to pay, not yours."

"That is not what I said."

"Nawal told me you asked, 'It wasn't even fully paid for.' So I paid it in full."

"I only meant to ask why you had taken on debt for the wedding."

"The debt was mine. My daughter went to your home, not the debt."

For a moment the veranda fell so silent that the fan's low hum could be heard clearly.

The electrician was tightening the base at that very moment.

Without raising his head, he continued working.

Jagmohan said, "You are taking my words to mean something else."

Ramakant replied at once, "People carry away the words; meanings are made later."

Madhu kept looking from one to the other.

She understood that choosing any single sentence would not mend the situation.

The honour that both families had tried to preserve in their own ways on the wedding day was now finding thorns in each other's words.

The fan was repaired.

But that night it did not return to the bedroom.

Shanti Devi had it placed in a corner of the veranda.

"The air will spread better here," she said by way of explanation.

The real reason did not need to be spoken.

Two weeks later, discussions began for the marriage of Jagmohan's younger daughter, Rupa.

Some people from the prospective groom's family came to see the house.

Chairs were set out on the veranda.

It was hot.

Shanti Devi said to Madhu, "Switch on the fan."

Madhu plugged it in.

The fan began to turn.

The red paper was still stuck beneath the base.

An elderly woman among the guests read it and laughed.

"Oh, this is the fan that came with Madhu beti."

Shanti Devi smiled too.

"Yes, from that wedding."

Rupa's uncle joked, "Then write down one fan for Rupa too. Otherwise her in-laws will say her sister had one in her home and she doesn't."

Everyone laughed.

Jagmohan did not.

Madhu saw his fingers begin tapping on the arm of his chair.

After the guests left, he said to the uncle, "Don't say such things in front of guests."

The uncle asked in surprise, "What happened? I was only joking."

"A joke later becomes a story."

Within three days that sentence reached Ramakant.

But by the time it arrived, its form had changed - "Jagmohan says that since a fan came from Madhu's home, one is wanted for Rupa too."

Ramakant heard this in the market from someone who did not know the whole context.

He said nothing at once, but that evening he asked his wife, "Did I give a fan, or did I set a price?"

His wife said wearily, "Everyone has a mouth and everyone has a version. Don't get entangled in the same mess again."

But the entanglement now lay between the two homes like the fan's cord, out of sight and yet stretched between them.

Rupa's marriage was fixed.

Jagmohan went himself to Ramakant's house to deliver the invitation.

The first five minutes passed in exchanging courtesies.

In the sixth, Ramakant asked, "Has it been decided that a fan will be given at Rupa's wedding?"

Jagmohan understood at once.

"Who told you?"

"People are saying it."

"Do people not say that I stopped the joke?"

"People hear only half. On the wedding day too they heard only half - that you had asked for nothing, but everyone was looking over all the goods."

Jagmohan's face hardened.

"Are you again suggesting that I took dowry?"

"I am not suggesting anything. I am saying that I gave the fan for my daughter. Don't make it an example and open an account for another daughter."

"I have opened no account."

"Then good."

"But you are speaking as though I make demands."

Neither man's voice rose, but the distance between them widened.

The invitation card remained lying on Ramakant's wooden seat.

Jagmohan got up and left.

Ramakant attended Rupa's wedding, but he arrived late.

He went straight to the dining rows and left soon afterwards.

Jagmohan too found an excuse in being busy.
They exchanged greetings but did not speak.
Madhu watched all this from a distance.

It seemed to her that although the fan was still at home, its shadow had reached all the way to the wedding pavilion.

After the wedding, Rupa left for her marital home.
The house grew quiet again.

The heat of Jeth had now become the humid heaviness of Ashadh.

One evening Shanti Devi sat before the kitchen fire, wiping the sweat from her face.

The fan stood idle on the veranda.

Madhu dragged it to the kitchen doorway.

Shanti Devi asked, "Why here?"

"Because this is where the air is needed."

Madhu plugged it in.

The fan started.

At first the air went straight towards Shanti Devi.

Then Madhu bent over the base and looked at the little red paper - "Madhu - Wedding."

Over all those months, one corner of the paper had come loose on its own.

This time she did not peel it off.

She merely turned the head of the fan so that the air spread into the kitchen.

A little later Sudhanshu returned from outside.

Not seeing the fan on the veranda, he asked, "Where did it go?"

Madhu indicated the kitchen with her eyes.

Inside, Shanti Devi was kneading flour.

The air was falling across her sweat-damp back.

The red paper was beneath the base; from a distance it was not even visible.

Sudhanshu asked nothing.

The fan kept running.

STORY 144

The Large Door

Two weeks before the month of Sawan began, two deep pits were dug in front of Nandakishor Yadav's house.

On one side lay the old bamboo fence; on the other, a heap of red bricks.

Fakira the mason was stretching a string and taking measurements.

Nandakishor kept walking out to the middle of the road to see how the new gate would look from a distance.

"Make the pillars two hands higher," he said. "The house should not look small from the road."

Fakira scratched his head.

"If we raise them higher, more bricks will be needed. The arch above will also become heavier."

"Use as much as it takes. It will be built only once."

From inside the veranda, Vimla Devi was listening to all this.

Before her stood two brass lotas.

On the bottom of one of them, the round stain left by last year's rainwater was still visible.

She came outside and said, "The roof too will be built only once. When will that be?"

Instead of answering, Nandakishor began explaining the width of the pillars to Fakira.

The house had begun thirty years earlier with mud walls and a tiled roof.

Little by little, two brick rooms were built, and then a veranda in front.

The previous year Nandakishor's elder son, Manoj, had found work in a textile factory in Punjab.

At the end of each month, whatever he managed to save, he sent home.

With that money the old tiles had been removed and the walls raised all around, but the money ran short before the roof could be completed.

One room had a concrete roof, the second was covered with tin sheets, while over the veranda in between lay a mixture of bamboo, plastic and old tiles.

In Jeth, Manoj had sent thirty-five thousand rupees and written, "Take care of the roof before the rains. I will not get leave this time."

Vimla had read that line three times.

Nandakishor had read it too.

But that very week, a new gate had been built in front of Rambali Sah's house across the road.

Two thick pillars, a rounded arch above, and gleaming iron leaves in the middle.

In the evenings people stopped to look at it.

For two days Nandakishor only watched.

On the third day he called Fakira.

"There still is not enough money for the whole roof," he argued. "With this money the roof will only be half done. The gate can be completed. At least the front of the house will improve."

Vimla had asked, "Will the rain fall on the appearance or inside the house?"

Nandakishor had laughed the question away.

Work on the gate moved quickly.

The pillars rose, a semicircular arch was built above them, and small square niches were made on both sides where lamps could be placed at night.

An artisan was called from the market for the iron leaves.

Vimla watched Manoj's remitted money turn into bricks, sand, cement, iron and paint.

Inside the house, the unfinished roof remained exactly as it had been.

The old plastic sheet was spread again over the bamboo above the veranda.

There was a hole in one corner, and Vimla cut up an old fertiliser sack and tied it over the gap.

Nandakishor's younger daughter, Gauri, studied at college.

One evening she said to her father, "Bhaiya sent the money for the roof."

"Does your brother see the house from that far away?" Nandakishor asked.

"Bhaiya knows what the rains are like."

"I know too. The roof is four days' work. We will do it with the next money."

Gauri fell silent.

She knew that for her father the gate was not merely brick and iron.

For years a bamboo fence had stood in front of the house.

After the main road through the village was paved, the fronts of newer houses changed, but from a distance theirs still looked unfinished.

Nandakishor cultivated land on share and also sold milk.

Sometimes, standing in front of his own house, he felt that passers-by saw not his labour, but only the bamboo fence.

Seven days later the gate stood complete.

Its leaves were dark green, edged in yellow.

In the centre of the arch, white letters on a blue plaque read: "Nandakishor Yadav."

On the day the paint dried, Nandakishor crossed to the other side of the road and stood looking at it for a long time.

Vimla was sitting inside by the hearth.

Gauri asked, "Ma, will you not come and see?"

Vimla came outside and looked once.

"It has been made well," she said.

Then she raised her eyes to the plastic over the veranda, fluttering in the wind.

A four-inch-high strip of cement had been built along the bottom of the gate so that its leaves would stay clean and mud from outside would not come in.

Fakira had said, "In the rains it will keep outside water from entering."

Vimla had then asked, "And where will the water from inside go?"

Fakira had laughed.

"Where will so much water come from inside?"

The first rain came at night.

First the wind rose, then all at once heavy drops began drumming on the tiles, the tin and the new gate.

Nandakishor got up and went to the veranda.

Raindrops stood like pearls on the new paint.

For a moment he was pleased - the gate looked even brighter in the rain.

Then Vimla's voice came: "Bring a bucket."

Water was dripping through the middle of the veranda.

One knot in the old plastic sheet had come undone.

Gauri brought a bucket from the room.

Within five minutes water began pouring from another place.

A lota was set there.

At a third place, slow drops began to fall.

"Move the sacks, the wheat will get wet," Vimla said.

Nandakishor and Gauri together began shifting the grain sacks into the room with the concrete roof.

Outside, the rain was roaring.

Water began collecting in the unpaved part of the courtyard.

At first this seemed ordinary; such rain came every year.

But earlier the water used to escape towards the road beneath the bamboo fence.

This time a four-inch strip of cement stood across the front.

Within half an hour the courtyard looked like a pond.

Gauri opened the gate.

Water was rushing along the road outside, but the water inside remained trapped by the cement strip.

Vimla said, "What was meant to keep the water outside has kept it inside."

Nandakishor said nothing.

He took a hand hoe and began scraping at one corner of the strip.

The cement was new, but the hoe in his hand could not break it.

He ran towards Fakira's house.

Fakira was not there; his son gave him a small hammer and chisel.

Back home, Nandakishor knelt at the right-hand corner of the new gate.

Beneath the yellow border, at the very strip whose smoothness he had been feeling with his fingers only the previous day, he set the chisel.

The first blow left a small white mark.

The second broke the corner.

With the third, a thin stream of water escaped outside.

Gauri stood silently holding the lantern.

Vimla brought a broom from inside and began sweeping the water towards the small opening.

After a while the stream grew thicker.

The water in the courtyard began to fall.

The gate stood open, both green leaves drenched in the rain.

Above, Nandakishor's name was still clear on the blue plaque; below, a crooked notch had been cut into the cement strip.

Until two in the morning the family kept clearing away water.

All four beds were placed close together in the one room with the concrete roof.

Nandakishor lay listening to the drip-drip into the bucket on the veranda.

By morning the rain had stopped.

A thin layer of mud covered the courtyard.

Outside the new gate, the road looked as though it had been washed clean.

Inside, Vimla was spreading the damp sacks out to dry in the sun.

When Fakira arrived, he was startled to see the broken corner of the strip.

"Who broke this?"

"I did," Nandakishor said.

"It was new work."

"There was no way for the water to get out."

Fakira bent and examined the notch.

"We will fit a drainpipe here and fill it up again."

Nandakishor said, "Do not fill it. Make a proper drain. Permanent."

Fakira nodded.

Then he asked, "Shall I finish the decoration still left on the two sides of the arch today?"

Nandakishor looked up at the roof over the veranda.

The stains from the night's rain ran all the way down the bamboo.

"No," he said. "First look above. Measure all the places where the water is coming through."

Fakira looked at his face, then asked for a ladder without saying anything.

At noon a letter arrived from Manoj.

Gauri read it aloud: the factory would give him an extra shift the following month, and then he would send some more money.

At the end he had written, "The roof has been taken care of, hasn't it?"

Gauri stopped after reading the line.

Nandakishor said, "Write back - the work has begun."

Vimla looked at him.

It was the first time he had answered without mentioning the gate.

For the next three days Fakira replaced the bamboo above the veranda, repaired the joints in the tin sheets, and took measurements for the portion that was to receive a concrete roof.

The arch of the gate remained with its decoration unfinished.

From the road it still looked grand.

People sometimes stopped to read the blue plaque.

No one paid attention to what lay below.

But when the rain came again, water ran straight into the roadside flow through the small drain made at the right-hand corner of the cement strip.

Gauri watched from the veranda.

This time only two or three drops fell through the newly repaired joints above.

Vimla did not bring a bucket.

Nandakishor stood by the gate.

The water was flowing out not beneath the plaque bearing his name, but through the small opening made at the very bottom.

He bent and removed a leaf caught at the mouth of the drain.

He closed the gate, but left the water's way open.

STORY 145

Certificate of Honour

It was the last week of Magh.

Mahendranath Jha was sorting old papers at his writing desk when the postman brought a blue envelope.

Across the envelope, in bold letters, was written: 'Mithila Literary Service Honour.'

Inside was an invitation card with a golden border.

His full name was printed on it, and in the middle were the words 'for long service to literature.'

Mahendranath read it three times.

The first time for the pleasure of seeing his name, the second to understand the date, and the third to read the small print at the bottom.

It said that a brief introduction to each honoured writer would be printed in the annual souvenir volume; contribution towards the souvenir: five hundred rupees; contribution towards the meal and hall: three hundred; travel at one's own expense.

He placed the invitation on the table and called his wife, Sulochana.

'Look, this time they have invited me too.'

Sulochana put on her spectacles.

She read the name and smiled.

'That is good. You should go.'

Mahendranath placed a finger on the small print.

'Eight hundred here itself. Bus fare extra. And if it gets too late at night, lodging will cost extra too.'

Sulochana looked at the invitation again.

'Will they honour you, or hold the ceremony with your money?'

'Not every organisation is like that,' Mahendranath said softly.

'They print a souvenir. They have to hire a hall. Asking for some contribution is not unnatural.'

Sulochana did not argue.

She looked towards the northern wall of the room, where a yellow stain still marked the plaster raised by rainwater.

'Seven hundred rupees are still due to the man who repaired the roof. Just remember that much.'

Mahendranath folded the invitation and slipped it between the pages of a book.

But he did no writing that day.
 Until evening, the bold letters of his own name kept circling before his eyes.
 For thirty years he had been writing poems, memoirs and stories.
 Some had appeared in magazines, and he had published two slim collections at his own expense.

In the village people called him 'Master Sahib' more often than 'writer.'
 For the first time, the invitation had placed before his name the word he had silently heard in his mind for years.

Two days later he deposited the eight-hundred-rupee contribution into the account given by the organisation, then went to the market to have the receipt printed.

The printer charged twenty rupees.
 Then he sent his white kurta to the washerman for the ceremony.
 His shoes were old; a polish would do.
 Mahendranath had a habit of writing down expenses.
 In the margin of his ledger he noted: eight hundred and twenty, kurta washing sixty, shoe polish thirty.

Sulochana saw the ledger and said nothing.
 She merely ran a finger over the entry opposite the roofer's name: '700 due.'
 The ceremony was at the district headquarters.
 Mahendranath caught the five-o'clock morning bus.
 Through the fog he kept wiping the windowpane again and again.
 Inside his cloth bag were his kurta, one of his books, the invitation card and a new story he had written.

He hoped that after the ceremony there would be a chance to talk to someone about the story.

At the entrance to the hall, a register lay open on a table.
 A young man asked his name, checked his receipt, and hung a paper badge around his neck.

On the badge were printed the words 'Honoured Guest.'
 'Where do I get the souvenir?' Mahendranath asked.
 'After the programme.'
 'I had sent my introduction.'
 'Everyone's has come.'

The young man turned towards the next person.
 Inside, a large number of certificates of exactly the same size were stacked on the stage.

Beside them lay gamchhas and small bunches of flowers.
 The first five rows of chairs were full.
 Mahendranath sat in the sixth row.
 Beside him was a poet from Sitamarhi, whose first question was, 'How much did you contribute?'

'Eight hundred.'

The poet laughed.

'They told me a thousand over the phone. I bargained and stopped at eight hundred.'

Mahendranath did not like the remark.

He turned his eyes towards the stage.

The programme began two hours late.

There were many speeches - save the language, the crisis of literature, the indifference of the new generation, the organisation's struggle.

Then the honours began.

Names were called one by one.

Some introductions ran to two lines, some to four.

When Mahendranath's turn came, the announcer mispronounced his pen name.

He went up to the stage, folded his hands, received the gamchha, the flowers and the certificate.

The photographer said, 'Look this way.'

A flash went off.

The next moment he was guided down from the other side of the stage, because the next name had already been called.

The whole thing had taken less than forty seconds.

Back in his chair, Mahendranath opened the certificate.

A golden border, red letters, and this time his name was correct.

Below were the signatures of the president and secretary.

He smelled the paper.

It carried the scent of fresh printing.

He was genuinely pleased.

While standing in the meal queue, he met an old acquaintance, a teacher.

The teacher asked, 'In which magazine has your new story appeared?'

Mahendranath placed a hand on his cloth bag.

'I haven't sent it anywhere yet. I brought it with me. I thought I might give it to someone to read.'

The queue behind the teacher began to move.

'Of course, send it sometime,' he said, and moved ahead.

The programme ended as evening was falling.

The souvenir volume was distributed.

Mahendranath looked for his introduction.

His name was there, and there were four lines, but the title of one of his books had been misspelled.

He thought of telling the secretary, then saw him behind the stage directing the people who were folding the chairs.

By the time Mahendranath reached the bus stand, the last direct bus had left.

Another bus would take him only halfway.

From there he would have to take a shared vehicle.

The total fare was more than he had estimated.

It was half past ten at night when Mahendranath reached home.

Sulochana opened the door.

'Your meal is kept ready. Wash your hands and face first.'

Mahendranath took the certificate out of his bag.

'Look.'

Sulochana read it carefully.

'They have printed your name properly.'

'Yes, this time it is correct.'

'Will you have it framed?'

Mahendranath answered at once, 'Yes. If I leave the paper like this, it will curl.'

The next day he went to the market.

A simple glass frame was quoted at four hundred and fifty rupees.

He asked for something cheaper.

The shopkeeper gave him a thin wooden frame for three hundred and fifty.

Mahendranath paid.

In his ledger he added up the total expense - contribution, printing, laundry, polish, bus, shared vehicle, tea, frame.

The sum came to one thousand nine hundred and sixty-five rupees.

He looked at the figure in silence for a while.

Then he closed the ledger.

At noon the frame came home.

Mahendranath took out a hammer and nail.

Three things already hung on the wall above his writing desk - his daughter's graduation certificate, a photocopy of his son's first appointment letter, and a faded photograph of his father, Ramlochan Jha.

Holding the certificate in his hand, Mahendranath measured the space.

There was no room in the middle.

'Shall I move our daughter's certificate to the other room?' he said.

Sulochana answered from inside, 'Which other room? That one has the grain sacks and the old trunk.'

Mahendranath went to the southern wall.

The plaster there was flaking.

He touched it once and lime dust came away on his fingers.

On the northern wall was the yellow stain of damp.

On the western wall, above the cupboard, were the clock, the main electrical box and two hanging bags.

A narrow strip remained above the door, but the frame would not sit straight there.

He went out to the veranda.

The roofer had left a nail there on his previous visit.

Mahendranath held the frame against it.

Just below ran an old mark left by rainwater.

At the first heavy rain, the paper might get wet.

Sulochana watched silently.

'There is no place,' Mahendranath said.

There was less complaint than surprise in his voice.

'The house is small,' Sulochana said. 'It was just as small before the honour.'

Mahendranath said nothing.

He set the frame on the table.

In the evening his granddaughter Naina came home from school.

Her eyes fell on the new frame.

'Baba, is this your prize?'

'A certificate of honour.'

'Where will you hang it?'

Mahendranath laughed.

'I'm still looking.'

Naina bent over the table and read the name.

'Hang it beside my picture.'

Her drawing hung on the lower part of the northern wall - a blue river, a red house, a green tree.

'There is damp there.'

'Then shall I take my picture down?'

Mahendranath answered at once, 'No. Your picture will stay.'

Naina went inside, reassured.

That night Mahendranath sat at his writing desk.

The frame was propped in front of him.

Lamplight fell on its glass, and behind the glass his name gleamed.

Beside it lay the new story that no one at the ceremony had had the chance to read.

He picked up the story.

He read the first page again.

He struck out two sentences and added one line.

For the first time in many days, his attention settled completely on the words.

Sulochana set down a glass of milk and asked, 'What will you do with the certificate?'

Mahendranath looked at his father Ramlochan's photograph, then at his daughter's certificate.

'I won't put it in the trunk,' he said. 'Let the roof be repaired first.'

'The roofer's seven hundred.'

Mahendranath opened the ledger.

Below the total expense of the honour trip, he drew a new line: 'Roof - 700 due.'

'I'll pay him tomorrow,' he said.

The certificate remained in its frame, but it was not hung on the wall.

It was left standing behind the writing desk, in front of the books.

The following week the roofer came.

The joint above the northern wall was opened, broken tiles were replaced, and the path of the rainwater was diverted.

When the work was finished, Sulochana looked at the yellow stain on the wall and said, 'Once it dries, there will be space here.'

Mahendranath nodded.

Even that day the certificate was not hung.

Mahendranath sat at the desk and opened the new story again.

His name still gleamed in the glass of the frame, but his eyes were on the page.

STORY 146

One Plate Less

It was a Phagun evening. In the western quarter of the village, the wedding feast for Ramlochan's daughter Suchitra was under way. Beneath the long bamboo shamiana adjoining the courtyard, leaf plates had been laid out row after row. The smoke from the hearths, the fragrance of cumin falling into ghee, and wedding songs sung in full voice - all three mingled in the air.

Ramlochan had been running about for three days and was exhausted. One moment he was at the cauldron of rice, the next at the tray of paan, the next watching the road for the groom's party. His young niece Maithili had been given one task - once a row filled, she was to count the leaf plates and the glasses of water.

Thirty-two leaf plates had been laid in the first row. Thirty-two in the second. While the third row was being laid, Maithili counted thirty-one.

She went to the storeroom. 'Uncle, one leaf plate is short.'

Ramlochan's elder cousin Raghuvir immediately said, 'It isn't short. The leaf plate in that corner has been removed.'

'Why, Uncle?'

Raghuvir signalled with his eyes for her to keep quiet. 'Your job is to count, not to ask the reason.'

Maithili turned back, but her eyes remained fixed on the empty place. There was a gap of nearly two hands' breadth in the middle of the row. As people sat down, they kept pretending not to notice it.

A little later, Ramvriksh came from the southern quarter with his wife Malti and their two sons. Ramlochan himself had invited them. The previous year, when Ramlochan had fallen ill, Ramvriksh had taken him to the hospital at night in a bullock cart. After the wedding date was fixed, Ramlochan had told him, 'Come with the whole family.'

When Ramvriksh reached the shamiana, Ramlochan raised a hand from a distance in welcome. 'Sit down. The row is filling now.'

Raghuvir stepped forward and said something close to Ramlochan's ear. Ramlochan's raised hand slowly came down.

'What happened?' Ramvriksh asked.

Ramlochan did not answer at once. Raghuvir said, 'Separate arrangements will be made for all of you later.'

Malti's face hardened slightly. 'Why separately?'

'There is a great crowd,' Raghuvir said.

Ramvriksh looked once towards the rows. He too noticed the empty gap in the middle. He did not count, but he understood.

'Was the invitation to sit with everyone, or to eat what is left later?' His voice was low.

Ramlochan said, 'Ramvriksh, don't make an issue of it. This is a wedding house.'

'I did not come here to make an issue of anything.' Ramvriksh looked at Malti. 'Come.'

Malti turned the boys around. The younger son, Nitin, had his eyes on the tray of sweets; he wanted to ask something, but his mother took hold of his hand. The four of them walked out as quietly as they had come.

Maithili watched it all. A clean leaf plate was in her hand. She had lifted it to lay in the gap, but from a distance Raghuvir shook his head and stopped her.

'Take that leaf plate back and put it away,' came his order.

Maithili carried the leaf plate back to the storeroom. A damp mark from her finger remained on one corner.

The road to the southern quarter was not very long. On reaching Ramvriksh's house, Malti began warming the leftover rice on the hearth. Nitin sat silently on a low stool. At last he asked, 'Why didn't they let us sit?'

Ramvriksh paused while filling a lota with water. 'If I answer that question today, I will fill you with anger. Understand only this much - never let an insult given by someone else become your identity.'

Malti lifted the lid from the rice and said, 'Eat first.'

Nitin said, 'I wanted sweets.'

Malti placed jaggery on his leaf plate. 'This will do for today.'

Vikram stood outside on the veranda, watching the glow of the wedding. The wind was rising. In the distance, the cloth of the shamiana lifted once and then flapped hard again.

The feast went on. Ghee, dal, vegetables, tarua, curd, sweets. The guests kept discussing the flavours. Someone said there was too little salt; someone else said the curd was good. One row rose, another sat down. Again and again, amid the filled rows, the empty gap remained visible like a small cut.

At about ten at night, the groom's party began to eat. Meanwhile clouds gathered in the sky behind the house. No one had expected such clouds in Phagun. At first the wind blew lightly; then the bamboo shamiana began to flap.

'Tighten the ropes!' the cook shouted.

Two young men ran towards the poles. Heavy drops of rain began to fall. People lifted their plates and started moving towards the inner rooms. The rows broke apart.

At the rear of Ramlochan's house, a temporary kitchen had been set up beside an old mud wall. Three large cauldrons stood on the fire there. In the

wind, the tarpaulin overhead began to billow violently. One rope was tied to an old peg in the wall. As the wet earth softened, the peg loosened.

Maithili was gathering empty glasses from the storeroom when she heard a cracking sound. She saw that one part of the rear wall was leaning outwards, while the tarpaulin rope was pulling it towards itself. Two children stood at the foot of the wall holding leaf plates of sweets.

'Move!' Maithili shouted.

Her voice was swallowed by the rain and the commotion.

Just then three people came running in through the outer gate - Ramvriksh, his elder son Vikram, and the younger Nitin. Malti was behind them. They had reached home and were only just changing their clothes when they saw one bamboo pole of the shamiana fall towards the road and heard the uproar.

Ramvriksh understood the situation at a glance. First he moved the children away from the wall. Vikram caught the dangling tarpaulin rope and gave it some slack, reducing the pull on the wall. Nitin kept moving people out through the narrow path behind the kitchen.

'Don't go near the cauldrons!' Malti said, stopping the women. 'They're hot.'

Ramlochan and Raghuvir also came running.

'Hold this bamboo on this side,' Ramvriksh told Ramlochan. 'If we untie the rope, the tarpaulin will come down, but the wall may be saved.'

Without asking a question, Ramlochan took hold of the bamboo. Raghuvir took the other side. Vikram loosened the knot. As soon as the rope came free, the tarpaulin sagged to one side and rainwater poured off it in a rush. The old wall trembled, but did not fall.

Meanwhile, one bamboo pole from the front shamiana fell to the ground. People panicked again. Ramvriksh's sons cleared the rows. A few young men who had until then only been watching now joined in. Within five minutes, the children and elderly people had been moved from the open dining area into the inner rooms.

Within twenty minutes, the rain eased as suddenly as it had begun. Leaf plates, flowers, torn paper streamers and water floated together in the courtyard. The cooking had partly stopped, but no one was seriously hurt. One cook had a small wound on his hand.

Ramlochan stood beside a veranda pillar, trying to catch his breath. His dhoti was wet up to the knees. In front of him, Ramvriksh was washing the mud from his hands with water.

'Why did you come back?' Ramlochan finally asked.

Ramvriksh shook the water from his hands. 'I saw the bamboo fall onto the road. There were children inside.'

'Even so...' Ramlochan's sentence remained unfinished.

Ramvriksh looked at him. 'Disaster does not ask a person's caste before it falls.'

Saying this, he turned towards Malti. 'Come. Let us go home now.'

Raghuvir stepped between them and said, 'Eat before you go.'

For the first time Malti looked at him directly. 'The time for the meal has already passed.'

Raghuvir's eyes dropped.

Maithili ran to the storeroom. She took out the clean leaf plate on whose corner the damp mark of her finger had dried. Then she picked up three more. Inside the veranda, she laid all four leaf plates in a straight line.

Raghuvir wanted to say something, but Ramlochan raised a hand and stopped him.

'No separate last row this time,' he said.

Ramvriksh stood for a few moments, uncertain whether to sit. Just then Nitin, tired with hunger, looked at his mother. Malti stroked his head.

'Let the children eat,' she said. 'We will eat later.'

Maithili served rice on the leaf plates. Nitin sat down. Vikram beside him. Ramvriksh was still standing.

Ramlochan himself picked up the bucket of dal. He poured dal onto Nitin's leaf plate, then Vikram's. Then he looked at Ramvriksh.

'Sit,' was all he said.

Ramvriksh slowly sat down. Malti sat beside him at last.

In one corner of the rain-soaked courtyard, the leaf plates laid earlier had become completely jumbled. It was difficult to tell who had sat in which row.

The bride's farewell took place at dawn. The guests thinned out. Ramlochan and Maithili were cleaning the courtyard. The wet leaf plates were being gathered in one place.

Out of her old habit of counting, Maithili looked at the bundle of leaf plates. Then she smiled and asked, 'Uncle, yesterday one plate was kept short, wasn't it?'

Ramlochan stopped sweeping. He looked towards the place on the veranda where four leaf plates had been laid in a straight line the night before.

'Yes,' he said.

'What will we do now?'

Ramlochan looked across the wet courtyard. 'Now we must count again from the beginning.'

Maithili did not answer. She took out all the clean leaf plates that remained in the storeroom and began putting them into a single bundle. This time, no leaf plate was set aside separately.

STORY 147

A City Address

The day Amresh hung a small tin nameplate outside his rented room, the rain had stopped. In blue paint it read, 'Amresh Kumar, Vidyapati Nagar, Darbhanga.' Beneath it there was no village name, no post office, no block.

The room was not on Vidyapati Nagar's main road. Leaving the main road, at the end of a second narrow lane, behind a grocery shop, stood a cramped courtyard with three rooms. Amresh had been living there for two months. But whenever anyone asked, 'Where do you live?' he would answer easily, 'Vidyapati Nagar.'

If the next question was, 'Village?' his voice would grow a little softer. 'Near Darbhanga.'

In fact, his village was Sonbarsa - about eighteen kos from the town. Written in full, the village address took four lines: village, post office, police station, block, district. Amresh felt that such a long address made him seem small.

It had been two years since he came to Darbhanga. At first he had come to prepare for competitive examinations. Later he began tutoring two children in the evenings and earning enough to pay the rent. At the first house where he taught, the owner, looking at his certificates, had asked, 'Sonbarsa? That's quite far inside, isn't it?'

Amresh had laughed and said, 'I live here now.'

At the second house he heard someone say, 'A young man who lives in town understands the value of time.'

After that one sentence, Amresh began changing the way he introduced himself. Earlier, in written applications, he used to write 'Sonbarsa'. Now he wrote 'Vidyapati Nagar, Darbhanga'. His father's letters did not come to the rented room; the village postman delivered them directly to his home. Even so, the town address seemed to Amresh like a new identity of his own.

One day he went to register his name at the district employment assistance centre. The clerk sitting behind the window asked, 'Native place?'

'Darbhanga.'

'Where in Darbhanga?'

Amresh paused for a moment. 'Vidyapati Nagar.'

The clerk looked at his Aadhaar card. 'This says Sonbarsa.'

'That's the old address. I live in town now.'

'Current residence and native place are different things.'

There was a long queue behind him. The clerk asked again, 'Shall I put Sonbarsa as the permanent address?'

Amresh felt that the young men standing behind him were listening. He said, 'No, put the town address. I live here.'

The clerk shrugged. He typed something into the computer. A receipt came out. Amresh folded it without reading it and slipped it into his pocket.

A few months later, a notice appeared for the state's records-assistant training programme: six months of training, a monthly stipend, and, for successful trainees, the possibility of contract work in various district record rooms. Amresh's graduation marks were good. He filled in the application. He also entered his registration number from the employment assistance centre.

'If you get this work, it will be very good for you,' his father Harinarayan said on a visit from the village. 'You've had the patience for reading papers and documents since childhood.'

Amresh smiled. 'It's only an application so far.'

Harinarayan read the tin nameplate. 'Vidyapati Nagar?'

'Yes, Babu.'

'You cut out Sonbarsa?'

Amresh said jokingly, 'Babu, who here is going to read such a long address?'

Harinarayan said nothing. He merely looked once at the door of the room, the wet courtyard and the nameplate.

Three weeks later, the selection list was posted on the district noticeboard. Amresh's name stood sixth. There were eight training places in all. His hand trembled. He read his name twice.

Opposite his name on the noticeboard was written 'Vidyapati Nagar, Darbhanga'. For the first time, Amresh looked carefully at that line. Seeing his name printed beside the town address stirred a faint pride within him. A young man standing beside him asked, 'Are you from this town?' Without thinking, Amresh said, 'Yes, I live here.' At that moment the name Sonbarsa rose as far as his tongue, then went back again.

On his way home, he bought a marked copy of the selection list. Reaching his room, he hung the sheet beneath the nameplate. At night, in the lamplight, his name and address could be seen on the same line. Amresh felt that after two years of running about, the town was finally accepting his name.

Verification was three days later. The list of required documents included educational certificates, identity card, employment-registration receipt and residence certificate.

That very night Amresh went to the village. His father took all the papers out of the iron trunk. The residence certificate clearly said, 'Village Sonbarsa, Post Office Bhalpatti...' Harinarayan asked, 'Will you need papers for the town as well?'

'No. This is for the native residence.'

At dawn Amresh caught a bus and reached the district office. Twelve young men and women sat on the veranda holding files of documents. They were being called inside one by one.

Amresh's turn came. The superintendent sat on one side of the table, two clerks on the other. The first clerk checked the certificates. The second examined the employment-registration receipt.

'The permanent address here is written as Vidyapati Nagar,' he said.

'Yes... at that time I was living here.'

'The residence certificate is for Sonbarsa.'

'That is my village.'

The superintendent looked over his spectacles. 'Then which is your permanent address?'

Amresh's throat went dry. 'Sonbarsa.'

'Then why does the employment register say Vidyapati Nagar?'

'It was supposed to be the current address... when the entry was made, both somehow became the same.'

The clerk turned the receipt towards him. 'There are two boxes here - current and permanent. Both say Vidyapati Nagar.'

For the first time, Amresh read the receipt carefully. It was true: the same address appeared on both lines.

'I can get it corrected,' he said at once.

'Verification is still in progress,' the superintendent said calmly. 'There is a discrepancy in the documents. Bring a corrected receipt from the employment centre. The deadline is four o'clock tomorrow.'

Amresh gathered up his file and ran.

The employment assistance centre was not very crowded, but the employee who corrected entries in the computer register was on leave that day. Another clerk told him to submit a written application.

'I need it by four o'clock tomorrow,' Amresh said.

'Submit the application. The old entry will be checked and corrected.'

'By when?'

'It is difficult to say just now.'

'My selection will be held up.'

The clerk looked at him. 'Did you check it when it was first entered?'

No answer came from Amresh's mouth.

He ran to the owner of the house he rented. He thought he might obtain some proof of his current residence in Vidyapati Nagar. The owner said, 'You do live here, but this rear portion has no separate house number in the municipal register. The electricity receipt is in my name.'

'A written certificate?'

'I can give one for current residence. How can I give one for permanent residence?'

By evening Amresh had run to three places - the ward office, the employment centre and the district office. Everywhere the same question kept returning in different words: 'What is your native address?'

He had always known the answer to that question. The difficulty was not in the answer, but in the papers.

When he returned to his room at night, the tin nameplate was hanging crooked to one side in the rain-wind. The blue letters of 'Vidyapati Nagar, Darbhanga' gleamed in the damp light.

Ranjit, who lived in the adjoining room, asked, 'You got selected, didn't you?'

Amresh said, 'The papers are stuck.'

'Which paper?'

'The address.'

Ranjit wanted to laugh, but hearing Amresh's voice, he fell silent.

Early the next morning Amresh reached the employment centre. The employee who handled corrections arrived at eleven. The old entry was opened. The clerk said, 'It can be corrected, but a copy of the original document must be attached, and the officer must approve it.'

'By four today?'

'We'll try.'

At one in the afternoon the file reached the officer's desk. At two he left for a meeting. At three thirty-five, Amresh's receipt was issued - this time with Vidyapati Nagar as the current address and Sonbarsa as the permanent address.

Clutching the paper, he ran towards the district office. Rain had begun. The shared vehicle got stuck in traffic midway. Amresh got out and ran on foot.

The office clock showed seven minutes past four when he reached the veranda.

The door of the verification room was half closed. Inside, the clerks were tying up their files.

'Sir, the corrected receipt.'

The clerk looked at the clock. 'The list has been closed.'

'Seven minutes...'

'I understand. But after the eighth place, the first candidate on the waiting list has already been called.'

Amresh placed the paper on the table. The superintendent looked at it. 'It has been corrected. Attach this one to your next application.'

'This time...?'

The superintendent remained silent for a few moments before answering. 'This time the deadline has passed.'

Amresh picked up the paper. Outside, the rain was still falling.

Two days later he went to the village. Harinarayan was sorting maize on the veranda. Amresh put the file down on the cot.

'It didn't happen?' his father asked.

'No, Babu.'

'Were your marks too low?'

'The address was wrong.'

Harinarayan put the maize in his hand to one side. 'The home address?'

Amresh nodded.

Just then the postman stopped his bicycle at the gate. 'Harinarayan Babu! A letter for Amresh.'

Amresh went outside. His full address was written on the envelope - Village Sonbarsa, Post Office Bhalpatti, block, district. Not a single line had been shortened. The letter was an examination notice from a private institution; there was still time.

The postman laughed and said, 'Your letters never get lost in the village.'

Amresh stood there holding the envelope.

Three days later he returned to Darbhanga. The tin nameplate outside his room was still crooked. He pulled out the nail and took the plate down. The blue letters had not faded; he placed the plate inside against the wall.

In the evening he sat down to fill in a new application. The box marked 'Permanent address' appeared.

Amresh did not pause his pen.

He wrote it out in full - 'Village Sonbarsa, Post Office Bhalpatti...' Beneath it, in the box for 'Current address', he wrote the full name of his room in Vidyapati Nagar, the landlord's name, and the nearest landmark.

It filled four lines.

This time, not one line seemed long to him.

STORY 148

The Smile in the Photograph

The thirteenth-day rites were over. The leaf plates spread in the courtyard had been cleared away, the brass utensils had been washed and set upside down in a corner of the veranda, and the smell of incense still clung inside the house. In that house near Madhubani, all that remained now was the preparation to leave.

Vinod Babu's four children had come from different places. The eldest son, Naresh, from Patna; the second son, Dinesh, from Delhi; their daughter Meera, from Janakpur; and the younger daughter, Sudha, had been living in that house with Babu for the last two years of his life. During Babu's illness, the medicines, tests, nights spent awake and hospital visits had mainly been managed by Sudha. But during the days of the rites, this fact was written on no list.

After midday Naresh said while tying up his bag, 'I have to catch the four o'clock train.'

Dinesh looked at his watch. 'I too have a bus at five.'

Meera was closing the travelling case kept beside a pillar of the veranda. Sudha was putting the rice left in the kitchen into a small container.

Meanwhile Naresh's son Aditya came into the courtyard and said, 'Everyone sit together once. Let's take a group photograph.'

No one showed much interest. Dinesh said, 'Now?'

'After so many days, all of us are together. Who knows when we shall meet again?' Aditya raised his mobile phone. 'There are old photographs of all of us with Baba, but this is the first time we are all together since Baba went away.'

Meera said softly, 'Take it. If Babuji were here, he too would say, "Stand there, all of you together, just once."'

Everyone stood before the northern wall of the courtyard. Naresh was in the middle, Dinesh beside him, then Meera and Sudha. Behind them stood the daughters-in-law and the grandchildren. In front was Babu's empty bamboo chair. Aditya reached out to move it to one side.

Sudha said, 'Leave it there.'

'The chair is coming into the middle.'

'Leave it there.'

Aditya said nothing. The chair remained where it was.

When the photograph was taken, everyone's face looked tired in the first picture. Aditya looked at the screen and said, 'This is very sad. Smile once, please. Baba liked seeing everyone laugh.'

No one's smile came naturally. Then Meera looked towards Sudha. Sudha wiped the corner of her eye and stretched her lips a little. Seeing her, Meera smiled. Naresh too composed his lips. Dinesh gave a faint smile without showing his teeth. The second photograph came out clear.

Aditya said at once, 'This one is good.'

By evening the photograph had been posted on social media. Above it was written: 'In Babuji's memory, the family together even in an hour of grief.'

Aditya cropped out part of the empty chair because, according to him, it made the picture look tilted. But one arm of the chair was still visible in the right-hand corner.

In the first hour it received fifty likes. By night, five hundred. Vinod Babu had taught for thirty years at the local school; many of his former pupils began sharing the photograph. One wrote, 'See Guruji's values; the family is still bound together as one.' Another wrote, 'Such unity is rare.' A third wrote, 'A smile in grief, the courage of life.'

Sitting on the bus, Naresh kept reading the comments. He sent a screenshot of one comment to the family's shared message group: 'See how Babu's name is being honoured.'

Dinesh replied, 'Good. But we also have to look at the final hospital accounts.'

The message group fell silent all at once.

Two days later Naresh sent a photograph of the account book. It added up the total spent on Babu's treatment, how much each person had given, how much had been withdrawn from the bank, and how much of the old household savings had been used. Naresh wrote, 'In my view, whatever savings remain in the house should be divided equally among everyone.'

For the first time Sudha wrote, 'Where is the account of my salary spent on medicines during the last two years?'

Dinesh replied at once, 'Do not measure service in money.'

Sudha did not reply for a long time. Then she wrote only this: 'Then do not measure the bank expenses only in money either.'

Meera wrote in between, 'Stop this discussion for now.'

Naresh wrote, 'Stopping it will not change the account.'

That night the photograph crossed a thousand likes. A local news page posted a brief comment with it: 'The inspiring unity of the family of renowned teacher Vinod Jha.'

Excited, Aditya posted this in the shared group. No one replied.

Three days later an argument began over the key to the house. Naresh wanted the house to be kept locked and cleaned twice a year. Dinesh felt that an empty house would deteriorate quickly and should therefore be rented out. Meera said that it would not be right for the prayer room from their mother's time and Babu's books to fall among strangers. Sudha said that she was still

living in that house; her job was at a nearby school, so the house was not 'empty'.

Dinesh wrote, 'I used the word empty in the ordinary sense.'

Sudha replied, 'I am not ordinary.'

Then no message came for two days.

Meanwhile the photograph kept circulating on social media. Former pupils kept writing stories about Vinod Babu - how he gave books to pupils who could not pay their fees, how he taught extra lessons before examinations. In people's eyes, the smiles of the family's four children became proof of Babu's successful life.

Alone in the house, Sudha kept hearing notifications for those comments. Aditya had created an account for her on her mobile phone. Now and then she opened it, then closed it again.

One evening, after returning from school, she was cleaning Babu's room. From beneath the pillow she found two old medicine receipts. One receipt mentioned money sent by Dinesh from Delhi; the other bore Naresh's name. Sudha looked at the papers for a long time. She remembered that in that month Naresh had delayed paying his son's fees so that he could send the money. Dinesh too had sent money while putting up with a delay in his rent. In the rush of Babu's illness, she had forgotten that.

Sudha thought of sending photographs of the receipts to the shared group, but did not. She put the papers into Babu's file.

The following week Meera arrived unexpectedly. In her hand was a large frame.

'Aditya had it printed,' she said.

In the frame was the same smiling group photograph. The colours were bright and everyone's face was clear. In the right-hand corner, half an arm of the empty chair could be seen.

Meera said, 'I thought we could hang it in Babu's room.'

Sudha looked at the wall. An old black-and-white photograph of Babu was already hanging there, showing him standing among the children of his school. There was room for a nail beneath it.

Then Meera asked softly, 'How far has the matter of the house gone?'

'Nowhere.'

'Dinesh was saying it should be rented out.'

'Naresh says it should stay locked.'

'And you?'

Sudha put the duster to one side. 'I live here - and that fact seems to be the hardest thing for everyone to decide.'

Meera fell silent. The frame remained leaning against the wall.

That evening a message came from Naresh: 'Next Sunday, let the four of us talk it through.' Dinesh wrote only, 'Fine.' Meera did the same. Sudha did not reply.

On Sunday the four of them spoke together. The conversation began with the house, moved to the hospital expenses, then went on to Babu's care, absences, leave from work, salaries, the key, the books and the old fields. At times voices rose; at times one or another fell silent.

Naresh said, 'Each of us did whatever we could from where we were.'

For the first time Sudha said clearly, 'Yes. But we should also name what we could not do.'

After a long silence Dinesh said, 'You are right.'

No decision was reached that day. But for the first time, in the shared group, a separate list of the days of care was made alongside the hospital expenses - not how much money each person had given, but who had been present when, and who had been unable to come when. The list was incomplete, but for the first time it was not only about rupees.

At night Sudha picked up the frame that was leaning against the wall. She went to hang it on the nail, then stopped. Everyone in the photograph was smiling. On social media that smile meant 'unity' to thousands of people. To Sudha, it was a five-second instruction: 'Smile once.'

She did not hang the frame beneath Babu's black-and-white photograph. She put it on the wall of the veranda, where everyone entering the house would see it.

A few days later Naresh came. He saw the frame and said nothing. Then Dinesh came. He too said nothing. The next month Meera came and wiped the glass of the frame.

On social media the likes on the photograph gradually stopped. Newer news pushed it down.

Inside the house, the discussion was still not completely over. Some matters arose again; some fell silent again. But now, whenever any of the four crossed the veranda, that five-second smile stood before them.

One day Aditya came to the house again. Looking at the frame, he asked, 'The photograph looks good here, doesn't it?'

Sudha was tying up Babu's file at the time. She looked up.

'It does.'

'Everyone is smiling.'

Sudha looked once more towards the frame.

'Yes,' she said, 'when the photograph was taken, all of us smiled.'

STORY 149

A Feast on Debt

On the third day after Jagesar Mandal died, two cloth bags lay in one corner of the veranda. One held his dhoti, gamchha and old woollen shawl; the other held Nilima's college books, two files, and eighteen thousand four hundred rupees tied in a blue cloth.

On that blue cloth Nilima had written in her own hand, in small letters: 'Room in town and next semester.'

Harinarayan Mandal, Jagesar's elder son, came and stood before that bag many times, then turned away without touching it. Babu's funeral rites were under way. Relatives were coming to the house. Some carried fruit, some rice, and some advice on their lips.

'How many people for the thirteenth-day meal?' his maternal cousin Shambhu asked.

Harinarayan lowered his eyes and said, 'We haven't counted yet.'

'Count first. If you run to the market on the last day, everything will cost twice as much.'

That night four people sat in the courtyard: Mother, Harinarayan, his younger brother Kailash, and Nilima. Mother said, 'Your Babu used to say while he was alive: don't make a show after I'm gone. Do whatever you can, quietly.'

Kailash agreed. 'Fifty or sixty of our own people. That's all.'

Harinarayan said nothing. For three months before Babu's death he had been making rounds of the hospital in town. Medicines, tests, transport - the savings had melted away in all of it. Even so, some other reckoning was going on inside him.

The very next day he met Baidyanath Sah at the market. Harinarayan had been buying household provisions from his grocery shop for years. Baidyanath himself raised the matter -

'Jagesar Kaka belonged to everyone. If you keep the feast small, people will talk.'

Harinarayan did not smile.

Baidyanath opened his ledger on the wooden counter. 'Rice, dal, oil, spices - write down whatever you need. How can you pay everything at once? Settle the account when the crop is sold.'

The blank page of the ledger lay before Harinarayan. The date was written at the top. Beneath it came the first entry - eight sacks of rice.

When he returned home that evening, he said, 'I've made provision for three hundred people.'

Mother looked straight at him. 'Who told you to?'

'No one. Babu had a name. People will come.'

Nilima was writing something in her file at the time. Her pen stopped. 'Three hundred?'

'The village, relatives, people who farmed with Babu - everyone.'

Kailash asked, 'Money?'

'Sah will give it on credit.'

Mother said softly, 'At a feast bought on debt, is it the soul that is satisfied, or the ledger?'

Harinarayan got up and went outside.

The preparations began. Bamboo arrived. A temporary hearth was built on one side of the courtyard. Leaf plates were counted. Pots of curd were arranged. An advance had to be paid for the fish. The sweet-maker asked for half his money in advance.

At night Harinarayan sat on the veranda and untied the knot in the blue cloth. He counted the notes. Eighteen thousand four hundred. He set ten thousand aside. Then, after pausing for a few moments, he tied the remaining notes back into the cloth.

Nilima was standing by the doorway.

'Babu?'

Harinarayan started. 'You haven't slept yet?'

'That was the money for my room.'

'I'll put it back in ten days.'

'Where will so much money come from?'

'I'll get an advance on the paddy.'

For a few moments Nilima kept looking at the notes in her father's hand. 'I asked where it would come from, not when.'

Harinarayan's voice hardened. 'This is not the time in this house for such accounts.'

Nilima did not reply. She picked up her file and went inside.

From early morning on the thirteenth day, the courtyard filled with smoke. Fish was washed. Dal went on the fire. Sacks of rice were opened. Relatives from far away arrived ahead of time. The dining rows filled not once but five times.

All day Harinarayan ran from one hearth to another, from the gate to the dining rows and from the rows to the storeroom. Babu's photograph hung on the veranda wall. The flowers before it were drying.

By the time the feast ended, it was night. Two large pots of rice were left, half a bucket of vegetables, several pots of curd, and countless used leaf plates.

As the guests left, each had something different to say.

'The arrangements were good.'

'The fish could have come round once more.'

'The curd was excellent.'

'It got crowded when we sat down.'

Harinarayan listened to all of it. Not one person said anything about Jagesar.

The next morning a man from Baidyanath Sah's shop came with the account. The total debt was far higher than Harinarayan had estimated. Rice, oil, spices, curd, firewood, leaf plates, labour - each was listed separately. The advances for the fish and sweets had already gone from Nilima's bundle.

'I'll pay after the crop,' Harinarayan said.

'To be paid after the crop,' the young man writing the account entered in the ledger.

Nilima was to return to college seven days later. The district headquarters was so far from the village that walking there and back every day was impossible. Five girls from the village travelled in the same hired vehicle. The rule was that the month's fare had to be paid together at the beginning of the month. Nilima's blue-cloth bundle had held the fare for those four months, the cost of laboratory materials, and money for books.

On the first day of the month the driver came to the gate and asked, 'This month's fare?'

Harinarayan said, 'Give me two days.'

Two days later he went to the paddy trader. The trader looked over the field, made an estimate, and said, 'If I give you an advance now, then at harvest I won't take the paddy at the market price. I'll take it at the price we fix today.'

The price was low. Harinarayan agreed anyway. Most of the advance went towards Baidyanath's debt. The rest paid two old hospital bills. Nilima's blue cloth remained empty.

On the third day the hired vehicle drove past without stopping. Nilima stood on the veranda with her bag of books in her hand.

'Didn't you go today?' Mother asked.

'The vehicle left without me.'

Harinarayan was folding the receipt for the paddy advance at the time. 'I'll arrange something tomorrow.'

The next day Nilima borrowed a bicycle from her neighbour Sarita. She left at dawn. By the time she returned, it was evening. The bicycle's front tyre kept losing air. On the fifth day it rained. When she reached home in wet clothes, Mother was waiting at the door.

'You won't go like this every day,' Mother said.

'Then how am I supposed to go?'

Mother did not answer.

For a week Nilima went sometimes by bicycle, sometimes in an acquaintance's vehicle, sometimes by bus. She went three days and missed two.

Her laboratory group was changed. Another student was put into the group in which she had worked with four other girls.

On Sunday her classmate Rashmi came to bring her file. 'Your laboratory attendance is falling,' she said. 'The teacher asked about you.'

Nilima turned a page. 'What did you say?'

'That there was work at home.'

Nilima looked at Rashmi. 'That was a lie.'

'Then what should I have said?'

Nilima did not answer.

From the following week she stopped going to college. The books did not close. After the morning chores, she studied in the afternoon. She copied Rashmi's notes. She wrote questions on separate sheets of paper. But the smell of the laboratory, questions put directly to the teacher, debates with classmates, and the library timetable were not available on the veranda at home.

Harinarayan understood this clearly for the first time on a Tuesday. It was ten o'clock. He returned early from the field and saw Nilima sitting on the veranda with a chemistry book open.

'Holiday today?'

Nilima looked up. 'Only I have a holiday.'

'From college?'

'Only me.'

Harinarayan wanted to say something, but no words came. He went inside.

That evening he went to Baidyanath Sah's shop to make the monthly payment. In the ledger, the debt from the feast was slowly shrinking. Baidyanath crossed off the amounts paid with a red pen.

'There isn't much left now,' he said.

Harinarayan turned the ledger towards himself and looked. Eight sacks of rice. Oil. Dal. Spices. Leaf plates. Firewood. One entry after another. All at once he remembered Nilima's file - laboratory dates, lists of lessons, blank days in the attendance record.

'When will this ledger be closed?'

Baidyanath added up the account. 'Two more months.'

Harinarayan said softly, 'The other ledger won't wait that long.'

Baidyanath looked at him questioningly, but asked nothing.

When Harinarayan returned home, he sat beside Nilima's books.

'How many days have you missed?'

Nilima did not count. 'Enough that I can't complete all the laboratory work this semester now.'

'Shall I find another vehicle?'

'Where will the money come from?'

Harinarayan was silent.

Nilima did not close the book. 'I haven't stopped studying. The semester has stopped.'

'What's the difference?'

'There is one for me.'

After that day Harinarayan began avoiding talk of the feast. If someone said the thirteenth-day meal had been splendid, he merely nodded. The monthly payments at Baidyanath's shop continued regularly. The field's paddy went at a low price. Household expenses were cut.

Nilima began tutoring two adolescent girls from the village in the evenings. She did not put that money towards the feast debt. She kept it in an old tin. Inside the lid she pasted a small piece of paper: 'Fare for next semester.'

One day Mother asked, 'Have you told Babu?'

'Not yet.'

'Why not now?'

'Let it fill up first.'

At the end of Paush, Harinarayan paid the final instalment at Baidyanath's shop. Baidyanath drew a red line across the entry in the ledger and wrote, 'Paid in full.' Then he handed him a small receipt.

When he reached home, Harinarayan placed the receipt beside Nilima.

'The feast account is finished.'

Nilima picked up the receipt. She looked at it for a while. Then she opened her laboratory file and placed it inside.

'Why there?' Harinarayan asked.

'That page was blank.'

Harinarayan could not bring himself to ask whether she meant the blank back of the receipt or the blank days of that semester.

In Magh a notice for the next semester came from the college. Nilima opened the tin and counted the money. It was not enough for the full fare, but it was more than half. Harinarayan supplied the rest. This time the blue-cloth bundle was tied again.

On the morning she was to leave, Shambhu met them at the gate - the same Shambhu who had asked about the size of the dining rows on the third day.

'The thirteenth-day feast was excellent,' Shambhu said. 'People still talk about it.'

Harinarayan asked, 'What do they say?'

Shambhu thought. 'The arrangements were good... the fish...'

He could not finish the sentence.

Nilima came out carrying her bag. The blue cloth was in her hand. The hired vehicle stopped outside the gate. She climbed in.

Harinarayan turned towards the veranda. Jagesar's photograph still hung in the same place on the wall. Beneath it there was no ledger of the feast.

A red line had already been drawn through the entry in Baidyanath's ledger.

In Nilima's attendance register, an entire semester remained blank.

STORY 150

The Rented Car

At eight in the morning, Nandkishor Jha straightened the two garlands of red flowers on the gate of his courtyard once again. Just behind them stood a gleaming black car. White flowers on the bonnet spelled 'Ravi', and a small yellow strip in one corner of the windscreen had been covered with flower petals.

'The strip cannot be seen, can it?' Nandkishor asked the driver.

The driver, Shambhu, bent down and looked. 'No. But that is the vehicle-service mark. If anything happens on the road, the number is written there.'

'Nothing will happen,' Nandkishor said. 'And if the mark is visible, people will know the car is hired.'

Shambhu said nothing. He merely opened the bonnet, looked towards the water reservoir, touched the cap, then closed it gently.

It was Ravi's wedding. For three days the house had been full of people's voices, incense, the smell of betel, and the band's rehearsals. Ravi's father, Harimohan Jha, had retired from a government school. The house was brick-built, but not new. There was an old scooter in the courtyard and a two-wheeler belonging to Amit, the younger son. That was all.

But the previous month, when the bride's maternal uncle had raised the matter of transport for the wedding day, Nandkishor had said casually, 'Ravi has a car. He lives in town and hardly uses it.'

Ravi had been sitting there at the time. He had opened his mouth to say something, but his father's look had stopped him.

On the way back Ravi had asked, 'Where is my car?'

Harimohan had said quietly, 'There will be a car on the wedding day. That is all.'

Nandkishor had cut in, 'It is only for one day. People watch these things. The groom must have his standing.'

After that, an expensive car was booked on hire from Darbhanga. Fourteen thousand for the day, flower decoration extra, deposit extra. Nandkishor borrowed five thousand rupees from a moneylender he knew to make up the deposit. Only four people in the house knew this.

All this weighed heavily on Ravi. He was an accounts assistant in town and earned a decent monthly salary, but he could not yet afford to buy a car of his own. Meera, the bride, knew this. Two months after the marriage had been fixed, Ravi had told her, 'I go to the office by bus.'

Meera had laughed and said, 'I went to college by bus too.'

After that simple answer, Ravi had felt no need to say anything more. But in the eyes of the family, a wedding was not merely a matter between two people; there was the village's gaze, the relatives' gaze, the wedding party's gaze - each a separate reckoning.

In the afternoon the wedding party set out. The band was in front, two small cars in the middle, and the black car at the very back. Ravi sat in the black car with his father and Nandkishor. Shambhu kept glancing towards the strip at the front, where the hire-vehicle service mark had been hidden by flowers.

After they had passed the village, the sun grew fierce on the paved road. Cool air circulated inside. Nandkishor was pleased. When two young men standing by the roadside looked towards the car, he leaned towards Ravi and said, 'See? At a wedding, this is what a first impression should be like.'

Ravi kept looking out at the fields where the paddy had already been harvested.

Beyond Sakri, when the road narrowed a little, Shambhu slowed the car. A red warning light flashed once on the dashboard.

He switched off the cool air.

Nandkishor spoke at once. 'Why did you switch it off?'

'The heat is rising.'

'The sun is blazing outside. Of course the heat will rise.'

'Not inside the car,' Shambhu said. 'The engine.'

He drove slowly for a little while. The red light flashed again. This time he pulled the car over to the side of the road.

The two cars behind also stopped. The band vehicle went a little farther and came to a halt.

'Why here?' Harimohan asked.

Shambhu opened the bonnet. A faint wave of hot steam rose. He stepped back.

'There is a split in the water hose,' he said. 'I told the vehicle service this morning that the car should be replaced. The owner said it had been reserved in advance for the wedding and would manage. I cannot take it any farther in this condition.'

Nandkishor's expression changed slightly. 'Inform the vehicle service.'

Shambhu looked towards the corner of the windscreen, then at the flower garland.

'The number was on that strip.'

For a few moments no one said anything.

Amit got out of the car behind and came over. 'It will be in the papers.'

Shambhu shook his head. 'The papers are deposited at the office. My driver's slip has only the booking number. The assistance number was written on the car.'

Nandkishor himself reached out to remove the flowers. The adhesive tape had stuck so firmly that half the lettering on the strip was buried under the flower glue. Amit slowly cleaned the paper. In bold letters on the yellow strip, the words emerged:

'Mithila Wedding Vehicle Service - For Hire.'

Two members of the wedding party standing behind read it. One of them said casually, 'Oh, so it is hired.'

No one laughed. But to Nandkishor those four words sounded louder than the band.

He said, 'Hired or owned, what matters now is getting there.'

Shambhu read the number and called from his mobile phone. He was told that a replacement car could be sent, but it would take an hour and a half to reach them from Darbhanga. An old white jeep was available at the nearest branch; it could arrive in twenty or twenty-five minutes.

Nandkishor asked, 'What is the white jeep like?'

'Ordinary,' Shambhu said.

'Flowers?'

'No. None at all.'

'The vehicle-service name?'

'Written on both sides.'

Nandkishor fell silent.

Time was running short before the auspicious wedding hour. The band players sat down in the shade of a peepal tree by the roadside. An elderly member of the wedding party walked towards a nearby tea stall in search of water. Within five minutes, half the wedding party had gathered there.

The owner of the tea stall recognised Ravi. 'Why, Ravi Babu! Today is your wedding!'

Ravi smiled. 'Yes, but our vehicle has given up halfway.'

The shopkeeper looked towards the car with its bonnet open. 'It will be fixed.'

'Maybe,' Ravi said. 'If not, there are other ways to travel.'

Nandkishor heard this answer from a distance.

Messages kept coming from the bride's house. First they asked where the wedding party had reached. Then whether there was any trouble. Each time Harimohan said, 'We are almost there.'

The third time Ravi took the mobile phone. It was Meera herself.

'What happened on the way?'

Ravi looked at the black car, at the yellow strip exposed among the flowers, and then at his father.

'The hired car broke down.'

There was silence at the other end for two moments.

'So what now?'

Ravi burst out laughing. 'So I am standing by the roadside.'

Meera laughed too. 'Is a wedding party made by the car or by the people?'

Before Ravi could answer, Nandkishor signalled for the mobile phone from his hand. Ravi did not give it to him.

Meera said, 'Come by whatever you can find. Mama can send a small bus.'

'Not a bus,' Nandkishor said almost in a whisper, but his voice carried as far as Ravi's phone.

Meera asked, 'Who said that?'

'Kaka.'

Laughter came again from the other end.

Meanwhile the old white jeep arrived. The vehicle-service name was clearly painted in blue letters on both sides. There was rope on the roof, an iron ladder at the back, and an old sheet on the seat inside. The driver got out and handed the papers to Shambhu.

'This is for the groom?' Disappointment showed in Nandkishor's voice.

'This is what is available,' the new driver said.

Ravi opened the door of the black car and took out the box containing his ceremonial wedding headgear. 'Come on.'

'In this jeep?' Nandkishor asked.

'Yes. This will do.'

'What will people say?'

For the first time Ravi looked directly into his uncle's eyes. 'By now, people know everything.'

After that sentence there was nothing left to say.

The wedding party set off again. The band in front, two small cars in the middle, and behind them the white jeep with the vehicle-service name written on it. The expensive black car remained by the roadside with its bonnet open; Shambhu stood beside it waiting for the assistance vehicle.

When the jeep reached the gate of the bride's house, the children first read the vehicle-service name, then watched Ravi step out of the flowerless vehicle. A few young men smiled, but the smile was not mocking; it was one of curiosity.

Meera's maternal uncle came forward and said, 'Did you have a lot of trouble on the way?'

Before Harimohan could answer, Ravi said, 'The expensive car brought us halfway. The ordinary one brought us the rest of the way.'

Her uncle said only, 'Come.'

The wedding rites began. The band started playing again. People became occupied with the meal, the rituals, the songs and meeting one another. Within an hour, talk of the car had almost ended.

Late that night, when Nandkishor was sitting to one side of the courtyard, Amit came and handed him the receipt from the hire-vehicle service. The assistance vehicle had taken away the black car. One line had been added to the receipt: 'Vehicle-service strip damaged by flower adhesive tape: cleaning charge.'

Nandkishor stared at that line for a long time.

'How much?' Amit asked.

'Eight hundred rupees.'

'Pay it.'

Nandkishor folded the receipt, then opened it again. 'Pay it.'

Amit went away.

A little later laughter came from the wedding pavilion. Nandkishor got up and went there. Ravi and Meera were sitting beside each other. Meera's younger brother was twirling the jeep key in his hand and saying, 'Jijaji, this same vehicle will be there for the return journey. I have already asked whether it will break down halfway.'

Light laughter spread all around.

Nandkishor smiled too. This time he felt no need to look at anyone's face.

At dawn the white jeep stood outside the gate. The vehicle-service name was plainly visible on both sides.

No one felt any desire to cover it with flowers.

STORY 151

Like Gold

One afternoon in Bhadau, Raghunath Jha was moving a trunk away from the wall of the back room of the house. Rainwater was seeping in from one corner, and rust had formed on the bottom of the old iron trunk. The only reason for opening the trunk was to keep the clothes inside from getting wet.

On top lay an old dhoti, two woollen blankets and Mother's yellowing letters. At the very bottom he found a small red velvet box. The edges of the box were worn, but the cloth inside was still soft.

Raghunath lifted the lid.

A necklace, two bangles, a nose-ring and a thin chain lay there filled with a golden gleam. Even in the muddy light of the rains, their shine seemed to set apart the darkness of the room.

'Where did these come from?' his wife Pushpa asked.

Raghunath's younger brother Rameshwar came in from the veranda. The moment he saw the box, he stopped short. 'Mother's?'

'Must be.'

The three of them looked at the jewellery for a long time. Mother had been gone eight years. All their lives they had seen her wearing only ordinary silver anklets and iron bangles. No one had ever spoken of there being so much golden jewellery in the house.

Rameshwar reached out to pick up one bangle, but Raghunath immediately said, 'Not now. Your hands are wet.'

Rameshwar stopped his hand.

By evening the news had spread through the whole house, but not beyond the gate. Raghunath's daughter Neha, Rameshwar's son Kundan, Pushpa, and Rameshwar's wife Meena - all of them had seen the box once. Raghunath told everyone, 'Don't tell anyone outside. It is an old thing. Let us first understand what it is.'

'Let's take it to a goldsmith,' Meena said.

Raghunath shook his head. 'Carry so much jewellery around the market in a bag? First let us keep it safe at home.'

That night the box did not go back into the trunk. It was placed in a small niche built into the wall behind the grain bin, and a new lock was put on the niche's wooden door. Rameshwar himself went to the market to buy the lock. When he returned, there were two keys.

'You keep one, and I'll keep one,' he said.

Raghunath stood for a few moments with both keys in his hands. 'It is better to have only one key. Two keys mean twice the risk.'

Rameshwar did not smile. 'This is my house too.'

'Who said it isn't?'

'Then why should the key be in only one person's hand?'

Pushpa intervened. 'Don't make more of this now. Let it be tested first.'

But it was not tested the next day. Nor on the third day. Raghunath kept saying that they would show it when they found a trustworthy goldsmith. Meanwhile, the lock began to be checked twice a day.

Earlier, Pushpa used to take jars of pickle, the grain measure and utensils for festivals from that room. Now Raghunath would tell her, 'Tell me whatever you need.'

The first two times Pushpa said nothing. The third time she said, 'For twenty years the keys of this house have been in my hands. Now will you take out even the pickle yourself?'

Raghunath's answer was brief. 'It isn't about the key. It's about what is inside.'

'Does what is inside belong to the house, or to you?'

Raghunath did not answer then.

Four days later Lalita came. She was Raghunath and Rameshwar's sister and, after marriage, lived near Benipatti. She had not heard it from anyone else; Neha had told her about it.

'Show me Mother's box,' she said directly.

Raghunath opened the lock. Lalita held the necklace in her hand and looked at it for a long time. 'I don't remember this.'

'Neither do I,' Rameshwar said.

Lalita laughed. 'Then Mother kept more secrets than all of us.'

A few moments later she grew serious. 'If it is Mother's, I have a share in it too.'

The room suddenly seemed smaller.

Raghunath said, 'First let us find out what it is.'

'And if it turns out to be gold?'

Rameshwar kept looking at the wall. Pushpa continued wiping the lid of a jar.

Lalita put the necklace back into the box. 'I am not asking for anything now. I only do not want to hear later - a daughter belongs to another household.'

That day she ate, but returned without staying the night.

The following week the key went missing.

Raghunath had put the key in his shirt pocket after locking the niche in the morning. At noon, when he went to open the room, the pocket was empty. First he searched his own room. Then the veranda. Then the courtyard.

Ten minutes later the entire house was looking for the key.

Raghunath asked, 'Who went near the room?'

Pushpa looked at him at once. 'I did.'

'Why did you go near the room?'

'For pickle.'

'Without me?'

'Must I ask even for pickle now?'

Rameshwar intervened. 'At a time like this, weigh your words before you speak.'

Pushpa's face hardened. 'I should weigh my words? Your elder brother is the one who has lost the key.'

Raghunath's voice was low, but the suspicion in that low voice was plain. 'I only asked.'

Pushpa did not eat that day.

In the evening the key was found in the other pocket of Raghunath's old shirt. He himself had put it there while changing clothes that morning.

Rameshwar handed him the key and said, 'Now?'

Raghunath went to Pushpa. 'The mistake was mine.'

Pushpa said only, 'The key has been found. Has the other thing been found too?'

That night, for the first time, Raghunath did not get up to check the lock.

But the next night he did.

Little by little, guarding the jewellery became part of the household routine. They discussed who would sleep on the veranda at night, who would keep the key when they went to the market, and whether the house would be left empty on festival days. Rameshwar suggested buying a small iron box. Raghunath said, 'When there is a niche in the house, why spend more money?'

Rameshwar replied, 'I don't trust the niche, and I don't trust the key either.'

Raghunath understood that the second part was meant for him.

In Kartik, the engagement of Lalita's daughter Pragya was fixed. Lalita came again. This time she asked for the necklace.

'For one evening,' she said. 'Pragya is Mother's granddaughter. If it is around her neck, Mother's thing will remain in her own family.'

Raghunath refused at once. 'It hasn't even been tested yet. What if something happens on the way?'

'Then have it tested.'

'I will.'

'When will you have it tested?'

There was no answer.

Lalita said softly, 'The jewellery is safe. Where have you kept the relationships?'

This time she did not eat either.

Raghunath and Rameshwar both went to Pragma's engagement, but they sat separately. Lalita spoke to them formally. Pushpa said very little. On the way home, Rameshwar said, 'Have it tested now. The longer the thing stays locked up, the more we are coming apart.'

Two days later Jagdish the goldsmith was called to the house at night. He was an acquaintance of Raghunath's and had run a shop in the market for thirty years. He was asked not to let the matter be discussed outside.

Jagdish placed the box in front of him and first examined the pieces with his eyes. Then he scratched the back of the necklace clasp with his fingernail. He took out a small black stone and rubbed the edge of the necklace against it.

Raghunath grew restless. 'Don't rub it too much.'

Jagdish looked at him. 'Shall I test it, or only look at it?'

'Test it.'

Jagdish rubbed again. A thin golden line appeared on the stone, but beneath it a dull line showed through at once.

He scratched the inside corner of one bangle. A small greenish-brown mark appeared.

Rameshwar leaned forward. 'What is it?'

Jagdish weighed one bangle in his palm. 'The workmanship is old. It is good.'

Raghunath's eyes brightened. 'How pure is it?'

Jagdish remained silent.

'Tell us, what is it?'

'It isn't gold.'

There was no rain in the room, yet it seemed to someone as though water had begun seeping from the wall again.

Raghunath tried to laugh. 'Look properly.'

Jagdish tested the other bangle, tested the chain, and examined the pin of the nose-ring. 'A brass-and-copper alloy with a golden coating. In a few places the coating has worn away. From a distance it shines like gold.'

Rameshwar sat down.

Pushpa stood at the door. Her eyes were not on the jewellery but on Raghunath.

'Value?' Raghunath asked.

Jagdish said, 'The workmanship may have value. The metal, not much.'

No one asked the next question.

Jagdish closed the box. 'Whoever owned it may have had it made for a wedding, a dance, or some occasion. In the old days, imitation jewellery this good was made too.'

Having said that much, Jagdish got up and left.

After the gate had been closed, Rameshwar said softly, 'We quarrelled over two keys.'

Pushpa said, 'I stood under suspicion for the sake of pickle.'

Raghunath remained silent.

After a while he opened the lock on the niche. Instead of putting the box inside, he placed it on the bench in the veranda. The key too was left beside it.

Lalita came the next morning. Rameshwar himself had sent word to her.

After hearing everything, she said nothing for a long time. Then she opened the box and lifted the necklace. The shine was the same.

'Next month Pragya's school is staging a play about an old-time wedding,' she said. 'This necklace may be useful.'

For the first time Raghunath answered without thinking. 'Take it.'

Lalita did not pick up the necklace at once. She looked at Pushpa. Pushpa slid the box towards her.

'Take the necklace,' Pushpa said, 'and the rest too, if you want.'

Lalita took only the necklace. 'Let the rest stay here.'

That night the room was not locked. Raghunath woke once at midnight. His hand went instinctively beneath the pillow, where for several weeks he had been keeping the key.

There was nothing there.

He got up and came as far as the veranda. The red box lay open on the veranda. Neha was trying one bangle on her wrist, while Kundan was trying to pull the other bangle from her hand.

Instead of scolding the two of them, Pushpa was laughing.

Raghunath stood there for a few moments.

Then he went back inside.

The box remained open on the veranda.

STORY 152

Ten Kilos of Rice

The morning sun had not yet fully climbed the yellow wall of the school, but a queue had already formed in the courtyard. Rain had been falling on and off for two weeks; even though the paddy had been transplanted, the rice pots in many homes had grown light. A notice from the panchayat had come: selected families would receive ten kilos of rice each.

Malti Devi had come with her eight-year-old son, Chhotu. This was Chhotu's own school. On a holiday, it felt strange to him to see his classroom shut; today, instead of the blackboard, there were three tables on the veranda, a strip of red cloth and sacks of rice.

Chhotu was not counting the people in the queue. His eyes were on the scales. Iron weights, the balance, and a white sack. In thick green letters on the sack was written: '10 KILOS ASSISTANCE.' Its mouth was stitched with blue thread, and there was a small tear at the right-hand corner. Two or three grains were caught outside the tear.

'Ma, is this ten kilos?' Chhotu asked.

'The scales will tell us,' Malti said. 'You keep quiet.'

In the middle of the veranda, a panchayat employee sat on a chair with a file open before him. Beside him, two young men were checking slips. In front, a man with a camera kept changing his position—sometimes by the gate, sometimes behind the red cloth.

The first name was called—Sukni Devi.

Sukni stepped forward. One of the young men lifted the white sack and placed it in her hands. The sack was heavy; Sukni's elbow bent at once. The employee motioned to her to smile. The camera flashed.

'That's enough,' the young man said.

Sukni tucked the sack under her arm and turned. She had not taken even two steps when a voice came from behind: 'Mother, leave it here. Let everyone's photograph be taken first. It will be distributed afterwards.'

Sukni stood still for a moment. Then she put the sack back on the table. She was given a pink slip stamped 'RECEIVED.'

Chhotu's eyes remained on the blue thread.

The second name—Jagarnath Paswan.

The same sack was lifted again. It was placed in Jagarnath's hands. He looked towards the camera. The flash went off. The sack went back on the table. Another pink slip.

The third name. The fourth name.

The same sack. The same blue thread. The same tear in the right-hand corner.

Chhotu peered beneath the table. Two more sacks lay there, but they looked flattened, as though only half full. The door of the room behind was shut.

'Ma,' he said softly, 'why is everyone getting the same sack?'

Malti's queue moved forward. 'I told you, keep quiet.'

'But where did Sukni Kaki's rice go?'

Malti gripped his hand tightly. Her experience had taught her that asking questions in a queue brought no benefit. To have one's name on the slip, to stand in the queue, to put one's thumbprint at the proper time—that much itself was a great deal.

In a corner of the veranda, Chhotu saw a grain of rice. It had fallen through the tear as the sack was being lifted and set down. He bent and picked it up. Then another.

By the seventh family he had collected five grains.

Malti's name was called eighth.

'Malti Devi, wife of the late Nathuni Sadai.'

Malti stepped forward. Chhotu followed her.

The white sack came into her hands. Chhotu looked at it from very close—the knot in the blue thread was on the verge of coming undone. A grain of rice was half sticking out through the tear in the right-hand corner. Chhotu tried to push it back in with his finger. The young man brushed his hand away.

'Don't touch.'

'This is my mother's rice, isn't it?' Chhotu asked.

Two or three people in the queue laughed.

The employee said, 'Yes, yes, you'll get it. Photograph first.'

The flash went off.

For the first time, Malti tried to smile. The photograph was taken. The young man then took the sack out of her hands almost immediately.

'Leave it here for now. As soon as the supplies arrive by evening, everyone will be given theirs. Keep the slip safely.'

Malti took the pink slip. Chhotu kept looking at the sack.

'Ma, will they give this to someone else again?'

'Come.'

On the way home, Chhotu opened his fist. There were five grains. He could not tell whether the sixth grain had fallen somewhere on the road or whether he had counted wrongly in the first place.

All that day, until evening, Malti kept looking towards the school. No vehicle came. At night the rice-water on the hearth was made thinner. Chhotu tried to count the grains of rice in his bowl, then stopped halfway.

The elderly Janakdulari of the household sat on the veranda cutting betel nut. She asked, 'Didn't they give you the rice?'

Malti showed her the pink slip. 'They said they would give it in the evening. Evening has passed.'

Chhotu broke in, 'Grandmother, they gave everyone the same sack. First Sukni Kaki, then Jagarnath Kaka, then Ma. The flash went off, and then the sack went back.'

Janakdulari turned the slip over in her hand. 'Are we supposed to eat rice on paper?'

Malti grew irritated. 'I'll ask tomorrow. What was the use of quarrelling today?'

Chhotu put his five grains into a fold of an old piece of paper and tucked it beneath the head of the cot. As sleep came, the scene from that day kept returning to him—the sack changing hands, the flash, then empty hands. He could not understand how giving something and showing it being given could become two separate acts.

The next day Malti went back to the school with the pink slip. Chhotu went with her. The veranda was empty. The red cloth had been removed. The tables had been taken inside the classroom. Only the panchayat assistant was there, putting files away.

Malti held out the slip. 'Yesterday you said ten kilos of rice.'

The assistant opened the file and found her name. 'It shows received here.'

'Received where? They put it in my hands, took a photograph, and then took it back.'

The assistant showed her the mark of her thumb. 'Your thumbprint is here.'

Malti's voice hardened. 'I put my thumbprint for the slip. The sack never reached my home.'

By then Sukni Devi had also arrived. The same pink slip was in her hand. Then Jagarnath came. Then two more families. Every file said 'RECEIVED.' No one's home had received rice.

The assistant's expression changed. He said, 'I was given the list yesterday. The distribution was being handled by a separate team.'

'Where is the team?' Jagarnath asked.

There was no immediate answer.

Chhotu sat on the steps of the veranda. The five grains from the previous day were still in his pocket. He placed them one by one on the step. Five small white dots.

Ramanand Babu, a teacher at the school, was arriving just then. Although it was a holiday, he had come to take some papers from a cupboard in one of the classrooms. When he saw the gathering, he stopped.

Ramanand Babu asked, 'What happened here?' Five voices rose at once.

Ramanand heard everyone out. He gave no judgement. Sitting down beside Chhotu, he asked, 'Were you here yesterday?' Chhotu nodded. Ramanand looked into his eyes and asked again, 'What did you see?'

Chhotu pointed to the five grains. 'There was one sack. They gave that same one to everyone. Then they took it back. These fell from this tear.' Ramanand asked, 'The same sack?' Chhotu said, 'Blue thread. A tear here.' He pointed to the right-hand corner of his shirt. 'Here.' Ramanand said nothing.

By noon, the news had reached the block office. Two members of the relief-distribution team arrived. With them came the man who had taken the photographs the previous day. An argument began—the supplies had arrived late, the photographs had been taken first, distribution was to happen afterwards, the list had been closed by mistake, the 'RECEIVED' stamp had been put on the slips too early.

'Then where is the rice?' Malti asked. Many sentences came out in answer to that question, but no rice did.

The photographer began showing the previous day's pictures on the screen of his camera. The first photograph—Sukni holding the white sack. The second—Jagarnath. The third—another family. The eighth—Malti. Ramanand Babu studied the pictures carefully. In every picture the sack was turned the same way. The knot in the blue thread was identical. There was the same small dark mark in the right-hand corner.

'These are not proof of distribution,' Ramanand said quietly. 'They are proof of one sack going round and round.' No one laughed.

The senior employee who had come with the team asked for the records. The previous day's signature register, the store's issue register and the available sacks were counted. The figures did not tally. Five sacks were found in the room behind the school, seven in the panchayat building. The rest of the consignment had never arrived by vehicle at all, yet the list already recorded the entire distribution as complete.

No photographs were taken that day. First the file was reopened. The red 'RECEIVED' mark was struck out, and beside it was written: 'ACTUAL DISTRIBUTION PENDING.' The pink slips were checked again. The available rice was counted. As many families as could be given the full ten kilos that day received it; the rest were given the date of the next consignment in writing.

Malti's turn came towards evening. This time the sack was placed directly on the scales. The needle settled at ten. The employee wrote the weight on the slip. The sack was not placed in Malti's hands; it was lifted straight onto her head.

Chhotu walked behind her. As soon as they passed through the school gate, Malti stopped. 'It feels heavy.' Chhotu did not laugh. He took the five grains from the previous day out of his pocket and placed them on top of the sack. 'Let these five go home too.'

Malti looked at him. 'What will five grains do?' Chhotu thought for a moment. 'Yesterday they came back alone.' Malti began walking again. On the road, the sack really was heavy.

STORY 153

Expensive Shoes

At dawn, before putting on his shoes, Ram Babu Mandal set them on a newspaper and looked at them for a long time. The black leather shone so brightly that even the bamboo post of the veranda was reflected upside down on it. There was nothing else in the house for which a rule had been made that it must be wiped with a separate cloth before being worn.

The shoes had been bought only the day before. Two thousand eight hundred rupees. The shopkeeper had said, 'At an interview, the first glance falls on the feet.' Ram Babu did not know whether that sentence was true, but after fifteen years as a lower-level employee in an office, he certainly understood that the day of a promotion interview was not an ordinary day.

His old shoes were still usable. The soles had been stitched twice, and the leather at the front had turned white along the crease, but they never deserted him in rain or water. His wife Lalita had asked, 'Wouldn't those do?'

Ram Babu had replied, 'They would do. But what will people see?'

Lalita had said nothing more. She had taken three five-hundred-rupee notes from a tin in the grain bin and the remaining money from a small savings box. The money had been kept aside for cloth for a new mosquito net.

The interview was at ten that morning. Ram Babu was ready by seven. The collar of his white shirt was stiff, his trousers grey, and a blue file was in his hand. In the file were a copy of his service book, his appointment letter, training certificate, caste certificate, educational certificates and three small photographs, each in a separate transparent sleeve.

Looking at the file, Lalita asked, 'Is everything there?'

Ram Babu counted each paper and said, 'Yes.'

'And your feet?'

Ram Babu smiled. 'They are the newest of all.'

The road to the bus stand was unpaved. The light rain in the night had left mud along both sides. Ram Babu walked protecting his shoes as though he were placing not his feet but two glass bowls on the road. Twice cyclists passed close to him. Once a calf tugged at its rope and came out onto the road. Ram Babu moved towards the ridge of a field, but not a drop of mud fell on the shoes.

The bus was crowded. He found no place to sit. Holding the file tight against his chest and keeping his feet tucked between two seats, he remained standing. When the edge of a boy's slipper was about to touch the front of the

new shoe, Ram Babu pulled his foot back. The boy looked at him, then at his own slipper.

It was nine twenty when he reached the district office. Twelve employees were sitting in the veranda for the promotion interview. Some wore new shirts, some old clothes. Ram Babu's eyes went involuntarily to everyone's footwear. Two men wore slippers. An elderly employee's shoes were torn at the front.

All at once, Ram Babu could see his two thousand eight hundred rupees very clearly.

His colleague Suresh Jha saw him and said, 'Why, Ram Babu! Today you look like an officer.'

Ram Babu laughed lightly. 'Let me become an officer first; then I can look like one.'

Suresh looked at his shoes. 'This is what you need. They look at appearance too in an interview.'

Hearing that, the tiredness in Ram Babu's feet lessened.

At ten fifteen his name was called: 'Ram Babu Mandal.'

He went inside. There was a three-member committee. The Joint Director sat in the middle, the Accounts Officer on the left, and the senior assistant of the Establishment Branch on the right. His application was already open on the table.

'Sit down,' the Joint Director said.

Ram Babu sat on the chair. His feet rested naturally in one place. The shoes were under the table; the committee was looking at the papers above it.

The first question was about his length of service. The second concerned the arrangement of office records. In the third, he was asked what procedure should be followed if the sequence of pages in an old register was found broken. Ram Babu answered. Fifteen years of work were on his tongue; it was not difficult to speak about what he did every day.

The Accounts Officer asked two or three more questions. Ram Babu answered them. Confidence slowly began to rise within him.

Then the senior assistant of the Establishment Branch said, 'Show us the original certificates.'

Ram Babu opened the blue file. One by one he took out the papers and placed them in front of them. Appointment letter. Educational certificate. Departmental accounts-training certificate.

The senior assistant took the training certificate in his hand. The paper was old at the right-hand corner. A small tear beside the circular edge of the seal had, over the years, grown larger. The transparent sleeve had held it together. The letters were clear. The name was clear. The date was clear. The signature of the training centre was clear. But almost a quarter of the seal had come away with the tear.

'This is torn,' the senior assistant said.

Ram Babu said at once, 'It is an old document, sir. The training was twelve years ago. All the lettering is visible.'

The senior assistant held the certificate up towards the light. 'The seal is not complete.'

'A copy is in the service book.'

'Verification of the original is required.'

Ram Babu took out the certified page of his service book. It recorded that he had passed the training.

The Joint Director looked at the page. 'The training is recorded in the official record. But under the promotion rules, verification of the training certificate is compulsory. If the original is damaged, you need a verified copy from the issuing institution.'

Ram Babu asked, 'Can I submit it today?'

'Where will you get a verified copy today?' the senior assistant asked in an even voice.

The training centre was in Madhubani, about seventy kilometres from the office. Ram Babu fell silent.

The Joint Director wrote something in pencil on the application. 'Your interview will be treated as complete. Document verification will remain pending. Submit a verified copy within seven working days.'

Ram Babu stood up. All three members bent again over the papers for the next name. As he walked out, it struck him that no one had looked at his shoes.

In the veranda, Suresh Jha asked, 'How did it go?'

Ram Babu opened the file and showed him the torn certificate.

Suresh did not look at the shoes. He kept looking at the tear in the paper. 'Because of this?'

'Because of this.'

At noon Ram Babu went straight to the bus stand. The bus to Madhubani was due in half an hour. The sun had grown fierce. The hard back edge of the new shoes began cutting into his heel. He found a seat on the bus, but his feet kept hurting.

It was four when he reached the training centre. A new three-storey building stood where the old building had been. Asking his way, he reached the Records Branch. The employee checked the register. The register for the batch from twelve years earlier was in the storeroom. The person who had taken the storeroom key was on leave that day.

'Come tomorrow,' the employee said.

Ram Babu told him about the seven working days.

The employee shrugged. 'Without the register, I cannot issue a verification.'

Ram Babu returned. As he got off the bus in the evening, it began to rain. The mud he had avoided in the morning had now spread across the road. He no

longer had the strength to walk while protecting his shoes. At the first puddle his foot entered, mud coated the black leather. Ram Babu did not stop.

When he reached home, Lalita first looked at his feet. 'Are the shoes ruined?'

Ram Babu opened the file. 'The shoes are all right. The paper is torn.'

The next day he went to Madhubani again. The storeroom was open. After three hours the register was found, but the training centre's old seal had since been changed. For a verified copy he needed an application, two photographs, service identification and a fee. Ram Babu submitted the application.

'How many days?'

'Normally ten days.'

'I have seven working days.'

The employee looked at him and opened the register again. 'Then get permission from the branch head.'

The branch head was in a meeting. Ram Babu waited for two hours. The wound on his heel had grown worse. Sitting in the veranda, he took off his shoes and placed a handkerchief behind his heel. In front of him, a sweeper in old rubber slippers was sweeping the floor.

By evening, permission was granted. He was assured that the verified copy would be ready within the next three days. Ram Babu returned to the office. The date for preparing the promotion list was close.

On the third day, he received the verified copy. Thick white paper, a new seal, a new signature. Ram Babu placed it in the blue file and handled it as though it were a newborn child. This time, on the journey back from Madhubani, he kept the shoes in a bag and wore his old slippers.

When he submitted the copy at the Establishment Branch, the employee gave him a receipt. Ram Babu asked, 'Is everything all right now?'

Looking at the pile of papers, the employee said, 'As far as I am concerned, the documents are complete. The committee will see the list.'

Two weeks later, the promotion list came out. Ram Babu's name was not on it. Against his application was written: 'Document verification incomplete by the date of the scheduled meeting; to be considered in the next vacancy cycle.'

Ram Babu stood looking at the list for a long time. The interview had not gone badly. The training was not incomplete. His service was not too short. It was only that when the committee met, the new paper had already reached the file, but the entry for the verification letter was made in the main list one day later.

Suresh Jha was promoted. He came to Ram Babu and said quietly, 'Appeal.' Ram Babu wrote an appeal. The reply came: under the rules, the matter would automatically be considered in the next vacancy cycle.

Months passed. The expensive shoes lay wrapped in cloth inside the trunk. Ram Babu again began wearing his old stitched shoes to the office; they did not

hurt his feet. One evening water began dripping from the roof. Lalita ran to move the trunk. Ram Babu got up too. Opening the trunk, he first took out the blue file. The paper of the verified certificate was dry. Then he took out the expensive shoes wrapped in cloth. The leather was still shining.

Lalita asked, 'Shall I keep the shoes above?' Placing the blue file on the topmost shelf of the cupboard, Ram Babu said, 'Let the shoes stay below.'

Before closing the file, his hand touched the old training certificate. The torn corner was still caught inside the transparent sleeve. He placed it beside the new verified copy. Both papers spoke of the same training—one carried the marks of time, the other a new seal. Lalita asked, 'Why keep the old one?' Ram Babu ran a finger over the lettering on the paper. 'I did the training on this one. The new one certifies that I did.' Lalita did not answer. She merely moved a lota under the drops falling from the roof.

Ram Babu kept both papers in the same file. The torn original at the back, the new verified copy in front. When the application for the next vacancy cycle came, it was now clear to him which paper had to be placed foremost. He made no separate decision about the shoes either. He dried the leather and wrapped them in cloth again; there was no reason to throw them away, nor any hurry to wear them.

That night the rain went on for a long time. The shoes were safe inside the trunk. On the top shelf of the cupboard lay a perfectly flat, untorn paper with a complete seal—waiting for the next vacancy cycle.

STORY 154

The Empty Envelope

On the second morning after the wedding, two or four flower petals still lay wet with dew on the veranda of Harinath Jha's house. The bamboo wedding pavilion had already been half dismantled, but the envelopes in the red cloth bag kept in a corner were safe. People had been coming and going until three in the morning, so no one in the house had had the patience to open the bag.

When Harinath returned after bathing, the first thing he did was place the bag in front of himself. His son Anup brought the red ledger. Five years earlier he himself had written on its cover: 'Give-and-take—weddings, sacred-thread ceremonies, housewarmings.' Inside were three columns against each name: amount, date and occasion.

Sumitra, putting tea on the stove, said, 'Eat something first. You have been awake all night.'

Harinath replied, 'The accounts first. If this is put off, who will later remember whose envelope contained how much?'

The newly married Gauri sat with her back against the veranda wall on her last morning at her parental home before the farewell. Her departure was to be at noon. Looking at her father's ledger, she smiled. 'Babu, the wedding is not even over and the accounts have begun.'

Harinath said, 'If we do not keep accounts, relations get out of balance. If someone gives us five hundred and we give five thousand at his house, people will say we have no sense.'

Anup opened the first envelope. 'Jagmohan Mama—two thousand and one.'

Harinath turned the pages of the ledger. 'At his daughter's wedding I gave one thousand and one. All right. Write it down.'

The second one: 'Kaushalya Phua—five hundred and one.'

From beside the stove, Sumitra said, 'When we went to her house, we gave one thousand and one.'

Harinath's brows drew together. 'Write it down. We will remember next time.'

In this way the envelopes kept opening. With each name an amount came out, and with each amount an old incident. Who had given less one year, who had given more, who had arrived on time, who had merely eaten and left—everything began to take its own shape in the columns of the red ledger.

Gauri listened silently. The people who had embraced her and wept the night before were now becoming two thousand and one, five hundred and one, eleven hundred and one.

Anup picked up a white envelope. Written on it in blue ink was: 'Ramvilas Jha, Sonbarsa.'

Harinath said at once, 'Barka Kaka. Let us see what he has done this time.'

Ramvilas was his elder cousin. They lived in different villages, but their childhood had been spent in the same courtyard. Meetings had grown fewer over the past few years. The previous day he had arrived early in the morning. He had tightened the ropes of the pavilion, had water pots filled, and had stood at the gate from the moment the first vehicle of the wedding party arrived. During the evening meal he had left early because his wife fell ill.

Anup tore open the envelope. There was nothing inside. He shook it again, turned it over, ran a finger inside, and said softly, 'It is empty.'

Harinath wondered whether a piece of paper might be stuck somewhere. He took the envelope in his hand and pressed both corners. Nothing.

'An empty envelope with the name written on it?' His voice hardened.

Sumitra lowered the flame under the stove. 'It may have been a mistake.'

'A mistake?' Harinath pulled the red ledger towards himself. 'At his son Neeraj's wedding I gave five thousand and one. It is written here.'

Anup found the entry. There it was, eight years old: Ramvilas Jha, son's wedding, 5,001.

Harinath placed the empty envelope on top of the ledger. 'People themselves tell you the value they place on a relationship.'

Gauri looked directly at him for the first time. 'Babu, Kaka was the first to arrive yesterday.'

'Coming is one thing, the customary gift is another.'

'When the labourer for the pavilion did not come, he tightened the ropes.'

Harinath's voice grew drier. 'One does not give five thousand for that.'

For a few moments, the only sound on the veranda was the tea boiling.

Anup placed his pen beside Ramvilas's name in the ledger. 'What shall I write? Zero?'

Harinath said, 'Write it.'

Just as the pen touched the paper, Gauri said, 'Wait a moment.'

She got up and went inside. Her small bag lay in the room where she had changed out of her wedding clothes the night before. From it she brought a folded receipt.

'This fell from near Babu's kurta last night. I thought it was some bill for the feast.'

The receipt was from Ramautar, the generator man. The time written on it was 9:40 p.m. The amount—three thousand. Harinath's signature was below.

The moment Harinath saw the receipt, he turned his face away.

Anup asked, 'This is from the time the generator stopped last night. But where did the money come from? At that time Raghunandan had the key to the cash box.'

Sumitra looked at Harinath. 'Did you pay it?'

Harinath did not answer.

Gauri said quietly, 'At that time I saw Babu opening an envelope behind the storeroom. I thought it contained some bill.'

Ramvilas's empty envelope was still in Anup's hand.

After a long while Harinath said, 'That envelope contained three thousand and one.'

Sumitra's hand stopped over the glass of tea. 'Then why is it empty?'

'Ramautar said the generator would not run for more than half an hour without fuel. He needed three thousand immediately. Raghunandan had the key to the cash box, and he had gone to the main road with the wedding party. The varmala ceremony was about to begin. If it had gone dark...'

He did not finish the sentence.

Anup looked at the ledger, then at the envelope. 'Then out of three thousand and one, the one rupee?'

Harinath felt in the small pocket of his kurta. He took out a coin and placed it on the table. 'This.'

Gauri's eyes remained fixed on the empty envelope.

Harinath said slowly, 'I thought I would write it down later. Then there was so much to do in one night... I forgot.'

Sumitra asked, 'Was this the only envelope you opened?'

Harinath remained silent.

The silence lengthened.

Anup did not close the ledger. 'More?'

Harinath's eyes went to the red bag. 'The band men demanded the five thousand still due. The sweet-maker's two thousand. The car owner's remaining three thousand five hundred after the advance. I opened three more envelopes.'

Sumitra slowly sat down. 'Whose?'

Harinath separated three envelopes from the bag. 'The names were written on them. I remember the amounts. I had written them on a piece of paper.'

'Where is the paper?'

Harinath searched the other pocket of his kurta. Nothing. 'It got wet during the night; perhaps it tore.'

The red ledger lay open in front of Anup, but its columns now seemed empty. Some of the money they had been treating as a measure of family relationships had already been spent in the middle of the wedding itself—on the night's lighting, the band, sweets and the balance due on the car.

Gauri asked, 'Did Ramvilas Kaka know that you opened his envelope?'

'No. He knew nothing about it.'

'He had given three thousand and one?'

'Yes, three thousand and one.'

'Then why write zero?'

Harinath took Anup's pen. Against Ramvilas's name he wrote 3,001. A few moments later, beside it in small letters, he wrote: 'Generator.'

Anup did not smile. 'This word has never appeared anywhere in the ledger before.'

Harinath turned through the old pages. It was true: there were only amounts there. That someone had stayed all night at the hospital during another's illness, that someone had saved another's paddy in a flood, that someone had kept another's child in his own home for a month so the child could study—there was no column for things like these.

Sumitra said quietly, 'Ramvilas Bhaiya had been carrying water since yesterday afternoon. His wife was ill, yet he still came.'

Harinath tried to close the ledger, then stopped.

Anup picked up another opened envelope. 'How much was in this one?'

'Two thousand and one.'

'Whose?'

'Kaushal Mama's.'

'And in the ledger?'

Anup looked at the 2,001 already written there. By chance, the amount had been remembered.

Harinath said, 'For every envelope I opened, we will check the amount again and write it down. If I do not remember one, we will not guess.'

'Then the accounts will remain incomplete.'

For the first time, Harinath's eyes met his son's. 'Let them.'

After that sentence, no one said anything at once.

Gauri's farewell took place at noon. Ramvilas did not come; he had taken his wife to the hospital. At the time of the farewell, Harinath put the red ledger inside the cupboard. He did not throw away the empty envelope. He placed it on the page of the ledger where Ramvilas's name was written.

Three days later Ramvilas came himself. Harinath seated him on the veranda. They talked for a long time about ordinary things—whether Gauri had reached her in-laws' home safely, how much rain had fallen, what the hospital tests had shown. Harinath did not bring up the envelope.

As he was leaving, Ramvilas said, 'The wedding went well. The electricity went off once at night, but came back almost immediately. I had thought the wedding party would be left in darkness.'

Harinath kept looking at him. 'Because of you, the lights came back at once.'

Ramvilas did not understand what he meant. 'Because of me?'

Harinath did not smile. 'Nothing.'

Ramvilas left.

Harinath went inside and opened the red ledger. Against Ramvilas's name, the amount 3,001 was written. Beside it was also the word 'Generator.'

He did not draw a line through the word 'Generator.'

He placed his pen on the next empty line below, but wrote nothing. After a long while, he closed the ledger.

The empty envelope remained pressed between the pages at that same place.

STORY 155

Invitation

When the afternoon postman entered the lane, Malti Devi rose from the bench on the veranda.

That week, red-and-gold envelopes had been reaching almost every house in the lane. Raised letters in the middle of each envelope read, 'Saumya's Wedding.' On the first day, the child from the house opposite Malti's ran off carrying a card. On the second day, an envelope of the same colour reached Mishraji's door two houses away. On the third day, the postman slowed his bicycle in front of Shashibhushan Jha's gate, rummaged through his bag, then moved on to the next house.

Malti said nothing. She went inside and filled a brass tumbler with water. Shashibhushan sat by the window, looking through an old register.

'Did any post come?' he asked.

'For two houses.'

'Our envelope?'

'Not ours.'

Shashibhushan turned a page of the register. The matter stopped there.

Saumya was Madanmohan's daughter. Madanmohan's father and Shashibhushan had taught at the same school. In the year of the flood, the two families had spent three nights on the same veranda. At Madanmohan's wedding, Malti had stayed at their house for five days, working from the kitchen through to the farewell. When Saumya was born, it was Malti whom Madanmohan's mother had called to give the baby her first oil massage.

Shashibhushan had never entered the account of such an old relationship in any register. But once the red envelopes began moving through the lane, the figures of that account began appearing by themselves in his mind.

Once, when Madanmohan's father had fallen ill, Shashibhushan had spent three nights with him on the hospital veranda. When Usha's mother died, Malti had taken charge of the stove and fed everyone in the house. On none of those occasions had there been an invitation card; word had travelled by mouth, and people had arrived. That was why their waiting for the red card was not merely a desire for the feast. To them, the card was a small assurance that the old line of the relationship had not yet been struck out.

Shashibhushan took out his old diary. Beside Madanmohan's name were two telephone numbers - one very old, one new. Beside his own name there was only the home address. He wondered whether relationships at today's weddings too

were managed through numbers and lists. Then he closed the diary. To voice the question seemed to him a lowering of his dignity.

'Perhaps they mean to give it by hand,' Shashibhushan said that evening.

Malti nodded in agreement. 'The house is so close. Why would they send it by post?'

Two days passed in that waiting.

A bamboo arch went up in front of Madanmohan's house. At the corner of the road a direction board appeared: 'Rajlakshmi Wedding Hall.' Flowers, lights, vehicles and cloth decorations began arriving. The lane filled with talk of the cards too. Who would sit where, what would be served at the feast, how large the wedding procession would be - amid all those questions, Malti remained silent.

On the third evening, their neighbour Kaushalya came over. She had a red card in her hand.

'Which way are you all going?' she asked casually. 'My card says seven o'clock.'

Watching the milk on the stove, Malti said, 'We'll see.'

Kaushalya placed the card on the table and went to look at what was being cooked. Saumya's name shone among the gold lettering. Below it were the names of Madanmohan and his wife Usha. At the very bottom was a small line: 'Arrangements and Guest Management: Rajlakshmi Wedding Hall Service Team.'

Malti read that line twice. Then she put the card back into Kaushalya's hand.

After Kaushalya left, Shashibhushan asked, 'What did it say?'

'Nothing special.'

'The card?'

'Yes, the card.'

'I think they have forgotten.'

This time, after 'Perhaps', both of them fell silent.

A day before the wedding, a teenage boy came from Madanmohan's house.

'Kaki, could we have twelve brass tumblers? The old tumblers at home are falling short.'

Malti went inside. She took tumblers out from beneath the cupboard. She gave him sixteen, not twelve.

The boy was counting them. Shashibhushan sat on the veranda. He felt like asking, 'What time tomorrow?' But the question rose to his lips and stopped there.

The boy went away with the tumblers.

Malti said, 'They remembered the tumblers, not us.'

Shashibhushan replied quietly, 'The number of tumblers is definite. Relationships have no number.'

On the wedding day, they decided to spend the evening like any ordinary day. At seven, decorated vehicles began leaving the lane. The sound of the band floated from afar. Malti prepared dinner early. Shashibhushan switched on the radio, but turned it off five minutes later.

At about eight there was a knock at the gate.

An unfamiliar young man stood outside. An identity badge hung from a blue ribbon around his neck. He carried two cloth bags and a paper list.

'Is the rear entrance to Madanmohan Babu's old house through here?'

Shashibhushan said, 'No. His house is two houses farther on.'

The young man looked at the list. 'I'm with the management team. Some of the family's things arrived in the wrong vehicle. They have to be taken over again.'

Hearing this from inside, Malti came out. 'Did you people distribute the cards too?'

The young man was startled by the question. 'Cards? They were sent from the office, according to the list.'

'The family didn't distribute them?'

'No, Maai. The family were not even given cards for themselves. They are the organiser's side. The guest register contains the names of the guests.'

Shashibhushan's hand went still on the gate. 'Madanmohan himself has no card?'

The young man laughed. 'Why would he need a card? It is his daughter's wedding. He has an organiser's badge.'

He pointed to his own blue identity badge and then went farther down the lane.

Malti and Shashibhushan stood by the gate for a few moments. Lights were circling in the sky in the direction of the wedding hall.

'An organiser's badge,' Malti said softly.

Shashibhushan did not answer at once.

The next afternoon Madanmohan himself came to return the sixteen tumblers. His eyes were red, and his face carried the weariness of a wedding finally completed.

'Kaki, you people were nowhere to be seen yesterday,' he said. 'I looked for you twice.'

Malti went on counting the tumblers. 'We were not invited.'

Madanmohan looked as though he was about to laugh, then his expression changed. 'What?'

Shashibhushan said directly, 'No card came.'

Madanmohan set the sixteenth tumbler on the table and remained silent for a long time. 'Kaka, do you think I made the card list myself?'

He took a folded paper from his pocket. It was a printed extract from the wedding hall's guest register. There were three columns - name, telephone

number, mode of delivery. Beside some names was written 'post', beside some 'by hand', beside some only a number. Shashibhushan's name was not there. Pointing with his finger to the corner of the page, Madanmohan said, 'For names in the old diary that had no number beside them, a separate list was supposed to be made. It seems that list was never completed.'

Shashibhushan looked at the page. For the first time, he felt the shape of his hurt changing. Until then he had believed the family had deliberately left him out. Now it seemed that some unfamiliar hand had seen an empty field and finished the job without carrying his name to the next page. He could not decide whether the insult had become smaller; but its owner had changed.

'Then who?'

'The wedding hall team. There was so much work at home that Usha said, "Just give them the names; they'll handle the rest." I gave them the old diary. They asked for telephone numbers with the names. Where there was no number, they asked for an address. Then the cards were printed, some went by post, some were delivered by hand. I myself saw the printed cards for the first time only on the table beside the stage on the wedding night.'

Malti was wiping the rims of the tumblers with a cloth. 'Was my name not in the diary?'

Madanmohan lowered his head. 'Your name was on an old page. There was no number beside it, so that must be why. Someone left it out while making the list.'

'And you?' Shashibhushan asked. 'Was your name there?'

This time Madanmohan really laughed, though the laughter was tired. 'My name isn't in the guest register. Nor Usha's. Nor Saumya's. Nor the groom's parents'. We all had a separate badge - "Family".'

'Meaning you people were not invited either?'

Madanmohan looked into Shashibhushan's eyes. 'It seems that way.'

Malti's hand stopped.

Madanmohan went on, 'Yesterday my mausi was stopped at the entrance. Her name wasn't on the list either. The guard asked for a card. Mausi telephoned me: "Son, has your daughter invited me or not?" I came down from the stage and went all the way to the gate. That was when I realised that half the family was in the arrangements, half was on the list, and some people were in neither.'

Shashibhushan asked quietly, 'Then who organised the wedding?'

Madanmohan looked towards the car standing outside the veranda, with the wedding hall's name written on it. 'I had the same question last night.'

He took a red-and-gold card from his pocket. One corner was slightly bent.

'This was left on the table beside the stage. I've brought it for you.'

Malti looked at the card but did not put out her hand.

Shashibhushan took it. Saumya's name was at the top. Below were the names of Madanmohan and Usha. At the very bottom was the same small line - the wedding hall's management team.

'What use is it now?' Shashibhushan asked.

Madanmohan's face fell. 'Perhaps it can be of some use for asking forgiveness.'

Shashibhushan did not fold the card. 'Forgiveness does not come through a card.'

Madanmohan remained silent.

Putting the sixteen tumblers beside the cupboard, Malti said, 'May Saumya be happy. The next time there is some occasion at home, tell us by word of mouth first.'

Madanmohan nodded.

After he left, Shashibhushan placed the card on the table. It remained there until evening.

Kaushalya came again that evening. Talking about the wedding, she said her card had been checked three times at the entrance, but once she was inside no one had asked how she was related to the bride or groom. Malti merely listened. Until yesterday, not receiving the card had felt to her like the absence of the relationship itself; today, even after receiving it, she understood that a printed paper had never been complete proof of a relationship. Yet the hurt caused by that paper was real, because people sometimes measure an old closeness by such small signs.

That night Malti opened an old iron trunk. Inside were cards collected over many years - weddings, sacred-thread ceremonies, housewarmings, funerary rites. The lettering on some had faded; some bore oil stains.

She picked up the new red card. Before putting it into the trunk, she paused for a moment.

'Shall I keep it?'

Shashibhushan said, 'Keep it.'

'For remembrance?'

'No. For forgetting.'

Malti did not smile. She placed the card among the old cards.

The trunk was closed.

That night, the remaining wedding lights in the lane went out one by one.

STORY 156

The Umbrella Man

By afternoon the sky had grown so dark that the bulb had to be switched on in Ramanarayan Chaudhary's newly painted sitting room even in broad daylight.

Two cars stood in front of the house. Guests were seated inside. Ramanarayan's younger son had found a job, and a small gathering for tea and snacks had been arranged to celebrate. The sitting room had new cushions, white curtains and a glass table. The family did not want even a single mark of mud or a wet footprint on the floor.

Just then a bicycle bell rang at the gate.

It was Raghunath.

He was the family's long-time servant - the kind who worked for wages, yet knew by heart the habits of three generations of the household. The morning market, the bank, medicines, rations, submitting some paper or other - wherever the family had no time to go, Raghunath's feet reached.

That day he had been asked to bring tea leaves, sugar and two kilos of savoury snacks from the market. On his way back, the rain caught him.

Raghunath carried an old black umbrella. Its cloth had patches of three different colours in three places - blue in one, green in another, brown in the third. The polish on the handle had worn away long ago.

The first heavy drop fell just as he entered through the gate.

On the veranda, Ramanarayan's daughter-in-law, Anjali, immediately said

-

'Raghu Kaka, wait there. There is a carpet inside. You are completely soaked.'

Raghunath held out the bag of savoury snacks. 'Take this inside. The rain is going to get heavier.'

Anjali took the bag.

'Leave the umbrella outside too. It will drip water.'

Raghunath closed the umbrella in a corner of the veranda and leaned it against the wall. He himself remained standing beneath the tin awning.

The rain suddenly came down hard.

Laughter continued inside the sitting room. Cups of tea went round. Ramanarayan talked about his son's appointment letter. Someone asked about the salary, someone about the town, someone about the size of the government quarters.

The first drop fell in the middle of the ceiling.

No one noticed.

The second drop fell on a corner of the glass table. The third landed directly near a guest's shoulder.

Anjali looked up.

A small dark patch was forming on the ceiling.

'Where is that coming from?'

Ramanarayan raised his head. The sitting-room roof had been redone three months earlier. The foreman who had built it had said there would be no need to worry about water for ten years now.

Within a minute the patch became round, then a line of water formed through its centre.

'Bring a bucket!'

A bucket was placed beneath it. But by then water had begun dripping at a second spot.

Then at a third.

The sheen of the sitting room suddenly gave way to the clatter of utensils. Bowls, buckets, an old cooking pot - whatever could be found was placed under the leaks. The guests began moving their chairs.

Raghunath watched everything from outside. The tin awning could no longer hold back the rain driven by the wind. His dhoti was wet up to his knees.

Just then Anjali's voice came from inside -

'Move Mother's medicine box!'

An old wooden chest stood in one corner of the sitting room. Ramanarayan's mother's medicines and some papers lay on top of it. A new stream of water was coming down directly over them.

The papers were removed. The chest was heavy; four people together shifted it.

At that moment lightning flashed. The bulb dimmed once.

From the veranda Raghunath looked towards the inner wall. A line of water was reaching the frame of the electrical switch.

He called out loudly -

'First switch off the mains!'

In the commotion inside, no one heard him clearly.

This time Raghunath came as far as the doorway. Stopping his wet feet outside the threshold, he said again -

'Switch off the mains. The water is reaching the wires.'

Ramanarayan's son ran. The main switch of the house was turned off. The sitting room went dark. There was only the grey light from the windows and the distant flashes of lightning.

The guests' conversation stopped.

Water was now falling in more places than there were buckets. There were no longer enough vessels in the house.

Ramanarayan said irritably, 'What sort of people built this roof!'

Raghunath said quietly, 'The drain above must be blocked. The wind fills it with leaves.'

'Who will go up there now?'

No one had an answer.

Raghunath went round towards the outer corner. A moment later he returned with his old umbrella.

Out of habit, Anjali said, 'Kaka, the umbrella inside -'

The sentence remained unfinished.

Raghunath opened the umbrella. Its three differently coloured patches stood out even in the darkness. Instead of holding it upright, he opened it upside down and placed it beneath the heaviest stream of water.

The cloth of the umbrella began collecting water like a bowl.

'Is there any rope?' he asked.

A thin coir rope was brought from the storeroom. Raghunath tied the ends of the four spread metal ribs like four corners and suspended them from an iron hook above. The umbrella hung upside down.

'Keep the handle pointing down,' he said.

A long strip of an old gamchha was tied near the handle. The water gathering in the umbrella began travelling slowly along the cloth into a bucket. The heavy stream no longer splashed over the floor of the sitting room.

For the first time the guests looked carefully at the old umbrella.

Ramanarayan's mother, who had been sitting in another room, came as far as the doorway with the help of her walking stick.

'Isn't that Raghu's old umbrella?'

'Yes,' Ramanarayan said.

The old woman looked at the blue patch on the umbrella. 'I put that patch on five years ago.'

Raghunath laughed. 'That is why it is still going.'

Ramanarayan's mother pointed towards the green patch. 'Who stitched this other one?'

'My daughter. She had her school examination that year. It rained heavily. Even though the umbrella was torn, I took her to the examination centre that day.'

The old woman was silent for a few moments. 'And the brown one?'

'I put that on myself. I found needle and thread in the market, but no cloth; I cut a piece from an old bag.'

The umbrella's three colours now stood out even more clearly against the sitting room's new curtains and white walls. None of the colours matched another, but all three patches were keeping out the water.

A few people smiled as well, but the sound of the rain was so loud that the smiles vanished at once.

For a second stream, Raghunath set two large brass platters at an angle against each other so that the water would run into a single bucket. At a third spot he found an old plastic sack and cut it into the shape of a gutter.

Fifteen minutes earlier the sitting room had been showing off its white carpet; now it held buckets, platters, a sack, an upside-down umbrella and guests sitting in the dark.

No one was asking about the salary or the government quarters any longer.

Ramanarayan's son kept looking upward in the light of his mobile phone. 'Kaka, how did you know the drain was blocked?'

'Yesterday two sacks of dry leaves were swept up in the back courtyard. The wind carried half the leaves up there. The roof is new; the drain is old.'

'Didn't the foreman see that?'

Raghunath shrugged. 'He looked at the roof. He did not know the habits of the house.'

The rain eased after half an hour.

By then the tea had gone cold. Anjali put water on the stove again, but none of the guests now insisted on tea. From the umbrella hanging in the middle of the sitting room, water travelled along the gamchha and fell drop by drop into the bucket. The sound was so regular that it seemed like a clock ticking in the middle of the conversation.

Ramanarayan looked once at his newly painted ceiling, then at Raghunath's patched umbrella. He opened his mouth to say something, but at that moment the bucket filled. Without saying a word, Raghunath lifted it, emptied it into the drain at the back, and put it back in place.

The guests began leaving one by one. Every person who went out glanced once at the upside-down umbrella.

Raghunath stood near the door. His clothes were still wet.

Ramanarayan suddenly said, 'Raghu, come inside and sit. Why are you standing outside?'

Raghunath looked at the floor of the sitting room. There was mud on his feet.

'The floor will get wet again.'

Ramanarayan tried to say something, then fell silent. Anjali brought not an old sack from the storeroom but a dry cloth and spread it beside the threshold.

Raghunath wiped his feet and came inside. But he did not sit on a chair. He kept watching the water in the bucket.

When the rain stopped at night, they climbed onto the roof. The drain really was blocked with leaves and broken bits of cement. Once the water was released, the streams inside the roof gradually stopped.

The upside-down umbrella remained hanging in the middle of the sitting room all night.

In the morning the mason came to inspect the roof. Ramanarayan went up with him. Anjali was having the sitting room cleaned. One corner of the carpet was wet, but most of it had been saved.

Raghunath was taking the umbrella outside to open it and dry it in the sun.

Anjali asked, 'Kaka, this umbrella has been stitched so many times. Why don't you buy a new one?'

Turning the handle in his hand, Raghunath said, 'I will buy a new one. But I won't throw this away. Its ribs are strong.'

He went outside.

By afternoon the sitting room was almost as it had been before. The buckets were gone, the platters had returned to the kitchen, and the gamchha was drying.

Only beside the door, where the umbrella had been propped outside the previous day, a new hook had been hammered into the wall.

Raghunath took out his bicycle to go to the market. The sky was grey again. He looked for his old umbrella.

The umbrella was not outside beside the wall.

It was hanging on the hook inside.

STORY 157

Number Plate

In the rear veranda of the District Transport Office, Ramakant Chaudhary had already changed queues for the third time. His new car gleamed outside in the sun, but his attention was not on the car. It was on the small box in the application form where the desired registration number was to be written.

An ordinary number would not do for him.

'I want 7777,' he said quietly to Bacchan, the broker.

Bacchan narrowed his eyes and looked at the list. 'There is a lot of demand. The government fee is separate; the arrangement is separate.'

'How much for the arrangement?'

Bacchan did not indicate the figure with his fingers. He wrote an amount with his pen in a corner of the paper and at once covered it with his palm. Ramakant looked at it for a moment, then opened his wallet. That amount did not appear on the official receipt. Behind the veranda, in the shade of an old file cupboard, Bacchan counted the notes and put them into his bag.

Ramakant felt lighter.

Two weeks later, the number-plate maker painted white letters on a black background. The last four digits—7777—were slightly larger than the other characters.

'Why are they so large?' his wife Nirmala asked.

Ramakant laughed. 'So that it can be recognised from a distance. Four sevens—no one will forget them.'

When the car stood in front of the house, the neighbours really did look first at the number and then at the car. The milkman read aloud, 'Seven-seven-seven-seven.' The children in the lane began repeating it in rhythm. Ramakant liked that.

He had a wholesale iron-and-cement business. From the village to the town, anyone who put up a building had, at some time or another, heard the name of his shop. Even so, Ramakant felt that the standing of his business ought to show on his car as well. In the market he parked where the number plate would be clearly visible. Weddings, meetings, business feasts—everywhere 7777 arrived before he did.

One day his daughter-in-law joked, 'Babuji, people may forget your name, but they won't forget the number of your car.'

Ramakant said proudly, 'An identity should be such that once seen, it stays in the mind.'

Three months later, on an evening in Bhadon, he was returning from the Madhubani side after checking the shop accounts. The day had been sultry; by evening a fine rain had begun. The earth along the roadside was slippery, and traffic on the road was sparse.

Ramakant was driving himself. With him was Kailash, the shop's accountant. On Kailash's lap lay the red-bound credit ledger whose accounts they had reconciled that day with three shopkeepers.

Half a kos before Pipar Chowk, the road narrowed. Ahead, a bullock cart was moving slowly. Behind it were two bicycles and a handcart. Ramakant sounded the horn twice. A bus was coming from the opposite direction.

Kailash said, 'Let the bus pass.'

Ramakant glanced at his watch. 'It's getting late. We have to reach home.'

The bus passed, but immediately behind it a motorcycle appeared. Ramakant edged the car a little to the right, then had to cut back to the left. At that moment, the bamboo basket of an elderly cyclist travelling along the edge of the road caught against the left side of the car.

There was a sharp scraping sound. The bicycle spun and fell. The old man too went down at the roadside. The small brass utensils in his basket scattered across the mud.

Ramakant stopped at once. The car came to a halt about forty cubits farther on.

Kailash began opening the door. 'Go back. Let's see.'

People were running up behind them. The bullock-cart driver had stopped. In the rain, a boy stood in the middle of the road waving his hand.

Ramakant looked in the mirror. He saw a pale scratch on the left rear side of his car. As the crowd grew, his hands tightened on the steering wheel.

'I didn't see that I hit him,' he said.

Kailash stared at him. 'The basket caught. The man fell.'

'If the crowd stops the car now, who knows what will happen? We'll inform the police station first.'

'Then call from here.'

Ramakant did not answer. He drove on.

The boy standing behind watched the car go. His name was Neeraj. He was in Class Eight at the nearby high school. On his way back from school he had stopped at his maternal uncle's tea stall. The car was not unfamiliar to him. Two days earlier, the same car had stood near the stall, and Neeraj had pointed out the four identical digits to his friend and said, 'Look, all four are sevens.'

This time, as the car receded behind the curtain of rain, the other letters grew blurred, but the four digits remained clear.

'7777,' Neeraj shouted.

Two men ran out from his uncle's stall. The old man's arm was bent at an awkward angle. There was no blood on his head, but he could not get up. His

name was Devkinandan Sah; in the nearby markets he repaired old brass and bell-metal utensils.

People took him to the health centre. Neeraj told the policeman who reached the station what he had seen.

'The complete number?'

Neeraj shook his head. 'I couldn't read the letters in front. The last four were 7777. The car was dark blue.'

The policeman repeated, 'All four sevens?'

'Yes. I'd seen it before too.'

At first, the clerk at the police station considered the information incomplete. The same last four digits could occur on vehicles in different classes. But Neeraj also described the car's colour, its shape, and the shiny silver strip on its left rear side. The police station requested the register from the Transport Office. In that area, three vehicles turned up with 7777 as the last four digits—an old motorcycle, a white goods carrier, and a dark-blue car registered three months earlier.

The clerk placed a finger on the line in the register.

'Whose is this new car?'

The name was read out—Ramakant Chaudhary.

The half-number Neeraj had seen had now become a road to the full address. He did not know the owner's name, his shop, or his house. He remembered only those four identical digits which the owner himself had chosen so that they would be remembered.

That night Ramakant reached home and wiped the scratch on the back of the car with a wet cloth. Nirmala stood in the veranda. 'How did this scratch get here?' Ramakant said, 'A bamboo basket brushed against it on the road.' Nirmala asked again, 'Whose basket?' 'I don't know.' Nirmala looked at his face for a few moments. Kailash put the credit ledger inside and quietly left.

As Ramakant drove the car in, he noticed splashes of mud on the number plate. He wiped those off as well. 7777 shone again.

Before the shop opened the next morning, two policemen arrived from the station. One asked, 'Is this your car?' The key was in Ramakant's hand. 'Yes.' Then came the question, 'Were you on the Pipar Chowk road yesterday evening?' 'Yes.' One policeman walked around to the back and examined the scratch; the other read the number plate aloud—'7777.' For the first time, Ramakant felt no pride on hearing those four digits.

Neeraj too had been called to the police station. He was not made to stand before Ramakant; the sub-inspector questioned him in a separate room about what he had seen. Neeraj described the colour of the car, the last four digits, the fallen bicycle, and the scattered brass utensils.

The sub-inspector checked the registration register. Among dark-blue new cars with 7777 as the last four digits, only one name appeared in that class in the district.

Ramakant said, 'I did stop. I got frightened when I saw the crowd. I thought the injury would be minor.' The sub-inspector asked directly, 'Did you see the injured man?' Ramakant did not answer. The sub-inspector asked again, 'If you didn't see him, how did you know it was minor?' Ramakant had no answer to that question.

Devkinandan's arm was broken, but his life was not in danger. Treatment expenses, statements, inspection of the car, insurance papers—the next few days passed between Ramakant's shop and the police station. The car was kept in the police-station compound for a day.

When Bacchan heard about it, he came quietly to the shop that evening. 'Things have gone wrong,' he said. Ramakant looked at him. Bacchan asked softly, 'Would you like to change the number?' Ramakant could not laugh. 'It's already registered. What can change now?' Bacchan fell silent too. Both remembered the day in the veranda when money outside the official receipt had been paid for four identical digits. Neither mentioned it.

After Devkinandan returned home, Ramakant went to see him. The old man's arm was bound in a white bandage. The bent bicycle from that day stood propped against the wall in the courtyard, and the basket had been set aside.

Ramakant said, 'Whatever the treatment costs—' Devkinandan did not interrupt. He heard him out. Then he said, 'The expenses can be settled. But if you had stopped, I would not have been left thinking that the man in the car had run away and abandoned me.' Ramakant's eyes rested on the bicycle's bent wheel. 'I was afraid.' Devkinandan said, 'So was I. The only difference was that I was lying on the road.' For a while after that, only the sound of birds was heard in the courtyard.

A week later the car returned home. The scratch had been painted over. The car looked new again. Only the number plate was exactly as before.

That evening Ramakant took the car out after closing the shop and set off for home. Two children playing in the lane read the number at the back —'Seven-seven-seven-seven.' Earlier, hearing that sound, he would see himself smiling in the mirror. This time he stopped the car and looked back for a moment. All four digits were clear—so clear that even on a rainy night a boy had not forgotten them. Ramakant slowly drove on.

STORY 158

The Village Stage

The Magh sun was still gentle, but the field of the village middle school had been warm with activity since morning. A red cloth had been stretched across the new bamboo stage, and above it a white banner bore large letters: 'One Village, One Dignity.' Green-leaf festoons hung on both sides of the stage.

Kedar had been there since six in the morning. He connected the wires of the loudspeaker system, ran cables up the bamboo poles, and repeatedly crawled beneath the stage to tighten loose joints. His father, Fekan, worked with bamboo; the four main corner posts of the stage had been cut to measurements taken by his own hand. Kedar had learnt electrical work in town, so the organising committee had called him to look after the sound system.

By ten o'clock the field was full. People had come from the north hamlet, the south hamlet, the settlement across the river and the market quarter. Mats were spread on the right for the women, and chairs were placed in front for the elderly. Behind the stage, near the school kitchen, three large pots were on the fire. Rice, dal, potato curry and tarua were being cooked.

The principal speaker at the event was Mahendra Babu. He spoke at many social gatherings in the district, and the villagers called him 'Netaji'. When he arrived and climbed onto the stage, Kedar lowered the loudspeaker volume slightly. Mahendra Babu placed a hand on Kedar's shoulder and said, 'Keep the sound clear. Today's message must travel far.'

Kedar smiled and nodded.

The meeting began. After two speakers, Mahendra Babu stood up. The people seated on the mats in front fell silent. He first spoke of the old fellowship of the village, then raised his voice and said—

'Where the rows for eating are separate, the rows in people's minds remain separate too. Equality is not merely a word on paper. Only when we sit and eat together and work together will the village change.'

There was applause. Sitting beside the loudspeaker, Kedar looked towards the back. His mother, Phoolo Devi, and his father, Fekan, were standing at the far end of the field. Neither had found a place to sit in front. Kedar raised a hand to signal that he would meet them near the kitchen after the meeting.

Mahendra Babu's speech lasted half an hour. At the end he said, 'In this field today there is no high or low. We are all people of the same village.'

There was applause again. Kedar too clapped twice.

After the meeting, a crowd gathered around Mahendra Babu in front of the stage. Someone handed him an application, someone bowed in greeting, someone raised the matter of a road to his hamlet. Before coiling the wires, Kedar went behind to look at the meal arrangements. He had eaten nothing since morning.

Near the kitchen, Devkant, the committee secretary, stood with a sheet of paper in his hand. Two boys were counting leaf plates. A long row had begun to form on one side. On the other, two thin bamboo stakes were being driven into the ground and a rope stretched between them.

Kedar asked, 'Why this second way?'

Devkant replied, 'There are too many people. With two rows, it will go faster.'

That sounded natural enough. Kedar moved on. Just then Mahendra Babu came round the back with three organisers. He looked towards the cooking pots, then at the place where the rows were forming.

'The north hamlet and the market quarter on this side,' Devkant said, looking at his paper. 'Everyone else on the other side.'

Mahendra Babu paused. 'The other side is too exposed. It can be seen from the stage.'

Devkant asked, 'Then?'

Mahendra Babu pointed towards the wall behind the school. 'Put them behind that wall. Old customs do not change in a day. Otherwise unnecessary talk will start in front of everyone.'

Kedar had a coil of wire in his hand. He went completely still. Devkant's eyes fell on him, but he said nothing. The two boys pulled out the bamboo stakes and carried the rope behind the wall.

There was no question of Kedar having misheard. The voice had been perfectly clear. It was the same Mahendra Babu who, only moments earlier on the stage, had said, 'Separate rows for eating mean separate rows in the mind.'

Mahendra Babu looked at him. 'Kedar, you are one of the stage people. Eat here with the organisers.'

Kedar asked quietly, 'My mother and father?'

Mahendra Babu looked at Devkant. Devkant said, 'They will eat in the row at the back. There will be less crowding there.'

'Why is my row separate?'

Devkant's expression hardened. 'You have worked for the event, so you are one of the organisers. What is there to question in that?'

Something tightened in Kedar's chest. He did not throw the coil of wire on the ground. He placed it slowly on the wooden table. 'Am I an organiser only as far as the stage?'

No one answered.

Behind the wall, the second row for the meal had already formed. Phoolo Devi had reached it. Fekan stood behind her. With them in the row were people from the settlement across the river and families of some labourers. Leaf plates were being laid out in the front row; in the row behind the wall, people stood holding their own leaf plates in their hands.

The moment Phoolo Devi saw Kedar, she said, 'You will get food at the stage, won't you? Go, eat there.'

Kedar's throat went dry. 'I will eat with all of you.'

Fekan looked at him but asked no question. He simply left a place at the back of his row.

Just then came the sound of plates from the front—the meal had begun. Mahendra Babu sat in the middle of the first row. Tarua, dal and rice were served on the leaf plate before him. The red cloth of the stage moved in the wind. Above it, 'One Village, One Dignity' could still be read clearly.

Kedar was about to sit in the back row when Devkant came running. 'Arre, your plate has been kept near the stage. Why are you here?'

Kedar replied, 'My mother and father are here.'

Devkant lowered his voice. 'Those who worked have been given special honour. You must understand.'

Kedar looked at him. 'If honour takes away the right to sit together, I do not want it.'

Devkant's lips trembled, but he did not argue. He turned away.

The two boys serving food came behind the wall. They carried small pots. In the first row, two pieces of tarua had been served to each person; here only one was being given. Phoolo Devi remained silent. An old man named Lakhan, seated beside Kedar, said, 'One is enough.'

Kedar kept looking at the mound of rice on his leaf plate. He was hungry, but he could not lift the first mouthful.

At that moment a sharp crackle came from the loudspeaker near the stage. Kedar raised his head. The system had not been switched off; its volume had only been lowered. A child had pulled a wire. Kedar began to rise, then stopped. Another young organiser ran over and disconnected the wire.

Fekan said softly, 'Go and see to the work. The equipment is your responsibility.'

Kedar replied, 'I will go after I finish eating.'

For the first time, Fekan smiled. 'All right.'

By the time the meal ended, the field had begun to empty. Mahendra Babu went towards his car. As he was leaving, Devkant said to him, 'The meeting went well.'

Mahendra Babu looked towards the stage. 'Send an extract of the speech to the district paper tomorrow. Keep the part about equality prominent.'

A short distance away, Kedar heard this while coiling the wires. He said nothing.

By evening everyone had left. Leaf plates, earthen cups and scraps of paper remained scattered across the field. The stage was being dismantled. Fekan was untying the bamboo joints. Kedar was taking down the loudspeaker equipment.

Near the wall behind the school, the marks of the two separate dining rows were still clear. Where people had sat, two long strips of earth had been pressed smooth. The rope between them had been removed, but the two small holes where the bamboo stakes had stood remained.

Kedar picked up the rope and came to the front of the stage. As the banner above was being taken down, Fekan said, 'Fold that cloth and keep it. It will be used again at the next meeting.'

Kedar climbed the bamboo frame and untied the banner that read, 'One Village, One Dignity.' When he brought it down, the cloth spread once in the wind. Devkant was still there. He said, 'Keep it carefully. Money was spent to have it made.'

Kedar began folding the cloth. In one corner lay the rope that had divided the dining rows. He picked up the rope, wound it around the folded banner and tied a knot.

Devkant watched him. 'Why the rope?'

Kedar said evenly, 'Both belong to the same event. They can stay together.'

Devkant said nothing.

Fekan lifted the bamboo onto his shoulder. Kedar took the folded banner in his hand. As he crossed the field, his eyes went to the two parallel smooth marks behind the wall. In front, where the stage had stood, the earth was even; behind it, the two rows could still be read separately.

Kedar walked towards home. In his hand was the cloth bearing the words 'One Village, One Dignity', and around it was tightly bound the same rope that had divided the dining rows that afternoon.

STORY 159

The Girl by the Window

The water from the last monsoon had made the wall beneath the window swell a little. A muddy streak marked the white coat of lime, exactly where Madhavi rested her elbow every day. The window opened to the west. From it, a small stretch of the village's main road was visible - the bend by the pipal tree, the roofs of two grocery shops, and, farther away, the bells of bicycles going towards the school.

Madhavi was fifteen. Her schooling had stopped after she completed Class Eight. The school with Class Nine was in the market, three kos from the village. Her father, Ramvilas, used to say, 'For a girl to go so far every day - from now on she can study from books at home.'

No one in the house had taken away her books. Only the road had been taken away.

In the mornings, when three girls of her age cycled towards the market, Madhavi watched them through the bars of the window. At first she used to wave. After a few months she stopped waving too. As soon as she heard the bells of the girls' bicycles, she would open a book, as though her eyes had never gone outside.

In the afternoons the postman, Raghunath, came along this road. An old leather bag was tied behind his bicycle. At the bend by the pipal tree he seldom rang the bell; a loose piece of tin at the back of the bicycle rattled by itself.

One day he stopped in front of Madhavi's window. He had a letter in his hand.

'Child, which way is Shivdulari Devi's house?'

Madhavi started. It had been a long time since anyone had asked her about a road.

'After the pipal tree, the earthen lane that turns left - the third house in that lane. There is a tulsi platform in front.'

Raghunath turned the letter over and looked at it. 'It only says "South Hamlet" here.'

Madhavi smiled. 'They call that the old South Hamlet. The new South Hamlet is across the pond.'

Raghunath laughed. 'You've saved me half my bag.'

He rode on. That was all. Yet that day, after Madhavi opened her book, she could not remain on the same page for long.

A few days later Raghunath stopped again. This time he was looking for an old man who had come to stay temporarily at his son's house. Madhavi gave him directions again. The third time, Raghunath merely asked, 'Has the school group gone by today?'

Madhavi's face tightened a little. 'I don't go to school.'

Raghunath did not press the question. 'All right. Then your window tells the time more accurately than my watch. When the sunlight reaches this far, I know it is nearly twelve.'

He pressed the bicycle pedal and moved on towards the next house.

Gradually their exchanges became a small acquaintance of two or four sentences. Sometimes Raghunath would ask, 'What's the name of the new tenant in this house?' Madhavi told him what she knew and plainly said when she did not know. Sometimes her eyes fell on the round stamp in the corner of an envelope and she would ask, 'Is that a Darbhanga postmark?'

Holding the envelope up from a distance, Raghunath said, 'Yes. The postmark tells where the letter set out from. The address tells where it has to reach.'

The sentence stayed in Madhavi's mind - where it had set out from, where it had to reach.

That evening, on the last page of an old exercise book, she wrote three lines - her name, the name of the village, and the name of the post office. Then she crossed them out. The second time she wrote them in clear letters. The third time she tried to write the full address of the school in the market, but she did not know the name of the road.

Two days later, when Raghunath came, Madhavi held the paper near the window and asked, 'If a letter has to be sent to the school, is this much address enough?'

Raghunath did not take the paper in his hand. He read it from outside the window.

'The school's name, the market, the block - all that is there. Add the PIN code.'

'PIN code?'

Raghunath took an old blank scrap of paper from his bag and wrote six digits on it. 'This is for this area. But are you going to write a letter?'

Madhavi took a moment before answering. 'I'll see.'

Raghunath only said, 'Keep the address clear. What goes inside the letter is yours.'

That night, for the first time, Madhavi wrote to the headmistress of her old school. She changed the opening three times. First she had written, 'I want to study.' The sentence seemed too small. Then she wrote, 'After I passed Class Eight, my studies stopped because of circumstances at home. If there is any way for me to enrol again in Class Nine, please tell me.'

She did not blame her father in the letter. Nor did she write a long account of her unhappiness. At the end she wrote her name and looked at it for a long time.

The next day the letter remained beneath her pillow. On the third day it lay inside a book. On the fourth, the moment she heard the rattle of Raghunath's bicycle, Madhavi's heart began to beat faster. She took the envelope in her hand, but after reaching the window she stepped back again.

Raghunath had reached the bend by the pipal tree.

Suddenly Madhavi crossed the veranda and came into the courtyard. She did not go as far as the gate. She only called from inside, 'Raghunath Kaka!'

The bicycle stopped.

Madhavi went to the gate. Perhaps for the first time since leaving Class Eight, she stood there alone for some purpose of her own. She stretched out her hand and gave him the envelope.

'Will you leave this at the post office?'

Raghunath read the address. 'There's no stamp.'

Madhavi's courage dropped at once. 'Then?'

Raghunath did not smile. In an ordinary voice he said, 'Buy a stamp from the shop, or go to the post office tomorrow and put it on yourself. The letter is yours. It would be good if, the first time, you completed the whole task yourself too.'

He handed the envelope back.

For a moment Madhavi felt that the work had stopped again. Then she took one step outside the gate. The grocery shop at the pipal bend was barely forty paces away. She called to her mother, 'I'm going to get a stamp.'

From the kitchen her mother only said, 'Come back quickly.'

Madhavi went. She bought the stamp. Raghunath was still at the bend, delivering a letter at another house. She returned and fixed the stamp to the envelope. Raghunath put it into his bag.

'Now it's on its way,' he said.

Madhavi looked towards the window. Her chair inside was empty.

Ten days passed. During that time Madhavi did not wait for the postman every day. She did the household work, solved old mathematics exercises, and dried pickles with her mother. But whenever she heard the bicycle rattling in the afternoon, her ears became alert of their own accord.

On the eleventh day Raghunath called at the gate, 'Madhavi Kumari!'

It was the first time her full name, spoken from his mouth, sounded like a name on a piece of mail.

Madhavi came outside. It was a white envelope. The sender was the Headmistress, Girls' High School.

She took the envelope inside, but did not open it in private. She opened it in front of her mother. The letter was short. The time for admission to Class Nine

had not yet ended. She was asked to come to the school with her Class Eight certificate and her guardian's consent. The interruption in her studies would not be an obstacle.

Her mother had the letter read out twice. 'We'll show it to your father when he comes.'

Ramvilas returned from the shop in the evening. He read the letter and remained silent for a long time. Then he said, 'It's three kos away. Who will go with you every day?'

Madhavi could have remained silent as before. At that moment she remembered her window, the forty paces to the stamp shop, and the six digits written on the envelope.

'Sarita, Neelam and Gudiya go every day. I'll go with them. They pass the pipal bend at seven ten in the morning. All three return together.'

Ramvilas looked at her. 'How do you know all these times?'

'From the window.'

At that answer her mother smiled faintly. Ramvilas did not smile. He folded the letter and placed it on the table.

'I'll go with you on the day you enrol,' he said at last. 'After that we'll see.'

Madhavi said, 'All right.' Her voice was not very loud, but it was clearer than before.

Early the following Monday she put her Class Eight certificate, the headmistress's letter and two photographs into a file. Her father was taking the bicycle out. Madhavi looked at her old chair by the window. Her exercise book lay open on it, and the address she had written was still there - name, village, post office, PIN code.

As they went out through the gate, Raghunath's bicycle appeared in the distance. Perhaps he had taken his route a little early that day. On seeing Madhavi, he rang the bell once.

'The window empty today?'

Madhavi pressed the file close to her chest.

'Today I'm on the road.'

Raghunath nodded and rode on.

Madhavi set off with her father towards the pipal bend. On reaching the bend she looked back once. From that distance the western window of her house seemed very small. The chair inside could not be seen. Only the morning light was coming out through the bars.

STORY 160

The Migrant's Daughter

The first bus coming from across the Jogbani border usually did not reach the bend in the village before nine. But by eight Kusum would sweep the veranda and sit beside her father's old iron trunk. Her father did not come on that bus. Sometimes a folded letter came in the driver's hand.

Her father, Harinarayan, worked at a grocery warehouse near Biratnagar, sorting goods, sewing sacks and loading them onto vehicles. It had been three years since he had left home. He returned twice a year - around Dashami and at the end of winter. The rest of the time, three signs of him remained in the house: a torn gamchha hanging on the wall, an old shirt inside the trunk, and a bundle of letters.

At first the letters were short.

'I am well. Keep studying. Listen to your mother. I will send money next month.'

Kusum would read those lines, fold the letter and put it away. To her, her father was a man earning far from home - money came from his hands, but no one at home knew how his days passed.

One day Ramsevak Kaka, the bus driver, handed her a letter and said with a laugh, 'This time your father has sent you a very fat letter.'

Kusum opened it. There were four pages inside. At the top of the first page was written: 'Story: The Knot in the Blue Rope.'

Kusum burst out laughing. The very idea that her father had written a story seemed strange to her.

The story was about a blue rope that spent the whole day tying different sacks. When a sack of rice was opened, it went to a crate of spices; when the crate was unloaded, it held together a bundle of soap. The rope kept thinking that it owned nothing of its own, yet wherever it went it kept something from coming apart. In the end a labourer cut away its frayed part and made several small knots from it; the rope grew shorter, but its work did not end.

Kusum read the story twice.

Her mother, Saraswati, was sorting lentils by the hearth. Kusum asked, 'Did Father use to write stories?'

Saraswati raised her head. 'Not that I knew.'

'This story about the blue rope.'

Her mother took the page, looked at the handwriting, and handed it back. 'It is his writing. But a story? Has going away to work turned him into a writer?'

Both of them laughed.

The next month another letter came. This time the title was 'The Broken Scale.'

In a warehouse, one pan of a balance always hung a little lower. People thought the scale was faulty, but an old labourer cleaned its pointer every day in his spare time. At the end of the story the scale was not repaired; the old man merely told everyone, 'A thing that weighs others ought to be right itself first.'

Kusum liked that line. She copied it into her exercise book.

After that, the letters regularly became stories: 'A Sack Soaked in the Rain', 'The Sack Sewn Three Times', 'The Bird Crossing the Border', 'The Empty Handcart', 'The Sleeping Dog'.

At first Kusum read only the stories. Slowly, she began to read her father through them.

'The Sack Sewn Three Times' said that an old sack had thread of three colours on it - red, black and white. Kusum thought: Father must really spend all day with torn sacks in his hands, choosing thread.

In 'A Sack Soaked in the Rain', a labourer stretched a sack over his own body to save the grain. The ink had spread at one corner of the page, as though water had fallen on it while her father was writing.

In the middle of one story, a line suddenly appeared: 'By afternoon the fine fibres of the thread work their way into the skin of the palm; in the evening, when water touches it, the sting is felt.'

Kusum stopped at that line. Her father never spoke at home about pain in his hands. When he came back on leave, she saw only the hardened skin of his palms. Away from home, he spent his days among thread, sacks and knots - this was a new father.

One day at school the teacher gave the class a topic: 'A Member of My Family.'

All the children chose their subjects. One chose a mother, another a grandmother, another a brother.

Kusum wrote: 'My father sorts goods in a warehouse.'

Her pen stopped after the first line. The sentence seemed incomplete.

She turned the page and wrote: 'My father spends all day looking at ropes, scales, sacks and handcarts.'

Her friend Reena peeped at the page and said, 'Does your father work in a warehouse or make up stories?'

Kusum covered the page at once. 'Both.'

The answer had come out of her mouth on its own.

Back home, she opened the letters again and counted the dates. The first story had begun in the month when her father had come home for Dashami and then gone back. That time Kusum had given him her old Class Five exercise book. 'There are blank pages in it. You can keep accounts in them.'

Now she remembered that as he took the book, her father had said, 'Why waste blank pages?'

Kusum searched inside the trunk. Among the old letters she found a short note from before the first story. It spoke only of sending money. The handwriting was stiff and uneven. In the story-letters, the letters of the alphabet had gradually grown rounder and clearer.

That night Kusum wrote to her father for the first time.

'Father, I liked the story about the blue rope. But if the rope had nothing of its own, did that make it sad?'

After writing it, she laughed at herself. Then she wrote below:

'What was the name of the old man with the scale? When you write the next story, bring that old man back.'

Her mother looked at the letter. 'Will you write this much?'

'Not just this much. I'll write more.'

'And the matter of money?'

'You write that.'

Saraswati looked at her for a while. Then she said, 'All right. I'll write my part on a separate page.'

The letter went with Ramsevak.

Three weeks passed without a reply.

Kusum grew restless. She was afraid her father might have laughed after reading her questions. Perhaps writing stories was only a pastime for him, and his daughter taking them seriously had made him uncomfortable.

In the fourth week, as soon as Ramsevak Kaka got down from the bus, he called from a distance, 'Kusum! This time your father has sent an argument along with his reply.'

The letter was thick.

The first line said:

'I had not written whether the rope felt sad or not. After your question I thought about it - perhaps it did.'

Kusum smiled.

On the second page, 'the old man with the scale' had returned. This time his name was Jagdish. In the story he learned to write the labourers' accounts himself, because earlier he had only put his thumbprint.

At the end of the story her father had written a separate line:

'Jagdish got his name because of your question.'

Kusum made her mother listen to that line three times.

After that, the letters were no longer one-sided. Kusum sent questions. In the next story her father sometimes answered them and sometimes avoided them. Kusum wrote, 'A bird crossing the border does not show papers to anyone. Why do people have to?' In his next letter, her father wrote a story

about two trees standing at the border - one on the India side and one on the Nepal side; beneath the soil, the roots of each reached the roots of the other.

Slowly Kusum understood that her father wrote little directly, but said a great deal inside the stories.

In one story, a labourer who sewed sacks did more than his own share of work for three days because another worker had cut his hand. The money sent with that letter was less than usual.

Kusum asked her mother, 'Was Father ill?'

'No. On the telephone he said he was well.'

'He must have been doing someone else's work too.'

Her mother looked startled. 'How do you know?'

Kusum opened the letter. 'It's in the story.'

Saraswati was silent for a long time. Then she said softly, 'I used to hear what he said only as accounts of expenses.'

That sentence stayed in Kusum's mind.

At the end of winter Harinarayan came home. When he got down from the bus, a blue bag hung from his shoulder and he carried a small box of sweets in his hand. Kusum ran to him, but this time her first question was not, 'What have you brought for me?'

She asked, 'What will Jagdish do now?'

Harinarayan stopped short.

'Who is Jagdish?'

Kusum frowned. 'Jagdish from the story about the scale.'

A smile slowly came to her father's face. 'Oh, him? His story isn't finished yet.'

After reaching home Harinarayan sat beside the trunk. Kusum took out the bundle of letters and placed it before him. Her father looked at the folds of the pages one by one.

'You've kept all these?'

'I didn't throw away a single one.'

'There must be many mistakes in the stories.'

'I've marked them.'

Harinarayan laughed. 'You've become an editor.'

Kusum brought out her exercise book. In it she had copied sentences from her father's stories, written her own questions, and noted a few new story-seeds.

On one page was written: 'Story: Two Shoes by the Border. Nepalese soil on one, Indian dust on the other.'

Harinarayan read it and looked at Kusum. 'You wrote this?'

'You write the rest.'

'The seed is yours.'

'Then half the story is mine.'

Her father said nothing. He rested the exercise book on his knee and looked at that one line for a long time.

After dinner that night, Harinarayan sat on the veranda beside the lantern. Kusum was studying inside. For some time the rustle of paper could be heard.

In the morning a new sheet lay on top of the trunk.

At the top was written:

'Story: Two Shoes by the Border.'

Below it, her father had written the first line:

'The two shoes belonged to the same pair, but all day they touched different earth.'

The second line after it was blank.

In the margin of the page, in small letters, was written:

'Kusum will write the rest.'

STORY 161

The Unfinished Song

The morning sun had reached only halfway across the veranda. Kaushalya Devi was picking pebbles out of an old winnowing tray of paddy. The grains clinked in the brass plate beside her, and from the room inside came the faint thud-thud of an unfamiliar rhythm.

At first she thought Mrinal was listening to some new music again. But three times, after that rhythm, a short melody rose—four notes climbed, one note paused, then an empty space. Kaushalya's fingers stopped among the grains.

The melody repeated.

This time she set the plate aside and rose.

The door to Mrinal's room was half open. Inside, she sat bent before the computer. Sheets of paper, two cables, a small speaker and an old red notebook lay spread across the table. From the speaker rose those same four notes once more.

Kaushalya stopped in the doorway.

'Where did you get that from?'

Mrinal turned. 'What?'

'What just played.'

'I made it.'

Kaushalya looked at her for a few moments. 'Play it again.'

Mrinal pressed a key. The rhythm began. First the clack-clack of a loom, then the thump of a bucket being filled with water, then the light ting of a bicycle bell. Above them all came Mrinal's humming—four notes, a pause, then an empty space.

Kaushalya said softly, 'You did not make that.'

Mrinal's eyebrows lifted slightly. 'I haven't heard it from anyone and written it down, Dadi.'

'Then you have heard it.'

'Where?'

Kaushalya did not answer. She sat on the cot. The fingers of her right hand began beating time on her knee—one, two, three, pause. Then a very thin note came from her throat.

'The transplanted row has turned, O...'

She stopped there.

Mrinal switched off the speaker.

'And then?'

Kaushalya tried to smile, but the smile did not quite form. 'What came next was not mine.'

'Whose was it, then?'

'Jhunki's.'

Mrinal had heard the name before. Jhunki Devi had been Kaushalya's childhood friend. On paddy-transplanting days the two worked in adjoining rows in the field. Kaushalya would raise the song; Jhunki would answer. Jhunki had died years ago. After that Kaushalya sang many songs, but this melody was never completed again.

'You don't remember the answer?' Mrinal asked.

Kaushalya shook her head. 'I remember fragments of words. Not the tune. Not the way Jhunki used to lift it.'

Mrinal turned over the papers on the table. 'I have to submit a new sound composition the day after tomorrow. The theme is the everyday sounds of the village. The loom, the bucket, the bell, the mortar... I took all of them from here. These four notes came into my head on their own. I didn't even realise they had been living somewhere already.'

Kaushalya said, 'Sometimes a tune enters not through the ear, but through the house.'

Mrinal fell silent.

She stopped working until noon. On the first page of the old red notebook she wrote: 'Source of the four notes?' Beneath it she paused before writing Kaushalya's name.

'Dadi, if this was the paddy-transplanting tune of all of you, how can I put my own name on it?'

Kaushalya pulled the winnowing tray towards herself again. 'Not in my name either. The song belonged to the field. Whoever's throat it entered, it became theirs; once it left that throat, it belonged to everyone again.'

'But you must have learnt it from someone.'

'From my mother. My mother from her aunt. Her aunt from whom—who knows?'

Mrinal wrote in the red notebook: 'Anonymous paddy-transplanting melody.' Then added: 'Heard from Kaushalya Devi.'

Kaushalya stopped her at once. 'Where is Jhunki's name?'

Mrinal looked at her.

Kaushalya began naming them one by one. 'Jhunki. Sudama Kaki. Parmesari. Chhotki Budhni. Sarju Mai...'

'So many people?'

'The song did not belong to one throat.'

Mrinal kept writing the names. At the fifth name Kaushalya stopped. Her eyes drifted towards the veranda. 'There were more. I don't remember all their names now.'

'We'll write as many as you remember.'

Mrinal asked, 'Why did you never sing this song again?'

Kaushalya picked a pebble from the tray and rolled it in her palm. 'The first transplanting season after Jhunki died, I raised it. The first line came out, but no answer came from anyone's throat. The other women caught up a different song. That day I understood that some melodies do not live by words alone; someone has to be standing opposite you as well.'

'So you gave it up?'

'One season at first. Then another. After that the field went out on sharecropping. Fewer people came for transplanting. The pace of the work changed. The song itself was left behind.'

Mrinal drew a short line along the margin of the red notebook. 'When I was little, did you used to hum this?'

Kaushalya thought. 'Possibly. When you wouldn't sleep, I used to turn the tune over without any words. I couldn't sing the words—they felt like Jhunki's share. Perhaps the melody remained.'

Mrinal looked at the marks she had made for her four notes. Suddenly she understood how often, while composing the melody, she had instinctively kept that same pause. She had not known why; the moment she removed the empty space, the whole rhythm felt unbalanced.

'So I learnt this from you, but didn't remember?'

'There is a difference between learning something and something settling inside you,' Kaushalya said. 'Some things are not taught. Living in a house, the body simply picks them up.'

That evening Mrinal opened her sound composition again. This time the empty space after the four notes began to trouble her. She tried to add a new note there—a flute-like sound once, a soft bell once, once a second line in her own voice. Everything sounded wrong.

Kaushalya was listening from outside.

'Leave it empty,' she said.

'Why?'

'That was where Jhunki used to come in.'

Mrinal's hand stopped. 'But in the composition the empty space will feel so long.'

'It felt long in the field too.'

Kaushalya came inside. 'While transplanting, we stayed bent low for one whole row. The first melody belonged to those bent bodies. Then came a pause for one breath—the waist straightened, the foot moved forward. After that pause Jhunki would raise the answer. Without the pause, the second line could never begin.'

Mrinal stopped the rhythm. 'So the empty space is part of the song too?'

Kaushalya said, 'Sometimes it is the most important part.'

The next morning the two went to the edge of the pond. A light mist lay over the water. Kaushalya hoped the tune might return to her in the open air. Mrinal had brought no equipment, only the red notebook.

Kaushalya raised the first line.

'The transplanted row has turned, O...'

Then the empty space.

She closed her eyes.

Mrinal said nothing.

Far out in the water a heron stood with its wings folded. From across the pond came the thump-thump of someone working a pestle. Kaushalya's fingers found the old beat on her knee by themselves. One, two, three—pause.

Suddenly two notes came from her mouth. She herself startled. Then a third note. Then a long descent.

'Was it like that?' Mrinal asked softly.

Kaushalya did not answer at once. Then she sang it again. This time her voice trembled on the last note.

'I cannot say exactly,' she said. 'But this is the path my body is taking.'

Mrinal made her own notation for the notes in the red notebook, but did not write any words.

'The words?'

Kaushalya shook her head. 'If I don't remember them, we won't invent them from our own minds. Let it remain unfinished.'

Mrinal smiled. 'In my sound composition too?'

'Add whatever new thing is yours there. But don't put it forward in the old song's name.'

The two returned home.

Mrinal worked all afternoon. After the four notes of the old melody she left the empty space exactly as it was. After that, she did not add the notes Kaushalya had half remembered as if they were Jhunki's reply. Instead she changed the new rhythm—the loom's clack-clack slowly became like the cadence of feet in a transplanting field, the thump of the bucket receded into the distance, and at the end only one new line rose in Mrinal's own voice, with words she herself had written.

In the note above it she wrote: 'Opening melody: anonymous village paddy-transplanting tradition. From the memory of Kaushalya Devi. In remembrance of Jhunki Devi, Sudama Devi, Parmesari Devi, Budhni Devi, Sarju Devi and the companions whose names are no longer remembered.'

Kaushalya read it and said, 'Why haven't you written "singer" beside my name?'

Mrinal laughed. 'You said yourself the song belonged to the field.'

Kaushalya laughed too.

Three days later Mrinal returned from college with no prize in her hand. There were only two lines of comment written by the teacher: 'A new composition has been created without claiming the old source as one's own. The use of empty space is effective.'

Kaushalya read the paper and asked, 'Did they understand the song?'

'Not all of it.'

'Then?'

'They all heard the empty space.'

Kaushalya folded the paper and placed it inside the red notebook.

That night after dinner Mrinal was gathering clothes from the courtyard when Kaushalya's voice rose from inside—

'The transplanted row has turned, O...'

Then the pause.

Mrinal stopped by the doorway. She did not know Jhunki's words. Nor did she sing the line from her own new composition. She only tapped the brass plate twice with her finger in the rhythm of that pause—ting, ting.

Inside, Kaushalya raised the next note.

The song was not completed.

But this time, she did not stop.

STORY 162

The River's Letter

Three months had passed since the floodwater receded, but old Buskatti still did not look like a village. Here stood half a wall, there a fallen bamboo post, elsewhere the soot-black mark of a hearth trapped in sand. The river had abandoned its old course and bent a little to the east, and the ghat that had once stood in the middle of the village had become a deserted bank at that bend.

Madhavi had come to the ghat with her father to gather driftwood. Her father collected branches higher up on the sand, while Madhavi went down towards the wet mud. There she saw the mouth of an old earthen water-pot, half buried. Before the flood, water for the boatmen had been kept in that pot. Now its belly was full of sand.

When Madhavi tried to set it upright, a flat piece of clay, no larger than her palm, came out from underneath. On it were two small scratches made by fingernails—parallel to one another.

Her breath caught.

Only she and Sudha used to make that sign. When they were children and shaped birds out of clay, they would make two scratches on the belly of each bird—one for Madhavi, one for Sudha.

On the piece of clay, written with the tip of a reed, were the words—

‘Madhu, do you come here? — Su’

Some letters were crooked, some blurred, but the moment Madhavi read the name her eyes filled with tears.

On the night of the flood, the two families had fled in different directions. Madhavi's family had reached a temporary settlement on the high road to the east; Sudha's family had gone west, near her maternal uncle's village. For the first few weeks no one had any certain news. Later they heard by word of mouth that both families had survived, but the road was broken, boats were irregular, and there was so much work at home that meeting was impossible.

That day, along with the driftwood, Madhavi took home a handful of smooth clay. At night, after the hearth had gone out, she kneaded the clay and made a palm-sized letter. With the point of a reed she wrote—

‘Su, I do come here. I'll come again next Tuesday. If you can read this, make two scratches.’

Below it she made two parallel marks with her fingernails.

The following Tuesday she went not with her father but with her mother, who was cutting grass. She placed her letter beneath the earthen pot at the ghat. She did not take Sudha's first letter home; she buried it there again. It seemed to her that if she carried the letter away, the ghat itself would be left empty.

Two weeks later, an answer was waiting.

'I read it. I come on Saturdays. Paper gets wet; clay does not run away.'

Madhavi burst out laughing.

From that day, the riverbank became a post office for the two of them.

Rules formed slowly. A letter must not be larger than a palm. After it was written, it had to dry in the sun for half a day. Two scratches were compulsory before it was placed beneath the pot. If there was too much to say, two clay letters could be made, but the first would bear one dot and the second two.

At first, their letters were short.

They never came to the ghat on the same day. Madhavi usually came on Tuesday or Wednesday evening, when the women who cut grass were returning along that route from the eastern settlement. Sudha came on Saturday mornings, on the pretext of going to the market with her maternal uncle. So after leaving a letter, an answer sometimes took four days, sometimes a whole week. During that interval neither tried to guess; the matter remained unfinished until the next letter.

'My goat has had a kid.'

'My mother still wakes at night at the sound of the river.'

'Did you find the old school's blackboard?'

'No. But the mango tree survived.'

After a while the letters grew longer. Sudha wrote that in her uncle's village the question of sending her to school kept being postponed because looking after the younger children of the household had become her responsibility. Madhavi wrote that a temporary school had opened in the eastern settlement, though the roof leaked on rainy days. She described her first day in such detail that two clay letters were not enough; she had to make a third.

Sudha's next reply was only one line—

'You keep studying. I will begin again.'

Madhavi held that letter in her palm for a long time. The next time, she wrote two small mathematics problems on her clay letter, the sort they had once asked each other to solve. Sudha answered one correctly and made a mistake in the other, then wrote below it, 'Don't laugh.' Madhavi replied, 'I got it wrong the first time too.' From then on, their letters were no longer only news of their lives; lessons too began to cross the riverbank.

At the beginning of winter, the river fell further. Sand on the far side could be seen from the old ghat. One day Madhavi felt tempted to wade through knee-deep water and walk across. People said the current in the middle was weak now. She mentioned it in a letter.

Sudha's reply was stern—

'The river has gone down, but the road has not returned. Do not step into it. The longing to meet must not become greater than the letter.'

At first Madhavi was annoyed when she read it. Then she drew a line in the mud of the ghat with her foot and stood looking at the water for a long time. That evening she wrote only—

'All right. I will stay on the bank.'

For the first time each had stopped the other from doing something, and in that restraint their friendship took on a new form.

Around Phagun, Madhavi once found a clay letter broken in half beneath the pot. All that could be read on it was—

'Madhu, now I no longer...'

The rest was missing.

Madhavi went cold. She searched the entire ghat. She clawed through the sand with her fingernails, looked beside the bushes, turned over small pieces of clay near the water's edge. Nothing.

She did not sleep that night. After 'now I no longer...', her mind kept completing the sentence on its own—I will no longer come, I will no longer study, I will no longer be here...

At dawn the next day she reached the ghat without telling anyone. The pot was empty. She had made a clay letter, but could not bring herself to write. At last she wrote only—

'Write the remaining words again. Do not leave half a sentence to the river.'

Three days later Sudha's complete reply came.

'Madhu, now I am no longer afraid. Mama has agreed to send me to school from next month.'

Madhavi read the letter, laughed first, then sat beside the pot crying. She kept the broken half-letter there too. The fear caused by that unfinished sentence taught both of them a new rule: if the meaning of something could change when it broke in the middle, the first line must contain the whole point; details could follow afterwards.

By the end of spring, a small heap of clay letters had gathered beneath the pot. Some were thin, some thick, some made of red clay, some grey. On some the letters were clear; others bore stains of damp. Neither girl took the letters home. To them, these belonged to the riverbank—like the bricks of the ghat, the sand, the old roots.

One day people from the panchayat came. Red bamboo stakes were driven in beside the old ghat. It was announced that before the next rains, earth would be filled along the bank to stop further erosion; the pot, the bushes and the half wall would all be buried.

Madhavi wrote in a clay letter—

'Our post office will be buried.'

Sudha's answer came—

'The post office was not the pot.'

Below were the two scratches.

In their separate homes, both began thinking about where the next place should be. The old peepal had fallen in the flood. The mango tree was too far. Too many people passed along the high embankment. At last Sudha suggested a small Shiva shrine half a kos north of the old ghat, where a dry recess remained between the upper bricks of a crumbling wall. Water would not reach there quickly.

Madhavi wrote—

'The place will change, not the sign.'

Before the rains returned, each came once more, at her own time, to the ghat with the earthen pot. They did not see one another. Madhavi went first. She counted the pile of clay letters—twenty-seven. Sudha's first letter, the one that said 'Do you come here?', was still among them.

Madhavi thought of taking all the letters, then stopped her hand. From the twenty-seven she chose only two—Sudha's first letter and her own reply saying, 'I will stay on the bank.' She arranged the rest again beneath the pot.

That evening Sudha came. She found two letters missing from beneath the pot and understood. She too chose two—the broken half that said 'now I no longer...', and the complete reply, 'now I am no longer afraid.' She covered the rest with a thin layer of earth.

The following week, panchayat labourers began filling the bank with soil. The pot, the bushes and the old masonry slowly disappeared into the embankment.

But the first new letter was already waiting in the wall of the Shiva shrine to the north.

Madhavi had written—

'Su, I found the new place. How is school?'

Two days later, beneath it was Sudha's clay letter—

'The roof is good. The teacher teaches fast. And I sit in the front row.'

Below it were the same two fingernail scratches.

The river began to rise again. The old ghat slowly went under water. Their homes were still far apart, the roads still separate, but the place where they spoke to each other kept changing with the river.

The clay dried, letters took shape, two scratches were made.

The letters kept travelling.

STORY 163

The Little Servant

On a winter morning, sunlight had not yet reached the long veranda at the back of the house. Two drops of dew gleamed on the old brass-coloured measuring tape kept in a corner by the wall. Ishan came running barefoot and stood with his back pressed against the doorframe.

“Kanhaiya, see—have I grown this much or not?”

Kanhaiya stopped in the middle of sweeping. He was only a little older than Ishan. Everyone in the house called him “the little servant”, but from the first day Ishan had called him by his name. Kanhaiya propped the broom against the wall, straightened the measuring tape and placed a finger on Ishan’s head to read the height.

“Half a finger more than yesterday,” he said with a laugh.

“In one night?”

“You drank milk all night, that’s why.”

Ishan at once drew a thin pencil line on the doorframe. There were already several marks there—‘Ishan 6’, ‘Ishan 7’, ‘Ishan 8’—his height from year to year. The writing belonged to different hands: sometimes his mother’s, sometimes his father’s, sometimes his grandfather’s.

Ishan held the pencil out to Kanhaiya.

“Let me measure you too.”

Kanhaiya laughed. “What will you do by measuring me?”

“Are you shorter, or am I?”

The question sounded like a contest. Kanhaiya stood with his back against the frame. Ishan tilted the measuring tape twice while trying to hold it straight. At last he drew a line and wrote—‘Kanhaiya 12’.

The two lines were almost at the same height.

Just then Ishan’s mother, Saroj, came out from inside. She had a wet cloth in her hand. She stopped when she saw the new writing on the doorframe.

“What have you written there?”

Ishan said proudly, “Both our measurements.”

Saroj’s eyes went first to Ishan’s line, then to ‘Kanhaiya 12’. Her voice was not harsh, but the easy smile had gone from it.

“Ishan’s height has been marked here for years. Don’t fill the whole doorframe with writing. Kanhaiya, get on with your work.”

With the cloth she rubbed away ‘Kanhaiya 12’. The pencil letters vanished, though a faint shadow of the line remained.

Kanhaiya picked up the broom. Ishan said nothing.

From that day the measuring tape became their game. But not in full view of the doorframe. In the storeroom an old plank leaned against the wall. Less dust gathered behind it because it stood flush against the wall. Ishan pulled the plank out a little and made their first mark on its hidden side.

“No one will see it here.”

Kanhaiya said, “What if someone throws the plank away?”

“Then somewhere else.”

Every month or two they began measuring each other’s height. Sometimes Ishan was half a finger ahead, sometimes Kanhaiya. Beside the lines there were no full names—only ‘I’ and ‘K’. The date went underneath.

But the measuring tape did not remain merely a thing for measuring height. One day Ishan got stuck on a mathematics exercise from school. The question was: on a cord one cubit long, at what intervals should five equal knots fall? Kanhaiya took an old clothesline, folded it twice, then folded it again and estimated five equal parts. Ishan’s answer had been wrong; the moment he saw Kanhaiya’s knots, he understood.

“Who taught you that?”

“Mother. We had to divide rope evenly along the field ridges.”

The next day Kanhaiya learnt from Ishan how to write his mother’s name. He could write his own name, but in ‘Phulkali Devi’ he kept getting the ‘li’ wrong. Ishan opened a book and showed him the vowel signs. Kanhaiya wrote it five times on the back of an old sheet of paper. The sixth time the letters came out clearly.

The two of them kept no account of this exchange.

The adults in the house did.

One day a tailor came. A new kurta was to be made for winter. Ishan stood on the veranda while the tailor measured his chest, shoulder and arm and wrote the figures on a sheet of paper. Kanhaiya was sitting nearby untangling a bundle of thread. Ishan called to him—

“See whether my arm is longer than yours.”

The tailor laughed. “Am I to measure both of you?”

Ishan said, “Just to see.”

Kanhaiya stretched out his arm. The tailor drew the tape from his shoulder to his fingertips.

“The same,” he said.

Ishan said at once, “See!”

Saroj called from inside, “Tailorji, finish the work first. It will be evening.”

Kanhaiya lowered his arm. Only Ishan’s measurements remained written on the tailor’s paper. The equal length of their arms entered no one’s account.

That evening, behind the storeroom plank, Ishan drew a new mark, but this time not for height. He made two thin lines of equal length for their arms. Kanhaiya laughed and said, "This piece of wood will turn into a whole ledger."

"Let it."

Kanhaiya said, "A ledger has names in it."

Underneath, Ishan wrote 'I' and 'K' in small letters.

Kanhaiya's mother lived in the village. At the end of each month, money from his wages was sent home. Whenever Kanhaiya received a letter from his mother, he first read the letters and words slowly, then asked Ishan about a few lines. Sometimes Ishan explained the meaning; sometimes he could not understand it himself. Then the two of them went to Grandmother, though Kanhaiya kept the letter in his own hands. Once Grandmother said—

"Ishan, have you finished your homework?"

Ishan ran towards his books. Kanhaiya folded the letter and tucked it into an inner fold of his kurta. Their studies once again took separate roads. But in the evening the measuring tape brought them back to the same plank.

When it was time for Ishan to go to school, his shoes were polished and his bag was ready. At that same hour Kanhaiya swept the courtyard, filled water in the kitchen and brought greens from the market. When Ishan returned, Kanhaiya carried his bag inside. Sometimes Ishan kept hold of the bag himself, but Grandmother would say—

"Kanhaiya is there, isn't he? Give it to him."

Kanhaiya took the bag. Ishan said nothing.

By evening the two would meet again near the storeroom. Sometimes they played marbles; sometimes they arranged coloured buttons from a broken watch-box into armies; sometimes they measured the length of the veranda by counting their steps.

Once carpenters came to the house. Termites had eaten into some of the old wooden doors. The doorframe on which Ishan's heights were marked had also become hollow at the bottom. The carpenter tapped it with his hammer and said—

"This frame will have to be replaced."

Saroj said at once, "But all the measurements from Ishan's childhood are on it."

The carpenter bent down and examined the frame. "Then cut out and preserve the strip where the measurements are. There is no point keeping the whole frame."

Ishan was standing there. Behind him Kanhaiya was gathering the wood shavings.

The next day the carpenter removed the frame. Dust fell with the first blow of the hammer. With the second, an old nail came out. With the third, the whole long piece of wood came away from the wall.

Saroj said, "Cut off a narrow strip where the measurements are written."

The carpenter turned the wood over so that he could draw the cutting line from the back.

Hammer raised, the carpenter stopped.

On the back of the wood, which no one had seen for years, were dozens of thin lines. Beside some was 'I', beside others 'K'. Beneath them were months and dates. Sometimes the two lines were half a finger apart, sometimes almost level. Between them were a few brief notes as well—"I ahead today", 'K had slippers on', 'measure again'.

Saroj took the wood in her hands.

Ishan's face turned red. Kanhaiya remained bent down, pretending to gather wood shavings.

"Who wrote all this?" Grandmother asked.

Ishan said softly, "Both of us."

"Since when?"

"For a long time."

Kanhaiya did not raise his head.

Saroj first looked at the old lines on the front—the ones everyone knew about. Then she turned the wood and looked at the lines on the back—the ones that had remained in the house yet outside the house's sight. The writing on both sides was in the same pencil, by the same unsteady child's hand.

The carpenter asked, "Which side's strip shall I save?"

For a few moments no one answered.

Ishan looked at Kanhaiya. Kanhaiya was still bent over, gathering each small splinter of wood into his palm.

Saroj handed the wood to the carpenter and said, "Leave both sides exactly as they are. Don't cut it. Remove only the rotten part at the bottom."

Grandmother seemed about to say something, then remained silent.

The long surviving piece of the doorframe was hung on the inner wall of the veranda. On one side were Ishan's neat old measurements. On the other were the two children's secret measurements, brought out from behind the plank.

That evening Kanhaiya looked at it openly for the first time. "Shall we measure again?" Ishan asked. Kanhaiya smiled. "Now it's on the wall. Everyone will see."

Ishan picked up the measuring tape. "So?" Kanhaiya stood with his back against the wood. Ishan placed a finger on his head and drew a new pencil line. Then, when it was his turn, he handed the pencil to Kanhaiya. Once again the two new lines were almost at the same height.

At the other end of the veranda, Saroj was gathering clothes. Her eyes went once to the wood and then to the two children. She said nothing. The

measuring tape remained propped beneath the wood. Heights continued to be written down.

STORY 164

Mother's Box

In the inner room of the old house in Benipatti, as Tara pulled the iron box out from beneath the cot, she first blew away the dust that had settled on its lid. A thin cloud of dust drifted towards the window.

Manjari came in from the veranda and said, "Wait. We'll open it when Renu arrives."

Tara stopped her hand.

It was the same box whose key Mother, Lalita Devi, always kept tied into the end of her sari. As children, the three sisters knew that the box held wedding saris, some old papers, Grandmother's silver anklets and "grown-ups' matters". But once they grew up, none of them knew exactly what was still inside.

On the twelfth day after Mother's death, the three sisters were sitting under the same roof again.

Manjari had come from Darbhanga. Renu from Janakpur. Tara had been living with Mother in this house for five years. When the question of taking stock of the household things arose, Tara herself had said, "The box will be opened in front of all three sisters."

No one asked whether there was more caution or affection in that sentence.

Renu arrived and sat with her back against the door. "Open it."

Tara turned the key. The lock did not open the first time. On the second attempt, the lid rose with a faint groan from within.

There were two old saris on top. Beneath them lay a ball of wool, a sewing box, empty medicine strips, old school certificates, and three notebooks of household expenses written in Mother's hand.

Manjari took the things out one by one and set them aside.

"Where did the anklets go?" Renu asked.

Tara looked at her. "Mother sold them three years ago. The roof was repaired."

Renu fell silent.

A faded blue cloth lined the bottom of the box. When Tara lifted it, three folded sheets appeared. The sheets were separate, but all three bore the same handwriting.

On the first was written, "For Manjari."

The second—"For Renu."

The third—"For Tara."

For a few moments, no one in the room reached out a hand.

Manjari slowly took her sheet. Renu took hers. Tara picked up the third, but did not open it.

Manjari began to read first.

“Manjari,

When you first went to the town to study, I told you that day not to worry about home. Later, when you began coming home less often, I repeatedly found myself saying that the town had changed you. I did not say that to hurt you, but to cover the sound of my own empty house. I had no right to stop you, yet I did not quite have the courage to send you far away either. That is why I kept saying both things at once. Now I understand that...”

The letter ended there.

Manjari turned the sheet over. There was nothing on the back.

“The second page?” Her voice grew hard.

Tara searched the box again. “It isn’t here.”

Manjari lifted the blue cloth, shook out each corner, and looked between the pages of the expense ledgers.

Renu opened her sheet.

“Renu,

In the second month after your marriage, you came home one night crying. You said, let me stay here for two days. At dawn I sent you back again. At the time, I thought that saving a home meant sending a daughter back to it. Much later I understood that a daughter first needs to be heard. You never opened that matter before me again. I too did not have the courage to ask. After that day, your silence I...”

The letter stopped there.

Renu folded the sheet sharply.

“This is only half of it.”

Tara still had not opened her own letter.

Manjari asked, “Did Mother ever say that she was writing letters?”

“Not that I saw.”

“Did you use to open the box?”

Tara did not answer at once. Then she said, “Not unless Mother told me to.”

Renu looked up. “But the key was with you during the last month.”

“Because Mother’s hands trembled.”

“I am not accusing you.”

“But that is how it sounds.”

Manjari intervened. “Read the third letter first.”

Tara held the sheet in her hand for a long time. Then she opened it.

“Tara,

You stayed with me for five years. Medicines, meals, accounts, visitors—you looked after everything. People kept saying that the youngest daughter was

serving her mother. I listened. But whenever I heard the word service, fear rose inside me, because you had a life of your own as well. The two times you gave up work outside, I took it as a convenience for myself and kept quiet. I never told you that..."

The letter stopped in the middle of the sentence.

Tara read it once. Then a second time.

Renu asked softly, "What comes next?"

Tara showed her the blank back of the sheet.

Three unfinished sentences lay before the three sisters.

Manjari took every paper out of the box. Old insurance slips, tax receipts, school mark sheets, two letters from Father, a wedding invitation, medicine accounts. There was nothing that could be the continuation of any of the three letters.

Renu kept turning the pages of the expense ledgers. "Mother never threw away papers. If she had written a second page, it would be here."

Tara said, "Perhaps she never wrote it at all."

Manjari said at once, "All three letters left unfinished at the same time?"

"They were not written at the same time."

Tara looked at the top of each sheet. There was a small date in one corner. Manjari's letter—Phagun twenty-seven. Renu's—Chait twelve. Tara's—Baisakh two. Three different days.

Manjari matched the dates against the expense ledger. On the page for Phagun twenty-seven were written rice, oil, medicine and "Manjari's letter". Beside it was a small empty square. On Chait twelve—"Write to Renu." Again, an empty square. On Baisakh two—"Talk to Tara." That square too was empty. Renu stared at the three empty squares for a long time. When Mother completed a task in the ledger, she drew a diagonal line through its square. Rice bought—a line. Tax paid—a line. Medicine bought—a line. There was no line beside any of the three letters. "Then there is no next page," Renu said. "No," Tara replied. "The matter itself was never completed."

The strain of searching on Manjari's face slowly loosened, but another uneasiness settled in its place. "I wanted to know what she would have written after 'Now I understand that...'. " Renu tried to laugh, but no sound came. "So did I. I wanted only one word—'mistake'. That's all." Tara ran a finger over her letter. "I wanted to know whether Mother stopped me, or whether I stayed back myself." "Who will tell us now?" Manjari asked. None of the three answered.

Outside, thin sunlight was sliding across the veranda. From a neighbour's courtyard came the sound of spices being ground on a stone slab. The house, which for so long had held the sound of Mother's breathing, was filling once again with ordinary sounds.

Renu unfolded her letter and smoothed it. "Shall I say one thing?" Her two sisters looked at her. "That night I did not tell Mother everything. I only said—

let me stay here for two days. If I had told her the whole thing, I do not know whether her answer would have changed.” Manjari said quietly, “For the first two years after I went to the town, I kept writing letters. In the third year I wrote less. I remembered only Mother’s bitter words, not my own silence.” Tara did not fold her sheet. “I left work twice. Once because of Mother. The second time because I myself grew afraid. But both times I put the blame on her.” For the first time, what stood between the three sisters was not so much Mother’s absence as their own unfinished words.

Manjari spread the blue cloth again across the bottom of the box. “We will not try to complete the letters.” Renu asked, “Why?” “Because words Mother did not write cannot be written in her name by us.” Tara looked again at the three dates in the expense ledger. “But the empty squares?” Manjari closed the ledger. “Let them remain empty.”

Renu folded her letter and put it back inside. Manjari did the same. Before putting away the third letter, Tara paused for a few moments. Then she took three clean sheets lying in a corner of the box. She gave one to Manjari, one to Renu, and placed one before herself. “What are these for?” Renu asked. Tara said, “Not to complete Mother’s letters. So that we do not leave our own words unfinished.”

That day, none of the three sisters wrote a long letter. Manjari wrote, “I had gone to the town; I had not left home.” Renu wrote, “Now I will tell the whole of what happened that night.” Tara wrote, “Of the reason I stayed back, half was Mother, and half was myself.”

The three sheets were kept separate from Mother’s letters. As Tara closed the box, she picked up the lock. She turned it in her hand for a few moments, then hung it on a nail in the veranda.

Manjari asked, “Won’t you lock it?” Tara ran her hand over the lid and said, “Not now.” The room’s window was open. The blue cloth inside could not be seen, nor could the letters. But for the first time, the box was without a lock.

STORY 165

The School Courtyard

Early morning sunlight had not yet properly settled over the school courtyard when Ratneshwar Jha opened the office door and spread a letter bearing a red seal on the table. He had read its two lines the night before as well, but in the morning he read them again: if enrolment in the new session remained below twelve, a proposal would be sent to merge the school with the larger school three kos away.

Ratneshwar looked outside. Eight small pairs of slippers lay scattered beneath the neem tree. That was how many children came regularly. The door of the second classroom had been shut for a month. On the blackboard, last week's addition still remained: forty-seven and twenty-eight.

The bell rang. The children stood in line. Ratneshwar folded the letter and put it into a file. The prayer went on as usual that day, but now and then his voice grew faint.

After the children had left at midday, he was sweeping the courtyard when Subhadra Devi appeared at the gate. She was around seventy, with a white end of her sari over her head and a folded paper in her hand. She lived in the western hamlet of the village. She passed the school twice a day, but rarely came inside.

"Master Sahib," she said, "will you teach me one letter?"

Ratneshwar stopped sweeping.

"Which letter?"

Subhadra unfolded the paper. It was a receipt from a cooperative group. Her name was printed at the bottom, and beside it was the round mark of her thumb.

"This here is my name, but I cannot read it. When they want my thumbprint, people say, put it here, put it there. I want at least to be able to write my own name myself."

Ratneshwar was silent for a few moments. Then he opened the locked classroom. There was dust inside, two broken low stools, and an old board leaning against the wall.

"May I sit now?" Subhadra asked.

"Sit."

The first lesson that day was 'su'. Subhadra's hand trembled as soon as she held the chalk. The first stroke went crooked, the second was far too long. The third time she pressed the chalk too hard and it snapped.

"My hand knows the sickle in the field," she said with a laugh. "This chalk is still a stranger to it."

Ratneshwar laughed too. "The hand will learn."

She came again the next day. And again on the third. Within a week there was less dust in the locked classroom. Subhadra had begun to recognise the first two syllabic signs of her name. She wrote them with a twig in the soil of the courtyard, in ash beside the hearth at home, and sometimes, after cutting vegetables, with a wet finger on her slate.

One evening Nathuni Kaki came with her.

"Teach me numbers," Nathuni said. "I want to know the difference between two hundred and five hundred."

Two days later Rahima Khatoon came as well. She wanted the first letter of her own name. After the children's lessons ended, Ratneshwar began keeping a half-hour evening class. There was no announcement. Three extra mats were simply spread in the courtyard.

The children grew curious. One day Munna of Class Three looked at his grandmother Subhadra's slate and said, "This 'dra' is wrong."

Subhadra did not take the chalk from his hand. "You make it. I'll watch."

Munna slowly formed 'dra'. Subhadra wrote it five times after him. On the fifth, Munna said nothing. He merely nodded.

Meanwhile the letter with the red seal remained in the file. Ratneshwar kept looking at the enrolment register. Eight names. Only two likely new children for the next session. Twelve still seemed far away.

One evening Subhadra asked, "Why was the other classroom locked before?"

Ratneshwar wanted to evade the question, but then took the letter from the file and showed it to her. Subhadra could not read all of it. She only searched for the letters she had learnt.

"What does it mean?"

"There are too few children. If the number does not rise, this school will be merged with another one."

Subhadra looked towards the courtyard. Beneath the neem tree a sheet of paper Munna had left behind was fluttering in the breeze.

"Then where will I learn my 'dra'?" she asked.

Ratneshwar smiled, but gave no answer.

For the next three days Subhadra did not come to the evening lesson. Ratneshwar thought perhaps the pain in her knees had grown worse. On the fourth day she arrived with a folded sheet in her hand. It carried the names of eight households - one with a five-year-old child, another with a six-year-old. The names were not in her handwriting; Nathuni's grandson had written them for her.

"Do all these children go to schools outside the village now?" Ratneshwar asked.

"Some do. Some still go nowhere. I only asked whether they would send them if our own village school remained open. Not everyone said yes."

"Then what next?"

"I marked the ones who said yes."

There was a small circle beside four of the names.

Ratneshwar kept the sheet. "Saying yes is not enough for enrolment."

"I know. I only went as far as their doors."

By the second week the school courtyard presented a curious sight. Eight children by day, five elderly men and women in the evening. Subhadra could now write the whole of 'Subhadra', though the 'vi' in 'Devi' still went wrong again and again. Rahima could read her own name. Nathuni could write numbers up to twenty.

Word of this small evening gathering spread through the village. People came to look. Some laughed; some stood for two minutes and went away. A few mothers came with their children. The children ran about the courtyard while the mothers watched Subhadra's slate.

One day Parvati, whose son attended a private school in the market, sat down beside Subhadra.

"The monthly fees there have risen a lot," Parvati said, "but if this school closes, the child will be stranded in between."

Forming the 'vi' on her slate, Subhadra said, "If we do not send children because we are afraid the school will close, and the school becomes more likely to close because we do not send children, I do not understand that arithmetic."

Parvati said nothing. The following Monday she came with her son's enrolment form.

After that two more names were added. One girl used to come with her grandmother to watch the evening class; her mother said it was difficult to send the child far away. Another family had kept their child at home because of farm work; Ratneshwar went to their house and spoke with them.

The enrolment register reached twelve. Ratneshwar closed it and rested his hand on it for a long time. But the letter said 'below twelve'. Whether twelve itself was enough was not clear. He carefully wrote to the block office reporting the new situation.

Meanwhile Subhadra had an examination of her own. One evening Ratneshwar placed a blank sheet before her and said, "Now write your name without looking."

Subhadra wiped her palm on the end of her sari. Slowly she wrote: 'Subhadra Devi'. The 'bha' leaned a little and the 'vi' was small, but the whole name could be read.

She looked at the sheet for a long time. Then she asked, "Do I need to put my thumbprint on this too?"

"No. Your name is enough now."

"Then this is me?"

Ratneshwar said, "Yes. This is your name, written by you."

The next day Subhadra went to the cooperative group's office. As before, they pointed to the place for her thumbprint on the receipt. She said, "This time I'll write my name." The clerk looked at her for a moment, then handed her a pen. The letters came down slowly, but they came.

That week an inspector came from the block office. He examined the enrolment register, the children's attendance sheets, and both classrooms. He did not stay until the evening lesson, but he noticed the five extra slates lying in the courtyard.

"Whose are these?" he asked.

Ratneshwar said, "Older people from the village come to learn in the evenings."

The inspector opened the register again. New enrolment had now reached thirteen; that very morning another family had registered a child. The inspector wrote a few remarks in red ink, closed the register, and left.

Ten days later a small envelope arrived. It informed them that the proposal for merger had been put on hold for the time being. Ratneshwar pinned the paper beside the blackboard. The children did not understand the whole matter, but from the master's smile they knew something good had happened.

When Subhadra came that evening, Ratneshwar read the notice aloud to her. She listened quietly, then opened her slate.

"Shall I write 'Devi' again now?"

"You can write it already."

"I can, but I do not want the hand to forget."

She wrote her name on the slate. This time the 'vi' was even. Two leaves fell from the neem tree. The second classroom stood open. Inside, two new children were practising letters.

Ratneshwar looked once at the notice, then at Subhadra's slate. The red-sealed paper was on the wall; the two words written in chalk were before him.

The courtyard no longer belonged only to the children. But the school had been saved - before the numbers, by people beginning to return.

STORY 166

The Vermilion Box

The first rain of Ashadh had stopped. The bricks of the courtyard had turned deep red in patches, and a thin stream of water was still sliding past the tulsi altar. Kamala Devi sat on the veranda sorting old clothes: one pile for her granddaughter Revati to play with, one for wiping, and a separate pile for clothes still fit for use.

Revati was playing house in the courtyard with two clay dolls. She had stuck a hibiscus petal on one doll's forehead and tied a thread around the other one's neck.

"Grandmother, do you have a small box?"

Kamala Devi looked up from the fold of cloth. "What will you keep in it?"

"The dolls' jewellery. These petals keep falling off."

"Look in the wooden chest."

Revati went inside. A little while later she returned holding a round brass box. A raised lotus was worked into the lid, and the rim had blackened.

"This one?"

Kamala Devi kept looking at the box in her hand for a moment. The fold she was making in the cloth remained unfinished.

"Where did you find it?"

"Behind the chest. It was wrapped in a blue cloth."

The box had remained in that same cloth for years. Kamala Devi had never opened it. Yet instead of reaching out to take it, she said, "The lid may be stuck. Don't force it."

Revati held the box between both palms and turned it gently. The lid opened with a scrape. Inside, only a very thin ring of red powder remained. Revati's eyes lit up.

"Was there vermilion in this?"

Kamala Devi began folding the cloth again. "A long time ago."

"Yours?"

"Yes. It was mine."

That was all the answer Revati's game required. She ran back into the courtyard with the box. Kamala Devi did not stop her.

In the afternoon Malati returned from the market. She was Kamala Devi's daughter and Revati's mother. The wet road had muddied her sari up to the knees. The moment she stepped through the gate, her eyes fell on Revati's game. The brass box lay in front of the clay dolls.

Malati stopped in her tracks.

"Revati, who gave you this?"

"Grandmother."

"Grandmother?"

Malati bent down and picked up the box. At the sight of the red residue inside the lid, her brows drew together slightly. She looked towards the veranda.

"Mother, you still had this?"

Kamala Devi said while untangling thread, "If it was kept, it was bound to be found."

"For Revati to play with?"

"It is a box. In a game it will serve as a box."

Malati said nothing. Holding the box in the corner of her sari, she walked inside. Revati followed close behind.

"Mother, my box."

"It isn't yours."

"Grandmother gave it to me."

"I'll give you another box."

Revati's face fell. Kamala Devi watched everything from the veranda. Malati placed the box on the upper shelf in the kitchen, beyond Revati's reach.

Until evening the work of the house went on as usual, but the little brass box seemed to lie not on the shelf but between three generations. Twice Revati dragged over a chair; both times Malati scolded her.

After the evening meal the rain began again. When the electricity went out, an oil lamp was lit on the veranda. Revati gathered up her dolls and sat beside Kamala Devi.

"Grandmother, why won't she let me play with that box?"

Kamala Devi looked at Malati. Malati was wiping the kitchen utensils. Her hands did not stop, but she was listening.

"Your mother thinks an old thing might get spoilt in play."

Revati said at once, "I won't spoil it."

Malati put down the utensil. "It isn't about spoiling it."

Kamala Devi asked, "Then how did that box become mine?"

"You know."

"I know, but Revati does not."

Malati's voice was low. "What meaning is there in keeping a vermilion box after becoming a widow?"

The lamp flame flickered once. Raindrops kept making a rhythm along the edge of the veranda. Revati did not understand the word 'widow', but seeing her mother's face, she fell silent.

Kamala Devi said very simply, "I did not keep that box for your father."

The cloth in Malati's hand became still.

"Then why did you?"

Kamala Devi stroked Revati's head. "For you."

Malati made as though she might laugh, but no laughter came. "A vermilion box for me?"

"Yes, for you."

Kamala Devi rose and went inside. She brought the box down from the shelf. This time she did not put it in Revati's hand but rested it on her own palm. She opened the lid. Red residue still clung to the rim.

"You don't remember?"

Malati shook her head.

"You were five years old. When your father died, the house filled with so many people that even reaching your own cot was difficult for you. One person removed my bangles, another changed my red sari, someone washed my head. Everyone said—it is the custom."

Malati sat down slowly.

Kamala Devi continued, "All day you went from one person's lap to another. At night there were fewer people. You woke, looked at me, and cried so loudly that everyone came running again."

Revati asked eagerly, "Mother used to cry?"

Without looking into her eyes, Malati said, "I was little."

Kamala Devi smiled. "Very little. You kept saying—this is not my mother."

A faint shadow of astonishment crossed Malati's face.

"I said that?"

"Not once. Again and again. You would take my hand, then look at my forehead and let go. To you, a mother had a red dot on her forehead and glass bangles ringing on her wrists. That day I had neither."

The rain outside grew heavier. The lamp flame trembled again.

Kamala Devi said, "It was very late by the time everyone grew tired. You lay in my room crying and crying. I gave you water, told you stories, held you in my lap—nothing worked. In the end you said only one thing: 'Call my mother.'"

Malati's eyes rested on Kamala Devi's head, whose hair parting had been bare for years.

"Then what happened?"

Kamala Devi touched the rim of the box with a finger. "Then I looked for this box."

Malati suddenly sat upright. "That day?"

"That night."

"Mother!"

It was hard to tell whether there was more astonishment or fear in her voice.

Kamala Devi remained calm. "I put a small red dot on my forehead. Not in the parting of my hair. Just that much. When you saw me, you stopped crying. First you touched it with your finger, then you clasped me around the neck. Within moments you were asleep."

Revati listened without breathing. Malati's eyes remained fixed on the box.

"Did anyone see?"

"No one."

"And you... after that?"

"Once you were asleep, I washed it off. By morning the house was full of people again. No one knew."

Kamala Devi paused a little. "The second night you woke again. The same thing. The third night too. On the fourth night you did not look at my forehead. You came straight into my lap and fell asleep. Then I wrapped the box in the blue cloth and put it away."

Malati said nothing for a long time. Her finger kept drawing a small circle on the cloth over her knee.

"I remember little bits of it as if from a dream," she said at last. "A red dot... and holding you around the neck. I used to think it must have happened on some other night."

Kamala Devi said, "Memory too sometimes waits for the right age before telling its story."

Malati picked up the box. She ran her thumb over the carving on the lid. "Why did you never tell me?"

"What would I have said? That on the very first night of the custom, I had broken the custom?"

"You could have told me."

"When you were a child, there was no need to tell you. When you grew up, you had the troubles of your own life. Then the matter became old."

There was a trace of guilt in Malati's voice. "It became old, so the box stayed hidden?"

Kamala Devi shook her head. "Not hidden. Kept. There is a difference."

Revati interrupted, "Grandmother, was it a sin to put on the red dot?"

Malati immediately tried to stop her with, "Revati," but Kamala Devi raised a hand.

"Who will decide what is a sin?"

"Mother put the box up there."

Embarrassment and laughter came to Malati's face at the same time.

Kamala Devi said, "Some customs are made to hold people's grief together, some to give grief a form. But a small child's fear does not understand custom."

Malati said softly, "And a mother's fear?"

Kamala Devi looked at her. "Nor does a mother's fear."

The silence that came between them this time was not as hard as before. The rain eased a little. Somewhere in the distance a frog began to call.

Revati asked for the box again. "Can I play with it now?"

Malati, still holding the box, looked at Kamala Devi.

"Do you want to give it to her?"

“I already did.”

Malati looked once at the red residue inside the lid. Then she tried to wipe it very gently with the tip of her finger, but Kamala Devi stopped her.

“Let that residue remain.”

“It is only residue.”

“Whatever remains, let it remain.”

Malati stopped her hand. Giving the box to Revati, she said, “Don’t bury it in the mud. When your game is over, give it back to me.”

Revati brightened. “All right.”

She placed the box beside the dolls’ house. There was no vermilion inside, so she plucked two thin hibiscus petals and put them in it. One petal was deep red, the other slightly faded by the rainwater.

Malati kept watching from a distance.

After a while she moved closer and sat beside Kamala Devi. “Mother.”

“Yes?”

“That fourth night... when I fell asleep in your lap without the red dot, how did you feel then?”

Kamala Devi looked out at the dark courtyard after the rain.

“I felt that you had recognised me again.”

Malati’s eyes grew moist, but she did not wipe them. She simply took her mother’s hand in her own.

In the courtyard Revati was not arranging a wedding for the dolls. She seated both dolls on the veranda of the same house and divided the hibiscus petals between them. When the game ended, she returned the box to Malati.

This time Malati did not put it on the shelf. Nor did she look for the blue cloth. She placed the box beside Kamala Devi’s sewing case, in the open.

The lid was closed, but the box was no longer hidden.

STORY 167

The Swing on the Tree

When Kusum got off the bus on that Sawan afternoon, the first thing she did was look up at the sky. Clouds had gathered, but the rain had stopped. Sinking into the muddy road with every step, she held her daughter Mansi by the hand and reached the gate of her mother's home. In her other hand was a cloth bag, and from its top peeped a loop of new, thick cotton rope.

All along the way, Mansi had kept asking about that rope.

'Ma, did you really swing on a tree?'

'Not on the tree—on a swing.'

'But the swing was on the tree, wasn't it?'

'Yes, on that very mango tree.'

'Then the tree is an acquaintance of mine too.'

Kusum laughed. 'See it first.'

The moment the gate opened, Mansi ran into the courtyard. Kusum stopped with one foot inside. The courtyard looked larger than before. Where shade used to lie even at noon between the bricks, a broad patch of white sunlight now fell. The eastern wall stood fully exposed. On that side of the wall, where a thick branch had once bent low and covered half the courtyard, there was only empty sky.

Kusum set the bag down.

'The tree?'

Mansi turned and asked, 'Which tree?'

Kusum did not answer. Her eyes searched the ground for old marks. In the middle was a rounded mound, levelled with earth and bricks. The newer bricks around it were a different colour.

Sharda Devi was rising from the veranda. 'Oh, you've come! Why did you walk through all this mud? You could have sent word to Madhukar.'

Kusum bowed to her, but her eyes did not leave the courtyard.

'Ma, where has the mango tree gone?'

Sharda Devi was silent for a moment. 'It was cut down.'

'Cut down?'

'Yes. It had to be cut.'

That brief answer tightened something inside Kusum. She looked at Mansi. The child was still cheerful; she had not yet understood that the thing her mother had promised to show her all along the road no longer existed in this courtyard.

‘When?’ Kusum asked.

‘Last Bhadon.’

‘You didn’t tell me?’

Sharda Devi picked up the bag. ‘Come inside first. Change your clothes. Then I’ll tell you everything.’

Kusum took the bag back from her hand. ‘No. Tell me this first—why was the tree cut?’

Just then Madhukar came out of the back room. He had a small metalworker’s hammer in his hand. Hearing his sister’s voice, he stopped.

‘I had it cut,’ he said.

Kusum turned to him. ‘What was the hurry?’

‘There was no hurry. I had been watching it for two years.’

‘You could have told me once.’

Madhukar set the hammer beside the wall. ‘And what would telling you have done?’

‘At least I would have known.’

‘Would you have known—or stopped us?’

Kusum had no immediate answer. Her hand moved unconsciously to the rope lying on top of the bag.

Mansi stepped between them and asked, ‘Mama, where was the swing?’

Madhukar stroked the child’s head. ‘Your mother used to fly from here all the way to there.’

He pointed towards the eastern wall. Mansi looked up in wonder, as though some rope might still be visible in the empty sky.

Sharda Devi said, ‘Eat first. Hold your court over the tree later.’

Kusum said little during the meal. Mansi kept asking her grandmother about mango pickle, fish from the pond, and the village children. Twice Madhukar tried to bring up the tree, but Kusum kept her eyes on her plate.

By afternoon the clouds had gathered again. When the wind rose, the tulsi leaves in front of the veranda began to tremble. Mansi pulled the new rope out of the bag.

‘Ma, where will we tie this now?’

Kusum looked at the rope. She herself had bought it at the town market the previous week. Remembering the old swing of her childhood, she had imagined seating Mansi on that same branch at least once this Sawan. She had even brought two small wooden fittings from home for fastening the seat-board to the rope.

‘Put it away for now,’ she said.

Mansi’s face fell. ‘You said I would swing at Nani’s house.’

‘I did.’

‘Then where is the swing now?’

Kusum had no answer.

Sharda Devi sat beside a pillar of the veranda. Her eyes fell on the rope. 'You even brought rope with you?'

'Yes, for Mansi.'

'The old habit.'

'The old habit would have been useful if the old tree were still here.'

Madhukar heard the remark as he returned from outside. This time he said nothing. He went straight to the rounded mound in the middle of the courtyard and nudged the edge of a new brick with his foot.

'The roots are still here underneath,' he said. 'Only the part above ground was removed. If we dug out the whole root system, the wall's foundation would have been disturbed.'

Kusum rose and went there. 'Was the tree diseased?'

'It had become hollow inside. In the first storm last Sawan, the southern branch came down. It tore the cowshed roof. Luckily no one was underneath.'

'One branch fell, so you cut down the whole tree?'

Madhukar answered a little sharply, 'It wasn't just one branch. When the trunk was opened, there were termites and rot inside. The carpenter said no one could tell which way it would fall in the next big storm.'

Kusum fixed her eyes on the ground.

Sharda Devi said quietly, 'At first Madhukar would not agree to cutting it. I told him to.'

Kusum looked at her suddenly. 'You?'

'Yes. I did.'

'You wouldn't even let a leaf of that tree be broken.'

'That was when it was a living tree.'

Kusum wanted to say something, but Sharda Devi placed a hand on her right knee. 'When you came last time, you saw that I had slipped, didn't you?'

Kusum remembered. Two years earlier her mother's knee had swollen. She had assumed she had slipped on wet bricks.

'The roots had lifted the bricks,' Sharda Devi said. 'I had already stumbled twice. Even then I had no heart to cut it. Then the branch fell on the cowshed. That night the wind kept blowing, and I lay in my room listening to the tree creak. For the first time I felt that when a memory begins to fall on your head, it is no longer merely a memory.'

Kusum fell silent after hearing her.

Mansi sat down on the rounded mound and scratched at the soil with a finger. 'Nani, did your daughter swing here?'

'From morning till evening.'

'Didn't she fall?'

Sharda Devi laughed. 'She did. Once her nose even bled.'

Mansi looked at Kusum excitedly. 'You never told me!'

Kusum laughed too, though the tightness inside her laughter had not quite gone.

It rained in the evening. The new bricks in the courtyard began to shine. When the rain stopped, Kusum came out from the veranda. No water had collected around the rounded mound. Madhukar had changed the slope of the drain. Along the eastern wall a new narrow path had been made, so that Sharda Devi could reach the tulsi platform without having to step over uneven ground.

Kusum had not noticed that path before.

‘Was this made after the tree was cut too?’ she asked.

Madhukar nodded. ‘The roots had pushed the ground up. I levelled it for Ma’s knee.’

Kusum walked slowly along the narrow path. In childhood, a thick root of the tree had lain there; she would step on it to catch the swing-board. Now there was no root, only level brickwork.

‘Why didn’t you tell me?’ she asked again, this time more softly.

After a pause, Madhukar said, ‘Because I knew it would hurt you. And also because I knew you’d say, “Wait, I’m coming.” But the tree was in no condition to wait.’

‘I would have come.’

‘I know you would have.’

‘Then why didn’t you tell me?’

Madhukar looked towards the eastern wall. ‘I was a little afraid that you would come and stand in front of the tree, and then I wouldn’t be able to have it cut. And if something happened in the next storm?’

For the first time Kusum looked fully at her brother. There were a few white hairs at his temples. In childhood, when he pushed the swing, Madhukar would run behind holding the ropes. Once, instead of giving him a push, Kusum had made him sit on the board, and both of them had fallen. After that, their mother had taken the swing down for three days.

Now it was not their mother who had taken down the swing. It was time.

That night Mansi slept beside her grandmother. Kusum went to her old room. In one corner of the wall there was still a scratch from her schooldays. The window looked smaller. She understood that a mother’s home remains the size of one’s childhood only in memory; in its daily form people grow old, walls are repaired, and trees too are cut down. The understanding brought no happiness, but the bitterness eased a little.

At dawn Mansi woke her. ‘Ma, get up. Nani says we’re going to the market.’

‘So early?’

‘To buy a tree.’

Kusum sat up. ‘What tree?’

Before answering, Mansi ran outside.

Sharda Devi was ready on the veranda. Madhukar had his bicycle with him.

‘Not the market,’ Madhukar said. ‘The nursery is on the road by the river.’

Kusum looked at her mother. ‘Had you already thought of this?’

‘I’ve been thinking about it ever since the tree was cut. We simply hadn’t decided what tree to plant.’

Mansi immediately said, ‘One for a swing.’

Sharda Devi laughed. ‘Will we find a tree with that name?’

At the nursery, mango, guava, neem, kadamba and jamun saplings stood in rows. Mansi asked the same question about every one: ‘Can a swing be tied to this?’ At last the old man selling the plants laughed and said, ‘It can, but you will have to be patient.’

Kusum stopped in front of a jamun sapling. Its leaves were deep green, and its trunk was only a little thicker than a finger.

‘Why not a mango?’ Madhukar asked.

Kusum remembered the old mango tree in the courtyard, then shook her head. ‘Why make another one just like that tree? Let this be a new tree.’

Mansi held two of the sapling’s leaves together. ‘This one.’

On the way back, the sapling was tied behind Madhukar’s bicycle. Mansi kept turning around to make sure its leaves were not being torn by the wind along the road.

When they reached the courtyard, everyone first stood by the rounded mound where the old tree had been. Mansi said, ‘Plant it here.’

Madhukar pressed the earth with his foot. ‘The old roots are underneath. We’ll have to plant it a little away from here.’

Kusum went towards the south-eastern corner. The evening sun fell there, but it was away from the drain. She marked a place with her foot.

‘In this corner.’

Sharda Devi asked, ‘Why?’

Kusum looked around as though measuring the courtyard’s directions. ‘When I sat on the old swing, the evening sun came from this side into my eyes. The shade of this tree will grow the other way. The house need not become the same house again.’

Madhukar brought a spade. He cut the first earth. Kusum took the spade from his hand. ‘Now me.’

The soil was wet, so digging deep was not difficult. Mansi kept removing small clods by hand. Sharda Devi sat on the veranda watching. When the pit was ready, Kusum carefully loosened the ball of soil around the sapling. The roots were fine, white fibres clinging to the wet earth.

‘Keep it straight,’ Madhukar said.

‘It is straight.’

‘A little towards me.’

‘You want everything turned towards you.’

This time they both burst out laughing together.

Mansi came running with the new rope. 'What do I do with this?'

Kusum gave her one end and held the other herself. Together they made a circle a little away from the sapling to mark the boundary within which the soil was to be pressed. Madhukar poured water in the middle. The rope became smeared with mud.

Mansi was upset. 'But this was for the swing.'

Kusum said, 'It will remain for the swing. For now, it is for measuring around the tree.'

'After how many years can we tie it?'

No one answered at once.

From the veranda Sharda Devi said, 'The day the tree can properly bear its own weight, it will be ready to bear someone else's.'

Mansi looked at the sapling's trunk. 'By then I'll be grown up.'

Kusum stroked her head. 'Perhaps.'

'Then will my child swing on it?'

Madhukar laughed. 'Your schooling hasn't even begun, and your child's swing is already decided.'

Mansi remained serious. 'I'll keep the rope safe.'

Kusum shook the mud from the rope and spread it out on the veranda.

By afternoon, two or three drops of rain shone on the new sapling's leaves. The rounded mound of the old tree was still in the middle of the courtyard; no one had covered it. The new sapling stood a little away from it—so small that its shadow was contained within its own leaves.

When it was time to leave, Kusum stopped at the gate and looked back. Mansi first looked at the old rounded mound, then began counting the leaves on the new sapling.

One, two, three, four, five.

The sixth leaf was half curled. Mansi did not straighten it with her finger. She only bent closer to make sure it was moving in the breeze on its own.

Kusum did not put the rope back in the bag. She hung it on a peg in the veranda.

'Let it stay till next time,' she said.

Sharda Devi said nothing. She looked once at the peg, then at the sapling.

There was no swing in the courtyard yet. But the rope stayed in the house.

STORY 168

The Clay Flute

The morning sunlight had not yet reached the rear wall of the potters' quarter. Ramlochan was turning the wheel, while his twelve-year-old son Nilu was drying small clay tubes beside it.

Pitchers, surahis, lamps and cooking pots came from Ramlochan's hands. From Nilu's hands came, at times, a horse, at times a bird, and at times some object for which he himself thought of a name only afterwards.

That morning the fourth tube cracked as well.

Nilu held it near his ear and blew into it. Only air came out.

'Again?' Ramlochan asked without stopping the wheel.

'The mouth became a little too wide.'

'I have told you three times that clay shrinks in the fire.'

'It shrinks, but not every tube in the same way.'

Ramlochan laughed. 'Then ask the clay first before you make it.'

Nilu did not answer. He picked up the fifth tube. One end was flattened, and there were six small holes along the middle. Around the holes he had pressed marks with grains of rice so that his fingers would not slip on the unfired clay.

He blew into it. The first note came out thin, the second a little heavier; on the third, the air broke. Nilu changed his fingering. This time three notes sounded in succession. The fourth went crooked again.

Ramlochan stopped the wheel and listened.

'It sounds like a flute.'

'Not bamboo. Clay.'

'Then will its name change too?'

'Why should the name change? It is the air that gives the note.'

Ramlochan covered his mouth as he laughed. 'All right, then. The wind is your guru.'

Nilu ran a finger over the flute's holes. He did not like the word guru. The wind told him nothing; only, if a hole shifted a little this way or that, the note changed. He listened and guessed.

By noon five flutes had been set aside. Two were cracked, two were out of tune, and one, by Nilu's reckoning, was usable.

The next day Ramlochan arranged his wares for the weekly market. Nilu placed the usable flute on top of the basket.

'Will you sell it?' his father asked.

'If someone can play it.'

‘What price will you ask?’

Nilu thought. ‘I don’t know the price.’

Ramlochan said, ‘If you don’t know the price, the market will know.’

At the market the flute first caught the children’s eyes. One blew into it and laughed; another held it backwards. A boy offered five paise, but Nilu would not give it to him.

‘Are five paise too little?’ the boy asked.

‘No. You didn’t cover the third hole properly.’

‘Am I buying it or sitting an examination?’

Nilu put the flute back on the basket.

By evening the pots had dwindled, but the flute was still there. As the market was breaking up, Ratinath, a dealer in earthenware who travelled towards town, bought Ramlochan’s remaining lamps and surahis together. While the basket was being tied, the flute fell to the ground.

Ratinath picked it up and blew. A thin note came out.

‘Will you give me this as well?’

Ramlochan looked at Nilu.

Nilu said, ‘Take it. But give it into the hands of someone who can play.’

Ratinath laughed. ‘In town I put every object into someone’s hands.’

‘No. Give this to someone who listens to notes.’

‘Does anyone listen to notes with his eyes?’

Nilu remained serious. Ratinath put the flute into his bag.

Three days later, a middle-aged man stopped before Ratinath’s shop in Darbhanga’s old market. His name was Devvrat Jha. At the town music school he taught boys and girls the flute and vocal exercises. While buying two clay flowerpots for his wife, his eye fell on the clay tube peeping from the side of the bag.

‘What is this?’

Ratinath said, ‘A flute. But don’t think of it as something for sale.’

Devvrat laughed. ‘Something that comes to a shop is not for sale?’

‘The boy who made it said it must be given to someone who listens to notes.’

Devvrat took the flute. He examined the holes, put it to his lips and blew gently. The first note came out clear. The second was a little low. The third climbed unexpectedly high. He stopped, then played again. This time he changed the pressure of his fingers and reduced the air. The third note rose to the same place again.

‘The hole is wrong,’ he said.

Ratinath shrugged. ‘A boy made it.’

Devvrat turned the flute over and over. The holes were not in a straight line. Two had shifted slightly to the right, and one was small. The impressions of the rice grains could still be seen around their edges.

‘How much is it?’

‘The boy gave no price.’

Devvrat gave him five rupees. Ratinath tried to return two, but he stopped his hand.

‘Can I meet the maker?’

‘Ramlochan the potter comes to the next market.’

Devvrat took the flute home. After dinner that night he played it again. His daughter Shruti came from the next room and asked, ‘A new flute?’

‘Not new. Strange.’

‘Why do you say that?’

Devvrat played the third note. ‘If this hole were here instead, the note would sit properly.’

Shruti asked, ‘Then enlarge the hole.’

Devvrat thought of heating a needle and enlarging the hole, but stopped when he looked at the clay. Fired clay was not easy to cut. Then another thing began to trouble him: the other holes too were not at classical intervals, yet two of the notes were unexpectedly sweet.

That night he did not alter the flute.

On the next market day Devvrat reached Ratinath’s shop early. When Ramlochan arrived, Nilu was with him.

Ratinath called from a distance, ‘This is the boy you were looking for.’

Devvrat looked at Nilu. He had expected to meet some young craftsman. Before him stood a thin-armed boy with clay under his fingernails.

‘Did you make this?’ Devvrat showed him the flute.

Nilu recognised it at once. ‘Yes. The third note runs high, doesn’t it?’

Devvrat was silent for a moment. ‘You know?’

‘I understood after it came out of the fire.’

‘Then why did you send it to be sold?’

‘If I had thrown it away because it was out of tune, why would I have made it?’

Devvrat placed the flute in Nilu’s hands. ‘Play.’

Nilu played the first two notes. On the third he half-opened the hole and blew slightly sideways. The note that climbed high in Devvrat’s hands became, in Nilu’s, a soft note in between.

Devvrat watched closely.

‘Again.’

Nilu played it again.

‘How did you learn that?’

‘The hole came out wrong, so I changed the air.’

For the first time Devvrat smiled. ‘You changed the air?’

‘Fingers can’t do everything.’

The market went on around them, but Devvrat sat for half an hour on Ramlochan's mat. He asked Nilu how many flutes he had made, what clay he used, how long he kept them in the fire. Nilu could not answer every question. Ramlochan supplied some of the answers.

At last Devvrat said, 'Can you come to town? I'll show you the intervals between notes.'

Nilu looked at his father.

Ramlochan asked, 'When?'

'On Sunday.'

Ramlochan shook his head. 'Sunday is when we open the kiln.'

Devvrat understood that this was not an answer of yes. He wrote his address on a piece of paper and gave it to Nilu. Nilu folded it and put it in his bag.

For two weeks Nilu did not go to town. In the third week Devvrat came to the potters' quarter himself.

That day Ramlochan was opening the kiln. The smell of hot ash hung in the air. Nilu was taking out the clay tubes one by one and laying them on straw. Some mouths had warped; some tubes had fine cracks.

Devvrat reached out to pick one up. Nilu stopped him at once.

'It is still hot.'

Devvrat drew his hand back.

'The lesson here today?' he asked with a laugh.

Nilu said, 'First let all these cool.'

Devvrat sat on the veranda until noon. Ramlochan showed him the wheel. Nilu made two unfired tubes. Devvrat took out his bamboo flute and measured the distance between its holes, then used a thread to mark the proportions on the clay tubes.

Nilu watched closely.

'If I make it like this, will the notes sit properly?'

'Very nearly.'

'After it shrinks in the fire?'

Devvrat stopped.

Nilu asked again, 'Is this distance for raw clay or for fired clay?'

Devvrat remained holding the thread. His measurements were for bamboo; he did not know how to calculate the clay's shrinkage.

Ramlochan, raising a new pot on the wheel, said, 'He has been troubling me with this question for three months.'

Devvrat laughed. 'Then let him trouble me too.'

That day the lesson was less about notes and more about measurements. Nilu marked five different spacings on five tubes. Ramlochan gave them clay from the same batch. Devvrat said they would measure them all again after firing.

Devvrat returned the following week. One of the five tubes had cracked. The other four had not shrunk equally. Nilu checked the measurements with the thread.

‘The clay was thicker on this side, so the hole shifted slightly inward.’

Devvrat played them one by one. Two flutes produced almost the same sequence of notes. The third took its own path again.

‘Useless?’ Devvrat asked.

Nilu took the flute. ‘No. Another tune will come from this one.’

Devvrat said, ‘Will you make a new rule for every wrong thing?’

For the first time Nilu returned his question. ‘Is every note that does not fit the rules necessarily wrong?’

Ramlochan burst out laughing from behind the wheel.

Devvrat laughed too, but did not answer at once.

After that, the arrangement of Sundays changed. Twice a month Devvrat came to the potters’ quarter. On the other two Sundays Nilu went to town after the kiln had been opened at noon. In the small room of the music school, for the first time he learnt the names of notes, understood ascent and descent, and practised keeping the breath flowing steadily instead of holding it.

But things on Devvrat’s table also began to change. Beside the bamboo flute there were now four clay tubes, thread, a small wooden ruler and a lump of raw clay given by Ramlochan.

One day the head of the school saw the clay in Devvrat’s room and asked, ‘Pottery along with music now?’

Devvrat said, ‘I am learning how much a note shrinks in the fire.’

Whether the head understood him or not, he asked no further questions.

Six months later Nilu made a new flute. It was not as beautiful as the old flute. Finger impressions showed on its surface, and its colour was uneven. But all seven notes sounded clearly in sequence.

He took the flute to town to give it to Devvrat.

Devvrat played it. First note, second, third—each in its place. At the last note he stopped.

‘This one is complete.’

Nilu said, ‘No.’

‘What is left?’

Nilu took the first old flute from his bag, the same one that had reached Devvrat through Ratinath.

‘In this one the third note runs high,’ Nilu said.

‘I know.’

‘But the breath I learnt for that note is not needed on the new flute. The new flute is easy.’

Devvrat placed the two flutes before him. One was close to the rules; the other held the memory of practice born from an error.

‘Which one will you keep?’ he asked.

Nilu said, ‘Both. From one I’ll learn the rules. From the other, the ear.’

Devvrat nodded slowly. Then he held out his old bamboo flute to Nilu.

‘Take this.’

Nilu did not take it. ‘It is yours.’

‘Consider it gurudakshina.’

Nilu asked in surprise, ‘Does the guru give the gurudakshina?’

Devvrat laughed. ‘Let someone change the rule today.’

Nilu took the flute, but did not put it straight into his bag. He placed the new clay flute in Devvrat’s hands and said, ‘Then you keep this. But on one condition.’

‘What is it?’

‘Next time we make the holes, you will not measure the thread.’

‘Then how?’

‘First the clay will measure. After it is fired, you will measure the notes.’

Devvrat turned the flute in his hand. ‘All right.’

That evening, after the music school closed, Devvrat placed the new clay flute beside the window. Next to it lay Nilu’s first flute with the crooked note. They were almost the same size, but the spacing of their holes was different.

The following Sunday Devvrat went again to the potters’ quarter. Nilu was not by the wheel; he was sifting clay behind the kiln. Devvrat sat down there quietly.

Nilu stopped the sieve and asked, ‘A lesson in notes today?’

Devvrat picked up a lump of raw clay.

‘Today, the clay lesson first.’

Nilu tested the lump’s moisture with a finger, then poured a little water into Devvrat’s palm.

‘This won’t become a flute yet,’ he said. ‘First let the clay rest a little.’

Devvrat put the lump back on the ground.

The two of them waited for it to rest.

STORY 169

A Name

When school let out that afternoon in Bhadra, rain clouds hung in the sky, though no rain had yet fallen. Anshu reached home with his schoolbag slung over his shoulder and opened his book as soon as he sat down on the veranda.

His mother, Shailaja, called from the kitchen, 'Studying so early today?'

Anshu did not answer. On one page of the book the teacher had written: 'Ask the people at home and bring the story of your name.'

That day in class all the children had told the stories of their names. One had been named by a grandmother, another after the month of birth, another in connection with the family deity. Anshu had laughed then and said, 'My mother named me.'

His teacher, Vibha Jha, had asked only, 'And before that?'

Anshu had given no answer.

He knew the story of his home. By the time he was six, Ma and Babuji had told him that he had not been born in their home; he had been adopted. It had never been kept as a secret. In the family it was as ordinary a fact as Babuji's liking for sweet paan and Ma's liking for gram-flour curry.

But he had heard the question 'And before that?' for the first time.

In the evening, when Babuji—Raghav—returned from the office, Anshu placed the book in front of him.

'Why did you name me Anshu?'

Raghav said as he took off his shoes, 'Your mother had been thinking of that name for five years beforehand.'

Shailaja called from the kitchen, 'Not five. Three years.'

'I thought it was five.'

'You add two years to everything.'

Anshu did not laugh. He asked again, 'When I came to your home, what was my name then?'

Raghav's hands stopped as he sat on the veranda taking off his shoes. The sound of the ladle from the kitchen stopped too.

Anshu looked from one to the other.

'I did have a name, didn't I?'

Shailaja came out slowly. Her hands were smeared with spices. She went to the water pot to wash them, then sat down in front of Anshu.

'You did.'

'What was it?'

‘Kush.’

Anshu repeated the name twice in his mind. Kush. Short, sharp as a single syllable.

‘Who had named me?’

Shailaja said, ‘A sister at the children’s home told us that your birth mother had given that name. I know only what I was told.’

Anshu remained silent for a while.

‘Then why was it changed?’

Raghav had now sat down on the veranda. ‘We had already thought of the name Anshu.’

‘Before you saw me?’

‘Yes.’

‘Then was the name mine or yours?’

The question was straightforward. An expression crossed Shailaja’s face as though she were searching for an answer, although only now, for the first time, did she seem to grasp the meaning of the question.

‘We had thought of it for you,’ she said.

‘But Kush had also been chosen for me, hadn’t it?’

Raghav started to say something in between, then stopped.

Anshu closed the book. ‘I’m only asking.’

He got up and went into the courtyard.

Shailaja kept looking after him.

Dinner that night was ordinary, but Shailaja kept glancing at Anshu’s plate. Once she asked, ‘Did anyone say anything at school?’

‘No. No one.’

‘Did anyone laugh because you were adopted?’

‘No. Nothing like that.’

‘Then why so much about the name?’

Anshu was mixing dal into his rice. ‘Because I didn’t know.’

‘Now you know.’

‘Yes. I know that much.’

‘Only that much?’

Anshu lifted his head and looked at his mother. ‘Do you think that if I’m called Kush, I won’t remain Anshu?’

Shailaja said at once, ‘I didn’t say that.’

‘But that is the question you’re answering.’

Raghav’s hand stopped over his plate. Grandmother Saroj, who had been eating quietly until then, drank some water and put down her glass.

‘A child does not change homes merely by hearing a name,’ she said, and nothing more.

Shailaja looked at Grandmother, but did not reply.

The next day, after Anshu had gone to school, Shailaja began remembering the old days. Thirteen years earlier, when she had gone to the children's home, the little boy had come into her lap and first clutched at her sari. He had not cried; he had only looked all around him.

One of the sisters had called him 'Kushu'. The child had turned his head at once.

Shailaja had paid no attention to it then. So many things had been running through her mind at once—how the child ate, how he slept at night, what sounds frightened him, which toy he kept in his hand. At the time, the name had seemed the simplest thing of all.

On his first night after being brought home, the child had not slept for a long time. Raghav had carried him in his arms and paced the veranda. Shailaja, exhausted, had been sitting on the cot. At one point she had said without thinking, 'Kushu, sleep now.'

The child had looked towards her voice and slowly grown quiet.

That night Shailaja had said 'Kushu' three times.

A few weeks later, 'Anshu' was heard more and more, while 'Kushu' was heard less and less. No one had given an order. The people of the house simply kept calling the new name, and the old one slowly fell silent.

For the first time Shailaja wondered—which had fallen silent, the name or she herself?

When Anshu returned that evening, he had no book in his hand, only a small sheet of paper.

'Did everyone tell the story of their name today?' Raghav asked.

'Some did.'

'And you?'

'I'll tell mine tomorrow.'

Shailaja looked at the paper. 'What have you written on that?'

Anshu put the paper on the table. There were two lines. On the first: 'Kush.' On the second: 'Anshu.'

A slight tightness came into Shailaja's chest.

'What were you doing?'

'Writing both names to see them.'

'Why?'

'To see how the letters look.'

'Do you like Kush?'

Anshu thought for a moment. 'It feels different.'

'And Anshu?'

'That one is familiar.'

Shailaja said nothing.

Anshu folded the paper and put it in his pocket. Then, in an easy voice, he asked, 'Ma, did you call me Kush at first?'

Shailaja started. 'Who told you?'

'Babuji.'

Raghav called from inside, 'I only told him about the first night.'

Anshu came and sat close to his mother. 'Do you remember?'

'I do.'

'Did I hear you then?'

'Yes. You turned your head and looked at me.'

'And when you called me Anshu?'

Shailaja smiled. 'Not at first. It took you a little time to learn that name.'

Anshu smiled too. 'So I had to learn two names.'

'Yes. You must have heard both.'

'You forgot one of them.'

The sentence was spoken like a joke, but Shailaja could not laugh.

The next day at school, Vibha Jha asked Anshu to stand and tell the story of his name. Anshu looked around the class. Some children had already given their answers.

He said, 'My name is Anshu. This name was given to me by my mother and father.'

Vibha Jha waited.

Anshu added, 'At the time of my birth, I was called Kush.'

A child at the back asked, 'Which name do you like?'

A little laughter rose in the classroom. Vibha Jha was about to quiet them, but Anshu answered for himself.

'It isn't a question of which one I like. Both say something about me.'

'So will they call you Kush at home?' another child asked.

Anshu thought for a moment. 'I'll leave that to the people at home. Hearing a name doesn't make me change homes.'

Vibha Jha looked at his book. 'Have you written the story of your name?'

'Only half of it so far.'

'Why have you left it half written?'

'The rest is still happening at home.'

The class laughed again, and this time Anshu laughed too.

That evening Shailaja was gathering clothes in the courtyard. Grandmother was placing a lamp beside the tulsi altar. Anshu sat on the veranda working out mathematics problems. Raghav had gone to the market.

As Shailaja carried a pile of clothes inside, the pages of Anshu's book fluttered in the wind. She reached out and held one page down. At the top was written: 'The Story of My Name.'

She did not read it. She only placed a small brass bowl on the page so the wind would not lift it again.

Anshu came out from inside and asked, 'Did you read it?'

'No. You haven't told me to yet.'

‘Then why not?’

‘I’ll read what you have written when you give it to me.’

Anshu looked at her for a few moments.

‘Ma.’

‘Yes?’

‘Knowing the name Kush didn’t make the name you gave me any smaller.’

Shailaja kept folding the clothes. ‘I know.’

Anshu smiled. ‘You didn’t know that yesterday.’

Shailaja smiled a little too. ‘Yesterday there were some things I didn’t know either.’

That night Raghav brought curd from the market. At dinner, Grandmother went around placing a bowl beside each plate. Shailaja spooned out curd in the kitchen, filled one bowl and said without thinking—

‘Put less sugar in Kush’s bowl. He likes his curd sour.’

Her hand stopped.

Grandmother looked at her. So did Raghav.

Anshu raised his head from his plate.

Shailaja corrected nothing. She placed the bowl in front of him.

Anshu stirred the curd with his spoon, looked once at his mother’s face and said—

‘Yes, that much sugar is just right.’

After that, the meal went on again.

That night, for the first time in the house, the name ‘Kush’ sounded not like the address of a place left behind, but like an ordinary call meant for a bowl of curd.

STORY 170

The Evening Lesson

As the sun went down, the shadow of the guava tree stretched long across the earth of the courtyard. At the edge of that shadow, Nayan sat with his notebook spread open. In front of him, his grandmother, Saryu Devi, was sorting two handfuls of paddy—full grains to one side, hollow ones to the other.

On the first page of his notebook Nayan wrote, “An Old Story from Our Village.”

Grandmother looked up and asked, “How old is an old story?”

“Master Sahib said we should listen to some elderly person at home and write one down. I have to submit it at school tomorrow.”

“An elderly person?” Grandmother raised an eyebrow. “Will you write that I am old, or will you write the story?”

Nayan burst out laughing. “The story. You just tell it.”

“Just?”

Grandmother stopped sorting the grain. “Is a story only told?”

Nayan’s pen hung suspended in mid-air.

Saryu Devi blew the empty grains aside. “Your great-grandmother used to tell a story called ‘The Bird Searching for Shade’. Will you hear it?”

Nayan nodded at once.

Grandmother began. It was the story of a little bird that, on a Jeth afternoon, went from tree to tree through the village searching for shade. One tree told it of its worry about saving its fruit, another about a broken branch, another about falling leaves. At last a small young sapling could not give it shade, but bent its one green leaf over the bird’s head. The bird sat there. The rains came, the sapling grew, and the next Jeth the bird returned with its young.

Nayan kept writing rapidly. Grandmother repeated one line again and again—“Shade is found not by growing large, but by bending down.”

The third time, Nayan said irritably, “Grandmother, I have written that line already. There is no need to keep saying it.”

Grandmother smiled. “If a line does not return in a story, how will the listener find the path?”

“In a written story, the reader can read it again.”

“You are the one writing it, so the rules are yours?”

Nayan did not answer.

The story ended. He turned the notebook towards Grandmother. “Look—three pages.”

Grandmother looked at the pages. To her, the letters were like countless footprints along a field embankment—whose they were and which way they had gone was hard to tell.

She asked softly, "What have you written here?"

Nayan read the first line.

Grandmother placed a finger on the second line. "And here?"

That was read aloud too.

Grandmother placed her finger on the third line.

Nayan laughed. "If you ask about every line like this, I might as well read the whole thing myself."

Grandmother's finger stayed still on the page. "You are writing my story. Am I not even to know what you have written?"

Nayan's laughter stopped.

After a few moments Grandmother rose and went inside. She returned with a slate and a piece of chalk that had been kept on top of an old trunk. One corner of the slate was broken. Nayan recognised it at once—it was the same slate on which he had written his first letter when he was five.

Grandmother placed the slate before him. "From today, every evening: half an hour for your lesson, half an hour for my story."

"You will learn to read?"

"First I will learn to recognise, on your written page, the words I myself have spoken. That much to begin with."

Excitement came over Nayan's face. "We will start with a, aa, i."

"No," Grandmother said. "First write 'inar'."

"Why 'inar'?"

"There was a well in the story."

Nayan started. "There was?"

"The bird first sat on the parapet of the well. There was a cat there, so it flew away. Did you write that?"

Nayan flipped through his notebook. The scene was not there.

"It was getting too long, so I cut it," he said.

Grandmother put the chalk in his hand. "Then the first lesson will begin with 'inar'. With what you cut."

Nayan wrote in large letters on the slate—"inar."

Grandmother studied the shapes of the letters. Nayan placed his finger on the first sound, then the next, then the last. Grandmother pronounced the word three times. The fourth time she did not look at the slate.

"I-nar."

"Good. Now the next letter."

"Now the story."

That was how the evening lessons began.

On the second day the word was “chhanh”—shade. On the third, “paat”—leaf. On the fourth, “baat”—path. Nayan did not follow the sequence used at school; Grandmother chose words from the story. Sometimes a word contained a vowel sign Nayan had not planned to teach yet. Then he had to change the order.

In return, Grandmother told stories, but Nayan was no longer allowed simply to write. First he had to repeat aloud, in his own words, what he had heard.

“The bird went to the peepal tree,” Nayan said one evening.

Grandmother stopped him at once. “Not peepal. Pakar.”

“They are both trees.”

“You and I are both human beings. If someone changes our names, do we become the same person?”

Nayan crossed out “peepal” in his notebook and wrote “pakar.”

Another evening he said, “The sapling gave the bird its leaf.”

Grandmother shook her head. “It did not give away its leaf. It bent the leaf down. If it had plucked off the leaf and given it away, what would the sapling have had left?”

Nayan corrected it again.

Slowly he began to understand that Grandmother’s story was not merely a chain of events. How many times a word returned, where the breath paused, where the voice softened—these too were part of the body of the story.

A week later Nayan brought home a printed sheet from school. The teacher had said that every student was to rewrite the story they had collected in a fair hand and submit it. Selected stories would appear in the school’s annual booklet.

Nayan was excited. After dinner that night, he sat down to rewrite his three-page story. He had little time. Some dialect words seemed to him “too rustic.” He thought of replacing “inar” with a more familiar word, then his eyes fell on Grandmother’s slate. “Inar” was still half-erased upon it. His hand stopped.

But he did not stop everywhere. He reduced the repetitions. The separate answers of the pakar, banyan and guava trees he compressed into a single line. The little episode at the well disappeared again. The written story seemed tighter to him.

The next evening Grandmother sat down with the slate. By then she could recognise ten or fifteen words. Nayan placed the newly written pages before her.

Grandmother tried to read the first line slowly. Joining the letters was difficult. Nayan helped her along.

Then Grandmother stopped at one place.

“Where is the inar?”

Nayan looked at the page. “I did not write it this time.”

“Why, child?”

“The story was getting too long.”

Grandmother settled the slate in her lap. “You taught me to read ‘inar’, but you removed the inar from your own writing.”

Nayan could say nothing.

“You think the story has become shorter?” Grandmother asked.

“Yes. It was long.”

“To me, the path has become shorter. Those are not the same thing.”

Nayan kept his eyes on the page.

Grandmother went on, “Why did the bird sit on the well?”

“For water.”

“No. It was tired. It saw the water later. It saw the cat first. If that is not there, where does its fear come from? And without fear, what value does the small sapling’s bent leaf have?”

Nayan understood gradually. He had thought of the well scene as only an extra incident; Grandmother understood it as part of the inner measure of the story.

He pulled a fresh sheet towards him. “I will write it again.”

“Not today,” Grandmother said. “Tell it first.”

Nayan began telling the whole story without looking at the notebook. He faltered twice. Once he forgot the order of the trees. Grandmother did not supply the answer at once. She waited. Nayan remembered it himself.

When he reached the last line, he said, “Shade is found not by growing large, but by bending down.”

Grandmother smiled. “Now write.”

Nayan wrote late into the night.

Three days later, the teacher looked through his pages at school. With a red pen she marked a few spellings, but after reading the story she asked, “Have you deliberately kept the repetition of this line?”

Nayan said, “Yes. When you listen to it, this line shows the way.”

The teacher looked at him. “Who told you that?”

Nayan replied, “Grandmother. But now I understand it too.”

Whether the story had been chosen for the annual booklet would be known a week later. Nayan did not tell Grandmother about that when he reached home. He had another task first.

That evening he wrote on the slate—“Saryu.”

Grandmother worked at joining the letters. She recognised the first sound, and the next as well. She stumbled over the final vowel sign. Nayan explained it. After a few tries Grandmother read the whole word.

“Saryu.”

“Who is that?” Nayan asked, laughing.

Grandmother laughed too. “Some old person.”

They both burst out laughing together.

Then Grandmother took the chalk. Her hand trembled a little. She tried to write Nayan's name on the slate. The first letter came out crooked. In the second, the vowel sign turned the wrong way.

Nayan reached out to correct it, then stopped.

Grandmother saw the mistake herself. She rubbed out the vowel sign with her finger and wrote it again.

"Nayan."

The word was not neat, but it could be read.

Nayan looked at the slate for a few moments. "Now the story?"

Grandmother said, "Today it is your turn. Tell me what happened at school yesterday as if it were a story."

"That is not a story. It is something that happened during the day."

"Stories are made from things that happen during the day. Where did it begin?"

Nayan thought. "When Master Sahib picked up the red pen."

"No," Grandmother said. "Before that."

Nayan thought again. His eyes went to the corner of the slate where dust from old chalk had gathered.

"When I had cut out the inar?"

Grandmother said nothing. She only turned the slate towards him.

On it were two names, written in crooked, uneven letters—"Saryu" and "Nayan."

Nayan opened his notebook. Before writing the first line, he looked at Grandmother.

"Tell me, where should I begin?"

Grandmother pulled the winnowing tray of paddy towards herself. The evening light was fading now. "From where you began to listen," she said.

STORY 171

The Border Fair

As evening fell, the fair at Janakpur grew even denser. Lights came on along the temporary bamboo arches; from the shop awnings came the clinking of bells, glass bangles and clay toys. Streams of people flowed from one side to the other. A little apart from the crowd, behind the bamboo basket of a flower seller, a small girl sat crouched with both hands clasped tightly around her knees, her eyes fixed on the path.

Manju Devi noticed her first. She had come to the fair with her husband Devesh and their daughter Gauri. Gauri had stopped to look at bangles when Manju's eyes fell on the child. She did not look more than five or seven years old. One of her plaits had come loose, but she was not crying.

Manju went closer and asked, 'Who is with you?'

The girl looked at Manju, then towards the crowd. 'Mother.'

'Where has your mother gone?'

'She was right here.'

Devesh came over too. 'What is your name?'

'Rani,' she whispered.

'Your father's name?'

Rani thought for a moment and said, 'Babu.'

Gauri almost laughed, but stopped when she saw her mother's look. Manju asked again, 'What is the name of your village?'

Rani frowned. 'The name of my house?'

'Yes, where you live.'

Rani pointed south. 'That way.'

Devesh looked all around through the crowd. Near one of the arches was an announcement booth where the names of separated children, found bags and missing people were being called out again and again. He said, 'We'll take you there.'

Rani immediately shook her head. 'No. Mother told me—if you get separated, don't run. Stand where you realise I'm not there.'

Manju asked, 'Did you get separated here?'

'No.' Rani's voice grew softer. 'There were many people over there. I was holding Mother's aanchal. Then the aanchal changed.'

Manju understood. The girl must have caught hold of another woman's aanchal and walked some distance before realising it. Now she was following

her mother's instruction by staying put—but this was not the place where her mother would be looking for her.

Devesh went to the announcement booth and gave Rani's name, age and the colour of her clothes. The reply was that no one had yet come looking for a child of that name.

Meanwhile Gauri had sat down on the ground beside Rani. 'Are there trees at your house?'

Rani looked at her. 'Yes.'

'What trees?'

'Three neem trees together.'

'Three?'

'Two big ones, one small.'

Manju returned. 'Did Mother tell you how you would go home from the fair?'

This time Rani answered without thinking. 'First the long road. Then Jatahi. Then water. Then Babu says—from here, India.'

Devesh and Manju looked at one another.

'India?'

Rani nodded. 'My home is in India. Mama's house is in Jatahi.'

That much information gave them a direction, not a house. They could head towards the Jatahi-Pipraun crossing, but on the Indian side Rani could not say which hamlet or which house was hers.

Manju decided to leave her own name and where she would be staying at the announcement booth, then take Rani to sit somewhere quieter. Gauri would keep hold of Rani's hand. Devesh would tell the fair organisers to inform them if Rani's family arrived.

They moved towards the open courtyard behind the temple, where the crowd was thinner. On the way Rani kept looking back. Manju did not try to buy her anything. She only said, 'Mother must be searching for you. We are here.'

At one side of the courtyard a family sat on a sheet spread on the ground. A small child slept in the man's lap, the woman was taking puris out of a metal box, and a boy of about ten held a bottle of water. Hearing their speech, Manju stopped. It was Maithili, but certain words and pronunciations sounded as though they were from the Indian side.

Devesh asked, 'Where are you all from?'

The man replied, 'From near Harlakhi. We came through the Pipraun crossing.'

Rani suddenly looked at him. 'Pipraun.'

Manju bent down and asked, 'Is your house in Pipraun?'

Rani nodded, then stopped herself at once. 'Beyond Pipraun. Babu says Pipraun. Mother says—near Rajghat.'

The woman of the other family, Savita, came and sat beside Rani. 'Near the Jamuni?'

Rani's eyes lit up. 'Yes. Across the water.'

Savita's husband Ramesh said, 'There are many houses around Rajghat. Your name?'

'Rani,' the child replied.

'Your father's?'

Rani smiled again. 'Babu.'

This time everyone laughed a little, Rani too. The first tightness in her face loosened.

Savita's son Abhay asked, 'What does your Babu do?'

'He takes milk out in the morning.'

'To whose house?'

'Many houses.'

'How many cows?'

Rani counted on her fingers. 'Two. There were three before. The black cow died.'

Ramesh said, 'There is no shortage of milkmen with two cows.'

Abhay asked again, 'What is near your house?'

'Three neem trees.'

'And?' Abhay asked.

Rani fell silent.

Gauri leaned towards her. 'What do you see just before you reach your house?'

Rani thought for a while at that question. 'A red wall. After that the road splits in two. Mother goes left. Babu goes right on his bicycle and then turns back.'

Ramesh scratched his head. 'There must be fifty red walls.'

'What is on the wall?' Abhay asked.

Rani narrowed her eyes as though trying to see it. 'White flowers are painted on it. No one lives inside.'

Savita said, 'The old rice mill?'

Ramesh turned to her. 'The closed godown west of Rajghat?'

'Its wall is red, and there are white round marks on it too.'

Rani did not understand the word 'godown', but she shaped a square with her hands. 'A big house. The door stays shut.'

The route was clearer now. Ramesh's family had planned to return to India before the fair ended. Manju and Devesh did not think it right to send Rani only with them. The fair organisers were told that both families were taking Rani towards Pipraun-Rajghat; Devesh's name and the place where they were staying in Janakpur were written down. If Rani's mother reached the booth, she would be told where they had gone.

Rani was asked, 'Will you come?'

She looked first at Gauri's hand, then at Abhay's. 'What if Mother isn't there?'

Manju said, 'Then we'll search again. But you won't be alone.'

Rani stood up.

The two families sat together in a vehicle going towards Jatahi. Rani sat between Gauri and Abhay. No one crowded her with questions on the way. Sometimes she looked out of the window; sometimes she closed her eyes.

By the time they reached Jatahi, the sky had turned deep blue. The shop lights were on. People were still moving towards and away from the border. Rani peered out of the window, started slightly, then checked herself and said, 'I drank juice here with Mama.'

Devesh smiled. 'So you recognise the road.'

'A little.'

Rani went quiet while they crossed the checkpoint. Lines of light trembled on the dark water of the Jamuni. As soon as they came off the bridge, she leaned forward.

'This water.'

Ramesh said, 'Now look for the red wall.'

Near Rajghat they left the main road and began moving slowly. A little farther on they found an old closed building—a red wall on which round patches of white lime were still visible.

Rani rose from her seat. 'Here!'

'Left or right?' Savita asked.

Rani tried to put her hand out of the window. Manju gently drew it back inside. 'Say it with your mouth.'

'Left.'

They got out of the vehicle and walked. The path split in two. Rani stopped once. In the evening darkness, both sides looked much the same—huts, bamboo and trees.

Abhay said, 'There's no hurry. Think.'

Rani looked down at the earth. Then she listened. From far away came the faint tinkling of a bell.

'Babu's cow.'

Everyone fell silent. The bell sounded again. Rani began to run to the right, but after two steps stopped herself. Her mother's words came back to her—don't run. She turned and caught Gauri's hand.

'This way.'

A little farther on they saw three neem trees—two large ones, with a smaller one between them. A strip of old blue cloth was tied around the trunk of the small tree. Rani's steps quickened.

The courtyard gate stood open. Inside, a woman was coming out barefoot. Her aanchal had slipped from her shoulder and hung halfway down her waist. She saw Rani first, then all the people behind her. For a moment she seemed unable to understand what she was seeing.

'Mother!' Rani cried and ran. This time no one stopped her.

The woman caught her and sank to her knees. She was crying, but no sound came from her. A few moments later a man came running from inside. In his hand was a bell he had removed from a bicycle. One of the two cows in the courtyard shook the bell at its neck.

With her face buried against her mother, Rani said, 'I didn't run.'

Her mother kissed her head. 'I know.'

The story slowly became clear. In the crowd Rani had caught another woman's aanchal and gone ahead. Her mother had searched first at the place where they had separated, then at the announcement booth, then around the outer part of the temple. There she had learned that the child had left with two families towards Pipraun. Rani's father had been just preparing to go towards the border.

Manju and Savita looked at one another. Dust from the fair and the road clung to both their clothes. Devesh and Ramesh stood at the edge of the veranda as though their work was now done.

Rani's mother urged everyone to come inside and sit. Ramesh said, 'It's getting late.'

Manju too was thinking about the journey back when Rani lifted her head from her mother's lap and said, 'Gauri and Abhay won't leave without eating.'

Her mother smiled for the first time. 'So you have learnt all their names too?'

Rani caught Gauri's hand and held out her other hand towards Abhay. 'She is from Nepal. He is from India.'

Abhay laughed. 'And you?'

Rani thought for a moment. Then, holding her mother's aanchal, she said, 'I am from here.'

A little later chura and curd were set out on the veranda. The adults kept talking about the road, the fair and the search. The three children sat near the small neem tree in the courtyard. Gauri asked, 'This little neem?'

Rani said proudly, 'This one is mine. Babu planted it when I was born.'

Abhay reached out to touch the blue cloth tied around the trunk. Rani stopped him. 'No, leave it there.'

'Why?' Abhay asked.

'So the way can be recognised.'

Abhay drew his hand back.

The night was growing deeper. On the road outside the courtyard, towards the border, the voices of travellers had thinned. The leaves of the three neem

trees rustled in the light breeze. The blue cloth tied to the small tree remained clearly visible in the darkness.

STORY 172

The Neem's Shade

The morning sunlight was still caught in the upper leaves of the neem tree in the courtyard. The shade below was cool and round, as though the night had left a piece of itself there. At about this hour Jamuna Kaki would usually lift the latch of the gate and come in. First she would lean the broom against the wall, then, with both hands, lift the little stool kept beneath the neem and move it a little farther inside the edge of the sunlight.

That morning the stool remained in its old place.

Savita looked towards the courtyard twice from the kitchen. The third time, she looked at the clock.

"Jamuna Kaki hasn't come today?"

Sudhanshu, sitting on the veranda with the newspaper open, said, "She must be a little late."

Kamala Devi rested her chin on the knob of her walking stick and kept looking towards the neem. "When is she ever late?"

After eight o'clock, Muniya from the neighbourhood came. She was Jamuna Kaki's granddaughter. She had a prescription in her hand.

"Kaki has had a fever since last night," she said. "The doctor has told her to rest for ten days."

Savita asked at once, "Very high?"

"It was high at night. It has come down a little now."

Kamala Devi made as if to rise. "I will go and see her."

Muniya stopped her. "She is asleep now. She said—tell them at the house, and tell them not to worry."

Sudhanshu folded the newspaper. "All right. Let her rest first. We'll divide the work here among ourselves."

The sentence was simple. There were four capable people in the house: Savita, Sudhanshu, their daughter Ira, their son Neel, and Kamala Devi, who still did much of her own work. Jamuna Kaki came for two hours in the morning and one in the evening—to sweep the courtyard, help with the dishes, sort the vegetables, hang out the clothes, put Kamala Devi's room in order, and do whatever little task happened to catch her eye.

Savita ruled a sheet of paper into three sections—morning, afternoon, evening.

"Neel, the courtyard is yours."

Neel pulled a face. "I have exams."

Ira said, "Will sweeping make your lessons fly out of your head?"

"You do the dishes."

"I will. But you'll hang out the clothes."

Sudhanshu laughed. "Less quarrelling, more work."

On the first day the house really did run. The courtyard was swept, the dishes washed, the clothes hung out, the vegetables cut. In the evening Savita put a small tick beside every line on the sheet.

"See?" Sudhanshu said. "The arrangement works."

Kamala Devi said nothing. She looked at the stool beneath the neem.

At midday on the second day Kamala Devi left half her meal uneaten.

Savita asked, "Is the dal not good?"

"The dal is fine."

"Then why aren't you eating?"

Kamala Devi drew her hand away from the plate. "I'm not hungry."

Savita thought it might be age. But in the evening she noticed that Kamala Devi was not sitting on the stool beneath the neem. She was lying on the cot on the veranda.

"Won't you go outside?"

"The stool is in the sun."

Savita looked into the courtyard. The stool was indeed still in the sunlight.

"I'll move it a little."

She lifted the stool and placed it under the neem. Kamala Devi came outside, but two minutes later went back in again.

Savita followed her. "What happened?"

Kamala Devi gave a short answer. "Nothing."

On the third day Ira came back from college and went straight to her room. Usually she would fling her bag onto the veranda and drink water first. That day she shut the door from inside.

Savita called to her twice. The answer was brief—"Nothing has happened."

At dinner Ira sat with her plate in front of her, but she was not eating.

Neel asked, "Did the result come again?"

Ira glared at him. "Do you have to interfere in everything?"

Neel fell silent.

Sudhanshu said, "That is no way to speak."

Ira pushed her plate away and got up.

For a few moments a kind of silence filled the house that had no line on Savita's list of chores.

That night Savita went to Ira's room. After a long while Ira said that her name had been removed from the final list for the college debate competition. No one had given her a clear reason. She was angry, but more than angry she was embarrassed—she had told everyone at home that her selection was almost certain.

Savita stroked her head. "Why didn't you tell me earlier?"

Ira was quiet for a while. Then she said, "If Jamuna Kaki had been here, I would have told her first."

Savita's hand stopped.

"Why her?"

"She doesn't ask questions first." Ira looked towards the pillow as she spoke.

"She just sits there sorting vegetables. I begin talking on my own."

Savita said nothing to that.

On the fourth day Neel returned from school and went straight beneath the neem. The stool was empty. He took off his bag and set it there, then pulled out a small paper. His marks in mathematics had fallen. He folded the paper and put it back in his pocket.

Kamala Devi was watching from the veranda.

"How much did you get?"

Neel started. "How did you know?"

"It is written on your face."

Neel tried to smile. "If Jamuna Kaki were here, she would say—eat some jaggery first, then show me the marks."

Kamala Devi smiled. "Do you show her all your papers?"

Avoiding her eyes, Neel said, "Not all."

Kamala Devi asked, "Then which ones?"

"The ones with low marks."

Kamala Devi laughed. "Why?"

Neel looked at the neem leaves. "She says—show the paper with low marks first; the one with high marks will go around showing itself."

Kamala Devi burst out laughing. When the laughter ended, her eyes looked a little moist.

That evening, when Sudhanshu returned from the office, he saw that every line on Savita's list had been ticked. Yet something inside the house still seemed unsettled. Nothing belonging to anyone was strewn about, no task had been left undone, but everyone was spending longer in their own rooms.

After dinner Kamala Devi said, "Tomorrow we will go and see Jamuna."

Sudhanshu agreed at once.

The next afternoon not everyone went, only Kamala Devi and Sudhanshu. Jamuna Kaki's house was two lanes away. A small courtyard, an earthen edge, a tulsi altar. Jamuna Kaki was half sitting up on the cot. Her face looked drawn, but the brightness in her eyes was the same as before.

"Why is everyone getting so worried?" she said as soon as she saw Sudhanshu. "I'll be back in ten days."

Kamala Devi sat beside the cot. "Without you I even forgot the time of the neem's shade."

Jamuna Kaki laughed. "Does the shade move when I tell it to?"

“Not the shade. The stool.”

“The stool has to be shown the sun.”

Sudhanshu paid attention to that little sentence. The neem had stood in that courtyard since his childhood. It had never occurred to him that the stool was moved twice a day.

Jamuna Kaki asked, “Did Ira go to the competition?”

Sudhanshu started. “No. Her name was dropped.”

Jamuna Kaki’s eyes narrowed a little. “She must have taken it very much to heart.”

Surprised, Sudhanshu asked, “How did you know?”

“Three days ago she was saying—if my name is dropped, I won’t tell anyone at home.”

Sudhanshu was silent.

“And Neel’s mathematics?” Jamuna asked again.

“His marks were low.”

“Did you give him jaggery?”

This time Sudhanshu laughed. “You know about that too?”

Jamuna Kaki closed her eyes. “If you live in a house, you hear the sounds of the house.”

Kamala Devi straightened the sheet near her feet. For a few moments all three were silent. Outside, a crow landed on the tulsi altar and flew away again.

On the way back Sudhanshu spoke very little. When he reached home, he looked at the chore list Savita had made. Courtyard, dishes, clothes, vegetables, room—everything was written there. He placed his pen on the blank space at the bottom of the sheet, but could not write anything.

Jamuna Kaki came on the morning of the twelfth day. She had no broom in her hand; Muniya had only come to drop her off. She still looked weak.

“No work today,” Savita said at the gate itself.

“Then why did you call me?”

“I didn’t call you. You came on your own.”

“Sitting at home was making my body ache even more.”

From inside, Kamala Devi called out, “First move the stool.”

Jamuna Kaki looked towards the neem. The stool, surprisingly, was exactly in the shade.

She looked at Savita.

Savita smiled. “I’m beginning to understand the time a little too.”

Jamuna Kaki sat down. Neel came from inside carrying the tin of jaggery. Ira brought two cups of tea. Sudhanshu came onto the veranda with an envelope in his hand.

“Your wages for the month,” he said.

Weighing the envelope in her hand, Jamuna Kaki asked, “Why so much? I did no work for twelve days.”

Before answering, Sudhanshu looked at Savita. Then he said, "Whatever was written in the ledger of chores, we managed all of that ourselves."

Jamuna Kaki waited.

After a pause Sudhanshu added, "We have no account of what was not written down."

Jamuna Kaki did not open the envelope. She tucked it into the corner of her sari.

"Then now one thing from me," she said. "My coming back does not mean Neel will give up the broom."

Neel protested, "That is unfair."

Ira laughed. "Think of it as punishment for low marks."

"And you will not stop doing the dishes either," Jamuna Kaki said, raising a finger towards Ira.

Kamala Devi said, "She is right. Let the work stay divided."

Jamuna Kaki looked at her in surprise.

"Then what is my work?"

Kamala Devi patted the place beside her in the neem's shade. "First sit here. We'll see about the rest slowly."

Jamuna Kaki moved the stool a little closer to her.

The broom remained leaning against the courtyard wall. Steam kept rising from the tea. The neem's shade shifted slowly, but this time no one was in a hurry to move the stool.

STORY 173

The Paper Boat

The rain had begun before noon. First came scattered drops, then an even drumming on thatch and tin. The white cord stretched across the courtyard of the old house had grown heavy with rain and sagged low enough to touch the earth here and there. Naresh stood on one side of it, Sudha on the other. Barely twenty cubits lay between them, yet they spoke as though the distance were one of years.

‘The three rooms north of this line are mine,’ Naresh said. ‘The two rooms to the south and the veranda are yours. We’ll make the passage to the back along the eastern side.’

Sudha looked not at the wet cord but at the old tulsi altar. ‘The eastern passage is less than four cubits wide. How will the trunk ever reach Mother’s room?’

‘How many more times is the trunk going to be moved now?’

‘Even if the trunk doesn’t move, people still have to.’

Naresh’s wife, Meena, set down the tea on the veranda and quietly went inside. In the last three months the question of dividing the house had arisen so often that everyone in the household could guess the end of a sentence as soon as it began. Their father had died five years earlier. Their mother the previous winter. At first Sudha had come every week; then one day it was the key to the cupboard, another day the garden at the back, a third day the rights over Mother’s room—little by little the discussion had moved from possessions to shares.

Naresh had remained in the house. Roof repairs, Mother’s medicines, the care of the fields—he remembered every account. Sudha had moved to Darbhanga after marriage, but she too had stayed for months at a time to look after their mother. She did not like hearing an account of her absences. Naresh could not bear to see the value of his presence diminished.

That day the village surveyor had come to measure the property. Halfway through the work he had been stranded at the square by the rain. Before leaving he had said, ‘If the rain stops, I’ll come back in the evening and finish marking the line.’

Instead of stopping, the rain grew heavier.

From the north-west corner of the courtyard, water began to run in a thin stream. It followed a depression in the joints of the old bricks, cut across the middle of the courtyard and headed towards the drain in the south-east corner.

The white cord lay diagonally across that stream. As the water touched it, the cord turned muddy.

Sudha said, 'If this drain is blocked, where will the water go?'

Naresh answered at once, 'The drain falls in my share. I'll keep it.'

'Will the water fall only from the roof over your share?'

Naresh fell silent. The sheet of water running off the northern tin roof, the drops falling from the southern tiles and the water spilling from the mouth of the veranda all gathered in that same depression.

'When the wall goes up, we'll leave a pipe underneath,' he said after a moment.

'And when the pipe gets blocked?'

'We'll clean it.'

'Who?'

That small question began to open the old quarrel again. Naresh wanted to say: whoever lives here. Sudha wanted to say: a house does not belong only to the one who lives in it. But neither spoke yet.

The flow of water strengthened. An old brick in the middle of the courtyard loosened and began to rock. Sudha lifted the edge of her sari slightly and put her foot on it. As the brick sank under her weight, bubbles rose from beneath.

She bent down at once and looked at the brick.

'Is this place still so low?'

Naresh heard the changed note in her voice. 'What?'

'Wasn't this where we used to build the bridge?'

Naresh's eyes settled on the little stream.

Until a few moments ago there had been only a dividing line in the courtyard. Now, from beneath that line, another courtyard began to rise into view—smaller, muddy, belonging to rainy days.

They had been children then. Their father would give them pages from old almanacs. Sudha was quick at folding boats; Naresh was better at sharpening the prow. Water falling from the roof collected in the northern corner, made a narrow stream and ran through this depression towards the drain. Each of them would launch a boat. Whoever's boat reached the mouth of the drain first won.

But there had been a problem in the middle. When Mother went from the kitchen to the cowshed, her feet got wet crossing the stream. One day, exasperated, she had said, 'There's a road for your boats, but none for my feet.'

The next day Naresh had brought two bricks. Sudha had dragged over a flat stone from the corner of the veranda. Together they set the stone on the bricks and made a little bridge—high enough for a paper boat to pass underneath, low enough for Mother to cross easily on foot.

The first time, Sudha's boat got stuck under the stone. Instead of claiming victory, Naresh lay flat on his stomach and pushed her boat through with one

finger. That day they made a rule: if one boat got stuck under the bridge, the other person would free it; no victory would count over a stranded boat.

Sudha laughed softly. 'You cheated too. While pushing my boat along, you used to send yours farther ahead.'

For the first time a smile appeared on Naresh's face. 'You used to make your boats so wide that somehow the bridge became guilty?'

'You built the bridge.'

'You brought the stone.'

For a few moments they laughed together in the rain. Meena watched from the veranda, but did not come outside.

Sudha bent down again. Beside the loose brick, the tops of two old bricks really were visible, parallel to one another. The stone above them was gone; it must have been removed during some repair long ago. But through the narrow gap between the bricks, the water still ran faster than elsewhere.

'Mother used to cross on this bridge,' Sudha said.

Naresh nodded. 'Later Father wanted to put cement over this place. Mother said, "Leave it. It's the children's bridge."'

'I had forgotten that.'

'So had I, until now.'

They fell silent again. Memory had not ended the quarrel. Naresh had borne more of the expense of Mother's medicines; that did not make Sudha's share smaller. Sudha had lived away after marriage; that did not end her belonging to the house. All the old accounts remained exactly where they were. Only now, among them, a small bridge had returned as well.

Naresh lifted the white cord. The rainwater wet his fingers. 'If the wall goes up here, the mouth of the drain will fall inside.'

Sudha said, 'And my passage to the back will be through that narrow lane on the east.'

'Yes. There.'

'Both problems are being created by the same line.'

Naresh began untying the knot in the cord. 'Shall we shift the line four cubits north?'

Sudha ran her eyes across the courtyard as though measuring it. 'Then your veranda will become smaller.'

'It will.'

'I don't need that much extra.'

'Then what do we do?'

Sudha looked at both sides of the stream. 'Leave five cubits in the middle as common space. The drain too, and the passage to the back. The walls can rise separately on either side.'

Naresh did not agree at once. 'A common space will only become another cause of quarrel.'

‘Separate spaces are already doing that.’

This time Naresh did not laugh, but his face was no longer hard either. He fetched the measuring rod kept beside the veranda. He measured five cubits. Then six. Then four.

‘A bullock cart won’t pass through five,’ he said.

‘Who brings a bullock cart here now?’

‘What if the house needs repairs someday?’

Sudha thought for a moment. ‘Six cubits.’

‘With six, the wall will come a little inward in front of my northern room.’

‘I’ll leave one cubit from the southern corner.’

Naresh looked at her. ‘The accounts even?’

‘Let the surveyor settle the account of the land. We’ll settle the account of the path ourselves.’

The rain was weakening now. The stream in the drain had thinned, but had not stopped. Naresh tied the cord again—this time not across the middle of the courtyard, but in two short lengths marking the two edges of the common passage.

When the surveyor returned in the evening, he first looked for the old line. ‘Where has the cord gone?’

Naresh said, ‘The line has changed.’

The surveyor frowned. ‘I’ll have to measure it again.’

Sudha said, ‘Please do. Six cubits in the middle will remain a common passage and drainage way.’

‘I’ll need a written agreement.’

‘Make one,’ Naresh said. ‘But don’t show the drain as belonging to either share.’

The surveyor looked from one face to the other. He was surprised that the two people who had been holding out over half a cubit until noon were now talking of leaving six cubits between them. But he asked nothing. He began the measurements again.

That night Sudha slept in Mother’s room. Outside the window, a light rain began again. In the darkness she could hear the sound of water in the drain. She remembered the paper boats—their wet prows, the two boats bumping into each other, the little white body of one caught beneath the stone.

At dawn Naresh was in the courtyard. He sat beside the old depression with two new bricks and a flat stone. Sudha asked, ‘What are you doing?’ ‘Making a place to cross the water.’ ‘For boats or for people?’ Naresh levelled the stone on the bricks and said, ‘They need different heights. This time I’m measuring properly.’

Sudha picked up a small scrap of paper from the veranda. She did not begin making a boat. She merely folded the paper to measure the gap beneath the stone, then opened it again and handed it to Naresh.

‘Leave this much space. The water won’t stop.’ Naresh looked at the fold in the paper and moved one brick a little farther out. The courtyard was still going to be divided. The rooms would have different owners, the keys would remain separate. But a path had been left through the middle for the rainwater, and over that path stood a small bridge—beneath which a paper boat could still pass.

STORY 174

Silence

Sarojini Devi and Rita rarely quarrelled.

The family considered this a blessing.

In truth, the two of them hardly ever spoke directly to each other.

If Rita needed something, she would tell Manoj, "Ask Mother where the lentils are kept." If Sarojini Devi had something to say, she too would tell her son, "Tell Rita not to leave the wet clothes outside all night."

One courtyard, one kitchen, one veranda; yet words usually travelled by way of Manoj.

This distance had not been created in a single day. During the first month after the wedding, Sarojini Devi, watching Rita at work in the kitchen, kept saying—less salt, a little more oil, sort the rice first, keep the milk vessel separate. Rita did not answer. She kept changing the ways she had learnt in her mother's home, but somewhere inside her settled the feeling that, in this house, everything she did would first be inspected.

In Sarojini Devi's eyes, Rita was far too quiet. She felt that her daughter-in-law never said what was in her heart, only nodded. Rita felt that her mother-in-law was ready to correct her before she was ready to listen.

After that, Manoj became the road between them.

Two years after the marriage, when Rita gave birth to a daughter, for the first time there was something in the house on which both their attention rested in the same place. The baby was named Aditi. Rita saw the smile that stayed on Sarojini Devi's face whenever she looked at her granddaughter; but over Aditi's clothes, sleep, milk and bathing, their ways were once again different.

"Mother says not to oil the baby in the evening," Manoj said one day.

Without looking up, Rita replied, "Tell her the doctor said the time does not matter."

In a tired voice Manoj said, "Why don't the two of you just tell each other?"

Both remained silent.

Aditi was twenty-three days old when that night came.

The baby had been a little listless all day. Rita had noticed it, but by evening she had fed properly twice. At eight that night, the moment milk touched her mouth, she let go. Rita tried again. The baby turned her face away.

Sarojini Devi was spinning thread on the veranda. Hearing the baby's very faint cry from inside, she rose and came in.

“Where is Manoj?” Rita asked.

“He has gone to Darbhanga. He said he would be back by ten tonight.”

Having said that, Sarojini Devi placed her hand on the baby’s forehead. Her expression changed.

“Her body feels hot.”

Rita checked with her own palm. She too felt the heat, but the moment fear entered her she no longer trusted herself to judge the temperature. She took out the thermometer kept in the house. The instant she saw the number, her fingers began to tremble.

Sarojini Devi said, “Come.”

That night, for the first time, Sarojini Devi spoke directly to Rita in the language of a decision.

Rita asked, “Where?”

“The primary health centre. With a baby this small, we are not sitting at home.”

Rita immediately wrapped the baby in cloth. Sarojini Devi took some money, Aditi’s birth slip and a clean towel from the box and put them in a bag.

They called Manoj’s mobile. It rang and rang, but there was no answer.

At the turn of the lane they found a rickshaw still out at night. Sarojini Devi climbed in first, then took half the baby’s weight from Rita’s lap into her own arms so that Rita could sit properly. Neither said anything. Whenever a wheel dropped into a small pothole on the unpaved road, both their hands reached towards Aditi at the same moment.

A yellow bulb burned in the veranda of the health centre. The nurse on night duty took the baby’s temperature again, counted her breaths and carried her inside at once.

Rita stood outside the door. Sarojini Devi stood directly behind her.

After a while, the doctor said that in an infant this young, fever together with reduced feeding could be a serious sign; tests and observation were necessary. The baby was kept at the centre that night, and advice was also sought from a higher-level facility.

Rita sat on a bench. Both her palms were empty. For the first time in twenty-three days Aditi was not in her lap, and Rita felt as though her own body had become unnecessary.

Sarojini Devi took the towel from the bag and placed it in her hand.

“Will you drink some water?”

Rita shook her head.

“No, not now.”

Two minutes later Sarojini Devi asked nothing more. She got up, brought water from the earthen pot in the corner of the veranda, and set the glass beneath the bench.

Rita looked at the glass but did not reach for it.

At half past eleven the nurse came out. "Who is the mother?"

Rita stood up.

"Stay inside. If the baby wakes, try to feed her."

Sarojini Devi rose too, but stopped at the door.

Rita looked at her for a moment. Earlier she would have said to Manoj, "Mother is outside, tell her..." But Manoj was not there.

She asked her directly, "Will you stay here?"

Sarojini Devi replied, "Yes. You go."

There was no special intimacy in those few words, but Manoj's name had not come between them.

Aditi lay in a small iron cot. A bandage was tied near a vein in her hand. Rita sat by her head. The baby opened her eyes, then closed them again.

Rita said softly, "I am here."

Her voice sounded strange to her own ears.

When she came out half an hour later, Sarojini Devi was still sitting upright on the same bench. The glass of water remained full beneath it.

"Did she drink?" was her question.

Rita could not tell whether the question was about the water or the baby's milk.

"She drank a little milk."

Sarojini Devi's shoulders loosened slightly. "Good."

Rita picked up the glass and drank the water.

After midnight the veranda grew quieter. Somewhere far away a dog barked, then fell silent. The ticking of the wall clock could be heard.

Sarojini Devi suddenly asked, "When did she first drink less during the day?"

Rita said, "Around two in the afternoon. I thought she was only sleeper than usual."

"Did you tell anyone?"

"Manoj."

"He did not tell me."

Rita wanted to fall silent as before, but this time the words came out on their own.

"I could have told you."

Sarojini Devi kept looking at the clock. "Yes."

After a few moments she added, "If you had told me, whether I would have listened first or started advising first—I do not know."

For the first time Rita looked properly at her face. That sentence did not sound like Sarojini Devi. Her answers were always ready; tonight she was leaving a question directed at herself.

Rita said, "I too have got into the habit of holding everything back from the beginning."

Sarojini Devi said nothing.

Silence returned, but now it was not a wall as before. Between them lay the open space of two sentences.

At half past one Manoj called. His voice was anxious. His vehicle had broken down on the road and he was looking for another ride.

“How is Aditi?”

Rita said, “The doctors are watching her. She has taken a little milk.”

Manoj asked, “Where is Mother?”

Rita looked at Sarojini Devi.

“She is sitting beside me.”

Manoj began to say, “Tell Mother—”

Rita interrupted him. “Whatever you have to say, tell her directly. I’m giving her the phone.”

Sarojini Devi took the phone. She spoke with Manoj for two minutes, then handed it back to Rita. Neither of them felt any need to comment on this small change.

At two in the morning the nurse called again. Aditi was ready to feed. Rita went inside. This time the baby managed to drink a little more. Afterwards she held Rita’s finger and fell asleep.

When Rita came back out, her eyes were wet.

Sarojini Devi did not immediately ask, “What happened?” She merely held out one end of her shawl. Rita wiped her eyes.

“I was frightened,” Rita said quietly.

“I was frightened too.”

Rita was startled. She had never heard a sentence like “I am frightened too” from Sarojini Devi.

“You always seem certain about everything,” Rita said.

Sarojini Devi gave a faint laugh, but it stopped at once. “Just because a person does not say something does not mean it is not there.”

The sentence lingered for a while in the yellow light of the veranda.

Towards dawn Aditi’s temperature came down. The doctor said she would remain under observation, but for now her condition was more stable than before.

Rita rested her head against the wall behind the bench. Sleep would not come. Sarojini Devi’s eyes too were red.

“Close your eyes for a while,” Rita said. “And you?” “I’ll keep going in and out to check.” Sarojini Devi said, “Then half an hour. After that, you.” “All right.” Earlier such arrangements would have been settled through Manoj. Tonight no third person was needed to divide the watch.

Sarojini Devi closed her eyes at one end of the bench. Rita kept looking at her. The hair at the front of her head had gone white, something Rita had never noticed so clearly amid the daily rush of the house.

After a while Sarojini Devi slipped a little in her sleep. Her hand began to hang over the edge of the bench. Rita lifted it and placed it safely inside—just as, on the rickshaw during the night, both of them had kept steadying Aditi.

When Manoj arrived in the morning, Aditi was asleep. The doctor said she would be kept for the rest of the day. Manoj looked from one woman to the other and began firing questions all at once.

“What happened last night? Mother, did you tell Rita that—”

Sarojini Devi cut in, “I’ll tell Rita myself.”

Manoj stopped.

Rita added, “And I’ll ask her myself.”

A tired smile came over Manoj’s face. “Then my work has decreased.”

No one burst out laughing, but all three faces softened a little. Two days later Aditi returned home. The baby’s clothes were hung to dry on the veranda. From inside, Sarojini Devi called, “Rita, shall I open the window halfway or all the way?” Earlier the question would have travelled through Manoj. Holding the baby in her arms, Rita answered directly, “Halfway. The air is pleasant.” Sarojini Devi opened the window halfway. Light from outside entered the room. The things that had travelled, not for years but for many months, along the road through Manoj had now found a direct path between the two women. The distance had not vanished; an old habit does not disappear in one night. But the silence was no longer a wall. A door had opened in it, and both of them knew that its latch was not in the hands of any third person.

STORY 175

The Postcard

That day, when the subject of post came up at school, more than half the children in Class Five had never even seen a postcard.

The teacher, Madhavi Jha, took ten yellow cards from her bag and spread them across the desk.

“This is not a mobile phone,” she said with a laugh. “What you write on it will not arrive at once. But when it does arrive, your handwriting will arrive with it.”

Seated at the back, Nayan picked up a card and sniffed it.

“Why does it not smell of glue?”

The class burst out laughing.

Madhavi said, “Because there is no envelope to seal. Whatever you write, you write openly.”

About a mile and a half from the school stood the “Sahachar Old-Age Home”. The headmaster had proposed that the children write one postcard each to an elderly resident there. The teachers would assign the names beforehand, but the children were not to write any artificial sermon or dutiful message.

“Write what you truly have to say,” Madhavi told them. “Do not discharge your duty merely by writing, ‘May you remain happy.’”

The class suddenly fell silent.

The name on Nayan’s card was “Gomti Devi”.

He first wrote two lines: “Namaskar. I am Nayan. I study in Class Five.” Then his pen stopped.

Srishti, seated in front of him, had already filled half her card. Nayan leaned forward to look, but Madhavi called from a distance—

“Do not read someone else’s card. The old-age home is not an examination centre.”

Nayan looked at his card again.

Writing about home seemed easiest. Yet he could not decide what in his home was worth writing about. His father worked at a bank branch. His mother did sewing. His grandmother lived in the village. During holidays they went to the village.

All at once he wrote: “My grandmother’s name is Bhawani Devi. She does not write letters to anyone, but she remembers the names of many people from long ago. She likes less fenugreek in mango pickle. There are two lychee trees behind our house, but one is now half dry.”

Madhavi did not laugh when she read the card. She only said, "I can see your home in this. Good."

At the end Nayan wrote, "If you remember any tree, write to me about it."

Three days later, two children from the school and an attendant delivered all the cards to the old-age home. Replying was not compulsory. The headmaster had made it clear that the purpose of the programme was not to place a new task on the elderly residents, but simply to open a path of connection.

A week passed in waiting.

On the following Monday Madhavi came into the classroom carrying a bundle of cards.

"Some replies have come."

Names were called: Srishti, Raghav, Anshu, Nayan.

The handwriting on Nayan's card was in large letters. Gomti Devi had written—

"Nayan Babu, which village is your grandmother Bhawani Devi from? If she is from Pipra Purbari Tol, ask her, 'Do you still remember Gomti Didi's yellow oleander?' If she laughs, write to me again."

Nayan read it three times.

"What is yellow oleander?"

Madhavi said, "Not a tree, a flowering shrub. But this question is for your grandmother."

That evening, at Nayan's house, the postcard seemed to become a larger subject than dinner. His mother read it. His father read it. They looked at one another.

"Shall we call Grandmother?" Nayan asked.

His father said, "The card says to ask her. We can ask her now."

In the village, Grandmother used the phone at their neighbour Ramsevak's house. It rang twice before Ramsevak's son answered. Bhawani Devi came five minutes later.

Without any preamble Nayan said, "Grandmother, do you remember Gomti Didi's yellow oleander?"

There was silence at the other end for a few moments.

Then came such a laugh that even without seeing his grandmother's face, Nayan knew that Gomti Devi had written the right thing.

"Where did you find that name?" Bhawani Devi asked.

"A card came from the old-age home."

The laughter stopped.

"Which old-age home?"

His father took the phone. He told her the place and repeated Gomti Devi's name. Bhawani Devi fell silent again.

"Send me a card," she said at last.

"Shall I send a photograph?" his father asked.

"No. A card."

The next day Nayan told the whole story at school. Madhavi asked carefully

"Does your grandmother know Gomti Devi?"

"It is a very old acquaintance. But she did not explain."

"Then will Grandmother write the next card?"

Nayan nodded. "Grandmother said she would write it herself."

The problem was that Bhawani Devi did not ordinarily write herself. She could read and could sign her name, but for years she had had someone else write letters for her.

On Friday, Nayan's father went to the village. Nayan went with him. Bhawani Devi was sitting on the veranda. In front of her lay a yellow postcard and, beside it, an old pen filled with black ink.

"Will you write?" Nayan asked.

"Today we shall see how much my hand obeys me."

The first letter trembled. The second came out clear. Bhawani Devi wrote—

"Gomti, the yellow oleander bush dried up two years after you left. But I cut one branch and planted it in the back courtyard. That too did not survive for long. I never thought you were dead; I only thought your life had gone so far away that my name would not reach there."

Nayan watched silently.

Bhawani Devi paused before writing the next line.

"Only that much?" Nayan asked.

"That much first."

Then she turned the card over and wrote in small letters at the bottom: "Nayan is my grandson. Had he not written, your name would not have reached me."

Nayan asked, "Are the two of you sisters?"

Bhawani Devi looked at him.

"My mother and her mother were real sisters. But we were both raised in the same house. Her mother died very early, so she called my mother 'Ma'. Everyone in the house thought of us as sisters."

"Then why did you lose touch?"

Bhawani Devi watched neem leaves falling.

"There was no single great reason. First marriage, then living far apart, then houses changed, letters grew fewer, addresses between people were lost. After a time, years went by while we kept saying, 'Now I will write.' Sometimes relationships are lost not through quarrels, but through laziness too."

Nayan had not been prepared for this answer. To him, an old relationship breaking had always meant a quarrel.

On Monday the card went to school, and from the school to the old-age home.

Four days later, what came was not a reply from Gomti Devi but a request: if possible, could she be allowed to speak with Bhawani Devi?

Madhavi made the school's rules clear.

"The children's programme will not make private decisions for families. Nayan's family and the manager of the old-age home will speak first."

His father agreed. Gomti Devi had a nephew who lived in Darbhanga and visited her regularly. Gomti Devi herself had chosen to live in the old-age home; her nephew's flat was on the third floor, the stairs were difficult for her, and the house remained empty all day. Hearing this, Bhawani Devi was silent for a long time.

"I had thought—she must have no one."

Over the phone Gomti Devi laughed. "You still have that old illness of yours—you make up the story first and ask questions later."

Bhawani Devi replied, "And you have your old illness—changing your address and telling no one."

Between their laughter, Nayan understood for the first time that the old affection of elderly people could also be filled with teasing, just like children's friendships.

Two weeks later, the school fixed a day to visit the old-age home. The children went as a group. Madhavi had already made it clear that Nayan and his family could have a separate private meeting, but the class programme was not to be turned into a family spectacle.

Bhawani Devi came from the village with Nayan's father.

In the courtyard of the old-age home, Gomti Devi was sitting on a low wooden seat. Her hair was almost entirely white. Bhawani Devi stopped at the gate.

Nayan had imagined that the two would run forward and embrace. Nothing of the kind happened.

Gomti Devi raised a hand and said—

"So late?"

Bhawani Devi replied—

"I could not find anyone to ask the way."

Gomti Devi looked at Nayan.

"Now you have."

Then Bhawani Devi went forward. The two women held hands and looked at each other's faces for a few moments.

Nayan stepped back two paces. He understood that in this moment his presence was necessary, but not his place between them.

On the other side of the courtyard, the children were meeting the elderly people to whom they had written. Someone was reading a poem, someone was talking about their village, someone was simply listening.

Gomti Devi asked Bhawani Devi—

“Did you really plant a branch of the yellow oleander?”

“Yes, I did.”

“Why did you plant it?”

“So I could tell you it had survived.”

“Then why did you never tell me?”

Bhawani Devi laughed. “There is no answer to that question.”

Gomti Devi laughed too.

Nayan took a blank postcard from his pocket. “This is for both of you.” Gomti Devi asked, “What are we to write now?” Nayan said, “I do not know. Whatever you feel like.”

Bhawani Devi took the card but handed the pen to Gomti Devi. At the top Gomti Devi wrote: “Recipient: Nayan.” Then she passed the card to Bhawani Devi. Beneath it Bhawani Devi wrote: “Message: The path has been found.” Nayan read the card. “Shall we put this in the post?” Gomti Devi said, “Certainly. If we hand it to you, the postcard will be offended.”

Three days later, that card arrived in Nayan’s name at the school address. Madhavi did not read it aloud in class. She quietly placed it in Nayan’s hand.

Nayan did not keep the card between the pages of his book. When he reached home, he put it in the tin box where Grandmother’s old letters were kept. Bhawani Devi asked, “Why there?” Nayan said, “Because this is not my card. It is the address of a road.” Bhawani Devi said nothing. She closed the lid of the box, then opened it again and placed the card on top—where, the next time the box was opened, it would be the first thing anyone saw.

STORY 176

The Flower at the Window

In that narrow lane of Laheriasarai stood an old house whose front wall was so close to the street that, in the rains, water falling from the roof brushed a passer-by's shoulder before reaching the ground. The wall bore an old coat of blue paint, with a small window of iron lattice in the middle. The window was a little above street level, but not so high that a child's eyes could not reach it.

Divakar took that lane to school. The main road was somewhat wider, but there were more rickshaws, handcarts and motor vehicles there. This lane was small, and in the mornings one saw only the milkman, the vegetable seller and children going to school.

One Monday Divakar saw a red hibiscus at the window.

The flower was not in a pot. There was only a single flower in a small brass bowl.

Divakar stopped as he walked. It was dark inside. No face could be seen behind the lattice.

When he reached school, he told his friend Mukul—

"There was a red flower at the window of that house with the blue wall today."

Mukul asked, "So?"

"Nothing. But I'll see tomorrow."

The next day there was a yellow marigold.

Looking at it, Divakar said to himself—

"Yellow today. That means no rushing today."

That day he had left his mathematics exercise book at home. Earlier he would have reached school and invented an excuse. But he remembered the yellow flower. Before class began, he went to the teacher and said plainly that he had left the exercise book at home. The teacher said—

"Bring it tomorrow. There is no need to hide it."

That evening Divakar thought—the yellow flower had been right.

On the third day there was a blue butterfly pea at the window.

Divakar decided—the meaning of blue was: ask questions.

In science class there was something he did not understand. Usually he stayed silent because he was afraid the other children would laugh. He raised his hand. The teacher listened to his question, drew a diagram on the board and explained it again.

On his way back from school, Divakar looked towards the window. The butterfly-pea flower had wilted a little.

He said softly—

“Today this flower did not go to waste.”

He could not be sure whether a faint laugh came from inside or whether he had imagined it.

In this way the flower at the window became the first sentence of Divakar’s day.

He gave the red hibiscus the meaning—do not put work off.

The yellow marigold—think slowly.

The blue butterfly pea—ask a question.

The white bela flower—do not quarrel.

Sometimes a small pink flower appeared whose name Divakar did not know. He gave it the meaning—whatever happens today, we shall see.

Mukul laughed at this game of his.

“Do the flowers give you orders?”

Divakar would say, “Not orders. I make the meanings.”

“Then what is the flower for?”

“You need something from which to make a meaning.”

Mukul had no answer.

Kamala Devi lived behind the window. She was seventy-two. Five months earlier she had slipped in the courtyard and injured her right knee. No bone had broken, but even after the injury healed, the courage to go outside had not returned.

She walked within the house—from the bed to the kitchen door, from there to the inner courtyard, then back to her room. But she did not go as far as the front door. She heard the street; she did not see it.

Her daughter-in-law Leela would say again and again—

“Mother, come as far as the front veranda.”

Kamala Devi would reply—

“The house is small. This much is enough for walking.”

One day the doctor had said clearly that the more the knee moved, the easier it would become. Leela had repeated that advice. Kamala Devi had grown irritated.

“Everyone is worried about my leg. Is the leg mine or everyone’s?”

The next morning she devised a method of her own. She plucked one flower from the inner courtyard, took a small brass bowl, and, leaning on her walking stick, went as far as the front window. She placed the flower in the bowl and returned.

It took her thirty-four steps to get there. Thirty-four to return.

For the first week, that was her limit.

Leela asked nothing about the flower. She understood that if Kamala Devi had devised a way for herself, it should not be turned into a rule.

But slowly Kamala Devi began to hear a new voice from the street.

Sometimes a boy would say—

“Red today. I won’t put work off.”

Sometimes—

“White. I won’t quarrel with Mukul today.”

Sometimes—

“Blue. I’ll ask a question.”

Kamala Devi would stand two arm-lengths behind the window and listen. From the angle of the lattice she could not see the boy’s whole face—only the hair on his head, sometimes the bag on his shoulder, and his feet as he went away.

One day she asked Leela—

“Who is that dark-complexioned boy who goes to school in the morning?”

Leela laughed.

“So many children go.”

“The one who talks to the flowers.”

Leela looked towards the window.

“That must be Shambhu Babu’s grandson Divakar. He lives in the lane opposite.”

Kamala Devi merely said, “Hmm.”

Even after that she did not change the way she chose the flowers. Whatever flower she found blooming in the morning, she placed there.

One day only the red hibiscus had bloomed.

As she put the red flower at the window, a laugh rose inside her—“Today he won’t put work off again.”

That day Divakar really was in a position to put something off. After school his friends wanted to go towards the pond, while he had to go home and bring medicine for his mother. He remembered the red flower at the window. He did not go with his friends.

That evening, as he handed the medicine to his mother, he thought—the flower had been right again.

But the following Wednesday the window was empty.

Divakar went two steps ahead, then turned back.

The bowl was there, but there was not a single flower in it.

He wondered—what did emptiness mean?

If Mukul had been there, he would have said, “The flower is on leave today.”

Divakar stood beneath the window.

There was no sound from inside.

He said softly—

“No meaning today?”

The silence inside remained unchanged.

It was almost time for the school bell. He ran off. But throughout the first class he kept remembering the empty bowl.

On the way back, the bowl was still empty.

This time Divakar put his hand on the front door.

From inside Leela asked—

“Who is at the door?”

“It’s me, Divakar.”

The door opened halfway.

Divakar was silent for a moment. Then he asked—

“Why is there no flower at the window?”

Leela smiled when she saw his face.

“So you are the one who talks to the flowers?”

Divakar grew a little embarrassed.

“I only look at them.”

“Mother did not go as far as the window today. Her knee is a little swollen. She walked only as far as the inner courtyard.”

Divakar looked through the doorway. In the distance an elderly woman with white hair sat on a low wooden seat.

Kamala Devi called out—

“Was the school closed because there was no flower?”

Divakar understood that she had been hearing him all along.

Standing there by the door, he said—

“I thought there might be some meaning.”

Kamala Devi said—

“The flower has no meaning.”

Divakar looked towards the bowl.

“Then why every day?”

Kamala Devi ran a hand over her walking stick.

“There are thirty-four steps from the inner courtyard to the window. If I put a flower there, it is thirty-four steps this way and thirty-four steps back. I don’t have to count. I see the flower and know—I had come this far today.”

Divakar was silent for a few moments.

Then he said—

“Then there is a meaning.”

Kamala Devi raised her eyebrows.

“Tell me, what meaning?”

“You reached the window.”

Leela burst out laughing. Kamala Devi did not laugh, but the hard lines of her face loosened a little.

The next day there was a yellow marigold at the window.

Divakar stopped. By his old rule he ought to have said—think slowly.

He did not.

He only said softly—

“You reached it today.”

A voice came from inside—

“Hmm, I heard you.”

After that, the old meanings of the flower colours came to an end.

Divakar no longer kept account of red, yellow or blue. He only looked to see whether there was a flower or not.

Sometimes Kamala Devi recognised the sound of his footsteps and would already be standing near the window. Half her face could be seen behind the lattice.

“Late today?”

“There was an assembly at school.”

“Bag heavy today?”

“Two extra books.”

“Flower small today?”

“The plant’s fault. Not mine.”

Divakar would laugh and walk on.

The rains began. One morning a strong wind was blowing. A white bela flower had been placed at the window, but the wind had tilted the bowl. Divakar reached out and straightened it.

From inside Kamala Devi said—

“Who told you to touch it?”

Divakar pulled his hand back.

“It would have fallen.”

“If it had fallen, I would have put another one tomorrow.”

Divakar said—

“But today’s one would still belong to today.”

This time Kamala Devi laughed openly.

By the time Bhadau was passing, she needed the support of the walking stick less on the way to the window. Leela noticed, but did not praise her. She understood that Kamala Devi did not like announcements about her progress.

One morning Divakar reached the lane and found the window empty.

His feet stopped of their own accord.

This time he was not afraid. He looked towards the door.

The door was open.

Just inside the doorway, Kamala Devi sat on a low wooden stool. Her walking stick leaned against the wall. In her hand was the same brass bowl. In the bowl was a small red hibiscus.

Divakar looked at the window, then at the doorway.

“The flower is in the wrong place today.” Kamala Devi asked, “Why?”
Divakar said, “The window is over there.”

Kamala Devi placed the bowl beside the stool. "Today my feet came this far." Divakar thought for a moment before answering. In the old days he would have invented some new meaning for the red flower. Now he merely nodded. "Then that is good." He set off towards school.

At the bend in the lane, he looked back once. The flower was not at the window. It was by the doorway. Kamala Devi had not stepped out into the street. She was sitting only just inside the threshold. Divakar said to himself, "This far today." The meaning of what came next he left for tomorrow.

STORY 177

First Earnings

In the first week before the new session began, Gopal's bookshop in Jhanjharpur was at its busiest. Parents holding school lists, children's bags, covering paper, name labels and pens—all rose and fell together across the counter.

Manjari had worked in that crowd for twelve days.

Each morning she finished the work at home and reached the shop at ten, covered books, cut name labels, straightened the corners of pages, and returned home at seven in the evening. For the first two days her fingers stayed sticky with glue. From the third day onward, her hands learnt to fold the paper almost by themselves.

On the evening of the twelfth day, Gopal Sah placed a brown envelope in her hand.

"Count it."

Manjari laughed.

"You have counted it."

"You did the work. The money is yours. Count it yourself."

Standing in a corner of the shop, she counted the notes—one thousand six hundred and eighty rupees.

For the first time she had so much money in her hand without having to ask anyone at home for it.

As soon as she put the envelope into her bag, her eyes went involuntarily to the upper shelf. Two books had been kept aside there. Three weeks earlier, at her request, Gopal Sah had reserved them for her—the books she needed for the first term of her postgraduate Maithili course.

Manjari looked away at once.

The two books cost seven hundred and twenty rupees. The re-enrolment fee was eight hundred. Together they came to one thousand five hundred and twenty.

She knew that calculation by heart.

But today the envelope had another purpose.

When she reached home, the first thing Manjari looked at was her mother's feet.

Sulochana Devi was sitting by the stove. The right strap of her black rubber slipper had again been tied with thread. Three months earlier a cobbler had stitched it once, but the strap had torn again at the edge.

While eating, Manjari asked—

“Mother, how many more days will these slippers last?”

Sulochana Devi drew her feet inward.

“As many as they are meant to.”

“What kind of answer is that?”

“Are you writing the biography of my slippers?”

Manjari smiled and let the matter rest there.

After her mother had gone to sleep that night, she took a length of red thread from the sewing box. The slippers were by the door. She measured the length of the sole with the thread, tied a knot in it, then slipped the thread between the pages of one of her books.

The next day was market day.

Early in the morning Manjari said—

“Come to the market with me today.”

“What do you have to buy?”

“Just come.”

“We can get vegetables near the house.”

“Not vegetables.”

Sulochana Devi looked at her face.

“Did you get paid?”

Manjari was startled.

“Who told you?”

“Were you working twelve days for free?”

Manjari burst out laughing.

“Then come.”

“Tell me first, what are we going to do?”

“Something for you.”

Sulochana Devi asked no more. She put on her old black slippers, tied a small purse into the corner of her sari, and set out with her daughter.

On the way, Manjari kept looking at her mother’s feet. The red thread lay safe between the pages of the book inside her bag.

Gopal Sah’s shop stood before the market.

Manjari had planned to pass without stopping, but Gopal Sah was standing outside.

“Manjari!”

Her feet stopped of their own accord.

Gopal Sah gestured towards the inside.

“Your two books are still here. If you don’t take them by Monday, I’ll have to give them to someone else. The next stock will take time to arrive.”

Sulochana Devi looked at her daughter.

“Which books?”

Manjari gave a brief answer—

“For class.”

Gopal Sah did not realise the weight of the matter.

"Isn't enrolment due by Monday too this time? Two college girls were saying so yesterday."

Manjari's fingers tightened around the strap of her bag.

Sulochana Devi asked—

"You haven't enrolled yet?"

"It will be done."

"Exactly when will you do it?"

"By Monday."

"The fee?"

Manjari did not answer.

Gopal Sah fell silent now. He understood that the matter no longer belonged to the shop.

Sulochana Devi asked quietly—

"How much are the books?"

"Eight hundred rupees."

"And the books?"

"Seven hundred and twenty."

"Total?"

Manjari's voice was low.

"One thousand five hundred and twenty."

Sulochana Devi looked at her daughter for a moment, then said to Gopal Sah—

"Keep the books. We'll take them on our way back."

Manjari said at once—

"No, Mother."

Sulochana Devi began walking.

Ten steps beyond the shop, Manjari caught her by the arm.

"I brought you here to buy you slippers."

Sulochana Devi looked at her own feet as though seeing the slippers for the first time.

"For these?"

"It is my first earnings."

"How much did you get from your first earnings?"

Manjari was silent for a few moments. Then she said—

"One thousand six hundred and eighty."

No surprise appeared on Sulochana Devi's face. She merely asked—

"You counted it?"

"Three times."

"Then the calculation is clear."

"What calculation is clear?"

"The books and the enrolment."

Manjari's voice grew a little sharper.

"That can happen later."

"With whose money?"

"I'll work again."

"When will you work again?"

"When the shop gets crowded again."

"And when will that crowd come again?"

Manjari did not answer.

Sulochana Devi stepped aside and stood at the edge of the road. People kept passing by them.

"Manjari, why did you bring me to the market?"

"To buy a gift."

"For whom?"

"For you."

"Then who gets to choose it?"

Manjari was silent.

"The person receiving the gift has the right to choose, doesn't she?"

Manjari looked at her mother's face. There were no tears in her eyes, nor any hardness. Only the look of an ordinary question.

"She does."

"Then I choose."

"The books are for me."

"And who will read them?"

"I will."

"Are you my daughter or not?"

Manjari pressed her lips together.

Sulochana Devi walked on.

"Come. First, the enrolment."

The college was half a kos from the market. Four students stood in a line on the veranda. Manjari had come here the previous day too, but had turned back before reaching the window.

Today her mother was with her.

When it was time to pay the fee, Manjari opened the envelope. As she took out eight hundred rupees, it felt as though her first earnings were being cut in half.

The moment the receipt came into her hand, Sulochana Devi said—

"Not half now. One task is complete."

Manjari said nothing.

The two of them returned to Gopal Sah's shop.

Gopal Sah brought the books down and set them on the counter. The corner of one cover was slightly bent. Without thinking, Manjari began straightening it with her fingers—twelve days of practice.

Gopal Sah said—

“Shall I put covers on these?”

Manjari smiled for the first time.

“I’ll do that myself.”

Seven hundred and twenty rupees went.

One hundred and sixty remained in the envelope.

Manjari folded the nearly empty envelope and put it into her bag. Just then the red thread slipped out from between the books.

Sulochana Devi bent and picked it up.

“What is this red thread?”

Manjari tried to snatch it, but her mother raised her hand.

There was a knot in the thread.

“This was the measure of my slipper, wasn’t it?”

Manjari grew embarrassed.

“Yes, Mother.”

For the first time Sulochana Devi laughed openly.

“You had imprisoned my foot between the pages of a book?”

“So I wouldn’t forget the size.”

“What will you do with this measure now?”

Before Manjari could answer, her mother placed the thread back in her hand.

“Keep it. My foot will not grow before your second earnings.”

They walked towards the market.

A footwear shop appeared ahead. Manjari’s steps slowed again.

Sulochana Devi noticed, but did not go inside.

A little farther on, a cobbler sat by the roadside. In front of him lay rubber straps, an awl, wire and old soles.

Sulochana Devi sat down there.

“Replace this right strap.”

The cobbler took the slipper in his hand and asked—

“Shall I replace both?”

“Only one is bad.”

Manjari said—

“Replace both.”

Her mother stopped him at once—

“The other one is still good.”

Smiling, the cobbler cut off the right strap and fitted a new, thicker one.

“Thirty rupees.”

Manjari took thirty from what remained and paid him.

Sulochana Devi put the slipper on and walked two steps.

“See? I got my gift.”

“This isn’t a gift. It’s a repair.”

"It is a new strap."

"I wanted to give you a whole new pair of slippers."

"The whole foot is old."

Manjari burst out laughing. Her mother did too.

One hundred and thirty rupees remained in the envelope.

On the way home, rain began to fall. They stood under the awning of a shop. Manjari opened her bag and checked—the books were not wet.

Sulochana Devi asked—

"Do you have the red thread?"

Manjari looked between the books.

"The thread is there."

"Good. We'll take the measure again."

Manjari looked at her mother's slippers. The new strap shone in the rainwater.

"With my second earnings?"

"First we'll see what breaks sooner—the slipper or the books for your second term."

Manjari was about to say something, then did not.

On Monday she went to college. The two books were in her bag. She had covered the first one herself that night. Inside the brown paper, at the corner, the little knot of red thread lay pressed—not for measuring, only because she had not yet felt like throwing the thread away.

As she was leaving the doorway, her mother called, "You have the receipt?" "Yes, that too." "Both books?" "Yes, both." "Money?" Manjari felt inside her bag. "One hundred and thirty."

Sulochana Devi tapped her right slipper twice on the ground. "The strap?" Manjari turned to look. "Strong." "Then go."

Manjari walked as far as the bend in the lane. When she reached it, she looked back. Her mother was standing by the doorway. Not new slippers, but one new strap on the old pair.

Manjari's first earnings had not reached her mother's feet in full. Part of it, saved along the road to those feet, was travelling in her bag in the form of books.

STORY 178

The Returning Song

After seven years, when Raghav got off at the bus stand of his village, for the first time he wondered whether he had got down at the wrong place.

Where a peepal tree had once stood at the unpaved bend, there was now a broad paved road. The peepal was gone. So was the paan shop beneath it. At the western ghat of the pond, where as a boy he had waded knee-deep into the water to catch fish fry, an iron fence now stood and a playing field was being laid out inside. The tin awning of the old oilman's shop had disappeared; in its place stood a white two-storey house.

Raghav hitched the bag higher on his shoulder and stood on the road for a few moments.

A young man stopped his bicycle and asked, "Where are you going?"

Raghav tried to smile. "Mishra Tola."

"Which Mishra Tola?"

At the question, his smile faded on its own. In his childhood there had been only one Mishra Tola.

"Near the old Sanskrit school."

The young man shook his head. "The school was demolished five years ago. There is a community hall there now."

Raghav tightened the strap of his bag. "Ramkishun Mishra's house?"

The young man thought for a moment, then said, "I've heard the name. Go as far as the new bridge to the east, then turn left. Ask someone there."

Raghav thanked him. The young man rode away.

That one small exchange opened such an emptiness within him that all seven years of distance seemed to stand before him at once.

Raghav worked in a textile-dyeing unit in Surat. For the first two years he had not been able to save enough money to come home. Later he had returned when his father fell ill, but after three days he had gone away again. After his father's death, his mother began living with his younger brother Neeraj. This time, when the factory closed for fifteen days, Raghav had thought—let me go and see the village.

He had not said, "I am going back." He had said, "I'll go and see."

He stopped at the new bridge. The drain they had once crossed in childhood on two bamboo poles now had a concrete bridge over it. The village name was written on a blue strip along the side. Even reading the name of his own village did not feel like being welcomed home.

The house was easy to recognise. The bel creeper his father had planted still grew at the doorway, though the veranda wall had been painted pink.

His mother came as far as the door the moment she saw him.

“Raghav!”

Even after so many years, hearing his own name from his mother’s mouth loosened something inside him. He set down his bag and touched her feet.

When Neeraj returned from the fields, the two brothers looked at each other for a few moments. Then Neeraj burst out laughing. “Half of *pardes* has settled into your beard.”

Raghav laughed too.

Much had changed in the house. His father’s cot was gone. The old grain bin in the corner of the veranda had been removed. His mother now slept in the small back room. A tin roof had been put over the middle courtyard so that rain no longer fell straight inside.

By evening neighbours came to see him. Some asked about his earnings, some about prices away from home, some said, “Now you people have become outsiders.”

The word “outsider” stayed lodged in Raghav’s ears.

He kept answering and smiling. But now and then his Maithili sentences stopped midway. After years of speaking a mixture of Gujarati and Hindi in Surat, many old words had drifted away from his tongue. Once his tongue searched for an old word; looking towards his mother, he finally said, “*thaam*”—place.

After dinner that night he stepped out through the doorway. There was electricity, but among all the new lamps along the road he found himself wanting to search for old patches of darkness.

Neeraj asked, “Where are you going?”

“Just walking around nearby.”

“You still know the roads, don’t you?”

Neeraj had meant it as a joke, but Raghav did not answer.

He walked north. Three houses had been built where the old threshing floor used to be. Half the bamboo grove had been cut down. A well from which they used to draw buckets of water in summer had been closed with a lid.

Raghav placed his hand on the lid. The iron held the coolness of the night.

Just then, from a distance, he heard a woman’s voice.

It was an old voice—a little tremulous, a little rough, yet at the end of each line there was a familiar turn.

There was no instrument. No festival. The voice stopped now and then, then began again.

Raghav stood where he was.

He did not understand the first line. In the middle of the second he caught one phrase—“the paddy leaf...”

No complete picture formed within him; only a road of sound opened.

Rain from childhood. Mud up to the waist. His mother transplanting paddy. Bent backs stretching far across the field. One group of women raising a line, another group answering it. Children running along the embankments. Raghav and Neeraj's task was to carry water in a lota.

The old voice rose again. This time the line stopped halfway.

A short response came out of Raghav's mouth by itself—the word the second group used to sing in the field.

The voice stopped.

After a few moments a voice came from the darkness—"Who is that?"

Raghav went closer. Beside a small courtyard, an earthen stove was dying out. On the veranda an old woman sat with a winnowing tray of paddy in her lap. Her white hair was tied at the back of her head.

Raghav tried to recognise her.

The old woman asked again, "Who answered?"

"Me... Raghav."

"Which Raghav?"

He felt a little embarrassed. "Ramkishun Mishra's elder son."

The old woman set down the tray and narrowed her eyes. "Oh—Saroj's Raghav?"

The moment he heard his mother's name, recognition came. This was Phulkumari Kaki—the same woman who used to raise the strongest voice in the fields. Her house had once stood behind the old bamboo grove; now that the bamboo had been cut, the house could be seen directly from the road.

"Kaki, you?"

"I am still right here. Ask where you have been."

Raghav laughed, but there was hesitation in the laughter.

Phulkumari Kaki said, "Sit."

He sat on the edge of the veranda.

"Why the song now?" he asked.

"Song?" Kaki took the winnowing tray in her hands again. "I was winnowing paddy. My mouth started on its own."

"That was the call from the rice-transplanting song, wasn't it?"

"It was. These days machines go round the fields at transplanting time. With whom am I to raise the call?"

Raghav remained silent.

Kaki picked two black grains out of the paddy and set them aside. "You still haven't forgotten the answer."

"I didn't even remember the line."

"Not the line. You remembered the turn."

It took Raghav a little while to understand what she meant.

Phulkumari Kaki raised the field call again. This time Raghav listened carefully. Half the words sounded unfamiliar. Some had not made sense to him even in childhood. Kaki stopped midway and asked, "Do you understand 'aripaniya'?"

Raghav shook his head. "Not properly now."

"Ask your mother. She will explain it."

"You explain it."

"If I explain it, you will understand the word. If you ask your mother, talk of the house will come out with it."

Raghav looked at Kaki. The old woman began winnowing paddy again, as though even saying that much were simply part of the day's work.

"The village has changed a great deal," Raghav said softly.

"If it doesn't change, it will rot."

The answer came at once.

"But I recognise almost nothing."

Kaki laughed. "In daylight you looked at the walls. At night listen to the voices. Put the two together and recognise it."

This time Raghav said nothing.

As he was leaving, Kaki stopped him. "Tomorrow morning tell Saroj I cannot remember the second line of her call. She will lie and say she has forgotten it too. Then she will hum it twice and it will come back."

When Raghav reached home, his mother was still awake. The lamp on the veranda was burning low.

"Where had you gone?"

"To Phulkumari Kaki."

An old familiarity lit his mother's face at once. "Does she still winnow paddy at night?"

"And she still sings too."

His mother laughed. "The day she stops singing, then know she is ill."

Raghav sat down. After a few moments he asked, "What was 'aripaniya' in that field call?"

His mother looked at him. "Where did you find that word?"

"In Kaki's song."

Before answering, his mother hummed half the line. The first time her voice was thin. The second time it steadied. The third time the line became whole.

Raghav's memory did not return as one picture of embankments, paddy, mud or childhood. He only felt that the words he had forgotten had gone on living without him in this house, in the throats of these two old women.

He interrupted his mother's line and said, "Kaki says you have forgotten the second line."

His mother replied at once, "A lie. She is the one who forgot it."

Raghav burst out laughing.

“Shall I get the two of you to sit together tomorrow?”

“Why should I? Let her come here.”

“She said you should go there.”

His mother leaned her back against the veranda pillar. “See? Even after seven years our quarrel is exactly as it was.”

Raghav woke late in the morning. His mother was not in the courtyard. Neeraj said, “She has gone to Phulkumari Kaki’s.”

Raghav stepped outside. From a distance came two old voices. One would raise a line, the other cut in and correct it. Then both would laugh. Then the line would begin again.

Raghav did not go there. He sat at the doorway and listened.

He had to go to the market that afternoon. The ticket for his return to *pardes* the following week was still in his bag. He made no great decision about staying in the village. Home, work, money—all those questions remained where they were.

But when he asked Neeraj, “Does the old road to the market still go by the pond?” the sentence came out without stopping halfway.

Neeraj said, “Not by the pond. Now you go by the new bridge.”

Raghav nodded.

In the distance Phulkumari Kaki’s voice rose. His mother answered.

Raghav understood—the road had changed; the way of answering was still alive within him.

STORY 179

The Border Papers

Seated beneath the tin shelter at the border post, Devaki Devi felt the knot in the end of her sari for the third time. There were no papers inside it. There were two keys—one brass-coloured, the other blackened iron.

The brass key was for the back room of her daughter's house. The iron key was for the grain store at the house of her son Shambhu, south of the border. She often tied both keys into the same knot. This time too she had tied them there while returning from her daughter's house.

That day special checks were under way at the post. A bamboo barrier had been put up since morning. Bicycles, pedestrians, sacks and baskets—everyone was being stopped and asked for identification. Devaki Devi had travelled this road so many times in fifty years that she could not have counted them. She had assumed that, as always, they would ask her name, ask her village, glance at the bag in her hand and let her pass.

But the young employee asked, "Do you have citizenship papers?"

Devaki Devi looked first at his face, then at her bag.

"Whose papers?"

The employee thought the old woman had not heard. He said loudly, "Your citizenship papers. An identity card."

"At home."

"Which home?"

Devaki Devi did not answer that question at once.

In the village to the north lived her daughter Muniya. In the back room there, a cot, a small wooden box, two sheets and a brass lota were always kept separately for her. In the village to the south lived her son Shambhu, in the old courtyard where the tulsi altar dated from her husband's time and a faded photograph from her wedding still hung on the wall.

Devaki Devi said, "The old papers will be in the house on this side. The newer papers will be in the house on that side."

The employee frowned. "I need one."

"I need one too. But you tell me which one."

The people standing in the queue burst out laughing. The employee did not. The senior officer seated behind him looked up from his papers.

"Mother, where are you coming from?"

"My daughter's house."

"And where are you going?"

"My son's house."

"Which country is your citizenship from?"

Devaki Devi was silent for a few moments. "When I was married, my father said the papers had been made. I came to this side with my husband. Later, some papers were made again. Shambhu keeps them."

"Where were you born?"

"On that side."

"Marriage?"

"On this side."

"Where do you live now?"

"Wherever there is work for me."

The officer stopped his pen.

Devaki Devi was told to sit in a corner of the shelter. "Let someone from your family bring the papers. Then we'll see."

She set her bag by her feet and sat down. Inside were flattened rice given by her daughter, a small tin of sattū, and two paper flowers made by her granddaughter. Muniya had said, "Mother, you'll reach by evening. I have already informed Shambhu."

Evening was still far away. But the Bhadau sun struck the tin roof so fiercely that time itself seemed to have grown hot.

Across from the shelter stood little shops on both sides of the road. On one side they accepted Nepali rupees, on the other Indian rupees. Devaki Devi remembered the night news had come of Muniya's first labour and she had crossed this road in the dark. No one had asked her country then; everyone had asked, "Is your daughter all right?" At the end of her husband's life, Muniya had come weeping along this road. At Shambhu's wedding, relatives from the other side had arrived singing along this road. In Devaki Devi's memory, the border was not a single line; it was a road along which people carried grief, ceremonial gifts, pickles, medicine, news and the names of children back and forth.

A boy selling tea came to the shelter. "Mother, tea?"

Devaki Devi asked, "Which side's money will you take?"

The boy laughed. "Whatever you give."

"Then your shop is wiser than the border."

The boy did not fully understand what she meant, but laughing, he set down an earthen cup. Devaki Devi drank half the tea and put the rest behind her bag. It seemed to her that water, sunlight and waiting—none of the three asked anyone's citizenship.

An hour later Muniya came running from the other side. Her son Naval was with her. Muniya stopped at the bamboo barrier.

"Mother, you're here?"

Devaki Devi began to rise, but the employee raised a hand and stopped her.

From a distance Muniya asked, "What happened?"

"They are asking for papers."

"Those must be with Shambhu Bhaiya!"

The senior officer asked, "Do you have any copy of her old citizenship document?"

Muniya shook her head. "There was an old document from her birth. But after we moved house, I don't know which trunk it went into."

Devaki Devi said at once, "The red box in the back room."

"There are clothes in the red box."

"Underneath."

"There are old letters underneath."

"Under those."

Muniya thought for a moment. "Mother, the red box opens with your key."

Devaki Devi touched the knot in her sari. The brass key was inside.

Muniya and Devaki Devi looked at each other. The bamboo barrier stood between them. The key was on this side, the box on that.

Naval said, "Shall I take the key?"

The employee refused. During the check, objects could not be passed across like that.

Devaki Devi sat down again. She felt like laughing, but when she saw Muniya's eyes fill, she did not.

By late afternoon Shambhu came racing up on a bicycle from the south. His kurta was soaked with sweat. In his hand was a plastic bag containing a bundle of papers.

"Mother, your papers weren't at home."

"Did you look on the upper shelf above the grain store?"

"It was locked."

Devaki Devi touched her sari again. The iron key was with her too.

This time Naval burst out laughing. Muniya wiped her tears and smiled. Shambhu put a hand on his head and said, "Mother has brought the keys to both houses with her."

A faint smile appeared even on the senior officer's face, but he immediately looked back at the papers.

In the bundle Shambhu had brought were an old ration document, her husband's death certificate, a land-revenue receipt, and a letter from the panchayat. In some, Devaki Devi's name was written as "Devaki", in others "Devakiya", and in one place "Devaki Devi". Her age was not the same in all of them either.

The employee spread out the papers one by one. "Her birthplace is not stated here."

Shambhu said, "She has lived in the village all these years."

"I am not disputing that. For today's check, her identity has to be clear."

From the other side of the bamboo barrier Muniya said, "She is my mother. She stayed at my house for three days."

From this side Shambhu said, "She is my mother. She lives with me."

Devaki Devi listened to both sides. It seemed to her that both children were pulling her towards themselves, while her body remained still beneath the shelter between them.

The officer asked, "Mother, you tell us yourself—where is your home?"

This time the question was asked gently.

Devaki Devi stood up. First she looked down the road to the north. Muniya stood there—the daughter at whose birth Devaki Devi had gone seven days without sleep. Then she looked south. Shambhu stood there—the son with whom, after his father died, she had completed their half-built house.

She said, "If fever rises at night, Muniya will say, 'Mother, stay here.' If the grain store has to be opened in the morning, Shambhu will say, 'Mother, give me the key.' If you ask where my papers are, some of mine lie in both houses."

The employee was about to interrupt, but the senior officer stopped him with a hand.

Devaki Devi continued, "I have answered where my home is. Now you look at the papers and give the answer about citizenship."

Silence spread beneath the shelter again.

The officer went through the papers Shambhu had brought once more. On the panchayat letter was written the serial number from an old electoral roll. He spoke to someone in the room inside. An assistant brought out an old register. Her name, her husband's name and the village were matched. Questions arose over the difference in age, then two elderly local women standing in the queue recognised Devaki Devi. They were asked only her name and family details; the employee wrote these down separately.

Half an hour later the officer said, "You may cross today. But next time, keep an identity document with you."

Devaki Devi lifted her bag. "Next time I'll divide the keys to the two houses as well."

Shambhu said, "Give me the key."

From the other side Muniya immediately called, "Open my box first."

This time Devaki Devi laughed. "See? The quarrel over the keys has started before the papers."

The bamboo barrier was raised. Devaki Devi took two steps south, then stopped and turned. Muniya was standing on the other side. Devaki Devi untied the end of her sari and held up the brass key.

"Send Naval next week. We'll open the red box."

Muniya said, "You come yourself."

Devaki Devi did not answer. She merely raised her hand.

By evening she reached Shambhu's house. The day's last light lay on the tulsi leaves in the courtyard. Shambhu asked for the key to open the grain store. Devaki Devi untied the knot and placed the iron key in his palm. She kept the brass key with herself.

After dinner Shambhu said, "Mother, tomorrow we'll put all your papers in one place. Your name, age, birth—whatever is wrong, we'll have it looked at."

Devaki Devi asked, "You'll keep them in one place?"

"Yes, in one place."

"Then in which house?"

Shambhu fell silent.

Devaki Devi hung the knotted end of her sari on the nail beside her cot. The iron key had remained with Shambhu. The brass key was still in the knot.

The papers would be kept in one place the next day. The keys still pointed in two directions.

STORY 180

Flood Camp

The water of the Kamla River had not reached the school grounds, so people from three villages had been brought there. Rows of blue tarpaulins stood all around the field. In the middle, a platform had been made by tying together old bamboo poles. Behind the platform were the school wall and a narrow passage where, during the day, sacks of rice, dry firewood and empty drums were kept.

On the evening of the fourth day of the flood, a red cloth was hung on the platform. In white letters it read—“Women’s safety is our first responsibility.”

The wire of the loudspeaker ran over the mud to the platform. The people in the camp were told there would be a special meeting at seven in the evening. The women were seated in front. The men behind them.

Ratna came out from the tarpaulin shelter with her twelve-year-old daughter Chunmun and sat in front. The wall of their house had been washed away. A brass plate, two towels, one bag and Chunmun’s old school satchel—that was all that remained.

On the platform sat the block official, a health worker, a panchayat representative and the coordinator of the volunteer group. The coordinator’s name was Harinandan. All day he moved about with a whistle round his neck and a canvas bag full of papers hanging from his shoulder.

Before the meeting, Harinandan ran about below the platform straightening chairs, tightened one corner of the red cloth, then turned towards the women and said—

“If anyone has any difficulty, speak without hesitation. There is a separate night watch.”

A little later the block official began his speech.

“A disaster does not merely break houses,” he said. “It also breaks the ordinary arrangements of safety. That is why special attention will be given to the dignity and safety of women.”

The people seated in front listened in silence.

“After eight at night, women should not go alone to the rear part of the camp. If anyone needs help, call a guard. A separate box has been placed for complaints. Do not remain silent under anyone’s pressure.”

Harinandan pointed towards a wooden box hanging in one corner of the platform. There was a narrow slit in its lid. On top was written —“Confidential.”

Chunmun whispered near Ratna's ear—

"Mother, what does confidential mean?"

Ratna said, "Something that is not said in front of everyone."

"Then will the box listen?"

Ratna stroked her head. "The paper will listen."

By the time the meeting ended, the darkness had deepened. The red cloth shone in the light of the bulb. Harinandan made another announcement—

"Anyone whose family grain coupon has not yet been completed can give the name now. The list will be closed tomorrow morning before distribution."

Chunmun's name was missing from Ratna's coupon. She had mentioned it three times during the afternoon. Harinandan had said, "We'll see in the evening."

Holding Chunmun's hand, Ratna went towards the platform. Five or seven people were standing there to have names entered. Harinandan examined one paper after another.

When Ratna's turn came, he looked at the coupon.

"My daughter's name is missing."

Harinandan gave a short reply—"Yes."

"Do you have the old family coupon?"

"The water took it."

"Any proof?"

Ratna pointed towards Chunmun. "Isn't she proof?"

Harinandan did not smile. He folded the coupon and put it into his bag.

"I'll reconcile the list tonight. Come back after a while."

Ratna asked, "Why not now?"

"There is a crowd."

Ratna wanted to say something, but the people standing behind pushed forward. She took Chunmun and returned towards the tarpaulin shelter.

For dinner that night, flattened rice, jaggery and boiled potatoes were distributed. Chunmun saved half a potato and put it into the bag.

"I'll eat it in the morning."

Ratna said, "By morning, half the village's ants will reach it through this mud."

Chunmun laughed.

At eight, the main bulb over the field was switched off. Only the bulb on the platform, the lantern near the kitchen, and two lights along the women's tarpaulin row remained lit.

Ratna could not forget the coupon. A family of five received five shares; the two of them were receiving only one. Chunmun kept saying she was not very hungry, but at night she kept looking at her mother's plate.

"I'm going to get the coupon," Ratna said.

Chunmun sat up. "I'll come too."

“No. Sit with Neelam Kaki.”

Neelam Devi from the neighbouring tarpaulin said, “Go. I’ll watch her.”

Ratna went towards the platform. No one was in front now. The red cloth was still hanging there. “Women’s safety is our first responsibility”—the words could be read in the half-light of the bulb.

Harinandan was not on the platform.

“Harinandan Babu?” Ratna called.

A voice came from behind—“Here.”

A lantern had been placed in the narrow passage between the platform and the school wall. Its flame was very low. Harinandan was bent near the rice sacks, looking through papers.

Ratna went there, but stopped at the mouth of the passage.

“My coupon?”

Harinandan took the coupon from his bag.

“The name can be added.”

“Then add it.”

He did not hand over the coupon.

“The list is full.”

Ratna did not understand. “My daughter is with me. Does a full list make my daughter any less real?”

Harinandan came a little closer.

“Some things do not happen through paperwork.”

Ratna stepped back. A bamboo post was behind her.

“Give me my coupon.”

Harinandan caught her wrist. His grip was not so hard that a cry came out on its own, but it was firm enough that she could not free her hand at once.

Ratna looked down. Harinandan’s fingers were around her wrist. In his other hand he held the coupon.

“Why make a noise?” he said softly. “I am only trying to help.”

Ratna jerked her hand. Harinandan moved in front of her and blocked the way.

“The name can also be struck off tomorrow.”

What followed that sentence made very little sound—the scrape of cloth, a palm striking the bamboo wall, Ratna’s muffled “Leave me,” and the trembling flame of the lantern. Harinandan pressed her towards the wall and put unwanted hands on her body. Ratna pushed his shoulder with all her strength. The end of her sari caught on a split in the bamboo and tore.

At that moment a child began crying in front of the platform.

Harinandan paused for an instant. Ratna did not bite his arm; she dug her nails in hard and scratched it, then got out of the passage.

When she reached the light of the platform bulb, she did not run. She walked slowly. Her right hand was trembling. She held the torn corner of her sari clenched in her fist.

When she reached the tarpaulin, Chunmun asked—

“Did you get the coupon?”

Ratna did not answer.

The moment Neelam Devi saw her face, she stood up.

Neelam asked again, “What happened?”

Ratna said, “Nothing.”

Neelam saw her wrist. Four red finger marks were clearly visible.

“This is nothing?”

Ratna opened her fist. The torn corner of the sari came out.

Lowering her voice, Neelam asked, “Who?”

Ratna looked towards the platform. The red cloth was still shining.

“The one who has the key to the complaint box.”

Neelam was silent for a few moments. Then she went to the neighbouring tarpaulin and brought Sugni Devi. Sugni was about sixty years old. Since the first day of the flood, she had taken it upon herself to keep watch at night along the women’s row.

Sugni listened to Ratna’s entire account. She did not interrupt even once.

Then she said, “You will not go alone.”

Startled, Ratna asked, “Where?”

“Back there.”

Ratna stared at her.

Ratna asked again, “Now?”

Sugni’s answer was brief—“Now.”

Neelam asked, “Why?”

Sugni said, “By morning that passage will be cleaned. The coupon will be changed. The lantern will be moved. And we will go on asking ourselves what happened.”

The three women moved towards the platform. Chunmun was left in the neighbouring shelter.

Two guards were sitting in front of the platform. Sugni told them, “Come to the back.”

Neelam asked, “Why?”

“Come.”

One guard got up. The other said, “Harinandan Babu is making the list.”

Sugni looked at him. “All the better.”

When they reached the back, Harinandan was not there. The lantern was burning. Ratna’s coupon lay on the ground. One corner of it was stuck in the mud. Two red threads from her sari were caught in the split bamboo.

Sugni touched nothing.

“Guard Sahib,” she said, “stand here.”

“What happened?”

“Remember exactly what you have seen.”

Ratna bent to pick up the coupon. Sugni stopped her.

“Not yet,” Sugni said.

This time Ratna’s voice was hard. “That is my daughter’s coupon.”

Sugni looked at her. “Then you pick it up.”

Ratna picked up the coupon.

At nine that night, the block official was called from his resting shelter. The woman panchayat representative also came. Harinandan was found and brought there.

When he arrived, there were four scratches on the back of his hand.

“What is this?” the official asked.

Harinandan replied, “I got them while lifting sacks.”

Ratna did not look at him.

The woman representative asked, “Ratna Devi, tell us.”

Ratna first showed the torn end of her sari. Then her wrist. Then the coupon. After that, she told what had happened once. Not a second time.

Harinandan began to speak in the middle—

“She is trying to defame me—”

Sugni said sharply, “Your turn will come later.”

A crowd began gathering in front of the platform. The red cloth seemed to tremble slightly though there was no wind, because people were moving behind it.

The woman representative said, “The meeting will be held inside. Clear the crowd.”

For the first time, Ratna looked directly at the platform.

“Why inside?”

For a moment, all voices there fell silent.

Ratna said, “The speech about safety was given outside. Why should this matter go inside?”

The official’s eyes went to the red cloth.

A little later, three chairs were placed in front of the platform. The loudspeaker was not switched on. Ratna did not repeat the entire incident again. She only said—

“I have said what I had to say. The guard saw the place at the back. Look at my wrist, my sari, my coupon and his hand. The rest is your work.”

Harinandan was removed from volunteer duty that night. Before he was sent out of the camp, his bag was checked. Inside were coupons from five families whose names had been held back with the words, “We’ll see in the evening.” Four of those coupons belonged to women.

No one immediately knew whether anything else had been said to anyone that night.

But by morning the complaint box had been moved from the corner of the platform to the middle of the women's tarpaulin row. Its key was given to the woman panchayat representative. Two people began sitting together to prepare the lists. The sacks were removed from the narrow passage at the back, and a brighter light was installed there for the night.

Another meeting was held in the morning. The official said—

"Yesterday's incident was unfortunate. The security arrangements will be made even stricter—"

Sugni interrupted, "Keep the speech short. Put up the lights first."

A soft laugh ran through the people, but Ratna did not laugh.

She was standing in the distribution line with Chunmun. Both their names were on the new coupon.

Chunmun asked, "Mother, why is the confidential box here now?"

Ratna looked at the box.

"Where people can see it."

"Will something confidential stay in sight?"

Ratna thought for a few moments.

"The box will stay in sight. What is inside will not."

Chunmun nodded as though she understood.

Yesterday's red cloth was still hanging on the platform. "Women's safety is our first responsibility."

The passage behind the cloth was now plainly visible. The rice sacks had been removed. A white light burned there instead of the lantern.

Ratna looked that way once.

Then she handed her coupon to Chunmun.

"This time, you keep it."

Chunmun put the coupon inside her school satchel.

Floodwater still filled the low-lying fields of the villages. The camp ground had begun to dry. Behind the platform, repeated footsteps through the mud had made a path.

STORY 181

The Red Blanket

The rear veranda of the city's old hospital remained open all night. There was a curfew on the main road outside, but the movement of injured people inside did not stop. In one corner of the veranda, two bamboo cots had been joined to make a temporary place. There lay the body of a boy, covered with a red blanket. A small earthen cup lay overturned near his head, and by his feet was a single slipper smeared with dust.

The boy had been found at the bend by the canal bridge after the evening riot. The rickshaw-puller who brought him had said only that, when the smoke cleared, he saw the boy lying by the roadside. By the time they reached the hospital, the boy had stopped breathing. No one knew his name.

At two in the morning, Nandlal, the hospital clerk, wrote in the register —“Unidentified boy, estimated age eight years.” He left the box for religion blank.

By dawn, two separate crowds had gathered outside. People from the eastern neighbourhood said the boy might be a child missing from their quarter. People from the western neighbourhood made the same claim. Police constables kept everyone outside the gate.

Karim Mian was with the first group. His nephew Sameer had been missing since the night before. Karim Mian said, “Sameer had a red blanket. His mother wrapped him in it when they left home.”

At the head of the second group was Ramvriksh Sah. His neighbour's son Munna was also missing. Ramvriksh said, “I saw his grandmother give him a red blanket with my own eyes. This boy is from our neighbourhood.”

The sub-inspector posted at the gate listened to both men.

“Two people from each family may go inside for identification.”

Karim Mian said at once, “We will go first. The boy was found on our side.”

Ramvriksh objected, “Half the road by the canal bridge lies on our side.”

In a tired voice, the sub-inspector said, “A dead body is not divided by measurement. Whoever can identify him, come inside.”

Sameer's mother, Shabnam, went in with Karim Mian. Munna's grandmother, Devaki Devi, went with Ramvriksh. Reaching the veranda, the two women stopped a little distance away. The red blanket covered the body from head to foot.

Shabnam's hands were trembling.

"There was a small burn mark near the ring finger of his right hand," she said softly.

Devaki Devi said at once, "Munna's little toe on his left foot was slightly crooked."

Sarita, the nurse, looked at both women.

"We will check one mark at a time. We will not keep lifting the blanket again and again."

The hand was uncovered first. Shabnam looked carefully. There was no old burn mark near the ring finger. She remained silent for a few moments, then shook her head.

"This is not Sameer."

The tension in Karim Mian's face eased a little. But it was not relief. Sameer was still missing.

Then the foot was shown. Devaki Devi bent down and looked. The little toe was straight.

"Not Munna," she said.

Ramvriksh immediately asked, "The child's age?"

"About eight," Sarita said.

"Munna is eight too."

Devaki Devi stopped him.

"A child does not become ours merely because the age matches."

Both families went outside, but the crowd did not disperse. The discussion now rested less on the boy's identity and more on the red blanket.

A young man named Akbar, who had come with Karim Mian, said, "The red blanket looks like the one from Shabnam sister's house. Look at the white stitching along the edge."

Raghunath from Ramvriksh's side replied, "Twenty blankets of this same kind were distributed in our neighbourhood last winter. They had white stitching too."

"Then prove it."

"You prove yours first."

Before long, both groups began collecting testimony of their own. Someone remembered that Sameer had been wrapped in a red blanket that night. Someone remembered that Munna's grandmother's blanket had thread of this same colour. Someone was sure that the bend by the canal bridge was on "their" side. Someone else was certain that the crowd had chased the boy there from the other side.

Nandlal listened to all this from inside the veranda. The register lay open before him. The blank box for religion seemed to him like the largest space on the page.

At half past seven, Mangla Devi, an employee of the municipal relief store, arrived at the hospital carrying three bundles. They contained sheets, bandages

and two blankets. As soon as she turned towards the veranda, she saw the red blanket.

"How did this blanket get here?" escaped from her mouth.

Sarita asked, "Do you recognise it?"

"It is from our store."

The people outside fell silent all at once.

Mangla Devi lifted one corner of the blanket. On the inner fold, a small '17' had been embroidered in black thread.

"Last winter, thirty-seven red blankets were stitched for the municipal store. A number was embroidered inside each one. This was number seventeen."

At that moment, Sita Musaharin, who had come with Mangla Devi, put down the bundle and examined the edge of the blanket. Her women's group had done the stitching for that municipal batch.

"Do you know why all those blankets have white thread on the edges?" she asked.

No voice answered.

"The red thread ran out halfway through. The market was closed. We finished the edges with whatever white thread was left. The same stitching went east and west alike."

Akbar kept his eyes fixed on the blanket. Raghunath folded his arms. What both sides had taken to be a special mark of their own homes had been stitched onto dozens of blankets in the same room on the same night.

The sub-inspector said, "The cloth has not identified him. Look at the things found on the body."

Sarita brought a small paper bag. Inside were a mud-stained glass marble, half a broken slate pencil, two chickpeas, and a small brass-coloured bell. No name, no amulet, no thread.

Ramvriksh looked at the bell. "Children keep these things for play."

Karim Mian said, "Everyone plays with marbles too."

"Then any of these things could belong to anyone," Nandlal said.

For the first time, no one objected to that sentence.

Karim Mian stepped forward.

"But the boy was found in this blanket."

Sarita turned towards him.

"No," Sarita said clearly.

Karim Mian stopped.

Sarita said, "The boy was brought in without a blanket. The night was cold. I took this blanket from the store to cover the body."

The murmuring from outside the gate slowly died away. The red colour that had become the claim of two neighbourhoods through the night turned out to be a number from the hospital's old store.

Ramvriksh asked, "Then whose child is he?"

The question remained unanswered in the veranda.

Nandlal looked at the register. The empty box was still empty.

At ten o'clock, two separate lists arrived from the police station. Seven names of missing people from the eastern neighbourhood, nine from the western one. The people who had made both lists were eager not to let their own number appear smaller. Nandlal circled the names whose ages matched the boy's, but none carried a distinguishing mark that could settle the matter.

"Add him temporarily to the eastern list," said a young man who had come with Karim Mian.

"Why?" Nandlal asked.

"He was found on that side."

Raghunath immediately said, "The bend is shared. Then put him on both lists."

Nandlal capped his pen.

"I will not record one child as dead twice."

With that, he set the lists aside.

By noon, five families had arrived. One had a seven-year-old son, another a nine-year-old. One child had a small mole near his ear, another a black thread around his wrist. Each mark was checked one by one. No one recognised this boy as their own.

But outside, the two groups gathered again. Now the argument was about who had first set fire near the bend where the boy had been found that night. The police kept trying to move both groups away. Inside the hospital, while drinking water, Sarita said, "We have not found the body's name, but people are ready to give his death their own name."

Mangla Devi straightened the edge of the blanket.

"Last night it was only something to keep out the cold."

Nandlal asked, "And now?"

"Now everyone is reading its colour."

In the afternoon, the sub-inspector decided that until identification was made, the body would remain under the hospital's care. It would not be handed over to any community. Both groups were dissatisfied, but this time they no longer had the red blanket to argue over. Sarita folded it and placed it beside Mangla Devi's bundles, then covered the boy with a white sheet.

In the evening Shabnam came again. Sameer had still not been found. She stood for a few moments at the veranda door. Devaki Devi too had come there looking for news of Munna. The two women recognised each other—they had stood on opposite sides of the same body that morning.

Shabnam asked softly, "Munna?"

Devaki Devi shook her head.

"Sameer?"

Shabnam shook her head too.

For a few moments, both women looked towards the white sheet inside the veranda.

Devaki Devi opened her bag. There were two rotis inside. She held one out to Shabnam.

“Have you eaten anything since morning?”

Shabnam took the roti. The two women sat down by the doorway. Inside, Nandlal sat with his pen resting over the blank box in the register. Outside, people from the two neighbourhoods moved along the road calling the names of their missing children.

As Mangla Devi tied up the bundle, she put the red blanket at the very bottom. The black-thread ‘17’ inside it appeared once more, then disappeared into the fold.

STORY 182

Don't Ask the Name

By half past ten at night, near the small bridge south of Kamtaul, the train did not so much stop as come to rest as though torn apart. The first three coaches had left the rails and tilted to one side. In the darkness came first the screech of metal, then the sound of glass breaking, and then many voices calling out at once. People from the nearby villages came running with lanterns, bamboo poles and sheets. Within ten minutes, the station's small waiting room had become a makeshift treatment area for the injured.

When Pragya Devi, a nurse from the primary health centre, arrived, seven injured people were already lying on the veranda. One had a split scalp, another an arm bent at an unnatural angle, another was breathing in short, shallow bursts. With her was Deepak, a laboratory assistant carrying a small blood-testing kit. Pragya knelt beside the first injured person.

"Name?" a local young man asked.

Pragya stopped him. "Don't ask the name yet. Check the breathing first."

She took the injured woman's pulse and told Deepak, "Test the blood group. Keep pressure on the head wound."

The young man looked a little taken aback. He had paper and a pen in his hand.

"Won't there be a register?"

"There will. But the treatment register comes first. The register of names comes after that."

Two large sheets of paper were hung on the station wall. On one, Pragya had "Treatment" written at the top, and below it: serial number, injury, blood group, destination sent to. The second sheet remained blank except for the heading: "Family Search."

The number of injured people kept increasing. The door of one coach had jammed; when it was forced open with bamboo poles, five people were brought out. Some could say their names, some could not. Those who could were entered separately on the Family Search sheet. For those who could not, only their clothing, approximate age and the coach from which they had been found were noted. On the Treatment sheet, only the serial numbers kept increasing.

"Number eleven—B negative," Deepak called out loudly. "Two units needed immediately."

There was a stir among the people standing outside the waiting room. Four young men came in to donate blood. Deepak began testing them. Just then a voice rose from the direction of the gate—

“Tell us the names of the injured first!”

It was not one voice. Within a short while twenty or twenty-five people had gathered near the gate. Some carried lanterns, some sheets of paper. Two separate groups had made lists of names of their own. Outside, people were guessing how many passengers on the train were from which neighbourhood, which caste, which religion.

Shambhunath, a local teacher who had been helping lift the injured, went outside.

“Whatever names have been verified are on the Family Search sheet.”

A young man said, “All the names aren’t there.”

“Not all are known.”

“Then how will we know which people are more badly injured?”

Shambhunath asked, “Whom are you looking for?”

The young man was silent for a moment. “Show us the list first.”

Inside, Pragya was bandaging the leg wound of number eleven. The man was semi-conscious. A ticket had been found in his pocket, but no paper bearing his name. A man from one of the groups outside came as far as the veranda and tried to look at his face.

“Who does he look like?” he asked the people standing behind him.

Pragya drew the curtain.

“Stay outside.”

“We need to know his name.”

“Right now he needs blood.”

“Religion?”

Pragya looked at him. “There is no box for that in the blood test.”

Having said that, she bent over the wound again.

Of the four possible donors, one young man’s blood matched. His name was Ramzan Ansari. Deepak wrote his name in the legal register and took his signature, but on the Treatment sheet on the wall he wrote—“Donor number four—B negative.” Ramzan asked, “Who will receive it?”

Deepak said, “Number eleven. The test matches.”

Ramzan looked towards the curtain for a moment, then held out his arm. “All right.”

Outside, the demand for names grew louder. Some people said the administration was hiding names. Others said injured people from one community were being taken inside first. Two different figures were circulating in mobile-phone messages—one said eight dead, another thirteen; both added guesses about religion, even though the death toll at the station had not yet been verified. Shambhunath looked at the papers held by two young men. The

same injured person had been counted under different names on both lists. He said, “Do not kill someone on a list before he has died. Write the name after it is verified.” The young man holding the paper was annoyed, but he had to strike out the number.

Meanwhile an elderly man, Baidyanath Chaudhary, pushed his way to the gate. His daughter Sunaina had been on that train.

“Where is the list of names?” His voice was trembling.

Shambhunath took him to the Family Search sheet. Seven names were written there. Sunaina’s was not among them.

Baidyanath’s face fell. “Names matter, Babu. If the name is not there, how am I to find her?”

Pragya heard him from inside and came out.

“Names matter,” she said, “for families. The treatment number matters too—for the injured. Do not make the two into the same thing.”

She asked Baidyanath for Sunaina’s age, clothing, seat and a description of the bag she had with her. At the bottom of the Family Search sheet they wrote—“Sunaina Chaudhary, about twenty-six, green shawl, second coach.” A question mark was placed beside it.

Fifteen minutes later a volunteer came running. “A young woman from the second coach has been sent to the school to the north. She had a green shawl.”

Baidyanath wanted to go there. Shambhunath sent a young man with him. This time the name was not a rumour; it had become a road.

By one in the morning, the crowd outside the station was doing two kinds of work—some people were genuinely searching for their own, while others were adding up numbers. A young man from one group raised his mobile phone to photograph the Treatment sheet. When he saw only serial numbers and blood groups, he grew irritated.

“What will anyone understand from this? Write the names.”

Deepak said, “From this, I understand who needs which blood.”

“What will people understand?”

“Show people the Family Search sheet.”

“There is no religion on it.”

“Why should there be?”

The young man did not answer. He went outside, but returned after a while. This time a teenage boy was with him, a bandage tied around his head.

“He can tell you his name—Sajid.”

Deepak added the name to the Family Search sheet. In the Treatment register, his entry already existed—number seventeen, blood group A positive, head wound, conscious.

The young man asked, “Will you write his name on the Treatment sheet now?”

Deepak shook his head. "The name will remain in the hospital file. This wall is for blood and injuries."

At two in the morning blood was needed again. This time the woman listed as number twenty-three was found to have O negative blood. A call went out. Only one elderly man stepped forward—Madhusudan Sah. His own son was missing, but his blood matched.

"I'll give it," he said. Deepak replied, "You are very tired." "Tired, not ill."

After the tests, the doctor gave permission. While donating blood, Madhusudan asked, "Has number twenty-three's name been found?" Pragma said, "No." "Then write—someone's mother, someone's daughter." Pragma did not smile. "That would not be a name. It would be a guess." Madhusudan fell silent. After a while he said, "All right. Write it when the name is found."

Pragma liked that small sentence. All night the crowd outside had wanted to put everyone immediately into some box; for the first time, someone had accepted that a name could be something worth waiting for.

A little before dawn, news came from the school to the north—Sunaina was safe, with an injury to her arm. The young man who had gone with Baidyanath returned and struck out the question mark on the list. Beside Sunaina's name was written—"Found."

At that same time, the man listed as number eleven regained consciousness. Pragma gave him water.

"Can you tell us your name?" The man moved his lips. "Harishankar Paswan."

Pragma added the name to the Family Search sheet. A man standing outside the gate immediately began writing something on his own list. On the other side, Ramzan was drinking tea with a bandage around his arm. He did not know that his blood had gone into Harishankar's body; Harishankar did not know who the donor had been. Both facts were linked by serial number in the hospital's internal register, not on the lists outside.

As morning light grew, both sheets on the station wall could be seen clearly. The Family Search sheet was now crowded with names—beside some was written "Found", beside others "Hospital", beside some there was still a question mark. Around that sheet people cried, laughed, asked directions and ran.

Beside it, the Treatment sheet did not contain a single name. Beside number seventeen was "bandaged", beside number twenty-three "blood", beside number eleven "sent to district hospital"—nothing more. A young man outside asked again, "Will you never write names on this sheet?"

Pragma looked at both sheets with eyes exhausted from the long night. "This sheet has a different job." The young man was about to say something, but at that moment a family saw the name of their relative on the Family Search sheet and ran towards the school to the north. The question was left where it was.

Deepak was sorting the empty blood bags. On the label of one bag were written only the serial number, blood group and time. He placed it in the treatment box. Outside, names were searching for the road home; inside, letters and numbers were tracing routes through bodies.

STORY 183

The Register

Evening sunlight was resting for the last time on half of a pillar in the police-station veranda when Bhawani Devi arrived with her son Jogendra. In her hand was an old photograph of Devaki—blue sari, no bindi on her forehead, her eyes not looking straight at the camera but a little to the left.

Devaki had not returned home for three days. She spent her days in a sewing room in the market, stitching borders on blouses. On the first day, Bhawani waited, thinking she had been delayed. On the second, the proprietor said Devaki had left work after midday. On the third morning, Jogendra said they should go to the police station.

The constable seated behind the desk opened the register. The date had been written at the top of the page in red ink. Below it, the details of four missing people had already been entered.

“First tell me the name.”

Bhawani Devi said, “Devaki Mahato.”

“Age?”

“About twenty-eight.”

The constable looked at Jogendra. “And you?”

“Her brother.”

He kept writing. Village, hamlet, clothing, height, the old burn mark on the left wrist. On the back of the photograph, Jogendra wrote the family name in pencil. Bhawani Devi could not read. At the end, the constable took her thumb impression and said that the information would be sent to police stations in all directions.

As they came outside, Jogendra said, “Mother, the work is done.”

Bhawani Devi tucked the empty photograph envelope into the end of her sari. “He wrote the name, didn’t he?”

“He did.”

On the fourth day, Chanda, Jogendra’s daughter, who studied at college, went to the police station. Her grandmother had told her, “Go and read the paper once. I put my thumb impression on it; you look at the letters.”

Chanda was reading the list of missing people posted on the veranda wall when she stopped. In the third row was Devaki’s photograph. Beneath it was written—“Devaki Devi, wife of Jogendra Mahato, age 32 years.”

Chanda looked first at the photograph, then at the line, then at the name of her own father, Jogendra.

She ran inside. “Why does this say Bua is Father’s wife?”

A different constable was on duty then. He opened the register and looked at the original entry. The first writer’s handwriting slanted. In the box marked “relationship”, at first glance it was not clear whether the word was ‘brother’ or ‘husband’; Jogendra’s name followed it. While preparing the list, someone had read it as ‘husband’. As to how the age had gone from twenty-eight to thirty-two, the register had no answer.

“We’ll correct it,” the constable said.

Chanda asked, “The paper on the wall?”

“A new one will be put up.”

“And the papers sent outside?”

The constable paused. “Wherever possible, the correction will be sent.”

Bhawani Devi came to the police station again. This time, before putting her thumb impression anywhere, she had Chanda read everything aloud. In small letters beside the original line in the register was added—“Unmarried; Jogendra, biological brother; age 28.” The old words were not erased. Only a thin line was drawn through them.

Bhawani Devi asked, “So now my daughter has become unmarried again?”

The constable opened his mouth to answer, but Chanda took her grandmother by the hand.

By midday the corrected notice for the wall had still not been made. The old paper remained posted in the veranda. Two women going to the market read it and carried the story as far as Bhawani Devi’s house: when had Devaki been married, who was Jogendra, and why had the family hidden it? Bhawani Devi answered no one. In the evening, she took Chanda and went to the police station again.

At that moment a constable from an outlying post arrived with a bundle of papers. The top sheet was a copy of the names of missing people. Beside Devaki’s name it now read—“Devaki Devi alias Devaki Mahato.” The space for relationship had been left as a blank line.

Chanda asked, “Why ‘alias’?”

The writing constable said, “The name in the first notice and the corrected name look different. So whoever copied it must have written it this way.”

Bhawani Devi said, “When did Devaki get two names?”

“She does not have two names. It is a correction in the paperwork.”

“Then does the paper understand that?”

The constable did not answer. In red ink he wrote “correction to be sent” on the returned list. Bhawani Devi asked how many such papers had gone out in all directions. No one could give a number.

Chanda said softly near her grandmother’s ear, “Bua is still only one person. The papers are multiplying.”

This time Bhawani Devi gave no thumb impression. She merely looked at the old notice on the wall and walked out.

On the fifth day, the police reached the sewing room in the market. The proprietor, Ramanand Sah, said Devaki had asked for an accounting of her wages three days earlier. There had been an argument over the account. He admitted that voices had been raised, but denied striking her. The other women workers said separately that Devaki's cheek had been swollen that afternoon and that her sewing box had been left behind in the room.

"She left on her own," Ramanand kept repeating.

"Tell us where she went."

"How would I know?"

A new note was added to the register—"Left the workplace voluntarily."

When Bhawani Devi heard this sentence read by Chanda, she asked, "Who wrote about the swelling on her cheek?"

Chanda read the register again. There was no mention of the swelling.

On the sixth day, a message reached the police station from a women's shelter in the district town. Four days earlier, a young woman had been found sitting near the bus stand. Name—Devaki Mahato. Father—late Ramnath Mahato. The village name was almost the same as well. A woman staff member at the shelter said on the telephone that the young woman could not remember her home telephone number, but said she had a brother named Jogendra.

The constable on duty looked at the old list on the wall. It still said—"Devaki Devi, wife of Jogendra Mahato, age 32."

"Our entry says her husband is Jogendra," he said. "Your young woman says Jogendra is her brother."

The shelter worker replied, "She is sitting in front of me. She says she has never been married."

"Age?"

"Twenty-eight."

For a few moments there was silence at both ends.

The constable opened the original register. He saw the correction beside the entry. Then the matter moved forward.

That evening Bhawani Devi, Jogendra and Chanda went with the police to the district town. In the small courtyard of the shelter, Devaki sat wrapped in a yellow shawl. The old burn mark on her left wrist was clear. The swelling on her cheek had gone down a little, but a blue bruise was still visible beneath her eye.

Bhawani Devi did not run the moment she saw her. At first she simply stood still. Devaki rose, took two steps, and then mother and daughter held one another.

Jogendra stood behind them. Chanda squeezed his hand.

The shelter worker said quietly, "She says the proprietor of the sewing room had withheld her wages. When she asked for the account, he hit her. After she

came out, she did not have the courage to return home. She walked as far as the bus stand. She spent the night there.”

Separating herself from her mother, Devaki said, “I kept thinking—should I go home or not? The proprietor had said he would turn it around and accuse me of theft.”

The policeman who had come with them said, “Your statement will be recorded at the police station.”

Devaki looked straight at him. “First write my name correctly.”

The policeman said nothing.

Before they left the shelter, a small slip was prepared at the desk saying “sent with family”. The worker asked Devaki to sign it. Devaki had Chanda read the slip aloud. Her name was correct there, but in the box marked “husband/father” was written Jogendra.

Chanda said at once, “He is her brother.”

The worker looked at the earlier telephone-message paper. “This is the only name the police station gave us.”

Devaki did not sign the slip. “First write Father—Ramnath. If you make my brother my father, tomorrow someone will again say I am telling it wrong.”

The worker made a new slip. The first slip was not torn up; it was placed in the file with “cancelled” written across it. Devaki looked at both versions of the paper together and said nothing.

On the seventh day, Devaki herself went to the police station. The same register in which her existence had been altered three days earlier was opened in front of her. The entry had now grown into three layers. The original read —“Devaki Devi, wife of Jogendra Mahato, age 32.” Beside it was the correction —“Unmarried; Jogendra, biological brother; age 28.” Beneath that was the note —“Left the workplace voluntarily.”

Devaki put her finger on the third sentence. “Who said this?”

“It was the proprietor’s statement.”

“Did anyone ask me?”

“You had not been found then.”

“So the words of the person who was available were written down. The words of the person who was missing were left blank.”

The officer seated behind the desk straightened his pen. “Your statement will be added now.”

Devaki said, “Add it. But after ‘voluntarily’, add that my wages had been withheld, that I was beaten, and that fear was why I did not return home.”

The officer measured the blank space left in the line. There was very little room. He took out a separate sheet and began attaching it to the file.

Devaki asked, “In the register?”

“There is no room here. Your full statement will remain in the file.”

Devaki looked again at the original line. "There was room for my name. There was room for the wrong relationship. There was room for someone else's statement. When it came to my words, the room ran out?"

Two people sitting in the veranda began looking that way. The officer's pen remained suspended in the air for a few moments. Then, in small letters beneath the next line of the register, he wrote—"Statement of missing person attached; previous note one-sided."

Devaki could not read. Chanda, who had come with her, slowly read the whole sentence aloud.

Devaki said, "And the name?"

The officer prepared a new notice—"Devaki Mahato, father late Ramnath Mahato, age 28, unmarried—found safe."

For the first time, Devaki took the paper into her own hands. Pointing out the letters, Chanda read the name to her—De-va-ki Ma-ha-to. Devaki ran a finger over her own name as though touching the body of the letters.

Outside the gate, the old notice was still hanging there, half torn. Rain splashes had spread the ink, but "wife of Jogendra" could still be read. Jogendra stepped forward to take it down. The constable said, "Leave it. A new notice will be put up."

Jogendra stopped his hand.

The new sheet was pasted over the old one. Glue was pressed into all four corners. A few letters from the old line still peeped out from underneath.

Bhawani Devi asked Chanda, "Is my Devaki on the paper on top?"

Chanda read the new line aloud.

Bhawani Devi nodded. "This time, she is."

Inside, the register was closed. Between its pages Devaki had been recorded three times in three different forms. Outside, on the new notice, she appeared once. Devaki looked at the paper, then walked over to her mother.

STORY 184

The Open Door

A thin strip of morning sunlight was entering the courtyard beneath the gate. Rekha sat to one side of that strip. The gate was open, but she did not step outside.

It was her fifth day back home. Fourteen months earlier, she had been taken to the city on the promise of work in a garment factory. After that, the roads kept changing, the people kept changing, and her control over both her labour and her own body kept diminishing. She was freed along with several other young women in a police raid, spent three months in a shelter home, and only after the paperwork was completed was she able to return to her parents' house.

Since the day she returned, the gate of the house had remained open all day. Her mother would say, "Let the air keep coming in."

Rekha understood—there was no need to open such a large gate merely for air.

On the first day her mother had held her tightly to her chest. Her father had stood by a pillar of the veranda, wiping his eyes again and again. Her younger sister Neelu had clung to her feet and cried. Her younger brother Chandan had watched from a distance.

From the second day, all the ordinary talk of the house began again—the price of paddy, Neelu's examination, the tyre of Chandan's bicycle, her father's knee, the leaking roof over the veranda.

Only Rekha's fourteen months were never spoken about.

Whenever she herself tried to say something, her mother would find some task or other to bring up.

"Eat first."

"You are very tired today."

"Leave what has passed behind."

Her father would turn the radio a little louder.

If Neelu began to ask something, her mother would stop her with a look.

Rekha could see that the house had made many preparations for her return—a new sheet, a washed pillow, a comb in her old brass box, clean curtains at the window. But no empty space had been prepared in the house for listening to her story.

On the third day, Malti Kaki came to the gate.

"Has Rekha come back?" Her voice carried into the courtyard.

Her mother immediately looked at Rekha.

"Go inside," she said softly.

Rekha stopped and asked, "Why?"

"People will have too many questions just now."

Rekha got up and went into the room. Outside, her mother said, "Yes, she has come back. She is tired. She is resting."

Malti Kaki asked, "May I see her?"

Her mother replied, "After a few days."

From inside, Rekha kept looking at the open frame of the gate. The way stood open, but she herself was not allowed to be present upon it.

That evening Neelu quietly came into her room. She had a schoolbook in her hand.

"Didi, are you angry with me?"

Rekha said, "No."

"Then why are you so quiet with me?"

Rekha tried to smile. "The silence was already here before I came. I am looking for a place for myself inside it."

Neelu did not understand. She opened her book and sat down.

At dinner that night, her father said that the discussion of Neelu's marriage would be taken up again the following month. Rekha kept mixing lentils into her rice.

Her mother said softly, "Until then, let as little as possible of the household matter go outside."

Rekha stopped her spoon.

"Which household matter?"

No one answered across the plates.

"My coming back?" Rekha asked.

Her mother began wiping the rim of her plate.

Her father said, "People are not good."

Rekha asked again, "What will people say?"

"Whatever comes into their minds."

"And what will I say?"

This time Chandan raised his head, but when his father's eyes fell on him, he looked down again.

Rekha ate her last mouthful of rice and got up.

A little later that night, she found Chandan by the courtyard well. He was pulling up a bucket with the rope. When Rekha stood there to take water, he said without looking at her, "Two boys in the market were asking about you today, using your name."

Rekha took hold of the bucket handle. "What did you say?"

Chandan said, "Nothing."

Rekha asked, "Why?"

For the first time Chandan looked at her. “Father said we should not talk to anyone.”

“What did you feel like saying?”

Chandan’s lips trembled slightly. “I felt like saying that Didi has come back. That’s all.”

Rekha filled the lota with water. “Then next time say exactly that.”

Chandan went on coiling the rope. “People will ask more.”

“You do not have to answer every question. But there is no need to hide the fact that I have come back either.”

Chandan said nothing, but he coiled the bucket rope more neatly than before. Rekha understood—the silence of the house had tied different knots over everyone’s mouth, not only hers.

The next morning she opened an old bamboo chest. Inside were a few half-made sikki-grass baskets, coloured thread, and two small fans. Before she had left home, she used to make sikki work with her mother. Malti Kaki helped them sell those things at the market.

Rekha took out a half-made basket and sat on the veranda. Her fingers did not move as quickly as before. The grass broke twice. On the third attempt, the knot sat properly.

At noon Malti Kaki came again. This time her mother had gone towards the pond.

“Rekha?” Kaki called from the gate itself.

Rekha got up, thinking she would go inside. Her foot turned for a moment, then stopped.

“I’m here,” she said.

Malti Kaki did not enter the courtyard. She remained standing by the gate.

“Good that you came back.”

That was all Kaki said.

Not “Where were you?”, not “What happened?”, not “Who did it?”

Seeing the half-made basket in Rekha’s hands reminded her of old times.

“You still make these?”

“My hands are learning again.”

“I need small baskets for my grandchild’s upanayan ceremony. Can you make four?”

For the first time in five days, Rekha answered without thinking, “I can.”

Malti Kaki said, “I won’t pay in advance. Otherwise your mother will say I am stealing work from you.”

Rekha laughed. It was a small laugh, but it was her own.

When her mother returned in the evening and heard about the four baskets, she fell silent.

“Why did you agree?”

“I know how to make them.”

"But people will keep coming and going from the house."

"The gate is open anyway."

Her mother looked at her at that sentence.

It rained that night. The gate was closed. Inside, the darkness felt a little deeper.

Rekha sat in the same room with her mother. Neelu was asleep. Outside, water fell with a steady drip.

Rekha said, "At the shelter home there was a door that remained open from morning until evening."

For the first time, her mother did not interrupt her sentence.

"Could you go outside?"

"Not without permission."

"Then why was it open?"

"They said it was for air."

Her mother remained silent for a few moments. The rain grew heavier.

Rekha said, "The gate here also stays open. But when Malti Kaki came, I was sent inside."

Her mother's hands became still in her lap.

"I am trying to protect you."

"From whom?"

"From people's mouths."

"During those fourteen months there were very few ways to protect myself from the people I met. If, in my own house, I must again stay shut inside a room in order to protect myself from people's mouths, then where is the difference?"

Her mother could not answer.

Rekha went on, "I will not tell everything today. There may be things I never tell. But whatever I do want to say, I need a place where it can be heard."

The rain eased a little. Her mother got up to close the window. When she returned, she sat beside Rekha.

"I will listen," she said. "I will be afraid, but I will listen."

Rekha did not tell the whole story then. She said only this much: that the first city was not the city whose name they had been told; that on the first night the door had been locked from the outside; that one girl kept repeating her own name again and again so she would not forget it; and that on the day the police came, Rekha could not believe the road outside truly led outside.

Her mother did not ask a single question in between.

At dawn her father was drinking tea on the veranda. Rekha placed the four unfinished basket circles in front of her.

"I'm going to the market today," she said.

Her father paused while lifting his cup. "With Malti?"

"First to her house. After that, on my own."

Many sentences came and went across her father's face. In the end he said, "If it starts raining on the way, stop by the shop near the peepal tree."

Her mother came out of the kitchen with a cloth in her hand. She moved to cover Rekha's head with it, then stopped her hand. She gave the cloth to Rekha instead.

"Wear it if you feel like it."

Rekha put the cloth into her bag.

Neelu came running. "Didi, bring me a black pen on your way back."

From the veranda Chandan called, "Will you take the bicycle?"

"I'll walk."

The gate was open. Rekha paused on the threshold for a moment. The lane outside was the same—mud, two goats, water on the leaves of the peepal tree, a vegetable seller's cry in the distance.

No one stopped her.

She walked slowly as far as Malti Kaki's house. Kaki examined the four baskets, turning one in her hand, and said, "Your knots are still as tight as ever."

Rekha said, "My hands are learning again."

At the market, two people recognised her. One woman looked at her for a little while, then merely began asking the price of vegetables. One man turned his eyes away. Rekha noticed both things, but she did not change the road by which she would return home.

In the evening, when she reached the gate, her mother was sorting paddy in the courtyard. As soon as Rekha stepped inside, her mother asked without looking up, "Did you bring the salt?" Rekha opened her bag. "I did."

"Neelu's pen?" Rekha laughed. "That too." Her mother then raised her head. "The baskets?" Rekha said, "Two were sold. The other two next week."

Her mother nodded, as though this were ordinary household accounting. Rekha took off her bag and placed it on the veranda. Behind her, the gate remained open.

STORY 185

Three Minutes

The hands on the clock tower in the middle of the market showed twenty-seven minutes past four when the first jolt came.

It was so slight that people sitting on the other side of the road did not even turn to look. A handcart rolled back, the front wheel of a bicycle caught against one of its bamboo legs, and two young men looked at each other at the same time.

The handcart belonged to Deepak. Raju was on the bicycle. The two already knew each other.

“Can’t you watch where you’re going?” Deepak said.

Straightening the wheel, Raju replied, “Why have you left your cart in the middle of the road?”

The matter could have ended there.

But the empty milk can tied behind the bicycle fell to the ground and rolled clattering as far as the vegetable stall. At the sound, three people turned around.

A young man who had arrived after the incident began asked, “What happened?”

Someone said, “He pushed him.”

By the time the sentence reached another mouth, it had become—“He hit him.”

By the third mouth—“People from the outside hamlet have come into the market and are beating our people.”

The clock hand reached twenty-eight minutes past four.

Deepak and Raju were still only arguing. But a circle had formed around them.

Two teenagers standing on the steps of the cloth shop raised their mobile phones. A young man who had come to buy vegetables opened his phone too.

“Go closer, go closer!” someone told him.

“I can see clearly from here,” he replied.

Raju looked at the crowd. For the first time, his voice rose.

“I did not push him.”

Deepak said, “His wheel got caught in my cart. That is all.”

That sentence did not reach the outer edge of the circle.

From outside came a new voice—“Whom did he hit?”

“Someone from our hamlet.”

Who? That question fell behind. “Our hamlet” moved ahead.

The circle was now becoming two semicircles. On one side, several young men stood behind Raju; on the other, some gathered near Deepak's cart. Even those who knew neither man were choosing a side.

At that moment, Nathuni Kaka was buying salt in the market.

He was about seventy-two. He heard very little in his right ear; even in the left, people often had to repeat themselves. Fifteen years earlier, after a firecracker exploded near the railway crossing, his hearing had slowly begun to decline. Children in the village sometimes tested him by calling from behind, and he would keep walking without turning.

Nathuni Kaka carried a small cloth bag and a bamboo stick.

He saw the crowd, but could not properly hear the slogans.

What he did see was this: Deepak's cart stood tilted to one side; Raju's bicycle lay on the ground; and from behind the circle, a young man was picking up half a brick.

Kaka placed his bag on the salt seller's counter.

"Keep this," he told the shopkeeper.

The shopkeeper asked something, but Kaka could not hear him.

The clock showed twenty-nine minutes past four.

In the video being recorded by one of the teenagers on the cloth-shop steps, the clock too appeared for a moment.

Two minutes had passed since the first jolt.

The young man who had picked up the brick was named Guddu. He had not seen how the incident began. He had only been told, "They hit one of our people."

He pushed through the crowd and moved forward.

Raju stepped back. His foot caught in the bicycle pedal and he fell to his knees.

Someone took that fall to mean, "They've hit him."

A voice rose—"We won't let this go now."

Three mobile phones went up together.

Nathuni Kaka reached the middle of the circle.

He could not properly hear the slogans from either side. But he could certainly see the brick in Guddu's hand.

He went and stood directly between Guddu and Raju, who was on the ground.

Guddu stopped. The old man's body had suddenly come in front of him, and a moment of uncertainty checked his hand.

"Move, Kaka," he said.

Kaka tried to read his lips.

"Say it again. I didn't hear."

"Move!"

Kaka raised a hand towards his left ear. "Speak louder."

Some people in the crowd laughed. The laughter came at such a moment that no one quite knew whether laughing was appropriate.

Guddu shouted again—“Move!”

This time Kaka understood.

He looked at Raju, then at Deepak.

“First pick up the bicycle,” he said.

“Kaka, don’t get in the middle of this,” Deepak said.

Kaka did not fully hear Deepak’s sentence either. He bent down and began lifting the bicycle by its handlebar.

Raju got up too.

That small act distorted the shape of the circle. Anyone who needed space to surge forward now found the bicycle in front of him. Anyone who wanted a clear view for a video now had Kaka’s back inside the frame.

A young man shouted, “Move him away!”

Nathuni Kaka did not hear that either.

Guddu still held the brick. Kaka straightened the bicycle and turned towards him.

“Where are you taking that brick?”

Guddu replied, “For these people—”

“To build a house?” Kaka asked.

Several people laughed again. This time the laughter was louder.

Guddu grew irritated. “They have hit someone!”

Kaka looked towards Raju. “Who hit you?”

Raju said, “No one.”

Deepak immediately said, “No one hit me either.”

Again, the answer did not carry clearly to the outside of the circle. But the ten or fifteen people in front heard it.

A young man holding up a mobile phone asked, “Then why are you fighting?”

Deepak looked at him. “How long have you been recording?”

The young man lowered the phone.

“Two minutes.”

“Then you didn’t see what happened first.”

After that sentence, for a few moments no new slogan rose.

The clock showed half past four.

Three minutes had passed since the first jolt.

At that exact moment, the brick slipped from Guddu’s hand. It struck the ground and broke into two pieces. No one knocked it away; his grip had simply loosened.

With his bamboo stick, Nathuni Kaka pushed one piece towards the side of the road.

“If this stays in the road, it will cut someone’s foot.”

Deepak began straightening his cart. Raju spun the bicycle wheel. It was slightly bent.

Someone said, "Is the matter over?"

Someone else replied, "Who knows."

The gathering did not disperse at once. Curiosity, like violence, also ebbs slowly. Some people were still watching the footage on their phones.

In one video, only Raju's fall could be seen.

In another, Guddu was moving forward with the brick.

In a third, Nathuni Kaka was coming into the middle, but the first jolt was missing.

No one's phone contained the first two sentences spoken by the two young men.

By evening, five versions of the story were circulating in the market. In one, Raju had hit Deepak. In another, Deepak had pushed first. In a third, twenty men from the outside hamlet had come together. In the fourth, Nathuni Kaka had snatched away the brick. In the fifth, Kaka had slapped Guddu.

Nathuni Kaka heard none of those five stories.

He went back to the salt shop to collect his bag. The shopkeeper said, "Kaka, you became a hero today."

Kaka raised a hand towards his ear. "What?"

The shopkeeper came close and said loudly, "Everyone says you stopped the crowd."

Kaka picked up his bag.

"You mean me?"

"Yes, you."

Kaka thought for a few moments.

"I only saw the brick."

The shopkeeper laughed. "You didn't hear the slogans?"

Kaka shook his head.

"Some sounds. Not the words."

"Lucky that your hearing is weak."

Nathuni Kaka did not laugh at that.

He looked towards the clock tower. The hands showed twenty-four minutes to five.

"It isn't a matter of luck," he said softly. "A brick is not something you need to hear."

The next day Raju came to the market to have his bicycle repaired. Deepak replaced one of the bamboo supports on his cart. At different times, both went to see Nathuni Kaka.

Raju wanted to give him a kilo of guavas.

Kaka refused.

Deepak wanted to pay for his tea.

Kaka refused that too.

“You saved me,” Raju said.

Kaka kept looking at his face.

“Did I save you, or Guddu?”

Raju was silent.

Kaka said, “The brick was in his hand. If it had fallen, it would have hit you. If it had flown, his life would have changed too.”

At midday, one of the teenagers who had stood on the cloth-shop steps came across him again.

He went up to Kaka and wanted to show him the video on his mobile phone.

“Look, this is where you went into the middle.”

Kaka looked at the screen. Inside the small frame was the crowd, raised hands, and his own back. The sound was loud, but to Kaka the words were still indistinct.

The teenager said, “A lot of people have watched these three minutes.”

Kaka asked, “Does it show the first jolt?”

“No, the first jolt isn’t there.”

“Does it show Deepak saying that no one hit him?”

The teenager moved the video back and forth.

“You can hear half of it.”

“Does it show the brick falling?”

“Yes, you can see the brick fall.”

Kaka handed the phone back.

“Then those three minutes aren’t complete.”

The teenager stared at Kaka in surprise.

Nathuni Kaka tucked his bag under his arm and began crossing the market.

When he reached beneath the clock tower, he did not stop. Above him, the hands kept moving. Below, people kept pausing the footage on their devices, moving it forward, and pausing it again.

STORY 186

Cloth

The floodwater was receding, but the clothes in the relief-camp courtyard were still not dry. On a rope tied between two school windows, saris, towels, a child's kurta and a torn sheet kept blowing against one another in the wind.

Since morning, word had spread that a truck carrying clothes would arrive that day. By noon, a queue had formed in front of the veranda. On the old classroom blackboard, the relief stock was written in white chalk—rice, lentils, salt, sheets, children's clothing, men's clothing, women's clothing. A number stood beside each item.

Roopkala Devi could not read the blackboard, but she recognised numbers. She asked, "How much women's clothing?"

Sangeeta, who was helping write down names, said, "Eighty-four bundles."

"And a screen?"

Sangeeta did not understand. "What did you say?"

"A screen for changing clothes."

At that moment, a young man unloading sacks from the truck shouted, "Call out the family numbers first. Don't break the queue."

Roopkala Devi fell silent.

Her granddaughter Sulekha was with her. Sixteen-year-old Sulekha had been wearing the same salwar-kurta for three days. On the first day, river water had reached her knees; on the second, there was mud all over the camp; on the third, she had not dared wash the clothes—because she had no second set to change into.

The distribution table was set up in the middle of the veranda. Two men opened the bundles and displayed the items one by one. A woman volunteer, Meenakshi, checked the numbers.

"Family forty-seven!"

An elderly woman went forward. She received a sari, a blouse and a sheet. Holding up the blouse, the young man asked, "Will this size do?"

The old woman tried to laugh. "How would I know?"

"Check it here. It can't be exchanged later."

The eyes of the people sitting in the veranda turned towards the garment. The old woman immediately wrapped the blouse inside the sari.

Roopkala Devi pressed Sulekha's hand.

"You won't go forward," she said softly.

"Then the clothes?"

“Let us watch first.”

Two families later, a sari came out of a young woman’s bundle that reached only to her waist. No one laughed, but smiles appeared on a few faces. The young woman put the sari back on the table.

“Give another one,” her mother said.

The young man looked towards the sack. “The bundles are already prepared. Take what you get. If anything remains at the end, we’ll see.”

The young woman stood behind her mother.

Sulekha whispered, “Grandmother, I won’t take any.”

Roopkala Devi did not answer.

The camp was arranged so that five or seven families lived in each classroom. Some families had hung a sheet between two bamboo poles to make a corner of their own, but the sheet was also needed as a covering at night. During the day, if a woman had to change clothes, the other women formed a screen around her. Sometimes the wind rose; sometimes children running past knocked the screen aside.

The previous night, Sulekha had waited for four women to stand holding up a sheet so she could change out of her wet kurta. Two women were looking after children, one elderly woman was asleep, and the fourth had gone to fetch water. In the end, Sulekha had slept in the same wet clothes.

The queue grew shorter. From time to time, Meenakshi took women aside and explained that if a size was very wrong, they would look again at the end. But whenever someone said something quietly, one of the men at the table would ask, “What do you need?”

Sulekha’s turn drew near.

Roopkala Devi left the queue and went to Meenakshi.

“Daughter, may I say something?”

“Tell me, Kaki.”

“Who will wear all these clothes?”

Meenakshi smiled. “All of you.”

“Where will we wear them?”

Meenakshi’s smile disappeared.

Roopkala Devi said nothing more. She merely pointed towards the open classrooms, the veranda, the courtyard and the road.

Meenakshi was silent for a few moments. Then she asked, “Isn’t there a separate room for women?”

Sangeeta said, “Six families sleep in that room at night.”

“During the day?”

“There are supplies in it during the day too. The door is broken.”

Meenakshi went inside. One leaf of the door had come off on the very first day of the flood. The other hung half-broken. There was no glass in the window.

She came back outside. The distribution did not stop. She merely looked at the sheets stacked at one corner of the table.

"Can we use two sheets?" she asked the young man in charge.

"Sheets are allocated by family."

"To make a screen."

The young man opened the register. "There is no category for a screen."

Roopkala Devi was listening.

She said, "If there is no category, there is cloth."

The young man looked at her. "What cloth?"

Roopkala Devi pointed towards the pile marked 'wrong size' in one corner of the veranda. Five saris, three blouses, two salwars, and some children's clothes.

"Those five saris haven't been given to anyone yet?"

"The sizes didn't fit."

"Then can we have them for five minutes?"

The young man frowned. "The clothes are for distribution."

"What I am doing is distribution too."

Roopkala Devi picked up the first sari. Meenakshi did not stop her. Sangeeta picked up the second. Two women brought down the rope from the courtyard. Two bamboo poles were stood up in front of the schoolroom's broken doorway. The saris were tied so that they overlapped slightly. A large sari was hung over the empty window frame in place of a sheet.

In ten minutes, the room had changed. It was not entirely empty even now, but trunks had been pushed into one corner. Dry sacks were spread on the floor. Outside, Meenakshi pasted up a small piece of paper—"Women."

Roopkala Devi could not read it.

"What did you write?"

"Women."

"Only that?"

"Only that."

Sulekha smiled for the first time.

Her family number was called. This time the bundle was not opened in the veranda. Meenakshi carried the bundles of five women inside together. Outside, the men continued distributing rice to the next family.

Inside, Sulekha opened her bundle. The salwar was large; the kurta a little loose.

"Will it do?" Meenakshi asked.

Sulekha held the clothes against her body.

"It will."

"Then change."

Sulekha looked around. For the first time in three days, she did not have to ask anyone to stand around her and make a screen.

Roopkala Devi remained seated outside.

A little later, a pregnant woman went inside. The clothes in her bundle were too small. Meenakshi brought another garment from the pile. It fit. The first garment went back to the pile.

By noon, the room was no longer merely a place to change clothes. The women had begun exchanging garments there. One had a salwar that was too large, another a blouse that was too small, another a sari that was too heavy. What had been marked 'does not fit' at the table outside would reach the room and fit someone or other.

Once, twelve-year-old Rani stopped at the doorway holding her bundle. Her mother stood behind her. Rani would not go inside. Roopkala Devi asked, "What happened?"

Rani kept her face lowered. Her mother said softly, "She needs underclothes. There are none in the bundle."

Meenakshi checked the distribution sacks. Such garments were in separate packets, but the packets were lying under the table in the veranda. Large numbers were written on them. Meenakshi brought all the packets inside and said from outside the doorway, "Whoever needs anything, look inside. There is no need to say your name."

At first, no one reached out. Then Rani's mother took one packet. After her, two young women, one elderly woman, then a pregnant woman. No one smiled, but the embarrassment that had made bodies shrink in the veranda loosened a little inside.

While straightening the sari at the doorway, Roopkala Devi said to Meenakshi, "The way you distribute something is as important as the thing itself."

Instead of replying, Meenakshi tightened the knot at the window once more.

The man in charge of distribution came to the doorway twice and asked, "How many saris are inside?"

The first time, Meenakshi said, "Five."

The second time, Roopkala Devi said, "Four on the walls, one on the window."

"The account will be short by five."

Roopkala Devi said, "Short where? They are all right here."

"But they have not been entered against anyone's name."

"For now, enter them against the room."

The young man did not laugh. He kept looking at the paper.

In the evening, distribution ended. The remaining garments were put back into sacks. On the blackboard outside, the old figures were struck through and new ones written. Rice zero, lentils three sacks, men's clothing seven bundles, women's clothing four.

The young man asked, "The five saris?"

Meenakshi pointed towards the room.

"They will stay there."

"I have to submit the account tomorrow."

Sangeeta stood with the chalk in her hand. "Under which heading shall I write them?"

The young man searched for an answer.

Roopkala Devi adjusted her spectacles.

"Write 'cloth'."

Sangeeta laughed. "Cloth is already written."

"Then write it again."

"What should I write?"

Looking at the saris hanging in front of the broken doorway, Roopkala Devi said—

"Cloth, even when it is not on a body."

At the very bottom of the blackboard, Sangeeta drew a new line. After thinking for a few moments, she wrote only the number five. She wrote no word.

That night, Sulekha washed her old wet kurta and spread it on the rope to dry. Wearing the new kurta, she came out of the room just as the wind rose. The saris at the doorway fluttered, but the screen inside did not open. Roopkala Devi herself had tightened the knots on the two bamboo poles.

Before lying down to sleep in the veranda, Sulekha asked, "Grandmother, who will get these saris tomorrow?"

With her eyes closed, Roopkala Devi said, "First let all the women change their clothes. After that we'll see who needs a sari."

Sulekha asked again, "And the screen?"

This time Roopkala Devi opened her eyes.

"The screen is made of cloth. But a screen is not clothing."

Sulekha said nothing.

Outside, the chalked number five on the blackboard was growing a little blurred in the damp night air. Inside, the saris were still.

STORY 187

The Station Room

It was half past ten at night. The train had already left Platform Three at Darbhanga station, but the crowd was still jammed between the footbridge steps and the outer gate. Porters were dragging empty trolleys, the tea seller was washing his brass-coloured kettle, and the announcement system was sending out broken fragments of information about the next train.

A little apart from that crowd, beside an iron pillar under the footbridge, sat a seven-year-old boy. In one hand he held a small paper bag; the other was empty. The top button of his striped kurta was broken. There were no tears in his eyes, but again and again he raised his neck towards the crowd, as though some definite figure might appear there once more.

Banshi the porter was the first to notice him.

“Who are you with?”

The boy kept looking towards the pillar.

“With Mother.”

“Where has your mother gone?”

The boy pointed towards the crowd. “There.”

Banshi looked around twice, then took him to the railway police room.

The room was not large. One desk, two chairs, a long wooden bench against the wall, a yellow light above. In one corner stood a water pitcher and in another an old umbrella. Ramvilas Yadav was on duty. He pulled the register towards him.

“What is your name?”

The boy said, “Ravi Kumar Mandal.”

Ramvilas asked, “Your mother’s name?”

“Sunita Devi.”

“Your father’s full name?”

“Shivnath Mandal.”

“Village?”

“Belahi.”

“Police station?”

Ravi scratched his head. “I don’t know that. Our house is near the well.”

Ramvilas asked, “Which direction is Belahi?”

Ravi moved his hand towards the crowd. “We came by train.”

Ramvilas wrote in the register—Ravi Kumar Mandal, mother Sunita Devi, father Shivnath Mandal, village Belahi. He left police station and district blank.

Meanwhile word spread that a child had been found. Such news has legs of its own at a station. Within five minutes, six people had gathered outside the room. Firoz the tea seller said, "I think he is a passenger's child. Look at the bag in his hand."

Banshi objected, "Does a bag prove someone is a passenger? Children who live around the station carry bags too."

A ticket examiner looked in and said, "Was a ticket found?"

Ramvilas said, "Would a child be walking around with the ticket in his pocket?"

The examiner shrugged. "Then how do we know he came by train?"

An elderly passenger sitting outside said, "Look at his clothes. He is a child from a proper home."

Firoz immediately asked, "Children who live at the station don't have homes?"

The old man fell silent.

In the middle of all this talk, Ravi picked up a small piece of chalk lying at the corner of the desk. On a soot-darkened strip low on the wall, he began drawing a small figure—a girl with two plaits, and beside her a round object.

Ramvilas asked, "Who is this?"

"Radhika."

"And the round thing?"

"Her lota."

"How old is Radhika?"

Ravi opened five fingers, then folded two down. "This many."

"Three years?"

Ravi nodded.

Ramvilas asked, "Where is Radhika?"

"With Mother."

"Where is Mother?"

Ravi again pointed towards the crowd. "There."

By eleven at night, the first claim arrived. Mohan Sah, who sold betel outside the station, came in. With him was a boy of about ten.

"He must be one of the children who wander around the station," Mohan Sah said. "I think I've seen a face like this two or three times."

Ramvilas asked, "Have you seen this child?"

Mohan Sah looked closely at Ravi. "I can't say for certain. The way his hair is cut looks familiar."

The moment Ravi looked at him, he said, "I do not live at the station."

Mohan Sah said, "Will a child tell you everything?"

Ramvilas put his pen down on the desk. "Whatever he tells us, we will first listen to that much."

Mohan Sah went outside, but the words “station child” remained among the people there.

A little later a woman passenger came with her teenage son. She had heard that a child from a family from Samastipur was missing.

“They said his name was Sonu,” she said. “Could this be Sonu?”

Ramvilas looked towards Ravi.

Ravi said clearly, “I am Ravi.”

The woman said, “He might be Ravi at home and Sonu outside.”

For the first time, Ravi became angry. “I am not Sonu.”

Outside, the argument began again—home name, school name, name on the ticket, what the mother called him, what the grandmother called him. Amid so many names, Ravi fell silent.

Ramvilas pulled the door halfway shut. “No one will ask the child any more questions now.”

Firoz sent in tea with two mathris. Ravi ate one. He sat for a while holding the other in his palm.

“Eat it,” Ramvilas said.

“This is for Radhika.”

“When Radhika is found, you can get another.”

Ravi shook his head. “I’ll give her this one.”

He put the mathri into the paper bag.

By midnight the station had grown somewhat quieter. The argument outside had not completely stopped. Some thought the child should be sent to a children’s home; some said information should first be sent to all the trains; some believed the family might have gone outside the station. One young man said, “He cannot properly tell his name and address. There must be something more to it.”

Ramvilas stepped out of the room and said, “A seven-year-old child has been separated at night in a crowd. Why do you want a court statement from him?”

The young man said nothing.

Ravi began to doze where he sat on the bench. Ramvilas brought out an old blanket. Ravi first placed the bag near his head, then covered himself with the blanket.

“Will the light go off?” he asked.

“I am not switching anything off yet.”

“Radhika cries in the dark.”

“The light will stay on here.”

Ravi closed his eyes.

At around one o’clock, a man came running from the direction of the outer gate. His clothes were covered in dust, sweat on his forehead. The moment he looked inside, he stopped.

“My child—”

Ravi was asleep.

Ramvilas raised a hand and stopped the man. “What is your name?”

“Mahesh Mandal. I am his maternal uncle.”

“The boy’s father?”

“Shivnath Mandal.”

“His mother’s name?”

“Sunita Devi.”

“The village?”

“Belahi. Jale police station.”

People gathered outside again. Mahesh explained that his sister Sunita had got off the train with two children. Ravi had been separated from them in the crowd on the footbridge. Sunita had thought Ravi was with his father; the father had thought Ravi was holding his mother’s hand. They realised only after reaching outside. Since then, the two of them had been searching in different directions.

“Where is the mother?” Ramvilas asked.

“She has gone towards Platform One. My brother-in-law is searching near the bus stand outside.”

Someone outside immediately said, “Proof first. Does saying he is the maternal uncle make him the maternal uncle?”

Mahesh turned towards him. “I know my nephew.”

Another man said, “The child is asleep. Wake him up and see whether he recognises him.”

In a hard voice Ramvilas said, “The child will not be woken from sleep for anyone’s argument.”

Mahesh saw the chalk drawing low on the wall.

“He drew Radhika, didn’t he?”

Ramvilas looked towards him.

Mahesh said softly, “Radhika is his little sister. She never goes anywhere without that lota.”

At this one sentence, the people outside divided again into two camps. To some it was proof; to others, it was something he could have heard earlier.

Ramvilas told Mahesh to sit on the bench outside. “Let the mother and father come. If the child is awake then, he can see for himself.”

Two o’clock came. A new train arrived at the station, the crowd rose again, then subsided. The yellow light in the room remained steady. In his sleep Ravi turned once and pulled the bag close to his chest.

A little before dawn, a woman’s voice was heard outside the room—

“Is Ravi here?”

Ramvilas opened the door. The woman was carrying a three-year-old girl. One of the girl's two plaits had come loose. In her hand was a small brass-coloured lota. Behind them stood a thin man, panting.

Before Ramvilas could ask anything, the little girl insisted on being put down.

"Where is Bhaiya?"

At that voice Ravi opened his eyes on the bench. For a moment he could not understand where he was. Then he saw Radhika.

"You didn't leave the lota?"

Radhika made a face and said, "You left us."

Ravi threw off the blanket and stood up. Instead of running first to his mother, he opened the bag. The mathri inside had broken into pieces. He placed the pieces in his palm and held them out to Radhika.

"I saved it for you."

Radhika put one piece in her mouth. She held another towards Ravi's mouth.

Some of the people who had argued all night about his identity were still standing outside. Someone's hand moved towards the blanket, someone's eyes towards Mahesh. But Ravi and Radhika kept sharing the mathri.

Sunita touched Ravi's head. "Where did you go?"

Instead of answering, Ravi asked, "Why did you leave me?"

Sunita was silent for a few moments. Her husband said from behind, "I thought you were with Mother."

Sunita said, "I thought you were with Father."

Ravi looked from one to the other.

"I was with Radhika."

Radhika placed the last piece of mathri in his palm.

Ramvilas pulled the register towards him. The blank space in the line written during the night still had to be filled. He picked up his pen, then looked at the people gathered outside the room.

"Everyone outside. The family stays here."

The door did not close completely. It remained half open. From outside came the whistle of the first train of the morning.

Ravi picked up his bag from the bench. Radhika took hold of one of his fingers. As he came out of the room, no one asked whether he was a passenger's child, a station child, Sonu, or someone by any other name.

Walking towards the stairs, Ravi turned back once. The yellow light was still burning. On the wall, the chalk drawing of Radhika and her lota remained where it was.

STORY 188

Silent Testimony

Morning sunlight had yet to reach the third-floor veranda of the district court. A thin strip of light fell on the floor through the latticed window to the east, but it was somewhat darker in front of the testimony room. Above the door, in black letters, was written—"Closed Proceedings—Unauthorised Entry Prohibited."

Kusum sat on a wooden bench three paces from that door. Her mother, Devmaya, sat beside her; a woman constable was in front; and Suchitra, the support worker, stood to one side carrying a bag of papers. Kusum's hands were empty. With the nail of her right thumb, she kept touching a small white scar on her left palm.

Suchitra said softly to Devmaya, "She will not have to answer too many questions today. The judge will control the pace."

Devmaya immediately said, "She used to speak little even before. After the incident she became completely silent."

Kusum did not look at her mother. She only said, "I did not become silent."

Devmaya turned towards her in surprise.

"Then what happened?"

"People began speaking more in front of me."

The bag in Suchitra's hand slipped a little lower. She seemed about to say something, then stopped.

At the other end of the veranda, the public prosecutor, Arunesh Mishra, was speaking quietly with the police inspector. The inspector said, "She gives short answers. Better to ask in yes or no."

Arunesh said, "Let her say as much as she wishes."

Just then defence counsel came up the stairs as well. Two young men were with him. They looked at Kusum for a moment, then turned their eyes away. The woman constable shifted her chair a little farther in front of the bench. Nothing was said, yet the narrow passage of the veranda became narrower still.

Arunesh came over to Kusum and said in a very low voice, "Answer only what is asked. If you do not remember something, say 'I do not remember'. If you become tired, ask for a break."

Suchitra immediately added, "If you wish, you may take your time before answering."

Devmaya gave a third piece of advice in her own way. "Don't look too much at anyone. Say what happened, then we'll go home."

Kusum listened to all three. One piece of advice came from the law, one from support, one from her mother. Their intentions were not different, yet each sentence had already begun to give her testimony a small shape of how it ought to be delivered.

She asked, "What if I do not understand the question properly?"

Arunesh said, "Ask for it to be put again."

"And if the question contains something I never said?"

This time Arunesh paused a little. "Then say clearly—those are not my words."

Kusum lowered her head and looked at her palm. Rubbing her thumb over the white scar, she seemed to be remembering not a sentence, but a right.

The bell inside rang.

Kusum stood up. Devmaya began to rise too, but the constable signalled with her hand—"Mother will remain outside."

Devmaya reached out as though to catch the end of Kusum's sari, then stopped her hand halfway. Kusum herself adjusted the sari over her shoulder and walked through the door.

The room was smaller than she had expected. The judge's seat was raised, but the chair kept for Kusum was ordinary. In front were the counsels' tables, to one side the recording clerk, and at the back only the necessary staff.

The first question was her name.

"Kusum Devi?"

"Yes, that is me."

"How old are you?"

Kusum told them.

"Have you come to give evidence of your own free will?"

Kusum paused.

"A summons came."

A brief silence spread through the room. The public prosecutor asked again, "But you are not objecting to giving evidence?"

"No. I will give evidence."

The recording clerk began to write.

She was asked the date of the incident. She was asked the place. Kusum kept answering. Sometimes one word, sometimes one sentence. When a question seemed unclear, she said, "Ask again." When a question contained two things at once, she said, "One at a time."

Once the public prosecutor said, "At that time you were very frightened?"

Kusum looked at him.

"At what time?"

"Immediately after the incident."

"I was trembling."

"Because you were afraid?"

"I was trembling—that is all I remember."

The recording clerk drew a thin line through the word he had first written and wrote the second sentence.

Kusum could see that thin line very clearly. When her statement had been written at the police post, she had never seen a word crossed out like that. There, the person writing would occasionally ask, "Shall I write it like this?" and Kusum, exhausted, would nod. Today she understood that nodding one's head and saying a sentence in one's own words were not the same thing.

Before the next question, the judge asked, "Would you like some water?"

Kusum said, "Not yet. Let the questions continue."

No one in the room attached any meaning to that small answer. Kusum found this strangely comforting.

Her eyes went again to the crossed-out line.

After a while, the defence questions began. The tone was courteous, but the edge of the questions was like a thin knife.

"Why did you not call out loudly for help at the time of the incident?"

Kusum said, "I did."

"That is not clearly stated in your first statement."

"I said it."

"Why was it not written?"

For the first time, Kusum looked directly into the counsel's eyes.

"Why are you asking me that?"

The judge intervened. "Reframe the question."

Defence counsel turned a page.

"Very well. When you gave your statement to the police, did you remain silent?"

"No. I answered."

"How much did you say?"

"As much as I was asked."

"Did you say everything?"

Kusum paused again.

"Can anyone say everything all at once?"

The room was quiet again.

The counsel moved on to another question.

A short break was taken before noon. When Kusum came outside, Devmaya held out a lota of water. Suchitra asked, "Are you all right?"

Kusum drank some water and said, "Yes."

Devmaya said to the constable, "See? She is nervous inside, but she does not show it."

Suchitra said softly, "Sometimes the body freezes by itself. It is a natural response of the body."

Kusum handed the lota back to her mother.

"I am sleepy right now."

Both women fell silent.

Kusum rested her head against the wall behind the bench. For five minutes she sat with her eyes closed. She did not fall asleep, but no one got the opportunity to explain the meaning of her silence.

After the break, the testimony resumed. This time there were questions about the medical examination, the time she reached home, and the first person to whom she had spoken about the matter.

The public prosecutor asked, "Why did you not tell your mother everything at first?"

Kusum said, "Mother had a fever that night."

"So you wanted to protect her?"

"I said—Mother had a fever."

"Meaning that you did not want to worry her?"

Kusum's eyebrows lifted slightly.

"That is your sentence."

Arunesh stopped.

The judge looked towards the recording clerk. "Record the witness's own words."

For the first time, Kusum looked towards the bench. There was no gratitude on her face, no relief—only attention.

In the second hour, the defence returned again to her silence that night.

"Your mother says that for two days you hardly spoke properly to anyone."

"Mother was at home. I went out from time to time."

"Where did you go?"

"The hospital. The police station. My aunt's house."

"So you spoke to people?"

"Whatever was necessary with each person."

"But about the incident?"

Kusum rubbed her thumb over the white scar on her palm.

"Sometimes I spoke. Sometimes I did not."

"Why was that?"

"Sometimes I could not find the words."

"Fear?"

"Sometimes."

"Shame?"

Kusum's thumb stopped.

"I did not use that word."

"Then the reason?"

Kusum looked at the counsel for a few moments. Then she said slowly, "Sometimes I was tired. Sometimes the person in front of me had already decided why I was silent. Then it seemed pointless to explain it to them."

The recording clerk's writing slowed slightly.

Defence counsel said, "Are you saying that people did not listen to you?"

Kusum shook her head.

"No. I am saying that people filled my silence with their own words as well."

For the first time in court, while her complete sentence was being written, no one interrupted.

Before the testimony ended, the judge asked, "Is there anything in the recorded statement that you wish to clarify?"

Kusum looked at the recording clerk.

"Read it aloud."

The recording clerk began reading the main portions from the beginning. Kusum stopped him twice. In one place it said "very frightened".

"Remove that. I said I was trembling."

In another place it said "did not tell her mother because of concern for her".

"Remove that too. Mother had a fever—that is all."

The recording clerk made the corrections.

The judge asked, "Anything else?"

Kusum said, "No. Let only as much remain as I said."

The proceedings ended. The door opened. Outside stood Devmaya, Suchitra, two constables and several people who were waiting. As soon as Kusum came out, a local reporter moved towards Suchitra.

"How did the testimony go today? Did she say anything?"

Out of habit, Suchitra opened her mouth to answer—"She spoke with great courage—"

Then she stopped.

She looked at Kusum.

The reporter turned the question to Kusum. "Would you like to say anything?"

Kusum said, "What I had to say today, I said inside."

"Not outside?"

"No. Not about this outside."

The reporter lowered his pen.

As they went down the stairs, Devmaya said softly, "People in the village will ask. What shall I tell them?"

Kusum went down three steps and stopped. In the courtyard below, the man selling lemon water was washing his glass tumblers.

"Say—what belongs to Kusum, Kusum will say."

Devmaya said nothing.

At the last turn of the staircase, Kusum herself asked, "Mother, shall we have lemon water?"

Devmaya said, "Whatever you want."

For the first time, a faint smile came to Kusum's face.
"Then two glasses."

STORY 189

Two Bodies

Three days later, the water of the Kamla had begun to recede, but the veranda of the primary school in Jhitki village was still filled with the smell of the river. The smells of wet earth, rotting leaves, kerosene and medicine had mingled together. Relief sacks lay on one side of the veranda, two bamboo cots on the other. Two dead bodies lay on the cots.

A small paper tag was tied near the feet of each—"Unknown 1" and "Unknown 2."

The first body had been found at dawn near the bamboo grove in the mango orchard. The second, towards evening, at the bend of an old channel. No one knew where the water had brought either of them from.

Even so, by ten o'clock the people standing outside the veranda had divided themselves into two groups.

"The first one is from our side," said Mahendra of the eastern hamlet. "Look, there is red thread around the wrist."

Someone's voice rose, "What does red thread prove?"

"And the other has a black cord around the neck. Can't you see?"

This time Karim Mian from the western hamlet stepped forward. "You'll write down someone's religion from a cord? Does a flood ask before it carries people away?"

Mahendra's voice hardened. "We cannot leave a body without cremation."

From the other side came the reply, "And we cannot give up the right to burial."

Sudhakar Jha, the school headmaster, stood between them. In his hand was the register sent by the block disaster team. Again and again he said the same thing—"Both are unidentified. First let them be identified."

But to the crowd, the word "unidentified" was like an empty space. Everyone wanted to fill it with a name of their own.

The dhoti of the first body was torn near the waist. Half of the second man's kurta had been washed away. The water had swollen the skin. The faces had changed so much that even someone familiar might not recognise them at once. The relief team had covered both bodies with thin white cloth.

A young man said, "The first one could be Shambhu from Hanumannagar. He has been missing since yesterday."

Another replied at once, "No, he was younger."

Someone said the second body was Salim from the Musahar settlement. Someone else said Salim had been thinner. In two minutes, five names appeared, then seven.

Sudhakar closed the register.

“Names will not be entered on guesses.”

Some people in the crowd fell silent, but the argument did not stop.

Just then, a woman’s loud voice was heard at the school gate. “Where are the unidentified bodies?”

It was Surti Devi. She was around seventy, her wet sari lifted to her knees, a short bamboo stick in her hand. Her husband Nandlal had been missing for two days. After the rear wall of their house collapsed, no one had seen whether he had managed to get out.

People made way for her.

Surti went to the first cot. She lifted the cloth from the face by a finger’s breadth. She looked for a long time. Then she moved to the feet. Without touching it, she examined the big toe of the left foot.

“This is not Nandlal.”

Mahendra asked, “How do you know?”

“Half the nail of his left big toe was missing. A sickle cut it while he was harvesting paddy.”

She went to the second cot. She looked at the fingers, then near the ear, and shook her head.

“Not this one either.”

Someone said quietly, “Did you check the religion?”

Surti looked towards him but gave no answer. She carefully arranged the cloth over both faces again.

Just then Rahman’s two sons arrived from the west. Their father, Abdul Qayyum, had been missing since the night of the flood. The elder son, Farid, examined the right hand of the first body.

“Father’s middle finger was crooked. This one is straight.”

He asked permission to see the teeth of the second body. Sudhakar called the relief team’s health worker. One of Qayyum’s front teeth had been capped in silver; this body had no such tooth.

Farid stepped back.

Mahendra said, “Then neither of these is yours?”

Farid looked at him. “I want my father. Not a number.”

For a moment after that sentence, the veranda was quiet.

Noon advanced. Even with the sun behind the clouds, the humidity increased. The ice kept beside the bodies was melting. Rekha Kumari, the health worker, said that if the bodies were not identified by evening, both would have to be taken to the cold room at the block hospital.

At that, the argument rose again.

"Once they go there, there will be delay."

"Let there be delay, but not the wrong funeral rites."

"How long can the bodies be kept?"

"Without identification, which rites?"

At one point two young men even took hold of the bamboo of one cot. One said they would take the first body to the eastern hamlet; the other said no body would leave yet. Sudhakar said loudly, "Take your hands off."

The two young men let go, but the hardness did not leave their eyes.

Then Jamir the boatman came up onto the veranda. His clothes were still stained with mud from the Kamla. The first body had been brought in his boat.

Mahendra immediately asked, "Where did you pick him up?"

"From the channel north of the mango orchard."

"Then he must have floated in from the east."

Jamir shook his head. "In this flood the current reversed three times. Things from the east went west, things from the west got caught in the mango orchard. Yesterday my own boat crossed the field and climbed onto the embankment of the pond. You cannot work out a village from the direction of a dead body."

Someone brought up the red thread again.

Jamir looked at the wrist of the first body. "I tied that thread."

Everyone turned towards him.

Mahendra frowned. "Why?"

"It was dark at dawn. I saw three things floating at once that looked like bodies. Two turned out to be tree stumps; this was a body. While lifting it into the boat, a red sack tore. I tied the wrist with a thread from that sack and braced it against the bamboo so the body would not fall back into the water."

Something changed for a moment on Mahendra's face, but he immediately looked towards the black cord on the other body.

"Then this?"

Jamir shrugged. "That I do not know."

The crowd had received half an answer; the other half remained open again.

Karim Mian said, "There may be an amulet inside the cord."

Rekha Kumari said quietly, "Shall we open it to look for a religion? If an examination is needed for identification, it will be done at the hospital. Not as a spectacle here."

At the word "spectacle", some people stepped down from the veranda. Not all.

Later in the afternoon another family arrived—Shambhu's mother, wife and younger brother. His mother began to cry as soon as she saw the first body from a distance, but fell silent when she came close. She looked for an old burn mark on Shambhu's right knee. It was not there. Nor was it on the second body.

"It is not my son," she said. There was no relief in her voice, only the exhaustion of having to continue searching.

As she was leaving, she stopped. Surti was still sitting beside a veranda pillar. "Yours?" Shambhu's mother asked.

Surti said, "No."

The two women looked at each other. Then Shambhu's mother took two old towels from her bag and handed them to Rekha Kumari.

"The ice is melting. There are too many flies. Keep these if they are of any use."

Rekha spread one towel over the face end of the first cot and the other over the second.

Until then, none of the people arguing about religion had noticed that the white cloth kept shifting in the wind.

Before evening, the block vehicle arrived. Preparations were made to take both bodies to the cold room. Sudhakar opened the register.

"Unknown 1," he read.

"Unknown 2."

The box for religion was left blank.

Mahendra asked, "Blank?"

Sudhakar held the tip of his pen over the register and said, "Why should I write what we do not know?"

Karim Mian said nothing.

Four people lifted the first cot and four the second. This time no groups formed. Whoever happened to be standing there took hold of the bamboo. Jamir held the front of the first cot; Mahendra the rear of the second. Farid stood holding open the vehicle door.

Surti walked behind them all.

Just before the vehicle left, she asked Rekha Kumari, "Those two towels will stay with them, won't they?"

"They will."

"If they are identified, will you give them to the family?"

Rekha said, "If they want them, yes."

Surti nodded.

The vehicle passed through the gate. Its wheels left two deep tracks in the wet earth. The crowd slowly dispersed. Only the two empty cots remained on the veranda—on one, a small piece of red thread; on the other, an unfinished guess about a black cord.

Sudhakar picked up the red thread and placed it beside the torn relief sack. He wrote nothing in the register about the black cord.

Outside, Surti and Shambhu's mother set off in different directions to search for their missing people.

The two bodies were still unidentified.

But by evening, at least the urgency to give either of them the wrong religious name had left the school veranda.

STORY 190

Curfew Milk

As dawn broke, two milk cans shone in the courtyard of Badri the milkman. Curfew had been in force for three days. On the first day people managed with the rice and lentils left at home; on the second, sugar began to run short; by the third, milk was what everyone spoke of most. But the lanes were deserted, shop shutters closed, and bamboo barricades blocked the main road.

Every day Badri delivered milk along this route from the northern hamlet to the southern one. At the sound of his bell, a brass lota would appear outside one house, an earthen pot outside another. Half a seer for one family, a quarter for another. Whose name, whose religion—Badri's account book recorded only quantities.

Two cans fitted into the iron frame behind his old bicycle. Near the mouth of the right-hand can was a small dent; a year earlier a child from the southern hamlet had run into it. The peg on the left-hand can had been replaced by the blacksmith from the northern hamlet. Badri did not count such marks as part of his accounts. His accounts recorded only how much milk went to which house, who had paid for how many days, and whose vessel had to be returned the next morning.

On the first morning of curfew he had wheeled the bicycle out through the doorway, but at the sound of a whistle on the main road he had taken it back inside. On the second morning the milk did not sell, so half of it was set as curd and some distributed among neighbours. On the third morning, looking at the full cans, for the first time he was less troubled about wasted milk than about the little girl whose house received a fixed quantity every day.

Two nights earlier, a quarrel had broken out along the route of a procession. After that, slogans turned into bricks and stones. One kiosk burned, two young men were injured, and curfew was imposed by dawn. By the third day, the two hamlets were learning even the news of each other through rumours.

Badri's wife Kamla said as she put the lids on the cans, "Don't go today either. Yesterday they detained two people at the crossing."

Badri gave no answer. He washed a small brass container and set it aside.

Kamla caught his hand. "Who is that for?"

"Maheshwar Sah's granddaughter."

"On that side?"

Badri nodded.

Maheshwar Sah lived in the last lane of the southern hamlet. His granddaughter was seven months old. The child's mother had remained weak since childbirth, so milk from Badri's house went there every day. The previous evening, Ramdhani, who was on watch duty, had stopped at Badri's door for water. In the course of conversation he had said, "The baby at Maheshwar's house has had no milk since yesterday. But I am not telling you to go out after hearing this."

Badri did not forget Ramdhani's words all night.

Kamla said, "Ramdhani told you not to go out."

"He also told me the baby had had no milk."

"Of those two things, why did you forget the first?"

Badri did not smile. He poured one and a half pao of milk from the can into the small container, tightened the lid, wrapped the container in a thick cloth and tucked it beneath his arm.

At the first bend in the lane stood four young men. Under curfew they had no reason to be there, but in three days keeping watch had itself become a kind of occupation. Manoj, one of them, asked the moment he saw Badri, "Where are you going?"

"To deliver milk."

Manoj immediately asked, "To whom?"

Badri looked towards the south.

Manoj frowned. "That side? Even after everything that has happened?"

Badri said, "A baby drinks milk."

Another young man cut in, "Their baby, your worry? Let your own hamlet stay hungry while you go serve that side."

There was still plenty of milk in the cans at Badri's house, but he did not argue. Manoj said again, "If you go over there today, tomorrow no one will trust you at your own door. Don't be hurt when people call you a traitor."

Badri asked only, "Will you let me pass?"

Manoj shifted the bamboo pole to one side, but his face wore an expression as though Badri were carrying not milk but some secret object.

The main road was under police guard. Badri did not go straight towards the crossing. Behind the old oil press ran a narrow lane that filled with water in the rainy season. Today the earth there was dry. He took that lane round and emerged behind the first house of the southern hamlet.

Three young men were keeping watch there too. One of them saw the cloth-wrapped container Badri was carrying. "What is it?"

"Milk."

The young man immediately asked, "From where?"

"From my house."

"Meaning from that side."

Badri nodded.

The young man reached out to touch the container, but Badri stepped back. "Don't open the lid. It is for a baby."

"Whose baby?"

"Maheshwar Sah's granddaughter."

At this, the young man standing behind laughed. "You haven't come into our lane for three days, and today you go straight to Maheshwar's house! Who knows what you have mixed into the milk?"

Badri put the container down on the ground. "Let them boil it. If they do not trust it, let them throw it away."

The first young man said, "And then you'll go back to that side, won't you? Carrying news both ways. Milk here, talk there. Quite a business."

"I sell milk."

"You know what they call someone who keeps a foot in two boats, don't you?"

From behind, someone said quietly, "A traitor."

For the first time Badri looked directly into their eyes. "Not two boats. There was one road. You people have cut it into two pieces."

Before anyone could answer, Sunita, Maheshwar Sah's daughter-in-law, came out of the house. She recognised Badri. "You brought the milk?"

Badri nodded. "Yes."

Sunita picked up the container. The young men did not stop her. One of them merely said, "Boil it first."

"We boil it every day," Sunita replied and went inside.

Badri did not remain there. As he turned to leave, he heard the baby crying from inside. A little later came the clink of a brass bowl. That was all. The crying did not stop at once, nor did anyone come to the doorway to praise Badri. He walked away.

By then two policemen had reached the narrow lane near the oil press. Badri was stopped and asked why he had come out during curfew. He explained. The younger constable scolded him; the older one merely wrote down his name and said, "Sit on this veranda until noon. Go home during the relaxation period."

Badri sat on the veranda empty-handed. On the shutter of the closed shop opposite, two different slogans had been written in charcoal the day before. Between them was a pale stain like dried milk—perhaps from an earlier day when one of his cans had knocked against the spot.

When the midday relaxation began, the road suddenly filled with people. Everyone needed rice, salt, oil, medicine, milk. Badri went home, lifted the cans and came to stand near the crossing. The police said he was not to cross the barricade; people would come from their own sides to collect milk.

People from the northern hamlet came first. Manoj was there too. He had not come for milk, but stood watching. A woman asked for half a seer. Badri dipped the measuring cup into the can.

Manoj immediately said, "Did that measuring cup go to the other side?"

Badri said, "No. This measuring cup did not go to the other side."

"Keep it separate. It must not touch vessels from over there."

Badri said nothing. He sent home for a second measuring cup.

A little later people from the southern hamlet arrived. One young man there saw the second measuring cup and asked at once, "Who was this used for before?"

Badri looked at Manoj, then at the young man. "For this side."

"Then we need a separate one."

Badri was silent for a moment. He did not have a third measuring cup. He thought of washing the first one and bringing it back, but the police relaxation would last only a short while. In the end, he began pouring milk from the can into a small brass bowl and from there filling people's vessels.

Maheshwar Sah himself came last. In his hand was the small container from the morning, washed and covered. He handed it to Badri. Inside were two extra rupees.

Badri took out the coins and placed them back in Maheshwar's palm. "Pay only for the milk."

Maheshwar looked at him for a few moments, then put the coins back in his pocket. "The baby drank it."

Badri only said, "Hmm."

The announcement came that the relaxation period was over. People began returning to their own lanes. As Badri lifted the cans, Manoj said, "From tomorrow, stay on this side. Don't go over there."

From the south came the voice of the young watchman, "And if you come to our side, first tell us where you came from!"

Badri lifted the can not onto his head but against his side. Very little milk remained now.

When he reached home, Kamla asked, "How was it today?"

Badri washed the two measuring cups and placed them on separate wooden seats. Then he poured the little milk left at the bottom of the can into an earthen pot.

Kamla asked again, "Will you go tomorrow?"

Badri said, "If there is a relaxation, I will go."

For the morning, Kamla again set aside the two measuring cups separately—one for the northern hamlet, one for the southern. Badri said nothing.

The two measuring cups were separate. The milk can was one.

STORY 191

The Broken Slipper

At the western corner of the crossing, the temporary bamboo barricade was half broken. Fifteen minutes earlier, the evening crowd had pushed through it while fleeing. Now grains of rice, two glass bangles, an overturned basket and a blue slipper lay on the road. The slipper's front strap had been torn away at the base; there was old stitching near the heel, and a dark red stain in the middle.

Journalist Arun Jha bent near the slipper. The photographer with him had not arrived, so he took two pictures with his small camera. Nearby, police were moving people away. Half the market shutters were closed; from the other half, people were peering through cracks in doorways.

Arun asked the paan seller, "Whose slipper is this?"

The shopkeeper shook his head. "How would I know? The crowd ran. I saw a woman fall, that's all."

"Did she get up?"

"Then the smoke came. I pulled down my shutter."

The boy at the medicine shop ahead said, "I saw someone being loaded onto a rickshaw."

"A woman?"

"It was far away. I can't say."

Arun noted: a woman fell; someone was put onto a rickshaw; a slipper was left behind. He had to send a report for the night edition. The editor had told him on the phone, "Don't send dry numbers. Find the human being inside the event."

Arun looked again at the slipper. The red stain held his attention. A police constable said, "Don't touch it. It will be removed when the road is cleared."

Arun asked, "Does it look like blood?"

The constable bent down and looked without touching it. "I can't say."

That "I can't say" did not go into Arun's notes. Instead, he wrote—"red stain."

That night, beneath a bold headline on the newspaper's front page appeared: "One Slipper, One Woman, and a Fleeing Market." In the report, Arun wrote that the blue slipper might be the last trace of an unknown woman who had lost it while running for her life from a violent crowd. He called the red stain "blood-like", and turned the unconfirmed account of someone being lifted onto a rickshaw into "people carried away the injured woman". At the end he

wrote: "Whether the owner is alive or not could not be established by nightfall."

In the morning, the photograph in the report was widely seen. At the shops, people pointed to the slipper and began adding stories of their own. Someone said the woman was from the other neighbourhood. Someone said she had a child with her. Someone looked at the red stain and said with certainty that she had been injured. Arun's written "blood-like" became simply "blood" in people's mouths.

At nine, a reporter from a neighbouring town called Arun and asked, "Did the woman die, or is she in hospital?" Arun said, "Neither has been verified." The reply came, "But your report says 'last trace'." Arun tried to explain that 'last trace' was a possibility, not a death notice. The only answer from the other end was, "We'll cite your report."

After putting down the phone, Arun reread his printed copy. He saw that wherever he had tried to be cautious by writing 'might be', 'like', and 'could not be established', all those words had become small beside the certainty of the headline. For the first time he understood that conjecture had wings faster than the sentences he had written; but he still did not know that before noon, the owner of the slipper would be standing in front of him.

At around eleven, a woman came to the newsroom door. On one foot she wore the other half of an old pair of blue slippers; the other foot was bare. Under one arm she carried an empty bamboo basket. The sole of her bare foot had turned grey in the sun.

She told the guard, "Call the journalist who wrote the story about the slipper."

Arun came out. The woman held the newspaper folded in her hand. Her finger rested on the photograph on the front page.

"Did you pick up this slipper?"

"No. The police probably removed it when they cleared the road. Why?"

"It's mine."

Arun looked first at her foot, then at the photograph. Near the heel was the same kind of stitching in yellow thread.

"You... were there?"

The woman did not smile. "If I had not been there, would the slipper have flown there by itself?"

Arun had a chair brought. "Sit down. Your name?"

"Shakuntala Devi. Before you write my name, tell me this—why did you turn me into a dead woman?"

"I did not write that you were dead. I wrote that it was not clear."

"First you wrote 'last trace', then 'not clear'. Which will the reader remember, the first thing or the second?"

Arun's hand stopped on his file. "Then tell me what happened."

Shakuntala spread the newspaper on the table. “First look at this red stain. You wrote blood.”

“Blood-like.”

“It was tomato.”

She turned the basket over and showed him. At the bottom was a dried red layer of crushed tomato. “I sell vegetables. The crowd shoved me, the basket fell, the tomatoes were crushed. The slipper fell into them.”

Arun kept his eyes fixed on the sentence about the red stain.

Shakuntala continued, “The strap was already weak. It tore when I ran. If I had kept one slipper on and one foot bare, I would have fallen. So I took off the other one too. The one I’m wearing now was picked up later by a boy from the lane and given back to me.”

“You were running from the crowd?”

“Everyone was running. But first I turned back towards my basket. The day’s earnings were tied in a cloth inside it. If you write that, people will say money was dearer to me than my life.”

Arun said at once, “I won’t write it like that.”

“You didn’t ask me the first time either. What did you write then?”

For a few moments, only the sound of the fan filled the room.

Shakuntala said, “While I was lifting the basket, I saw Chhotan fall. His mother sells bangles. That day he was closing the stall alone. People were running over him. I dropped the basket again and pulled him up. Another handcart man helped me. The person people saw being put on the rickshaw was Chhotan, not me.”

“How is Chhotan?”

“His knee is scraped. He’ll be back at the stall tomorrow.”

Immediately another headline rose inside Arun—“Woman Believed Dead Was Saving a Child.” He picked up his pen. Shakuntala was watching his hand.

“Now don’t turn me into a goddess,” she said. “I first went back to save my money. Then I saw the child and pulled him up. That makes me neither a sinner nor a goddess.”

Arun put the pen down.

The editor came out from inside. When he heard the news, his eyes lit up. “This could be tomorrow’s second front-page story. The owner is alive, and she saved a child!”

Shakuntala looked at him. “I came to collect my slipper. Not to give you a story.”

The editor was silent for a moment. “The slipper will be with the police. We’ll get it for you. But what we printed wrongly must be corrected.”

“Print the correction. Do not write about me what you did not see.”

That same evening Arun went back to the crossing. The boy at the medicine shop identified Chhotan. There was a bandage on Chhotan’s knee. He said,

“Shakuntala Kaki pulled me up by the hand. I was the one who went on the rickshaw.” The handcart man said the same. The paan seller admitted that he had not seen the woman fall, only bend down; in the confusion of the crowd, he had made an assumption.

In one corner of the police post was a sack containing objects collected after the incident. Arun found the blue slipper. Its strap was indeed broken. The red stain had dried to a dark red-black. Beside the stain, a tiny tomato seed was stuck—the detail his eyes had missed on the first day.

The correction appeared the next morning, but not on the front page. On an inside page, under a two-column headline, it said—“Owner of Blue Slipper Is Alive.” In the first sentence, the newspaper admitted that the previous day’s report had presented unverified assumptions as though they were facts. The second stated that the red stain was from crushed tomato. The third gave Chhotan’s account.

The editor asked Arun, “So short? Where has the human angle gone?”

Arun said, “There is as much as has been verified.”

At noon he took the slipper to Shakuntala’s cart. She was arranging tomatoes. Taking the slipper in her hand, she felt the stitching near the heel, then examined the broken strap.

“It can be repaired,” she said.

“Buy a new pair,” Arun blurted out.

Shakuntala smiled. “A new pair may be cheap for newspaper people. Stitching is cheaper for me.”

The cobbler nearby put two stitches into the strap. Shakuntala put on the slipper and walked two steps. Then she returned to the basket.

Arun took out a copy of the correction to give her. Shakuntala took the paper, read the headline, folded it inward and placed it beneath the basket.

“All right now?” Arun asked.

Shakuntala ran a finger over the slipper strap. “The slipper is all right. You decide about the news.”

Arun turned and walked away. As he crossed the square, he opened his notebook. On the previous day’s page were the words—“red stain.” Beside those two words he drew a small arrow and wrote—“crushed tomato; verified.”

STORY 192

The Locked Room

By half past five in the morning, the shutters of the shops in the textile market on the western side of the city had begun to rise. On the second floor of the last building in the lane, one room was still closed off with three girls inside. There was no heavy padlock on the door from outside, only an iron chain; yet for the three adolescent girls within, that chain had blocked every road in the city for four months.

Fifteen-year-old Neelam had been told that she would learn sewing, earn four thousand rupees a month, and within two years be able to pay for her younger sister's schooling. For the first week, the broker who had brought her from the village came twice a day. After that, the owner's wife would leave food, slide half-finished lengths of cloth into the room, and count the completed pieces in the evening. The girls were allowed out of the room only as far as a narrow corner of the roof, and even then someone always stood outside the door.

To count the days, Neelam scratched small lines into the wall with her fingernail. After a while there were so many lines that she had to count them all over again. Then she changed her method: she began tying small knots, one for each day, into an old piece of cloth using thread given for sewing. She kept the cloth inside her pillowcase.

That morning, heavy footsteps suddenly sounded on the stairs. First came the owner's voice, then someone else's, hard and firm—"Open the door." Inside, the three girls looked at one another. Malti, the oldest, picked up a bundle of thread and pushed it into a corner. Neelam clutched the pillowcase in her lap.

The chain rattled. The moment the door opened, the light from the lane flooded suddenly into the room. With the light came five or six people, two women, a police officer, and several unfamiliar faces craning from the staircase behind them. One person had a camera raised in his hand.

The woman standing in front said, "We are from the district child-protection team. Do not be afraid. We are going to take all of you out of here."

Instead of feeling happy at seeing the door open for the first time, Neelam pulled the end of her sari over her head. At the mouth of the staircase, the round eye of the camera was looking straight into the room.

"Move back," the woman police officer said. "No photographs."

But by then there had already been one flash. For a moment Neelam's eyes turned white with light, then dark.

The raid papers were read out. The room was measured. Three sewing machines, twelve half-finished salwars, two iron trunks, one water jar and a window fastened shut from inside were entered into the record. The things that had been Neelam's entire world for four months were becoming an inventory.

The building owner came up the stairs and began saying that the three girls had come to "learn", that there was no confinement. Rashmi pointed to the bolt on the inside of the door, the plank nailed across the window, and the three pairs of old slippers kept in the corner. "If they came to learn, who decides when they may go outside?" At that question, the owner looked first at his wife, then at the police officer. No answer came at once.

The question startled Neelam. In four months, no one had asked her where she wanted to go. She had only been told—sit, sew, eat, go to the roof, do not go downstairs now. Hearing the question, she remembered the village market, where her mother would sometimes say, "Choose for yourself what you want." Here, she had not even been given a choice about the food on her plate.

"Name?" asked the young man making the record.

"Neelam Kumari."

"Age?"

"Fifteen," Neelam said softly.

"The full name of your village?"

She gave the full name of her village. The young man asked again, "Who brought you here?"

Neelam gave the broker's name. A murmur ran through the people standing on the stairs. Someone said, "So this sort of thing was going on in this building?" Another said, "We had no idea at all."

Neelam felt like asking: if no one had known anything, why did so many people want to look now?

Rashmi, the woman from the child-protection team, began clearing the staircase. "Anyone who is not part of this operation, go downstairs."

From below came another question: "How many girls were found? How many days had they been locked up?" A police officer opened his mouth to give the number, but Rashmi raised a hand to stop him. "First get them out. Count later." The remark seemed small to Neelam, yet something inside her loosened. For the first time that morning, they were not three numbers but three people.

A newspaper representative said, "It is a matter of public interest. We only need one image."

Rashmi looked straight at him. "For the public interest, photograph the room, not the child's face."

Hearing that sentence, Neelam looked properly at Rashmi for the first time.

Before the three girls were taken out, they were told to collect whatever belongings they had. Malti had one bag. The third girl, Rukhsana, had nothing. Neelam opened the pillowcase and took out the knotted cloth. Rashmi asked, “Do you want to keep that?”

“Yes.”

“Is anything written on it?”

“Days.”

Rashmi asked nothing further.

As she came down the stairs, Neelam understood that having a road open out of a room was not the same as being out of other people’s gaze. A police vehicle stood in the lane. Shop shutters were half raised, and people leaned out beneath them. Two cameras rose again. The woman police officer spread her dupatta between the three girls and the crowd like a screen.

“Why are you hiding their faces?” someone called out.

Malti stopped walking. In a low voice she said, “Because this is my face.”

Once inside the vehicle, Neelam turned her back to the window. After four months the road was moving outside, but she did not look at it. Someone’s voice came from beyond the vehicle—“The rescued girls!” The words struck the metal body and entered. Neelam tightened her fist around the knotted cloth.

The first place they were taken was not the police station but a temporary protection room. There they were again asked their names, ages, villages, and the names of their parents. Neelam answered. A third time, a form was prepared for a medical examination. A fourth time, the admission register at the shelter home. The questions were almost the same everywhere; only the people asking them were different.

By noon Neelam’s voice had grown thin. The fifth time, an officer asked, “Why were you brought to the city?”

At the same time, a worker from an organisation was telling someone on the phone, “Three girl children have been rescued.” Neelam heard the word “rescued”. It did not seem wrong to her, only incomplete. If being rescued meant having to tell the same event five times in front of different people, then this day was not over yet.

Neelam remained silent.

The officer asked again.

Rashmi intervened. “This has already been recorded. Do not ask it again unless it is necessary.”

The officer frowned. “It is procedure.”

“Count the child’s fatigue as part of the procedure too,” Rashmi said.

By evening the matter had become a pile of papers. Legal staff, organisation workers, medical personnel—everyone was completing their own part. Neelam understood that many of these people wanted what was best for her. Even so, whenever a door opened without a knock, she started.

Once, two unfamiliar women came inside and began talking to Malti. A young man with them stood at the door taking notes. Neelam asked Rashmi quietly, "Have they come to look at us, or to listen to us?" Rashmi was silent for a moment, then said, "If you do not want it, no stranger will meet you now." She went outside and put a notice on the door: "Permission before entry."

Neelam could not read the notice from a distance. But later, when a staff member wanted to come in, he stopped at the door and asked, "May I come in?" Without thinking, Neelam replied, "Yes, come in." That small question seemed to her as different as a shuttered window and an open sky.

In the shelter home, she was given a bed in a small room. There was a grille over the window, and the door could be locked from inside. The attendant, Meera, showed her in and then, before leaving, put a hand on the door and asked, "Shall I close it, or leave it open?"

Neelam looked at Meera for a moment, trying to understand the question. For the first time in four months, the state of a door was going to be decided by what she wanted.

"Halfway," she said.

Meera pulled the door halfway closed. "I am outside. Call if you need anything."

That night Neelam opened the knotted cloth. The last knot was from that morning. She untied it, but did not throw the cloth away. She did not feel like undoing all the other knots; those days had passed, but they could not be erased.

After a while she heard two staff members talking in the corridor—tomorrow a statement before a judicial officer, then contact with the family, then a decision. "Some people will want to meet her tomorrow," one voice said.

Neelam looked at the half-open gap of the door. She got up and closed the door completely. From inside, she slid the bolt into place. This time, hearing a door close did not make her body tremble.

A few moments later Meera knocked softly twice from outside.

"Neelam?"

"Yes, I'm awake."

"Shall I leave some water?"

Neelam opened the bolt and made only enough of a gap for the water jar to pass through. Meera placed it inside and stepped back. No face leaned into the room, no question came.

Neelam closed the door again. She put the knotted cloth back inside the pillowcase. The locked room of four months and the locked door of this night were not the same. The key to the first had been in someone else's hand; the bolt on this door lay beneath her own fingers.

STORY 193

The Scar

The fan was running in the district assistance office, but Bimla Devi sat with a blue shawl drawn tightly over her shoulders. It was the humid month of Bhadon. Her file lay open on the desk in front of her, with "Assistance for Victim of Violence" written across it in red letters.

Turning over the papers, the committee member seated on the other side of the desk said, "The medical report is here. There is also a copy of the police-station register. But if the scar mentioned here could be seen once, the matter would become clear."

At first Bimla thought she had misheard. Her fingers stopped on the edge of the shawl.

"What is to be seen?" she asked.

"The scar on your arm," the member said casually. "Just one look. That much will make the decision quicker."

Above Bimla's left elbow was a long, crooked scar. Six months earlier, during a quarrel at night, the edge of broken glass had cut her. She had needed stitches. The hospital papers recorded the length, location and depth of the wound. The police had written down her statement. She had also told a judicial officer what had happened. Even so, after all that, her arm was being asked to appear again.

Her cousin Manju, who had come with her, said quietly, "Show them. Then the work will be over."

Bimla did not look at Manju. "Whose work?"

For a moment the room was silent.

The committee member tapped a pen against the file. "We have to see proof. Many applications come in for this assistance."

"The proof is in the papers."

The committee member pulled a thin sheet from the file. "The other side has submitted a written objection saying this mark could be from an old accident."

For the first time Bimla leaned towards the paper. "When did they see my arm?"

"That is what they have written."

"And if you see it, will you know how old the scar is?"

Unease crossed the committee member's face. "I am not a doctor. But verification of the application—"

Rukmini interrupted softly, "The medical report records an examination from when the wound was fresh. The answer to that objection is already there."

It seemed to Bimla that the mark on her body had now become a third document between two pieces of paper—one paper said there had been a wound, another said perhaps there had not, and the third piece of proof was being demanded from her skin.

"Other people write the papers."

"Who writes this body?" Bimla asked.

The member's fingers stopped. No immediate answer occurred to him.

Rukmini, the junior clerk seated beside him, bent over the file. "The medical report contains the identifying mark, the number of stitches and the date of examination," she said. "If another inspection is necessary, it can be done in the medical room in the presence of a woman employee."

The committee member glanced at Rukmini. "I was only suggesting a way to shorten the procedure."

Bimla thought: for six months, everyone had wanted to shorten the procedure for her. At the police station a woman had said, "Raise your arm a little." At the hospital the dressing had been opened three times. The lawyer had said, "If they ask in court, do not be nervous." Two women from the village had come to her house and said, "We are your own people; show us, what exactly happened?" An organisation had asked for a photograph—not her face, only the scar—so they could use it in "public awareness" material.

Each time, Bimla had wondered whether the scar was on her arm or in other people's eyes.

When she came out of the committee room, a woman from an organisation was waiting in the corridor. Her name was Rekha. She already knew Bimla.

"Was there a decision?" Rekha asked.

"They will look at the papers."

"Did they see the scar?"

Bimla remained silent.

Softening her voice, Rekha said, "Please do not take it the wrong way. Sometimes when clear proof is right in front of people, they fall silent. If you want, I can take a photograph in such a way that your face does not appear."

"Which people will fall silent?"

"Those who say the incident has been exaggerated."

"If they see my arm, will they believe it?"

Rekha took a breath before answering. "At least they will have fewer excuses."

Bimla loosened her shawl. The mark lay beneath the cloth on her arm. She did not want to show the scar; she only wanted to ease the fabric. Rekha's eyes went there instinctively, then immediately moved away.

"I do not want this mark to become everyone's property," Bimla said.

Rekha asked quietly, "But for justice?"

"I have given what is necessary for justice. Everyone's curiosity is not justice."

No decision was made in the assistance office that day. The file was held over with the note, "Whether additional examination is required." On the way home, Manju tried several times to say something, but seeing Bimla's face, she remained silent.

When Bimla reached home, she took off the shawl and hung it on a peg. In the courtyard, her mother Dhaniya was sorting lentils. She looked at her daughter and asked nothing. She only said, "The rice is on the fire. Wash your hands and face."

That ordinary sentence gave Bimla relief. There were still people at home who could speak of things that did not begin with the scar.

In the evening, Sita Kaki from next door came and sat with her mother on the veranda. Bimla was inside the room, but she could hear them clearly.

"I heard she will receive assistance," Sita Kaki said.

"The meeting is still pending," Dhaniya replied.

"Is the scar very large?"

The lentils in Dhaniya's winnowing tray stopped rattling. After a few moments she said, "Ask whether my daughter is large or the scar."

Sita Kaki changed the subject. Bimla did not come out. She liked her mother's answer, but she also understood that the scar had now crossed the walls of the house and become neighbourhood talk.

That night, while bathing, a slight sting rose when water touched her left arm. The wound had healed, but the skin pulled tight like something hardened. She touched the edge of the mark with a finger. The whole night of the incident returned to her not when she looked at the scar, but through that pulling sensation—the sound of the door being pushed shut, broken glass, the oil lamp fallen on the floor, and the three-kos road to her mother's house.

There were no other people's eyes in that memory. That was why Bimla felt the memory was her own.

The next day a message came from Rukmini that the medical room had decided no re-examination was necessary. The first report was sufficient; the committee would decide the file at its next meeting.

Manju was pleased to hear it. "See? Now the matter is settled."

Bimla did not smile. "Is the matter settled, or has my arm been spared?"

This time Manju did not laugh either. She simply held Bimla's hand and walked with her for a while.

Three days later there was a women's meeting in the village. Rekha had invited Bimla. The subject was silence about violence inside the home. Bimla spent until afternoon deciding whether to go. In the end she went, but said beforehand that she would not sit on the stage.

The meeting began. Two women spoke of their experiences. One widow said that no marks from the beatings remained on her body, but the fear of years still woke her at night. Hearing this, Bimla looked at her closely for the first time.

Then Rekha said, "Among us is a sister whose body bears a clear mark of violence—"

Bimla rose from her seat.

Rekha stopped mid-sentence.

Everyone at the meeting looked towards Bimla. Some eyes held sympathy, some curiosity, some the expectation of seeing the thing that had not yet been shown.

Bimla did not go towards the stage. Standing where she was, she said, "My name is Bimla. My statement is in the papers. I will say what I wish to say. My arm is not an exhibit for everyone."

No one applauded immediately. Bimla liked that. Applause too could sometimes become another form of staring.

Rekha lowered her head. "All right," she said. "Say only what you wish to say."

Bimla sat down. That day she did not say a single word from the stage.

After the meeting she went straight to Nasima, the tailor at the market. The left sleeve of her old kurta rubbed against the scar. Spreading out the cloth, Nasima said, "Raise your arm a little so I can take the measurement."

Bimla paused for a moment, then removed the shawl herself and raised her arm.

Nasima's eyes fell on the scar. She asked neither "What happened?" nor "Who did it?" She simply measured the cloth at a finger's distance and marked it with chalk. "Shall I keep the seam a little farther out here?" Nasima asked. Bimla placed a finger on the scar and said, "Yes. Let the cloth not rub here."

Nasima began measuring the other sleeve. The conversation moved on to the colour of the cloth, the neckline and the buttons. Bimla lowered her arm. The scar remained where it was. Its measurements were written in documents, its night lived in memory. But in this small shop, she had told only where the seam should not fall.

STORY 194

The Night Truck

By ten at night, a yellow truck had come to a halt behind the closed warehouse at Belaha Crossing. Of the three electric lights across the road, two were out. In the light of the one still burning, faded patches of old lettering could be seen on the truck's body, and a blue tarpaulin tied over the back.

Under the warehouse awning, twenty-two labourers sat with their bundles gathered around them. One had clothes tied in a sheet, another a brass plate, another two pairs of torn garments. After seven months in the city carrying bricks, lifting iron rods and plastering walls, this was all the property they had left. Work had stopped three weeks earlier; the contractor had paid half their wages and said—now fend for yourselves.

Since evening Lalit Sah had been explaining to everyone, “Not just to the border. We’ll cross the border and drop you at Barahiya Bend. From there, each of you takes your own road. Fifteen hundred per person. A child would be half fare, but there are no children. No getting off midway.”

“Fifteen hundred is too much,” said Jagdish Paswan. In his pocket were two thousand five hundred rupees he had saved to buy medicine for his mother once he reached home.

Lalit looked at him as though, along with the fare, the road itself were his private property. “Then walk. The border is seven kos away. The police will stop you at night, the sun will burn you by day. I am taking the risk, and risk has a price.”

Badri Yadav, the truck driver, came to the back and checked the knots of the tarpaulin. “Not twenty-two,” he said to Lalit. “You told me twenty.”

“Two more joined. The money will increase.”

Badri looked inside. “We’ll talk about the money later. Don’t tie the tarpaulin completely tight. Leave this back corner open by a hand’s breadth.”

Lalit said at once, “If it stays open, they’ll be seen at the checkpoint.”

“If it stays closed, people will suffocate inside.” Badri left the knot half loose. “The vehicle is mine. There are people inside, not sacks.”

Lalit laughed. “A lot of righteousness has awakened in you now. Remember it when you take your money.”

The labourers climbed in one by one. Beneath the tarpaulin, the smells of diesel, rope, old onion sacks and human sweat mingled together. Jagdish sat near the open corner at the back. Beside him was Sito Devi, who carried sand with a construction crew. Her husband had returned to the village two years

earlier; she had left her daughter with her mother-in-law and worked in the city.

When the truck moved, everyone's body tilted in the same direction at once. No one laughed. Once the first bend was behind them, the lights outside grew fewer. Through the small gap in the blue tarpaulin, night air entered like a narrow stream. Sito turned her face towards it.

After about an hour, the vehicle suddenly slowed. Badri gave two short signals—the sign Lalit had explained earlier meant they were near a checkpoint. Conversation inside stopped at once. Reaching forward, Lalit pulled the gap in the tarpaulin tight. The darkness thickened.

Jagdish whispered, "Leave it open."

"Quiet," Lalit's voice came back. "Two minutes."

Two minutes grew long. The truck moved, then stopped. From outside, the beam of a torch swept across the tarpaulin. Someone barked, "What's in the back?"

Badri answered, "Empty sacks."

At that instant someone inside coughed. One cough, then another. The torchlight stopped on the tarpaulin.

"Open the knot."

Lalit's body went rigid. Badri said something, but the voice outside remained hard. The knot was opened. Cold night air rushed in, along with light. Sub-Inspector Jaikant at the checkpoint looked at every face, one by one.

"Everyone get down," he said.

No one had the courage to object. On the barren earth beside the road, the twenty-two labourers stood in something like a line. Ahead of the border post, a thick white-painted line cut across the road. On this side was one state, on the other another. Far away in the dark, the light of the other checkpoint flickered.

Jaikant asked Badri, "Why are there people in a goods vehicle?"

Badri said evenly, "Sahib, they've been stranded for three weeks. I was returning empty. I thought I'd drop them off."

Lalit cut in, "We are helping them. There are no buses, no trains. People will die on the road."

Jaikant looked at the labourers. "How much did you pay?"

For a few moments no one spoke. Then Sito said, "Fifteen hundred."

A voice from the other side said, "Same for me."

Then three or four people repeated it together. Badri turned towards Lalit. "You told me eight hundred per person," he said quietly but clearly.

Lalit narrowed his eyes. "Finding the route, understanding the checkpoints, gathering people—does all that happen for free?"

"Then don't call it help," Sito said. "Call it business."

Lalit's lips tightened. "If I weren't doing business, all of you would still be sitting behind that warehouse."

Jaikant raised a hand and stopped the argument. “Do not hold a council over accounts in front of me. The rule is clear—passengers cannot cross the border like this in a goods truck.”

“Then where are we supposed to go?” Jagdish asked.

“Go back where you came from. Arrangements will be looked into in the morning.”

At this, unease spread through the line. Someone said the warehouse owner would not let them back in now. Someone else said arrangements for the morning had been promised for the last two days as well. Sito remained silent, but held the knot of her bundle tightly in both hands.

Jaikant listened to everyone for a while. The constable standing behind him said, “Sir, impound the truck. Action will be taken against the driver.”

“If we impound it, these twenty-two people will be left here by the roadside,” Jaikant said. “There is no room in the shelter home at this hour.”

Lalit immediately came closer and tried to say something in a low voice. Jaikant stepped back two paces. “No tea-and-snacks talk. Whatever you have to say, say it in front of everyone.”

Badri kept looking towards the open corner of the tarpaulin. “If my vehicle is seized, the owner will dismiss me. I did not take these people’s fare; what was fixed for me was for diesel and the risk.”

“Risk?” Jagdish exclaimed.

Badri looked at him. “Yes, risk. If we are caught, all of you will look for another way home. I will lose my livelihood.”

“I have already lost mine,” Jagdish said. But after that sentence, no one said anything. Night spread over the road again.

Jaikant went to the checkpoint desk. He turned over some papers, looked at the time, then at the white line across the road. After a while he came back out. “The truck will cross the border empty. All of you will cross the line on foot. Three hundred paces beyond it there is an old peepal tree. The vehicle will stop there. From this checkpoint, I will not allow passengers to cross in a goods vehicle.”

Lalit’s eyes lit up. “That’s all? Come on, come on.”

The constable looked at Jaikant in surprise. “Sir—”

Jaikant stopped him. “I will write what I see—the vehicle was checked empty and allowed through. The people went on foot. What happens on the other side is not my responsibility.”

Sito looked first at the white line, then at Jaikant. “Meaning the rule will also survive, and we will also be counted as having crossed?”

Jaikant did not answer.

The twenty-two labourers lifted their bundles. Bodies that had sat cramped inside the truck for an hour had to learn to walk again. The white line was not very wide, but that night, to none of them was it merely paint. One by one, they

crossed. When Jagdish reached the line, he instinctively looked back. Badri was slowly driving the empty truck forward; Lalit sat beside him; Jaikant stood in the checkpoint light.

He had said three hundred paces, but the peepal tree appeared after five hundred. When they reached it, Sito put her bundle down on the earth. The soles of her feet were burning. Some people sat down beside the road.

The truck arrived. Badri got down and opened the rear flap. "Climb in quickly. There will be more checks ahead."

Lalit began counting again—"One, two, three..."

Sito did not climb in. "For fifteen hundred, the agreement was that the truck would take us across the border."

"You did cross," Lalit said.

"I crossed on my own feet."

"I made the route possible."

"The police saved the rule, the driver saved the vehicle, you saved your earnings," Sito said calmly. "Did you ask what we saved?"

For a moment Lalit had no answer. Then he said, "You'll reach home. Is that nothing?"

Sito did not reply. She climbed into the truck, because home was still very far away.

Badri began tying the tarpaulin. This time Jagdish left the rear corner open by more than a hand's breadth. Badri saw it but did not come to tighten it. "A lot of dust will get in," he merely said.

"Let it," Jagdish replied. "Air will get in too."

The truck moved on. Through the gap in the blue tarpaulin, the lights of the border post grew smaller. Lalit sat in front adding up his accounts; Badri measured the road ahead; behind them, Jaikant would be writing in his register that an empty truck had been checked. Inside, the twenty-two labourers were once again pressed against one another.

Sito put her bundle beneath her feet and turned her face towards the gap in the tarpaulin. Air was coming in. They had crossed the border, but as to whose mercy, whose business and whose rule governed that short stretch of night, everyone had a different answer. Only the five hundred paces they had walked hurt alike in every body.

STORY 195

The Identification Tag

In the rear veranda of the district hospital, the smell of ice and the smell of wet earth seemed to be fighting one another. The night's unrest had subsided, but bamboo barricades still stood between the city's two neighbourhoods. At daybreak, three bodies had been brought to the hospital. Two had been identified; from the wrist of the third hung a small tag tied with string—"Unknown, approximately thirty-five years old, possibly from the western neighbourhood."

The word "possibly" was small, but that day it carried great weight in the city.

By noon, Naseem's brother Salman and sister Zahira reached the hospital. Naseem had not returned home since the previous night. He was a tailor and in the evenings brought cloth home from a shop in the market. His route passed through the crossing where stones had been thrown the night before.

A police constable stopped the two of them outside the veranda. "First give a description."

Salman said, "Age thirty-seven. An old cut mark behind the right ear. Half the little toe on the left foot is missing. Inside the armpit seam of his shirt, he stitches with blue thread himself."

The constable kept writing on the paper. Then he asked, "Religion?"

Zahira looked once at Salman. From beyond the bamboo barricade came sounds like slogans.

"His name is Naseem Ansari," Salman said quietly.

The constable stopped his pen. "The external tag on this body says western neighbourhood."

"What does that prove?"

"It means that in the list of last night's dead, they are being counted separately. A lot of people outside are asking for numbers."

Zahira asked, "Are we to look at the body or the list?"

The constable said nothing. He went inside, and a short while later an employee came and took them to the cold-room door.

As soon as the sheet was lifted, Zahira's breath caught. The face was swollen, one part of the forehead covered with a dressing. But the cut mark behind the ear was there. Salman bent towards the feet. Half the little toe was missing. Then he turned up the armpit seam of the shirt—uneven stitches in blue thread.

Zahira pulled the sheet back up. "This is Naseem."

The employee opened the tag. "Think once more. Information has already gone out saying western neighbourhood."

Salman's face hardened. "If the information is wrong, correct it."

The employee's eyes went towards the door. "Correct is an easy word. The name will change on the papers, the religion will change, the count will change. The people outside who are already claiming three of the dead as theirs will say two. The other side will gain one. After that, who will ask how Naseem died? Where he was found? Whose crowd it was?"

"All those questions should be asked," Zahira said.

"They should. But also think about which road you will take home tonight."

Silence spread through the veranda.

Naseem's house was in a narrow lane in the northern neighbourhood. At the mouth of that lane, a handcart had been burned the previous day. At night Salman had seen the flames from inside the window. Their mother Sakina was still at home with two grandchildren. Zahira thought—if Naseem's full name and religion went onto the list, the crowd might carry that name to the house before the body ever reached it.

The employee said, "The identification tag will not be changed yet. First meet the officer in charge."

There were three chairs and five people in the officer's room. On the desk lay two registers, one seal, and half a glass of tea. From outside, journalists were calling questions—"How many dead? From which neighbourhood?"

The officer listened to Salman's statement. "Are the identifying marks clear?"

"Three marks," Salman said.

"Any identity card?"

"At home. None was found on the body."

"Then we can make a provisional identification. But the community name has already gone onto the public list."

Zahira asked, "Why was the community name put there?"

A clerk said, "There was a red thread on the wrist. The body was found near the western lane. It was a rushed night."

Zahira immediately remembered Naseem's wrist. "A red thread?"

She went back to the cold room. Beneath the sheet, there really was a faded red thread around the right wrist. Zahira looked at it without touching.

"My daughter tied this thread at the Sonapur fair last year," she said. "The little girl liked the colour and tied it on him. Naseem did not cut it off. He used to say—you should not quickly undo a knot tied by a child's hand."

The clerk's face changed. "How were we supposed to know that?"

"You could not know. Then why did you turn a guess into a religion?"

The employee placed a finger on the word “possibly” on the tag. “That is why ‘possibly’ was written.”

“Did ‘possibly’ reach the list outside?”

The employee remained silent.

Outside in the corridor, two young men were arguing. One said, “Three of our people are gone.” The other said, “Add a name to our side too.” The number of bodies had become like counters in a neighbourhood-by-neighbourhood account.

Salman took Zahira into a corner. “The name has to be corrected.”

“Yes. This is Naseem.”

“But if the religion goes onto the public list?”

“Mother is at home.”

“And the children?”

Zahira looked at the wall, where plaster was flaking away. “If we leave the wrong name, Naseem’s final paper will remain under a name that was not his.”

“And if we write the truth, the living are at risk?”

Neither of them had an answer.

Meanwhile an elderly cleaner, Ramsevak, stopped while crossing the veranda with a mop. He knew Naseem; Naseem had stitched his grandson’s school uniform. “Was this Naseem the tailor?”

Salman said yes.

Ramsevak silently bowed his head. Then he looked at the tag. “Why does it say western neighbourhood here?”

Zahira merely pointed towards the red thread.

Ramsevak said nothing for a long time. Then, showing his own wrist, he said, “There is a black thread on my hand. Can you work out my full name from that?”

The question travelled back to the desk. The officer called for the tag. The red thread, place found, clothing—each was written separately as a note. At the box marked “community”, the clerk’s pen stopped again.

“Write what the family says,” the constable said.

Salman’s face tightened again.

Zahira pulled out a chair and sat down. “Write Naseem’s name. Father—Yusuf. Home—Madhubani Lane, northern neighbourhood. Identification—cut behind the ear, missing part of toe, blue stitching. Leave the religion box blank on the public tag.”

The clerk said, “The rules do not allow us to leave it blank.”

“Then write whatever is necessary in the internal register. On the tag tied to his wrist outside, write only the name and serial number.”

The officer thought for a while. “Make two tags. One for identification in the cold room, one for public information. No community on the public tag.”

“And the list that already went outside?” Salman asked.

"We will issue a correction. But no community will be given with the name."

Outside, the journalists were asking questions again. The officer came to the door and said, "The unidentified deceased has been identified by the family as Naseem Ansari. The initial community classification is withdrawn. Further inquiry will continue."

A voice called, "Which community?"

The officer replied, "For identification, the name is sufficient."

Another voice asked, "Which side should the death count be added to?"

"Add the death count to the dead."

Hearing that sentence did not bring Zahira relief. Naseem could not come back. But at least his body would not be given another name in the quarrel over numbers.

The paperwork continued until evening. There was no immediate way to send word home; Salman sent an acquaintance on a bicycle with the news. After sunset, the crowd outside the hospital gate grew again. The police said it would not be safe to take the body home at night.

Salman grew restless. "Mother is waiting."

Zahira said, "Let the news reach our living mother first. The body will go in the morning."

That night Zahira remained seated in the veranda. A new tag hung on the cold-room door—"Naseem Ansari, No. 3." Nothing more. The red thread was mentioned in the internal register; it was not interpreted.

In the morning, the hearse arrived. Naseem's body was covered with a white sheet. Salman asked, "People in the lane at home will ask his religion again."

Straightening the edge of the sheet, Zahira said, "Anyone who comes to our house, we will tell them Naseem's name. Anyone who comes to demand a count, we will say—first sit down in front of Mother."

Before the hearse left, Ramsevak came running. In his hand was the previous day's old tag. "This was to go into the file. But you should see it."

On the tag, "possibly western neighbourhood" had been crossed out. Over the red line was stamped—"Initial assumption withdrawn."

Salman took the tag in his hand, then returned it to Ramsevak. "Keep it in the file. We do not want this at home."

"Why keep it in the file?"

"At home we have his measuring tape, his scissors, the unfinished sleeves of children's uniforms. Those are enough for identification."

The hearse passed through the gate. The city's bamboo barricades had still not been removed. The driver had to take another route. Zahira kept looking out of the window. The fear of the night had not yet ended; correcting the truth had not automatically brought safety. But on the new tag tied to Naseem's wrist, a name had replaced an assumption.

The vehicle stopped at the mouth of the lane. Mother Sakina stood at the doorway. Her eyes went first not to the sheet but to the tag on the wrist. She could not read the name. Zahira took her hand and said, “Amma, this time the name is not wrong.”

Sakina did not ask for the tag. She only placed her hand on the sheet. Naseem’s little daughter came out from inside. In her hand was the remaining bundle of red thread—the same thread from the fair, a piece of which had been tied around Naseem’s wrist.

The child looked at the thread, then placed it in her mother’s hand. There was no longer any need for anyone to ask which community he belonged to.

STORY 196

The Child's Question

On the third day after the night the village market burned, bamboo mats were hung in the courtyard of the panchayat house. The administration said they were meant to keep out the wind. But people understood that the mats kept out eyes more than wind. Families from the eastern hamlet sat on one side, families from the western hamlet on the other. In the space between them stood relief sacks, water jars and two lanterns.

Nayan was nine years old. There was a scratch on his left elbow, on which his mother applied turmeric paste twice a day. On the night of the fire he had seen nothing. His father had taken him and his little sister out by the back way and run towards the fields. He had heard only sounds—running feet, breaking glass, and somewhere far away a voice shouting, “Run!”

At the panchayat house, for the first time he heard the words “those people” so often.

“Those people cannot be trusted.”

“Those people had prepared in advance.”

“Even their children are taught.”

“Those people are always waiting for a chance.”

Nayan kept wondering—who were those people?

At noon his mother sprinkled salt over his rice. Nayan asked, “Mother, why weren’t those people like us?”

His mother’s hand stopped for a moment. “Don’t ask such things now.”

“Everyone says it.”

“Everyone says many things.” His mother pushed the bowl towards him. “Eat.”

Nayan put a mouthful of rice into his mouth, but the question would not go down. In the evening, his father’s younger brother Devesh sat near the mat, a bandage tied around his head. Nayan asked again, “Kaka, why weren’t those people like us?”

Devesh answered without thinking, “Because they take the side of their own people.”

“Don’t we?”

Devesh looked at Nayan. “You’re a child. You won’t understand what these things mean.”

“Then who threw the first stone?”

“It came from that side.”

“Did you see it?”

Devesh narrowed his eyes. “Ramesh saw it.”

Ramesh was gathering up playing cards in the next corner. Nayan went to him. “Ramesh Kaka, did you see the first stone?”

Ramesh laughed. “Me? Raghu told me.”

Raghu was not at the panchayat house. His arm had been injured and he had gone to his maternal grandfather’s village. For the first time, Nayan realised that the first stone kept moving farther away from him—from Devesh to Ramesh, from Ramesh to Raghu, and from Raghu who knew where.

Dinner was being served. Khichdi had been cooked in one large cauldron, but two separate queues formed on either side of the mat. Ramcharit, the relief volunteer, served first here and then there with the same ladle. Nayan kept watching him. The ladle crossed the gap in the mat; people did not.

Just then, from the other side of the mat came a child’s voice: “Ammi, why aren’t those people like us?”

The bowl stopped in Nayan’s hand. He recognised the voice—Sahil. They studied in the same class at school. On rainy days they used to float paper birds together along the edge of the pond. Sahil was quick at sums, Nayan at handwriting.

From the other side came a woman’s soft reply, “Eat quietly.”

“But Mamu says those people are different.”

“No questions now.”

Nayan moved close to a gap in the mat. Sahil’s eyes appeared from the other side. For a moment both remained silent.

Sahil whispered, “Were you told that too?”

“Told what?”

“That we are different.”

Nayan nodded. “Kaka says your people threw the first stone.”

Sahil said at once, “My Mamu says your neighbourhood threw first.”

For a few moments they remained silent on the two sides of the gap.

“Did your Mamu see it?” Nayan asked.

Sahil bit his lip. “He said Nazir Chacha saw it.”

“Where is Nazir Chacha?”

“At my aunt’s village.”

Nayan remembered Devesh, Ramesh and Raghu. On both sides, the first stone was fleeing into the distance in exactly the same way.

From behind the mat came Devesh’s voice. “Nayan! What are you doing there?”

Nayan moved away. Devesh caught his arm and brought him back. “Didn’t I tell you not to go near the gap?”

“It was Sahil.”

“Don’t take names.”

“He is in my class.”

Devesh let go of his arm, but his voice remained hard. “There is no class now. Stay with your own people now.”

This answer was new to Nayan. School was closed, so was the class closed too? He wondered: when school opened again, would Sahil become someone from his class again, or would he remain someone from the other side of the mat?

The next morning Grandmother sat in the sun turning the beads of her tulsi rosary. Nayan told her his question. Grandmother said, “Religions are different, customs are different.”

“Do different customs make people different?”

“Some things have come down from the ancestors.”

“Who told the ancestors?”

Grandmother stopped turning the beads. “You have too many questions.”

Nayan wondered whether there were too many questions or too few answers.

At noon soap was distributed as relief. There were separate cartons for the two hamlets, but the soap was from the same factory and had the same smell. Nayan brought one bar to his nose. Devesh pushed his hand down. “This is not a toy.”

Behind the mat, Sahil coughed. Even though he wanted to, Nayan did not go near him. The previous night’s “Don’t take names” was caught in his ears.

In the evening three elderly men sat outside the panchayat house talking. Nayan listened. One said, “Their way of eating and drinking is different.” Another said, “You know as soon as you hear the name.” The third said, “They are taught their own history.”

Nayan wondered what he understood merely on hearing Sahil’s name. All he knew was that Sahil borrowed his pen during the half-time break and worked out difficult sums quickly.

At night clouds gathered in the sky. The old roof of the panchayat house began leaking in three places. First the families on the eastern side shifted their sacks. A little later water began dripping on the western side too. The earth beneath the mat in the middle turned soft.

Ramcharit said, “If we don’t remove the mat, the posts will sink.”

Voices came from both sides—“No, let it stay.”

Ramcharit pressed earth around the posts. The mat tilted. Now a space about two hands high opened beneath it. Through that gap water flowed from one side to the other. No one had time to stop it.

Through that empty space Nayan saw Sahil’s feet. Sahil saw his feet too. Both remained silent.

By morning the rain had stopped. On the earth of the courtyard, a single stream had cut a track across both halves. Nayan was touching the mark of that stream with a finger when his father came and said they had been given permission to go and look at the house.

On the road home were burnt shops, black walls and broken windows. His father walked quickly. Nayan followed. At the turn into their lane, he saw the outer door of Sahil's house. Half the lattice had burned away.

"Don't look there," his father said.

"Why?"

"Just don't look."

"That is Sahil's house."

His father stopped. He opened his mouth to say something, then closed it. Finally he said, "The situation is bad now."

For the first time Nayan understood that adults removed names before saying "those people". With a name, the matter became difficult. If he said Sahil, he remembered the class, the pen, sums and the paper birds at the pond; if he said "those people", only the mat remained.

The smell of smoke still lingered inside the house. His mother was cleaning the broken edge of the hearth. His little sister Rinni was making a circle in the ash in the courtyard. Nayan sat beside her.

Rinni asked, "Who stayed behind the mat at the panchayat house?"

Nayan was silent for a few moments. He remembered Devesh saying, "Don't take names."

He said, "Sahil."

"Who is Sahil?"

"A boy in my class."

Rinni made a small path through the circle she had drawn in the ash. "Will he go to school again?"

"When the school opens."

His mother had been listening from inside. She came out, but did not forbid him to say Sahil's name. She only said, "Nayan, don't go to his house just now."

Nayan nodded. "All right."

After a while he asked again, "Mother, if Sahil is not like us, why was his mother telling him that we are not like them? There is an 'us' on both sides, so who is 'them'?"

His mother kept looking at the circle in the ash. She had no immediate answer.

Outside in the lane, someone called for bamboo to be lifted. His father moved towards the door. His mother stroked Nayan's head and said only, "Do not make an answer to that question too quickly."

Nayan fell silent. For the first time, someone had stopped his question not in order to silence it, but to keep from giving it a hurried answer.

Rinni widened the path she had made in the ash. Outside, the burnt smell of the market was still in the air. The school was still closed. Nayan did not

know whether Sahil had reached his own house. The question remained where it was—smaller than all the answers, yet finding its way between them all.

STORY 197

The Price of Testimony

In the veranda of the district court, Lakhan Sada had folded his summons four times and tucked it into the inside pocket of his shirt. The corner of the paper had softened with sweat. He had left home in the dark to catch the morning bus, but his mind was still stuck at the gate of the brick kiln.

The previous evening, Bhubneshwar, the kiln clerk, had told him, “In court, say only what you said before. If you suddenly remember anything more, from tomorrow all three names from your house will disappear from the work register.”

Three names—Lakhan, his wife Budhni and his younger brother Harinath. All three worked at the same kiln, each at a different task. If one name was struck off, the household shook; if all three were, even the cooking fire became a question.

Lakhan had not told Budhni what the clerk had said that night. He had only shown her the summons. Budhni had tied up a small parcel of rice for him and said, “Say what you saw. The rest is with God.”

“Will God pay the wages?” Lakhan had blurted out.

Budhni had given no answer. She had only pushed the half-burnt stick deeper into the ashes.

Beside Lakhan in the veranda sat Malti. Her husband, Jatan Mandal, had fallen to his death four months earlier from a bamboo scaffold beside an unfinished kiln chimney. After the accident, Lakhan had told the police, “Jatan was above, the bamboo broke, and he fell.”

That statement was not false. But it was not complete either.

That day a westerly wind had been blowing across the kiln. Dust from half-baked bricks stung the eyes, and the night dew still made the bamboo scaffold slick. Jatan was arranging bricks above; Lakhan was passing mortar up from below.

One bamboo pole was split thin through the middle. Old jute rope had been wound around the crack. Whenever Jatan put his foot on it, the rope tightened, then slackened again. Even so, in the rush to load the cart on time, no one ordered the scaffold cleared.

When Jatan fell, dust rose first, then people ran. Bhubneshwar had been the first to say, “No one touch the bamboo.” Lakhan had not understood that sentence then; by evening the split bamboo had been replaced.

Before it broke, Jatan had looked down twice and said, "This bamboo is split. Give me another one."

Bhubneshwar had not looked up. Looking towards the cart, he had said, "We have to finish loading this batch today. Work another half hour, then we'll change it."

At that moment Lakhan had been two arm-lengths away from Jatan. He could still hear the creak of the bamboo in his ears.

When the police wrote his statement, Bhubneshwar was standing five paces away. That evening the wages were also to be paid by his hand. Before saying "split bamboo", Lakhan saw Bhubneshwar's eyes and shortened his sentence.

Now, four months later, the court had summoned him again. In four months, the rice in Jatan's house had run out, Malti's gold nose-flower had been sold, and Lakhan's debt had increased twice over.

Malti asked softly, "Did you bring food?"

Lakhan touched his pocket. "Budhni gave me some."

"Do not worry on my account," Malti said. "Say only what you can bear to say. You have a household too."

That sentence did not bring Lakhan relief. Instead, the balance inside him trembled even more.

They had to wait a long time before entering the courtroom. For the first time, Lakhan understood that a poor person's time also had a price, but it was a price he had to pay himself. The day's wages were already gone.

At noon, Lakhan opened his food parcel in a corner of the veranda. Inside were cold rice, salt and two green chillies. Malti did not open hers.

"Won't you eat?" Lakhan asked.

Malti said, "I am hungry, but nothing stays in my stomach."

Lakhan pushed half his rice towards her. Malti ate two mouthfuls, then pushed the parcel back to him. In that small exchange, neither of them spoke about testimony.

In the afternoon his name was called. Reaching the witness stand, he wiped his palm on his dhoti.

The public prosecutor began with simple questions—name, village, work, how long he had known Jatan. Lakhan answered each in a few words.

"Where were you at the time of the incident?"

"On the scaffold, near Jatan."

"Did anything happen before the bamboo broke?"

Lakhan's eyes went towards the door. Bhubneshwar was not outside, but the previous day's sentence was standing inside—three names.

"Jatan had said the bamboo was split," Lakhan said.

Malti's body straightened slightly.

The lawyer asked again, "Did anyone answer him?"

Lakhan remained silent.

The judge said, "Say only what you remember. Do not guess."

This was not a matter of guessing. The memory was very clear. In Lakhan's mind, Budhni's ash-filled stove, Harinath's torn towel, and the gate of the kiln appeared together.

He said, "The clerk, Bhubneshwar, said—this batch has to be loaded today, work another half hour, then the bamboo will be changed."

For a few moments the room was silent. Lakhan's own voice sounded far away from him.

The other lawyer stood up. His first question was sharp. "The kiln owner owed you two days' wages?"

"Yes, two days."

"You were angry about that?"

"If I did not get my wages, I was angry."

"Then would it not benefit you to say something like this against the owner's people?"

Lakhan looked first at Malti, then at the lawyer. "The account of two days' wages is one thing. The split bamboo was another."

The lawyer read out the first police statement. Bhubneshwar's words were not in it.

"Now, after four months, where has this new thing come from?"

Lakhan's throat went dry. He was given water. As he drank, he thought—if he answered this question, the clerk's threat from yesterday could also enter the courtroom.

He put down the glass. "The first statement was written at the kiln. The clerk was standing there. That evening the wages were to come from his hand."

"Meaning you were afraid?"

Lakhan did not say yes at once. The word fear made him feel as though the door of his house, Budhni and Harinath would also be entered into the record.

"I did not tell the whole thing because I was afraid of losing work," he finally said.

The other lawyer asked a few more questions—what time of night it was, how much light there was, whether Jatan had been drunk, how far away Lakhan stood. Lakhan said only what he had seen; where he had not seen, he said, "I do not know."

Outside the door, Bhubneshwar was not there, but a young new worker from the kiln stood beside a pillar. On seeing Lakhan, he immediately looked away. Lakhan could not tell whether he was there only on court business or to carry news back to someone.

In that moment, Lakhan felt less fear about what he had said than about the road home. Even so, he walked slowly forward through the crowd in the veranda with Malti.

When they came outside, his knees were shaking. Malti stepped forward to thank him, but Lakhan raised a hand and stopped her.

"No thanks yet," he said. "We'll see the gate tomorrow."

Malti lowered her eyes. "If you lose your work because of me?"

"Not because of you. Because of the bamboo."

At the other end of the veranda, a clerk was stamping a witness travel-allowance slip. Lakhan's slip was made too, but he was told the money would come later.

Lakhan put the slip in his pocket. He had already borrowed the bus fare for the day.

It was evening by the time he reached home. Budhni was washing brick dust in the courtyard. Looking at Lakhan's face, she understood that he had not stopped with the first statement.

"You told them?"

"Yes, I did."

"Everything you saw?"

"What I saw."

Budhni remained silent for a few moments. Then she asked, "Did you tell them about the clerk's threat too?"

Lakhan started.

"He told me too," Budhni said. "I didn't tell you because I thought you might break before you even went."

Now both understood that each had been hiding fear from the other.

That night no stone came, no one pounded on the door. But whenever dogs barked in the lane, Lakhan woke up. For the first time he understood that sometimes safety is not the absence of an event, but the waiting for one.

In the morning all three went to the kiln. Inside the gate, the names of workers were written in chalk on a bamboo board. Lakhan's name was not there. Harinath's name was not there either.

Budhni's name was there.

From a distance Bhubneshwar said, "One person from a house is enough."

Budhni looked at Lakhan. "Shall I go in?"

For a moment something bitter rose inside Lakhan—if she went in, would it mean accepting the clerk's favour? If she did not, the food at home would shrink.

He said, "Go. Your work is yours."

Budhni went inside. Without saying anything, Harinath tucked his basket under his arm and set off towards another kiln.

Lakhan remained alone outside the gate. In his pocket was the court-stamped travel-allowance slip; in his hand, no work token.

He took out the slip and looked at it. His name was written correctly on it. His testimony from the previous day had also been entered into the court record.

But having one's name written correctly and having work attached to that name were two different things.

Lakhan folded the slip again, put it in his pocket and began walking towards the crossing where labourers gathered. He did not know whether he would find work that day. He knew only this much: the full price of one sentence spoken yesterday had still not been paid.

STORY 198

Across the River

On a night in Bhadau, the Bagmati's current was surging ahead, erasing the signs of homes and doorways. The moon was behind the clouds, and after the embankment on the eastern side of the village breached somewhere, water had filled lane after lane. People were fleeing towards the raised road, carrying on their heads whatever they had managed to seize.

A section of the old bridge had collapsed that very evening. Now there was only one way to reach the road: by boat—Bansi Sahni's old wooden boat, which on ordinary days carried ten people. That night more than twenty people had gathered at the ghat.

Bansi raised the lantern and said, "Eleven at a time. Leave the heavy sacks at the ghat. Lives first, sacks later."

Ramnarayan Jha was clutching a small sack of paddy. Jhagru Paswan had his five-year-old granddaughter Munni tucked against him. Sakina Bibi was with her twelve-year-old son Faizan, and one hand of old Mahavir Mandal was trembling. No one had time to ask who anyone else was.

When the first boat pushed off, the voices of those left behind at the ghat blurred into the distance. Bansi drove the oar into the water and cut diagonally across the current. The water was not calm; at times the boat rose, at times it seemed to sink to its belly.

Ramnarayan put the sack beneath his feet and said, "It is leaning too much to the right."

Bansi said at once, "Names and lineages later. Whoever is heavy, move towards the middle now."

Everyone shifted. Jhagru handed Munni to Sakina because he had to brace the side of the boat with his own body. Without asking anything, Sakina covered the child with the end of her sari. Faizan took Mahavir Mandal's trembling hand and moved him towards the middle.

The boat had reached midstream when there came a sound like a 'thak' beneath its wooden floor. Bansi's face tightened. A submerged bamboo pole had grazed the belly of the boat. The next moment cold water began to collect around their feet.

"Whatever vessel you have, use it to throw the water out," Bansi shouted. "Otherwise the weight will increase."

Whose vessel belonged to whom no longer mattered. Ramnarayan's brass lota reached Jhagru's hand. Mahavir Mandal took Sakina's small bowl. Faizan

picked up the aluminium container that had been resting on the sack of paddy and began bailing. With one hand everyone steadied themselves; with the other they kept throwing the river back into the river.

Munni began to cry in fear. Sakina whispered close to her ear, “Keep holding on to me. The boat will reach the bank.” The child clasped her neck tightly.

A fierce wave came. Ramnarayan’s sack slid to one end of the boat. The boat tilted again. Bansi roared, “Throw the sack out!”

Ramnarayan’s hand fell on the sack, but he hesitated for a moment. It held the paddy that remained in his house. Then Jhagru reached out with his free hand and dragged the sack to the edge. Together they pushed it into the water. The sack surfaced once, then vanished into the dark current.

Ramnarayan said nothing. He took his own lota from Jhagru’s hand, bailed twice, then, without looking, passed the lota to Faizan.

In the boat, no one’s identity was separate any longer. One hand supported the oar, another bailed water, another held the body of a child or an old person steady. In midstream, caste, faith, hamlet, lineage—all such words seemed to have been left behind at the ghat.

Far away, three lanterns could be seen on the raised road. Bansi said, “Head that way. The current will pull left now.”

Faizan folded his gamchha behind Mahavir Mandal’s back so that the edge of the wood would not press against his bones. Mahavir said breathlessly, “Son, a little higher.” Faizan shifted the gamchha upwards.

Munni had stopped crying in Sakina’s lap. Exhausted, the child rested her face on Sakina’s shoulder. Jhagru looked over from time to time, but did not insist on taking her back.

Just before the boat reached the bank, another wave struck. This time Ramnarayan instinctively caught hold of Jhagru’s shoulder and sat down. Jhagru spread his legs and braced himself to keep him from falling. Neither looked at the other; there was no time to look.

Bansi ran the boat into the mud. “Get down one at a time. Once you are off, move ahead. Keep holding the boat until the old people and the children have got down.”

Faizan jumped first. His feet sank into the mud up to the ankles, but he turned and caught Mahavir Mandal’s hand. Ramnarayan supported the old man’s arm from the other side. Jhagru took Munni from Sakina’s lap, but when Sakina slipped as she stepped down, Jhagru caught her by the elbow.

Everyone climbed onto the road. Behind them the river’s roar was just as fierce, but the ground beneath their feet was firm now.

At the roadside, two young relief workers had kept a bucket of drinking water and small pieces of jaggery. They told the people from the first boat to

catch their breath until the second load arrived. There was only one bowl with the bucket.

The bowl went first to Mahavir Mandal, then to Sakina, then Jhagru, then Ramnarayan. It did not occur to anyone to ask who had drunk from it before them. The river was still roaring before their eyes; within that roar, thirst had a religion of its own.

Ramnarayan took two sips and held the bowl to Munni's mouth. The child drank half the water and spilled the rest over Jhagru's dhoti. Sakina burst out laughing. For a few moments, everyone's laughter sounded like a single voice.

A school beside the raised road had been turned into a temporary shelter. A lantern burned on the veranda. The villagers who had arrived earlier began calling out as soon as they spotted people they knew.

"Jha Ji, this way! We have kept a room for our people."

"Jhagru, your hamlet is on the back veranda."

"Sakina sister, the people from the mosque hamlet are gathered under that neem tree."

The voices suddenly gave everyone their identities back. Those who in the boat had been nothing but drenched bodies began, on reaching the road, to become hamlet, caste and faith once again.

Ramnarayan saw his brass lota in Faizan's hand. Faizan was still holding it in the posture of bailing water from the boat, as though his hand had not yet understood that the danger was over.

"This is yours," Faizan said, holding the lota out.

Ramnarayan took it. For a moment he looked at its dulled surface. The mud of the ghat, the river water, Jhagru's palm, Faizan's fingers—the marks of all of them were on it.

His nephew came running from a corner of the veranda. "Uncle, come here. There is water." His eyes fell on the lota. Quietly he asked, "Whose hands was this in?"

Ramnarayan did not answer. He put the lota on the ground and began wringing out his wet dhoti.

On the other side, Jhagru's daughter-in-law saw Munni wrapped in the end of Sakina's sari and came running. Seeing the child safe, she first bent as though to touch Sakina's feet, then stopped midway. She took Munni into her arms.

Sakina smiled and said, "She has stopped crying now."

Instead of thanking her, the daughter-in-law merely nodded. Someone behind her said, "Come, there is a place with our own people." She took Munni away.

Mahavir Mandal was seated on a mat inside the veranda. Faizan's gamchha was still behind his back. Mahavir's son pulled it out and handed it to Faizan, saying, "Your cloth." There was gratitude in his voice, but immediately

afterwards he shifted the mat a little farther inside, as though the boundary needed to be made clear again.

Two hearths began to be made in the school courtyard. On one side there was chivda and jaggery; on the other, preparations were under way to put rice on to cook. No one had given any explicit order about who was to sit where, yet people drifted towards their own marked groups.

Bansi was still by the boat. After setting down the people from the first trip, he was thinking of turning back at once for the second. Water had gathered again in the belly of the boat.

He climbed up to the road and said, "Can someone lend me a lota? I have to empty the boat."

Ramnarayan's lota lay right in front of them. His nephew picked it up, but hesitated before holding it out towards Bansi. He remembered whose hands had touched it.

Ramnarayan took the lota from his nephew's hand. Until a few moments earlier he had been silent. Now he handed it to Bansi and said, "Take it. There is still plenty of river water."

Bansi did not laugh. He simply took the lota and went down the slope.

Ramnarayan's nephew said softly, "Uncle, we can wash it later."

Ramnarayan kept looking towards the river. "Yes," he said, but there was no certainty in his voice whether he was speaking about the lota or about something else that had awakened again inside him.

The second boatload was coming in. The boat's lantern could be seen swaying in the darkness. Meanwhile, in the school courtyard, smoke from the hearths was rising in different directions.

From his own veranda, as he settled Munni to sleep, Jhagru looked once towards Sakina in the distance. Sakina looked too, but now dry ground lay between them—ground on which people had once again drawn their own circles.

In the river, the lota was changing hands again. On the bank, hands were choosing identities again.

STORY 199

Kurthi Lentils

It was the first week of Chait. A trace of winter chill still lingered in the morning air, but the earth in the courtyard dried as the day rose. Saraswati had set an earthen pot on the hearth and was boiling kurthi lentils. The lid trembled from time to time, steam escaped, and smoke caught in the rafters of the veranda.

Ramlochan took down the small bamboo measure hanging from a peg and went into the storeroom. He felt the sack kept in a corner with his hand. It was less than half full. He filled the measure with grain, then poured it back into the sack. He did this three times.

Looking towards the pot, Saraswati asked, "Will the measure change if you count it three times?"

Ramlochan did not answer. He dragged the sack outside. "About twenty-six seers."

His mother, Jagmaya, sat on a cot on the veranda, wrapped in a blanket. For three weeks her body had been weak. She ate little, grew breathless quickly, and by evening her thighs and knees ached. Two days earlier the village health worker had told them not to delay taking her to the block hospital. There would be some cost for tests, travel besides, and perhaps medicines to be bought outside.

Jagmaya looked at the sack. "Will you sell all this?"

Ramlochan said, "Where will the money come from if we do not sell it? The wheat is still in the field. Whatever paddy we had was finished in Magh. There has been no wage work for two weeks."

Saraswati added salt to the pot. "Not all of it. Six seers are set aside for seed."

"What use is keeping seed if Mother lies ill at home?" Ramlochan's voice was not harsh, only tired. "Yesterday at the haat, Nandu the trader said the price of kurthi has risen. In the city, well-off people now buy it calling it a health grain. If we give him twenty seers, the tests, medicines and travel will all be covered."

Jagmaya laughed softly. "In the first Chait after my marriage, my mother-in-law told me—when paddy runs low, kurthi saves the household. Now the city folk have given it a grand name, so has its price become grand too?"

Saraswati took the pot off the hearth. The dal was thin, but the smell of garlic and cumin rose from it. Dividing it among three bowls, she placed Jagmaya's bowl before her first.

Ramlochan rested a hand on the sack and said, "Whatever its name, we need money."

The household accounts were visible not on paper but in utensils and sacks. The paddy bin was empty. The bottom showed in the lentil tin. Only two finger-widths of oil remained in the bottle. The sack of kurthi alone was something that, at a glance, showed Saraswati the next month's cooking. She could soak kurthi at night and boil it in the morning, grind it into a vegetable dish, or, if rice ran short, thicken its broth and fill their stomachs.

She dragged the sack inside. She brought out three bamboo baskets. Into the first she measured six seers. Into the second, twelve. Into the third, the remaining eight.

Ramlochan asked, "What is this?"

"The first is seed. The second is for the household to eat. The third is to sell."

"Nandu will not take eight seers. He does not load anything under twenty seers onto his cart."

Saraswati fell silent. The three baskets remained in a row on the veranda. Jagmaya looked at the first, then the second, then the third.

"Leave my tests," she said.

Ramlochan replied at once, "Do not say that again."

"Then leave the seed."

This time Saraswati raised her face. "If we give up the seed, next Asadh we will be at the moneylender's door again. If we give up the basket for food, in Baisakh we will buy dal from the market. What is cheap now, we will buy dear with that very money then. Cut away one of the three, and two days later a hole will open somewhere else."

At noon Ramlochan put the eight seers from the basket into a sack and took it to Nandu the trader's warehouse. Nandu was sitting by the scales. The moment he saw the sack he asked, "How much?"

"Eight seers."

Nandu shook his head. "I told you before. Not less than twenty. I have to send it to the city. What will I do with little sacks?"

"Pay me two rupees less on the rate."

"It is not about the rate. I need the quantity."

Ramlochan stood there for a while. Inside the warehouse, five large sacks of kurthi were stacked one upon another. Outside, two labourers panted as they loaded maize onto a bullock cart. Nandu bent over his scales again.

"Bring twenty seers," he said. "I'll pay cash."

Ramlochan tucked the sack under his arm and returned home. He stopped twice on the way: once at the pond ghat, once beside a dry bamboo thicket. Reaching home, he set the sack down on the veranda.

Saraswati did not ask what Nandu had said. The sight of the sack told her.

By evening Jagmaya's fever had risen. Her forehead was hot, her hands cold. Ramlochan borrowed a neighbour's bicycle and fetched the health worker. She checked Jagmaya's pulse, asked a few questions, then said, "Take her to the hospital tomorrow morning. It is not right to keep her at home on guesswork."

No fresh meal was cooked that night. The leftover kurthi dal from noon was reheated. Three bowls were shared among four people. Ramlochan's daughter Lalita, who had spent the day at her maternal uncle's house, quietly pushed her own bowl towards her grandmother. Jagmaya ate half a spoonful and pushed the bowl back. "Will you be able to study without eating?"

Lalita said nothing. She drew the bowl back to her place.

Ramlochan sat on the veranda until late that night. The three baskets were before him: seed, food for the household, and the portion to be sold. At last he rose and, not from the first basket but from the second, lifted twelve seers and added them to the third. The twenty seers for sale were now complete. The household's food basket was empty.

Saraswati had been watching from inside. She came out and sat beside the empty basket.

"What about tomorrow?" she asked.

"Tomorrow, first Mother's tests."

"And after that, how will the household run?"

Ramlochan searched for an answer, but did not find one at once. "The wheat harvest will begin. There will be wage work."

"There are twelve days until the harvest."

"We'll manage somehow."

As she tied the sack, Saraswati said, "We will not touch the seed."

Ramlochan nodded. That night, one of the three baskets stood empty.

In the morning Nandu weighed the twenty seers and paid cash. Ramlochan tied the money into an inner fold of his shirt and went with his mother to the block hospital. It was crowded. First the registration slip, then the tests, then the doctor. By the time they returned near evening, he had two packets of medicine in his hand, instructions about food and drink on a sheet of paper, and very little money left. But the doctor had said there was no immediate grave danger; she needed regular meals, rest and medicine, and should be brought back after seven days.

On reaching home, Jagmaya lay down on the cot, exhausted. Saraswati gave her the medicine with water. Then she went towards the hearth.

"What will we cook today?" Lalita asked.

Saraswati opened the grain bin. A handful of rice. A few potatoes. Salt. That was all.

That night they made a thin potato broth. Jagmaya could not eat more than two mouthfuls. The next day Ramlochan went to a landowner's house to ask for wage work; he was told there would be work in three days. On the third

day the rice ran out. Saraswati did not go to a neighbour to borrow. She lifted the piece of sacking from the basket kept for seed. Six seers of kurthi lay there quietly.

She reached out to fill the measure, then stopped.

Jagmaya was watching from the cot. "Take some out."

"This is seed."

"The seed will go to the field, but only if people stay alive until the field."

Saraswati took out half a measure. "Only this much."

That day kurthi went into the pot again. The dal was thinner than before, but four bowls of hot steam rose in the house. Over the next five days, the seed basket lost one and a half seers. As soon as Ramlochan found the first harvesting work, he brought home two days' wages. Some rice, salt and oil came into the house. From the third day onward, he remained in the fields continuously.

On the seventh day Jagmaya went to the hospital again. This time Saraswati went with Ramlochan. The doctor said her body was weak and that her meals should be kept regular. The empty basket rose unbidden in Saraswati's mind, but she said nothing.

Baisakh passed. With the wages from the wheat harvest, the household hearth became regular again. Jagmaya slowly recovered her strength. But as soon as Asadh arrived, a new question stood before them: the time to sow kurthi.

Ramlochan took down the seed basket. A little more than four seers of grain remained. The previous year they had used six seers of seed. It was clear that they would have to reduce the field by two kathas.

"Shall I buy two seers from the market?" Ramlochan asked.

Saraswati asked the price. On hearing it she laughed, but there was no joy in the laughter. The same kurthi that had been sold in Chait to buy medicine would now have to be bought back as seed at twice the price.

"No," she said. "Sow whatever we have. We'll plant marua on the remaining strip."

Ramlochan looked towards the field. "If there is less kurthi, what about next Chait?"

Saraswati was silent for a few moments. "We do not have the answer to next Chait today. Today the seed has survived, Mother is up and walking, and no new knot of debt has been tied around the household. That is not a small thing."

On the morning of sowing day, Ramlochan and Saraswati reached the field. The soil was softer than the year before. Ramlochan took a handful of kurthi and began scattering it along the rows. The first two rows went at the usual spacing. At the third he stopped his hand. There was too little seed. Saraswati said, "Make it a little thinner. Spread what we have."

By the time the day rose, four seers of seed could not fill the whole field. A strip on the western side remained empty. There Saraswati scattered marua seed.

When they returned home, Jagmaya was sitting on the veranda. Before her, in an earthen bowl, lay the last handful of kurthi—the broken and shrivelled grains that had been separated while sorting the seed.

Jagmaya spread those grains across her palm and looked at them. “These will go into the cooking.”

Saraswati laughed and asked, “Not into the seed?”

“What is not fit for the field may still be fit for the stomach.”

In the evening the earthen pot went onto the hearth again. This time there was little dal, with marua rotis beside it. Ramlochan took the first mouthful and said nothing. Outside, the western strip of the field was no longer empty; another seed had already been sown there.

Saraswati placed the three baskets back in the corner of the kitchen. One still awaited the new grain. The second was empty. In the third, two handfuls of broken kurthi remained. She covered the baskets.

Saraswati covered the embers of the hearth with ash. The fire was not entirely out; within, it remained red for the morning.

STORY 200

The Dream of One Bigha

In the Agahan sunlight, the field boundaries stood out clearly. The paddy had been harvested, and egrets settled here and there among the stubble. Shivanath was walking around Devanath Chaudhary's field with an old length of rope. The rope was twenty cubits long. He hooked one end around a bamboo peg driven into the boundary ridge, pulled the other end taut, and counted the knots.

Devanath stood at a distance, smiling. "Measure it. I won't short-change you on the land."

Shivanath smiled too, but his eyes stayed on the rope. He had cultivated this field on share for five years. He knew, as he knew his own courtyard, where water lingered longest, on which strip the wheat grew thin, where rats gnawed into the ridge to make their burrows. The only difference was that on the day the harvest was divided in half, the field became someone else's again.

One bigha. A full bigha.

Devanath's two sons lived in town. He needed money to repair the house, and so he had raised the question of selling this plot. Buyers from the market had come to look twice, but the field lay far from the main road, along a track that turned muddy in the rains. Devanath had told Shivanath, "You've been cultivating it for five years. If you want to buy it, I'll speak to you first."

Shivanath had not slept properly for three nights.

Inside the house, an old chest made by a blacksmith held thirty-nine thousand two hundred rupees. The money had not been gathered in a day. The proceeds from selling two goats, a little saved from his share of the wheat, five thousand given by his younger brother who had gone away for work, and two years of Manjula's sewing earnings - all of it had accumulated slowly in that chest. At first the money had no name. Later, whenever Shivanath opened the chest, he began calling it "the land money."

Devanath had said that if Shivanath paid an advance of thirty-five thousand, he would not sell the land to anyone else for three months. The balance could be paid in three instalments over two years. The deed would be executed on the final payment. The condition was hard, but it did not seem impossible to Shivanath. Once he had one bigha of his own, there would be no obligation to give away half the produce. For the first time, the future seemed visible in the shape of an account.

As he coiled the rope, he said, "I'll pay the advance by the day after tomorrow."

Devanath nodded. "By the evening of the day after tomorrow. After that the outside buyer is coming again."

When he returned home, Manjula was shaking paddy straw at the doorway. Shivanath hung the rope from a peg.

"Did you measure it?" she asked.

"A full bigha."

A faint smile came to Manjula's face. "The rope didn't come up short or long?"

"I've cultivated that field for five years. The rope may deceive me; my eyes won't."

That afternoon their daughter Rama arrived home from the district headquarters. She was in her second year at the government women's college and lived in the hostel. The short winter break had begun. In her bag, among her clothes, was a folded notice.

After the meal she placed the notice before her father. The fee for the next term, three months' hostel charges, and some laboratory materials came to twenty-two thousand four hundred rupees. Because the previous crop had been poor, the money set aside for her studies had already gone into household expenses and cultivation.

Shivanath read the notice again. "By the end of Paush?"

"Yes," Rama said. "After that they won't hold my hostel room. The arrears will show in the examination register too."

"Could you travel from home?"

"Even if I catch the first bus in the morning, I'll miss the first class. By the time I return in the evening, it'll be night."

Shivanath folded the notice and put it back in her hand. "We'll see."

Those two syllables - we'll see - hung in the house until evening.

After dinner that night, Manjula opened the chest. The money was tied in separate knots inside an old cloth bag. She took it all out and laid it on the cot. Rama was studying in the inner room. Their younger son, Mohan, was asleep.

When Manjula finished counting, she said, "Thirty-nine thousand two hundred."

Shivanath said, "I know."

"Thirty-five thousand for the land advance. Twenty-two thousand four hundred for Rama. And Bhola Sah?"

Shivanath remained silent.

The previous Asadh they had taken fertiliser, seed, and pesticide twice on credit from Bhola Sah. After selling their share of the paddy they had paid twelve thousand, but fourteen thousand eight hundred still remained. Sah had

said that if they wanted supplies for the wheat in Magh, they must first reduce the old balance.

Manjula added the three amounts in her head and looked again at the pile of notes. "This money won't open all three doors."

Shivanath said quietly, "If the land slips from our hands, we may never get another chance like this."

"And if Rama's studies stop halfway?"

"She'll sit at home. Who knows when she'll ever return to it?"

Manjula said nothing. She tied the bag again.

Rama called from inside, "Ma, the lamp oil is running out."

Manjula got up. Sitting on the cot, Shivanath kept looking at three invisible piles of money - land, education, debt.

Early the next morning he went to Bhola Sah's shop. Sacks of fertiliser stood in a row by the entrance. Bhola opened his ledger.

"Fourteen thousand eight hundred," he said. "I'm ordering the next consignment. Pay something towards the old account, then I'll enter the wheat supplies."

Shivanath asked, "What if I pay half?"

Bhola shrugged. "If you pay half, I'll have half the confidence. But you need the full supplies, don't you? I don't get goods on credit either."

Shivanath stepped out of the shop. Across the way, the tea seller had a kettle on the stove. He did not drink tea. What had earlier been three separate worries had now become a single knot. Even after buying the land, he would need fertiliser and seed to cultivate it. If he left the old debt untouched and paid the land advance, he would have to borrow again before the first harvest. The first season on his own land would begin in someone else's ledger.

That afternoon he went to the sharecropped field. The owner's share had already been taken away. His own share of the straw lay in one corner. He sat on the ridge and began picking at the dry soil. He could not remember exactly how much produce had been halved over five years, but he remembered every scene of division - two piles, an empty strip between them, one sack this way, one sack that way.

On Devanath's one bigha, that scene would not happen. That was the dream.

In the evening Rama sat at the doorway covering her books for the next term. Shivanath sat down beside her.

"If we can't arrange the hostel and fee money this time, what will you do?"

Rama stopped her hands. "I'll stay at home and study from the books. I'll try again next term."

"Won't it hurt?"

"It will."

The answer was direct. Shivanath looked at his daughter. Rama went back to straightening the book cover.

After a while she said on her own, "Babu, don't give up the land. I can stay at home this term."

Shivanath asked, "Who told you to say that?"

"No one."

"Then who has just made the decision?"

Rama smiled. "I'm only saying it."

Shivanath stood up. He could not tell whether his daughter was trying to lighten his burden or hide her own fear. He made no decision about it that night.

On the third day Devanath was sitting in his courtyard with two buyers. When Shivanath arrived, they got up and left. Devanath asked, "Have you brought the advance?"

Shivanath had the cloth bag in his pocket. "I have. But not the full thirty-five."

Devanath's brow tightened slightly. "How much?"

"Ten thousand now. The remaining twenty-five by Phagun."

Devanath shook his head. "That wasn't the condition before. The outside buyer will pay the full advance."

"I know."

"Then?"

Shivanath was silent for a few moments. "An expense for education came up suddenly at home."

Devanath looked away. "I understand your difficulty, but work on my house is held up too. Land isn't sold out of pity."

Shivanath rested a hand on the bag in his pocket. "All right."

"If you can arrange thirty-five by this evening, the deal is still yours."

Shivanath did not say yes. He simply bowed in greeting and returned home.

On the way he could have turned towards a moneylender's house. There were two people in the village who could give him thirty-five thousand at once - at monthly interest. The advance on one bigha from his savings, Rama's next term on borrowed money, Bhola Sah's old debt pushed onto the next harvest. On paper the arithmetic worked. Only, in that arithmetic, the harvests of the next two years were already spent.

When he reached home, he opened the chest.

Manjula asked, "What happened?"

"Devanath wouldn't agree to ten thousand."

"Then?"

Shivanath counted the thirty-nine thousand two hundred again. First he set aside fourteen thousand eight hundred. Then twenty-two thousand four hundred. Only two thousand remained on the cot.

Manjula understood. But she did not say anything at once.

Shivanath said, "First we'll close Bhola Sah's account. We'll buy the wheat seed without tying a new knot of debt. The rest is for Rama's next term."

"The land?"

"Gone."

After saying the word, he looked for the first time at the empty bottom of the chest. Old newspaper lined it, dust gathered in the corners. Five years of savings would go in two directions in a single evening. Nothing would remain in his hand - neither a land deed nor a bag of rupees.

Manjula said softly, "Not the land. Rama will study."

Shivanath looked at her. "Don't preach to me now."

Manjula fell silent. A few moments later she said only, "All right. We'll go tomorrow morning."

The next day Shivanath cleared the old balance in Bhola Sah's ledger. Sah drew a red line against the amount. Shivanath watched that line, but the relief did not feel as great as he had imagined it would.

After that he went to the district town with Rama and Manjula. The queue at the college accounts window was long. By afternoon the fee, hostel charges, and laboratory amount had been paid. Rama put the receipt in her bag, came outside, and asked, "Babu, shall we have tea?"

Shivanath laughed. "I've got two thousand left now - more than enough for tea. We will."

The three of them drank tea at a roadside shop. They talked about the next term, books, the hostel bedding, and the sattu Rama would take from home. No one mentioned the land.

Four days later, a teacher from another village bought Devanath's one bigga. The news spread through the village in the ordinary way. Shivanath heard it, said, "All right," and walked towards the wheat field.

At the end of Paush, the new owner came to Shivanath's house. He worked in the city and was in no position to cultivate the field himself.

"You've been cultivating this field already," he said. "Will you take it on share this year as well?"

Shivanath was silent for a moment. In front of him, hanging from the peg, was the same twenty-cubit rope.

"What will the terms be?" he asked.

"Whatever is customary in the village."

Shivanath did not answer at once. The land he had dreamed for five years of making his own was before him again with the offer that he give away half its crop. Something tightened inside him, but the wheat season did not wait.

"I'll take it," he said at last, "but the seed and fertiliser costs will be half and half."

The new owner thought for a moment and agreed.

In the first week of Magh, Shivanath prepared to sow wheat on that one bigha. This time he bought the seed from Bhola Sah's shop for cash. The amount was small, but no new credit was entered in the ledger.

Rama had already gone back to the hostel. In a corner of the house, two old book covers lay on her empty cot. Now and then Manjula placed clothes there and then moved them away again.

Shivanath took the rope to the field. The new owner had asked him to straighten the boundary ridge a little. Shivanath drove in a peg and pulled the rope taut. It was the same rope with which he had measured the land in Agahan, before the planned purchase.

A labourer asked, "Measuring it again?"

Shivanath said, "No. This time I'm checking the line for sowing."

The rope remained stretched from ridge to ridge. The measure of one bigha had not changed. Only its meaning had.

Shivanath unfastened the rope, set it aside, and lifted the basket filled with seed. His hand moved along the first row. The wheat grains fell into the cold earth.

“

Stories remain alive as long as people and language remain alive.

— GAJENDRA THAKUR

Gajendra Thakur's three hundred selected stories form a vivid mirror of the many shapes of life in Mithila, Vajji and Anga: folk life, human relationships, changing times, village and city, sorrow and joy, tradition and modernity, nature and society, women and men, childhood, old age, migration, memory, struggle and hope.

Across these three volumes, the simplicity of the people's language, the depth of life, and the cultural pulse of Mithila, Vajji and Anga dwell together.

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The Philosopher Betel-Seller

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Curfew Milk

Half a Samosa

Love on Credit

The Rented Dog

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The Dream of One Bigha



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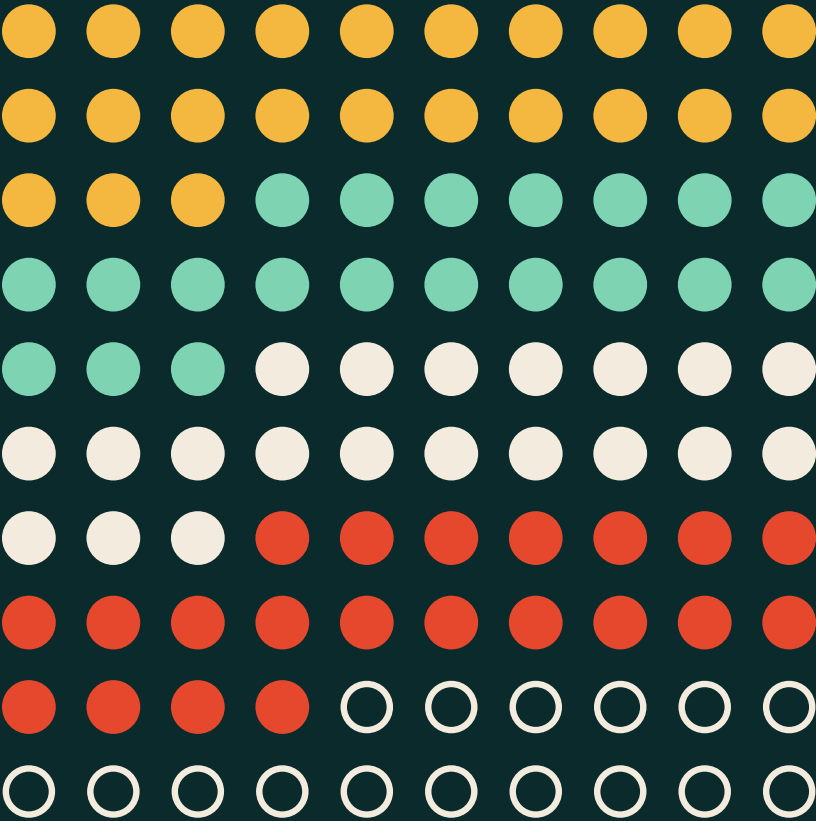
VOL.

III

The Hundred- Story Trilogy

Three Hundred Selected Stories · Stories 201–300

ONE HUNDRED STORIES · ONE HUNDRED DOTS



GAJENDRA THAKUR

Translated from the Maithili by the author himself

The Hundred-Story Trilogy
(Volume III)

The Hundred-Story Trilogy (Volume III)

(Three Hundred Selected Stories by Gajendra Thakur)

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A story lives as long as its people and their language live.

Gajendra Thakur

The Hundred-Story Trilogy (Volume III) — Gajendra Thakur

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Author: Gajendra Thakur

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The Empty Bag

It was a Wednesday in the month of Bhadra.

The morning sun had not yet properly risen.

Gopinath Sah took down an old cloth bag from a peg on the veranda.

Its mouth was tied with three knots.

One of the knots had grown old and hardened.

Sarojini Devi was sitting by the hearth.

She glanced once at the bag.

“Have you packed the rope?”

Gopinath Sah said, “Yes.”

“The ledger?”

“Yes.”

“The weights?”

“Yes.”

Sarojini Devi asked nothing more.

From an inner room, Gopinath Sah brought the ledger wrapped in a red cloth.

The corners of the ledger had worn away.

His father’s name was written at the top of the first page.

Beneath it was Gopinath Sah’s own name.

The yearly accounts began on the second page.

Several pages bore stains from lentils.

On others were small yellow marks of mustard oil.

He put the ledger into the bag.

He added the pointer of a small brass balance.

Four weights.

A strip of old cloth.

A handful of thin cord.

And two empty paper packets.

Sarojini Devi said, “Food?”

“I’ll eat something at the haat.”

“Take something from home.”

Gopinath Sah did not answer.

Sarojini Devi wrapped two rotis and a small box of salt and chillies in a cloth.

That too went into the bag.

Gopinath Sah stepped out through the doorway.

From behind him, Sarojini Devi said, "Don't make it too heavy."

He turned and looked back.

"How heavy can it be now?"

Whether Sarojini Devi smiled at that or not, Gopinath Sah did not see.

The haat was two kos from the village.

Earlier he used to go by bicycle.

Now he went on foot.

Half the road was unpaved.

The night's rain had left mud in two places.

Gopinath Sah walked on with the bag tucked under his right arm.

Near Majhdhar Tola he met Kishun Mandal.

"Early today?"

"On market day, early is better."

"How much seed is left?"

"We'll see."

Kishun Mandal said nothing to that answer.

By the time Gopinath Sah reached the haat, the sun had grown fierce.

From a distance he could see the blue tarpaulin stretched over bamboo slats.

It was Gopinath Sah's old spot.

But that day the tarpaulin had already been put up.

Manju was there.

Manju was Gopinath Sah's daughter.

For the past three months she had been coming at dawn on market days.

That day she had arrived before him.

Paper packets were arranged on the bamboo bench.

Mustard in one lot.

Lentils in another.

Peas in another.

Bottle-gourd, pumpkin and okra seeds in little packets.

With a piece of charcoal, Manju was writing the price on one packet.

Gopinath Sah stood in the shade of the tarpaulin.
Manju looked up.
“What took you so long?”
Gopinath Sah said, “There was mud on the road.”
Manju laughed.
“There was mud yesterday too.”
Gopinath Sah put the bag beneath the bench.
He did not sit down.
The first customer was an elderly farmer.
He said, “Two pao of mustard.”
Manju picked up the balance.
She looked towards Gopinath Sah.
Gopinath Sah rested a hand on one corner of the bench.
He said nothing.
Manju weighed the seed.
The pointer tilted once to the right.
She removed two grains.
The pointer came to rest in the middle.
The elderly farmer looked at Gopinath Sah.
“Right?”
Gopinath Sah said, “The pointer is in the middle.”
The farmer placed the money in Manju’s hand.
Manju entered it in the ledger.
Gopinath Sah did not touch the ledger.
The next customer was a boy.
He asked for okra seed.
Manju told him the price.
The boy said, “Uncle used to charge less.”
Manju replied, “That was a different batch of seed.”
The boy looked at Gopinath Sah.
Gopinath Sah looked at the packet of seed.
“This is a new lot.”
The boy quietly paid.
The crowd lasted until noon.
Now and then Gopinath Sah passed a packet forward.
Now and then he held out a blank sheet of paper.
Manju handled the rest of the accounts.
Twice she ran short of change.

Both times she opened the little cash box inside the bench.
Gopinath Sah did not tell her which compartment held the change.
Manju found it herself.
After noon the haat grew a little quieter.
Manju said, "Eat your roti."
Gopinath Sah opened the bag.
He took out the cloth in which the rotis were wrapped.
He set the little box of salt and chillies outside.
He sat down behind the bench.
Manju sat down too.
They ate half a roti each.
Gopinath Sah drank water.
Manju said, "Shall I take the ledger home today?"
Gopinath Sah kept chewing his roti.
After a while he said, "It would be better if it stayed at the haat."
Manju's hand stopped.
"At the haat?"
"In the box under the tarpaulin."
"It will get damp there."
"We'll put a brick on top."
Manju said nothing.
After they had eaten, Gopinath Sah opened the bag.
He took out the ledger wrapped in red cloth.
He opened it and looked at the last page that had been written on.
It was not yesterday's account, but the account from the previous market day.
His handwriting was at the bottom.
He held the ledger out towards Manju.
Manju did not extend her hand.
Gopinath Sah placed the ledger on the bench.
"Add today's account to this."
Manju slowly picked up the ledger.
She tied the red cloth around it again.
Gopinath Sah reached into the bag.
He took out all four brass weights.
One by one, he placed them beneath the bench.
He put the balance pointer there too.
Then the bundle of thin cord.

And the strip of old cloth.
Manju asked, "All this stays here?"
"It will be needed here."
"Next time?"
Gopinath Sah looked inside the bag.
Only the empty roti cloth and the little box of salt and chillies remained.
He wrapped the box in the cloth.
"Whatever is needed next time will be found here."
Manju kept looking at his face.
Gopinath Sah left the mouth of the bag open.
In the afternoon the customers began to come again.
A woman asked for lentils.
Manju weighed them.
Gopinath Sah glanced once at the pointer.
It stood in the middle.
He turned his eyes away.
A farmer asked for goods on credit.
Manju opened the ledger.
She searched for his name.
Gopinath Sah did not stop her.
Manju said, "Your previous credit is still unpaid."
The farmer looked at Gopinath Sah.
Gopinath Sah kept his eyes on the ground.
The farmer said, "All right, give me half."
Manju gave him half.
Towards evening the market thinned out.
Manju counted the packets that remained.
Gopinath Sah untied one corner of the tarpaulin.
Manju untied the other.
Together they folded the tarpaulin.
The box was put away inside.
The ledger was placed not on top of the box, but inside it.
Gopinath Sah picked up a brick.
Manju said, "I'll put it there."
Gopinath Sah handed the brick to her.
Manju placed it on the lid of the box.
Gopinath Sah picked up the bag.

It was suddenly light.
So light that his hand rose slightly with it.
Manju noticed.
She said nothing.
As he was leaving the haat, Ramdev the vegetable seller called out,
“Uncle, potatoes?”
Gopinath Sah stopped.
He looked at the bag.
Then he said, “Not today.”
“Going home empty-handed?”
“I have the bag.”
Ramdev laughed.
Gopinath Sah did not.
Beyond the market the earthen road began.
The sun was sinking.
The empty bag under his arm puffed slightly in the wind.
He folded its mouth and pressed it down.
Near Majhdhar Tola he met Kishun Mandal again.
Kishun asked, “Sold everything?”
Gopinath Sah paused for a moment.
“Everything stayed there.”
Kishun Mandal did not understand what he meant.
“All right.”
The two went their separate ways.
By the time he reached home, evening had fallen.
Sarojini Devi was standing near the doorway.
She looked at Gopinath Sah’s hand.
The bag hung low.
There was no shape inside it.
Sarojini Devi asked, “No vegetables?”
“No.”
“Salt?”
“No.”
“Oil?”
“No.”
Gopinath Sah sat down on the veranda.
He placed the bag on the ground.
Sarojini Devi picked it up.

She opened its mouth.
Inside were the roti cloth and the little box.
She took them both out.
The bag truly was empty.
Sarojini Devi asked, "The ledger?"
"There."
"The weights?"
"There."
"The pointer?"
"There."
Sarojini Devi stood holding the bag in her hand.
"Everything?"
Gopinath Sah said, "Everything."
For a while there was silence on the veranda.
A bird drank from the water kept in one corner of the courtyard.
Sarojini Devi ran a hand inside the bag.
Two or three mustard seeds were caught at the bottom.
She shook them into her palm.
"These were left behind."
Gopinath Sah looked at the seeds.
"Let them be."
Sarojini Devi did not put them back into the bag.
She threw them onto the earth at the edge of the courtyard.
Then she shook out the bag.
She hung it on the peg.
It hung flatter than before.
That night Manju came at dinnertime.
She carried a small cloth sack in her hand.
Inside were potatoes, okra and a quarter-seer of salt.
Sarojini Devi said, "He was the one who went to the market."
Manju said, "I went too, this time."
Gopinath Sah kept eating his rice.
Manju looked at him.
"I put the ledger in the box."
Gopinath Sah nodded.
"The brick?"
"It's on top."
"Watch for damp."

“I will.”

That was all they said.

Manju left.

At night Sarojini Devi looked towards the peg.

“Next Wednesday?”

Gopinath Sah was stretching out, preparing to sleep.

He asked, “What?”

“The market.”

Gopinath Sah was silent for a while.

“We’ll see in the morning.”

The next Wednesday, Sarojini Devi rose at dawn.

Gopinath Sah rose too.

He washed his face.

He swept the veranda.

The bag hung from the peg.

Once, he reached out his hand.

His fingers touched a corner of the bag.

From outside came the sound of a bicycle bell.

Manju was at the doorway.

A bamboo basket was tied behind her bicycle.

Manju said, “Babu, where is the thick cord for tying the tarpaulin?”

Gopinath Sah went inside.

From the top of the old trunk, he took down the cord.

He placed it in Manju’s hand.

“Pull both corners equally tight.”

Manju said, “Yes.”

She left.

The bicycle bell receded along the road.

Gopinath Sah came back and sat on the veranda.

The empty bag hung from the peg.

Whenever the breeze touched it, its mouth opened a little.

Gopinath Sah did not tie it shut.

A Patch of Sunlight

It was a Paush morning.

The night's mist still clung like pearls to the bricks of the tulsi altar.

Sunlight was climbing over the eastern wall of the courtyard.

Inside the house, the cold was still sharper.

From a corner of the wall, a narrow strip of sunlight descended into the courtyard.

It was no more than two handspans wide.

Jagdish Mahato sat on a woven stool in the veranda.

An old woollen wrap lay over his shoulders.

The phlegm in his chest had not yet cleared completely.

Whenever a cough rose, he turned his face away.

Basanti Devi came from inside carrying two medicines and a glass of lukewarm water on a brass tray.

A woollen bandage was tied around her right knee.

When she walked, she could not bend that leg fully.

"Take your medicine," she said.

Jagdish Mahato looked at the tray.

"And you?"

"I have taken mine."

"When?"

"While you were coughing."

Jagdish Mahato put the medicine into his mouth.

He drank the water and set the glass back on the tray.

Basanti Devi looked at the narrow strip of sunlight.

"It is coming down now."

Jagdish Mahato looked too.

The doctor had said the previous day that both of them should sit in the sun for a little while.

For Jagdish's chest.

For Basanti's knee.

The courtyard was such that, on winter days, sunlight never stayed there for long.

First, after crossing the eastern wall, it fell near the tulsi altar.

Then in the middle of the courtyard.

After that, on the western veranda.

Before noon, it disappeared again.

Jagdish Mahato bent to lift the stool.

Basanti Devi immediately said, "Leave it."

She lifted the stool herself.

As she bent her knee, her face tightened a little.

Jagdish Mahato saw it.

He said nothing.

Basanti Devi placed the stool in the sunlight.

"Sit."

"You sit."

"I still have work to do."

"What work?"

"To see to the hearth."

"The hearth is out."

Basanti Devi fell silent.

The strip of sunlight covered half the stool.

Jagdish Mahato did not sit on it.

He brought another stool.

He placed it beside the strip of sunlight.

The two stools would not both fit in it at once.

One could remain fully in the sun.

Only the front legs of the other.

Basanti Devi kept watching.

Jagdish Mahato turned the first stool toward her.

"Sit."

"It is your chest."

"It is your knee."

"The knee is not going to run away."

"Nor is the chest."

Basanti Devi turned her face and smiled a little.

The smile faded quickly.

Jagdish Mahato coughed.

Basanti Devi sat on the first stool.

Jagdish Mahato on the other.
The sunlight fell on Basanti's right knee.
Jagdish's feet remained in shadow.
For a while, neither spoke.
Outside the courtyard, the milkman passed on his bicycle.
The bell rang.
Then receded into the distance.
A drop of condensed mist fell from the eaves.
It made a round mark on the brick.
Basanti Devi opened one end of her wrap.
She laid it over Jagdish's knee.
"I am warm enough," Jagdish said.
Basanti Devi did not take the end back.
"If you are warm, let it stay."
Jagdish Mahato pushed the edge of the wrap a little lower with his hand.
The sunlight moved forward.
Now Basanti's feet were fully in the sun.
The sunlight reached as far as the toes of Jagdish's left foot.
He moved the foot a little forward.
Basanti Devi saw him.
She dragged her own stool back by half a palm's breadth.
Jagdish Mahato saw that too.
"Why did you move?"
"The brick was uneven."
Jagdish Mahato looked down.
The brick was level.
He said nothing.
Again they were silent.
The strip of sunlight widened a little.
Jagdish Mahato shifted his stool slightly inward.
Now both his feet were in the sun.
Less sunlight fell on Basanti's knee.
Basanti Devi picked up the tray.
"I'll put this inside and come back."
She stood.
At the first step, her knee clicked.
Jagdish Mahato held out his hand.

Basanti Devi did not take it.
She placed one hand behind her on the stool and straightened herself.
“I am all right.”
She went inside.
Jagdish Mahato sat with one leg folded on the stool.
The sunlight did not reach his chest.
He loosened the wrap and lowered it from his shoulders.
After a while he coughed again.
From inside the house came the sound of a metal tin.
Basanti Devi returned.
A small bottle of oil was in her hand.
“What is that?”
“For rubbing on the knee.”
“In the sun?”
“The doctor said so.”
“Put the oil on.”
Basanti Devi sat again on the stool.
She opened the bottle.
The smell of oil rose.
She began to rub the oil slowly into her knee.
Jagdish Mahato kept looking at the sunlight.
Most of it now lay in the empty space between the two stools.
He shifted his stool.
Its leg scraped against the brick.
There was a rasping sound.
Basanti Devi looked up.
“Why so close?”
“The sunlight is escaping through the middle.”
“Can sunlight escape?”
“If we keep sitting here, it will.”
Basanti Devi laughed again.
This time the laughter lasted a little longer.
Jagdish Mahato smiled too.
At once a cough rose in his chest.
Basanti Devi stopped rubbing the oil and stroked his back.
The coughing subsided.
“Come inside,” Basanti said.
“Why?”

"There is a breeze."

"There is sunlight too."

"Your chest will worsen again."

"And your knee?"

"It will remain as it is."

Both of them stayed seated.

The sunlight left the legs of the stools and slowly climbed higher.

Basanti's woollen bandage began to glow.

The edge of Jagdish's dhoti looked bright white.

An earthen water pot in one corner of the courtyard stood in shadow.

A patch of sunlight fell on the brass bowl covering its mouth.

The bowl flashed.

Jagdish Mahato narrowed his eyes.

"Do your eyes hurt?"

Basanti asked.

"The glare caught them."

Basanti Devi tried to rise.

"Shall I move the bowl?"

"Stay seated."

"It is glaring."

"I can look the other way."

Basanti Devi sat back down.

Jagdish Mahato moved his stool outward by half a palm's breadth.

It made more room for Basanti's stool.

"You have gone into the shade again," Basanti said.

"My feet are in the sun."

"The doctor said it was for your chest."

"The feet will send word to the chest."

Basanti Devi shook her head.

"You have become very wise."

"In winter, all wisdom runs down toward the feet."

Basanti Devi closed the bottle of oil.

The cap caught after two turns.

She placed the bottle on the tray.

The sunlight had now reached the middle of the courtyard.

The strip was broad.

Both stools could fit inside it completely.

Jagdish Mahato rose to move his stool.

Basanti Devi said, "Leave it, I'll do it."

"You are not getting up."

"Then what?"

Jagdish Mahato lifted his stool.

A pull tightened across his chest.

He stopped for a moment.

Basanti Devi saw him.

She took the stool from his hands.

Both of them remained holding the same stool.

For a few moments.

Then they lifted it together.

They set it in the middle of the sunlight.

Together, they moved the second stool as well.

Now they sat not facing one another, but looking in the same direction.

Toward the east.

Above the wall, a clear blue sky was visible.

A crow flew past.

Its shadow crossed their feet for a moment.

Basanti Devi stretched out her right leg.

Jagdish Mahato drew his left foot slightly inward.

A palm's breadth of space remained between them.

"Is this all right now?" he asked.

Basanti Devi said, "Yes."

After a while, Jagdish's hand trembled.

He pulled the wrap back over his shoulders.

Basanti Devi noticed.

"Are you feeling cold?"

"No."

"Your hand is trembling."

"It is age."

"You did not have age yesterday?"

Jagdish Mahato did not answer.

Basanti Devi opened the other end of her wrap as well.

The two ends of their wraps overlapped.

Jagdish Mahato did not move his away.

The sunlight now lay on his hands.

On Basanti's fingers too.

The shadows of their fingers fell on the brick.
Separate.
A little apart.
Inside the house, the clock ticked.
Neither of them looked at it.
The sunlight kept shifting.
First a little to the right of Basanti's knee.
Then toward the front of Jagdish's feet.
Basanti Devi tried to move her stool again.
Jagdish said, "Leave it."
He stood up.
This time, slowly.
He moved both stools away.
He leaned them against the courtyard wall.
Basanti Devi looked at him questioningly.
Jagdish Mahato went inside.
He returned carrying an old bamboo mat.
A thin mat used for drying paddy.
He spread it in the middle of the sunlight.
"Shall we sit on the ground?"
"How will we get up?"
"If both of us are here, we will get up."
Basanti Devi looked at the mat.
Then at Jagdish.
"The knee?"
"Slowly."
Jagdish sat down first.
He braced his hands behind him.
Holding his shoulder, Basanti Devi lowered herself slowly.
Her knee hurt as it bent.
It showed on her face.
Jagdish Mahato said nothing.
Basanti Devi said nothing either.
They sat close beside each other on the mat.
The patch of sunlight fell at once over their feet, knees, and hands.
No one's stool stood outside it now.
No one's body was half in shadow.
Both were silent.

The last drop of mist fell from the eaves.

Then Basanti Devi said softly, "Is it reaching your chest now?"

Jagdish Mahato did not look at the sunlight.

"Yes."

"And the knee?"

"You tell me."

Basanti Devi placed a hand on her knee.

"Yes."

The sunlight slowly moved westward.

They shifted the mat once.

Then a second time.

The third time, Jagdish Mahato could not rise to move it.

He caught one corner of the mat and pulled it toward himself.

Basanti Devi took hold of the other corner.

Still seated, the two of them dragged the mat into place.

It rasped over the bricks.

The sunlight fell over them again.

Basanti Devi said, "This way is better."

Jagdish Mahato said, "The stools took up too much room."

"Was there too little sunlight?"

"There was too little space."

Basanti Devi was quiet for a while.

Then she said, "We used to sit separately."

Jagdish Mahato did not answer.

He drew his wrap a little higher.

Basanti Devi caught one end of it and pulled it down over her knee.

The wrap now lay between them.

The sunlight fell on it.

The shadow on the courtyard wall climbed higher.

The patch of sunlight began to shrink.

They did not move again.

Basanti Devi drew her right foot a little inward.

Jagdish moved his left foot slightly outward.

The sunlight fell half on one, half on the other.

After a while Basanti asked, "What time is the second dose of medicine?"

"Look at the clock."

"You look."

“The clock is inside.”
Neither of them got up.
Inside the veranda, the clock kept ticking.
The patch of sunlight grew smaller still.
Now it fell only on their hands.
Basanti Devi placed her hand on the mat.
Jagdish Mahato did the same.
Two fingers’ breadth of space lay between their hands.
The sunlight fell on that small space too.
After a while, Basanti moved her hand a little closer.
It did not touch Jagdish’s hand.
Only came near.
Jagdish Mahato did not move his hand away either.
Inside the house, the medicine tin lay on the low cot.
The glass was empty.
The two stools leaned against the wall.
One patch of sunlight remained in the courtyard.
Both their hands were inside that patch.
The rest of their bodies had passed into shadow.
Basanti Devi said, “Shall we go inside now?”
Jagdish Mahato said, “A little while longer.”
“The sunlight has gone.”
“There is still a little.”
Basanti Devi did not get up either.
Slowly, the sunlight slipped from their hands onto the empty part of
the mat.
Then it climbed the wall.
The courtyard became cold again.
For a few moments, they remained sitting just as they were.
Then Jagdish Mahato held out his hand.
Basanti Devi took it.
Jagdish stood first.
Then he helped Basanti to her feet.
They did not carry the stools inside.
The mat too remained where it lay.
Basanti Devi picked up the tray.
Jagdish Mahato picked up the bottle of oil.
Together they walked toward the veranda.

Behind them, there was no sunlight left in the courtyard.
The bamboo strips of the mat were slightly pressed down in two places.

The Boat Remained Tied

At dawn, the mist lay low over the river.

The bamboo mooring stake at the landing stood half-submerged in the water.

Raghunath Sahni was loosening the knot in the rope and tightening it again.

The boat had remained tied there all night.

Across the river, brightly coloured cloths could be seen hanging over the field.

Today was the fair.

The village school's annual function was being held there as well.

The first boatload arrived just as the sun was rising.

Three families.

Two children.

One old man.

Four baskets.

One drum.

Everyone was in a hurry.

Raghunath said nothing.

He had the baskets placed in the middle of the boat.

He seated the children on one side.

He settled the old man against the bamboo plank.

"Uncle, will you go and see the fair today too?"

One of the children asked.

Raghunath dipped the oar into the water.

"Let me get all of you across first."

The boat moved out into the current.

In the mist, the river did not seem very wide.

When they reached midstream, the sound of music from the far bank could be heard.

The drummer had one hand resting on his drum.

"Not yet," he said to himself.

Raghunath heard him.
He said nothing.
The boat came in on the sand of the far bank.
Everyone got off.
The children ran away.
The old man climbed up slowly.
Raghunath turned the boat around again.
“Why don’t you stay here?” the old man said.
“There are still people on this side.”
Raghunath replied.
The boat was empty.
The current turned an empty boat quickly.
Raghunath held the oar slightly at an angle.
On reaching this bank, he brought the boat alongside the bamboo stake again.
The second load was ready.
By noon he had found no time to count the trips.
Sometimes seven people.
Sometimes twelve.
Sometimes only two old people.
Once, four goats as well.
The faces of those going toward the fair were different.
No one was thinking about the return journey.
Everyone kept looking at the colours on the far bank.
Raghunath kept looking at the water.
The current had not risen.
But it was cutting into the sand on the southern side.
Whenever he brought the boat in on the far bank, he had to drive the bamboo pole into the sand again and again.
Near noon, his wife, Phoolo Devi, came to the landing with their daughter Sunita.
Sunita carried a blue cloth bag in her hand.
She was part of the school singing group.
Her white scarf was in the bag.
“Babu, our song is at three,” Sunita said.
Raghunath was throwing two potfuls of water out of the bottom of the boat.
“Yes.”

“At three.”

“I heard you.”

Phoolo Devi looked at Sunita.

Then at Raghunath.

“When there are fewer people, come over,” she said.

Raghunath lifted the rope.

“We’ll see.”

Sunita sat down in the boat.

Phoolo Devi placed the girl’s bag in her lap.

Seven other people climbed in as well.

The boat set off.

In midstream, Sunita kept looking toward the far bank.

Raghunath, toward this one.

When they reached the other side, everyone got off.

Sunita stepped out and paused.

“At three.”

Raghunath had already turned the bow of the boat around.

“Go. You’ll be late.”

Sunita walked away.

Raghunath returned alone once more.

There were fewer people now on this bank.

The shade of the neem tree at the landing had grown small.

A tea seller was packing up his utensils, waiting to cross to the other side.

“Will anyone be left after you?” Raghunath asked.

The tea seller looked back along the path.

“People from two households are coming.”

Raghunath sat down inside the boat.

He rested the oar across his knees.

The blisters on his palms were old.

Today they had grown a little red.

The tea seller said, “Uncle, won’t you charge fare today?”

“Why not?”

“It’s fair day.”

“The river doesn’t hold a fair.”

The tea seller laughed.

Raghunath did not.

He kept looking at the worn place in the rope.

The two families arrived.
One woman carried a brass plate.
A young man was wheeling a bicycle.
It took time to get the bicycle into the boat.
Raghunath wedged its front wheel against a bamboo plank.
“On the far bank, take it down and wheel it straight ahead,” he said.
The young man nodded.
The tea seller boarded last.
The boat was full.
Raghunath looked once toward the path on this bank.
No one.
Two empty earthen cups lay beneath the neem tree.
The dog from the landing too came up to the boat, wanting to follow the people to the far bank.
Raghunath let it aboard.
“That’s everyone now,” the tea seller said.
The boat pushed off.
This time there was no mist over the river.
Sunlight fell directly on the water.
The fair on the far bank could be seen clearly.
The Ferris wheel was turning.
Brightly coloured flags fluttered.
The school’s name was being announced over the loudspeaker.
The boat came in on the far bank.
Everyone got off.
The dog jumped out first of all.
The tea seller unloaded his utensils and paused.
“Uncle, tie the boat here now and stay.”
Raghunath probed the sand at the bank with the bamboo pole.
The pole sank half an arm’s length.
“A knot won’t hold here.”
“There’s a bamboo post by my stall. Tie it there.”
“At night the current will turn.”
“Then what?”
Raghunath said nothing.
The young man with the bicycle had also stopped.
“Everyone has come across. Who will you go back for now?”

Raghunath pushed the sand that had collected in the boat into one place with his foot.

Then he picked up the oar.

“The boat’s landing is not on that bank.”

The young man laughed.

“Stay here just for today.”

Raghunath pushed the boat away.

“We’ll see when it’s time to come back tonight.”

The boat entered the current.

The people on the far bank watched for a few moments.

Then they walked toward the fair.

Raghunath came back alone to this side once more.

The landing was empty.

As soon as the bow touched the earth, he stepped out.

He tied the rope to the old bamboo stake.

One knot.

Then another over it.

He tugged the rope to test it.

The boat moved a little.

The knot did not come loose.

Raghunath sat down beneath the neem tree.

There was no sound on this bank.

On the far bank there was every sound.

The announcement loudspeaker.

The drum.

Children shouting.

The creak of the iron Ferris wheel.

At times, applause.

Raghunath took some betel nut from his pocket.

He cut it with a small knife.

He put one piece in his mouth.

He folded the rest in paper and put it away.

He had no watch with him.

He looked at the sun.

It must have been around three.

The loudspeaker said something on the far bank.

The words broke apart while crossing the river.

“...school...”

Then came applause.
Raghunath raised his head.
For a few moments he listened.
Then he looked at the boat again.
A shapely leaf was caught in the bottom of the boat.
He took it out and placed it on the bank.
A song began on the far side.
Girls' voices together.
From that distance, the words could not be made out.
Only the tune reached him.
Raghunath kept chewing the betel nut.
Once, in the middle of the song, his hand stopped.
Then it moved again.
The song ended.
The sound of applause crossed the river and arrived faintly.
Raghunath leaned his back against the trunk of the neem tree.
Two crows flew across to this side.
One perched on the bow of the boat.
The other on the sand.
After a while, the first crow flew away too.
Raghunath stood up.
A strip of cloth was wrapped around the grip of the oar.
The cloth had loosened.
He untied the knot.
Then tied it tight again.
On one plank of the boat, a nail had risen slightly.
He hammered it down with a stone.
He checked the rope once more.
The fair continued on the far bank.
The path on this side remained empty.
The sun began to descend.
The neem tree's shadow stretched all the way to the river.
Raghunath went home once.
His house was five minutes from the landing.
The door was not shut.
The courtyard was empty.
The hearth was cold.
A plate lay overturned.

Phoolo Devi had left the morning rice covered.
Raghunath ate two mouthfuls.
He drank water.
Then he returned to the landing.
The boat was still there.
The rope was taut.
The current had grown a little stronger.
He pressed down the earth around the stake with his foot.
He brought another bamboo pole.
He drove it into the ground behind the first stake.
He looped one turn of the rope around that one as well.
Now the boat was tied between two bamboo stakes.
Across the river, the lights were slowly increasing.
The brightly coloured cloths of daytime were now less visible in the dark.
The rows of lamps could be seen clearly.
Raghunath sat down on the sand.
After a while, a lantern on the far bank moved up and down three times.
The old signal of the landing.
It was not yet time to return.
It was only a question—was the boat there?
Raghunath lit his own lantern.
He raised it twice.
The answer—yes.
The lantern on the far bank became still again.
Raghunath set his lantern beside the stake.
From far away, a man's voice came over the announcement loudspeaker.
The words were breaking apart again.
Then something like the sound of Sunita's laughter came across the water.
Raghunath raised his head.
There were many people on the far bank.
It was hard to tell who had laughed.
He looked at the rope again.
The knot was sound.

After a while, something like Phoolo Devi's red shawl moved near a light.

Raghunath narrowed his eyes a little.

He could not make it out clearly.

He did not get up.

He did not untie the boat.

Everyone was on the far bank.

On this bank, only the landing.

One boat.

Two bamboo stakes.

One lantern.

And Raghunath Sahni.

The current pulled the rope taut.

Then the rope slackened again.

Raghunath reached out and touched the knot.

There was applause again on the far bank.

The boat remained tied.

The Sound of the Refrigerator

There had been no electricity since evening.

The heat of Bhadra still clung to the walls even after the day had faded.

Outside the veranda, people sat in the lane fanning themselves with hand fans.

Inside the house, the darkness seemed a little deeper.

In a corner of the kitchen, the old refrigerator stood silent.

Its sound had been stilled for four hours.

Once the refrigerator fell silent, the other sounds of the house became distinctly audible.

The tick-tock of the wall clock.

The ting of a bicycle passing through the lane.

The scrape of a neighbour dragging a bucket across the roof.

And, every now and then, the slap of a hand killing a mosquito.

Naresh and Meena were both in the room.

Neither was speaking to the other.

The silence between them had begun before the power went out.

That afternoon Naresh had pasted a sheet of paper on the refrigerator door.

In bold letters it said - FOR SALE.

When Meena returned from the market, she saw the paper.

For a while she stood in front of the refrigerator.

Then she peeled off the paper and folded it.

She said nothing.

Naresh said nothing either.

From that moment, conversation had ceased.

The refrigerator was four years old.

It was not new.

Naresh had bought it from a family in Jhanjharpur.

The family had been leaving the town.

The paint on the refrigerator had peeled away in two places.

There was a small dent at the right-hand corner of the door.

One of the shelves inside was half-cracked.

But it worked well.

At first, all it did in the house was chill water.

Sometimes leftover vegetables.

Sometimes curd.

Sometimes the fish brought home from the Sunday market.

Over the past five months, its purpose had changed.

Meena had begun bringing milk home early each morning.

Some of it was for the household.

With the rest she set curd.

At first two neighbouring households bought it.

Then five.

Then the tea seller in the lane said he wanted two bowls every day as well.

Meena had made herself a small ledger.

Beside each name she wrote the quantity.

Half a seer for one.

A seer for another.

Only on Saturdays for someone else.

The ledger always lay on top of the refrigerator.

A blue pen always rested upon it.

Naresh had a small shop selling iron goods.

For three months, sales had been falling.

A new large shop had opened on the main road.

There, nails, wire, locks, pipes and paint could all be bought in one place.

Naresh's old customers still came to his shop.

But fewer of them.

At the end of the month, adding up the accounts made his head feel heavy.

That month the iron wholesaler had come three times asking for his money.

The household electricity bill was already two days overdue as well.

That morning, standing before the refrigerator, Naresh had said -

"If we sell this, two accounts can be cleared at once."

Meena had been boiling milk.

She turned and looked at him.

"Then where will I keep the curd?"

Naresh had said -

"How much do you earn from this anyway?"

Meena looked toward the stove.

The milk was rising.

She lowered the flame.

"How much I earn is written in the ledger."

Naresh did not open the ledger.

He said -

"It takes larger sums to run a household."

Meena replied -

"Large sums are made by adding small ones."

At that, Naresh fell silent.

Before leaving for the shop that afternoon, he wrote the notice and pasted it on the refrigerator.

In the evening Meena had peeled it off and folded it.

Now the folded paper lay on the sill of the kitchen window.

There was no electricity.

The refrigerator was silent.

So were they.

From time to time Meena placed a hand on the refrigerator door.

The cold inside was fading.

Two pieces of yesterday's ice were still left in the freezer compartment above.

She did not open the door.

Opening it would let the cold escape more quickly.

Naresh sat on the charpoy.

There was a fan in his hand.

He fanned himself only a little.

He watched more than he fanned.

The kitchen window.

The refrigerator.

The folded paper on the sill.

Meena went outside once.

From the veranda she brought in an earthen water pitcher.

She filled two glasses with water.

One she placed before Naresh.

She said nothing.

Naresh picked up the glass.

The water was warm.

He drank it.

He set the glass gently on the floor.

“How much curd is there?”

The question came as far as his lips.

But it did not come out.

Meena dampened a cloth and lifted the ledger from the top of the refrigerator.

She set the ledger on the low stool in the veranda.

For the first time, Naresh saw one of its pages lying open.

The dates of the month ran one beneath another in separate lines.

Amounts of money stood on the right.

Little totals below.

A check mark stood beside some names.

Beside others was written “tomorrow.”

From where he sat, Naresh tried to make out the figures.

He could not see them clearly.

He did not get up.

Meena closed the ledger.

Someone in the lane said -

“Still not back?”

Another voice answered -

“They’re working near the electricity pole.”

Naresh looked at the clock.

Eight twenty.

On an ordinary day, by this hour Meena would have washed the vessels for the next morning’s milk and set them upside down.

Today the vessels lay empty.

If the curd in the refrigerator spoiled, the morning’s orders could not be filled.

Naresh understood that.

He understood, too, why Meena had twice asked people in the lane about the electricity while he was closing the shop that evening.

But he said nothing.

In Naresh’s pocket was a small receipt from the wholesaler.

Again and again his fingers touched one corner of it.

The amount on the receipt was circled in red ink.

Selling the refrigerator might bring in that amount.
It might.
The refrigerator was old.
Who knew what price it would fetch?
He had not thought of that when he pasted up the notice that afternoon.
He had thought only of the amount.
In the darkness of night, the amount seemed small.
The refrigerator seemed large.
The curd inside the refrigerator was not larger than the refrigerator.
But behind that curd lay the account of every day.
Meena rose again.
She opened the ledger.
This time the page faced Naresh.
Whether deliberately or by accident,
Naresh could not tell.
Naresh looked at the figures.
The first date.
The second.
The third.
The total below.
Then the expenses.
Milk.
Sugar.
Earthen bowls.
Electricity bill.
Naresh's eyes stopped on that line.
"Electricity - twice."
Two dates were written to the right.
In both those months Naresh had thought the electricity money had gone from the cash box at his shop.
Perhaps it had.
Perhaps half of it had.
He could not remember clearly.
Meena turned the page.
Had Naresh asked, he would have understood.
He did not ask.
Had Naresh spoken, the conversation might have begun.

He did not speak.
It was nine o'clock.
The heat eased a little.
The mosquitoes grew worse.
Meena lit an old incense stick used for fumigation.
The smoke curled up in front of the refrigerator.
Naresh suddenly rose.
He went into the kitchen.
He placed a hand on the refrigerator door.
Meena looked at him.
Naresh did not open the door.
He merely kept his hand there.
"It's getting warm."
He could have said that.
He did not.
He picked up the folded paper from the window sill.
He unfolded it.
"FOR SALE."
In the darkness, the letters were only half visible.
Naresh folded the paper again.
He put it in his pocket.
This time too, Meena said nothing.
Suddenly a child shouted in the lane -
"It's back!"
First a light flickered on in the house opposite.
Then in another house.
Then the fan in their room jerked and began to turn.
The bulb on the wall glowed yellow.
For two moments the refrigerator remained silent.
Then came a small click from inside.
Then a low grrr-grrr.
Then a continuous hum.
The refrigerator came to life.
At first its sound was a little loud.
As though it were releasing four hours of silence all at once.
Meena opened the refrigerator door.
There was still some cold left inside.
No water had seeped out around the bowls of curd on the upper shelf.

She examined each bowl in turn.
Naresh stood behind her.
The refrigerator had three levels inside.
Curd on the top.
Two vessels of milk in the middle.
Below, Naresh's bottles of water and yesterday's vegetables.
Naresh took out the bottle from the bottom.
Instead of drinking a sip, he carried the bottle out to the veranda.
Then he came back.
He took out the second bottle as well.
Meena stood watching him.
Naresh cleared the entire bottom level.
He put yesterday's vegetables into a smaller bowl and tucked it into a corner.
Meena did not ask, "Why?"
Naresh did not say, "Put the curd here."
The hum of the refrigerator filled the space between those two unspoken sentences.
Meena washed the empty milk vessels.
She wiped one of them with a cloth.
Then she opened the ledger.
Against tomorrow's date she wrote three new names.
Naresh went back to the charpoy.
The folded paper was in his pocket.
He took it out.
For a while he held it on his palm.
Meena did not look.
Naresh looked at the blank reverse side of the paper.
He picked up the blue pen.
Meena raised her head.
Naresh wrote -
"Morning - two seers of milk."
Below it -
"Earthen bowls - twelve."
He did not paste the paper back on the refrigerator.
He placed it beside the ledger.
Meena picked up the pen.
She crossed out "twelve" and wrote "sixteen."

Naresh watched.
Meena closed the ledger.
The conversation had still not begun.
The fan was turning.
The children in the lane had gone out to play again.
The refrigerator's hum had settled into an even note.
Naresh sat on the charpoy.
Meena sat at the kitchen threshold.
Five handspans lay between them.
Naresh's glass was empty.
Meena filled it from the earthen pitcher.
She held it out to him.
This time, as Naresh took the glass, his hand brushed hers.
Neither of them withdrew at once.
Only for a moment.
Then Meena drew her hand back.
Naresh drank the water.
"I'll bring the milk in the morning."
Naresh said it softly.
It was the first complete sentence in four hours.
Meena did not answer at once.
She listened to the refrigerator's hum.
Then she said -
"Before six."
Naresh nodded.
That was all.
No apology.
No grand declaration.
The debt was still there.
The wholesaler's receipt was still in his pocket.
Sales at the shop were not going to rise suddenly tomorrow.
Meena understood all this too.
Neither of them said whether the question of selling the refrigerator was now over.
But the words on the front of the paper now lay face down.
The reverse side faced upward.
On it were written tomorrow's milk and the earthen-bowl account.
The night deepened.

The refrigerator kept running.
Sometimes its sound was loud.
Sometimes soft.
Meena put away the utensils.
Naresh switched off the fan.
They prepared to sleep.
The kitchen bulb was switched off.
In the darkness, the sound of the refrigerator was distinct again.
This time it was not the only thing inside the house.
The time for the morning milk had already been settled.

A Month's Rent

It was the fifth day of the month.

There was still an hour before evening.

Jyoti had set the lentils to cook on the kitchen stove.

The flame was low.

Every now and then she lifted the lid to look, then put it back without saying anything.

In the outer room Amar sat with the newspaper open before him.

The same page had been in his hands for half an hour.

He was not reading.

Again and again he looked at the clock hanging on the wall.

Ten minutes past four.

Fourteen minutes past four.

Seventeen minutes past four.

The hands of the clock kept moving.

Inside the house, time stood still.

From the kitchen Jyoti asked -

“Shall I make tea?”

Amar did not lift his eyes from the newspaper.

“At the usual time.”

Jyoti did not reply.

Ruchi lay on her stomach on the floor, working out multiplication problems.

She was nibbling the point of her pencil with her teeth.

“Babu, five times seven?”

“Thirty-five.”

Amar answered at once.

Ruchi moved on to the next problem.

No one had decided that the house must look like an ordinary day.

Yet each of them went about their work with such care that even an ordinary day seemed something to be rehearsed.

Washed clothes hung on the line in the veranda.

Twice Jyoti went out and straightened their folds.

Amar bent a corner of the newspaper and then smoothed it out again.

Ruchi placed her eraser exactly in the middle of her notebook.

The front door stood open.

Shashikant Babu had said that he would come around five.

He was the landlord.

When he came to collect the monthly rent, he usually sat in this room for five or ten minutes.

He drank a cup of tea.

He wrote out a receipt.

Then he left.

This month they owed four thousand two hundred rupees.

There were three thousand seven hundred in the envelope.

Five hundred short.

The envelope lay in the upper compartment of the cupboard.

Jyoti had counted the money three times that very morning.

Amar had counted it twice as well.

The total had not changed.

Three thousand seven hundred.

At the warehouse where Amar worked, no consignment had arrived on two days the previous week.

He had received no wages for those two days.

The remaining three hundred rupees had gone to the chemist the day before.

Ruchi's cough had worsened over the past three nights.

Twice that afternoon Amar and Jyoti had begun discussing which of these three reasons should be mentioned first to Shashikant Babu.

Both times the conversation had remained unfinished.

"Two days' wages..." Amar had said.

Jyoti had interrupted - "The medicine..."

Then both had fallen silent.

Whether there was one reason or three, the shortage was five hundred rupees.

At half past four Jyoti made tea.

Not three cups.

Two.

Ruchi was drinking milk.

Jyoti set one cup in front of Amar.

The other was for herself.
“What if he comes now?” Amar asked.
“Then I’ll make some more.”
“Sugar?”
Jyoti looked at Amar.
“There is some.”
The answer was brief.
Amar picked up his cup.
The tea was hot.
He blew on it and began to drink.
Ruchi suddenly got up and went to the door.
A bicycle bell had rung somewhere in the lane.
“Has he come?”
Jyoti asked.
“No, the milkman.”
Ruchi returned to her notebook and sat down again.
Amar folded the newspaper.
Then immediately opened it again.
“Why do you keep doing that?” Jyoti asked softly.
“Doing what?”
“The newspaper.”
Amar said nothing.
He put the newspaper down on the table.
One leg of the table was slightly short.
A folded scrap of paper had been wedged beneath it.
As Ruchi got up, she struck that leg with her foot.
The paper slipped out.
The table began to wobble.
Amar bent and picked up the paper.
It was an old rent receipt.
For the month of February.
It had been folded into four.
Amar folded the receipt again and pushed it back under the table leg.
Jyoti watched him.
“Why an old receipt?”
“I needed a piece of paper.”
“Wasn’t there any other paper?”
“There was.”

Silence again.

With her pencil, Ruchi was drawing a line beneath five times seven.

Five minutes to five.

Jyoti got up and swept the room once more.

The floor was already clean.

She merely swept two specks of dust from beside the door out of the room.

Amar said -

"It's already so clean."

"I could see it."

"See what?"

"The dust."

Amar did not answer.

At five o'clock footsteps sounded in the lane.

This time there was no bicycle bell.

Ruchi started to rise.

Jyoti said -

"You do your sums."

Ruchi remained seated.

Shashikant Babu appeared in the doorway.

In one hand he carried an old brown receipt ledger.

In the other, an umbrella.

The sky was clear.

"Come in, Babu." Amar stood up.

Shashikant Babu propped the umbrella in the veranda.

"It's very hot."

"Yes."

From inside Jyoti called -

"Shall I make tea?"

"If you're already making it."

Jyoti paused for a moment.

Then she said -

"It is being made."

She went towards the kitchen.

Amar offered Shashikant Babu a chair.

Ruchi remained bent over her notebook.

Shashikant Babu looked at her.

"Studying?"

Ruchi said -

“Multiplication.”

“Five times seven?”

Startled, Ruchi raised her head.

“Thirty-five.”

Shashikant Babu laughed.

“Good.”

Amar too tried to smile.

The smile did not quite form.

Shashikant Babu placed the receipt ledger on the table.

The table leg wobbled again.

He steadied the table with his hand.

“Has this leg come loose again?”

Amar said -

“I’ve wedged some paper under it.”

“How long will paper hold it?”

Amar said nothing.

Shashikant Babu looked at the shaft of his umbrella, then at the table.

“The carpenter is coming tomorrow. I’ll tell him to give you a thin piece of wood.”

“Let it be. It’s managing.”

“Managing and being right are two different things.”

It was an ordinary sentence.

Amar heard its meaning somewhere else.

Jyoti came in with the tea.

She brought only one cup.

For Shashikant Babu.

She had already washed her own cup and Amar’s and set them upside down.

“None for you?” Shashikant Babu asked.

Jyoti said -

“We’ve had ours.”

It was true.

Shashikant Babu began to drink his tea.

Once again the ticking of the clock could be heard in the room.

Ruchi’s pencil kept moving over the paper.

A vegetable vendor’s call passed through the lane.

No one brought up the rent.

The pocket of Amar's trousers was damp with sweat.
The envelope was in the cupboard, not in his pocket.
Even so, he felt as though the envelope were there in his pocket.
Shashikant Babu finished his tea.

Then he drew the receipt ledger towards himself.

"So?"

That was all he said.

Amar got up and went to the cupboard.

He opened the upper compartment.

He took out the envelope.

At that moment Jyoti went into the kitchen, on the pretext of checking the stove flame.

Ruchi remained absorbed in her mathematics.

Amar set the envelope down beside Shashikant Babu.

"We're five hundred short this time."

He said it in the very first sentence.

Shashikant Babu did not open the envelope.

"How much is there?"

"Three thousand seven hundred."

"The rest?"

"I'll pay it by the tenth."

Amar gave no reason.

Not the two days' lost wages.

Not the medicine.

Not Ruchi's cough.

Only the date.

Shashikant Babu opened the envelope.

He counted the notes.

Once.

Then a second time.

"Three thousand seven hundred."

He said it aloud.

Amar nodded.

Shashikant Babu opened the receipt ledger.

He wrote the date.

He wrote the amount.

Three thousand seven hundred.

Below it, in small letters, he wrote -

“Balance: five hundred.”

He tore out the receipt and held it out to Amar.

Amar took it in his hand.

The old February receipt was still wedged beneath the table leg.

The new receipt was in his hand.

Shashikant Babu stood up.

“The tenth?”

“Yes.”

“All right.”

With that, he picked up his umbrella.

Jyoti came out of the kitchen.

“More tea?”

“No, it’s getting late.”

Shashikant Babu looked at Ruchi.

“Finish your multiplication.”

Ruchi said -

“Yes.”

He left.

For a little while his footsteps could be heard receding along the lane.

Then no longer.

Amar did not close the door.

He sat down on the chair.

Jyoti picked up the empty cup from the table.

“Did you tell him?”

“Yes.”

“Everything?”

Amar paused for a moment.

“Five hundred.”

Jyoti understood.

“The reason?”

“No.”

Jyoti carried the cup back into the kitchen.

Amar opened the new receipt and looked at it.

Three thousand seven hundred.

Balance: five hundred.

There was nothing written about the tenth.

Only the balance.

Amar began to fold the receipt.

Then did not fold it.
He laid it flat on the table.
Ruchi said -
“Babu, seven times eight?”
Before answering, Amar looked at the clock.
Twenty-seven minutes past five.
Then he said -
“Fifty-six.”
Ruchi wrote it down.
Jyoti lifted the lid from the lentils.
Steam rose out.
“Shall I put the rice on?”
“Yes.”
Amar picked up the newspaper again.
This time not the front page.
He opened an inside page.
For a while, he actually read.
The table wobbled again.
Ruchi shifted her notebook.
Amar bent and pulled out the old receipt.
The February receipt had been crushed into four folds.
He opened it.
The corners of the paper were flattened and creased.
Amar went to the cupboard, cut a thick piece from an old newspaper,
and brought it back.
He folded it into four.
He wedged it beneath the table leg.
The table stood level.
The February receipt remained in his hand.
Jyoti looked from the kitchen.
“What will you do with that?”
Amar put the receipt in the lower compartment of the cupboard.
“Where receipts belong.”
Jyoti said nothing.
Outside, evening was descending.
Ruchi turned the page of her mathematics notebook.
Rice had been set on the stove.
The house filled again with its ordinary sounds.

The clink of a lid.

The scratch of a pencil.

The rustle of a newspaper page turning.

The ticking of the wall clock.

Five hundred rupees were still due.

The month too was still unfinished.

But the old receipt was no longer under the table leg.

The Blue Mug

The blue mug had not slipped from Sarita's hand.
It had slipped from Pradeep's.
Both of them were in the kitchen at the time.
So there was no question of who had broken it.
Pradeep was taking down the tea leaves from the upper shelf.
The mug was standing at the corner of the shelf.
His elbow struck it.
The mug fell first onto the wooden bench.
Then onto the floor.
The handle went one way.
The body of the mug broke into two pieces.
A small shard slid and lodged beside a leg of the stove.
Sarita was watching the milk on the stove.
It had not yet risen to the boil.
She turned off the stove.
Pradeep bent down.
"Don't touch it."
Sarita said,
"I can see it."
Pradeep began gathering the pieces.
He placed them on a sheet of newspaper.
The blue was not blue on the inside.
A line of white clay showed within.
Sarita put the milk back on the stove.
"I'll bring a mug tomorrow."
Pradeep said,
"Now?"
Sarita looked at the pan of milk.
"Tomorrow."
"You mean it's necessary to buy one right away?"
Before the milk could boil over, Sarita took it off the stove.

She said nothing.

Pradeep was folding the newspaper around the pieces.

"We have steel tumblers."

"We do."

"Then?"

Sarita strained the tea into two tumblers.

She set one in front of Pradeep.

The other before herself.

Pradeep touched the tumbler, then drew his hand back.

It was hot.

He looked for a cloth.

Sarita took an old cloth from a peg on the veranda and handed it to him.

"A mug was easier to hold," Pradeep said.

Sarita looked at him.

"That is why I'll bring one tomorrow."

Pradeep held the tumbler with the cloth.

"How much will it cost?"

"Sixty or seventy."

"Sixty or seventy is money too."

Sarita blew across the rim of her tumbler.

"I know."

"Expenses have been high this month."

"I know."

"There's the electricity bill."

"I know."

"The household provisions—"

"I know that too."

Pradeep fell silent.

The kitchen still held the stove's lingering heat.

Outside in the lane, a child kicked a ball.

It struck the wall with a dull tap.

Sarita went on drinking her tea.

Pradeep said,

"I'm only saying we can wait four or five days."

This time Sarita answered at once,

"We can wait."

"Then fine."

"But I'll buy it tomorrow."

Pradeep's hand stopped on the tumbler.

"Why?"

Sarita did not answer.

Pradeep asked again,

"What will happen in four days?"

"Nothing."

"Then?"

Sarita put her tumbler down.

"I want to buy it."

The sentence was short.

But in the kitchen it sounded perfectly clear.

Pradeep looked at her.

"When did I forbid you?"

Sarita did not smile.

"You asked—is it necessary?"

"Does that amount to forbidding you?"

"No."

"Then?"

Sarita fell silent again.

Pradeep picked up the broken mug wrapped in newspaper.

"I only keep an eye on the household expenses."

Sarita said,

"Don't I?"

Before answering, Pradeep tightened the folds of the newspaper.

"That isn't the point."

"What is the point?"

"You're bringing in something else again."

This time Sarita looked directly at him.

"The other thing was already here."

Pradeep's expression changed slightly.

"What?"

Sarita rose and opened the cupboard.

In the lower compartment was a small cloth pouch.

She took it out.

Pradeep watched.

The pouch held notes from her sewing earnings.

Tens.

Twenties.

Fifties.

One folded two-hundred-rupee note.

Sarita did not count them.

She merely placed the pouch on the table.

"I'll buy it with this money."

Pradeep said,

"This is household money too."

Sarita's hand remained on the pouch.

"Yes."

"Then, keeping the household expenses in mind—"

"It is household money," Sarita said again.

"Are the decisions household decisions too?"

Pradeep said nothing.

It was not the first time this sentence had come between them.

Only the words had been different before.

Three months earlier, the small low stool in the kitchen had broken.

Sarita had spoken of buying a new one.

Pradeep had said,

"It isn't necessary yet."

A brick had been placed beneath one leg of the old stool.

It was still there.

The previous winter, the belt of the sewing machine's treadle had worn thin.

Sarita had wanted to order a new belt.

Pradeep had said,

"It will last another two days."

Two days became two weeks.

In the end, Sarita asked one of the women whose clothes she stitched to bring a belt when she went to the market.

Pradeep perhaps kept a different account of such things.

To him they were small matters.

To Sarita too they were small.

The problem was that the small matters had to be explained to him again and again.

Pradeep looked at his mobile phone lying at the corner of the table.

Its new case gleamed.

Sarita did not look at the phone.

She said nothing.
Pradeep himself picked it up.
Then set it down again.
“The old case had torn,” he said.
Sarita said quietly,
“Did I say anything?”
“No.”
“Why didn’t I?”
Pradeep did not answer.
Sarita opened the pouch again.
She took out one fifty-rupee note and one twenty-rupee note.
She laid them flat on the table.
“Tomorrow I’ll buy the mug with this money.”
Pradeep said,
“Buy it.”
Sarita put the notes back into the pouch.
“Not now.”
“What?”
“I’ll take them out tomorrow.”
Pradeep’s tea was growing cold.
He drank half the tumbler in one swallow.
“Do you think I don’t let you spend money?”
Sarita looked towards the wall.
“Have you said that?”
“No.”
“Neither have I.”
“But that is where this is heading—”
“The point is this,” Sarita cut across him,
“Whatever you buy is considered necessary first.”
Pradeep frowned.
Sarita continued,
“When I say I want to buy something, the first question is—is it necessary?”
Silence returned to the kitchen.
The stove was cold now.
A fine stain of tea leaves had settled along the rims of the two tumblers.
Pradeep got up to wash his tumbler.

Sarita said,

“Leave it. I’ll wash it.”

Pradeep turned on the tap.

“I can wash it.”

Sarita said nothing.

He had almost finished washing the tumbler when it nearly slipped from his hand.

Both of them reached out at the same instant.

The tumbler was saved.

Pradeep laughed softly.

Sarita did not.

Pradeep turned the tumbler upside down to dry.

“It’s steel. It won’t break so easily.”

Sarita said,

“I’m not talking about the mug breaking.”

Pradeep’s smile vanished.

“I know.”

Perhaps it was the first sentence that night in which both of them understood the same thing.

Pradeep picked up the newspaper containing the broken mug.

He went towards the rubbish basket.

Then stopped.

“Shall I throw it away?”

Sarita said,

“Yes.”

Pradeep put the newspaper into the basket.

A small piece of the blue handle fell out of it.

He bent, picked that up too, and put it inside.

They did not discuss the matter again that night.

Sarita sat down at the sewing machine.

Two pillow covers needed their edges finished.

Pradeep sat on the veranda looking over the account pages.

After a while his pen stopped.

“Sarita.”

“Mm?”

“Are you running short of sewing cord again?”

Sarita stopped the machine.

“Why?”

"It's entered twice in last month's ledger."

"That isn't cord. It's thread."

"All right."

Sarita started the machine again.

Pradeep said,

"How much does it cost?"

Sarita stopped the machine.

"What?"

"Thread."

"Why are you asking?"

Looking at the page, Pradeep said,

"Just so I can write it down."

Sarita looked at him for a while.

"Depends on the colour."

With his pen, Pradeep drew a short line in an empty space in the ledger.

He wrote nothing.

The next morning Pradeep woke earlier than usual.

Sarita had not yet made tea.

He went into the kitchen.

He took down two steel tumblers.

Sarita came in behind him.

"Up early today?"

"My sleep broke."

Once again they drank tea from steel tumblers.

The blue mug was gone.

Its place was empty.

Sarita prepared her bag for the market.

She put in the list of vegetables.

She wrote soap.

She wrote oil.

She left one line blank at the bottom.

Pradeep was sitting near the table.

He looked at the list.

"You haven't written the mug?"

Sarita said,

"I remember."

"The price?"

Sarita looked at him.

Pradeep said at once,

“No, leave it.”

Sarita picked up the bag.

When she returned from the market, she had a mug in her hand.

Not blue.

A pale earthen colour.

With a thin green line around the rim.

Pradeep took it in his hand and looked at it.

“It’s good.”

Sarita said,

“Seventy.”

Pradeep set the mug on the table.

He did not say, “Seventy?”

Sarita began unpacking the shopping.

Pradeep drew the ledger towards himself.

Under the month’s expenses he wrote—

“Mug — 70.”

He paused.

Beside it, in small letters, he wrote—

“From Sarita’s sewing money.”

Sarita saw it from a distance.

“Why did you write that?”

Pradeep kept the pen in his hand.

“For the accounts.”

Sarita said,

“Wasn’t it household money?”

Pradeep looked at the page.

After a while he drew a thin line through “From Sarita’s sewing money.”

The words remained legible.

But they were visibly crossed out.

Below them he wrote—

“Household.”

Sarita did not close the ledger.

She went to the tap to wash the new mug.

Pradeep picked up a steel tumbler and put it on the shelf.

The new mug was placed in the middle of the shelf.

Sarita did not move it towards her side.
Neither did Pradeep.
Tea was made in the afternoon.
There was one mug.
And one steel tumbler.
Pradeep reached for the mug.
Then stopped his hand.
“You take it.”
Sarita said,
“Will you take it?”
“It’s all right.”
Sarita picked up the mug.
Pradeep took the steel tumbler.
For a while they drank their tea in silence.
The mug was new.
The argument was old.
It had not ended.
But this time its price had been entered in the ledger.
And beside it, no one had written, “Necessary?”

The Charger

The charger was not in its place that morning.

Its place was on the small shelf beside the kitchen doorway.

There was an electrical socket below the shelf.

A white cable rose from it and usually hung from a nail above.

Everyone in the house knew—the mobile-phone charger stayed there.

That morning there was only the empty nail.

Manoj first looked at the nail.

Then at the socket.

Then at the corner of the shelf.

The charger was not there.

He lit the screen of his mobile phone.

Seven percent.

At half past seven he had to speak to the grocery-van driver from the market.

The payment message too would come on the phone.

He looked at the nail again.

Kusum was heating milk on the stove.

Manoj asked,

“Where is the charger?”

Kusum did not turn around.

“Where it always is.”

“It isn’t there.”

Kusum took the milk pot off the stove.

She came to the doorway.

She looked at the nail.

“It was right here last night.”

Manoj said,

“Who plugged it in last night?”

Kusum looked at him.

“You did.”

Manoj was silent for a few moments.

He remembered that he had put his phone on charge at night.
But he could not remember whether he had taken the charger down afterwards.

He moved the little box kept on the shelf.

An old key.

Two coins.

A scrap of cloth stained with turmeric.

No charger.

Kusum said,

“Ask Neera.”

Manoj’s eyes went towards the inner room.

Neera was gathering her books for school.

Her own charger had stopped working two weeks earlier.

Since then she too had been using the one charger in the house.

Manoj stood in the doorway of the room.

“Neera.”

“Yes, Babu.”

“Do you have the charger?”

Neera did not lift her eyes from the books.

“No.”

“Did you use it last night?”

“In the evening.”

“Where did you put it after taking it off?”

“On the nail.”

Manoj took two steps into the room.

Neera’s blue schoolbag lay on the cot.

Manoj looked at it.

Neera looked at it too.

Neither said anything.

Manoj opened the upper compartment of the bag.

Neera’s hand stopped on the book she was holding.

Manoj took out a notebook first.

Then the geometry box.

Then a small cloth handkerchief.

There was no charger.

Neera said,

“Look in the other compartment too.”

Manoj stopped his hand.

“I’m only looking for the charger.”

Neera said,

“Then look through everything.”

Kusum had come to the doorway.

The milk ladle was in her hand.

She said nothing.

Manoj opened the second compartment of the bag.

There were Neera’s school identity card, two pens, a folded slip of paper, and a small cloth purse.

No charger.

Manoj closed the bag.

Neera went on arranging her books.

Kusum turned away.

The milk in the kitchen had begun to rise.

Manoj came out as well.

He said,

“Why have you kept your bag here?”

Neera did not answer.

On ordinary days too, she kept the bag there.

Manoj knew that.

Sunlight had not yet entered the courtyard.

The electricity was on.

The phone had fallen to six percent.

Manoj checked the pocket of his shirt.

Nothing.

He opened the drawer.

An old ledger.

A strip of medicine tablets.

A receipt.

No charger.

Kusum brought tea.

Manoj picked up the cup.

“It isn’t in your sewing bag, is it?”

Kusum looked at him.

“If you want to, look.”

The sentence was short.

So was her tone.

Manoj put down the tea.

"I only asked."

"I answered."

Kusum kept her sewing bag on the veranda.

It held scissors, thread, a measuring tape, two customers' garments, and her small earnings ledger.

Manoj went towards the bag.

He held out his hand.

Then stopped.

Kusum kept looking towards the stove.

Manoj did not open the bag.

He said,

"Leave it."

Kusum did not reply.

Neera came out.

Her books were now inside the schoolbag.

She had tied the cord at the top again.

On ordinary days she did not tie it so tightly.

Manoj noticed.

He said nothing.

Neera did not drink tea.

She took a glass of milk.

All three were on the same veranda.

There was no conversation.

Only the sound of a spoon striking a vessel.

A vegetable seller called from outside the courtyard.

Manoj looked at the phone again.

Five percent.

He could have asked for a charger from his neighbour Jagdish.

He thought of doing so.

But he did not go.

He wanted first to find his own charger.

He looked beneath the cot.

An old slipper.

A crumpled ball of paper.

Dust.

No charger.

Neera said,

"Babu, I'm getting late."

“Go.”

Neera stood up.

Then stopped.

“Will you look through my bag again?”

Manoj started.

“No.”

Neera watched his face for a few moments.

“All right.”

She went out.

Kusum watched her as far as the courtyard gate.

Manoj remained seated near the cot.

Kusum came back.

She picked up her sewing bag and took it inside.

Manoj said,

“I didn’t open it.”

Kusum said,

“I saw.”

Then she went back to tending the fire.

Manoj’s phone was at four percent.

He went to Jagdish’s house.

Jagdish gave him his charger.

“I’ll return it in the evening.”

Manoj said,

“By noon.”

Back home, he plugged in his phone.

The charging symbol appeared on the screen.

He felt relieved.

But the silence in the house remained exactly as it was.

At half past seven the grocery-van driver called.

Manoj spoke to him.

The payment message arrived.

The work was done.

Meanwhile Kusum had finished measuring garments for two customers.

She was writing something in her ledger.

Manoj’s eyes went to the sewing bag.

It now hung from a peg inside the house.

Earlier it used to remain beside the low stool on the veranda.

Manoj asked,
“Why did you hang it there?”
Kusum said,
“It will keep the place clear.”
Manoj understood that this was not the whole answer.
He said nothing more.
At noon Neera returned from school.
She took her bag straight into her room.
Earlier she used to toss it on the cot in the veranda.
Manoj noticed this change too.
Neera went to wash her hands and face.
Manoj said,
“The charger still hasn’t turned up.”
Neera replied,
“You have Jagdish Kaka’s, don’t you?”
“Yes.”
“Then that will do.”
Her tone was ordinary.
But she did not look into her father’s eyes.
They ate lunch.
Manoj took rice.
Kusum served dal.
Neera took the vegetables.
They spoke only of salt and water.
After the meal Kusum began wiping the shelf.
A drop or two of the morning milk had dried there.
She moved the turmeric box.
Then pushed the cloth behind the shelf.
The cloth caught on something.
Kusum reached her hand inside.
Between the wall and the shelf, the end of a white cable showed.
She pulled it gently.
First the cable came out.
Then the small white block.
The charger.
It had fallen and lodged behind the shelf.
A knot of blue thread on it was grimy with dust.
Holding it in her hand, Kusum looked towards Manoj.

Manoj looked first at the charger.
Then at the empty nail.
Then at Kusum's hand.
"It was here?"
Kusum said,
"Right here, behind it."
Manoj peered behind the shelf.
There was a gap of two fingers between the wall and the wood.
"But I looked everywhere."
Kusum said,
"You looked on top."
"Not behind."
Manoj did not answer.
He took the charger in his hand.
The cable was intact.
The block was intact.
No one had taken it.
No one had hidden it.
No one had kept it in a bag.
Manoj hung the charger on the nail.
Kusum went to wash clothes.
Manoj remained seated on the veranda.
Jagdish's charger was plugged into his phone.
The charger from his own house hung before him.
Both did the same work.
But Manoj's attention was on neither cable.
He remembered Neera's tightly tied schoolbag.
And Kusum's sewing bag.
He stood up.
He unplugged Jagdish's charger.
He plugged in the charger from the house.
Then, carrying Jagdish's charger, he stepped outside.
When he returned it, Jagdish asked,
"Found yours?"
Manoj said,
"Yes."
"Where was it?"
Manoj paused for a few moments.

“It had fallen behind the shelf.”
Jagdish did not laugh.
He only said,
“Small things do that.”
Manoj returned home.
The afternoon wore on.
Neera came back from school.
She was taking her bag straight into her room.
Manoj said,
“Neera.”
She stopped.
Manoj pointed towards the nail.
“The charger turned up.”
Neera looked at the nail.
“Where was it?”
“It had fallen behind the shelf.”
Neera was silent for a few moments.
Then she said,
“All right.”
She started to go inside.
Manoj called again,
“Neera.”
She turned.
“Bring your bag here.”
Neera’s face grew a little hard.
Manoj said at once,
“Not to search it.”
Neera said nothing.
She placed the bag on the cot.
Manoj looked at the cord.
“I opened it this morning.”
“Yes.”
“I should not have opened it.”
Neera looked at him.
Manoj said,
“You had not told me to look.”
Neera said quietly,
“I had said—look through everything.”

Manoj understood.
That sentence had not been permission.
It had been a wound.
Manoj did not touch the cord of the bag.
He only said,
“I won’t open it again unless you yourself ask me to.”
Neera picked up the bag.
“All right.”
She went inside.
Kusum was sewing.
Manoj went to her.
“Your bag too.”
Kusum stopped her needle.
“What?”
“I had thought of opening it.”
Kusum said,
“But you did not.”
“I should not even have thought of it.”
Kusum looked at Manoj’s face for a few moments.
Then she said,
“You found the charger, didn’t you?”
“Yes.”
“Then let this matter find its place too.”
Manoj understood that this was not forgiveness.
But neither was the door closed.
In the evening Manoj examined the gap behind the shelf.
He brought a narrow strip of wood.
He hammered in two small nails.
He fixed the strip so that the charger could no longer fall behind the shelf.
Kusum watched while continuing her work.
Neera kept writing her homework.
Manoj hung the charger on the nail again.
At night Neera plugged in her phone.
“I’ll keep it on charge for half an hour.”
Manoj said,
“All right.”
That was all.

The rain began again.
Wind blew spray into the veranda.
Neera's bag lay at one corner of the cot.
Manoj stood up.
As before, he could simply have picked up the bag and carried it inside.
He reached out his hand.
Then stopped.
"Neera."
"Yes, Babu?"
"Rainwater will fall on your bag."
"Shall I put it inside?"
Neera came out.
She looked at the bag.
"Yes, put it inside."
Manoj picked up the bag.
Its cord remained just as it was.
He placed it on the cot inside.
As he turned back, his eyes went to the charger.
It was on the nail.
Behind the shelf was the new strip of wood.
And inside, on the cot, was Neera's bag.
Manoj had put it there.
Without opening it.

The Clothesline

The sun came out that morning after three days of rain.

The mud in the lane was still soft.

Water had stopped dripping from the eaves, but the bricks of the courtyard were still wet.

Sharda Devi first swept the veranda.

Then she came out carrying the wet clothes in a bamboo basket.

On one side of the courtyard stood an old iron post.

On the other, an iron hook had been driven into the top of the boundary wall.

A clothesline was stretched between the two.

The whole line did not lie within Sharda's courtyard.

By the time half of it reached the boundary wall, it leaned towards Kamli Devi's house.

The arrangement was so old that no one remembered how it had begun.

The moment the sun appeared, clothes were washed in both houses.

Sharda first spread out her granddaughter's white school kurta.

Then two towels.

A blue sari.

A small sheet.

She went on fastening clothespins.

Meanwhile Kamli's voice came from the other side of the wall.

"Sharda, how much space is left on the line?"

Sharda did not look up.

"As much as you can see."

Kamli did not laugh.

"What I can see is half a handspan."

"Then half a handspan is what there is."

A little later Kamli came carrying a large wet bedcover.

She placed a low stool beside the boundary wall.

Climbing onto it, she caught hold of the line.

Her hand brushed against Sharda's blue sari.

Sharda turned at once.

"Don't touch the sari."

Kamli stopped her hand.

"I'm holding the line."

"Hold the line. Not the sari."

Kamli folded the bedcover in half.

She placed one edge over the line.

The other hung down towards the ground.

"Will it dry like this?" Kamli asked.

"How would I know?"

"The line is between both houses."

For the first time Sharda looked straight at her.

"There is a wall in between."

Kamli's hand went still on the line.

Across the lane, the milkman had stopped his bicycle and was measuring out milk.

Hearing the two women's voices, he looked over once.

Then turned his face away.

Kamli slowly took down the bedcover.

"All right."

She stepped down from the stool.

Sharda straightened the corner of one of her towels.

The sunlight began to grow stronger.

Everyone needed sun that day.

Three days' worth of damp clothes had piled up in every house.

In her own courtyard Kamli tied a thin cord between the backs of two chairs.

The bedcover would not stay properly on it.

The moment the wind blew, the cord sagged in the middle.

Kamli took the bedcover down again.

Her daughter-in-law Reena called from inside, "Ma, shall I spread it on the roof?"

Kamli looked up.

There was still water on the roof.

"No."

"Then in the veranda?"

"Where is the sun there?"

Reena fell silent.

On this side of the boundary wall, Sharda heard everything.

She spread her grandson's trousers over an empty stretch of the line.

The line was now almost full.

In Kamli's courtyard, the stool still stood beside the wall.

After a while Sharda's son Nandu came out to go to the market.

He looked at the line.

Then at the stool on the other side of the wall.

"What happened again?" he asked.

Sharda said, "Nothing."

Nandu looked at his mother's face.

"If it were nothing, your face wouldn't look like that."

Sharda picked up the box of clothespins.

"Go to the market."

Nandu went on putting on his shoes.

"You didn't give her any space on the line?"

"My clothes were there."

"The line is old."

"So is my house."

Nandu said nothing.

He went out.

At that moment Kamli's son Ravindra came into the lane carrying two empty sacks.

Nandu and Ravindra came face to face.

Once, the two of them had gone to school together.

Now even their greetings had grown brief.

"Going out?" Ravindra asked.

"Yes."

"Me too."

They walked away in different directions.

Inside the house, Sharda's granddaughter Anushka sat with a book open before her.

She had heard the exchange outside.

"Grandmother."

"What?"

"Does that line belong to them too?"

Sharda did not answer.

"Babu said it is old."

“Do your studies.”

Anushka looked down at her book again.

After a moment she asked, “Who owns old things?”

Sharda dropped the clothespins sharply into the box.

“The one who takes care of them.”

On the other side, Kamli heard the sentence.

She was standing in the veranda with the bedcover in her hands.

Softly she said, “A great many things can be taken care of.”

Sharda heard her.

She did not reply.

The sunlight moved slowly along the clothesline.

The white kurta dried first.

Sharda took it down.

A handspan of space opened on the line.

Kamli looked at the stool.

Then did not rise.

Sharda kept folding the kurta.

The empty space on the line shone in the sun.

Wind passed unhindered through that empty stretch.

Ten minutes went by.

Kamli spread the bedcover in the veranda.

Reena said, “Ma, space has opened up now.”

Kamli replied, “Let it remain empty.”

Sharda's hands stopped.

She took down the blue sari.

Now another large space opened in the middle of the line.

Kamli did not look towards it.

Sharda went inside.

She put water on in the kitchen.

While washing rice, her eyes kept straying through the window to the line.

Two towels fluttered in the wind.

Empty line between them.

Directly behind that empty stretch stood the boundary wall.

The wall was new.

It had been built four years earlier.

The clothesline was much older.

Even when the wall was built, the line had not been removed.

The mason had left the hook in place.
Why he had spared it, no one had asked.
Long ago there had been no wall there.
Only a bamboo screen had stood between the houses.
Each courtyard had been half visible from the other.
The clothesline had run from the mango tree of one house to the post of the other.

From a distance it had been difficult to tell whose clothes were whose.
At that time Nandu and Ravindra had been small.
The school shirts from both houses used to hang on the same line.
Then, one year, there had been a flood.
Water had entered Kamli's house up to the knees.
For five nights she and her family had stayed in Sharda's veranda.
During those days, most of the clothes on the line belonged to Kamli's household.

Wet towels.

Children's clothes.

Bedding.

A white sheet.

On the morning of the sixth day, the sun had come out.

Sharda's mother-in-law was ill.

There were too many people in the house.

The kitchen was small.

The courtyard was wet.

Sharda was exhausted.

Kamli had washed the white sheet and spread it on the line.

Then, in front of everyone, Sharda had said, "How many more days will your whole house remain spread across my courtyard?"

That was all she had said.

But five people had been there at the time.

Kamli had looked at Sharda once.

Then she had taken down the white sheet.

That evening Kamli had gone back to her still-damp house.

The water had not even fully receded.

They never spoke of the incident again.

The floodwater went down.

The bamboo screen was rebuilt.

The children grew up.

There were marriages in both houses.
There were two deaths.
Once the well was cleaned jointly.
Salt and spices passed back and forth countless times.
But that sentence remained in the clothesline like a knot.
Sharda strained the rice in the kitchen.
She remembered the white sheet.
At the time she had understood her own words as exhaustion.
Kamli had understood them as humiliation.
For all those years, the two meanings had lived side by side.
By noon the sun was fierce.
All of Sharda's clothes had dried.
She cleared the line.
The whole line was empty.
Kamli's bedcover was still damp in the veranda.
Sharda came to the wall.
The stool was on the other side.
She called, "Kamli."
No answer.
"Kamli."
Reena came out.
"Ma is inside."
Sharda said, "Spread out the bedcover."
Reena looked at her for a moment.
Then went inside.
Kamli herself came out.
Her hands were empty.
"What is it?"
"The line is empty."
"I can see that."
"Spread out the bedcover."
Kamli looked at the hook on top of the wall.
"I'll spread it over the chairs."
Sharda was silent.
After a while she said, "It won't dry properly on the chairs."
A slight hardness came over Kamli's face.
"Some things take longer to dry."
Sharda opened her mouth to answer.

Then closed it again.
The wind moved the line.
The empty line made only the faintest sound.
A small metallic creak.
Sharda took her hand off the wall.
She went inside.
So did Kamli.
Later in the afternoon the sky began to turn grey again.
Gathering in the clothes, Reena said, "It will rain again."
Kamli touched the bedcover.
It was still damp.
She looked up at the roof.
The sunlight was fading.
On this side of the boundary wall, Sharda came out carrying a short piece of old bamboo.
Nandu had already returned from the market.
"What are you doing?" he asked.
"Making a hook."
"Where?"
"On this side of the wall."
Nandu understood.
"A new line?"
"Yes."
"Will the old one come down?"
Sharda looked at the old line.
"No."
Nandu cut the bamboo into a small peg.
It was fixed into the wall on Sharda's side.
A new thin wire was stretched from that peg to the old iron post.
Now Sharda had a separate line for her clothes.
The old line still ran as before to the hook on the boundary wall.
Kamli watched all this from her courtyard.
She said nothing.
The first two drops of rain fell.
Kamli immediately picked up the bedcover.
She placed the stool by the wall.
Climbed onto it.
Caught hold of the old line.

Paused for a moment.
Then spread out the bedcover.
Sharda was gathering the dry towels from her new line.
Neither woman looked at the other.
The bedcover opened out fully across the old line.
The rain had not yet grown heavy.
Only the wind had strengthened.
Kamli clipped one edge in place.
The wind kept lifting the other.
Sharda took a wooden clothespin from her box.
She placed it on top of the wall.
She said nothing.
Kamli saw the clothespin.
She reached out and picked it up.
She fastened the other edge of the bedcover.
“This line has gone slack,” Kamli said.
Tightening her new line, Sharda said, “I’ll have Nandu tighten it tomorrow.”
Kamli said, “Ravindra will be here too.”
Sharda was silent for a moment.
“The two of them can tighten it.”
Three or four more raindrops fell.
Kamli took the bedcover down again.
“It won’t dry today,” she said.
Sharda looked at the sky.
“No.”
Both women carried their own clothes inside.
It rained during the night.
By morning the sky was clear.
Nandu and Ravindra met in the lane.
Nandu had a ladder in his hands.
Ravindra had a pair of pliers.
Kamli held one end of the old line.
Sharda held the other.
Nandu tightened the hook.
Ravindra pulled the line taut.
No one spoke of the old flood.
No one spoke of the white sheet.

No one said whose line it was.
The line grew taut.
The new line was stretched along that side as well.
The two lines now ran parallel.
One new.
One old.
The sun climbed.
Kamli spread out her bedcover first.
Sharda spread her granddaughter's kurta on the new line.
The wind rose.
The two lines moved separately.
But atop the boundary wall, the old hook was still the same one.

The Closed Tap

The first light of dawn had not yet reached the veranda.

Kalyani Devi turned the tap in the courtyard.

At first there was a faint gurgle from the tap.

Then a single drop fell.

After that, nothing.

She shut the tap again and stood there for a few moments.

Far away on the road, the milkman rang his bicycle bell.

From the neighbour's house came the sound of an iron bucket being set down.

Kalyani turned the tap again.

This time there was not even a gurgle.

She looked at the first bucket standing in a corner of the courtyard.

Empty.

She looked at the second bucket.

There was only a palmful of water at the bottom.

The earthen drinking-water pot was a little more than half full.

Kalyani tightened its lid.

Before going to bed the previous night, she had said—

“Fill two buckets and keep them ready.”

Listening to the news, Dinesh Babu had said—

“Chandan will fill them.”

Gathering his books, Chandan had said—

“Didi is still awake.”

Madhavi had risen late from her studies.

She had thought—Mother must have filled them.

Kalyani had thought—someone or other would fill them.

By the end of the night, the buckets had remained empty.

At that time there had been water in the tap.

Now there was none.

From inside came Dinesh Babu's voice—

“Is the tea ready?”

Kalyani did not answer.
She went into the kitchen.
A small empty pot stood on the hearth.
She opened the lid of the drinking-water pot.
She took out one lota of water and set it beside the hearth.
Then her hand stopped.
One lota was enough to make tea.
But Madhavi had to leave at seven.
Chandan too had to go to school.
Dinesh Babu had to open the shop.
Kalyani had to deliver two stitched garments by eight.
All four tasks belonged to the same household.
One lota of water stood before them.
Dinesh Babu came out onto the veranda.
“No water?”
Kalyani shook her head.
Dinesh went to the tap.
He turned it himself.
The tap remained silent.
“The supply must be shut off.”
Kalyani said—
“Must be.”
Dinesh looked at the sky.
There was a light winter mist.
“Did water come in the house behind us?”
“I don’t know.”
“Ask them.”
Kalyani looked at him.
“You ask.”
Dinesh said nothing.
Madhavi came out from inside carrying a towel.
“Ma, have you heated the water?”
Kalyani looked at the towel.
“There is no water.”
Madhavi stopped short.
“None at all?”
“There is drinking water.”
Madhavi turned the tap.

Nothing.

"I have an exam today."

Dinesh said—

"Wash your face and hands with a little water."

Madhavi fell silent.

She folded the towel and put it on the chair.

Chandan came out, his eyes still heavy with sleep.

He was holding his little tooth-cleaning tin.

"The tap's dry?"

Madhavi said to him—

"You were told to fill the buckets last night."

Chandan answered at once—

"Babu said you would fill them."

"Who told me?"

"I heard it."

"You heard it; nobody told me."

Dinesh intervened—

"Don't quarrel this early in the morning."

Madhavi turned towards him.

"Who started the quarrel?"

Dinesh fell silent.

Kalyani sat down beside the hearth.

She took down the small pot meant for tea.

"Tea later."

Dinesh said—

"I have to get to the shop early."

Kalyani replied—

"I too have work to deliver."

"Your work is at home."

The sentence was short.

The kitchen was small.

But the sentence took up a little too much space in it.

Kalyani kept turning the lid of the small pot over and back again.

Madhavi looked at her father's face.

Chandan put away his tooth-cleaning tin.

Dinesh said a little more softly—

"I meant that you don't have a fixed time when you must go out."

Kalyani said—

"The person whose clothes I promised for today has a fixed time."

Dinesh said nothing more.

The tap in the courtyard remained silent.

In that silence, the empty buckets from the night before seemed plainly visible.

Madhavi took half a lota of water from the drinking pot.

Kalyani said at once—

"How much did you take?"

Madhavi stopped her hand.

"To wash my face."

"Do it with half a lota."

"This is only half."

"Then fine."

Madhavi washed her face in a corner of the courtyard.

She poured the last two mouthfuls over Chandan's hands.

"Clean your teeth."

Chandan did not laugh.

He quietly did as she said.

Dinesh put on his shirt.

He felt in his pocket.

Two twenty-rupee notes, one ten, and a few coins.

"Shall we buy water from the market?"

Kalyani asked.

Dinesh said—

"They charge forty rupees for one container of water in the market."

"So?"

"I have only sixty with me right now."

"Until evening?"

"If I get money at the shop, then."

Madhavi came out carrying her bag.

"My fare is separate."

Dinesh said—

"Who asked you for it?"

Madhavi tightened her grip on the bag.

"I'm saying, if we have to buy water, I have twenty rupees."

Dinesh's face hardened slightly.

"Keep it. Take it for your exam."

Kalyani rose from beside the hearth.

She went into the room off the veranda.

On the sewing machine lay a garment half stitched since the night before.

Two finished garments had been wrapped in paper.

Kalyani put them into a bag.

From behind her Dinesh said—

“Where will you go before the water comes?”

Kalyani turned.

“To deliver the clothes.”

“Leaving the house like this?”

“Where is the house going?”

Dinesh looked towards the tap.

“There is no water.”

“There is no water. There is still work.”

Something came to Dinesh’s lips, then stopped.

Chandan went out into the lane.

A little later he returned and said—

“The tap behind us is dry too.”

“Everywhere?”

“Nandu Kaka says it may come by seven.”

Madhavi looked at the clock.

Twenty past six.

“I can’t wait till seven.”

Kalyani said—

“Then go. Wash your hands and face at a tea stall on the way.”

Madhavi pulled a face.

“On the day of my exam?”

“Will the exam look at the water or at you?”

Madhavi looked at her mother for a few moments.

Then she tried to laugh.

The laugh did not quite come.

Dinesh said—

“I’ll bring water from near the railway station.”

Kalyani asked—

“How?”

“I’ll take two buckets.”

“Carry two buckets all that way?”

“What else can I do now?”

Chandan said at once—

“I’ll carry one.”

Dinesh looked at him.

“School?”

“I have time till seven forty-five.”

Madhavi said—

“I’ll carry one too.”

Dinesh said—

“You have an exam.”

“We’ll be back in ten minutes.”

All three looked at the buckets.

Kalyani watched the scene in silence.

The previous night, filling even one bucket had been nobody’s task.

Now three people were ready together to lift two.

Kalyani said—

“Bring only one bucket.”

Dinesh asked—

“What will one do?”

“First we’ll fill the drinking-water pot. Then we’ll see.”

Dinesh picked up an iron bucket.

Chandan caught its handle.

“I’ll come.”

Madhavi slung her bag over her shoulder.

“I’ll go straight on to the bus stand.”

The three of them started towards the lane.

Kalyani came as far as the doorway.

Dinesh turned and asked—

“Your clothes?”

“Eight o’clock.”

“Shall I deliver them when I get back?”

Kalyani paused a moment before answering.

“We’ll see.”

The three went out.

For the first time, the house grew quiet.

Kalyani sat down at the sewing machine.

She threaded the needle.

The wheel of the machine began to turn.

The empty tap stood in the courtyard.

The sound of the sewing machine filled the house.
Five minutes later Chandan's voice came from the lane.
"Ma!"

Kalyani came out.

Chandan was running towards the house.

His hands were empty.

"What happened?"

"The water's back!"

Kalyani looked towards the tap.

It was still silent.

Chandan ran to it and turned it.

First came air.

Then muddy water.

Then a clear stream.

Chandan shouted—

"Bucket!"

Kalyani looked towards the room.

The two empty buckets were still there.

She moved to lift one.

Then stopped.

Chandan himself ran and brought one.

He set it under the tap.

"Fill this one first."

Kalyani said—

"This will go into the drinking-water pot."

Chandan nodded.

Within two minutes Dinesh too returned.

He was carrying a half-filled bucket.

"We didn't have to go as far as the railway station."

He set the bucket on the ground.

Chandan's bucket was filling under the tap.

Dinesh picked up the other empty bucket.

He said to Kalyani—

"After this one fills, where?"

Kalyani said—

"Fill the drinking-water pot first."

Dinesh lifted the earthen pot and set it by the tap.

Madhavi had not yet reached the turn in the lane.

She came back.

“Water?”

Chandan said—

“It’s back.”

Madhavi did not take off her bag.

She filled a small lota.

“This is enough.”

Kalyani did not stop her.

Madhavi washed her face.

She ran her wet hands over her hair.

“Now I’m going.”

Dinesh said—

“Wait, I’ll drop you.”

Madhavi said—

“You fill the water.”

Dinesh’s hand was on the bucket handle.

He did not let go of it.

“All right.”

Madhavi went out.

Chandan picked up his schoolbag.

“I’ll be late too.”

Kalyani said—

“Go. Your hands and face are done.”

Chandan ran towards the lane.

Now only Dinesh and Kalyani remained in the courtyard.

The tap was running.

One bucket was full.

The second was half full.

The drinking-water pot was full.

Dinesh said—

“You have two garments to deliver by eight, don’t you?”

Kalyani said—

“Yes.”

“It’s seven now.”

“I know.”

Dinesh turned off the tap.

Kalyani looked at him at once—

“Why did you close it?”

“The buckets are full.”
“We need to fill two more and keep them ready.”
Dinesh opened the tap again.
He brought a third bucket.
Kalyani went into the room.
She picked up the bag.
Dinesh said—
“Shall I deliver your work?”
Kalyani stopped at the doorway.
“Your shop?”
“I’ll open it ten minutes late.”
Kalyani said—
“Will ten minutes ruin anything?”
Dinesh tried to smile.
“No.”
Kalyani did not smile either.
She simply handed him the bag.
“Then these two garments can be delivered.”
Dinesh took the bag.
“Whose house?”
Kalyani gave him the name and the lane.
Dinesh listened.
The third bucket was filling under the tap.
Kalyani looked at it.
“Turn it off after this one fills.”
Dinesh asked—
“Enough for the evening?”
“Enough for now.”
Dinesh nodded.
Kalyani sat down again at the sewing machine.
Dinesh slung the bag over his shoulder.
He went as far as the doorway.
Then came back.
The tap was still running.
The third bucket was almost full.
He turned off the tap.
This time Kalyani said nothing.
Dinesh set the full bucket against the veranda wall.

He picked up the bag and went out.
There were three full vessels in the courtyard.
The lid was on the drinking-water pot.
The tap was closed.
Kalyani turned the wheel of the sewing machine.
The water had come late that morning.
But after that, no one needed to call Kalyani for water again.

Half a Kilo of Rice

The evening light was slipping away from the veranda and climbing the courtyard wall.

Malti Devi opened the earthen rice jar in the kitchen.

There were only one or two handfuls of rice at the bottom.

She touched the bottom of the jar with her hand.

Then she put the lid back on.

On the veranda, Shashikant was folding an old newspaper.

Malti said—

“We’ll have to bring half a kilo of rice.”

Shashikant went on straightening the fold of the newspaper.

“Today?”

“For tonight.”

“There is flour.”

“Mother needs rice.”

From the inner room, his mother, Janaki Devi, coughed.

For a few moments both of them were silent.

Malti said again—

“Half a kilo will be enough.”

Shashikant set the newspaper down on the table.

“Money?”

Malti untied the knot at the end of her sari.

There were three ten-rupee notes.

And two coins.

She placed them all on the table.

“This is what we have.”

Shashikant counted it.

“It won’t be enough.”

“Basudev Sah will put the rest on the account.”

Shashikant’s hand stopped over the coins.

Malti did not look at his face.

She went back toward the kitchen.

Shashikant counted the thirty rupees on the table once more.
Counting did not make the sum grow.
He rose.
He took the cloth bag from the peg on the wall.
Malti came out.
“Go before the shop closes.”
Putting on his shoes, Shashikant said—
“It won’t close.”
“All right, then.”
“Has the credit become too much?”
Malti paused for a moment.
“The ledger is there.”
“You don’t know?”
“I know roughly.”
“How much is ‘roughly’?”
Malti did not answer.
Inside, Janaki Devi coughed again.
Malti went to her.
Shashikant took the bag and went out.
Basudev Sah’s shop was a five-minute walk from the house.
By the time he crossed the lane, the light had faded further.
Two low wooden stools stood in front of the shop.
Ramsevak sat on one.
Dularchandra on the other.
Both were drinking tea.
Inside, Basudev Sah was wiping the pan of the weighing scale.
Shashikant reached the front of the shop and stopped.
Ramsevak said—
“Come.”
Shashikant nodded.
Basudev Sah looked up.
“What shall I give you?”
Shashikant placed the bag on the shop counter.
“Half a kilo of rice.”
“Which one?”
“The one we usually take home.”
Basudev Sah opened the mouth of a sack.
He placed the weight on the scale.

The grains made a small sound as they fell into the pan.
Shashikant did not look toward Ramsevak and Dularchandra.
The two of them were absorbed in their own conversation.
Basudev Sah poured half a kilo of rice into a paper bag.
“Anything else?”
“No.”
Shashikant took out the thirty rupees and the coins.
He placed them on the counter.
Basudev Sah counted them.
“Shall I write down the balance?”
Shashikant’s eyes went to a corner of the shop.
A thick ledger lay there.
Bound in blue cloth.
Its edges worn.
A little loop of red thread at the top.
Shashikant said—
“Leave it.”
Basudev Sah looked at him.
“Then?”
“Don’t give me half a kilo. Give me a quarter kilo.”
Basudev Sah kept his hand on the paper bag.
“I’ve already weighed it.”
“Take half of it back.”
Ramsevak’s laughter came from behind him.
He was laughing at something in his own conversation.
Shashikant’s back straightened a little.
Basudev Sah said quietly—
“Seventeen rupees remain.”
Shashikant was silent.
“The earlier balance is separate.”
Shashikant looked at him.
“How much?”
Basudev Sah reached toward the ledger.
Shashikant said at once—
“No. Leave it.”
Basudev Sah’s hand stopped midway.
“All right.”
He did not open the ledger.

He put the bag of half a kilo of rice into Shashikant's cloth bag.
"Shall I write down the seventeen?"
Shashikant again looked toward Ramsevak and Dularchandra.
This time Ramsevak was looking at him.
Shashikant said—
"I'll pay it tomorrow."
Basudev Sah nodded.
He took a small slip of paper from beneath the counter.
With a pencil he wrote on it: "17".
He folded the slip and put it under the scale.
He did not open the ledger.
Shashikant picked up his bag.
Ramsevak said—
"Have some tea?"
"No, there's work at home."
"All right."
Shashikant left the shop.
Once he entered the lane, his pace quickened.
Malti was standing at the doorway of the house.
There was an empty water pot in her hand.
"Did you get it?"
Shashikant handed her the bag.
"Yes."
Malti opened it.
She took out the paper packet.
"The full half kilo?"
"Yes."
"The balance?"
Taking off his shoes, Shashikant said—
"Seventeen."
Malti carried the packet into the kitchen.
Shashikant sat down on the veranda.
A little while later, water began to boil in the kitchen.
The sound of rice being washed came from inside.
From the inner room Janaki Devi asked—
"Will there be rice?"
Malti said—
"Yes, Mother."

Shashikant picked up the newspaper.

Just then Malti came out.

“How much is the old balance?”

Shashikant opened the newspaper.

“I didn’t ask.”

Malti looked at him for a few moments.

“Why?”

“What would we do by knowing?”

“Pay it.”

“Do we have the money to pay it?”

“Not all at once.”

“Then?”

“We’ll keep paying whatever we can.”

Shashikant turned a page of the newspaper.

“Our name will remain written in the ledger.”

This time Malti did not answer at once.

She hung the empty water pot on the peg on the veranda.

“Our name is already there.”

Shashikant stopped turning the page.

“Who told you?”

“I see it when I go to buy rice, oil, salt.”

“You open the ledger and look?”

“Sahji opens it.”

“And everyone in the shop keeps looking?”

“Who?”

“People.”

Malti’s face remained still.

“People go to the shop to buy things.”

“People look as well.”

“At what?”

“How much is owed beside whose name.”

Malti said softly—

“I don’t look.”

“You don’t have to.”

“And you?”

Shashikant folded the newspaper.

“Rice was never written on credit against my father’s name.”

Malti looked toward the smoke from the kitchen.

"Your father was there then."

Shashikant was silent.

"And now?"

"Now I am here."

"Yes."

"Then?"

Malti went back toward the kitchen.

Shashikant watched her back as she walked away.

The smell of cooked rice slowly reached the veranda.

Janaki Devi's coughing had eased.

At dinner that night, Janaki Devi ate rice.

Malti and Shashikant ate rotis.

A little rice was left over.

Malti put it in a small bowl.

Shashikant asked—

"For tomorrow?"

"For Mother's morning meal."

Shashikant nodded.

Before going to bed, Malti took down a tin from the top of the cupboard.

There were a few notes inside.

Shashikant saw them.

"What is this?"

"Money from sewing."

"How much?"

"One hundred and seventy-five."

"Why didn't you tell me before?"

"Why would I?"

Shashikant's expression changed.

Malti placed the notes on the table.

"We'll pay the seventeen tomorrow."

"And the rest?"

"First we'll find out how much the rest is."

Shashikant said—

"This money is yours."

Malti closed the tin.

"Whose rice was it?"

Shashikant said nothing.

Malti put the tin back on top of the cupboard.

The notes remained on the table.

The next morning, before the shop's opening time, Shashikant reached Basudev Sah's shop.

Basudev Sah was sweeping.

"So early?"

Shashikant placed seventeen rupees on the counter.

"For yesterday."

Basudev Sah picked up the money.

"All right."

Shashikant remained standing.

Basudev Sah stopped sweeping.

"Anything else?"

"Show me the old account."

Basudev Sah went inside.

He brought out the ledger bound in blue cloth.

He opened it on the shop counter.

Shashikant leaned forward.

Where the name was written on the page, it said: "Shashikant Household".

Below it were the dates.

Flour.

Oil.

Salt.

Soap.

Once, half a kilo of rice.

Twice, small medicinal items.

Payments made from time to time.

Shashikant looked at the total written at the bottom.

The sum was less than he had imagined.

But it was not zero.

He kept looking at the page.

Basudev Sah said—

"You don't have to pay it all at once."

Shashikant did not answer.

He read the name again.

"Shashikant Household."

He asked—

“Why have you written ‘Household’?”

Basudev Sah pushed his spectacles up.

“Malti sister also buys things here.”

“My name is written.”

“Yes.”

“Then why ‘Household’?”

Basudev Sah looked at the page.

“Earlier I used to write only the name.”

“And now?”

“Now, when an account belongs to a household, I write ‘Household’ beside the name.”

Shashikant remained silent.

Basudev Sah did not close the ledger.

Shashikant put his hand into his pocket.

From Malti’s one hundred and seventy-five rupees, he took out one hundred.

He placed it on the counter.

Basudev Sah said—

“So much?”

“Write it down.”

Basudev Sah entered one hundred against the repayment.

Shashikant watched.

Then the ledger was closed.

Shashikant returned home.

Malti was finishing the morning work in the kitchen.

Seventy-five rupees lay on the table.

Beside them Shashikant placed the small receipt for the one-hundred-rupee payment.

Malti came out.

She saw the receipt.

“How much remains?”

Shashikant told her the amount.

Malti nodded.

“All right.”

Shashikant sat down on a chair.

Malti picked up the receipt.

“What is written in the ledger?”

Shashikant was silent for a few moments.

“Shashikant Household.”

Malti looked at him.

“Not just your name?”

“Household.”

Malti folded the receipt.

She took down the tin from the top of the cupboard.

She put the receipt inside.

And the seventy-five rupees as well.

Shashikant said—

“From tomorrow we’ll write down our expenses.”

Malti asked—

“Where?”

“At home.”

“In a ledger?”

“I’ll bring a small account book.”

Malti closed the tin.

“Bring one.”

Shashikant rose and started outside.

At the doorway he stopped.

“Do we have rice for today?”

Malti looked at the kitchen jar.

“Until noon.”

Shashikant nodded.

“I’ll bring some in the evening.”

“How much?”

“As much as we need.”

Malti said nothing.

Shashikant went out.

That evening Basudev Sah opened the ledger.

Shashikant told him how much rice he wanted.

Basudev Sah placed the weight on the scale.

Shashikant saw the ledger lying open.

This time he did not look away.

The rice was weighed.

The full amount was not paid.

Basudev Sah wrote down the balance.

On the page Shashikant read: “Shashikant Household”.

He picked up the bag.

Two men were sitting outside the shop.
Neither of them was looking at the ledger.
Shashikant set off toward home.
The bag was not heavy.
But this time he was not carrying it hidden from view.

The Balcony Flowerpot

The balcony was flooded with bright light that Sunday afternoon.

Rajni was taking the clothes down from the line.

A large earthen flowerpot stood in one corner.

A hibiscus plant grew in it.

The leaves on one side had dried up.

The edges of some leaves had turned black.

A half-open flower drooped from its stem.

As Rajni folded a bedsheet, she glanced at the plant.

She touched a dried leaf.

The corner of the leaf broke off and fell the moment her finger brushed it.

From inside, Vinay asked—

“Have the clothes dried?”

“Yes.”

Rajni folded a towel.

Then she said—

“We should move this flowerpot now.”

Vinay came to the balcony doorway.

He was holding the notice about the rent increase.

“Why?”

“The plant is drying up.”

Vinay stepped outside.

He bent down near the flowerpot.

“But the soil is damp.”

Rajni looked at him.

“I watered it this morning.”

“I watered it yesterday evening too.”

Rajni was silent for a few moments.

“Then perhaps it has had too much.”

Vinay touched the soil with a finger.

“It’s damp on top. We’ll have to see what it’s like underneath.”

Rajni picked up the bundle of clothes.

"It has been like this for three weeks."

Vinay looked at both sides of the plant.

The leaves facing the inside of the balcony were still green.

The leaves facing outward were much more scorched.

He said—

"One side is much worse."

Rajni looked again.

"Yes."

"If watering were the problem, wouldn't every side look the same?"

"How would I know?"

Rajni went inside.

A second copy of the notice lay on the table.

The landlord had written that the rent would increase from the following month.

For three days the two of them had begun talking about that paper and left the conversation unfinished.

Rajni put the clothes on the cot.

Vinay set the notice on the table.

"The landlord will call again this evening."

Rajni said—

"Let him."

"What shall we tell him?"

"Whatever we decide."

Vinay pulled out a chair and sat down.

"What have we decided?"

Rajni folded the bedsheet again.

"I don't know."

"You said paying this much rent wasn't right."

"Yes."

"Then we were supposed to look for another house."

"We were."

"Did you look at anything?"

Rajni set a kurta aside.

"No."

Vinay said nothing.

The sound of the fan filled the room.

Something fell on the balcony.

Rajni looked that way.

Another hibiscus leaf lay on the floor.

Vinay stood up.

“Let me have a proper look.”

Rajni said—

“At what?”

“The sunlight.”

“The sun has always fallen here.”

“Like this?”

Rajni did not answer.

They both went out to the balcony again.

A bright strip of sunlight was falling across the outer side of the flowerpot.

Vinay shaded his eyes and looked across the lane.

A band of gleaming glass had been installed on the balcony of the new house opposite.

The glass was reflecting the light straight toward their balcony.

Rajni said—

“That wasn’t there before.”

“They must have put it up last month.”

“I didn’t notice.”

Vinay held his hand near the outer side of the flowerpot.

“It’s hot.”

Rajni reached out too.

The earthen pot was indeed very hot on that side.

The side facing inward was not nearly as hot.

Vinay said—

“How long does this light stay here in the afternoon?”

Rajni shook her head.

“I don’t know.”

“Let’s see today.”

Rajni did not laugh.

“Are we going to sit here all afternoon for the sake of a plant?”

“We don’t have to sit. I’ll mark it.”

Vinay went inside.

He brought a pencil and an old sheet of paper.

He drew a small line on the floor where the sunlight reached the outer edge of the flowerpot.

Rajni asked—

“What’s that?”

“After half an hour we’ll see how far the line of sunlight has moved.”

Rajni carried the bundle of clothes inside.

Vinay came in too.

The notice was still lying in front of them on the table.

He said—

“You were packing a bag yesterday.”

Rajni’s hands stopped.

“They were old clothes.”

“I thought—”

Vinay fell silent.

Rajni asked—

“What did you think?”

“That you were thinking of going to your mother’s.”

Rajni looked straight at him.

“Did I say anything like that?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“I saw the bag.”

Rajni rested a hand on the pile of clothes.

“You saw one bag and decided the whole story for yourself?”

Vinay folded the notice.

“You haven’t asked me anything for three days either.”

“I kept asking. The answer was always, ‘We’ll see.’”

“I wasn’t clear about what I wanted to decide.”

“If it wasn’t clear, you should have said that.”

Vinay lowered his head.

“Yes.”

Rajni began putting the clothes into the cupboard.

Again neither of them said anything.

Half an hour later Vinay looked at the clock.

“Shall we check the line of sunlight?”

Rajni closed the cupboard.

“Come.”

They went out to the balcony.

The bright strip had shifted almost a handspan across the floor from the first line.

But the outer side of the flowerpot was still within it.
Vinay drew a second line.
Rajni examined the leaves carefully.
The leaves in the sunlight felt warm the moment she touched them.
“All the leaves on this side are damaged.”
Vinay nodded.
“Watering it won’t fix this.”
Rajni said—
“Then where should we put it?”
They looked around the balcony.
There was a clothesline on one side.
A small stool stood on the other.
By the inner wall there was morning sun and afternoon shade.
Vinay said—
“Shall we move it there?”
Rajni tried to get her hands under the flowerpot.
It was heavy.
Vinay said—
“Wait.”
Together they gripped it from opposite sides and lifted it.
An old circular mark remained visible on the floor.
They placed the flowerpot by the inner wall.
Rajni spread the leaves apart and looked at them again.
“Will it get less air here?”
Vinay held out his hand.
“There’s air.”
“And sun?”
“It will get some in the morning.”
Rajni said—
“But not that fierce strip in the afternoon.”
Vinay looked at the mark where the pot had stood before.
“We’ll look again tomorrow.”
Rajni said nothing to that.
She picked off the dried leaves and placed them in a small plate.
Vinay looked at two leaves on the green side of the plant.
Among them was a new tender shoot.
“Look at this.”
Rajni bent closer.

"It's still alive."

"Yes."

Rajni did not touch the new shoot.

They both went back inside.

The rent notice was still on the table.

Vinay said—

"I made enquiries about two houses."

Rajni's expression changed.

"When?"

"The day before yesterday."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I only asked about the rent."

"Even so."

Vinay stayed silent.

Rajni sat down on a chair.

"How much?"

Vinay told her the two amounts.

The first was lower than their present rent.

The second was almost the same.

"Where are they?"

Vinay named the two places.

The first house was closer to Rajni's workplace.

The second was closer to Vinay's parents' home.

Rajni asked—

"Have you decided?"

"No."

"Why?"

"The routes are different for each of us."

Rajni traced a small line on the table with her finger.

"That is exactly why you should have asked me."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

Vinay looked toward the balcony.

"That night you said you no longer felt at home in this house."

"I was talking about the rent and the damp."

"I thought you meant more than just the house."

Rajni was silent for a moment.

"I too kept thinking something more."

“What?”

“That you didn’t care where I had to live.”

Vinay looked at her.

“I do care.”

Rajni did not answer.

Vinay said again—

“I should have said so.”

“And you should have asked too.”

“Yes.”

The fan kept turning.

The sunlight on the balcony shifted slowly.

On the back of the notice Vinay wrote the names of the two places.

Rajni wrote down the distances.

“Is there a direct bus to the first house?”

“Yes.”

“And the second?”

“We would have to change once.”

Rajni did the arithmetic.

“Some of what we save on rent will go in travel fares.”

Vinay said—

“We’ll think after we’ve seen them.”

Rajni nodded.

“I can leave at five tomorrow.”

“I can leave at half past five.”

“The first house at six?”

“All right.”

Vinay wrote the time on the paper.

Rajni put a question mark beside the second house.

“What if we like the first one?”

“We’ll still see the second.”

“Why?”

“Otherwise we’ll be guessing again without comparing.”

Rajni gave a small laugh.

“You are avoiding a great deal of guesswork today.”

Vinay smiled too.

“The sunlight is teaching us a lot today.”

Rajni replied at once—

“Don’t turn the plant into a guru.”

Vinay laughed.

“All right.”

This time Rajni laughed too.

It was brief.

But it was the first time in three days.

As the afternoon waned, Vinay went out to the balcony again.

The bright strip of sunlight had now moved away from the flowerpot’s old place.

The new place was in shade.

He called Rajni.

“Look.”

Rajni came outside.

“It’s fine here.”

“Tomorrow morning we’ll see whether it gets any sun.”

“All right.”

Rajni touched the soil.

“No water yet.”

“Yes.”

Vinay adjusted the shallow tray beneath the flowerpot.

The dried leaves had been placed in a small box.

Rajni picked up the box.

“Shall I throw them away?”

“Yes.”

Rajni put the dried leaves into the rubbish bin.

A blackened part of one stem was still on the plant.

She asked—

“Shall I cut this?”

Vinay came closer.

“If it’s completely dry.”

Rajni lightly scraped the surface of the stem with her fingernail.

It was green underneath.

“Leave it.”

“Leave it.”

They said almost the same thing at almost the same moment.

Rajni looked at Vinay.

Vinay smiled.

That evening the landlord called.

Vinay answered.

“Yes.”

He listened for a while.

Rajni was sitting on the other side of the table.

Vinay said—

“We’ll let you know by tomorrow evening.”

He put the phone down.

Rajni asked—

“He agreed?”

“Yes.”

“Then tomorrow we’ll see both houses.”

“Both.”

At dinner that night they sat at the same table.

They did not talk much.

Rajni asked—

“Does the first house have fixed water-supply hours?”

“I didn’t ask.”

“We’ll ask tomorrow.”

“Write it down.”

Rajni wrote on the paper: “Water?”

Below it: “Sunlight?”

Vinay read it.

“Sunlight too?”

Rajni said—

“The flowerpot will come with us, won’t it?”

Vinay looked toward the balcony.

“If the plant survives.”

Rajni slid a roti toward his plate.

“It has survived.”

Vinay said nothing.

After dinner they went through the household expenses.

Rent.

Travel fares.

Electricity.

Water.

Daily groceries.

Some of the totals did not agree the first time.

They counted again.

The night deepened.

Before going to bed, Rajni opened the balcony door.
The plant stood still in the shade.
The soil was still damp.
She did not water it.
Vinay asked from behind her—
“What are you looking at?”
“Just the soil.”
“Dry?”
“No.”
Rajni closed the door.
In the morning, soft sunlight fell on the inner wall of the balcony.
The light reached the flowerpot’s new place.
It was not harsh.
Rajni came outside.
A green leaf was damp with dew.
Vinay came out too.
“It’s getting sunlight.”
“Yes.”
“Let it stay here.”
Rajni touched the soil.
“No water today.”
“All right.”
They both went inside.
Breakfast was early.
Before leaving, Vinay looked at the paper on the table.
“Quarter to six at the crossing?”
Rajni put the key in her bag.
“Yes.”
“We’ll see both houses?”
Rajni opened the door.
“Both.”
That evening they reached the crossing at the same time.
They saw the first house.
The kitchen was small.
The balcony opened to the east.
Rajni decided nothing.
They saw the second house.
The rent there was higher.

But water was available throughout the day.

Still, they decided nothing.

On the way back Vinay asked—

“Which one is better?”

Rajni said—

“We’ll look at the figures when we get home.”

“All right.”

When they reached home, Rajni went straight to the balcony.

The plant was still drooping.

But unlike the day before, no new leaf had fallen.

Vinay came out too.

“Can you see any difference?”

Rajni said—

“It’s too soon to say.”

Vinay nodded.

“Then we’ll keep watching.”

Rajni looked at the two lines they had drawn on the balcony floor on the first day.

The lines were still there.

The flowerpot was now outside that strip of sunlight.

Rajni went back inside.

The calculations for the two houses lay on the table.

She pulled out a chair.

Vinay sat opposite her.

They began adding the figures again.

The plant on the balcony did not turn green at once.

The decision about the house was not made at once that night either.

But this time neither of them was hiding a paper from the other.

Wrong Number

Harinath Jha did not look at the clock in the morning.

A clock hung on the wall, but its hands did not command the shape of his day.

If his eyes opened, it was morning.

If they did not, morning simply came a little later.

When his wife was alive, tea used to be made at seven.

For the past two years, tea had had no fixed hour.

Sometimes at seven.

Sometimes at nine.

Sometimes not until noon.

That Tuesday, the mobile phone rang at twenty past seven.

Harinath reached toward the pillow.

“Hello?”

From the other end came a woman’s flat recorded voice—

“Saroj Devi, it is time to take your morning medicine.”

Harinath opened his eyes.

The voice continued—

“If you have taken the medicine, press one.”

Harinath looked at the mobile phone.

“Wrong number.”

The recorded voice finished its message—

“If no response is received, another reminder will be sent.”

The call ended.

Harinath put the mobile phone back beside the pillow.

He closed his eyes again.

Five minutes later, the phone rang once more.

“Saroj Devi, your morning medicine—”

This time Harinath cut the call.

Outside, the milkman rode past the lane ringing his bicycle bell.

Harinath sat up.

Yesterday’s kettle still stood in the kitchen.

He washed it.
He put water on to boil.
He made tea.
At seven thirty-five, the phone rang for the third time.
Harinath answered it with the tea still in his hand.
“Saroj Devi—”
He pressed one.
The recorded voice said—
“Thank you. Your next reminder is at one this afternoon.”
The call ended.
Harinath set the cup of tea on the table.
“Saroj Devi,” he said softly.
No one in the house answered.
At one in the afternoon, Harinath was reading an old page of the newspaper.
Lunch had not yet been made.
The mobile phone rang.
“Saroj Devi, it is time to take your afternoon medicine.”
Harinath put a hand to his forehead.
“I am not Saroj Devi.”
The recorded voice could not hear him.
“If you have taken the medicine, press one.”
This time Harinath cut the call.
Ten minutes later it rang again.
He did not answer.
Five minutes later, again.
Harinath turned the mobile phone face down on the table.
Only then did he remember that he was hungry.
He went into the kitchen.
There was rice left from the day before.
He warmed it with a little water.
He took out some pickle.
By the time he finished eating, it was two.
At eight in the evening, the phone rang again.
Harinath had been dozing in front of the television.
The sound startled him awake.
“Saroj Devi, it is time to take your night medicine.”
He did not cut the call.

He listened to the entire message.

"If you have taken the medicine, press one. If you have not, press two."

Harinath pressed nothing.

"If no response is received, another reminder will be sent."

The call ended.

Harinath switched off the television.

He went toward the kitchen.

He had not made dinner.

He cooked one roti.

There were two pieces of boiled potato.

He ate those with it.

At eight twenty, the phone rang again.

Harinath pressed one.

"Thank you. Your next reminder is tomorrow morning at seven twenty."

The call ended.

Harinath looked at the clock on the wall.

Eight twenty-two.

He went to bed early that night.

The next day, his eyes opened on their own at seven fifteen.

The phone had not rung yet.

For a while he lay looking at the ceiling.

Then he got up.

He washed the kettle.

He put water on to boil.

He took out the tea leaves.

At seven twenty, the phone rang.

"Saroj Devi—"

As he lifted the kettle from the stove, Harinath said—

"I understand now."

He pressed one.

"Thank you."

The call ended.

This time the tea was hot.

Harinath sat in the veranda.

The milkman came by.

"One packet," Harinath said.

The milkman stopped his bicycle.

“After a long time, Babu.”

Harinath paid him.

“There should be milk in the house.”

The milkman smiled and rode away.

Before the one o’clock call, Harinath had already served himself rice.

He had placed the mobile phone on the table in front of him.

At exactly one, it rang.

“Saroj Devi, your afternoon medicine—”

Harinath pressed one.

“Thank you.”

He began to eat.

The evening call came at eight.

Before that, he had walked as far as the turn in the lane and back.

He had already kneaded the dough for dinner.

The phone rang.

He pressed one.

He cooked the rotis.

On the third day, all three calls came on time.

All three times Harinath pressed one.

The fourth day was the same.

That afternoon, after the call ended, Harinath wondered whose service this actually was.

The recorded voice never gave any name at the end.

He looked at the number appearing on the mobile phone screen.

All the calls came from the same number.

Harinath called it back.

It rang several times.

Then a young man answered—

“Health Reminder Service.”

Harinath said—

“You people are calling Saroj Devi?”

“Please give me the registered number.”

Harinath gave his own number.

There was some rustling at the other end.

The young man said—

“Yes, Saroj Devi. Three medication reminders a day.”

“I am not Saroj Devi.”

“Oh.”

"I have been getting these calls for four days."

"There was probably an error while entering the digits."

"The correct number?"

"That is part of the patient's information. I cannot give it to you."

"I do not want it either."

The young man said—

"I'll mark this as a wrong number in the register. The calls should stop within twenty-four hours."

Harinath said—

"All right."

"Sorry for the inconvenience."

The call ended.

Harinath put the mobile phone on the table.

At eight that evening, the phone rang again.

"Saroj Devi, it is time to take your night medicine."

A faint smile came to Harinath's face.

"Twenty-four hours," he said.

He pressed one.

"Thank you."

Then he made the rotis.

On the fifth day, the phone rang at seven twenty.

Harinath had already made tea.

He pressed one.

The phone came at one in the afternoon as well.

He was eating rice.

At the ring, he washed his hand and got up.

He pressed one.

At eight in the evening, the phone did not ring.

At seven fifty-five, Harinath was sitting by the table.

The mobile phone was in front of him.

Eight o'clock.

No ring.

Eight oh-five.

No ring.

Harinath picked up the mobile phone.

He looked at the screen.

There was signal.

The sound was on.

He put it down again.
At eight ten, he went into the kitchen.
The dough had not been kneaded.
He thought, "Because the phone didn't ring?"
No one answered.
He took out the flour.
He made rotis.
He ate.
The next morning, his eyes opened at seven twelve.
Harinath looked at the clock.
He remained sitting on the bed until seven twenty.
No call.
At seven twenty-five he got up.
He made tea.
The milkman was riding past the lane ringing his bell.
Harinath opened the door and called—
"Wait."
The milkman turned his bicycle around.
"Late today, Babu?"
Harinath said—
"Five minutes."
The milkman laughed.
"You keep track that closely now?"
Harinath smiled too.
"For the past few days."
At one in the afternoon, no call came.
By twelve forty, Harinath had already taken the rice off the stove.
He sat at the table.
At one, the clock hand stood straight.
The house was silent.
Harinath took his first mouthful.
That day he understood that the calls had stopped.
At eight in the evening, there was no ring either.
He ate on time.
He watched television for a little while.
At nine he switched it off.
On the seventh morning, he got up at seven.
He did not look at the hands of the clock.

As soon as his eyes opened, he rose.
He put the kettle on.
He watered the two flowerpots.
He swept the veranda.
At seven twenty, no call came.
Harinath went on drinking his tea.
At one in the afternoon, still no call.
He went on eating.
At six in the evening, he walked as far as the temple and back.
At eight he cooked rotis.
The day was settling into its rhythm again.
This time without a bell.
The eighth day was Wednesday.
Sandhya was supposed to call at eight that night.
Sandhya was Harinath's daughter.
She lived in Pune.
She usually called on Wednesday nights.
Sometimes a meeting made her late.
Sometimes she called the next day.
Harinath did not want to miss her call.
So he kept the mobile phone on the table.
At eight fifteen that night, the phone rang.
Harinath answered.
The recorded voice came—
"Saroj Devi, it is time to take your night medicine."
Harinath sat upright.
"Again?"
The recorded voice said—
"If you have taken the medicine, press one."
Harinath did not press one.
He listened to the full message.
"If no response is received, another reminder will be sent."
The call ended.
Harinath immediately called the Health Reminder Service.
This time, instead of the young man, a woman answered.
"Health Reminder Service."
"My number has been put back into Saroj Devi's record."
The woman asked for the number.

Harinath gave it.

After a few moments she said—

“You are right. The patient’s family has still not provided the correct number. The system has reactivated the old number.”

“So the calls will keep coming?”

“We can stop the service.”

Harinath was silent.

The woman asked—

“Shall I stop it?”

Harinath looked at the clock on the wall.

Eight nineteen.

He asked—

“Then how will Saroj Devi get her reminders?”

“She will not receive them until we get the correct number.”

Harinath’s grip tightened around the mobile phone.

“Tell the family again.”

“We will send them a message.”

“And my number?”

“Shall I stop it?”

Harinath said—

“Yes.”

The woman said—

“You will not receive any more calls after today.”

The call ended.

Harinath remained sitting at the table.

At eight twenty-five, Sandhya called.

“Babu, have you eaten?”

“Not yet.”

“Why so late?”

“There was a wrong call.”

“Whose?”

Harinath told her about Saroj Devi.

Sandhya did not laugh.

“For how many days?”

“Eight days.”

“Why didn’t you tell me earlier?”

“What was there to tell?”

Sandhya fell silent.

Then she asked—

“Has it stopped now?”

“Yes.”

“That’s good.”

Harinath said—

“Yes.”

After a while Sandhya asked—

“Are you eating your meals on time?”

Harinath looked at the clock.

“For these eight days.”

“Why?”

Harinath was silent before answering.

“It just kept making the time clear.”

Sandhya said nothing.

The conversation ended.

On the ninth day, no call came at seven twenty.

Harinath had already risen at seven.

The tea was made.

The milk had arrived.

He left the mobile phone on the table and sat in the veranda.

No call came at one.

Lunch was on time.

No call came at eight.

The rotis were made on time.

The tenth day was the same.

On the eleventh morning, at half past seven, a call came from an unknown number.

Harinath was reading the newspaper in the veranda.

He went inside.

He answered the phone.

“Hello?”

An elderly man’s voice came—

“Saroj Devi?”

For a moment Harinath’s body went still.

“No.”

The man at the other end said—

“Sorry. Wrong number.”

The call ended.

Harinath stood with the mobile phone still in his hand.
He could have told the man about the Health Reminder Service.
He did not know the correct number.
Nor did he know who Saroj Devi was.
He put the phone down on the table.
The tea in the veranda was growing cold.
Harinath went outside.
He picked up the cup.
The milkman had already reached the far end of the lane.
Sunlight was slowly climbing the wall.
It must have been around seven forty.
Harinath did not look at the clock.
He turned to the second page of the newspaper.

The Old Curtain

By evening on the day before they were to leave the house, only the curtain still hung at the window.

The wall clock, the photographs, the shelf—everything had been taken down and packed into boxes.

The curtain was pale green, but the middle had faded almost white in the sun.

Four rows of loops had been sewn along the top at different heights.

Ruchi looked at it as she closed a box.

“This isn’t going.”

Mala was tying a bundle of clothes.

“What?”

“This curtain. We’ll throw it away in the morning.”

Sudhir came out of the other room.

“What are you talking about throwing away?”

“The curtain,” Ruchi said.

Sudhir looked towards the window.

“We’ll see.”

Ruchi frowned.

“What is there to see? Are we going to hang this in the new house?”

Sudhir said—

“I said, didn’t I? We’ll see.”

Ruchi went into her room.

Mala went on tightening the knot of the bundle.

After a while she asked—

“Will we really throw it away?”

Putting the screwdriver into a box, Sudhir said—

“Will this look right in the new house?”

“Is it a question of how it looks?”

“Ruchi has been asking for new curtains for some time.”

“You promised her too.”

Sudhir fell silent.

The three of them ate dinner sitting on the floor.

Ruchi asked—

“Will the curtain man come tomorrow?”

“Let us reach the house first,” Sudhir said.

“You took the measurements, didn’t you?”

“I did.”

“Then?”

Mala intervened—

“Let us get the things there first.”

Ruchi kept looking at her plate.

“Everything is always ‘let us reach the house first.’”

No one answered.

After dinner Mala went to the window.

She held the edge of the curtain.

The cloth had grown thin.

The first row of loops was stitched with old thread.

The second had been machine-sewn.

The third by hand.

Mala had added the fourth the previous year.

Sudhir asked—

“How old is this?”

“Older than this house.”

“From the room in Darbhanga?”

“Older than that too.”

Sudhir remembered.

In their first rented room there had been no door between the kitchen and the sleeping space.

Mala had tied a rope and hung this curtain there.

Ruchi had been five then.

Later, in another house, an extra strip of cloth had been added to the curtain.

It was meant to separate off a corner where Ruchi could study.

The crooked seam of that addition was still visible.

Sudhir said—

“Let us not tell all this in front of Ruchi.”

Mala asked—

“Why?”

“She’ll think we’re clinging to old things.”

“Are we?”

Sudhir did not answer.

The power went out at night.

The three of them sat in the dark.

Ruchi asked—

“How much will curtains for three windows cost in the new house?”

Sudhir gave an estimate.

Mala asked at once—

“That much?”

“The fabric is wide.”

Ruchi fell silent.

After a while she asked—

“Why buy all of them at once?”

Sudhir said—

“We don’t have to buy them all at once.”

“Then mine first?”

“We’ll see.”

Ruchi said nothing.

When the electricity returned, she went inside.

Mala said softly—

“We’ll see.”

Sudhir grew irritated.

“What am I supposed to do now?”

“Nothing. Just look at the figures.”

“Don’t start on money again.”

“I didn’t start it.”

“If the whole deposit from the old house had come back, there wouldn’t have been a problem.”

“We knew beforehand they would deduct for painting.”

“Not this much.”

“And the moving charges went up too.”

Sudhir was silent.

Mala said—

“Why did you promise Ruchi a new curtain as though it were settled?”

“It’s a new house. She’ll want something.”

“A new rented house.”

“So?”

“Nothing.”

At eleven that night Sudhir pulled over a chair to take the curtain down.

Ruchi came out.

“Are you throwing it away?”

“I’m taking it down.”

“The sack for rubbish is over there.”

Sudhir unhooked the first loop.

Mala held the curtain from below.

The moment the last loop came free, the window lay completely exposed.

The light from the house opposite was visible inside.

Without thinking, Ruchi shifted to one side.

Mala began folding the curtain.

Ruchi said again—

“The sack is over there.”

Sudhir looked at the window.

“At night?”

Ruchi said—

“Hang up a bedsheet.”

Mala opened the curtain out again.

Sudhir climbed back onto the chair.

The curtain was hung up again.

No one said anything.

That night Mala asked—

“Shall we take it with us tomorrow?”

“Ruchi doesn’t want it.”

“We can throw it away another day too.”

Sudhir said—

“Yes.”

The vehicle arrived late in the morning.

Meanwhile the belongings began going out one by one.

Boxes, mattresses, stove, gas cylinder, cupboard.

The curtain was the last thing left.

Mala folded it into four and placed it between the folds of a bedsheet.

Sudhir said—

“Leave it?”

Mala did not answer.

Ruchi was standing near the door.

She said—

“Take it. We’ll see there.”

Sudhir looked at her.

Ruchi went outside.

The old house was empty.

Square marks remained on the walls.

Only the bare rod remained at the window.

Sudhir locked the door.

The vehicle moved off.

The new house was three kilometres away.

The staircase was narrow.

The mattress had to be bent to get it upstairs.

The corner of the cupboard scraped against the wall.

Ruchi opened the window in her room.

About thirty cubits away, another house had a balcony facing it.

Two women were gathering clothes there.

Ruchi shut the window again.

Mala asked—

“Why?”

“There’s a house directly opposite.”

“What about the air?”

“Later.”

The curtain came upstairs with the mattress.

The bedsheet around it had come loose.

A green corner hung out.

Ruchi saw it.
She said nothing.

At noon the three of them sat over spread-out newspaper, drinking tea.

Sudhir kept adding up the expenses.

Mala asked—

“How much is left?”

“I’m still adding it up.”

Ruchi asked nothing.

After a while Sudhir said—

“We’ll go to the curtain shop this evening.”

“Today?” Mala asked.

“Yes.”

Sudhir looked at Ruchi.

“Yours first.”

Ruchi set down her cup.

“Not today.”

“Why?”

“Unpack the things first.”

“That work will keep going on.”

“We’ll see tomorrow.”

Sudhir kept looking at her.

By evening the rear window had been opened again.

The balcony opposite was clearly visible.

Mala looked at the old curtain lying on the mattress.

Ruchi looked at it too.

“There’s no rod,” Ruchi said.

“There’s rope,” Mala replied.

Two old hooks were fixed above the window.

Mala brought out a thin rope.

Ruchi held one end.

The first row of loops sat too low.

The second too high.

The third fitted properly.

Mala began threading the third row of loops onto the rope.

Ruchi held the other end.

The curtain was slightly wider than the window.
Its lower edge hung two fingers above the floor.
Mala stepped back and looked.
“It’s all right.”
Ruchi looked too.
The faded patch was plain in the middle.
So was the line of the old join.
Ruchi said—
“It looks awful.”
Mala said—
“Yes.”
Ruchi gave a small laugh.

Sudhir came in.
He stopped at the doorway.
“You hung this up?”
“For now,” Mala said.
“I’m going to the shop.”
Ruchi said—
“Not today.”
“I’m saying it for your sake.”
“This will get me through the night.”
Sudhir wanted to say something.
Then he did not.

After dinner Mala asked for the sheet of expenses.
Sudhir looked at Ruchi.
“Tomorrow.”
Ruchi went on drinking water.
After a while she went inside.
Mala asked again—
“How much?”
Sudhir handed her the paper.
Mala looked at the figures.
“Does this include the electrician?”
“No.”
“Groceries?”

“No.”

“Then the curtain?”

Sudhir said—

“We can buy one.”

“We can.”

“I promised her.”

Mala handed the paper back.

“Keep your promise. But there was no need to throw the old thing away first.”

Sudhir remained silent.

Before going to bed, Ruchi came out.

“Babu.”

“Yes?”

“Give me the curtain seller’s number.”

Sudhir picked up his mobile phone.

“Why?”

“I’ll ask about cheaper cloth.”

“What colour do you want?”

“One that keeps the sun out.”

Sudhir read out the number.

Ruchi wrote it down.

She did not call.

“Tomorrow,” she said.

She went inside.

The electrician came in the morning.

He repaired the switch, took his payment, and left.

Sudhir measured the outer window again.

Ruchi came and stood at the doorway.

“How much?”

Sudhir told her the measurement.

“My window?”

“Yours is covered for now.”

Ruchi looked at the old curtain.

“Temporarily.”

“Yes.”

Sunlight was falling on the faded part of the curtain.

Ruchi ran a finger along the seam.

“Did you sew this?” she asked Mala.

“Some of it. Some was done by a seamstress.”

“So many rows of loops?”

“We kept moving house. The height of the rods kept changing.”

Ruchi looked at each row in turn.

“Was this also used for my study corner?”

Mala looked at her.

“You remember?”

“A little.”

“That was when the second piece was added.”

Ruchi looked again at the joined seam.

For a while no one spoke.

Ruchi looked at her father.

“Babu, buy a new one for the outer window.”

“And yours?”

Holding the curtain, Ruchi said—

“I have this for now.”

“Shall we replace it at the end of the month?”

“We’ll see.”

Sudhir laughed.

“Yesterday you were going to throw it away.”

Ruchi said—

“Yesterday the house was different.”

At noon Sudhir brought home a plain curtain only for the outer window.

It was not very expensive.

Nor was it very cheap.

Ruchi looked at the cloth.

“This is fine.”

Sudhir asked—

“I didn’t ask what colour you wanted for yours.”

“I have one for now.”

Sudhir looked at the old curtain.

"One month?"

Ruchi said—

"We'll see."

Two days later Mala took down the old curtain to wash it.

The first water turned grey.

Then pale green.

Wringing out the cloth, Mala said—

"It has become very weak."

Ruchi asked—

"Then?"

Mala looked at her.

"Throw it away?"

Ruchi lifted one corner of the curtain.

"Let it dry first."

"Then?"

"Then we'll see."

Mala smiled.

"You're talking like your father now."

Ruchi smiled too.

By evening the curtain had dried.

Ruchi took it down and folded it.

She did not look for the rubbish sack.

Nor did she hang the curtain back at the window.

She placed it on top of a box.

Mala asked—

"Where have you put it?"

"Here for now."

"For how long?"

Ruchi looked at the new curtain in the outer room.

Then at the open frame of her own window.

"Until it's decided."

"What is to be decided?"

Ruchi ran her hand over the fold of the curtain.

"Whether it should be thrown away or used again."

Sudhir came in from outside carrying vegetables.

He saw the old curtain on top of the box.

He asked nothing.

Ruchi said—

“Babu, the top row of loops is ruined.”

Taking off his shoes, Sudhir said—

“The third row is still good.”

Ruchi laughed.

“You remember too?”

Sudhir paused for a moment.

“The third row fitted in this house, didn’t it?”

“In the old house,” Ruchi said.

Sudhir pushed his shoes to one side.

“Yes. In the old house.”

Outside, the new curtain stirred lightly in the breeze.

The old curtain lay folded on top of the box.

No one called it a keepsake.

No one put it with the rubbish either.

It simply remained in the house until they decided what its next use would be.

The Cylinder Ran Out

At ten minutes past nine that night, the flame on the stove thinned once and went out.

Anima turned the knob off.

The first roti was already on the griddle.

There was steam in the kitchen, but no fire.

She looked at the cylinder.

Then towards the doorway.

In the outer room, Shashank was folding the newspaper.

Anima said—

“The cylinder has run out.”

Shashank put the newspaper down.

“Now?”

“Yes.”

“The other one too?”

“There isn’t another.”

Shashank came into the kitchen.

He looked at the griddle.

The dal in the pot was already cooked.

The potato curry was ready too.

Only the rotis remained.

“I’ll bring rotis from outside.”

Anima looked at the clock.

“The eatery downstairs closes by this time.”

“We’ll get them on the main road.”

“Half a kos away.”

Shashank moved towards his slippers.

Just then, from the inner room, Shuchi called—

“Ma, are the rotis ready?”

Anima answered—

“The gas has run out.”

Shuchi came out with a book in her hand.

"I'll eat dal and rice."

Anima said—

"The rice is left over from lunch."

"That's fine."

Shashank stopped while putting on his slippers.

"Then shall I not go?"

Shuchi said—

"Not for me."

Anima said—

"I can manage too."

Shashank took his slippers off again.

For a few moments all three were silent.

Then Shashank said—

"Where is that little electric hot plate?"

Anima's hand stopped.

Shuchi immediately asked—

"What hot plate?"

Shashank looked at Anima.

Anima said—

"The old single-burner electric hot plate."

"Where is it?"

Shashank asked again.

Anima did not answer.

Shashank himself turned towards the outer room.

Three cardboard boxes were stacked against the wall.

They had been there for the past four days.

Shuchi had noticed them, but had never opened them.

On one box, in thick marker, was written—"Books."

On another—"Clothes."

Nothing was written on the third.

Shashank bent beside that third box.

Anima stood at the kitchen doorway.

"Is it in there?"

Shashank asked.

Anima said—

"Yes."

Shuchi slowly came into the outer room.

“Where are these boxes going?”

No one answered.

Shashank began peeling the tape from the top of the third box.

The tape was strong.

He asked for scissors.

Anima brought them from the kitchen.

Shuchi kept looking at the blank place on the box where nothing had been written.

Shashank cut the tape.

He opened the lid.

On top lay an old towel.

Beneath it, two steel plates.

A glass.

A small pressure cooker.

And at the bottom, a single-burner electric hot plate.

Shuchi said—

“Why is all the kitchen stuff in the same box?”

Shashank took the hot plate out.

“It just got packed that way.”

Shuchi looked at the steel plates.

“Are these plates from our house?”

Anima said—

“Yes.”

“Then why are they in a box?”

Shashank kept uncoiling the cord.

Anima said—

“Let us make the rotis first.”

Shuchi looked at her.

“Ma.”

Anima looked away.

Shashank placed the hot plate on the kitchen counter.

Its cord was short.

The wall socket was too far away.

He began looking for an extension board.

Shuchi remained standing there.

“Where are these boxes going?”

Shashank said—

“Shuchi, let us eat first.”

“Where are they going?”

Anima pulled out a chair and sat down.

The gas stove in the kitchen was dead.

The little electric hot plate lay on the counter.

Its cord hung loose.

Shuchi put her book on the table.

“These boxes have been here for four days.”

Shashank said—

“Yes.”

“Whose clothes are those?”

Shashank said nothing.

Shuchi moved towards the lid of the box.

Anima said—

“Don’t open it.”

Shuchi’s hand stopped.

“Why?”

Before Anima could answer, Shashank said—

“They are my clothes.”

Shuchi looked at her father.

“Where are you going?”

Shashank let out a breath.

“I’ll live separately for a few days.”

The ticking of the kitchen clock suddenly became clear.

Shuchi looked first at Anima.

Then at Shashank.

“Separate from whom?”

No one answered at once.

Shuchi’s face changed slightly.

“From me?”

Shashank stepped forward.

“No.”

“Then?”

Anima said—

“We have been thinking of living apart from each other for a while.”

Shuchi sat down on the chair.

She pulled the book towards herself on the table.

“Since when?”

Shashank said—

"It isn't decided yet."

Anima looked at him.

Shashank corrected himself—

"The place is decided. The day wasn't."

Shuchi looked at her father again.

"The place?"

Shashank was silent.

Anima said—

"A rented room near his office."

"Have you paid the rent?"

Shashank said quietly—

"I've paid the advance."

Shuchi lowered her eyes.

The electric hot plate's cord still did not reach the wall socket.

Shashank took an extension board down from the shelf.

He dusted it off.

Shuchi said—

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Anima said—

"You had exams."

"I still do."

"Yes."

"Then why tell me now?"

No one answered.

Shuchi looked at the box.

"Because the gas ran out?"

Something came over Anima's face that was not quite a smile and not entirely sorrow either.

"More or less."

Shashank plugged in the extension board.

The red light on the hot plate came on.

He placed the griddle on it.

Anima stood up.

"I'll make them."

Shashank took his hand away from the griddle.

Anima put the rolled roti on it.

The griddle heated slowly on the electric hot plate.

The roti did not puff.

Shuchi remained seated at the table.

"I knew you two quarrel."

Anima kept rolling the dough.

Shashank looked at the wall.

"Every household has quarrels," he said.

Shuchi answered at once—

"Not every household packs boxes."

Shashank fell silent.

Anima rolled the second roti.

Shuchi said—

"How long will you live apart?"

Anima said—

"That isn't decided either."

"A month?"

"Maybe."

"Then?"

Shashank said—

"Then we'll see."

Shuchi said—

"See what?"

There was weariness on Shashank's face.

"We can't manage to talk while living in the same house."

Anima turned the roti over.

"Perhaps living apart will make things clearer."

Shuchi looked at her mother.

"Do you want this?"

Anima took a long time to answer.

"I want us not to keep having the same argument every day."

"That isn't an answer."

Anima stopped the rolling pin.

"No. It isn't a complete answer."

Shashank sat down on a chair.

"I can't give you a complete answer either."

Shuchi began folding the corner of her book page.

Anima said—

"Don't fold the page."

Shuchi stopped her hand.

All three were silent for a moment.

Then Shuchi said softly—
“Even at a time like this, you notice the page.”
Anima looked at her.
She said nothing.
The third roti went onto the griddle.
The electric hot plate had gradually grown hot.
The roti was cooking a little better now.
Shashank got up and took out plates.
Not the two plates packed in the box.
Three old household plates from the kitchen shelf.
He set them on the table.
Shuchi watched.
“Why did you pack the plates in the box?”
Shashank said—
“Those are my old office plates.”
“The glass?”
“That too.”
“The pressure cooker?”
Shashank gave a faint laugh.
“I bought that new.”
Shuchi did not laugh.
“So you have made all the preparations.”
Shashank’s smile disappeared.
“I’ll need a few things.”
“Has Ma made preparations too?”
Anima took the roti off the griddle.
“Where would I go?”
Shuchi said—
“So Babu is the one who is going.”
“Yes.”
“And me?”
“Here.”
“With whom?”
Anima looked at her.
“With me.”
Shuchi looked at Shashank.
“You had already decided that?”
Shashank said—

"Your school is close from here."

"That isn't an answer to the question."

Shashank was silent.

Anima switched the griddle off.

Six rotis had been made.

She put the pot of dal on the electric hot plate to warm it.

Shuchi asked again—

"You decided all this without me?"

Anima said—

"I thought we should first decide between ourselves."

"And I am not between you?"

"Not in that sense."

"In what sense?"

Anima searched for an answer.

Shashank said—

"You are our daughter. That will not change."

Shuchi raised her eyes.

"The house will."

Shashank was silent again.

The dal bubbled lightly as it warmed.

Anima lowered the heat.

The heat on the small electric hot plate did not fall at once.

She slid the pot a little to one side.

Shuchi said—

"Will you take this hot plate too?"

Shashank instinctively looked towards the box.

Anima did too.

No one answered.

This time Shuchi gave a faint laugh.

"If the gas hadn't run out, I wouldn't have known anything."

Anima said—

"I was thinking of telling you tomorrow."

Shashank looked at her.

"Tomorrow?"

Anima said—

"Yes."

"You didn't tell me that."

"Do I have to tell you everything first?"

Shashank's face hardened.
Shuchi looked from one to the other.
"Don't start quarrelling again now."
At that sentence, both fell silent.
Anima served the dal into three bowls.
The curry too.
The rotis were placed in a plate in the middle.
The three of them sat down to eat.
The first roti was for Shuchi.
The second for Shashank.
The third for Anima.
For a while there was only the sound of plates.
Shuchi asked—
"Where is the rented room?"
Shashank named the place.
Shuchi calculated the distance in her head.
"By bus?"
"Twenty to twenty-five minutes."
"Can I go there?"
Shashank answered immediately—
"Whenever you want."
Anima stopped with a morsel in her hand.
Shuchi looked at her.
"Do you object?"
Anima shook her head.
"No."
"Can I stay there at night?"
Before Shashank could answer, Anima said—
"First the place should be checked properly."
Shuchi laughed again.
"You have to check the windows, locks and water everywhere."
Anima said—
"Yes."
"Babu's room too?"
Anima said nothing.
Shashank said—
"She has seen it."
Shuchi looked at her mother.

"You went there?"

"Once."

"Both of you?"

"Yes."

Shuchi kept mixing the dal into her rice.

"Then this has been going on for a long time."

Shashank said—

"Two weeks."

"Not just four days of boxes."

"No."

Shuchi fell silent again.

The meal ended.

Anima reached out to pick up the plates.

Shuchi lifted her own plate herself.

Shashank did the same.

All three stood in the kitchen.

There was hardly room for three people at once in the small kitchen.

Anima said—

"You two go outside. I'll wash them."

Shuchi said—

"I'll wipe them."

Shashank said—

"I'll wash them."

Anima looked at him.

"Now?"

Shashank could not tell whether the question was about the plates or something else.

He turned on the tap.

"Now."

Shuchi took a cloth and began wiping the plates.

Anima stood there for a few moments.

Then she went into the outer room.

The open box lay near the table.

Inside it remained the towel, the empty spaces where the plates had been, the glass, and the small pressure cooker.

The electric hot plate was in the kitchen.

Anima did not close the box.

Shuchi came out after wiping the plates.

She sat beside the open box.
“Can I open the box with the clothes?”
Shashank came out of the kitchen.
His hands were wet.
“Why?”
“To see.”
“What?”
“How many clothes you’re taking.”
Shashank dried his hands on the towel.
“What will you know by looking?”
Shuchi said—
“I’ll know how long you have prepared for.”
Shashank looked at Anima.
Anima was standing by the window.
“Open it,” she said.
Shashank cut the tape on the clothes box.
Inside were four shirts, three pairs of trousers, two kurtas, a gamchha,
a towel and a sweater.
Shuchi took the sweater out.
“It’s hot now.”
Shashank said—
“Winter will come later.”
Shuchi remained holding the sweater.
“So, until winter?”
Shashank did not answer at once.
“Maybe.”
Shuchi put the sweater back in the box.
Her face was calm now.
That calm made Anima even more uneasy.
“Shuchi—”
“I’m fine.”
“You don’t have to be fine.”
Shuchi looked at her mother.
“Then what am I supposed to be?”
Anima did not answer.
Shuchi picked up her book.
“I’m going to study.”
Shashank said—

"If you don't study today, even then—"

Shuchi cut him off—

"My exam is tomorrow."

She went into her room.

This time the door closed completely.

The two open boxes remained in the outer room.

Anima sat down on a chair.

Shashank sat opposite her.

For a while neither said anything.

Then Shashank said—

"You were thinking of telling her tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Why tomorrow?"

"Because I didn't like the idea of her finding out by seeing boxes like this."

"But the boxes have been here for four days."

"That is why."

Shashank looked towards the window.

"I thought we should let the exam pass."

"There are exams every month."

"This is the main exam."

"Our decision to live apart cannot keep moving according to her question papers."

Shashank's face slackened with fatigue.

"The decision to live apart."

Anima said—

"For a few months."

"Changing the words doesn't make it smaller."

"I'm not saying it is small."

"Then?"

"I'm saying we should call it what it is."

Shashank looked at the box.

"Now it has been said."

Anima said—

"The gas ran out, and it got said."

For a moment both were silent.

Then a very faint smile came to Shashank's face.

"I had thought the big conversations in this house would happen in the sitting room."

Anima smiled faintly too.

"In our house, the big conversations happen near the kitchen."

The smiles disappeared at once.

From inside came the sound of Shuchi's chair being moved.

Shashank said quietly—

"Should I not go tomorrow?"

Anima looked at him.

"To the room?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"She has an exam."

"And four days later?"

Shashank said nothing.

Anima said—

"Will changing the day change the reason?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I feel guilty."

Anima lowered her eyes.

"So do I."

"You'll be with her."

"That doesn't make the guilt any less."

Shashank nodded.

"No."

The clock struck ten.

In the kitchen, the electric hot plate was cooling.

Anima got up and unplugged it.

Shashank lifted the lid of the box.

"Shall I put this hot plate back?"

Anima said—

"Leave it out until tomorrow."

"Shall we order the cylinder in the morning?"

"Yes."

"Then it should come by afternoon."

"Maybe."

Shashank did not put the hot plate back in the box.

It remained on the kitchen counter.

The two empty spaces where the plates had been remained open inside the box.

At night, Anima went to her own room.

Shashank spread his bedding in the outer room.

This arrangement had been in place for the past two months.

Shuchi had never directly asked the reason for it.

Now the reason had a name.

At half past ten, Shuchi's door opened.

She came out to drink water.

Shashank was still awake.

So was Anima.

Seeing both of them awake, Shuchi stopped.

"Can I ask one thing?"

Anima said—

"Ask."

"Are you getting divorced?"

Shashank said at once—

"No."

Anima did not answer quite as quickly.

Shuchi looked at her mother.

Anima said—

"There is no such decision right now."

"Meaning it could happen later?"

Anima filled a glass with water.

"We don't have the full answer about the future right now."

Shuchi took the glass.

"Don't lie to me."

Shashank said—

"We won't."

"And don't stop the conversation by saying I have exams."

Anima nodded.

"All right."

Shuchi drank the water.

She moved towards the door.

Then turned and said—

"Tomorrow I'm going to see Babu's room."

Shashank looked at her.

“After your exam tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

Anima wanted to say something.

Then she did not.

Shuchi went back inside.

The next morning there was still no gas.

Anima heated water on the little electric hot plate.

Three cups of tea were made.

Shuchi drank tea while revising for her exam.

Shashank quietly divided chura into three bowls.

The open box was still visible beside the dining table.

Before leaving for school, Shuchi looked at it.

“Don’t take this today.”

Shashank asked—

“Why?”

“I’ll see it this evening.”

“What?”

“Where everything will go in the room.”

After a moment Shashank said—

“All right.”

Shuchi left.

Anima closed the door.

Shashank said—

“She will go with me.”

“Yes.”

“You?”

Anima kept looking at the tea leaves left in her cup.

“If she asks me to.”

Shashank said nothing.

At nine o’clock the cooking-gas order was placed.

The cylinder arrived in the afternoon.

The deliveryman took away the empty cylinder.

The new cylinder was connected.

Anima lit the stove to test it.

The blue flame was normal.

She turned it off.

The little electric hot plate was still on the counter.

She could have put it back in the box.

She did not.

In the evening Shuchi returned from her exam.

She put down her bag and went straight to the kitchen.

She saw the new cylinder.

Then the small electric hot plate.

"The gas has come?"

"Yes."

"Then why is this still here?"

Anima said—

"Babu isn't taking it yet."

Shuchi looked at her for a few moments.

Then she went into the outer room.

Shashank had not yet returned from the office.

The open boxes were still there.

Shuchi did not close the lid of the clothes box.

She only moved the sweater from the top to the bottom.

At night Shashank came home.

Shuchi said—

"Come."

"Where?"

"To see the room."

Shashank looked at Anima.

Anima said—

"Go."

Shuchi asked—

"You're not coming?"

Anima thought for a moment.

"Not today."

Shuchi nodded.

Shashank took the key.

He bent to lift the box.

Shuchi said—

"Not the box yet."

Shashank straightened.

"Why?"

"First we'll see the place."

Anima looked at Shuchi.

In her own voice, not imitating her mother's, Shuchi said—

“Windows, locks, water—everything.”

Shashank smiled faintly.

Anima did too.

The two of them went out.

Anima remained standing at the doorway.

The open box was in the outer room.

The new cylinder was in the kitchen.

The little electric hot plate still lay on the counter.

The problem of the empty gas cylinder had been solved.

Everything else was still open.

Two Plates

By half past seven on Sunday evening, Kiran had set two plates on the table.

Both plates were stainless steel.

One had a delicate floral engraving around the rim; the other was plain.

Sadanand chose the plain plate for himself.

The flowered one was for the guest.

From the kitchen, Kiran asked—

“What time is it?”

Sadanand looked at the clock on the wall.

“Seven thirty-two.”

“Did he say seven?”

“Seven to seven-thirty.”

Kiran lifted the lid and looked at the dal.

A thin skin had begun to form on top.

She stirred it again.

The pot of rice on the stove was still warm.

There was potato-and-pointed-gourd curry in the pan.

In a small bowl were two pieces of fish.

Fish was not part of the household’s ordinary meal that day.

Sadanand had said that morning—

“Manoj Babu may come. Make something nice.”

Kiran had asked—

“About work?”

Sadanand had said—

“No, just a visit.”

Kiran had not asked again.

She had brought the fish on credit.

The shopkeeper had written forty-five rupees on a slip.

Kiran had tucked the slip beneath her sewing box.

Sadanand had not noticed it.
Half past seven came and went.
The sound of a motorcycle came from outside.
Sadanand stood up.
The sound turned into the next lane.
He sat down again.
There were two glasses on the table as well.
Kiran filled one with water.
She left the other empty.
“Shall I fill it beforehand?”
Sadanand said—
“When he comes.”
Kiran left the glass where it was.
On the road outside the house, the vegetable seller was packing up his cart.
Someone called out asking for two kilos of potatoes.
Someone answered—
“Take them tomorrow.”
Inside the house, the wall clock kept ticking.
At eight, Kiran turned off the stove.
“It will have to be reheated.”
Sadanand said—
“He must be on his way.”
“Call him.”
“What if he is on the road?”
“Then he won’t answer.”
Sadanand picked up the phone.
Manoj Babu’s name was visible on the screen.
He did not place the call.
He set the phone back on the table.
Kiran noticed this small gesture.
She said nothing.
An old brown file lay on the kitchen counter.
When Kiran saw it during the day, she understood that it contained Sadanand’s employment papers.
The file had been in the iron trunk for three months.
Today it had been taken out, wiped with a clean cloth, and placed on the counter.

Kiran had not put it back in the trunk.

Neither had Sadanand.

At ten past eight, Kiran asked—

“Tea?”

“No.”

“When he comes, will he have tea or dinner?”

“Dinner.”

“Are you sure?”

Sadanand looked at Kiran.

“I told him.”

“What?”

“Come and eat.”

“That was all?”

“Yes.”

Kiran lifted the lid again.

The fish gravy had thickened.

She added a spoonful of water.

Then she put the lid back on.

At twenty past eight, the power went out once and came back immediately.

The clock stopped for two seconds, then began moving again.

Sadanand got up and went to the window.

Three boys went down the lane, pushing their bicycles.

The shutter of one shop was half down.

Manoj Babu was nowhere to be seen.

Kiran wiped a corner of the table.

The flowered plate shifted slightly.

Sadanand straightened it again.

“You should eat,” Kiran said.

“He’ll be here.”

“If you are eating when he comes, he can eat too.”

“It feels better to sit and eat together.”

Kiran did not smile.

“After how many days?”

Sadanand did not answer.

It had been five months since the printing press closed.

Earlier, Sadanand had operated the press machine on the night shift.

He would leave home at seven in the evening.

Kiran would eat alone then.
Many nights, Sadanand returned at three in the morning.
At those times, Kiran would get up and warm rice on the stove.
After the printing press closed, the two of them were usually at home at the same time.
Yet they rarely ate together.
Sadanand ate late during the day.
Kiran ate whenever she found time between her sewing jobs.
Today there were two plates on the table.
Food had not yet been served on either one.
At eight thirty-five, the phone rang.
Sadanand picked it up at once.
It was a message from the bank.
He read it and placed the phone face down on the table.
Kiran asked—
“Manoj Babu?”
“No.”
“Who?”
“The bank.”
“What?”
“Nothing.”
Kiran fell silent again.
An unfinished blue blouse lay beside the sewing machine.
The customer was due the next morning.
Kiran could have sat down and finished the stitching then.
She did not.
She kept moving between the kitchen and the table.
Sadanand remained seated in the chair.
At eight forty, Kiran picked up the file.
“Why did you take this out?”
Sadanand looked at it for a moment.
“No reason.”
“For the first time in five months, for no reason?”
Sadanand reached out and took the file.
He placed it beneath the table.
“Has Manoj Babu heard about the work?”
“What work?”
“The new printing press.”

Sadanand remained silent.

Kiran said—

“Ramchandra said yesterday that a printing press has opened in the industrial area.”

“Does Ramchandra know everything?”

“Not from me. People were talking at the shop.”

“So?”

“So nothing. I’m asking.”

Sadanand moved away from the back of the chair and sat upright.

“Manoj knows people there.”

“So that is why dinner tonight?”

“People come for dinner too.”

Kiran looked at the flowered plate on the table.

“Yes.”

For a while, neither of them spoke.

A dog barked outside.

Far away, a pressure cooker whistled in another house.

Kiran asked—

“Have you told him?”

“What?”

“That you need work.”

“Not directly.”

“Then?”

“He understands.”

“How?”

Sadanand’s voice grew slightly harder.

“Does everything have to be said in words?”

Kiran did not raise her voice either.

“No. But if you need work, what is wrong with saying it?”

Sadanand ran a finger along the rim of the plate.

“You won’t understand.”

“I have been managing the household accounts for five months.”

“That is different from the matter of work.”

“No.”

Sadanand looked at Kiran.

For the first time, Kiran looked straight into his eyes.

“I brought the fish on credit.”

Sadanand’s finger stopped on the plate.

“Why?”

“We were short of money.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

Kiran gave a faint laugh.

“Does everything have to be said in words?”

Sadanand’s face did not change.

But his hand moved away from the plate.

At nine, Kiran reheated the food again.

This time she took down the rice too and set it on the pan to warm.

Steam rose again.

She served rice onto the two plates.

Sadanand said—

“Now?”

“Why let it go cold?”

“He’ll come.”

“If he does, I’ll warm it again.”

Kiran served the dal.

She put the larger piece of fish on the flowered plate.

The smaller piece went on the plain plate.

Sadanand noticed.

“And yours?”

“I’ll eat later.”

“Why?”

“I had set out two plates.”

Sadanand wanted to say something.

Then he did not.

The two plates, filled with food, remained set on the table.

It became nine ten.

Then nine twenty.

A skin began forming on the dal again.

This time Kiran did not stir it.

Sadanand picked up the phone and called Manoj Babu.

It rang.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

There was no answer.

He ended the call.

"He must be on the road," Kiran said.

There was no sarcasm in her voice this time.

Sadanand said—

"Perhaps."

At nine thirty, Kiran sat down at the sewing machine.

She picked up the blue cloth.

She turned the machine wheel once.

Then stopped.

"How much is left?" Sadanand asked.

"Half an hour."

"Finish it."

"I don't feel like it."

Sadanand's eyes went back to the two plates.

Kiran said—

"Did you invite him for dinner, or to show him the file?"

"It could be both."

"Yes."

"Kiran."

"What?"

"I am not begging."

Kiran placed the cloth on the table.

"I didn't say you were."

"That is how your words sound."

"I am saying that a matter of work should be handled like a matter of work."

"What do you mean?"

"Call him. Fix a meeting. Take the file. Say—I need work."

Sadanand was silent.

Kiran continued—

"Why should you have to feed him fish in order to ask for work?"

"He is an old acquaintance."

"Then feed him as an acquaintance. Keep the matter of work separate."

"Can you keep everything separate?"

Kiran thought for a moment.

"No."

She picked up the blue cloth again.

"But accounts still have to be kept."

Sadanand got up and went to the window.

The lane was almost empty.

An empty milk van passed slowly.

The shops had closed.

The smell of fish spread over the table.

At nine forty-five, the phone rang again.

This time Manoj Babu's name appeared.

Sadanand picked up the phone.

"Hello?"

He listened.

"Yes."

Then—

"No problem."

Then—

"No, no, not at all."

Kiran sat by the machine watching him.

Sadanand said—

"Tomorrow?"

He listened.

"All right."

Then—

"Yes, I have the file."

Kiran's hand stopped on the cloth.

Very softly, Sadanand said—

"Yes, it was about work."

The call ended.

For a few moments, only the sound of the clock remained in the house.

Kiran asked—

"What happened?"

"He won't be able to come."

"Tonight?"

"Yes."

"Tomorrow?"

"He asked me to meet him outside the printing press tomorrow."

"What time?"

"Eleven."

Kiran nodded.

Sadanand came back to the table.

The rice on both plates had gone cold.

He looked at the flowered plate.

“Take this away.”

Kiran rose from the machine.

“Why?”

“He isn’t coming.”

“But the food is here.”

“Set a plate for yourself.”

Kiran pulled out the chair in front of the flowered plate.

“This can be my plate.”

Sadanand looked at her.

“You’ll eat the larger piece of fish?”

“Today I will.”

For the first time, Sadanand smiled faintly.

Kiran did too.

She sat down.

Neither plate was reheated again.

Kiran mixed dal into her rice.

Sadanand broke off a piece of the smaller fish.

For a while, they ate in silence.

Then Kiran asked—

“What will you take in the file tomorrow?”

“The old appointment letter, the experience certificate, and the paper from the printing-machine training.”

“Do you have photocopies?”

“Two.”

“Is your phone number written at the top?”

“The old number.”

“Change it.”

Sadanand nodded.

Kiran said—

“Will they want a photograph?”

“Perhaps.”

“Get one taken tomorrow morning.”

“Money?”

Kiran stopped eating and looked at him.

“I have a sewing delivery. I’ll get two hundred.”

Sadanand immediately said—

“No. I have enough.”

Kiran began mixing her rice again.

“Then good.”

“Kiran.”

“Yes?”

“I’ll pay the forty-five rupees for the fish tomorrow.”

“Do.”

“I’ll give it to the shopkeeper.”

“All right.”

The matter ended there.

They finished their meal.

Kiran reached out to pick up the plates.

Sadanand picked up the flowered plate.

“I’ll wash this.”

“Both?”

“Both.”

Kiran sat down at the sewing machine again.

Sadanand began washing the plates at the tap.

The sound of the water was soft.

Kiran resumed stitching the blue cloth.

The wheel of the machine began turning evenly.

A little later, Sadanand opened the file on the table.

He drew a line through the old phone number.

Under it, he wrote the new one.

Without stopping the machine, Kiran asked—

“Eleven?”

“Yes.”

“Leave at ten.”

“That early?”

“You have to get the photograph taken too.”

Sadanand closed the file.

“All right.”

At ten fifteen that night, the table was empty.

The two plates had been washed and placed beside each other on the wall shelf.

The guest had not come.

The food had not gone to waste.

The job had not yet been found.

But eleven o'clock tomorrow was no longer vague.

The Neighbour's Television

Malti Devi's wall clock had been stopped at four seventeen for three months.

She had not taken the clock down.

Nor had she changed the battery.

She had another way of knowing the time.

There was a television on the other side of the wall.

The television was not hers.

It belonged to the neighbours.

Malti Devi had never even seen it.

She only heard its sound.

At seven every morning, a devotional programme began.

At eight, the loud theme of the news came on.

At half past one in the afternoon, the song from a serial could be heard.

At five in the evening, there was a children's programme.

And at eight at night, the news again.

Malti Devi's day was divided among these five sounds.

She measured time less by a clock than by the sounds beyond the wall.

Her room was small.

One cot.

One low stool.

Two brass bowls.

Three tin boxes.

And two sacks of makhana.

Malti Devi sorted makhana at home.

The large kernels went into one box.

The medium ones into another.

The broken pieces into the third.

The shopkeeper left the sacks on Wednesday.

On Sunday he collected the sorted stock.

As soon as the devotional programme began, Malti Devi put the tea on.

At the first notes of the news theme, she sat down beside the stool.

When the afternoon serial's song was heard, she put away the first sack.

Then she warmed the rice.

When the laughter from the five o'clock children's programme came through, she made tea.

After the night news, she covered the boxes of makhana.

Between these markers, she had no need of a clock.

She had a mobile phone.

But it usually lay on the cot.

Malti Devi sat at the stool sorting makhana.

There was no reason to stretch her hand all the way to the phone.

Four people lived in the neighbouring flat.

Ramesh Babu.

His wife, Reena.

His mother, Sharda Devi.

And their twelve-year-old daughter, Minni.

Malti Devi knew all their names.

They spoke very little.

If they met on the stairs, they exchanged greetings.

Sometimes, if someone needed salt, two spoonfuls passed from one home to the other.

Sometimes a parcel arrived at the wrong door and was returned.

That was all.

The wall was thin.

The television came through more clearly than conversation.

If someone wept in a serial, Malti Devi could not make out the words, but she understood the weeping.

If someone argued loudly on the news, she recognised the tone.

In the children's programme, canned laughter returned again and again.

Malti Devi did not think of these as programmes; she thought of them as signs of the hour.

On Tuesday morning, the devotional programme was heard as usual.

So was the news.

Malti Devi sorted enough makhana to fill the first bowl.

The second bowl became half full.

She remained seated.
After a while, she realised her stomach was empty.
She turned an ear towards the wall.
Nothing.
The serial's song had not yet come.
She thought it must not be half past one yet.
She went on sorting makhana.
Outside in the lane, the vegetable seller called out once.
Then silence.
Malti Devi opened the third box.
She tipped the makhana from the bowl into it.
Then her stomach pulled again.
She went to the cot for her mobile phone.
The screen showed two fifty-six.
For a few moments, Malti Devi stared at the phone.
Then she looked towards the wall.
"Is the television switched off?"
The question was addressed to no one.
The rice was cold.
The vegetable curry was from the morning.
She warmed her meal.
While she ate, the sound of utensils came through the wall.
Someone spoke.
The words were not clear.
The television did not come on.
The five o'clock children's programme did not come either.
Malti Devi made tea at half past six.
By then she had had to check her phone three times.
There was no night news either.
She put away the makhana at eight thirty-five.
After looking at the time.
Not after hearing the eight o'clock sound.
The next morning, the devotional programme did not play.
Malti Devi had woken at six fifty-five.
She thought—
"It will start in five minutes."
Seven o'clock came.
Then seven ten.

Silence.

Sitting on the cot, she kept listening to the wall.

The neighbouring flat was not empty.

Someone turned on a tap.

A chair scraped.

Minni seemed to ask something.

Reena's voice came through.

But no television.

Malti Devi made tea.

That day, before she began sorting makhana, she placed the mobile phone on the stool.

At eight she looked at the screen.

Again at ten.

Again at five past twelve.

She grew irritated with herself for doing this.

"I should have had the clock fixed."

The old clock on the wall still showed four seventeen.

Malti Devi got up and took it down.

She opened the cover at the back.

She removed the battery and placed it on her palm.

It was dead.

There was no new battery in the house.

She put the old battery back in.

The clock did not move.

Around noon, when she went out to throw away the rubbish, she met Reena on the stairs.

Reena was carrying a basket of clothes.

Malti Devi stopped.

Reena said—

"Namaste, Didi."

"Namaste."

Reena began climbing upstairs.

Malti Devi asked—

"Has your television broken down?"

Reena stopped.

"No."

"Oh."

"Why?"

"Nothing. I just haven't been hearing it."

Reena shifted the basket to her other hand.

"Minni has examinations. We moved the television into the inner room."

"Hmm."

"When it was against the wall, the sound disturbed her studies."

Malti Devi nodded.

"You did the right thing."

Reena started climbing again.

Malti Devi said—

"I only wanted to know whether it had broken down."

Reena turned back.

"You used to hear it?"

"The sound came through."

"Was it very loud?"

"No."

Malti Devi quickly added—

"It never troubled me."

Reena smiled faintly.

"Ma keeps the volume high. She does not hear very well."

"All right."

They went towards their separate doors.

Malti Devi came home and put down the rubbish bin.

She sat at the stool.

She looked at the phone screen.

Two eighteen.

She began sorting makhana.

She thought of setting an alarm for five.

Then she did not.

A little later, there was a knock at the door.

Malti Devi got up.

Sharda Devi was outside.

She held a small steel bowl.

"Do you have sugar?"

"Yes."

Malti Devi went inside.

She put four spoonfuls of sugar from the tin into the bowl.

Sharda Devi stood at the door.

Her eyes fell on the stool inside.

“Are you sorting makhana late today?”

Malti Devi looked at her.

“Late?”

“Yes. I didn’t hear the bowls at all this afternoon.”

Malti Devi was silent for a few moments.

Sharda Devi said—

“I used to know from that sound that it was time to eat.”

“From my bowls?”

“When you fill the first box and make them clink, you know.”

Malti Devi glanced instinctively towards the stool.

The brass bowls stood beside each other.

Sharda Devi said—

“It happens sometime between half past one and two.”

“Every day?”

“Almost.”

Malti Devi smiled faintly.

“I used to tell the time from your television.”

At first, Sharda Devi did not understand.

“What?”

“The half-past-one serial. As soon as it came on, I would eat.”

Sharda Devi’s mouth remained open for a moment.

Then she laughed.

“So I was your clock, and you were mine?”

Malti Devi laughed too.

“The television.”

“Yes, the television.”

For a few moments, both women stood by the doorway.

Sharda Devi lifted the bowl.

“The television will stay in the inner room until Minni’s examinations are over.”

“Let it stay there.”

“You should get your clock repaired.”

“I’ll buy a battery tomorrow.”

“I may have one.”

“No, I’ll buy it.”

Sharda Devi left.

Malti Devi closed the door.

She sat down beside the stool.
 She picked up a brass bowl.
 She did not deliberately strike it against the empty box.
 She simply poured in the makhana.
 The clinking was ordinary.
 No television played beyond the wall.
 That evening, Malti Devi set an alarm on her mobile phone for five o'clock.
 The alarm rang.
 She made tea.
 At eight at night, a second alarm rang.
 She put away the makhana.
 Three days passed like this.
 On the fourth day, Minni met Malti Devi on the stairs.
 "Kaki."
 "Yes?"
 "Grandmother says you put away the makhana early today."
 Malti Devi stopped.
 "Yes, there was less stock."
 Minni said—
 "She drank her five o'clock tea at four forty-five."
 Malti Devi laughed.
 "Because of me?"
 "She says the bowls went quiet."
 "Tell her to look at the clock."
 "I do. She doesn't listen."
 Minni ran upstairs.
 Malti Devi went to the market.
 She bought a battery for the clock.
 She also looked at a small, inexpensive clock.
 The shopkeeper said—
 "This one is cheap."
 Malti Devi did not buy it.
 Back home, she put the new battery into the old clock.
 The thin hand began to move.
 She set the time by looking at her mobile phone.
 Four fifty-two.
 She hung the clock back on the wall.

She removed the five o'clock alarm.

And the eight o'clock one as well.

The following Sunday, the shopkeeper came to collect the makhana.

He weighed all three boxes.

"Ready on time this week."

Malti Devi said—

"It always is."

The shopkeeper said nothing.

He lifted the sack and left.

In the evening, Malti Devi cleaned the stool.

The wall clock showed five twelve.

The television was still in the inner room; its sound no longer came through the wall.

Sometimes, when an inner door in the neighbours' flat opened, a faint tune travelled through the corridor and reached her room.

That day, a little burst of laughter from the children's programme could be heard. Malti Devi looked at the clock—five fourteen.

She got up to put the tea on.

Then, from beyond the wall, came three faint metallic sounds. Sharda Devi was perhaps setting down a cup.

Malti Devi paused to listen, then walked towards the kitchen.

The clock was running, the television was farther away; but between the two homes, time still came and went in sound.

The Stalled Lift

Reena Devi lived on the fifth floor.

Vinod Thakur on the seventh.

Both their doors opened in front of the same lift, only two floors apart.

In four years, their conversations had never gone beyond five or seven sentences.

“Namaskar.”

“Namaskar.”

“Going down?”

“Yes.”

“You first.”

That was all.

Reena Devi used the lift most often around eight in the morning.

She cooked meals at home and sent them to offices.

There were small steel tiffin boxes.

Sometimes five.

Sometimes seven.

In a good month, as many as nine.

The boxes stood upright in a blue basket with a blue strap.

It took time to place the basket inside the lift.

Then the boy who carried the meals downstairs would arrive.

He would lift the second basket.

Sometimes the boy was late.

Reena Devi would hold the lift door open with one hand.

At that very time, on the seventh floor, Vinod Thakur would keep pressing the button.

His office bus stopped on the main road at eight twenty.

It left two minutes later.

Once he had missed it.

Vinod Thakur had taken a hired vehicle to the office.

It had cost one hundred and eighty rupees.

The second time, he had reached half a day late.

The third time, a sheet of paper was posted on the apartment notice board.

“Do not hold the lift unnecessarily.”

Below it was the seal of the management committee.

Reena Devi read the notice.

She said nothing.

The next day she sent the first basket down.

Then she called the lift back up.

She took the second basket down.

The lift made two trips.

It did not take less time.

Only the door was not held open.

This continued for two weeks.

One evening Reena Devi was returning from the market.

In one hand she carried a bag of potatoes.

In the other were three empty steel tiffin boxes nested inside one another.

The lift opened on the ground floor.

Vinod Thakur was standing inside.

In his hand was an old brown office bag.

Reena Devi stepped in.

“Namaskar.”

“Namaskar.”

Vinod Thakur had already pressed the button for the seventh floor.

Reena Devi pressed the button for the fifth.

The doors closed.

The lift began to move.

Between two floors there was a jolt.

The sound was not very loud.

Only like someone setting a heavy trunk down on the floor.

The lift stopped.

Reena Devi first looked at the buttons.

Vinod Thakur pressed seven again.

Nothing happened.

He pressed five.

Nothing happened.

The small fan overhead kept running.
The light was on as well.
Vinod Thakur pressed the emergency bell.
Somewhere below, they heard a bell ring.
Both remained silent.
The bag of potatoes tugged at Reena Devi's wrist.
She set it on the floor.
The three tiffin boxes clattered.
Vinod Thakur said—
"It has broken down again."
Reena Devi asked—
"Before too?"
"Two months ago, for ten minutes."
"I wasn't here."
"Perhaps it was in the afternoon."
Vinod Thakur took out his mobile phone.
There was one bar of signal.
He called the guard.
The first call did not connect.
The second did.
"Yes, Ramesh?"
He listened.
"There are two of us."
He listened again.
"Between five and seven."
Reena Devi kept watching his face.
Vinod Thakur said—
"He is calling the mechanic. He said twenty minutes."
Reena Devi nodded.
She loosened the knot of the potato bag.
The thin strap had dug into her fingers.
For a while there was only the sound of the fan.
Vinod Thakur kept looking at the lift's floor numbers.
The red light was stuck between 3 and 4.
Reena Devi said—
"Was it you who wrote that notice on the board?"
Vinod Thakur looked at her at once.
"Which one?"

“Do not hold the lift.”

For a few moments he did not answer.

Then he said—

“I had made the complaint.”

“I knew.”

“I hadn’t written my name.”

“I knew that too.”

Vinod Thakur shifted the brown bag to his other hand.

“I kept missing the bus.”

Reena Devi said—

“My meals were getting late too.”

Silence again.

The lift fan shuddered once.

Reena Devi looked up.

The fan resumed its normal whirl.

Vinod Thakur said—

“Holding the door probably puts strain on the machine.”

Reena Devi’s face hardened.

“I did not break it.”

“I didn’t say you did.”

“Then?”

“I was only saying.”

“Let the mechanic decide what belongs to the mechanic.”

“All right.”

Vinod Thakur fell silent.

So did Reena Devi.

The lid of one tiffin box was loose.

She pressed it down with a finger and fixed it.

Then she pushed the second box farther inside the first.

The metallic sound seemed loud inside the lift.

Vinod Thakur asked—

“How many boxes do you send these days?”

Reena Devi looked at him.

“What?”

“The meal boxes.”

“Earlier there were nine. Now five or seven.”

“It has gone down?”

“Two offices opened their own canteens. One person carries food from home now.”

Vinod Thakur nodded.

“That boy?”

“Sonu?”

“I don’t know his name.”

“That’s who I mean. He didn’t come today.”

“So these empty boxes?”

“I brought them back myself.”

“By the stairs?”

“There was a lift, so I used the lift.”

Vinod Thakur laughed softly.

Reena Devi did not laugh.

Then she too smiled.

“Now there is no lift either.”

Vinod Thakur said—

“Now I’m in this with you.”

Both fell silent again.

The time on the mobile phone was seven fifty-eight.

Reena Devi asked—

“Your office is still in the same place?”

“Yes.”

“The morning bus?”

“Yes.”

“Eight twenty?”

Vinod Thakur looked at her in surprise.

“How did you know?”

“In the mornings you press the button at eight fifteen.”

Vinod Thakur started to say something, then stopped.

Then he said—

“And you used to hold the lift from eight ten to eight sixteen.”

“I wasn’t looking at the clock.”

“I was.”

Reena Devi rested her hand near her foot on the potato bag.

“One day the boy was late.”

“That day I missed the bus.”

“So you complained.”

“Yes.”

“You could have told me.”

Vinod Thakur looked at the wall.

“It didn’t feel easy to say.”

“The complaint felt easy?”

He did not answer.

Reena Devi did not take the matter further either.

After a few moments Vinod Thakur said—

“A hired vehicle costs one hundred and eighty.”

Reena Devi said—

“Sonu asks fifty for a second trip.”

Vinod Thakur looked at her.

Reena Devi said—

“If both baskets go down together, it is one trip. Separately, it is two.”

“Fifty?”

“His time matters too.”

“Yes.”

“If a customer’s meal is late, they deduct money.”

“If I’m late to the office, they deduct half a day.”

They looked at one another.

Then both looked away at the same moment.

The emergency bell was pressed again.

This time someone below shouted loudly.

The words were not clear.

Vinod Thakur leaned an ear towards the door and said—

“He’s coming.”

“Who?”

“The mechanic, perhaps.”

Ten minutes passed.

The doors did not open.

The lift was growing slightly warm.

Reena Devi wiped her forehead with the end of her sari.

Vinod Thakur opened the zip of his brown bag.

Inside was a small bottle of water.

He took it out and said—

“Water?”

Reena Devi first shook her head to refuse.

Then she said—

“One sip.”

She took the bottle.

Without touching it to her mouth, she poured water from above and drank.

She handed the bottle back.

“Thank you.”

“Yes.”

Vinod Thakur also drank two sips.

Less than half the water remained in the bottle.

He put it back in his bag.

Reena Devi asked—

“What time do you leave tomorrow morning?”

“Eight fifteen.”

“I can have the boxes sent down by eight ten.”

Vinod Thakur immediately said—

“I’ll withdraw the complaint—”

“Why withdraw the complaint?”

He fell silent.

Reena Devi said—

“The rule is not wrong.”

“Then?”

“I did not understand the timing.”

“I didn’t understand your timing either.”

“Every day it may not be eight ten.”

“And every day the bus does not arrive at exactly the same time either.”

Reena Devi laughed softly.

“Then both clocks are faulty.”

“The lift is the third.”

This time both laughed.

The laughter was brief.

It ended at once.

From below came the sound of a tool striking metal.

The lift trembled once.

Reena Devi caught hold of the wall.

Vinod Thakur did the same.

The door opened half an inch and closed again.

A voice came from outside—

“Don’t panic!”

Vinod Thakur said—

“We’re not panicking.”

Reena Devi looked at him.

“Neither am I.”

Two minutes later the lift began to slide slowly downward.

The doors opened on the third floor.

Outside stood the mechanic, the guard, and two residents.

Ramesh said—

“The lift will remain shut now. It has to be inspected.”

Reena Devi lifted the potato bag.

Her wrist was pulled again.

The three empty tiffin boxes were in her other hand.

Vinod Thakur put his bag on his shoulder.

Both moved towards the stairs.

From the third floor to the fifth, Reena Devi climbed slowly.

On the fourth floor she stopped.

She set the potato bag on the floor.

Vinod Thakur stopped too.

“Give them to me. I’ll carry the tiffin boxes.”

Reena Devi said—

“You have to go up to the seventh.”

“The fifth comes first.”

“Leave it.”

Vinod Thakur said nothing.

He simply picked up the potato bag.

Reena Devi kept the tiffin boxes.

When they reached the fifth floor, he placed the bag beside her door.

As Reena Devi took out her key, she said—

“Save your one hundred and eighty.”

Vinod Thakur said—

“And your fifty.”

Reena Devi smiled.

She went inside.

Vinod Thakur continued up the stairs.

The next morning a paper was pasted on the lift door—

“Repairs in progress.”

At eight five, Reena Devi carried the first basket down by the stairs.

Sonu came up and carried the second basket down.

At eight fourteen, she met Vinod Thakur coming down the stairs.

"The lift didn't open?"

"Not yet."

"The bus?"

"There's time."

Sonu went down ahead with the basket.

Reena Devi stood at the turn of the fifth-floor landing.

Vinod Thakur went down two steps and stopped.

"They say it will be fixed by tomorrow."

"We'll see."

He went down.

Two days later the lift began running again.

At eight twelve in the morning, Reena Devi was placing a basket with seven tiffin boxes inside.

The doors were about to close.

A call signal came from the seventh floor.

Reena Devi withdrew her hand.

The lift went up.

Vinod Thakur entered on the seventh floor.

He looked at the basket.

"Seven today?"

"Yes."

"Good."

He pressed the ground-floor button.

The doors closed.

Reena Devi said—

"Eight thirteen."

Vinod Thakur looked at his watch.

"There's time."

The lift went down.

This time neither of them reached out a hand to hold the door.

The Grocery List

On Wednesday morning, Sudha lifted the rice tin.

The bottom of the tin was visible.

She reached inside and lifted a fistful of rice.

Then let it fall back.

Vinay was drinking tea by the kitchen window.

Sudha said—

“We’ll have to buy groceries today.”

Vinay looked up from his cup.

“How much is left?”

“Enough rice for today.”

“Lentils?”

“Half a bowl.”

“Oil?”

“Till tomorrow.”

Vinay stopped drinking his tea.

A small slip of paper was held down at one corner of the table.

A piece cut from an old electricity bill.

All week Sudha kept writing things on it.

Salt.

Turmeric.

Mustard oil.

Laundry soap.

Matches.

At the bottom of the paper was Vinay’s handwriting.

Five kilos of rice.

One kilo of masoor dal.

Tea leaves.

Half a kilo of sugar.

Both their handwritings were on the same slip.

So little space remained in the middle that two lines had been written at a slant.

Vinay picked up the list.

“Let’s get five kilos of rice.”

Sudha looked at the water on the stove.

“Now?”

“The rate is lower if we buy five kilos.”

“The rate will be lower, but more money will go at once.”

“If we go again later, that will cost too.”

“The shop is two lanes away.”

Vinay folded the list and opened it again.

“But if we buy three kilos, we’ll need rice again in five days.”

Sudha said—

“In five days the money will have come.”

Vinay did not answer.

His wages had been delayed by two days that month.

Yesterday the workshop accounts office had said—Friday.

Today was Wednesday.

The household cash was kept in a white envelope on top of the cupboard.

Sudha took the envelope down.

She counted the notes.

Seven hundred and eighty rupees.

She set aside three twenty-rupee notes.

“This is for milk and vegetables.”

Vinay said—

“Bus fare too.”

Sudha set aside two more twenty-rupee notes.

Seven hundred rupees remained on the table.

Vinay kept looking at it.

“Will seven hundred be enough?”

“If we buy small quantities, it will.”

“If we buy small quantities, it will cost more.”

“If some money remains, tomorrow can still run.”

Vinay did not smile.

Neither did Sudha.

This was not an argument.

Not yet.

Vinay had the second shift that afternoon.

He had to leave home at twelve twenty.

Sudha had two stitched garments to deliver by evening.

They decided to go for the groceries at nine.

“Will you come?” Sudha asked.

“Yes.”

Sudha put the list in his hand.

Vinay read it.

“Two soaps?”

“Not two. One.”

“It looks like two here.”

“The other line is for matches.”

Vinay narrowed his eyes at the list.

“All right.”

Sudha said—

“The matchbox has been empty since yesterday.”

“The stove has an ignition button.”

“It doesn’t work every time.”

Vinay made a small mark on the list with his nail.

“Keep the matches.”

Sudha said nothing.

At nine, the two of them left the house.

The lane was sticky with mud from the night’s rain.

Two crates had been turned upside down in front of Mahesh Sah’s shop.

Potatoes on one.

Onions on the other.

Inside, sacks of rice stood in rows.

Mahesh Sah sat behind the counter.

The moment he saw Vinay, he said—

“Both of you together after a long time.”

Sudha said—

“Money is short, so we’ve both come to check the arithmetic.”

Mahesh Sah laughed.

Vinay did not.

He placed the list on the counter.

Mahesh Sah pushed his spectacles up.

“What first?”

Vinay said—

“Rice.”

At the same time Sudha said—

“Oil.”

They looked at each other.

Mahesh Sah’s hand stopped over the scale weights.

“Shall I do the rice?”

Sudha said—

“Yes.”

Vinay looked toward the sacks.

“How much is this one?”

“Fifty-two.”

“For five kilos?”

“Two hundred and sixty.”

“The other one?”

“Fifty-six.”

“Is this one good?”

“Both are fine.”

Sudha said—

“Give us three kilos of the fifty-two one.”

Vinay immediately said—

“Five.”

Mahesh Sah looked at both of them again.

Sudha held down a corner of the list.

“If we take five, nearly half the money will go right here.”

“Not half.”

“Almost.”

“We’ll need rice again anyway.”

“We need the other things too.”

Mahesh Sah rested the tin measure on the sack.

He had not yet scooped out any rice.

Vinay said—

“With three kilos, it costs two rupees more per kilo.”

“Six rupees.”

“Six rupees is money too.”

Sudha said—

“And soap is money too.”

Vinay looked at the list.

“The soap can wait till Saturday.”

“I have to wash two of your shirts tomorrow.”

Vinay looked at his sleeve.

That day a thin streak of machine oil marked the cuff of his blue shirt.

“One shirt will do.”

“You have two days of shifts.”

Vinay said nothing.

Mahesh Sah asked softly—

“So, the rice?”

Sudha said—

“Three.”

Vinay said—

“Four.”

Mahesh Sah weighed four kilos.

Sudha wrote a small ‘4’ beside the five on the list.

She did not cross out the five.

She simply wrote four in front of it.

Mahesh Sah lifted the oil bottle.

“One litre?”

Sudha said—

“Half a litre.”

Vinay looked at her.

“The rate is lower for one litre.”

“The same thing again.”

“The rate is lower.”

“And the money is lower too.”

Mahesh Sah measured out half a litre.

Vinay said—

“How much is left at home?”

“Enough for two lots of vegetables.”

“Then this is for four or five days.”

“Yes.”

“Again on Friday.”

“Yes.”

Mahesh Sah lifted the lentil tin.

“One kilo?”

Vinay said—

“One.”

Sudha said—

“Half.”

This time Vinay did not answer at once.

He looked outside the shop.

A cyclist passed with milk cans hanging from the bicycle.

“How much for half a kilo?”

Mahesh Sah told him the price.

Vinay calculated in his head.

“With one kilo, it comes five rupees cheaper.”

Sudha said—

“With half a kilo, seventy-five rupees stays with us now.”

Vinay placed a finger on the list.

“That isn’t saving. It’s postponing.”

“Not postponing. Making room till Friday.”

Mahesh Sah weighed half a kilo of lentils.

He began writing the prices on the list with his pencil.

Salt.

Turmeric.

Matches.

There was no dispute over those three.

There was over the soap.

Mahesh Sah took out one bar.

Vinay said—

“Give us the smaller one.”

Sudha said—

“This is for washing clothes. The smaller one dissolves quickly.”

“Five rupees less.”

“And lasts three days less.”

Vinay held the two sizes of soap in his hands and looked at them.

“The bigger one.”

Mahesh Sah set down the larger bar.

Sudha slid it into the bag.

Now came the tea leaves.

Mahesh Sah read the list.

“Tea?”

Sudha looked at Vinay.

Vinay said—

“One hundred grams.”

Sudha asked—

“And what’s left at home?”

“Enough till tonight.”

“Shall we drink hot water tomorrow morning?”

Vinay looked at her.

Sudha made no attempt to smile.

She was genuinely asking.

After returning from the night shift, Vinay drank one cup of tea.

Another in the morning.

Sudha usually drank half a cup.

Mahesh Sah stood there holding a small packet.

Vinay said—

“Do you have fifty grams?”

“Yes.”

“Give us that.”

Sudha said nothing.

Half a kilo of sugar remained on the list.

Sudha said—

“Cross this out.”

Vinay asked—

“Why?”

“There is jaggery at home.”

“In tea?”

“For two days.”

Vinay looked at the list.

“Then cross out the sugar.”

Mahesh Sah drew a line through sugar.

For the first time, one item on the list was completely crossed out.

Mahesh Sah added up all the items.

“Six hundred and forty-two.”

Vinay took seven hundred from his pocket.

Sudha said—

“How much remains?”

“Fifty-eight.”

Mahesh Sah counted out five- and ten-rupee notes and coins.

Sudha read the list once more.

“Half a litre of mustard oil.”

“Yes.”

"Half a kilo of lentils."

"Yes."

"Four kilos of rice."

Vinay said—

"Not three."

Sudha looked at him.

"Four."

They both picked up the bags.

Vinay took the bag of rice.

Sudha took the bag with the oil, lentils, salt, turmeric, soap and tea.

As they came out of the shop, Vinay said—

"We could have saved six rupees."

Sudha asked—

"Where?"

"By taking five kilos of rice."

"Then fifty-eight would not have remained."

"We would have saved more later."

"We would have had less now."

They walked some distance in silence.

Water had collected at the turn in the lane.

Vinay shifted the bag of rice to his other hand.

"You look at everything in little pieces."

Sudha said—

"And you look at everything in big ones."

"Five kilos isn't big."

"Does soap seem small?"

Vinay did not answer.

Sudha went on—

"Matches?"

"Very small."

"Salt?"

"Small."

"Turmeric?"

"Small."

There was a faint laugh in Vinay's voice.

Sudha said—

"How long will the big sack last without all these little things?"

This time Vinay did not laugh.

He said—

“And how long will the little things last without the big sack?”

Sudha did not answer.

When they reached home, they put the groceries in the kitchen.

Sudha poured the rice into the tin.

With four kilos in it, the tin was more than half full.

Vinay said—

“See? Five kilos would have fitted too.”

Sudha placed the half-litre bottle of oil on the shelf.

“This fitted too.”

Vinay looked at her.

A faint smile appeared on both their faces at the same time.

Then Sudha took out the soap.

She looked at the cuff of Vinay’s blue shirt.

“I’ll soak this today itself.”

Vinay said—

“Do it tomorrow. You have sewing today.”

“The machine oil on the cuff will set.”

“Then today.”

Sudha went to fill a bucket with water.

Vinay sat at the table.

Mahesh Sah’s list was still in his pocket.

He took it out and smoothed it flat.

Small figures stood beside the prices.

On the rice line, first there was five.

Then Sudha’s four beside it.

Half written over the one for lentils.

Half instead of one litre of oil.

A straight line through sugar.

Tea leaves: fifty grams.

Beside soap, Mahesh Sah had written: large.

Vinay folded the list again.

Sudha returned carrying the bucket.

“Give me the list.”

“Why?”

“I’ll write the calculation for next time.”

Vinay gave her the slip.

Sudha looked at the back.

There was empty space.
She picked up a pencil.
She wrote—
“Friday: rice?”
Vinay said—
“Why the question mark?”
“We’ll see how much is left.”
“There will be three kilos.”
“There are four now.”
“One kilo in two days?”
“Sometimes more gets cooked.”
Vinay said nothing.
Sudha wrote a second line—
“Oil?”
Vinay said—
“That’s a question too?”
“Yes.”
“Lentils?”
“That too.”
Vinay took the pencil.
On the back of the list he wrote a third line—
“No soap.”
Sudha looked at him.
“Why?”
“We bought the large one today. We won’t need it on Friday.”
Sudha laughed.
“All right.”
Vinay wrote a fourth line—
“Check tea.”
Sudha said—
“Put a question mark there too.”
Vinay added a question mark.
In the afternoon Vinay left for work.
Sudha sat at her sewing.
The blue shirt was soaking in the bucket.
The half-litre bottle of oil stood on the kitchen shelf.
Four kilos of rice in the tin.
Half a kilo of lentils in the small tin.

Fifty grams of tea leaves.
A new matchbox beside the stove.
In the evening Sudha looked at the slip once more.
Prices were on the front.
Question marks on the back.
She tucked the slip beneath the sugar tin.
At half past ten that night Vinay returned.
The shirt had been washed and hung on the clothesline to dry.
Sudha had made tea for him.
There was no sugar in the cup.
A little jaggery had been dissolved in it.
Vinay took a sip and paused.
“Jaggery?”
“For two days.”
Vinay drank again.
“It will do.”
Sudha made half a cup for herself.
They sat on opposite sides of the table.
Vinay asked—
“Is there money for vegetables tomorrow?”
Sudha said—
“Twenty out of the fifty-eight.”
“Milk?”
“Set aside separately.”
“Bus?”
“That too.”
Vinay nodded.
After a while he said—
“On Friday, let’s not buy five kilos.”
Sudha put down her cup.
“Then?”
“We’ll look at the list first.”
Sudha looked toward the sugar tin.
“There are too many question marks on the list.”
“That’s good. We’ll answer them when the money comes.”
Sudha smiled.
Vinay finished his tea.
Their handwriting on that small slip was still different.

But for the next purchase, both of them had left the same empty space on the back.

The Old Mattress

On Friday morning, while Renu was gathering the sheet, her hand once again caught on the bulge in the middle of the mattress.

The cotton inside had shifted toward one side.

Both sides had sunk.

In the middle rose a narrow ridge like a small mountain.

Madhav was still lying there with his eyes closed.

Renu said—

“Shall we turn it over again today?”

Madhav opened his eyes.

“We turned it over last Monday.”

“Then let’s rotate it.”

“That has been done too.”

Renu stood holding the sheet in her hands.

Madhav sat up.

He pressed a corner of the mattress.

The lump of cotton shifted inside.

“This won’t do anymore.”

Renu said—

“You’ve been saying the same thing for six months.”

Madhav did not laugh.

He lifted the corner at the foot of the mattress.

The wooden slat below was visible.

“Let’s buy a new mattress.”

Renu looked at him.

“This month?”

“This month.”

“What about repairing the awning?”

“Next month.”

“The previous electricity bill?”

“I’ll pay that today.”

Renu folded the sheet and placed it on the chair.

“All right.”

Madhav said—

“We’ll go to the shop in the afternoon.”

Renu said again—

“All right.”

The answer was the same both times.

The tone was different.

That afternoon they went to the mattress shop on the main road.

Outside the shop, two white mattresses stood one against the other.

Inside, mattresses wrapped in thin transparent covers were stacked along the wall.

The shopkeeper, Umesh, asked them both to sit.

“What size?”

Madhav said—

“Four and a half by six feet.”

Renu said—

“It’s an old wooden cot.”

Umesh asked—

“Standard size or custom size?”

Madhav said—

“Standard.”

Renu looked at him.

“It would be better to measure first.”

Madhav said—

“For twenty years that same cot has had a four-and-a-half-by-six-foot mattress.”

Renu said quietly—

“It was a cotton mattress. It adjusts its own shape.”

Umesh picked up a measuring tape.

“If the cot is old, my boy can come and measure it.”

Madhav said—

“Is that really necessary?”

“A standard mattress cannot be cut. If it is too small, there will be a gap; if it is too large, it will bend.”

Renu said—

“Let it be measured.”

Madhav remained silent.

Umesh wrote their address on a slip.

“The boy will come by evening.”

On the way home, Madhav kept saying—

“We came to buy a mattress, and now a whole measuring operation has begun.”

Renu said—

“Do you stitch clothes without taking measurements?”

“A mattress is not a piece of clothing.”

“And a cot is not a notebook in which every page is the same size.”

Madhav looked at her.

Renu kept looking at the road.

At five in the evening, Umesh’s nephew Nandu arrived.

A measuring tape and a small notebook hung from his shoulder.

Renu removed the sheet from the cot.

Madhav gripped the mattress and dragged it out to the veranda.

The moment the mattress was set on the floor, one corner curled upward on its own.

Nandu burst out laughing.

“This mattress doesn’t want to leave the cot.”

Madhav looked at him.

Nandu immediately fell silent.

He opened the measuring tape.

First he measured the width at the head.

“Fifty-six inches.”

Madhav said—

“That sounds right.”

He measured at the foot.

He stopped.

Then measured again.

“Fifty-two and a half.”

Renu looked at Madhav.

Madhav said—

“The tape is crooked.”

Nandu measured again.

“Fifty-two and a half.”

In the middle, the width came to fifty-four.

The length was seventy-two inches on one side.

On the other, seventy-two and three-quarters.

Nandu kept writing in his notebook.

Madhav stood beside the cot.

“How did the cot become so crooked?”

Renu said—

“It didn’t become crooked all at once. It became this way over time.”

Madhav turned toward her.

Renu placed her hand on the right slat at the foot of the cot.

“This isn’t the original slat.”

Madhav looked at it.

The colour of the wood was indeed different.

“When was it changed?”

Renu asked—

“Don’t you remember?”

Madhav looked at it for a while.

“After the flood?”

“Yes. When we left the last house.”

Nandu was winding up the measuring tape.

Renu pointed to the other foot.

“This leg was shortened.”

Madhav said—

“The floor in our first rented house sloped.”

“Yes.”

There was an iron plate fixed to the upper left corner.

Madhav touched it.

“Father had fitted this.”

Renu said—

“When Kajal was born.”

Nandu closed his notebook.

“A standard mattress won’t fit properly.”

Madhav asked—

“Custom size?”

“It can be made. But it will cost more.”

“How much?”

Nandu gave an approximate figure.

Madhav’s brows tightened.

Renu asked—

“What if the cot is straightened?”

Nandu said—

"A carpenter will have to see it. He can say how straight it can be made."

Madhav immediately said—

"What if we buy a new cot?"

Renu fell silent.

Nandu looked at both of them.

"We sell cots at the shop too."

Madhav said—

"I've seen them."

Renu said to Nandu—

"Just give us the measurements. We'll decide the rest."

Nandu left.

The old mattress lay in the veranda.

The cot was empty.

On the bare cot, every joint was clearly visible.

Madhav ran his hand from one side to the other.

"What is the point of keeping this cot now?"

Renu asked—

"What is wrong with it?"

"One corner is three and a half inches different from the other."

"But it still isn't broken."

"Does everything have to be broken before it is replaced?"

Renu did not answer.

She kept looking at the old stitching on the mattress cover.

Madhav said—

"We're replacing the mattress. Let's replace the cot too."

Renu said—

"If we replace both together, the awning repair will be postponed again."

"The awning can wait two weeks."

"Last month the fan was postponed by the same two weeks."

"Then what do we do? Stay clinging to every old thing?"

Renu lifted her head.

"Am I clinging to old things?"

Madhav did not answer at once.

Outside the door, the milkman stopped his bicycle.

Renu took a vessel and went out.

Madhav sat on the empty cot.

The cot creaked softly.
He stood up again.
The subject returned over dinner that night.
Stirring salt into his lentils, Madhav said—
“The shopkeeper will give a discount on the larger cot.”
Renu continued serving rice.
“How much?”
Madhav told her the amount.
Renu calculated silently.
“With the mattress?”
Madhav gave another figure.
Renu said nothing.
Madhav said—
“The payment can be spread over six months.”
“How many months?”
“Six.”
“What about Kajal’s course fee?”
“That’s next month.”
“And the first instalment of this divided payment?”
Madhav put down his spoon.
“Renu, there will always be one expense or another.”
“That is exactly what I’m saying.”
“Then?”
“Then replace what is necessary. Why replace what still works?”
Madhav made something like a laugh.
“I’ve been hearing that sentence for twenty years.”
Renu stopped her hand.
“What sentence?”
“It still works.”
Renu fell silent.
Madhav continued—
“The stove in the first house—it still works.”
“It did work.”
“The old cupboard—it still works.”
“It still does.”
“The bicycle?”
“You’re the one who insisted on keeping that.”
Madhav stopped.

For the first time, a faint smile appeared on Renu's face.

But it disappeared at once.

Madhav said—

"I'm saying that sometimes we have to make room for new things too."

Renu asked—

"How is room made?"

"The old goes out."

"All old things?"

"Whatever is in the way."

"Is the cot in the way?"

"The mattress won't fit it properly."

"Then fix the cot."

"More joints, more plates, more cutting and trimming."

Renu took her hand away from her plate.

"Do you have a problem with joints?"

Madhav looked at her.

"I didn't say that."

"But you are saying it."

"I'm only talking about the cot."

Renu said quietly—

"So am I."

That night they did not sleep on the cot.

The mattress was in the veranda.

Renu spread two old mats on the floor of the room.

She folded two thin quilts over them.

Madhav said—

"Let's bring the mattress inside."

"It's heavy. We'll see in the morning."

They both lay down on the floor.

The fan turned slowly.

Madhav shifted onto his side.

The floor was hard.

Renu asked—

"Can't you sleep?"

"And you?"

"No."

There was silence for a while.

Madhav said—

“Do you remember the first year?”

Renu said—

“What?”

“The room in Jayanagar.”

“The one with the tin roof in Jeth?”

“Yes.”

“We didn’t even have a cot there.”

“Three months.”

“Four.”

“Three.”

“We stayed until Sawan.”

Madhav fell silent.

Renu said—

“Four.”

Madhav laughed.

“All right, four.”

Silence again.

Madhav asked—

“Do you remember everything?”

Renu said—

“No.”

“Then all this?”

“Things that keep becoming useful stay in memory.”

Madhav closed his eyes.

“Remembering that a slat of the cot was changed became useful?”

“It did today.”

Madhav laughed again.

This time Renu did too.

After a while Renu said—

“What you’re saying isn’t entirely wrong either.”

Madhav opened his eyes.

“What?”

“It isn’t right to keep putting everything off by saying, ‘It still works.’”

Madhav waited for her to continue.

Renu went on—

“But it isn’t right to throw everything away the moment we say ‘new’ either.”

Madhav said—

“I’m not saying we should throw everything away.”

“The cot?”

“The cot...”

He paused.

“We’ll look at the cot.”

Renu turned onto her side.

“We’ll see.”

At dawn, as soon as Madhav got up, he went to the veranda.

The old mattress was cold from the night’s dampness.

He stood it upright against the wall.

The cot was bare again.

He brought the measuring tape.

Fifty-six at the head.

Fifty-four in the middle.

Fifty-two and a half at the foot.

He measured both lengths again.

The same difference.

Renu came with tea.

“So the tape was right?”

Madhav said—

“It was right.”

Renu handed him the cup.

Madhav bent beneath the cot.

A joint in the replacement slat at the foot was sticking out.

He pressed it with his hand.

The slat moved slightly.

“This is loose.”

Renu bent down too.

“For a long time?”

“I don’t know.”

Renu said—

“Call a carpenter.”

Madhav said—

“I will.”

At ten, Satyanarayan, the neighbourhood carpenter, arrived.

He turned the cot over.
He examined all four legs.
He tapped the joints.
He measured with the tape.
“The whole cot does not need replacing.”
Madhav asked—
“Can it be straightened?”
Satyanarayan said—
“As much as the wood allows.”
Renu asked—
“Can it be made the same size throughout?”
“To make it exactly the same, I would have to open the head slat too.
That wood is good. Why open it?”
Madhav said nothing.
Satyanarayan pointed to the replacement slat at the foot.
“This one was fitted short. They must have used whatever was available
at the time.”
Renu said—
“After the flood.”
“Then that explains it.”
Satyanarayan wrote two options in his notebook.
One—repair only the loose joint.
Two—replace the foot slat and bring the width closer to even.
He wrote the cost of each separately.
Madhav looked at the second figure.
“So little?”
Satyanarayan laughed.
“If I sold cots, I would have quoted more.”
Renu laughed.
Madhav smiled too.
“Do the second one.”
Renu looked at him.
“You won’t open the head slat?”
Madhav said—
“Why touch what doesn’t need touching?”
Renu said nothing.
Satyanarayan began work.
By noon, the foot slat had been replaced.

The cot stood upright again.

The original measurements Nandu had written down were taken again.

The head remained fifty-six.

The foot was now fifty-five and a half.

The middle was fifty-five and three-quarters.

There was still a half-inch difference in the length.

Satyanarayan said—

“It’s old wood. This is as good as it can be.”

Madhav looked at the measurements.

Renu asked—

“A standard mattress?”

Madhav said—

“Maybe.”

Satyanarayan shook his head.

“There will be a gap.”

Renu said—

“Custom size.”

Madhav remained silent for a few moments.

“Custom size.”

That afternoon they went back to Umesh’s shop.

Umesh looked at the new measurements.

“The difference is much smaller now.”

Madhav said—

“What about the standard one?”

Umesh said—

“It will fit. But there will be a half-inch gap at the foot.”

Renu asked—

“And custom size?”

“It will fit exactly. It will take seven days.”

Madhav asked the price.

The price was lower than the first estimate.

There was no longer any need to buy a new cot.

Madhav stood holding the order slip.

Umesh asked—

“Would you like to mix in the cotton from the old mattress? Some people mix old cotton with the new. It brings the cost down.”

Renu thought of the old mattress.

The bulge in the middle.
The hollows on both sides.
The cover that had been stitched three times.
She looked at Madhav.
Madhav asked—
“What do you think?”
Renu said—
“No.”
Umesh asked—
“No old cotton?”
“No. A new mattress with new cotton.”
Madhav signed the order slip.
“Can the old cotton be made into pillows?”
Umesh said—
“It can.”
Renu said—
“Not two. Four small cushions.”
Madhav looked at her.
“Four?”
“For the veranda.”
“All right.”
Umesh wrote on the slip—four small cushions.
For seven days, the old mattress went back onto the cot.
But because of the new foot slat, its old shape no longer fit properly.
The cotton rose outward along one side.
Twice each night Madhav pushed it back into place.
Renu said—
“Now the cot no longer fits the mattress.”
Madhav said—
“The mattress no longer fits the cot.”
They looked at each other.
Then both burst out laughing.
On the seventh day, the new mattress arrived.
Nandu and another boy carried it inside.
The mattress was placed on the cot.
It fit properly at the head.
The corners at the foot sat well too.
A narrow gap still remained near the right foot.

Nandu said—

“It’s an old cot. This much will remain.”

Madhav put a finger into the gap to check it.

Renu said nothing.

Madhav withdrew his finger.

“Give me the sheet.”

Renu opened the new sheet.

Together they pressed down all four corners and fitted the sheet over the mattress.

There was no bulge in the middle.

There were no hollows on either side.

The surface was even.

That night Madhav slept on his old side.

Renu on hers.

There was space left in the middle.

The fan kept turning.

After a while Renu changed sides.

The mattress sank slightly.

Madhav’s side barely moved.

Madhav asked—

“Sleepy?”

Renu said—

“It’s coming.”

“Not too firm?”

“No.”

After a while Renu asked—

“Your back?”

“Fine.”

Silence again.

In the veranda, four small cushions made from the cotton of the old mattress were stacked one on top of another.

The cot was still not perfectly rectangular.

But the new mattress had not been bent or forced down anywhere.

Once in his sleep, Madhav shifted toward the middle.

Renu did too.

The level space between them did not remain empty.

The Doorbell

On Monday evening, Govind Babu said that a family would come to see the house that night.

Shyamanand was returning from the shop at the time.

Taking the phone away from his ear, he rested a hand on the iron railing of the veranda.

“Tonight?”

“Yes. They’re coming by train.”

“What time?”

“Hard to say.”

Govind Babu added,

“They’ll ring the bell. Just show them the place.”

Shyamanand was silent for a moment.

“We’re still living here.”

“I know.”

“There are still three months left.”

“I know.”

The conversation ended there.

Shyamanand went inside the house.

Kamala was taking the rice off the stove in the kitchen.

Nilima had her history notebook open on the table.

Anshu was racing two wooden cars across the floor.

Shyamanand took off his shoes and left them by the door.

Kamala merely looked at his face.

“He said it again?”

“Some people are coming to see the house tonight.”

Nilima’s pen stopped.

Anshu did not stop his cars.

Kamala asked,

“When?”

“They’re coming by train. There’s no fixed time.”

Kamala turned toward the stove.
Steam continued to rise from the rice.
Shyamanand said,
“Govind Babu says they’ll ring the bell.”
Nilima did not close her notebook.
She only straightened the pen lying across the page.
Kamala put the lid on the rice.
“Shall we eat first?”
Shyamanand looked around.
Anshu’s school shoes lay in the veranda.
Kamala’s sari was drying over the back of a chair.
Nilima’s bag hung from a nail in the wall.
Two buckets stood near the window.
“Let’s tidy up a little.”
Kamala did not smile.
“Are they coming to see the house, or to see whether no one lives in it?”
Shyamanand did not answer.
Nilima got up.
She took down her bag and put it in her room.
Anshu asked,
“My cars?”
“Put them in the box.”
“Why?”
“People are coming.”
“Will they look at my cars?”
“No.”
“Then why should I put them away?”
Kamala said,
“Put them away. You can take them out again later.”
Anshu picked up both cars and placed them on top of the box.
The box was not closed.
Kamala took down the sari from the veranda.
She pushed the basket of potatoes farther into the kitchen corner.
Nilima picked up three notebooks from the table.
She left the history notebook behind.
Then she picked that up too.
Shyamanand straightened the old umbrella hanging behind the door.

Kamala watched him.

"Is the umbrella a fault in the house too?"

Shyamanand withdrew his hand.

"No."

The evening light slowly faded.

In the two-room house, things left their usual places and moved into temporary ones.

Nilima's books did not go into the box.

They slid under the bed.

Anshu's cars went from the top of the box to inside it.

Kamala's grinding stone moved a handspan back from the kitchen doorway.

Shyamanand's bundle of old newspapers was pushed under the cot.

At seven-thirty, Kamala asked,

"Dinner?"

Shyamanand looked at the clock.

"Let's eat."

He took out four plates.

Then stopped again.

"What if they arrive while we're eating?"

Kamala said,

"They're coming to see the house, not count our rice."

Even so, she took the pot of dal off the stove and put it inside.

All four ate quickly.

Anshu left half his rice.

Kamala picked up his plate.

Nilima looked toward the door as she drank water.

The bell was silent.

At eight, Shyamanand switched on the veranda light.

Govind Babu had said the outside staircase was poorly lit.

Shyamanand tried to make the light from his own home reach as far as the stairs.

At eight-twenty, Anshu yawned.

"Can I sleep?"

Kamala stroked his head.

"Sit for a little while."

"When will the people come?"

"Don't know."

“Where will we live?”

“Where?”

“When this house belongs to someone else.”

Kamala’s hand stopped.

Shyamanand looked toward the window.

Nilima said nothing.

Anshu asked again,

“Will my school become far away?”

Shyamanand said,

“We haven’t decided on any place yet.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means we don’t know yet.”

Anshu was not satisfied with the answer.

But he did not ask again.

At eight-forty, the bell rang.

Once.

All four looked toward the door at the same time.

Shyamanand got up at once.

Kamala adjusted the end of her sari.

Nilima looked at the books under the bed, then looked away.

Anshu put a hand on the lid of the box.

Shyamanand opened the door.

No one was outside.

The stairwell light was on.

The door on the floor below was closed.

From above came the sound of a water pump.

Shyamanand went down one flight of stairs and looked.

There was no sound of footsteps.

He looked upward again.

No one.

Kamala asked from inside,

“Who is it?”

“No one.”

“Maybe they went downstairs.”

“Why?”

“To fetch their luggage.”

Shyamanand stood on the stairs for a few moments.

Then he went back inside.

He did not shut the door completely.
He only set the latch loosely in place.
Anshu asked,
“Was it a ghost?”
Nilima glared at him.
“Quiet.”
Shyamanand said,
“It must have been the wrong bell.”
Kamala said,
“If that was the wrong bell, the right bell will ring now.”
They all sat down again.
No bell rang until nine.
Shyamanand checked his phone.
There was no new message from Govind Babu.
He thought of calling him.
Then did not.
Kamala understood.
“Ask him.”
“They must be on the way.”
“Then what is there to lose by asking?”
Shyamanand turned off the glow of the phone screen.
“He said the time isn’t fixed.”
Nilima wanted to take out her history notebook again.
She reached under the bed.
Then she stopped, not because she feared the bell, but because she
laughed at herself.
“What happened?” Kamala asked.
“Nothing.”
“Take out your notebook.”
“What if the people arrive?”
Kamala said,
“They won’t reduce the rent because they see a notebook.”
Nilima took out the notebook.
She did not place it on the table.
She kept it in her lap and began to read.
Anshu sprawled on the cot.
Kamala straightened him.
“Not here. Inside.”

“Will the people see me sleeping?”

Kamala paused before answering.

“Yes. And what if they do?”

“Then let me sleep.”

Kamala took him to the cot in the inner room.

But the bedding had not been laid out completely.

While cleaning in the morning, the sheet on the mattress had been folded away.

Kamala unfolded the sheet.

Then looked toward the door.

Then spread the sheet over the bed.

Anshu did not fall asleep within five minutes.

He lay with his eyes closed, waiting for the bell.

At nine-thirty, Shyamanand finally called Govind Babu.

The phone rang.

No answer.

He called a second time.

No answer.

Kamala said,

“The people aren’t coming to see his house.”

Shyamanand put the phone on the table.

Nilima kept her eyes on the notebook.

After a while she asked,

“How much is he raising the rent?”

Kamala looked at Shyamanand.

Shyamanand said,

“Eight thousand five hundred.”

Nilima looked up from the notebook.

“And now?”

“Seven thousand.”

“Fifteen hundred more?”

“Yes.”

Kamala added,

“And electricity separate.”

Nilima was quiet for a while.

“Then we won’t be able to stay?”

Shyamanand said,

“We’ll see.”

This time Kamala did not remain silent.
“For three months I’ve been hearing ‘we’ll see.’”
Shyamanand rubbed his palm over his knee.
“I’m looking for a place.”
“Where?”
Shyamanand did not answer at once.
Nilima closed her notebook.
“Where?”
“I saw a house behind the bus stand.”
Kamala heard this for the first time.
“When?”
“Saturday.”
“Why didn’t you tell me?”
“It wasn’t right.”
“What was wrong with it?”
“Only one room.”
Kamala looked at the wall.
This house had two rooms.
The two rooms were small.
But until now, there had been two.
“Rent?”
“Six thousand two hundred.”
“Water?”
“Two hours in the morning.”
Kamala fell silent again.
Nilima asked,
“From school?”
“You’d have to change buses.”
Nilima rested a hand on her history notebook.
“Can we stay here until my exams?”
Shyamanand said,
“We’ll try.”
Kamala said softly,
“My exams won’t be over in three months.”
Shyamanand’s eyes shifted to the door.
The bell was silent.
At ten, someone on the floor above dragged a bucket.
For a moment all four became alert again.

Anshu called from inside,
“The bell?”
Kamala said,
“No. Sleep.”
Nilima opened her notebook again.
This time she was not reading.
She merely kept the page open.
Kamala went into the kitchen.
She brought out the pot of leftover dal.
She lifted the lid.
Then put it back.
“Shall I make tea?”
Shyamanand said,
“Make it.”
Kamala took out three cups instead of two.
Nilima said,
“For me too?”
“Will sleep come now?”
“What sleep is left now?”
Kamala made three cups of tea.
She warmed milk for Anshu.
Half asleep, Anshu came outside.
“The people didn’t come?”
“No.”
He took the glass of milk and sat on the chair.
“Can I take out my cars?”
Shyamanand said,
“Take them out.”
Kamala immediately said,
“Leave them for now.”
Anshu looked at both of them.
Then he did not take out the cars.
At ten-forty-five, Kamala said,
“I’ve heard of a place too.”
Shyamanand put down his cup.
“Where?”
“Behind the dispensary.”
“Whose?”

"Sarita, the vegetable seller, told me."

"How much rent?"

"Five thousand eight hundred."

Shyamanand frowned.

"That little?"

"There's a drain behind it."

"Rooms?"

"Two. But one is very small."

"Water?"

"A hand pump in the courtyard."

Shyamanand said nothing.

Nilima asked,

"How far from school?"

Kamala said,

"Twenty minutes on foot."

For the first time Nilima looked closely at her mother's face.

"Did you go to see it?"

Kamala got up to wash the tea cups.

"Only from outside."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Kamala let water run over the cup.

"It wasn't right."

Shyamanand laughed lightly.

The laugh ended at once.

"Each of us has found one bad house."

Kamala turned and looked at him.

"A good house has a good rent."

Nilima said,

"I know one place that seems good to me."

Both parents looked at her.

"Where?"

"Shyama Didi's aunt's house behind the school."

Kamala was startled.

"When did you ask?"

"I didn't ask."

"Then?"

"She said the upstairs room would be vacant."

Shyamanand asked,

“Rent?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then how is it good?”

“It’s near the school.”

This time Kamala smiled.

“Good means something different to everyone.”

Nilima smiled faintly too.

Shyamanand did not smile.

He checked his phone again.

Govind Babu still had not replied.

At eleven, the street outside began to grow quiet.

The last clatter from the tea stall stopped.

Two motorcycles passed.

A dog barked.

The bell did not ring.

Kamala said,

“Shall we close the door?”

Shyamanand looked at the loosely set latch.

“What if they arrive?”

“There’s a bell.”

“Yes.”

He closed the door and fastened the latch.

Anshu went inside again.

This time he took his cars with him.

Kamala did not stop him.

Nilima placed her history notebook on the table.

She did not hide it again.

At eleven-thirty, Kamala hung up the old cloth.

On the back of the chair that had been cleared in the evening.

Shyamanand saw it.

He said nothing.

At midnight, all four were still awake.

Anshu opened his eyes from time to time.

Nilima gave up pretending to read and sat by the window.

Kamala kept folding and unfolding a sheet.

A small slip of paper lay in front of Shyamanand.

The monthly expenses were written on it.

Rent — 7,000.

Electricity — about 900.
School bus — 1,100.
Groceries — however much they cut back, never little enough.
Shyamanand crossed out 7,000 and wrote 8,500.
Then added the total.
Then folded the slip.
Kamala asked,
“How much are we short?”
“Don’t ask.”
“That’s why I’m asking.”
Shyamanand opened the slip.
“More than two thousand.”
Kamala said,
“I can take in more sewing again.”
“Until night?”
“During the day.”
“And the housework during the day?”
Kamala did not answer.
Nilima said,
“I can stop taking the bus.”
Shyamanand answered at once,
“No.”
“I’ll go by bicycle.”
“It’s a long way.”
“Not every day.”
Kamala looked at Nilima.
Nilima lowered her eyes.
From inside Anshu said,
“I’ll stop drinking milk?”
All three looked toward his voice.
Kamala got up and went inside.
“You sleep.”
Anshu asked,
“How much milk comes in two thousand?”
Kamala put a hand on his head.
“Your milk won’t change the house.”
“Then?”
“It’s grown-ups’ arithmetic.”

Anshu closed his eyes.

Kamala came back out.

Shyamanand had folded the slip and kept it down.

Nilima was looking out of the window.

At one in the morning, Shyamanand called Govind Babu again.

This time the phone was switched off.

He placed his phone face down on the table.

Kamala said,

“They won’t come now.”

Shyamanand said,

“The train may be late.”

“Which train?”

Shyamanand was silent.

“Did you ask?”

“No.”

Kamala laughed for the first time.

It was a tired laugh.

“We don’t even know whose train we’re waiting for.”

Nilima wanted to laugh too.

But the laugh did not come.

At one-twenty, footsteps sounded on the stairs above.

All four became alert.

The footsteps went upward.

The bell did not ring.

Shyamanand went to the door.

He did not open the latch.

Then he came back.

Kamala said,

“Shall I spread the mat in the veranda now?”

Shyamanand nodded.

Kamala took out the mat that had been pushed behind the box in the evening.

She spread it in the veranda.

The house began to recover its own shape.

Nilima put her books back on the table.

Anshu’s cars lay in one corner.

Clothes hung over the back of the chair.

The grinding stone came back beside the kitchen doorway.

Only Shyamanand's bundle of newspapers remained under the cot.

At two, Nilima said,

"If they come, what will we say?"

"What will we say?" Shyamanand asked.

"That we will leave after three months?"

"Govind Babu has told them."

"But they'll ask us."

Kamala said,

"We'll tell the truth."

Shyamanand looked up at Kamala.

Kamala added,

"That we are still living here."

Nilima asked,

"And about the rent being raised?"

Kamala paused for a while.

"If they ask, we'll tell them."

Shyamanand said quietly,

"Govind Babu won't like that."

Kamala said,

"I won't lie either."

Silence returned to the house.

This time the silence was less about waiting for the bell than about whose home would be shown when the door opened.

At two-forty-five, Nilima fell asleep with her head on her notebook.

Kamala gently pulled the notebook away and set it aside.

Shyamanand got up to switch off the veranda light.

Then did not switch it off.

"The people may come."

This time Kamala did not stop him.

At three, Shyamanand opened the slip again.

On the blank side he wrote down three places.

Behind the bus stand — 6,200.

Behind the dispensary — 5,800.

Behind the school — rent to be asked.

Kamala looked at it.

"Ask the rent for the third place first."

"Yes."

"There's no need to see the one-room place."

Shyamanand said,

“What if the other two don’t work out?”

Kamala looked at Nilima.

She had fallen asleep with her head on the table.

“Then we’ll see.”

Shyamanand smiled.

“Now you’re the one saying ‘we’ll see.’”

Kamala smiled faintly too.

“Sometimes that phrase has a use.”

By four, the street was almost completely silent.

The veranda light was still on.

Shyamanand’s eyes kept closing and opening.

Kamala sat on the mat with her back against the wall.

Nilima slept at the table.

Anshu lay stretched out on the cot inside.

The bell did not ring.

At four-thirty, Kamala got up and went into the kitchen.

She put water on to boil.

“Tea?” Shyamanand asked.

“For morning.”

“Is the night over?”

Kamala looked out of the window.

The sky was still black, but the blackness had begun to change slightly.

“It is ending.”

At five, Nilima woke.

She looked first not at the bell, but at the clock.

“They didn’t come?”

Shyamanand shook his head.

Nilima straightened her notebook.

Then asked,

“Should I go to school today?”

Kamala said,

“Why not?”

“Sleep.”

“You can sleep after you come back.”

Nilima laughed.

“At school?”

Kamala laughed too.
 It was the first easy laugh of the night.
 At five-twenty, Anshu came out.
 He had a wooden car in his hand.
 He drove it across the mat in the veranda.
 No one stopped him.
 At five-forty-five, Shyamanand's phone rang.
 It was Govind Babu.
 Shyamanand answered immediately.
 "Yes?"
 Govind Babu said,
 "That family isn't coming."
 Shyamanand said nothing.
 "They changed their mind during the night."
 "The train?"
 "Not the train. They never left home."
 Shyamanand looked at the veranda light.
 In the growing daylight, it was almost no longer needed.
 "All right."
 Govind Babu added,
 "I'll tell you when someone else wants to see it."
 Shyamanand replied,
 "All right."
 The call ended.
 Kamala asked,
 "They're not coming?"
 "No."
 Nilima asked,
 "Then who rang the bell last night?"
 Shyamanand looked toward the door.
 "Don't know."
 Anshu said at once,
 "A ghost."
 Nilima picked up his car and handed it to him.
 "Let your ghost play with the car."
 Anshu laughed.
 At six, Savitri Devi, the upstairs neighbour, was returning with milk.
 She saw Shyamanand's open door.

“Did your bell ring last night?”

Shyamanand was startled.

“Yes.”

“My nephew pressed the wrong button.”

Kamala came and stood in the kitchen doorway.

Savitri Devi said,

“It was his first time here. He didn’t look at the number.”

Laughing, she went upstairs.

Shyamanand stood for a few moments at the open door.

The entire night’s waiting had begun with one wrong button.

But the things that had come out during that waiting were not wrong.

He went back inside.

Kamala switched off the veranda light.

Nilima sat at the table with her history notebook open.

Anshu raced his car across the mat.

Kamala spread another sari over the back of the chair.

Shyamanand reached under the cot.

He pulled out the bundle of newspapers.

The slip with the monthly expenses was caught underneath it.

He opened the slip.

On the front was the calculation for the increased rent.

On the back were three possible places.

Behind the bus stand.

Behind the dispensary.

Behind the school.

Shyamanand put a small question mark beside the third line.

Then he picked up his phone and began searching for the number of Shyama Didi’s aunt.

The doorbell was silent.

All the other sounds of the house had returned to their places.

The Leftover Vegetables

After the evening meal, Nirmala Devi looked at the vegetables left at the bottom of the pan.

There were potatoes, pointed gourd, and two or three pieces of eggplant left.

She had already put out the stove.

Mahendra Babu sat on the veranda, writing down the day's accounts.

Nirmala Devi said, "So much is left."

Mahendra Babu did not raise his head.

"It will do with tomorrow morning's rice."

Nirmala Devi lifted the lid of the pan and looked again.

There was a little too much vegetable curry for the morning rice.

From the lower section of the cupboard, she took out an old steel container.

Two letters had been scratched on its lid—"M" and "R."

In earlier days, the midday meal for both brothers had gone out in that container.

For eight months, the container had hardly been used.

After the household was divided, the utensils too had been divided between them.

But no one had been able to decide which side this container belonged to.

Nirmala Devi put the leftover vegetables in it and closed the lid.

"I'll warm it in the morning," she said.

Mahendra Babu said, "Hmm," and remained bent over his notebook.

The courtyard was still one.

But on the northern side stood Mahendra Babu's cooking hearth, and on the southern side, Ramesh's.

Between them stood the old tulsi platform.

No one had ever discussed whose share the tulsi platform belonged to.

Their mother Saraswati Devi's room stood just behind it.

For that reason, her room too did not fall cleanly into either share.

On the day the house was divided, all this had seemed convenient to everyone.

Eight months later, that same convenience repeatedly turned into inconvenience.

When Nirmala Devi rose in the morning, the container of last night's vegetables was no longer where she had left it.

At first she thought Mahendra Babu might have taken it outside.

But Mahendra Babu had not even gone to bathe yet.

"Where is the container?"

"Which container?"

"The one with last night's vegetables."

Mahendra Babu looked inside from the veranda.

"I didn't touch it."

Nirmala Devi looked all around the stove.

She looked beneath the brass plate.

She looked beside the water pitcher.

The container was not there.

Saraswati Devi came out of her room.

In her hand was Ramesh's old cloth lunch bag.

"I put it in this," she said casually.

Nirmala Devi looked at her.

"Whose?"

"In Ramesh's bag."

"Why?"

Saraswati Devi paused a little.

"It was empty in the morning. The container was lying there. I thought it was food."

Nirmala Devi's hand stopped.

Mahendra Babu closed his notebook.

Ramesh had already left through the southern door.

He worked at a seed shop in town.

He carried his lunch from home.

For eight months now, his bag had been separate, his containers separate, even his route almost separate.

Their mother still sometimes moved things according to the old routine.

This was not the first time.

But this time, the thing she had moved was food.

Nirmala Devi said, "Ma, you could have asked."

Saraswati Devi looked at the empty space in the bag.

"What was there to ask? It was leftover vegetables."

"I had kept it for the morning."

"Then make something else."

Nirmala Devi did not reply.

Mahendra Babu said softly, "Let it be."

"What did I say?"

"Nothing."

On the southern side, Bina had put lentils on the stove.

She had heard everything.

But she did not come outside.

Her son Sonu was buttoning his school shirt.

He asked, "Did Baba take my lunch box today?"

Bina said, "He took his own bag."

"But my blue box is here."

Bina said nothing.

At midday, Ramesh opened his lunch bag in the back room of the seed shop.

First came out the small container of rice.

Then the old steel container.

The moment he saw the "M" and "R" on the lid, his hand stopped.

He had not seen those two letters together for eight months.

He opened the container.

The smell of potato and pointed gourd rose from it.

He understood at once that Bina had not cooked this.

Nirmala always used a little more fenugreek seed in her vegetables.

Ramesh put the lid back on.

The shop owner, Harinarayan Sah, said, "Aren't you going to eat?"

"I will."

"Is the vegetable curry bad?"

"No."

Ramesh opened the container again.

He ate half the vegetables with his rice.

He left the other half.

That was not his habit.

He did not like wasting food.

But that day, emptying the container completely felt strange to him.

When he returned in the evening, he washed the container beside the tap.

Bina noticed it.

"Where did this come from?"

"Ma put it in my bag."

"What was in it?"

"Vegetables."

"Whose?"

Ramesh turned off the tap.

"From the north side."

Bina looked at the container for a few moments.

"Did you eat it?"

"Half."

"Why only half?"

Ramesh did not answer.

After washing it, he placed the container on the low platform in the middle of the courtyard.

Neither on the northern veranda nor beside the southern hearth.

Right in front of the tulsi platform.

When Nirmala Devi came to fill water in the evening, she saw the container.

The lid had been placed separately.

A single drop of water gleamed inside.

She did not pick it up.

Rice was cooked that night.

Nirmala Devi made fresh vegetables.

Bina too had cooked pumpkin and chickpeas in her own kitchen.

Saraswati Devi first sat down by the northern hearth.

Nirmala gave her a plate.

After two mouthfuls, she got up.

“Why are you eating so little?” Nirmala asked.

“I’m not hungry.”

“What did you eat at noon?”

Saraswati Devi did not answer.

On the southern side, Bina too had set a plate for Saraswati Devi.

When she reached there, the mother ate two more mouthfuls.

Sonu laughed and said, “Grandmother, you eat twice.”

Bina immediately hushed him.

Saraswati Devi kept looking at her plate.

“Not twice,” she said, “in two places.”

It was a small sentence.

But Bina’s hand stopped while serving the food.

The next morning, the container was still on the low platform by the tulsi shrine.

The night dew had chilled its lid.

Saraswati Devi picked it up and took it into her own room.

No one said anything.

Three days later, Saraswati Devi became dizzy.

At midday, while sitting near the doorway of her room, she slipped to the floor.

Sonu saw her first.

He shouted for Bina.

Bina came running.

Nirmala too left the northern hearth and ran over.

Mahendra Babu was not at home then.

Ramesh was at the shop.

Bina placed the mother's head in her lap.

Nirmala brought water.

Saraswati Devi's eyes were open, but her face had gone pale.

"Have you eaten anything?" Nirmala asked.

"In the morning."

"What?"

"Flattened rice."

"At noon?"

The mother was silent.

Bina asked, "You didn't come to me."

Nirmala said, "Nor to me."

They took their mother to the clinic.

The doctor said it was not safe to take medicine while going hungry.

Her blood sugar had fallen very low.

Two hours later she returned home.

Mahendra Babu and Ramesh had both arrived.

That evening, for the first time, all four of them sat together in one room for so long.

Mahendra Babu asked, "Where does Ma eat lunch?"

Nirmala said, "Sometimes here."

Bina said, "Sometimes there."

Ramesh looked at his mother.

"And sometimes nowhere?"

Saraswati Devi rested her head against the pillow.

"Whichever side I go to, the other side assumes I am eating there."

"Did any of us say that?" Bina asked.

"It does not have to be said."

For a while, only the sound of the fan remained in the room.

Mahendra Babu said, "Then let us fix a time."

Ramesh immediately asked, "At whose place?"

Mahendra Babu looked at him.

The sound of their old quarrel had entered that question.

Nirmala quickly said, "Not whose place. Fix the meal."

Bina too nodded silently.

From the next day, it was decided that Saraswati Devi's midday meal would be cooked only once.

A weekly schedule was written down showing which hearth would cook on which day.

Monday, Wednesday, Friday: north.

Tuesday, Thursday, Saturday: south.

On Sunday, whichever side found it convenient.

Saraswati Devi looked at the paper.

"There will be another quarrel on Sunday," she said.

Sonu burst out laughing.

Mahendra Babu too gave a faint smile.

For the first time in eight months, Ramesh looked at his brother and laughed.

On the first Monday, Nirmala cooked rice, moong dal, and bottle gourd for Saraswati Devi.

A little was left over.

She thought she would keep it for the night.

Then Saraswati Devi said, "Put it in the container."

"Which one?"

"The M-R one."

Nirmala paused slightly.

The container was now on the shelf in the mother's room.

She took it down and put the food inside.

On Tuesday, Bina cooked her own midday meal.

A little of yesterday's bottle gourd was still in the container.

She opened the lid and looked at it.

Instead of throwing it away, she warmed it and fed Saraswati Devi that first.

Then she served the dal and rice she had cooked herself.

In the evening, she washed the container and returned it to the shelf.

In this way, the container began to live in the mother's room.

It no longer bore the name of either kitchen.

Whatever little remained was put into it.

At her next meal, the mother ate the leftovers first.

Less food began to be wasted.
But the real change was in where the container belonged.
It belonged neither to the north nor to the south.

Two weeks later, it rained.

Water began to drip from the roof over the southern hearth.
Bina placed a bucket beneath it.
When Ramesh returned in the evening, he examined the bamboo slat.
“This part is joined to Mahendra’s wall,” he said.
Bina replied, “Water does not read walls.”
Ramesh said nothing.

That night, Mahendra Babu stood on his veranda looking at the roof.

Ramesh came into the middle of the courtyard.
“Shall we call the mason tomorrow?”

Mahendra Babu asked, “How much will it cost?”

“We’ll know after he sees it.”

“Half and half?”

Ramesh did not answer at once.

“Where the joint is shared, half and half.”

Mahendra Babu nodded.

It was the same sentence neither of them had been willing to accept eight months earlier.

The mason came the next day.

He opened the bamboo roofing and examined it.
An old beam rested across the walls of both sides.
“If this has to come out, both sides will have to be opened,” he said.
Mahendra Babu and Ramesh looked at each other.
Neither said “mine” nor “yours.”

The mason worked through the afternoon.

Nirmala cooked rice.

Bina made chokha.

Saraswati Devi said, “Set a plate for the mason too.”

Nirmala asked, “From whose kitchen?”

The mother pointed toward the container.

“First take out the leftover vegetables.”

Bina laughed.

“Those are mine from yesterday.”

Nirmala said, “Today’s dal is mine.”

Saraswati Devi said, “The plate is the mason’s.”

All four did not laugh at once.

But the air in the room grew a little lighter.

The mason worked until evening.

The two brothers stood beneath the roof.

Sometimes holding a bamboo pole, sometimes a rope.

When the work was done, Ramesh took out the money.

Mahendra Babu paid the other half.

Neither opened the old accounts.

That night, potato and pointed gourd were cooked on the northern hearth.

Pumpkin and chickpeas were cooked on the southern hearth.

The two households still ate separately.

No one said that from now on there would be one kitchen.

No one said the old quarrel was over either.

After the meal, Nirmala saw that a little potato and pointed gourd remained.

She went to the mother’s room to look for the old steel container.

It was not on the shelf.

“Where has it gone?”

Saraswati Devi said, “To the south side.”

Nirmala paused.

She crossed the courtyard to the south side.

Bina was putting pumpkin and chickpeas into the container.

Nirmala stood in the doorway.

Bina looked up.

“Do you need something?”

Nirmala said, “The container.”

Bina's hand stopped as she was putting on the lid.

"My leftovers are in it."

"Mine too."

For a few moments, the two women looked at each other.

Bina opened the lid again.

"How much do you have?"

"Only two small bowls."

"There is half a container of space here."

Nirmala brought her bowl.

She put the potato and pointed gourd on one side of the container.

The pumpkin and chickpeas were on the other side.

The two vegetables mixed slightly in the middle.

Nirmala tried to separate them with a spoon.

Bina said, "Let it be."

Nirmala stopped her hand.

The container was full.

The lid would not close easily.

Bina pressed down a little.

Nirmala held the other side.

There was a small "click."

The lid settled into place.

Sonu was watching from the courtyard.

He asked, "Whose vegetables are these?"

Bina said, "Leftovers."

"Whose leftovers?"

This time Nirmala answered, "The house's."

The container was placed back on Saraswati Devi's shelf.

The scratched "M" and "R" were still clear on the lid.

But no new mark was added.

The Closed Window

At seven in the evening, the spice-grinding mill would start up.

Earlier, the mill had operated during the day.

For the past two weeks, the owner had extended the work until nine at night.

Naresh's rented room stood directly behind the mill.

Between them lay a narrow lane and a brick wall.

High in the wall was a broad window.

Two panes in the window were already cracked.

One corner of the mesh had also come loose.

Whenever the mill ran, even the utensils inside the room trembled faintly.

Rashmi would sit bent over her notebook.

Ten minutes later, she would press her hands over her ears.

"Babu, I can't study like this."

For the first three days Naresh said,

"It will stop by eight."

But the mill did not stop at eight.

Nine o'clock came.

Then nine-twenty.

On the fourth day Rashmi closed her book.

"My exams begin tomorrow."

From beside the stove Meenakshi said,
“Close the window.”

Naresh pulled hard on both shutters.
The wood had swollen.
One shutter came halfway.
The other remained stuck.

He pushed it with his shoulder.
The glass rattled.
The rumbling outside grew a little softer.
But it did not stop.

Rashmi opened her book again.
Five minutes later she raised her head.

“It’s still too loud.”

This time Naresh did not reply.
He stuffed an old towel into the gap in the window.

After dinner at night, all four of them lived in that same room.
Rashmi’s cot stood on one side.
Chhotu’s bedding lay on the other.
In the middle, Meenakshi and Naresh spread out their folded mattress
at night.

Meenakshi was washing the utensils.
Naresh sat beside the window.
Outside, the mill had shut down.
From the lane came the ring of bicycle bells, talk from the tea stall,
and the horn of a distant bus.

Naresh said softly,
“This month we’ll have to pay the rent two days late.”

In the same low voice Meenakshi asked,
“Why?”

“The money for the extra work at the office hasn’t come yet.”

Chhotu turned over.
But he did not wake.

Meenakshi said,
“Rashmi’s examination fee is due this week too.”

Naresh looked outside.
Two motorcycles passed together through the lane.
His reply was lost inside the noise.

“How much?”

“Twelve hundred.”

“We’ll see.”

This was their old way.

After the children slept, they would sit by the window and quietly work through the household accounts.

The noise outside kept their words from spreading through the room.

The children thought their mother and father were simply sitting by the window for some air.

The next day Naresh spoke to the landlord.

The landlord examined the window.

He ran a finger over the glass.

“We’ll split the cost of new panes half and half.”

“How much?”

“About eighteen hundred.”

Naresh did not smile.

He simply kept looking at the window.

That evening he brought two thick sheets of cardboard and a sack of discarded cotton scraps from a second-hand goods shop.

Altogether they cost two hundred and seventy-five rupees.

Meenakshi asked,

“What is all this?”

“We’re not replacing the glass.”

First he folded an old sheet and fixed it inside the mesh.

Over that he packed the cotton scraps.

Finally, he nailed the thick cardboard sheets into the window frame.

Rashmi stood watching with her book in her hands.

“Now?”

Naresh listened to the mill running.

The sound was still there.

But it was about half as loud as before.

Rashmi smiled.

“Now I can study.”

Meenakshi ran her hand over the cardboard.

“What about air?”

“We’ll keep the door open.”

That night, for the first time, the room was unnaturally quiet.

After the mill stopped, the other noises from outside were also greatly reduced.

Chhotu fell asleep early.

Rashmi studied late.

Naresh spread out the mattress.

Meenakshi put the utensils away.

The two of them did not sit beside the window.

Their usual place was directly beneath the cardboard-covered frame.

Even so, there was no breeze there now.

Naresh said softly,

“About the rent...”

Rashmi’s pen stopped.

Meenakshi said at once,

“We’ll see tomorrow.”

Rashmi began writing again.

A little later Meenakshi asked,

“The money from the office...”

Chhotu opened his eyes.

“What money?”

Naresh said,

“Nothing. Go to sleep.”

That night the household accounts were not discussed.

Nor the next night.

On the third night Meenakshi only said,
“Bring less milk tomorrow.”

Naresh asked,
“Why?”

Rashmi was listening while memorising her lesson.
Meenakshi said,
“Just for this week.”

The conversation ended there.

Four days later a new habit had formed in the house.

When the children were awake, Naresh and Meenakshi spoke only about small practical matters.

“The salt is finished.”

“Bring soap.”

“Has Chhotu’s shirt dried?”

“Close the door.”

Beyond that, the conversation did not go.

Naresh had received his salary slip at the office.

The payment for the extra work had not been added that month either.

He put the slip inside his bag.

Meenakshi did sewing work.

Two customers had said they would pay the following week.
She did not tell Naresh this.

The deadline for Rashmi's examination fee was drawing near.

She brought a notice home from school.
She placed it between the pages of a book.

Earlier she would have handed it straight to her mother.

This time she did not.

That evening, while straightening Rashmi's bag, Meenakshi found the notice.

"What is this?"

Rashmi remained silent.

Meenakshi read the notice.

"The last date is the day after tomorrow?"

Rashmi nodded.

"Why didn't you tell me earlier?"

Rashmi kept straightening the corner of her book.

"I thought you two weren't talking about money anymore."

Meenakshi's hand stopped.

"Who told you that?"

“No one.”

“Then?”

Rashmi looked at the cardboard covering the window.

“Before, at night, you two used to sit by the window and talk.”

Meenakshi said nothing.

Naresh had not yet come home.

That night he arrived at half past eight.

He hung his bag on the peg.

He washed his hands and face and sat down.

Meenakshi served him a plate.

Rashmi placed the notice in front of him.

Naresh read it.

“The day after tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

“You’ve had this all this time?”

Before Rashmi could answer, Meenakshi said,

“I only saw it today too.”

Naresh looked at Rashmi.

“Why didn’t you tell us?”

This time Rashmi answered directly,
“You two listen, but you don’t talk about your own things.”

Chhotu kept mixing rice on his plate.
He did not look up.

Naresh did not fold the notice.
He laid it flat on the table.

“Twelve hundred?”

Meenakshi said,
“It says thirteen hundred and fifty on the notice.”

Naresh read it again.
“Examination fee plus laboratory charges.”

Meenakshi asked,
“How much do you have?”

Rashmi stood up at once.

“I’m going to study.”

She moved to the other corner of the same room.
The distance was no more than seven cubits.

Naresh said quietly,
“Eight hundred at the moment.”

The sound of Rashmi turning pages continued.

Meenakshi spoke just as softly,
“I have five hundred and thirty-five.”

Chhotu asked,
“How much?”

Meenakshi said,
“Not for you.”

Naresh stopped eating.

The room was very quiet.
Outside, the mill was running.
But behind the cardboard and cotton, its sound was muffled.

Naresh said,
“The extra-work money didn’t come this time either.”

Meenakshi looked at him.

“You never told me.”

“I would have.”

“When?”

Naresh looked at the cardboard over the window.

Meenakshi understood that this was not an answer.

Running her finger along the edge of her plate, she said,
“Payment for two sewing jobs is held up too.”

Naresh asked,
“How much?”

“Nine hundred.”

“You didn’t tell me that either.”

“When would I have told you?”

Both fell silent.

Rashmi’s pen kept moving across her notebook.

Chhotu finished his rice and drank water.

After dinner Naresh opened his bag.

He took out the salary slip.

He placed it in front of Meenakshi.

Meenakshi read it.

“There is a deduction of five hundred here too.”

“Against the old advance.”

“You didn’t tell me this either.”

Naresh tried to smile.

The smile did not form.

“We used to say everything by the window.”

Meenakshi looked at the cardboard-filled frame.

“Did the window close, or did our mouths?”

Naresh did not answer.

That night, after the children slept, the two of them remained awake.

The ticking of the clock was clearly audible in the room.
The clock had never seemed so loud before.

Once Meenakshi said,
“Shall we go up to the roof?”

Naresh looked toward the outside.

“The landlord’s family sleeps upstairs.”

“Then?”

“Tomorrow.”

Meenakshi turned over.

The next day the mill ran again.
Rashmi studied.
Chhotu did his homework.

On his way home from the office, Naresh collected an old table fan from a repair shop.
It was his own fan.
Three months earlier, he had left it for repair because it made a noise.

Meenakshi asked,
“Is it fixed?”

Naresh said,
“Not completely.”

He switched on the fan.
The blades began to turn.
Along with them came a “gharr-gharr” sound.

Rashmi raised her head.

“It’s making noise again.”

Naresh switched it off at once.

“I’ll get it fixed.”

At ten that night Chhotu fell asleep.

Rashmi also closed her book.

Naresh placed the table fan on the floor.

He ran it at low speed.

“Gharr... gharr... gharr...”

Meenakshi looked at him.

“Rashmi is awake.”

From behind the curtain Rashmi’s voice came,

“I’m going to sleep.”

A little later even the sound of her turning over stopped.

Naresh left the fan running.

Meenakshi sat on the corner of the mattress.

For the first time, the two of them sat away from the window.

Naresh said,

“We have to pay thirteen hundred and fifty the day after tomorrow.”

Meenakshi said,

“I’ll give five hundred and thirty-five.”

“I have eight hundred.”

“We’ll still be fifteen short.”

They were silent for a few moments.

Meenakshi said,

“The milkman owes me fifteen.”

Naresh nodded.

“The rent?”

“Two days late.”

“The landlord?”

“I’ll tell him.”

Over the sound of the fan Meenakshi asked,

“How many more months will the deduction continue?”

“Three more months.”

“The belt on the sewing machine needs replacing.”

“How much?”

“One hundred and eighty.”

“This week?”

“No. Next week.”

The conversation slowly widened.

From rent to medicine.

From milk to school shoes.

From Chhotu's torn bag to Rashmi's books for the following month.

There was no grand solution.

Some things were simply written down.

Some were pushed forward.

On some, the two still disagreed.

The fan kept going gharr-gharr.

In the morning Rashmi got up and looked at the fan.

"Did this run all night?"

Meenakshi said,

"For a while."

Rashmi switched it off.

The room became completely quiet again.

She looked at her mother.

"The fee?"

Meenakshi said,

"It will be paid today."

Rashmi only said, "All right."

When Naresh returned that evening, the window was still closed.

The cardboard sheets were just as they had been.

The mill was running.
Rashmi was studying.
Chhotu was drawing.

From beside the stove Meenakshi asked,
“Will you get the fan repaired?”

Naresh remembered its gharr-gharr sound.

“Not completely.”

Meenakshi smiled.

After dinner Naresh switched the fan on at low speed.

Rashmi looked once over the top of her book at her mother and father.
Then she lowered her eyes to the page again.

The window remained closed.

But this time Naresh said,
“Let’s make next month’s accounts in advance.”

Meenakshi said,
“Yes. Tell me.”

Sunday Clothes

On Sunday afternoon, the clothes in Kamala Devi's courtyard were drying quickly.

There had been a light drizzle at dawn.

After ten, the sun came out.

Malati brought down the first bamboo basket from the roof.

Sudha followed with the second basket.

Both sisters had come to their mother's house on the same Sunday for the first time in a month.

A nerve in their mother's right arm had been strained.

The doctor had told her not to lift heavy buckets.

Kamala Devi sat in a low chair.

She insisted on folding the clothes.

Malati said,

"You sit. We'll do this."

Sudha set the basket down between them.

Inside were their mother's three cotton saris, two petticoats, four blouses, two towels, an old bedsheet, and a few smaller pieces of clothing.

Malati began separating the saris.

Sudha, the blouses.

Kamala Devi said,

“Keep the sari with the red border on top. The puja is on Wednesday.”

Malati said, “Yes.”

For a while, there was only the rustle of cloth.

In one corner of the courtyard stood a pot of tulsi.
A faint smell rose from its damp earth.

Sudha picked up a blouse.
She ran a finger over the seam near the sleeve.

“This is still holding up?”

Kamala Devi looked from a distance.
“Why wouldn’t it?”

Without looking up, Malati said,
“It was stitched in those days.”

Sudha’s hand stopped.

The inside seam of the blouse had been turned twice.
The small stitches along the edge were still strong.

Sudha folded the blouse.

Malati spread out another sari.

Nothing was said.

Kamala Devi tried to get up.
Malati said at once,
“You stay seated.”

“I’ll bring water.”

Sudha got up.

She brought three glasses of water from inside.

Kamala Devi took two sips, then leaned back in the chair.

Sudha set down her glass.

Then she looked again at the pile of blouses.

“If the machine were still here, this sleeve could be made good for a while longer.”

For the first time, Malati looked directly at her.

“If the machine were still here.”

Kamala Devi had closed her eyes.

Sudha said,

“The same thing again?”

Malati went on folding the sari.

“I didn’t start it.”

“But you said it.”

“I said what was true.”

The courtyard fell quiet again.

Ten years earlier, Kamala Devi’s cataracts had grown worse.

A date had been fixed.

They had fallen short of money.

At the time, Malati lived in Patna.

Her husband had a small job in the accounts department of a hospital.
Their two children were in school.

Sudha lived with their mother in this house.

She tutored children at home.

Two days before the cataract operation, Sudha sold their mother's old foot-operated sewing machine.

The money made up the shortfall.

Malati heard about it only after the surgery.

From that day on, one question remained suspended between the two sisters.

Malati would say—had you told me once more, I would have sent the money.

Sudha would say—there was no time, and when I had told you earlier, I had not received a clear answer.

Each of them had her own accounting of what had happened.

Neither account could cancel the other.

Sometimes Kamala Devi said selling the machine had been necessary.

Sometimes she said, "You could have waited a few days."

That only made the dispute hazier.

Sudha folded a small towel.

"Your phone was switched off that night."

Malati said,

"It wasn't switched off. I was on a bus."

“I called three times.”

“I called back.”

“The next day.”

“At eleven that night.”

“By then the buyer had already come to see the machine.”

The sari remained half-folded in Malati’s hands.

“You could have waited one day.”

Sudha did not answer at once.

She picked up a towel.

She evened out the two ends.

Then folded it in half.

“That day, I did not know whether waiting one more day was safe.”

Malati said,

“I thought it was.”

“Yes.”

“I still do.”

“And I still think selling it was the right thing to do.”

Kamala Devi opened her eyes.

“Were you two supposed to fold clothes, or hold court?”

Sudha did not laugh.

Neither did Malati.

But both picked up the clothes again.

Malati’s pile grew into neat squares.

Sudha’s leaned a little crooked.

That difference had been there since childhood.

Kamala Devi said,

“Sudha, make the corners even.”

Sudha said,

“Ma, the clothes are going into a cupboard. No one is grading the measurements.”

A faint smile appeared on Malati’s face.

“That’s why everything falls out the moment the cupboard opens.”

This time Sudha laughed.

“Your piles stand like soldiers.”

Kamala Devi said,

“Enough. Now that’s better.”

The afternoon was waning.

A square of sunlight on the rear wall was slowly sinking lower.

Malati picked up their mother’s blue petticoat.

The drawstring at the waist had half come loose.

“This needs stitching again.”

Sudha said,

“I’ll do it by hand.”

Malati said,

“Two washes and it will come loose again.”

“Then we’ll give it to the tailor.”

“Yes.”

Sudha was quiet for a moment.

“If the machine were here, five minutes.”

Malati turned the petticoat over and looked at it.

“If it were here.”

This time there was no barb in her voice.

Sudha did not carry the point any further.

Kamala Devi said,

“Are you going to leave the petticoat torn now in the name of the machine?”

Malati said,

“No.”

Sudha said,

“No.”

They spoke at the same time.

Kamala Devi smiled.

Malati took a small pencil from her bag.

On an old piece of paper she wrote—"Blue petticoat—drawstring."

Sudha looked at her.

"You still make lists?"

"If I don't, I forget."

"I forget first and remember later."

"You forget more."

"That is also true."

For a while, the two worked quietly again.

In the courtyard there was only the soft sound of clothes being folded.

Now and then a handcart passed on the distant road.

Now and then a child shouted next door.

Sudha picked up an old pillowcase.

"Throw this away."

Kamala Devi said at once,

"No."

Malati examined one corner of the pillowcase.

The cloth had worn thin on one side.

“What good will keeping it do?”

Kamala Devi said,

“It can become a cleaning rag.”

Sudha looked at Malati.

“See? It’s hard to sell anything from this house.”

Kamala Devi raised an eyebrow.

Malati’s hand stopped again.

Sudha said quickly,

“All right, I shouldn’t have said that.”

Malati did not toss the pillowcase back into the basket.

She placed it beside the pile meant for cleaning rags.

“No. You’ve said it now.”

Sudha was silent.

Malati said,

“I still grieve for that machine.”

Sudha said softly,

“So do I.”

Malati looked at her.

“Then?”

“Grief and a decision are not the same thing.”

Malati said nothing.

Sudha went on,

“I sold it. Even now I would say that, at the time, it seemed necessary to me. But why should that mean I cannot grieve for it?”

Malati folded the blue petticoat neatly once more.

“I still think you acted too quickly.”

“All right.”

“What do you mean, all right?”

“I mean you still feel that way.”

For the first time, Malati laughed.

“And you still feel that you did the right thing.”

“Yes.”

“So where does that leave us?”

Sudha picked up the sari with the red border.

She held out its loose end toward Malati.

“Here.”

Malati caught the end.

Holding opposite sides, the two of them pulled the sari slightly taut.

The creases straightened.

Sudha said,

“Perhaps this has no solution.”

Malati said,
“Perhaps it doesn’t.”

“Then?”

“Then fold the clothes.”

Together they folded the sari down the middle.

From the stool, Kamala Devi said,
“The puja sari goes on top.”

Malati said,
“I remember.”

Sudha said,
“Put it on your list.”

Malati gave her a look.

This time both of them burst out laughing.

Before evening, all the clothes had gone into the cupboard.

The blue petticoat lay in a separate bag.
It would go to the tailor on Monday.

The pillowcase meant to become a cleaning rag was left in a corner of the kitchen.

The sari with the red border remained on top.

Malati got up to leave for home.
Sudha began looking for her slippers as well.

Kamala Devi asked,
“Who will come next Sunday?”

The sisters looked at each other.

Malati said,
“My children have exams.”

Sudha said,
“I can come by afternoon.”

Malati said,
“You wash them. I’ll come in the evening and fold them.”

Sudha thought for a moment.

“All right.”

Malati reached the doorway.
Then she turned back.

“Tell the tailor to put in a strong drawstring.”

Sudha said,
“I will.”

Malati stepped outside.

No clothes were left in the courtyard.

The old dispute had not gone anywhere either.

But that Sunday, neither of them needed the old dispute to be resolved.

After the Mustard Harvest

The mustard had been harvested.

In the field, small stubble now stood where the yellow flowers had been.

Whenever the wind blew, the dry stalks rubbed against one another with a faint rustling sound.

Bhola Mandal sat beside the field bund.

An old ledger was in his hand.

There were two round oil stains on its cover; he had wiped them with a cloth many times.

The stains had faded, but they had not disappeared.

Ramvilas was coming through the field.

As he came, he pulled up one or two mustard stalks left after the harvest and tossed them aside.

Bhola said,

“The weight tallied.”

Ramvilas asked,

“How much?”

“Thirteen maunds and twenty-seven kilos.”

“I had estimated twelve maunds.”

“The grain was heavy this time.”

Ramvilas sat down.

Bhola opened the ledger.

On one page were written oil, seed, fertilizer, ploughing, harvesting, transport - everything.

The last line was blank.

Ramvilas asked,

“Why is it blank?”

Bhola said,

“This time the account is stuck right there.”

“How much is left?”

“It is not money that is left.”

Bhola slid the ledger towards him.

For twenty years, the partnership on this field had been half-and-half.

The field did not belong to Bhola Mandal.

Nor did it belong to Ramvilas.

Janki Devi, who lived at the edge of the village, owned sixteen kathas of land.

After her husband died, Janki Devi could no longer cultivate the field herself.

At first she had given the land to different people on sharecropping terms.

Sometimes there was a quarrel over seed, sometimes fertilizer, sometimes the weighing.

Twenty years earlier, Bhola and Ramvilas had taken the field together.

After giving Janki Devi her agreed share, they divided whatever remained equally between them.

At that time Bhola had bullocks.

Ramvilas had more cash.

Bhola ploughed, repaired the bunds, and spent nights guarding the field.

Ramvilas bought seed, brought fertilizer, and sold the crop at the market.

If anyone asked why they divided it equally, both gave the same answer:

“He does what I cannot; I do what he cannot.”

How much labour equalled how much money had never been measured.

Year after year, equality became a habit.

But now there were no bullocks.

Bhola's bullocks had been sold five years earlier.

Ploughing was done with hired machinery.

Threshing too was done by machine.

A hired small vehicle carried the crop to the market.

Ramvilas's son Pradeep said that the old arithmetic of the partnership had itself grown old.

That day Pradeep too came to the field.

He had a small notebook in his hand.

“Babu,” he said to Ramvilas, “I’ve added up everything.”

Bhola looked at him.

Pradeep opened the notebook.

“The total cash expense is fourteen thousand three hundred and twenty.”

Ramvilas said,

“Yes.”

“Nine thousand two hundred came from our house.”

Bhola remained silent.

Pradeep continued,

“Five thousand one hundred and twenty came from Bhola Kaka’s house.”

Ramvilas said quietly,

“You have counted the money.”

“Accounts are made in money.”

Bhola said,

“And the work?”

Pradeep turned towards him.

“We can add wages for the work.”

“Add them.”

Pradeep turned a page in the notebook.

“There was no transplanting; it was mustard. Ploughing by machine. Labourers for harvesting. Vehicle for transport. Looking after the field...”

He stopped.

Bhola said,

“What is the rate for looking after a field?”

Pradeep tried to smile.

“That is...”

“That is what?”

Ramvilas interrupted,

“Son, not every kind of work has a market rate.”

Pradeep said,

“So it cannot be accounted for at all?”

Bhola closed the ledger.

The wind blew.

The smell of mustard still lingered in the harvested field.

In the distance, a woman was gathering stalks.

Bhola said,

“This time I paid half the fertilizer money later.”

Pradeep said,

“Yes, it is written here.”

“And the night the water pump broke down?”

“Three hundred and forty for repairing the water pump.”

“Whose bicycle brought the mechanic at two in the morning?”

Pradeep said nothing.

“I went. Three kos.”

“We can count that as labour.”

“How much?”

Pradeep looked at the page of his notebook.

Bhola asked again,

“When the bull got into the field in Jeth, whose son slept here for three nights?”

“Manoj.”

“Manoj is my son.”

“We’ll add his wages too.”

Bhola laughed.

“Manoj will say the wage for sleeping in the field at night is different from the wage for daytime.”

Pradeep grew uncomfortable.

Ramvilas ran his hand over the ground.

The soil was dry, but a little moisture remained underneath.

He said,

“Pradeep, what you are saying is not wrong.”

Bhola looked at Ramvilas.

Ramvilas continued,

“It is true that now more of the cash expense comes from our house.”

Bhola said,

“Then say it.”

“Say what?”

“Shall we stop dividing half-and-half?”

Ramvilas did not answer at once.

The question had come up before too.

But never this directly.

Seven years earlier, Bhola's wife had been ill.

That season Bhola had spent less time at the field.

For three weeks Ramvilas alone looked after the water pump, fertilizer, and weeding.

When the crop was divided, it was still half-and-half.

The next year, Ramvilas's daughter was getting married.

For two months, Bhola did most of the fieldwork.

The crop was again divided half-and-half.

Sometimes one household gave more time.

Sometimes the other gave more money.

Their twenty-year partnership had survived on the understanding that every year would not be weighed separately.

Pradeep said,

"All I'm saying is that the work has changed now."

Bhola said,

"Yes, it has changed."

"Then the shares should change too."

Bhola looked towards the field.

"To what?"

Pradeep added some figures in his notebook.

"Cash and labour together... perhaps sixty-forty."

"Whose sixty?"

Pradeep did not answer.

Ramvilas said,

"That is exactly the question."

Pradeep gave an awkward laugh.

“Whoever contributes more.”

Bhola said,

“Will we decide the contribution beforehand, or after the harvest?”

“Beforehand.”

“It was not decided beforehand this time.”

Pradeep fell silent.

After a while he left.

Bhola and Ramvilas remained seated in the field.

Ramvilas asked,

“Did you feel hurt?”

Bhola said,

“The point is not bad. The timing is.”

“Why?”

“If you change the rule after dividing the crop, it is no longer a rule; it is a claim.”

Ramvilas nodded.

“Right.”

Bhola opened the ledger again.

“Half-and-half this time?”

“As we had agreed.”

“Next time?”

Ramvilas looked towards the far edge of the field.

Janki Devi’s grandson was cutting date-palm leaves there.

“Next time we’ll write it down beforehand.”

Bhola said,

“Write what?”

“Money.”

“Work.”

“Yes.”

“Time?”

“Yes.”

“Watching the field?”

“Yes.”

“Work done by people from the household?”

Ramvilas looked at him.

“That too.”

Bhola smiled.

“Then the ledger will grow fat.”

Ramvilas said,

“Let it.”

Two days later, the crop was sold at the market.

Janki Devi's share was set aside.

Bhola and Ramvilas divided the remaining money equally.

Pradeep said nothing.

But he did not throw away his notebook.

A week later, Janki Devi called both of them.

She was sitting on a low wooden seat in the veranda.

“The next crop?” she asked.

Ramvilas said,

“We're thinking of moong.”

Bhola said,

“If the rains come on time.”

Janki Devi said,

“I have something to say.”

Both fell silent.

“This time my grandson says I should give the land to just one man. The paperwork would be simpler.”

Bhola looked at Ramvilas.

Janki Devi continued,

“I told him that two men have been running this field for twenty years. Why should I suddenly put down only one name?”

Ramvilas asked,

“What do you want?”

“I want the field kept properly. Sown on time, harvested on time. I want my share clear.”

Bhola said,

“Then the partnership remains.”

Janki Devi said,

“The partnership is between the two of you. I only want my field not to lie vacant.”

On the way home, Bhola said,

“See? Even the owner of the land does not understand our shares.”

Ramvilas smiled.

“Do we understand them ourselves?”

The next day Bhola bought a new ledger.

The old ledger was only half full.

Even so, he bought a new one.

On the first page he wrote -

“Moong - next season.”

Below it he made two lines.

One line: “Money.”

The other: “Work.”

Ramvilas came.

Looking at the page, he said,

“Two lines?”

Bhola said,

“Your son’s accounting.”

Ramvilas sat down.

“First, let’s make the rules.”

They talked for half an hour.

What should the rate be for a day’s fieldwork?

If the water pump broke down, did bringing the mechanic count as work or as expense?

Was going to the market work, or responsibility for selling?

Was judging whether seed was good or bad a matter of time, or of experience?

Several lines were filled.

Even then, no rule emerged.

Ramvilas said,

“I think you made the wrong lines.”

“Then?”

“If we keep separating money and work, they will never become equal.”

Bhola asked,

“Then what should I write?”

Ramvilas thought for a while.

“Responsibility.”

Bhola looked at the page.

Ramvilas said,

“One man will take responsibility for seed, fertilizer, and sale. The other for the field, timing, machinery, and labourers. Whoever takes a responsibility must see it through. Expenses will be shared.”

Bhola said,

“And the shares?”

“We’ll talk about that again.”

“Again?”

“Yes. How can we fix the share before we have made the rules?”

Bhola smiled.

“I thought the rules would protect the share.”

Ramvilas said,

“Perhaps rules only make the quarrel clearer.”

Both walked out towards the field.

Some green grass had begun to grow in the harvested mustard field.

They discussed loosening the soil in one corner for moong.

Ramvilas said,

“This time I’ll arrange the ploughing.”

Bhola asked,

“Your responsibility?”

“Write it down.”

“Seed?”

“You.”

“Market?”

“Me.”

“Water pump?”

Bhola and Ramvilas both stopped at once.

For twenty years, the water pump had never been the sole responsibility of either man.

Whoever was available operated it.

When it broke, whoever noticed first went looking for the mechanic.

Ramvilas said,

“The water pump is shared.”

Bhola laughed.

“An old word has slipped back in.”

That evening Pradeep looked at the ledger.

“Where is the line for the shares?”

Ramvilas said,

“Not yet.”

“Then the account is incomplete.”

Bhola was sitting there too.

He said,

“Let the work begin first. Whatever we decide, we’ll write it down beforehand. We won’t change it after the harvest.”

Pradeep asked,

“Will it remain half-and-half?”

Before Ramvilas could answer, he looked at Bhola.

Bhola said,

“I bought the new ledger to answer that question.”

Pradeep said nothing.

Two days later, the machine for turning the soil came to the field.

The driver quoted his rate.

Ramvilas settled the rate.

Bhola measured the fuel.

When the machine started, they remembered the ploughing with bullocks twenty years earlier.

Back then, Bhola's bullocks had been half the foundation of the partnership.

Now that foundation had turned into a rental receipt.

When half the ploughing was done, the driver stopped to drink water.

Bhola picked up a handful of soil.

Ramvilas asked,

“What are you looking at?”

“Just the soil.”

“What is it worth?”

Bhola looked at him.

“Ask Janki Devi that.”

Both laughed.

By evening the field had been turned.

The mustard stubble had gone under the soil.

No sign of the yellow season remained above ground.

Before leaving for home, Bhola said,

“Tomorrow we'll look at the seed.”

Ramvilas said,

“You look. That’s your responsibility.”

“Money?”

“Shared.”

Bhola smiled again.

“The word has come back again.”

This time Ramvilas did not laugh.

He kept looking at the turned field.

The mustard had been harvested.

The crop had been sold.

The money had been divided half-and-half.

But after the bullocks were gone, after machines arrived, after the work of the market changed, the basis of the old half-and-half partnership was still not clear on paper.

The new ledger lay open.

For the first time, the question was being written before the crop, not after it.

The field was not empty.

Before the next crop, the meaning of the old partnership still had to be decided anew upon it.

The Herdsman's Footpath

The morning sun had not yet climbed above the tops of the mango trees.

Bisanpur's new road was shining with the night's dew.

Two or three leaves had fallen on the black paved strip along the side.

On one side of the road ran a concrete drain; on the other rose a high earthen verge.

Budhan Paswan reached the road with his seven goats and two calves.

At that point all the animals stopped at once.

Budhan stopped too.

Earlier, at this very spot, the footpath had crossed where the road now lay and gone straight towards the Simraha grazing ground.

After the road was built, the footpath had been cut into two pieces.

The stretch on this side lay beneath his feet.

The stretch on the far side, used far less for two months, was sinking into the grass.

Between them lay the new road.

And along the road, the concrete drain.

The goats looked at the drain, then back at Budhan.

Budhan said,
 “Come on.”

The first goat put a foot forward.

Seeing the width of the drain, it stepped back again.

Budhan laid his short bamboo stick across the drain.

“This is no bridge for you,” he said to himself.

Then he turned the herd southward.

Three hundred paces farther along the new road was a concrete culvert.

The drain could be crossed there.

But going up to the culvert, circling to the other side of the road, and then picking up the old footpath added nearly half a kos.

Budhan was nearing seventy.

His stride was still steady, but his knees were not what they had once been.

The goats were always in a hurry.

The calves kept stopping to tear at the grass.

Budhan repeatedly urged them on towards the culvert.

A bicycle bell rang behind him.

It was Runki.

Budhan's granddaughter.

A bag of notebooks and books on her back.

She was on her way to school.

Runki stopped her bicycle.

"Grandfather, going by the culvert again?"

"What else? Shall we fly across the drain?"

Runki looked to the far side of the road.

The old footpath could still be made out.

A faint brown line through the grass.

"Earlier we used to go straight from here."

"Earlier there was no road."

"Has the road been a good thing or a bad thing?"

Budhan laughed.

"Did your teacher ask you that question?"

"No."

“Then go to school. You’ll be late.”

Runki pedalled away.

After going a little distance, she turned to look back.

Budhan was still driving the animals towards the culvert.

The new road was no longer new to the village.

It had been inaugurated two months earlier.

Before that, in the rains, the earthen track from Bisanpur to the market turned into bog in three places.

Two-wheelers got stuck.

A sick person had to be carried on a cot as far as the main road.

People tying milk cans to bicycles lost half their milk to splashing on the way.

All that changed when the new road came.

The morning milk vehicle began coming directly to the hamlet.

For the first time, the little school vehicle arrived on time even on rainy days.

Measured by the clock, the market seemed closer.

Budhan himself had praised the road in its first week.

“Now our slippers won’t get left behind in the mud,” he had said.

But while the road was being built, the footpath existed nowhere on the map.

It was not in the land records.

Nor was it the boundary of anyone's field.

It was simply a line in the earth, made by animals going out from three hamlets of the village.

Years upon years of feet had made that line.

The small hooves of goats.

The broad hooves of cows.

The bare feet of herdsmen.

In the rains, the deep marks of bamboo staffs.

In winter, a thin layer of dust.

No one had made it.

So the people building the road did not think they were breaking it either.

The road simply went down over it.

In the first week, the animals crossed the paved surface.

The drain had not yet been completed.

In the second week, the drain was cast.

In the third, earth was piled along the edge.

Then the old straight route was blocked.

Maheshwar Rai, who kept a larger herd, faced no particular difficulty.

His eight cows now stayed mostly in the cowshed.

Green fodder came by vehicle.

Even when two of the cows went out in the evening, they only went as far as the field behind the house.

But for small livestock keepers like Budhan, the Simraha grazing ground was essential.

Kamli Devi's three goats.

Ramesar's one cow and two calves.

Karim's five sheep.

All of them went out to the grazing ground by day.

And all of them now had to detour by the culvert.

Earlier, Budhan reached the grazing ground from home in fifteen or seventeen minutes.

Now it took more than half an hour.

The same on the way back.

An hour had been added to the day's walking.

For some people, an hour was a small thing.

For Budhan, an hour was a matter of his knees.

For Kamli Devi, an hour was a matter of the hearth.

For Ramesar's daughter, it was a matter of school, because she returned from the morning herding and then went to class.

One Sunday, Runki went with Budhan.

"Why today?" Budhan asked.

"To see."

"What?"

"The route."

She carried not a phone but a small notebook.

Runki began counting her steps.

From the bend near the house to the old footpath.

Then south along the side of the road.

The culvert.

Then north again.

Then the old footpath once more.

"How many?" Budhan asked.

“One thousand two hundred and thirty-seven steps.”

“Your steps are small.”

“That’s why the number is big.”

Budhan laughed.

On reaching the grazing ground, Runki wrote in her notebook: ‘New route.’

Then Budhan showed her the old one.

“Straight from the roots of this mango tree.”

Runki walked back along the old footpath.

She reached the road.

She stopped on this side of the drain.

The line on the far side was not perfectly straight.

Now that the road was wide, the old line looked as though it had shifted two or three hands’ breadths.

“Grandfather, wasn’t the footpath straight?”

“Is a path ever straight like a line on paper?”

Runki fell silent.

Budhan sat down on the edge of the drain.

“There used to be a little hollow here. In the rains it filled with water. The animals went round it on the left. That’s why the path bent here.”

Runki drew a crooked line in her notebook.

“There is a drain here now.”

“Yes.”

“Is the drain necessary?”

“Necessary. Otherwise the road will break up.”

“Is the footpath necessary?”

Budhan looked towards the grazing ground on the other side.

“You tell me.”

After returning home at noon, Runki opened her notebook and laid it in the courtyard.

She wrote down the step-counts for both the old route and the new one.

Old route—short.

New detour—long.

But the notebook could not get anyone across the drain.

The next day Runki went to school.

When she returned in the evening, she saw that the smaller of Budhan’s calves was walking with a limp.

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“Why is it limping?”

“It slipped on the paved stretch near the culvert.”

Runki bent down and looked at the hoof.

There was a light scrape.

No blood.

“Medicine?”

“I washed it with salt water.”

Budhan kept the matter small.

That day Runki did not open her notebook.

Three days later it rained in the village.

The first heavy rain.

Water gleamed on the paved surface of the new road.

The drain filled and began flowing fast.

The road remained intact.

People were pleased.

Had it still been the old earthen track, this rain would have turned it to mud again.

When the rain stopped in the evening, Runki went out with Budhan.

At one point in the drain, muddy water was swirling.

Exactly where the old footpath had crossed the road.

From the field on the far side, a small streamlet was running into the drain.

Dried mustard stalks, grass and earth had jammed inside the drain.

The water was rising towards the edge of the road.

Two labourers were clearing the drain with spades.

One of them was Nandu the mason.

He was from a village near Bisanpur.

He had worked there when the road was being built too.

Seeing Budhan, Nandu said,
“Uncle, mud gets stuck here again and again.”

Budhan said,
“Water used to drain out here before too.”

“Where was the drain then?”

“There wasn’t a drain. There was a hollow.”

Runki opened her notebook.

“And the footpath too.”

Nandu laughed.

“You’ve been measuring it as well?”

“I counted the steps.”

She showed him the notebook.

Nandu stopped working and looked at the paper.

“The path on this side was here, and the one on that side there?”

“Yes.”

“And the drain in between.”

“Yes.”

“So what do you want now?”

Runki did not answer at once.

Budhan said,

“We don’t want the road broken.”

Nandu smiled.

“That’s a good start.”

“The drain should remain too.”

“That’s good as well.”

“We only want the animals to be able to cross.”

Nandu judged the width of the drain with his eyes.

“If you make something like a culvert, it’ll cost money.”

Budhan said,

“We’re not asking for a culvert.”

Runki looked at two thick concrete slabs lying beside the drain.

They were drain covers, like the ones placed in front of house entrances so people could cross on foot.

“Like these?” she asked.

Nandu said,

“If slabs like these are laid, the water can flow underneath. But you’ll also need a slope at the roadside. The animals will slip otherwise.”

Budhan said,

“Make the slope rough, with earth and grit.”

Nandu picked up his spade again.

“I don’t make the decisions. It has to be approved from above.”

The matter ended there.

Runki expected something to happen the next day.

Nothing happened.

The road remained as it was.

The drain remained as it was.

Budhan kept detouring by the culvert.

A week passed.

In the meantime, Maheshwar Rai sent two large cans of milk to the market along the new road.

He was pleased.

“It used to take half an hour; now it takes ten minutes.”

Kamli Devi heard him.

“It used to take me fifteen minutes to get my goats to the grazing ground; now it takes half an hour.”

Maheshwar laughed.

“Everyone has their own time.”

Kamli did not answer.

Runki had heard the exchange.

The word ‘time’ stayed in her mind.

That night she wrote in her notebook—

‘The road saves ten minutes.’

And underneath—

‘The footpath detour adds fifteen minutes.’

Then she stopped.

Whose ten minutes?

Whose fifteen minutes?

The notebook did not answer that question.

The next Sunday, Runki spoke to Kamli Devi, Ramesar and Karim at the grazing ground.

“Do all of you go round by the culvert?”

Kamli said,
“What else can we do?”

Karim said,
“Sometimes I make the sheep jump the drain.”

“Isn’t that dangerous?”

“For me or for the sheep?”

Everyone laughed.

Ramesar remained serious.

“Twice, motorbikes came past fast. The animals scattered across the road. There isn’t much room to get off the road near the culvert.”

Runki asked,

“What if slabs were laid across the drain at the old crossing, with an earthen slope?”

Kamli said at once,

“Then it would be straight through.”

Karim said,

“A width of one and a half or two hands would be enough for sheep.”

Ramesar said,

“More for a cow.”

“How much?”

They stretched out their arms to show her.

Budhan was laughing from a distance.

“Now the footpath is being measured not in feet, but in hands.”

Runki said,

“No one measured it before either. Now there is a drain, so a measurement is needed.”

Budhan stopped laughing.

He said,

“You’re right.”

Four days later workers came to the roadside again.

This time two concrete drain covers had broken.

A junior engineer was there with Nandu the mason.

Runki stopped there on her way back from school.

Budhan was already standing there.

Nandu said,

“Look at this girl’s notebook.”

The engineer first looked at the drain.

Then at the notebook.

“This isn’t an official measurement,” he said.

Runki’s face fell.

Nandu said,

“Take the official measurements later. First look at where the path is.”

The engineer crossed to the other side of the road.

He looked at the old footpath disappearing into the grass.

Then he came back to this side.

Then he walked as far as the culvert.

Ramesar’s cow happened to be coming round by the culvert at that very moment.

His daughter was with the cow.

As a vehicle approached, she pulled the cow sharply to the side.

The engineer said nothing.

He came back and measured the width of the drain.

“Three slabs will be needed.”

Nandu said,

“And on the sides, rough earth and stone that hooves can grip.”

“It won’t rise onto the paved surface?”

“The slope will stay below road level.”

The engineer wrote something on a sheet of paper.

Budhan asked,

“Will it be built?”

“We’ll add it to the repair work.”

“When?”

“I can’t say that.”

Budhan nodded.

He was accustomed to answers like that.

Runki said nothing either.

Another day passed.

Then a week.

The old footpath on the far side grew greener still.

Where no feet fall, doob grass fills in quickly.

Every day on her way to school, Runki looked at that green strip.

She was afraid the footpath would disappear altogether.

One day she said to Budhan,

“If everyone keeps going round, the old path will vanish.”

Budhan said,

“Does a path vanish?”

“The grass has filled it.”

“When the grass goes, it will form again.”

“What if people no longer remember it?”

Budhan planted his staff in the earth.

“A path survives less by memory than by need.”

Runki did not write that sentence in her notebook.

She felt that putting it on paper would make it sound too grand.

In truth, Budhan had said it as an ordinary thing.

In the last week of Ashadh, there was another spell of heavy rain.

This time the drain filled at two places.

The repair vehicle came.

With it came three concrete slabs.

When Runki returned from school, there was no crowd by the drain, only Nandu and two labourers.

Budhan was not there either.

Nandu was cutting away earth.

“Is it being made?” Runki asked.

“Can’t you see?”

One by one, the three slabs were laid across the drain.

A cow could not pass abreast with another, but two or three smaller animals could cross comfortably.

On both sides of the road, below the paved surface, rough slopes of gravel and earth were made.

The drain remained open.

Water kept flowing beneath the slabs.

Runki asked,
“Is this the footpath now?”

Nandu said,
“This is a drain crossing.”

“The footpath?”

“The animals will make that.”

In the evening, Budhan came with the herd.

The first goat stopped at the new slabs.

It sniffed them.

It put one foot down.

Then the other.

Crossing the slabs, it stepped onto the grass on the far side.

The other goats followed it.

The calf hesitated for a while.

Budhan stroked its neck.

“Come on.”

The calf crossed too.

Runki stood at the roadside and watched.

There was no inauguration.

No ribbon was cut.

No plaque bore anyone's name.

Maheshwar Rai came along with the milk vehicle.

The vehicle slowed as it passed.

From behind the glass, he raised a hand.

Budhan raised his hand too.

That was all.

The next morning Budhan set out again with the animals.

This time he did not turn towards the culvert.

He went straight to the old crossing.

He crossed the three slabs.

On the far side, the old footpath was still faint in the grass.

The goats wandered a little, each tearing grass in a different direction.

Budhan kept calling them on.

Within two days, a brown line appeared again through the grass.

Within seven days, the line was clear.

But it was not exactly as it had been before.

Coming up to the road, it now climbed onto the three concrete slabs.

It crossed the drain.

It touched the little rough slope beside the paved strip.

Then it descended on the far side.

The old footpath did not remove the new road.

Nor could the new road erase the footpath completely.

At one small place, each altered the shape of the other.

On Sunday, Runki opened her notebook again.

She did not cross out the old step-count.

Nor did she cross out the step-count of the new detour.

Underneath, she wrote—

‘After the drain crossing was made—measure again.’

Budhan looked at the notebook.

“You’ll count your steps again?”

“Yes.”

“What will you do with all this measuring?”

Runki said,

“I’ll see how much shorter the route has become.”

Budhan smiled.

“The route hasn’t become shorter.”

“Then?”

“The detour has become smaller.”

Runki asked,

“What’s the difference?”

Budhan looked towards the road.

Then towards the grazing ground.

“A path is where it has to take you.”

Runki did not write that sentence either.

She closed the notebook.

The morning sun was falling on the black paved surface of the road.

Vehicles moved along it.

On the three slabs at the side, a little earth clung from the goats’ hooves.

Those marks of earth did not spread across the road.

They ran only from this side of the drain to the other.

And beyond them, through the grass, a slender footpath was beginning to form again.

The Pond Keeper

On a Jeth evening, the pond water shone from afar like a thin sheet of metal.

On the western side of the village the fields had turned from yellow to grey, but in the pond's northern corner two or three clumps of reeds were still green.

Near those reeds, an egret stood on one leg.

Just behind the egret, Vanshi Mahato was pushing a slender bamboo rod into the water.

Small marks, cut long ago with a knife, ran along the rod.

Some marks had worn smooth; some were still sharp.

Vanshi Mahato turned the rod once to the right and examined it.

Then he bent towards the surface of the water.

"Another half an inch lower today," he said to himself.

The pond was called Kajraha.

No one in the village could now say whether the name had come from the colour of the water or from the dark grass that had once grown along the pond's edge.

For Vanshi Mahato, the question of the name did not matter.

He watched the water.

How much it had fallen and when, when it had risen at the same time as the well water, when the eastern drain had brought in silt—all this lived in his memory as separate years.

People in the village called him "the keeper of the pond."

It was not an official post.

He had neither an appointment letter nor a monthly wage.

Long ago, on the communal fishing day, he would be given five seers of fish.

Sometimes, after the paddy harvest, two paseris of grain.

Later, even that stopped.

But the name remained—the keeper.

That evening Vanshi was pulling the rod out when dust rose from the direction of the road.

First came a small truck.

Behind it came an excavator.

Last came Arun Thakur on a motorcycle.

Arun was not from this village.

He lived at the other end of the district and was the new contractor.

The panchayat had awarded the contract for the “restoration” of Kajraha pond.

On paper, the work was clear: remove silt, strengthen the banks, repair the paved ghat on the southern side, put up safety fencing all around, and clear the drainage before the rains.

The contract period was eighteen days.

On the first day, Arun walked all around the pond and inspected it.

With him were two labourers, the excavator driver, and Rajiv, the panchayat assistant.

Rajiv carried the measurement ledger.

Vanshi Mahato stood there with his bamboo rod.

Looking towards the northern bank, Arun said,

“If we dig from here, we’ll get good silt.”

The driver nodded.

Vanshi Mahato said,

“Don’t remove silt from here.”

For the first time, Arun looked at him properly.

“Why?”

“This is the silt basin.”

Arun did not understand.

Vanshi pointed to the narrow drain on the northern side.

“In the rains, runoff from the fields comes here first. The soil settles here. The middle of the pond stays clear.”

Arun did not laugh, but impatience was plain on his face.

“Uncle, on the plan this is part of the pond too.”

“It is part of the pond. That is why it must be left.”

Rajiv looked up from the ledger.

Arun said again,

“We’ll deepen it. It will hold more water.”

Vanshi rested the rod on the ground.

“The deep part is in the middle. The shallow edge has a different job.”

“The work will be done according to the plan.”

“Water doesn’t read plans.”

Rajiv gave a faint smile.

Arun did not.

He did not prolong the argument on the first day.

The labourers began cutting away the brush gathered near the southern ghat.

The excavator moved down to the western side.

Vanshi Mahato planted his bamboo rod in the northern corner and went home.

At dawn on the second day, the sound of the machine reached the village.

Earth rose in scoop after scoop and piled up on the bank.

Children stood at a distance and watched.

Vanshi Mahato arrived at around nine.

He had an old spade in his hand.

He went towards the eastern outlet.

Roots of kans grass and dry leaves were clogged there.

He began clearing them slowly.

Arun saw him from a distance.

“Uncle, the labourers will do that.”

Vanshi did not answer.

After a while Arun came over.

“The labourers are working on the western side right now.”

Vanshi said,

“Then who will open the eastern mouth?”

“We’ll clear it tomorrow.”

“And if it rains tomorrow?”

The sky was completely clear.

Arun looked up.

“Rain today?”

“I’m not talking about rain. I’m talking about the mouth doing its job.”

This time Arun laughed.

“All right. Clear it.”

Vanshi Mahato kept working the spade.

By noon, the narrow eastern channel was clear.

Tiny snail shells gleamed along its edge.

Without picking up a single shell, Vanshi scraped the earth away from beside it.

On the third day, it was the turn of the shallow northern section.

The excavator reached it.

Vanshi Mahato was already standing there.

Arun stopped the vehicle.

“Uncle, move aside.”

Vanshi did not move.

“Leave this section.”

“If we leave it, the measurement will fall short.”

“You’ll damage the pond just to make up the measurement?”

Arun’s voice hardened.

“I haven’t come here to damage the pond. I have a responsibility.”

Vanshi said,

“So do I.”

“Whose responsibility is on paper?”

The question hung in the air for a moment.

Vanshi Mahato looked at Arun’s face.

Then at his own bamboo rod.

“On paper, yours.”

He said softly,

“In the water, mine.”

Arun signalled to the driver to switch off the machine.

“Rajiv!”

Rajiv came running.

Arun said,

“Call the panchayat head. Let this be decided today.”

By afternoon, the pond bank had turned into a small gathering.

The village head, Usha Devi, arrived.

With her came the ward member, two farmers, Ramdin the fisherman, and a few curious villagers.

Usha Devi first listened to Arun.

Opening a page of the measurement ledger, Arun said,

“The contract requires this much cubic earth to be removed. If we leave the northern section, the quantity will fall short. Then the accounts will get held up.”

Usha Devi looked at Vanshi.

“What do you say?”

With the edge of his spade, Vanshi Mahato drew a crescent in the soil.
“The drain releases water here.”

He drew a small line through the middle of the crescent.

“In the first hard rain, the silt spreads here.”

Then he pointed towards the middle of the pond.

“This bank catches the silt. If you dig it out, the soil from the first rains will go straight into the deep part.”

Ramdin said,

“Fish fry live here too.”

Arun immediately asked,

“What kind of fish?”

Ramdin fell silent.

He did not have a definite answer.

Vanshi Mahato did not come to Ramdin’s rescue.

He said,

“Leave the fish aside. Talk about the silt.”

Arun looked at the lines drawn in the earth.

“All this is guesswork.”

“Yes.”

Vanshi said it calmly.

“And some of it is what I have seen.”

“Where is it written down?”

Vanshi lifted his bamboo rod.

“Here.”

A few people laughed.

Usha Devi did not.

She took the bamboo rod in her hand.

“What are these marks?”

Touching each mark in turn, Vanshi said,

“This is Jeth from three years ago. This is Ashadh that year, when the pond filled in two nights. This is Bhadon last year. This is Kartik the year the water fell before its time.”

“Dates?”

“There are no dates.”

Arun said,

“That is exactly the problem.”

Vanshi Mahato accepted it.

“Yes, that is the problem.”

His agreement surprised Arun a little.

Vanshi continued,

“I could not write it down. But you can.”

The gathering did not reach an immediate solution.

Usha Devi said work on the northern section should be stopped for two days.

Excavation could continue elsewhere.

Arun's face fell.

“I'll lose two days.”

“Work elsewhere.”

“And the measurement?”

“We'll look at the measurement again.”

The gathering dispersed.

Arun remained silent until evening.

Vanshi Mahato sat beside the eastern channel.

As the sun went down, the water turned yellow.

An egret landed in the shallow margin and took two steps.

Arun came over while gathering his papers.

“Uncle.”

Vanshi looked up.

“Do you think I'm your opponent?”

Vanshi thought for a moment.

“No.”

“Then why did you stand in front of the machine?”

“Because the machine did not know me.”

At first Arun did not understand.

Vanshi rested his hand on the handle of the spade.

“You know me. The machine doesn't.”

Arun said nothing.

He kept looking towards the middle of the pond.

After a while he asked,

“Do you object to the fence too?”

Vanshi said,

“To a complete fence.”

“Children can fall in.”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

“Leave two slopes for livestock. Leave one ghat. Put fencing around the rest.”

Arun looked at him in surprise.

“So you aren’t against the fence?”

“I’m against closing off the pond.”

This time Arun smiled.

“There’s a difference?”

“A great deal.”

The wind changed during the night.

Lightning flashed far to the north.

It did not rain, but the smell of earth rose in the air.

The next morning Arun took Rajiv with him to inspect the northern drain.

Vanshi Mahato was already there.

This time Arun had brought a measuring tape.

He measured the width of the drain.

Then the shallow crescent-shaped section.

Then the depth in the middle of the pond.

Rajiv kept writing the figures in the measurement ledger.

Vanshi watched in silence.

Arun asked,

“How much of the silt basin should be left?”

Vanshi marked the boundary with his spade.

“From here to here.”

“That much?”

“You can make it smaller.”

Arun replied at once,

“Yesterday you were saying leave it.”

“I said leave it. How much to leave can be measured.”

Arun stretched the measuring tape across the ground.

He measured twice.

Then he said,

“If we leave this much, we’ll have to remove a little more earth from the deep western section.”

Vanshi asked,

“How far down is the old bed there?”

Instead of answering, Arun looked at Rajiv.

Rajiv turned the pages of the ledger.

"It hasn't been fully checked."

Vanshi said,

"Check that first."

This time Arun did not get irritated.

By noon, bamboo poles had been lowered at three places in the western section to test it.

There really was more silt there than in the middle.

The measurements were redrawn.

The required quantity could almost be met.

More than half of the northern silt basin could be saved.

Arun said,

"All right. The machine won't enter here."

Vanshi Mahato did not immediately thank him.

He asked,

"And the eastern outlet?"

Arun burst out laughing.

"Will you settle every account at once?"

"Rain falls everywhere at once."

Arun nodded.

"We'll look at that too."

The contract work picked up speed again.

Silt was removed from the western side.

Two broken steps at the southern ghat were rebuilt.

Posts were planted for the fence.

Vanshi Mahato came every day, but he no longer stood in front of the machine.

Sometimes he checked the distance of the fencing; sometimes he pulled out grass caught in the outlet.

Whenever Arun saw him, he would ask, "Uncle, what's left now?"

Most days Vanshi said nothing.

One day he said,

"Move this post two cubits back."

Arun put a hand to his head.

"Again?"

Vanshi pointed to old hoof marks in the earth along the bank.

"Cattle come down here."

Arun said,

"I'm already leaving two slopes."

"This is the third."

"I can't leave three."

Vanshi remained silent for a while.

Then he said,

"All right. Close this one. But make the eastern slope wider."

Arun looked at him.

"Don't you want to win every point?"

Vanshi Mahato laughed.

"Is the pond a wrestling match?"

The question stayed with Arun.

On the evening of the twelfth day, the first heavy rain fell.

The sky suddenly turned black.

The dust settled.

The unpaved paths began to shine.

Arun had gone out of the village that day.

Vanshi Mahato sat on his veranda and watched the rain.

When it grew heavier, he rose with his walking stick.

His daughter-in-law stopped him.

"Where are you going in this rain?"

"To the pond."

"Now?"

"Now is when it has to be seen."

He went out without taking an umbrella.

When he reached the pond, the eastern drain was not roaring, but it was running fast.

Muddy water from the northern fields was spreading across the shallow crescent-shaped section.

There, the current slowed.

The first thin layer of silt settled along the margin.

The water in the middle was still a little clearer than that.

Vanshi Mahato went to his bamboo rod.

The water had risen by two marks.

He did nothing.

He only watched.

That night it rained for three hours.

At dawn Arun came straight to the pond.

His clothes were smeared with mud up to the knees.

Vanshi was already there.

Arun looked at the northern section.

The new silt was plainly visible.

With the edge of the spade he checked its thickness.

“This much from one rain?”

Vanshi said,

“This was a small rain.”

Arun looked towards the middle of the pond.

“If we had dug this section out...”

Vanshi did not finish the sentence for him.

He only said,

“Then next monsoon you would have seen where the silt settled.”

Arun was silent for a while.

Then he called Rajiv.

“Bring the measurement ledger.”

Rajiv brought it.

Arun said,

“Write a note.”

“What?”

Arun looked towards the northern section.

“The shallow northern strip has been retained to trap silt entering with runoff.”

Rajiv wrote it down.

Arun continued,

“The eastern outlet is to be kept open.”

Rajiv wrote that too.

Vanshi Mahato kept looking at the page in the ledger.

There was no triumph on his face.

Suddenly he said,

“One thing is wrong.”

Arun looked startled.

“What?”

“Don’t write that it was left because I said so.”

Arun looked at the ledger.

“I haven’t written that.”

“Good.”

“Why?”

Vanshi planted the bamboo rod in the water.

"Tomorrow I may not be here. The ledger should contain the reason, not the name."

Rajiv stopped in the middle of writing.

Arun said quietly,

"All right."

The work was completed on the seventeenth day.

The fencing was installed, but the southern ghat and the wide livestock slope on the eastern side were left open.

The northern silt basin remained intact.

The western section was deepened.

At the mouth of the outlet, instead of an iron grille, a thick bamboo barrier like a removable lattice was fitted, so that leaves caught there could be cleared away.

At first Vanshi Mahato was doubtful about this.

Arun said,

"A fine iron grille would trap the leaves. You were right about that."

Vanshi said,

"I wasn't against iron."

"I know."

"I was against a fine mouth."

"I know that too."

On the eighteenth day, the panchayat came for inspection.

Usha Devi walked all around.

She checked the accounts.

The measurements matched.

The work was declared complete.

People looked at the new ghat, the fencing, and the deep water.

No one paid special attention to the shallow northern section.

There, two small birds were pecking at the thin layer of muddy silt.

Vanshi Mahato sat at a distance in the shade of a peepal tree.

When the inspection was over, Arun came to him.

"Uncle, the contract is finished now."

"Yes."

"And your work?"

Vanshi looked at the pond.

"The contract is finished. The pond isn't."

Arun laughed.

"You've started again."

Vanshi smiled too.

Arun took a new measuring rod out of his bag.

It was not an ordinary bamboo pole.

It was a slender iron rod, marked and numbered at every inch.

"This is for you."

Vanshi did not reach for it.

"Is there something wrong with my bamboo?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Keep both."

Vanshi took the new rod.

He planted it beside the old bamboo one.

The two rods stood side by side in the water.

The old bamboo carried no dates.

The new rod carried numbers.

Vanshi looked at both.

Then he said to Arun,

"When the next rain comes, you will write down the first mark."

Arun asked,

"Me?"

"In your ledger."

Arun was silent for a moment.

"I won't be here."

"Then Rajiv will write it."

"And if Rajiv isn't here either?"

Vanshi looked at the pond water.

"Then whoever is here will write it."

Evening was descending.

Sunlight broke through a gap in the clouds in the western sky.

The shadows of the new fence posts fell across the water.

Between those shadows, the old bamboo rod and the new measuring rod were both visible.

The rain-deposited silt along the edge was still soft.

Three slender egret footprints marked that soft silt.

Vanshi Mahato looked at the prints.

He did not measure them.

He simply kept them in his memory.

Evening at the Cattle Shed

Agahan evenings descended early.

The sun had dipped beyond the empty paddy fields.

A crow cawed twice on the cattle-shed roof and flew away.

Jagarnath Yadav sat on the field ridge beside the heap of dung.

A slender bamboo stick was in his hand.

His eyes were on the cattle shed.

Naresh brought a long wooden board from the courtyard.

Five columns had been drawn on it in white chalk.

At the top were written—

“Name.”

“Milk.”

“Fodder.”

“Medicine.”

“Remarks.”

Jagarnath looked at the board.

“What is this?”

Naresh leaned the board against the wall.

“The evening register.”

“Will the cattle shed run by a register?”

“If the cattle shed runs by guesswork, how will we understand the expense?”

Jagarnath did not laugh.

There were eight animals in the cattle shed.

Five cows, two calves, and one old cow.

Jagarnath had named them all.

Dhauri.

Kajri.

Phulwa.

Supti.

Birni.

The two calves were named Tikuli and Sonari.

The old cow was named Jhumki.

On Naresh's register, the column beside the names was blank.

He picked up the chalk and wrote—

"Dhauri — 5.2"

"Kajri — 4.7"

"Phulwa — 6.1"

"Supti — 2.8"

"Birni — 3.9"

Beside Jhumki's name he wrote—

"0.6"

Jagarnath's gaze stopped at that number.

"Zero point six?"

"This evening."

"She has grown old."

"That is what I'm saying."

"What?"

Naresh put down the chalk.

"Fodder will fall short this winter."

Jagarnath remained silent.

"Jhumki eats all day," Naresh said, "and gives around half a seer of milk. She has already needed medicine twice. If we sell her, the pressure on fodder will ease."

Jagarnath looked toward the cattle shed.

Jhumki was tethered beside Supti.

Supti was a young cow that had calved for the first time.

That was why the evening milking was most troublesome with her.

Jhumki stood beside her, quietly chewing the cud.

"Sell her today?" Jagarnath asked.

"Not today. The market is the day after tomorrow."

"So by the day after tomorrow she will increase her milk?"

Naresh grew irritated.

"Babu, this isn't about increasing milk. It's about the accounting."

"Does everything enter the accounting?"

"Anything that matters can."

Jagarnath scratched the earth with his stick.

"Then write it."

"What?"

“Supti gives milk because Jhumki stays beside her.”

Naresh looked at the register.

“Is that something measured?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“Measure it.”

Naresh looked at his father’s face.

There was no laughter in Jagarnath’s voice.

The evening work of the cattle shed began.

First, straw was put into the troughs.

Then came a thin mash of bran.

Naresh had changed the portions from that month.

In place of the small brass bowl, he had brought an iron measuring vessel.

Two measures for Dhauri.

One and a half for Kajri.

Two for Phulwa.

One and a half for Supti.

One for Birni.

Half for Jhumki.

Earlier Jagarnath fed them all by eye.

“So little?”

“It is enough for Jhumki.”

“Have you looked at her body?”

“I estimated her weight.”

“Estimated?”

“I measured the girth of her chest.”

Jagarnath fell silent again.

He did not dislike what Naresh had said.

Without saying anything, he ran a hand over Jhumki’s back.

Her bones were not jutting out as they once had.

“All right,” he said.

Naresh was surprised.

“What?”

“Not half. Give three-quarters.”

“Why?”

“Winter is beginning.”

Naresh wrote on the register in chalk—

“Jhumki — fodder 0.75.”

Jagarnath said,

“If you keep writing zero point this and zero point that, the cow won’t understand.”

Naresh laughed.

“The cow won’t read it.”

“You will.”

For the first time that evening, both of them laughed.

But the matter did not end there.

The next day Naresh began changing the order of the tethering ropes in the cattle shed.

His idea was that the cows giving more milk should stand on one side.

Those giving less on the other.

That would make feeding easier.

It would take less time to move the milking bucket.

Recording the amount of milk would be easier too.

“Dhauri, Phulwa, Kajri in this row.”

He said this while untying the ropes from the posts.

“Supti and Birni in that row.”

Jagarnath asked,

“Jhumki?”

“At the end.”

“Not beside Supti?”

“It will disturb the order.”

Jagarnath said nothing.

He untied Jhumki and tethered her where Naresh had said.

By evening the new arrangement looked neat and orderly.

Equal distances.

Equal open space in front of the troughs.

A clear path for placing the buckets.

Naresh was satisfied.

Dhauri was milked first.

Then Phulwa.

Kajri.

Everything went well.

Then came Supti’s turn.

Naresh washed her udder.

Supti kicked a hind leg.

“Move.”

Naresh sat down again.

Supti lashed her tail.

The bucket overturned.

There was no milk in it, only the washing water.

Naresh picked up the bucket.

“What happened today?”

Jagarnath stood a little way off.

“Ask the register.”

Naresh did not look at him.

He stroked Supti’s head.

The cow stretched her neck and looked toward the other row.

Jhumki was there.

Supti lowed loudly again.

Jhumki answered with a soft sound.

Naresh untied the rope.

“All right.”

He tethered Jhumki beside Supti again.

Supti shifted her feet twice.

Then she stood still.

Naresh sat down to milk her.

This time the bucket did not overturn.

Jagarnath said,

“Write it.”

Naresh said nothing.

After the milking, he went to the board.

In the “Remarks” column he wrote—

“Supti — calm when Jhumki is beside her.”

Jagarnath read the words.

“Measured now?”

“Half measured.”

“Why only half?”

“It is only one day’s observation.”

“All right.”

On the third day, Naresh deliberately did not move Jhumki away again.

Supti remained calm.

The fourth day as well.

On the fifth day Jagarnath himself said,
“Now write it—three days.”

Naresh wrote it.

On the sixth day, something else emerged from his register.
Birni’s milk had been falling steadily.

From 3.9 to 3.6.

From 3.6 to 3.3.

From 3.3 to 3.1.

Jagarnath kept saying,

“The weather is changing.”

Naresh said,

“The weather changes for all of them. Why only Birni?”

Jagarnath looked at Birni’s head.

Her eyes were clear.

Her nose was moist.

Her gait was normal.

She was chewing the cud as well.

“Nothing is wrong with her.”

Naresh looked at the trough.

Bran was almost always left in Birni’s trough.

“Why does she leave this?”

“Perhaps she does not like it.”

“She used to eat it before.”

Naresh looked at the fodder register from the previous week.

The decline had begun on the day the new straw arrived.

He took some straw in his hand.

There was more fine dust in it.

Jagarnath also took some in his hand.

He brought it to his nose and smelled it.

“This is straw from the bottom of the stack.”

“What does that mean?”

“It had got damp and was dried again.”

“Bad?”

“Not bad. But Birni is avoiding this smell.”

“Why didn’t you tell me earlier?”

Jagarnath did not answer directly.

“All the cows are eating from the same stack.”

Naresh said,

"But only one cow's milk is falling."
 They looked at each other.
 This time there was no argument.
 Naresh set aside some of the older, dry straw for Birni.
 Two days later her milk was 3.4.
 The next day, 3.6.
 Naresh wrote in the register—
 "Possible effect of the smell of the straw."
 Jagarnath was pleased to read the word "possible."
 "That is a good word."
 "Why?"
 "Not everything becomes certain at once."
 Naresh handed him the chalk.
 "Then you write too."
 Jagarnath did not take the chalk.
 "My writing is slow."
 "Is the cattle shed running away?"
 Jagarnath looked at him.
 Naresh was smiling.
 Jagarnath took the chalk.
 "What should I write?"
 "What you see."
 "Everything?"
 "What is useful for the register."
 Jagarnath wrote on the first line—
 "Phulwa — in the evening she slightly favors the left leg."
 The letters were crooked.
 Naresh read them.
 "Since when?"
 "Since yesterday."
 "Why didn't you tell me?"
 "I was watching. If it was there today too, I would have told you."
 Naresh lifted Phulwa's foot.
 A small pebble was lodged between the hooves.
 He took it out.
 He washed the foot.
 Phulwa stood normally again.
 Jagarnath said,

“Now write—cause found.”

Naresh wrote it.

From that day a new column was added to the board.

Naresh wrote at the top—

“Observation.”

Jagarnath asked,

“Wasn’t there already ‘Remarks?’”

“That was mine.”

“Whose is ‘Observation?’”

“Yours.”

Jagarnath said,

“Observation is not only mine.”

Naresh had not written “yours” in chalk.

He left only the word “Observation.”

A week later a livestock-feed trader came.

He looked at Jhumki.

“She is old. Will you sell her?”

Before answering, Naresh looked at the register.

Jhumki’s milk figure was small.

The cost of her fodder looked large beside it.

There were two marks in the medicine column.

But three things were written in the “Observation” column—

“Supti is calm when she stays beside her.”

“The calf Sonari shares the trough with her.”

“At night, when the herd stirs, she calls out first.”

The trader asked,

“How much?”

Naresh said,

“Not now.”

Jagarnath looked at Naresh.

Naresh did not look at him.

The trader left.

At night Jagarnath asked,

“You won’t sell her?”

“The accounting isn’t complete yet.”

“The milk figure is complete.”

“The accounting of the cattle shed is not only milk.”

Jagarnath smiled.

“Where did you learn that?”

“From the register.”

Jagarnath understood that Naresh was turning his own answer back on him.

He did not pursue the matter.

But the fact that Jhumki had been spared brought him relief.

The relief was not hidden.

Naresh saw it.

A few days later the problem came from the opposite direction.

While distributing the evening fodder, Jagarnath dropped an extra handful of bran into Supti's trough.

Naresh saw him.

“Now what is this?”

“Her body is asking for it.”

“She has had her full measure today.”

“Look at her eyes.”

“Will we measure her stomach with her eyes?”

Jagarnath was silent.

Naresh looked at the register.

Supti's milk had risen over the previous four days.

From 2.8 to 3.4.

From 3.4 to 3.9.

From 3.9 to 4.2.

Calculations ran through Naresh's mind.

If milk had increased, fodder should increase too.

But adding a whole handful at once was not right.

He said,

“From tomorrow we'll increase the portion by a quarter. No extra today.”

Jagarnath put half the handful of bran back into the vessel.

“Half?”

“Half.”

They laughed again.

The work of the cattle shed had now become less an argument and more a negotiation.

How much fodder.

How much rest.

Whose rope where.

How many times which calf should be allowed near its mother.
 When a cow's milk fell, what should be checked first.
 Naresh kept the numbers.
 Jagarnath kept the signs.
 One day Naresh asked his father,
 "How did you name all the cows?"
 "As they seemed to me."
 "Kajri is black, that makes sense. Dhauri is white. Phulwa has a flower-
 like mark on her forehead. But Supti?"
 Jagarnath laughed.
 "When she was little, she slept all day."
 "And Jhumki?"
 "The end of her tail looked like a tassel."
 Naresh had written small numbers beside the names in the register.
 1, 2, 3, 4.
 One day Jagarnath asked,
 "Have you run out of names?"
 "No. Numbers are easier on medicine slips."
 "Will the names remain?"
 "They will."
 That evening Naresh brought small iron tags.
 On one side of each tag was a number; on the other, a name.
 Jagarnath picked one up and read—
 "4 — Supti."
 "Both?"
 "Both."
 "Why?"
 "One for you and one for me."
 "What a foolish thing to say."
 "Then?"
 "Both are for her."
 Naresh did not answer.
 He hung the tag above the rope.
 By the first week of Paush, the evenings had grown colder.
 A thin layer of mist rose from the fields and drifted toward the cattle
 shed.
 Jagarnath now wrapped himself in a thick blanket in the evenings.
 Naresh placed dry fodder in the troughs.

One day the electricity went out.

The courtyard went dark.

Naresh began reading the register by the light of his phone.

Jagarnath said,

“Lower the light. The animals are getting frightened.”

Naresh lowered the light.

It was difficult to record the milk quantities in the dark.

“Leave it today?” Jagarnath said.

“No.”

“Why?”

“If we leave one day, tomorrow we’ll say two days.”

Jagarnath leaned his stick against a post.

“Then I say milk them first. The numbers can come later.”

They began working in the dark.

The sound of milking was clear.

Milk fell into the bucket in a stream.

The cows’ breathing.

The rubbing of the calves’ ropes.

The crackle of dry straw.

Jhumki’s low call.

Supti’s answer.

For the first time Naresh felt that even without seeing, half the condition of the cattle shed could be understood by sound.

The milking ended.

The light was switched on again.

Naresh wrote down the measurements.

In the “Observation” column Jagarnath wrote—

“All calm in the dark.”

Naresh read it and laughed.

“Is this useful for the register?”

Jagarnath said,

“You’ll understand tomorrow if it is dark again.”

Naresh did not erase it.

By the time Magh approached, the board had filled up.

Old figures were erased and new ones written.

But there were some remarks Naresh would not allow to be erased.

“Supti — calm when Jhumki is beside her.”

“Birni — eats less straw that has been damp.”

“Phulwa — check the left foot.”

“Jhumki — little milk, but a different use within the herd.”

Jagarnath read the last line.

“Who wrote this ‘different use’?”

“I did.”

“It isn’t clear.”

“Then you write it.”

Jagarnath took the chalk.

He erased the old line.

He wrote a new one—

“Jhumki — keep her with Supti; the calves heed her.”

Naresh read it.

“It’s long.”

“Truth can be long.”

“The register is small.”

“Then make a bigger register.”

Two days later Naresh brought a thick paper file from the market.

On the first page he wrote—

“Evening at the Cattle Shed.”

Jagarnath asked,

“The register has a name too?”

“I gave it one.”

“Why evening?”

“Because the arguments happen in the evening.”

Jagarnath burst into laughter.

For a moment all the cows in the cattle shed raised their heads and looked.

Naresh laughed too.

Then he drew two broad columns on the first page.

On the left he wrote—

“Measure.”

On the right he wrote—

“Observation.”

Jagarnath asked,

“What goes in the middle?”

“In the middle?”

“What is neither a measurement nor merely an observation.”

Naresh thought for a while.

Then he left a narrow blank space between the two columns.
“Here?”
Jagarnath said,
“We’ll understand that later.”
That evening the sun was red.
Smoke lay across the empty fields.
Somewhere in the distance, stubble was burning.
Inside the cattle shed, Jhumki was chewing the cud.
Supti stood calmly beside her.
Phulwa was bearing her weight evenly on her left foot.
Birni was eating the older dry straw.
Naresh measured the milk and wrote it down.
Jagarnath kept looking over the animals’ bodies.
After a while Naresh held out the file to him.
“You write today’s observation.”
Jagarnath took a pen, not chalk.
Slowly he wrote—
“Evening fine.”
Naresh read it.
“Only this much?”
“This much today.”
“Nothing special?”
“Nothing being special is also something.”
Naresh looked at the left-hand column of the page.
All the numbers were normal.
He looked at the right-hand column.
Only two words—“Evening fine.”
The narrow blank space in the middle was still empty.
Naresh did not try to fill it.
Outside, the darkness was deepening.
Jagarnath picked up his stick.
“Come, let’s eat.”
Naresh closed the file.
He checked the ropes in the cattle shed once more.
Jhumki and Supti stood side by side.
Both the number and the name shone on the iron tag.
Naresh turned off the light.
In the darkness, the first sound was Jhumki’s slow chewing of the cud.

Then Supti's breathing.
And after that, nothing.
The evening really was fine.

The Mango Orchard

It was the first week of Jeth.

Noon had not yet fully risen, but the dust on Belahi's unpaved road had begun to turn pale in the light.

The car from the city stopped beside the mango orchard.

Amarnath got out first.

Then his wife Kavita and their daughter Richa.

The driver pulled the car to the side of the road in search of shade.

Amarnath took a folded paper from his pocket.

Three figures were written on it.

The total area of the land.

The agreed price per kattha.

And the date of registration.

Kavita asked, "Will Badri Kaka be here?"

Amarnath looked at his watch.

"He said he would be in the orchard."

Richa looked inside the orchard.

Mango trees stretched far into the distance.

Some trees were heavy with fruit; some had very little.

Some branches rested on bamboo supports.

Dry leaves, small unripe mangoes, and branches broken by the previous night's storm lay on the ground.

It was Richa's first visit to this orchard.

She had lived in the city since birth.

She had heard stories about her grandfather's house, but the house had been sold five years earlier.

Only the orchard had remained.

"Is it this big?" she asked.

Folding the paper, Amarnath said, "It is as large as the papers say."

Then a voice came from inside.

"Trees do not become more or fewer because of what a paper says."

Badri Mahato emerged carrying a bamboo basket.

An old gamchha was draped around his body.

There was mud on his feet.

Behind him, a teenage boy came dragging a broken branch.

Amarnath smiled.

“Kaka, I was talking about the acreage.”

“The acreage is correct.”

Badri set the basket on the ground.

“The accounting of the trees is separate.”

Amarnath paid no attention to the remark.

“Where is Devkinandan Babu?”

“He should be coming.”

“He’ll have the measurements checked again today, and the papers will be ready tomorrow.”

Badri looked at the folded paper in Amarnath’s hand.

“Does the paper also say anything about this year’s mangoes?”

Amarnath paused.

“The mangoes?”

“Yes.”

“The mangoes belong to the orchard.”

“The orchard belongs to you.”

Badri spoke softly.

“But this year’s fruit has already been contracted out.”

Kavita turned toward him.

“How?”

Badri took a small oil-stained cloth pouch from inside the basket.

Inside it was a folded receipt.

There was writing in blue ink on the paper.

At the top was a date from the month of Phagun.

Below it was written: twenty-five thousand rupees in advance for this year’s mangoes from sixty-two fruit-bearing trees.

In the place for the signature was the name of Amarnath’s father, Shyamanand Jha.

Amarnath read the paper twice.

“Babuji never told me about this.”

Badri did not reply.

Kavita asked, “Is that his signature?”

Amarnath held the paper up toward the sunlight.

"It looks like his."

Richa asked, "Why sixty-two trees? There are more than that here."

Badri motioned for her to walk farther inside.

"Come, I'll show you."

In the first row of the orchard, thin white rings of lime marked the trunks of some trees.

Others had no rings.

Badri placed a hand on one tree.

"This is a Dasheri. It has little fruit this year."

He pointed to another tree.

"This is a Maldah. This one is included in the deal."

A branch on a third tree was dry.

"This one hasn't been right for three years."

Richa noticed a small red thread tied around a trunk.

"What is this thread?"

"The fruit trader's man tied it."

Amarnath frowned.

"Kaka, I think Babuji must only have taken some money, and the rest would have been settled later."

"Yes."

"Then once the orchard is sold, we can settle the account."

Badri looked at him.

"The account of the money can be settled."

"Then?"

"Fruit is not money."

Amarnath fell silent.

Badri walked on.

In the middle of the orchard stood a small old brick platform.

An earthen water pot had been kept there.

An inverted brass bowl rested on top of the pot.

Badri drank some water.

Then he said, "Raghunath Sah made the deal after looking at the fruit in Phagun."

"He paid twenty-five thousand."

"Since then, medicines, guarding, bamboo, labour—some expenses have been his, some mine."

"If the crop is poor, the loss is his."

"If it is good, the profit is his."

“The land still remains yours.”

Amarnath said, “But after registration the land will belong to Devkinandan Babu.”

“That is why I asked whether the papers say anything about the mangoes.”

From the road in the distance came the sound of a motorcycle.

A few moments later Raghunath Sah arrived.

He was of medium build.

A white gamchha was wrapped around his head.

He carried a small ledger.

He greeted Amarnath respectfully.

“How is Babuji’s health?”

“He is not keeping well.”

“I called twice.”

“He does not talk much these days.”

Raghunath nodded.

Then he asked directly, “Badri Kaka showed you the receipt?”

“He did.”

“I have to pay the remaining amount when the fruit is harvested.”

Amarnath asked, “What if I sell the orchard tomorrow?”

Raghunath closed his ledger.

“Sell the land.”

“I have not bought the land.”

“I have contracted this year’s fruit.”

“Will the new owner accept that?”

“That is a question for you to ask him.”

His tone was not harsh.

But the point was direct.

Kavita spoke in between.

“And if the new owner does not accept it?”

Raghunath looked at the trees for a while.

“Then I will take the loss.”

“Only the twenty-five thousand?”

“Twenty-five thousand was only the advance.”

“Add the medicines, smoke treatment, labour twice, bamboo—everything spent so far.”

Badri said, “And four nights of guarding during storms.”

Raghunath looked at him.

“That is Badri Kaka’s labour.”

“I will pay him separately for that.”

For the first time Richa understood that three different accounts were running within the same orchard.

The account of the land.

The account of the fruit.

And the account of guarding it.

The same trees appeared in all three.

But in each account, the trees were not the same kind of thing.

By noon Devkinandan Chaudhary arrived.

Two men who took measurements came with him.

Devkinandan did business between the town and the village.

He was more interested in the acreage than in the orchard itself.

Driving a bamboo stake at the boundary, he asked, “From here, how far north does it go?”

Badri pointed to an old shisham tree in the distance.

“In a straight line with the shisham.”

The surveyor stretched the measuring cord.

Devkinandan told Amarnath, “If registration is tomorrow, we’ll begin putting up the fence the day after.”

Raghunath was standing there.

“Put up the fence.”

Devkinandan looked at him.

“You?”

“I have contracted this year’s fruit.”

Devkinandan laughed.

“I am buying the land with the trees on it.”

“Buy the land with the trees.”

Raghunath said.

“The fruit has already been sold.”

The laughter stopped.

Amarnath held out the receipt.

Devkinandan read it.

“This was a private arrangement made by your Babuji.”

Amarnath said, “The arrangement concerns the fruit of the orchard.”

“But I agreed to the sale price after seeing an orchard full of fruit.”

At that, Amarnath fell silent.

It was true.

When the price had been agreed, Devkinandan had come to inspect the fruit.

Amarnath had been in the city.

Badri had shown him the trees.

Kavita asked softly, "So you did not know about this arrangement either?"

Devkinandan said, "No one told me."

Badri looked uncomfortable for the first time.

"I thought the owners would know."

Amarnath said, "I did not know."

Raghunath said, "I thought the buyer would be told later."

The four of them looked at one another.

Richa quietly sat down on the brick platform.

No koel called in the orchard.

There was only the faint rustle of leaves.

Somewhere in the distance came the sound of a hoe striking earth.

Devkinandan said, "Then the price will have to be negotiated again."

Amarnath said at once, "The price has already been settled."

"With the fruit."

"The paper does not mention the fruit."

"It mentions the trees."

"The trees and this year's fruit are not the same thing."

Devkinandan did not smile.

"Is this how you buy land in the city?"

Amarnath's tone changed.

"Do not speak to me as though I am some city outsider."

Badri stepped back two paces.

Kavita looked toward Richa.

She understood that the matter could now move from fruit to pride.

She said, "First let us understand how many days it will take to harvest the fruit."

Raghunath said, "The main crop, fifteen to twenty days."

"All of it?"

"No."

"Some trees are late-bearing."

"Until the end of Jeth."

Devkinandan asked, "Then for a month I am not to do any work on my own land?"

“Measure the boundary.”

Raghunath said.

“Put up the fence.”

“But do not cut or prune the fruit-bearing trees.”

Devkinandan narrowed his eyes.

“I am not planning to cut the trees now.”

It was the first time everyone realized that no one had clearly asked why he was buying the orchard.

Amarnath asked, “Will you keep the orchard?”

Devkinandan said, “Some of the trees.”

“I am thinking of building a storage shed in the vacant portion to the south.”

“The old trees on the north side will remain.”

Badri looked at him closely for the first time.

“Water stands longer in the north.”

Devkinandan said, “So?”

“The south is better for a storage shed.”

Devkinandan said nothing.

By afternoon the measurement was complete.

The figures were written down on paper.

Raghunath checked the number of trees again in his ledger.

Badri showed all sixty-two trees one by one.

Richa walked along with them.

She noticed that the red threads were not tied at the same height on every trunk.

Some trunks were thick.

Some were so slender that they hardly seemed old enough to be called trees.

Two green mangoes lay beneath one tree.

Richa picked one up.

Badri said, “That fell from one of the contracted trees.”

Richa turned the mango in her hand.

“Then does this belong to Raghunath Kaka?”

Raghunath laughed.

“I do not claim fallen green mangoes.”

“Why not?”

“If I did, I would have to carry home baskets full of windfall green mangoes.”

Richa placed the mango on the platform.

By evening the discussion still had no conclusion.

Devkinandan said the price should be reduced somewhat.

Amarnath did not agree.

Raghunath said that if he was to give up the fruit, the advance, expenses, and expected profit would have to be added together and settled.

Devkinandan did not agree to that.

Badri, in between, kept talking only about the trees.

“The first picking will be in three days.”

“If a strong wind comes, the date will change.”

“The fruit on four trees to the north will ripen late.”

All this irritated Amarnath.

What he saw was Monday’s registration, the train back to the city, and his leave from the office.

Raghunath saw the mango season.

Devkinandan saw the land coming into his possession.

Badri saw the trees.

That night they all stayed in the old village house.

The house no longer belonged to the family.

Its new owner lived in the city and had opened one room for them as guests.

Spreading a sheet on the charpoy, Kavita said, “I thought selling the orchard would be a two-day matter.”

Amarnath said, “If Babuji had told me this earlier, there would have been no complication.”

Richa asked, “Why did Dada sell the mangoes?”

“He must have done it every year.”

“I did not even know.”

“Why did you need to know?”

Richa fell silent.

After a while she said, “Then why do I need to know that the orchard is being sold?”

Amarnath did not answer.

Kavita kept looking at an old nail on the wall.

A photograph must once have hung there.

Now only a pale square remained.

In the middle of the night, the wind grew strong.

Leaves rustled across the tiled roof.

From the direction of the distant orchard came the knocking of bamboo.

At dawn Badri knocked on the door.

“Some fruit fell in the storm.”

Amarnath got up irritably.

“How much?”

“We should go and see.”

They all reached the orchard.

Mangoes were scattered across the ground.

Not many.

But enough to fill five or six baskets.

Raghunath was already there.

Two of his labourers were gathering the fruit.

Devkinandan had also arrived.

Looking at the fallen mangoes, he said, “This is why I say the price was fixed with the fruit included.”

Raghunath said, “And this is why I say the risk was mine.”

The two faced each other again.

Badri kept lifting the baskets.

Richa saw that the mangoes that had been on the branches yesterday were on the ground today.

The land was still where it had been.

The question of ownership was still where it had been.

But in a single night, the fruit had changed its condition.

She said to Kavita, “Ma, land papers do not change this quickly, do they?”

Kavita smiled.

“No.”

“Fruit changes.”

“Yes.”

“Then it must be difficult to write both in the same line.”

Kavita looked at her.

“That is why people write many lines.”

The morning light grew stronger.

Badri sorted the fallen fruit.

The unripe ones separately.

The bruised ones separately.

The sound fruit separately.

Raghunath's labourers were marking the baskets.

Devkinandan was asking the surveyor something about the boundary.

Amarnath sat on the brick platform with the receipt and the draft sale deed open before him.

Both sheets of paper fluttered in the wind.

On the small sheet were the fruits of sixty-two trees.

On the larger sheet was the entire land.

Suddenly Amarnath called Badri.

"Kaka."

"Yes?"

"How much of your guarding payment for this year is still due?"

Badri set down the basket.

"Why now?"

"Tell me."

Badri did not answer at once.

"Raghunath will pay me after the fruit is harvested."

From a distance Raghunath said, "I will pay him."

Amarnath asked, "How much?"

Raghunath opened his ledger.

"The two labourers are separate."

"Six thousand is still due to Badri Kaka for guarding."

"And the medicines?"

"That is my expense."

Amarnath wrote six thousand on the paper.

Devkinandan came closer.

"Are we making a new account now?"

"No."

Amarnath said.

"We are clearing the old account."

"I will not reduce the price."

Devkinandan said, "Then the fruit?"

"Raghunath Sah will take the fruit from the sixty-two marked trees this year."

"Until the end of Jeth."

"Until then Badri Kaka will look after the fruit and the trees."

"You may measure the boundary, put up the fence, and begin work on the vacant southern portion."

“No cutting on the fruit-bearing trees to the north until the end of Jeth.”

Devkinandan thought for a while.

“And if a branch breaks in a storm?”

Badri said, “If it must be cut for safety, cut it.”

“But tell me first.”

Devkinandan looked at Badri.

“You will tell me?”

“The land will be yours.”

“The fruit this year belongs to someone else.”

“The tree stands in between.”

For the first time Devkinandan laughed.

“The tree is in a bad position.”

Badri laughed too.

“A tree is always in between.”

On the day of registration, two additional lines were added to the draft.

The fruit from the sixty-two identified trees for this year shall be harvested under the prior arrangement until the end of Jeth.

Until that period, access to the orchard by the fruit trader and the keeper shall not be obstructed.

Devkinandan added one more line.

If any tree or the new fence is damaged during the harvesting of the fruit, the fruit trader shall compensate for the damage.

Raghunath read it and said, “Fine.”

Badri could not read.

Amarnath read the lines aloud to him.

Badri only asked, “Is the keeper mentioned in the paper?”

“Yes.”

“Then it is fine.”

The registration was completed in the afternoon.

The money reached the account.

In his mind Amarnath calculated how much of the remaining loan on the city house could now be repaid.

Kavita thought about the next expense for her mother’s treatment.

Richa sat in the shade of a neem tree outside the registration office.

Before returning, they all went to the orchard once more.

This time Devkinandan walked in front.

His men had planted new bamboo stakes along the boundary.

A red cloth had been tied to one of the stakes.

Inside that red marker began the old rows of mango trees.

Raghunath's man was checking again the threads tied to the sixty-two trees.

Badri was sawing off a dry branch.

Amarnath asked, "Kaka, after the end of Jeth?"

Badri stopped the saw.

"Then?"

"The guarding?"

Badri looked toward Devkinandan.

Devkinandan said, "I will need a man."

"But the account will be new."

Badri said, "Accounts are always new."

Amarnath said nothing.

Richa went to the tree beneath which she had picked up the green mango the day before.

The mango was no longer on the platform.

Perhaps someone had picked it up.

Perhaps it had rotted.

Perhaps some child had carried it away.

She did not look for it.

As the car was about to leave, Badri brought a small bag.

Kavita asked, "What is it?"

"Fallen mangoes."

From a distance Raghunath called out, "Those are not in my account."

Devkinandan burst out laughing.

Badri placed the bag in the car.

"These are from yesterday's storm."

Amarnath asked, "Who owns these?"

Badri said, "Whoever eats them."

The car started moving.

The orchard receded behind them.

The red boundary cloth flashed once, then disappeared among the trees.

Richa opened the bag.

The mangoes were still unripe.

She held one to her nose.

There was a faint fragrance.

In Amarnath's bag was the large registration document.

Inside it he had also kept the small receipt that had come out of Badri's old pouch.

Kavita asked, "Why are you taking that receipt with you?"

Amarnath said, "I'll show it to Babuji."

"But the account has been settled."

"Yes."

After a moment he said, "Still, I'll keep it."

Richa kept looking out of the window.

On both sides of the road lay empty paddy fields.

Behind them, in the orchard, the owner of the land had changed.

The fruit still belonged to the old deal.

The keeper was still there.

And the wind of Jeth knew the name of none of the three.

The Current of the Kamla

Bhado was drawing to a close.

This time the Kamla was not flowing past the eastern side of the village; it had cut across the south-eastern corner.

As a child wipes away a chalk line with the palm and draws it somewhere else, so the river had shifted its bank.

Sand gleamed in the bed of the old channel.

The earth beside the new current was still wet.

When a foot was set upon it, the heel sank half an inch.

Sudama Yadav was walking towards the ghat with three bamboo stakes tucked beneath his arm.

Behind him came his nephew Neeraj, carrying the measuring rope.

Neeraj lived in the city.

This year he had come to the village at his father's insistence.

The reason was land.

Six katthas on paper.

How much on the ground—that had been discussed at home for three days.

Sudama said, "River land is easy to measure on paper."

Neeraj replied, "And without paper, how do we know the land has been measured at all?"

Sudama smiled.

"You'll see this time."

Across the ghat stood an old silk-cotton tree.

Fifteen years earlier, Sudama's father had driven the first survey peg in line with that tree.

The peg was gone.

The tree remained.

That was why Sudama still treated the tree as the first marker for measurement.

But this time the river no longer lay between the silk-cotton tree and the field.

It had shifted far to the south of the tree.

There was sand through the middle of the old channel, and reeds had sprung up amid the sand.

Neeraj stretched out the rope.

“From here?”

Sudama said, “First take the line of the silk-cotton tree.”

“But the bank is over there.”

“The bank is over there today.”

Neeraj looked at him.

Sudama drove a bamboo stake into the ground.

“The river’s today and the paper’s yesterday are not the same thing.”

A woman’s voice came from a distance.

“Driving the pegs again?”

It was Phoolo Devi.

Her field adjoined Sudama’s.

She was coming with an empty basket balanced on her head.

Phoolo’s husband had died three years earlier.

Since then she had managed the field accounts herself.

She came closer and looked at the bamboo stake.

“So my field must have grown this time too?”

Neeraj laughed.

“The river has moved back, so consider the land increased.”

Phoolo did not laugh.

“Whose is the increased land?”

Neeraj’s laughter stopped.

Sudama said, “That is precisely why land is measured.”

Phoolo set the basket down on the sand.

“Measure it, but remember the old division.”

Sudama looked at her for a moment.

“I brought the bamboo precisely for remembering.”

Ramvilas, the village surveyor, was expected by noon.

It was not an official survey.

For now they were only matching the old markers so the household could understand the situation.

Neeraj opened a photograph of the land register on his phone.

The plot number was clear.

The boundary was written there—north: the current of the Kamla.

The whole dispute had caught on those four words.

“North: the current of the Kamla.”

If the current shifted, did the northern boundary shift too?

Phoolo said, “My father-in-law used to say the boundary ran from tree to tree.”

Neeraj asked, “Are the trees written in the document?”

“The document was never read out to me.”

“Then?”

“The field has been read.”

Sudama remained silent.

He did not like what Phoolo had said, yet it did not seem wrong either.

In the older way of farming, boundaries often depended less on paper and more on memory.

Which thorn tree stood on which ridge.

Where whose oxen used to turn.

From where whose first row of transplanting began.

All of that was recorded in people’s minds.

The river read no such register.

It simply cut, abandoned, and cut again.

Ramvilas arrived at noon.

He carried a measuring tape, an old survey notebook, and a small red-cloth pouch.

He first looked at the silk-cotton tree.

Then at the bamboo stake.

Then at the new current.

“Whose measurement do you want?”

Neeraj said at once, “Whether the full six katthas are there or not.”

Phoolo said, “And where my boundary is.”

Sudama said, “First recover the old line.”

Ramvilas listened to all three requests.

He said, “There are three questions. One measurement will not answer all three.”

Neeraj frowned.

“But the land is only one.”

With his foot Ramvilas drew three small lines in the sand.

“One—the area entered in the register.”

A second line.

“Two—the old boundary markers.”

A third line.

“Three—the land cultivable at present.”

He lifted his foot.

“On land by a river, these three are often not the same.”

Neeraj said, “Then how are we supposed to sell it?”

Sudama slowly turned his eyes towards him.

It was the first time Neeraj had spoken openly of selling.

At home he had spoken only of ‘clearing up the account.’

Phoolo turned her head towards Neeraj.

“Sell?”

Winding the rope, Neeraj said, “Father wants to clear the loan on the house in the city.”

Sudama said nothing.

He had not been unaware of this.

But beside the river, the word sounded different to him.

Ramvilas began his work.

The first bamboo stake was set in line with the silk-cotton tree.

From there they measured to the remains of the old ridge.

Half the ridge had been eaten away.

On the half that remained were two clumps of doob grass.

Pointing to one clump, Phoolo said, “My transplanting used to turn here.”

Sudama said, “So did mine.”

Ramvilas did not laugh.

“The two fields adjoined each other. Both rows turned here.”

He continued writing down the measurements.

Neeraj entered the figures on his phone.

A little farther on, the rope fell across the sand of the old channel.

No one cultivated there.

There were only reeds and timber washed down by the last flood.

Neeraj said, “But this is land.”

Phoolo said, “It may be, by Jeth.”

“What is it now?”

“Sand the river has left behind.”

Sudama said, “If it stays for two years, it will become a field.”

Neeraj was dissatisfied.

“The register says six katthas. I want a measurement.”

Ramvilas said, “I am giving you a measurement, not a verdict.”

They moved on.

By the time they reached the new current, the measuring tape lay across wet earth.

The river water was not clear.

The faintly muddy current slowly licked at the eroding bank.

Neeraj took off his shoes.

He had imagined the river had shifted a great distance away.

But standing on the bank of the new current, he understood that the river had not gone far; it had merely carried its question elsewhere.

Ramvilas did not drive a stake at the water's edge.

Neeraj asked, "No marker here?"

"Who knows where a marker beside water will be tomorrow?"

Five hands back from the bank, he drove in a short stake.

"This is only today's witness."

Phoolo said, "So the northern edge of my field is here too?"

Ramvilas said, "The cultivable ground ends here. The old boundary was not here."

"Then my land has become smaller?"

"The ground has become smaller. The question of rights is different."

Neeraj immediately asked, "And what about the sand that has appeared in the old channel?"

Ramvilas looked at him.

"Have you cultivated it yet?"

"No."

"Any ridge?"

"No."

"Any fixed marker?"

"No."

"Then do not force it into a box on the paper yet."

Neeraj fell silent.

The noon sun was fierce.

They all sat in the shade of the silk-cotton tree.

Phoolo took sattu from her basket.

She looked at the three men.

"Have some."

Neeraj refused at first.

Then he accepted.

Sudama held out a lota of water.

For a little while no one spoke of land.
A crow cawed from the silk-cotton tree.
Wind moved over the sand of the old channel.
The reeds bent to one side.
Ramvilas opened his survey notebook.
"According to the old measurement, Sudama's share is six katthas."
Neeraj sat upright.
"And cultivable now?"
Ramvilas looked at the figures.
"About four katthas and sixteen dhurs."
Neeraj's face changed.
"So little?"
"Erosion has taken the rest."
Phoolo asked, "Mine?"
"Your register says five katthas and eight dhurs. Cultivable now, about four katthas and twelve dhurs."
Phoolo remained grave.
"So both have shrunk."
Ramvilas said, "On this bank, yes."
Neeraj looked towards the sand of the old channel.
"If we add that?"
Ramvilas closed the notebook.
"You are in a hurry to make the number whole."
Neeraj replied, "My sale price will depend on area."
For the first time Sudama spoke sharply. "Why should land that is not yet a field fetch the price of a field?"
Neeraj too grew irritated.
"It is ours on paper."
Phoolo cut in, "On paper, the current of the Kamla is also the boundary."
All three fell silent.
The river was not loud.
Yet in that silence it could be heard clearly.
Ramvilas said softly, "That is why documents have to be read differently beside a river."
Neeraj stood up.
"I want a clear answer."
Ramvilas too rose.

“A clear answer will come from the court, the circle office, the old survey, the new survey—all of them together. Today I am showing you the land.”

Neeraj said, “Then today’s measurement is useless?”

Sudama kept looking at him.

Winding the tape, Ramvilas said, “It becomes useless only when you treat one number as the whole truth.”

Phoolo picked up her basket.

“What I understood today is simply this: the river eats both our fields, and the quarrel will be between the two of us.”

Sudama gave a faint laugh.

Neeraj did not.

They turned back towards home.

Near the old ridge, Sudama stopped.

He did not step on the clump of doob grass.

Neeraj had walked ahead.

Sudama called him back.

“Look at this.”

Neeraj turned.

Sudama scraped at the soil.

A small piece of brick emerged from within.

“This was the corner of the old ridge.”

Neeraj bent to look.

“What does that prove?”

“Nothing.”

Sudama put the brick back where it had been.

“Only that land too has a memory.”

In the evening the survey notebook was opened again in the courtyard.

Neeraj’s father, Shyamsundar, joined by phone from the city.

He kept asking the same question.

“Are the six katthas there or not?”

Before answering, Neeraj looked at Sudama.

Ramvilas had already left.

Phoolo too had gone home.

Only Sudama, Neeraj, and the old papers remained in the courtyard.

Neeraj said, “The register says six katthas.”

Shyamsundar asked, “On the ground?”

Neeraj paused briefly.

“Four katthas and sixteen dhurs are cultivable.”

There was silence at the other end.

Then came the question, “The rest?”

Neeraj said, “Some has gone in erosion, some lies as sand in the old channel.”

Irritated, Shyamsundar said, “Then add the sand and measure it.”

Sudama lowered his eyes.

Neeraj did not agree as quickly as he would have before.

“It is not stable yet.”

“Land is land.”

Neeraj said quietly, “Beside a river, it is not that simple.”

Sudama looked at him.

Shyamsundar said, “I sent you to the village to measure land, not to study philosophy.”

Neeraj’s face tightened.

He did not answer.

The call ended.

It rained at night.

Not heavily.

But enough for a steady patter to sound on the roof.

At dawn Sudama went alone towards the river.

Neeraj followed behind him.

The bamboo stake set up yesterday as ‘today’s witness’ had tilted.

A thin slice of earth had fallen from the bank during the night.

The bamboo was now very close to the water.

Neeraj said nothing.

Neither did Sudama.

The two stood beside the tilted bamboo.

A little later Phoolo came too.

She looked at the bank.

“In one night?”

Sudama said, “In one night.”

Phoolo looked towards her field.

“So yesterday’s measurement is already old?”

Neeraj said quietly, “Not the area. The line of the bank.”

Phoolo looked at him.

“You understand the difference now?”

Neeraj smiled.

"A little."

He took a small notebook from under his arm.

Yesterday he had written only figures.

Today, beneath the figures, he wrote three separate headings—

"Area in the register."

"Cultivable at present."

"Portion changing because of the river."

Sudama read them.

"You'll show all three to the buyer?"

Neeraj said, "Yes."

"The price will fall."

"It may."

"Then?"

Neeraj looked towards the new current.

"What is the point of adding a price for what we do not understand?"

Phoolo started towards her field.

As she went, she said, "Write my measurement in three boxes too."

Neeraj said, "I will."

Sudama stepped forward to straighten the bamboo.

Neeraj stopped his hand.

"Leave it."

"It is crooked."

"Even so."

Sudama asked, "Why?"

Neeraj said, "Where it stood yesterday and where it stands today—that too is a measurement."

For a while the two of them looked at the tilted bamboo.

The current of the Kamla flowed slowly on.

It completed no one's six katthas.

Nor did it preserve anyone's five katthas and eight dhurs.

It only made its own course.

And beside it, people went on drawing their own lines—on paper, on earth, and in memory.

The Scent of Paddy

On a Kartik evening, the first thing Anil smelled as he stepped off the bus was dust.

At the village turn, the old tea stall beneath the peepal tree was gone. In its place stood two new shops with tin awnings.

Seven years earlier, when he had last come home at harvest time, bullock carts still turned at this bend. Now motorcycles passed again and again, throwing up dust.

Anil tucked his small bag under his arm and took the footpath.

It should have taken him fifteen minutes to reach the house. But at the first bend he stopped.

The scent of paddy was coming from the distant fields.

It was not the scent as it lived in his memory.

In memory, the scent of paddy was warm—mingled with afternoon sun, straw, dung, dust, and the smell of his mother's sari-end.

Now there was more of wet leaves and the greenness of cut stalks in it.

Anil drew one deep breath.

Suddenly he remembered the warehouse in the city where he counted bundles of cloth. During the rains, when trucks arrived with damp sacks, the mingled smell of raw cotton and moisture was something like this.

He smiled.

In seven years, even the smells of the village had begun, inside him, to ask for comparison with some room in the city.

When he entered the courtyard, his mother, Saraswati Devi, looked first at the bag, then at her son.

"Such a small bag?"

"I'm here for three days."

"Three days?"

Anil laughed. "The factory wouldn't give me five days' leave. Two days will go in travel."

His mother's smile grew smaller at once.

On the veranda his father, Parmanand Jha, sat on an old woven munj stool. A warm cloth was tied above his right knee.

“So you’ve come?”

“Yes.”

“Just in time.”

Anil understood that this was not a welcome but information.

His younger brother Rajesh came out from inside.

The boy who, seven years earlier, used to steal Anil’s kurta and wear it was now a man of his height.

There was a sickle in Rajesh’s hand.

“Harvest starts at dawn tomorrow,” Rajesh said.

“By machine?”

“Half is already done by machine. There’s water in the western corner. The machine can’t enter there. One and a half bighas will be cut by hand.”

Anil put down his bag.

“I’ll come too.”

Rajesh looked at his palm.

“With that hand?”

Anil looked at his own palm as well.

Friction from cloth bundles, ropes, and boxes had hardened it, but gripping a sickle was another matter.

“It’s a hand,” he said.

Rajesh said nothing.

At dinner that night, talk of the harvest kept returning.

Mother asked, “How many labourers are coming?”

Rajesh said, “Six are fixed. Budhni Kaki will bring four women. There’ll be two men.”

Father said, “He’ll be the seventh.”

He looked at Anil.

Anil laughed. “I’m not the seventh. I’m family.”

Mixing rice on his plate, Father said, “When a hand works a sickle, the hand may belong to the family, but the work is labour.”

Rajesh looked at Father for a moment, then at his plate.

Anil noticed the glance.

“Why count me in the wage calculation?”

Father said evenly, “The field belongs to both brothers. The expense falls on both brothers. Whoever gives labour, his labour will be recorded too.”

The morsel in Anil's mouth stopped.

"And the money I send?"

"That is recorded too."

Rajesh again said nothing.

After dinner Father went inside and returned with a thin file.

The file held pages of farm accounts—seed, fertilizer, ploughing, pump, machine, wages, sacks, transport.

On some pages amounts were written against Anil's name.

On others, the amounts against Rajesh's name were smaller, but beside them were short notes—"three days at the pump," "opened the drain," "night watch," "with the paddy transplanting."

Anil kept turning the pages.

"The value of all these days isn't written."

Father said, "That's what I'm saying. This time we'll write it."

Rajesh suddenly said, "Not everything can be written."

Parmanand looked at him. "Why?"

"How many times I went to the field, how many times I checked the water, how many times cattle got in—will we count all of it?"

"Then why count money?" Father asked.

Rajesh fell silent.

Anil closed the file.

It seemed to him that on his first night home after seven years, the smell rising most sharply was not the scent of paddy but the smell of these old pages.

He rose at five in the morning.

Rajesh was already in the courtyard.

He was examining the edge of a sickle.

"This is for you," he said, holding out an old sickle to Anil.

"Why an old one?"

"A new sickle will cut your hand."

Anil laughed. "An old one won't?"

"An old one gives warning first."

The two brothers set off for the field together.

In the morning mist the paddy field was not a single colour. Here it was golden, there green, elsewhere muddy. The western corner really was wet. Their feet sank in.

Where the machine had cut the day before, short stalks stood at an even height.

In the section that had to be cut by hand, the paddy bent low.

Budhni Kaki arrived with five others.

Anil greeted her respectfully.

“Will the city babu take up a sickle?” she laughed.

“Today I will.”

“Tomorrow we’ll inspect your palm.”

Everyone laughed.

The work began.

Within the first five minutes Anil understood that cutting paddy was much simpler in memory than in the hand.

Grip a fistful of stalks with the left hand, draw the sickle with the right, lay the cut paddy in one direction, watch where you place your feet, and do not slow the person behind you.

His first fistful was only half cut before it snagged.

From behind, Rajesh said, “Not force. Change the angle.”

Anil changed the angle.

The stalks came through.

After ten minutes his back began to protest against bending.

After half an hour, the hardness earned from old ropes in his palms proved useless.

After an hour he understood that standing eight hours in the city and bending two hours in a field were two different kinds of exhaustion.

Budhni Kaki moved ahead of him.

Without appearing to hurry, she cut at twice his pace.

Anil watched her hands.

There was not a single unnecessary movement.

Rajesh was fast too, but every so often he stopped cutting to straighten a bundle, open a small channel to drain water from a wet patch, or inspect the edge of someone’s sickle.

For the first time, Anil saw all these tasks inside the word “harvest.”

By ten, the sun had grown fierce.

Mother sent water and flattened rice with jaggery.

Everyone sat on the field ridge.

Budhni Kaki looked at Anil’s palm.

Blisters were rising in two places.

“Back to the city tomorrow?”

“The day after.”

“Then these blisters will go to the city with you.”

Anil laughed.

Rajesh did not.

He was looking toward the section cut by machine.

Anil asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing."

"Say it."

Rajesh broke off a small piece of jaggery.

"Tomorrow Father will write today's day of yours in the file too."

"Let him."

"Will he write my whole year?"

Anil did not answer.

Rajesh said, "I don't want him to write it. But if he writes one day and leaves all the other days unwritten, the account will lean crooked."

Anil said slowly, "Do you think that because I send money, I consider my share greater?"

Rajesh looked at him.

"I didn't say that."

"But you feel it?"

Rajesh was silent for a while.

"Sometimes."

Anil put the piece of jaggery into his mouth.

"Sometimes I feel that without me, where would the money for fertilizer, seed, and the pump come from?"

"You're right to feel that."

"Then?"

"Both things can be true."

From a distance Budhni Kaki called, "If the rest is over, the paddy won't cut itself."

The brothers rose.

By noon Anil's pace had improved somewhat.

He now gripped smaller fistfuls.

A smaller fistful cut faster, though it made more bundles.

Rajesh said, "This is fine. Find your own pace."

"Not yours?"

"Mine was made over seven years."

Anil's sickle stopped for a moment.

Rajesh had probably said it without any second meaning. But the sentence sank deep inside Anil.

By evening only the last strip in the western corner remained.

The water there was below the knee, but the soil was soft.

That was why the machine operator had given up on it the day before.

Budhni Kaki's group said the wages for this patch would have to be separate.

Father had come to the ridge.

"We'll pay what was agreed," he said.

Budhni Kaki answered directly, "What was agreed was for dry ground. This will be cut in water."

Rajesh looked at Father.

Anil understood that the argument was about money, but he remembered days at the city factory when a bundle of wet goods weighed twice as much yet was counted as one bundle all the same.

He said, "The waterlogged patch is different."

Father looked at him.

"What do you know of it?"

Anil said quietly, "Today I'm learning."

Budhni Kaki did not laugh.

Neither did Rajesh.

After some discussion, an additional wage was fixed for the waterlogged strip.

Work began again.

This time Anil was at the very back.

His feet sank into the mud and came free again.

The stalks were wet.

The scent of paddy was stronger here.

For a moment Anil straightened and breathed in.

It was the same scent that had stopped him on the road the day before, but now there was less memory in it and more fatigue.

He liked that.

A scent did not have to be old in order to be beautiful.

By sunset the last strip had been cut.

All the bundles were brought to the ridge.

Budhni Kaki settled the wages with her group and left.

Anil, Rajesh, and Father remained.

The harvested field suddenly looked very large.

The boundary that had seemed clear while the paddy stood had now become rows of short stubble.

Father said, "Threshing tomorrow."

Anil was blowing on his palm.

"I'll stay."

"You leave the day after tomorrow."

"I'll stay until morning."

Rajesh looked at him but said nothing.

That night Father brought out the file again.

Today's wages were added to the expense page.

So was the extra amount for the waterlogged strip.

Then Father wrote—"Anil—1 day harvesting."

He left some space after it.

"The rate?" Anil asked.

"We'll decide tomorrow."

Rajesh stood by a pillar of the veranda.

Anil said, "Don't write a rate."

Father stopped his pen.

"Why?"

"Writing a price for one day won't make the account right."

"Then?"

Anil pulled the file toward himself.

He opened a new page.

At the top he wrote—"Money."

Beside it he wrote—"Days."

Then, after thinking, he made a third column.

Father asked, "What's this?"

Anil paused with the pen.

"What fits completely neither into money nor into days."

Rajesh came forward slowly.

"What's its name?"

Anil smiled.

"You name it."

Rajesh took the pen.

He stared at the empty column for a long time.

Then he wrote—"Care."

Anil read it.

"That's hard to measure too."

"So should we leave it blank?"

"No. Let it be written that this exists too."

Father kept looking at the file.

Perhaps he did not like the new page.

But he did not tear it out.

Mother called from inside, "The food is getting cold."

Rajesh reached to close the file.

Anil stopped him.

"One more thing."

"What?"

"The extra wages for Budhni Kaki's waterlogged patch today—that expense should not simply be split half-and-half between the two brothers."

Father frowned.

"Why?"

"The drainage channel in that patch stayed blocked this year. Rajesh opened it alone three times, and it filled again. If his work goes under 'care,' then mistakes should go in that column too. But living far away, I can't pay half the expense and claim equal responsibility just because I sent half the money."

Rajesh said at once, "The fault wasn't mine alone. The pump pipe was lying there."

Anil laughed.

"Then write that."

Rajesh laughed too.

Father smiled faintly for the first time.

"You two will turn the file into a book of stories."

Anil said, "The old pages tell quite a few stories already."

After dinner Anil prepared to sleep on the veranda.

On one side of the courtyard lay several wet bundles brought in from the harvest.

As the night deepened, their smell spread.

Anil's palm ached.

He rubbed into the blisters the mustard oil his mother had given him.

Rajesh sat down beside him.

"What do you do with these hands in the city?"

"Count bundles, tie them, lift them."

"How many bundles?"

"Depends on the day."

"Does your file there record your days?"

Anil laughed.

"There, they record hours."

"Care?"

"There is no such column."

The two were quiet for a while.

From somewhere far away came the low hum of a threshing machine.

Rajesh said, "At dawn tomorrow we'll turn the bundles. The paddy from the waterlogged patch is wet."

"I'll get up."

"The blisters?"

"With the blisters."

When Anil woke before dawn, the courtyard was not yet fully light.

Rajesh was already turning the bundles.

Without saying anything, Anil took hold of one side.

Together the brothers turned the bundles.

A steam-like smell rose from inside the wet paddy.

Anil drew another deep breath.

This time he thought neither of the city warehouse nor of his childhood seven years earlier.

He understood only that this paddy had been cut yesterday, had lain wet through the night, and had to be turned in the morning.

Rajesh asked, "What are you smelling?"

Anil said, "Paddy."

"You recognized it after so many years?"

Anil turned another bundle.

"Before, I was recognizing the wrong thing."

Rajesh asked, "What?"

Anil thought for a moment.

"I used to think the scent was home."

Rajesh looked at him.

Anil continued, "The scent belongs to the paddy. The reckoning of home is separate."

Rajesh said nothing.

He lifted another bundle.

The morning light kept growing.

The courtyard remained full of the scent of paddy.

The file lay closed on the table inside.

Its new page had three columns—money, days, care.

There was still a great deal of empty space in the third column.

The day after tomorrow Anil would return to the city.

Rajesh would remain with the fields.

The paddy would be threshed, sacks filled, half sold, half kept at home.

The accounts would be made again.

But this time money alone would not be counted.

And the scent of paddy—it would remain under its own name.

The Shade of a Tree

It was the last week of Jeth.

From early morning, the courtyard of Madhuban Primary School was filled with dust and the smell of lime.

A plan had been approved for two new classrooms, a toilet, a drinking-water tap, and an accessible ramp.

For three months, the headmistress, Saroja Jha, had grown weary of moving the paperwork for the work from office to office.

Now the contract had finally been awarded.

The sand had arrived.

The first truckload of bricks had also been unloaded.

At eight in the morning, the contractor, Vinod Mandal, arrived with two labourers, a mason, and a tin of red paint.

Junior engineer Amresh was with him.

Amresh carried the plan folded in his hand.

He began measuring from the northern corner of the school.

Saroja Jha watched from the veranda.

“The first room here,” Amresh said.

He drew a straight line of lime on the ground.

“And the second here.”

The second line ran up to the southern roots of the old peepal tree and stopped.

The peepal had stood there since before the school was built.

Its trunk was so thick that even three children with their arms spread could not encircle it completely.

One part of its root rose above the ground like a snake.

Another had broken through the old earthen platform and emerged outside it.

Amresh opened the plan again.

“The tree falls right in the middle here.”

Vinod had already understood that.

He opened the tin of red paint.

Dipping the mason's brush into it, he painted a thick cutting mark on the peepal trunk.

Saroja Jha came down from the veranda.

"Is that the mark for cutting it?"

"Yes," Vinod said. "Otherwise the veranda will not sit straight."

Amresh added, "The drainage channel also has to pass along this side."

He showed her a blue-pencil line on the plan.

"If the tree remains, the drain will have to bend."

Saroja Jha said nothing.

She was remembering all the applications of the previous year.

Once the funds had been sanctioned and then sent back.

Once an objection had been raised over the measurement of the land.

Once the contractor had withdrawn before even beginning the work.

This time she wanted nothing that might stop the work again.

Just then Chhedi Paswan, the school's former attendant, entered through the gate.

Chhedi had retired five years earlier.

But his house was half a kos from the school, and he often wandered over here in the mornings.

Sometimes he checked the bell.

Sometimes he tightened the tap.

Sometimes he picked up papers the children had thrown away.

Saroja Jha saw him from a distance.

"Chhedi Kaka, look—the work is finally beginning."

Chhedi looked at the heap of bricks.

Then he looked at the peepal with the red mark on it.

For a while he remained silent.

Vinod saw his face and laughed.

"Kaka, if this is about worship or ritual, say so now. Don't have the work stopped later."

Chhedi looked at him.

"It is not about worship or ritual."

"Then?"

"Wait until the first rain."

Vinod burst out laughing.

"Does cutting a tree require permission from the rain?"

Chhedi looked again toward the roots of the peepal.

"Whether you cut the tree or leave it is for all of you to decide. But we still have to see where the water goes."

Amresh folded the plan.

"The drainage is shown on the plan."

Chhedi said, "Does the plan show where the water comes from?"

Amresh did not answer him at once.

Vinod put the brush back in the tin.

"Kaka, these are official measurements. Not guesses."

Chhedi smiled.

"Mine is not a guess either."

He walked to the western side of the peepal.

Between the roots he pointed out a low hollow.

In summer it was filled with dry leaves.

"Look here."

Amresh bent down.

"What?"

"The colour of the soil."

The soil in the hollow was darker than the rest of the courtyard.

Amresh scraped it with a finger.

Dry on top, somewhat hard beneath.

"What does that prove?"

Chhedi said, "In the rains, water from the northern fields enters here. When it reaches the roots it divides into two. One stream goes toward the gate, the other toward the old watercourse."

Vinod looked around.

"Where is the watercourse?"

Chhedi pointed toward the south-western corner of the school.

There, between two bushes and some grass, lay a slightly lower strip of ground.

In summer it looked like a footpath.

"That way."

Vinod said, "That is not a watercourse. It is empty ground."

Chhedi said, "In Jeth every watercourse looks like empty ground."

Saroja Jha intervened.

"Chhedi Kaka, has water ever entered the school because of this before?"

"Eight years ago."

Chhedi answered at once.

“The small embankment to the west had been raised. After three days of rain, the water came up to the veranda.”

Saroja Jha had not been at the school that year.

“What happened then?”

“The embankment was cut open.”

“Is anything written about it?”

Chhedi shook his head.

“The water went down, and the matter went down with it.”

Amresh opened the plan again.

He compared the old building, the new rooms, and the proposed line of the drain.

The ground had been dry when the plan was drawn.

The courtyard had been recorded as almost level.

“No slope is shown here,” he said.

Chhedi replied, “A slope does not form by looking at paper.”

Vinod’s face hardened slightly.

“There is a deadline for the work. If we wait until the rains, there will be trouble with the foundations.”

Saroja Jha knew that too.

The foundations had to be filled within fifteen days.

She asked Amresh, “Is it necessary to cut the tree?”

Amresh said, “According to the approved plan, the corner of the veranda falls here. So does the drain. If we change it, the measurements will have to change again.”

“By much?”

“We will have to see.”

Vinod immediately said, “If it changes, the calculations for brick, cement, and labour will all change.”

Chhedi quietly moved away.

He did not begin a campaign to save the tree.

He called no panchayat.

At noon the school meal was served.

As on an ordinary day, the children sat with their plates in the shade of the peepal.

The red cutting mark shone on the trunk.

Some children saw it and asked,

“Will the tree be cut?”

The teacher Neelam said, “Nothing has been decided yet. Eat your meal.”

The children returned to their rice and dal.
 Saroja Jha sat in the office looking through papers.
 Outside, the contractor's men were marking the ground for excavation.
 The peepal was not cut that day.
 Vinod said the woodcutters would come the next day.
 The next morning the sky was grey.
 The air was hot, but the leaves were turning their undersides upward.
 Chhedi came to the school again.
 He said nothing.
 He began clearing the bushes to the south.
 Neelam asked, "Kaka, what are you doing?"
 "Removing the leaves."
 "Why?"
 "Let the water recognise its path."
 By noon the clouds were rumbling heavily.
 Before the school-closing bell, the wind grew strong.
 Saroja Jha ordered the children to be sent home early.
 Most of them left.
 A few children from distant villages remained on the veranda.
 The first drops were large.
 Then, within five minutes, the courtyard blurred beneath the rain.
 Water struck the tin roof so loudly that conversation became difficult to hear.
 Vinod's labourers were covering the bricks with tarpaulin.
 Amresh was not at the school that day.
 Saroja Jha was about to close the office door when Chhedi called out.
 "Madam, come here."
 She could not step down from the veranda.
 There were two fingers of water in the courtyard.
 Chhedi stood to the west of the peepal.
 A muddy stream from the northern fields was cutting through the school's raw earthen edge and entering the courtyard.
 The stream came straight toward the peepal roots.
 Saroja Jha watched from a distance.
 The water struck the raised root.
 One part turned east and flowed toward the gate.
 The other caught the hollow beneath the roots and turned south-west.

In the low strip that Vinod had called empty ground, a thin stream suddenly began to gleam.

Chhedi had cleared away the bushes, so the water flowed without obstruction.

But a heap of sand lay near the marked line of the new classroom.

The heap blocked part of the flow.

Within ten minutes the water began spreading back toward the veranda.

Vinod saw it too.

“Move the sand!” he shouted at the labourers.

Two labourers ran over with spades.

A small channel was cut through the heap of sand.

The water rushed out with a hiss and ran southward.

Rainwater streamed down over the red cutting mark.

Some of the paint washed from the trunk into the soil.

Chhedi said nothing.

He only watched the water flow.

Half an hour later the rain eased.

Saroja Jha’s sari was wet up to her knees.

Vinod’s sandals were packed with mud.

He stood by the peepal roots and kept looking at the low strip to the south.

“Does this stream run all through the rainy season?” he asked Chhedi.

“Whenever the northern fields fill.”

“Every time?”

“The heavier the rain, the stronger the stream.”

Vinod said nothing more.

The next morning Amresh arrived early.

He had brought a long transparent tube, two bamboo poles, and a measuring tape.

This time Chhedi asked him no questions.

Amresh repeatedly measured the school’s northern edge, the peepal roots, the southern strip, and the height of the veranda.

Neelam taught the children on the other veranda.

Every so often their eyes strayed toward the measuring.

Amresh rolled up the tape.

“There is a slope.”

Vinod asked, “How much?”

“Small, but enough. The water will seek this way.”

Chhedi remained silent.

Amresh looked at the old blue line on the plan.

The proposed drain was meant to cut past the tree and run straight south.

The actual water first went east, then curved by the roots and moved south-west.

"If the room is built here," Amresh said, "one corner of the foundation will fall in the flow."

Vinod immediately said, "Then we will make the drain masonry-lined."

Amresh shook his head.

"We can line the drain, but where will we catch the water? The inflow from the north is separate."

Saroja Jha brought chairs out from the office.

The four of them sat around the plan.

Chhedi remained standing at a distance.

Saroja said to him, "Kaka, you come too."

Chhedi said, "I do not understand papers."

"You understand water."

He came and sat down.

Amresh drew a new line.

"If the first classroom is shifted three hands east and the second set at a slight angle to it, this low strip will remain open."

Vinod immediately said, "The veranda will not look straight."

Saroja Jha looked at him.

"Is a school built to be looked at or to be studied in?"

Vinod did not laugh.

He was calculating.

"The brickwork will not increase much," Amresh said.

"The roof-junction will change."

"It will."

"The ramp?"

"The ramp will come round from the east. The gradient will be gentler."

"The drain?"

"We will follow the old water-path and take it outside the southern wall. We will put a grate midway."

For the first time, Chhedi placed a finger on the plan.

"The ground is low here."

Amresh drew a small circle where his finger rested.

“We will not make a deep collection pit here. The flow will remain open.”

Vinod asked, “The tree?”

Amresh paused for a moment.

“The tree will not fall in the middle of the drain. The roots should not be cut.”

“So the tree stays?”

“With this measurement, it can.”

Chhedi did not look at the peepal.

He asked, “And the water?”

Amresh said, “The water too.”

Saroja Jha let out a breath.

But the matter did not end there.

The revised measurements had to be sent to the office.

Some items in the contract estimate had to be rewritten.

Vinod was dissatisfied.

He said, “You have twisted a straightforward job.”

Amresh replied, “The ground is not straight.”

For three days, work continued only on the eastern foundation.

The red cutting mark on the peepal had washed half away.

On the fourth day, approval for the revised drawing came by phone; the written copy was to arrive later.

Vinod showed the labourers the new lines.

The mason asked, “Will it be built crooked like this?”

Vinod said, “Not crooked. According to the ground.”

Chhedi heard from a distance.

He did not smile.

The work gathered pace again.

The grass in the old water-path was cut.

Its edges were not sealed completely with brick.

Where the students had to cross, two flat slabs were laid.

The foundations of the two rooms were built at a distance from the peepal.

The ramp rose to the veranda from the eastern side.

The new toilet was built in the southern corner.

Vinod often said, “The whole plan was turned around for one tree.”

One day Chhedi replied, “Not for the tree.”

Vinod asked, "Then for what?"

Chhedi pointed toward the southern drain.

"For what the rain showed."

By Sawan the walls had risen.

The shade of the peepal no longer fell on the new wall as it had before.

At noon the shadow of its leaves now reached halfway across the ramp.

The children's meal began to be served on the new veranda.

Some children still carried their plates beneath the peepal.

Some sat on the threshold of the new classroom.

For no one was it a victory.

For no one was it a defeat.

One evening in Bhadon there was another heavy rain.

This time water from the new roof came down through the spout and entered its own drain.

Water from the northern fields followed the old low strip and reached the peepal roots.

At the raised root the flow divided in two.

One part entered the drain.

The other went toward the gate.

The foundations of the new classrooms remained dry.

Saroja Jha stood on the veranda watching it.

Chhedi was not at the school that day.

The next morning he came by on his walk.

The soil in the courtyard was still damp.

He bent near the new drain and looked at the line in the mud.

Then he looked at the peepal trunk.

Only a faint pink stain of the red cutting mark remained.

As Saroja Jha opened the office, she asked, "Kaka, did the water go properly?"

Chhedi said, "It did."

"And the new rooms were safe?"

"They had nowhere to go."

Saroja laughed.

The school-opening bell rang.

The children ran in through the gate.

One child looked toward the new classroom and asked, "Madam, why isn't this veranda straight?"

Before answering, Saroja Jha looked toward the southern drain.

Yesterday's rainwater had left a thin brown line there.
She said, "Because the ground is like this."
The child looked at the line for a few moments.
Then went into the classroom.
The shade of the peepal slowly moved across the new ramp.

The Dom's Flute

On the last Wednesday of Kartik, a village festival was to be held in the grounds of the Belsandi Middle School.

For three days already, a bamboo gateway, cloth pennants, and rows of earthen lamps had been taking shape.

A long sheet of paper had been hung on the school veranda.

The programme schedule was written on it.

Welcome song at five in the evening.

Girls' dance at five twenty.

Panchayat address at six.

Performance by the visiting singers' troupe at six thirty.

Prizes at seven thirty.

Group song at eight.

At the bottom, in red ink, it said—Times may change according to circumstances.

Chandeshwar Dom stood beside that sheet twice.

The first time, he searched for his name.

The second time, he made sure that it truly was not there.

An old cotton bag was tucked under his arm.

There were three flutes in the bag.

One long.

One medium-sized.

One small.

The mouth of each was covered with a strip of cloth.

After reading the list, Chandeshwar went toward Pramod Jha's office.

Pramod Jha was secretary of the festival committee.

He sat amid papers, receipts, and the ledger of payments due.

Standing at the door, Chandeshwar asked, "Where have you put my time?"

Pramod Jha looked up.

"Whose?"

“The flute’s.”

Pramod Jha thought for a moment.

Then he said, “Was your name written down?”

Chandeshwar did not smile.

“The day before yesterday you yourself said you would keep ten minutes in between.”

Pramod Jha turned the pages of the ledger.

“I said I would keep ten minutes. Nothing was said about printing your name.”

“Where is anything printed? This is a sheet written by hand.”

Pramod Jha did not look toward the sheet.

He said, “The schedule is very tight. The outside troupe should arrive by seven. If there is a gap in between, we will have you play.”

Chandeshwar asked, “And if there is no gap?”

“Next time.”

Chandeshwar adjusted the bag under his arm.

He went outside.

On the veranda, Rekha Teacher was writing down the children’s names.

Seeing Chandeshwar, she asked, “Uncle, where is your performance?”

“Wherever an empty place turns up.”

Rekha looked at the list.

She wanted to say something, but Chandeshwar had already gone down the steps.

A bamboo decoration was being built in the northern corner of the field.

Chandeshwar himself had supplied the twelve poles used in it.

The committee had already fixed the price of all twelve poles.

The poles had been counted.

A receipt had been written.

Payment would be made after the festival.

There was no receipt for the flute.

Chandeshwar’s house stood half a kos west of the school.

A bamboo screen stood in front of the house.

Baskets and winnowing trays were kept on one side of the doorway.

On the other lay trimmed bamboo strips and hollow offcuts.

Between them, five half-made flutes rested on a narrow bench.

Chandeshwar’s father too had made flutes.

He had also played them at fairs and village gatherings.

As a child, Chandeshwar had learned to recognise the smell of bamboo before he learned the names of notes.

Which bamboo was dry inside.

Which bamboo had a hairline crack in its body.

Which bamboo had to hang for six months after cutting.

All this he had learned through his hands.

But at festivals he was not invited to play for this knowledge.

He was asked to play when there was an empty stretch in the programme.

When the outside artists were late.

When the children's dance costumes were not ready.

When a speaker had not yet arrived.

He did not call his flute "time in between."

For him, it was complete time.

On the day of the festival, the field began filling from the afternoon onward.

Chandeshwar arrived at four.

He was given no identification badge.

The volunteer at the entrance said, "Uncle, you are one of us. Just go in."

Chandeshwar went inside.

He sat near the roots of the peepal tree behind the stage.

He placed the bag by his feet.

The sound-system men were joining wires.

Two large loudspeakers stood at the two corners of the stage.

A word spoken onstage carried all the way to the far end of the field.

Sometimes its echo came back.

Ramavatar was looking after the sound system.

Glancing at Chandeshwar's bag, he laughed and said, "Uncle, will your voice fight with my speakers today?"

Chandeshwar said, "My voice does not fight."

Pulling a wire, Ramavatar said, "Without all this, the back rows will not hear a thing."

Chandeshwar replied, "Then if the back rows want to hear, they can come forward."

Ramavatar burst out laughing.

"Where will so many people fit in front?"

Chandeshwar rested a hand on his bag.

"Then as many as hear, will hear."

At five, the welcome song began.
 The amplified voice struck the school's tin roof and came back.
 The girls' dance followed.
 There was applause.
 The panchayat speeches began.
 The first speaker rose for ten minutes and spoke for twenty-five.
 Instead of shortening his own turn, the second speaker began
 answering the first speaker's points.
 Pramod Jha kept looking at his watch.
 Chandeshwar remained seated by the peepal tree.
 At six forty-five, the visiting singers' troupe had still not arrived.
 Pramod Jha came over to him.
 "Uncle, play for five minutes."
 Chandeshwar asked, "Five?"
 "Only until the troupe arrives."
 Chandeshwar opened his bag.
 Just then came the rumble of a vehicle from the south side of the
 school.
 Pramod Jha turned to look.
 It was the singers' troupe's vehicle.
 He immediately said, "Leave it. They have arrived."
 Chandeshwar put the flute back into the bag.
 He said nothing.
 The singers' troupe climbed onto the stage.
 A loud beat burst from the speakers.
 Young men in the front of the field began to dance.
 Chandeshwar stayed seated at the roots of the peepal tree.
 Rekha Teacher came to him.
 "Uncle, aren't you going home?"
 "The payment for the twelve bamboo poles is still due."
 Rekha understood that this was not the whole answer.
 She asked nothing more.
 At seven thirty-five, the prize distribution began.
 During the prizes, the electric lights flickered twice.
 Ramavatar ran to the rear.
 He checked the wires.
 The lights steadied again.
 The group song was to begin at eight five.

The children stood in a line behind the stage.
 At that very moment, the entire field went dark.
 The speakers fell silent.
 The stage lights went silent.
 The school veranda went silent.
 For the first two moments, people simply stared into the darkness.
 Then many voices rose at once.
 "The power is gone!"
 "Where are the children?"
 "Move back!"
 "Don't step on the wires!"
 Ramavatar ran again.
 In the light of his phone, Pramod Jha began looking at the programme sheet.
 Someone said the joint in the main wire had come loose.
 Someone said it might take half an hour.
 Someone said it would be fixed in five minutes.
 Between those five minutes and that half hour, the festival was stranded without a voice.
 People began talking among themselves.
 Some got up and started toward home.
 Some children began laughing in the dark.
 The chairs in front of the stage began scraping and shifting.
 Pramod Jha came to Chandeshwar.
 "Uncle."
 Chandeshwar looked up.
 "Play something until the power comes back."
 Chandeshwar asked, "In this noise?"
 Pramod Jha looked around.
 "We'll quieten the people."
 Chandeshwar said softly, "Will you quieten them first and then have me play, or have me play and then quieten them?"
 Pramod Jha did not answer.
 Rekha Teacher was listening.
 She said, "First seat him on the stage."
 There was no electric light.
 A small oil lamp was placed on the stage.
 In its glow, only half the chair could be seen.

Chandeshwar sat not at the centre of the stage, but at the right-hand corner.

From his bag he took out the medium flute.

He removed the strip of cloth.

He wiped the mouth of the flute with a finger.

Without a microphone, Pramod Jha shouted, "Please be quiet! Local artist Chandeshwar—"

He paused for a moment.

Then he said, "Chandeshwar Dom will play the flute."

Many people in the back rows did not hear.

Conversation continued.

Chandeshwar put the flute to his lips.

The first note was very soft.

So soft that even people in the front row could lose it in one another's talk.

The second note was a little longer than the first.

At the end of the third, the air left a faint rasp inside the bamboo body.

A child in the front row said to his mother, "Quiet."

The mother looked at him.

The child turned an ear toward the stage.

Two chairs behind him, someone stopped talking.

The person beside him stopped too.

The flute still had not grown louder.

To hear it, people had to lower their own voices.

That change travelled slowly from the front row toward the back.

Someone signalled with a hand.

Someone touched the person beside him with a knee.

Someone said no "hush," but simply turned an ear toward the stage.

The noise in the field began to fall, layer by layer.

First the scraping of chairs became audible.

Then that too diminished.

After that came the faint tinkling of a bell from a distant cattle shed.

The rustling of peepal leaves could be heard.

So could the sound of someone's foot brushing the dry Kartik grass.

Through all of it, the notes of the flute went on.

Chandeshwar was not playing any famous tune.

It was a walking tune his father used to blow in the evenings while shaving bamboo.

Four short notes.

A long pause.

Then two low notes.

The pause too was part of the melody.

For the first time, the people were listening to the pause.

The field grew so quiet that the sound of water being poured from an earthen pitcher behind the stage could be heard clearly.

Ramavatar was bent over the wires.

He raised his head and looked toward the stage.

A wire was in his hand, but he did not connect it.

Chandeshwar changed the tune.

This time he lifted the small flute.

Its voice was thin and clear.

Old Sudama Devi, seated near the front, suddenly took her granddaughter's hand.

The granddaughter asked, "What happened?"

Sudama Devi merely shook her head.

She did not want to say anything.

Two young men standing in the back row slowly moved forward.

They did not begin to dance.

They only shortened the distance from which they were listening.

Meanwhile, the electricity flickered back on in the school veranda.

One light came on.

Then another.

A faint hum rose inside the loudspeakers.

Ramavatar reached toward the switch.

Pramod Jha saw him.

He signalled with his hand for him to stop.

Ramavatar's hand halted where it was.

The lights had returned.

The sound system remained off.

Chandeshwar's flute continued.

Now the whole field could hear him, because the whole field was quiet.

Rekha Teacher stood by the stage steps, holding the programme sheet.

She looked at the blank space beneath the red writing.

In that space she wrote in pencil—Chandeshwar Dom—Flute.

She looked at her watch to write the time.

Eight eighteen.

She wrote 8:18.

She left the finishing time blank.

Chandeshwar lifted the long flute.

This flute had a deeper tone.

He played a short melody he had made while drying cut bamboo after the rains.

There was no festival cheer in the tune.

No name of any deity.

No fragment of any famous song.

There were only breath, bamboo, and pauses.

The final note was not long.

It slowly grew smaller.

Then it ended.

Chandeshwar lowered the flute from his lips.

For a few moments afterward, the field remained silent.

No one applauded at once.

For those two or three moments, Chandeshwar did not look ahead.

He ran a finger over the holes of the flute.

Then a clap rose from the front row.

Then another.

After that, the whole field filled with applause.

The loudspeakers were still off.

The sound of the clapping travelled far without amplification.

Chandeshwar did not stand and bow.

He simply wrapped the flute in cloth and put it into his bag.

Pramod Jha climbed onto the stage.

He said, "Very beautiful. Now the group song—"

Rekha Teacher said softly, "First write down the time."

Pramod Jha looked at the list.

"How long was it?"

"From eight eighteen to eight thirty-eight."

"Twenty minutes?"

Rekha said, "Yes."

Pramod Jha looked at Chandeshwar for a moment.

An artist called for five minutes had played for twenty.

No one had been watching the clock.

The group song followed.
The festival ended at ten that night.
People began to go home.
Half the lamps by the bamboo gateway had already gone out.
Chandeshwar was picking up his bag near the peepal tree.
Pramod Jha called to him.
“Uncle, take the payment for the twelve bamboo poles.”
He counted the amount from the ledger.
Chandeshwar counted it and put it inside his bag.
Pramod Jha said, “And thank you for the flute.”
Chandeshwar remained standing.
He did not start to leave.
Pramod Jha asked, “Anything else?”
Chandeshwar said, “There were twelve bamboo poles.”
“Yes.”
“They were counted.”
“Yes.”
“Their price was written down.”
“Yes.”
Tying the mouth of his bag, Chandeshwar said, “The flute was twenty minutes.”
Pramod Jha was silent.
He understood the point.
“Are you asking for a fee?”
Chandeshwar said, “If you called me an artist and had me play on the stage, will there be some entry for that in the ledger, or only a thank-you?”
Pramod Jha sat down on the chair again.
He opened the expenditure page of the ledger.
That page listed—Sound system.
Cloth decorations.
Visiting singers’ troupe.
Oil for the lamps.
Prizes.
Bamboo decoration—Chandeshwar.
Pramod Jha looked at the next blank line.
“The committee had not fixed any payment for you.”
Chandeshwar said, “It had not fixed one. That is true.”

"Then how much should I write now?"

Chandeshwar did not immediately name a figure.

He looked out toward the field.

In front of the stage, Ramavatar was gathering the wires.

Rekha Teacher was collecting the things the children had left behind.

Chandeshwar said, "Write what you pay a local singing group for one performance."

Pramod Jha said, "There are four people in that group."

"I am one."

"Then one-fourth?"

Chandeshwar smiled.

"Was the song heard in four separate parts?"

Pramod Jha too smiled faintly.

"No."

He looked at the ledger again.

Rekha Teacher came inside.

She said, "Five hundred can be entered for a local solo performance. Two prize items are left over; there is money remaining under that head."

Pramod Jha said, "If we shift the budget head, it will have to be explained in the accounts."

Rekha said, "Write the explanation."

A few moments later, a new line was added to the ledger.

Local solo artist—Chandeshwar Dom—Flute—five hundred rupees.

Pramod Jha signed it.

Chandeshwar did not put a thumbprint; he wrote his name.

Slowly.

Chandeshwar Dom.

He counted the five hundred rupees.

Then he asked, "Who will make next year's list?"

Rekha said, "We will."

"In an empty slot?"

Rekha replied, "No. We will give you a time."

Chandeshwar made no promise in response.

He simply slung the bag under his arm.

Then he walked home.

The next morning, the festival field was half empty.

The bamboo pennants were being taken down.

Ramavatar was loading the loudspeakers onto a vehicle.
Yesterday's programme sheet still hung on the school veranda.
The wind fluttered one corner of it.
The pencilled name beside 8:18 was still clear.
Chandeshwar Dom—Flute.
A thin line had been drawn through to 8:38.
Rekha Teacher came to take down the sheet.
For a moment she looked at the name.
Then she did not fold the paper.
She placed it straight inside the ledger.
The wind moved through the peepal leaves in the field.
Their sound was very soft.
No one had to order anyone to be quiet in order to hear it.

The Map of the Hut

At half past seven in the morning, two bamboo stakes were driven into the ground in front of Phulbasiya Devi's courtyard.

A red string was stretched between the stakes.

The string ran straight across the corner of the veranda towards the rear wall.

At first Phulbasiya thought some child was playing a game.

But when she looked towards the road, she saw three men in yellow caps taking measurements.

One held a measuring tape, another a sheet of paper, while the third was marking small signs on the ground from a bag of lime.

Phulbasiya stepped down from the veranda.

"Why is this red string running through my house?"

The young man sprinkling lime raised his head.

"The drain will pass through here."

Phulbasiya kept looking at him.

"A drain is supposed to run outside. How can it pass through a house?"

The young man looked towards the man holding the paper.

The man folded the map and came forward.

"This strip is vacant on the map, Mother."

Phulbasiya did not smile.

She turned and looked at her veranda.

The tiled roof was not new, but the earthen walls had been plastered many times.

Three shades of earth showed in the wall like layers from different periods.

The innermost layer was blackish brown, the middle one red, and the upper part a pale yellow.

"Where is it vacant?" Her voice was quiet.

The man with the paper opened the map again.

On it, the road was a thick line, the edge of the pond a thin blue line, and between them lay one long blank strip.

Phulbasiya's house stood in that blank strip.

"There is no house marked here," the man said.

"Is there no mark for the house, or is there no house?"

The man was silent for a moment.

"We are doing the survey. We first go by what is on the map. Then we check it on the ground."

"Then look now."

Phulbasiya spread out her hand and pointed to the veranda, the walls, the tulsi platform, and the small vent through which smoke from the hearth escaped.

"Three generations have been looking at this place. Has the map only just seen it?"

This time the man gave a faint smile, but it vanished at once.

"My name is Shailendra. I am with the panchayat survey team. Today we are marking the line of the drain. I will not make the decision alone."

"If this red string is going to make the decision, write down its name too."

A voice came from behind.

"Ma!"

Mahendra was running towards them.

He was Phulbasiya's son.

He weighed grain sacks at a shop in the market, and reaching there by eight every morning was his daily routine.

That day a neighbour's child had run to tell him that surveying was under way at his house.

"What happened?" Mahendra asked, panting.

Phulbasiya pointed at the red string.

"Our house is not on the map. So the drain is going through the house."

Mahendra wanted to see Shailendra's paper.

Shailendra did not hand the map over; he held it in his hand and showed it to him.

A drain five cubits wide was proposed along the eastern side of the road.

It was to run south as far as the school bend and then meet the old drainage channel.

On paper the line was clear.

On the ground it was not nearly so clear.

The strip between the road and the pond lay two cubits lower in one place, a cubit higher in another; here there was scrub, there a house, elsewhere a cowshed.

“Why aren’t the houses on this map?” Mahendra asked.

Shailendra said, “This is not a map of house ownership. The drainage work has been drawn on an old base map. Only the principal structures are shown.”

“And our house is not a principal structure?”

Before Shailendra could answer, a loud voice came from the road.

“How long are you going to stay at one spot?”

The contractor, Jagdish Babu, was approaching in a white shirt.

A mobile phone was in his hand, shining shoes on his feet.

He looked at the red string, then at Phulbasiya, then at the paper.

“Keep the line straight. Every extra bend means more bricks, sand and labour.”

Mahendra stepped forward.

“To keep it straight, will you cut through a house?”

Jagdish Babu answered not him but Shailendra first.

“Is the house recorded in the file?”

Shailendra said, “Not on the work plan.”

“Then get a written revision from the panchayat. I will not bend the line on my own.”

Phulbasiya said, “Will the red string be removed until the written revision comes?”

“We cannot stop the work.”

“The house cannot stop either.”

Jagdish Babu looked at his watch.

“Mother, I have not come here to argue. I have work to finish.”

“I too have a life to finish.”

By then people from nearby had begun to gather.

One held a brass pot of milk, another had a child under her arm; someone on the way to the fields had stopped mid-step.

Government surveying in a village often stops people in their tracks.

A line drawn on paper may or may not coincide with someone’s field, someone’s wall, someone’s footpath, but everyone begins measuring his own land in his mind.

Phulbasiya’s neighbour Ramdev said, “This house was here even when I was a child.”

From behind, Sarita Kaki said, “My wedding palanquin stopped in front of this veranda.”

Jagdish Babu grew impatient.

"A drain cannot be built out of old stories."

Shailendra did not fold the map.

He ran his eyes from the level of the road to Phulbasiya's courtyard.

"Let me measure the slope once."

Jagdish Babu said, "The slope is given on the plan."

"It has to be matched with the ground."

"Do it quickly."

Shailendra had his assistant bring a transparent tube and water.

Water was filled into both ends of the tube.

One end was held at the mark by the roadside, the other behind the courtyard.

Phulbasiya watched the water settle in the tube.

For the first time, inside that small tube, the line on the government map began to speak with the slope of the earth.

Shailendra measured three times.

Then he measured twenty cubits farther east along the road.

Then near the old embankment of the pond.

"From here the water naturally falls towards the south-east," he said.

Ramdev laughed.

"You need a tube to learn that? Sleep here on a rainy night and the water itself will tell you."

Phulbasiya smiled for the first time.

"On a rainy night the map will get soaked, Ramdev."

People laughed.

Jagdish Babu did not.

"Where will you put the bend?"

Shailendra did not pull up the stake holding the red string.

He first went to the northern corner of the courtyard.

There was an old shallow channel in the earth there, barely visible through the grass.

"What is this?"

Phulbasiya said, "An old watercourse."

"How old?"

"It was here when I came here as a bride."

Mahendra said, "Father used to say his father had made it."

Shailendra studied the direction of the channel.

Without touching the wall of the house, it sloped towards the south-east and, thirty cubits farther on, met the proposed line of the drain.

Jagdish Babu said, "The old watercourse is narrow."

"It can be widened," Shailendra replied.

"There will be two bends."

"Two bends, but less excavation. The ground is already lower here."

Jagdish Babu fell silent.

He was calculating the cost in his head.

Mahendra looked at Phulbasiya.

"Ma, didn't Father say that in the old days the pond water drained through this channel during the rains?"

Phulbasiya shook her head.

"Not the pond. The water from the three courtyards uphill. When the pond filled, water used to back up this way instead."

Shailendra immediately went to inspect the upper end of the old channel.

Weeds, broken bricks and two tarpaulin sacks were lodged there.

The moment Phulbasiya saw them, she said, "The grocer threw those tarpaulin sacks there yesterday."

Mahendra said, "I'll remove them."

"Remove them now," Shailendra said.

As soon as the sacks were pulled away, the soil beneath was seen to be damp.

There had been a light rain the previous evening.

A thin line of moisture clearly traced the direction of the old watercourse.

With his pencil Shailendra drew a second line along the margin of the work plan.

He did not strike out the first straight line.

He merely wrote beside it: "Alternative ground slope observed on site."

Jagdish Babu asked, "Can work begin on this basis?"

"No. The panchayat engineer will inspect it."

"Until then?"

"Excavation will remain stopped near this house. Work can continue on the other section."

Jagdish Babu's face hardened.

"Will the whole team stop for one house?"

"Not the whole team. Twenty cubits."

“Twenty cubits today will become forty tomorrow.”

Phulbasiya said, “If forty houses are found within forty cubits, the map will have to look forty times.”

Jagdish Babu looked at her.

Then said nothing.

Speaking to someone on his mobile phone, he walked towards the southern section.

The red string still stretched across the courtyard.

Shailendra did not remove it.

“Why are you leaving this?” Phulbasiya asked.

“Let the line that has been questioned remain a question. The engineer will come and see both.”

Phulbasiya looked at the string.

“For the first time, a question in this house is visible in red.”

By noon the villagers had begun telling the story of the house in their own different ways.

Someone said Ramkhelawan had built the first hut there after a flood.

Someone said the strip was government land.

Someone said it was fallow ground belonging to the pond.

Someone said bullock carts used to turn at that spot before the road was built.

Phulbasiya heard every story but did not interrupt any of them.

That afternoon Mahendra did not go to the shop.

He opened the old trunk in the house.

There were no land papers in it.

There was an old ration slip, two wedding invitations, Mahendra’s school certificate, his father’s death certificate, and a yellowing photograph.

Half of the same tiled roof could be seen in the photograph.

A small neem tree stood in front.

Phulbasiya took the photograph in her hand.

“The neem broke in storms three times. The house was re-thatched three times. Not once was any paper made.”

Mahendra said, “Shall we show all this?”

“To whom?”

“To the engineer.”

“He will inspect the drain, not the age of the house.”

“Then what are we supposed to prove?”

Phulbasiya put the photograph back in the trunk.

“Only this much: the drain cannot pass through the house. Who owns the land is another matter.”

Mahendra looked at his mother in surprise.

“You won’t raise the question of the land?”

“Why should a matter for which we have no papers be decided on the day of the drain?”

There was neither anger nor fear in Phulbasiya’s voice.

“If every battle is fought on the same day, none of the battles remains clear.”

By evening the red string looked black in the shadow of the veranda.

Phulbasiya stepped over it and went to the hearth.

She did not remove the string.

That night Mahendra’s daughter Gudiya came home from the city after finishing her studies.

The moment she put a foot through the doorway, she saw the red string.

“What is this?”

Mahendra said, “Our house is not on the map.”

Gudiya laughed.

Then she saw her father’s face and stopped laughing.

She studied geography in college.

“Which map?”

Mahendra told her about the paper.

Gudiya went outside.

She looked at the road, the pond, the house and the old watercourse.

“It is easy to say the map is wrong,” she said, “but perhaps the map was never made for this purpose.”

Stirring the vegetables on the hearth, Phulbasiya said, “If it was not made for this purpose, why were they using it to cut through a house?”

Gudiya fell silent.

After a while she said, “That is a fair question.”

At ten the next morning the panchayat’s junior engineer arrived.

Shailendra, Jagdish Babu and panchayat member Sita Devi were with him.

Gudiya too stayed home.

The engineer first looked at the map.

Then at the red string.

Then at the house.

“This structure is not on the base map,” he said.

Phulbasiya asked, "How old is the base map?"

The engineer looked at a corner of the paper.

"Twelve years."

From behind, Ramdev said, "The house is more than fifty years old."

The engineer did not look at him.

He examined the alternative line drawn by Shailendra.

"Did you check the slope?"

"At three points."

"The old watercourse?"

"It exists on the ground. Its upper end was blocked. After it was cleared, yesterday's moisture was visible."

The engineer took the measurements himself.

He walked twice around the house.

He stopped near the northern corner of the veranda and examined the soil.

"If excavation is done here, the foundation will be exposed."

Jagdish Babu said, "So we bend it?"

"Widen the old watercourse. But at the southern end there must be a flap gate to stop backflow from the pond."

Shailendra began writing.

Jagdish Babu asked about the cost.

The engineer gave an estimate.

It was not much higher than the straight alignment, because the old watercourse was already low and therefore required less excavation.

Jagdish Babu's face relaxed.

"All right."

Phulbasiya said, "Then the red string?"

The engineer said, "It will be removed."

Shailendra moved to pull up the stakes.

Gudiya stopped him.

"One minute."

Everyone looked at her.

Gudiya asked, "Will the house be added to the work plan?"

The engineer said, "The revised line of the drain will be added."

"The house?"

"This is not a revenue record."

"I am not asking about ownership. Will the object on the ground that caused the line to be changed be marked on the work plan or not?"

The engineer thought for a few moments.

Shailendra said quietly, "We can record the site condition as 'existing residence'."

The engineer nodded.

"Write it."

Jagdish Babu said, "If later this leads to some ownership claim—"

The engineer stopped him midway.

"A work plan does not confer ownership. But what exists on the ground must be shown on the plan used for the work."

Shailendra picked up his pencil.

Beside the straight red line he drew a small rectangle.

Inside the rectangle he wrote: "Existing Residence."

Mahendra kept looking at the map.

Phulbasiya did not look at it.

She said to Shailendra, "Remove the string first."

The red string was untied.

The corner of the veranda lay open again.

Two small holes remained where the stakes had been pulled out.

Phulbasiya pushed soil into those holes with her big toe.

Work began on the third day.

The grass in the old watercourse was cut away.

As the soil was dug out, fragments of old baked brick were found inside.

Phulbasiya said, "They must be from Ramkhelawan's time."

Mahendra asked, "How old?"

"You don't ask a brick its age."

Jagdish Babu's labourer laughed.

Phulbasiya laughed too.

Two days later the bend in the drain passed along the northern side of the house.

The veranda was saved.

The old watercourse now had brick edges.

A flap gate was fitted at the southern end to stop water backing up when the pond filled.

The first heavy rain came a week later.

Gudiya was preparing to return to the city that day.

As soon as the rain began, Phulbasiya stopped her.

"Don't go. First watch the map sit its examination."

Everyone sat on the veranda.

Water from the road entered the drain.

At the bend it swirled for a moment, then ran south between the new brick edges of the old watercourse.

The courtyard remained dry.

Water from the pond did not back up.

Mahendra said, "This time the map passed."

Gudiya said, "Not the map. The ground and the map both."

Phulbasiya kept looking outside.

Raindrops were falling where the red stakes had stood.

The ground had become level again.

"Is the house on the government map now?" she asked Gudiya.

Gudiya said, "No. On the work plan it is marked 'Existing Residence.' The revenue map is a separate process."

Phulbasiya nodded. "Then half the work is done."

Mahendra said, "We'll do the rest too." "We will. But today, look at the drain."

The rain grew heavier. Water poured from the roof in a stream. That stream turned towards the old watercourse.

For three generations the house had stood on the land, yet on paper it was still not fully a house. But for the first time, a small rectangle had appeared in the blank strip of a government work plan.

Inside that rectangle there was no owner's name. There were only two words: "Existing Residence."

Those words were enough for Phulbasiya that day. The map had not given her house any legal right. But at least it no longer treated it as empty ground through which a line could simply be drawn.

The Cow's Bell

It was the last week of Phagun.

The morning sun had not yet properly reached the cattle shed, but Mohan sat in the courtyard with old papers spread before him.

The papers held three years of accounts.

Straw.

Dry fodder.

Oilcake.

Medicine.

Bechan's monthly wages.

Repairs to the plough.

Rope for the yoke.

And in the middle, in bold letters, were written the names—Hirna and Kajru.

Hirna and Kajru were the two bullocks of the household.

They were not the same colour.

Hirna's body was pale grey, with a small white patch on his forehead.

Kajru was deep brown, but the rim of his right ear looked as though it had been clipped from birth.

Both bullocks wore bells around their necks.

Hirna's bell had a heavy note.

Kajru's was a little thinner.

From a distance, Bechan could tell from the sound which of the two was walking in front.

Mohan placed a finger on the paper and said, "Babu, look at this account again."

Ramsagar was sitting on a low wooden cot.

He had no desire to inspect the accounts, but Mohan had been raising the same point for three days.

"I've seen it," Ramsagar said.

"Then?"

"Then what?"

Mohan turned the paper towards him.

"This is the hire charge for ploughing two bighas by machine. Add up three rounds. Then look at the cost of keeping the bullocks for a whole year."

Without touching the paper, Ramsagar said, "I've added it."

"Then keeping bullocks is a losing bargain now."

This time Ramsagar picked up the paper.

"In farming, losses do not come from bullocks alone."

"I'm not saying they do."

"Then?"

"I'm saying—the work for which the bullocks were kept is now done by a machine in less time."

The sound of a bell came from the cattle shed.

First the heavy one.

Then the thinner note.

Ramsagar looked that way.

Bechan had untied both bullocks and was taking them towards the pond.

Mohan heard them too, but kept his finger on the paper.

"The market is the day after tomorrow," he said. "Ramesh of Bisanpur says he wants the pair."

Ramsagar was silent for a while.

"The price?"

Mohan told him.

Ramsagar fell silent again.

Mohan had expected his father to object.

He had thought the proposal to sell the bullocks would cause a major quarrel in the house.

But Ramsagar merely said, "The price is not too low."

Mohan's face relaxed.

"Then shall I tell him?"

"Speak to Bechan first."

Mohan lifted his eyes from the paper.

"Bechan?"

"Yes."

"The bullocks are ours."

"I know that as well as you do."

"Then?"

Ramsagar folded the paper.

“The bullocks are ours. But their days are spent with Bechan.”

Mohan said nothing.

The remark struck him as sentimental.

And he did not want sentiment in this matter.

Two years earlier Mohan had left a small private job in town and returned to the village.

He did not want to give up farming.

On the contrary, he wanted the economics of it to be understood clearly.

How much was invested.

How much was harvested.

How much went into the household.

How much was sold.

How much remained.

He disliked his father's old answer—“The field knows the account of farming.”

He would say, “If you do not write down the account, you will call the loss tradition.”

Ramsagar usually laughed at that.

This time he did not.

At noon Bechan returned after grazing the bullocks.

Hirna went straight to the trough.

Kajru first stopped beside the tap in the courtyard.

Bechan stroked his head.

“Thirsty?” he said.

Kajru gave no answer.

He stretched his neck towards the tap.

Mohan brought a bucket from inside.

“Bechan Kaka,” he said, “sit for a moment.”

The moment Bechan heard Mohan's tone, he understood that this was not an ordinary conversation.

He sat down beside the wall of the cattle shed.

Ramsagar came too.

Mohan spoke plainly.

“The day after tomorrow Hirna and Kajru will be sold.”

Bechan first looked at Mohan.

Then at Ramsagar.

Then at the bullocks.

"Both?"

"Yes."

"Not one?"

"They'll fetch a better price as a pair."

Bechan nodded.

There was little surprise on his face.

In the previous two years, five households in the village had sold their bullocks.

At first the new ploughing machines had come from the market town.

Now two hired machines were available in the neighbouring village.

A field that took a day and a half to plough with bullocks could be done by machine in a few hours.

Bechan had been watching all this.

"All right," he said.

The answer came more easily than Mohan had expected.

"Ramesh will come himself to take them."

"All right."

"The morning after tomorrow."

"All right."

Bechan began to rise.

Ramsagar said, "Sit a little longer."

Bechan sat down again.

For a few moments only Hirna's bell could be heard.

He was moving his neck as he ate from the trough.

Suddenly Bechan asked, "Up to what date will my account be settled?"

Mohan did not understand.

"What account?"

"My wages."

"You'll get this month's full wages."

"This month's?"

"Yes."

Bechan nodded again.

"And my share of paddy?"

Mohan fell silent.

Bechan's wages had two parts.

The monthly cash amount was not large.

When the paddy was harvested, he also received one maund of grain.

That arrangement had continued since Ramsagar's father's time.

Mohan said, "The paddy won't be harvested until Agahan."

"I know that too."

"Then?"

Bechan wiped his palm on the edge of his dhoti.

"The paddy I receive in Agahan is not wages for the month of Agahan."

Mohan said nothing.

"It is my share for looking after the bullocks through the year."

Ramsagar looked at Mohan.

There was no complaint in Bechan's voice.

He was only explaining the account.

"By Phagun more than half the year has passed," Bechan said. "If the bullocks are sold, that is fine. But we should understand how far my share of paddy has accrued."

Mohan remembered the account sheet lying before him.

Straw.

Dry fodder.

Oilcake.

Medicine.

Bechan's monthly wages.

His annual share of paddy had not been written separately on that paper.

It was usually taken straight out of the harvest.

"I'll add it," Mohan said.

Bechan did not smile.

"Add it."

He stood up.

After noon Mohan sat down with the papers again.

This time he added a new line—

Bechan—annual share of paddy.

How much would half of it be?

How much for eight months?

If the bullocks were sold the day after tomorrow, how much of the year would count as completed?

He began counting the months on his fingers.

Ramsagar watched from a distance.

"Not so finely," he said.

Mohan replied, "You were the one who said the account should be made."

"Make the account. But don't cut a man into pieces of months."

Mohan grew irritated.

"Then give him the full maund?"

"How much of his work is complete?"

"Up to Phagun."

"When did we buy the bullocks?"

"In Jyeshtha."

"Bechan has been looking after them from that day."

Mohan stopped.

In truth, he had been thinking of the year as beginning in January.

The agricultural year did not begin in January.

Hirna and Kajru had not been bought at the market last Jyeshtha.

They had been in the household for seven years.

But the annual cycle of wages ran through transplanting, ploughing, paddy, wheat, straw, and then the summer fodder.

Mohan folded the paper again.

In the evening Bechan was brushing down the bullocks.

Hirna stood with his eyes closed.

Kajru kept lifting a hind leg now and then.

"Stand still," Bechan scolded.

Kajru stood still.

Ramsagar came into the cattle shed and said, "Are you feeling bad?"

Without turning, Bechan asked, "About what?"

"The bullocks being sold."

Bechan kept brushing them.

"Were the bullocks mine?"

"No."

"Then does the right to feel sorrow belong only to the owner?"

Ramsagar said nothing.

Bechan laughed himself.

"There is sorrow. But sorrow cannot buy straw."

Ramsagar smiled too.

Bechan checked the strap of Hirna's bell.

The leather strap was tearing on one side.

"This will have to be replaced," he said.

Ramsagar said, "Why replace it now? He'll be gone the day after tomorrow."

Bechan turned and looked at him.

"Will we send him out of this house wearing a torn strap?"

Ramsagar gave no answer.

Bechan took an old strip of leather from his bag.

"I'll stitch it tomorrow."

The next morning the ploughing machine arrived.

No one in the village gathered to watch it.

It was no longer something new.

The driver climbed down at the edge of the field and asked Mohan the area.

"Two bighas and eight kathas."

"Is the soil dry?"

"The upper part is dry. There is a little moisture in the back corner."

The driver looked over the field.

"We'll do the upper part first."

Ramsagar stood at a distance.

Bechan was feeding Hirna and Kajru in the cattle shed.

The machine's roar spread across the field.

Long rows of earth turned over.

Mohan looked at his watch.

At this hour Ramsagar would once have had his hands on the plough handles.

Hirna and Kajru would have been in the yoke.

Bechan would have walked in front, watching the clods of earth.

Now there was only the driver.

There was Mohan.

And the sound of the machine.

By noon the upper field was finished.

Mohan was pleased.

"See?" he said to his father. "Two days' work."

Ramsagar said, "I see."

"And the bullocks?"

Looking across the field, Ramsagar said, "For ploughing? You are right."

No look of victory came over Mohan's face.

He had not expected his father to agree so easily.

He realised that an argument is difficult only when the other person disagrees.

Here the real difficulty lay elsewhere.

That evening Bechan stitched the strap and fastened the bell around Hirna's neck again.

The bell rang.

Its note was as heavy as before.

Bechan bent his ear towards it and listened.

"Good."

Mohan asked, "What need is there for the bell? Ramesh has an enclosed cattle shed."

Bechan said, "Are you asking what need there is?"

"Yes."

"I don't know."

"Then why all this effort?"

Bechan tugged the strap to test it.

"Whatever is my responsibility until tomorrow, it is my work to keep it in good order."

Mohan fell silent.

The next morning Ramesh arrived early.

He had brought two men with him.

The price had already been settled.

Even so, the bullocks' teeth were examined.

Their legs were inspected.

Their shoulders were felt.

Seeing the white patch on Hirna's forehead, Ramesh asked, "Did this one work more in the plough?"

Bechan replied, "Both worked."

"This one looks heavy."

"Hirna is slow, not weak."

Ramesh looked at Bechan.

"Will you come?"

"Where?"

"As far as my village. You can show us the way."

Bechan looked at Ramsagar.

Ramsagar said, "Go and come back."

The money was counted.

Mohan counted it twice.

Ramesh once.

The paper was signed.

Hirna and Kajru were led out.

At the mouth of the courtyard Kajru stopped once.

Bechan slackened the rope.

“Come.”

A bell rang.

First the thinner one.

Then the heavy note.

The two bullocks moved towards the road.

Ramsagar stood at the doorway.

Mohan stood on the veranda.

Neelu, the small child of the household, came running out from inside.

“Where are the bullocks going?”

Mohan said, “To another home.”

“Will they come back?”

“No.”

Neelu stared for a few moments.

“The bells too?”

“Yes.”

The bullocks passed the bend.

Their bells could be heard for a while.

Then they stopped.

Bechan returned on foot after noon.

His hands were empty.

But he had something tucked under his arm.

Ramsagar asked, “What is it?”

Bechan opened it and showed them.

Kajru’s old, thin-toned bell.

Mohan was startled.

“That went with the bullock.”

“The strap tore on the way.”

“But you stitched it only yesterday.”

“Hirna’s. This is Kajru’s.”

Mohan laughed.

“Then what did Ramesh say?”

“He said, ‘Keep it. I have no need for a bell.’”

Bechan turned the bell in his hand.
Mohan said, "You keep it."
Bechan did not ring it this time.
"Me?"
"Yes. You recognised that sound for so many years."
Ramsagar too said, "Keep it."
Bechan looked at the bell.
Then he set it down gently on the ground.
"I don't want the bell."
Mohan's eyebrows rose.
"Why?"
"What will I do with a bell if I take it home?"
"Remember."
Bechan gave a faint laugh.
"Can memory run a household?"
Mohan was silent.
Bechan said, "I want what is still owed to me."
The sentence was not harsh.
But it was clear.
Ramsagar said at once, "You will get it."
Mohan went inside.
That evening all three sat down with the papers again.
This time Mohan did not add up only the cost of the bullocks.
Bechan's monthly wages.
His share of paddy.
The period from the previous Jyeshtha until now.
The cash still owed.
Ramsagar said, "Give him the full paddy share."
This time Mohan did not object.
Bechan said, "Why the full amount?"
Ramsagar replied, "Because we are ending your year in the middle."
Bechan shook his head.
"A little more than half would be fair."
Mohan looked at him.
"Why are you asking for less?"
"Because for the next six months I will not be looking after the bullocks."
Ramsagar smiled.

“So you keep accounts too.”

“If a poor man does not keep accounts, hunger teaches him to.”

Mohan wrote the amount in the ledger.

After a while Bechan asked, “Would the ploughing-machine owner need a man?”

Mohan said, “For what work?”

“Not with the driver. The owner keeps someone to handle oil, ropes, spare parts, and note the order of the fields.”

“Would you do it?”

“I can learn.”

Ramsagar kept looking at Bechan’s face.

“From bullocks to a machine?”

Bechan said, “The bullocks did not do my work. I did the work. The bullocks were with me.”

Ramsagar’s expression changed.

Mohan’s pen stopped in the middle of a line.

Bechan added, “The bullocks are gone. Why should I stop?”

The next day Mohan spoke to the owner of a ploughing machine in the neighbouring village.

The man would not promise work immediately.

“There will be a rush in Baisakh,” he said. “Then I’ll need a man for two weeks.”

Mohan told Bechan.

Bechan said, “I’ll start with two weeks.”

“And the other days?”

“Some field labour. Some goats.”

“Goats?”

“I have two. I’ll get two more.”

Mohan laughed.

“Then tie the bell around one of those goats.”

Bechan laughed too.

“A bell this big would break a goat’s neck.”

Until evening Kajru’s bell lay there at the edge of the courtyard.

Neelu picked it up and began ringing it.

Clang.

Clang.

Clang.

Ramsagar said, “Don’t ring it so much.”

Neelu asked, "Why?"

Ramsagar searched for an answer.

Bechan said, "Let him ring it. It isn't around a bullock's neck now."

Neelu rang it again.

The sound echoed through the empty cattle shed.

At that moment Mohan had opened his account ledger.

On the old page was written—

Bullock expenses.

He did not cross out the line beneath it.

He merely wrote beside it—

Ended: Phagun.

Below that he wrote—

Bechan—paddy share and remaining cash to be settled.

Then he left some space.

Ramsagar asked, "Why leave it blank?"

Mohan said, "For the next work."

Ramsagar looked outside.

The cattle shed was empty.

A little old straw lay in the trough.

The tethering post was still there.

The plough leaned against the wall.

The need for bullocks had genuinely diminished.

That was not difficult to accept.

What was difficult was understanding how many other accounts opened the moment one need came to an end.

Evening was deepening.

From the direction of the neighbouring village came the heavy sound of a ploughing machine.

In the courtyard Neelu rang the bell once more.

Clang.

Bechan paused as he crossed the doorway.

He did not turn back.

He only said, "Neelu, not so hard. It's brass; it may crack."

Neelu rang the bell softly.

This time the sound was small.

But clear.

The Unpaved Road

It was the first week of Bhadra.

For three days the rain had been falling off and on.

The wheel-ruts in the unpaved road of Balha village were still fresh.

Yet by six in the morning people would already be gathering at the bend in the road.

There was only one reason.

The bus.

Not even a month had passed since a regular bus service had begun in the village.

Earlier, reaching the main road meant walking three and a half kos.

Older people looked for a bullock cart.

Schoolchildren pedalled their bicycles through the mud.

Women going to the market set out at dawn with baskets on their heads.

Now the bus left the bend at six twenty in the morning.

In the evening it dropped them there again at five ten.

During the first week, the villagers learnt the bus's time not from a clock but from its sound.

A rumble would rise from the distant road.

Dogs would begin to bark.

Raghu, who ran the tea stall, would put water on the stove for the second time.

And Kanak would pick up the schoolbag.

Kanak was sixteen.

Kanak studied at the block higher secondary school.

Earlier, Kanak's father, Dhaneshwar, used to take Kanak by bicycle as far as the main road.

If the day turned bad, school was missed.

Now Kanak would say, "I will go on my own."

Whenever Dhaneshwar heard this, pride and a sense of emptiness came over his face together.

The rear seat of the bicycle had been left empty.

The bus had changed more than Kanak's day.

Shanti Devi could now take two baskets of vegetables to the town market on Tuesdays and Fridays.

Earlier she could not carry more than one basket.

On the way back, the empty baskets held salt, oil, medicine and exercise books for the children.

Budhan Mahato had already gone twice to the hospital to have his eyes examined.

Three boys from the hamlet at the far end had begun going to town every day for wage work.

Raghu's tea stall had shifted to the bend.

His brother sat at the old spot, but there were fewer customers there now.

One bus had redrawn many small lines inside the village.

Where someone's day would begin.

Where someone's goods would be sold.

Who would receive news first.

Who would have to wait.

For the first two weeks the road remained dry.

Ramji, the bus driver, said, "The road is unpaved, but it can take the weight."

The villagers took the sentence as praise.

In the third week it rained.

On the first night, rain fell hard for two hours.

The next morning the bus did reach the bend, but in the low southern stretch its rear wheel sank halfway into the mud.

All the passengers got down.

The men pushed.

The women stood at the edge, steadying their baskets.

Kanak took off the shoes, carried them by hand and crossed the mud.

It took half an hour before the bus could get free.

Ramji said nothing.

He kept turning back to look at that stretch of road.

When the bus returned in the evening, the conductor called out, "If it is like this tomorrow, the bus will not come as far as the bend."

That single sentence spread anxiety through the village.

Raghu said, "We will have to fill the road here."

Dhaneshwar said, "We may be able to get broken bricks from the kiln."

Shanti Devi said, "If the bus stops coming, we will be back to the old days."

That evening ten or fifteen people went out with lanterns to inspect the road.

Where the bus had sunk, the road was naturally a little lower.

Rainwater came from the fields to the east, crossed that low stretch and drained towards a hollow on the west.

The old bullock carts used to pass along one side of that channel.

A cyclist could put a foot down and get across.

For the bus, the depression was too deep.

At dawn the next day, people began bringing broken brick, earth and pieces of old roof tile.

By noon the low stretch had been filled.

The road had been made level.

In the evening Ramji brought the bus and drove slowly over the repaired patch.

The bus crossed without sinking.

No one clapped.

But relief showed on every face.

"Now it is all right," Raghu said.

That night it rained again.

This time the rain went on for a long while.

Before the rumble of the bus was heard at dawn, a cry came from the southern hamlet.

"Water is coming into the house!"

Dhaneshwar ran.

Raghu left the stove and ran.

Kanak followed with the schoolbag.

The southern hamlet lay a little lower than the road.

Parvati Devi's courtyard was filled with water up to the knees.

The first step of the veranda was under water.

The chickens had climbed onto a bamboo platform.

Two sacks of paddy had been placed on a cot.

Parvati's granddaughter Meera was throwing water out with a brass bowl.

Kanak caught hold of her hand.

"What will happen if you keep throwing out this much?"

Meera said, "Nothing. But I cannot just stand here either."

Dhaneshwar looked towards the road.

Where there had been a low channel the previous day, there was now a raised filling of brick and earth.

The water coming from the eastern fields could no longer cross the road.

It had turned south and poured into Parvati's courtyard.

Raghu said quietly, "We have blocked the water's way."

No one answered.

Just then the sound of the bus came from far away.

Meera looked at her wet clothes.

She too studied at the block girls' school.

The new bus service had made it possible for her to remain enrolled.

Earlier her mother had said that sending her every day on a three-kos walk to the road was not possible.

Meera said, "Do not stop the bus."

Parvati Devi looked at her.

"Who is stopping it?"

Meera fell silent.

Parvati went on, "We need the bus. But we do not need water inside our house. Both things can happen together."

The bus stopped on the other side of the filled patch.

Ramji got down and looked at the situation.

Scraping the mud near the wheel with his foot, he said, "If you raise the road, you must leave a way for the water."

Raghu was a little irritated.

"Yesterday you said the bus was sinking."

Ramji replied calmly, "It was sinking. But I did not tell you to stop the water."

The statement was simple.

That was why it also sounded a little harsh.

The bus left half an hour late.

Kanak and Meera climbed aboard.

Meera sat with her wet feet tucked beneath the seat.

As the bus moved off, she kept looking at her house through the window.

Parvati Devi was still draining water from the courtyard.

Kanak went to school after reaching town.

So did Meera.

But in the village that day, the question of the road became larger than the question of the bus.

People gathered near the panchayat house in the afternoon.

Someone said, "Remove the filling."

Someone said, "If you remove it, the bus will stop coming."

Someone said, "Turn the road another way."

Someone asked, "Who will give the land?"

At that question, everyone fell a little quiet.

There were private fields on both sides of the road.

Those who wanted the road widened for the sake of the bus were not so ready to give up even two hands' width of their paddy field.

Shanti Devi sat down after setting her basket aside.

She had returned early from the market.

She said, "If we remove the bricks, the first problem returns. If we keep the whole stretch filled, Parvati's house will flood. We need a passage through the middle for the water."

Dhaneshwar said, "Shall we cut a drain?"

An elderly farmer named Bindeshwar shook his head.

"If you only cut a drain, the bus wheel will sink there again."

For a while people drew lines in the earth with sticks.

Bindeshwar understood the old construction of the road.

He said, "There used to be two thick bamboos laid here, with earth above them. The water passed underneath."

Raghu laughed.

"Will the bus run over bamboo now?"

Bindeshwar laughed too.

"Not the bus. Understand the idea. Weight above, a passage for water below."

This time no one laughed.

Two old concrete pipes lay in a rear room of the panchayat building.

They had originally been brought for draining a hand pump, but had never been used.

That afternoon they were measured.

If the two pipes were laid side by side, the water could pass through.

When Ramji brought the bus back that evening, he inspected the place again.

He said, "Pack the earth firmly above them. If the wheel passes straight over it, the bus should manage."

"And the rain?" Dhaneshwar asked.

"The rain will tell. The road is unpaved. I cannot make it paved on paper."

Shanti Devi smiled at that.

That night the bus did not come as far as the bend.

It stopped near the main road.

The villagers walked out to it.

Kanak said, "One day on the old route."

Meera replied, "The old route feels short now."

The next day the pipes were laid.

The broken bricks were set in place again.

The earth was tamped down.

Small bamboo stakes with red cloth tied to them were planted on both sides so that the driver would know there was a water passage underneath.

Parvati Devi sat there all day.

Someone told her, "You look after the house. We are all here."

She replied, "The house is visible from here. I will watch the road too."

By evening the work was finished.

A little rain fell that night.

At dawn Parvati Devi was the first to rise.

She went to the pipes.

Water was coming from the eastern fields.

It entered the mouths of the pipes, passed beneath the road and flowed towards the hollow on the west.

She watched it for a while.

Then she went home and set Meera's schoolbag outside.

By six fifteen people had begun gathering at the bend.

Raghu was pouring tea.

Shanti Devi's baskets held aubergines and okra.

Kanak had the schoolbag tucked under one arm.

Meera was scraping mud from her slippers.

At six twenty the sound of the bus was heard.

The bus approached the low stretch slowly.

Ramji reduced speed.

Everyone's eyes were on the wheels.

The bus passed over the pipes.

The earth sank a little.

The red cloth fluttered.

Underneath, the water kept flowing.
The bus stopped at the bend.
The conductor called out, "Town! Town!"
People began to climb aboard.
Parvati Devi gave Meera two rupees separately.
"Buy an exercise book."
Meera asked, "And the house?"
Parvati looked at the water flowing beneath the road.
"The house is standing for now. You go."
The bus moved away.
Its wheels left two fresh lines on the unpaved road.
Looking at those lines, Raghu said, "This road will always need repairs like this."
Bindeshwar replied, "If a road is used, it will bear marks."
Dhaneshwar asked, "And troubles?"
Bindeshwar was silent for a moment.
Then he said, "Where people travel, the reckoning travels too."
Kanak and Meera were already so far away that only the red rear of the bus could be seen.
Below, water kept flowing through the pipes.
Above, wheels kept moving along the unpaved road.

Guardian of the Fields

Dukhan Mahato removed the two thorny branches laid across the eastern entrance to the grazing ground.

The morning dew still clung to the blades of grass.

When the first cow of the morning went in, the bell at its neck rang once.

With his knife, Dukhan made a notch on the small bamboo stake at the edge.

No one had ever told him to do this.

For twenty or twenty-two years, he had been doing it on his own.

At first his younger brother used to be with him.

Then his brother left for the city.

After that, Dukhan alone kept removing thorns, mending broken embankments, and filling with earth the foot-tracks hollowed out after the rains.

People in the village called him the "guardian of the fields."

Dukhan would laugh whenever he heard the name.

"What can I guard about the grazing ground?" he would say. "Where cattle and goats walk, the paths make themselves."

That morning three herds went in.

The first was Ramlochan's five cows.

The second was Kaushalya's seven goats.

The third was Chhotan's two buffaloes and a heifer.

By the time the sun had risen, the grazing ground looked almost empty.

The cows had gone down into the low northern stretch.

The goats were near the thorn scrub to the west.

The buffaloes lay beside the muddy edge of the pond.

Only Dukhan remained at the eastern entrance.

Just then a government vehicle from the block office arrived.

Three people got out of the vehicle.

Chandrakant, the village mukhiya, was with them as well.

One young man carried a map in his hand.

Another had a measuring tape.

The third man was Arvind, the son of Mangaru from the village.

After living away for fifteen years, Arvind had returned and started a milk-collection business in the village.

He wanted to lease six bighas of the grazing ground and grow fodder there.

"It will be fenced," Arvind said, "but villagers will be able to buy cut fodder at a low price."

Dukhan asked no questions.

They began measuring.

The young man kept drawing lines on the paper.

"There are no animals in this part," he said.

Dukhan replied, "Not now."

The young man looked up.

"The survey is happening now."

"Yes."

"Then I will write what is here now."

Dukhan remained silent.

By noon the measuring was complete.

A six-bigha section in the south was enclosed on the map with a blue pencil line.

Chandrakant said, "The village income will rise. Land lying idle will finally yield something."

Dukhan said nothing again.

The government vehicle drove away.

That afternoon the goats came into the very southern section that had been marked.

There was less grass there, but more leafy scrub.

From a distance Kaushalya called, "Dukhan Kaka, will they put thorns around this side from tomorrow?"

"Not yet."

"Arvind said the land is going to be given to him."

"So far, only a line has been drawn on paper."

Kaushalya did not take her eyes off the goats.

"Which comes first - the line on the paper, or the thorns?"

Dukhan did not laugh.

In the evening he sat beside the bamboo stake.

He looked at the old knife-notches from all those days.

There was no proper count of how many marks there were.

Some were for cows, some for buffaloes, some for the day an embankment had broken.

Those marks were his memory, not evidence.

The next day Dukhan brought an old school notebook from home.

Half its pages were still blank.

On the first page he wrote -

"Grazing Ground - Movement."

Below it he made four columns - time, household, animals, direction taken.

Writing came slowly to him.

Ramlochan's five cows went in.

He wrote, "Morning. Ramlochan. Five. North."

Kaushalya's seven goats went in.

He wrote, "Morning. Kaushalya. Seven. West."

At ten o'clock the grazing ground again looked almost empty.

Dukhan wrote nothing in the register.

At two in the afternoon, Kaushalya's goats went south.

He wrote, "Afternoon. Seven. South."

In the evening Chhotan's buffaloes went exactly where the blue line had been drawn.

He wrote that down too.

On the third day Manjari came.

Manjari taught at the village school.

She looked at Dukhan's register.

"What is this?"

"The movement on this land."

"Who told you to write it?"

"No one."

Manjari turned the pages.

"You are writing the time as well?"

"Those people came at noon."

Manjari understood.

"One day will not be enough."

"That is why I will write for seven days."

"Why seven days?"

Dukhan thought for a moment.

"There is a market day in a week, the school is closed on one day, and people's work changes."

Manjari asked, "And the rain?"

"When the rain comes, I will write again."

Manjari stayed there until evening that day.

She added a new column to the register - "How many times."

"The same animal may come twice in a day," she said.

Dukhan nodded.

On the fourth day Arvind came.

He looked at the register.

"Kaka, do you want to stop my work?"

Dukhan said, "Where is your work in my hands?"

"People say you are opposing it."

"I am writing."

"What?"

"What moves here."

Arvind read the page.

"What will this prove?"

"I do not know."

"Then why?"

"When a decision is made, it should not be made by calling this empty land."

Arvind was silent for a moment.

"Kaka, does this grazing ground pay for itself now?"

Dukhan understood the question.

"Will the grazing ground pay, or the animals?"

"I am talking about income for the village."

"Yes."

"If the lease is granted, the panchayat will receive money."

"Yes."

"And fodder will grow here too."

"Yes."

Arvind grew a little irritated.

"Then what is the problem?"

Dukhan pointed to the register.

"I am writing down the problem."

Arvind burst out laughing.

"You have not lost this habit of yours."

"What habit?"

"Not giving a straight answer."

Dukhan laughed too.

"On land that is not straight, straight answers are hard to find."

The fifth day was market day.

Many of the village animals reached the grazing ground late.

Young men from some households had taken animals to the market to sell them.

Until noon the southern section remained almost empty.

In the evening, three herds suddenly gathered there.

Manjari kept noting the times.

The sixth day was a school holiday.

Children brought the calves and goats out early.

The grazing ground stayed full from morning onward.

Dukhan said, "If the survey had happened today, the land would have looked heavily used on paper."

Manjari said, "And yesterday, hardly used."

"That is why you cannot understand the habits of land from a single glance."

On the seventh day there was a light rain.

The soil in the southern part absorbed the water quickly.

Water stood in the low northern section.

All the cows and buffaloes moved south.

Dukhan kept the raindrops from falling on the register.

That afternoon Chandrakant came.

"The gram sabha meets tomorrow," he said. "The lease will be discussed."

Dukhan handed him the register.

Chandrakant turned the pages.

"You wrote all this?"

"Manjari did too."

"How many animals were there?"

Manjari said, "The same animals came repeatedly, so there are two counts. One is the number of distinct animals; the other is the number of visits."

Chandrakant frowned.

"Who at the gram sabha will understand so much accounting?"

Dukhan replied, "The ones who divide the land will understand it."

The next day the gram sabha met on the school veranda.

Arvind stated his proposal clearly.

Fodder would be grown on six bighas.

A fence would be put up.

The panchayat would receive an annual lease payment.

Village livestock owners would be able to buy cut fodder at a low price.

Some people agreed.

Some opposed it.

Kaushalya stood up.

"I have seven goats. If I have to buy cut fodder, where is the profit in keeping goats?"

Arvind said, "It will be sold cheaply."

Kaushalya said, "At present I pay nothing for grass."

Ramlochan said, "But the grazing ground does not provide enough grass throughout the year either."

At that Kaushalya fell silent.

It was true.

In summer the green part of the grazing ground shrank greatly.

Chandrakant opened Dukhan's register.

He read out the figures from the seven days.

No one applauded.

No one changed their opinion at once either.

Arvind asked for the register and studied the entries for the southern section.

"Why did all the animals come this way on the rainy day?"

Dukhan said, "Water was standing in the north."

"And in summer?"

"Goats at midday. Buffaloes in the evening. Fewer cows."

Arvind opened the map.

"What if I take three bighas instead of six?"

Kaushalya did not object at once.

She came closer to the map.

"Where would the fence go?"

Arvind showed her the blue line.

For the first time, Dukhan took the map in his own hands.

He put a finger on a narrow strip.

"Leave this path open."

"Why?"

"The goats use this way to reach the scrub on the west."

Ramlochan pointed to another place.

"Do not fence this low section. In the rains the animals turn this way from the north."

Manjari checked each point against the register.

The meeting went on for a long time.

In the end, no lease was approved.

Nor was it rejected.

It was decided that livestock movement would be recorded for another two months, especially between the end of summer and the first heavy rain.

After that, they would meet again to decide how much of the land, if any, could be fenced.

Arvind looked disappointed, but as he rose he handed the register back to Dukhan.

"Kaka, next time write down my fodder figures too."

Dukhan said, "You write those."

"Two registers?"

"Yes. One for the movement of the land, one for your costs."

Arvind laughed.

"Then who will decide?"

Dukhan looked out from the veranda toward the grazing ground.

"Whoever has to decide will read both."

In the evening Dukhan again removed the thorny branches from the eastern entrance. Ramlochan's cows went in. Kaushalya's goats followed behind them.

The two small survey stakes still stood in the southern section. No one had pulled them out. No one had stretched wire between them either.

Beside those stakes, Dukhan stood his old bamboo upright. It bore the old knife-notches. In his hand was the new register.

From that day on, Dukhan stopped making notches. What he had once only remembered, he now began to write down. The grazing ground was still shared. And the decision was still to be made.

The Paddy-Planting Song

The morning water still lay motionless in the paddy field. The night's rain had stopped, but the clouds hung low. Along the edge of the field, yesterday's footprints in the mud had been half washed away.

Sonmati came towards the field, gathering her sari up to her knees. In her hand was a short, old bamboo stick with which she used to set the first line for transplanting.

Behind her came Basanti, Rekha, Devaki, and three other women. Each carried bundles of paddy seedlings.

Looking across the field from a distance, Sonmati said, "Today we'll begin from the eastern corner. The water is right there."

Basanti laughed. "What rises first—the song or the seedlings?"

Sonmati said, "Without the song, the row goes crooked."

Rekha laughed. "A row is straightened by the eye, Kaki, not by a song."

"Can your eyes watch the feet of nine people at once?" Sonmati replied.

Just then a rumbling sound came from the road.

They all turned. Pawan, Devkant's son, was bringing a rice-transplanting machine. Behind it were iron teeth and square compartments for holding seedlings.

Basanti's laughter stopped.

Devkant followed on a motorcycle.

"Today the transplanting will be done by machine," he said. "We've got a two-day break between spells of rain. This much field won't be finished by hand."

Sonmati planted the stick in the mud. "Then why did you call us?"

Devkant told her, "The machine can't reach everywhere. The corners, along the embankments, wherever seedlings are missed—you'll fill those places. The wages will be counted separately."

Rekha went up to the machine. "How much can it do in a day?"

Pawan said proudly, "As much as all of you would do in two days."

Sonmati did not look at Pawan. She kept looking at the field.

Earlier, on transplanting days in this field, ten or twelve women would step into the water in a single line. One would raise the opening line of the song and another would answer. To the beat of the song their hands went down, seedlings sank into the mud, and their feet advanced together.

A woman who was falling behind would shorten her answering line. If one part of the row moved ahead, the woman leading it would hold the opening note a little longer.

The song was time, measure, and play all at once.

Today the machine made its first round.

Its rumble spread across the field.

Pawan sat on the seat. Devkant walked along the embankment. The women followed behind, watching.

The iron teeth picked up the seedlings and pressed them into the water at fixed intervals. The row was so straight that Rekha said, "See, Kaki? Straight even without a song."

Sonmati said nothing.

After the first round, Pawan stopped the machine.

"Mark the places where there are gaps," Devkant said.

Basanti asked, "How do we mark them?"

Pawan handed them three small bamboo pegs. "The more empty spots each person fills, the more will be counted. We'll settle the account in the evening."

For the first time Sonmati looked at Pawan. "The empty places will be counted?"

"Yes. Everyone's wages according to the work done."

Basanti picked up her seedlings. "Come then. Let's go looking for empty places."

The seven women did not form a single line.

One went east, another to the middle, another along the embankment.

For the first half-hour Sonmati remained silent.

She was used to keeping her pace by watching the elbow of the woman on her left. Now there was no one on her left. The machine's noise came from the right.

From a distance Basanti called, "Five missed here!"

From the other side Rekha called, "Seven for me!"

Devaki shouted, "Don't count—plant!"

Pawan laughed. "Without counting, how will we settle the evening's account?"

By noon, three-quarters of the field had filled with straight rows.

The women's backs had not remained bent continuously as before. From time to time they could stand upright.

Basanti said, "This is one advantage. My back hasn't broken."

Sonmati conceded, "It is an advantage."

Rekha said, "And tomorrow we'll be able to take up another field."

Devaki said softly, "What if a machine comes to that field too?"

No one answered.

They ate their midday meal on the embankment. Earlier, the transplanting team sat together in one place. Today Pawan sat in the machine's shade, Devkant ate the flatbread brought from home, and the women sought shade under different trees.

Sonmati opened her cloth bundle: flattened rice, salt, and green chillies.

Basanti came and sat beside her.

"Kaki, start a song."

Putting some flattened rice into her mouth, Sonmati said, "A transplanting song doesn't rise while you're sitting."

"A song is a song."

"No. It moves with the movement of the hands."

Rekha came over too. "Then sing to the pace of the machine."

Sonmati smiled. "Will the machine answer?"

Rekha wanted to say something, then fell silent.

After the meal Pawan took up the western corner. There the field narrowed like a triangle, with a bamboo grove on one side and an old embankment on the other.

The machine tried twice to turn. Its rear teeth touched the embankment.

Pawan got down to inspect it.

"This corner will have to be done by hand," he said.

Devkant called the women. "All of you come here together. Let's finish it quickly."

Sonmati picked up her bamboo stick again.

"Where do we start the row?" Rekha asked.

Sonmati placed the stick in the water and aligned two points. "From beyond the bamboo grove's shadow to this mark."

The seven women again stood in one row.

For the first time that day, their shoulders were close to one another.

Sonmati lifted a handful of seedlings.

Without thinking, a line came from her lips—

"Moon in the mud, a current in the water..."

Basanti answered at once—

"Plant the paddy together, harvest the burden together..."

It was not a line from an old song. Sonmati too had perhaps never sung it before.

Devaki laughed. "Did you make that up just now?"

"It came out of my mouth," Sonmati said.

A second line rose.

This time Rekha answered.

The song was not very loud. The machine was switched off, so the sound travelled far.

Four rows were planted.

Sonmati raised the opening line, Basanti answered, Rekha added words in between. Once Devaki laughingly said the wrong words, and everyone burst out laughing.

The triangular corner slowly turned green.

Pawan sat on the embankment watching.

"If you work like this, how will the counting be done?" he suddenly asked.

The song broke off.

"What?" Basanti asked.

"How many seedlings did each of you plant in this corner? I have to record everyone's wages separately this evening."

Sonmati placed the seedlings in her hand down in the water.

Rekha said, "The four of us did it together."

"Not four, all seven," Devaki corrected her.

Pawan opened the register. There was a space beside each name for a number.

"Then how do I divide the corner into seven?"

Basanti laughed. "How can a corner be cut into seven pieces?"

Devkant said, "Write the same amount for everyone according to the time spent."

Pawan wrote the same figure beside all seven names.

Rekha bent down to look. "What is this number?"

"One corner," Pawan said.

Rekha laughed again. "The measure of the work has become like the song."

Sonmati asked, "How is it like the song?"

"One person begins, another answers, but in the end what's written is—one corner."

For a few moments Sonmati looked at Rekha's face.

Then she picked up the seedlings again.

By the time the triangle was finished, the clouds had thickened again.

Pawan started the machine. The rumbling once more filled the field.

The women again dispersed in search of empty spots.

No song rose.

Once Sonmati tried to begin a line, but her own voice came back only as far as her own ears.

She fell silent.

By evening the field was finished.

The machine's straight rows were filled here and there by small corrections made by hand. In the western triangle the rows curved slightly, but there was no empty patch.

Pawan opened the register and began calculating wages.

Beside Rekha's name: twenty-seven empty spots. Beside Basanti's: twenty-two. Beside Devaki's: nineteen. Beside Sonmati's: only eleven.

Looking at the register, Rekha said, "Kaki, you filled fewer."

Sonmati said quietly, "I was watching the row."

Pawan said, "There is no separate wage for that."

Devkant intervened. "An equal share of this corner has been added to everyone."

Sonmati said nothing.

The wages were distributed.

Counting her coins, Basanti said, "Earlier our backs stayed bent all day during transplanting. Now the work is finished in half a day."

Devaki said, "Earlier we got seven days of work. Now it is three."

Rekha said, "I'll sew for the other four days."

Devaki laughed. "You know how to sew."

Rekha fell silent.

In that silence, no one blamed the machine. No one praised it either.

Sonmati picked up her bamboo stick from the embankment.

Pawan took the machine towards the road. Its rumble gradually faded into the distance.

The women went to the canal bank to wash their feet.

Mud dissolved away into the water.

Very softly Basanti began the first half of the new line again—"Moon in the mud..."

Sonmati looked at her.

Rekha kept washing her feet. Devaki wrung out her sari. No one answered at once.

Basanti did not complete the line either.

Sonmati smiled, but did not force the song to rise.

On their way back, they passed by the western corner of the field.

In the evening light, the machine's straight rows looked alike all the way into the distance. Near the bamboo grove, the rows planted by hand held a slight curve.

Looking towards that corner, Rekha said, "The machine still won't be able to turn there."

From far away Pawan called, "Next time I'll bring a smaller machine!"

They all laughed.

Sonmati laughed too.

She said nothing about whether the song would rise next time.

That question was not settled in the field. Only this much was certain: wherever they still had to step into the water together in one line, the first note might yet come from someone's mouth.

Across the rest of the field lay the machine's straight rows, and the evening wind moved through them even without a song.

The Register Beneath the Banyan

It was a Jeth afternoon. The banyan's shade was not round; it had stretched eastward. Dry leaves had gathered among the roots, and an old wooden bench stood over them.

Munilal sat on the bench. Before him lay open a thick register bound in cloth. The corners of the cover had worn white.

Everyone in the village called it 'the Banyan Register.'

It was called a register, but it was not an official one.

No one entered wedding dates in it, nor land holdings. What it recorded was when canal water arrived, how far it reached, whose field received its turn, whose turn was missed, and who exchanged a turn with someone else.

Munilal had once been a farmer. As he grew older, his son took over the fields. Twenty-five years earlier, two families had fought over canal water. After that, the practice began of sitting beneath the banyan and writing down the turns.

The first page had held only seven names.

Now it held the names of twenty-seven households.

That day Munilal was turning the pages when Sudha, a teacher at the school, came hurrying up.

'Uncle, people have come from the block office.'

Munilal pushed his spectacles up. 'What for?'

'To inspect the drought-relief claims.'

'There was no rain, and that needs inspection?'

Sudha could not smile. 'The papers say our village is irrigated.'

Munilal's hand stopped on the page.

'Irrigated?'

'The government canal register says water was released into this branch on eleven days between Jeth and Bhadav.'

Munilal said quietly, 'It may well have been released.'

'As far as the village?' Sudha asked.

Munilal turned the register toward her. 'Look at this.'

Sudha bent over it.

Jeth 12 - second watch of the night. Water as far as the first eastern bend.

Jeth 13 - dawn. Water stopped at Harigovind's field.

Ashadh 4 - midnight. Two hours.

Ashadh 19 - water entered the branch, did not reach the mouth of the village channel.

Sawan 7 - silt at the gate. No water.

Sawan 21 - held back in the upstream village.

Bhadav 3 - one hour at night, only five fields.

Bhadav 14 - branch dry.

Sudha kept turning the pages.

'Where are the eleven days?'

Munilal said, 'On paper.'

From beyond the banyan, Mahendra, who sold tea, called out, 'The government people are sitting in the panchayat house. They're asking all the farmers for their papers.'

Sudha lifted the register.

Munilal immediately put a hand on it. 'Where are you taking this?'

'To show them.'

'This is not a government document.'

'So?'

'So they will say: you people wrote this yourselves.'

Sudha did not close the register. 'We wrote it ourselves, yes. But the dates are not lies.'

Munilal remained silent.

Near the banyan roots, a tethered goat stretched its rope and sniffed at the dry leaves. Far away the canal embankment lay pale under the sun. There was no water there, only fine dust.

Two officials and a junior engineer were seated in the panchayat house. On the table lay government registers, measurement sheets, and a stack of applications.

The farmers went in one by one.

Ramvilas came out with his face drawn.

'What happened?' Sudha asked.

'They say my field falls in the irrigated category. Relief is only for unirrigated fields.'

'Did you get water?'

Ramvilas laughed. 'Water? I hired a private pump twice.'

Munilal came slowly, the register tucked under his arm.

The moment he saw him, Ramvilas said, 'Uncle, show them your register.'

The official inside heard the voice from outside. 'What register?'

Sudha said, 'The village canal-water register.'

The official held out his hand. 'Bring it.'

Before handing it over, Munilal asked, 'Will this document be accepted?'

The official looked at the page. 'It does not belong to the department.'

'Then?'

'We can look at it. Whether it counts as evidence is another matter.'

Munilal placed the register on the table.

The junior engineer turned the pages. 'Who writes this?'

'On a day when someone exchanges a turn, there is also a thumbprint or signature beside the name,' Munilal said. 'I write the rest.'

The engineer stopped at one page. 'It says here: Ashadh 4, midnight, two hours. How can the time be so exact?'

Munilal replied, 'That night Phulkumari's daughter-in-law was in labour. Someone had gone to bring a vehicle. We looked at the clock when the water was released because it was her field's turn. The vehicle arrived two hours later. The water was cut off then.'

From outside Phulkumari called, 'It is true.'

The official looked toward the door. 'Don't all speak at once.'

The engineer looked at another page. 'Bhadav 3 - one hour, five fields. Names?'

Munilal read out the five names.

Two of those five people were present in the panchayat house. Both raised their hands.

The official leaned back in his chair. 'Look, the departmental register records the days on which water was released from the main canal into the branch. Your register records whether it reached the village. Those are not the same thing.'

Sudha said at once, 'Then which one was used when the area was classified as irrigated?'

Before the official could answer, the engineer said, 'Water was released into the branch, so the area must have been treated as irrigated.'

'And if the water never reached the fields?' Ramvilas asked from outside.

The official said again, 'That is why an inspection is being conducted.'

Munilal ran a hand over the register. 'If the inspection happens at noon, the canal will look dry. How will you see the one hour of water that came at night?'

For a few moments the room was silent.

The engineer asked, 'Where is the gate?'

'A mile and a half upstream from here.'

'Where does the silt collect?'

'At the third bend.'

'Will you show me?'

Munilal closed the register. 'Now?'

'Now.'

The afternoon was beginning to decline when five people set out along the canal embankment: the engineer, the official, Sudha, Munilal and Ramvilas.

The mouth of the canal was wide. In two places upstream the grass was green, but toward the village the ground was cracked.

At the third bend there really was a high mound of silt.

The engineer pushed a bamboo measuring rod into it.

'How long has this been here?'

Ramvilas said, 'At least two years.'

Munilal corrected him. 'It has been this high since Bhadav last year. Before that it was half as high.'

'Is there a record?' the official asked.

Munilal opened the register.

Bhadav 27 - silt at the third bend after the water fell. Next turn blocked.

On the next page: Kartik 8 - five households cut away the silt together; half the passage opened.

Phagun 3 - filled again.

The engineer kept looking at the page.

'How did you remember all these dates?'

Munilal said, 'I did not remember them. That is why I wrote them down.'

At that sentence Sudha looked at Munilal.

People called the register beneath the banyan a memory, but Munilal regarded it as a way of escaping the unreliability of memory.

When they reached the last field in the village, Ramvilas pointed out the dry stubble of his paddy.

'Water came here on Bhadav 3,' Munilal said.

Ramvilas looked startled. 'Not as far as my field.'

'Your name is not among those five.'

Ramvilas quickly checked the register. It was true. The five names belonged to other fields.

He was silent for a few moments.

Sudha asked, 'Then why did you write in your application that you received canal water once?'

Ramvilas said awkwardly, 'It came into the village, so I wrote that I had received it too.'

The official smiled for the first time. 'See? The village register does not take everyone's side either.'

Munilal said, 'If a register takes sides, what kind of register is it?'

The inspection continued until evening.

The engineer wrote three things on his measurement sheet: water was released into the main branch; there is a silt obstruction at the third bend; regular delivery to the lower seventeen fields could not be verified.

The official said, 'This is today's inspection. I cannot say yet whether the relief will be approved.'

Ramvilas's face fell again.

Munilal remained calm. 'At least this much has now been written down. It was not there before.'

Back at the panchayat house, the official placed the Banyan Register on the table again.

'Uncle, we need a copy of this.'

Munilal said at once, 'Not the whole thing.'

'Why?'

'It does not contain only irrigation turns. People exchange seed, bamboo, bullocks and pumps with one another too. Not everything in it is a matter for a government file.'

The official thought for a moment. 'Then only the canal pages.'

Sudha said, 'I'll make photocopies.'

Munilal agreed.

The next day the bench was set beneath the banyan again. The register lay open. Sudha had photocopied the canal pages and tied them together with red string.

As Mahendra set down the tea, he asked, 'Uncle, will the government register accept what your register says now?' Munilal said, 'Whether it accepts it or not is its affair.' 'Then what was the use?'

Munilal opened a fresh page and wrote the date. 'The use is that today, for the first time, an official paper recorded that releasing water and water

reaching the fields are two different things.' Sudha sat at the other end of the bench. 'And in your register?'

Munilal wrote: Today the third bend was measured again. Delivery to the lower seventeen fields was checked. Decision pending. He stopped his pen. 'My register will record that the decision is still pending.'

A dry leaf fell from the banyan onto the open page. Munilal did not remove it. When the breeze rose, the leaf slid on its own toward the edge of the register.

The canal was still dry. In the government register, water would remain recorded as having been released on eleven days. In the Banyan Register, it would remain recorded how many nights, how many bends and how many fields the water reached within those eleven days.

The two registers were not substitutes for one another. But now one had been placed before the other.

The Flood Mark

It was the last week of Jeth. The air remained hot until afternoon, but since the previous evening thin clouds had begun gathering in the eastern sky. Vinod had called Bhola the mason to scrape the old limewash from the western wall of the house.

A bamboo ladder lay beneath the wall. Bhola kept scraping away the lime with his trowel. Beneath the white layer, first a grey band appeared, then a straight brown line.

“Stop here,” he said. “Is this a damp stain, or old floodwater?”

Sitting on the veranda sorting makhana, Sharda Devi raised her head. She narrowed her eyes and looked toward the wall.

“Water,” she said. “That time it came up to here.”

Vinod came in from outside. “Which time?”

Sharda Devi laughed. “Have all the floods become the same colour to you?”

Bhola scraped again. A second, fainter line emerged a cubit below the first. Beneath that, beside the doorway, was a third small stain, half hidden under the limewash.

Nikhil came with a measuring cord. “Let me measure the highest one. We’ll keep the floor of the new room two bricks above it.”

“Only that much?” Vinod asked.

“If it stays above the highest flood mark, it should be safe.”

Sharda Devi set down the winnowing tray of makhana. “Measuring a wall is easy. Measuring a house is hard.”

Nikhil smiled. “Another riddle today?”

“Not a riddle. The floor you’re standing on now was not this high when the first flood came.”

Nikhil stopped the measuring cord.

Vinod said, “True. It used to be an earthen floor.”

“And before even that?” Sharda Devi asked.

Vinod fell silent.

Bhola slipped his trowel beneath the threshold. “There are old bricks here.”

He removed the crust of lime. Beneath the present threshold the edges of two courses of old brick appeared. Below even those was a hard layer of packed earth.

"That was the first floor," Sharda Devi said. "When I first came to this house."

Nikhil bent his knees and looked. "So the doorway went down this far?"

"Not the doorway. The ground was lower."

Bhola said, "That is why the doorway looks short now. The floor has been raised again and again."

Vinod looked at the upper brown line on the wall. "Was this from the first flood?"

"No," Sharda Devi said. "This is from the second."

"Where is the first?"

She went to the other side of the doorway. "Where your father once built the bamboo platform for the paddy, the plaster was redone. The stain was rubbed away."

Nikhil asked, "So all three lines are from different years?"

"All three are different. But the house too was different each time."

Bhola stopped working and sat in the shade of the veranda. He understood that before deciding the floor level of the new room, they first had to understand the measurements of the old house.

Without any preamble, Sharda Devi began the story of the first flood.

Vinod had been ten then. The floor of the house was earth. Sacks of paddy were kept directly on the floor in the eastern room. The floodwater came not at night but in the afternoon. First the courtyard filled, then the veranda, then the room. Vinod's father, Maheshwar, built two bamboo platforms and lifted the sacks onto them.

"Were the sacks saved?" Nikhil asked.

"Half of them," Sharda Devi said. "As many as we could lift high enough."

After the water receded, Maheshwar brought soil from beside the pond. Four men from the village lent their bullock carts. For three days the floor of the house was raised. Vinod used a bucket to wet the soil.

Vinod laughed. "I did less work with the bucket than I did playing with the water."

"You played, but by evening your clothes were always covered in mud," Sharda Devi said.

The mark of the first flood had not survived on the wall, but the old bricks buried beneath the doorway still showed where that floor had been.

The second flood came much later. By then Maheshwar was gone. Vinod was earning in Punjab. Sharda Devi, Manju, and two small children were at home. The water seemed lower than in the first flood, but because the floor had already been raised, everyone assumed the danger was less when it entered the room. As night deepened, the water rose to the level of the cot.

Manju came out from inside. "The little one had a fever that time."

Sharda Devi said, "You had laid her on the bamboo platform. I sat all night with her head in my lap."

Manju looked at the brown line on the wall. "This one?"

"Yes. Up to here."

Nikhil was startled. "I thought this was the oldest one."

Manju said, "It was before you were born."

After that flood, Vinod returned home. Fired bricks were bought with his earnings. A brick floor was laid over the earth. The house rose by another course. The lower part of the old doorway disappeared into earth and brick.

"So this line appears much higher above the floor now than it did then," Nikhil said slowly.

"Yes," Bhola said. "The line stayed in the same place on the wall, but the level beneath people's feet changed."

Nikhil opened the measuring cord again. He measured from the present floor to the line, then added the distance down to the buried old floor. On the paper he drew two short marks.

"And the third?"

The third flood was not so long ago. By then the western part of the house had a brick floor, but the northern room was still earthen. Nikhil was in school. Vinod was not away in another city; the whole family was at home. The water rose slowly, so everything was lifted in time. Less paddy was soaked that year, but the lower part of the wooden trunk rotted. Nikhil's certificates survived because Manju had already put them in a brass box and raised it onto the platform.

"All I remember is that school was closed for two days," Nikhil said.

Vinod said, "A child whose things are saved remembers less of the hardship of those days."

Sharda Devi replied, "And the owner of whatever goes under remembers more."

After the third flood, the family did not raise the floor of the whole house. Money was short. Bricks were laid only in the northern room, the grain platform was raised by a cubit, and a new wooden shelf was fixed to the wall for papers and documents.

Bhola kept looking at the three lines on the western wall. "Then, to decide the floor of the new room, we cannot look only at the highest stain. We must also see where the house used to be and where it is now."

Nikhil said, "But the new room will be built on today's ground. We can keep it two bricks above the highest water line."

Bhola shook his head. "We can. But then the roof will sit lower, and the doorway will become short again. If we raise the whole house that high, the cost will go up."

Vinod looked toward a post of the veranda. "Then?"

Manju spoke first. "Why raise every room? Build one room high enough that when the flood comes, the papers, medicines, grain, and children can all be taken up there."

Sharda Devi looked at Manju. "The work the bamboo platform used to do—now a room will do it?"

"Four people cannot fit on a platform," Manju said.

Nikhil drew a square on the ground with his finger. "The north-west corner is higher. A small room can be built there. Three steps from outside. The inside floor three bricks above the highest mark."

Bhola got up and went to that corner. He dug into the soil and examined it. "The old fill underneath is hard. The foundation will have to be checked separately, but the place looks right."

Vinod began counting the cost: bricks, mortar, timber, roof. Less than raising the whole house, but still not a small sum.

"We'll do half this year," he said. "First the floor and walls. The roof next month."

Manju said, "The rain will not wait for next month."

For a few moments, everyone was silent.

Sharda Devi rose and went to the old trunk. From it she took out some money tied in a piece of cloth.

Vinod said at once, "Not this."

"What is this money for?"

"Your medicines."

"The medicines will be kept in that high room, won't they?" Sharda Devi said. "Then let the room be built."

Vinod did not take the money. But the reckoning was made again. Manju added her sewing savings. Nikhil said he would work as Bhola's labourer for the next two weeks. Bhola laughed and said, "I won't waive the wages. If you work, it will be entered in the accounts."

By evening, the measurements of the new room had been settled.

Nikhil measured all three lines on the wall separately. Then he measured the old floor buried beneath the doorway, the first brick floor,

and the present floor as well. He did not write years on the paper because no one in the house remembered the exact dates of all three floods with certainty. Instead he wrote—

First: Father alive, earthen floor.

Second: before Vinod returned from Punjab, Manju's little one had a fever.

Third: Nikhil in school, the trunk got wet.

Vinod looked at the paper and said, "Those are not dates." Sharda Devi said, "For a house, those are dates enough."

The next day Bhola began scraping the lime again. Nikhil wanted to photograph all three water lines. Sharda Devi neither stopped him nor showed any enthusiasm.

"Keep them if you like," she said. "But let the wall remain a wall." "The marks will be plastered over?" "They will." "Won't that trouble you?" Sharda Devi looked toward the western sky. The clouds had grown dense now. "Marks are not preserved merely to be looked at. If a mark teaches you something, its work is done."

Three days later, fresh limewash covered the western wall. The brown line, the grey line, the faint stain below them—all disappeared. In the north-west corner, the foundation of the new room began to rise. Its floor was kept three bricks above the old house. The first things carried inside were not photographs of ancestors, but a box of medicines, land papers, school certificates, two sacks of seed, a sealed box of matches, and a small brass bell that Sharda Devi kept to wake everyone on rainy nights.

Inside the doorway of that room, Nikhil made a small notch with the measuring cord. Beside it he wrote: upper water line of the old western wall. Three bricks of space were left above it. The first rain did not come that week. Twice the clouds gathered and then cleared. The new limewash dried.

In the evening, Sharda Devi sat on the veranda looking toward the western wall. The water lines had been covered. The old floor lay buried beneath the doorway, and in the north-west a new high room was rising. The family had understood: a flood leaves its mark on a wall, and afterward a family goes on changing the house.

The First Tractor

It was the first week after Ashadh had set in. Early in the morning, a long trail of dust rose along the eastern road of Simra village, and through that dust a red tractor came slowly towards the village. The company's name gleamed in white letters on its front, while behind it the new ploughshare caught the first light of the sun and flashed.

Naresh had been standing at the doorway for a long time. Since the night before he had come out three times to look down the road. The tractor had been bought with a bank loan, two years of savings, and a little money borrowed from his maternal uncle. Naresh's arithmetic was simple—plough his own twelve bighas, then take up hired ploughing in the village and neighbouring hamlets; save time, save labour, and pay the loan instalments on schedule.

Jagessar stood beside the doorway. In his hand was the old cord of the bullocks' bell. The previous evening he had untied Nandu and Karma from the cowshed and taken them to graze by the pond. Jagessar had been ploughing for this household since Naresh's father's time. In twenty-five years he had come to know the field ridges, the colour of the soil, the movement of water, and the temper of the bullocks as well as he knew the joints of his own body.

When the tractor entered the courtyard, the children came running. Some touched the bonnet; others tried to measure the huge rear wheels. Laughing, Naresh kept shooing them away.

"It's hot. Don't touch it."

Jagessar quietly folded the bell cord and put it into his pocket.

Naresh looked at him. "Kaka, now see for yourself—a day's ploughing in two hours."

Jagessar looked at the tractor's ploughshare. "Will the soil agree in two hours?"

"If the soil doesn't agree, the machine will make it agree." Naresh laughed.

Jagessar too gave a faint smile, but said nothing.

The first day was reserved for ploughing their own land. Naresh had called a driver from town—Ramakant. He had learned to operate the

machine at the company's depot. At seven in the morning the tractor entered the large western field.

Jagessar remained seated on the ridge. Nandu and Karma were tied in the cowshed. Earlier, by the time the bullocks completed one round of this field, they would be wet with sweat and Jagessar would have shifted his grip on the plough-handle twice. Now the tractor went growling round, turning in a single pass as broad a strip of soil as the bullocks would have turned in four.

Villagers gathered on the ridge. There was curiosity in some eyes, calculation in others.

"How much diesel does it drink?"

"What does one bigha cost?"

"What use are bullocks now?"

At this last question Jagessar looked once towards Nandu and Karma's shed.

By noon the field had been ploughed. Victorious fatigue showed on Naresh's face. He came over to Jagessar.

"Kaka, keeping bullocks is a losing bargain now. I'm thinking of selling both."

Jagessar kept rubbing a pinch of ridge-soil between his fingers. "Your bullocks, your decision."

Naresh paused for a moment. "Don't worry about your work. Loading sacks, unloading fertiliser, keeping the tractor clean—there's plenty to do."

Jagessar dusted the soil from his hand. "There is plenty of work, but not all work is the same."

The remark made Naresh slightly uncomfortable. He had expected Jagessar to thank him, or at least to feel reassured. Instead, Jagessar rose and walked towards the house.

Within two weeks Nandu and Karma were sold. The cowshed stood empty. Naresh stored two drums of diesel, grease, and a box of tools there. The old yoke remained hanging on the wall.

Work for the tractor increased rapidly. People from Simra, Barail, and the southern hamlet began coming to Naresh's courtyard to book dates for ploughing. In a notebook Naresh wrote down the field, the estimated time, and the payment.

Jagessar watched all this in passing, but he no longer appeared at the doorway every morning without being called, as he once had. Sometimes he cut bamboo, sometimes scattered paddy seed for another farmer, sometimes worked his own half-bigha sharecropped plot.

One day Naresh said, "Kaka, tomorrow at four in the morning we'll go to the field by the small channel. If we leave before daylight, we can finish two fields before nine."

Jagessar asked, "Tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Tomorrow I have already promised Ramcharittar that I'll split bamboo for him."

Naresh was surprised. "Can't you leave it for one day?"

Jagessar looked straight at him. "Earlier your father would say, 'Come at dawn,' and I would go. The way my work was arranged then was different. Now, if you need me, ask me first. My day is mine too."

No answer came at once to Naresh's lips.

"I was only..."

"I understand," Jagessar said, "but calling me 'Kaka' instead of by the old name does not change the old arrangement by itself."

Jagessar left. Naresh stood there for a long time. For the first time he realised that the tractor was changing not only the pace of the fields; it was also changing the way people came and went through his courtyard.

The next morning Naresh reached the field by the small channel with Ramakant. The owner, Sahdev Mahato, was waiting on the ridge.

The field was long, but there was a slight rise in the middle and, along the southern edge, the trace of an old drainage course almost hidden under grass. Ramakant drove the tractor straight in.

The first two rounds went smoothly. On the third, the rear ploughshare cut too deep along the southern side. From a distance Sahdev shouted, "Slow there!"

Ramakant stopped the machine.

Sahdev came down from the ridge. "There used to be an old watercourse on this side. If you cut too deep, all the rainwater will enter here."

Naresh looked at the soil. It seemed to him an ordinary slope. "We'll rebuild the ridge."

Sahdev shook his head. "The ridge is above. The water turns underneath. If Jagessar had been here, he would have seen it."

Naresh did not like that. "A tractor ploughs; it doesn't listen to stories."

But after the first heavy rain, the southern portion of Sahdev's field remained under water for two days. The ridge was intact, but the mouth of the old drainage course had opened again. Sahdev said nothing; he simply did not book Naresh for the next ploughing.

Two days later the soil at Barail was wet. Jagessar happened to meet them on the road. Naresh was taking the tractor there.

Jagessar picked up a little soil, squeezed it in his fist, then opened his palm. The earth remained stuck together like smooth dough.

“Not today,” he said.

“The customer has booked the date.”

“Wait till tomorrow afternoon.”

“If we wait, the next three fields will all be pushed back.”

Jagessar put the clod from his fist down on the ridge. “Then go. The soil doesn’t read your booking dates.”

That old thorn of discomfort rose again inside Naresh. He drove the tractor on.

The ploughing was completed, but the soil did not break into a fine crumb behind the machine; it turned into large sticky clods. Three days later the sun came out hard and those clods baked as solid as bricks. The landowner had to hire labourers again to break them. He did not deduct money from Naresh’s payment, but the complaint travelled through the village.

That evening Naresh sat in the empty cowshed. A drum of diesel stood beside him. The old yoke hung on the wall. On its wood he could still see the polish left by years of Jagessar’s palms.

For the first time Naresh wondered—had Jagessar’s work been only to drive the bullocks, or had it also been to read the soil?

The next day he went to Jagessar’s house.

Jagessar was shaving thin strips from a split bamboo in the courtyard. He saw Naresh, but did not stop his hands.

“Kaka, I had two things to say.”

“Say them.”

“I made a mistake at the small channel. At Barail too.”

Jagessar put the shaved bamboo aside. “The machine didn’t make the mistake.”

“I did.”

“Yes.”

That ‘yes’ felt lighter to Naresh than he had expected. He had prepared arguments in his defence, but Jagessar did not enlarge the blame.

Naresh said, “If you agree, I want you to look at a field once before we take the tractor in. Where to turn, where to reduce the depth, whether the soil is ready—all that.”

Jagessar asked, “What is this work called?”

Naresh laughed. “I haven’t thought of a name yet.”

“Then don’t think of the name first. Think of the payment.”

Naresh fell silent.

Jagessar went on, “When I was a ploughman, there was the year’s paddy, clothes, sometimes cash, sometimes credit—everything mixed together. If the work is separate now, the payment should be clear too.”

Naresh sat down on the ground. The two talked for half an hour. The rate would not be according to the size of the field, but according to time and distance. If Jagessar merely examined the soil, one rate; if he stayed on the ridge through the entire ploughing and gave directions, another. If he found the soil unsuitable, he would say so plainly; the final decision would belong to the customer and Naresh.

At the end Jagessar said, “And one more thing. If we are to leave at four in the morning, ask me the evening before.”

Naresh smiled. “Is that the most important condition of all?”

“It is for me.”

At first the village laughed at this new kind of work.

“Payment even for looking at a field?”

“Has Jagessar become a doctor now?”

“New diseases of the soil every day?”

Jagessar laughed the jokes away. When he reached a field, he first walked around it. Here he pressed the earth with his heel, there he cleared grass from an old ridge, elsewhere he asked the farmer—which way had the water stood after the last rain? Where had the bullocks turned before? Where were the roots of old trees buried in the field?

Naresh, in turn, taught him about the machine. How wide a strip the ploughshare cut in one pass, where the tractor needed more room to turn, at what depth it consumed more diesel, in which soils the wheels slipped.

Earlier, when Jagessar inspected a field, he thought only of soil and water. Slowly he began to measure with his eyes the turning circle of the machine as well.

One day he himself stopped Naresh. “On this ridge the old way of turning would be fine, but your tractor’s rear plough is wide. Turn two cubits farther in and the ridge will be saved.”

Naresh changed direction without arguing.

Within a few months the laughter diminished. There was no miracle behind it. Simply, less diesel was wasted, fewer ridges were broken, and the machine was not forced into wet fields. Sometimes Jagessar’s judgement was wrong too. Once he thought a sandy field too wet and advised waiting half a day; by afternoon a wind rose and the soil was ready at once. Naresh joked, “The doctor’s medicine missed its mark.”

Jagessar replied, "Then stop calling me a doctor. The soil is older than I am."

Both laughed.

At the end of Sawan, the owner of a large field wanted urgent ploughing. It had rained at night, but the owner said, "If you don't plough today, I'll call another tractor." The payment was good. A loan instalment was near.

Naresh called Jagessar.

Jagessar walked around the field and returned. "Half of it can be ploughed today. Not the lower strip."

The owner flared up. "I'm paying for the whole field. Is the machine yours or this old man's?"

Jagessar said nothing. He looked at Naresh's face.

For a moment Naresh wanted to plough the whole field. The instalment date, the diesel debt, the fear of losing the customer—all rose together.

He climbed onto the tractor, started the machine, and entered the higher strip first. After one round he reached the edge of the lower ground and saw the slick mud flung from the wheels. It was sticking to the tyres in a thick layer.

Naresh stopped the machine.

"The upper half today. The lower half tomorrow."

The owner cursed, threatened to call another tractor, but Naresh did not take the machine down into the lower strip.

Jagessar offered no praise that day. In the evening he merely asked, "What time tomorrow morning?"

Naresh said, "What time are you free?"

A smile appeared in Jagessar's eyes. "Six."

"Then six."

By Kartik, dust and scratches had settled over the tractor's red paint. The first loan instalment had been paid. Nandu and Karma's empty shed had become a tool room, but Naresh had not taken the yoke down from the wall.

Jagessar's son Birju worked at a bicycle-repair shop. One day he came to watch the tractor's oil being changed. Ramakant taught him how to open the filter. Two weeks later Birju enrolled for a short diesel-engine training course at the district headquarters.

At first Jagessar said nothing. Naresh asked, "Don't you want Birju to learn machine work?"

Jagessar said, "Why wouldn't I? I only don't want him to go on being called somebody's 'own man' until he forgets the value of his own day."

This time Naresh did not answer at once. He understood what Jagessar meant.

The following year, in Phagun, an outside trader came to the village to buy seed. Seeing Naresh's tractor, he asked, "Is yours the first tractor in this village?"

"Yes."

At that moment Jagessar was examining the soil in a nearby field. Pointing towards him, the trader asked, "Is he your ploughman?"

The old answer almost came out of Naresh's mouth. He stopped himself.

"He used to plough for our household," he said. "Now I learn the movement of the fields from him, and he asks me about the movement of the machine. We agree on the work before we do it."

The trader probably understood half of this and not the other half. He turned back towards the sacks of seed.

Jagessar had heard from a distance. He came over to Naresh.

"You said something very grand," he said with a smile.

Naresh laughed too. "Was it wrong?"

"Not wrong. But no single person understands the movement of a field. The rains change, the canal changes, people change."

"The tractor too?"

"That has been changing since its first year—look, half its paint is gone."

They both looked at the tractor. Dust lay on the bonnet, there was a small dent on one side, and a dried crust of soil clung to the rear ploughshare. The machine was no longer a new object; its growl had blended into the village's everyday sounds.

That evening Naresh took the tractor to plough the western field. Jagessar walked along the ridge. Here he raised a hand to signal that the depth should be reduced; elsewhere he remained silent.

Earlier Jagessar had walked behind the bullocks with his hand on the plough-handle. Now Naresh was on the machine, but Jagessar did not walk behind him. He followed his own path parallel to the ridge—sometimes ahead, sometimes a little behind.

Between the two of them lay a broad strip of newly turned soil. Across that strip, neither the old line of ownership remained clearly visible nor was any new declaration of equality written. Only the way of working was changing, and with it the measure of the distance between the two men.

The Boundary Stake

It was the last week of Phagun. In the western hamlet of Hariharpur, the wheat ears were filling with milk, bees circled the mango blossom, and the old bamboo fence between two adjoining houses was being cut down and stacked to one side.

Nayan Jha had decided to raise a brick wall along the western edge of his courtyard. His reasons were simple: goats kept getting into the vegetable beds, children at play wandered into the neighbouring courtyard, and the bamboo fence had to be replaced every year or two.

His neighbour, Rameshwar Mandal, had not objected at first. "Build your wall, but let the old boundary remain where it is," was all he had said.

The trouble began when Budhan, the mason, stretched his measuring cord one morning.

Near the entrance stood an old brick pillar. At the rear, by the orchard, a thick sal-wood stake had been driven into the ground, and the bamboo of the old fence had been tied to it. Budhan stretched the cord from the pillar to the stake and marked on the earth the line along which the bricks were to be laid.

Rameshwar came down from the veranda. The moment he saw the line on the ground, he said, "You've come an inch onto my side."

Budhan looked up. "How much?"

"One inch."

Nayan laughed. "You measured an inch with your eyes?"

Rameshwar went inside, brought out an old measuring tape, and measured from the eastern edge of the stake to the marked line. "See for yourself."

Budhan placed his own tape against it. The difference really was close to an inch.

Nayan stopped laughing. "The cord runs through the middle of the stake."

Rameshwar said, "The boundary does not run through the middle of the stake. It is along the edge on your side. The stake was driven into my land."

"Who told you that?"

“My father did.”

“My father said the stake stood on the boundary.”

Budhan let the cord slacken. “Then first decide whether the boundary is the edge of the stake or its middle.”

Within half an hour, the matter of one inch had spread through both houses and beyond. Rameshwar’s son Manoj laughed and said, “All this quarrelling over a strip of land narrower than a finger?”

Rameshwar glared at him. “Land is not small or large. A line is a line.”

The words stung Nayan. It seemed to him that Rameshwar was questioning not merely an inch of land but his father’s word.

The two households had been neighbours for fifty years. The fence between them had at different times been made of bamboo, thorn branches, or jute stalks, built and rebuilt again and again. But the thick stake at the back had stood there for so long that the younger generation had come to think of it as a natural part of the ground itself.

Nayan went over to the stake. It was nearly two inches thick. Up to four cubits above the earth, the wood had been worn smooth. Here and there were thin knife-cuts, letters, and numbers.

Nayan had never paid attention to those marks before.

“What are these?” Manoj asked.

Rameshwar bent to look. Beside one line something like ‘N 8’ had been carved. Beside another, ‘R 9’. Higher up was an ‘S’ and an incomplete year.

Nayan’s expression changed. “Could this ‘N’ be for my name?”

Rameshwar looked once at him and once at the stake. “And the ‘R’?”

Manoj burst out laughing. “Yours?”

Rameshwar did not laugh. His eyes had begun searching for something very old.

Someone in the gathering said, “Ask Aunt Jagatarini.”

Jagatarini was Rameshwar’s father’s cousin. She was past eighty-five and walked slowly, but she remembered the old houses and courtyards with remarkable clarity.

They brought her to the stake. First she ran her hand over the wood; then she touched the knife-marks.

“Before you look for the boundary, look at the children’s measurements,” she said.

Nayan stared. “The children’s measurements?”

“Yes. This ‘N’ is Nayan. Eight years old.”

A smile slowly spread across Rameshwar’s face.

Jagatarini touched the other line. "This 'R' is Rameshwar. Nine years old. He was a finger's breadth taller than Nayan then. Very proud of it too."

Laughter rose from the crowd. This time Rameshwar laughed as well, though he quickly composed his face.

Jagatarini began to explain. On the first Sunday of Chait, the children of both households used to stand with their backs against this stake. A straight piece of bamboo would be placed on each child's head and a thin mark cut with a knife. The first letter of the name and the age would be written beside it.

"Why?" Manoj asked.

"So we could see how much the child had grown."

"Why not mark it on the wall of the house?"

Jagatarini laughed. "Were the children of both houses jointly owned? Who would write the measurements of one household on the wall of the other?"

Manoj was left searching for an answer.

Nayan looked again at the lines on the stake. The 'S' was perhaps his sister Saroj's. A thin mark lay above it. On the other side was an 'M'—Rameshwar's sister Manju. The children of both households had climbed upward on the same piece of wood, line after line.

"But the boundary?" Rameshwar asked again. His voice was softer now, but the question remained.

Jagatarini said, "The boundary used to be taken through the middle of this timber."

Rameshwar immediately asked, "Why?"

"Because the fence was tied through the middle."

Nayan looked at Rameshwar. "Then Budhan's cord is right."

Jagatarini raised a hand to stop him. "I only said the fence used to be tied through the middle. Don't ask me exactly where the legal line of the land ran."

The look of victory on Nayan's face stopped halfway.

Budhan the mason, who was gathering his tools a little distance away, said, "An old bamboo fence has thickness. If one person takes the eastern edge as his and another the western edge, an inch or two of difference appears by itself."

Rameshwar looked at him. "You are a mason, not a surveyor."

Budhan answered calmly, "True. That is why I have stopped the wall."

No foundation was dug that day. The pile of bricks lay in the sun. The children played on the sand until evening.

That night Nayan kept remembering old things. A blurred memory returned: standing with his back to the stake beside Rameshwar in childhood; Rameshwar lifting his heels to appear taller; Nayan's father, Shivnarayan, laughing and saying, "A year doesn't grow just because you lift your heels."

In the morning Nayan went to Rameshwar.

"Do you remember?"

Rameshwar was silent for a moment. "The business with the heels?"

Nayan laughed. "Yes."

For a moment the tension left Rameshwar's face. "You started crying. You said Rameshwar had cheated his way into being taller."

They both laughed. Then, at the same moment, they looked towards the stake, and the laughter turned awkward again. The question of the land was still there.

Rameshwar said, "Memory has its place. Once the wall is built, I don't want another quarrel."

Nayan agreed. "Nor do I."

Both households began searching their old papers. They found field-area records, house-tax receipts, and partition slips, but nowhere was the thickness of the bamboo fence between them recorded. The old map was not precise enough to answer a question of one inch.

During that search, a thin, blackened piece of wood emerged from Rameshwar's granary. Sita Devi, Rameshwar's wife, first took it for an old shelf-board from the hearth. The moment Jagatarini saw it, she said, "This is part of the first measuring stake."

It too bore cut-marks. The letters had faded, but some could still be read—'Shi', 'Shya', 'J', 'P'.

Nayan's heart gave a start. 'Shi' was Shivnarayan—his father. 'Shya' was Shyamsundar—Rameshwar's father.

"Their measurements too?" Manoj asked in astonishment.

Jagatarini said, "Yes. In those days the stake stood in the middle of the bamboo fence. Your grandfathers marked their children's heights on it as well."

Manoj held the piece of wood in his hand and stared at it for a long time.

Rameshwar asked softly, "Then when was this newer stake put in?"

Jagatarini said, "When the old wood rotted at the bottom. Ramanand the carpenter made this one."

Ramanand Paswan was now close to eighty. The moment he heard, he came leaning on his stick. He smiled when he saw the stake, then

touched the grain of the wood and said, "I chose the sal timber myself. Shyamsundar and Shivnarayan were both there."

Nayan asked, "Exactly where the old stake had stood?"

Ramanand frowned and thought. "In the same place. But if you are going to ask me about one inch, I cannot say."

Rameshwar immediately said, "That is exactly what I am asking."

Ramanand laughed. "Then shall I pull a one-inch answer from my eighty-year-old head about something thirty-five years ago?"

The crowd laughed again. This time Rameshwar did not take offence.

Ramanand walked around to the back of the stake and looked at it. "One thing I do remember. The new timber was thicker than the old one."

Budhan, who had happened to return to look at the work, immediately measured the stake. "A little over two inches."

"The old one?" Nayan asked.

Ramanand measured the wooden fragment. "About an inch and a half."

For a few moments everyone was silent.

Then Budhan drew two lines on the earth—one showing the narrower width of the old stake, the other the thicker new one. "If the centre line remained exactly the same, the edges of the new stake would fall differently on both sides. If you treat an edge as the boundary, a difference is bound to appear."

Manoj said at once, "So the land didn't move—the stake just got thicker?"

Rameshwar cut in, "Don't reach a conclusion so quickly."

But his voice no longer had the hardness of the first day.

Nayan kept looking at the two lines Budhan had drawn on the ground. It slowly became clear to him that the two families might be calling different things the 'old boundary'—one meant the middle of the fence, another the edge of the stake on its own side. For years, while a flexible bamboo barrier stood there, the difference had served no practical purpose. The solid brick wall was making the question rigid for the first time.

"Why wasn't a wall built earlier?" Manoj asked Jagatarini.

"There was no money," she said simply. "And less need. The children ran through both courtyards. When a goat had to be caught, no one asked whose house it was in."

Rameshwar said, "Times have changed."

"They have," Jagatarini agreed. "So the old way cannot continue exactly as it was. But drawing a new line without understanding the old way is not right either."

At that, Nayan fell silent.

The next day both families had the land measured again from two fixed old points at the outer corners. The surveyor said plainly that the available documents confirmed the total width of the two house plots, but no paper could say to whom the one inch inside the old bamboo fence belonged. That question would have to be settled by agreement between the two families.

Rameshwar was disappointed. "So after all this measuring, we still have to decide it ourselves?"

"Yes," the surveyor said. "The papers tell you the area of the land. They do not know which edge of the timber in an old shared fence belonged to whom."

That evening the members of both households sat by the stake. There was no crowd from the village council, only the families.

Nayan said, "I am the one building the wall. If I keep the whole wall on my own land, I will leave this one inch aside."

Rameshwar immediately said, "Then tomorrow someone will say the strip outside the wall is mine. That will start a new quarrel."

Nirmala, Nayan's wife, spoke for the first time. "Then build a shared wall."

Everyone looked at her.

"Take the centre line through the middle of the stake. Half the thickness of the wall on this side, half on that. Split the expense too. Write it down that the wall is shared and that no other claim over either plot changes because of it."

Before Rameshwar could answer, Sita Devi said, "Why did no one think of this earlier?"

Manoj laughed. "Because everyone was pulling that one inch towards his own side."

Rameshwar glared at him, but even he could not keep from laughing.

After thinking for a while, Nayan said, "All right. But what about the stake?"

Budhan said, "It will fall inside the foundation of the wall. It has to come out."

At that, Jagatarini started. "Don't throw the stake away."

Rameshwar said, "If the boundary stake is removed, where will we keep it?"

Jagatarini looked at the lines cut into the wood. "It is not only a boundary anymore."

They did not uproot the stake that night. The next morning the children from both houses gathered around it—Manoj's daughter Khushi, Nayan's grandson Anshu, and two younger children from the neighbourhood. Jagatarini showed them the old cut-marks.

"See this—your grandfather was this tall at nine."

Khushi looked at her father and laughed. "So small?"

Manoj said, "My father, not me."

"Then how tall were you?"

Manoj had no answer. His own height had never been marked on the newer stake. By the time he was a child, the Chait tradition had already died out.

That made Jagatarini a little sad. "You people bought plenty of measuring tapes, but stopped cutting the children's growth onto the stake."

Khushi immediately stood with her back against it. "Mark mine."

Rameshwar laughed. "Let the wall be built first."

Three days later the stake was carefully removed. Budhan stretched a line through the middle on the ground. This time the cord did not follow either edge of the timber but its centre point. Nayan and Rameshwar both held the cord with their own hands when the first brick was laid.

The wall was built chest-high, with an open bamboo lattice above it. The two families agreed that it should keep animals out and small children safe, but not shut one courtyard completely from the sight of the other.

The expense was recorded half and half. On a small sheet of paper, both men signed: shared wall, shared repairs. No sentence was written about whose one inch it had been, because by the end both had understood that the answer depended on which edge of the stake one chose.

The old sal-wood stake was not thrown away. Beside the small shared gate between the two houses that opened towards the pond, it was planted again—not on the boundary line but inside the gate, where the children of both households could reach it.

On the first Sunday of Chait, Khushi and Anshu stood beside it. Jagatarini sat watching from a chair.

First a thin piece of bamboo was placed on Khushi's head. Rameshwar took the knife, then paused and looked at Nayan.

"You make the mark."

Nayan smiled. "The first mark is for your granddaughter."

Rameshwar said, "The stake belongs to both of us."

At last Jagatarini said, "Make the cut together, or you'll quarrel over another inch."

Everyone burst out laughing.

Nayan gripped the handle of the knife, Rameshwar placed his hand over Nayan's, and a thin new line was cut into the wood. Beside it they wrote 'Kh 7'. Then they measured Anshu.

By evening the shadow of the new wall fell half into each courtyard. Air moved through the bamboo lattice. The old fence was gone, and the old arrangement was gone with it. But beside the shared gate stood the stake on which the heights of the children of both families continued to climb up the same piece of wood.

Once the wall was built, the question of the one inch of land was, in practical terms, over. But the story it had opened was not really about land. It was about the way generations often give different names to the same thing. One generation calls it a boundary, another a fence-post, another the measure of its childhood.

And the wood, taking no one's side, keeps every mark on the same body.

The Empty Cattle Shed

There was a time when mornings in the village of Belahi opened to the sound of bells in Baisakh. Somewhere a cow would be untethered, elsewhere a calf would tug at its rope, and somewhere a brass bell would tinkle as a bullock moved its neck. The smell of dung and water, the scrape of fodder being chopped, and the herdsmen's calls mingled in the lanes.

Now the sounds of morning had changed. Motors ran in a few houses, water tanks filled on rooftops, bicycles sped towards the main road carrying packets of milk. There were still animals, but not in even half as many homes as before.

In the eastern quarter of the village, Shivnath Jha's old cattle shed stood out amid this change: long mud walls, a sloping tiled roof, three posts driven into the floor, and a stone trough in one corner.

The cattle shed was empty.

Even so, Shivnath Jha swept it every morning.

First he swept the courtyard and poured water over the tulsi plant. Then he took an old bamboo broom into the cattle shed. Dry leaves, dust, bits of straw fallen from the roof, sometimes bird droppings—he gathered everything into one heap and left it outside near the compost pit.

One day his grandson Nachiketa asked, “Baba, what is there here now?”

Shivnath kept sweeping. “Dust.”

“Then leave the dust. It will come back again.”

Shivnath did not stop sweeping. “You bathe, don't you? Your body gets dirty again too.”

Nachiketa burst out laughing. “Are a body and a cattle shed the same thing?”

“No. But sometimes the answer to a task is the same.”

Nachiketa found the answer incomplete. He ran off.

Shivnath was seventy-eight. His back had bent a little, but when he swept there was still a rhythm in his hands: first the right-hand corner, then behind the trough, then circles around all three posts, and finally a long stroke towards the doorway.

No one had taught him that rhythm. Fifty-five years of practice had shaped it on its own.

At one time the shed had held as many as nine animals: two bullocks, three cows, two heifers, one calf, and for a whole year an old cow belonging to a neighbour who had gone away to earn.

In those days Shivnath did not clean the cattle shed alone in the mornings. His wife Devaki sprinkled water, his elder son shook out the straw, and his little daughter kept refilling the lota beside the trough.

It had been twelve years since Devaki died. Their daughter lived in Nepal with her family. The elder son, Pramod, was still in the village, but he no longer kept cattle.

First the tractor came. Then the number of bullocks declined. Later the milk-collection vehicle arrived, but fodder became expensive. Some families kept two better-breed cows and sold more milk; others gave up animal rearing altogether. In homes where young men had gone away to earn, space for a motorcycle became more necessary than space for cattle.

The change had not come in a single day. Shivnath had heard it in the diminishing sound of bells.

Earlier, forty-seven or fifty animals would return together every evening from the southern hamlet. Then the number fell to thirty, then twenty. Now sometimes five returned, sometimes seven. Even the animals that remained came back at different times.

"The village has emptied out," Shivnath's contemporary and friend Ramlochan said one day.

Shivnath smiled. "There are more people in the village than ever."

"More people, fewer animals."

"Then the village is not empty. It has changed."

Ramlochan looked towards his cattle shed. "This is empty, though."

Shivnath did not answer.

The last cow in the shed—Surti—had been sold four years earlier. She had grown old and gave very little milk. Pramod had calculated that fodder, medicine, and care cost more than the milk was worth.

Shivnath had not objected.

On the day Surti left, he had stroked her forehead, placed the rope in the new owner's hand, returned home, and cleaned the cattle shed.

He did the same the next day.

And the day after that.

Three months later Pramod asked, "Babuji, shall we store the sacks of paddy in the cattle shed?"

"Do."

"They will cover half the space."

“I won’t sweep where the sacks are kept.”

Pramod thought Babuji had finally accepted that the cattle shed was now a storeroom. But once the sacks were removed, Shivnath began sweeping the entire floor again.

A year later Pramod’s wife Sudha suggested replacing the old roof tiles. “How much should we spend on the roof of an empty building?”

Shivnath said, “Replace two rows where it leaks. Not the whole roof.”

“What purpose does that serve?”

“Only that water should not come inside.”

Sudha laughed. “The trouble with your cattle shed is that it needs no cattle, yet it still needs a roof.”

Shivnath laughed too. “Does every room meant for people always have people living in it?”

Small exchanges of this sort arose in the house from time to time and then ended. Shivnath quarrelled with no one. Nor did he tell sorrowful stories about the emptiness of the cattle shed.

That was why people found his daily cleaning all the stranger.

One Jeth afternoon, three village boys sat down in the cattle shed to play carrom. The shade was good there, and the floor was level and clean. Shivnath saw them but said nothing. In the evening, after the boys gathered up the coins and left, he swept away the spilled powder and scraps of paper.

They came again the next day.

On the third day Nachiketa asked, “Baba, they make a mess. Why don’t you stop them?”

“They make a mess; I’ll clean it.”

“So has the cattle shed become a games room?”

Shivnath said, “When people sit in a place, that place acquires a purpose.”

When the rains began, the boys stopped playing there. The cattle shed fell quiet again.

One evening in the middle of Sawan, the eastern sky turned black. A fierce wind rose. A newly built tin roof beside the main road blew away, and rain began slanting down.

At that very time Parvati Devi of the Chamar hamlet was returning home with her only cow. Part of her small cowshed had collapsed in the morning storm. There was no safe place to tie the cow indoors.

She stopped at Shivnath’s doorway.

“Kaka, just for one night...”

Before she could finish, Shivnath opened the cattle-shed door. “Bring her inside.”

Parvati stood there hesitantly. "The trough..."

"I'll fill the trough with water."

"I'll clean it in the morning."

Shivnath said, "In the morning, you look after your own house. I am here."

As soon as the cow entered the shed, she paused for a moment. Perhaps the smell was unfamiliar. Then she moved towards the trough, pressed her nose to the old stone and sniffed it, and was tied to a post.

Nachiketa stood watching from the doorway.

"Baba, there's a cow here again!"

Shivnath did not laugh at his excitement. "For one night."

It rained all night. Drops fell through the roof in two places, but the cow stayed dry.

At dawn Shivnath arrived with the broom and found fresh dung on the floor. After four years.

For a few moments he stood looking at it.

Nachiketa thought Baba would grow emotional. But Shivnath only picked up the shovel and said, "Take this to the compost pit. I'll do the sweeping."

Two days later Parvati's cowshed was repaired with bamboo and tin. The cow went back.

The cattle shed was empty again.

But after that incident, Nachiketa no longer saw only habit in Shivnath's broom.

For a school assignment, he was conducting a small survey on changing livelihoods in the village. His teacher had said, "Ask the older people in each household which kinds of work have declined over the past twenty years and which have increased."

Nachiketa went first to Shivnath.

"Baba, how many animals were there in the village earlier?"

"I don't remember the count."

"An estimate?"

"Writing down an estimate does not turn it into a fact."

Nachiketa made a face. "Then what will I give my teacher?"

Shivnath thought for a moment. "Ramsevak, the livestock worker, used to keep the old vaccination registers. He is retired now. Go ask him."

From Ramsevak's house, Nachiketa did not get photocopies of the three old registers, but he did get figures copied out by hand. Fifteen years earlier, Belahi had recorded one hundred and forty-two cattle and more

than sixty bullocks and calves. In the previous year's panchayat livestock-camp list, the total was forty-nine animals.

Nachiketa was startled by the numbers.

He told Shivnath.

Shivnath only said, "The sound of the bells was not lying."

Because of the survey, Nachiketa went from house to house. He realized there was no single reason for the decline in livestock. Some families had less land; some had settled elsewhere; for some, buying fodder had become too expensive; others were dissatisfied with the price of milk. In a few homes, on the contrary, one cow had become three because a milk-collection centre had opened nearby.

The village's change was not a straight line.

He wrote a separate page about the cattle shed: "New Uses of Old Animal Spaces."

Shivnath read it and said, "Don't make my cattle shed an example. A cow stayed here for one day, children played here for three days. That does not make a rule."

"But because you keep it clean, it can be used."

Shivnath looked at him. "That you may write."

In Kartik came a notice for the village livestock-health camp. This time the worker said vaccinations would not be given house to house; animals from each hamlet were to be brought to one clean, shaded place.

A question arose in the eastern hamlet: where?

The school was far away. The panchayat building had a paved courtyard but no shade. The temple side was crowded.

Someone mentioned Shivnath's cattle shed.

Pramod was taken aback at first. "That is private property."

Shivnath said, "Open it for one morning."

Sudha asked, "Eight or ten animals will come together. What if the walls get damaged?"

"Walls are damaged by water, not by animals. It was built for animals."

On the morning of the camp, the cattle shed was truly full for the first time in four years. Seven cows, two heifers, one old bullock, and Parvati's cow—eleven animals in all—were tied separately with ropes.

Their owners were there too: one from a landless family, one a teacher, one a grocer, one a cultivator. Earlier, keeping animals had been tied mainly to agricultural work; now the reasons varied—milk, household use, a small income, affection, sometimes tradition.

Shivnath sat by the doorway and watched.

Ramlochan came too. Laughing, he said, "See? The empty cattle shed has filled up."

Shivnath said, "For four hours."

"Even so."

"Empty and full—neither is permanent."

The vaccinations ended. The animals left one by one. Circular hoofprints, bits of chopped fodder, dung, and splashes of water remained on the floor.

The worker said, "Kaka, this was a very good place."

Shivnath replied, "The place was already here."

After everyone left, Nachiketa picked up the broom.

Shivnath said, "Leave it. It is heavy."

"I'll do it."

"For what purpose?" Shivnath asked deliberately.

Sweeping, Nachiketa said, "The dust will come back again."

A faint smile touched Shivnath's lips.

In December, Pramod considered laying bricks over the front half of the cattle shed. There was a plan to extend the rear room of the house. Before doing anything, he asked Babuji.

"What if we take half the space?"

Shivnath looked around the interior of the shed. Two of the three posts were useless now. One side of the trough was broken. The rear part of the roof sagged low.

He said, "Extend the house. But leave the front part open."

Pramod was surprised. He had expected Babuji to insist on keeping the entire cattle shed exactly as it was.

"How much?"

Shivnath drew a line on the ground with his stick. "This much. Enough for two animals to stand, ten people to sit, and goods to remain dry in the rains."

Pramod asked, "Then will it remain a cattle shed or become a veranda?"

Shivnath said, "Why quarrel over the name? The name will change according to the work it does."

The construction was carried out. The rear half of the old cattle shed was absorbed into a room of the house. One post was removed. The stone trough was shifted into the front section. The roof was made from a mixture of new tin and old tiles.

On the first day, Shivnath swept the new floor.

A few weeks later he fell ill. It was only an ordinary fever, but for two mornings he could not get up.

On the third day he came outside leaning on his stick. He looked towards the cattle shed. The floor was clean.

Nachiketa had swept it before leaving for school.

“Why?” Shivnath asked.

Putting on his shoes, Nachiketa said, “A lot of leaves fell yesterday.”

“Is anyone coming?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Nachiketa was silent for a moment. Then he completed the answer that, months earlier, had seemed incomplete to him.

“If an empty place stays clean, it can find a purpose again.”

Shivnath said nothing.

Morning sunlight was sliding in from the edge of the new roof. The stone trough lay half in light, half in shade. From some distant house a cow lowed. From the other hamlet to the north came no answering animal call; only a child’s voice, then the bell of a bicycle.

The village was no longer as it had once been. Neither was the cattle shed.

But the thin lines left by the broom were still visible across the floor—lines made not to preserve something unchanged, but to keep a place from closing itself off.

The Last Harvest

On a Kartik dawn, the sky to the east of Belahi had not yet turned blue. A thin veil of mist lay over the paddy fields, and dew clung to the tips of the leaves, ready to flash at the first touch of light.

Harinarayan Jha stood on the field ridge, leaning on his stick.

Before him lay two bighas of land. The paddy had ripened to gold. In places the ears bent under their own weight; elsewhere, because of the lingering water from the last rains, the stalks had remained short.

Beyond the ridge ran the new paved road. Stacks of bricks and sacks of sand lay along its edge.

The registration of this field was due three days later.

The buyer, Vinesh Sahu, had already said, "The crop is yours. Harvest it and hand over the field empty."

Harinarayan had replied, "All right."

The matter had seemed that simple.

But the previous week, when Vinesh mentioned calling the harvesting-machine operator, Harinarayan's daughter Rama suddenly said, "No machine. This time we will harvest it ourselves."

Harinarayan kept looking at her.

"We?"

"Yes. Once."

Rama's two brothers—Jagdish and Mithilesh—were sitting on the veranda at the time. Both laughed at first. Then neither objected.

Today was the day of that decision.

Mithilesh arrived first. He lived in the village itself, though farming was no longer his main work. He ran a small seed-and-fertiliser shop in the market. Most of the ploughing, transplanting, and threshing on his fields he now had done by hired labourers and machines.

He carried five sickles tucked under his arm.

"I had them sharpened," he said.

Harinarayan took one in his hand and touched the edge with the tip of his thumb.

"Very sharp."

"That is good."

“For a hand that is not used to it, too sharp can cause mistakes as well.”

Mithilesh laughed. “Then shall I keep the blunt one for Bhaiya?”

Just then a car stopped on the road.

Jagdish got out with his wife Neelam and their son Aarav. He did accounts work in Darbhanga and came to the village two or three times a year.

He had new shoes on his feet and cloth gloves on his hands.

Seeing the gloves, Mithilesh asked, “What are those?”

Jagdish said casually, “They will protect my hands.”

Harinarayan said nothing.

Rama arrived a little later with her daughter Sakshi. Her marital home was five kos away, but she now rarely took part in farm work.

Sakshi wanted to take a photograph of the field.

Rama said, “Work first.”

Kaushalya Devi came slowly from the house carrying a bamboo basket and an old gamchha. Her waist had bent with age, but her gait was still measured.

She looked at everyone once.

“Two big has with this many people?”

Jagdish said, “We have the whole day.”

Kaushalya replied, “Having the whole day does not make the hands faster.”

Harinarayan sat down on the ridge.

Mithilesh gathered the first handful of paddy and showed them where on the stalk it should be cut.

“If you cut too low, soil will come with it. If you cut too high, you lose straw.”

Aarav asked, “What is the straw used for?”

Kaushalya looked at him.

“That question tells me you have not watched a harvest for a very long time.”

Aarav laughed.

The number of cattle in the village had fallen, but straw was still sold. Some households stored it under their sheds, some traders carried it away, and some people chopped it in the field and mixed it into the soil.

Mithilesh took the first row.

Rama stood beside him.

Jagdish wanted to begin from the other side.

Harinarayan immediately said, "Not from two ends. One direction only."

"Why?" Jagdish asked.

"Where will you put the bundles? Where will the footpath remain? Will you walk again over what has already been cut?"

Without replying, Jagdish came over beside Rama.

The harvesting began.

Within the first five minutes everyone understood that memory and bodily practice were not the same thing.

Rama's grip returned quickly. With her left hand she gathered the paddy, with her right she drew the sickle, and she laid each cut handful behind her.

Mithilesh worked at a steady pace.

In the very first row Jagdish caught the sickle twice. Once a thick clump of weed roots snagged along with the stalks.

Neelam cut slowly, but the bundles she made were even.

At first Sakshi and Aarav were not allowed to cut. The two began gathering the harvested paddy into small heaps.

The sun climbed. The dew began to dry.

In a distant field, the growl of a machine began.

A red harvesting machine moved slowly through the yellow paddy. Behind it appeared even rows of short stubble.

Aarav kept watching it.

"How long would that machine take to cut this field?"

Mithilesh said, "Not even an hour."

"Then why are we—"

Before he could finish the sentence, Rama said, "Because today we did not call the machine."

Aarav went back to work.

Sitting on the ridge, Harinarayan watched the row they were cutting.

After a while he called to Jagdish.

"You are leaving the stalks too high."

Jagdish straightened up.

"My knees hurt."

"Then sit down. This is not work to be hurried."

"Babuji, do you still think I am twelve years old?"

Harinarayan laughed.

"When you were twelve, you did not leave stalks this high."

Rama burst out laughing.

Jagdish smiled too.

At twelve, Jagdish was always finding excuses to escape the harvest. Sometimes his stomach hurt; sometimes he had a school notebook to finish.

Rama was two years older than her brother then. She took her place in the row beside their mother.

"I remember," Rama said. "Once, over in that corner by the pond, you left your sickle in the field and ran away."

Jagdish said, "That is a lie."

Without lifting her head, Kaushalya said, "It is true."

Everyone laughed.

Kaushalya herself was not cutting. She was tying the harvested paddy into bundles.

Her fingers were still quick. She pulled out two small handfuls of straw, twisted them, folded them in the middle into a rope, and tightened them around the belly of a bundle.

Neelam kept watching her hands.

"Ma, teach me this knot."

Kaushalya said, "It is not a knot. It is straw holding straw."

Neelam tried. Her first binding came loose.

Kaushalya showed her again.

"Not too tight. Bend it at the right place."

By ten o'clock the first row had broken into different rhythms.

Mithilesh was ahead. Rama followed him. Neelam was steady. Jagdish straightened his back again and again.

Sakshi passed around water. Aarav gathered the heaps.

Harinarayan's stick lay on the ridge.

Suddenly he stood up and asked Mithilesh for the sickle.

Mithilesh tried to stop him.

"You sit."

"I will cut two handfuls."

"Your knees—"

"My knees are mine."

From a distance Kaushalya said, "Give it to him."

Harinarayan stepped into the field.

As he grasped the first handful, his hand trembled for a moment. Then the sickle entered the stalks.

The sound was very small—the dry whisper of many stems breaking together.

He cut three handfuls. At the fourth he stopped.

"That is enough," he said.

He handed the sickle back to Mithilesh.

Jagdish asked, "Only that much?"

Harinarayan said, "I was not trying to prove I could work."

He sat down on the ridge again.

Before noon, Phulkumari Devi came by on her way to her own field. For years she had worked with the village transplanting and harvesting crews.

Seeing the scene from afar, she laughed.

"So the old days have returned to the Jha household today?"

Kaushalya said, "If the old days had really returned, you too would be standing in the row."

Phulkumari stopped.

"If you call me, I can still stand there."

Laughing, Rama said, "Today the family itself will do the harvesting."

Phulkumari's smile faded a little.

She looked at the cut field.

"The family itself?"

Kaushalya understood the look in her eyes.

"They think that in the old days the family did all the work by itself."

Phulkumari said, "Include my mother, your aunt, Somni from the Musahari, Budhni from the western hamlet—then call it the family."

Rama laughed.

Jagdish's hand stopped.

Harinarayan said quietly, "That is true."

The harvests of the past had never been only the labour of one household. Days of exchanged work, lines of wage labourers, neighbours' hands, bullock carts, threshing crews—all of them together brought the crop home.

In memory, saying "we harvested it ourselves" was simple; an actual field had never been that simple.

Phulkumari did not pick up a sickle.

She merely looked at one handful Jagdish had cut.

"When you grip the stalks, do not keep your thumb inside. The blade will catch it."

Jagdish changed his grip at once.

"And this bundle?" Neelam asked.

Phulkumari examined the binding she had made.

"It is fine. Just do not press wet ears into the middle."

She went on her way.

Watching her go, Rama said, "Then what we are doing today may never have happened like this before."

Kaushalya said, "That is possible."

They ate their midday meal on the ridge.

Flattened rice, curd, potato curry, pickle, and jaggery.

Everyone left the row and sat in the shade.

The distant field worked by machine had already been cleared completely. Its owner stood beside the road talking to someone on his phone.

Aarav looked at his palm.

Even through the gloves, one patch had been rubbed red.

"Will it hurt tomorrow?"

Mithilesh said, "It will."

"The day after?"

"Less."

"Three days later?"

Harinarayan said, "The hand will forget."

Kaushalya immediately said, "Not the hand. The pain."

For a moment everyone fell silent.

After the meal Jagdish asked, "How much is left?"

Mithilesh swept his eyes across the field, measuring it.

"A little more than half."

Jagdish looked at his watch.

"Shall I tell Vinesh to send the machine? It will be difficult to finish by evening."

Rama looked at him but said nothing.

Gathering up the bamboo basket, Kaushalya said, "If you are tired, stop. Calling it the last time does not make the work easier."

Jagdish fell silent.

Harinarayan said nothing either.

After a while Jagdish stood up of his own accord and picked up the sickle.

"Come on."

This time he did not hurry.

In the afternoon sun the colour of the field changed. The golden ears lost their pale gleam and deepened to yellow. A small lizard darted along

the ridge. Two field mice shot out ahead of the advancing row and disappeared in the distance.

Sakshi took out her phone once, then put it back in her bag.

She began lifting the bundles with Neelam.

Rama asked, "No photograph?"

Sakshi said, "Later."

"Why?"

"My hands are not free."

Rama said nothing.

At three o'clock Vinesh Sahu arrived on a motorcycle.

He stopped at the edge of the field and looked at the scene.

"Still half left?"

Mithilesh said, "Not half. A quarter."

Vinesh said, "Shall I send two men? The work at my place is finished."

Harinarayan replied politely, "No. They will finish it today."

Vinesh looked at the family.

"All right. I am not in a hurry. The registration date remains the same."

He spoke about the papers, asked about the road measurement, and then left.

Jagdish watched his motorcycle recede.

"What will he build here?"

Mithilesh said, "At first he was talking about a warehouse. Now I hear three shops in front and storage behind."

Rama looked across the field.

"No paddy again?"

"Does not look like it."

Kaushalya said, "The one who bought it will decide."

There was no complaint in her voice.

That made the words feel heavier to Rama.

She began cutting again.

Evening drew nearer.

After so much fatigue, everyone's pace strangely began to resemble everyone else's. No one had strength left to hurry, so their separate rhythms dissolved into one slow tempo.

Mithilesh cut. Rama gathered the handfuls. Neelam tied the bundles. Jagdish cleared weeds from ahead. Sakshi and Aarav slid the bundles toward the ridge.

Now and then Kaushalya tightened a binding that had come loose.

Harinarayan was no longer on the ridge. He walked slowly behind the advancing row.

The final patch remained in the eastern corner.

The ground there was slightly lower. The paddy was short, but the ears were full.

Harinarayan stopped.

“Water used to stand here for a long time,” he said.

Jagdish asked, “But there is a drain now.”

“The drain came later.”

That was all.

No one asked for the old story.

For the final row, Rama tried to hand the sickle to Jagdish.

Jagdish said, “Let us all cut it together.”

Mithilesh laughed. “Five sickles for one handful?”

“Then leave five handfuls.”

He divided the remaining patch into five small parts.

Harinarayan was invited too.

He declined.

“I cut my share this morning.”

Kaushalya did not take a sickle either.

“My work was the tying.”

So Rama, Jagdish, Mithilesh, Neelam, and Sakshi each grasped a handful.

Standing beside them, Aarav counted, “One... two... three.”

The five sickles moved at different moments.

Some earlier, some later.

The last five handfuls did not fall together.

Everyone burst out laughing.

“This will not look right in a photograph,” Sakshi said.

Rama replied, “We did not cut it for a photograph.”

Aarav immediately asked, “Then why did we cut it?”

This time no one answered at once.

Climbing onto the ridge, Harinarayan said, “To finish the work.”

The bundles were gathered to one side.

Kaushalya inspected the last binding. One was loose. She opened it and tightened it again.

The sun was setting. Traffic noise on the road had grown louder. The distant machine had already fallen silent.

The field now looked empty, but not even like the neighbouring field harvested by machine.

In some places the stubble was low, in others high. Here and there two or three stalks had been missed. Elsewhere the soil had been pressed down by feet.

Jagdish tried to identify the row he had cut. "Where did I begin?" Mithilesh waved his hand. "Over there." Rama said, "No, you were here." Neelam laughed. "Now no one can tell whose row was whose."

Harinarayan let his gaze travel across the field. "Once the harvest is over, the field does not keep that account." Rama looked at him. Harinarayan said nothing more.

Before returning home, Sakshi made everyone stand on the ridge for a photograph.

Kaushalya said, "I will not stand holding a sickle." "Why?" "The work is over. Put the tools down."

The sickles were laid on the ridge. The photograph was taken.

The next day the bundles went for threshing. On the third day, the registration was completed.

The document contained the area, the boundaries, the price, and the signatures. There was no mention of the harvest.

Rama read the document, signed it, and handed the file back to Mithilesh.

That evening, when everyone began leaving the village, the car passed beside that field on the road.

Looking out of the window, Aarav asked, "Which part was the one I cut?"

Jagdish tried to see, but the car moved on. No mark was clear anymore. In the falling light, stubble short and tall shone in the same colour. Nowhere on the field was it written that this had been the last harvest.

The Village of Certificates

The first thing one noticed on entering the village of Sonbarsa was the walls.

On one veranda wall hung, framed behind glass, a “Clean Courtyard Award”; in another house’s sitting room, a certificate for “Advanced Seed Training”; at someone’s doorway, “Water-Conservation Participant”; and inside another home, “Women’s Group Excellence.”

The paper of some certificates had yellowed, but the frames still shone.

In some houses, certificates hung beside the household shrine. In others, family photographs were placed beneath them.

People in the village used to joke, “Sonbarsa has become the Village of Certificates.”

At first it had been a joke. Over the last two years, people had begun to say it almost as a matter of pride.

When a new guest came to a house, the wall was sometimes shown before tea was served.

“This one is my father’s.”

“This one belongs to the daughters’ group.”

“This is my grandson’s—from the sports meet.”

“Look at this—second place in the entire block.”

Sometimes the family had forgotten which competition that second place had come from, but they never allowed dust to settle on the frame.

At the centre of the village stood the primary school—three rooms, a veranda, an old neem tree, and an iron gate.

Above the gate, the school’s name was painted in blue letters. Beneath it hung five small plaques—“Full Enrolment,” “Clean Campus,” “Children’s Assembly Participation,” “Nutrition Awareness,” and “Green Week.”

There was no shortage of certificates inside the school either.

The only difference was that for three months there had been no teacher in the school.

After the previous teacher, Ramakant Mishra, had been transferred, no replacement had arrived. Twice they had been told that

“arrangements are being made,” but no one in the village understood where, on paper, those arrangements were actually taking place.

The school key remained with Saroja, who cooked the midday meal.

Every morning she opened the gate, swept the veranda, checked the kitchen, and when the children arrived, opened the classrooms for them.

Sometimes the children came carrying notebooks; sometimes they came with a ball.

The little children of Classes One and Two sometimes copied letters after the older ones. Sometimes they sat beneath the neem tree for a while and then went back home.

The villagers understood the inconvenience, but they placed it among the ordinary troubles of daily life—like a broken field embankment, seed that arrived late, or a hand-pump whose stream had grown weak.

“The teacher will come.”

That sentence had been in circulation for three months.

One day a notice arrived at the panchayat office saying that a team from the block would visit Sonbarsa the following week.

The reason was the unusually large number of training programmes, campaigns, and community-participation initiatives in the village.

The notice also said that the village would put up a “Community Achievement Exhibition.”

The panchayat secretary, Navalkishore Jha, read the notice twice.

Then his face brightened.

“All our certificates will be displayed.”

There was a stir among those present.

Ramdev Mahato immediately asked, “Where?”

“The panchayat building will be too small.”

Ratna Devi said, “Two rooms in the school remain empty.”

Someone said quite naturally, “They are empty anyway.”

It was a small sentence, but a silence spread across the veranda for a moment.

Navalkishore changed the subject. “The school is clean. The walls are empty too. It will be a good place for the exhibition.”

From the next day, certificates began to arrive.

Some people brought them still behind glass; others removed the frames and brought only the paper.

Some did not want to hand over the original.

“Take a copy.”

“A copy won’t have the same shine,” Navalkishore would say.

And then the original would arrive.

The first classroom began to fill with certificates from house after house.

Saroja first rolled up the mats that had been spread on the veranda for the children.

“Keep these to one side,” she said. “Where will the children sit?”

Ratna Devi replied, “For two or four days they can sit under the neem tree.”

Saroja said nothing.

Gauri, who studied in Class Six at the neighbouring middle school, came there with her younger brother Chandan.

Chandan was a Class Three student at this primary school.

Seeing the heap of certificates by the doorway, he asked, “Are all these books?”

Gauri laughed. “No, certificates of honour.”

Chandan tried to pick one up. Saroja stopped him. “Are your hands clean?”

Chandan looked at his palms.

Then he began sounding out the letters from a distance.

“Wa... ter...”

He stopped.

Gauri read it for him—“Water-Aware Family.”

Chandan asked, “What does water-aware mean?”

Gauri thought for a moment.

“People who save water.”

Chandan began reading the recipient’s name, but when he got stuck halfway, Gauri read that for him too.

By evening, fifty-eight certificates from the village had been deposited at the school.

The next day the number crossed one hundred.

Navalkishore was making a list of all the certificates.

“Subject, year, recipient, institution.”

He ruled four columns in the register.

Ratna Devi said, “Put the biggest honours in front.”

Showing his own paper, Ramdev Mahato asked, “How will you decide which is biggest?”

“District-level first.”

“Mine is state-level training.”

“Training is not an award.”

“Then why did they give me a certificate?”

Three people argued for half an hour over which word carried more weight—participation, training, selection, commendation, or award.

At last Navalkishore said, “Look at the size of the lettering. The bigger the title, the bigger the frame.”

Everyone laughed, but the arrangement was settled almost on that basis.

The school’s own certificates had already been hanging on the wall of the office room.

Ratna Devi wanted to add those to the exhibition as well.

Standing on a chair, Saroja began taking them down one by one.

The first was “Full Enrolment Achievement.”

The second—“Clean School Commendation.”

The third—“Children’s Reading Week Participation.”

The fourth—“School Garden Campaign.”

A thin layer of dust lay on the fifth. It read, “Commitment to Continuous Learning.”

Chandan stood below, watching.

He asked, “What does learning mean?”

This time Saroja remained silent.

Ratna Devi said, “Studying.”

Chandan immediately asked, “Then who got this?”

“The school.”

“The school studied?”

People in the room burst out laughing.

Ratna Devi laughed too, but Saroja did not.

She set the certificate down.

Three days later, the layout of the exhibition was drawn up.

First room—agriculture, water, cleanliness.

Second room—women’s groups, health, nutrition, handicrafts.

Veranda—school and youth achievements.

Children beneath the neem tree.

Navalkishore wrote, “Living proof: our children.”

Gauri read the slip and smiled.

“Where will the living proof sit?”

Navalkishore said, “Under the neem tree.”

“And the teacher?”

Navalkishore’s pen stopped.

“The teacher is a separate matter.”

“How separate?”

“The appointment is in the hands of the block office.”

Gauri said nothing more.

That evening she saw her father, Anand Yadav, taking certificates down from the wall at home.

There were three papers in Anand’s sitting room—Dairy Group Training, Organic Manure Participation, and Farmers’ Meeting Commendation.

He was choosing the one with the brightest frame.

Gauri asked, “Babu, there is no teacher in the school. Where is the certificate for that?”

Anand laughed. “A certificate for what?”

“For there being no teacher.”

“You don’t get a certificate for that.”

“Then how will people believe it?”

Anand stopped wiping the frame.

“Everyone knows.”

“The people from the block too?”

Anand gave no answer.

The next day Gauri went to the school office to look through the old files.

Saroja said, “Don’t touch the papers.”

“I’ll only look.”

The lower compartment of an iron cupboard stood open.

Inside were the attendance register, the midday-meal accounts, the inspection book, and copies of several letters.

Gauri saw one letter—an “Application for Replacement” sent after Ramakant Mishra’s transfer.

It was dated three months earlier.

After that came two reminders.

All of them bore receipt stamps.

“This is proof,” Gauri said.

Saroja took the file from her hands.

“This is not a certificate of honour.”

“But it is a certificate.”

“No. It is an office letter.”

Gauri seized upon the words.

“What is the difference between a certificate and proof?”

Saroja said, “A great deal.”

“How much?”

Saroja looked towards the window. Under the neem tree, Chandan was writing the letter ‘ka’ in the dust.

“One is hung on a wall,” she said quietly. “The other lies in a file until something gets done.”

Gauri carried that sentence home with her that day.

The day before the exhibition, the school was decorated.

Strips of coloured paper, an aripan on the floor, two bamboo arches, and rows of certificates on the walls.

Some of the frames knocked against one another.

Ramdev Mahato saw that his certificate had been hung low.

“Why is mine so far down?”

Ratna Devi said, “There is no room higher up.”

“My training certificate carries the minister’s signature.”

“People can raise their heads to see the signature.”

“Raise their heads, or strain their necks?”

Its position was changed again.

Meanwhile, the children sat beneath the neem tree.

Gauri said to Chandan, “Today write ‘ksha’.”

Chandan formed it incorrectly twice in the dust.

Raushan, sitting beside him, said, “I’ve forgotten ‘tra’ now.”

Gauri tried to teach them.

After a while it was time for her to leave for her own school.

As she rose, she said, “Again tomorrow.”

Chandan asked, “But tomorrow is the exhibition.”

“Then the day after.”

“Will the teacher come the day after tomorrow?”

Gauri wanted to answer, but she did not know.

On the morning of the exhibition, the villagers came to the school in clean clothes.

Three people came from the block—an assistant from the education office, a development worker, and a women’s-group coordinator.

Two local employees accompanied them.

In his welcome address Navalkishore said, “Sonbarsa’s special quality is that its achievements are visible not merely on paper, but in every home.”

The sentence sounded excellent.

Ratna Devi whispered, “Write that down. It will be useful next time.”

The team inspected the first room.

Agricultural training.

Water campaign.

Cleanliness.

Gardening.

One person asked about certificate dates. Another asked what work the recipient had done. Someone else took photographs.

Villagers stood beside their own papers.

Ramdev Mahato showed his signature to three different people.

The second room held the women's-group certificates.

Ratna Devi narrated the story behind each programme.

The visiting team seemed impressed.

Then everyone reached the veranda.

The school's five certificates hung there in a row.

The education-office assistant read the first one—"Full Enrolment."

He smiled.

"How many children?"

Navalkishore opened the register.

"Thirty-six."

"How many are present?"

Eyes turned towards the neem tree.

Twenty-three children were sitting there.

"Where is the teacher?"

It was a simple question.

Navalkishore replied, "The post is vacant at present."

"For how many days?"

Someone said three months. Someone else said four.

From inside, Saroja said, "Eighty-two days."

Everyone looked at her.

"Eighty-two?"

"I have been counting from the day after Ramakant Babu left."

The education assistant's expression did not change. He asked for the register.

Navalkishore went towards the school office.

Gauri, who had taken leave from her own school to see the exhibition, went and stood beside Saroja.

The education assistant examined the attendance register, copies of the letters, and the receipt stamps.

"Reminders were sent."

"Twice," Navalkishore said.

“Copies have been kept?”

“Yes.”

He closed the file.

Meanwhile the development worker continued looking at the school’s certificates.

“When was this ‘Commitment to Continuous Learning’ issued?”

Ratna Devi gave the year.

“There was a teacher then,” someone said from behind.

“And now?”

No one answered.

Chandan rose from beneath the neem tree and came towards the veranda.

He tried to read “Children’s Reading Week” on the wall.

“Chi... ld... rea...”

When he faltered, Gauri softly supplied, “Reading.”

The education assistant looked at Chandan.

“Which class?”

“Three.”

“Where is your book?”

Chandan pointed towards the neem tree. “In my bag.”

“No lessons today?”

Chandan answered simply, “Today we are looking at certificates.”

A few people on the veranda laughed.

It was a very small laugh.

No one could quite tell whom the laughter was aimed at.

The team moved on.

At the end of the programme, a small stage had been set up in front of the panchayat building.

Navalkishore gave a speech. Ratna Devi spoke about the achievements of the women’s groups. Anand Yadav said a few words about changes in agriculture.

Then the block team announced that Sonbarsa would receive a new commendation—“Special Recognition for Community Participation.”

There was applause.

A large frame was brought onto the stage.

Navalkishore stepped forward.

At that moment Gauri’s eyes went to the children beneath the neem tree.

Chandan was forming ‘ksha’ in Raushan’s notebook.

For the first time, he had made it correctly.

Gauri did not clap.

Saroja too remained silent.

Navalkishore accepted the frame. A photograph was taken.

After the programme ended, people began taking back their certificates.

The schoolrooms slowly emptied.

A nail had come loose from one frame. One paper had turned upside down. Someone put another person's certificate into his own bag, then saw the name and exchanged it.

Lifting his certificate, Ramdev Mahato said, "There is a scratch on my glass."

Ratna Devi said, "Wipe it when you get home."

By evening the walls were empty again.

The school's five old certificates began to be rehung.

Saroja stood holding "Commitment to Continuous Learning."

"Where does this go?" Ratna Devi asked.

Saroja looked at the old nail.

Gauri said, "One minute."

She brought a plain sheet of white paper from the office.

In large letters she wrote—

"Teacher's post vacant in the school."

Below it—"Today: 82 days."

Ratna Devi started.

"Why will you hang this?"

Gauri said, "For proof."

"This is not a certificate."

"No. It is evidence."

A faint smile came to Saroja's face.

Navalkishore, who was looking after the frame of the new commendation, came over.

He read the paper.

"This is not an official notice."

Gauri said, "Then let 'Today: 82 days' remain. Tomorrow we will make it 83."

Before Navalkishore could reply, Saroja asked, "Is it wrong?"

Navalkishore checked the date in the file.

"It is not wrong."

"Then?"

He looked at the wall.

On one side was “Full Enrolment,” on another “Clean School,” and on the third an empty nail.

Navalkishore said quietly, “Hang it lower down. The children should not be able to reach it.”

Gauri hung the paper on the nail.

The certificate for “Commitment to Continuous Learning” was placed in the cupboard that day.

The block’s new commendation was hung in the panchayat building.

The old certificates in the village homes returned to their former places.

The next morning Saroja opened the gate.

Chandan was the first to arrive.

He began reading the white paper on the wall.

“Scho... ol... has...”

Saroja listened from a distance.

He stumbled over the word “teacher.”

This time Saroja did not supply the word.

Chandan sounded out the letters twice.

“Tea... cher.”

Then he read the number below—“82.”

Saroja brought a red pencil.

She drew a thin line through 82 and wrote beside it—“83.”

Chandan asked, “What will we write when the teacher comes?”

Saroja closed the red pencil.

“That day the number will stop increasing.”

Chandan looked at the paper again.

It was the only paper on the wall without a frame around it.

But that morning, it was the first sentence read aloud in the school.

Cleanliness Day

The paved road that ran through the middle of Belahi village had, at one bend, acquired a dumping place between an old peepal tree and a disused grain warehouse.

No official board gave the place a name, but everyone knew that sweepings from homes, leaf plates from the market, broken slippers, rotting vegetable peelings, and leftover thermocol from wedding feasts would eventually find their way there.

Across the road stood the primary school.

From the windows, the children would sometimes watch crows, dogs, and goats searching the heap for their respective shares.

By the end of Bhadau, the heap had grown large.

The village's small garbage-collection vehicle had not come for two weeks.

Sometimes people were told that its axle had broken, sometimes that it had been sent to another panchayat, and sometimes that the driver was ill.

Malti Devi kept the dates of all three explanations in a small file of her own.

She was the panchayat sanitation worker.

Every morning she swept both sides of the road, cleared the mouths of the drains, and gathered the rubbish at the one place where the vehicle normally stopped.

People called her the sweeper woman, but Malti called her work "keeping the road clean."

In the first week of Ashwin, a notice from the panchayat reached the headmaster of the school.

The following day would be observed as "Cleanliness Day."

Schoolchildren, teachers, women from local groups, panchayat employees, and shopkeepers from the market would all take part in cleaning the road.

At the end there would be a group photograph.

The headmaster read the notice and said, "A good thing. The children will get into the habit."

Malti was standing there, straightening the bamboo handle of her broom.

She asked, "Where will the rubbish be taken?"

The headmaster looked at the notice again.

"It doesn't say that here."

Malti smiled.

"It mentions cleaning, but not collection?"

The headmaster did not answer her question.

The next morning the road was unusually lively.

The schoolchildren were made to stand in pairs of rows.

Some held new brooms, some empty sacks, and some cloth gloves.

Dheeraj, the panchayat assistant, was unfolding a white banner and tying it to the peepal tree.

In large green letters it read: "Clean Village, Healthy Village."

Malti looked at the heap of rubbish beneath the banner.

"Will the letters stay up there, or will the rubbish be removed first?" she asked.

Dheeraj laughed.

"Today you'll be in the photograph too, Malti-di."

"I live with this rubbish every day. Will being in the photograph today get it a vehicle?"

Dheeraj began looking here and there.

"A vehicle has been requested. It will come."

"At what time?"

"By the end of the programme."

Malti opened her file and wrote down the date.

Dheeraj asked, "What are you writing?"

"Vehicle requested - no time stated."

Dheeraj laughed and moved on.

At nine o'clock, two guests arrived from the block office.

With them came a photographer, a black bag slung over his shoulder and a large camera in his hand.

The programme began.

It had been agreed beforehand that the speeches would be brief, but three people spoke in succession about cleanliness, discipline, and public participation.

The children stood in the sun holding their brooms and listened.

Then, at the signal, everyone spread out along the road.

Where the rubbish was thickest, Malti and two of her co-workers had already begun.

The children picked up leaf plates and filled sacks.

The shopkeepers swept the ground in front of their shops.

The women from the groups picked plastic from along the drains.

Within half an hour, a long stretch of the road truly did look clean.

The problem was the rubbish.

Seven sacks, two bamboo baskets, three heaps of wet leaves, and one broken plastic chair lay gathered by the roadside.

The vehicle had still not arrived.

The photographer called Dheeraj over.

"The view is good from this side, but the sacks show in the background."

Dheeraj looked at Malti.

"Put them behind the warehouse for ten minutes."

Malti stood still.

"The drain slopes that way. If it rains, all the muck will go into the drain."

"Only ten minutes."

"The vehicle?"

"It should be here any moment."

The photographer began arranging the children in front of the banner.

The guests took brooms in their hands.

On one of the brooms, even the binding cord had not yet been untied.

Malti looked at her co-worker Ramvilas.

Ramvilas said softly, "Let the photograph be taken first. We'll see afterward."

Two sacks went behind the warehouse.

Then the other five.

The baskets too.

The broken chair was placed out of sight behind the wall.

The heaps of wet leaves were pushed so far in with bamboo slats that they could no longer be seen from the road.

For a few minutes, the bend gleamed.

The photographer changed position three times.

"Everyone smile."

In one photograph, the children stood in front.

In another, the guests were in the middle.

In the third, the panchayat employees held brooms.

Dheeraj looked for Malti.

She was behind the warehouse, straightening the sacks.

"Di, come quickly. This one is for all the employees."

Malti came, but she did not take a broom.

"Take a broom," the photographer said.

"My broom is where the work is."

Everyone burst out laughing.

The photographer too.

The photograph was taken.

After that, packets of biscuits were distributed.

People were instructed to put empty water bottles into one sack.

The guests got into their vehicle.

Dheeraj walked to the end of the road to see them off.

The photographer's motorcycle sped away, raising dust.

The programme was over.

At that very moment, Bhola, the warehouse watchman, came running.

"Who put this rubbish at the back?"

Ramvilas said, "The vehicle is coming."

Bhola put a hand to his head.

"Grain sacks are to be unloaded here tomorrow. I need this place empty. And look - all the water will run into the drain."

Without arguing, Malti lifted the sacks.

"Where?" Ramvilas asked.

"Where the vehicle looks for them every day."

"Back by the road?"

"At the designated place beside the road. Otherwise the vehicle will come and go back empty."

Two children were still standing at the school gate - Kavita of Class Seven and Sonu of Class Five.

They watched all seven sacks that had just been removed from the photograph come back to the roadside.

The broken chair too.

The wet leaves too.

The bend that had gleamed ten minutes earlier looked as it had before.

Astonished, Sonu asked, "Malti-kaki, why are you making it dirty again?"

Malti set down the sack and looked at him.

"I'm not making it dirty. Did the rubbish go anywhere?"

Sonu looked behind the warehouse.

"There."

"Did putting it there make the place clean?"

Sonu fell silent.

Kavita said, "It was clean in the photograph."

Malti did not laugh.

"Then today the photograph has been cleaned. The road is still left to do."

A light rain fell in the afternoon.

The sacks got wet, but Malti raised them onto bricks so that they would not block the mouths of the drains.

She wrote another line in her file: "Photograph 10:17. Collection zero."

The next morning, a colour photograph had been pasted on the notice board of the panchayat building.

Under it was written: "Cleanliness Day successfully completed."

Dheeraj looked at the photograph with satisfaction.

The colours had come out well.

The banner could be read clearly.

There was no rubbish on the road.

Malti came sweeping in front of the building.

Dheeraj said, "See? You're standing at the back too."

Malti searched for her face in the photograph.

Indeed, she was standing at one edge, empty-handed.

"Did the vehicle come?"

Dheeraj's smile shrank.

"It will come today."

"At what time?"

"We've informed them by phone."

"Shall I write that down?"

"Why do you write down everything?"

Malti closed her file.

"Rubbish doesn't remember. Dates do."

At school that day, Kavita was given an essay to write: "Our Cleanliness Day."

Many children wrote that everyone had worked together to clean the village.

Kavita wrote the same thing in her first line.

In the second she wrote: "After that, the rubbish was put back by the road."

The teacher's red pen stopped.

"Is it necessary to write this?"

Kavita asked, "If I don't, will the essay be complete?"

Before answering, the teacher looked out of the window toward the road.

The heap was still there.

She did not strike out the sentence with her red pen.

She only put a question mark in the margin.

For three days, the vehicle did not come.

The heap of rubbish began to spread again.

Animals tore open the sacks.

The wind blew thin pieces of plastic as far as the school fence.

Every day Malti gathered them again.

On the fourth day, Sonu took a piece of chalk and wrote two short lines on the outside wall of the school:

"Cleaned - 2nd."

"Collected - _____."

The headmaster saw it.

"Who wrote this?"

Sonu raised his hand.

"Why?"

"Malti-kaki said the road was still left to do."

Malti was not there.

The headmaster looked at the wall for a few moments.

Then he said, "Draw the line straight. Your writing is crooked."

The children laughed.

All day, everyone who passed in front of the school noticed the two lines.

Someone asked, "Why is 'collected' blank?"

Someone said, "The vehicle must not have come."

For the first time, some people understood that sweeping and taking the rubbish away were two different jobs.

In the evening, Dheeraj too saw the lines on the wall.

"This isn't an official notice board," he told the headmaster.

"No," the headmaster said. "Think of it as a mathematics exercise. The first date is given; the second has to be found."

Dheeraj said nothing.

At noon on the fifth day, the rumble of a vehicle was heard in the distance.

Malti was cleaning a drain.

She raised her head.

The small garbage-collection vehicle was coming around the bend.

As soon as the driver got down, he asked, "A lot?"

Malti pointed toward the sacks.

"Five days' worth."

Dheeraj too came running when he heard the news.

He took out his phone.

"Let's get one photograph. The vehicle is here too."

Malti said, "Lift it first."

"We can take one while it's being lifted."

"Then half the rubbish will be left behind again."

The driver laughed.

He reversed the vehicle.

Ramvilas began loading the sacks.

Malti separated the wet leaves, put the pieces of glass into a separate container, and kept aside the metal from the broken chair.

Kavita and Sonu came to the gate.

They kept count: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven sacks.

The vehicle filled up.

For the first time, the ground at the bend was truly empty.

The packed earth underneath was black, and two thin blades of grass remained in the middle.

Dheeraj raised his phone.

By then the vehicle had begun to move.

"Wait! One photograph!"

Whether the driver heard him or not was impossible to tell.

The vehicle turned the bend and disappeared.

Dheeraj took a photograph of the empty road.

"How will people know the vehicle came?"

Malti opened her file.

"The date is written."

"A photograph is clearer proof."

Malti pointed toward the wall.

Sonu, chalk in hand, was filling the blank line:

"Collected - 6th, 2:40 p.m."

Dheeraj looked at the writing for a while.

Then he put his phone back into his pocket.

That week, the colour photograph from Cleanliness Day remained displayed in the panchayat building. In the photograph the road gleamed, everyone smiled, and no rubbish was visible anywhere. On the school wall, the two chalk lines slowly blurred under splashes of rain. But the children wrote a new date again the following week, because the vehicle came eight days later. The entries in Malti's file kept growing too.

A few months later, the headmaster added two new columns to the school's cleanliness register: "Cleaning done" and "Rubbish collected." The first column was marked almost every day. The second was marked only on the days when the vehicle actually came. No one made it for an award. No photograph was taken of it.

One day Sonu asked Malti, "Kaki, which day should we now say the road is clean?" Malti stopped sweeping and looked at the place where the heap used to be. There was nothing there that day. "When I no longer have to be asked that question," she said.

Whether Sonu fully understood her or not, Malti did not ask. She began sweeping again. Beneath the peepal tree, dry leaves gathered to one side. The school bell rang. There was no banner on the road, no guest, no photographer. But the bend was empty.

The Educated Gathering

Chairs had been set out on the veranda of Bardaha Middle School since morning.

A white cloth banner hung on the wall: "A Literate Village, an Empowered Village." Beneath it, in red letters, was written: "Read your own work, understand it yourself."

Deepak read the banner without smiling. He merely straightened the corner that hung crooked.

The headmaster, Ramanand Jha, called to him from behind. "Deepak, one minute."

He had a three-page application form in his hand.

"This is the application for repairs to the teachers' quarters. I have filled in the upper part, but I cannot make sense of the two boxes below. Have a look."

Deepak took the pages and read them.

"It says here: 'If benefit under this head has been received earlier, state the year and amount.'"

Ramanand Jha pushed his spectacles up. "Yes, I understand that. But I do not remember how much the earlier amount was."

"Then leave it blank. We can fill it after checking the file."

"It has to be submitted today. Just write something. Fill it the way you did last time."

Deepak handed the page back. "If I guess the amount and write it down, it may cause trouble later."

Ramanand Jha looked at his watch. "All right. We'll check after the meeting. Keep the application with you."

He went towards the dais. Five minutes later his voice boomed through the microphone: "Literacy is not merely recognising letters; it is understanding one's own rights and responsibilities."

Deepak sat at a small table beside the door of the school's old library. There was no pile of papers before him. Only a blue pen, a glass of water, and an empty register.

People in the village called him "Deepak of the applications."

He did not work in any office. After graduating and returning home, he sat near the panchayat office between rounds of competitive examinations and helped people read applications: old-age assistance, scholarships, caste and residence certificates, corrections to bank accounts.

At first he helped only the elderly. Gradually, people began coming to his table who themselves gave speeches at the school, conducted meetings, and drafted resolutions.

Today's meeting had been called before the village submitted its nomination at district level for the "Full Literacy Achievement."

Mukhiya Janaki Devi reached the dais. Ten minutes before the speeches began, she came to Deepak's table.

"This is my sister's widow-assistance application. I have filled in her name and address. You fill in the rest."

Deepak looked at the page.

"Here it asks for the family's annual income."

Janaki Devi said softly, "Write whatever keeps it within the limit."

"The actual income?"

"Who counts the actual amount? She has two katthas of land. She had a cow, not anymore. Her son works outside, but if we write how much he sends home, the application will get stuck."

Deepak laid the pen on the table. "I can write the words. I cannot invent the answers."

Janaki Devi looked at him for two moments, then gathered the papers. "We'll sit down and fill it after the meeting."

She climbed onto the dais and said, "In an educated society, no one needs to depend on another person."

The schoolchildren seated at the back applauded.

The third person to come to Deepak's table was Bhubaneswar Babu, chairman of the cooperative society. He had the application for renewal of the seed-distribution centre's licence.

"What is the difference between 'declared storage capacity' and 'actual available capacity'?"

Deepak explained it.

Bhubaneswar Babu scratched his head. "The godown can hold fifty sacks, but the register says one hundred. Which should I write?"

"What it can actually hold."

"Then it will not match the old register."

"Then the old register is wrong."

Bhubaneswar Babu laughed. "You keep very straight accounts. Government papers do not run on such straight accounts."

Deepak did not reply.

A little later Bhubaneswar Babu spoke for five minutes from the dais on literacy and “scientific thinking.”

The meeting continued. The panchayat secretary read out literacy figures. Retired teacher Nandkishore Babu spoke of the old days when people used thumb impressions. Vikas, president of the youth club, said that the village’s young men and women now read the whole world on their phones.

After stepping down from the dais, Vikas came straight to Deepak.

“Brother, fill out this grant application for the playground. I have to submit it at the block office by evening.”

“But you’re a graduate.”

Vikas laughed. “I am, but if there is a mistake in the application the money will get held up. You understand all these boxes.”

“Not all of them.”

“Still, more than the rest of us.”

Deepak read the page. The fifth box said: “Nature and estimated value of local contribution.”

“What should go here?” Deepak asked.

Vikas answered at once, “Voluntary labour.”

“How many people, for how many days?”

“You work all that out.”

Deepak slid the page back towards him. “You tell me the number of people. You tell me the days. I’ll multiply them.”

Vikas’s smile shrank. “Let the meeting end first.”

Applications kept accumulating on the table.

Hardly anyone came on his own behalf; nearly everyone brought someone’s “urgent work”—a daughter’s scholarship, a group account, correction of a name in land records, a pension declaration.

Deepak no longer picked up his pen and filled everything as he once had. He read each paper, called the person concerned, asked for the answer, and placed the empty box before them.

“Write it here in your own hand.”

“My handwriting is bad.”

“Bad handwriting is better than a false answer.”

“You write it. I’ll sign.”

“Above the signature it says that the information has been read and understood before being given.”

Some people became irritated. Some laughed. Some looked for another table, but there was no one else at the school filling applications.

Meanwhile an elderly woman came to the table. Her name was Phulkumari Devi. For three months she had been attending the new-literacy class. In her hand was an old-age assistance application.

"Son, I have filled in 'permanent address.' Under 'present address,' should I write the same thing again?"

Deepak looked at the page. The letters trembled, but they were clear.

"If you still live there, yes, write the same."

Phulkumari Devi slowly wrote the name of her village again.

"Here it asks for the bank branch. How do I write 'branch'?"

Deepak read out the bank's name. "This word is difficult. I'll write it for you, but first read it yourself."

She read it letter by letter. She stumbled twice in the middle, then said, "This is what is written on that signboard at the bank."

"Yes."

"Then next time I'll write it myself."

She did not fold the application; she kept it flat.

On the dais, meanwhile, the main proposal was being read. The district office had invited villages to apply for the "Functional Literacy Award." Ramanand Jha announced that Bardaha would send its name this year.

There was applause.

The panchayat secretary brought a thick application form to Deepak. "This is the most important one. Fill it today. The vehicle leaves this evening."

Deepak read the first page. It contained figures for the village population, school, new-literacy classes, library, and women's groups. The secretary read out numbers from the register and Deepak wrote them down.

There were five questions on the second page.

The first: "How many adults can independently read and understand an ordinary public notice?"

The secretary said, "Write one hundred percent."

Deepak stopped. "What is the basis for that figure?"

"The village has been declared fully literate."

"The declaration and this question are not the same thing."

The secretary frowned. "Write the next one."

The second question: "How many adults can fill an ordinary application form without assistance?"

Deepak's blue pen rested on the paper but did not move.

The secretary said, "That too—one hundred percent."

Deepak looked towards the dais. Ramanand Jha, Janaki Devi, Bhubaneswar Babu, and Vikas were all sitting in the front row. The applications of all four lay on his table.

"I cannot write that number."

The secretary lowered his voice. "Why?"

Deepak pointed to the papers on the table. "The applications of four people who spoke at today's meeting are lying here. All four gave them to me to fill."

The secretary glanced around. "There is no need to say this from the dais."

"I'm not saying it from the dais. I have to write a number in the application."

"You are only the person doing the writing."

For the first time Deepak looked directly into the secretary's eyes. "Then who is the person giving the answer?"

For a few moments, both were silent.

At the microphone, Nandkishore Babu concluded his speech: "Literacy frees a human being from dependence."

Phulkumari Devi was still standing by Deepak's table. She was reading her application again.

The secretary said quietly, "Write seventy-five."

"On what basis?"

"If you keep asking for a basis, no application will ever get filled."

Deepak capped his pen. "Then this box will remain blank."

The secretary picked up the application and went behind the dais.

Ten minutes later Deepak was called over. Behind the dais the four speakers and the secretary stood in a circle. Ramanand Jha said, "Deepak, this award concerns the whole village. It is not right to stop the application over one box." Deepak asked calmly, "Has anyone counted how many people can fill an application without assistance?" "No." "Then what should I write?"

Bhubaneswar Babu said, "Write an estimate. Everything works on estimates." Phulkumari Devi, who had been listening from a distance, came forward. "Where will you count me?" Everyone looked at her. She opened her application. "I filled half of it myself. This young man explained one word. So am I 'filled it myself' or 'took assistance'?" No one answered at once.

Phulkumari Devi asked again, "And someone who can read but is afraid and gets another person to fill it—where will you place that person?" Deepak smiled faintly for the first time. Ramanand Jha remembered his teachers' quarters application. Janaki Devi remembered

the income box in her sister's form. Vikas remembered the number for voluntary labour. Bhubaneswar Babu remembered the godown capacity.

Whispers began among the students in front of the dais. The next part of the programme was being delayed. Janaki Devi said, "Let us end the meeting here. If the application does not go today, it can go tomorrow." The secretary was startled. "The vehicle is here today." "The award is not going to run away." She returned to the dais and took the microphone.

"There is one change," she said. "We have spoken a great deal today about literacy. But there is one question to which we do not have an answer: how many people in our village can read and fill an ordinary application form by themselves?" Silence fell across the veranda. She continued, "So the application for the award will not be sent today. First we will find that answer."

Someone at the back murmured, "For such a small matter?" Phulkumari Devi raised her paper. "The box was small. The matter turned out to be large." A few people laughed, but this time there was less mockery in it. The following Sunday, chairs were set out at the school again. This time there was no banner. There was no microphone either.

On the library table Deepak placed five kinds of blank forms—bank, scholarship, assistance, cooperative, and school. Ramanand Jha was not in the front row; he sat beside the table. In his hand was the application for repairs to the teachers' quarters. He had found the old amount in the file.

Bhubaneswar Babu had measured the godown—fifty-five sacks, sixty if packed tightly. He said, "The register says one hundred. I will also have to fill out an application to correct that." Vikas had measured the playground with three young men and counted the days of voluntary labour. Janaki Devi had brought her sister with her. The income calculation was still not perfectly clear, but this time they were working out the monthly average together.

Phulkumari Devi had arrived before everyone else. She wrote the bank branch's name in her own hand. The letters still trembled. Deepak did not pull anyone's application towards himself. He only read the questions, explained difficult words, and handed the pen back to the applicant. Two weeks later, the award application was opened again. "How many adults can fill an ordinary application form without assistance?"

This time the box was not blank, but neither did it say one hundred percent. The number was far lower than expected. The secretary looked once at Janaki Devi. "If we write such a low figure, we may not get the award." Janaki Devi said, "If a false figure brings us the award, it will not be an award for literacy." Deepak wrote the number, but stopped his pen at the final declaration.

“It says here: ‘The above information is based on village-level verification.’ Who will keep the verification register?” Ramanand Jha pushed an empty register towards him. “Not you this time,” he said. “It will stay at the school. Whoever learns will fill in their own line.” Deepak pushed the register back. “Then who will fill the first line?” Phulkumari Devi picked up the pen.

She wrote her name slowly. One letter went crooked in the middle. She did not strike it out. Beside it she wrote the letter correctly again. On the veranda wall the old banner still lay folded: “Read your own work, understand it yourself.” No one suggested hanging it again. The sentence was no longer working on the wall; it was working among the open application forms on the table.

Model Square

It was the third week of Sawan. After rain had fallen all day, evening over Kusumpur's crossroads had turned grey. The pothole in the very middle of the square was full of water and looked like a small pond.

Jagdish Mistri had placed a blue signboard beneath the awning of his shop and was painting letters on it in white: "Model Square."

His granddaughter Sumedha sat nearby, copying the letters into her notebook. She was in Class Eight, and her interest in the shapes of letters had come from her grandfather.

"Grandfather, why are the letters in 'Model' so close together?"

Jagdish paused his brush. "If I space them too far apart, the name won't fit on the board."

Sumedha turned the board over and looked at the back. A few letters showed through beneath the old paint—"New Awa...". She grew curious. "What was this square called before?"

"New Awareness Square."

"And before that?"

"Harmony Square."

"And before that?"

"Youth Square."

Sumedha laughed. "And before that?"

Jagdish looked out from the shop at the water-filled pothole. "Peepal Bend. There was a peepal tree here then. No signboard."

The peepal had fallen in a storm twelve years earlier. The tree was gone, but the four roads of the bend remained where they had always been. After that, the panchayat put up a permanent sign for the first time. The signs kept changing. The pothole appeared five years ago after a water pipe was laid, and slowly grew wider.

From beneath the awning of the tea stall she ran on the square, Budhni Devi called, "Brother Jagdish, when you write a new name, does the old pothole become new too?"

Jagdish did not smile. In five years he had heard that joke in many forms.

Sumedha looked at Budhni. "Auntie, can a pothole have a name?"

“Whatever lasts the longest, people give it a name of their own,” Budhni said. “The bus conductors still call this ‘Peepal Bend.’”

The next morning two panchayat employees came to remove the old sign and put up the new one. There was no ceremony. The secretary said Kusumpur’s crossroads would now be entered in the district list as “Model Square.”

While the sign was being fixed, one employee’s foot sank into the mud beside the pothole. Irritated, he said, “Why hasn’t anyone put bricks here?”

Straining tea, Budhni said, “That question doesn’t come with the signboard.”

Everyone laughed. So did the employee. Then he straightened the sign and left.

That afternoon a vegetable cart, trying to edge around the pothole, clipped the corner of Budhni’s bench. Two baskets of aubergines toppled and scattered across the wet road. Kisun, who pushed the cart, picked up two aubergines and swore, then fell silent. Even swearing at the square had grown old.

“Why isn’t it repaired?” Sumedha asked.

Kisun looked at her. “It keeps almost getting repaired.”

“Who stops it?”

Kisun first looked toward the secretariat, then toward Budhni’s shop. “That’s a big question.”

That week at school, the teacher asked the children to write the name of a place in their village whose name had changed over time. Sumedha wrote “Model Square.” Beside her, Sonu wrote “Peepal Bend.” Rehana wrote “New Awareness Square,” because her father still called the place by that name.

The teacher looked at all three notebooks. “Three names for the same place?”

The class burst out laughing.

Sumedha said, “Five names, Ma’am. Harmony and Youth as well.”

The teacher wrote five names on the blackboard—Peepal Bend, Youth Square, Harmony Square, New Awareness Square, Model Square. “Which of these names lasted the longest?”

“Peepal Bend,” Sonu said.

“And the pothole in the middle of the square?” Sumedha added on her own.

The class laughed again. This time the teacher smiled, but immediately asked, “How long has the pothole been there?”

No child could give the exact answer.

"Go home and ask. If you can find the dates of the names, write them down—and the date of the pothole too."

That evening Sumedha told her grandfather about the homework at his shop. Jagdish laughed at first, then opened the back room. Three old signboards stood propped against the wall. On one, half the letters of "Youth Square" had flaked away; moss covered another that read "Harmony Square"; the third was "New Awareness Square," removed only the day before.

"Did you paint all of these?"

"Yes."

"Were you paid every time?"

Jagdish paused for a moment. "I did the work, so I was paid."

"Whose job was it to fill the pothole?"

Jagdish looked into the darkness of the back room. "The road people."

"Didn't they come?"

"They did."

Sumedha was startled. "When?"

Jagdish did not answer at once. "Once after Youth Square. Again when it was Harmony Square. And once after New Awareness Square had been put up."

"Then why wasn't it filled?"

"The day never worked out."

"How can a day not work out?"

Jagdish began washing his brush. "The crossroads has to be closed for half a day. They have to cut open the pothole and fill it from the bottom. Shops, carts, vehicles—everything has to stop."

"So?"

"So people said, 'Not today.'"

Sumedha kept looking at her grandfather's face. "Who do you mean by 'people'?"

Jagdish did not answer.

The next day Sumedha asked Budhni. At first Budhni tried to brush the matter aside. But the child's question was simple: "Auntie, did the road workers come or not?"

Washing tea glasses, Budhni said, "They came."

"Did you stop them?"

"Not only me."

"Did you stop them?"

Budhni's hands stopped. "The first time they came on a Monday. Mondays are crowded market days at my tea stall. I told them—do it on Tuesday."

"What happened on Tuesday?"

"On Tuesday they went somewhere else."

Kisun was arranging vegetables nearby and had been listening. He said on his own, "The second time, I stopped them. It was harvest season. If the road had been closed, I would have had to take the cart a mile and a half around. I told them—three days later."

"Three days later?"

Kisun kept straightening his pile of aubergines. "The crew never came back."

Sumedha looked toward her grandfather's shop.

Jagdish kept moving his brush.

That evening Sumedha asked again, "The third time?"

Jagdish's hand stopped. "The third time my signboard was to be installed."

"Which signboard?"

"New Awareness Square."

"So?"

"If the road had been closed for half a day, the ladder, bamboo, paint—everything would have been stuck in the middle. I said, put up the sign first; do the road the next day."

"And the next day?"

"The rains came."

Sumedha said nothing for a long time.

Jagdish said, "You think the pothole only causes trouble for everyone. But when the time comes to fill it, the trouble of half a day appears all at once before everybody."

"And the trouble of five years?"

Jagdish had no answer.

On Sunday the class discussed the homework. The children brought different dates, estimates and memories. No date was complete. But one thing became clear—the crew had come three times to fill the pothole, and all three times the work had been postponed.

The teacher asked, "Then whose fault was it?"

Sonu answered at once, "The panchayat's."

Rehana said, "The shopkeepers'."

A voice from the back said, "The rain's."

Sumedha remained silent.

The teacher said, "Don't rush to one answer. When everyone pushes a task forward for small reasons, five years later whose reason does it become?"

The class fell quiet.

That evening there was a small accident at the square. Thirteen-year-old Raju, carrying milk on his bicycle, slipped beside the pothole. The milk can overturned and his knee was scraped. The injury was not serious, but his mother came to the square and had plenty to say.

"We look at this pothole every day. What are we waiting for?"

People named the secretary. Someone named the road department. Someone else the panchayat.

The secretary arrived too. He first looked at Raju's knee, then at the crowd on the square. After listening for a while, he said, "Tomorrow we'll look at the register in the panchayat building. Three postponements are recorded there."

"Postponements?" Kisun's voice dropped.

The next day five or seven people went to the panchayat building. Sumedha was with her grandfather. The secretary opened the old meeting register.

The first entry read: "Repair of the square postponed until the next available day because of commercial crowding." Beneath it was the consent of the shopkeepers around the square. Budhni's thumbprint was there.

The second entry read: "Work postponed at local request because of disruption to harvest transport." Beneath it were seven signatures, including Kisun's.

The third entry read: "Local request that beautification of the square and installation of direction signs be completed first." Jagdish's signature was beneath that too.

Sumedha recognized her grandfather's signature.

Jagdish remained bent over the register. "That is my signature."

The secretary said, "This does not absolve me of fault. It was my responsibility to schedule the work again. But every time the objection rose from here."

Budhni said quietly, "We kept cursing the pothole, yet couldn't give up half a day."

Kisun reached out to close the register, then stopped. "Set the day now."

The secretary said, "Next Tuesday. From seven in the morning until one in the afternoon, traffic through the middle of the square will be closed. Small side routes will remain open in all four directions, but carts won't be able to pass."

Kisun immediately said, "A lot of vegetables come in on Tuesdays."

Everyone looked at him.

Kisun left the sentence unfinished. After a moment he said, "All right. I'll keep my cart on the southern road."

Budhni said, "I won't sell tea for half a day."

Jagdish said, "I'll keep my shop closed."

The secretary wrote the date in the register. This time the word "postponed" did not appear beneath the agreement.

Meanwhile an order also came for new direction signs for "Model Square"—four arrows pointing toward the school, health centre, market and pond. Jagdish got the job.

The secretary said, "Rewrite the central 'Model Square' sign neatly too. People from the district may come."

Jagdish looked at the new sign. "It's already neat."

"The letters are a little small."

For the first time Jagdish refused a job for which he would have been paid. "We'll look at the central sign after the repair. I'll make the four direction signs."

The secretary was surprised. "Why?"

"This time don't change the order of the work."

Sumedha looked at her grandfather. Jagdish did not look back at her, but his voice was steady.

The day before Tuesday, Jagdish himself put up small notices on all four shops around the square: "Tomorrow, repair of the square from 7 a.m. to 1 p.m. Please bear the inconvenience."

Kisun read it and said, "Did it need 'Model Square' written on it?"

Jagdish said, "No. The name of the work is enough."

At six on Tuesday morning, Budhni did not light her stove. Kisun took his cart to the southern road. Jagdish pulled his shop shutter halfway down.

At twenty past seven, the repair crew arrived.

They first drained the water from the pothole. Then they cut back the edges and removed the loose soil. The pothole turned out to be wider below than it looked from above. The earth beside the old pipe had repeatedly subsided with the rains.

"If we only put gravel on top, it will sink again," the mason said. "It has to be filled from below and compacted."

The work continued. At eight, the first customer came to Budhni's closed shop. "No tea?"

Budhni pointed toward the road. "The pothole is being filled today."

“What harm could one glass of tea do?”

Budhni thought for a moment, then said, “If I light the stove, ten people will stand here. Not today.”

Two of Kisun’s customers came looking for his cart at its usual place. From a distance he called, “Southern road!”

At half past nine a jeep tried to move the bamboo barrier so it could cross the square. Jagdish came out of his shop and said, “Two hours later.”

The driver said, “I’m in a hurry.”

“Everyone has been in a hurry for five years,” slipped out of Jagdish’s mouth. He himself was startled. The driver understood some of it and some he did not; he turned the jeep around.

Before leaving for school, Sumedha stood at the square for ten minutes. She saw that Jagdish had brought the old “New Awareness Square,” “Harmony Square” and “Youth Square” signboards out of his shop and propped them along three sides of the road. The written faces were turned inward, their blank backs outward. They served as temporary barriers.

“Grandfather, you’re blocking the road with the old names?”

Jagdish laughed. “For the first time today, they’re useful.”

By noon the pothole had been filled and compacted. The top layer was to be laid the next day, so the bamboo enclosure would remain for now.

Budhni lit her stove. The first tea she made was for the repair workers. Kisun brought his cart back to the square.

“Half a day gone,” he calculated.

Budhni said, “Small compared with five years.”

Kisun did not argue.

By evening the new direction signs were up—school east, market south, health centre north, pond west. The central “Model Square” sign remained as it was. Jagdish did not touch its letters again.

That night it rained hard. Sumedha lay listening to the sound of water at the window. She worried that the filled spot would sink again.

At dawn she reached the square before her grandfather. Inside the bamboo enclosure the earth was wet, but no water had collected in the middle. It had drained toward the side channel.

Jagdish came up behind her. “What are you looking at?”

“It’s all right for now.”

“For now,” Jagdish repeated.

The final surface layer was laid the next day. In the evening a bus stopped. Out of habit the conductor called, “Peepal Bend! Peepal Bend!”

An unfamiliar passenger read the new sign and asked, “Isn’t this Model Square?”

The conductor laughed. “Call it Model, call it Peepal—the place to get down is the same.”

Sumedha sat at Budhni’s shop listening. She remembered her teacher’s question—which name would last the longest?

She went home and opened her notebook. Beneath the five names she did not add a sixth. She wrote only one line: “Day the pothole was filled—Tuesday.” Then she added the date.

Jagdish looked at her notebook. “Didn’t you write a name?”

“What’s the name of the work?”

Jagdish stood the old signboards up again behind the shop. “The name of the work doesn’t need changing.”

Sumedha asked, “Will you throw these old signs away?”

“No. If someone ever asks why the square’s name changed so many times, I’ll show them.”

“And the pothole?”

Jagdish looked toward the new road. “It doesn’t need a photograph. If it forms again, we’ll write the date again. We won’t change the name again.”

Three days later Jagdish noticed a small scratch on the edge of the “Model Square” sign. The brush was in his hand. He opened the paint tin, filled the scratch, and stopped. He did not repaint the letters.

The new surface in the middle of the square still shone wet. No name was written on it.

The Ribbon of Development

It was the first Tuesday of Bhadau. A red ribbon had been stretched across the mouth of the new drain on the eastern side of Sonbarsa market.

The ribbon had come from Jagmohan the tailor's shop.

Jagmohan was sixty-five. The measuring tape for cloth usually hung around his neck; the red ribbon for ceremonies stayed separately rolled on top of the cupboard.

That morning a boy from the panchayat came running in. "Kaka, five cubits of red ribbon. Quickly."

Jagmohan asked, "For what?"

"The inauguration of the drain."

Jagmohan looked out through the window. For three months bricks, sand and mortar had been lying by the market; the drain had taken shape amid them.

"Is it finished?"

The boy laughed. "Once the ribbon is cut, it will be considered finished."

Jagmohan measured out five cubits and cut it. He put the remaining roll back on top of the cupboard.

His granddaughter Abha sat in a corner of the shop doing her school homework. She was in Class Eight.

Abha asked, "Does the inauguration happen because the drain is finished, or does the drain become finished because it has been inaugurated?"

Measuring the sleeve of a kurta, Jagmohan said, "In my work, the measurement is completed first. Only then do the scissors move."

Abha closed her notebook and went outside.

The drain ran almost across the entire market toward the old pond. New bricks gleamed along the upper stretch. In some places the covers had not yet been laid. At the far end, before joining the pond's old outlet, it stopped at a strip of earth.

That strip was no more than seven cubits long.

Abha measured it by counting her steps. One, two, three, four, five, six, seven.

Once the drain water reached that point, it was supposed to enter the old earthen channel ahead. But the seven cubits between them were still only mud.

The ceremony was at the other end of the drain.

The mukhiya, the ward member, two people from the market committee and the school headmaster had come.

The ribbon was stretched between two bamboo poles.

In the speech it was said, "Sonbarsa market will now be free from waterlogging."

Jagmohan too stood in the crowd. He had no particular interest in watching a ribbon being cut, but he had an old habit of seeing how his material was used.

The scissors moved. Applause broke out.

Abha picked up the small red piece that had fallen after being cut.

Jagmohan asked, "What will you do with that?"

"Keep the measurement safe."

"The ribbon's measurement?"

"The drain's."

Jagmohan said nothing.

Three days later it rained.

Water from the market roofs poured into the drain. For the first half kos the flow ran well. But at the eastern end the seven cubits of earth stopped the water.

Slowly, the drain filled up.

Budhni, who sold tea, shouted as she lifted the bench in front of her shop, "The water is turning back again."

People tried to open an outlet with bamboo poles. Some of the water escaped by cutting through a field embankment.

The next day the matter came up in the market.

The secretary said, "The main drain has been completed. The final connection falls under the work of the old outlet. That belongs to another budget head."

Budhni asked, "Does water check the budget head before it flows?"

Everyone laughed. The secretary did not.

That day Abha tied the first red ribbon to the first bamboo pole beside the unfinished seven-cubit stretch.

Jagmohan saw it. "What is this?"

"So we remember that the measurement is still unfinished here."

A month passed.

All the covers were laid. Lime was applied along the sides of the drain. Small iron grilles were fitted at two places.

At a meeting, the market committee decided that the covered and secured drain should have a 'public-use opening.'

The panchayat boy came again to Jagmohan's shop.

"Kaka, five cubits of red ribbon."

Jagmohan looked over the top of his spectacles. "What is being inaugurated?"

"The drain."

The scissors stopped in his hand.

"That drain was opened last month."

"That was the inauguration of construction. This is the inauguration of use."

Jagmohan took the same roll down from the top of the cupboard.

Abha did not smile. She only asked, "Was the five cubits from the first time entered in the account?"

Jagmohan opened the old ledger. "It is written here—drain inauguration, five cubits."

"And this?"

"What shall I write?"

The boy said, "Public-use opening."

Jagmohan wrote in the ledger: "Same drain—public use, five cubits."

For the second ceremony, coloured paper pennants were hung as well.

Budhni did not go. Tea was boiling on her stove.

Abha went to the far end of the drain. The seven cubits of earth were still exactly as before.

The first red ribbon had faded in the rain.

After the ceremony ended, she picked up the second cut piece of ribbon too.

She tied both pieces to the same bamboo pole.

Jagmohan watched from a distance.

"A memory of two occasions?"

"Two inaugurations."

"The drain?"

"The same one."

Bhadau passed. In Ashwin the market stayed dry. The drain's defect again slipped from people's sight.

Children jumped across the unfinished seven cubits. During the night someone placed bricks there to make a crossing.

One day word came that an inspection team from the block office was coming.

People from the market committee had the sides of the drain cleaned. Leaves caught in the grilles were removed. The covers received another coat of white paint.

The inspection took place.

The officer looked at the beginning of the drain. The line was straight and the covers were properly set.

Abha wanted to follow the officer all the way to the end, but the crowd turned back midway.

Two weeks later a notice was posted: "Drainage system transferred to the market committee."

Another programme was fixed for the day of the handover.

The panchayat boy came to Jagmohan's shop for the third time.

This time, the moment Jagmohan saw him, he asked, "Five cubits?"

The boy smiled sheepishly. "Yes."

"The same drain?"

"Handover ceremony."

Jagmohan opened the cupboard. The red roll was now thinner than before.

He measured five cubits, but before he could use the scissors Abha said, "Baba, cut seven cubits."

The boy started. "The order is for five cubits."

Abha said, "Seven cubits are still missing from the drain."

The boy snapped, "What does the ribbon have to do with the drain?"

Jagmohan looked at his granddaughter. Then he cut only five cubits.

"My work is to give the measurement that has been asked for," he said quietly.

Abha fell silent.

Clouds had gathered on the day of the third ceremony.

This time the ribbon was stretched across the broad middle part of the market, where the fresh paint on the drain gleamed most brightly.

The speeches were kept short.

One speaker said, "Construction, use and handover—all three stages have been completed successfully."

Abha stood at the back of the crowd. Her eyes were on the line of the drain.

The first heavy drop fell.

The rain intensified along with the applause.

People ran toward the shop awnings.

The cut ribbon lay soaking on the ground.

Abha picked up the third piece.

Budhni was gathering things from the stove at her tea stall. "This time let us see how far the water accepts the inauguration."

Within ten minutes the drain began to fill.

The water entered the opening at a good speed, moved forward noisily beneath the covers, but stopped again at the final seven cubits.

The mud split and formed a small channel, then the earth caved in and blocked the mouth again.

The water began rising back toward the west.

People from the market were still standing under the awnings. Many of them had attended all three ceremonies.

No one made a speech.

Clutching all three red pieces in her fist, Abha ran toward the far end.

Jagmohan followed her without an umbrella.

Abha untied the first ribbon from the first bamboo pole. She joined the second and third pieces to it.

Joined together, the three red pieces formed a strip nearly seven cubits long.

She spread it on the ground parallel to the unfinished section of the drain.

Jagmohan stood watching.

"Baba," Abha said, "five cubits were cut three times. The leftover pieces together are enough for seven cubits. Please complete this much of the drain."

The arithmetic was not exact; each ceremonial ribbon had been a full five cubits, while the pieces that fell after cutting were small. But the image was clear—the red line lay across the unfinished earth.

Jagmohan picked up the ribbon. "A measurement is not made with symbols. It is made with a mason's line."

The mason unwound his alignment cord.

The cord was stretched across the strip of earth. The distance came to roughly seven cubits.

Budhni had arrived too. The secretary, members of the market committee and several shopkeepers came behind her.

The secretary said, "This section belongs to the old drainage scheme."

Jagmohan asked, "Does water change schemes?"

This time the secretary gave no answer.

The market committee president planted his stick in the earth and said, "If these seven cubits are not joined, how can I sign that we are taking charge of the drain?"

The handover register was still getting wet on the ceremonial table.

For the first time, the secretary left the final line of the document blank.

"Stop the signatures for today," the president said. "Join it first."

The next day no ribbon was stretched.

Four labourers, one mason and two market shopkeepers began work on the unfinished section.

The mouth of the old outlet was found blocked with earth and plastic. Clearing it took half a day.

From time to time Jagmohan stepped out of his shop to watch.

Abha returned from school and checked the knot in the alignment cord once more.

"Measuring again?" the mason asked.

"Not for an inauguration this time."

The seven-cubit section was completed. Its slope was matched to the old outlet.

In the evening two buckets of water were poured in from the upper end.

The stream ran all the way toward the pond without stopping.

Budhni said, "Now the drain understands where its road lies."

No one applauded.

On the third day the handover register was signed. The president asked, "Shall we hold a small programme?" Jagmohan was there. He said, "The work is complete. Now complete the paperwork." The president laughed. "No ribbon?"

Jagmohan pointed to the cloth-measuring tape around his neck. "Why should I cut, in a ceremony, the tape meant for measuring work?"

Word spread through the market that there had been no fourth inauguration of the drain. Some people joked, "One opportunity has been lost." Others breathed a sigh of relief.

Abha did not take the three red pieces home. She tied them to an old nail inside Jagmohan's shop. Below them, Jagmohan was looking at the three entries in his ledger—'drain inauguration', 'same drain—public use', 'handover ceremony'.

Beneath the third entry he added a fourth: "Final seven cubits—no ribbon." Abha read it. "Is this an account of expenses?" "No," Jagmohan said, "an account showing that the measurement was completed."

The first hard rain of Kartik fell at night. In the morning Budhni opened her shop and saw that no water had collected in front. She went to the mouth of the drain. The flow had passed through; only a few leaves were caught at the edge.

Jagmohan came too. Budhni asked, "Shall we cut a ribbon once now, to give thanks?" Jagmohan laughed. "Remove the leaves. That much thanks is enough."

On her way to school, Abha stopped at the far end of the drain. The bamboo pole where the red piece had once been tied was gone. In place of the mud, a straight seven-cubit stretch of brick gleamed. She did not count her steps. She only watched the water follow its own path, without any ceremony.

The Distinguished Family

On a bright morning in Ashadh, a new plaque, gleaming like brass, arrived at the gate of the Jha family home in Belatoli.

Two young men had brought it wrapped in cloth. As soon as the cloth was removed, bold letters appeared: "Distinguished Family."

Below, in smaller letters, it read: "For the social and cultural contribution of three generations."

Shashikant Jha wiped his spectacles and read the words again.

His wife Sudha called from inside, "Wipe the dust first. The paint on the gate is peeling too."

Ranjan, who was in Class Twelve, took out his phone and began taking photographs.

Thirteen-year-old Gauri kept looking at her own face in the plaque's shine.

Inside the veranda, eighty-two-year-old Subhadra Devi sat on a folded cot.

No one called her over to see it.

The application for this award had been submitted three months earlier.

The cultural forum had been looking, in the village and five nearby settlements, for families in which three generations lived under one roof, took part in public work, and maintained a link between old traditions and the new generation.

While filling out the application, Shashikant had written Subhadra Devi's name at the very top.

In the line marked "Contribution of the senior member of the family," he had written: "Folk songs, ritual tales, old wedding customs, and the living memory of the household's history."

Against the question "Does the senior member reside with the family?" the box marked "Yes" had been ticked.

There was no lie in that answer.

Subhadra Devi truly did live in that house.

The only question was where in the house she lived.

The house had been built nearly forty years earlier.

At that time Subhadra Devi's husband was alive, her two sons were small, and in the room on the eastern side of the courtyard she kept her trunk, spinning wheel, and bedding.

For many years after her husband died, that room remained hers.

Over the last ten or twelve years, the uses of the house had gradually changed.

First, Ranjan needed a quiet place to study.

Subhadra Devi said, "The boy will study. Let him take the room."

When Ranjan's examinations were over, Shashikant's files began to multiply.

For a few months the room was called "the papers room."

Then the younger son came from outside with his family for two months, and guests stayed in that room.

After that, certificates of honour, old copper plaques, mementoes, school trophies, and framed citations began to accumulate in the house.

One day Sudha said, "It would be better if all these things stayed in one place."

From that day, the old room became "the room of honours and memorabilia."

Subhadra Devi's trunk shifted to the wall of the veranda.

Her cot began to be folded away.

At night, wherever space was found, the cot was opened there.

By day it was folded and kept sometimes under the stairs, sometimes behind the sitting room, sometimes against the veranda wall.

No one in the family called this a problem.

Everyone called it an "arrangement."

Subhadra Devi too rarely protested.

Sudha gave her medicine on time.

Shashikant massaged her feet at night.

Ranjan brought her a cord for her spectacles, oil, and sweets from the market.

When Gauri returned from school, she told her the day's news.

There was care.

There was no fixed place.

On the day the honour plaque was to be fixed at the gate, cleaning began throughout the house.

People from the forum were coming in the evening to take photographs.

The two gateposts were repainted.

The curtains in the sitting room were changed.

The room of honours and memorabilia was opened and the frames were dusted.

Sudha selected the frames one by one and hung them on the sitting-room wall.

That day Subhadra Devi's folded cot stood behind the sitting room.

Sudha said, "This cot won't look good in the photograph here. Ranjan, put it inside."

Ranjan lifted the cot and carried it to the door of the room of honours and memorabilia.

Inside there were already three light chairs, a broken harmonium, two boxes, and piles of thick backing board from frames.

The cot would not fit.

"Ma, there's no space."

"Put it under the stairs."

Under the stairs were a broom, an old bucket, and an empty rice sack.

Ranjan moved them all out and stood the cot there.

Subhadra Devi watched the whole scene in silence.

Gauri came and sat beside her.

"Grandmother, why are they hiding your cot?"

"They're not hiding it, child. They're making room for the honour."

Gauri tried to laugh, but there was no smile on Subhadra Devi's face.

At noon, remembering her school homework, Gauri took out her notebook.

The geography teacher had said, "Draw a simple floor plan of your house. Write the main use of each room."

Sitting in the courtyard, Gauri began estimating the measurements.

First she drew the outer walls.

Then she marked the sitting room, kitchen, prayer corner, Ranjan's study room, her parents' room, the guest room, and the room of honours and memorabilia.

The veranda ran long through the middle.

She drew the staircase too.

The plan was almost complete.

Gauri's pencil stopped.

She looked at Subhadra Devi.

"Grandmother, which room is yours?"

Subhadra Devi closed her betel-nut box.

"Mine?"

"Yes. I have to write it on the plan."

For a few moments Subhadra Devi looked through the house as though the answer to the question might be written on its walls.

"Look at night and you'll know," she said at last.

Gauri did not find this answer useful for her homework.

She went to her mother.

"Ma, which room is Grandmother's?"

Sudha was wiping a plate.

"She stays on the veranda, doesn't she?"

"The veranda isn't a room."

"Then write the guest room. When there are no guests, she sleeps there."

"Uncle is coming tomorrow."

Sudha stopped her hand. "Then the cot will be opened in the sitting room."

"I've written 'place for guests to sit' for the sitting room."

Sudha laughed. "Your map follows stricter rules than the house does."

Gauri went to her father.

Shashikant was checking the nails around the honour plaque at the gate.

"Babu, which room is Grandmother's?"

"This whole house is hers, isn't it?"

"Should I write 'the whole house'?"

Shashikant laughed. "A floor plan doesn't have room for that much sentiment."

"Then which room?"

Shashikant gave a nail head a light tap with the hammer. "Wherever she is comfortable."

Gauri looked at an empty square in her notebook that did not actually exist in the house.

She thought of drawing a new room for Grandmother on the plan.

Then she remembered her teacher's words: "Show what is there, not what ought to be."

She erased the square.

In the evening, three people from the forum arrived.

One carried a register, another a camera, and the third a bouquet of flowers.

The family stood in front of the new plaque at the gate.

The photographer said, "The senior member should be in the middle. The award is about three generations."

Ranjan ran inside.

“Grandmother, come outside. They’re taking photographs.”

Subhadra Devi got up.

Sudha adjusted her sari and straightened the edge of her anchal.

Gauri picked up her walking stick and handed it to her.

At the gate, Subhadra Devi was given a chair in the middle.

The honour plaque gleamed a little above her head.

The photographer said, “Everyone come a little closer. Around Grandmother.”

The family moved closer.

“Smile.”

One, two, three photographs were taken.

The forum secretary wrote something in his register.

He said to Subhadra Devi, “You are the root of a family like this. May we take a separate photograph in your room? It would be good for the article if there were old objects with you.”

Shashikant was silent for a moment.

Sudha said at once, “Yes, yes, come inside.”

Everyone moved in.

They passed through the sitting room.

At the guest-room doorway, bedding was being laid out for Uncle.

Ranjan’s study room was piled with books.

Sudha opened the door of the room of honours and memorabilia.

Inside were frames, trophies, thick papers, and old objects.

The forum secretary asked, “Grandmother stays here?”

Sudha said, “No, this is the room for things.”

The secretary asked again, “Then hers?”

No answer came at once.

Subhadra Devi herself laughed.

“My room keeps moving. It is difficult to catch it for a photograph.”

The secretary tried to laugh too, but the hand holding his register went still.

The photographer lowered his camera.

Gauri stood by the doorway.

Her homework notebook was tucked under her arm.

She said softly, “It can’t be caught on the map either.”

Shashikant heard her.

He said nothing.

No separate photograph was taken that day.
At night, Uncle arrived with his family.
The guest room filled up.
People sat in the sitting room until late.
The wind was strong on the veranda; raindrops blew well inside.
Subhadra Devi's cot stood folded under the stairs.
At half past ten, Sudha asked, "Ma, where should we open your cot tonight?"
Subhadra Devi said, "Wherever the map is empty."
Sudha could not tell whether it was a joke or weariness.
At last, when the sitting room emptied, the cot was opened there.
Five newly hung certificates of honour were on the wall above Subhadra Devi's head.
In the middle of the night, Ranjan got up to drink water.
Crossing the sitting room, his foot struck the corner of the cot.
Subhadra Devi woke up.
"Sorry, Grandmother," Ranjan whispered.
"It is your house. Go on."
Ranjan drank water and came back, but this time he walked more slowly.
In the morning the cot was folded again.
Tea had to be served to the guests; the sitting room had to be clear.
Subhadra Devi placed her pillow on the veranda bench.
Gauri did not submit her homework that day.
At school the teacher asked, "Why is the plan unfinished?"
Gauri opened her notebook.
Every room had a name written on it.
Beside the veranda in the middle was a small question mark.
"What is this?"
Gauri said, "I'm looking for Grandmother's place."
The class burst out laughing.
The teacher did not laugh.
She placed the notebook on her desk and studied it carefully.
"Does Grandmother live in the house?"
"Yes."
"Then why the question mark?"
Gauri repeated all the answers she had been given at home—the veranda, the guest room, the sitting room, the whole house.

The teacher did not give any mark with her red pen.

At the bottom she wrote: "A house plan is not only a map of walls; when you write the main use of a space, consider people's fixed needs too."

"Should I draw it again now?" Gauri asked.

"First look at the house. The map can come later."

That evening Gauri returned home with her notebook.

Two neighbours stood in front of the honour plaque, reading it.

One of them said, "The Jha family really is distinguished. They have kept the old people with them."

Gauri went inside.

Subhadra Devi was shelling peas on the veranda.

Two of Ranjan's old books lay on top of her trunk.

Gauri removed the books.

"Is this yours?"

"The trunk is mine."

"And the space on top?"

Subhadra Devi laughed. "The space on top belongs to whoever puts something there first."

Gauri showed her the red comment in her notebook.

Subhadra Devi read it slowly.

"Your teacher has written the right thing."

"Tell Babu that you need a room."

Subhadra Devi dropped the peas into the bowl.

"Asking is not difficult. It is more important that the people of the house see it for themselves."

"Does it trouble you?"

"Trouble is not always a hard cot, Gauri. Sometimes not being able to decide where to keep your own spectacles is trouble too."

For the first time Gauri noticed that Grandmother's spectacles, medicine, bottle of oil, and betel-nut box all stayed in one small cloth bag.

The bag moved with her all day long.

That night Gauri did not draw the plan.

She counted the fixed places of things in the house.

In the kitchen, the spice box had its fixed shelf.

Ranjan's books had their fixed cupboard.

Babu's files had their fixed drawer in the desk.

The certificates of honour had their fixed wall.

Even the broken harmonium had a fixed place in the room of honours and memorabilia.

Grandmother's spectacles were in the cloth bag.

Grandmother's cot was folded under the stairs.

Grandmother herself sat on the bench on the veranda.

The next day, before leaving for the office, Shashikant opened the door of the room of honours and memorabilia.

For the first time in many days, he stepped fully inside.

Against the wall stood an old certificate of honour belonging to his father.

In one box was a school trophy whose event no one remembered anymore.

The glass in three frames was broken.

One chair was missing a leg.

The bellows of the harmonium were torn.

In one corner, Subhadra Devi's old spinning-wheel frame was gathering dust.

Shashikant lifted it.

"How did this get here?"

Sudha came to the door. "It has been here a long time."

"It was Ma's."

"Yes."

Shashikant looked around the room.

"Are all these things necessary?"

Sudha did not answer at once.

Together they began sorting the objects.

Some of the frames could go on the sitting-room wall.

Photocopies could be made of some papers and the originals stored safely in a box.

The broken chair could be thrown away.

The harmonium could be sent for repair.

They thought of returning the school trophy to the school.

By noon, half the room was empty.

Subhadra Devi asked nothing.

She only took the spinning-wheel frame in her hands and looked at it.

"This had survived?"

Shashikant said, "We had forgotten it."

"When a thing has a place, people remember it."

Shashikant looked at his mother's face.

This time he did not search for an answer to the sentence.

In the evening Sudha swept and wiped the room and opened its window.

The western breeze came in.

The smell of old dust slowly faded.

Ranjan brought the folded cot from under the stairs.

The cot was opened.

Subhadra Devi stood in the doorway.

"What are you doing?"

Shashikant said, "Ma, this room is yours again."

Subhadra Devi did not go in at once.

"Where will all the honours go?"

Sudha laughed. "The things that are meant to be seen will go on the walls. The things that are only meant to be kept will go in boxes."

"And the guests?"

"Guests stay in the house for two nights. You stay in the house every night."

Subhadra Devi's eyes went to the window.

"Will the window open?"

"It will."

"Will the trunk come inside?"

"It will."

"The cot won't be folded again at night?"

Ranjan said, "No."

Subhadra Devi went inside.

The room was not large.

There was just enough space for a cot, a trunk, a small table, and the window.

Gauri placed Grandmother's cloth bag on the table.

A small box was placed by the window for her spectacles.

A shelf was cleared for her medicines.

Subhadra Devi did not put the spinning-wheel frame on top of the trunk; she leaned it against the wall.

"It won't work now," Gauri said.

"So what if it won't work? This time, at least, I'll know where it is."

Three days later, the secretary of the cultural forum came again.

He wanted a separate photograph of Subhadra Devi for the article.

Shashikant led him inside.

The secretary looked at the room.

The window was open.

Subhadra Devi sat on the cot cutting betel nut.

There was no certificate of honour on the wall.

Only an old family photograph and a clock hung there.

The secretary asked, "If there were some old cultural object here, the photograph would have greater impact."

Subhadra Devi looked toward the spinning-wheel frame.

"This is here. But not for effect; it is mine."

The secretary smiled.

The photograph was taken.

This time there was no honour plaque behind Subhadra Devi.

When the article was published, it also carried a photograph of the plaque at the gate, but Gauri's eyes stayed on the photograph from inside.

Behind Grandmother, the open window could be seen.

At school, Gauri submitted the plan of the house again.

This time the small room on the eastern side was clearly labelled: "Grandmother's Room."

The teacher made only a small mark of approval beneath it.

Gauri came home and showed the plan to Subhadra Devi.

"Is it right now?"

Subhadra Devi looked at the plan.

"Now the house has come into my map."

Gauri laughed. "Isn't that the other way round?"

"Both."

The rains of Sawan began.

Small water marks started appearing on the honour plaque at the gate.

One day Shashikant said, "We'll have to get another transparent coat put on this plaque, or its shine will fade."

Sudha said, "We'll have it done. What is the hurry?"

At that moment, inside, Subhadra Devi was wiping the frame of her own window.

Ranjan said, "Grandmother, I'll do it."

Subhadra Devi did not hand him the cloth.

"This is my window. Sometimes it feels good to wipe your own things yourself."

The plaque at the gate kept getting wet in the rain.

Inside, in the eastern room, the cot remained open through the night.

The trunk had its place, the spectacles their box, the medicines their shelf.

The household's objects of honour were now divided among different walls and boxes.

For the first time, the main use of one room in the house was not an object, a ceremony, or a guest.

That room belonged to a person.

The Day of Rumour

It was an evening in the middle of Sawan. After a day of sunshine, clouds were gathering in the west, but the rain was still far away.

Most people in Beltoli had already returned home from the fields, the market, and school.

At half past seven in the evening, a message appeared in the village WhatsApp group, 'Our Beltoli.'

The message was short, but its letters were large and bold.

'Tomorrow at eight in the morning there will be an inspection of tap connections. Only the houses with a blue bucket outside will have their names entered in the register. Do not remove the bucket. Forward this so no one's name is left out.'

There was no office name beneath it.

There was no date.

There was nothing to say who had issued it.

But the final line said—'Forward this so no one's name is left out.'

The message first reached Ramvilas Sah's phone.

Ramvilas kept a grocery shop at the square, and he had one number or another for nearly every family in the village.

He read the message and frowned slightly.

'An inspection of tap connections?'

His wife Nirmala, sorting rice, asked, 'Whose taps?'

'It doesn't say.'

'Why a blue bucket?'

Ramvilas read the message again.

Then he thought—if it turned out to be true and he did not forward it, people would say he had withheld the news.

He forwarded the message to the group.

Within five minutes, it had been forwarded nine times.

Within ten minutes, it had reached three separate family groups, two women's groups, the school parents' group, and the milk-collection group.

No one asked, 'Source?'

The first question was—‘Where can we get a blue bucket?’

Beltoli had buckets of every colour—red, green, white, yellow, black.

All at once, a blue bucket ceased to be an object and became an opportunity.

The plastic-goods shop at the square closed at eight at night.

Before eight, five families had reached it.

The shopkeeper Murli had only seven blue buckets left.

‘How many do you want?’ he asked.

‘One.’

‘One for me too.’

‘Give me two. My brother lives away; his house mustn’t be left off the list either.’

Murli brought out all seven buckets.

When the eighth customer arrived, he said, ‘No blue ones left.’

‘Can you bring some by tomorrow?’

‘The inspection is at eight.’

Those who already owned blue buckets suddenly found their houses had become important.

The handle of Kamla Devi’s old blue bucket was half broken.

Two neighbouring families came to ask for it at the same time.

Kamla Devi said, ‘And my own name won’t be entered.’

Both fell silent.

Then one said, ‘You have two earthen pitchers, don’t you? You can manage with those for one night.’

Kamla Devi placed the bucket in her own courtyard.

In the eastern hamlet of the village, there were only three blue buckets.

Someone tied a blue cloth around an old white bucket.

Someone painted a thick blue band over a red bucket with leftover paint from the house.

Someone wrapped a blue plastic sack around a bucket.

By nine at night, blue had spread across the doorways of the village.

Neha, a ninth-class student, was placing a bucket at the door with her father, Manoj.

Neha had read the message twice.

She asked, ‘Babu, who is coming to do this inspection?’

Manoj said, ‘Someone from a department.’

‘Which department?’

‘The water people.’

‘Name?’

Straightening the bucket, Manoj said, ‘You need a name for everything.’

‘There isn’t even a date.’

‘It says tomorrow, doesn’t it?’

‘Was this message written today, or is it an old one?’

Manoj was silent for a few moments.

Then he said, ‘What harm is there in putting it out?’

Neha did not answer that sentence.

At half past nine, a second message appeared in the group.

‘Those who do not have a photocopy of their Aadhaar ready will have their names entered later.’

This time, three folded-hands symbols appeared before the message.

Again, there was nothing to say who had written it.

Ramvilas’s shop had no photocopy machine, and the copy shop at the square had already closed for the night.

People began opening old files at home.

Some looked for copies of Aadhaar, some for ration cards, some for old tap-tax receipts.

Anyone who found nothing asked a neighbour, ‘Can your son make me a photocopy in the morning?’

By ten at night, the inspection of tap connections had changed shape across the village.

It was no longer only a matter of blue buckets.

Documents, numbers, doorways, presence—everything began to be prepared for an invisible inspection team.

Neha opened the group again.

The first message appeared under Ramvilas’s name, but she knew Ramvilas could not have written it.

She sent him a private message—‘Kaka, who sent this to you?’

Ramvilas replied—‘Sanjay.’

When she asked Sanjay, the answer came—‘Deepen sent it to me.’

Deepen wrote—‘It came from the group in my maternal uncle’s village.’

‘Which village?’

For a while, there was no reply.

Neha’s mother said, ‘It’s very late. Put the phone away now.’

Neha put down the phone, but even in sleep she kept seeing the colour of blue buckets.

When Ramvilas woke at five in the morning, the blue bucket outside his door was gone.

He panicked.

Ten minutes later it was found near the neighbour's mango tree. A dog had nudged it and dragged it away in the night.

As soon as news of this small incident spread, people began guarding their buckets.

Someone put a brick inside one.

Someone tied the handle to a post at the doorway with a rope.

Someone placed a slip of paper with the household name inside the bucket.

At six in the morning, the lanes of the village looked strange.

Outside every house stood some vessel or other in blue.

For those who had no real blue bucket, the improvised signs looked brighter from a distance.

Kamla Devi washed and wiped her old bucket and set it at the door.

She usually went for a walk by the pond at six.

That day she did not go.

'If the inspectors come, someone must be at home,' she said.

Two labourers delayed leaving for the fields by half an hour.

The women who delivered milk hurried to the collection point, handed it over, and returned quickly.

Seven schoolchildren were kept at home so that if the inspection team arrived, the adults could be called back from the fields.

At seven, the copy shop at the square opened.

Normally it opened at nine.

The moment its door opened, a queue formed for photocopies.

The shopkeeper, Naveen, asked, 'Which documents?'

The answers varied.

'Aadhaar.'

'Ration card.'

'Should we keep a copy of the bank page too?'

'Someone said a photograph is required.'

Naveen was startled. 'Who said so?'

No one could name anyone for certain.

At half past seven, Neha was dressed in her school uniform and ready.

Manoj said, 'Wait until eight. If the team comes, see them first and then go.'

Neha asked, 'If I don't go, my name will be marked absent.'

Manoj laughed. 'What can one day do?'

Neha looked at the blue bucket by the door.

'In one day, will my name be left out here, or at school?'

Manoj looked at her but did not answer.

Eight o'clock came.

No vehicle appeared on the village's main road.

It was ten past eight.

Ramvilas wrote in the group—'Where is the team? Does anyone know?'

Three thumbs-up symbols appeared, but no answer.

At twenty past eight, someone wrote—'They are checking the southern hamlet first.'

'Who told you?'

'Heard it.'

Someone from the southern hamlet wrote—'They haven't come here.'

At a quarter to nine, a third message spread—'The team will come at ten.'

This time the message said 'confirmed news.'

The source of the confirmed news was missing again.

Manoj did not go to the fields.

Kamla Devi did not go for her walk.

Ramvilas kept his shop half open and kept half his attention on the doorway.

The first school bell rang, but some of Beltoli's children were still at home.

Neha did not listen to her father.

At a quarter to nine, she left for school.

On the way, the blue buckets outside every door looked to her like the same question repeated over and over.

On reaching school, she went straight to Arun Sir, the library teacher.

'Sir, has the school received any notice about an inspection of tap connections?'

Arun Sir shook his head.

'No.'

Neha showed him the message on her phone.

After reading it, Arun Sir's first question was—'Where is the place named?'

'It isn't.'

‘Date?’

‘No.’

‘Department?’

‘No.’

‘Contact?’

‘No.’

Arun Sir said, ‘Then this is less information than fear.’

Neha said, ‘But the whole village believes it.’

Arun Sir looked out of the window.

‘When no one is certain, the easiest thing is to do whatever everyone else is doing.’

He told Neha to go to class, but he himself called the panchayat secretary.

The secretary said, ‘I have received no such notice.’

The coordinator of the water-supply committee said, ‘Nor have I.’

They called the number of the block-level tap-scheme assistant.

The answer came—‘No team has been sent to Beltoli today.’

Arun Sir wrote these four lines and sent them to the group.

The message was read, but the blue buckets did not immediately go indoors.

Ramvilas wrote—‘A team could arrive suddenly from above.’

Someone wrote—‘In government work, the secretary doesn’t know everything.’

Someone else wrote—‘Let’s wait until ten.’

Ten o’clock came.

No team arrived.

At twenty past ten, Neha received Deepen’s reply from the night before—‘It wasn’t my uncle’s village Bishharia; I think it was the group from neighbouring Mejhaulia.’

Neha stopped at the word ‘think.’

With Arun Sir’s help, she called a student named Preeti at the school in Mejhaulia.

Preeti burst out laughing.

‘Blue bucket?’

‘Yes.’

‘That was the sign for the plumber in our western hamlet yesterday.’

Slowly, the story became clear.

In Mejhaulia’s western hamlet, the taps in fourteen houses had been giving little water for three days.

The plumber, Harinarayan, did not want to spend the whole day searching for all fourteen houses.

He had written in the local group—‘If your tap has low water, put a blue bucket outside tomorrow at eight. I’ll enter the names in my register and check the pipes.’

On someone’s phone, the opening line of the message had been cut off—‘If your tap has low water.’

In the next version, ‘I’ became ‘the team.’

In the third, ‘check the pipes’ disappeared.

And a new line was added—‘Forward this so no one’s name is left out.’

After passing through four hands, a local sign meant for fourteen houses became a government rule for all of Beltoli.

The source of the second message about Aadhaar copies turned out to be even more ordinary.

Naveen’s younger brother, who helped at the copy shop, had joked to a friend the night before—‘Keep your Aadhaar with the bucket too; the government will move into your house.’

The friend cut off the first part of the sentence and forwarded it to a group.

When this news reached Beltoli, there was laughter at first.

Then the laughter faded.

Because everyone could see the blue bucket outside their own door.

By afternoon, people began carrying the buckets back inside.

The person who had painted a red bucket blue in the night kept staring at it.

Kamla Devi had missed her walk.

Two labourers had lost half a day’s work.

Seven schoolchildren had been marked absent.

More than forty unnecessary photocopies had been made at the copy shop.

Murli’s seven blue buckets had all been sold.

Someone wanted to blame him.

Murli said, ‘I sold what people asked for. I didn’t make the message.’

Ramvilas said, ‘I only got it from Sanjay.’

Sanjay said, ‘I only got it from Deepen.’

Deepen said, ‘I only got it from my uncle’s village.’

Everyone’s sentence began with ‘I only...’

Neha kept looking through the old messages in the group. She counted: in the first hour the message had been forwarded thirty-four times, but there had not been a single author.

In the evening, people gathered on the veranda of the panchayat building. It was not a formal meeting; after finishing their work, they had come to laugh about the incident, explain themselves, and count one another's mistakes.

Ramvilas said, 'Understand this—I didn't believe it. I forwarded it only so no one's name would be left out.'

Manoj said, 'I didn't trust it either. I put out the bucket only as a precaution.' From a distance, Kamla Devi said, 'For something you didn't trust, I gave up my walk?'

Some people laughed. Manoj laughed too, though his laughter was a little shorter.

Arun Sir gave no speech. He simply wrote four words on the blackboard—'Place. Date. Source. Person responsible.' 'And if those four are missing?' Neha asked. Arun Sir said, 'Then ask first, forward later.'

Ramvilas said, 'And what if it turns out to be true?' Kamla Devi replied, 'A true thing doesn't die because you ask about it.' Laughter rose again on the veranda. This time it was not aimed at anyone else, but at everyone's own haste.

The next day, the village returned to normal. Blue buckets again became ordinary things for bathing, washing clothes, and carrying water. Not one blue bucket remained in Murli's shop, though buckets of other colours were piled high.

At school, Neha wrote the four words on the last page of her notebook—place, date, source, person responsible. Three days later, another message appeared in the 'Our Beltoli' group.

It said—'From tomorrow, electricity will be completely shut off for three days. Finish all essential work today itself.' For ten seconds, no one replied.

Then Ramvilas wrote—'Which supply line?' Neha wrote—'Date?' Manoj wrote—'Source?' Kamla Devi's grandson wrote—'Number of the person responsible?'

Five minutes later, the sender wrote—'Wait, I'm asking.' That evening, nothing was arranged outside any doorway in Beltoli.

But the village's behaviour had changed again. This time, a message had not sent people running; it had taught them to stop and ask questions.

The Topper's Photograph

At the front veranda of Kanakpur High School stood a long wall. Half of it changed from time to time with examination notices, holiday circulars, and meeting dates; the other half remained fixed for gleaming glass frames.

Those frames held photographs of the boys and girls who had secured the highest marks in the school.

At the very centre was a photograph of Rashmi Kumari—white ribbons between her two braids, a fine sheen of sweat on her forehead, and the salwar-kameez she had prepared for Results Day after borrowing an iron from a neighbour's house.

Beneath the photograph, in bold letters, was written: 'Rashmi Kumari—Science—94 per cent.'

Directly opposite that wall, on the other side of the veranda, was a door. In blue paint it read: 'Science Laboratory.'

The paint on the door had faded. The padlock was still strong.

In three months, Naina of Class Nine had memorised the names beneath every photograph on the wall, but she did not know what was inside the laboratory.

In her science book she studied the cells in the thin membrane of an onion, drew diagrams of a microscope, and wrote down the names of mirrors, knobs, and glass slides as the teacher dictated them.

One day she raised her hand and asked, 'Sir, when will we actually look at an onion through the microscope?'

Vinod Sir looked at the clock.

'The laboratory is closed at present.'

'Why?'

'There is no room inside.'

Naina's eyes widened. 'In the laboratory?'

Vinod Sir closed his notebook. 'Yes. Let the class finish.'

After school, Naina went to the laboratory window. In one corner of the mesh, the paper covering had torn. Through the gap, what she could see looked nothing like the laboratory in her textbook.

Cardboard boxes stood on the tables. On one, in black ink, was written: 'Annual Examination 2022.'

Behind it was another: 'Half-Yearly Examination 2023.'

On a sack below was written: 'Old Result Registers.'

Naina pressed her eye to the gap.

'What are you looking at?' Bhola Kaka asked from behind her.

The elderly school attendant stood there with a broom in his hand.

'The laboratory.'

'Through the window?'

'The laboratory is full of examinations.'

Bhola Kaka laughed, then fell silent at once. 'That is well said.'

Naina asked, 'Why are the boxes here?'

Bhola Kaka looked towards the veranda roof. 'There used to be a records room behind the office. Five years ago, the roof began to leak in the rains. The boxes were brought here for three weeks to save the papers.'

'Three weeks?'

'Yes.'

'And they have been here for five years?'

Bhola Kaka began sweeping again. 'Some temporary things in a school learn very quickly how to become permanent.'

Naina looked towards the veranda wall. Beneath Rashmi's photograph, the 94 per cent gleamed.

That week, a notice went up for an 'Alumni Inspiration Day'. Five former students had been invited. Rashmi Kumari's name was first.

Headmaster Shashibhushan Jha told the classes that Rashmi was the pride of the school. She had studied science at the district college and was now working as a trainee at a diagnostic centre.

As soon as the notice went up, cleaning began on the veranda wall of photographs. Bhola Kaka took down the frames and wiped the glass. The '94 per cent' beneath Rashmi's photograph was darkened again in black paint.

The laboratory door remained closed that day as well.

Naina asked Vinod Sir, 'Was the laboratory open in Rashmi Didi's time?'

Vinod Sir said, 'I was not here then.'

'Bhola Kaka says the boxes came five years ago. Rashmi Didi's photograph is seven years old.'

Vinod Sir looked at Naina. 'Then ask her the question yourself.'

On the morning of Inspiration Day, chairs were arranged in the veranda. A white cloth was hung behind the stage. Rashmi's framed

photograph was lowered a little so that it would show clearly in the ceremony photographs.

At ten o'clock, Rashmi arrived.

In the photograph on the wall she was eighteen; now her hair was short, she wore thin-framed spectacles, carried a file of papers under one arm, and held a black bag in her hand.

The headmaster presented her with a small bouquet. 'The pride of the school, back in her school.'

Rashmi smiled. The moment she saw her own photograph on the wall, her smile changed slightly.

'It is still here?'

'Why should it not be?' Shashibhushan Jha said. 'The children draw inspiration from it.'

From a distance Bhola Kaka said, 'It is the photograph from Results Day. Your mother came with sweets.'

Rashmi walked up to the glass frame. 'You still remember?'

Bhola Kaka said, 'When you sweep the same wall every day, you remember the wall's stories.'

The ceremony began. Two speakers spoke about the importance of hard work. One former student described his experience in business. Then Rashmi's name was called.

In his introduction, the headmaster mentioned her 94 per cent three times—in science, in the school, and in the district merit list.

Rashmi stood on the stage. She opened the prepared sheet. She read two lines—about hard work, discipline, and the value of time. Then she folded the paper.

'I want to tell you something that is not written beneath my photograph.'

Naina sat up straight in the front row.

'In my first practical class in college, when the teacher handed me a microscope, I did not know how to adjust it properly.'

A faint murmur ran through the gathering.

Rashmi said, 'My marks were not false. I had studied. I knew how to write the answers. But I had done very few experiments at school. I understood that for the first time in college.'

Vinod Sir listened closely.

'In my time the laboratory did open,' Rashmi continued, 'but not regularly. Sometimes examination boxes arrived there, sometimes materials for a function, sometimes broken benches. Clearing a table before an experiment was itself a task.'

Naina looked at the question she had written at the back of her notebook: 'When will the laboratory open?'

Rashmi said, 'Today I would like to see inside, if I may.'

The headmaster leaned towards the microphone. 'Certainly. After the programme.'

When the programme ended, tea was taken to the office. Naina remained standing in the veranda. She feared that 'after the programme' might come to mean 'sometime later'.

When Rashmi came out, Naina stepped directly in front of her. 'Didi, shall we see the laboratory?'

Rashmi asked, 'Have you ever been inside?'

'No.'

That one word took the last trace of ceremony-smile from Rashmi's face.

The headmaster sent for the key from the office. Bhola Kaka opened the padlock. As soon as the door was pushed inward, it struck a box with a thud.

Four people together shifted the first box aside. Only then did the door open fully.

There were three tables inside, but their use had changed their names. One had become 'Answer Scripts', another 'Examination Materials', and the third 'Old Registers'.

In the glass cupboard against the wall, microscopes, glass vessels, measuring cylinders, and small pieces of science apparatus were still there. The objects had not disappeared; they had merely been buried behind the boxes.

Naina read the year on the first box—2021. The second—2022. The third—2023. Then she began recalling the years beneath the photographs on the wall.

'Sir,' she asked the headmaster, 'every year a new photograph went up on the wall. And every year a new box came in here?'

Before Shashibhushan Jha could reply, clerk Mahendra Babu said, 'Not every box can simply be thrown away.'

'Who said anything about throwing them away?' Vinod Sir asked.

Mahendra Babu opened the file he had brought with him. 'Some answer scripts have to be retained for a fixed period. Some result registers are permanent. Some examination papers may be disposed of according to rules after their retention period ends. The problem is that everything has been kept as though every box were the same.'

Rashmi asked, 'In five years, were they never sorted?'

Mahendra Babu looked slightly uncomfortable. 'At first the records-room roof was not repaired. Later the office ran short of space. Then the next examination came.'

Bhola Kaka said, 'The boxes could not go anywhere, but the years certainly kept moving on.'

Naina drew a line with her finger through the dust on top of one box.

Rashmi said, 'To me this is not only about a locked laboratory. The papers recording results are occupying the very place where science is supposed to be done.'

The headmaster looked at her. 'The papers are necessary.'

'Yes,' Rashmi said at once. 'That is precisely why sorting is necessary. What must be preserved should have a proper place. What has completed its retention period should be dealt with according to the rules. But calling everything "necessary" and letting it keep growing in the same room is not a solution.'

Vinod Sir opened the laboratory cupboard. He took out a microscope. A thin film of dust lay on its mirror, but the instrument seemed sound.

Naina stepped a little closer. 'Will we see the onion today?'

Vinod Sir smiled. 'First let the table become visible today.'

No experiment was conducted that day.

But the laboratory door was not immediately locked again.

In the afternoon Mahendra Babu returned with a list of examination records. Shashibhushan Jha, Vinod Sir, Bhola Kaka, Rashmi, and two other teachers began matching the years and contents written on the boxes.

No papers were thrown away. First, three categories were made: permanent records, papers to be retained for a specified period, and materials whose retention period had ended and on which a decision had to be taken according to rules.

Behind the old school library stood an empty metal cupboard. The librarian said the top two shelves could be given to records, provided the list remained clear.

A narrow metal rack in the office veranda was also cleared. The permanent result registers were arranged there in order.

For materials whose retention period had ended, it was decided that the list would first be placed before the school committee. Not a single page was removed without a decision.

The work continued for two days. Slowly, the laboratory tables began to recover their old shape.

On the second day Naina noticed that when the cardboard box marked 2023 was removed, a clean rectangular mark remained on the tabletop. Dust lay all around it; in the middle was a pale rectangle.

‘Is this history too?’ she asked Bhola Kaka.

Bhola Kaka said, ‘Yes, but not the kind worth putting in a frame.’

On the third day Vinod Sir called ten students from Class Nine into the laboratory.

The tables were clean. The windows were open. The contents of the glass cupboard had been counted and arranged again.

‘No one will take photographs today,’ Vinod Sir said.

The students laughed.

The first experiment was very simple—a thin onion membrane, a clean glass slide, a drop of water, and a microscope.

Naina turned the mirror towards the light. At first she saw darkness. Then a blurred glow. When she slowly turned the focusing knob, the fine network of cells emerged.

Naina suddenly fell silent.

‘Can you see it?’ the student behind her asked.

Without lifting her eye she said, ‘Smaller than the picture in the book... but I am seeing it with my own eyes.’

Vinod Sir said, ‘Now let someone else see.’

At the end of the experiment that day, Vinod Sir opened a new register. Its title was: ‘Laboratory Use Register.’ Date, class, experiment, materials used, teacher’s name.

Naina asked, ‘Will this paper fill the laboratory again?’

Everyone laughed.

Vinod Sir said, ‘No. This register will keep account of why the room is being kept clear.’

A month later, the last period on Wednesdays and Fridays came to be called the practical period. There was not an experiment every time; sometimes instruments were checked, sometimes samples prepared, sometimes an earlier experiment discussed. But the door no longer stayed shut merely because of examination boxes.

One day Rashmi came again. This time there was no ceremony. She had come to visit her mother, and so she stopped by the school.

Her photograph was still at the centre of the veranda wall. The lettering of 94 per cent was still dark.

Naina led her towards the laboratory.

There was a yellow stain from turmeric solution on a table. In one corner was a round mark where water had spilled. The glassware in the

cupboard stood in order. No examination boxes remained against the back wall.

Rashmi turned the pages of the use register. Naina's name appeared three times—onion cells, leaf stomata, solubility.

‘And how much is your 94 per cent?’ Rashmi asked with a laugh.

Naina said, ‘The results have not even come yet.’

‘Then what will you measure?’

Naina looked at the microscope. ‘First I will learn to see this properly. Marks can come later.’

Rashmi looked once more at her own photograph on the wall. ‘Do you feel like taking that photograph down?’ Naina asked. Rashmi thought for a moment. ‘No. It is a truth from that time. I got those marks—that is true too. I did too few experiments—that is also true. Why should one truth erase the other?’

The school bell rang for dismissal. Students began pouring out. Some children stopped before Rashmi's photograph, looked at her standing there in person, then looked back at the photograph. Bhola Kaka was sweeping the veranda. He said, ‘Even the wall seems changed now.’ Rashmi asked, ‘New paint?’ ‘No. The door opposite stays open.’ Rashmi turned to look.

The laboratory door stood open. Inside, Vinod Sir was showing two students how to wash glassware. Evening light fell slantwise through the window. On the veranda wall Rashmi's photograph was still fixed in the same old smile, but in its glass there was no longer a reflection of piled examination boxes; instead, the small moving figures of children inside the open laboratory kept passing through it from time to time.

The Cleanest House

As Sawan drew toward its close, a new announcement was made in Bishahariya panchayat: a “Cleanest House” competition. A white notice was pasted on the wall of the panchayat building, slips were handed to the schoolchildren, and an announcement over the microphone said that homes would be inspected three days later.

The prize was not very large—a brass water pot, two fruit-tree saplings, and a certificate from the panchayat. But it was the second line of the announcement that stayed more firmly in people’s minds: “A photograph of the winning house will remain displayed in the panchayat building for one year.”

The moment Sarita Devi read the slip, she said, “This time our house ought to be on that list.”

Her husband, Devanath, smiled. “The house is already clean.”

Resting the handle of her broom against the wall, Sarita said, “There is a difference between clean and the cleanest.”

Her mother-in-law, Hemkali Devi, seated in a corner of the courtyard, heard this and laughed. “Does being the cleanest come with a different kind of dust?”

Sarita did not answer. From that moment her eyes began to notice things in the house she had never paid attention to before—the cobweb on a bamboo of the roof, dry leaves behind the tulsi altar, three broken earthen bowls in a corner of the veranda, a thin film of soot above the hearth, an old rope from the cattle shed, and a heap of half-broken bricks by the entrance.

When her twelve-year-old daughter Neetu returned from school, she brought another copy of the notice.

“Ma, they will inspect five things—the courtyard, water drainage, the toilet, separation of waste, and where the waste is disposed of.”

Sarita took the slip and read it. She paused slightly at the last line, then said at once, “First make the house shine.”

The next morning Devanath returned from the market with two new brooms, lime, and a small tin of blue paint. The lower wood of the gate was painted again. Old stains on the veranda wall were covered. Neetu and her younger brother Sonu kept bringing out old papers, empty oil packets, torn slippers, bits of wire, and broken toys one after another.

By noon, five heaps had formed in the middle of the courtyard.

Hemkali Devi asked, "Where will all this go?"

Devanath said, "We'll give it to Lalita when she comes."

Lalita went from hamlet to hamlet collecting household waste. Her cart carried two sacks—one for dry waste, the other for wet. The panchayat had also given her a register in which each household's name and the mark for collected waste were entered.

That day it was nearly evening by the time Lalita was due to arrive. By then the heaps in the courtyard had begun to trouble Sarita's eyes.

"The inspectors may start making rounds early tomorrow," she said. "What will they see if these heaps are lying at the door?"

Devanath said, "Lalita will come."

But the evening darkness deepened, and the bell of Lalita's cart was not heard.

Neetu sat with her book open. Sarita kept looking toward the courtyard again and again. At last she picked up an old basket.

"Beyond the bamboo fence at the back, Jaykali Kaki's field is empty. Put it there for two days. Once the inspection is over, we'll give it to Lalita."

Neetu looked up. "Did you ask Kaki?"

Sarita said, "We are only putting it there, not building a house on it."

Devanath said nothing at first. Then he lifted the basket. "Only the dry waste."

There was a gap between two bamboos in one place along the fence. Through that opening, Devanath emptied the baskets one by one into the fallow field of their neighbour, Jaykali Devi. Empty packets, torn paper, plastic bags, a broken slipper, bits of glass mixed with ash, and short pieces of old rope spread across the soil.

Sarita called from behind him, "Keep it in one place. Don't scatter it."

Devanath gathered the heap together with his foot. "We'll pick it up tomorrow."

Neetu stood by the fence. The field did not look "empty" to her. Jaykali Kaki had sown sunn hemp there two weeks earlier. Tender green stems were rising through the soil.

"There is sunn hemp here," Neetu said.

With a trace of irritation, Devanath replied, "I've put it along the edge, not among the crop."

It did not pour that night, but a fine rain fell. By morning some pieces of paper had slipped from the heap into the rows of sunn hemp.

Jaykali Devi came to inspect the field in the morning. She carried a small hand hoe. The moment she saw the coloured packets from a distance, she stopped.

She picked up one packet. It bore the stamp of the shop whose oil Sarita's household used. Sonu's name was also written on a torn page from a notebook.

Jaykali looked toward the fence. On the other side Sarita was mixing lime.

Their eyes met once.

Sarita said at once, "Kaki, we have kept it there only for two days. We'll remove it as soon as the inspection is over."

Jaykali folded the page in her hand. "I thought the wind might have brought it."

"No, it belongs to us."

"Then that is good. It is good to recognise what belongs to one's own house."

Saying only that, Jaykali walked farther into the field. She picked up two pieces of glass and placed them by the bamboo shelter. She left the paper and plastic where they were.

Sarita found that silence more uncomfortable than a scolding.

That day the cleaning grew even more vigorous. The toilet wall was washed. Leaves clogging the small drain were removed. Fresh earth was packed around the tulsi altar. The shoes by the gate went inside. Even an old sack used every day was put away in a room, out of sight.

Hemkali Devi said, "Are we cleaning the house, or hiding the things the house actually uses?"

Sarita laughed. "It's only for three days."

At noon Lalita arrived with her cart.

"Waste?" she called from the gate.

Sarita came out. "There's nothing today."

Lalita looked toward the courtyard. "You didn't give me anything yesterday either."

"We cleaned everything out."

Lalita smiled faintly. "If you cleaned everything out, where did the waste that came out go?"

Before Sarita could answer, Sonu called from inside, "Behind—"

Neetu shot him a look. Sonu stopped.

Sarita said, "We have separated some old things. We'll give them tomorrow."

In her register, opposite Sarita's household name, Lalita once again drew a small empty circle. "All right. Call me when there is something."

She moved on.

Neetu asked her mother, “Why is there an empty circle in the register?”

“Because we didn’t give anything.”

“Will the inspectors look at the register?”

Wringing the wet cloth in her hands, Sarita said, “They will inspect the house. Nobody looks at every register.”

Hemkali Devi had been listening from the veranda. Quietly she said, “A thing does not disappear simply because its account is not inspected.”

On the evening of the third day, two panchayat volunteers came to tell them the inspection time—ten o’clock the next morning. With them was Rekha Jha, the school’s science teacher, because her name was on the competition’s evaluation team.

Rekha Jha handed Sarita a copy of the notice. “We will also look at the arrangement for separating waste.”

Sarita immediately placed two empty buckets by the entrance—one marked “wet” in charcoal, the other “dry.”

Neetu noticed that both buckets were completely empty.

After dinner that night, Devanath said, “Shall we pick up the heap in the field early tomorrow?”

Sarita remained silent for a moment. “If we bring it back now, the waste will be visible near the house again. After the inspection.”

“Did Jaykali Kaki say anything?”

“No.”

“Then leave it.”

Neetu kept mixing the rice on her plate. Jaykali’s sentence returned to her: “It is good to recognise what belongs to one’s own house.”

At dawn Sarita sprinkled water across the courtyard. She made a white lime border. Not a single leaf remained under the neem tree. The sweeping extended all the way beyond the gate.

At ten o’clock the evaluation team arrived: panchayat member Chandresh, Rekha Jha, health assistant Manju, and two school students, one of whom was Neetu’s classmate Savita.

Standing at the gate, Chandresh said, “Very good.”

Sarita’s face lit up.

The team inspected the courtyard, the drainage, and the toilet. Manju lifted the lids of the buckets. “Both empty?”

Sarita said, “There has been no waste this morning.”

Savita burst out laughing. Rekha Jha signalled her to be quiet.

“And yesterday’s waste?” Rekha Jha asked.

Sarita paused for a moment. "We disposed of it."

"Where?"

"To the collector."

Neetu's heart began to pound.

At that very moment the bell of Lalita's cart sounded outside. She was carrying waste from another house. Chandresh called her over.

"Lalita, was waste collected from this house?"

Lalita opened her register. "Not for three days."

The brightness vanished from Sarita's face in an instant. Devanath stood by a pillar of the veranda.

Chandresh looked at them questioningly.

Sarita said quickly, "It was old material. We have kept it temporarily behind the house. We'll give it after the inspection."

Rekha Jha asked, "Behind the house where?"

No one answered.

Neetu looked toward the fence. Just then a gust of wind rose. Above the bamboo fence, the corner of a white sheet of paper fluttered into view.

Savita said, "There?"

The team went to the fence. Through the gap between the bamboos, the field was clearly visible. Coloured waste lay scattered among the green rows of sunn hemp. The rain had spread the heap wider.

Chandresh said nothing. Manju only took a deep breath.

Sarita hurried to say, "This is Jaykali Kaki's fallow field. Just for two days—"

"It is not fallow," a voice came from behind them.

Jaykali Devi was coming from the far side of the field. In her hand she carried the small box in which she had kept the pieces of glass that day.

"I have sown sunn hemp," she said as she came closer. "And even if it were fallow, a field is not a rubbish bin."

Devanath lowered his eyes.

Chandresh said, "Why didn't you make a complaint?"

Jaykali replied, "The competition lasts three days. Neighbourhood lasts for years. I thought I would first let these three days pass."

For a moment after that, no one said anything.

Rekha Jha looked at her evaluation sheet. Courtyard—ten out of ten. Drainage—nine out of ten. Toilet—ten out of ten. Waste separation—two empty buckets. Waste disposal—her pen stopped beside that line.

She asked Chandresh, "How do we score this line?"

Chandresh said, "Improper disposal—zero."

Rekha Jha shook her head. "This is not a question about only this house. Our form is incomplete too. We ask whether a house is clean; we do not ask where that cleanliness becomes somebody else's dirt."

Lalita closed her register. "Mine too only records whether I collected waste or not. It says nothing about where a household dumped it on its own."

For the first time Sarita looked at the two empty buckets. They no longer seemed clean to her. They seemed empty.

Through the gap in the fence Neetu saw the notebook page with Sonu's name on it. The ink had spread in the night rain.

The evaluation team did not go immediately to the next house. A half-hour meeting was held at the panchayat building. The competition was not cancelled, but the result was postponed for a week. Every house would be checked again with one additional question: "Where does the household waste go?"

When the news spread through the village, people reacted in different ways.

Someone said, "If there are this many rules, what is the point of holding a competition?"

Someone laughed, "Cleaning your own house isn't difficult. Finding a neighbour's field is."

Someone mocked Sarita by name.

For two days Sarita went out through the gate less often. It was not the lost prize that hurt so much as people's laughter.

On the third morning Jaykali came to the gate.

"Come," she said.

Sarita did not understand. "Where?"

"The field. Waste does not walk back by itself."

Sarita picked up a basket. Devanath came too. Neetu and Sonu followed behind.

Jaykali had already made four heaps in the field—dry leaves and ash, glass and metal, plastic, and things that could be used again.

"I'll keep this old rope," she said. "It will be useful for training a bottle gourd vine."

Hemkali Devi also arrived slowly. The moment she saw the pieces of the broken earthen bowl, she said, "This could have become a flowerpot."

Sarita held a shard of the bowl in her hand. On the first day of the competition she had separated that very object as "waste."

It took three hours. The glass and metal were given to Lalita. The plastic went into a separate sack. For leaves, ash, and kitchen matter that

could rot, a small compost pit was dug behind the house, within their own boundary. Things that could be used again were kept separately.

When the work was finished, Chandresh came to take a photograph.

Jaykali raised her hand and stopped him. "Not today."

Chandresh was surprised. "Why?"

"There was no photograph when the waste was thrown here. There is no need for one on the day it is picked up either. See whatever there is when you come for the competition inspection."

Chandresh put his phone back into his pocket.

Sarita smiled for the first time. There was embarrassment in the smile, but relief too.

A week later the inspection was held again. This time Sarita's courtyard did not gleam as it had before. The lid of the compost pit was plainly visible in one corner. A bamboo basket for dry waste stood inside the entrance. Lalita's register contained two collection dates.

In Jaykali's field, the sunn hemp was standing upright again. There were rain spots on a few leaves, but no coloured scraps of plastic.

The evaluation team spoke very little this time.

On the day the result was announced, Sarita's house did not come first. It did not come third either. The certificate went to another household, where kitchen waste had been composted for months and dry waste was regularly handed to Lalita.

Sonu was disappointed. "We worked so hard, and still no prize?"

Sarita stroked his head. "The first time we worked to make the house look right. The second time we worked to understand the house."

Hemkali Devi said, "At least this time we understood where the dust went."

In her school notebook, Neetu wrote a short piece about the competition. She wrote: "The boundary of a house may end at the wall; the boundary of its waste does not end there."

Rekha Jha circled the sentence in red ink, but did not write "Very good." In the margin she added only one question: "Then where does the boundary end?"

On the next page Neetu wrote her answer: "Wherever something we throw away can still alter another person's life."

A few weeks later the "Cleanest House" notice rotted in the rain and fell from the gate. Sarita picked it up and placed it in the basket for dry paper.

That morning the bell of Lalita's cart sounded. Sarita brought out the dry waste. Lalita entered the date in her register.

Beyond the fence, Jaykali was cutting the sunn hemp. She looked up once toward Sarita. Sarita raised a hand in greeting. Jaykali raised hers too.

Two or three dry leaves had fallen in the courtyard again. Sarita noticed them, but she did not immediately run for the broom. First she put the empty basket back in its proper place inside the gate. Then she picked up the broom.

The Felicitation Ceremony

It was a bright evening in Kartik. For two days, strings of coloured paper pennants had been going up along the veranda of the Belahi panchayat building.

Above the doorway hung a large cloth banner that read, "Public Service Felicitation Ceremony."

Five names were printed below it.

The first four names were correct.

The fifth read, "Harinandan Jha — Village Postal Service, Forty Years."

Raju, the young man hanging the banner, noticed nothing unusual in the name.

He tightened the rope and climbed down.

Panchayat secretary Ramakant Babu looked at the banner from a distance and said, "The letters are clear. The evening photographs will come out well."

No one read the names aloud again.

The man who was to be honoured was named Harinarayan Jha.

He was the village's old postal worker.

For forty years his work had been to deliver letters to houses that had neither house numbers nor street names.

If an address said only, "Jagdish, son of Rameshwar Jha, western hamlet," he would still get there.

Even "Shakuntala Devi, Belahi, near the pond" was enough to lead him to the right door.

If two people had the same name, he remembered the father's name, occupation, direction of the house, even the style of the sender's handwriting.

A joke ran through the village: "The post office may forget, but Harinarayan Kaka does not."

He had retired from service three years earlier.

Now he walked along the field embankments in the morning, sorted old papers in the afternoon, and sat on the veranda chatting with people in the evening.

He had received news of the felicitation three days earlier.

The panchayat youth committee had sent an invitation to his house.

The invitation said only, "Respected Sir, it has been decided to honour you for your long public service."

His name had not been written in by hand.

Harinarayan turned the card over and over.

"Where is my name?"

The young man laughed.

"Kaka, who here does not know you?"

Harinarayan laughed too.

"If everyone knows me, that is all the more reason to write it."

The young man took this for an old postman's habit and let the matter pass.

On the day of the ceremony, Harinarayan put on a freshly washed white kurta.

He strapped his old watch to his wrist.

His granddaughter Meera said, "Kaka, take your phone."

Harinarayan said, "At a felicitation, am I going to use a phone or receive the honour?"

Meera laughed and put the phone in her own bag.

The two walked to the panchayat building.

At the entrance, five paper name cards lay on the reception table.

The volunteers checked each guest's name and showed them to their seats.

Harinarayan said, "I have been invited."

One volunteer looked at the list.

"Name?"

"Harinarayan Jha."

Her finger moved down the page.

Once from top to bottom.

Then a second time.

"There is no Harinarayan."

Meera stared.

"Look at the list of those being honoured."

The volunteer opened another sheet.

"There is Harinandan Jha—village postal service."

Harinarayan gave a slight smile.

"Then seat Harinandan in front."

The volunteer did not understand.

Meera said softly, "There is a mistake here. Kaka is Harinarayan."

The volunteer immediately crossed out "nandan" in pencil and wrote "narayan."

"Done."

Harinarayan looked at the sheet.

"It is done on this page. Where else is it written?"

Before the volunteer could answer, the crowd behind them thickened.

She folded her hands and said, "Kaka, please sit inside first. We will check later."

Five chairs in the front row of the hall had name cards on them.

Four honourees sat in the chairs bearing their names.

The fifth chair read, "Harinandan Jha."

Meera picked up the card and showed it to Sonu, the secretary's assistant.

Sonu laughed. "Oh, it is only a mistake in the name."

Harinarayan went and sat in an empty chair in an ordinary row at the back.

Sonu hurried over.

"Kaka, please come to the front."

"That chair belongs to Harinandan."

"I will change it."

"Change it. Then I will sit."

Sonu turned the card over and wrote "Harinarayan Jha" on the back with a pen, then placed it on the chair.

Harinarayan rose and sat in the front.

Meera looked up at the main banner hanging over the stage.

It too said Harinandan.

She pointed it out to Sonu.

This time Sonu did not laugh.

"That has already been printed."

"Cover it."

"The banner will look bad."

"Will the wrong name look good?"

Sonu had no answer.

Five minutes remained before the ceremony began.

The chief guest, an officer from the block office, arrived.

A garland was placed around his neck.

Photographs were taken.

The microphone was tested.

Secretary Ramakant Babu sat on the stage with the programme sheet open before him.

Meera went up to him.

"Babu, Kaka's name has been printed incorrectly."

Ramakant Babu pushed up his spectacles and looked at her.

"Where?"

"On the main banner. It was on the chair card. It was on the list."

Ramakant Babu looked at the programme sheet.

There too it read, "Shri Harinandan Jha."

His brow tightened slightly.

"Have you seen the certificate?" Meera asked.

Ramakant Babu immediately pointed toward the small office room.

"Sonu, bring the fifth certificate."

A thick sheet in a red frame was brought out.

In the centre, in golden letters, it read, "Shri Harinandan Jha."

The description below was correct: "For forty years of devoted public service in Belahi village postal service."

Ramakant Babu scratched his head.

"How did this happen?"

Sonu said, "Everything was printed from the list that went to the press."

"Who made the list?"

"The youth committee."

Vikas, the youth committee coordinator, was called.

Vikas was arranging a tray of flowers behind the stage.

As soon as he saw the paper, he said, "I had written Harinarayan."

"Where had you written it?"

"On the nomination slip."

The slip was searched for.

A folded paper came out of the file.

It clearly said, "Harinarayan Jha."

Ramakant Babu asked, "Then who typed it?"

Sonu fell silent.

Vikas fell silent.

Pawan, who operated the computer, was contacted by phone.

From home he said, "I typed the five names exactly as they were sent to me on the phone."

"Who sent the message?"

"Sonu Bhaiya."

All eyes turned to Sonu.

Sonu opened his phone.

He found the three-day-old message.

It said, "Harinandan Jha."

Sonu lowered his head. "I did not type it from the slip. Vikas Bhaiya had told me the name over the phone. I heard it and sent it on."

Vikas said at once, "I said Harinarayan."

Sonu said, "I heard Harinandan."

Ramakant Babu looked at the clock.

The chief guest was already seated on the stage.

The audience was growing.

"We will trace the cause later," he said. "First, correct it."

Someone suggested pasting a white strip over the certificate and writing the correct name on it.

It was decided to paste a paper strip over the main banner as well.

The announcer would read the correct name from the programme sheet.

"That is enough," Ramakant Babu said. "Everything is fixed."

Meera asked, "And the news sent to the press and the reporters?"

Ramakant Babu went silent.

A short notice about the ceremony had already been sent to two local correspondents.

That too named Harinandan Jha.

One correspondent was sitting in the last row of the hall.

He had already copied the same name into his notebook.

Ramakant Babu beckoned him over.

"Make the fifth name Harinarayan Jha."

The correspondent asked, "Why was it wrong before?"

Ramakant Babu said, "A printing error."

Harinarayan sat in the front chair, watching and listening to all of it.

No one had yet asked him directly what his name was.

Everyone was correcting his name, while the person himself sat silent in the middle of the correction.

Meera bent toward him. "Kaka, will you say something?"

Harinarayan said, "For now, let us see whether Harinarayan reaches the stage."

The ceremony began.

There was a welcome address.

The panchayat's development work was discussed.

The first felicitation went to an elderly schoolteacher.

The second to a midwife.

The third to a weaver.

The fourth to the coordinator of a pond-cleaning team.

Each time, the name was read clearly.

A garland was placed.

A shawl was presented.

The certificate was handed over.

A photograph was taken.

When the fifth honour was announced, the announcer looked down at the programme sheet.

It still had Harinandan printed on it.

Along the margin, Ramakant Babu had written "Narayan" in blue ink.

The announcer faltered for a moment.

Then he said, "We now invite Shri Harinarayan Jha to the stage in recognition of forty years of service in the village postal service."

The hall broke into applause.

Harinarayan rose.

As he reached the front of the stage, his eyes went to the main banner.

A long strip of white paper had been pasted over the wrong name.

In black letters written by hand, it said, "Harinarayan Jha."

The edges of the old printed letters were still visible on both sides underneath.

The chief guest lifted the shawl.

Harinarayan folded his hands.

A garland was placed around his neck.

Then, when it was time to present the certificate, Sonu became a little nervous.

A white strip had been pasted over the certificate too.

The correct name was written on the strip, but one or two letters of "Harinandan" still peeped out from beneath the golden print.

Harinarayan took the certificate in his hands.

He did not immediately raise it for the photograph.

He read it first.

The chief guest smiled. "The name is correct now, isn't it?"

A few people in the hall laughed.

Harinarayan smiled too.

"It is correct on top now."

The chief guest looked at him questioningly.

The announcer said, "Kaka should say a few words."

Harinarayan went to the microphone.

He had prepared no speech.

He placed the certificate on the table.

"I delivered letters for forty years," he began. "If a name on a letter was wrong, sometimes the letter still reached the right house because the village was small. But I never corrected a name from my own head."

The hall grew quiet.

"First I asked: Is this so-and-so's letter? Who should receive it? Sometimes a single letter changes the person."

Ramakant Babu straightened in his chair.

Harinarayan continued, "The story printed on the honour I received today is correct—forty years of postal service. But another man's name was printed on it. That means the work was mine, the person was someone else."

A few people laughed again, but this time the laughter was smaller.

"Mistakes happen," Harinarayan said. "I have made them too. Once I mixed up the letters of two Ramji Yadavs. I realised it in the evening and walked another four kos to exchange them. There is less shame in a mistake if the correction reaches the right place."

He looked toward the main banner.

"A paper has been pasted there. Good. The certificate too. But correct the list from which all this was made. Correct the news as well. Keep the right name in the records. Otherwise next year Harinandan may be honoured all over again."

This time the hall laughed openly.

Harinarayan laughed too.

Then he stepped away from the microphone.

The speech had not lasted even two minutes, but after the programme it was discussed more than anything else.

The photographer stopped him and said, "Kaka, hold the certificate a little higher."

Harinarayan raised it.

The white correction strip was clearly visible.

The photographer said, "That strip shows too much. Cover it with your hand."

Harinarayan asked, "Why?"

"The photograph will look better."

"Is the mistake ugly, or the correction?"

The photographer had no answer.

Meera laughed.

Harinarayan kept holding the certificate as it was.

The photograph was taken.

When the ceremony ended, people moved toward the tea and pakoras.

Behind the stage, Sonu began peeling the white correction strip off the main banner.

Harinarayan noticed.

"Why are you taking that down?"

"The banner is of no further use. It will be thrown away."

"Give me the paper with the correct name."

Sonu stared.

"This?"

"Yes."

Sonu peeled the paper off carefully.

The edge tore slightly because of the glue.

Harinarayan did not fold it. He handed it to Meera.

"Keep it flat in the bag."

On the way home, Meera asked, "Kaka, why did you keep the paper pasted over the wrong banner?"

Harinarayan said, "I do not want the wrong name. But I want to remember how the right name came back."

After dinner that night, he opened his old postal box.

A few things from his service years remained inside—an old stamp, a bundle of red thread, two covers from undelivered letters, his retirement paper, and a small notebook in which he had written how to distinguish people who shared the same name.

"Ramji Yadav—southern hamlet—red gate."

"Ramji Yadav—near the bamboo grove—son Suresh."

"Shanti Devi—old pond—husband late Damodar."

Harinarayan placed the correction strip between the pages of that notebook.

Meera asked, "And the wrong certificate?"

Harinarayan looked at the certificate.

“This is no longer wrong. The correct name is on top. But the old letters underneath are still showing. That is all right too.”

The next day at the panchayat office, Vikas placed the original nomination slip, the typed list, and the news copy on the table together.

Looking at the message on Sonu’s phone, he typed the correct name again.

Ramakant Babu said, “Let us make one rule now—before printing, the name of every person being honoured must be read back and confirmed by that person or someone in the family.”

Vikas asked, “Every time?”

Ramakant Babu looked at the cloth banner that had been taken down.

“Every time.”

A new list was not printed.

On the old sheet, the wrong name was struck through in black ink, the correct name written above it, and the date added beside it.

The correspondent corrected his report and sent it again.

He wrote, “Shri Harinarayan Jha was honoured for his service in the village post.”

The incident of the wrong name did not appear in the report.

Three days later, the photograph appeared in a local newspaper.

Harinarayan stood wrapped in the shawl, holding the certificate.

The white correction strip was visible even in the small photograph.

At the tea stall in the square, someone said, “The certificate looks a little untidy in the photograph.”

Blowing on his tea, Harinarayan said, “The name looks good.”

The people at the stall laughed.

A week later, Rajesh, the newly appointed postman, came to his house.

He was carrying a government envelope.

The envelope said, “Harinarayan Jha, Belahi.”

Rajesh said, “Kaka, there was no house number, but as soon as I saw the name, I knew.”

Harinarayan took the envelope in his hand.

“You read it first?”

“Yes.”

“Read it correctly?”

Rajesh laughed. “Who would dare misread your name these days?”

Harinarayan laughed too.

Before opening the envelope, he looked at the name once more.

The letters were ordinary black.
No golden frame.
No garland.
No stage.
But this time, the name was right.

The Anti-Cheating Speech

In the first week of Phagun, a new cloth banner was hung over the main gate of Kalyanpur High School.

In bold letters it read: "Cheating-Free Examination Week."

Beneath the banner, two students stood holding a bamboo ladder steady.

Clerk Aniruddh Jha, perched above, was tightening the rope.

On the veranda, Headmaster Shambhunath Mishra was looking over the programme schedule.

The half-yearly examinations were to begin the following Monday.

The district office had instructed the school to hold an anti-cheating awareness programme before the examinations.

Shambhunath Babu did not want it to become a mere formality.

He said, "This time, do not merely frighten the children. Make them understand the reason."

Nirmal Jha, the school's Hindi-Maithili teacher, was given responsibility for the main address.

Nirmal Jha was known for discipline.

If he saw anyone's answer sheet tilted toward another student during an examination, he would call out the name from across the room.

Two years earlier, when a small slip of paper had been found in the pocket of a Class Nine student, he had had the entire examination cancelled.

So "the anti-cheating speech" seemed a natural assignment for him.

Nirmal Babu smiled when he heard of it.

"Ten minutes?"

The headmaster said, "Up to twelve. Keep it worth listening to for the children."

Nirmal Babu said, "The point is simple enough. Work hard. Do not cheat."

"It is difficult to say a simple thing well," Shambhunath Babu replied.

Nirmal Babu folded the schedule and slipped it into his pocket.

After school that day, he had to attend a block-level training session.

There was an inspection the next day.

On the third day, guests were due at his home.
Thinking he would find time for the speech later, he left.
The school also had a small literary circle.
Anupama, Ranjan and Salma of Class Ten were members of it.
They were asked to prepare a wall magazine for Anti-Cheating Week.
The librarian, Chandrakala Devi, gave all three a clear rule.
“Wherever you take an idea from, write the name of the source.”
Ranjan asked, “Even if it is only two lines?”
Chandrakala Devi said, “Two lines or two pages—if the thought is not yours, show the road it came by.”
Anupama looked through old magazines.
Salma selected a few points from a book on education.
Ranjan opened the internet on the school computer.
The connection was very slow.
A single page took so long to open that Ranjan went off twice to drink water while waiting.
Whatever the three found useful, they wrote down in their notebooks.
Alongside it, they also recorded the source.
Anupama stopped at one sentence.
It said: “Cheating may give you an answer, but it will not make you a friend of the question.”
She said, “That is good.”
Chandrakala Devi replied, “Then write the source below it.”
On the wall magazine, the name of the webpage was written in small letters beneath the sentence.
Elsewhere Anupama wrote a sentence of her own: “Calling an answer mine when I do not understand it does not increase my knowledge.”
There was no source beneath that line.
Ranjan laughed and asked, “Shall I put your name under this one?”
Anupama said, “No. It is a wall magazine, not my autobiography.”
On Saturday evening, Nirmal Babu remembered the speech.
He had returned tired from the training session.
After dinner he opened a sheet of paper on the table.
He wrote the first line: “Dear students...”
Then his pen stopped.
He wondered how many times one could say “Do not cheat” over twelve minutes.
Then he picked up his phone.
On the internet he searched for “speech on the harms of cheating.”

A number of articles on the same subject appeared.

Some were for students, some for teachers, some for colleges.

Nirmal Babu opened one page.

It had five points in sequence.

A second page contained a story-like example.

A third had several sentences about education and honesty.

He began copying them quickly onto paper.

He changed a few words.

He translated some sentences into Maithili.

Some he paraphrased almost as they stood.

Between them he inserted his own forms of address: "Children, remember..."

Within forty minutes, a five-page speech was ready.

He looked at the pages and breathed with relief.

"Done."

For a moment, the thought of noting the sources crossed his mind.

Then he told himself this was a speech, not a research paper.

He folded the pages and put them in his bag.

On Monday, all the classes assembled in the school prayer ground.

Two tables had been joined together in front to make a small stage.

Behind it, the banner reading "Cheating-Free Examination Week" fluttered in the wind.

To the right of the stage hung the students' wall magazine.

From a distance, Anupama could see the line she had written.

The headmaster gave the opening remarks.

He spoke about the effect cheating has on marks, confidence and learning.

Then Nirmal Jha was called to speak.

There was applause.

Nirmal Babu stood before the microphone.

He adjusted his glasses and opened the first page.

"Dear students, cheating is not merely breaking a rule; it is a lack of faith in your own intelligence."

The ground fell quiet.

Nirmal Babu's voice was clear.

He moved on: point one, point two, point three.

Anupama listened closely.

At one point, her eyebrow rose.

Nirmal Babu said, "Cheating may give you an answer, but it will not make you a friend of the question."

Ranjan immediately looked toward the wall magazine.

Salma lightly pressed Anupama's arm.

The three looked at one another.

On the wall magazine, the source was written beneath that sentence.

On the stage, the sentence had no source.

Nirmal Babu continued.

A little later he gave an example involving a "hostel honor code."

Kalyanpur school did not even have a hostel.

Ranjan whispered, "Where did that come from?"

Anupama whispered back, "It was on the webpage."

All three had read that page while preparing the wall magazine.

Nirmal Babu had changed the setting of the example, but the sequence was the same.

Then came a list.

All four points in the list were in the same order as on the webpage.

Anupama felt a strange tension in her head.

She did not want to laugh.

Nor was she wholly angry.

She could only remember Chandrakala Devi's sentence from Saturday: "If the thought is not yours, show the road it came by."

The speech ended.

There was applause.

The headmaster took the microphone.

He said, "You may ask questions now."

At first, no hand went up.

Smiling, Nirmal Babu said, "Are you afraid even to ask questions about cheating?"

A few children laughed.

Then a Class Eight student asked, "Sir, is asking a friend for an answer cheating?"

Nirmal Babu answered by explaining the context.

Another student asked, "What about looking at the book while practising at home?"

"Look at the book while learning; in the examination, write what you understand," he replied.

Then Anupama raised her hand.

Nirmal Babu knew her.

“Yes, Anupama?”

Anupama stood up.

“Sir, is it cheating to use a sentence written by someone else in one’s own speech?”

A murmur ran through the ground.

Without hesitation, Nirmal Babu said, “If you take it word for word and do not give the source, it can be considered plagiarism.”

Anupama asked, “What if a few words are changed?”

“If the idea is still someone else’s and you present it as your own, the problem remains.”

Chandrakala Devi was sitting beside the stage.

She looked at Anupama.

Anupama asked a third question.

“What if it is in a speech?”

This time Nirmal Babu’s hand stopped on the paper.

The ground fell silent again.

The headmaster kept looking at Anupama.

Nirmal Babu said, “Even in a speech, it is proper to give the source.”

Before Anupama could sit down, Ranjan called from beside the wall magazine, “Sir, that sentence is written here with its source.”

Every eye turned to the wall magazine.

The same sentence that had been heard from the stage five minutes earlier was displayed there in black letters.

Below it, in small type, was the name of the webpage.

Nirmal Babu looked at it too.

Then he looked down at his five pages.

For the first time, the sentences written on the paper sounded separate from his own voice.

The headmaster moved the microphone toward him.

“Let the question be answered,” he said calmly.

Nirmal Babu was silent for a moment.

He could have said that these were general ideas.

He could have said that a speech was not a research paper.

He could have said that he had been short of time.

All three arguments came into his mind together.

But at that very moment he remembered an earlier class.

Two years before, the student in whose pocket the little slip had been found had also said, “I did not have time, sir.”

Nirmal Babu had replied then, "Lack of time does not make a wrong thing right."

That sentence now seemed to stand against him.

He took the microphone.

"Anupama's question is right."

No one in the ground laughed.

"I took a large part of this speech from different pages on the internet."

The headmaster's face grew slightly stern.

Nirmal Babu continued, "I changed some words, changed the language, but I did not cite the sources."

He raised the pages.

"That is a mistake."

A child sitting at the back in Class Six looked at his friend.

Perhaps he was surprised that a teacher too could publicly say, "I made a mistake."

Nirmal Babu said, "Perhaps the most useful line in today's speech is not any that I read out, but this: the rule I apply to all of you applies to me as well."

This time the applause did not come at once.

There were a few moments of silence first.

Then Chandrakala Devi began to clap.

Gradually, other hands joined in.

Anupama sat down.

It did not feel like a victory to her.

It only felt that the question had not been left unfinished.

After the programme ended, discussion began in the teachers' room.

One teacher said, "Was it necessary to admit so much in front of the children?"

Another said, "Now the children will start catching teachers out."

Setting down the tea, Chandrakala Devi said, "During Anti-Cheating Week, practice in catching things is not a bad idea."

Someone laughed.

The headmaster did not.

He asked Nirmal Babu, "How much of it came from outside?"

Nirmal Babu opened the five pages.

Taking a red pen, he began marking each paragraph beside the margin.

Three paragraphs on the first page.

Almost the whole of the second page.

Two lists on the third.

One example on the fourth.

Only the last five lines of the fifth page were entirely his own.

Seeing it himself made him uncomfortable.

"I thought translating it made it mine," he said quietly.

Chandrakala Devi replied, "The language changes, not the parentage."

Aniruddh Jha asked, "What happens now?"

The headmaster picked up the pages.

"Do not throw them away."

Nirmal Babu looked surprised.

"Why?"

"Because this has become the first proper lesson of the week."

The next day, a brief ten-minute gathering was held after prayer.

This time there was no stage.

Nirmal Babu stood on the ground among the children.

In his hand were the five pages from the previous day.

Their margins were covered with red marks.

He said, "Yesterday I advised all of you not to cheat."

"And while preparing yesterday's speech, for my own convenience, I made the same mistake."

He turned through the five pages.

"Everything on these pages that came from elsewhere now has its source written beside it."

He named no one and reread none of the borrowed sentences.

He explained only the method: read another person's idea, understand it, keep the source, and build your own argument from your own experience.

Then he closed the pages.

"Now five minutes without paper."

The children laughed softly.

Nirmal Babu said, "The first time I caught someone cheating, I felt very proud."

He told them an incident from his life as a teacher.

A student had copied an answer, but did not understand one word in the middle of it.

Nirmal Babu had struck out the answer then.

“Yesterday I read five pages, but if Anupama had not asked her question, perhaps I would never have applied the question of sources to my own speech.”

He looked toward Anupama.

“This time, a question saved the teacher’s answer.”

Anupama lowered her head and smiled.

That week, the school started a new register.

It was called the “Source Register.”

Sources for ideas taken from elsewhere in wall magazines, speeches, projects and the school magazine would be recorded in it.

Ranjan opened the first page.

He wrote the date at the top.

The first entry was not a student project.

He wrote: “Anti-Cheating Speech — Nirmal Jha — multiple internet sources; sources added later.”

Nirmal Babu signed it himself.

Then Anupama wrote the second entry: the sources used in the wall magazine.

Closing the register, Chandrakala Devi said, “Now borrowed words will not lose the road they came by.”

The examinations began.

On the first day, Nirmal Babu was invigilating in the Class Ten room.

Anupama sat in the third row.

The question papers were distributed.

After a while, a faint sound came from the back—the rustle of paper being moved.

Nirmal Babu turned and walked over.

One student covered the side of his answer sheet.

Nirmal Babu looked at him only once.

The student moved his hand away.

There was no speech.

There was no humiliation.

The room became quiet again.

Nirmal Babu returned to his desk.

On one corner of the desk lay a photocopy of the first page of the Source Register.

The headmaster had asked him to bring it to the inspection that afternoon.

Nirmal Babu looked at his own signature on the page.

Until yesterday, his speech had been kept in a file labelled “Final Copy.”

Today the name of the file had changed: “Notes with Sources.”

He opened his phone and, instead of deleting the old search history, left it as it was.

For now, that history was no longer a mistake to be hidden, but evidence of learning.

The Library Inauguration

The old seed-store room of Belauri Panchayat had been turned into a library in three months.

The walls had a fresh coat of lime, the windows had iron grilles, and on the door, in blue letters, was written—“People’s Library, Belauri.”

On the day of the inauguration, the village was so crowded that it was difficult to see the sixteen books inside.

There was the first lock on the gate. The second was on the veranda grille.

Inside were four book cabinets, each secured with two locks.

There was one on the desk drawer, one on the register box, one on the donation box, and five separate locks hung from the small door of the storeroom.

Naina, who was in Class Eight, reached eighteen as she went on counting.

Then she counted the books arranged on the table. Sixteen.

Naina nudged her friend Shikha with her elbow and said, “Two more locks.”

Suppressing a laugh, Shikha said, “Count the photographs. There will be more of those than anything else.”

An officer had come from the block office for the inauguration.

The village head, the school headmaster, the ward member, two donors, and the bookshop owner from the market were all seated around the small table on the stage.

A photographer kept making people stand up and sit down in turn.

First there was a photograph of the ribbon being cut. Then one of the door being opened.

Then one of a book being placed in the officer’s hand. Then another book in the village head’s hand.

Then the children were made to stand in a row, each holding five books.

The book Naina was holding was called “Our River—Our Village.”

As soon as the photograph had been taken, the attendant took the book from her hand and put it back on the table.

Naina asked, "Can I take this home?"

The attendant replied, "The inauguration is still going on."

Naina decided it would be proper to ask after the inauguration was over. By afternoon, thirty-four photographs had been taken.

In the evening, all the books were placed in the four glass-fronted cabinets. The two locks on each cabinet were closed.

The keys were not kept in one place.

One pair went to the secretary of the library committee, one pair to the village head, one pair to the headmaster, and one pair to the principal donor, Ramvilas Babu.

The arrangement was that no one person should be able to open a cabinet on his own.

"There will be accountability," said the secretary, Maheshwar Jha.

Everyone agreed.

Naina still kept looking at the blue cover of "Our River—Our Village" behind the glass.

Two days later, after school, she went to the library.

The gate was open, but the grille was locked.

Inside the grille sat Janardan Babu, a retired teacher who had been appointed to run the library.

Naina said, "I want to borrow the book about the river."

Janardan Babu smiled.

"That is very good."

He searched for the keys in his shoulder bag.

He found the key to the main door and the key to the register box, but not the key to the book cabinet.

"The secretary has it," he said.

Naina went to the secretary's house. The secretary had gone to the market.

The next day she went again. The secretary was at home, but his key was only for the left-hand cabinet.

The river book was in the cabinet on the right.

"The other key to that one is with Ramvilas Babu," the secretary said.

Ramvilas Babu's house was half a kos from the library.

Naina reached there in the evening.

Before giving her the key, Ramvilas Babu asked, "Where is the man who runs the library?"

"There."

"Then how can I put the key into your hand? I will come myself."

He had guests that evening, so he could not go.

On the third day Naina went to the library again.

At the sight of her, Janardan Babu looked embarrassed even before she said anything.

“We will open it today,” he said.

Ramvilas Babu came, and so did the secretary.

The two locks were opened.

The glass door of the cabinet creaked.

Naina reached for the blue book.

Just then the secretary said, “First open the issue register.” Janardan Babu had the key to the register box, but the format for filling in the first page of the register had not yet been prepared.

Whose name, for how many days, the price of the book, the guardian’s signature—the three men began discussing all this.

Naina stood waiting. Half an hour later it was decided that no book would be allowed to go home until the rules had been framed.

The book went back into the cabinet. The two locks were fastened again.

This time Naina said nothing. She sat on the veranda and began reading one of her schoolbooks.

Within two weeks, photographs of the library inauguration had been put up at three places in the village.

Eight photographs were displayed in the Panchayat building. Five on the school veranda.

There were eleven inside the library. In one photograph Naina was smiling, holding the blue book.

People who saw that photograph would say, “The children are making excellent use of it.”

At first Naina would correct them: “I haven’t read it. I only held it.”

People would laugh. “You will read it too.”

A month passed. The rules were framed, but a new difficulty arose.

To take a book home, two signatures were required—one from the librarian and one from a member of the committee.

The committee member came to the library only on Tuesdays.

On Tuesdays Naina had an extra mathematics class at school.

Twice she thought of missing the class, but she did not.

Meanwhile, a request came for new photographs of the library.

The block office’s monthly report required proof of “reader activity.”

Maheshwar Jha said, “Call the children on Sunday. Put books in their hands, take photographs, and we’ll send them.”

Janardan Babu said softly, "Shall we open the books for reading too?"

"Yes, yes, of course. First let the photographs be taken."

Ten children came on Sunday.

Once again, three people had to be gathered to open the book cabinets.

The photographer did not come, so Maheshwar Jha took the photographs on his mobile phone.

One child was given a geography book, another a book of poetry, a third a book on agricultural science.

Naina was given "Our River—Our Village" again.

She opened the book.

On the first page she read the printer's name.

On the second page there was a map of an old channel of the Kosi.

Maheshwar Jha said, "Look up. I am taking the photograph."

Naina did not look up.

She kept looking at the map. "Naina, smile once."

She asked, "May I read for ten minutes?"

Maheshwar Jha looked at her for a few moments, then said, "All right. But the book must not go outside."

In ten minutes Naina read three pages. Then the book was put back in the cabinet.

That day's photographs went into the monthly report. In the library register, the number of readers was entered as ten.

No one took a book home. In the second month, something strange happened.

Raghunath Sah, the village's old bookbinder, brought five old books for the library.

Their covers were worn, there were finger marks along the edges, and in two of the books children's old names had been written in pencil.

Maheshwar Jha looked at the books. "The donation is good, but these will not look good in the inauguration cabinet."

Raghunath Sah laughed. "Did I give the books to decorate a cabinet, or to be read?"

Maheshwar Jha gave no answer.

The five books were placed temporarily under Janardan Babu's desk because they had not yet been entered in the catalogue.

For that reason, no lock was put on those five books.

When Naina arrived that day, she pulled an old book called "The Ponds and Waters of Mithila" from under the desk.

"May I read this?"

Adjusting his spectacles, Janardan Babu said, "It is not on the list yet."
Naina could not understand whether that meant yes or no.

From the veranda Raghunath Sah said, "If it is not on the list, then it has no lock either. Read it."

Janardan Babu smiled.

Naina did not take the book home; she sat on the veranda and read half of it.

Shikha read it the next day. On the third day, Rajesh of Class Six read it.

Within a week, new folds had appeared on the pages of three of the five old books.

When one page seemed in danger of coming loose, Raghunath Sah stitched it back in with thread.

The sixteen books inside the glass cabinets still gleamed.

The five books under the desk slowly grew soiled.

At first Janardan Babu was worried by the dirt. Then one day he said, "This is not bad dirt. It is the mark of hands."

At the end of Phagun, word came that an inspection would be held by the block office.

The committee immediately became active.

The glass was cleaned. The locks were oiled.

The photographs on the wall were straightened. Maheshwar Jha said, "Remove those five old books for now. They look torn."

Naina was sitting there.

She asked, "Why?" "The inspector is coming. The library should look good."

Naina was holding a loose page of "The Ponds and Waters of Mithila."

"But these five have been read more than any of the others."

Maheshwar Jha said, "That is true, but look at their condition."

Naina looked at the wall.

There were eleven photographs from the inauguration.

Four new photographs of the monthly activities had also been added.

She looked at the glass cabinet.

Sixteen books.

Door, cabinets, register, drawer, storeroom—all together, eighteen locks. Fifteen photographs on the wall.

If the photographs in the Panchayat building and the school were added, the number went far beyond that.

Naina said softly, "There are fewer books, and more locks and photographs."

No one laughed.

Janardan Babu rose from his chair.

For the first time he looked at all the locks together, as though until then they had been separate objects and today they had become a single account.

The officer came on the day of the inspection.

Maheshwar Jha gave him an account of the library's establishment, inauguration, donations, and monthly activities.

The officer looked at the photographs on the wall. Then he asked for the register.

The register contained the number of readers, but the rows for books taken home were almost empty.

He asked, "How many books have gone out?" Janardan Babu said, "The system has become difficult."

The officer asked them to open one of the cabinets.

It took twenty minutes to gather the keys.

Meanwhile, the officer watched the children sitting on the veranda.

Rajesh was reading an old book. Shikha was carefully turning the pages of another.

The officer asked, "Which cabinet do these books belong to?"

Naina replied, "They don't belong to any cabinet." Raghunath Sah burst out laughing.

Janardan Babu told the whole story plainly. The inspector gave no speech.

He only said, "Security is not another name for preventing books from being used."

That evening the committee met. For a long time they discussed keys, responsibility, books being lost, pages being torn, and keeping accounts.

At last Raghunath Sah said, "If a book tears, I will stitch it. If it is never read, who will stitch up its silence?"

No one wrote that sentence in any register, but from that point the meeting changed.

It was decided that there would be one lock on the main door.

The locks inside the book cabinets would remain open while the library was open.

One signature from the librarian would be enough. A child could take a book home; the name and date would be entered in the register.

Responsibility for a lost book would be fixed according to the rules, but readers would not be stopped merely out of fear that a book might be lost.

The next day Janardan Babu opened the seventeen extra locks and put them into a cloth bag.

Naina asked, "Will you throw them away?" He said, "No. Let them stay in the storeroom. We will use them when they are needed."

Naina took out the blue-covered "Our River—Our Village."

For the first time, the name of the book and the date by which it was to be returned were written beside her name in the register.

She took the book home.

When she brought it back three days later, one corner had bent slightly. Straightening it, Janardan Babu said, "Now it is no longer new."

Naina became alarmed. "Did I spoil it?"

Janardan Babu said, "No. Now it has become a library book."

A year later, the anniversary of the inauguration came round again.

No one on the committee arranged a grand ceremony. Raghunath Sah brought two new books.

The children made a list of all the old books. The photographer came on his own.

He said, "All the children, take a book in your hands and look up once."

Laughing, Janardan Babu said, "Read first. Photographs later, if there is time left."

The old inauguration photographs were still on the wall. But on the shelf beneath them, the covers of the books no longer shone alike.

One had a bent corner, another a faint fingerprint on a page, another a slip tucked between its pages.

Naina did not count the photographs on the wall.

She wrote the name of the next book in the register and opened the glass door without a key.

The Caste Chair

After the rains, the roof of the village community hall had been repaired once again.

Along with the new roof came twenty-eight blue chairs, all the same colour.

The chairs looked so alike that from a distance it was hard to tell which was old and which was new.

But all the chairs were new.

What was old was the way they were arranged.

On the day of the first meeting, Bhola Kaka opened the community hall early in the morning.

He was seventy-eight, but the key still hung from the old cord tied around his waist.

As soon as he opened the door, he swept the floor first, then carried the chairs outside and set them in the sun.

At half past eight, Nilu arrived.

Nilu was in Class Nine at the high school.

Her mathematics teacher had asked her to prepare a small register of the number, condition, and placement of the chairs that had come to the panchayat community hall.

The reason was that the school students were going to use the same hall for a science exhibition the following month.

Nilu opened her notebook.

“Kaka, shall I write numbers on the chairs?”

Bhola Kaka said, “Write them underneath. If you write them on top, people will ask why the number of their chair has changed.”

Nilu burst out laughing.

“Whose chair? They all belong to the village.”

Bhola Kaka looked at her, then gave a small smile.

“Yes, they belong to the village.”

Turning the chairs over one by one, Nilu began painting plain numbers underneath them—1, 2, 3...28.

She was enjoying herself.

When she had finished numbering them, Bhola Kaka began arranging the chairs inside.

Nilu saw that he placed six chairs in the first row, eight in the second, eight in the third, and six against the back wall.

"If we put seven in each row, it will look more even," Nilu said.

Bhola Kaka shook his head.

"This is fine."

"Why?"

"People have always sat like this."

Nilu drew a small map of the chairs' positions in her notebook.

First row: 1–6.

Second: 7–14.

Third: 15–22.

Back: 23–28.

At half past nine, people began to arrive.

Mahendra Babu came first.

Bhola Kaka seated him on chair 2.

Then came Shivji, Amarnath, Sudama, Harilal, and Rameshwar.

No one looked at the numbers written beneath the chairs.

But Nilu kept watching.

Chairs 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, and 6 filled up.

The second row too filled gradually.

The six chairs at the back remained empty for a long time.

Then Mangal, Durga, Budhan, and Shambhu came from the southern hamlet.

At the doorway, all four first began taking off their sandals.

Bhola Kaka said, "There is no rule that sandals must be left outside."

Mangal said, "It is a habit."

All four came inside.

Two chairs in the second row were empty.

But they all went to the back.

Nilu wrote in her notebook—23, 24, 25, 26.

The meeting was about drain water and preventing soil erosion before the next monsoon.

On paper, the main issue was straightforward.

Where the drain needed deepening, where a small culvert was required, and near whose field the water should not be diverted.

But before the discussion could properly begin, the positions of people's bodies had already been settled.

Nilu noticed this for the first time.

Until then, she had thought only that whoever came early would sit in front and whoever came late would sit at the back.

Mangal had arrived late, so that made sense.

Durga too.

But Budhan had reached the doorway before Shivji.

He remained standing outside, talking to Bhola Kaka, until the chairs in the first row had filled.

Nilu drew a small question mark in her notebook.

In the middle of the meeting, the map of the drain was opened.

The village's three main roads, the pond, the school, the shrine, the southern hamlet, and the eastern fields were all marked on the paper.

Mangal stood and said, "If the water is diverted here, the courtyards of three houses near our hamlet will flood again."

Mahendra Babu could not see the map clearly.

He asked Mangal to come forward and show him.

Mangal came forward, but he did not sit on the empty chair 7.

He remained bent over the paper, pointing to it with his finger.

"Sit down," Nilu said without thinking.

Everyone's eyes turned towards her for a moment.

Nilu began looking at her notebook.

Mangal laughed and said, "I'm fine standing."

He remained standing for five minutes.

Then he returned to his chair at the back.

After the meeting ended, Nilu counted the chairs again.

Her mathematics assignment was complete.

But the question mark did not disappear.

The second meeting was two weeks later.

This time the subject was the repair of the community well and a new pulley for drawing water.

Nilu deliberately arranged the chairs in four rows of seven.

When Bhola Kaka arrived, he stopped short.

"What have you done?"

"It is easier to count."

"People will change them again."

"Then let them."

Bhola Kaka said nothing.

People arrived.

For the first five minutes, everything remained as it was.

Then Harilal dragged his chair two handspans forward.

Rameshwar turned the chair beside him.

No instruction was given.

No one told anyone where to sit.

But within ten minutes, the four even rows had taken the old form again—a short row in front, two wider rows in the middle, and six chairs clustered against the back wall.

Nilu looked at the numbers underneath.

This time chairs 1 through 6 were not in front.

The front row held 3, 8, 12, 16, 18, and 22.

The numbers had changed.

The pattern had not.

She drew a second map in her notebook.

After that, she wrote no names, only chair numbers.

After the meeting, she placed the two maps over each other and compared them.

The numbers were different, but the empty spaces, the distance between rows, and the direction people faced were almost the same.

At home, she copied the two maps onto paper in pencil.

Her mother asked, "What kind of lesson is this?"

Nilu said, "Mathematics too, perhaps history as well."

Her mother looked at the maps.

After a while she said, "Do not write any names."

"Why?"

"You are a child. People will draw their own conclusions."

"I won't write names. But even without names, the thing can still be seen."

Her mother did not answer.

On the day of the third meeting, it rained heavily.

The community hall's new roof was sound along the main side, but water began dripping through one joint in the back corner.

Exactly where the six chairs at the back usually stood.

Bhola Kaka placed a bucket there.

Chairs 23 through 28 had to be moved.

Nilu placed those six chairs in an empty space at the front left.

The meeting began.

Five people came from the southern hamlet.

They stopped near the doorway.

There was a bucket in their old place at the back.
There were six empty chairs in front.
Mangal moved towards one chair, then stopped.
Durga stood against the wall.
Bhola Kaka said, "Please sit down."
Mangal said, "Here?"
"The chair is dry."
"I'll stand."
This time Nilu said nothing.
The meeting went on.
After half an hour, Durga's knee began to hurt.
He slowly leaned his weight against the wall.
Mahendra Babu noticed.
"There is an empty chair. Sit down."
Durga said "no" again.
Mahendra Babu looked at Bhola Kaka with questioning eyes.
Bhola Kaka lowered his gaze.
The sound of the rain grew louder.
For a few moments, the discussion in the meeting stopped.
Nilu opened her notebook.
She had drawn the maps of all three meetings on a single page.
"May I show you something?"
Her voice was not very loud.
Mahendra Babu said, "Show us."
Nilu placed the notebook in the middle.
"This is the first meeting. This is the second. This is today."
No one immediately understood what it meant.
Mangal bent over to look.
"These are the chair numbers?"
"Yes."
"Where are the names?"
"I have not written any names."
Harilal said, "Then what does this show?"
Nilu turned the page.
On that page there were only square marks—six in front, rows in the middle, six at the back.
"The numbers kept changing, but this pattern did not."
No one said anything.

Nilu continued, "Today water is falling at the back. Even so, these six chairs are empty and five people are standing."

Durga gave a faint laugh.

"Forget my knee. Look at your mathematics."

A few people laughed.

The laughter was brief, but the knot of tension in the room loosened a little.

Mahendra Babu looked at Durga.

"Truly, why did you not sit?"

Instead of answering directly, Durga said, "The place that feels like mine is where the water is falling."

"Who decided that place?"

"No one."

"Then?"

Durga looked at Bhola Kaka.

Bhola Kaka said, "Ever since I was given the key, this is how I have seen it."

Mangal said, "My father too used to sit like this."

Harilal said quietly, "My father too, in front."

After that short sentence, the sound of rain inside the hall suddenly seemed much clearer.

No one had made a rule.

Each had inherited a place from his father.

And that place was stronger than the number written beneath a chair.

The meeting was about the well, but the discussion came to a halt over the chairs.

Mahendra Babu said, "We will not abandon today's subject. A decision about the well is necessary."

Mangal said, "First those who are standing will sit. Then we will talk about the well."

Durga looked at him.

"You sit first."

Mangal sat down on the empty chair 24.

Today that chair stood at the front left.

When he sat, no one applauded.

No one made an announcement.

Only all four legs of the chair came to rest on the floor at once.

Durga sat on 25.

Shambhu on 27.

Budhan on 28.

The fifth man, Chhotelal, sat on the empty chair 26 and drew his feet in, as though his body were still asking where its old boundary lay.

The meeting began again.

There were two opinions about the well's pulley.

Those who were accustomed to speaking from the back now spoke from the front.

For those sitting in front, it was not as easy this time to cut them off mid-sentence.

Nilu did not write that in her notebook either.

She wrote only the decision—the old pulley would be removed, a new iron pulley installed, and the cost shared by all four hamlets.

When the meeting ended, people got up.

Durga began carrying his chair back to its old place at the rear.

Nilu said, "There is still water there."

Durga stopped.

Then he left the chair where he had been sitting.

The following week, the joint in the roof was repaired.

Bhola Kaka called Nilu.

"Finish the chair register. The school people will ask for it."

Beside each of the twenty-eight numbers, Nilu wrote—"Good."

She left the column for permanent location blank.

Bhola Kaka looked at it.

"You won't write the location?"

"The location will keep changing."

"Will it?"

Nilu said, "Let it."

The fourth meeting was held two months later.

This time Bhola Kaka did not arrange the chairs.

He unlocked the door and sat to one side.

As people arrived, each brought out a chair from the storeroom for himself.

For the first five minutes, the old pattern began forming again.

Then Mangal placed his chair beside Mahendra Babu's.

Because he had to show him the measurements for the new drain.

Durga sat near the doorway, because that was where the breeze was strongest.

Harilal went to the back, because he wanted to rest his back against the wall.

No new rule was made.

The old rule had never been written down, so no written order was issued to strike it out.

But for the first time, the chairs began to move according to the work at hand.

Nilu sat at the back and opened her notebook.

She could have drawn a new map.

But this time she did not.

At the top of a blank page she wrote—"Meeting 4."

Underneath she wrote one line—"Chairs: twenty-eight. Permanent location—none."

Then she closed the notebook.

There were twenty-eight blue chairs in the community hall.

All the same colour, the same height, the same price.

The only difference was that now, merely by looking at them, one could no longer tell whose place was whose.

The Digital Village

A new signboard had been put up three months earlier at the western entrance to Bankatta village.

White letters shone against a blue background—“Fully Digital Village — Bankatta.”

A small solar panel was fixed above the signboard.

All day it drank in the sunlight, and as soon as evening fell, two white lights began to shine on the letters.

Whether the village had electricity or not, the signboard glowed all night.

Whether there was a mobile network or not had nothing to do with it.

In Bankatta, there was almost never a network.

Now and then one bar would appear, then vanish before a conversation could even begin.

The villagers had long accepted this as though it were their fate.

After the signboard went up, the deficiency became much more visible to them.

For now, whenever “No network available” appeared on a mobile phone, at that very moment “Fully Digital” kept shining on the signboard to the west.

One day, the science teacher gave Aarti, who was in Class Eight, homework: draw a map on the subject “The New Facilities in Our Village.”

Aarti came home and drew the road, pond, school, community hall, health room, and the new digital signboard on a sheet of paper.

Then she stopped.

Her mother asked, “What happened?”

Aarti said, “Where should I draw the digital facility?”

Her mother laughed.

“Draw it beside the signboard.”

Aarti drew a small mobile phone beneath the signboard.

Then she took her own mobile phone there.

Her maternal uncle had given her an old phone for her studies.

Standing beneath the signboard, Aarti held the phone up.
Not a single bar.

She went to the roadside.

Nothing.

She went to the western embankment of the pond.

For a moment, one bar appeared.

Aarti marked a red dot in her notebook.

That evening, her homework took on a new form.

The next day, on her way to school, she opened her phone at three places and checked the network.

The school veranda—zero.

North of the old peepal tree—one bar, for only ten breaths.

At the culvert over the irrigation channel—two bars.

She marked three red dots in her notebook.

By the third day, Aarti had understood that Bankatta's digital map was not a map of buildings, but a map of the network's scattered breaths.

The culvert turned out to be the most dependable place.

At dawn, two bars could be found there.

At noon, one.

In the evening, sometimes all three bars lit up together.

The culvert was about half a kos east of the village's main road.

There was neither shade there nor any proper place to sit.

Fields lay on both sides, with a narrow brick culvert in between.

Earlier, people stopped there only to cross the channel.

Now it was gradually becoming a place for catching the network.

Mohan, who sold milk, stood there at dawn to see his payment message.

The schoolteacher wandered about holding his phone aloft so that he could download the examination list.

Rita, the seamstress, opened there the picture showing the measurements sent by her customer in the city.

Krishnadev's son saw the notice for his job interview there.

People gave the culvert a name—"Network Ghat."

The name existed in no official record.

But if anyone in the village asked, "Where can I get a network?" the answer came at once: "Go to Network Ghat."

Aarti drew a thick red circle around the culvert on her map.

When the science teacher saw the map, he smiled at first.

Then he asked, "What are all these red dots?"

Aarti said, "Places where the mobile phone gets a network."

"I asked you to draw facilities."

"Isn't this a facility?"

The teacher was silent for a few moments.

The other children in the class leaned towards Aarti's paper.

Sonu said, "One bar comes on our roof in the evening."

Phulkumari said, "Not in our courtyard, but it comes near the cattle trough."

Dilip said, "My uncle says if you climb the guava tree, you get two bars."

The whole class burst out laughing.

The teacher said, "We will not mark a tree-climbing point on the map."

Aarti asked, "Why?"

"It is dangerous."

Aarti wrote beside the red dot: "Not usable."

It was the first time her map had ceased to be merely homework.

The children began bringing reports about the network from their own hamlets.

Within a week, there were twenty-seven dots on the paper.

Some points worked at dawn, some in the evening, and some only when it was not raining.

Aarti began writing the time beside each dot as well.

"North of peepal tree—6–7 a.m."

"Channel culvert—5–9 a.m., after 5 p.m."

"School roof—sometimes."

"Beneath the Fully Digital signboard—zero."

She had written this last line as a joke.

But the teacher did not strike it out.

Meanwhile, a "Digital Assistance Corner" was set up in the community hall.

A table, a chair, an old computer, and a small network device were placed there.

A sheet of paper was pasted on the door: "All digital services here."

Ten people came on the first day.

The computer started.

The network did not.

The assistant, Ramesh, watched the device's light for half an hour.

The green light blinked once, then turned red.

Ramesh said, "Give it a little time."

An hour later, the people went home.

The next day, Ramesh placed the network device on the window.

On the third day, he tied it high on a piece of bamboo.

On the fourth day, he himself climbed onto the roof carrying the device.

The network came for two minutes.

One application opened, but could not be submitted.

On the fifth day, Ramesh told those ten people, "If the work is urgent, come to Network Ghat."

People laughed.

The community hall's "Digital Assistance Corner" remained indoors; the digital assistance moved to the culvert over the channel.

Ramesh made a cloth bag.

In it he kept the network device, a small power bank, two wires, and a sheet of plastic.

People with urgent work gathered at Network Ghat in the morning.

Some brought their own mobile phones, some brought papers, and some came only to receive a one-time password on an elderly father's phone.

Ramesh took no pride in this arrangement.

Nor was he ashamed of it.

He merely said, "Where there is a network, there the work gets done."

Aarti's map was hung on the wall of the community hall.

It was Ramesh, not the teacher, who hung it there.

He used the red dots.

Whenever Network Ghat failed, he looked at the map and searched for another place.

One day, two officials from outside came to the village.

They were there to inspect its "Fully Digital" status.

Seeing the signboard at the village entrance, one official said, "The signboard has been maintained well."

The other looked at its solar light.

"Does it stay on at night too?"

The mukhiya said, "Every night."

The officials were pleased.

When they reached the community hall, Ramesh switched on the computer.

Red light.

He placed the network device on the window.

Nothing.

One official asked, "How many services are handled here?"

Ramesh showed him the register.

The register recorded the date, the work, and its status.

The official asked, "Digital records?"

Ramesh said, "When the network opens, I'll show you."

The two officials looked at each other.

Then their eyes fell on Aarti's map on the wall.

"What is this?"

Ramesh said, "Our real network map."

Aarti was at school that day.

She was called.

She came carrying the new copy in her notebook.

The official asked, "Which department made this map?"

Aarti said, "Class Eight."

A faint laugh rose in the room, but the official did not laugh.

He asked, "Why the red dots?"

Aarti explained.

"Here there is a network in the morning. Here in the evening. This place works only in clear weather. I marked this tree point as unusable."

The official studied the map carefully.

"And zero beneath the signboard?"

"Yes."

"Never?"

"Not once in three months, as far as I have seen."

The mukhiya shifted slightly in his chair.

One official walked outside, all the way to the signboard.

Everyone followed.

Evening was falling.

The solar lights came on by themselves.

"Fully Digital Village" shone white again.

The official took out his mobile phone.

There was no network on its screen.

The other official checked his phone as well.

Zero.

Ramesh said softly, "The signboard has a different network here."

The official looked at him.

Ramesh explained, "The signboard's light runs on solar power. It does not need a mobile network."

No one laughed.

The signboard shone so clearly that the faces of everyone standing beneath it looked bright.

No announcement was made that day.

Nor was the signboard taken down.

The officials wrote something in the inspection register and left.

People in the village kept guessing whether a communication tower would now be installed, whether the lines would be changed, or whether another team would come.

For two weeks, nothing happened.

In the third week, a team arrived.

They went around with an instrument for measuring the network.

One by one, they stood at the red dots on Aarti's map.

They spent the most time at Network Ghat.

Returning from school, Aarti saw a man asking for the direction of the red circle drawn on her paper.

She felt pleased, but said nothing.

A month later, work began to improve the network.

Some poles were replaced, and a new small device was installed on the school roof.

The network did not change at once, as if by magic.

First, one bar became steady in the community hall.

Then two.

The crowd at Network Ghat began to thin.

Ramesh's bag began to stay in the cupboard.

But it was not thrown away.

One day at school, the teacher told Aarti, "Now change the old map."

Aarti took a new sheet of paper.

This time, the red dots became fewer.

She drew a green circle over the community hall.

A green circle over the school.

The southern hamlet still had a red dot.

At Network Ghat, she made a mark that was half red and half green.

The teacher asked, "Beneath the signboard?"

Aarti decided to check again in the evening.

After sunset, she went to the western entrance.

The solar lights came on.

White letters shone again on the blue signboard—"Fully Digital Village — Bankatta."

Aarti opened her mobile phone.

One bar appeared.

It remained for ten breaths.

Then it became two.

She wrote in her notebook: "Beneath the signboard—two bars, 6:12 p.m."

Then she looked at the word "Fully."

The southern hamlet was still red on her map.

She did not write "Fully."

At the top of the notebook she wrote only: "New map of the Digital Village—incomplete, until there is a network everywhere."

The signboard, by its own reckoning, kept shining as though complete.

By her own reckoning, Aarti left the map incomplete.

Proof of Poverty

It was at the school that Kamli Devi first learned that poverty, too, required proof.

Meera was studying in Class Nine.

That year the school had started a student assistance fund.

For families with very low incomes, the fund would pay the examination fee and part of the cost of books.

When Meera came home after reading the notice, there was hope in her eyes.

Kamli made leaf plates and, from time to time, also worked as a farm labourer.

When the rains were bad, farm work dwindled.

When the season of wedding feasts arrived, the demand for leaf plates rose.

The household income did not run on paper; it ran on the seasons.

Meera spread the notice before her mother.

"Ma, it says here—we have to submit an economic-status certificate."

Kamli asked, "Where do we get that?"

"From the circle office."

"How much will it cost?"

Meera read it again.

"Fee: zero."

Kamli smiled.

"Then that is good."

The following Tuesday, Kamli gave up half a day's farm work and went with Meera to the office.

A tempo from the village to the market, a bus from the market to the circle office.

After paying both fares, Meera took out the application form.

The employee at the first window said, "The application is in order. Attach a photocopy of the ration card, the first page of the bank passbook, two photographs, and proof of residence."

Kamli asked, "How much is the fee for this?"

The employee said, "Nothing here. The certificate is free of charge."

Outside the office was a photocopy shop.

Meera had four papers photocopied.

The shopkeeper charged twenty rupees.

The photographer asked for sixty rupees.

Kamli untied the knot in the end of her sari.

She counted the money.

Meera watched in silence.

That day they did not have the old residence document with them.

Kamli said, "It must be in the trunk at home."

The two of them went back.

By evening the farm work was already over.

Kamli did not receive that day's wages.

That night Meera opened an old mathematics notebook.

On the back she wrote—

"First day: fare 80. Photocopies 20. Photographs 60. Ma lost half a day's wages."

Kamli saw it.

"What are you writing?"

"An account."

"Of what?"

"Of the certificate."

Kamli laughed.

"But the certificate is free."

Meera closed the notebook.

Two days later they went again.

This time they had the residence paper with them.

The employee said, "Village verification is required. Get the revenue official's signature."

"Where is he?"

"He has gone out into the field today. You may find him tomorrow."

Weariness settled over Kamli's face.

Meera asked, "Do we have to come here again tomorrow?"

"Yes. That is the rule."

They came outside.

As they walked towards the bus stand, Kamli said, "I was supposed to cut five hundred leaves for plates today."

Meera said nothing.

That night a second line was added to the back of the notebook—
“Second day: fare 80. Ma lost one day’s leaf-plate work. Papers not submitted.”

For the third journey Meera insisted on going alone.

Kamli refused.

“You will miss school.”

“And you keep missing work.”

Kamli did not answer.

On the third visit they found the revenue official.

He looked at the papers.

“I will have to see the condition of the house.”

Kamli said, “Now?”

“Not today. I will be making field visits this week. Stay at home.”

“When?”

“The day is not fixed. I will let you know by mobile phone.”

Kamli had a basic mobile phone, whose network often disappeared in the village.

She gave him the number of her neighbour Ramdulari.

For four days Kamli did not take work in distant fields.

“The inspector may come,” she kept saying.

No one came the first day.

Nor the second.

At noon on the third day Ramdulari came running.

“Kamli! The man from the office is asking for you near the pond.”

Kamli left the leaf plates and ran.

The revenue official inspected the house.

Mud walls, a tin roof, two cots, one trunk, bundles of leaf plates.

He asked, “Land?”

“Five dhurs behind the house.”

“Cattle?”

“None.”

“Income?”

Kamli thought for a few moments.

“If I get a day’s work, wages. If I get leaves, leaf plates.”

The official wrote something on the form.

Meera saw that a figure was being entered in one box for monthly income.

She asked, “How did you arrive at that figure?”

The official said, "Average."

"Average of what?"

"Work like this."

Kamli looked at her daughter.

Meera fell silent.

The inspection ended.

The official said, "Now come and collect the certificate after three days."

Kamli asked, "Any money to pay here?"

"No. Everything is free."

He left.

Meera wrote on the back of the notebook—

"Did not take distant work for four days because of the inspection. Inspection: half an hour."

After reading it, Kamli said, "Do not write half an hour. Write four days."

Meera looked at her mother's face.

"But you made leaf plates at home."

"I made leaf plates, but I gave up two days' farm work. Write that too."

For the first time, Meera handed the notebook to her mother.

With her finger Kamli drew two short lines in the empty margin of the page.

"These are the two days."

Meera wrote the words beside them.

Three days later the certificate was not ready.

The employee had signed it, but the officer who had to stamp it had gone to a meeting.

"Come tomorrow," they were told at the window.

This time Kamli asked nothing.

She came outside and sat down beside a pillar of the veranda.

Meera sat down too.

The two ate the flattened rice they had brought with them.

Kamli said, "How much school fee will this save?"

After Meera told her the amount, she opened the notebook.

By then, the cash expense had reached nearly a third of the assistance amount.

If lost wages were added, it was more than half.

For the next journey, there was not enough fare left in the knot of Kamli's sari.

She borrowed a hundred rupees from Ramdulari.

Meera wrote that down in the notebook too.

Kamli did not snatch the notebook away.

She only said, "Do not stop counting."

The next day the officer was there.

The stamp was affixed.

The certificate came into Kamli's hands.

Across the top, in bold letters, it said: "Economic-Status Certificate."

Below, one line read: "Issue fee: 0."

Kamli placed her finger on that zero.

Meera looked at her mother's face.

Kamli did not smile.

"The paper is not lying," she said.

Meera asked, "Then?"

"The paper states its own cost. Not ours."

When they reached the school, it was the last day for submitting assistance applications.

The clerk counted the papers.

"Certificate—yes. Bank passbook—yes. Photograph—yes. Signature—yes."

He accepted the application.

Meera asked, "Should I submit this notebook?"

The clerk looked startled.

"What notebook?"

Meera opened the pages at the back.

"The cost of getting the certificate made."

The clerk smiled.

"That is not required."

"But all this money was spent to prove poverty."

"It is not in the rules."

Meera closed the notebook.

The assistance committee met at the end of the week.

The headmaster, two teachers, and the member overseeing the fund were examining the applications.

Meera sat outside on the veranda.

Kamli had gone to the market carrying bundles of leaf plates.

Meera was called inside.

The headmaster asked, "Why did it take so long for your certificate to be made?"

Meera answered, "It was free."

For a few moments everyone looked at her face.

The headmaster asked again, "I asked why it was delayed."

Meera opened the notebook.

She read aloud everything she had written, from the first journey to the last.

Fare.

Photocopies.

Photographs.

The half-day lost.

Two days of farm work lost.

Waiting for the inspection.

Another journey for the stamp.

The teachers sitting in the room fell silent.

One member said, "But there was no fee for the certificate."

Meera showed them the zero on the certificate.

"There is a zero here."

Then she showed them the notebook page.

"There is no zero here."

No one answered at once.

The headmaster read the papers again.

The assistance was approved.

When Meera came home, Kamli had already returned from the market.

She put the certificate and the approval slip together in the same blue file pouch.

In the rear pocket of the pouch still lay the slip from the photocopy shop, the photographer's small receipt, and two torn bus tickets.

Kamli started to take them out and throw them away.

Meera stopped her.

"Let them stay."

"Why?"

"All of this is behind the zero on the paper."

Kamli put the tickets back inside.

A month later the school prepared the assistance notice for the next session.

The rule had not changed.

The economic-status certificate was still compulsory.

But the school added a new arrangement.

It would check the papers of applicant families at the school in a single day, send them to the circle office in a group, and have the verification day fixed in advance.

The headmaster said, "We cannot remove the certificate. We can reduce some of the running around."

Meera heard him.

The sentence did not seem like a complete solution to her.

But for the first time, the pages at the back of her notebook had found a place in an official process.

The following year, their neighbour Sunita considered applying for assistance for her son.

She came to Kamli.

"Sister, how much money does it take to get proof of poverty made?"

Kamli took out the blue file pouch.

She opened the certificate.

With her finger she pointed to "Issue fee: 0."

Then she opened the rear pocket of the pouch.

She took out the old receipts, the tickets, and Meera's folded account sheet.

Kamli placed her finger on the zero once more.

"Nothing here."

Then she handed the account sheet to Sunita.

"Look at the rest here."

Sunita read through it slowly.

Her eyes stopped on the last line—"Ma's four days."

Kamli said nothing.

A heap of leaf plates lay in the courtyard. Meera's certificate was still clean, flat, and free of charge. The days spent making it had remained folded behind the paper.

The Silent Committee

A new wooden box had been hung on the veranda of the Sonbarsa Sewing Cooperative Centre.

In white paint on the box were the words—"Complaint Box."

Below, in smaller letters—"Your matter will be kept confidential."

Eighteen women at the centre stitched school uniforms, bags, and pillowcases.

They were paid by the piece.

At the end of each week the bundles were submitted, the number was entered in the register, and payment was then prepared.

Sunita Devi had been sewing there for six years.

Her machine was old, but its stitches ran straight.

Twice she had been praised as the worker with the fewest returns.

In the last week of Phagun she submitted thirty-four girls' shirts.

Her bundle bore her mark: two knots of blue thread.

Everyone could recognize her bundle from a distance by that mark.

On payment day, the slip showed twenty-eight.

Six shirts missing.

Sunita went to the accounts desk.

"I submitted thirty-four."

Pramod Babu, who handled the accounts, turned the pages of the register.

"It says twenty-eight here."

"Was the bundle opened?"

"There is an inspection."

"Where did the other six go?"

Pramod Babu shrugged.

"If the register says twenty-eight, then twenty-eight must have been received."

Sunita took out her little notebook.

She had been recording the figures ever since she began the work.

How much cloth she received, how many shirts she made, how much thread remained—everything.

"Thirty-four on this date."

Pramod Babu looked at the notebook, then at the register.

"I cannot prepare your payment on the basis of a notebook you keep at home."

"Then what about my six shirts?"

"A complaints committee has been formed. Put it in writing and drop it in the box."

The box had been hung there a month earlier.

On the day it was inaugurated, the chairman of the centre had said, "No one's voice will be suppressed now."

For the first time, Sunita looked closely at the slot in the box.

The slot was so narrow that the folded paper had to be folded twice again.

That night she wrote out her complaint at home.

"On Phagun 23 I submitted thirty-four shirts. Payment was made for twenty-eight. I want an account of the remaining six shirts."

She wrote her name beneath it.

Hesitating all the while, she dropped it into the box the next morning.

Three days later she was summoned before the committee.

There were five people on the committee.

Chairman—the cooperative centre's vice-chairman, Harinandan Jha.

Secretary—accounts assistant Rita Kumari.

Two women members—Phulmaya Devi and Nasima Khatoon.

One outside member—retired teacher Badrinath Mishra.

There was a round table in the middle of the room.

Her complaint lay face down on the table.

Harinandan Jha said in a gentle voice,

"First understand one thing. Until the inquiry is complete, you must not discuss this matter with anyone outside."

Sunita asked,

"Why?"

"For confidentiality."

"It is fine if my complaint remains confidential. But I am not even to ask anyone anything?"

Rita Kumari said,

"The fewer people who know, the more impartial the inquiry will be."

Badrinath Mishra added,

"If word spreads, the centre's reputation may also suffer."

Sunita kept looking at the paper lying face down on the table.

“What am I supposed to do?”

Harinandan Jha said,

“Remain silent. The committee will look into it.”

The sentence was short.

But it left the room with Sunita.

The next week Rukhsana came to borrow the belt from Sunita’s machine.

As Sunita handed it over, Rukhsana said,

“Didi, did you get the right payment?”

Sunita’s hand stopped.

“Why?”

Rukhsana smiled and tried to brush the matter aside.

“I was just asking.”

Sunita remembered the committee.

“It was fine.”

She lied.

Two days later Manju Devi said,

“The register is strange this time.”

Threading her machine, Sunita asked,

“What happened?”

Manju said only,

“Nothing.”

The two women looked at each other.

Then the machines started up again.

A week passed.

The committee summoned her again.

Rita Kumari said,

“The receipt register says twenty-eight. The stock register also says twenty-eight.”

Sunita asked,

“Who counted the bundle when I submitted it?”

“Two employees.”

“Have you asked them?”

“They are being questioned.”

“My bundle had two knots of blue thread on it.”

Harinandan Jha said,

“That mark is not official.”

"The shirts were official."

For a moment the room fell silent.

Badrinath Mishra cleared his throat.

"Please be patient."

"And outside?"

Harinandan Jha said,

"Until the inquiry is over, it would be proper to remain silent."

Sunita returned to work.

That day, in the payment queue, Rukhsana stood for a long time looking at her slip.

Manju folded her slip and tucked it inside her blouse.

Kusum switched off her machine and went straight home.

Sunita saw everything.

She asked no one anything.

The centre's work went on as usual.

The rattle of machines, the snap of scissors, the hiss of the iron, the smell of cloth.

From time to time, the wood of the complaint box gleamed, warmed by the sun.

Three weeks later, one evening, the committee secretary Rita was opening the box.

The rule was that the box had to be opened in the presence of two members.

That day Phulmaya Devi was with her.

Five slips of paper came out of the box.

Rita wrote a serial number on each paper in turn and placed it in an envelope.

Phulmaya asked,

"Won't you write the subject?"

"The rule is to keep the name confidential."

"The name is one thing. The subject?"

Rita paused.

Under the old procedure, only the serial number was written on the outside of the envelope.

"If we write the subject, the person's identity may be revealed."

Phulmaya said,

"Then five complaints will remain five sealed envelopes. How will anyone know that three concern the same thing?"

Rita did not answer.

At the committee's next meeting, all five envelopes were placed on the table.

The first was opened.

Four pieces short in the wages.

The second.

The number submitted and the number paid for did not match.

The third.

Seven bags treated as missing.

The fourth.

An incorrect deduction for thread.

The fifth.

Payment delayed by two weeks.

Phulmaya Devi set the first three papers apart on the table.

"These three are the same kind of complaint."

Rita Kumari pulled the register towards her.

The three complaints were from different weeks.

On all three submission days, the same team of employees had been on duty.

Harinandan Jha said,

"This could also be a coincidence."

Phulmaya said,

"It could. But the three people did not even speak to one another."

Badrinath Mishra removed his glasses.

"Why?"

The room fell silent again.

Rita said softly,

"We advise everyone to remain silent."

Harinandan Jha immediately said,

"For the impartiality of the inquiry."

Phulmaya asked,

"Has that produced impartiality, or separate patches of darkness?"

No one answered.

That evening Sunita was summoned for the third time.

This time Rukhsana and Manju were also seated before the committee.

The three women looked at one another.

Rukhsana spoke first,

"You too?"

Sunita looked at the committee.

Harinandan Jha said,

“Now all of you may share the facts.”

Sunita gave a faint laugh.

“Now?”

Rita Kumari lowered her head.

All three opened their notebooks.

Sunita’s thirty-four had become twenty-eight.

Rukhsana’s forty-two had become thirty-seven.

Manju’s thirty had become twenty-five.

Three different days.

But the same team of employees had written the receipt register.

Rukhsana said,

“I had wanted to ask Sunita Didi. Then the committee told me—not to discuss it with anyone.”

Manju said,

“Me too.”

Sunita asked,

“So the three of us stayed separately silent for three weeks. What was the committee listening to?”

Badrinath Mishra had a pen in his hand.

He stopped writing.

Phulmaya Devi said,

“The committee was listening to papers. People were not listening to one another.”

The nature of the inquiry changed.

The old unfinished bundles in the storeroom were counted again.

In a small room beneath the receiving desk, twenty-two finished articles without names were found.

They had been kept aside for three weeks marked “inspection pending,” but their original bundle numbers had not been entered in the register.

Sunita’s six shirts with the two knots of blue thread were in that pile.

Rukhsana’s five bags bore small loops of red cord.

Manju’s five shirts had triangles drawn on them in pencil.

Theft was not proved.

Nor was it immediately proved that the deductions had been made deliberately.

But the procedure was plainly wrong.

Items set aside for inspection were not treated as received in the register, and payment was prepared on that reduced number.

Pramod Babu said,

“It is the old practice. If we find a defect, we keep the item aside.”

Sunita asked,

“Do you record the defect?”

“There is no time.”

“Do you tell the worker?”

“Later.”

“Do you deduct it from the payment?”

Pramod Babu fell silent.

For the first time, the committee did not advise him to remain silent.

A week later, the unpaid wages of all three women were added to their payments.

A new register was created for items kept aside—bundle number, worker’s name, number of items, reason for setting them aside, date, and decision.

But Phulmaya Devi made another proposal.

“As important as the complaint box is, it is equally important to be able to see the status of a complaint.”

Harinandan Jha said,

“The name must not go outside.”

“Not the name. The subject.”

Rita Kumari made a white notice board.

It had four columns—serial number, subject, status, and date of next hearing.

There was no column for the name.

The first three lines were entered—

“Wages/receipt count—inquiry complete.”

“Wages/receipt count—inquiry complete.”

“Wages/receipt count—inquiry complete.”

Below them was written—“Confidentiality applies to a person’s name; asking questions about facts is not forbidden.”

Harinandan Jha kept his eyes on that sentence for a long time.

“This will encourage people to discuss things too much.”

Badrinath Mishra said,

“The committee exists to listen. If people do not speak at all, what will it hear?”

The board was hung beside the complaint box. The next month the box was opened again. There were three new complaints. One about leave accounting. One about the cost of repairing a machine. One about a broken fan. Rita read the papers. Phulmaya wrote down the subjects.

Then Rukhsana called from the veranda, "Will the paper from my old complaint still be kept?" Rita said, "Yes. In the file." "And the advice to remain silent?" Rita thought for a moment. "That will not be kept."

Sunita was seated at her machine. A ball of blue thread lay before her. She tied two knots on the new bundle. Manju joked, "Didi, that mark is not official." Sunita laughed. "No. But it can be seen."

The complaint box on the veranda was still closed. It still had a lock. But the subject board beside it was open. People could put papers into the box, read the status of their complaints on the board, and ask one another questions about the facts.

At the committee's next meeting, an elderly worker quietly asked before stating his complaint, "Do I first have to remain silent?" Harinandan Jha opened his mouth to answer. Then stopped. Phulmaya Devi said, "No. First, you speak."

Everyone in the room fell silent. This time the silence was not part of the complainant's role. The committee was listening.

The Ideal Wedding

A red cloth banner had lain folded for five years on the veranda of the old panchayat building in Sarisab.

In white letters it read—“No dowry; we want equality.”

The banner did not come out every day.

When the wedding season began, Shashibhushan Jha would spread it out in the sun.

The cloth had faded white along the fold lines.

But the letters were still clear.

Shashibhushan Jha was the coordinator of the “Dowry-Free Marriage Campaign.”

He travelled from village to village holding meetings.

Sometimes on a school veranda, sometimes on the platform in front of a temple, sometimes at the market square on market day.

His voice carried far.

“Dowry is not only what is demanded aloud.”

He said it again and again.

“A hint, pressure, a list, an expectation in the name of prestige—all of these can become forms of dowry.”

People applauded at this sentence.

The line was printed in the campaign’s little booklet as well.

On the last page of the booklet were five questions.

“Did the groom’s side suggest the name of any item?”

“Was the size or number of gifts discussed?”

“Is there social pressure behind the word ‘voluntary?’”

“Is there fear that the marriage may be stopped or that someone may be humiliated?”

“Are both sides equally free?”

Shashibhushan called these five questions “the five lamps.”

“Whenever there is confusion, light all five lamps.”

People remembered that line too.

That year, when the marriage of Shashibhushan’s son Aniruddha was settled, all of Sarisab became curious.

People's first question was not the bride's name.

The first question was—"Let us see how the coordinator conducts a wedding in his own house."

Aniruddha was a bank assistant in Madhubani.

The bride, Mrinalini, taught mathematics at a high school.

The two families already knew each other.

Mrinalini's father, Jagdish Mandal, was a retired headmaster.

The match was settled quickly.

Shashibhushan told everyone,

"A completely simple wedding. The question of dowry will not arise."

People were pleased.

A few suppressed a smile.

Preparations began at home.

The northern room off the courtyard was cleared for Aniruddha.

The old cupboard was taken out.

The ceiling was whitewashed.

The window mesh was replaced.

Shashibhushan's wife, Vimala Devi, said,

"When the new bride comes, the room should be in proper order."

There was no dispute about that.

Two days later, Vimala Devi went to the market with her sister Manjula.

When she returned, she had a notebook in her hand.

On the first page was written—"Aniruddha-Mrinalini Household Arrangements."

Below it were the names of things.

Bed.

Mattress.

Cupboard.

Fan.

Refrigerator.

Mixer.

A small scooter was discussed on a separate page.

There were tick marks beside some of the names.

Others were blank.

Shashibhushan saw the notebook.

His brows drew together.

"What is this?"

Vimala Devi said evenly,

“Things for setting up the household.”

“In our house?”

“Their house. The new couple’s.”

“Who is to provide them?”

“Jagdishji has said that whatever he gives his daughter, he will give of his own accord.”

Shashibhushan closed the notebook.

“There will be no list.”

Vimala Devi said,

“This is not a list of demands. It is for convenience, so that the same thing is not bought twice.”

Manjula laughed.

“You people are afraid of words. This is not dowry; it is customary giving.”

Shashibhushan said nothing.

The notebook remained on the table.

The next day Aniruddha came from Madhubani.

He looked at the room.

The smell of fresh whitewash still lingered on the walls.

He saw the notebook on the table.

He turned the pages.

“Scooter?”

His mother said,

“Your old motorcycle keeps breaking down.”

“But why is this on the list?”

“We did not ask for it. The subject came up from their side.”

Aniruddha looked at Shashibhushan.

Shashibhushan said,

“Nothing has been decided. Remove the notebook.”

Vimala Devi picked it up.

But she did not throw it away.

She placed it on the upper shelf in the kitchen.

Shashibhushan’s niece Komal also lived in the house.

She was an undergraduate student and often handed out leaflets at campaign meetings.

A few days later she found the notebook on the shelf.

She opened it.

That day a new printing of the campaign booklet had arrived at the house.

Komal placed the two papers together on the table.

On one side, "The Five Lamps."

On the other, "Household Arrangements."

She said nothing.

Taking a red pen, she drew five small circles beside the list.

Inside the first circle she wrote—"Were names of items suggested?"

In the second—"Number/size?"

In the third—"Voluntary?"

In the fourth—"Prestige?"

In the fifth—"Are both sides equally free?"

Then she put the notebook back on the shelf.

In the evening Vimala Devi took it down.

The moment she saw the red circles, she called out,

"Komal!"

Komal came in from the veranda.

"Did you do this?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"I applied Kaka's five lamps."

Manjula was sitting there too.

She burst out laughing.

"Will there be a meeting inside the house now as well?"

Komal did not answer.

Shashibhushan came in from outside.

Vimala placed the notebook before him.

"Look at your pupil."

Shashibhushan read the red circles.

His hand came to rest on the first page.

Komal asked,

"Kaka, are these five questions only for other people's houses?"

Shashibhushan said,

"No."

"Then do they apply to this list?"

"They do."

"What are the answers?"

Shashibhushan did not answer at once.

After dinner that night, there was a small meeting in the house.

Aniruddha, Vimala, Shashibhushan, Komal, Manjula.

The notebook lay in the middle.

Shashibhushan read the first question.

“Did the groom’s side suggest the name of any item?”

Vimala said,

“I did not say anything directly.”

Komal asked,

“Then where did the names come from?”

Vimala said,

“In the course of conversation. Jagdishji asked—what does the room need?”

“And what did you say?”

“We talked about the old bed, the small refrigerator—things like that.”

Shashibhushan read the second question.

“Was the size or number of gifts discussed?”

Manjula said,

“That naturally happens when a household is being set up.”

Komal said nothing.

Shashibhushan read the third question.

“Is there social pressure behind the word ‘voluntary?’”

This time the room fell silent.

Aniruddha said softly,

“Mrinalini told me that her father says, ‘Your family will not take dowry, but my daughter cannot go empty-handed.’”

Shashibhushan raised his head.

“Why did you not tell us earlier?”

“I thought it was a matter for their family.”

Komal said,

“Who decides how empty an empty hand is?”

No one answered.

The following Sunday there was a campaign meeting.

The subject was—“The Difference Between Voluntary Giving and Pressure.”

The topic had been fixed two weeks earlier.

Even if he wished to, Shashibhushan could not change it.

The meeting was held at the panchayat building.

The red banner was spread out again.
 The booklets lay on the table in front.
 Shashibhushan began speaking in his usual way.
 "Dowry is not merely the name of cash or goods..."
 At that sentence his eyes fell on Komal in the front row.
 The same notebook was in Komal's bag.
 Komal did not take it out.
 Shashibhushan's voice faltered for a moment.
 Then he completed the speech.
 After the meeting three young men surrounded him and said,
 "Babu, your son's wedding will become an example."
 Shashibhushan smiled faintly.
 "Before making an example of it, we must examine the accounts of
 our own house."
 People took this for modesty.
 Shashibhushan knew the answer was only half the truth.
 Two days later Jagdish Mandal came to the house.
 He carried a box of sweets.
 They discussed the wedding date.
 Then Vimala said gently,
 "We are not asking for anything. Whatever you give your daughter is
 entirely your wish."
 Jagdishji breathed a sigh of relief.
 "That speaks of your values."
 At that moment Shashibhushan asked,
 "Jagdishji, what if you give nothing at all?"
 Jagdishji was startled.
 "Nothing at all?"
 "Yes. Clothes and jewellery, whatever your daughter wants for herself.
 But household goods, a vehicle—nothing."
 Jagdishji said at once,
 "How can that be? What will people say?"
 Shashibhushan remained silent for a few moments.
 Then he asked,
 "Is fear of what people will say voluntary choice?"
 Jagdishji kept looking at his face.
 "I understand what you are saying. But am I not to give my daughter
 anything?"

Aniruddha, who was standing at the doorway, said,

“Babuji, whatever Mrinalini wants for herself is hers. We will meet the needs of our home together.”

Jagdishji’s eyes went to Aniruddha.

“The refrigerator?”

Aniruddha laughed.

“The old one still works.”

“The scooter?”

“The bus works.”

No one laughed.

Jagdishji did not open the box of sweets.

After a long time he said,

“I am afraid people will say—the schoolmaster gave his daughter nothing.”

Shashibhushan said softly,

“I too was afraid people would say—the coordinator’s son has an empty room.”

The two older men looked at each other.

This time the conversation was less about the definition of dowry than about their own fears.

The date was fixed.

But the notebook was not finished with.

Vimala did not tear it up.

She said,

“A household will still need things to run.”

Komal replied,

“Then make an account in which each pays half.”

Vimala was annoyed.

“A marriage is not arithmetic in a textbook.”

For the first time, Mrinalini joined the discussion directly.

She said to Aniruddha on the phone,

“Even half-and-half is not necessary. Each according to what they can afford. But the list must not go to my father’s house.”

Aniruddha asked,

“Will it stay in our house?”

“Yes. Our list. Not a condition of marriage.”

Aniruddha bought a new notebook.

On the first page he wrote—“Expenses After the Wedding.”

Below it he made three columns.

"Needed now."

"Later."

"Not needed."

The bed from the old list went under "Needed now."

The refrigerator under "Later."

The mixer under "Later."

The scooter under "Not needed."

Beside "cupboard," Mrinalini wrote—"There is an old one in the house; we will manage with that first."

Vimala looked at the notebook.

"You will buy all this after the wedding?"

Aniruddha said,

"Yes. When we have the money."

Vimala said,

"People will see the new bride in an empty room."

Mrinalini smiled.

"The room will not be empty. I will be there."

Vimala did not answer.

A week before the wedding, the campaign members decided that a plaque reading "Dowry-Free Marriage" should be presented at the ceremony.

Aniruddha and Mrinalini were the first names proposed.

Shashibhushan stopped them at once.

"No plaque."

His colleague Ramvilas asked,

"Why? This is a matter of pride for our campaign."

Shashibhushan said,

"A wedding is to take place, not an examination."

"But people will be inspired."

"First we must get the meaning of our own words right."

Ramvilas laughed.

"You are becoming very strict."

Shashibhushan replied,

"I became strict too late."

On the wedding day, the campaign's red banner was not put up at the gate of the house.

Shashibhushan did not want the wedding to become a display for the campaign.

The wedding pavilion was simple.

Jagdishji gave his daughter clothes, books, and an old brass plate from her maternal home.

Mrinalini had chosen the plate herself.

No other large item arrived.

Some guests whispered.

“Masterji gave nothing?”

Someone said,

“Because he was afraid of the coordinator.”

Another said,

“No, it is a matter of principle.”

The truth lay somewhere between the two remarks.

Jagdishji heard the whispering.

His face tightened slightly.

Mrinalini squeezed his hand.

“Babu, I wanted the plate.”

Jagdishji nodded.

Three days after the wedding, Vimala took out the old “Household Arrangements” notebook again.

A few pages were blank.

The five red circles were still there.

She placed the notebook before Shashibhushan and said,

“Shall I throw it away?”

Shashibhushan said,

“No.”

“Then?”

“I will keep it in the campaign file.”

Vimala was surprised.

“Our household notebook?”

“Precisely because it is from our house.”

“Will people read it?”

“Not the names. But the example will remain.”

Komal was there.

She asked,

“What will you write?”

Shashibhushan thought for a long time.

Then, on a blank page of the new edition of the booklet, he wrote—

“Pressure does not disappear simply because a demand is renamed ‘customary giving,’ ‘gift,’ ‘setting up a household,’ or ‘voluntary.’ Apply the five questions to your own home as well.”

Komal read it.

“Will this line be printed?”

“Yes.”

“In whose name?”

Shashibhushan smiled.

“In the campaign’s name. The mistake is not mine alone; it belongs to the custom. But I will write down my own part in it.”

The next month the new booklet was printed.

On the first page was the old slogan—“No dowry; we want equality.”

On the last page, the five lamps remained just as they were.

But a new line had been added below them—

“Ask these five questions first in your own home.”

At a meeting, when Shashibhushan came to this line, a young man asked with a laugh,

“Coordinatorji, why this new rule?”

Shashibhushan looked toward the old notebook lying at the corner of the stage.

The notebook was closed.

Inside it, the red circles were safe.

Shashibhushan said,

“Because it is easy to speak of principles from a stage. At home, the things covered by those principles acquire different names.”

The gathering fell silent.

He went on,

“And changing the name does not change the nature of a demand.”

This time the applause did not come at once.

Some people kept looking down at their feet.

Then an elderly woman in the back row began to clap softly.

A few hands joined in.

Shashibhushan did not smile.

More than the applause, he remembered the moment when he had seen five red circles on the notebook from his own house.

A few months later, a new bed arrived in Aniruddha and Mrinalini’s room.

The two of them had bought it with their own money.

The refrigerator was still old. No scooter came. The brass plate was on a shelf in the kitchen. From time to time Vimala took it down and polished it.

One day Komal joked, “Kaki, is this dowry?” Wiping the plate with a cloth, Vimala said, “No. It is the old plate Mrinalini chose.”

Komal asked again, “The five lamps?” Vimala paused for a moment. Then she said, “Light all five. Then we can say.” On the veranda, Shashibhushan heard this answer. He said nothing.

The campaign’s red banner was drying in the sun on the wall. The old fold lines were still visible on it. But this time, before folding it, Shashibhushan placed the booklet containing the five questions inside. The banner and the booklet were folded together. For the first time, the slogan of the stage and the questions of the home lay within the same fold.

Everyone's Opinion

A strip of red cloth had hung on the veranda of Sonbarsa's panchayat building for a year and a half.

In white letters it read, "Open Discussion Meeting."

Below it, in smaller letters, was another sentence: "We all think independently."

The right corner of the strip had curled a little in the rain, but the sentence remained clear.

In the village, a meeting was held on this veranda on the evening of the second Sunday of every month.

Sometimes the talk was about tap water, sometimes about the market day, sometimes about the crowd near the school gate.

Shyamsundar Babu opened the meeting.

He was fifty-five, loud-voiced, and quick to fashion a sentence on any subject.

One sentence of his had almost become a proverb in the village: "We all think independently."

He would say it, and the people seated before him would nod.

The first time, someone had said, "Quite right."

The second time, two people had said together, "We all think independently."

After that, the reply became customary.

Shyamsundar Babu would say the sentence.

From row after row came the response: "We all think independently."

Sometimes someone arrived late, and then his neighbour would nudge him with an elbow and say, "Say it."

He too would say, "We all think independently."

Sudhanshu kept the meeting register.

Sudhanshu wrote in a neat hand, recording the date, the subject, the names of those present, the proposals, everything.

At the beginning of the register entry he invariably wrote one line: "The meeting was held in an atmosphere of complete freedom of thought."

No one questioned this line.

There seemed no need to question it.

For on the next page of the register were the signatures of everyone present.

One Sunday the subject was whether the weekly market should remain on Wednesday or be shifted to Friday.

Fewer buses ran on Wednesday, but more farm labourers were paid on Friday.

The shopkeepers were divided into two groups.

The milk sellers looked to the timing of the morning buses.

Some of the women said that when the market was held on Wednesday, in the middle of the school day, the road became crowded.

For some people, the crowd around the time of Friday prayers was a concern.

The matter was not a small one.

The veranda filled up.

Shyamsundar Babu rose.

He looked once at the red strip, then at the people.

“Look,” he said, “there is no pressure on anyone here. We all think independently.”

From the front row came the immediate reply: “We all think independently.”

The second row too said, “We all think independently.”

The boys sitting at the back repeated with laughter, “We all think independently.”

Within three moments, the whole veranda was filled with the same sentence.

Shyamsundar Babu was pleased.

“That is why our meeting is different from those elsewhere,” he said.

Then the discussion about the market day began.

The first speaker said, “Wednesday is the old custom. I see no reason to change it.”

The second speaker said, “I think the same.”

The third said, “Thinking independently, I say Wednesday is right.”

The fourth said, “My independent opinion too is Wednesday.”

The fifth speaker rose, thought for a moment, then said, “Since everyone independently says Wednesday, mine is Wednesday too.”

Kanak was sitting beside one of the veranda pillars.

She ran the village tailoring shop and had come to the meeting for the first time.

A change in the market day would directly affect her work.

More customers came on Friday; Wednesday gave her time to deliver clothes.

She kept listening.

Eight people spoke in favour of Wednesday.

The first man to rise in favour of Friday said, "I prefer Friday myself, but since everyone says Wednesday, then..."

Before he could finish, someone from the back said, "Say your independent opinion."

People laughed.

The man laughed too, and in the end said, "All right, Wednesday."

Kanak raised her hand.

Shyamsundar Babu saw her.

"Speak, Kanak sister."

"I want Friday."

The veranda did not fall completely silent, but the direction of the sound changed.

A few people looked towards her.

Shyamsundar Babu smiled.

"Very good. That is what freedom means."

Kanak said, "But I will give my reason too."

"Certainly."

"On Friday, customers have their wages in hand. Women buy clothes, oil, salt, medicine, everything that day. When the market is on Wednesday, many people go to another market on Friday."

Sudhanshu wrote in the register: "Kanak Devi—Friday."

He did not write the reason.

Kanak kept looking at his hand.

There was no vote at the end of the meeting.

Shyamsundar Babu said, "The majority in favour of Wednesday is clear."

The register recorded: "After free deliberation, unanimous decision to retain Wednesday."

While signing, Kanak noticed the word "unanimous."

She asked Sudhanshu, "I said Friday. Then how is it unanimous?"

Putting the cap on his pen, Sudhanshu said, "Did you object at the end?"

"I said Friday."

"But you were silent when the decision was made."

Kanak looked at him for a few moments.

“So silence is a vote?”

Sudhanshu laughed. “That is how meetings work.”

The next month Kanak came again.

This time the subject was whether the empty space behind the veranda should be used for parking two-wheelers or left for children to play.

Shyamsundar Babu began, “We all...”

Everyone completed it together: “think independently.”

This time Kanak did not speak.

She kept watching Sudhanshu’s register.

After the meeting she asked, “May I take the register home for a few days?”

Sudhanshu was startled.

“Why?”

“I want to look through it as I look through old account pages in the tailoring shop. I’ll return it tomorrow.”

At first Sudhanshu refused.

Hearing this, Shyamsundar Babu said, “The register is public. Take it.”

That night, after closing the shop, Kanak opened the register.

On the page for the first month, the opening line was: “We all think independently.”

The second month too.

The third month too.

After six months, Sudhanshu had begun adding in brackets after this sentence: “Supported by all members present.”

On a page from a year later it was written: “Repeated in one voice.”

Kanak counted the old pages.

Seventeen meetings.

Seventeen times the same opening.

Then she stopped at one page.

Under the heading “Individual Opinions” were the names of forty-two people.

Beside most names the same sentence had been written: “We all think independently.”

In a few places only the order of the words had changed.

At the end Sudhanshu had written: “Total independent opinions—
42.”

Kanak placed her finger on the sentence and read it many times.

One sentence forty-two times.

Forty-two independent opinions.

The next day she returned the register.

She said nothing.

But a week before the next meeting, Shyamsundar Babu came to her shop.

He had freshly printed invitation leaflets in his hand.

"Kanak sister, distribute these among the people. This time the subject is important."

At the top of the leaflet, in red letters, was written: "Open Discussion Meeting."

Below it: "We all think independently."

Kanak asked, "Was it necessary to print this line?"

Shyamsundar Babu laughed.

"Why, this is the identity of our forum."

"If the discussion is open, why give people the sentence beforehand?"

At first Shyamsundar Babu did not understand the question.

"What do you mean?"

Putting the leaflet before him, Kanak said, "People read this sentence before they come to the meeting. As soon as they enter, you say the same thing again. Then everyone repeats it. In the register it is written— independent opinion."

Shyamsundar Babu's smile faded a little.

"Repeating a sentence and repeating an opinion are not the same thing."

"Right. So this time let us see without the sentence."

"What should we do?"

"Fold the banner and put it away. Strike this line from the invitation. Before the meeting begins, give everyone a small blank slip. Write only the subject. One line for the reason. No need to write a name."

Shyamsundar Babu kept looking towards the pillar.

Kanak said again, "If everyone still writes the same thing, I will accept that the sentence was not at fault."

Shyamsundar Babu picked up the leaflet.

"Shall we conduct an experiment?"

"Not on opinions. On the sentence."

That month the subject of the meeting was whether the village community hall should close at eight at night or remain open until ten.

The young men wanted ten o'clock.

The elders said there was noise late into the night.

The women's self-help group sometimes finished its meetings after eight.

Ramvilas, who looked after the hall, wanted to go home at eight.

There were genuinely different interests involved in the matter.

On the day of the meeting, the red banner was gone.

Only two old nails could be seen on the pillar.

People asked, "Where is the banner?"

Sudhanshu said, "It has gone to be washed."

That was half true.

The banner lay folded in a room at Shyamsundar Babu's house.

As each person entered the veranda, Kanak handed them a small white slip.

At the top it read: "Until what time should the hall remain open? Reason—"

There was no space for a name.

This time Shyamsundar Babu did not say his familiar sentence.

He said only, "First fill in the slips. Then we will talk."

The first five minutes were awkward.

Someone wanted to look at a neighbour's slip.

Kanak said, "Write your own."

Someone asked, "What is the right answer?"

Kanak said, "There is no right answer here."

A few people laughed when they heard this.

The slips were collected.

Sudhanshu began reading them one by one.

"Eight o'clock—the watchman's home is far away."

"Ten o'clock—the boys study here."

"Nine o'clock—a time between the two sides."

"Ten o'clock, but no music."

"Ten on the days the group meets, eight on the other days."

"Not a fixed time; let two people keep keys."

"Change Ramvilas's shift."

"Nine in winter, ten in summer."

Laughter rose in the veranda.

No two slips were exactly alike.

Shyamsundar Babu took the slips from Sudhanshu's hand.

He turned them over and over many times.

"Why did no one say so many different things before?"

A voice came from the back: "Before, you used to say it."

Everyone laughed.

Shyamsundar Babu laughed too, but not at once.

He asked, "What did I use to say?"

Four or five voices rose together: "We all think independently."

The laughter grew louder.

Kanak did not laugh.

She said, "See? The sentence is still ready."

Whether Shyamsundar Babu turned red or merely looked so in the veranda's yellow light, no one could say for certain.

He spread the slips on the table.

"Then today I will not say it. You all speak."

This time the discussion went on for a long while.

Ramvilas said that his home was two kos away, and if he stayed until ten, his evening meal grew cold.

Manoj, one of the young men, said that the hall's light was useful during examination months.

Rekha Devi of the self-help group said that twice a month her group kept accounts until after eight.

In the end a rule was made: nine o'clock on ordinary days; ten during examination months and on announced group-meeting days; and on late days the watchman's shift would be changed.

The decision did not entirely please everyone.

But this time Sudhanshu did not write "unanimous" in the register.

He recorded the three opinions separately.

Below them he wrote the reasons for the decision.

Kanak stood beside him.

"How many independent opinions in all?" she asked softly.

Sudhanshu stopped his pen and looked at her.

Then he wrote in the register: "The opinions were counted; the reasons were recorded separately."

The next month the red banner hung again on the veranda. It had not been washed; the old dust was still on it. But over the smaller sentence below, a narrow strip of white cloth had been sewn. "We all think independently" was covered. Only "Open Discussion Meeting" remained above it.

Shyamsundar Babu rose to begin the meeting. From old habit his mouth opened: "We all..." He stopped. The people on the veranda waited. No one completed the sentence.

Ramvilas, seated at the back, said, "What is today's subject?" For the first time, Shyamsundar Babu looked at the people's faces instead of at the red banner. He said, "First you tell me. What should the subject be?"

Not one voice rose. Many voices did.

Worthy of the Award

On the veranda of the block office, three things were almost always together on Naval Kumar's table—a blue pen, an old stack of carbon paper, and people's incomplete applications.

Naval was not a government employee.

In one corner of the panchayat building, the youth club had given him a table two cubits wide, where he filled out whatever applications people brought—old-age pension, scholarship, seed grant, caste and residence certificates, bank corrections.

Someone would leave five rupees for tea, someone vegetables, someone only say, "May God bless you," and go away.

Naval was not afraid of paperwork.

Where people saw six boxes, he saw six answers.

That was why the village said, "Go to Naval; the paper will find its way."

Saryu Kaka was the exact opposite when it came to paper.

He had an old tool bag made of red cloth.

The bag held two spanners, a cutter, a short length of rope, round leather washers, two or three nuts and bolts, and a thin iron wire.

Whenever a public hand pump in the village began to rattle, its handle came loose, or the water would not rise, someone or other went looking for Saryu Kaka.

If he was in the fields, he came from the fields; if he was at the market, from the market; if he was sitting down to eat, he went after his meal.

He took no wages.

If a part had to be replaced, the villagers pooled the cost.

There was no register.

No receipt.

Saryu Kaka would say, "Whether the pump works or not—that is the account."

One day in Ashadh, a notice arrived at the panchayat building.

The District Public Service Trust had invited applications for the "Jan-Sahara Award."

The notice said: “Continuous community service, solution of local problems, public participation, and lasting impact.”

Not the mukhiya, not the school headmaster, not the panchayat secretary—the first to say it was Ganesh the tea seller: “We should send Saryu Kaka’s name.”

When the suggestion spread, no one objected.

When Saryu Kaka himself heard, he laughed.

“If they give me an award, will the pumps repair themselves?”

Ganesh said, “No, but people will know.”

Lifting his bag, Saryu Kaka said, “People already know that if a pump breaks, they should call me.”

Even so, the people of the panchayat decided to send his name.

And the task of filling out the application naturally came to Naval.

The application ran to six pages.

The first page was simple—name, age, address.

On the second page was the question: “Year in which service began.”

Naval asked, “Kaka, since which year have you been repairing pumps?”

Saryu Kaka scratched his head.

“Since the first green pump was installed in the eastern hamlet.”

“The year?”

“The year Ramcharitar’s elder son was married.”

Naval stopped his pen.

“That answer will not fit in the box.”

The school’s old register was consulted.

The eastern pump had been installed twelve years earlier.

Naval wrote: “12 years.”

The next question: “Estimated number of beneficiaries per year.”

Saryu Kaka said, “Everyone who drinks water from the pumps.”

“How many?”

“Do people who drink water get counted?”

Naval did not laugh.

He counted the houses around the three public pumps, added the schoolchildren, and estimated the number for market days.

In the end he wrote: “Approximately 480 direct beneficiaries.”

Saryu Kaka looked at the page.

“When did so many people ever come to me?”

Naval explained, “Not to you. To the pumps.”

The third page was difficult.

“Innovation.”

Naval asked, “What is new in the work you do?”

Saryu Kaka opened the red bag and took out a worn leather washer.

“If you turn old leather over, it lasts another two months. When a new one is not available.”

Naval bent to write.

Saryu Kaka added, “But that is not new. My father did it too.”

Naval stopped his pen again.

The box could not be left blank.

He wrote: “Low-cost maintenance using locally available materials.”

Saryu Kaka could not read it; Naval read it aloud to him.

After a moment Kaka said, “What I do has such a grand name?”

The fourth page asked for “evidence.”

Here the difficulty increased.

There was no photograph of Saryu Kaka repairing a pump.

No receipt.

No work order.

Ganesh the tea seller said, “I will testify.”

The school cook said, “Take my signature too.”

Thirty-two signatures were collected from three hamlets.

Naval found old notes recording the days when the school had been without water.

In shopkeeper Mohan’s credit ledger, they found three old entries saying, “Leather for pump—Saryu.”

Someone said, “Now the application has become strong.”

Naval smiled as he arranged the papers in order.

On the fifth page was a box: “Project Head / Person Responsible.”

Below that box it was mandatory to enter a mobile number, email address, and time of availability.

Naval looked at Saryu Kaka.

Kaka had a basic mobile phone, but he was usually in the fields and often did not hear it ring.

He had no email address.

Naval said, “I’ll put my name here. If the people doing the verification call, I’ll get the message to you.”

Saryu Kaka asked, “It is my name that is being sent for the award, isn’t it?”

“Yes, Kaka. Think of this as only the contact box.”

Naval wrote his own name: “Naval Kumar.”

Below it, his own number and email address.

In small print there was a line: "In a team application, this person shall be regarded as the official representative."

Naval read it.

He paused for a moment.

Then he thought—a representative was only a representative; Saryu Kaka's name appeared above as the person doing the work.

The sixth page contained the declaration.

Saryu Kaka did not use a thumb impression; he wrote his own name.

Slowly, he wrote "Saryu."

Naval filled in the date and submitted the application.

Two weeks later, two members of the trust came to the village.

At that time the handle of the pump in the southern hamlet had broken.

Saryu Kaka was there.

They found Naval at the panchayat building.

The verification team asked, "How was the figure of 480 beneficiaries calculated?"

Naval immediately opened the papers.

"Eighty-seven houses around the three pumps, 214 schoolchildren, and a separate average for market days."

"The innovation using local materials?"

Naval showed them the worn leather washer that Saryu Kaka had taken from his bag and left as evidence.

"This is Saryu Kaka's method."

The verifier kept writing.

"And the documentation?"

"I did it."

"Coordination?"

"Me."

"Reporting?"

"Me."

Just then Saryu Kaka arrived.

The sleeves of his kurta were wet.

A rusted spanner was in his hand.

The verifier asked, "What role do you play in the project?"

Saryu Kaka looked at Naval.

Then he said, "When a pump breaks, I repair it."

"And the records?"

“Naval keeps them.”

“Beneficiary figures?”

“Naval does those too.”

“Reports?”

Saryu Kaka laughed. “I look at the water, not the reports.”

The verification team laughed too.

Naval felt vaguely uneasy, though he could not clearly say why.

A month later, a letter arrived.

The village’s name had been selected.

The list said: “Jan-Sahara Award: Naval Kumar, Project Head, Kusumpur Community Water Facility Initiative.”

At first Naval thought it was a printing error.

He took out the application.

The name was not wrong.

The paper was correct.

“Project Head”—Naval Kumar.

Below it, Saryu Kaka’s name appeared in the list of “Field Work Associates.”

Naval ran to the panchayat secretary.

The secretary looked through the entire application.

“You filled this in yourself.”

“For contact purposes.”

“The form treats the representative as the head.”

“But the work?”

The secretary shrugged. “The marks for the work are separate; the structure of the application is separate.”

The award ceremony was held at the district headquarters.

Saryu Kaka did not go.

“Why leave the pumps and sit there all day?”

Naval said, “Kaka, please come. I’ll say on the stage that the work is yours.”

“If it has to be said on the stage, why did you fill out the paper?”

Naval had no answer.

At the ceremony, his name was called.

Engraved on the brass-coloured plaque were the words: “For Outstanding Contribution to Community Water Service—Naval Kumar.”

Naval went up to the stage.

He accepted the award.

He came to the microphone for a brief speech.

He said, "It is Saryu Kaka who does this work."

Smiling, the host patted his shoulder. "That is the mark of leadership—giving the credit to one's team."

The hall broke into applause.

Naval's next sentence was drowned in the clapping.

When he returned to the village, people congratulated him.

Saryu Kaka turned the brass plaque over in his hands and examined it.

"It is heavy."

"Kaka..."

"What?"

"I'll write to have the name changed."

Saryu Kaka handed the plaque back to him.

"First look at the southern pump. Then look at the name."

The next morning, a child came running to Naval's table.

"Naval Bhaiya, the school pump is not bringing up water."

Naval was about to say automatically, "Call Saryu Kaka."

The child said, "He has gone to the market. Master Sahib said the award was given to you, so you should look at it."

Naval remained silent for a few moments.

Then he picked up Saryu Kaka's red bag, which had been left at the panchayat building the previous evening.

The children gathered around him at the school pump.

Naval worked the handle.

A hollow sound came from inside.

He opened the bag.

Of the two spanners, he did not know which one to use first.

Of the three round leather washers, he did not know which size belonged to this pump.

It had been easy to write "low-cost maintenance using locally available materials" in the award application.

The sentence could not tell him which nut inside the pump was loose.

Saryu Kaka returned at noon.

He saw Naval sitting beside the pump.

He said nothing.

He took the bag.

He opened the handle joint.

He inserted the thin wire.

He drew out a worn pin.

"This has to be replaced."

Naval asked, "How did you know?"

"From the sound."

"How can that be written on paper?"

Saryu Kaka laughed. "Learn to listen first. Write later."

The pump was working again within half an hour.

The children began filling water.

Naval picked up the red bag and walked behind Saryu Kaka.

That evening he wrote to the award trust. Not the whole story. Only one question: "If the person who fills out the application and the person who performs the service are different, on what basis is the name for the award decided?"

Ten days later, the reply came. "The name of the official project head entered in the original application shall be treated as final. There is no provision for changing the name after the result has been announced." Below it was written: "In the next cycle, state the team structure clearly."

Naval read the reply twice. This time he laughed. The paper was saying that the paper was correct.

The Bhadon wind was strong. Applications fluttered on the veranda of the panchayat building. Naval set the brass plaque on the table to hold the papers down.

A few days later, a new notice arrived—nominations for the next Jan-Sahara Award. This time the women of the village wanted to send the name of Sushma Devi, who for five years had been running evening study sessions for the children.

Naval opened the application. The same box was there again: "Project Head / Person Responsible." Beneath it, on the same line, were spaces for name, mobile number, and email address. Sushma Devi had no email address.

Naval stopped his pen and looked outside. In the distance, Saryu Kaka was walking toward the eastern hamlet with the red bag.

Naval wrote in the box: "Sushma Devi." In the space for the mobile number, he wrote his own. Then, on the back page of the application, he added a separate line: "Application filled out by: Naval Kumar; service performed by: Sushma Devi." There was no designated box for that line.

The wind rose again. The brass plaque remained on top of the papers as a weight.

That day, for the first time, the award on Naval's table was not an ornament but a paperweight. And beneath it lay the page on which the

names attached to the work and to the application had been written separately.

The New Rule

It was the first Monday of Agahan.

The gate of the Bhairavpur cooperative seed storehouse opened before sunrise.

One hundred and twenty sacks of wheat seed had been unloaded from a truck during the night.

In the morning mist, the white mouths of the sacks seemed pressed against one another.

Beside the gate hung a large yellow board—"New Rules for Seed Distribution."

The board was old, but the word "New" still shone in thick black paint.

Seventeen rules were written below it.

Rule 1—No entry without a queue token.

Rule 2—One person from each family.

Rule 3—Wait behind the yellow line.

Rule 4—Do not bring empty sacks inside.

Rule 5—Do not bring children with you.

Rule 6—Do not hand your queue token to another person.

The list went on like this up to seventeen.

Neelima Kumari, the new assistant clerk, was reading the whole board for the first time.

She had been posted to this centre three days earlier.

Bhola Paswan, the storehouse's old attendant, said as he swept, "If you read them all, the time for distributing seed will be over."

Neelima laughed. "How did so many rules get made?"

Bhola rested his chin on the broom handle.

"One for every incident."

"The first incident?"

Before Bhola could answer, the crowd at the gate grew.

Ramphal Mandal arrived with the first queue token.

Behind him stood Phulkumari Devi, and behind her, Jaynarayan Yadav.

Everyone took their place by the yellow line.

At eight o'clock, Secretary Harinarayan Jha arrived.

He ran a hand over the board to wipe away the dust, opened the lock, and said, "Order runs on rules."

The entrance to the storehouse was four cubits wide.

But an old iron cupboard stood on the right in such a way that it blocked almost half the doorway.

One door of the cupboard did not close properly.

Its brass-coloured handle stuck out by about a finger and a half.

Ramphal went inside.

As a labourer lifted a sack of seed, he settled it under Ramphal's arm.

While turning, Ramphal's sack caught on the cupboard handle.

The sack tore.

Wheat seed spilled across the floor in a stream.

Ramphal tried to hold the sack together.

The people behind him moved forward.

The doorway became jammed.

The secretary called out sharply, "Move back! Haven't you read Rule Three?"

Phulkumari said, "The line is outside. The jam is inside."

Harinarayan Babu looked at her, then at the torn sack.

"From now on, lift the sack under your arm and go straight out. Do not drag it."

Neelima said, "That has become a new rule."

"Yes. Write it down—Rule Eighteen."

Neelima looked toward the cupboard.

"What if the cupboard were moved?"

The secretary's face took on the look of someone being asked about something very far away.

"It is entered in the asset register."

"If it is entered there, can it not be moved?"

"There is a procedure for changing its location."

Gathering the seed that had spilled on the floor, Ramphal said, "In which register is the procedure for my torn sack?"

A few people laughed.

Harinarayan Babu did not.

Neelima wrote down Rule Eighteen, but did not pin the paper to the board.

Ten minutes later, there was another complication.

Phulkumari Devi's queue token bore her husband's name.

Rule Two said—one person from each family.

But Rule Seven said—"The holder of the queue token must be present in person."

Phulkumari said, "The token is in the name of the holding. The land belongs to both of us."

The secretary opened the register.

"The seed goes to the person whose name is written here."

"He has a fever."

"Then write an application."

"The seed is being distributed today. When will the application be considered?"

The secretary thought for a moment.

"All right. There will be a separate declaration form for a family member."

Neelima asked, "Rule Nineteen?"

Harinarayan Babu said, "Write it down. Decisions made in a crowd are not remembered."

By noon, Rule Twenty had also been created.

The reason was that an elderly farmer could not see the yellow line.

Rule Twenty—"If the yellow line has faded, people shall keep a distance of two cubits on their own."

Bhola Paswan said softly to Neelima, "We'll paint the line again tomorrow."

Neelima asked, "Then Rule Twenty?"

Bhola smiled. "The paint will dry. The rule will remain."

By evening, not even half the distribution had been completed.

People kept reading the rules on the board, showing their queue tokens, filling out declaration forms, and turning one by one at the doorway as they went in and out.

The cupboard stood silently in its place.

Corners of old papers were stuck to its door.

Neelima looked more closely.

They were old copies of rules.

One bore the words "Rule 11," another "Temporary Arrangement," another "With Immediate Effect."

When the centre opened the next day, Harinarayan Babu brought new yellow paper.

"Write Eighteen through Twenty neatly."

Neelima asked, "Where is the original paper for the first seventeen?"

"It must be in the cupboard."

"The key?"

The secretary felt through his pockets.

Three keys came out.

The first did not fit.

The second turned halfway.

The third opened the cupboard.

There were fewer files inside than expected.

On the top shelf were five old books of queue tokens.

On the second was a dried stamp pad.

Below lay a bundle labelled "Orders Concerning Distribution Arrangements."

More than half the cupboard was empty.

Neelima opened the bundle.

The oldest sheet was eight years old.

Its heading read—"Temporary Arrangement."

Below it was written—"During roof repairs, the records cupboard shall be placed temporarily on the right side of the entrance doorway."

Neelima read it again.

"During roof repairs."

Bhola spoke from behind her. "That roof was repaired seven years ago."

Harinarayan Babu took the sheet in his hand.

"Why wasn't the cupboard moved back?"

Bhola shrugged.

"The secretary was someone else then. The repairs were completed. The next day there was seed distribution. There was a crowd. It was said—distribution first, cupboard later."

Neelima pulled out the second sheet from the bundle.

It contained the decision from the meeting held that day—"To reduce crowding at the doorway, only one person shall enter at a time."

That Rule Eight had by now become Rule Four on the present board.

The third sheet was from the following year.

"To make the order of entry clear, a yellow line shall be painted."

The fourth sheet—"One person from each family."

The fifth—"No empty sacks inside."

Neelima kept laying the sheets on the floor in order.

Eight years of rules spread across the floor like a thin river.

Every one of them had begun at the same doorway.
Not one sheet contained a decision to move the cupboard.
Neelima picked up the first sheet again.

“Temporarily.”

Harinarayan Babu said, “Then it ought to be moved.”

Bhola immediately said, “The asset register.”

The secretary fell silent.

Neelima did not laugh.

She opened the asset register.

Cupboard Number 17.

In the location box it read—“Main room, right wall.”

The main room was indeed on the right side of the doorway.

“The register is not wrong,” Harinarayan Babu said.

Neelima asked, “The right wall is four cubits long. Why is the cupboard here in the doorway?”

They all went inside.

The rear part of the right wall was empty.

The cupboard could easily fit there.

But an old wooden plank lay on the floor.

Bhola moved the plank.

Beneath it, black letters showed through the whitewash—“Cupboard 17.”

A rectangle had been marked around it.

Neelima bent her knees and examined the mark.

“This was its original place.”

Bhola scratched his head.

“Yes. When the roof leaked, it was moved from here.”

Harinarayan Babu looked in turn at the doorway, the cupboard, the rules spread across the floor, and the old rectangle.

“So twenty rules were made in seven years?”

Bhola said, “Twenty are written now. Two rules were removed in between as well.”

The secretary stared at him.

“Why didn’t you say this earlier?”

Bhola replied calmly, “No one asked. Every time, they asked about the rule.”

Distribution was not stopped that day.

But at one in the afternoon, the secretary called three committee members.

The subject was—“Change of Location of Cupboard Number 17.”

As soon as the meeting began, one member said, “This requires a written procedure.”

Neelima pushed a sheet of paper forward.

“Make the procedure. But first look at the cupboard.”

Everyone went to the doorway.

Ramphal had come again to collect seed; half a sack was still due to him to make up for yesterday’s torn bag.

He pointed at the cupboard.

“My sack tore here.”

Phulkumari was there as well.

“My form was made here.”

The elderly farmer stood on the yellow line.

“I got Rule Twenty.”

The committee members looked at one another.

Neelima brought a measuring tape.

The doorway measured four cubits and two fingers.

The cupboard occupied nearly two cubits of it.

The clear passage was less than two cubits wide.

“The rules kept managing the crowd,” Neelima said, “but the crowd kept passing through half a doorway.”

One member said, “The cupboard is heavy.”

Bhola said, “Four men can lift it.”

“The files inside?”

“Half empty.”

“The asset register?”

Neelima opened the register. “Main room, right wall. The rear wall is also in the main room.”

For a few moments, no one had a new rule.

Four labourers were called.

The cupboard was lifted.

Beneath its feet remained four black square marks from seven years of dust.

The cupboard was placed against the rear wall, inside its old rectangle on the whitewash.

The doorway suddenly began to look wide.

Bhola carried a sack under his arm from outside to inside, turned, and came back out without twisting his body.

Ramphal said, “What number is this rule?”

This time Harinarayan Babu laughed.

“No number.”

The next morning, the yellow board was back at the doorway.

The twenty rules were still written on it.

People stood in line.

But the movement in and out had changed.

Two people could now pass each other side by side.

Sacks no longer caught on the cupboard.

Before a crowd could gather at the yellow line, the queue kept moving forward.

By noon, twice as much seed as the previous day had been distributed.

The paper for Rule Eighteen lay on Neelima’s desk.

So did Rule Nineteen.

So did Rule Twenty.

In the evening, the committee met again.

Harinarayan Babu said, “The board needs to be revised.”

One member proposed, “Cross out the rules that are no longer necessary.”

Another said, “Crossed-out rules will cause disputes later. Make a new list.”

A third pulled a sheet toward himself and began writing the heading — “Revised New Rules.”

Neelima did not stop his hand.

She merely placed the first sheet, eight years old, in front of him.

“During roof repairs... temporarily.”

For a while, the room was quiet.

Harinarayan Babu picked up his pen.

“Add one thing.”

Neelima asked, “Another rule?”

“No. One question before writing a rule.”

Above the board, just before “New Rules for Seed Distribution,” he wrote one line—

“What is the root difficulty?”

A committee member said, “That too has become rather like a rule.”

Harinarayan Babu thought for a moment.

Then he set back on the table the pen he had lifted to write “Rule 21.”

“No number.”

Bhola laughed from behind them.

“If you give it a number, people will start obeying instead of answering.”

The following week was the final day of seed distribution.

The board was still there.

Of the twenty rules, some had red lines drawn through them, some bore the word “Necessary,” and some “Reconsider.”

At the very top was the question—“What is the root difficulty?”

Ramphal carried his final sack through the doorway with ease.

He did not stop to read the board.

Neither did Phulkumari.

The elderly farmer paused for a moment at the yellow line, then saw that the queue was moving and stepped forward.

At her desk, Neelima was folding the papers for Rules Eighteen, Nineteen and Twenty.

She did not throw the three sheets away.

She placed them with the old bundle.

On top she wrote a small slip—“Rules made before the cupboard was moved.”

Harinarayan Babu read the slip.

“Why are you keeping these?”

Neelima looked toward the cupboard in its new place.

“So that next time, before someone makes a rule, they will look to see whether a cupboard is standing in the doorway.”

Outside, as the gate was being closed, the yellow board trembled lightly in the breeze.

The twenty rules were still written there, but the doorway was fully open.

The Cupboard Inside

The Bhadon rain had stopped three days earlier. The western wall of the innermost room was still damp.

Across the white limewash, brown dampness had climbed from bottom to top. Suresh, the mason, tapped the wall and said,

“This time a coat over the top won’t do. We’ll have to open it up all the way behind.” Dilip asked, “How do we open the back?”

Suresh pointed at the old iron cupboard. “This has to move first.” The cupboard had stood in that same place for eleven years.

It had come to be known in the house as the cupboard inside, because it was not in the sitting room but in the innermost room of the house.

Kamla Devi slept there at night, Sushma sewed there in the afternoons, and in winter Parna studied there.

The cupboard’s black-grey paint had been scraped away in many places.

In the middle of the right-hand door was a round mark where, years ago, Parna had struck it with a bowl while playing.

A small bloom of rust had broken out in the lower corner. Dilip said casually, “Empty it. It’s a five-minute job.”

Sushma was shelling peas on the veranda at the time. She raised her head and looked at the cupboard. “Five minutes?” Dilip laughed.

“Take out the clothes, take out the papers, that’s all.” Sushma began dropping peas into the bowl again. “All right.”

Dilip heard no question in that “all right.” In the afternoon, Abhay came home early from the office.

He said that before the cupboard was moved, it would be sensible to make digital copies of all the papers.

“What is the point of keeping so many old papers? We’ll put everything on the phone.” Meera heard him and came inside. “First let’s see what is there.”

Parna followed her in. Kamla Devi sat up on the cot. “Don’t throw away my pension papers.” Abhay burst out laughing.

“Grandmother, no one is going to throw away your pension.” Sushma rose to fetch the key.

The key was not tucked into the fold of her sari, as Dilip had assumed. From a small wooden peg above the window, she took down a loop of blue thread.

There were two keys on the loop. When the cupboard opened, it was papers, not clothes, that came into view. On the narrow top shelf lay two blankets and three dhotis.

The other three shelves were filled with cloth folders, old envelopes, plastic bags and files tied with string. Parna exclaimed in surprise,

"Whose are all these?" Sushma said, "The household's." Abhay picked up a folder with a red border. Written on it was: "Kamla Devi—pension, bank, medicines."

On another: "Meera—education, bank, health." On a third: "Parna—school, birth, vaccination." On a fourth: "Sushma—originals."

Dilip peered into the cupboard. "Where are the men's papers?" Sushma took a thin green bag from the upper corner. "Here."

Dilip weighed the bag in his hand. "Only this much?" Meera laughed. "Three shelves for us, half a bag for all of you." Dilip said,

"We have fewer papers." Sushma said quietly, "Our names have changed fewer times." For a moment, the room fell silent.

Trying to lighten the mood, Abhay said, "Come on, today this mystery will be solved too." He spread a white sheet over the cot.

"We'll sort them person by person. Let each one make a pile of what belongs to them." Sushma said nothing. The folders began coming out one by one.

Kamla Devi's folder was the thickest of all.

It contained old ration slips from after her marriage, three old bank passbooks, her pension order, receipts for life certificates, medicine prescriptions, and her name written four different ways.

On one paper: "Kamla Devi." On another: "Kamli Devi." On a third: "Kamla Jha."

On an old letter there was only: "Kamla, wife of the late Raghunath." Kamla Devi put on her glasses and looked. "Who is this Kamli?" Sushma said,

"You." "When did I become Kamli?" "That is how the clerk wrote it in the first pension register." Kamla Devi shook her head.

"I don't remember." "I do." Sushma's reply was matter-of-fact, but Meera looked at her.

Abhay set the paper with "Kamli" written on it to one side. "It's wrong. Shall I throw it away?" Sushma said at once, "No." "Why?"

"The first pension account was opened using that paper. Later, the correction letter was attached to it." Abhay stopped his hand.

Sushma took out a thin sheet. "Look—Kamli to Kamla." Parna burst out laughing.

"Great-grandmother had to prove that Great-grandmother really was Great-grandmother?" Kamla Devi laughed too. "The government had more doubts about me than I did."

Meera opened her folder. Her B.A. certificate carried her parental-home address. Her bank passbook carried her address after marriage.

On one health document her name was "Meera Kumari." On another it was "Meera Abhay Jha."

A photocopy of the marriage registration was attached to one application. Meera frowned. "When did all this come to you?" Sushma said,

"It was in the trunk your father gave you after the wedding. Your mother-in-law said, 'Leave the papers with Sushma.'"

Meera asked directly, "Was I asked?" The room went silent again. Dilip coughed and began looking outside.

The phone remained in Abhay's hand. Sushma met Meera's eyes. "No." Meera looked at the papers for a while.

"Did anyone ask you either whether you would keep everyone's papers?" This time Sushma did not smile. "No." Kamla Devi said softly,

"Earlier, the daughter-in-law who lived in the inner part of the house kept the key." Sushma looked at her. "Was it the key she kept, or the work?"

For a few moments, the old days settled over Kamla Devi's face. "Both." Parna was looking at the inside of the cupboard door.

Suddenly she asked, "Why are all these knots here?" Twelve short threads were tied along the inner left side of the cupboard.

Some were red, some blue, some faded yellow. Some had only one knot, some had two. Abhay had never noticed them before.

Sushma rose and went to the cupboard. "Months." "Months?" "Twelve months." She touched the first knot. "Kartik—Mother's life certificate." The second.

"Agahan—Parna's school fee-waiver application." The third. "Pus—renewal of Meera's health document." The fourth.

"Magh—not the house insurance, the name-check on the electricity account." Dilip interrupted, "That is in my name." Sushma looked at him.

"Do you remember the date?" Dilip fell silent. Parna excitedly began counting the remaining knots. "Phagun, Chait, Baisakh..." Sushma said,

"Papers run less by names than by time." Abhay was still enthusiastic about making digital copies. He said,

“We’ll put all these dates on the phone. The cupboard will become lighter.” Sushma nodded. “Write them.” She did not object.

That seemed simple enough to Abhay. From outside, the mason called, “How much longer?” Dilip answered, “Half an hour.” Suresh laughed.

“Five minutes has become half an hour.” Sushma heard him but said nothing. Abhay began making digital copies.

He straightened each paper, held the phone camera above it, and named the files—“Grandmother pension,” “Meera bank,” “Parna school.”

Meera stopped him. “Add the date.” Abhay said, “It will show when the digital file is opened.” Meera looked at Sushma. “Write the date separately.”

Abhay wrote it. Dilip opened his green bag and looked inside.

It contained land-revenue receipts, bank papers, an old challan book and two certificates. With satisfaction he said,

“See? Ours are straightforward.” Sushma asked, “Where is the original of this old land receipt?” Dilip stopped. “Isn’t this the original?”

“This is a photocopy.” “The original?” From behind Kamla Devi’s folder, Sushma took out a brown envelope.

“It bore your father’s name. When Mother’s pension papers were being prepared, this original was needed along with the genealogy certificate, so it came here.”

Dilip took the paper. “So even the men’s papers end up in a woman’s folder?” Meera smiled. “Papers obey the rules of the house too.”

Kamla Devi laughed. Sushma did not. She opened Parna’s folder.

Birth certificate, vaccination card, three school slips, a small bank passbook, four copies of photographs.

On the back of one paper, in pencil, was written: “Original with Meera, copy at school.” Meera read it and started. “The original is with me?” “It was.”

“Where?” “In the bottom layer of your red trunk.” Meera got up. Ten minutes later she returned with the original from the red trunk.

“I didn’t remember.” Sushma said, “That is why I wrote it.” Meera kept the paper in her own hand. “From now on, this stays with me.”

Sushma said only, “All right.” In that “all right,” neither protest nor relief was clearly visible. Parna went on reading her school slips.

Suddenly she picked up Sushma’s folder. “Grandmother, yours?” Sushma laughed. “Yes, now look at mine too.”

“Grandmother, why is your folder so thin?” Sushma’s folder really was thin.

It contained an old school certificate, one bank passbook, a copy of her voter card, and two papers concerning land at her parental home.

That was all. Abhay asked, "The rest?" Sushma did not understand. "What rest?" "Your papers." Sushma thought for a moment. "These are all."

Meera turned the folder over and over. "Your health document?" "It was never made." "Why?" "I never got the time." Abhay said casually,

"We'll get it made." Sushma looked at him. "When?" There was no answer on Abhay's face. Parna counted the cupboard's twelve knots again.

"Which knot is yours?" Sushma laughed. "No knot is tied for my work." "Why?" "I remember."

Meera said at once, "Why would the person who keeps everyone else in mind remember her own work?" This time Sushma looked at Meera for a long while.

Outside, Suresh had begun knocking loose plaster from the wall with a hammer. The thud-thud came all the way into the room.

Dilip looked at the papers spread over the cot. "Were you handling all this alone?" Sushma said, "How was I alone? The work belonged to everyone."

"But the remembering?" "The remembering was mine." No one laughed. Kamla Devi laid her palm on her thick folder.

"All I remembered was that in Kartik I had to go to the bank. She used to tell me the date." Meera said,

"I remembered that the papers were in the cupboard inside. Which paper was which, she used to tell me." Abhay said softly,

"I remembered that Mother had everything." Dilip said nothing.

Sushma looked at the empty bowl that had held the peas, still lying on the veranda. Parna asked, "Do you like this work?"

The question was so direct that Sushma could not answer at once. "It wasn't a matter of liking or disliking." "Then?" "It was work that had to be done." Meera asked,

"Who had to do it?" Sushma looked at the fingers of her hand.

"At first Mother-in-law did it. Then the papers increased. Her eyesight weakened. One day she gave me the key. After that, everyone began giving their papers to me."

Kamla Devi said quietly, "I thought, the daughter-in-law is educated, she will manage." Sushma smiled. "I managed."

Kamla Devi lowered her eyes. "I didn't ask." "No." Meera pulled her own folder into her lap.

“The same thing happened on my wedding day. The trunk came, the papers came here.” Abhay said, “I thought they were safe.” Meera looked at him.

“They were safe. But no one asked whose responsibility it was.” This time Abhay said nothing. Dilip looked at the shelves of the cupboard as they emptied.

“So what do we do now?” Before Sushma could answer, Meera said, “First, let each person be shown the papers that belong to them.” Kamla Devi laughed.

“If you explain everything to us, it will be night.”

“Let it become night,” Meera said, “but next Kartik you won’t be the only one running around.”

Sushma said nothing, but her face softened. Abhay opened a new list on his phone.

Sushma stopped his hand. “Papers first.” She placed Kamla Devi’s folder in her hands.

“Mother, the life certificate is in Kartik. The bank passbook is inside here. Don’t throw away the old paper with ‘Kamli’ on it.”

Kamla Devi listened carefully. “I won’t be able to remember.” “One person will stay paired with another.” Meera said, “I’ll be with her.” Sushma nodded.

“Then write two names on this folder—Mother and Meera.” Meera wrote them. Parna lifted her own folder. “Who is with me?” “Your mother.” “What about me?”

“Your name first.” Parna was delighted. She wrote her own name at the very top. Meera wrote only her own name on her folder.

Abhay asked, “Me?” Meera said, “If I need you, I’ll ask you—not the other way around.” Kamla Devi laughed.

Dilip looked at his green bag. “The original land paper?” Sushma handed him the brown envelope. “Now it’s yours.”

Dilip took the envelope, then asked, “The date of the next land-revenue payment?” Sushma remained silent. Dilip waited a few moments.

Then he opened the old receipt. “Is it written here?” “Look on the back.” Dilip turned it over. The date was written there in pencil.

He entered the date on his phone himself. Only then did Sushma say, “All right.” The afternoon was fading. Suresh peered inside and asked,

“Has the cupboard become lighter?” Abhay said, “Not much lighter; we understand more.” Suresh did not grasp what he meant. “I only have to move it.”

This time everyone laughed. The papers went back into the cupboard, but not in the old order.

Kamla Devi's folder was placed not on the bottom but on the middle shelf, where her hand could reach it.

It was decided that Meera's folder would go into her own small box; only verified copies would remain in the cupboard.

Parna's school folder went into the drawer of her study table.

Dilip put his brown envelope in the wooden chest in the sitting room, where he himself kept the key. The twelve knots still remained inside the cupboard.

Parna asked, "Shall I untie all of these?" Sushma said, "Not yet." "Why?" "First let's see how everyone's months run now."

Meera cut a small piece of paper. On it she wrote the twelve months.

Beside each month she wrote no name, only the task—life certificate, school, health document, bank, land revenue.

Then, after each task, the people taking responsibility wrote their own names in their own hands. Beside Kartik: "Kamla + Meera."

Beside Agahan: "Parna + Meera." Beside land revenue: "Dilip." Sushma saw the blank space beside her health document.

Parna put the pen in her hand. "Here?" Sushma wrote: "Sushma." Meera asked, "With?" Sushma looked at Meera.

"For now, let one name remain." Meera smiled. "All right." This "all right" was different from the first one.

Suresh and his helper slid the cupboard out. After eleven years, the wall behind it came into view.

There were stains of damp on the wall, a few cobwebs, and the grey rectangular imprint of the cupboard's four corners. Suresh said,

"See? Because it stayed inside, you couldn't even see what condition the wall was in." Parna immediately looked at Sushma. Sushma understood the look.

"Don't turn me into the wall." Parna burst out laughing. For two days the cupboard remained on the veranda. The wall was dried, the plaster replaced, and fresh limewash applied.

Meanwhile, the papers were kept in different places. On the first day Dilip found his brown envelope himself. On the second day Kamla Devi said to Meera,

"How many days until Kartik?" Meera counted. Sushma opened her mouth to answer, then closed it again. Meera herself said,

"Twenty-seven." Kamla Devi nodded with satisfaction. Parna came home from school and put her slips straight into her own drawer.

In the evening Sushma asked, "Did you write the date on the back?" Parna stopped short. Then she ran off. "I've written it now." Sushma smiled.

On the third day the wall had dried. Suresh asked, "The cupboard back in its old place?" Dilip looked at Sushma.

No one had asked her such a question before. Sushma measured the wall. "Two finger-widths to the south. Air will pass behind it."

Suresh shifted the cupboard two finger-widths south. The cupboard remained in the inner room, but there were not as many papers in it as before.

One whole shelf had become empty. Dilip asked, "What will we keep here?" Sushma said, "Let it stay empty for now."

That evening she opened her thin folder again. Beneath the old school certificate was a folded paper.

It bore the stamp of the health centre from six months earlier. Sushma read: "Get a blood test."

She moved her hand to fold the paper again. Then she saw the new month-list fixed inside the cupboard door.

She read "health document" written beside her name. She did not fold the paper again. She placed it on top of her folder.

The next morning, while drinking tea, Dilip asked, "Going to the bank today?" Sushma said, "No. Today I'm going to the health centre."

Dilip asked casually, "Whose work?" Sushma looked at him. "Mine." After a moment Dilip nodded. "All right."

He did not raise the matter of the bank again. From the inner room Kamla Devi called, "Sushma, where is my old paper with 'Kamli' on it?"

Before Sushma could answer, Meera called back, "Mother, it's with me. In your folder." Kamla Devi said, "All right."

Sushma quietly finished her tea. The cupboard still stood inside.

The keys were still on the loop of blue thread, but now there were three keys on the loop. One was Sushma's. One was Meera's.

The third, a small brass key, was in a box behind Kamla Devi's pillow. The twelve knots were still inside the cupboard.

But the work of the coming month would no longer pass through the memory of one woman alone.

Two Hours on the Roof

It was a night in Jeth. The day's heat was still trapped in the walls, but by ten a light westerly breeze had begun to move across the roof.

The rest of the household had gone with the wedding party. Neeraj, Ramudgar Babu, Ritu and Vibhor - all four had left at seven in the evening. Shailaja Devi had not gone because of the swelling in her knee. Kanak had not gone either.

As he was leaving, Neeraj had said three times, "Kanak, come along. Urmila Kaki from next door will stay with Mother." All three times Kanak had given the same answer: "I'll stay here."

Shailaja Devi had then assumed that her daughter-in-law did not want to leave her alone. Kanak had not explained her reason.

Dinner was over by eight. Two plates, two glasses, that was all. On an ordinary day, that much crockery would increase three times over in the middle of the meal - someone wanted curd, someone a second roti, a child dropped a glass.

Tonight the kitchen was unusually quiet. As Kanak washed the dishes, she kept glancing towards the doorway, as though at any moment someone might call, "Mother," or "Kanak."

Shailaja Devi covered the pot of dal and said, "I don't like so much silence."

Kanak laughed. "At first I used to like it. Now I don't know what to do with it."

At half past nine the electricity went out. One fan could run on the battery, but Shailaja Devi said, "It's stifling downstairs. There'll be air on the roof."

Kanak remembered that two white sheets had been hanging on the line since evening. "We'll bring the sheets down too. They'll catch dew at night."

The two of them climbed the stairs. Shailaja Devi climbed slowly; Kanak would go two steps ahead and then stop to wait. On an ordinary day Shailaja Devi would have cut short that waiting with, "Hurry up." Tonight she said nothing.

When they reached the roof, Kanak unclipped one corner of the first sheet. The moment the breeze caught it, the whole sheet billowed and

flapped. Instead of opening the clips on the second sheet, she sat down on the woven munj stool near the parapet.

Shailaja Devi asked, "Aren't you taking them down?"

"Sit for two minutes. The breeze is lovely."

Shailaja Devi sat too. There was a hand's breadth of space between them. The white sheets on the line filled with wind and then collapsed again.

Now and then the sound of a motorcycle came from the road below. Somewhere far away music was playing - perhaps from the same wedding party.

For the first five minutes they spoke only about the house.

"Should we get two extra litres of milk tomorrow?"

"Ritu has an exam. We'll run short of curd."

"Ramudgar Babu has only three tablets left."

"I'll have them sent for in the morning."

Then the conversation stopped.

Kanak rested her palm on her knee and looked out at the dark houses in the distance. Shailaja Devi suddenly turned towards the stairway door.

"What happened?" Kanak asked.

"Nothing. I thought someone called."

Both fell silent again.

A little later Kanak too looked towards the stairs. She distinctly felt that Vibhor was calling "Mother" from below. Then she remembered - Vibhor was not at home.

Kanak laughed softly. "My ears are ringing too."

Shailaja Devi looked at her. "What?"

"I thought Vibhor called."

Shailaja Devi laughed as well. "The house is empty, but our ears aren't."

After that sentence, for the first time, their laughter rose together.

The clock at the nearby temple struck ten. Kanak took out her mobile phone and checked the time. There were messages, but she switched off the screen again.

Shailaja Devi said, "Look at the wedding photographs. Everyone must have sent them."

"I'll look tomorrow."

"You like photographs."

"I do. But not today."

Shailaja Devi watched her for a few moments. "What do you want today?"

Kanak did not answer at once. The question was unusual. At home she was often asked what would be cooked, what was needed, what was left, what had run out. "What do you want today?" sounded different.

"Nothing," she said. Then she laughed at herself. "That isn't the right answer either."

"Then?"

"Maybe just two hours when no one calls me."

Shailaja Devi raised her eyebrows. "Two hours?"

"Yes. Without 'Kanak, look at this,' 'Kanak, give me that,' 'Kanak, answer the phone,' 'Kanak, where is the child?'"

As she spoke, Kanak's voice filled with mild irony. Shailaja Devi first tried to laugh, then her face grew serious.

"Do I say 'Kanak, look at this' too often?"

Kanak looked for a way out. "We all do."

"Do I say it too often?"

This time Kanak answered directly. "Yes."

The breeze blew the corner of a sheet onto Shailaja Devi's head and then lifted it again. She brushed the corner aside.

"Does it bother you?"

"Sometimes. I feel as though I'm taking an exam all day. The spices must be right, the curd right, the child's notebook right, the clothes right."

Shailaja Devi opened her mouth, but Kanak spoke first. "I know you don't say it to find fault."

"Then why didn't you tell me?"

With a finger, Kanak drew a straight line through the dust on the parapet. "When would I have said it? You say, 'There's too little salt,' and I say, 'I'll watch it next time.' Before anything else can be said, another voice comes in between."

Shailaja Devi too looked towards the stairs. This time no one called.

"I used to think I was helping you," she said quietly.

"You are."

"Then why does it feel like an exam?"

"It can be both."

A faint look of surprise came over Shailaja Devi's face. Kanak added, "When someone is watched all day, even help can sometimes feel like inspection."

For a while only the wind made a sound.

Shailaja Devi straightened her knee. "In the first year of my marriage, there was one day when the milk didn't come. Your father-in-law's

father had gone to the market. He said he would bring milk back. He forgot.”

Kanak listened in silence.

“There was no tea that evening. There were five people in the house. No one asked him why he had not brought the milk. I was asked, ‘Didn’t you remember?’”

Shailaja Devi laughed, but there was no amusement in it. “That was when I understood that whatever the house needs, remembering it in advance is a woman’s job. Someone else’s forgetting can become your own fault.”

Kanak said, “Is that why you ask about everything beforehand?”

“Perhaps. Is there milk? Is there gas? Is there medicine? Was the fee paid? Did you take an umbrella? Before anyone can ask, I ask first.”

“And you ask me.”

“Yes.”

“Then I ask Ritu.”

They looked at each other.

Kanak said, “I ask her five times about her pencil, water, notebook, everything. She gets irritated.”

Shailaja Devi smiled. “You test her?”

Kanak laughed. “Looks like it.”

The distant music stopped, then began again. The air on the roof was cooler now. The white sheets were still on the line.

Kanak suddenly said, “I didn’t stay back today only because of you.”

Shailaja Devi looked at her.

“Neeraj kept telling me to come. I didn’t. Half the reason was you. The other half was - I wanted the house empty.”

“Empty of me?”

“No.” Kanak laughed at once. “Empty of the house’s voices. One evening when no one asks for anything.”

Shailaja Devi adjusted the end of her sari. “I thought my daughter-in-law was devoted to serving me.”

“There’s nothing wrong with service. But sometimes, once it is called service, it becomes difficult to speak of your own tiredness.”

Shailaja Devi remained silent over that sentence for a long time.

“People call me very devoted to serving others too,” she said at last. “When my knee hurts, the praise is no use.”

Kanak burst out laughing. Shailaja Devi laughed too.

“What do you feel like doing when no one asks you for anything?” Kanak asked.

"Sleeping," Shailaja Devi answered at once.

They both laughed again.

"And after sleeping?"

Shailaja Devi looked towards the dark neem tree beyond the roof.
"Reading."

"What?"

"Whatever I can get. I can't even finish the newspaper. I look at the front page, then someone calls. I pick up a magazine and three months later half of it is still unread."

Kanak was surprised. "I see you reading, but I didn't know you wanted it this much."

"When did you ever get the time to ask?"

At that, both fell silent again. This time the silence was not uncomfortable.

From inside the cover of her mobile phone, Kanak took out a small folded slip.

"What is that?" Shailaja Devi asked.

"A new measuring-and-cutting class has started at the tailoring centre in the market. Saturdays from two to four."

"You want to go?"

"Yes."

"Then go."

Kanak did not laugh. "That simple?"

"What is difficult about it?"

"Ritu comes home between two and four. Babuji's medicine is at three. Vibhor's milk. The vegetable seller comes at four. Your knee hurts. Neeraj is at the shop even on Saturdays."

Shailaja Devi listened to each item. "You added all this up and cut out your own two hours?"

"I didn't cut them out. I just understood there was no room for them."

"Room can be made."

Kanak said at once, "And then you'll handle everything again?"

Shailaja Devi paused. "That wouldn't be right either."

They both fell into thought again.

After a few moments Shailaja Devi said, "Ritu is thirteen. She can come home and drink water by herself. Babuji can set an alarm on his watch for his tablet. Neeraj can give Vibhor a glass of milk if I tell him beforehand."

Kanak said slowly, "The vegetable seller will come again another time."

“Yes. The village won’t run out of vegetables because of two hours.”

Kanak laughed so loudly at this that her eyes went automatically to the stairway door. Then she remembered - no one was there.

The temple clock struck eleven.

Shailaja Devi said, “Has it been an hour?”

“Yes.”

“So quickly?”

“Because we’ve been talking without interruption.”

Shailaja Devi rubbed one hand over the other. “I have a slip too.”

“For what?”

“The library.”

Kanak’s eyes widened.

“Urmila told me that on Sundays from three to five women sit there, read and talk. She told me two months ago. I never went.”

“Why?”

Shailaja Devi looked at Kanak. “I didn’t like the thought of leaving you alone with the house.”

Kanak stared at her for a few moments, then held her head and burst out laughing. “You didn’t go because of me, and I didn’t go to the class because of you.”

“We kept doing each other good.”

“And swallowed up each other’s two hours.”

This time Shailaja Devi’s laughter came freely.

The wind grew stronger. One corner of a sheet came loose from the line and began to hang over the parapet. Kanak placed a hand down to rise, but Shailaja Devi said, “Leave it. It won’t fall.”

Kanak sat back down.

The small incident surprised them both. On an ordinary night, if a corner of a sheet hung even half a hand below the line, Kanak would get up at once. Shailaja Devi herself would say, “It’ll catch dew.”

Tonight they both kept watching. The sheet continued to drink in the wind.

Shailaja Devi said, “Do I stop you too much?”

Kanak thought before answering. “Not directly, very often. But I read your face and stop myself.”

“What kind of face do I make?”

“When I say I’m going out, you first begin calculating - the child, the meal, Babuji, milk. You don’t say, ‘Don’t go.’ But as soon as I see the calculation, I say, ‘Leave it.’”

Shailaja Devi turned her face and looked into the distance. "I think I am warning you about the difficulties beforehand."

"As soon as I hear the difficulties, I take them like a refusal."

"Then?"

"Maybe first ask, 'How long will you be out?' Not, 'How will the house run?'"

Shailaja Devi slowly nodded. "And you do this for me too."

"Me?"

"If I say I'm going to the library, don't begin with 'your knee.'"

Kanak smiled. "All right."

"And on Saturday I won't begin your class with 'Babuji's tablet.'"

"All right."

"But the tablet?"

"We'll teach Babuji to set the alarm on his watch."

Their laughter rose again.

After a while Kanak said, "There's one more thing."

"Say it."

"When you get tired, you don't tell me to sit down. You go and find more work for yourself. Then it feels almost wrong for me to remain seated."

Shailaja Devi was startled. "Do I stop you from sitting?"

"No. But you don't sit yourself."

Shailaja Devi looked at the woven munj stool beneath her. "I'm sitting now."

"That's why I'm saying it."

After a while Shailaja Devi said, "I remember my mother. After meals she would lie down on the cot for five minutes. I used to think - Mother rests a lot. After marriage I understood how five minutes are saved."

Kanak's eyes softened. "Did you forget to give your daughter-in-law those five minutes?"

"Perhaps."

"Will I forget to give them to my daughter too?"

"You might, if she doesn't remind you."

"Then I'll tell her - correct me."

Shailaja Devi laughed. "She already corrects you without being told."

The night deepened. The music now sounded very far away. The concrete roof was releasing the heat of the day and turning cool.

With one hand on the parapet, Kanak asked, "What did you misunderstand about me?"

Shailaja Devi did not laugh at the question. "Many things."

"Tell me one."

"I used to think you looked at your mobile phone too much because you were less interested in the house."

Kanak was silent.

"And now?"

"Now I understand that on the phone you are looking at tailoring measurements, school messages, bank notices, photographs of medicines - half the time you're looking at the house itself."

Kanak said, "And half the time I'm escaping."

"Where?"

"For five minutes where no one calls. I listen to songs. Sometimes I just stare at the screen."

Shailaja Devi nodded. "I didn't have a mobile phone, so I used to open the spice box for no reason and close it again."

Kanak laughed loudly. "What was that?"

"In the kitchen no one would ask why I was standing there. It looked as though I was working."

They laughed for a long time.

The temple clock struck twelve.

Kanak checked the time in surprise. "Two hours."

Shailaja Devi looked towards the sheets on the line. A faint dampness of dew had settled along the edges of both.

"Look," Kanak said, "because of me the sheets got damp."

Shailaja Devi touched them. "They're not wet. It's only dew."

"We'll have to dry them again in the morning."

"They'll dry."

Shailaja Devi said it so simply that Kanak looked at her face. They both stood up.

This time the sheets were taken down. Kanak folded one; Shailaja Devi the other. On the way downstairs, Shailaja Devi went first and Kanak followed.

Below, the house was exactly as it had been - the pot of dal, the medicine box, the school notebooks, the half-filled water bottle, everything in its place. Even without their attention for two hours, the house had not fallen apart.

Before going to sleep, Kanak asked, "Will we tell everyone tomorrow?"

"Tell them what?"

"What we talked about on the roof."

Shailaja Devi straightened her pillow. "Does every conversation need an announcement?"

Kanak smiled. "No."

"What has to change, we'll change and see."

The next morning the members of the wedding party woke late. Neeraj came into the kitchen looking for tea. Kanak was kneading dough. Shailaja Devi had the newspaper open.

Neeraj said, "Kanak, tea -"

Without lifting her eyes from the newspaper, Shailaja Devi said, "The water is on the stove. The tea leaves are in that tin. Make it."

Neeraj stood there for two moments, then opened the tin. Kanak kept kneading the dough.

A little later Ritu, searching for a school notebook, said, "Mother, my science -"

Before Kanak could answer, Shailaja Devi said, "Look in the second drawer of your desk."

Ritu went away. Kanak looked at Shailaja Devi.

"Am I testing her again?" Shailaja Devi asked with a smile.

"This time you gave her the answer."

"Next time we'll let her search."

On Saturday afternoon Kanak changed her clothes. It was ten minutes to two. Neeraj asked, "Where are you going?"

Kanak said, "Measuring-and-cutting class. Until four."

Neeraj asked casually, "Vibhor?"

Before Kanak could answer, Shailaja Devi said, "Vibhor is a child of this house, not Kanak's private possession. I'm here, and you'll be back from the shop at three."

Neeraj looked at Shailaja Devi. "I was only asking."

Folding the newspaper, Shailaja Devi said, "We have all spent too many years only asking."

Kanak suppressed a smile and went out.

The following Sunday at three, Shailaja Devi picked up her small bag. Kanak asked, "The library?"

"Yes."

Kanak did not ask anything about her knee. She only said, "Until five?"

"Yes."

"All right. Bring a magazine on your way back."

Shailaja Devi started towards the stairs. At the door she stopped and asked, "For you?"

“No. Whatever you want to read.”

Shailaja Devi went out.

The sounds of the house did not cease. Vibhor kept asking for milk, Ramudgar Babu forgot the time for his medicine, and the vegetable seller called out at exactly four. Some work still came back onto Kanak's and Shailaja Devi's heads.

But now, sometimes, one waited for the other to finish her sentence. Sometimes one of them would say, “Finish what you were saying first.”

And those two white sheets on the roof? The next morning they were spread in the sun again for half an hour. No one asked why they had caught dew during the night.

While taking the sheets down, Shailaja Devi said to Kanak, “See? They dried.”

Folding a sheet, Kanak replied, “Yes. Not every task has to be done at once.”

For a moment they looked at each other. Then they carried the sheets inside. The roof was empty again, but the space of those two hours had begun, little by little, to make room for itself inside the house as well.

The Daughter-in-Law's Room

On the day they received the keys to the new house, Sudha Devi first opened the rear veranda.

Just inside the large gate, Jagdish Babu's book room was on the right, Mukul's room on the left, the guest room ahead, and upstairs was Trisha's small study. Standing at the turn of the staircase, Sudha Devi said proudly, "This time no one will be able to say there is no space in the house."

Madhavi smiled.

When she had married two years earlier, they had all been living in the three rooms of the old house. Jagdish Babu and Sudha Devi in one room, Mukul and Trisha in the second, Madhavi and Aniket in the third. One corner of the veranda was always cluttered with Aniket's papers and mobile-phone wires.

In that house Sudha Devi had often said, "When the new house is built, I'll give you a separate room. A daughter-in-law needs a place for her own clothes, her own things, her own mind."

Madhavi had not taken that sentence as a joke.

While the new house was being built, she too had come to the site two or three times. But amid the masons, sand, gravel, paint and pipes, it had never been clear to her which wall would belong to whom.

Today the house was ready.

Sudha Devi came down the stairs and went behind the kitchen. There was a narrow passage. At its end stood a blue door.

"This is yours," she said, placing the key in Madhavi's palm.

Madhavi opened the door.

The room was not large, but it had a window. Through the south-facing window she could see the neighbour's guava tree. The walls still gave off the smell of fresh paint.

Madhavi's eyes went first to the window, then to the floor.

Three tin trunks stood in the middle of the floor.

In one corner were two sacks of rice, one sack of wheat, a box containing an old lantern, four folded iron chairs, a brass cauldron used for pujas and festivals, two extra mattresses, and four quilts tied up in plastic.

Madhavi laughed. "All this?"

Sudha Devi laughed too. "It's only here for now. We're moving house, aren't we? It'll be gone in two days."

Aniket came up behind them. He had a coil of electrical wire in his hand.

"Your separate kingdom," he said, standing in the doorway.

Madhavi tossed the key up and caught it. "Half the kingdom is ruled by sacks of rice."

Mukul called from the veranda, "Put my cricket bag in that room too. There's no space left upstairs."

Sudha Devi answered at once, "Keep it there for two days. After that everything goes to its own place."

Madhavi tied the key into the end of her sari.

On the day of the housewarming, the house filled with people.

Whoever came to see the new house, Sudha Devi took them around and showed them everything.

"This is Babuji's book room. This is Mukul's. Upstairs is Trisha's study. The guest room is in front. And at the back, a separate room for the daughter-in-law."

"A separate room for the daughter-in-law?" the aunts would ask approvingly.

"Yes, a daughter-in-law needs a place of her own too."

Madhavi was mostly in the kitchen at such times. But whenever she heard "the daughter-in-law's separate room," she thought of the blue door—and inside it, the quilts, sacks, chairs and cauldron.

Three days later, one of the tin trunks was removed.

It went into Jagdish Babu's book room, because it contained his old magazines.

The other two trunks remained.

"These have Trisha's childhood books in them," Sudha Devi said. "How can we throw them away?"

"Don't throw them away," Madhavi said. "Put them in Trisha's room."

Trisha spoke up at once. "My study is so small. Let them stay there until my exams are over."

Madhavi fell silent.

Two of the four folded chairs went to the guest room. Two remained.

As for the brass cauldron, Jagdish Babu said, "Don't touch it until Durga Puja. We'll need it."

The quilts were to stay until winter.

Within fifteen days the sack of wheat was half-empty, but another sack arrived and was placed beside it.

A month later the amount of stuff in Madhavi's room had not diminished; it had merely changed.

Her small cot was placed beneath the window. An old wooden cupboard came for her clothes, but on top of it were piled the household's empty tins, oil lamps, Chhath winnowing trays, and two bags of artificial flowers left over from a wedding.

Madhavi did not sleep alone in that room on the first night. She and Aniket slept in the main bedroom. The "separate room" was called Madhavi's during the day—for changing clothes, sitting sometimes, keeping her things.

Aniket had a work room of his own as well. In the small room at the front were a desk, chair, computer and drawers for papers. No one in the house went into that room very often without calling him first.

Madhavi noticed this difference gradually.

Her own door opened and closed all day long.

Sudha Devi needed rice.

Trisha needed an old school-certificate file, and no one remembered exactly which trunk it was in.

Mukul needed his cricket bag.

Jagdish Babu needed an old bronze lota kept inside the festival cauldron.

Bindo, who came during the day to sweep and mop, had her spare broom handle stored there too.

At first Madhavi handed the key to everyone.

Then she realised there was no point. Sudha Devi had a duplicate key made.

"It's household stuff," she said casually. "If you're out, the work shouldn't get held up."

Madhavi said, "Yes."

The door to the room could now be closed, but the room was not private.

One afternoon Madhavi had bathed and was changing her clothes. The bolt was fastened from inside.

Mukul knocked twice from outside.

"Bhabhi?"

"What is it?"

"I need my bag. The match is at four."

"Wait five minutes."

There was silence for a moment.

Then Mukul said, "It's just behind the door. Open it and I'll take it out."

Madhavi's hand stopped at the hook of her blouse.

She tried to laugh. "Cricket won't cease to exist in five minutes."

Mukul laughed too, but remained standing outside.

Madhavi changed her clothes and opened the door.

Mukul kept his eyes lowered as he took out the bag. On his way out he said, "Bhabhi, I'll keep this upstairs."

That evening the bag really was removed.

Madhavi felt pleased, but the next day Sudha Devi had two large canisters placed in the empty space.

"Only until the rains are over," she said.

For the first time Madhavi asked, "Ma, how long does 'only' last in this room?"

Sudha Devi did not understand the question. "What?"

"Nothing."

There was a small iron hook above the door. Madhavi hung her clothes bag from it. It was the only thing in the room that no one ever asked for.

Two weeks later the carpenter came.

Showing him the back room, Sudha Devi said, "Put wooden shelves all along this wall. Things get dirty when they stay on the floor."

Madhavi was sitting by the window shelling peas.

The carpenter measured the wall. "How deep?"

Jagdish Babu said, "Deep enough for the cauldron."

Trisha said, "And my box of books."

Mukul called down from upstairs, "One corner for my old sports things."

Sudha Devi added, "Make a closed compartment at the top for quilts."

The carpenter looked at Madhavi. "What do you need to keep?"

Madhavi had a pea in her hand.

She looked around the room.

"Mine?"

Sudha Devi said easily, "Yes, it's your room, isn't it? Have it made to suit you as well."

Madhavi laughed. "First decide how much of the wall will be left for me."

She had said it as a joke, so everyone laughed.

The carpenter did not. He went on writing measurements on his sheet of paper.

The wooden shelves were built.

The room looked better than before. The sacks were lifted off the floor, the quilts went up, the cauldron gleamed on a shelf, and the trunks slid underneath.

Sudha Devi was very pleased.

“See? Your room looks so much more open now.”

It was true: in the middle there was now a strip of empty floor about five handspans wide.

Madhavi spread a mat over that empty floor.

In the afternoons she sometimes sat there drinking tea, sometimes dried her hair there, sometimes simply watched the guava tree through the window without doing anything.

The shelves had organised the household things, but now people could find what they wanted more quickly; instead of decreasing, the sound of the door opening increased.

One afternoon an electrician was changing wires in Aniket’s work room. Aniket brought his computer into Madhavi’s room.

“I’ll work here for a while,” he said.

Madhavi rolled up the mat and gave him a corner for his table. Aniket shut the door.

Twenty minutes later Sudha Devi knocked for rice.

Ten minutes after that Trisha came looking for an old notebook.

Then Jagdish Babu needed the bronze lota.

The fourth time, Mukul came to the door and asked, “Would my white cap be behind the cauldron?”

Aniket lifted his head from the computer. “Why is everyone’s stuff in this room?”

Looking towards the window, Madhavi said, “Because this is my separate room.”

Aniket did not reply.

His work was interrupted again and again that day. In the evening he picked up his computer and went back to the front room.

Madhavi did not close the door. She only kept looking at the empty strip of floor in the middle.

In the first week of Ashadh, a municipal surveyor came.

For the assessment of property tax on the new house, the approved plan was being checked against the house as built.

Jagdish Babu took out the file and sat on the veranda. The surveyor went from room to room.

“This is the bedroom.”

“This is the study.”

“This is the guest room.”

“The store room at the back.”

Madhavi heard the words from the kitchen.

Sudha Devi immediately called out, “No, no, that is the daughter-in-law’s room.”

The surveyor looked at the plan. “The approved plan says ‘store’.”

“Whatever the paper says,” Sudha Devi replied, “we gave it to our daughter-in-law.”

The surveyor opened the door and looked inside.

Canisters, cauldron, quilts, trunks, winnowing trays, old notebooks, spare bulbs and festival decorations all sat in their proper places on the shelves.

Madhavi’s mat lay in the middle.

The surveyor said nothing. He made a mark on the paper and moved on.

Madhavi was standing half-hidden behind the door.

She was surprised: for the first time, an outsider who had never heard the household’s story had given the room its proper name.

No one discussed the matter that evening.

Madhavi said nothing either.

The next morning the carpenter came to collect the balance due to him. Two leftover wooden planks were leaning against the veranda.

Madhavi showed him the empty floor beneath the window. “Could you make a low platform from these two planks?”

The carpenter measured the space. “For storing things?”

“No. For sitting.”

Trisha heard and laughed. “There’s already a mat here.”

Madhavi said, “The mat can be folded up, and then everyone puts things on it. A platform can’t be folded.”

The carpenter asked nothing more. By afternoon a low platform, four feet long and three feet wide, stood beneath the window.

Madhavi wiped its wooden top and spread a thin seat on it.

That evening Sudha Devi came in carrying two empty oil tins. She moved towards the platform, then saw the seat spread there.

“Shall I keep these here?”

“This platform is for sitting, Ma,” Madhavi said.

Sudha Devi slid the tins beside the shelves. "Then this surface will stay empty?"

"Not empty. I'll sit here."

Two days later Jagdish Babu too noticed the platform. "A sitting place in the store room?"

Looking towards the window, Madhavi said, "If it has two names, let it have two uses as well."

Jagdish Babu pushed his glasses up, seemed about to say something, then quietly walked towards his book room.

Once or twice over the next week a bag or tin was left on the platform, but whoever came to sit there moved it beside the shelves. Gradually the platform ceased to be a permanent place for storing things.

In Sawan, Trisha's exams ended.

She took her box of old books upstairs.

"I have room now," was all she said.

The quilts remained.

The cauldron remained.

The rice canister remained.

Madhavi's platform by the window remained too.

One evening Sudha Devi's sister came from her parental home. While being shown around, she reached the blue door.

"Whose is this?"

Without thinking Sudha Devi began, "The stor—"

She stopped halfway through the word.

Madhavi was sitting inside.

Sudha Devi looked at her for a moment, then said, "Madhavi's room. Some household things are kept here too."

Her sister peered inside. "There's quite a lot of stuff."

Setting down the tea, Madhavi said, "When a house grows bigger, its things grow bolder too."

The two sisters laughed.

Even after that day there was no family meeting. No one said, "Empty the room."

But the movement of things began to change.

People had begun sitting more often on the veranda in the evenings, so the two remaining folded chairs went outside.

Jagdish Babu moved one bundle of magazines into his own book room. Mukul gave away some of his old sports equipment to children.

The Chhath winnowing trays went to the upper shelf in the kitchen. The scrap dealer took away two empty tins.

Not everything could be removed. The quilts and the rice canister were still there. Madhavi did not insist that everything must go either.

Two months later, the autumn breeze began to blow.

The platform now held a thin mattress, a glass of water, and a small tulsi plant in the corner by the window.

A new bolt that could be fastened from inside had been fitted to the door as well.

Mukul had fitted it with his own hands.

While installing it he had said, "Bhabhi, cricket can wait five minutes."

Madhavi looked at him. She remembered that afternoon behind the closed door.

"And ten minutes?"

"We might lose the match, but it'll wait."

They both laughed.

Before winter began, Sudha Devi brought two new blankets from the market.

She came as far as the door. She opened her mouth to say in the old way, "Keep these in your room—"

Then she stopped.

Madhavi was writing something on the platform.

Holding the blankets in her arms, Sudha Devi asked, "Where should I keep these two?"

Madhavi looked up.

It was a small question.

The room had not suddenly become completely empty. There were still quilts on the shelves, one canister, and a Chhath basket that had been forgotten there.

But for the first time, new belongings had stopped at the door before coming in.

Madhavi got up and pointed to an empty compartment on the upper shelf.

"Keep them here. Until winter is over."

Sudha Devi put the blankets away and went out through the door.

Madhavi sat down on the platform again.

Two leaves of the guava tree trembled in the breeze beyond the window. One corner of the platform was empty; no one's bag, tin or canister had yet been placed there.

The room was still half a store room. But that day, before crossing the doorway, two new blankets had paused and listened for the answer from inside.

The Key to Her Parents' Home

Anima's key ring held five keys.

Two were for her own house—the main door and the upstairs grille. One was for the cupboard at the school, where she kept science laboratory materials. One was for the vehicle. The fifth key was the oldest—the brass worn dull and tarnished, a faded dot of red nail polish on its head, and one corner of its teeth slightly bent.

One Sunday, Ajit took the ring in his hand and asked, "What does this old key still open?"

Anima was bringing tea from the kitchen. Without thinking, she replied, "My parents' home."

"Still?"

"Yes."

Ajit laughed. "They haven't put in a new lock?"

"The lock is old, stubborn like me."

"You're new enough."

Anima handed him his cup. "The key is old. Why are you turning me old along with it?"

The matter dissolved into laughter.

But the key really was old.

Ramlochan Babu had given it to Anima in the year when she was leaving home every morning at half past seven for teacher training and sometimes returning later than everyone else in the evening.

"No need to stand waiting at the door," Babuji had said. "It is your own home. Open it and come in."

At the time, her mother, Sushila Devi, had marked the head of the key with a dot of red nail polish. There were four or five keys in the house then; this was her way of knowing which lock each key opened.

On her wedding day, while sorting her clothes, books, certificates, and small belongings, Anima had picked up the key ring as well.

No one told her to return the key.

No one told her to keep it either.

The key simply went with her.

Nine years after the wedding, it was still on the ring.

In those nine years, much had changed in her parents' house.

Anima's old room had first become Raghav's study; after Raghav's marriage it was given to him and Purnima; and now Raghav and Purnima's son Anshu occupied most of the space with his books, coloured pencils, and toys.

Anima's old wooden table had moved to the veranda. Two boxes of her books were in the upstairs room. A small bed now stood by the window where she had once studied for her examinations.

These changes caused Anima less sorrow than wonder.

How could a house go on by keeping only memories?

If people lived in it, places would change.

Even so, the old lock on the main door was still the same.

And so was the key with the red dot.

When Anima reached her parents' house, she usually did not ring the bell.

She would put in the key, open the door, step inside, and call loudly, "Ma."

Sushila Devi would answer from the kitchen, "You're here?"

Ramlochan Babu, folding his newspaper on the veranda, would ask, "Straight from school?"

If Raghav was at home, he would say, "Didi, will there be tea?"

Purnima would laugh and say, "Now that Didi is here, tea will make itself."

And Anima would feel that the key opened not merely a lock, but an old sentence: "It is your own home."

One day, on her way back from school, she suddenly turned towards her parents' house.

She remembered that the packet of medicine she had bought for her mother had been lying in her bag for three days. She did not feel like calling. The house was only two lanes in from the road.

It was nearly two in the afternoon.

Raghav's motorcycle was not outside. Babuji's slippers were not by the door.

Anima inserted the key.

As usual, the old lock caught at first. She lifted the key a little and turned it. It opened with a 'click'.

She opened the door quietly.

There was an unusual silence inside.

"Ma?"

No answer.

She called again.

Then Purnima's voice came from the inner room. "Who is it?"

"Me."

A few moments later Purnima came out. Her hair was loose, the corners of her eyes red. A mobile phone was in her hand.

"Oh, Didi! You?"

"Yes. I came to give Ma her medicine. Where has everyone gone?"

"Ma and Babuji have gone to Mama's. Raghav is at the bank."

Purnima immediately switched off the mobile screen.

Anima asked, "Everything all right?"

"Yes, yes."

The answer came too quickly.

Anima put her bag on the table. "Shall I make tea?"

"No, I'll make it."

Purnima went towards the kitchen.

Anima kept watching her go.

She felt she had interrupted something.

A little later, she heard Purnima's low voice from the kitchen. She was on the phone again.

"No, Ma, I won't say anything now... yes... I was just feeling low..."

Anima stopped in the middle of the veranda.

Deliberately, she walked further towards the veranda so that she would not hear the rest.

Five minutes later Purnima came with the tea. Her eyes looked freshly washed.

Anima asked nothing.

Purnima said nothing either.

They drank their tea. When it was nearly time for Anshu's school bus to arrive, Anima got up to leave.

At the door, Purnima said, "Didi, next time, give me a call."

Anima asked naturally, "Why? Do you need anything?"

Purnima smiled at once. "No, just... if I'm at home, I'll keep the tea ready."

Anima smiled too.

As she locked the door from outside, the key with the red dot was between her fingers.

"Give me a call"—those three words stayed in her mind.

But three days later she again went in the old way, putting the key into the lock and walking inside.

A habit of eight or ten years does not change after a single hint.

This time both Ma and Babuji were on the veranda. Purnima was in the kitchen. No one said anything.

Anima herself was not prepared to attach too much importance to what had happened that previous afternoon.

"It is home," she said to herself.

"My own home."

Then a month passed.

In the last week of Sawan, Ajit's sister Deepa came with her two children for three days. Deepa had married two years before Anima. She lived at the other end of the city.

Ajit had already given his sister a spare key to the house. The reasons were straightforward—sometimes she had to leave the children there, sometimes Ajit was away, sometimes she needed to keep something at the house.

Anima had never objected to this.

The next day, Anima had a half-day training session at school. She returned at half past twelve. Ajit was at the office. Deepa had gone to the market with the children.

Anima bolted the door from inside, changed her clothes, warmed her food, and then, because her head hurt, sat on the sofa and closed her eyes.

She had hardly fallen asleep when she heard the lock turn.

The door opened.

Deepa came in with the children.

"Bhabhi, you're back?"

Anima sat up with a start. Her sari end had slipped from her shoulder; her notebook, school papers, and a half-written private letter lay open on the table.

Deepa's son ran towards the inner room. Anima quickly folded the papers.

"Yes, the training ended early."

"I thought the house would be empty."

"You could have rung the bell."

Deepa stopped. "I had the key, didn't I?"

The answer was entirely ordinary.

Anima knew, too, that no offence had been committed here.

Even so, in that moment, inside her own house, her body, her papers, her silence—all of it suddenly seemed exposed.

That evening, after Deepa had gone upstairs with the children, Anima said to Ajit, "Deepa came straight in with the key."

Ajit asked while taking off his shoes, "So?"

"I was at home."

"How was she to know?"

"She could have rung the bell."

Ajit, drinking water, said, "She thinks of it as her own home."

Anima's hand stopped on the table.

Ajit looked at her face. "What happened?"

"Nothing."

"Are you angry?"

"No."

The truth was that Anima was not angry with Deepa.

She was hearing one of her own sentences: "It is home. My own home."

Before going to bed that night, she placed the key ring on the table.

The red dot on the fifth key was still visible, though more than half the colour had worn away.

She picked up the key.

A piece of metal.

A tool for opening a lock.

A permission.

Or entry without permission?

Anima grew irritated with her own question.

Why measure a relationship in terms of keys and doors?

But the next time she went to her parents' house, the moment she reached the door, her hand moved into her bag by itself.

The key came into her fingers.

She moved it towards the lock.

She could hear the sound of utensils from inside.

Purnima was at home.

Anima's hand stopped.

She turned the key back and put it into her bag again.

She rang the bell.

A few moments later Purnima opened the door.

Her face was genuinely full of surprise.

"Didi?"

"Yes."

"Didn't you have the key?"

"I do."

Purnima opened the door fully. "Then why the bell?"

Taking off her slippers, Anima said, "You were inside."

Purnima looked at her for a few moments. Then she said only, "Come in."

Sushila Devi was cutting aubergine in the kitchen.

"Who came?"

"Didi," Purnima said.

Sushila Devi came out. "Why were you standing there ringing the bell like that? You have a key, don't you?"

Anima smiled. "I do, Ma."

"Then?"

"There were people inside."

It was not clear whether Sushila Devi understood the question. She said, "They are our own people."

Anima took the knife from her mother's hand. "I'll cut the aubergine."

The matter returned to the kitchen again.

That day Purnima was not unusually quiet.

She talked about Anshu's school, about prices in the market, and even about her younger sister's admission back at her parents' home.

Anima did not mention the telephone call from the previous afternoon.

When Anima was leaving, Purnima came to see her to the door.

"Didi."

"Yes?"

"That day... when you came suddenly..."

Anima stopped.

Purnima said again, "Nothing. Leave it."

Anima too said, "All right."

Purnima smiled faintly. "The bell felt good today."

Anima smiled back.

On the way home she thought—what a strange thing. Having a key was one kind of closeness; but ringing a bell was not distance. Sometimes it was respect.

After that day, Anima did not make a rule.

She did not write on a piece of paper that she would call before going to her parents' house.

Nor did she remove the key and put it away in some box.

Only the habit of her hand began to change.

If she heard sounds inside the door, she rang the bell.

If the house was empty and Ma had said, "Come and leave the packet there," she opened it with the key.

If she saw Babuji reading the newspaper, she sometimes tapped on the window.

At first Ramlochan Babu would say, "What is the use of keeping a key if you still have to ring the bell?"

Anima would laugh. "Its use is for when you are not at home."

Babuji would shake his head. "Too many rules now."

"Not rules."

"Then what?"

Anima would not answer. She herself could not find the word.

One afternoon she rang the bell. There was no reply from inside.

She rang a second time.

Then she called.

Ma said, "I'm on the roof. Open the door and come in."

Only then did Anima use the key.

The lock caught, as before. She lifted the key and turned it.

'Click.'

She felt an odd satisfaction—the key still recognised her hand.

During the autumn Navratri, the house began to be repainted.

Opening the door leaf, the workman said, "The lock is very old. Shall I replace it?"

Ramlochan Babu said at once, "No. It works."

Raghav laughed. "Babuji, this lock opens less according to the key and more according to the door's mood."

Purnima said, "Didi can open it."

The workman looked towards Anima. "Your hand is used to it?"

Anima showed him the old key. "Its teeth are bent, yet it still works."

The workman said, "If the lock is changed, this key will become useless."

Anima replied naturally, "If the lock works, let it stay for now."

Ramlochan Babu said with satisfaction, "See? A daughter understands the value of old things."

Purnima was closing a tin of paint. For a moment she looked towards Anima. Neither of them said anything.

The lock was not changed.

With the repainting, the door became green; the lock remained the same black-brown.

The key with the nail-polish mark continued to turn in the green door just as before.

In Kartik, Sushila Devi went to her parents' home for two days. Ramlochan Babu went with her. Raghav had to go to Patna for office work. Purnima and Anshu were at home.

Anima came in the evening to deliver some items for worship.

She rang the bell.

Anshu ran to open the door. "Bua, you have a key!"

"I do."

"Then why did I open it?"

Anima stroked his head. "Because you are at home."

Anshu was not satisfied with this answer. "A key is faster."

Purnima laughed from behind him. "The bell is more civilised."

At the word "civilised," Anima laughed too.

"Don't make such a big thing of it," she said.

After dinner that night Purnima said, "Didi, tomorrow I'm taking Anshu to the dentist. We'll be back by two. A book parcel is due to arrive. If you happen to come this way from school, could you receive it?"

Anima asked, "The house will be empty?"

"Yes."

"Then the key will be useful."

Purnima nodded.

The next day Anima arrived at half past one. The house really was empty.

Without ringing the bell, she used the key.

The lock opened.

She went inside; the man delivering the book parcel arrived, she received the parcel and placed it on the table.

There was no one in the house.

For a few moments she stood on the veranda.

All the sounds of an old house are different when no one is inside—the ticking of the clock is louder, a bicycle bell on the road sounds clearer, the whirr of the fan carries farther.

She remembered her adolescence, when she would return from school, open this door with this key, and the first sound in the empty house would be the thud of her book bag.

Back then, the key had been an object of freedom.

For some years after her marriage, she had continued to think of it as a sign of her right.

Now she understood—the key said only that the lock recognised her hand. The minds of the people inside, their rest, their conversation, their silence—those needed a different signal.

Anima laughed at herself for the thought.

“The things I think about,” she said to the empty veranda.

She left the books on the table and closed the door.

While locking it, the key caught again.

She lifted it and turned it.

‘Click.’

After winter began, Deepa came one day to give them a few things. Ajit was not at home.

Anima was inside, in the kitchen.

The doorbell rang.

She came out.

Deepa was standing there with a bag in her hand.

Opening the door, Anima said, “Oh, you have the key.”

Deepa laughed. “I left it. I thought, since you’re at home, I’d ring.”

For a moment Anima looked at her.

“You did right.”

Deepa came inside. That was all there was to it.

Later Anima did not ask Ajit whether he had said anything to Deepa about it.

Nor did she feel any need to.

One evening in Magh, Sushila Devi called.

“Anima, we have all gone to Raghav’s in-laws’ house. Purnima will go straight to the market with Anshu after his extra class. Your Babuji’s thick spectacles have been left on the sitting-room table. He’ll need them tomorrow morning. Can you pick them up on your way back from school?”

“Yes.”

When Anima arrived, the house was empty.

She used the key, took the spectacles, and closed the door.

As she was leaving, she ran her hand over the lock. The old metal was cold.

Suddenly she remembered—during the first month after her marriage, Ma had once said, “Keep the key safely. If it gets lost, another one can be made, but it won’t work as quickly as the old key.”

At the time, Anima had understood that sentence as being only about the lock.

Even now she did not want to turn it into some great meaning.

The value of some things lies in their use, of some in habit, and of some in the fact that, over the years, they come to know the shape of one's hand.

She put the key back on the ring.

When she went to her parents' home in Phagun, the door was open from inside.

Purnima and Anshu were ready to go out. Sushila Devi had gone to a neighbour's house, and Babuji was sitting in the sun behind the veranda.

Purnima said, "Didi, I'm going to the market for half an hour. Babuji is at the back. When you leave, please lock the main door."

"All right."

Purnima went out with Anshu.

Anima sat with Babuji for a while. They had tea. They talked about the school's annual examinations. Babuji spoke about an old colleague.

Evening was falling.

Anima got up.

"I'm leaving."

Ramlochan Babu said, "Lock the door. Purnima has a key."

Anima pulled the main door shut from outside.

She took her old key from her bag.

The red dot had now dwindled to no more than a thin line.

She put the key into the lock.

Her fingers, of their own accord, lifted it to suit its bent tooth.

'Click.'

The lock closed.

She drew the key out and held it in her palm for a moment.

It was the same key that had once brought her inside without making her wait.

Now it opened the door when the house was empty, locked it when the people of the house went out, and, when someone was inside, usually remained silent in her bag.

Anima put the key back on the ring.

The bell was still outside the door.

The key was in her bag.

Both were exactly where they belonged.

Sewing Expenses

Sudha's sewing machine was like a clock in the house.

Once after the milk had boiled in the morning.

Twice after the midday meal had been cleared away.

Again in the evening, after the rush of customers had thinned.

Sometimes the steady hum of the motor, sometimes the slow rhythm of a foot on the pedal.

The people in the house were so used to the sound that when the machine was silent, at first no one even noticed that something was missing from the house.

Sudha sat sewing in a corner of the veranda.

There was a low table, a box of thread, scissors, a measuring tape, tailor's chalk, four small boxes of buttons, and bundles of cloth.

In the table drawer lay a thick notebook.

On its first page, Sudha had written in her own hand: "Measurement Register."

Below it she had made five columns—name, measurements, cloth, advance, amount due.

Pramod called this notebook "Sudha's little account."

Kusum Devi, Sudha's mother-in-law, called her earnings "sewing expenses."

"The main household expenses run on Pramod's salary," she often said. "Sudha's sewing expenses take care of the little things."

There was no contempt in her voice when she said this, only a kind of easy certainty.

As though small expenses somehow found small earnings for themselves.

Sudha usually said nothing.

She wrote down measurements.

She cut cloth.

She straightened seams.

And after midday she circled in red ink the dates on which customers' clothes had to be delivered.

One Monday, Pramod stopped on the veranda on his way to the office.

"Sudha, do you have fifteen hundred?"

Sudha stopped the machine.

"Why?"

"Today is the last day for the motorcycle insurance. The card payment isn't going through. I'll withdraw it this evening and give it back."

Sudha opened the drawer.

She took three five-hundred-rupee notes from an envelope and handed them to him.

Folding the notes, Pramod said, "Your little earnings come in very handy at important times."

Sudha smiled.

"Don't forget to give it back this evening."

"I won't."

Pramod came home tired that evening.

He had the insurance papers, two office files, and a bag of vegetables with him.

The matter of the fifteen hundred did not come up again that day.

Sudha did not bring it up either.

The next day Kusum Devi's medicine ran out.

"Daughter-in-law, I need eight hundred and twenty rupees. Pramod will be late tonight."

Sudha gave it to her.

On Thursday a message came from Naman's school—the materials for the science exhibition had to be submitted by the next day.

"Ma, four hundred and fifty rupees."

"So much?"

"I have to buy the motor, wire, board, all of it."

Sudha gave it.

On Friday the milkman came with the old account.

One thousand two hundred and ten.

Kusum Devi called from inside, "Daughter-in-law, there are still three days before Pramod's salary comes. If you have it, pay him."

Sudha paid him.

That week the advance column of the Measurement Register held several figures.

Sumitra—800.

Neelam—500.

Rekha—1,200.

Uniforms for four schoolgirls—2,000.

These were all advances customers had paid so that lining, thread, hooks, zips, elastic, and some extra cloth could be bought.

Earlier, Sudha did not keep advances separate from her own earnings.

Whatever notes came into her hands went into the envelope in the drawer.

Whatever expense appeared before her was met from the same place.

At the end of the month, all she knew was that she had done a great deal of work, but how much money was left—she had no clear idea.

She was not greatly troubled by this either.

The household ran.

The machine ran.

Customers kept returning.

Then one day the machine began skipping stitches now and then.

Sudha changed the needle.

She changed the thread.

She filled the bobbin again.

She cleaned the machine.

Even then, on the back of the cloth three stitches would be right and the fourth missing.

She slowed the pedal.

For a while it worked properly.

Then the same thing again.

While making Rekha's blue blouse that afternoon, the cloth puckered in one place.

Sudha immediately unpicked the seam.

That day, for the first time, the sweat on her forehead came not from work but from worry.

In the evening, Shambhu, the sewing-machine mechanic, was called.

Shambhu opened the machine cover and examined it for a long time.

"The shuttle is worn out. The motor belt is loose too. It will run for now, but if the workload increases it will ruin the cloth."

"How much will it cost?"

"Replacing the parts will be about two thousand eight hundred. Cleaning and labour are extra."

"Total?"

"Allow three thousand two hundred."

Sudha fell silent.

Pramod was there too.

In an easy tone he said, "Put off that expense for now. Use the hand pedal for a few days. It doesn't make sense to spend three thousand two hundred all at once on a small income."

Shambhu closed the machine cover.

"Sister does a lot of work. If you delay, the shuttle plate may be damaged too."

Pramod said, "We'll see next month."

Shambhu left.

Sudha spread the cloth over the machine again.

That night she completed two blouses using the hand pedal.

Her speed was cut in half.

The next day the manager of a school came.

"Sudhaji, the new session begins next month. Can you make thirty-six skirts and eighteen kurtis?"

Normally, for a job like that, Sudha would immediately begin counting dates.

This time she looked at the machine.

"I can't take it on just now."

"Why? Last time you delivered on time."

"The machine isn't right."

"How many days?"

"I don't know."

The manager paused for a few moments.

"I need a decision within a week. Otherwise I'll have to give it somewhere else."

"Give it somewhere else."

It was not easy for Sudha to say that sentence.

The thirty-six skirts and eighteen kurtis would have been her biggest income for three weeks.

The manager left.

Kusum Devi had heard from inside.

"How much work was it?"

"A lot."

"Tell Pramod to get the machine repaired."

"He said next month."

Kusum Devi was silent for a moment.

"Yes, there are a lot of expenses this month."

Sudha opened the notebook.

That day, for the first time, she added up the figures in the advance column.

Four thousand five hundred.

She opened the drawer.

Two thousand one hundred and thirty.

The difference—two thousand three hundred and seventy.

For a while she kept counting the notes.

Then she opened the last blank page of the notebook.

At the top she wrote: "Went to the household."

Below it she began writing by date.

Monday—motorcycle insurance 1,500.

Tuesday—Ma's medicine 820.

Thursday—Naman's exhibition 450.

Friday—milk 1,210.

Total—3,980.

Sudha looked at the figures for a long time.

Some of the money among those four amounts had been her own earnings; some had been customers' advances.

The problem was not that money had gone into the household.

The problem was that no one knew which money belonged to whom.

That night, after dinner, Pramod was watching television.

Sudha came carrying the notebook.

"Look at something."

Pramod adjusted his glasses.

Sudha placed the page in front of him.

"What is this?"

"What went from the sewing drawer into the household this week."

Pramod read it.

"I was supposed to return the fifteen hundred for the insurance."

"Yes."

"I forgot."

"All right."

"Medicine is a household expense anyway."

"Yes."

"So is milk."

"Yes."

Pramod looked up.

"Then?"

Sudha opened the advance column of the notebook.

"These four thousand five hundred rupees are advances from customers. I was supposed to buy materials with them. There are two thousand one hundred and thirty in the drawer now. The machine needs three thousand two hundred for repairs. I turned down the large school order because the machine can't be trusted."

Pramod looked over the accounts for a while.

"Are you saying you shouldn't contribute to household expenses?"

Sudha did not immediately shake her head.

"No. Household expenses have to be met. But customers' advances are not my earnings. That is money for the work. Between us, we have been treating it as expenditure money."

"Between us?"

"Me too."

Hearing that answer, Pramod's face relaxed a little.

Sudha went on, "I wasn't keeping proper accounts either. Whatever came in, whatever went out. Now that the machine needs repairing, I can see it."

Pramod looked at the notebook again.

"How much do you earn in a month?"

Sudha laughed.

"I don't know exactly."

"It's your own notebook."

"This notebook has measurements and amounts due. It doesn't have all the expenses."

"Then all these days..."

"I just kept working."

The two of them were silent for a while.

The news continued on television.

Kusum Devi coughed in her room.

Naman had a book open, but his ears were turned towards the sitting room.

Pramod said, "Tomorrow we'll sit down and work out the accounts."

Sudha picked up the notebook.

"I have two garments to deliver tomorrow. I'll have to finish them tonight."

She went towards the veranda.

The machine began running again on the hand pedal.

The next evening Pramod came home early from the office.

He had brought a small calculator as well.

Sudha laughed.

"It isn't such a big account."

"We'll see."

The two of them sat down with the Measurement Register.

The first difficulty appeared at once.

Sudha had written down amounts due for many customers, but cloth, lining, hooks, zips, thread, electricity, machine oil—all of these existed separately in memory.

"This eight hundred is Sumitra's advance."

"Yes."

"Total due?"

"Thirteen hundred."

"Materials?"

"The lining is hers. The hooks are mine. The thread is mine."

"How much?"

Sudha estimated.

"Fifty or sixty."

"No estimates. We'll write it down."

"Who remembers now?"

Pramod smiled.

"So the little account has turned out to be quite difficult."

Sudha looked at him.

Hearing his own words, Pramod looked slightly embarrassed.

They began adding up the accounts for the previous three months.

Sudha took out the credit slips from Kailash, the thread seller.

She checked the amounts written on the small packets of zips and hooks.

They looked through old mobile-payment messages.

Many expenses could not be remembered.

Even so, a broad picture emerged.

Total receipts over three months—forty-two thousand seven hundred.

Materials and direct work expenses—around thirteen thousand.

Amounts that had gone separately into the household—more than seventeen thousand.

Sudha silently stared at the figures.

Pramod pressed the calculator again.

"Out of this seventeen thousand, my fifteen hundred, medicine, milk, the children..."

"Two gas cylinders."

"Those too?"

"Yes."

"And Ragini's dance costume?"

"The cloth was hers."

"You did the sewing for free."

"She's family."

Pramod said nothing.

Neither did Sudha.

There was no column in those accounts for domestic labour.

Cooking meals, giving an elderly mother her medicine on time, keeping track of the children's school notices, folding clothes—neither of them felt any wish to turn these things into figures.

The argument was not about fixing a price for Sudha's labour.

This time they were only trying to trace the money that had gone on changing hands until it lost its name.

Pramod said, "Tomorrow I'll return the fifteen hundred for the insurance. Also write down how much we have taken from the sewing money for household expenses this month."

Sudha said, "First the machine."

"Yes. The machine."

The next day Pramod offered to give the full three thousand two hundred.

Sudha refused.

"Why should you pay the whole amount?"

"The money fell short because of household expenses."

"Some of it is my earnings too."

In the end they decided that Pramod would first return the fifteen hundred. Milk and medicine would be counted under shared household expenses. Sudha would put in the rest from her own savings.

Once the matter was put on paper, there was less room for quarrel.

The amount was no longer anyone's honour; it was simply an amount. Shambhu came again.

He changed the shuttle.

He tightened the belt.

He opened the motor and cleaned it.

He ran the machine.

The first seam was completed without a single skipped stitch.

Sudha ran her hand over the back of the cloth.

"It's fine now."

Shambhu said, "You work a great deal. Give it some rest from time to time too."

Sudha laughed.

"The machine?"

"Both of you."

Shambhu left.

Meanwhile, the order for thirty-six skirts and eighteen kurtis had already gone to another tailor.

Sudha made no attempt to win it back.

It was a loss.

It was also the first clear lesson of the accounts.

Sudha added two new columns to the Measurement Register — "Materials" and "Went to the household."

Ragini stood by the table watching.

"Ma, why so much accounting?"

"So I can see where the money from the work went."

"Couldn't you see before?"

"Roughly."

"And now?"

"Now it's a little clearer."

Ragini read the words "Measurement Register" written at the top of the notebook.

"It should be called 'Sewing Accounts.'"

Sudha said, "The accounts won't work without the measurements either."

Ragini laughed.

A few days later, as Kusum Devi was leaving for the market, she came to the veranda.

"Daughter-in-law, do you have five hundred? I need to buy a few things for the puja. Pramod is at the office."

Sudha opened the drawer.

There were now two envelopes inside.

On one was written: "Advance/Materials."

On the other: "Income."

Sudha opened the second envelope.

She took out five hundred.

Kusum Devi looked towards the first envelope.

"There's more in that one."

"That is customers' advance money, Ma."

"Oh."

Kusum Devi took the five hundred.

"Will you write this under household expenses?"

Sudha looked at her for a moment.

"Yes."

Kusum Devi left.

Sudha wrote the date in the notebook.

"Puja items—500."

She wrote nothing beneath it.

Not "small."

Not "large."

The month changed.

The sound of the machine became regular again.

Now, before taking on a job, Sudha thought not only about the date but also about the expense.

How much thread would be needed.

How much lining.

How much time.

How much advance she should ask for.

Earlier, when a customer said, "Why so much advance?" Sudha would become self-conscious.

Now she simply said, "The money for materials is separate."

There was no harshness in that sentence.

Only a boundary.

One evening, two of Pramod's colleagues came to the house.

Tea was made.

In the course of conversation, one colleague looked at the machine on the veranda and asked, "Bhabhiji, does she sew as a hobby, or does she take paid work too?"

Pramod opened his mouth to answer.

Sudha was straightening the edge of a piece of cloth.

Pramod paused for a moment.

"She takes work."

That was all he said.

"She must make a decent amount?"

Pramod looked at Sudha again.

Sudha said, "It depends on the month."

The conversation moved to another subject.

There was no announcement in the house after that brief reply.

Nor did Kusum Devi immediately stop using the words "sewing expenses."

Even now, from time to time, she would say, "Pay it from the daughter-in-law's sewing money."

The only difference was that Sudha now looked at the envelope first.

Whose money was it?

For the work?

Income?

How much could reasonably be taken out as the household's share?

One night Pramod came with the household-expense notebook.

"Next month Naman's school fees, Ma's check-up, and the electricity bill all fall in the same week."

Sudha stopped the machine.

"Yes."

"How much do you expect to save from sewing this month?"

Sudha opened the Measurement Register.

She looked at the list of work.

"If everyone pays on time, around five thousand. But I'll have to leave two thousand for materials."

Pramod wrote something in his notebook.

"Then we shouldn't count on more than three thousand for the household?"

"Not for now."

"All right."

He got up and left.

Sudha started the machine again.

Ragini was doing her homework there.

She looked up.

"Ma, Papa doesn't call your earnings small anymore?"

Sudha cut the thread with scissors, not with her teeth.

"It takes time for people's words to change."

"Then?"

"The accounts changed first."

Ragini bent over her notebook again.

Sudha took out the bobbin.

It was almost empty.

She fitted a new spool of thread and began winding the bobbin.

The fine thread spun rapidly, building itself up around the little tube.

From a distance, its thickness had seemed almost nothing.

When the machine stopped, the bobbin was full.

Sudha placed it on her palm, looked at the date of the next job on the open page of the Measurement Register, and then fitted it back into the machine.

The Examination Form

In Prabhakar Jha's house in Sonpura village, two dates had been chasing each other since the second week of September.

September twelfth.

September thirteenth.

September twelfth was the last day for Ragini to fill out her B.Sc. third-year examination form.

September thirteenth was the date for depositing the second instalment of Roshan's competitive-exam coaching fee in Darbhanga.

There was only one night between the two dates, but in the eyes of the household they did not carry equal weight.

Ragini kept the printed sheet of her examination form between the pages of a book.

The university's name was printed at the top; below it were her registration number, subjects, choices of examination centre, and the final date in bold type.

The total amount due was three thousand four hundred and sixty rupees.

One corner of the sheet had bent slightly because several times a day Ragini would take it out, look at the date, and put it back inside the book.

Roshan's fee slip lay openly on the table in the sitting room.

Second instalment: twelve thousand five hundred rupees.

The first instalment had been paid two months earlier by borrowing from their maternal uncle and adding Prabhakar Babu's savings.

Roshan was preparing for bank, railway, and Staff Selection examinations.

At home, his coaching was called "preparation."

Ragini's college was usually called simply "college."

No one had written down this distinction as a rule.

But the words had made their own chairs in the house.

Prabhakar Babu's main income came from the milk collection centre.

Payment came every fifteen days.

This time the next payment was due on September seventeenth.

There was about six thousand rupees in cash at home.

There were also two old dues for oil, medicines, and provisions.

In the morning, counting money on the table, Prabhakar Babu said, "We won't be able to arrange Roshan's instalment by the thirteenth."

Putting tea on the stove, Neera Devi asked, "What about Ragini's form?"

Prabhakar Babu's fingers stopped on the notes.

"How much?"

"Three thousand four hundred and sixty."

"That much?"

"Form fee, laboratory fee, and old dues—all together."

Prabhakar Babu counted one of the notes again, as though counting it a second time might make the sum grow.

"We'll see."

In that house, "we'll see" was the sort of sentence spoken both before making a decision and in order to postpone one.

Ragini was sitting on the veranda with her chemistry notebook open.

She heard the conversation from the kitchen clearly.

Her hand went to the examination form tucked inside the book, but she did not take it out.

That afternoon Shashibhushan Kaka arrived.

He was Prabhakar Babu's younger brother and ran a seed-and-fertiliser shop in the market.

Whenever money was short in the household, his advice arrived even without being asked for.

After serving tea in the sitting room, Ragini was turning to go inside when Shashibhushan Kaka said, "First decide the priority."

"What priority?" Prabhakar Babu asked.

"Roshan's age is passing. Two or three years matter a great deal in competitive examinations. If his coaching breaks midway, even the first instalment will have been wasted."

Neera Devi stopped beside the doorway.

Kaka went on, "Ragini is studying anyway. What harm will there be if she waits a year? She can sit the examination next year."

For a moment such silence fell over the sitting room that even the tap-tap of the grinding stone outside could be heard.

Ragini forgot to go inside.

Prabhakar Babu lowered his eyes.

Roshan moved a finger over his phone screen, though the screen had gone dark long before.

Neera Devi asked softly, "What do you mean by making her wait a year?"

"Don't have her fill the form. Don't pay the fee now. Later, when the household's condition improves."

"Her year?"

"A year isn't going to run away, is it?"

By then Grandmother Bindeshwari Devi had also come in from the courtyard. She said, "The girl has studied. She's reached B.Sc. Let her stay home for a year; she'll see to the household work too."

For the first time, Ragini entered the sitting room.

She looked at no one.

She placed her examination form on the table beside Roshan's fee slip.

The two sheets touched each other.

On one: twelve thousand five hundred.

On the other: three thousand four hundred and sixty.

On one: the thirteenth.

On the other: the twelfth.

Ragini said only, "My date comes first."

Suppressing a smile, Shashibhushan Kaka said, "Just because the date comes first doesn't mean the need comes first."

Ragini did not answer.

She left the sheet on the table and went to her room.

Her room was really a space she shared with her grandmother.

Grandmother's cot stood on one side, an iron trunk on the other, and between them Ragini's small study table.

She sat at the table but could not open a book.

Outside, voices rose again in the sitting room.

Neera Devi was saying, "Stopping is an easy word. Starting again is difficult."

Grandmother said, "In our time, which daughter studied this much?"

Neera Devi replied, "Her time is not your time now."

Grandmother's voice sharpened a little. "So does money grow on trees in this house?"

Roshan spoke for the first time. "Don't quarrel because of me."

Kaka immediately said, "Not because of you. Because of your future."

Roshan fell silent again.

By evening the household had not split into two rows, but everyone's sentences had chosen a side of their own.

Grandmother and Kaka said Roshan's preparation must not be interrupted now.

Neera Devi said stopping Ragini's studies was not an option.

Prabhakar Babu was caught between money and dates.

Roshan stayed silent.

Ragini listened.

At dinner, Ragini served rice as usual.

Grandmother's plate first.

Then Babuji, Kaka, Roshan, Ma, and finally her own.

No one noticed that order.

After dinner, while Neera Devi was tidying the kitchen, she asked Ragini, "What are you thinking?"

Ragini kept wiping the plates for a while.

"First I want to understand what actually closes after which date."

"What do you mean?"

"Everyone says that if Roshan's instalment isn't paid on the thirteenth, the first payment will be lost. Has anyone asked?"

Neera Devi did not answer.

"If I don't fill my form, no one has asked when I will be able to take the next examination either."

Wringing out the cloth, Neera Devi said, "Go and ask tomorrow."

The next morning Ragini went to college.

The college veranda was crowded with students filling out forms.

Someone was searching for a photocopy of an Aadhaar card, someone for a registration number, someone for the amount of the fee.

Ragini helped her friend Nutan fill out her form.

After the form had been submitted, Nutan asked, "Yours?"

Ragini said, "Tomorrow."

"Tomorrow is the last day."

"I know."

A notice was pasted outside the college office.

Regular fee until eleven fifty-nine at night on September twelfth.

September thirteenth and fourteenth with a late fee.

After that, the portal would close.

Ragini photographed the notice on her phone.

She asked the office clerk, "If I don't fill the form this time, then next time?"

Pushing his spectacles upward, the clerk said, "You'll have to wait until the next examination cycle. We'll have to see the university schedule. It may affect the continuity of your scholarship as well."

"A year?"

"I can't say exactly right now. Whenever the next cycle opens."

Ragini asked no second question.

After leaving the college, she called the office number of Roshan's coaching centre.

No one answered the first time.

The second time, a young man answered.

Ragini did not give her name.

She asked, "If the second instalment isn't paid on the date, is the student expelled?"

The reply came from the other end, "No. There is a seven-day grace period. If an application is submitted, there is also a facility to change batches. Practice tests can continue separately."

"Will the first instalment be wasted?"

"No."

"Where can I find the written rule?"

"You can collect the fee policy from the office."

Ragini ended the call.

There was no miracle in that short conversation.

Twelve thousand five hundred was still twelve thousand five hundred.

The household's shortage was still a shortage.

But for the first time, the fear that "if not by the thirteenth, everything is over" grew a little smaller.

When Roshan returned from coaching that evening, Ragini stopped him on the veranda.

"Your instalment has a seven-day grace period?"

Roshan was startled.

"Who told you?"

"The office."

"I didn't know."

"Had you asked?"

Roshan remained silent.

He had looked only at the date printed in bold on the fee slip.

"There is also a facility to change batches," Ragini said.

Roshan's face did not change, but for the first time he asked the date on his sister's examination form.

“Tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

“And after that?”

“Two days with a late fee. After that, the portal closes.”

Roshan leaned his back against a pillar of the veranda.

“The milk payment will come on the seventeenth.”

“If it comes on time.”

“Usually it’s a day early or late.”

“Then it should come within seven days.”

For the first time, Roshan looked at his fee slip not as a crisis but as a paper carrying a date.

That night the family gathered in the sitting room again.

This time Ragini herself said, “I want to speak for five minutes.”

Shashibhushan Kaka was still at the house.

Grandmother was sitting on the cot, propped against a pillow.

A small bundle of notes lay in front of Prabhakar Babu.

Ragini showed the college notice on her phone.

Roshan opened the photograph of the fee policy he had obtained from the coaching office.

Ragini said, “I’m not saying Roshan’s coaching isn’t necessary. It is.”

Kaka nodded.

“All I’m saying is this: before deciding, look at which expense will immediately close something if it isn’t paid today, and which one allows seven more days.”

Prabhakar Babu read the fee policy.

“Did Roshan know this rule?”

Roshan said, “No. I asked today. It’s correct.”

Kaka looked at him. “What if the coaching people make excuses later?”

Roshan said, “I’ll submit the application in writing. I’ll take a receipt.”

Ragini placed the college notice on the table.

“My regular fee is valid until tomorrow. There is a late fee for two days. After that, the portal closes. Then I have to wait for the next examination cycle. It may affect my scholarship too.”

Grandmother asked, “How much is the scholarship?”

“Six thousand a year.”

For the first time, a calculation seemed to enter Grandmother’s eyes.

Shashibhushan Kaka said, “But even a week lost from Roshan’s preparation is a loss.”

Ragini looked at him.

“Maybe. Even so, would it be right to stop my entire examination cycle out of fear of losing seven days?”

Kaka did not fall silent.

“A boy has an age limit for competitive examinations.”

“My university session has limits too.”

This time Neera Devi spoke in between. “At least let the one whose studies we are talking about stopping finish what she has to say.”

For the first time, Ragini sat down on a chair in the sitting room.

Until then she had been standing by the doorway.

The small change happened without anyone announcing it.

Prabhakar Babu asked, “Then what’s the solution?”

Ragini said, “There is about six thousand in the house. Pay for my form. The rest will cover the essential household expenses. Roshan will submit an application tomorrow for the seven-day grace period. The milk payment will come on the seventeenth. Even if it is delayed by a day or two, it will still be within seven days.”

Prabhakar Babu did the sums in his head.

“What if the payment is five days late?”

Roshan said, “Then I’ll take the option of changing batches. I won’t stop studying. I’ll keep using the library and taking the practice tests.”

Kaka immediately said, “If you change batches, the teacher will change.”

In a calm voice Roshan said, “If one week can break my preparation, what have I learned from six months of coaching?”

The sentence was not loud.

That was why it was heard clearly.

Grandmother looked at Ragini.

“Can’t you stay at home for a year and study?”

Ragini said, “I can study. But without the examination, that study won’t move to the next stage.”

Grandmother was silent for a while.

Then she asked, “When is the examination after the form is filled?”

“Two months later.”

“Will you pass?”

Ragini did not smile.

“If I study, the chances will improve.”

The corner of Grandmother’s mouth moved slightly.

The decision did not come from any speech.

Prabhakar Babu counted the notes again.

He set aside three thousand four hundred and sixty.

Giving the remaining money to Neera Devi, he said, "Run the house for five days with this."

Neera Devi asked, "Roshan will submit the application tomorrow?"

Roshan said, "First thing in the morning."

As he rose from his chair, Shashibhushan Kaka said, "I only said what I thought was proper."

Without smiling, Neera Devi replied, "Even what seems proper can change when you look at the time and the date."

Kaka said nothing.

The next day the cyber centre was crowded.

Ragini reached there at nine in the morning.

The server stalled twice.

Once, an error appeared in the spelling of her name.

She corrected it.

She selected her laboratory subject.

The photograph uploaded.

When it was time to pay the fee, her hand trembled slightly.

A circular symbol kept spinning on the screen for a long time.

Then the words appeared: "Payment successful."

The man at the centre printed two copies for her.

Ragini did not fold the first sheet.

She went straight to the college, had it verified, signed it, and deposited one copy in the file.

She kept the second copy to take home.

At that same time, Roshan was standing in a queue outside the coaching office in Darbhanga.

He wrote an application: payment from the milk collection centre was expected on September seventeenth; he requested a seven-day extension for the instalment.

The office clerk changed the date and wrote September nineteenth.

Roshan did not leave without taking a receipt.

By the evening of September seventeenth, the milk payment had not arrived.

For the first time, Prabhakar Babu became worried.

Kaka said over the phone, "I told you."

On the morning of September eighteenth, a message came from the collection centre: the payment had reached the account.

Prabhakar Babu withdrew the money from the bank and brought it home.

Roshan deposited the instalment before the nineteenth.

The coaching teacher did not change.

The batch did not change either.

No one in the house celebrated the matter as a victory.

The crisis had passed, that was all.

But the calendar hanging on the sitting-room wall had changed.

Earlier, Roshan had drawn a red circle around September thirteenth.

There had been no mark on Ragini's twelfth.

On the night the form was filled, Neera Devi made a small blue tick on the twelfth.

Roshan drew a thin line through his red circle on the thirteenth and made a new circle around the nineteenth.

The next morning, looking at the calendar, Grandmother asked, "Why did this date move?"

Roshan said, "The fee date moved."

Grandmother looked toward the blue tick on the twelfth.

"And this?"

From the veranda, Ragini answered, "The form was filled."

Grandmother asked nothing more.

The calendar remained hanging on the wall as before.

The blue tick on the twelfth stayed where it was.

The red circle on the nineteenth stayed where it was.

The two dates no longer crossed each other's path.

The Kitchen Door

The kitchen door in the old house at Rambagh was the busiest door of all.

It did not open toward the road.

It opened onto the courtyard.

Even so, from five in the morning until ten at night, someone or other would be standing at its threshold.

“Tea first.”

“Porridge without salt.”

“Pack a dry vegetable dish in the lunchbox today.”

“I have to leave at seven.”

“Make the eggs later; the worship is still to be done.”

From inside the kitchen, all these voices belonged to different people.

But there was only one stove.

The second burner of the gas stove had been out of order for three days.

The repairman had said a part would have to be ordered.

Kiran had been a daughter-in-law in this house for twelve years.

She knew the kitchen sequence by heart.

Her father-in-law Harimohan Babu’s porridge.

Her mother-in-law Vimala Devi’s milk for worship.

Her husband Shailesh’s flatbread and vegetable dish.

Her brother-in-law Neeraj’s eggs.

Her daughter Ritu’s school lunchbox.

Phulo’s tea.

Phulo washed the dishes and swept and mopped for two hours every morning, then went to work in another house.

Kiran’s own tea was not written anywhere in the sequence.

She usually managed two sips while changing pans.

On the first morning after the second burner failed, the whole sequence went awry.

While Harimohan Babu’s porridge was on the stove, Shailesh came to the door.

“My train is at half past six. Can you make two flatbreads?”

Kiran looked at the clock.

Ten past six.

Ritu’s school vehicle came to the bend at six thirty-five.

Her potato-and-chickpea dish was only half cooked.

Kiran took down the porridge and put the griddle on the flame.

From the veranda Vimala Devi called, “Has onion touched the griddle?”

“No.”

“Boil the milk for the offering first. After that, make whatever you have to.”

Kiran took the griddle off.

She put the milk on.

Ritu came to the door with her schoolbag on her back.

“Ma, my lunchbox?”

“It’s being made.”

“The vehicle will be here.”

Shailesh was looking at the clock.

Neeraj stood at the threshold holding two eggs.

“My workout is at seven.”

Kiran looked at him.

“Not the eggs now.”

Vimala Devi came inside.

“Eggs will not go on the stove before the worship.”

Neeraj put the eggs in a bowl.

“Then I’ll eat outside.”

Vimala Devi’s face tightened a little.

“Outside, when there is food at home?”

Neeraj said nothing.

Ritu’s vehicle sounded its horn at the bend.

Kiran filled the lunchbox with the potato-and-chickpea dish.

The flatbread had not been made.

She put in two slices of dry bread as well.

Ritu ran off.

For one moment, the space by the door was empty.

Then Phulo came and stood there.

“Didi, I have to leave at seven ten.”

Kiran looked toward the stove.

The milk was about to boil over.

Shailesh's flatbreads were still to be made.

Harimohan Babu's porridge was cooling in the bowl.

She said to Phulo, "Could you have tea at the next house today?"

Phulo said, "All right," and turned away.

That evening Kiran took down the old black slate hanging on the kitchen door.

The slate had once been for the milkman.

How many litres of milk had come and how much was due used to be written on it.

For a long time there had been nothing on it but white chalk smudges.

Kiran washed it and wiped it clean.

The next morning she wrote—

5:45 — Babuji's porridge

6:05 — milk for the offering

6:15 — Ritu's lunchbox

6:30 — Shailesh's flatbreads

6:50 — Neeraj

7:05 — Phulo's tea

She did not write her own name.

She hung the slate outside the door.

Things ran a little better on the first day.

Harimohan Babu ate his porridge at seven, but it was ready at five forty-five.

Vimala Devi was pleased that the offering was ready on time.

Ritu's lunchbox was closed by six twenty.

Shailesh left on time.

Neeraj looked at his phone until his eggs were made.

Phulo's tea was ready at seven ten.

On the second morning Kiran saw that "Shailesh's flatbreads" had moved upward on the slate.

6:30 had been struck out and 6:10 written in its place.

Ritu's lunchbox had been pushed to 6:25.

Kiran asked no one about it.

She began work according to the new sequence.

At six twenty Ritu was standing at the door again.

"Ma, my lunchbox?"

“Five minutes.”

“The vehicle won’t wait five minutes.”

Kiran did not reply.

Taking his flatbreads, Shailesh said, “It worked out properly today.”

Ritu’s lunchbox was ready, but she had to run to the bend.

The vehicle had already left.

Shailesh took her to school on his motorcycle.

That evening he said, “So much trouble over this?”

Taking off her shoes, Ritu said, “The trouble was five minutes.”

Shailesh did not laugh.

On the third day there was another change on the slate.

“Milk for the offering” had moved from 6:05 to 5:50.

“Babuji’s porridge” was at 6:15.

Early that morning Vimala Devi said, “It is Ekadashi today. I’ll do the worship early.”

Kiran nodded.

Harimohan Babu was reading the newspaper on the veranda.

When the porridge was brought to him, he looked at the clock.

“So early?”

Kiran said, “The sequence said six fifteen.”

Harimohan Babu pushed his glasses up onto his forehead.

“When did I say six fifteen?”

Kiran paused.

“It was already like that in the sequence.”

“When do I ever eat before seven?”

From the door of the prayer room Vimala Devi said, “That is how it has always been done.”

Harimohan Babu put the lid back on the bowl.

“If it has been done that way, must it always be done that way? What sort of rule is that?”

Vimala Devi said nothing.

For the first time Kiran turned and looked at the slate again.

Times were written on it, but the reasons for those times were not.

The stove repairman came in the afternoon.

He opened the stove and examined it.

“The part will be available tomorrow.”

Kiran asked, “Will it run on one burner?”

“It will, but changing vessels again and again will take time.”

Vimala Devi said, "If it takes time, wake up earlier in the morning."

Kiran said nothing to that sentence.

She woke at four forty-five in the morning.

That night after dinner, everything on the slate was written again.

This time Kiran left the chalk on the doorframe.

Whoever wanted whatever time could write it themselves.

In the morning the slate was full.

5:30 — offering

5:45 — Babuji

6:00 — Shailesh

6:10 — Neeraj

6:20 — Ritu

6:40 — tea

No one had written "why."

Kiran lit the stove.

First she put the milk on.

Then the porridge.

Then the flatbreads.

Then the eggs.

Ritu's lunchbox came last.

At six twenty-three Ritu came to the door.

She read the slate.

"My vehicle is at six thirty-five."

From inside Neeraj said, "My workout is at seven too."

Ritu said, "You can walk there five minutes late."

Neeraj laughed.

"You'll decide that?"

Ritu fell silent.

Kiran was filling the lunchbox with the vegetable dish.

Again the flatbread could not be made.

That night, while doing her homework in her room, Ritu brought up the slate.

"Ma, does whoever writes a time first get their food first?"

Folding clothes, Kiran said, "For now, that's what it seems like."

"Then I'll write five o'clock the night before."

Kiran burst out laughing.

"Then everyone will write four o'clock."

Ritu laughed too.

Then she asked seriously, "Where is your name?"

Kiran's hands stopped for a moment.

"I'm the one who makes it all."

"But your tea?"

Kiran straightened the fold in the clothes.

"Tea happens somewhere in between."

Ritu asked nothing more.

The next morning Kiran's name was not on the slate.

But "Phulo's tea" had disappeared too.

Reading the slate, Phulo said, "Who erased what I wrote?"

Kiran was startled.

"You had written it?"

"I wrote it last night when I was leaving."

6:40 was still written on the slate, but in the place where the name had been there was a grey chalk smear.

Vimala Devi came out and asked, "What happened?"

Phulo said, "Nothing."

She picked up the broom.

Kiran did not stop her.

But that day she made Phulo's tea at five past seven.

Lifting the cup, Phulo said, "I don't need to write my time, Didi."

Kiran asked, "Why?"

Phulo shrugged.

"I work here. I'm not family."

The sentence was short.

Inside the kitchen it remained for a long time.

Kiran went on wiping the griddle.

Outside the door Shailesh was talking about office matters on the phone.

Neeraj was tying his shoes.

Ritu was looking for her schoolbag.

Vimala Devi was pouring water at the tulsi plant.

Kiran did not know whether anyone had heard Phulo's sentence.

That afternoon the second burner of the stove was repaired.

The repairman lit the flame and tested both burners.

"Now the work will go faster."

Kiran smiled.

"It used to go fast before too."

The repairman did not understand what she meant.

He gathered his tools and left.

Once the second burner had been repaired, everyone assumed the slate would no longer be needed.

Vimala Devi said, "Take it down now. It makes the door look bad."

Kiran did not take the slate down.

She only wiped it clean.

That evening Harimohan Babu looked at it and asked, "Has tomorrow's sequence been written?"

Kiran said, "You all write it."

Harimohan Babu picked up the chalk.

Before writing anything he asked, "What time is Ritu's vehicle?"

"Six thirty-five."

"Shailesh?"

"Seven ten."

"My medicine?"

From inside Vimala Devi said, "After seven fifteen."

Harimohan Babu did not write anyone's name on the slate.

He wrote—

6:00 — school lunchbox

6:25 — office flatbreads

6:50 — porridge for medicine

Then he handed the chalk to Kiran.

Neeraj was watching from outside.

"And mine?"

Harimohan Babu said, "Your workout place is five minutes away. Run there on an empty stomach and eat when you return."

Neeraj laughed.

"Babuji, are you making the rules now?"

Harimohan Babu laughed too.

"Not rules. I'm measuring distances."

Vimala Devi came to the slate.

She took the chalk to write "offering."

She paused for a few moments.

"Can the milk be boiled at night and kept ready?"

Kiran said, "It can."

"Then there's no need to hold up the stove in the morning."

Saying this, she put the chalk back.

Kiran felt no sense of victory rise within her.

She only thought that in twelve years, this question had been asked for the first time.

The next morning there were fewer names on the slate, because most places had times written instead. Kiran made Ritu's lunchbox first, then Shailesh's flatbreads.

Harimohan Babu's porridge stayed warm until seven. Neeraj's eggs were made when he returned from his run, and by then Vimala Devi had finished her worship.

Phulo washed the dishes and was about to leave, but she stopped at the door.

There was an empty line at the bottom of the slate, and the chalk lay on the doorframe. Phulo picked it up.

Slowly she wrote—

7:05 — Phulo's tea; 7:15 next house

After writing it, she put the chalk back where it had been. Kiran stood by the stove; she read the slate and said nothing.

At three minutes past seven, she put the water on to boil. The door was open.

Morning light from the courtyard was reaching all the way inside.

The Red Box

Bhagirathi Devi's room stood at the very back of an old neighbourhood in Saharsa.

For years, a red iron box had been kept beneath the cot in that room.

The red paint was no longer as bright as it once had been.

The corners had blackened, and a long scratch ran across the middle of the lid.

Even so, everyone in the house still called it simply "the red box."

No one called it the old-clothes box, or the jewellery box, or the chest of papers.

Just the red box.

Bhagirathi Devi herself never listed its contents in front of anyone either.

Within the family, this was more a habit than a mystery.

The problem began when it was decided that the floor in the back room had to be replaced.

During the rains, damp rose in that part of the house, and two planks near the cot had rotted underneath.

The carpenter said every heavy object would have to be moved out for two days.

As Umesh Babu looked over the things in the room, his gaze stopped at the red box.

"This should be emptied first," he said. "Then it will be easier to lift."

Bhagirathi Devi remained seated on the cot.

"Why empty it?"

"It is heavy."

"Four people can lift it."

Umesh Babu laughed, but Bhagirathi Devi did not.

Just then Sushma came in from the kitchen.

She was Umesh Babu's wife and had lived in this house for thirty-six years.

"Ma, the damp should be checked too," Sushma said. "If there are clothes inside, they may have been ruined."

Bhagirathi Devi glanced once at the box.

"If anything is ruined, I will see to it."

For a moment, something like hurt crossed Sushma's face.

In thirty-six years of running the household, she had taken care of everything from Bhagirathi Devi's medicines to her spectacle case.

But the red box lay beyond the reach of her hands.

"I am not insisting that it be opened," she said softly. "I am talking about something practical."

Aditi, standing by the doorway, had been listening to all this.

Aditi was Umesh Babu and Sushma's daughter; she studied in Delhi and had come home for the holidays.

At once she said, "If Grandmother does not want it opened, why does it need to be?"

Umesh Babu turned toward her.

"A household does not run by rules from books."

Aditi said, "A private thing can remain private even inside a family home."

"Private?" Sushma repeated the word.

This time there was more weariness than hurt in her voice.

"What is there in this house that I can call private, Aditi?"

Aditi fell silent.

The matter rose from the red box and spread through the whole house.

Umesh Babu said that in an old family home, ownership of every object could not be determined separately.

Sushma said that those who cared for the family ought at least to know what was kept where in case of an emergency.

Aditi said that caring for someone did not mean opening things without permission.

Bhagirathi Devi listened to all three of them.

She took no one's side.

She said only, "Replace the floor. The box will be lifted closed."

The next day two labourers and the carpenter arrived.

The cot was carried out, the table was moved, and the old chest was placed on the veranda.

It took four pairs of hands to lift the red box.

It was heavier than they had expected.

As they lifted it, something metallic inside gave a faint clink.

The sound was very small, but everyone present in the house heard it.

Umesh Babu said nothing.

Neither did Sushma.

Aditi instinctively looked at the lid of the box.

Bhagirathi Devi caught her glance.

Aditi immediately looked away.

The box was placed against the veranda wall.

By afternoon, piles of other things had gathered around it, yet the red box continued to stand apart.

As though a closed object could speak more loudly than all the open ones.

The subject came up again over lunch.

This time the reason was a phone call from the younger uncle.

He wanted an old family silver bowl, which he believed Bhagirathi Devi had with her.

After putting down the phone, Umesh Babu said, "See? Everyone thinks you have something or other."

Bhagirathi Devi went on mixing dal into her rice.

"Let them think what they like."

"Do you have the bowl or not?"

"Is this question about the bowl, or about the box?"

Umesh Babu did not answer.

Aditi wanted to smile, but stopped when she saw Sushma's face.

That night, while folding clothes, Sushma said to Aditi, "You must think I want to open the box."

Aditi said, "That is what you said."

"In this house I have taken Ma through two operations, counted out her medicines, brought her pension from the bank, but nowhere else has a boundary like this been drawn."

"So?"

"So sometimes this boundary feels like distrust of me."

For the first time, Aditi understood that the same closed lid was saying three different things to three generations.

For Grandmother, it meant a place of her own.

For her mother, it was a line drawn just beyond belonging.

For her father, it was one more uncertain object among countless others in the house.

And for her, it was a principle whose value she had read about in books but was testing at home for the first time.

The next morning, the carpenter was prying up the rotten planks.

Bhagirathi Devi sat on a chair on the veranda, looking at the red box.
Sushma brought her tea.

After a while Bhagirathi Devi said, "Sushma."

"Yes?"

"Do you remember the sari with the red border that I wore on the second day after your wedding?"

Sushma looked startled.

"Yes."

"It is in that box."

Umesh Babu looked up from his newspaper.

Aditi heard her too.

Bhagirathi Devi went on, "Come with me this afternoon. I will take it out. I want to give it to you."

For a few moments Sushma said nothing.

"To me?"

"Yes. But receiving the sari does not mean you have the right to look through the box."

The sentence was not harsh.

Bhagirathi Devi said it in an ordinary tone, as if she were remarking that there was too little sugar in the tea.

That afternoon Sushma went with her into the half-finished part of the room.

The door was not shut, but Aditi and Umesh Babu stayed outside.

A little later Sushma came out carrying the old sari with the red border.

Aditi could not tell whether her eyes were wet or whether dust had got into them.

The box was closed again.

"The silver bowl?" Umesh Babu asked, half joking.

Sushma laughed for the first time.

"Ask your younger uncle."

The work on the floor continued until evening.

The next day new planks were fitted and covered with a layer of earth and cement.

The carpenter asked, "Will the box go under the cot again?"

Umesh Babu answered naturally, "Ask Ma."

At those three words, Aditi looked at her grandmother.

Bhagirathi Devi pointed out the right-hand corner beside the cot to the carpenter.

"Here. There will be less damp underneath now."

Four people lifted the box again.

This time no one mentioned its weight.

The box was placed in its new position.

Sushma did not send the sari with the red border to be washed.

She folded it and placed it on top of her own cupboard.

That evening Aditi came into her grandmother's room.

"Grandmother, what is really inside?"

The question had barely left her mouth when she herself burst out laughing.

Bhagirathi Devi laughed too.

"You want to know?"

"Very much."

"All right."

Aditi was startled.

Bhagirathi Devi did not open the box.

From beneath her pillow she took out an old cloth pouch containing several buttons.

"Choose two from these. They will suit your kurta."

Aditi kept looking at the buttons.

The red box lay quietly beside the cot.

After a while she chose two blue buttons.

Bhagirathi Devi tied the pouch again.

Aditi got up to leave, then paused at the doorway.

She turned back and looked not at the box, but at her grandmother.

Bhagirathi Devi was cleaning her spectacles just then.

The red box was closed, but for the first time in that house, its remaining closed did not seem like anyone's defeat.

The Sister's Phone

In Vidyanand Jha's house, the sound of a phone after ten at night was an event in itself.

All day long Abhishek's mobile kept ringing—office, clients, bank, friends, motor mechanic.

People called Vidyanand Babu too until evening—sometimes about the electricity bill, sometimes insurance, sometimes to ask after an old colleague.

Malti Devi's small phone usually lay by the kitchen window, and once or twice during the day her sister or some woman from her parental home would speak to her on it.

But the timing of Mrinalini's phone was measured by a different standard in the house.

She was the younger daughter of the family, twenty-four years old, and a temporary teacher at the nearby girls' school.

Three evenings a week, she taught the village's adolescent girls free of charge.

Her phone held the numbers of students, colleagues, the school head, the bookshop, and sometimes the mothers of students.

Even so, if her phone rang after ten at night, even the turning of a newspaper page in the sitting room would stop for a moment.

This rule was written on no piece of paper.

The rule was written into the habits of the household.

At ten, Malti Devi would say, "Mrinal, put your phone on charge."

The charger was by the sitting-room window.

Mrinalini would leave her phone there.

Abhishek took his phone into his own room, because his "office work" might come even at night.

Vidyanand Babu kept his phone beside his pillow, because "I am getting old; there might be an emergency."

Sometimes Mrinalini asked, "And my emergencies?"

The answer was usually laughter.

"Who is going to call you this late?" Abhishek would say.

"And whoever does should be questioned first," Vidyanand Babu would add.

Everyone understood what that sentence meant.

A few months earlier, there had been a great deal of talk in the lane about a teenage girl in the neighbourhood speaking on her mobile at night.

No one knew the whole story, but everyone had an opinion ready.

From that day on, Vidyanand Babu began using the word "propriety" more often.

Mrinalini did not argue.

She knew that some rules reveal their weakness not through argument but in an unexpected moment.

That moment came one night in Ashwin at eleven forty-two.

The house was almost ready for sleep.

The courtyard bulb had been switched off.

Malti Devi was checking the kitchen door.

Vidyanand Babu was turning off the radio in the sitting room.

Abhishek had come out to drink water.

Then Mrinalini's phone, lying on charge by the window, rang.

It was not very loud, but in the stillness of the night the sound reached the whole house.

Abhishek was nearest.

He looked at the screen.

An unknown number.

"Mrinal!" he called.

The phone rang a second time.

Mrinalini was coming out of her room when Abhishek answered it.

"Hello?"

A man's voice came from the other end.

"Is Mrinalini Didi there?"

Abhishek's face changed at once.

"Who are you?"

"I am Ranjit Sah. I have a medicine shop at Shankar Chowk. There is a girl—"

Abhishek cut him off. "At this hour?"

Mrinalini had reached them by then.

"Give me the phone."

"Wait. Let me understand first."

Vidyanand Babu had come over too.

"Who is it?"

Covering the mouthpiece with his hand, Abhishek said, "Some man. He is asking for Mrinalini."

Mrinalini took the phone from his hand.

"Hello, this is Mrinalini."

Ranjit Sah spoke quickly from the other end. "Didi, one of your students is sitting at my shop. She says her name is Kajal. I am giving her the phone."

Mrinalini was silent for a moment.

Vidyanand Babu asked, "Who is Kajal?"

Mrinalini gestured with her hand—wait.

Very faint breathing could be heard on the phone.

Then came the trembling voice of a teenage girl.

"Didi?"

"Yes, Kajal. Tell me. Where are you?"

"Shankar Chowk... at the medicine shop."

"Why are you there so late? Did you tell anyone at home?"

Kajal did not answer at once.

Mrinalini moved toward the veranda.

From behind her Vidyanand Babu said, "Put it on speaker so we can all hear."

Mrinalini turned and looked at him.

"No, Babu."

That small word suddenly became enormous in the house.

Vidyanand Babu's brows tightened.

"Why?"

Keeping the phone to her ear, Mrinalini said, "She called me."

"Why should anything in the family be kept secret from the family?"

"First let me hear what she has to say."

She walked to the other end of the veranda.

Malti Devi stood by the door.

Abhishek looked at his father.

Vidyanand Babu wanted to say something, but just then he saw Mrinalini's expression change.

On the phone, Kajal was slowly telling her something.

Mrinalini asked only short questions in between.

"When did it happen?"

"Is there any woman at the shop?"

"Are your clothes very wet?"

"Is the pain severe?"

"Do you remember your home number?"

At the last question, Mrinalini fell silent again.

A few moments later she said, "All right. Don't tell anyone anything. I am coming now."

After ending the call, she went straight to her mother.

"Ma, come with me."

One look at her eyes told Malti Devi that this was not an ordinary matter.

"What happened?"

Mrinalini whispered something very softly into her ear.

Malti Devi stopped for a moment, then, without asking another question, turned toward the kitchen.

"Where is the old dark-blue salwar kept?"

"In my wardrobe."

"Take a large shawl too. And I will pack what else is needed."

Vidyanand Babu watched all this.

"What exactly is the matter?"

Mrinalini said, "Kajal has started her period and is having difficulty. Her clothes are stained. She cannot go home alone."

The hardness in Abhishek's face eased a little.

Vidyanand Babu said at once, "Then call her family."

"Her mother does not have a phone. She is afraid to speak to her father on his phone."

"Why is she afraid?"

Mrinalini looked directly at her father.

"Because she has been out late. He will first ask why she is late, and only after that, perhaps, what has happened to her."

Vidyanand Babu fell silent.

After the evening study session, Kajal had stayed at a tailoring shop to finish edging a wedding garment in place of her mother.

The owner wanted the work quickly.

When the shop closed, she set out for home.

On the way, her period began.

She was not prepared.

A stain spread across her salwar.

Two young men passed by laughing.

Kajal turned back and went into the medicine shop at Shankar Chowk.

Ranjit Sah's wife was in the rear of the shop, so Kajal found somewhere to sit.

Kajal did not have her own phone with her.

She remembered the number at home, but did not want to call her father directly.

Once at school, Mrinalini had made all the girls write down her number—"If you ever face trouble on the road, with your studies, or with your health, call me."

Kajal had memorized that number from the back of her notebook.

Vidyanand Babu kept listening.

"And that is why it has become eleven at night?" His voice was no longer as hard as before.

"Trouble does not ask permission from the clock before it comes," Malti Devi said as she took clothes from the wardrobe.

Abhishek picked up the car keys.

"I will drive."

Vidyanand Babu did not stop him.

Malti Devi prepared a small bag.

Into it she put the salwar, the shawl, a plastic bag, a clean cloth, and the things needed during a period.

Mrinalini kept her phone in her hand.

Suddenly Vidyanand Babu said, "I will come too."

Abhishek looked at him.

"All four of us?"

"Yes. It is night."

Mrinalini said nothing.

The car set off toward Shankar Chowk.

The road was almost empty.

The shutters of the shops were half down.

Dogs lay asleep in the middle of the road and moved aside slowly when the headlights fell on them.

No one spoke in the car.

Only once did Vidyanand Babu say, "Her father must be informed."

Mrinalini replied, "First we will ask Kajal."

"She is a minor."

"That is why we must take her home. But there is no need to tell the whole street about her body."

Vidyanand Babu began looking out of the window.
The medicine shop's shutter was half open.
Ranjit Sah stood outside.
Abhishek stopped the car.
"Didi?" Ranjit Sah said when he saw Mrinalini. "She is sitting at the back. My wife is with her."
Malti Devi and Mrinalini went inside.
The men remained outside.
In the small room at the back, Kajal sat curled up on a plastic chair.
Her face was not wet with tears, but her eyes looked as though she had been holding back her crying for a long time.
Ranjit Sah's wife had tied an old towel around her waist.
As soon as Mrinalini entered, Kajal tried to stand.
"Stay seated."
Malti Devi opened the bag.
"Change your clothes first."
Kajal looked at Malti Devi.
"Auntie, at home—"
"We will deal with home when we reach home. Your body first."
Mrinalini bolted the door from inside.
A little later Kajal came out in the blue salwar and dark shawl.
Her old clothes were in the plastic bag.
Vidyanand Babu stood at a distance.
Abhishek was asking Ranjit Sah about the shop's hours.
Kajal came over to Mrinalini.
"Didi, don't tell Babu that..."
She could not finish the sentence.
Mrinalini said, "We will say only as much as you feel is right. But someone at home must be informed."
Kajal said softly, "Ma can be told. Babu keeps the phone. Ma may answer if I ring twice—cut once, then call again."
That was the signal used in their home.
Mrinalini dialled the number.
The first time the phone rang, no one answered.
She cut the call.
The second time, after three rings, a woman's voice answered.
"Hello?"
Kajal's mouth trembled.

Mrinalini handed her the phone.

"Ma..."

The first question from the other end was, "Where are you?"

Kajal said nothing.

Then Mrinalini took the phone.

"Auntie, this is Mrinalini. Kajal is with me. She suddenly fell ill. We are bringing her home."

The woman's voice became very quiet.

"Very ill?"

Mrinalini said only, "You will understand. We have brought clothes with us."

There was silence on the other end for a few moments, then came the reply, "Bring her. I will wait by the gate."

The call ended.

In the car, Kajal sat between Malti Devi and Mrinalini.

She had pulled her shawl tightly across her knees.

Vidyanand Babu sat in the front seat.

As they reached the turn into the village, he suddenly said to Abhishek, "Don't sound the horn. Stop the car in front of the house."

Mrinalini looked at him.

That small act of care did not escape her notice.

The gate of Kajal's house stood half open in the darkness.

Her mother was outside.

The moment the car door opened, she caught hold of her daughter.

"What happened?"

Kajal whispered something into her ear.

Her mother closed her eyes for a moment.

Then she took the bag from Malti Devi.

"Thank you so much."

Just then a man's voice came from inside. "Who is there?"

Kajal flinched.

Her father came as far as the veranda.

"At this hour? What is all this?"

There was concern in his voice, but anger could be heard before the concern.

"The tailoring shop till this late? I had told you—"

Vidyanand Babu got out of the car.

Kajal lowered her head.

Mrinalini thought he would now tell him everything.

But Vidyanand Babu said only, "The child became unwell on the way. Take her inside first. The rest can wait until morning."

Kajal's father knew him.

"Oh, Vidyanand Babu! You all—"

"Mrinalini received a call. So we brought her home."

"What happened to her?"

Vidyanand Babu looked at Malti Devi for a moment.

"The women understand. The child is tired."

That was all.

For the first time, Mrinalini saw her father know something and still choose not to make it public.

The car turned back toward home.

It was past one in the morning now.

On the way, Abhishek reached to turn on the radio, then withdrew his hand without doing so.

After some distance, Vidyanand Babu asked, "What if I had put the call on speaker for everyone to hear?"

Before answering, Mrinalini looked at her mother's face.

Malti Devi was looking out of the window.

"Then perhaps Kajal would not have spoken at all," Mrinalini said.

Vidyanand Babu said nothing.

After reaching home, everyone went toward their own rooms.

Mrinalini started to put the phone back by the charger.

At that moment Vidyanand Babu said, "It is very late now. Take the phone with you."

Mrinalini looked at him.

"The battery is low."

"We will put another cable there tomorrow."

Abhishek almost laughed, but did not.

There was no formal family meeting the next morning.

Vidyanand Babu made no speech titled "Last Night's Incident."

He simply drank his tea and read the newspaper as usual.

Mrinalini was getting ready to go to school.

Abhishek ate breakfast while looking at messages on his phone.

Then the electrician arrived.

Mrinalini was startled.

"So early?"

Without folding the newspaper, Vidyanand Babu said, "The plug in your room is loose. Have it fixed."

The electrician went inside.

He installed a new socket by the study table.

Abhishek smiled.

"Well, special treatment."

Vidyanand Babu looked up from the newspaper.

"Your phone has always stayed beside your pillow. Who had the special treatment?"

Abhishek's smile stopped halfway.

Malti Devi kept stirring sugar into the tea, but the corner of her mouth lifted slightly.

Mrinalini said nothing.

Kajal did not come to school that afternoon.

Mrinalini looked at her empty bench but did not call.

She thought, let her have one day to breathe at her own pace.

In the evening, a short message came from Kajal's mother—"She is fine."

Mrinalini replied with only, "Good."

At ten that night, the old habit stirred again.

With the phone in her hand, Mrinalini came to the sitting-room window.

The old charger cable hung there.

She stood for a few moments.

Vidyanand Babu was listening to the news on the radio.

His eyes fell on Mrinalini.

"Why are you standing there?"

"I was going to put the phone on charge."

"Isn't the socket by your table fixed now?"

Mrinalini said only, "Yes."

She went back to her room.

She plugged the phone in by the table.

The door was half open.

A little later the screen lit up.

It was a message from Kajal—"Didi, I will come to class tomorrow."

Mrinalini read the message and lowered the phone screen.

The sound of the radio continued in the sitting room.

No one asked whose message it was.

The Tenant Girl

In that lane of Laheriasarai, the clink of the gate-chain at night could be heard more clearly than the daytime bell.

By day, rickshaws, vegetable sellers' calls, children's bicycles, and the whirl of sewing machines blended all sound together. After ten at night, if the chain on the old blacksmith-made gate clinked even once, curtains stirred at the windows of three houses.

When Anamika Jha came to live as a tenant in that lane, Ram Pyari Devi showed her the gate on the very first day and said, "I fasten the chain at ten at night."

Anamika stood beneath the staircase with two trunks and a cloth bag beside her.

"I'm a nurse at the hospital," she said. "My shifts keep changing. Sometimes I'll return at midnight; sometimes I'll have to leave at five in the morning."

Ram Pyari Devi's hand stopped on the chain.

Her son Pramod had been showing Anamika the upstairs room. He came down and said, "It'll be difficult to keep opening the gate at all hours of the night."

Anamika said calmly, "If I can get a second key, I'll open and lock it myself."

Ram Pyari Devi did not answer at once. The upstairs room had been empty for three months. Her pension did not cover all the household expenses, and the income from Pramod's notebook-and-book shop rose and fell with the season.

At last she took out an old brass key and handed it to her.

"Don't ever leave the gate open."

"Never."

That second key became the lane's first piece of news.

That evening Lalita Kaki, who lived opposite, asked Sudha, "A separate key for the tenant girl?"

Sudha laughed. "Her work is like that."

"Work is work. But night is still night."

Sudha gave no reply to that sentence.

Anamika's routine matched no one else's.

Sometimes she came down the stairs at half past four in the morning, a small steel lunch box in her hand, a blue bag on her shoulder, her hair tied tightly back. Even the milkman had not arrived by then.

Sometimes she returned at one in the afternoon and slept through the evening.

Sometimes, at eleven at night, the hospital vehicle dropped her at the turn of the lane. She walked in and opened the gate with the brass key.

The clink of the chain became a clock for the households.

"She came at half past eleven last night."

"No, it was already midnight."

"My clock said eleven fifty-five."

They never agreed on the time, but there was always a discussion.

At first Anamika noticed none of this. Returning from the hospital, she would wash her hands and face, change her clothes, put rice on the small stove, and go to sleep.

Two weeks later she realized that even her sleep was a subject for the neighbourhood.

One afternoon she came downstairs to fill water. Lalita Kaki was there too.

"Slept this late today?"

Placing her bucket under the tap, Anamika said, "I was on night duty."

"I can never sleep in the daytime."

"You can after staying awake all night."

Lalita Kaki laughed, but the questioning did not end.

"Are there women at the hospital at night too?"

Anamika looked at her.

"Whether the patient is a woman or a man, the nurses have to be there."

She lifted the bucket and went upstairs.

The following week, one night, the hospital's small vehicle came all the way into the lane. It was raining hard. The driver opened an umbrella and escorted Anamika to the gate.

By morning, it was the driver's umbrella that had become the subject of discussion, not the rain.

"A man came all the way to the gate to drop her."

"It was the hospital vehicle," Sudha said.

"Does a man become a hospital just because 'hospital' is written on the vehicle?"

Sudha fell silent again.

That day Ram Pyari Devi went upstairs for the first time without any particular reason.

Anamika was not looking at a prescription on the table but at the printed schedule of her shifts.

Ram Pyari Devi stood at the door.

“Did you want to say something?” Anamika asked.

“No, only... it rained a lot last night, didn’t it?”

“Yes.”

“The vehicle came all the way in.”

Anamika folded the schedule.

“The driver dropped me here. The road was under knee-deep water.”

Ram Pyari Devi had her next sentence ready, but it did not come out.

She only said, “There are clothes spread out on the roof, and I can see clouds gathering again.”

Anamika got up.

“I’ll bring them down.”

“No, you’ve been awake all night. I’ll do it.”

It was the first time Ram Pyari Devi had treated Anamika’s daytime sleep not as laziness, but as sleep after work.

But the rest of the lane’s clock kept ticking.

Customers began coming to Pramod’s shop and asking for news of the tenant.

At first Pramod laughed it off. Then it began to make him uncomfortable.

One evening he said to his mother, “We could rent the room to someone else. All this coming and going at night isn’t right.”

Ram Pyari Devi was picking through rice.

“She pays the rent on time.”

“It isn’t about the rent.”

“Then what is it about?”

Pramod searched for an answer.

“It’s a neighbourhood. What will people say?”

Ram Pyari Devi picked a small stone from among the grains and set it aside.

“Will the people pay the rent?”

Pramod grew irritated.

“Ma, not everything is about money.”

Ram Pyari Devi looked at him.

“Exactly. Then understand the hours of her work as work, not in terms of money.”

Pramod said nothing.

Even so, the pressure did not end.

One day Shivrinarayan Jha from the house opposite stopped Ram Pyari Devi near the gate.

“My daughter is grown up. This sort of coming and going at all hours of the night affects the conduct of the household.”

Ram Pyari Devi asked, “Until what hour does a household’s conduct remain proper?”

Shivrinarayan Babu did not understand the question.

“I’m saying there ought to be a fixed time.”

Ram Pyari Devi did not argue that day.

That night she called Anamika.

“What if the gate isn’t opened after ten at night?”

Anamika was silent for a few moments.

“Then I won’t be able to do night duty.”

“Can’t you change your shifts?”

“I can change one or two. Not every time. Everyone at the hospital has to do nights.”

Ram Pyari Devi lowered her eyes.

Anamika said, “If it’s difficult for you, give me a month. I’ll find another place.”

The sentence came more easily than Ram Pyari Devi had expected. She had thought Anamika would argue, become angry, list her rights.

She merely spoke of finding a new place.

For the next ten days, along with going to the hospital, Anamika also went looking for a room.

One landlord asked, “You’ll live alone?”

“Yes.”

“What time will you return at night?”

“Depends on the shift.”

“Then it’s difficult.”

At another place she was told, “If you were a woman living with a family, that would be different.”

At a third place the room was good, but the gate was locked at nine every night.

One day, sitting in the hospital rest room, Anamika crossed out three numbers.

Meanwhile, a letter arrived at Shivnarayan Babu's house.

His daughter Neelima, having completed her nursing training, had received a six-month appointment at a hospital in the city.

Her schedule for the first week included two night shifts.

Shivnarayan Babu read the paper three times.

"Night?"

"Yes, Babujee," Neelima said. "I did them during training too."

"That was in the hostel."

"The work is the same."

That evening, for the first time, the meaning of a time limit changed in Shivnarayan Babu's house.

When Neelima left for her first night shift, her father himself walked her to the turn of the lane.

As he returned, Anamika was leaving for the hospital.

Shivnarayan Babu stopped when he saw her.

"Your hospital vehicle drops employees home at night, doesn't it?"

Anamika stopped too.

"Our hospital vehicle does. Neelima's hospital may have a different arrangement. She should get the number from the hospital office."

"A reliable driver..."

"First find out what the hospital provides. An outside vehicle can come later."

Shivnarayan Babu nodded.

Anamika went on her way.

She neither reminded him of the old conversation nor smiled.

Two days later Neelima returned at a quarter past midnight.

The gate of the house opposite was already open. Shivnarayan Babu was sitting on the verandah.

That night Ram Pyari Devi was awake too.

Anamika was at the hospital then.

A vehicle stopped in the lane, Neelima got out, and the gate closed.

The curtain at Lalita Kaki's window stirred faintly.

In the morning she said to Sudha, "Neelima came home late last night."

Kneading flour, Sudha asked, "She was on duty, wasn't she?"

Lalita Kaki was silent for a moment.

"Yes, it was work."

It was the very sentence Sudha had once used for Anamika. This time no question followed it.

That day Ram Pyari Devi went upstairs.

In the room Anamika had set two empty boxes on a spread-out newspaper and was sorting her things into piles—things to keep, things to throw away, things to take with her.

“Found a place?” Ram Pyari Devi asked.

“I found one. It’s far from the hospital, but there’s no restriction on coming and going at night.”

Ram Pyari Devi placed a hand on the doorframe.

“There’ll be no restriction here now.”

Anamika kept putting the books in her hand into the trunk.

“I understand.”

“Then stay.”

This time Anamika looked at Ram Pyari Devi.

“Maaji, the rule has changed—that is a good thing. But now, whenever the chain clinks, the first thing I wonder is which window will move. When I come back from work, before I remember my own room, I remember people’s eyes.”

Ram Pyari Devi remained silent.

Anamika continued, “At the new place, at least I’ll be able to begin afresh.”

There was sorrow on Ram Pyari Devi’s face, but she did not invent another argument to stop her.

On the last Sunday of the month, Anamika’s belongings were loaded onto a small tempo.

Pramod settled the final rent account. Sudha packed puris and vegetable curry into a box for her.

Ram Pyari Devi stood by the gate.

Anamika placed the brass key on her palm and handed it to her.

Looking at the key, Ram Pyari Devi said, “I had another copy made. You could have kept this one.”

Anamika smiled.

“The key belongs to the house.”

“It stays in the hand of whoever lives in the house.”

“Someone else will live here now.”

Ram Pyari Devi closed her fist around the key.

The tempo drove out of the lane.

For a few days, Ram Pyari Devi’s gate remained silent after ten at night.

Out of habit, she sometimes woke at midnight. She would lie waiting for the sound of the chain, then smile at herself.

One night, at about half past one, there came a clear metallic clink.

Ram Pyari Devi sat up in bed.

For a moment she thought—Anamika has returned.

Then she realized that the sound had not come from her gate, but from Shivnarayan Babu's gate across the lane.

Neelima was returning from night duty.

Ram Pyari Devi did not go to the window.

She lay down again.

The chain clinked once more in the lane, and then the night returned to its old silence.

The Gift Sari

In a lane off Nehru Marg in Laheriasarai, Arun Jha's house was one where the custom of giving gifts went back a long way. Books on birthdays, clothes at festivals, sweets for the children after returning from a journey—some object or other was always changing hands.

When Madhulika came into the family after her marriage, Renu Didi was the first to explain this custom to her.

Renu was Arun's elder sister. She had never married. She taught history at a girls' school in town and quietly met many of the household's small and large expenses from her own earnings.

When Madhulika first arrived at her marital home carrying her school appointment letter, it was Renu who had a monthly bus pass made for her, showed her the route on the first day, and even wrote down the headmistress's name.

"In a new place, the first month brings more questions," Renu told her. "Don't hesitate to ask."

Madhulika really did ask her a great many things.

Which market had good Maithili books, which tailor delivered clothes on time, which road flooded less in the rains—Renu always had an answer.

For this reason Madhulika began to regard her not merely as a sister-in-law, but as an elder sister of her own.

On Madhulika's first birthday after the wedding, Renu returned from school in the evening carrying a long paper bag.

"Wash your hands first," she said. "Then open it."

Madhulika laughed. "So many rules?"

"It's something nice. Not with hands smelling of oil and spices."

Inside the bag was a deep-blue cotton sari. Along the border ran a fine red stripe, and the pallu was patterned with tiny fish motifs.

The moment Madhulika unfolded the sari, she stopped short.

"I love this colour."

Renu's face lit up.

"I know. That's why I had the shop keep it aside for two weeks."

From behind them Arun said, "Didi had been looking at it for herself. In the end she gave it to you."

Renu immediately looked at Arun.

"Do you have to tell everything?"

Holding the sari against her chest, Madhulika said, "Then I won't take it. You had chosen it for yourself."

"It's yours now," Renu said. "Once something has been given, it isn't passed back again."

Maya Devi, Arun's mother, ran a hand over the sari and said, "The colour is lovely. It will look very good at pujas and festivals."

Renu immediately added, "The first time she wears it will be next month, at Rashmi's upanayan feast."

Madhulika looked at her.

"I was thinking I'd wear it to the school's annual function."

"The annual function is only ten days away. Wear it first among the family. After that, wherever you like."

The last part of the sentence was light, but the first part was clear.

Madhulika said nothing.

Renu folded the sari again and separated out the blouse piece.

"Give this to me. I'll have it stitched by Shanti, the seamstress. She'll match the border and put on a red edging."

"My old red blouse will do."

"No. Such a lovely sari with an old blouse?"

Renu put the cloth into her own bag.

Madhulika laughed at this then. She thought—this was Renu's way of loving: to give something and then make sure it was complete.

Two days later Renu returned from the seamstress and said, "She asked for your measurements. I'll take you on Saturday."

"I can go myself on my way back from school."

"Tailors are careless with measurements. If I'm there, she'll make it properly."

Madhulika laughed again, but this time her laugh was smaller.

On Saturday they both went.

As Shanti took her measurements, she asked, "How long should the sleeves be?"

"To the elbow," Madhulika said.

Renu answered at once, "Not that long. Four fingers shorter. The sari isn't heavy; short sleeves will look better."

Madhulika looked at the seamstress's eyes. The woman had paused with her scissors, waiting for an answer from the two of them.

“At school I have to raise my arm to write on the board,” Madhulika said. “Long sleeves are more comfortable.”

Renu was silent for a few moments.

“All right, to the elbow. But don’t make the neck too high.”

Softly Madhulika said, “I’ll tell her about the neck.”

Shanti marked the measurement slip with her pencil.

On the way back, the two of them ate kulfi. Their conversation became ordinary again.

But for the first time a small question stayed in Madhulika’s mind—if the sari was hers, whose decision should its sleeves and neckline be?

The annual function drew near.

That year the school had also arranged a literary gathering for teachers from across the district. Madhulika had been given charge of conducting the Maithili story-reading session.

Looking over the list, the headmistress said, “Madhulika, wear a colourful traditional sari on stage. There will be photographs too.”

Madhulika’s mind went at once to the blue sari.

That evening she asked Renu, “Is the blouse ready?”

“Half done. Shanti said by Wednesday.”

“The gathering is on Tuesday.”

Renu said casually, “Wear another sari. This one is to be worn first at Rashmi’s feast.”

This time Madhulika did not laugh.

“Didi, did you give me the sari for my birthday, or for Rashmi’s feast?”

For a moment Renu looked startled.

“I gave you the gift. But the first wearing has a meaning too.”

“Who decides that meaning?”

From the veranda Maya Devi called out, “What are you arguing about?”

Renu said, “Nothing, just clothes.”

Madhulika did not take the matter any further that day.

Early Tuesday morning, before leaving for school, she took out her old paddy-green sari.

The blue sari lay folded in the trunk. Its blouse piece was in Renu’s bag along with Shanti’s measurement slip.

Madhulika put on the paddy-green sari.

The gathering went well. The headmistress praised the way she conducted it.

She was happy on her way home, but the moment she opened the trunk and saw the blue, something like a faint scratch ran across that happiness.

Rashmi's upanayan feast was postponed by two weeks because Rashmi's father fell ill.

Renu brought the finished blouse home.

"Look how well the fit has come out."

Madhulika tried it on. The sleeves came to the elbow as she had asked. The neckline was simple too.

She looked at Renu.

"You told the seamstress what I had said?"

"It's your blouse, isn't it?" Renu said. "Whatever feels right to you."

Something in Madhulika softened.

But Renu immediately added, "Don't send it to the washerman yet. After you wear it the first time, I'll tell you how it should be washed."

Madhulika fell silent.

Time passed.

The sari remained in the trunk.

Sometimes Renu would ask, "You've kept neem leaves with it, haven't you?"

Sometimes she would say, "Don't fold the border over; it will leave a crease."

Sometimes Maya Devi would say, "Has Renu given you the sari, or is she keeping the sari herself?"

Everyone would laugh.

Renu would laugh too, but by now Madhulika no longer added her own answer to that laughter.

One evening news came from school. The next day, at the district book fair, Madhulika was to be honoured on stage as a teachers' representative. The headmistress herself said, "Be there on time tomorrow. Dress formally."

Arun was out of town. Maya Devi had gone to her brother's house.

Renu returned late because of examination work at school.

Madhulika took the blue sari out of the trunk.

She put on the blouse, ran an iron over the border, and wore two red glass bangles.

Standing before the mirror, for the first time the sari truly felt like her own.

She went to the door of Renu's room.

Renu was tired and was checking exercise books.

Madhulika said, "I'm wearing this to the book fair tomorrow."

Renu stopped her pen.

"Tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Rashmi's feast still hasn't taken place."

In a calm voice Madhulika said, "The feast may be postponed again. My occasion is tomorrow."

Renu looked at the sari.

"I had wanted to see you in this sari the first time you wore it."

"See me now."

Renu said nothing.

Madhulika spoke again. "Didi, when I wear something you gave me, I'll remember your love. But if you also decide the day I wear it, when will the sari become completely mine?"

Renu's face tightened slightly.

"I'm only saying it out of love."

"I understand it as love too. That's why I'm saying this."

Silence settled between them.

Renu lowered her eyes to the exercise book again.

"Wear it wherever you like."

The sentence sounded like permission.

For that very reason, Madhulika was not pleased.

The next day she wore the blue sari to the book fair.

Her name was called on stage. She received a certificate. Photographs were taken. Her colleagues asked about the sari.

"My sister gave it to me," Madhulika said.

She felt proud as she said it.

By evening, the photographs had appeared in the school group.

Renu saw them too.

When Madhulika returned home, Renu asked in an ordinary tone, "Did the programme go well?"

"Yes."

"Under the stage lights, the colour of the sari looks even deeper."

"I thought so too."

Nothing more came of it.

Madhulika took off the sari and left it out to air.

The next day Renu picked it up and examined it.

"There's a small pin mark on the pallu."

Madhulika was silent for a moment.

"Yes, the pallu kept slipping while I was walking on stage."

"You shouldn't use a thick pin on cloth like this."

The old tone had returned.

This time Madhulika did not explain the pin.

She only asked, "Didi, if the sari tears, will it hurt you more, or me?"

Renu did not answer.

Madhulika folded the sari and put it away in her own trunk.

That night Arun called during dinner. Madhulika told him about the programme. Renu answered in a normal voice now and then as the conversation went on.

Laughing, Arun said, "So Didi's sari has finally been inaugurated."

Renu was listening from that end of the phone.

"The sari is Madhulika's," she said quietly.

Arun probably did not notice. The conversation moved on.

A few days later Rashmi's feast took place.

Maya Devi asked Madhulika, "Will you wear the blue sari?"

Madhulika said, "I'll wear the yellow one today. I've already worn the blue one at the book fair."

Maya Devi looked at Renu.

Renu was sorting flowers into a plate.

"Let her wear whatever she wants," she said.

This time the sentence did not sound like permission, only like an ordinary statement.

In the bustle of the feast, the matter ended there.

Two weeks later, when Madhulika returned from school, she found a small brown envelope on her table.

There was no name on the envelope. Inside were a narrow strip of leftover cloth from the blue sari's blouse piece, an extra hook, and Shanti's old measurement slip.

Madhulika took the slip in her hand and went to Renu.

Renu was checking her students' answer books on the veranda.

"You had these?"

Without looking up, Renu said, "Yes. The seamstress gave me the leftover cloth. I thought if it was ever needed, it would be with me."

"And now?"

Renu put the cap on her pen.

"Now I thought—why should the leftover cloth from your sari be with me?"

For a few moments Madhulika looked at the little strip of cloth.

“Maybe I’ll make a bangle pouch out of it.”

Renu smiled.

“Tear it, cut it, make a pouch—don’t ask me.”

Madhulika burst out laughing.

Renu laughed too, but she did not immediately add what colour thread should be used.

That evening Madhulika took the blue sari out of the trunk and left it to air.

The small pin mark was still there on the pallu.

She ran a finger over the mark but made no attempt to remove it.

On the veranda, Renu was checking exercise books.

Madhulika placed the leftover strip of cloth beside the scissors.

This time, before she picked up the scissors, no permission came to mind.

The Dining Table

The dining table came to Nagendra Babu's house very late.

For years, meals in this house had been eaten on low wooden stools on the veranda outside the kitchen. First the children, then the men, and then the women. No one called this order a rule. The rule seemed to have made a place for itself without ever being spoken.

When Deepak received a bonus from his office, he bought a four-chair teak dining table for the house.

The table got stuck twice while being brought in through the door. The labourers tilted its legs and carried it inside. Mira kept clapping.

"Now our house is like a city house too," Ayush said.

Sumitra Devi ran her palm over the table's smooth surface.

"Such a big thing in this small room?" she worried.

Deepak laughed.

"There are four chairs. We are seven people. We will eat in two sittings. Nothing difficult about that."

Kumud had just returned from school. A bag of answer sheets hung from her shoulder.

"We used to eat in two sittings before as well," she said, taking off her shoes.

Deepak heard her, but did not reply.

The table was placed near the kitchen door, with a wall on one side and a window on the other. A cushion belonging to Nagendra Babu was tied to the back of one of the four chairs because his lower back hurt.

Deepak began hanging his office bag on the back of the second chair.

Ayush's schoolbag was often left on the third.

Mira was always the first to claim the fourth chair.

On the first night, there was something festive in the house when dinner was served at the table.

Madhavi brought plates from the kitchen. Sumitra Devi set out the water. Kumud opened the pickle jar.

"Mother, you sit too," Mira said.

Sumitra Devi laughed.

"I'll eat later. Let the children eat first."

"I'm not a child," Ayush protested.

"Then get up," Kumud said.

Everyone burst out laughing.

In the first sitting, Nagendra Babu, Deepak, Ayush and Mira sat down.

Madhavi kept moving between the kitchen and the table.

Kumud stood by the window, reading a message from school.

Sumitra Devi kept saying, "Eat while it's hot."

Twenty minutes later, the first sitting got up.

Then Sumitra Devi, Madhavi and Kumud sat down.

There were four chairs at the table. The fourth remained empty.

"Who will sit on the fourth?" Mira asked, peeping in from the doorway.

"Your doll," Kumud said.

There was laughter again.

In this way, the table became part of the house.

For a few days no one noticed whether the two sittings existed because there were too few chairs, or because the old order of the house was stronger.

At breakfast too, the order was almost the same.

Nagendra Babu's medicine had to be taken on time, so he came first.

Deepak had to hurry to the office, so he came first.

Ayush's bus arrived at seven twenty, so he came first.

Mira's school vehicle came five minutes later, so she too came first.

Sumitra Devi would say, "Where do I have to go?"

Madhavi would say, "Let me send everyone off first."

Kumud would say, "I'll eat something at school."

These three sentences were repeated so often that, little by little, they ceased to be reasons and became identities.

Kumud taught science at a secondary school. The school was fifteen minutes away by bicycle.

One Monday, the headmaster sent a message saying that examinations were near and the teachers had to arrive half an hour early.

Kumud was ready by half past six in the morning.

Madhavi was cooking parathas in the kitchen.

"Please give me mine quickly," Kumud said.

Madhavi prepared a plate for her.

When Kumud went to sit at the table, Ayush's bag was lying on the third chair, Mira was tying a ribbon in her hair on the fourth, Nagendra

Babu sat on the first chair with his newspaper open, and Deepak was still bathing.

Deepak's chair was empty.

Kumud sat there.

Sumitra Devi stopped at the kitchen door.

"Deepak sits there."

Kumud looked at her.

"He's still bathing. I'll get up in five minutes."

Sumitra Devi said nothing.

Madhavi set down Kumud's plate.

When Deepak came in, he stopped for a moment.

"Where should I sit?"

Ayush immediately picked up his bag, but the chair did not become free - he himself was sitting there.

Kumud had eaten half a paratha.

"Your five minutes," she said. "I'm getting up now."

Plate in hand, she stood at the window ledge and ate the rest of her meal standing up.

There was no quarrel with anyone.

But on the way to school, for the first time she understood that a chair in the house was not merely an object made of wood.

Some chairs had owners.

Some people did not.

That evening Kumud did not mention it.

Two days later, the matter surfaced again.

Ayush had an extra mathematics class. He was to return at half past eight at night.

Dinner was ready at eight.

Nagendra Babu sat in his chair. Deepak in the second. Mira in the third.

The fourth chair remained empty.

Kumud came with a bundle of answer sheets from school.

"May I sit?"

Sumitra Devi looked at the clock.

"Ayush must be coming."

"He said half past eight."

"How long is it now until half past eight?"

Kumud placed the answer sheets on a corner of the table.

"Half an hour."

Deepak said, "Sit down. When Ayush comes, I'll get up."

Again Sumitra Devi said nothing.

Kumud sat down.

That night Ayush came at ten past nine.

By then Kumud had eaten and was checking answer sheets in her room.

Ayush came to the table and sat in the fourth chair.

No one told him that Kumud had sat there.

For the next few days, the order at meals returned to the old pattern.

That is how small rules work in a house - they shift once, then slip back into their old grooves.

One Sunday, two of Deepak's office colleagues arrived with their families.

Madhavi spent the whole afternoon preparing the meal.

Deepak borrowed three folding chairs from the neighbour's house.

Mira kept opening them and arranging them around the table.

"Look," she said happily, "now there are seven chairs."

Kumud was standing at the door.

"Seven chairs for seven people," she said.

"But today we have guests as well," Deepak replied.

The table was moved a little away from the wall. The room that had seemed full with four chairs now held seven.

The guests sat down.

Nagendra Babu sat down.

Deepak sat down.

Ayush and Mira sat down too.

Madhavi remained in the kitchen.

Sumitra Devi kept serving water.

Kumud kept bringing plates.

There were seven chairs.

Even then, not one of the three women sat down at that time.

Kumud did not want to count this, but her eyes counted by themselves.

After the guests left, the three folding chairs remained propped against the wall.

Dinner was ready.

Deepak reached out to open one of the folding chairs.

Sumitra Devi said, "These all have to be returned tomorrow. Don't open them; we'll only have to fold them again."

Deepak drew back his hand.

The first sitting again consisted of four people.

This time Kumud said nothing.

Madhavi looked at her once.

That was all.

The next morning the neighbour's son took the chairs away.

The room became a four-chair room again.

At school, Mira was asked to draw a picture on the theme "My Family."

That evening she sat at the dining table with coloured pencils.

She drew a house, a tree, and seven people.

Then she began to draw the dining table.

After drawing four chairs, she stopped.

"Aunt Kumud," she called, "there are seven of us, aren't there?"

"Yes."

"Then why are there only four at the table?"

"Because the table is for four people."

"What about the other three?"

Before Kumud could answer, Madhavi called from the kitchen, "The other three eat in the second sitting."

Mira drew three small figures behind the table.

One had a plate in her hand, the second a jug, the third a notebook.

"Who are these?" Kumud asked.

Without looking up, Mira said, "Grandmother, Mummy, and you."

Kumud said nothing.

That night the picture was fixed to the refrigerator door with a magnet.

Nagendra Babu saw it when he went to get water.

"Why is my moustache so big?" he laughed.

Mira came running.

"So people can recognise you."

"And why are these three at the back?"

Mira said naturally, "They eat in the second sitting."

Nagendra Babu's laughter stopped for a moment.

Then he said, "All right. It's a good picture."

That was all.

But the picture remained on the refrigerator.

A week later, Nagendra Babu's old friend Ramanand Jha came to visit.

The two talked on the veranda for a long time.

Ramanand Babu stayed until mealtime.

Madhavi said, "Have your meal before you go."

Ramanand Babu refused at first, then agreed.

There were four chairs at the table.

Deepak had gone to the market.

So one chair was empty.

Nagendra Babu, Ramanand Babu, Ayush and Mira sat down.

By then Kumud had returned from school.

She washed her hands and face and came in.

Madhavi asked, "Will you eat?"

Kumud looked toward the table.

All four chairs were occupied.

"Later."

Ramanand Babu said casually, "Come now, let the daughter sit. I'll sit on a low stool."

Nagendra Babu immediately said, "No, no. How can a guest sit on a stool?"

Kumud smiled.

"I've got used to it."

The moment the sentence came out, it sounded strange even to her.

Used to it.

Used to what?

Putting off hunger?

Waiting for the owner of an empty chair?

Keeping her own time behind someone else's?

She went into the kitchen.

Madhavi was standing by the stove.

Kumud said quietly, "I didn't like that phrase, 'used to it.'"

Keeping her eyes on the griddle, Madhavi asked, "Why?"

"Because it isn't a habit I chose."

Madhavi took the griddle off the stove.

After a few moments she said, "Neither did I."

The two fell silent again.

Sumitra Devi had heard everything from behind them.

She took no side.

That night, after Ramanand Babu had left, Sumitra Devi looked again at the picture Mira had drawn and pinned to the refrigerator.

"Why has she put a jug in my hand?" she asked.

Mira said, "You serve the water."

"And a plate in your mother's hand?"

"She serves the plates."

"A notebook in Aunt Kumud's hand?"

"She looks at notebooks."

"All right."

Sumitra Devi looked away from the picture.

The next day, a small incident occurred at mealtime.

Mira had sat down in the first sitting, but she was not hungry.

She kept playing with her food.

Madhavi was in the kitchen.

Kumud had come home from school hungry.

She said to Mira, "If you're not hungry, may I sit?"

Mira got up at once.

"Yes."

Sumitra Devi said, "If the child eats later, it'll create trouble again."

Kumud stopped.

Mira stood there with the chair half pulled out.

Deepak looked up from the newspaper and said, "Mother, look at who is hungry."

Sumitra Devi looked at Deepak.

Deepak lowered his eyes to the newspaper again.

Kumud sat down.

Mira happily stood behind her and began untying her hair.

"Aunt Kumud, is this your chair now?"

Kumud laughed.

"No. It was empty just now."

Sumitra Devi said nothing.

That night, for the first time, the order of the sittings shifted a little according to hunger rather than names.

But change does not move in a straight line.

The next day, when Deepak came home tired from the office, Ayush had spread his books over Deepak's chair.

"Move these," Deepak said.

Ayush moved them at once.

Kumud stood at the door and watched.

The chair had an owner again.

On the third day, when Nagendra Babu came late for dinner, everyone waited for him.

On the fourth day, Mira was hungry, so she ate first.

On the fifth day, Madhavi had a headache; Sumitra Devi told her to sit down first.

It was as though the house was not making a new rule, but practising how to forget the old one.

Meanwhile, one leg of the table began to wobble slightly.

Deepak called a carpenter.

As the carpenter turned the table over and tightened the leg, he said, "The table is good. It must be taking too much weight on one side."

Everyone laughed.

"Even the table knows who sits where," Ayush joked.

Kumud did not laugh.

The carpenter removed all four chairs and put them out on the veranda.

Because of the repair, dinner that night was again eaten on low stools spread on the floor.

There were not seven stools.

Everyone sat wherever they found a place.

Nagendra Babu by a pillar.

Sumitra Devi beside him.

Deepak and Madhavi facing each other.

Kumud with the children.

There was no first sitting.

When Madhavi got up once toward the kitchen, Sumitra Devi said, "Sit. Whoever needs something can get it themselves."

Deepak got up and brought the water.

When the meal was over, Mira said, "It would be nice if the table stayed broken."

Everyone burst out laughing.

Nagendra Babu too.

The next day the repaired table returned to its place.

Four chairs around it once again.

But it was as though the memory of the night of the repair had remained somewhere in the wood.

A few days later, it was a rainy evening.

Deepak called from the office to say there was water on the road and he would be late.

Ayush had gone for extra lessons.
Mira had gone to study at the neighbour's house.
At home were Nagendra Babu, Sumitra Devi, Madhavi and Kumud.
Four people.
Four chairs.
Dinner was ready.
Madhavi said naturally, "Shall we sit?"
Sumitra Devi looked at the clock.
"Deepak?"
"He'll be late."
"Ayush?"
"Half past nine."
"Mira?"
"She said she'll eat there."
Sumitra Devi looked at the clock again.
Nagendra Babu had already sat down in his chair.
Kumud pulled out one chair.
Madhavi sat in another.
One chair remained empty.
Sumitra Devi stayed standing.
"And you?" Kumud asked.
"I'll eat later."
This time Madhavi did not look toward the kitchen.
"After whom?"
A faint bewilderment crossed Sumitra Devi's face.
Really - after whom?
Deepak would be late.
Ayush would be late.
Mira was out.
The fourth chair was empty.
Sumitra Devi looked toward Nagendra Babu's cushioned chair.
Folding his newspaper, Nagendra Babu said, "This one is here."
He got up from his chair.
Sumitra Devi was alarmed.
"Oh, why are you getting up?"
"I'll sit in the other one."
"No, no."
"Changing the chair won't change my back."

Kumud smiled.

Nagendra Babu sat down in the ordinary chair beside it.

Sumitra Devi slowly sat in the cushioned chair.

Her hand rose automatically toward Madhavi's plate, as though there were something she ought to serve.

Madhavi said, "I have everything."

Sumitra Devi drew her hand back.

All four ate together.

The conversation was entirely ordinary.

The leak in the school roof.

The price of potatoes in the market.

Deepak's phone call.

The neighbour's electricity.

There was no announcement.

No decision was written down.

When the meal ended, Sumitra Devi got up and began gathering the plates.

Kumud picked up her plate.

"I'll put this away."

This time Sumitra Devi did not object.

When Deepak returned that night, his meal was covered and kept for him.

He sat down at the table.

Madhavi brought his plate from the kitchen.

"Has everyone eaten?"

"Yes."

Deepak paused for a moment.

"Mother too?"

"Yes."

"Earlier?"

Madhavi looked at his face.

"On time."

Deepak said nothing.

He began to eat.

No new rule was announced in the house the following week.

There were still only four chairs.

There were still seven people.

For many days, meals continued to be eaten in two sittings.

But the names attached to the chairs slowly began to fade.

Sometimes, if Nagendra Babu was late, Sumitra Devi sat in his cushioned chair.

Sometimes, if Kumud was in a hurry, she ate in the first sitting and left for school.

Sometimes, if Mira was absorbed in play, Madhavi sat in her place.

At first Ayush would ask, "My chair?"

Mira would immediately say, "It's yours when it's empty."

One night Ayush returned from extra lessons.

Madhavi, Sumitra Devi, Mira and Kumud were sitting at the table.

All four chairs were occupied.

Deepak was talking on the phone on the veranda.

Nagendra Babu was listening to the radio in his room.

Ayush stopped for a moment at the doorway.

Madhavi was sitting in the chair that had once been called his.

His plate lay covered on a corner of the table.

An old folding chair stood against the wall - the one that was brought out whenever guests came.

Ayush opened it.

He placed it at the corner of the table.

The chair legs made a faint sound on the floor.

No one looked up.

Madhavi merely drew her elbow a little inward to make room for him.

Ayush sat down.

The table no longer looked like a four-chair table.

The Silent Mami

Everyone in the house held the same opinion about Sharda Mami—she was very quiet.

It was said as though silence were not part of her nature but proof of a weakness.

“What is the point of asking Mami? She will agree to whatever we say,” Nikhil would say with a laugh.

“She does not like fuss,” Anjana would add.

Mamaji, Raghunath Jha, would generally nod at this.

Only Anvi, the sixteen-year-old granddaughter of the house, sometimes watched Sharda Mami’s face closely. She noticed that while Mami listened to everyone, her eyes were never silent.

During the summer holidays, Rashmi came to stay in that house for two weeks. Rashmi was Sharda Mami’s niece. As a child she had followed Mami everywhere, but after marriage and a job, their meetings had grown infrequent.

On the very first evening, Rashmi heard a curious sentence in the house.

Anjana said, “From now on we shall have dinner at eight. It will be better for Mami.”

Nikhil agreed at once.

Raghunath Mamaji said, “Yes, eating late is not good.”

Sharda Mami was rolling rotis in the kitchen. No one asked whether eight o’clock was convenient for her.

Rashmi thought—perhaps it was a small thing.

The next morning, Nikhil called a workman to cut two thick branches from the neem tree in front of the house.

“There is dampness under so much shade,” he said. “Mami needs sunlight now.”

Sharda Mami stood on the veranda looking towards the neem tree.

“Could these branches not be left uncut?” she asked softly.

Nikhil did not hear her, or heard her and chose to act as though he had not.

The workman set the saw to the wood.

When the branch fell, the courtyard suddenly flooded with light.

Rashmi saw Sharda Mami stand for a long time in the place where, until yesterday, there had been shade.

On the third day, Anjana had two old brass flowerpots placed on the loft above.

“Mami should not keep bending so much to tend plants now. I am moving them for her sake.”

Sharda Mami again said nothing.

That evening Anvi quietly brought one flowerpot down.

“Grandmother, you used to water this tulsi yourself, didn’t you?”

Sharda Mami smiled.

“Watering it is not difficult. What is difficult is knowing when someone will decide that it is difficult for you.”

Anvi did not laugh.

Rashmi paused over that sentence.

A great many things in the house were done “for Mami.”

The morning milk was made without sugar—for Mami.

The box of sweets was kept on a high shelf—for Mami.

The door was shut from inside at seven in the evening—for Mami, so that the sounds of the night would not disturb her.

Anjana went less often to the evening gatherings of the neighbourhood women because “Mami would be left alone.”

Nikhil brought a large quantity of vegetables from the Saturday market in one trip because “Mami should not have to keep going to the market.”

Raghunath Mamaji did not like guests staying for more than two days because “Mami would get tired.”

Amid all these sentences, Rashmi was finding it difficult to understand where Sharda Mami herself was.

Gradually, Rashmi began to notice a difference.

Sharda Mami was asked many questions in the house—“Where is the rice?”, “Has Kunal drunk his milk?”, “Have you seen Mamaji’s spectacles?”, “How much dal should I soak today?”

Whenever the answer concerned work, everyone needed her voice.

But when the question concerned her own life—where she would go, when she would rest, whom she would meet, what she would keep, what she would give up—the answer was formed before the question could become a sentence.

One afternoon, Usha Kaki from the neighbourhood came by. In the course of conversation she said, "Sharda sister is truly fortunate. Her family takes such good care of her."

Anjana said happily, "Yes, we do not let her worry about anything."

Usha Kaki turned towards Sharda Mami.

"You have nothing but rest and comfort."

Sharda Mami held out a cup of tea to her.

"When someone else decides what your rest should be, even rest can sometimes begin to feel like work," she said.

Usha Kaki laughed as though it were a joke.

Anjana laughed too.

Rashmi did not.

She was beginning to understand that Mami's sentences were often tucked away inside laughter so that no one would have to answer them.

One afternoon, the postman delivered a thick invitation card.

It had come from Rajbiraj. The granddaughter of Sharda Mami's younger sister Bimala was getting married.

The wedding date was printed in red—the twelfth of the following month.

Sharda Mami held the invitation in her hands for a long time.

"How many years has it been since you went to Bimala's house?" Rashmi asked.

"Six."

"Then will you go this time?"

Before Sharda Mami could answer, Raghunath Mamaji came onto the veranda.

Seeing the card, he said, "So far away? How will you manage such crowds now?"

When Nikhil returned from the office, he too saw the invitation.

"Ma, the journey will be too much for you. If we go by car, I will need two days' leave. You cannot go by bus."

Anjana said, "Where will you get any rest at a wedding? We will send a gift from here."

The three sentences were different; the conclusion was the same.

Sharda Mami folded the invitation and set it above the doorway.

No one asked her—do you want to go or not?

This time Rashmi did not remain silent.

"What does Mami herself say?"

Nikhil replied easily, "We know what is best for her."

Rashmi looked at Sharda Mami.

Mami began sifting flour.

That night, while studying, Anvi came into the kitchen for water.

Sharda Mami was sitting alone. The invitation lay open before her.

“Grandmother, do you want to go?” Anvi asked.

After a long pause, Sharda Mami said, “Yes.”

“Then why didn’t you say so?”

“To whom?”

“To Papa.”

“He had already said what I wanted before I could.”

Anvi fell silent.

Straightening a corner of the invitation, Mami said, “When other people know your wishes before you do, you have to speak very loudly to be heard. I never learnt to speak loudly.”

Anvi closed her book.

The following week, a new problem arose for Nikhil’s household.

Anjana had to go to Muzaffarpur for three days of training. Nikhil had the annual accounts at his office. Anvi’s school examinations were near. The younger son, Kunal, had music class in the evenings.

Everyone’s schedules began to be fitted together in the sitting room.

Nikhil said, “Ma will be here anyway. She can get Kunal ready at four, give Anvi something to eat, and give Baba his medicine on time.”

Anjana breathed a sigh of relief.

Raghunath Mamaji said, “If Sharda is at home, there is nothing to worry about.”

Rashmi listened.

The woman who three days earlier had been declared “too weak” for a bus journey was now the natural choice to manage two children, meals, medicine, and the entire household day.

Sharda Mami said nothing this time either.

Only Anvi looked at her.

That night, Anvi came to her grandmother.

“Grandmother, won’t you get tired?”

“From the work?”

“Yes.”

“Work makes you tired. The tiredness that comes from giving up your own wishes lasts much longer.”

Anvi fell silent again.

Two days later, Rashmi was getting ready to go to the market when Sharda Mami called her.

There was a small piece of paper in her hand.

“Rashmi, will you do something for me?”

“Tell me.”

“Find out the timings of the buses to Rajbiraj.”

Rashmi stared at her.

“You are going?”

“Yes.”

“Nikhil Bhaiya—”

For the first time, Sharda Mami interrupted Rashmi mid-sentence.

“Nikhil will not decide the bus timings.”

Her voice was not loud. But the sentence was complete.

Rashmi opened her phone.

There was a bus at seven in the morning that went as far as Jayanagar. From there, transport across the border was easy to find. There was another bus in the afternoon.

Sharda Mami chose the morning one.

“It will be less crowded,” she said.

“The ticket?”

“I’ll buy it.”

“Alone?”

“Rashmi, I came to this house alone when I was twenty-two. No one thought I was weak that day.”

Rashmi laughed, but Mami did not.

She merely opened her small iron trunk and took out some notes.

Inside the trunk were an old cloth bag for journeys, a folded umbrella, a small box of medicines, and Bimala’s previous letter.

Rashmi arranged the ticket for her.

Sharda Mami said, “Do not tell anyone yet.”

“Why?”

“Because then everyone will start making decisions for me again.”

Five days before the wedding, Anjana returned from her training. The household routine became normal again.

That evening, after dinner, Sharda Mami placed her ticket on the table.

“On the twelfth, I am going to Rajbiraj.”

Nikhil looked first at the ticket, then at his mother.

“Ma, who bought this?”

"I did."

"You didn't tell me?"

"I am telling you now."

Raghunath Mamaji pushed his spectacles up and said, "You're going alone?"

"By bus as far as Jayanagar. Bimala's son will meet me there."

"But your convenience—"

Sharda Mami's eyes settled on Mamaji.

Raghunath Mamaji left the sentence unfinished.

Nikhil pulled out a chair and sat down.

"Ma, I am saying this for your own good."

"What is good for me and what I want are not the same thing, Nikhil."

This was perhaps Sharda Mami's longest protest ever heard in that house—just one sentence.

Anjana asked softly, "What if you have trouble on the way?"

"I'll call."

"What if you get tired?"

"I'll sit down."

"What if—"

Mami smiled.

"All the 'what ifs' will travel with me. You all stay here."

Anvi suppressed a laugh.

Disagreement was plain on Nikhil's face. But the ticket lay before him.

For the first time, the decision was not "for Mami"; it was Mami's.

The next day, a strange air of caution spread through the house.

No one directly told her not to go, but everyone kept looking for some new reason.

Raghunath Mamaji checked the weather.

Nikhil checked the road reports.

Anjana made a list of clothes.

Sharda Mami quietly packed two saris, a shawl, her medicine box, and a yellow chunari for Bimala into her small bag.

Rashmi noticed that there was no haste in her preparations.

On the morning of the journey, Nikhil himself took her to the bus stand.

On the way he asked three times, "Ma, if you change your mind, we can still turn back."

The third time, Sharda Mami looked out of the window and said, “If you change your mind, you turn back.”

Nikhil fell silent.

The bus arrived.

Sharda Mami climbed aboard. She took a seat by the window.

Nikhil stood outside.

As the bus began to move, Mami waved.

There was no weakness in that hand.

Sharda Mami returned five days later.

She brought back stories from the wedding at Bimala’s house—who had danced well, whose paag had sat crooked, which vegetable dish had too little salt, which child had cried all night.

Everyone in the house listened in surprise at how much Mami noticed.

In truth, she had always noticed everything. It was only that everyone heard so little of what she said.

After the journey, all the household rules did not change in a single day.

Nikhil would still sometimes begin, “Ma, for you—”

But halfway through the sentence he would remember.

Then he would turn it into a question.

“Ma, would you like...?”

Sometimes Mami said “yes.”

Sometimes “no.”

Sometimes she said, “I’ll think about it and tell you.”

For the first time, the family understood that “I’ll think about it and tell you” was also a form of answer.

Two weeks later, new green leaves appeared where the neem branches had been cut.

Anvi called her grandmother.

“Look, the leaves have come back.”

Sharda Mami came outside.

There was sunlight in the courtyard, but the neem’s new leaves had begun to make small patches of shade.

At that moment, Anjana was bringing down the two flowerpots from the loft above.

“Mamiji,” she asked, “where should I put this tulsi?”

Earlier, the house would have supplied the answer to such a question by itself.

Sharda Mami looked at three places in the courtyard.

Then she pointed towards the new shade beneath the neem.
“Here.”

Anjana placed the flowerpot there.

No one said that this place was good for Mami.

Only Mami had said—here.

The Parlour Mirror

Twelve days before the wedding, Surabhi sat for the first time before the large mirror at Aabha Parlour.

It was no ordinary mirror.

Around it ran a slender brass-like frame, and small pieces of coloured paper were tucked along its edges.

One slip said “pale pink”, another “low bun”, another “don’t thin the eyebrows”; on some, there was only a name.

As soon as Surabhi sat down, she looked at those slips before she looked at her own face.

Malati, the owner of the parlour, stood behind her, parting her hair with a comb, and asked, “How do you like it?”

Before Surabhi could answer, her mother, Sudha Devi, said, “Keep the colour very light. She has been running around for work for so many days; her face looks tired.”

Surabhi’s cousin Rashmi immediately added, “And make the line of kohl at the eyes a little longer. It will look good in photographs.”

Isha, her future sister-in-law, sitting on the sofa opposite, opened a photograph on her phone and showed it to them.

“Bhaiya said not to make the make-up too heavy. Something natural-looking like this.”

Malati glanced once at the photograph on the phone.

Then at Surabhi.

“You?”

Surabhi laughed.

“You decide first. I don’t understand much about all this.”

Malati said nothing.

She tucked a yellow slip into the left side of the mirror’s frame — “light colour—Mother.”

Below it, a pink slip— “longer eyes—Rashmi.”

A third, green one— “not too heavy—Isha.”

Surabhi looked at her reflection.

Three coloured slips hung around three sides of her face.

“Why all these?” she asked.

Malati laughed.

"If I forget later who said what, there is an argument. When it comes to a bride's make-up, everyone remembers exactly what they said."

Sudha Devi laughed too.

"You are right. In a wedding house, memory is sharpest of all."

The first day was meant to be only for advice about hair and skin care.

But within half an hour Surabhi's face had turned into a small conference.

"Don't make the hair lie too flat on the forehead," Rashmi said.

"A centre parting looks good," Sudha Devi said.

"Isha, in your family, how is the veil usually worn over the head?" Malati asked.

Isha rose enthusiastically and came to stand behind Surabhi.

"I have a sample like that."

The phone was raised before the mirror again.

Surabhi kept looking alternately at the unfamiliar bride inside the phone and at her own face in the mirror.

Malati added two new slips.

That evening, on the way home in the car, Rashmi asked, "How did you like it?"

Surabhi said, "Fine."

"Just fine?"

"What else should I say?"

Rashmi looked at her.

"What kind of hairstyle do you like?"

Looking out of the window, Surabhi said, "When I go to the office, I tie it up."

"A wedding isn't the office."

"I know that."

Rashmi burst out laughing.

But the question remained where it was.

Over the next three days, amid saris, jewellery, invitations and guest lists, Surabhi's face too became a list.

Her aunt said, "Tell them to cover the little mole on the left side of her nose."

Another aunt said, "Why the mole? That is what makes her face recognisable."

The photographer called and said, "No very shiny base; under the strong camera light, the face can look too pale."

Isha sent a message—"Bhaiya says he doesn't like red lips."

Surabhi replied with only, "Fine."

At night, while folding clothes, Sudha Devi asked, "What will you do about the mole?"

"Let it stay."

"Your aunt was saying it will look large in photographs."

Surabhi went to the mirror and looked at the mole.

It was above her left cheek, two finger-widths below the eye, smaller than a lentil.

"How can something this small become large in a photograph?"

Sudha Devi laughed.

"In wedding photographs, there are plenty of people whose job is to make small things look large."

Both of them laughed.

The matter ended there, but the mole did not.

On the sixth day, Surabhi went to the parlour a second time.

This time only Rashmi was with her.

The five slips from the previous visit were still tucked into the mirror's frame.

Malati had not removed them.

"Your slips are safe," she said.

Rashmi joked, "Our family constitution is being drafted here."

Malati said, "In some families, it becomes bigger than the constitution."

She took a slim file from the table drawer.

Against every bride's name were written the date and a brief note.

"Why do you write so much?" Surabhi asked.

"Because make-up is not merely a matter of colour. Someone's mother will say—cover the head. Someone's sister will say—leave it open. Someone's groom will say—natural. And then five people understand 'natural' in five different ways."

Rashmi laughed aloud.

"True."

Running a thin brush along Surabhi's eyebrow, Malati asked, "What does 'natural' mean to you?"

Surabhi did not answer at once.

"I... don't want my eyes to look smaller."

Malati's hand stopped.

"Smaller?"

"Rashmi says the kohl should be drawn longer. But when it is too long, my eyes begin to look like someone else's."

Rashmi looked toward the mirror.

"I only said it for the photographs."

"Yes, I know."

There was no quarrel in Surabhi's voice.

For the first time, Malati tucked a white slip into the frame.

"Eyes in their own shape—Surabhi."

Surabhi read the slip.

It felt strange to her.

Perhaps seeing her own name beside an instruction about her own face was the first new thing that had happened that day.

Rashmi said softly, "All right, not long."

Malati drew a light line on one eye and left the other undecorated for the moment.

"Look."

Surabhi studied the difference between the two eyes.

"This one on the left looks better."

"The one with less?"

"Yes."

"Fine."

No second white slip was made.

On the first slip, Malati added in small letters—"light."

On the way home that day, Rashmi remained silent for a long time.

Then she said, "If you don't like something I say, tell me at once."

Surabhi smiled.

"I don't dislike everything. Some things simply aren't mine."

Rashmi nodded.

"I'm beginning to understand the difference."

Five days before the wedding came the jewellery trial.

Sudha Devi brought out the old maang-tikka from her own wedding.

It was wrapped in yellow cloth, with a small red stone at its centre.

"I want you to wear this."

Surabhi placed the ornament on her forehead and looked in the mirror.

"I like this too."

Sudha Devi's face lit up at once.

"Really?"

“Yes. But I won’t part my hair in the centre; I’ll keep it a little to one side.”

For a moment, Sudha Devi looked at the ornament.

“If you wear it to one side, it won’t look like it did in my time.”

Surabhi laughed.

“It will look like my time.”

Sudha Devi laughed too.

“All right.”

There was no defeat in that small “all right”.

The old ornament was finding a new place on a new forehead.

Three days before the wedding came the final make-up trial at the parlour.

This time Sudha Devi, Isha and Rashmi all went with her.

Looking at the mirror’s frame, Malati said, “Settle everything today. I don’t want a courtroom here on the wedding day.”

Everyone laughed.

Malati began reading the slips.

“Light colour—Mother.”

Sudha Devi said, “Not too pale. Let her own complexion remain.”

Malati struck a line through the yellow slip and wrote—“her own complexion.”

Surabhi looked at her mother.

Sudha Devi looked back as if it were nothing remarkable.

“Longer eyes—Rashmi.”

Rashmi herself said, “Cross that out.”

Malati crossed it out.

“Not too heavy—Isha.”

Isha said, “Let that stay. But I won’t decide what ‘too heavy’ means.”

“Then who will?” Malati asked.

Isha pointed at Surabhi.

“She will.”

The slips on the frame began to grow fewer.

Malati picked up the next one.

“Centre parting—Mother.”

Sudha Devi said, “That has changed too. To one side.”

“The maang-tikka?”

“That stays.”

Surabhi said, “Mother’s one.”

For the first time, Malati smiled at Sudha Devi.

“That is a joint decision.”

Then came the matter of the mole that her aunt had mentioned.

Malati asked, “Cover it or leave it?”

Sudha Devi was silent.

Rashmi was silent.

Isha too.

All three faces were visible behind Surabhi in the mirror.

Surabhi looked at her mole.

“Let it stay.”

On a white slip Malati wrote—“mole stays—Surabhi.”

Isha said softly, “Bhaiya probably won’t even notice.”

Surabhi smiled.

“He doesn’t have to notice.”

At that sentence, everyone fell silent for a moment.

Then Malati returned to her work.

When the trial was finished, Surabhi remained seated before the mirror.

The make-up was light.

The maang-tikka sat slightly to one side.

The mole was visible.

Her eyes had kept their own shape.

The colour on her lips was a shade deeper than the sample Isha had sent, because Surabhi had said she liked it.

Rashmi raised her phone to take a photograph.

Malati stopped her with a hand.

“One minute.”

She began removing all the old slips still left on the mirror’s frame.

Surabhi asked, “Why?”

“The work is settled now.”

“You’ll throw them away?”

“Yes.”

Malati gathered the slips in her hand.

Yellow, pink, green, white.

Surabhi looked at them for a moment.

“Give them to me.”

Malati asked in surprise, “These?”

“Yes.”

Surabhi took the slips.

Laughing, Rashmi asked, "Keeping them as souvenirs?"

"Maybe."

Surabhi put them into her purse.

On the morning of the wedding, voices, the clatter of utensils, the scent of flowers and ringing phones filled the house all at once.

When Surabhi reached the parlour, Malati was already prepared.

"Today's rule," Malati said. "Only the bride sits in front of the mirror. Everyone else stays behind."

Sudha Devi sat down on a chair outside.

Rashmi and Isha did the same.

For the first half hour, no instructions came.

Malati worked according to what had already been decided.

Surabhi kept watching her face in the mirror.

At times she closed her eyes, at times she opened them.

Near the mole, Malati paused with the brush and asked, "Sure?"

"Yes."

The brush moved around the mole, not over it.

While her hair was being arranged, Sudha Devi once rose as if to come inside, then stopped herself.

"Something?" Malati asked.

"No. I only wanted to see whether the maang-tikka was straight."

Surabhi said, "Come and look."

Sudha Devi came and stood behind her.

Malati set the ornament slightly to one side.

Sudha Devi reached out and adjusted one tiny prong.

"Is it right here?"

Surabhi looked in the mirror.

"Yes."

Sudha Devi went back outside and sat down.

Isha took out her phone and read a message from her brother, but said nothing.

Surabhi saw her in the mirror.

"What has he written?"

Isha laughed.

"He's asking whether you're ready yet."

"Reply."

"What should I say?"

“Tell him—it’s happening.”

Isha typed it out.

Two hours later, Malati turned the chair slightly.

“Done.”

Surabhi first looked at her own face.

Then, in the mirror, at her mother, Rashmi and Isha seated behind her.

All three looked as though they were ready to say something, yet no words came immediately from any of them.

Malati asked, “Change anything?”

Surabhi looked at the mirror’s frame.

Today it was empty.

Not a single coloured slip remained.

“No.”

Sudha Devi said softly, “The maang-tikka looks very beautiful.”

Rashmi said, “The eyes too.”

Isha laughed. “Whatever Bhaiya meant when he said ‘natural’, I doubt this is what he had in mind.”

Everyone burst out laughing.

Surabhi too.

Long after the wedding, when she finally reached her room at night, she opened her purse while taking off the heavy jewellery.

The old slips from the parlour were still inside.

One read “light colour—Mother”, another “longer eyes—Rashmi”, a third “not too heavy—Isha.”

Some had lines struck through them.

Some had new words added.

On two white slips was her own name.

Surabhi did not tear them up.

She put them into a small envelope.

Then she picked up the small round mirror lying on the table.

The wedding make-up was still on her face, but the kohl had smudged a little at one corner of an eye.

The mole was still there.

With a finger, Surabhi wiped away the smudged kohl.

Now the mirror held not only her face—the day’s exhaustion, laughter, traces of tears, the scent of flowers, her mother’s old maang-tikka, and the colours she herself had chosen were all there together.

She placed the small mirror back on the table.

The large parlour mirror was not here.

Nor were anyone's slips tucked into a frame.

And for the first time she understood that an empty frame did not make a face smaller; it showed it whole.

The First Month on the Job

When Sanjana started going to work, for the first three days everyone at home remembered the time of her bus.

At seven forty-five in the morning, her mother would call from the kitchen, “Have you taken your lunch box?”

Her father would say from the veranda, “Leave ten minutes early. The crossing gets crowded.”

Her younger brother Anup would come as far as the door, and if he saw one end of her dupatta caught in the zip of her bag, he would free it.

Her grandmother always had the same question—“You do eat lunch, don’t you?”

Sanjana would answer all the questions with a smile and leave.

Her work in the office of a private school involved the ledger, the fee register, and applications from parents.

During the first week, what she found hardest was not that the work was new.

What was hard was that even after sitting in a chair all day, by evening her body would be so tired that climbing the stairs at home felt like one more task.

On the first Monday evening, when she reached home, her mother made tea for her.

On the second Monday, when she came home, her mother said, “I’ve made tea, but from tomorrow make it yourself. My work increases in the evening too.”

Sanjana said, “Yes.”

It seemed natural to her.

A job changes not only one’s income but one’s routine as well—Sanjana understood that.

By the third week, the family too had understood that Sanjana came home tired every day.

But in the meantime, something else had quietly changed.

Earlier, whenever her expenses came up, her father would say, “Study for now. I’ll take care of the money.”

Now, while she was getting her bus pass made, he said, “You’ve started earning now.”

Sanjana laughed.

She liked paying for her first monthly pass from her own account.

When her shoe tore, her mother said, “Buy a new pair. You earn now.”

Sanjana liked that sentence too.

She did not buy new shoes.

She had the sole of the old pair stitched instead.

Before her first salary came, she had thought of saving something.

How much, she had not decided.

Only this much—that at the end of the first month her account should not be empty.

On the nineteenth day of her job, the principal came into the office and said, “This time the salary will reach you by the fifth.”

A small smile appeared on the faces of the employees.

Sanjana too looked at her phone, on which no message had arrived yet.

That evening at dinner, her father asked, “What date will the salary come?”

“The fifth.”

“Good.”

That was all.

The next day, her mother looked at the empty gas cylinder and said, “This will have to be refilled this time.”

Sanjana said, “Get it refilled.”

Her mother paused a little and said, “I was thinking, once your salary comes, it can be paid from that.”

Sanjana kept stirring the dal with her spoon.

“All right.”

That was the first “all right.”

The day after that, Anup came back from coaching and said, “Didi, my headphones have stopped working.”

“So?”

“I can’t hear anything in the classes on the phone.”

“Can they be repaired?”

“The shopkeeper said it would be better to buy new ones.”

Her mother called from inside, “Didi’s salary is coming, isn’t it? She’ll see about it.”

Sanjana looked at Anup.

Anup immediately said, “No, no, I didn’t say that.”

Sanjana smiled.

“First see if they can be repaired.”

On Sunday, her aunt came over.

In the course of conversation, talk turned to a wedding the following month.

Her mother said, “Sanjana has a job now. She’ll give Chachi a sari.”

Sanjana was straining the tea at the time.

Her aunt laughed and said, “I don’t want anything. Let her keep her first earnings for herself.”

Her mother laughed too.

“What will she keep for herself? A daughter of the house will spend on the house.”

The sentence was spoken lightly.

No one wanted an argument.

As Sanjana poured the tea, she saw that one cup had filled almost to the brim.

She poured a little of it back into the saucepan.

At half past ten on the morning of the fifth, her phone vibrated.

It was a message from the bank.

Her salary had been credited to her account.

It was less than the monthly amount she had read in the appointment letter.

The school accountant explained it to her—provident fund, no deduction for absence but a proportional deduction because of the date on which she had joined, and a one-time fee for the employee identity card.

Sanjana read the figure again.

She was not disappointed.

For the first time, she simply understood that “salary” was not one number; it reached one’s hand only after several smaller numbers had been cut and divided out of it.

At lunch, her colleague Meera asked, “First salary?”

Sanjana nodded.

“Sweets at home?”

“Maybe.”

“Buy something for yourself first.”

Sanjana laughed.

On her way home that evening, she bought half a kilo of peda.

As soon as the sweets reached home, Grandmother fed the first piece to Sanjana.

Her father said, "This is the sweetness of your first salary."

Anup clapped.

Her mother, her eyes shining, said, "May God take you very far."

At that moment, Sanjana felt that the first month of work had been successfully completed.

After dinner that night, her father asked, "How much came?"

Sanjana told him the amount.

Her father was silent for a moment.

"The appointment letter mentioned more than that."

"There were deductions."

"How much for what?"

Sanjana opened her phone and showed him the salary slip.

Her father read it carefully.

"All right. Provident fund is not a bad thing."

Her mother asked, "Shall we refill the gas cylinder?"

"Yes."

"It'll be refilled tomorrow."

Anup said nothing.

Neither did Grandmother.

Sanjana herself said, "I was thinking I'd give six thousand for the house."

Her father immediately said, "No. Why so much in the first month?"

Her mother too said, "See to your own needs first."

Sanjana felt relieved.

She said, "The bus pass, phone, shoe repair—all that is separate. Giving six thousand won't cause me any difficulty."

Her father did not insist much.

"All right. But only because you want to."

"Yes."

That night, Sanjana transferred six thousand to her mother's account from her phone.

As soon as she saw the message, her mother came into Sanjana's room.

"Now you really are an earning woman."

There was pride in her voice.

Sanjana smiled.

The gas cylinder was refilled the next morning.

Two days later, Grandmother's medicines were bought.

After getting the medicines, her mother said, "I paid for these from the six thousand for the house."

Sanjana liked that no one had asked her separately for the money.

But that evening, her father was speaking to the insurance agent on the phone.

"Yes, keep the next instalment date as the tenth. Now the daughter earns too, so cash at home will be a little easier."

Sanjana heard the sentence while taking off her shoes in the veranda.

Her father did not see her.

She went inside.

On the third day, her mother said, "We won't buy Chachi's sari from here. We'll get a good one from the market. We'll give it in your name."

Sanjana asked, "In my name?"

"Yes. Your first customary gift after getting the job."

"The money?"

Her mother looked at Sanjana's face.

"It'll be from your side, won't it?"

Sanjana said nothing.

Her mother immediately added, "Not very expensive. We'll get a good one for fifteen hundred or two thousand."

That night, Anup was opening up his broken headphones and placing the screws on the table.

"Fixed?" Sanjana asked.

"Half."

"How can it be half?"

"There's sound in one ear now."

They both laughed.

Then Anup said softly, "Ma said I should get new ones, that Didi would pay."

Sanjana looked at him.

Anup kept turning the screw.

"I told her no. It feels bad to me."

"If you need headphones, you can say so."

"I do need them. But why should it already be decided that you'll pay?"

For the first time, Sanjana heard that question from outside herself.

That night, she opened her account.

It had been five days since the salary had come.

Six thousand for the house.

The monthly bus pass.

The monthly phone expense.

Extra lunch on two days when she had not been able to take her lunch box.

The shoe repair.

Two simple kurtas for school, which her father had said he would buy before she started the job, but which Sanjana had paid for herself.

There was still money in the account.

But the amount she had thought of as “savings” now had words gathering all around it—sari, insurance, headphones, medicine, gas.

Some of these were necessities.

Some were affection.

Some were convenience.

Some were merely assumptions.

The problem was not the size of the amount.

The problem was that before those assumptions were made, no one seemed to feel any need to ask Sanjana.

The following week, the rush to deposit fees increased at the school.

Sanjana reached home at seven in the evening.

As soon as her mother opened the door, she said, “Wash your hands and face quickly. Guests are coming.”

“Who?”

“Your Mama and Mami. They’ll eat here.”

Sanjana put down her bag.

“Is there anything I need to do?”

“Just cut the salad and help with the rotis.”

Sanjana used to do these things anyway.

But that day, for the first time, she felt that although she had started working, her old time at home was still assumed to be available.

She cut the salad.

She rolled the rotis too.

Over dinner, Mama asked how the job was going.

“How much is the salary?”

Before Sanjana could answer, her father gave the amount from the appointment letter—the figure before deductions.

Sanjana looked at her father.

He did not notice.

Mama said happily, “Wonderful! The house will have a great deal of support now.”

Her mother said, "Yes, the girl is standing on her own feet now."

Sanjana turned the roti on the griddle.

That night, after Mama and Mami had left, Sanjana asked her father, "The amount you mentioned doesn't actually come into my hands."

Her father folded the newspaper.

"How much difference can there be?"

"Whether the difference is small or large, people form expectations on the basis of that figure."

Her father looked at her.

"I said it with pride."

"I understand."

"Then?"

Sanjana did not answer at once.

"Just let me understand the accounting of what actually comes into my hands too."

Her father opened the newspaper again, but did not read it.

The next day was Sunday.

Sanjana had planned to sleep late.

At eight, her mother called, "Get up. We have to go to the market to buy Chachi's sari."

Sanjana sat up.

She did not suddenly become angry.

Instead, she felt an odd calm.

"Ma, is it necessary to give the sari?"

"How is it necessary? It's a customary gift."

"Am I giving the gift, or are you giving it in my name?"

Her mother did not understand the question.

"Aren't they the same thing?"

"Not to me."

Her mother sat down on the edge of the bed.

Sanjana said, "If I'm giving it, then I'll choose it, decide how much to spend, and when to give it. If you're giving it, why use my name?"

Her mother was silent for a while.

"So much accounting as soon as you get a job?"

The sentence stung Sanjana.

But she did not raise her voice.

"Why did all the accounting start being put in my name as soon as I got a job?"

For a few moments, there was only the sound of the fan in the room.

Her mother got up.

“All right. Forget the sari.”

This “all right” was not a pleased one.

Sanjana did not take it as a victory either.

Until afternoon, both of them spoke very little.

In the evening, Grandmother came and sat beside Sanjana.

“Is your mother angry?”

“A little.”

“And you?”

“Me too.”

Grandmother laughed.

“At least being angry costs nothing. That’s something.”

Sanjana burst out laughing.

Then Grandmother grew serious again.

“When someone earns money for the first time, people do not see the money. They see their own shortages.”

Sanjana remained silent.

“Your mother too has been looking at shortages for a long time.”

“I understand.”

“Understanding and filling every shortage are not the same thing.”

Sanjana looked at Grandmother’s face.

Grandmother got up.

Perhaps that was all she had wanted to say.

On the twenty-fourth day of the month, her father brought up the insurance matter again.

“This instalment is a little heavy. If, over and above your six thousand, I could get another two thousand...”

Sanjana did not interrupt him.

Her father finished what he had to say.

“I’ll return it next month.”

Sanjana asked, “Is this a regular household expense, or only for this month?”

Her father looked surprised.

“Only this month.”

“Then I can give it.”

“All right.”

“But next month, my share for the house will still be six thousand.”

Her father looked at her for a moment.

“You’ve decided that?”

“Yes.”

“Did you ask me?”

Sanjana did not smile.

“I’m asking this time—is six thousand regularly all right?”

Her father slowly nodded.

“All right.”

It was the first time that “Sanjana’s money for the house” had ceased to be a vague phrase and become a fixed amount.

That night, Sanjana printed her salary slip.

At the top of the paper was not the basic salary from the appointment letter, but the actual amount she had received.

The deductions were listed below.

Sanjana did not take the paper to her father.

She put it in her file.

Beside it, she placed the receipt for the monthly bus pass.

Then, on a small piece of paper, she wrote, “House—6000.”

Below that, she wrote another line: “Own savings—first.”

As soon as she wrote it, the sentence seemed a little harsh.

She crossed out “first.”

Then she wrote, “Own savings—regular.”

There seemed to be less of a quarrel in that word.

In the final week of the month, Anup’s headphones stopped working altogether.

This time he came directly to Sanjana.

“Didi, I really do need new ones now.”

“How much?”

He showed her three options.

Sanjana chose not the most expensive one, but the middle one.

“I’ll pay half. You pay half from the money left from your tuition.”

Anup made a face.

“I have very little tuition money.”

“My salary isn’t three salaries either.”

Anup laughed.

“All right.”

Two days later, he brought his half of the money.

Sanjana added the rest and ordered the headphones.

When the package arrived, Anup first handed the box to Sanjana.

“You open it.”

“It’s yours. You open it.”

Anup opened it himself.

Sanjana liked that small thing.

On the last day of the month, the file for the next salary cycle was being prepared at the school.

The accountant joked, “The first month is over. Now even the salary is old.”

Sanjana laughed.

On the bus home, she thought—the job had not grown old in the first month.

Only the language of the people around it had quickly slipped into an old pattern.

“You earn now.”

Within those four words there was congratulations too.

There was relief too.

There was entitlement too.

And sometimes there was also a list of expenses drawn up without the earning person being present.

When Sanjana reached home, her mother was in the kitchen.

“You’re back?”

“Yes.”

“Tea?”

Sanjana put down her bag.

“I’ll make it.”

Her mother said, “Sit down first. I’m making it.”

It was not a great change.

Her mother had made tea for her many times before as well.

Sanjana did not want to turn it into a sign.

She simply sat down.

Her mother brought the tea.

As she set down the cup, she said, “I bought Chachi’s sari.”

Sanjana looked at her mother.

“Good.”

“In my name.”

Sanjana smiled faintly.

Her mother did too.

“If something is to be given in your name, I’ll ask you.”

Sanjana did not immediately say thank you.

She picked up the cup.

The tea was hot.

On the fifth of the next month, her phone vibrated again.

Sanjana was matching the fee register in the office at the time.

A bank message had arrived.

This time the amount was a little higher than in the first month, because there was no deduction on account of her joining date.

Sanjana read the message and placed the phone face down on the desk.

When she reached home that evening, her mother asked, "Has the salary come?"

"Yes."

Her mother did not immediately mention gas, sari, medicine, insurance—anything.

She only asked, "When will you send the six thousand for the house?"

Sanjana said, "Tonight."

"All right."

Anup was studying with his new headphones on.

Her father had folded one corner of the newspaper and was looking for the insurance agent's number.

Grandmother was watering the tulsi plant.

The house was the same house as before.

The shortages had not vanished either.

Sanjana went to her room.

She opened the file and placed the second salary slip beside the first.

A day-old crease had formed on the first sheet.

The second was perfectly straight.

She took out the small paper marked "House—6000."

This time, she wrote nothing new beneath it.

She put the paper back in the file.

From outside came her mother's voice—"Sanjana, dinner in ten minutes."

Sanjana answered, "I'm coming."

She closed the file.

The first month was over.

The salary was now a part of the household.

But not the whole household.

The Old Petticoat

Before the rains withdrew, it was customary in the house to sort through the old clothes.

This time they began with the loft upstairs.

Nira said, "Clothes fit to be worn, on one side. Things that can still be put to some use, on the other. Whatever is completely worn through, in a third pile."

Three sheets were spread out in the courtyard.

On the first went saris, kurtas, and clothes the children had outgrown.

On the second went torn towels, old pillowcases, curtains, and scraps saved for sewing.

On the third went all those things at which everyone said at once, "This is of no use to anyone now."

Sudha Devi was sitting on the veranda, picking through neem leaves.

She was in no hurry.

For everyone else in the house, this was cleaning.

For her, sorting clothes was nothing new.

For thirty years, which garment had torn when, whose size had changed, which sari had become which pillowcase - her hands seemed to remember all of it on their own.

But today Nira was the one making the lists.

She was Sudha Devi's daughter-in-law.

With her was Anvita, the granddaughter, who was in college.

"Grandmother, this?" Anvita asked, lifting a faded brown garment.

Sudha Devi looked at it from a distance.

"Leave it."

"Fit to wear?"

"No."

"Then the second pile?"

Breaking the stems off the neem leaves, Sudha Devi said, "Keep it separate for now."

Anvita unfolded the garment completely.

It was a petticoat.

Its colour was hard to make out.
 Perhaps it had once been a deep maroon.
 Now it was brownish in places, muddy in others, with a faint trace of red here and there.
 The hem was not all of one kind.
 In one place, a blue piece of cloth had been attached.
 In another, a green one.
 Near the seam at the back was a yellow, flowered patch.
 The waistband was of a cloth different from the original fabric.
 Nira laughed.
 "Mother, does this get a separate pile of its own?"
 Sudha Devi said, "Make one."
 "What shall we call it? Historical artefacts?"
 Harinarayan Babu, sitting on the veranda, folded his newspaper and laughed.
 "This is your mother's museum."
 Sudha Devi did not answer.
 Anvita placed the petticoat in her lap and sat down.
 Her eyes remained fixed on the hem.
 "Grandmother, has this been sewn this many times?"
 "Yes."
 "Why didn't you throw it away?"
 Sudha Devi gathered the pile of neem leaves together.
 "The cloth would tear. The work would not stop."
 Hearing this, Anvita turned the petticoat over again.
 The inside of the hem was more interesting than the outside.
 Seam upon seam.
 Some stitches had been done by hand.
 Some by machine.
 In one place, thick cloth had been folded twice.
 Elsewhere, an old seam had been opened and joined again.
 "What cloth is this blue patch from?" Anvita asked.
 Nira bent down to look.
 "I think this is from Dhiraj's school shirt."
 Dhiraj came out of the inner room.
 "Mine?"
 He came over to the petticoat.
 The moment he saw the blue cloth, his face changed.

"Yes, my shirt in Class Five was this colour."

Harinarayan Babu said, "That year the school had changed the shirt to blue."

Dhiraj laughed.

"I tore two shirts that year."

Everyone remembered Dhiraj's shirts.

Sudha Devi remembered the night she had sewn on that patch.

She said, "It was cloth left from the back of the shirt after it tore."

"You put it on this?" Anvita asked.

"That summer, the tap in the lane had gone dry."

No one understood at once.

Sudha Devi took the petticoat in her hands.

She placed a finger on the blue patch.

"I used to bring water from the hand pump by the railway line. One day this hem caught on a broken brick and tore. That night I cut up Dhiraj's old shirt and patched it."

Dhiraj fell silent.

He remembered his blue shirt.

He did not remember his mother's petticoat as she carried water.

Harinarayan Babu tried to open the newspaper again, but did not.

Anvita asked, "So this patch isn't from Class Five. It's from the year of the water?"

Sudha Devi smiled.

"If you want to give it a name, write whatever you like."

Nira was lifting an old towel from the second pile.

Anvita said, "And this green one?"

Sudha Devi pulled the petticoat closer to herself.

The green patch was small, but the stitching around it was dense.

"That was Pinki's frock," Nira said at once.

Pinki was Sudha Devi's daughter; she now lived in Madhubani.

Harinarayan Babu said, "She was very fond of green."

Sudha Devi nodded.

"It was a frock."

"When was it patched?"

"Pinki had fallen ill."

Nira stopped.

"Typhoid?"

"Yes."

Everyone in the house knew the story of Pinki's illness.

The fever had risen.

The doctor had arrived late.

Harinarayan Babu had kept a wet cloth on her forehead all night.

That story had been told again and again.

No one had heard Sudha Devi's version.

"Her bedsheet had to be changed four times a day," she said.

"Washing the bedding over and over, the edge of this petticoat wore against the stone. After Pinki recovered, I patched it with a frock she had outgrown."

Harinarayan Babu said softly, "I don't remember that."

In an even voice, Sudha Devi said, "You remember the fever."

Anvita ran her palm over the green patch.

"And you remember the washing."

Sudha Devi did not answer.

The sunlight in the courtyard had moved from one corner of the sheets to another.

All three piles kept growing.

But the petticoat was no longer in any pile.

It lay open before Anvita.

The waistband had been remade with thick red cloth.

Looking at it, Nira said, "This must be the border of one of Mother's old saris."

Sudha Devi laughed.

"My sari."

"Which one?"

"The one I wore in the first year of your marriage."

Nira looked startled.

"My marriage?"

"Not yours. Your brother-in-law's."

Nira burst out laughing.

"I've lost track of the reckoning altogether."

Harinarayan Babu corrected her this time: "At Dhiraj's wedding, Sudha wore a red-and-black sari."

From inside, Dhiraj said, "That sari lasted a very long time."

"It did," Sudha Devi said.

Anvita opened the waistband and looked inside.

There were two layers of old cloth within it.

"Why was this changed?"

Sudha Devi was silent for a moment.

"The waist changed."

Nira was about to laugh, then stopped.

Sudha Devi herself laughed.

"Does a person's body remain the same size forever?"

Anvita smiled too.

"When?"

"After Dhiraj's wedding."

Harinarayan Babu joked, "Once the daughter-in-law came, you must have got some rest."

Sudha Devi looked at him.

Her gaze was neither sharp nor gentle.

Only direct.

"The daughter-in-law had come, and still getting up at four every morning was my work."

Nira looked at Harinarayan Babu.

Harinarayan Babu began straightening the corner of his newspaper.

Sudha Devi said, "That year Babu's knee went bad. Dhiraj had just started a new job. The younger son was away. There were more people in the house, and more work too."

A thread in the waistband caught on Anvita's fingernail.

She freed it carefully.

"So the waistband is a record of your waist growing?"

"No."

Sudha Devi folded the cloth and opened it again.

"This waistband is a record of the fact that there was no time to buy new cloth."

Nira said softly, "A petticoat could have been bought."

"It could have."

"Then why?"

For a few moments Sudha Devi kept untangling the drawstring at the waist.

"The list of household expenses was long. This one was still serviceable for me."

It was a very ordinary sentence.

Even so, the courtyard fell silent for a moment.

Anvita asked, "Grandmother, do you remember every single seam in it?"

"Not all of them."

"You remember so many."

"When the hand does the same work again and again, some trace of it remains in the hand."

Nira now stopped sorting the third pile and came to sit beside the petticoat.

She looked at the yellow flowered patch.

"This isn't from any of my clothes."

Sudha Devi said, "No."

"Pinki's?"

"No."

Harinarayan Babu guessed, "A curtain?"

Sudha Devi nodded.

"An old kitchen curtain."

Nira immediately said, "When did the kitchen ever have a curtain?"

"Before you came here."

"How did this patch get put on?"

Sudha Devi smiled.

"That isn't a good story."

Anvita grew eager.

"Then you must tell it."

"Once, a tin of mustard oil fell."

Harinarayan Babu laughed.

"Such a small incident?"

"It seems small to you."

There was laughter in Sudha Devi's voice too.

"The whole kitchen was covered in oil. I slipped. The hem caught on the corner of the stove and tore."

Nira asked, "Were you hurt?"

"I scraped my knee."

"Did anyone see?"

"Everyone was busy saving the oil."

This time Harinarayan Babu did not laugh.

Anvita noticed a small black stain beside the yellow patch.

"From that day?"

"Could be."

"You didn't say anything?"

"What was there to say? The oil had spilled. It had to be cleaned."

Anvita turned the petticoat over again.

For the first time she understood that a tear in cloth was not merely an event in the life of cloth.

Behind every torn place there was a body.

Behind the body, work.

Behind the work, time.

And behind time, a house.

Dhiraj had now come fully into the courtyard and sat down.

He looked again at the patch from his blue shirt.

"Ma, how old is this petticoat?"

Sudha Devi did the arithmetic in her head.

"Older than your Class Five days."

"Meaning thirty years?"

"About that."

Anvita was startled.

"The same petticoat for thirty years?"

Sudha Devi corrected her at once: "It hasn't remained the same cloth."

"What do you mean?"

"Half of it has changed."

She ran a finger along the inside of the hem.

"The original cloth is here and here. The rest was added later."

Anvita laughed.

"Then this petticoat is like a ship - one plank after another keeps being replaced, but the name remains the same."

Dhiraj said, "You've been reading too much in college."

Sudha Devi did not ask what she meant.

She only said, "What difference does changing the name make?"

Nira lifted the lower hem of the petticoat.

"Mother, why are there three folds in this hem?"

"It used to be longer."

"Then?"

"I shortened it."

"Then?"

"Then I lengthened it again."

Anvita burst out laughing.

"Did the body change again?"

"The body, the work, everything."

Sudha Devi said, "When the children were small, if the hem hung low it gathered water, ash, mud - everything. So I turned it up."

"Why lengthen it again?"

"The children grew up. I began going out more. I opened the old fold."

Slowly, Nira separated the three layers.

The cloth inside was less faded than the outer part.

As though time had remained preserved within it.

On one layer was an old white soap stain.

On another, a black trace of smoke.

On the third, many tiny needle holes.

Anvita said, "These really are layers."

Sudha Devi said, "When cloth stays folded, the part inside wears less."

"And life?"

Harinarayan Babu smiled. "Now the philosophy begins."

Anvita laughed.

Sudha Devi did not.

She simply put the folds of the petticoat back together.

The sorting began again.

A little while later, Pinki called.

Jokingly, Nira said, "We found your old frock here."

Pinki laughed over the phone.

"My frock?"

Anvita picked up the phone as if to take a photograph, then stopped.

She looked at Sudha Devi.

"May I take a picture?"

Sudha Devi said, "Of the cloth?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Anvita thought about her answer.

"For remembrance."

Sudha Devi said, "Talk to Pinki first."

The phone was handed to her.

Pinki's voice could be heard out in the courtyard.

"Ma, you've kept that petticoat till now?"

Sudha Devi laughed.

"You people are only finding out now."

Pinki said, "I loved that green frock."

"Everyone remembers the frock."

"Then?"

"Nothing."

Sudha Devi handed the phone back to Anvita.

Anvita did not take a photograph.

She kept looking at the petticoat with her own eyes.

The afternoon declined.

The clothes on the first sheet were packed into sacks.

The scraps on the second were put away in the sewing corner.

Some clothes from the third pile were to be cut up for wiping the floor.

Nira brought the scissors.

"Come, now for the third pile."

Anvita pulled the petticoat closer to herself.

Nira asked, "Which pile does this go in?"

Anvita looked at her grandmother.

Sudha Devi said, "Give it to me."

Nira handed her the petticoat.

Harinarayan Babu asked, "Back into the trunk?"

"No."

"Then?"

Sudha Devi went over to the sewing machine.

A dust cover lay over the machine.

She spread the petticoat on the table.

One seam along the hem had begun to come completely apart.

"First this has to be mended."

Surprised, Nira asked, "You'll wear it again?"

"No."

"Then why sew it?"

Sudha Devi said, "If I leave it torn, the cloth will unravel further."

Anvita pulled up a chair and sat beside the machine.

"Shall I sew it?"

Sudha Devi looked at her.

"Can you sew a straight seam?"

"I can learn."

Sudha Devi opened an old box.

There were many spools of thread.

Brown, maroon, black, blue.

Anvita picked up a yellow spool.

Nira said, "That doesn't match the colour at all."
Anvita looked at her grandmother.
"Shall I use one that matches?"
Sudha Devi looked at the old seams on the petticoat.
Every one of them had been sewn with thread chosen to match.
So that no one's eye would fall on them.
For a few moments she was silent.
Then she put the yellow spool back into Anvita's hand.
"Use it."
Anvita tried to thread the machine needle.
The first time, the thread would not pass through the eye.
Nor the second time.
Sudha Devi did not take the needle from her hand.
She only said, "Wet the end of the thread."
Anvita did so.
This time the thread went through.
The wheel of the machine turned slowly.
The yellow seam showed clearly against the old brown hem.
From a distance Harinarayan Babu said, "Such bright thread?"
Sudha Devi answered, "Let it show."
Dhiraj looked at the patch from his blue shirt.
Nira at the yellow flowered patch.
No one had anything to say.
Anvita completed the seam.
Her line was not perfectly straight.
At one place the thread veered slightly crooked.
Nervously she asked, "Shall I open it and do it again?"
Sudha Devi touched the seam with a finger.
"No."
"It's crooked."
"Leave it."
Anvita removed the petticoat from the machine.
Very little sunlight now remained in the courtyard.
Sudha Devi shook out the cloth and lifted it to fold it.
First the waist went inside.
Then the hem.
Then the blue patch disappeared within the folds.
The green one too.

The yellow flowered piece as well.

At the end, the new yellow seam remained facing outward.

Anvita said, "It shows even when it's folded."

Sudha Devi opened the cloth again.

This time she folded it so that the yellow seam did not go inside.

The small bright line remained on top.

Nira asked, "Where shall we keep it?"

Sudha Devi pointed to the basket beneath the sewing machine.

"Here."

"Not in the trunk?"

"No."

"Not in the throwaway pile?"

"No."

"Then what will it become?"

Placing the petticoat in the basket, Sudha Devi said, "Nothing for now."

After dinner that night, Harinarayan Babu came onto the veranda carrying his old white kurta.

One sleeve of the kurta was torn.

He put it beside Sudha Devi and said, "Does this too have thirty years of history, or does it go straight to wiping the floor?"

Sudha Devi picked up the kurta.

She gave it one look.

Then she laughed.

"This doesn't carry so many marks of work. It carries more marks of rest."

Harinarayan Babu laughed too.

Anvita was listening from inside.

The next morning, before leaving for college, she went to the sewing machine. The petticoat lay folded in the basket. The crooked yellow seam was clearly visible on top. Anvita did not touch it; she simply stood there for a moment.

Inside the house, her mother was making tea. Grandmother was sweeping the courtyard. Babuji was looking for the newspaper. Dhiraj was taking out the motorcycle. Every task had already begun in its own voice.

Anvita walked toward the gate. From behind, she looked once more at the basket by the sewing machine. She no longer saw the blue shirt, the green frock, the red sari, or the yellow curtain as separate things.

What she saw were the seams - old, dense, almost invisible. And one new one - yellow, crooked, deliberately visible.

The Guest Room

There were four bedrooms in Devaki Devi's house.

Even so, if anyone asked her, "Which room is yours?" she would pause for a moment.

The reason for that pause was not that the house was small.

The house was, in fact, large.

Madhav Babu had built it in the old quarter of Laheriasarai five years before his retirement: a veranda in front, a square courtyard in the middle, two rooms on the right, two on the left, the kitchen at the back, and an open terrace above.

While the house was being built, Devaki Devi had counted the bricks, kept account of the masons' wages, and, when the rains came, had had sacks spread over the half-built walls.

Madhav Babu would joke, "The house may bear my name, but every brick has been counted by you."

Devaki Devi would reply, "Let the name be yours; just make sure the roof doesn't leak."

Madhav Babu had been dead for seven years now.

The elder son, Prabhat, lived in the house with his wife Nirmala, their daughter Isha, and their son Manav. The younger son, Alok, worked in Pune and came home twice a year.

The four rooms had never been divided on paper; habit had divided them.

The front room belonged to Prabhat and Nirmala.

The one beside it was Isha's room for studying and sleeping.

The smaller room at the back was Manav's, where there were more cricket bats, shoes, and wires than books.

The fourth room was the cleanest of all.

A small brass-coloured plaque hung on its door: "Guest."

Nirmala had bought the plaque in Janakpur.

The guest room was always ready: a white sheet, two matching pillows, a light curtain at the window, an empty table, a water jug, and two empty shelves in the cupboard.

It was a matter of pride for the household.

Nirmala would say, "If someone arrives unexpectedly, they should feel that the house was waiting for them."

Devaki Devi never objected to that sentence.

The only difficulty was that the woman who had lived in the house for forty years had no room permanently waiting for her.

While Madhav Babu was alive, he and Devaki Devi had lived together in one of the two front rooms.

After his death, Prabhat said, "Ma, what will you do alone in such a large room? Nirmala and I have more things. Stay in Isha's room. The two of you will have each other's company too."

Devaki Devi agreed.

Isha was ten then. At night she would fall asleep listening to stories from her grandmother.

Three years later, Isha's final school examinations drew near.

One evening Nirmala said, "Maaji, Isha needs privacy at night too, just for three months. Please move into the guest room."

Devaki Devi agreed again.

She liked the guest room on the first night. From the window she could see the upper branches of the neem tree.

She set her little clock on the table, placed her tulsi beads beside the pillow, and put the red medicine box behind the water jug.

The next day, while folding the white sheet, Nirmala said, "This one is for guests. I'll put the flowered sheet on for you."

Devaki Devi said, "All right."

Three weeks later, Nirmala's maternal uncle and aunt were coming to stay for two nights.

Devaki Devi's bedding was tied up again.

A folding cot was opened in Manav's room.

Manav objected. "If Dadi stays in my room, where will I study at night?"

Prabhat said, "It's only for two nights."

Devaki Devi said, "I'll sleep on the veranda."

Everyone said, "Why on the veranda?"

But in the end, for those two nights Devaki Devi slept on the veranda, because the veranda lay outside every dispute.

From that day on, her bedding remained permanently tied up.

A mattress, a thin quilt, two sheets, and a pillow—in a blue cotton cover.

By day the blue bundle stayed under the stairs; by night it was opened wherever space happened to be available.

Devaki Devi did not call it “my room.” She called it “my bundle.”

Isha would laugh.

“Dadi, your house walks around with you.”

Devaki Devi would laugh too.

But gradually her belongings also began to settle in different parts of the house.

The red medicine box sat on top of the food cupboard.

Her old spectacle case lay beside the kitchen window.

Two good saris were kept in Prabhat’s room, because Isha’s cupboard was full.

Her woollen shawl was on the upper shelf of the guest-room cupboard.

Three letters from Madhav Babu were in an iron trunk kept under the stairs behind the blue bundle.

At night, when she needed her medicine, she first had to remember: where is the red box today?

Sometimes Nirmala would say, “Maaji, why don’t you keep your things in one place?”

Devaki Devi would smile.

“If I find one place, I will.”

Nirmala took it as a joke.

One winter, Alok came from Pune with his wife and child.

They were given the guest room.

Manav gave his room to Alok’s child.

Manav spread a mattress on the floor of Isha’s room.

Devaki Devi slept on a folding cot in the sitting room.

The sitting room had to become a sitting room again every morning, so she had to put away her bedding before sunrise.

One day Manav slept until seven. His mattress was still lying in Isha’s room.

No one woke him.

Devaki Devi had already folded her quilt into the blue cover at five.

That day, for the first time, she saw the difference clearly: the person who had a room could make the household’s timetable bend around their sleep; the person who had no room had to make their sleep obey the household’s timetable.

She said nothing to anyone.

In Phagun, her old friend Janki Jha came to visit.

Janki Devi was a widow and lived in Patna with her younger daughter.

The two sat on the veranda talking for a long while.

Janki Devi said, "Your house is beautifully done up now. Come, show me your room."

Devaki Devi rose, then stopped.

"Which one?"

Janki Devi laughed. "Your room. The one where you sleep."

Devaki Devi tried to laugh too.

"At present, in Manav's room."

"At present?"

"He has gone to the hostel, you know."

This time Janki Devi's laugh grew shorter.

She asked nothing more.

The two went into Manav's room. There were photographs of cricketers on the wall, mathematics books on the table, and Manav's jacket on a hook. Devaki Devi's blue bundle had been pushed under the bed.

Janki Devi said only, "Where are your things?"

Devaki Devi moved her hand in a circle.

"All over the house."

At that answer both women laughed, though both understood the reason for the laughter.

In Baisakh, Manav returned from the hostel.

Devaki Devi moved back into the guest room, because no guest was expected for three weeks.

This time she did not fully open her blue bundle.

She took out only the quilt and the pillow.

Instead of setting the clock on the table, she kept it on top of the bundle.

At night she took out the medicine box; in the morning she put it back inside.

Isha noticed.

"Dadi, if you're staying here, why don't you unpack your things?"

Devaki Devi said, "Once things are opened out, it is hard to pack them again."

"Are guests coming?"

"Not yet."

"Then?"

Devaki Devi went on wiping the glass of the clock.

"They may."

Two weeks later Nirmala brought news: her aunt's son from Samastipur was coming with his wife for three days.

They were due on Friday.

On Tuesday itself Nirmala said, "Maaji, please get the guest room ready. The sheet has to be changed and the curtain washed."

Devaki Devi asked, "They are coming four days from now, aren't they?"

"Yes, but it is better if the room is ready beforehand."

Devaki Devi tied up the blue bundle.

This time Isha watched her lift it.

"Dadi, where will you stay for these four days?"

"In the sitting room."

"But the guests aren't here yet."

Devaki Devi said, "Their room has arrived before they have."

Isha said nothing.

On Wednesday, the cot was opened in the sitting room.

On Thursday, a phone call came from Samastipur—the aunt's daughter's child was ill, and the journey had been postponed.

Nirmala put down the phone and said, "All right, they aren't coming now."

The guest room remained clean, white, and empty.

Devaki Devi's blue bundle remained in a corner of the sitting room.

In the evening she began to open the cot.

Isha said, "Dadi, the guest room is empty."

From the kitchen Nirmala called out, "Let it be, Maaji. A fresh sheet has just been spread. It'll get spoiled again."

Devaki Devi's hand stopped on the leg of the folding cot.

For a few moments she looked toward the white door.

Then she opened the cot.

That night sleep came late.

No one's behaviour was harsh enough to be given the name injustice.

Prabhat bought her medicines. Nirmala served her meals on time. Isha massaged oil into her hair. Manav brought her favourite sugar crystals from the market.

They all loved her.

But inside that love was a question so small that no one noticed it: where in the house would her night come to rest?

The next morning Devaki Devi did not tie up the blue bundle.

After folding the cot in the sitting room, she went straight to the guest room.

The white sheet was exactly as it had been.

She opened the cupboard. Two empty shelves were in front of her. Above them were two guest towels, a box of soap, and an extra pillow.

Devaki Devi put her red medicine box on the lower empty shelf.

Beside it she placed the spectacle case.

Then she opened the iron trunk under the stairs, took out Madhav Babu's three letters, and placed them there too.

Nirmala came and stood at the doorway.

"Maaji?"

Devaki Devi turned.

Nirmala looked at the cupboard, then at the white sheet.

"Are you looking for something?"

"No. I'm putting things away."

"What things?"

"My things."

Nirmala fell silent.

Devaki Devi's voice was neither sharp nor complaining.

She was simply putting her things away.

Nirmala said softly, "What if guests come?"

Devaki Devi closed the cupboard door.

"Then they will stay in the house."

Nirmala remained silent, as if searching for an answer.

Devaki Devi went on, "So will I."

There was no family council that day.

Prabhat went to the office. Manav went to college. Isha sat down with her books. Nirmala ground spices in the kitchen.

In the afternoon Devaki Devi brought her two saris from Manav's room and put them in the guest-room cupboard.

In the evening she opened the blue bundle.

The mattress was spread on the bed. The flower-printed sheet went over it. The white guest sheet was folded and placed on the upper shelf.

The brass plaque on the door still said "Guest."

Devaki Devi did not take it down.

Three days later, Prabhat's maternal uncle arrived without notice.

Nirmala looked at Devaki Devi for a moment.

Out of old habit, the words had nearly left her mouth: "Maaji, for two nights..."

But the sentence was never completed.

Prabhat himself said, "I'll open the folding cot in the sitting room. Mama will get better air there too."

Mama laughed and said, "As long as I get a cot, that's enough. I'm not a king just because I'm a guest."

The matter ended there.

That night Mama slept in the sitting room.

Devaki Devi slept in the guest room.

No one's dignity diminished.

The following week Isha brought home a small wall clock from the market.

"Dadi, your old clock keeps falling over. Shall I hang this one up?"

Devaki Devi looked at the wall.

There was no nail in the guest-room wall, because Nirmala used to say that a clean wall looked beautiful.

Devaki Devi asked for a small hammer.

Isha held the nail.

The first tap was light.

At the second, the nail went into the wall.

Hearing the sound from the doorway, Nirmala came over.

She looked at the clock, looked at the nail, and looked at grandmother and granddaughter.

She said nothing.

Isha hung up the clock.

Devaki Devi stepped back two paces.

The clock was running.

The blue bundle was empty now. It was folded and placed at the bottom of the cupboard.

The plaque on the door still read "Guest."

But inside, the clock had found its place on the wall.

And for the first time, when Devaki Devi woke in the morning, she did not have to wonder where her bedding would be opened that night.

Secret Savings

Malati Devi's savings were not kept in any box.

Not inside the cupboard, not beneath the mattress, not knotted into an old sari.

Even if the people of the house had searched her room ten times, they would not have found even five hundred rupees together in one place.

Even so, Malati Devi was firmly certain that if a need arose, she had money.

That certainty lay scattered along her daily route.

In that small neighbourhood of Laheriasarai, on the one-and-a-half-kilometre road from her house to the market, her invisible savings lay in four places—Gopal Sahu's grocery shop, Shambhu the milkman's ledger, Savitri Pharmacy, and the torn red notebook of Revati, the vegetable seller.

Sometimes seven rupees.

Sometimes twenty-three.

Sometimes forty-two.

At times a full two hundred.

Malati Devi would buy something, settle the bill, and if the shopkeeper said, "I don't have change; take it next time," she would reply, "Write it under my name."

Even if change was available the next day, she did not immediately take it.

"Let it stay. Let it keep adding up."

At first Gopal Sahu used to laugh.

"Auntie, have you opened a bank?"

Malati Devi would say, "What is in the bank will come by the bank's route. This is money on the road."

Gopal Sahu did not understand what she meant by that answer, but on one page of his ledger he wrote "Malati Jha" and kept adding the small amounts.

At home, the matter was never discussed.

Jagdish Babu, Malati Devi's husband, worked in the accounts section of the electricity department. Accounts were his profession. On the first

day of every month he gave Malati Devi the money for household expenses and took it for granted that the family's finances ran on his earnings and his bank account.

"Twelve thousand went on groceries and milk this month?"

He would say.

Malati Devi would answer, "Yes."

"Last month it was eleven thousand seven hundred."

"Mustard oil became more expensive this month."

Jagdish Babu would open the calculator, add two or four figures, shake his head, and the matter would end there.

He never asked why Gopal Sahu had charged thirty-five rupees less than the price printed on the tin of mustard oil, or how Malati Devi had compared prices at two shops for a five-kilo sack of rice and saved fifty-eight rupees.

Malati Devi did not tell him either.

To her, saving meant this: from a sum that was already destined to be spent, something should remain in her own hands as a choice she could make herself.

The money was small.

The choice was not.

There were two children in the house—twenty-three-year-old Pranav and nineteen-year-old Mansi. Pranav was preparing for competitive examinations, and Mansi was in her second year of college. Paying by phone, banking, QR codes, and the new ways of keeping accounts all came very naturally to them.

One day, while buying vegetables from Revati, Mansi heard her mother talking.

Revati said, "Didi, thirty-four from last time and sixteen from today—that makes fifty."

Malati Devi said, "Let it stay written down."

On the way home Mansi asked, "Ma, why did you leave fifty rupees there?"

"I didn't leave it. It's mine."

"Then bring it home."

"What do I need it for right now?"

Mansi laughed. "You're asking what fifty rupees is for? If money stays at home, will it go bad?"

Malati Devi laughed too. "Small money disappears fastest at home."

"Who takes it?"

"No one. The house takes it."

Mansi laughed again at that answer, but Malati Devi was serious.

No one stole the five-, ten-, or fifty-rupee notes in the house. Sometimes Pranav would say, “Ma, give me twenty for the auto.” Sometimes Jagdish Babu would say, “Do you have change? The tea seller can’t break five hundred.” Sometimes an extra packet of milk would arrive. Sometimes the broom would break. Sometimes a guest would turn up without warning.

Small money, once it stayed at home, took the shape of the household.

Written in a market ledger, it retained its own name.

Malati Devi had not devised this method after a great deal of thought.

Years earlier, when Mansi was five, she had developed a high fever one night. Jagdish Babu was away on tour. There were one hundred and thirty-seven rupees in cash at home. The pharmacy was open at night, but the two medicines the doctor had prescribed cost two hundred and ten rupees.

That night Harinarayan, the owner of Savitri Pharmacy, had said, “Give me what you have. Pay the rest later.”

Malati Devi had never forgotten that sentence.

A few days later, when she paid the balance, she gave ten rupees extra. When Harinarayan tried to return it, she said, “Let it stay. Under my name.”

Those ten rupees later became forty-seven.

Then one hundred and twenty-two.

Slowly, a small sum began to remain under Malati Devi’s name at Savitri Pharmacy.

The memory of that night’s fear was not money, but the money became its form.

Malati Devi never added up the total of all four places at once.

She kept only a rough estimate in her mind.

Around two thousand, perhaps, with Gopal.

Less than a thousand in the milkman’s ledger.

At the pharmacy, sometimes more and sometimes less—because the amount also went down whenever she bought medicines there.

Five or seven hundred with Revati.

Besides this, she deposited two hundred rupees a month in the neighbourhood women’s savings group. The money was in her name, but there was a rule for withdrawing it—in an emergency, the signatures of three members were required.

Jagdish Babu knew about the women’s group, not about the savings.

To him, those meetings were merely “neighbourhood gossip.”

“You all sit for two hours drinking tea,” he would joke.

Malati Devi would say, “We drink the tea with our own money.”

One Tuesday morning, Jagdish Babu’s phone rang.

It was a message from the bank: because an unusual transaction had been attempted on the account, transactions had been temporarily blocked for security reasons.

At first Jagdish Babu assumed it was some ordinary technical problem.

He tried to pay the electricity bill by phone. It did not go through.

He went to an ATM. The card was declined.

At the branch he learned that during the night, two unsuccessful attempts had been made to transfer large sums from his account. The bank had frozen the account. An application, identity documents, a written complaint, verification—the whole process had to be completed. The officer said, “It may take three to seven working days.”

“Seven days?” Jagdish Babu almost shouted.

“It is a security matter.”

“But all my salary money is in this account.”

“You will have access to everything once the block is lifted.”

That answer was sufficient for the bank. It was not sufficient for the household.

When Jagdish Babu returned home, his face had changed.

It was the eighteenth of the month.

There were one thousand three hundred and twenty rupees in cash at home.

The gas cylinder was on the verge of running out.

The last date for Pranav’s examination application was four days away. The fee was eighteen hundred.

Mansi’s college bus-pass renewal was due in two days.

There were three days’ worth of Jagdish Babu’s mother’s blood-pressure and diabetes medicines left.

There was enough rice in the house for five days.

The milkman’s account for the previous week also had to be paid—or so Jagdish Babu believed.

He sat down in the sitting room and spread papers out before him.

“First Pranav’s form,” he said. “Can we delay the bus pass for two days?”

Mansi said, “If we delay it, there will be a fine.”

“Then whom do we borrow from?”

Pranav said quietly, “Mama?”

Jagdish Babu’s face tightened.

Only the previous month they had borrowed ten thousand from Mama while buying the refrigerator, though it had been repaid within two weeks. Jagdish Babu did not like the thought of holding out his hand again.

“An advance from the office?” Malati Devi asked.

“The procedure takes at least five days.”

“And the bank account will take five to seven days.”

“Yes.”

For a few moments, everyone was silent.

Then Jagdish Babu said, “I’ll take five thousand from Shambhunath. He’ll give it.”

Malati Devi looked up at once.

Shambhunath was the man in the neighbourhood who lent money at interest. Five hundred a month on five thousand. If the date was missed, there was a separate penalty.

“No,” Malati Devi said.

Jagdish Babu looked at her. “Then?”

“Wait until tonight.”

“What will waiting change?”

“Let me see.”

Irritation entered Jagdish Babu’s voice. “Malati, this isn’t a vegetable bill. We have to run the house for seven days.”

Malati Devi did not answer.

In the afternoon she took her shopping bag and went out.

Mansi asked, “Where are you going?”

“To the market.”

“With what money?”

“I have money.”

The first stop was Gopal Sahu’s shop.

Malati Devi said, “Gopal, how much is there under my name?”

Gopal Sahu took out his ledger and turned the pages.

“Two thousand seven hundred and twenty-six.”

Malati Devi herself was surprised. Her estimate had been lower.

“Give me goods worth one thousand today. Leave the rest written down.”

Gopal Sahu did not strike out her name. He wrote the new balance below—one thousand seven hundred and twenty-six.

Rice, lentils, oil, salt, potatoes, and soap went into the bag.

The second stop was Savitri Pharmacy.

"Harinarayan ji, how much is there under my name?"

"One thousand one hundred and seventy."

"Give me a full month's medicines for Maaji."

The medicines came to nine hundred and eighty.

"One hundred and ninety remains," Harinarayan said.

Malati Devi folded the slip and put it into her bag.

The third stop was Shambhu the milkman.

His ledger showed eight hundred and forty rupees deposited in Malati Devi's name.

"Deduct this week's milk from that," she said.

Shambhu laughed. "Auntie, you really do run a bank."

This time Malati Devi did not laugh.

"When the bank shuts, this bank stays open."

Shambhu too fell silent.

There were six hundred and twenty-five rupees with Revati. Malati Devi bought vegetables for three days, then told Revati, "Don't return the rest yet."

Revati asked, "Is there trouble?"

"A little."

"Then take all of it."

"No. Let the trouble remain little; that's why I won't take all of it."

When she returned home, Mansi was astonished by the weight of the bag.

"Ma, where did the money come from?"

"Mine."

"How much?"

For the first time, Malati Devi tried to add up in her mind what still remained at all four places.

Even after deducting the groceries and medicines, the total came to somewhere around five thousand.

When Jagdish Babu returned from the office, he saw the medicines, provisions, and milk slip on the table.

"Is all this on credit?"

"No."

"Then?"

"Money paid earlier."

Jagdish Babu picked up the slips one by one.

"Two thousand seven hundred and twenty-six with Gopal?"

"There was."

“Eight hundred and forty with the milkman?”

“There was.”

“One thousand one hundred and seventy at the pharmacy?”

“There was.”

The surprise in his voice slowly hardened into something like accusation.

“You were keeping all this money hidden from me?”

Malati Devi remained calm.

“Not from you. I was saving it out of the household expenses.”

“Aren’t those the same thing?”

“No.”

Jagdish Babu was about to say something, but Malati Devi spoke first.

“If fifty rupees were lying at home, Pranav would ask for auto fare. You would ask for change. An extra packet of milk would come. It would be nobody’s fault. The money would be spent. When it stays under my name at the shop, it still serves the household, but it doesn’t dissolve away all at once.”

Pranav kept looking at the slips on the table.

Mansi looked at her mother’s face.

Jagdish Babu said, “But I should have known the accounts.”

Malati Devi asked softly, “Why?”

It was not a loud question.

But everyone in the sitting room heard it.

Jagdish Babu did not answer at once.

Malati Devi continued, “You give me the money for the household provisions. Saving from it was part of my work. If there is a shortfall, you ask why. If there is a saving, does every right over that already belong to you as well?”

Jagdish Babu put the slips back on the table.

The conversation did not turn into a quarrel.

Because at that moment the problem had still not ended.

Pranav’s examination fee was still unpaid.

So was Mansi’s bus pass.

Malati Devi said, “The women’s group meets tomorrow.”

Jagdish Babu was startled again. “There too?”

“I deposit two hundred a month.”

“How much has it become?”

“Seven thousand four hundred.”

This time such silence spread through the sitting room that the bell of a rickshaw outside could be heard clearly.

Jagdish Babu sat upright in his chair.

“Seven thousand four hundred?”

“A little at a time, for three years.”

“And I...”

Malati Devi did not interrupt him.

She waited for him to complete the sentence himself.

Jagdish Babu did not complete it.

The next day Malati Devi went to the women’s group meeting. Under the group’s rules, in an emergency a member could immediately withdraw part of her savings. Three members signed. Malati Devi withdrew four thousand.

From those four thousand, Pranav’s examination fee was paid. Mansi’s bus pass was renewed. A gas cylinder arrived.

Malati Devi left the remaining money in the group.

Jagdish Babu said, “If you had taken it all out, we would have been more comfortable.”

“Why?”

“What if the bank takes longer?”

“Then we’ll see again.”

“It is better to see to it now.”

Malati Devi smiled. “I don’t like keeping all the money in my hands at once.”

Jagdish Babu said nothing to that.

On the fifth day, the bank called. Verification was complete. The account had been unblocked.

Jagdish Babu went straight to the ATM. He withdrew money and brought it home.

The crisis could have ended there.

But afterward a new discomfort remained in the house—everyone now knew that Malati Devi’s financial world was larger than the four walls within which the family had long regarded her merely as the person who spent the household money.

That evening Jagdish Babu placed a sheet of paper on the table.

“I was thinking,” he said, “we should open an emergency account. A joint one. We’ll deposit a thousand every month.”

Pranav immediately said, “That’s good.”

Mansi nodded too.

Malati Devi looked at the paper.

“Joint with whom?”

“You and me.”

“That will do.”

Jagdish Babu’s face relaxed.

Then Malati Devi added, “But my small savings will remain separate.”

His expression faltered again for a moment.

“Why?”

“Because the emergency account will belong to the household. This is money I decide how to use.”

Before Jagdish Babu could answer, Mansi burst out laughing.

“Babu, you’ve started asking again.”

Jagdish Babu looked at his daughter, then at Malati Devi.

This time his smile came slowly.

“All right. But at least I’ll know that something is there.”

Malati Devi said, “Knowing that much is enough.”

On the first day of the next month, Jagdish Babu gave Malati Devi the money for household expenses.

Along with it, he gave her a white envelope.

On it was written—“Emergency.”

Malati Devi did not open the envelope to look inside. She placed it on the upper shelf of the cupboard.

In the afternoon she went to the market. From Revati she bought okra, pumpkin, and coriander. The total came to one hundred and eighty-two rupees. Malati Devi gave her two hundred. Revati began to return eighteen rupees. Malati Devi looked at the two notes for a moment. “Write it under my name.” Revati opened the red notebook.

“Starting again?” Revati asked. Malati Devi said, “When did it ever stop?” Revati laughed. She wrote the date in the red notebook and entered the amount—eighteen. Malati Devi picked up her bag and started home.

Along the way stood Savitri Pharmacy, the milk cart, and Gopal Sahu’s shop. At all four places, little numbers would begin gathering again. At home, the white envelope would remain in its place, and Malati Devi’s savings would once again not be kept in any one place.

The Woman Missing from the Photograph

Manjari Devi's face did not appear in any of the family's old albums.

At first, no one found this surprising, because no member of the family had ever opened all the albums together.

While preparations were being made for Babuji's eighty-fifth birthday, the task fell to Ishani.

Ishani studied in Delhi and had come to Darbhanga for the holidays. She was told to choose old photographs and make a slideshow that would be projected on the wall on the evening of the birthday.

"Start with Dada and Dadi's wedding," her father, Nachiketa, said. "Then our childhood, the weddings, the children... Keep the order right."

"Don't worry about the order," Manjari Devi called from the kitchen. "The blue album has the first five years. The green one goes from Nachiketa's upanayan to Rashmi's wedding. The dates in the red album are in reverse order."

Ishani laughed. "Kaki, you remember all of it?"

Manjari Devi came out. There was turmeric on her hands. "If I don't remember, who will date all the photographs in this house?"

Until then, the sentence had sounded ordinary to Ishani.

She opened the first album.

Black-and-white photographs. Babuji young. A large bindi on Dadi's forehead. Three trees in the background. On the second page, four brothers standing in a row. On the third, Nachiketa's annaprashan.

On the back of the photograph, in pencil, someone had written: "Annaprashan, 12 March 1987. Date asked from Manjari."

Ishani paused.

She turned over the next photograph. On the back it said: "Housewarming of the new house. Bhadon. Manjari knows the exact day."

Further on: "Rashmi's farewell. Original negative with Manjari."

Then: "Feast for Nachiketa getting a job. Photographs selected by Manjari."

Ishani kept turning the pages. Manjari Devi's name appeared again and again on the backs, but her face was nowhere.

The green album had more than forty photographs from Rashmi's wedding. The bride, the groom, parents, maternal and paternal uncles and aunts, neighbours, the confectioner - even the driver standing beside the groom's car appeared in one photograph.

Not Manjari Devi.

The red album contained three naming ceremonies, two mundans, one retirement function, five weddings, and a house-warming.

Not Manjari Devi.

Ishani's curiosity turned from a game into a question.

She went to the kitchen. Manjari Devi was tempering cumin.

"Kaki, where are your old photographs?"

"Mine?"

"Yes. I haven't found even one in these albums."

Manjari Devi stirred the ladle. "I was never very fond of having my photograph taken."

"Not even one?"

"There must be one somewhere."

"Where?"

"The dal will burn now. Look at this first."

Ishani understood the answer - there was no time for this subject just then.

That evening, when everyone in the family was sitting on the veranda, she raised the question again.

"Why isn't there a single photograph of Kaki?"

Rashmi Mausi burst out laughing. "She never sat still long enough."

Nachiketa said, "At every function, it was as if Manjari had wheels on her feet."

Babuji pushed up his spectacles and said, "Whenever it was time for a photograph, she would remember some job or other."

"Did she remember the jobs herself, or did everyone remind her of them?" Ishani asked.

For a moment, the veranda fell silent.

Rashmi Mausi tried to lighten the matter. "This girl has started doing research."

Manjari Devi came carrying tea. "Leave the research. Have the cups and plates been counted? Fifty extra people may turn up for the birthday."

Ishani looked at her. Once again, the answer to a question had become a task.

The next day, she was taking down four old boxes from the top of a cupboard. One contained cards, invitation letters, bills, and receipts.

Under them she found a thick register bound in cloth. Its corners were worn. On the cover, in blue ink, was written: "Functions."

Ishani opened it.

The first page: "Rashmi's Wedding."

Below was a list: confectioner - advance paid. Utensils - count. Groom's party lodging - sheets. Dadi's medicine - nine at night. Groom's garlands - two. Rashmi's slippers - in the car before the farewell. Photographer - from two in the afternoon. Nachiketa - station. Digambar - bank. Manjari - keep all slips together.

The second page: "Nachiketa's Upanayan."

Manjari - priest's materials. Manjari - children's food. Manjari - guest room. Manjari - Dadi's insulin. Manjari - photographer's remaining payment.

The third: "Babuji's Retirement."

Manjari - garlands. Manjari - sound system. Manjari - tea. Manjari - sweets. Manjari - house key.

Ishani kept turning the pages. Nowhere was there "Manjari - photograph."

Her name was always beside the work that took place outside the photograph.

An old envelope slipped out from the middle of the register. Inside were five photographic negatives and a sheet of paper.

The sheet contained the photographer's account. At the bottom was written: "Group photograph, two copies. Younger daughter-in-law paid."

The younger daughter-in-law was Manjari Devi.

Ishani searched for the group photograph. She found it.

Everyone was there. Not the younger daughter-in-law.

She took the register to Manjari Devi.

"Is this yours?"

The moment Manjari Devi saw the register, she laughed. "These old papers still haven't been thrown away?"

"Did you write down all these functions?"

"Someone had to write them down."

"And in every one, your name is beside a task."

"There was work to do."

"You aren't in the photographs."

This time Manjari Devi was not stirring a ladle. She was picking dry leaves from the tulsi plant. Her hand stopped for a moment.

“Not being in a photograph does not mean a person is outside the event.”

“But how will someone looking at it later know?”

Manjari Devi threw away the leaf. “Whoever needs to know will know.”

“I didn't know.”

At those words, Manjari Devi looked at Ishani.

She said nothing.

Responsibility for Babuji's eighty-fifth birthday had once again settled on Manjari Devi - this time without any formal announcement.

Babuji had only said, “Keep it simple.”

Nachiketa said, “The food will be catered from outside, so Manjari will have less work.”

Rashmi Mausi said, “I'll take care of the flowers.”

Digambar Kaka said, “I'll arrange the chairs.”

Three days later, the caterer was calling Manjari Devi. The florist was asking Manjari Devi about colours. The chair supplier was asking Manjari Devi for the count. Babuji's medicine, a room for the maternal uncle coming from out of town, milk for the children, electrical wiring, where to keep the cake - every question ultimately reached her.

Ishani made a new page. At the top she wrote: “Babuji 85.”

Below it she assigned a name to each task.

Nachiketa - catering.

Rashmi - flowers.

Digambar - chairs and electricity.

Ishani - photographs and slideshow.

Manjari - Babuji's medicine and the guest room.

Manjari Devi looked at the list.

“Does Nachiketa know the headcount for the meal?”

“He'll find out.”

“Will the florist answer Rashmi's phone?”

“He'll have to.”

“Does Digambar know where the electrical board is -”

“Kaka will find it.”

Manjari Devi smiled. “Are all of you putting me on leave?”

Ishani said, “No. We're only checking whether the word 'leave' applies to you too.”

Until noon on the day of the function, the list worked very well.

At three, the first crack appeared. The caterer brought twenty plates fewer than required. Nachiketa immediately began looking for Manjari Devi.

Ishani showed him the list. "Your name."

Nachiketa laughed, but made the call himself.

At four, the florist brought garlands in the wrong colour. Rashmi Mausi first called, "Manjari!" then stopped herself mid-sentence and spoke to the florist.

At half past four, an electrical connection came loose. From the veranda, Digambar Kaka called, "Manjari, the pliers -"

Then he looked at Ishani.

"Where are the pliers?"

In an easy voice, Manjari Devi said, "Yellow box under the stairs."

Ishani understood: work could be divided, but memory could not be reassigned at once.

At five, Babuji's old friends began arriving. Manjari Devi stood at the door, recognising names and directing people to their places inside.

Ishani thought of taking a photograph of her, then stopped.

She did not want to quietly turn Manjari Devi into an image of "the woman at work" and once again make that old place outside the frame permanent.

At seven in the evening, the cake was cut. There was applause. The children gathered around Babuji.

The photographer said, "Now the whole family together."

At that one sentence, the old arrangement of the household sprang instantly back to life.

"Manjari, clear the plates."

"Manjari, where is Dadi's shawl?"

"Manjari, hold the little child."

"Manjari, have the cake taken inside."

Her name came from four directions.

Quite naturally, Manjari Devi began moving away from the place for the photograph.

This time Ishani did not catch her hand. She only said loudly, "Whoever's job it is should do it. Kaki belongs in the group."

Nachiketa picked up the plates. Rashmi brought the shawl. Digambar took the child in his arms. The caterer's boy carried the cake inside.

Manjari Devi was left standing in the middle of the veranda.

Her hands were empty. Perhaps for that reason, she seemed not to know where to put them.

The photographer said, "Maaji, you stand here."

Manjari Devi stood at the edge.

Ishani said, "Kaki, a little further in."

"This is fine."

"There is room inside."

Manjari Devi took two steps inward.

Just then, Babuji's cap slipped to one side. Manjari Devi raised her hand, then stopped herself. Nachiketa straightened the cap.

The photograph was taken.

The camera flashed the first time.

The second time, one child closed his eyes.

The third time, Babuji burst out laughing because the child in Digambar Kaka's arms was tugging at his garland.

Three photographs were taken. Manjari Devi was in all three.

By the time the function ended, it was eleven at night. Everyone was tired.

Manjari Devi got up to collect the last cup. Rashmi Mausi said, "Leave it. Tomorrow."

Manjari Devi looked at the cup.

"It can stay till tomorrow?"

"It can."

She sat down again.

To Ishani, this scene looked more unusual than the group photograph.

The following week, the photographer delivered the prints. Ishani placed all three group photographs on the table.

In the first, everyone was serious. In the second, a child's eyes were closed. In the third, everything was slightly out of order - a garland crooked, Babuji laughing, Digambar managing the child, Rashmi's shawl half fallen, and in Manjari Devi's hand the small paper slip on which the time for Babuji's medicine was written.

Nachiketa said, "The first one is clearer."

Rashmi Mausi said, "Everything is untidy in the third."

Babuji picked up the third photograph.

"In this one, people look alive," he said.

Manjari Devi looked at the third photograph.

"Why is there a slip in my hand?"

Ishani laughed. "Because that was the one moment when you had nothing else in your hands."

At first Manjari Devi placed a finger over the slip in the photograph as though to hide it, then moved her finger away.

“Let it stay.”

Ishani put the third photograph in the album.

When she began writing the names on the back, her pen stopped.

On the backs of the old photographs there had been sentences such as: “Ask Manjari for the date,” “Original negative with Manjari,” “Manjari knows the account.”

This time she wrote everyone’s names in order.

Babuji. Rashmi. Nachiketa. Digambar. Manjari. Ishani. The children.

Only names. No tasks.

Manjari Devi read what was written on the back.

“You haven’t written the date?”

Ishani handed her the pen.

“You write it.”

Manjari Devi wrote the date. Beneath it, unlike before, she added no account, instruction, or reminder.

She turned the photograph face-up again.

In the third row, between Babuji’s crooked garland and a child’s raised hand, her face was clear.

Before closing the album, Manjari Devi looked once more at her own name on the back.

It was the first time that the name had not been written after some task.

The Nameplate

It was an evening in Bhadon. Rain had been falling on and off all day. One screw of the brass-coloured nameplate fixed to the right-hand gatepost had come loose. Whenever the wind blew, the plate knocked against the post with a tap-tap sound.

Shailaja Devi went out twice and straightened it by hand. The third time, when a strong gust rose, the plate sagged to one side.

From inside, Naveen called out, "Ma, leave it. I'll have a new one put up tomorrow."

Shailaja Devi cupped a hand beneath the plate. A green film of moss had gathered over the letters—"Shridhar Jha, Retired Headmaster."

She took the plate down and placed it in a corner of the veranda.

At dinner that night, the nameplate came up in conversation.

Naveen said, "This time we'll get a good one made. Black stone, gold lettering. Babuji's name, and mine underneath. We'll have our designations written too."

Mixing ghee into his rice, Shridhar Jha said, "Leave out my 'retired'. It makes the whole thing too long."

Naveen laughed. "No, Babuji, let it stay. People know you by that."

Setting down a glass of water, Archana asked, "And my name?"

Naveen looked at her and smiled. "You're with me, aren't you?"

Archana laughed, but Shailaja Devi's hand paused for a moment.

She said, "And mine?"

A brief silence settled over the table.

In an easy tone, Shridhar Jha said, "Why would your name be needed? A nameplate is for identification."

"Whose identification?"

"The house's."

Shailaja Devi said nothing more.

Early the next morning, Gopal, the man who made nameplates, arrived. With a thin measuring tape he measured the width of the gatepost.

"Fourteen inches will look good here," he said. "Two lines will be clearly visible. If we make it three, the letters will have to be smaller."

Naveen immediately wrote on a sheet of paper—

“Shridhar Jha — Retired Headmaster.”

“Naveen Jha — Assistant Engineer.”

Looking at the paper, Gopal said, “This won’t fit in two lines. If the names and designations are separate, it will take four lines.”

Shailaja Devi was sweeping just inside the gate.

Gopal asked, “Are these the only two names of the owners?”

Shailaja Devi stopped sweeping.

Naveen said, “Yes, write only these.”

Shailaja Devi asked quietly, “How many people live in the house?”

Naveen looked at her. “Ma, are we going to put everyone’s name on the plate?”

Gopal was about to laugh, but seeing Shailaja Devi’s face, he fell silent.

She began sweeping again.

At noon the overhead water tank did not fill. The motor ran, but the water did not rise upstairs.

From the veranda Shridhar Jha called, “Shailaja, is the lower tap open or not?”

Shailaja Devi came out of the kitchen and brought the key to the meter room.

Naveen was checking the motor wiring. “Ma, what did the mechanic say last time?”

“Air gets trapped in the lower pipe. Open this small tap first, then run the motor.”

Within five minutes the water began rising upstairs.

Gopal had returned just then to show a sample. He watched everything.

Then the milkman arrived.

“Madam, are two days missing from last month’s account?”

Shailaja Devi brought the ledger from inside and showed him the dates.

Then the boy from the pharmacy arrived.

“One strip is missing from the medicine ordered for Shridhar Babu.”

Shailaja Devi opened a file and took out the old prescription.

Then Archana said, “Ma, the gas man said our number will come tomorrow. Where’s the old receipt?”

“Blue file, second compartment.”

By evening Gopal had heard the word “owner” three times, yet every practical question in the house had made its way to Shailaja Devi.

As he was leaving, he unfolded the paper again.

"Mataji, what name should I write for you?"

Naveen said at once, "Oh, nothing has been decided yet."

Shailaja Devi took the paper from Gopal's hand.

She wrote nothing. She only looked once more at the width of the gatepost.

Rain began again at night. The old nameplate lay in the corner of the veranda, gleaming faintly.

Shailaja Devi went to pick it up. On the back were two old holes filled with rust.

She remembered—this had not been the first nameplate.

The house's old things were stored in the upstairs room. She lit a lantern and climbed the stairs.

In an old tin trunk, the earlier nameplates from the gate had been kept.

The first wooden plate read—"Raghunath Jha, Village Worker."

The second—"Vinodanand Jha, Teacher."

The third—"Shridhar Jha, Headmaster."

And the fourth, now lying downstairs—"Shridhar Jha, Retired Headmaster."

All four plates belonged to different times; every name on them was a man's.

Shailaja Devi ran a finger over the back of the first wooden plate. In charcoal someone had written—"Left screw short."

The handwriting was her mother-in-law's.

On the back of the second plate, in chalk, was written—"Paint after the rains."

Shailaja Devi recognised that handwriting as her own.

On the back of the third plate was a date—the day the gate had been painted. That date too was in her hand.

Men's names on the front; women's memories of repair on the back.

For a long while Shailaja Devi did not look at the plates. She simply put them back into the tin trunk, one by one.

After breakfast the next day, Naveen brought home a sample of black stone.

"Look, Ma. Isn't it good?"

Shailaja Devi took the sample in her hand.

"How large will the letters be?"

"Babuji's name, an inch and a half. Mine, an inch and a quarter. The designations smaller."

“Why?”

Naveen laughed. “Babuji is senior.”

“Will seniority in the house be shown by the height of the letters?”

Shridhar Jha folded his newspaper. “What is it you want? Say it plainly.”

Shailaja Devi placed the sample on the table.

“I’m asking—is this plate an introduction to the household, or to our posts?”

“Both.”

“Then where is the introduction to the people who run the household?”

Naveen said, “Ma, you’re back to the same thing.”

“Not the same thing. Yesterday—the tank, the milk, the medicine, the gas—everything inside the house was running through my name. Outside, on the gatepost, there wasn’t a single letter of my name. I had never thought about it before. Now I have.”

Shridhar Jha remained silent.

Archana stood listening at the kitchen doorway.

Looking at her, Shailaja Devi said, “Your name isn’t there either.”

Archana said softly, “I’m still new to this house.”

“Does a name require seniority too?”

Archana did not answer.

At noon Gopal returned.

This time he had brought four different samples.

The first had only Shridhar Jha.

The second had Shridhar Jha and Naveen Jha.

The third had four names—Shridhar, Shailaja, Naveen, Archana—but Shridhar’s name was the largest.

The fourth sheet was blank.

Gopal said, “Whatever you say, I’ll make that.”

Naveen picked up the third sample. “This is fine. Ma’s name has been included now.”

Shailaja Devi looked at the sample.

“My name has been included, but the question hasn’t gone away.”

“What now?” There was weariness in Naveen’s voice.

“Why aren’t the letters the same size?”

“Babuji is the head of the family.”

For a moment Shailaja Devi looked at Shridhar Jha.

Shridhar Jha himself bent over the paper.

“Will you write ‘head of the family?’” he asked Naveen.

“No.”

“Then why should the letters be larger?”

Naveen said nothing.

No great quarrel broke out in the house over this small question.

Only the evening tea went cold for a little while.

Gopal left the fourth, blank sheet behind and went away.

That night Archana came to Shailaja Devi’s room.

“Ma, do you want your own name put on it?”

Folding clothes, Shailaja Devi said, “Yes. But the matter won’t be complete merely by adding my name.”

“Then?”

“I don’t like it that a man’s position is written outside the house, while the work a woman does inside has no name at all. The work can’t be written on the plate. So at least the names of the people should stand equally.”

Archana sat down on the edge of the bed.

“If my name is written there, my people from my parents’ home will see it.”

Shailaja Devi smiled. “Is that why your name matters?”

Archana laughed too. “No. But it will feel good.”

The next morning Shridhar Jha himself brought all four old nameplates downstairs.

For a long time he looked at the first wooden plate.

“This is from Babuji’s time,” he said.

“Yes,” Shailaja Devi replied.

“This writing on the back—is it Ma’s?”

“Yes.”

With his finger Shridhar Jha traced the words ‘Left screw short.’

“I had never noticed this writing on the back.”

“A nameplate is viewed from the front,” Shailaja Devi said.

After saying it, she herself fell silent. She felt the remark had come out sharper than she meant.

But Shridhar Jha did not take offence.

He simply laid all four plates in a row.

At noon everyone gathered again on the veranda.

On the blank sheet, Naveen wrote four names.

Shridhar Jha. Shailaja Devi. Naveen Jha. Archana Jha.

Then, of his own accord, he struck out ‘Retired Headmaster’.

Shridhar Jha said, "And your engineer?"

Naveen paused with his pen.

"Shall I strike that out too?"

"As you wish."

Naveen struck out 'Assistant Engineer'.

Archana laughed. "Now the plate will become very small."

Shailaja Devi said, "Let it be small, as long as the letters can be seen."

When Gopal came that evening, he took the measurements away. All four names fitted into two lines in letters of the same size.

He asked, "Who goes on the first line?"

Shridhar Jha said, "The two of us old people."

Shailaja Devi glared at him. "You are the old one."

Laughter rose on the veranda.

In the end they decided on Shridhar Jha · Shailaja Devi on the first line, and Naveen Jha · Archana Jha on the second.

The plate arrived three days later.

It was not black stone but ordinary grey metal. Gopal said the black stone would be too heavy, and the old holes in the gatepost were weak.

Naveen was a little disappointed at first, then brought out his tools to tighten the screws himself.

Shailaja Devi stood just inside the gate.

Gopal held the plate straight. Naveen tightened the screws. Shridhar Jha stepped back two paces to look.

Archana said, "Half an inch higher on the right."

"You all wanted the names equal, and now the spacing has to be equal too?" Naveen laughed.

Archana said, "Yes."

The plate was straight.

There was no applause. No ritual was performed.

By noon the house had returned to its old rhythm.

Shailaja Devi checked the milk account. Archana put away the gas receipt. Shridhar Jha looked through his pension papers. Naveen replaced the broken switch on the motor.

In the evening, it rained.

Drops of water gathered on the nameplate. Shailaja Devi went outside and began wiping it with an old cotton cloth.

At first, almost by habit, her hand moved towards Shridhar Jha's name.

Then she stopped.

She moved the cloth from one end to the other—Shridhar, Shailaja, Naveen, Archana—all four names wiped clean in the same sweep.

The screws Gopal had fitted were tight. This time the plate did not rattle even when the wind blew.

The Third Step

Kedar Mishra's house in an old neighbourhood of Jhanjharpur stood a little below the road and a little above the courtyard. Two black-stone steps led from the courtyard up to the veranda on the eastern side.

The first step was broad, the second a little narrower.

In the thirty-seven years since the house had been built, those two steps had been worn down countless times, splashed with lime countless times, and endured countless monsoon rains - but two had never become three.

Kedar Mishra could say this with such certainty that even with his eyes closed he knew he had to bend his knees twice to reach the veranda.

His wife Girija Devi's knees were no longer what they had once been.

In the mornings she placed the tip of her walking stick on the first step, then on the second, and only then climbed onto the veranda.

"One day these two steps will be the death of me," she often said.

The family would laugh.

Her son Alok would say, "Ma, let the winter pass. I'll have a ramp built."

They had been talking about the ramp for three winters.

The third winter passed, then Phagun, then Chait.

It happened one night in Jeth.

Alok's wife Nivedita was returning from a neighbour's house carrying a pot of hot milk. Their cow had calved, and that day they had distributed the first milk.

The electricity had gone out in the courtyard.

A small oil lamp burned inside the veranda, but its light did not properly reach the steps.

Nivedita climbed the first step.

She climbed the second.

Then her right foot rose again of its own accord.

Certain that her foot would meet only empty air, she drew her body back to steady the pot.

But her sole came down on something solid.

Perfectly level.

Cold like black stone.

She rose a third time and found herself on the veranda.

The milk trembled to the rim of the pot but did not spill.

She took two steps forward, then looked back.

In the darkness the shape of the steps was not clear.

She set the pot in the kitchen and came back carrying the lamp.

There were only two steps below.

Nivedita kept looking at them for a long time.

Then she told herself she must have stumbled in the space between the two steps.

In the morning she told no one.

At noon, when the courtyard was being washed, she deliberately counted the steps.

One.

Two.

Veranda.

She laughed.

Who could trust the body at night?

Two nights later Alok returned late.

He shut the gate and crossed the courtyard with his shoes in his hand, because Girija Devi had gone to sleep and she disliked the clack-clack of shoes.

As his foot touched the steps, he counted softly - one, two -

Then his knee bent a third time.

He reached the veranda and stopped.

The shoes fell from his hand.

From inside Nivedita asked, "What happened?"

Alok replied, "Has something changed in these steps?"

Nivedita came to the doorway.

"What?"

"I climbed three times."

Nivedita was silent for a few moments.

"So did I."

At first Alok laughed, then he saw that Nivedita was not laughing.

They both took the lamp and went down.

One.

Two.

Courtyard.

Then they climbed again.

One.

Two.

Veranda.

"A trick of the dark," Alok said.

Nivedita asked, "The same trick for both of us?"

"It's the same staircase."

The matter was left there.

Nothing happened for the next seven days.

On the eighth night, at ten o'clock, Mili wanted a drink of water. Mili was Alok and Nivedita's twelve-year-old daughter.

She went down from the veranda to the tap in the courtyard.

Then she came back inside and said, "Baba, have the steps grown?"

Alok had a book in his hand. He looked up.

"How many are there now?"

"Three."

Nivedita came out of the kitchen.

"Did you see them?"

"No. I felt them with my feet."

Mili started to go outside again.

Alok stopped her. "Not now."

"Why?"

"That's enough."

Mili pulled a face, but did not go.

At dawn everyone gathered by the steps.

Girija Devi stood there leaning on her walking stick.

Kedar Mishra ran a hand over the stone.

"There are only two," he said.

Mili immediately said, "In the daytime."

Kedar Mishra laughed.

"Are stones born at night?"

Mili replied, "Does it have to be stone?"

At that question Kedar Mishra's laughter stopped midway.

That day Alok wrote '1' in lime on the edge of the first step and '2' on the edge of the second.

Nivedita asked, "What's that for?"

"So we can count them at night."

Girija Devi said, "Don't catch this disease of counting. Have the ramp built."

Alok said, "Let me understand it first."

There was electricity that night. The courtyard light was on.

Alok went up and down four times.

Two steps.

Nivedita went three times.

Two steps.

Mili went once.

Two steps.

"See?" Alok said.

Mili said, "It's not here today."

As though she were speaking of some lizard that had gone into hiding.

Three days later it happened again.

This time with Kedar Mishra present.

His cough medicine had run out that night. When Alok returned from the shop with the medicine, Kedar Mishra had come as far as the veranda.

Alok was climbing up from the courtyard.

In the light of the lamp Kedar Mishra could see clearly - the first step, the second step, the veranda.

Alok stepped onto the first.

Then onto the second.

Then his body rose a third time.

Before Kedar Mishra's eyes, his head reached exactly the height it should have reached in two rises.

But the motion had happened three times.

Alok came onto the veranda and said, "It happened this time."

Kedar Mishra said nothing.

He lowered the lamp and looked at the stone.

Only two.

"Did you see it?" Alok asked.

"I saw your body," Kedar Mishra said. "Not the step."

The next day a measuring tape was brought.

The total height from the courtyard to the veranda came to thirteen inches.

The first rise was six and a half.

The second, six and a half.

There was not even an inch left for a third.

Alok wrote the measurement on a sheet of paper.

Mili said, "Measure it at night."

They measured it at night.

Thirteen inches.

That night no one found a third step.

Alok grew irritated.

"Whenever we measure it, it disappears."

Nivedita said, "You can call it disappearing only if someone has seen it before."

Kedar Mishra said quietly, "No one has seen it."

Girija Devi grew impatient with the whole affair.

"Even two steps are hard enough for me, and all of you are searching for a third."

Then Alok actually called a mason to have the ramp built.

The mason's name was Jabbar.

He looked at the stones, measured them with a tape, looked at Girija Devi's walking stick, and said, "I'll remove both stones and make a ramp. I'll put iron handrails on both sides as well. Three days."

Mili asked, "Will you work at night?"

Jabbar laughed. "Do I build houses for ghosts at night?"

Mili remained serious.

Alok glared at her.

On the night before the work was to begin, Nivedita deliberately went into the courtyard barefoot.

The stones had been hot all day, but by night they had cooled.

She placed her foot on the first step.

Then on the second.

Then on the third.

This time she stopped.

For a few moments both her feet rested on a level, cold surface that was not there before her eyes.

She bent and reached out a hand.

Her hand touched the edge of the veranda directly.

What was beneath her feet was not beneath her hand.

She climbed up at once.

She called out to no one.

At dawn Jabbar prised up the first stone.

Beneath it lay old bricks, sand, and a layer of lime mortar.

He lifted the second stone.

The same lay beneath that one too.

Mili sat nearby the entire time.

"Anything third?" she asked.

Jabbar said, "Third what?"

"Nothing."

For three days the place where the steps had been smelled of earth, brick, and mortar.

The ramp was completed.

A gentle slope, with iron handrails on both sides.

For the first time Girija Devi climbed slowly up it, leaning on her walking stick.

She was pleased.

"No more counting now?" she asked Alok.

Alok said, "No more."

The lime-painted '1' and '2' disappeared along with the two stones.

Jabbar placed the old stones in a corner of the courtyard.

Mili wanted to write 1 and 2 on them again, but Nivedita stopped her.

"Leave it now."

For a few days the house truly remained quiet.

Everyone grew accustomed to the ramp.

Girija Devi even began going down into the courtyard in the evenings.

The tip of her walking stick slid and tapped along the ramp.

One night the first heavy rain of Sawan arrived.

There was water in the courtyard. Lightning flashed again and again.

Mili stood on the veranda watching water pour from the roof drain.

Nivedita went to call her inside.

Just then Kedar Mishra's old friend Janardan Babu arrived at the gate.

Alok took an umbrella and crossed the courtyard to bring him in.

Janardan Babu saw the ramp.

"Ah, you've had it made nicely. Convenient for old people."

From inside Kedar Mishra said, "Everyone finds it convenient to call me old."

They all laughed.

Janardan Babu went toward the tap to wash his slippers.

Then, while climbing the ramp, he suddenly stopped.

"Why have you left a little rise in the middle here?"

The umbrella in Alok's hand went still.

"Where?"

Janardan Babu felt the middle of the ramp with his foot.

"Here. Now it's gone."

He moved his foot over the place again.

"Strange. It felt as though there was a step."

Kedar Mishra and Girija Devi looked at each other.

Mili quietly went inside from the veranda.

After dinner that night, Alok went to the ramp again.

Nivedita said, "Don't start again."

"Just once."

"If you keep saying 'just once', the whole house will be counting again."

Alok stopped.

Then he came back inside.

This time no one measured anything.

No one wrote numbers in lime.

No one called Jabbar.

But the matter did not end either.

Some nights no one felt anything at all.

On some nights Girija Devi's stick made three distinct taps on the ramp, though she crossed the gentle slope in one continuous climb.

Sometimes Mili's foot would rise once in the middle and come down again on the same level surface.

Sometimes Alok's body would give a small, unexplained jerk.

One day Kedar Mishra said, "If the step was never in the stone, then what exactly did we remove?"

Nivedita did not answer.

She remembered the night when the edge of the veranda had been beneath her hand while a third cold surface had been beneath her feet.

Gradually the family learned to live with it.

At night, when climbing from the courtyard to the veranda, no one counted anymore.

Not even Mili.

One day at school she was given an assignment to draw a picture on the theme 'My Home'.

She drew the gate, the tulsi plant, the tap, the veranda, and the ramp.

Nivedita looked at the picture.

Mili had drawn three short horizontal lines across the ramp.

"What's this?" Nivedita asked.

Mili looked at the drawing.

"I don't know."

"Why are there lines on the ramp?"

Mili raised her hand to erase them, then stopped.

"Let them stay."

One evening in Kartik, Girija Devi's knees were hurting badly. She had not gone down into the courtyard.

After everyone had gone to sleep, she remembered the lamp by the tulsi plant.

Nivedita had already extinguished it, but Girija Devi was not convinced.

Taking her walking stick, she came to the doorway.

The courtyard was clear in the moonlight.

There was no water on the ramp.

She slowly went down, checked the lamp, and turned back.

Holding the handrail, she began to climb.

The tip of the stick sounded - tap.

She took one step forward.

Again - tap.

She reached the middle of the ramp.

Again - tap.

Girija Devi stopped.

She looked down.

A smooth ramp.

The veranda was only one step away above her.

She lifted the stick, held it in the air for a moment, then placed it on the veranda.

This time there was no sound.

In the morning no one asked her about the night.

Girija Devi said nothing either.

Morning sunlight fell on the ramp Jabbar had built.

There was not a single step on it.

But on the tip of Girija Devi's walking stick, resting in a corner of the veranda, were three very small rings of dried mud.

The Upside-Down Calendar

The date for leaving the old house in Laheriasarai had been fixed long ago.

On the morning of 7 October, the keys were to be handed over to Shambhunath Chaudhary.

Nilmani Jha had put a copy of the sale deed in a red file, the gate of the new house had already been locked, and even the movers had been told the date.

So there ought to have been nothing uncertain left in the house now.

But when one is leaving a house, it is the things thought settled that create the greatest obstacles.

Where the tulsi from the courtyard would go, whether Father's old chair should be taken or left behind, which brass plate was useful and which was only a memory—no sale deed could be drawn up for such matters.

A thick calendar hung on the north wall of the sitting room.

In blue letters at the bottom it said, "Harihar Cloth Store, Gudri Bazaar."

At the top were the date, day, lunar date, sunrise and moonrise; below were two lines of advertising.

Nilmani Jha had an old habit of tearing off the calendar page each day.

In the morning, before drinking tea, he would pull off yesterday's page and put it in the basket.

When the children were small, they used to write multiplication tables on the backs of those torn-off pages.

Padma Devi would sometimes write the market list on them.

Rachna had once written short formulas on them while making her college notes.

Saurabh had even used them to make kite tails.

The calendar did not merely tell the date in that house; its pages performed all sorts of small household tasks as well.

After the decision to sell the house, Nilmani Jha found the page for 7 October and circled it in red ink.

“We hand over the house on this day,” he said.

Saurabh had joked, “And from 8 October onward, we’ll be guests in this house?”

Nilmani Jha laughed.

Padma Devi did not.

She only kept looking at the calendar.

From 25 September onward, Saurabh began counting each day how many pages remained before the one with the red circle.

Twelve.

Eleven.

Ten.

“The days are shrinking,” he would say.

Padma Devi would reply, “The belongings aren’t.”

By 27 September, the books from the first room had been packed.

On the twenty-eighth, half the kitchen utensils were sent to the new house.

On the twenty-ninth, the iron trunk on the veranda was emptied.

By the evening of 30 September, the house looked unusually open.

On the walls, where photographs had hung, square white patches remained.

When the cupboard was moved, the paint behind it looked different from the rest of the wall.

For the first time, the old cobweb in the corner under the eaves could be seen in full.

“Now the house really is becoming empty,” Rachna said.

Padma Devi answered at once, “The spices, the tulsi, the grinding stone, Father’s chair, three flowerpots, the puja box, and the files upstairs are still left.”

Saurabh counted the calendar pages.

“Seven days.”

“Seven days is a long time,” Nilmani Jha said.

That night everyone went to bed early.

On the morning of 1 October, Nilmani Jha walked up to the calendar with his tea.

He raised his hand to tear off yesterday’s page, but stopped midway.

At the top, in large red numerals, was written—31.

Below it—September.

He removed his glasses and wiped them.

Then put them on again.

The date did not change.

“Padma!”

A voice came from the kitchen. “What happened?”

“Did September have thirty-one days this year?”

Padma Devi came out.

First she looked at Nilmani Jha, then at the calendar.

“It must be a printing error.”

Hearing the voices, Saurabh came over.

“Wonderful! An extra day.”

Nilmani Jha tried to lift the page to see what lay underneath, but the calendar was bound at the top.

He raised the 31 September page halfway.

Beneath it was 32 September.

Saurabh stopped laughing.

“There’s a thirty-second here too.”

Rachna checked her phone.

The phone said 1 October.

The newspaper said 1 October.

Even the milk packet was stamped 1 October.

Only the calendar on the wall was unwilling to leave September behind.

Nilmani Jha gripped the lower corner of the calendar and began counting the pages.

The page for 7 October with the red circle was still inside.

But yesterday it had been seven pages away; today it was eight.

Saurabh counted again.

“Eight.”

Rachna counted a third time.

“Eight.”

“An extra sheet of paper will not postpone the date on which we hand over the house,” Padma Devi said.

Nilmani Jha said slowly, “But yesterday there were seven pages.”

That day two dates ran through the house.

Outside, it was 1 October.

On the wall, it was 31 September.

For the first part of the day, everyone treated it as a joke.

Saurabh stuck a label on the spice tin: “Use by 31 September.”

Rachna wrote on her box of books: “Outside date: 1 October.”

Padma Devi paid no attention to any of this.

She went on sorting the old spices.

That night Nilmani Jha tore off the page for 31 September.

“Tomorrow we’ll see what comes next.”

In the morning, 32 September faced them.

“We saw this yesterday,” Rachna said.

“We saw it yesterday, but yesterday it was paper. Today it has become a date,” Saurabh said.

Nilmani Jha stared at him after that sentence.

Outside, it was 2 October.

On the household calendar, 32 September.

The page for 7 October with the red circle was now nine pages away.

“Instead of decreasing, the days are increasing,” Rachna said for the first time without laughing.

Nilmani Jha reached up to take down the calendar, then stopped himself.

“Let’s first see how far this goes.”

“Are you going to watch the calendar or pack the belongings?” Padma Devi asked.

That day the files upstairs were opened.

Nilmani Jha separated old electricity bills, land records, Saurabh’s school certificate, Rachna’s first appointment letter—everything into separate piles.

Some papers were meant to be thrown away, but he began reading them all.

“Keep this?” Rachna asked.

“We’ll see tomorrow,” Nilmani Jha said.

Rachna looked at the calendar.

She said nothing.

That same evening Padma Devi brought up the matter of changing the soil in the tulsi pot.

“Not today,” she said herself. “Tomorrow.”

Saurabh burst out laughing at once.

“If we go by this calendar, 7 October will never come any nearer.”

Padma Devi scolded him.

“Don’t talk nonsense.”

On the third morning, it was 33 September.

Outside, it was 3 October.

This time no one laughed.

Saurabh silently counted as far as the page with the red circle.

Ten pages.

Rachna went to the basket to look for the pages torn off over the last two days.

She found 31 September.

And 32 September as well.

Both were real sheets of paper.

The same colour, the same lettering, the same advertisement.

On the back of the thirty-first, Padma Devi had written a market list—cumin, soap, thread.

On the back of the thirty-second, Saurabh had written, “Outside: 2 October.”

“This page wasn’t created yesterday,” Rachna said. “It remained even after it was torn off.”

Nilmani Jha tried to open the metal strip at the top of the calendar.

The strip was stuck with old rust.

Saurabh brought tools to loosen the screws.

Together, the four of them opened the calendar’s binding.

The pages spread out across the table.

September was normal up to the thirtieth.

After that came thirty-one, thirty-two, thirty-three, thirty-four, thirty-five, thirty-six, thirty-seven...

Then came 1 October.

Then 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7 October.

Nilmani Jha’s red circle remained intact on the page for 7 October.

“These extra pages weren’t here yesterday,” he said.

“Are you sure?” Saurabh asked.

Nilmani Jha paused before answering.

“I had counted them.”

“So had I,” Rachna said.

Padma Devi kept looking at the pages spread across the table.

“How many extra ones are there?”

Saurabh counted.

“Eight. But whether there were six or seven yesterday, I can’t say now.”

Nilmani Jha arranged the pages back in order.

“Shall we remove all the extra pages?”

“Why?” Padma Devi asked in an ordinary voice.

“Because they’re wrong.”

“If you remove the wrong pages, will the date become right?”

Nilmani Jha fell silent.

In the end, the extra pages were not removed.

The calendar was hung back on the wall.

From then on, the way everyone looked at it changed.

In the morning, they no longer looked first at the date but at the thickness of the stack.

Saurabh would press it with his fingers and estimate.

Rachna would count the distance to the red-circled page.

Nilmani Jha would write the outside date separately on a piece of paper.

Padma Devi simply went on working.

Outside, it was 4 October; inside the house, 34 September.

That day Shambhunath Chaudhary phoned.

“I’ll come at ten in the morning on the seventh.”

“Yes, that’s settled,” Nilmani Jha said.

After hanging up, he looked at the calendar.

34 September.

The red circle lay eleven pages inside.

For the first time he gave an uneasy laugh.

“By this calculation, 7 October is very far away now.”

“By Chaudharyji’s calculation, three days,” Padma Devi said.

That night Rachna decided to make another test.

She took the calendar down from the wall.

With a red pencil, she drew a straight line down the right edge of the bound pages, from top to bottom.

The line cut across the edges of all the pages at once.

“If a new page appears in between, there’ll be a white break in the red line,” she said.

Saurabh wrote the first letter of his name, very small, on the metal strip at the top of the calendar.

“This time we won’t open the binding,” Nilmani Jha said.

“Are we testing the date or the paper?” Padma Devi said, and nothing more.

No one answered.

The calendar was hung back on the wall.

That night the files upstairs were sorted.

The tulsi pot was sent to the new house.

A decision was made about Father’s chair—it would go with them.

The three old flowerpots were given to a neighbour.

Half the tins of spices were distributed.

The puja box was packed.

By eleven at night, the house was almost empty.

Padma Devi pointed toward the upper shelf in Saurabh's room.

Two bamboo sticks from a kite and a reel of red kite string had been left there.

Saurabh immediately took them down and put them in a box.

Nilmani Jha walked through the house and looked around.

A few files, two pairs of clothes, the utensils they used every day, the bedding—that was all.

Everyone went to sleep.

In the morning, it was 35 September.

Rachna looked first not at the date but at the right edge of the pages.

The red line drawn the day before ran from top to bottom, but in the middle there was one very thin white gap.

Saurabh used his fingernail to separate the page at that gap.

There was not a trace of red on the edge of the page for 35 September.

It was as though that page had been slipped into the stack after the red line was drawn.

Saurabh's tiny initial on the metal strip at the top was unchanged.

There was no sign that the binding had been opened.

Nilmani Jha stood holding the calendar for a long time.

At last he hung it back on the nail.

"Now what?" Saurabh asked.

"Now we won't forget the outside date," Nilmani Jha said.

Outside, it was 5 October.

Inside the house, 35 September.

When Rachna went to college, she wrote 5 October in the attendance register.

When Nilmani Jha went to the bank, he signed a slip dated 5 October.

When Saurabh met a friend, he said it was 5 October.

But the moment they stepped through the gate, everyone's language changed.

"It rained on the evening of 35 September," Saurabh would say.

"On the thirty-fifth, the tulsi went to the new house," Padma Devi would say.

One day Rachna was startled by this.

They were no longer treating the impossible dates as a joke; they were turning them into memories.

“Why are we accepting this?” she asked.

“How are we accepting it? The outside date is separate,” Nilmani Jha said.

“But when we talk about the house, we say thirty-five.”

No one answered.

The evening of 6 October was their last night.

By the outside reckoning.

On the household calendar, it was 36 September.

Nearly everything had been packed.

Only the calendar still hung on the wall.

“Shall we take this down too?” Rachna asked.

“We’ll take it down last. In the morning I want to compare it with the outside date,” Nilmani Jha said.

The four of them looked at one another.

“So the last thing left in the house will be this calendar,” Padma Devi said softly.

That night the house sounded very empty.

Whenever someone spoke, the voice came back from the rooms.

In the kitchen there was only one pot, four glasses and some tea leaves.

On the veranda, Father’s chair stood tied with rope, ready to go.

The old tulsi platform in the middle of the courtyard was empty.

Padma Devi poured a little water over it, though the plant had already gone to the new house.

“Why are you watering empty soil?” Saurabh asked.

“There was dust blowing,” she said.

Rachna knew there had been no dust blowing.

At midnight, the phone changed to 7 October.

Rachna got up and went into the sitting room.

On the calendar, 36 September remained exactly as before.

She did not tear off the page.

She only touched it.

The paper was ordinary.

Its back was blank.

In the morning, Nilmani Jha was the first to wake.

On the wall, it was 37 September.

Outside, 7 October.

Without saying anything, Saurabh counted to the page for 7 October with the red circle.

Thirteen pages.

"Today is the day we hand over the house," Nilmani Jha said.

"By whose reckoning?" Saurabh asked.

This time no one laughed.

The movers arrived before ten.

The bedding, trunks, chair and utensils were loaded onto the vehicle.

At last, only the four of them, a broom, a bunch of keys and the calendar remained in the house.

Shambhunath Chaudhary arrived at exactly ten.

He walked through the house and looked around.

"Everything empty?"

"Yes," Nilmani Jha said.

Padma Devi looked toward the wall of the sitting room.

"One thing is still here."

Everyone's eyes went to the calendar.

Chaudharyji read the date.

"37 September?"

He laughed.

"What printing press produced this marvel?"

Nilmani Jha tried to laugh as well.

"Think of it as a printing error."

"Throw it away."

It was a very ordinary sentence.

But the four of them remained silent for a few moments.

Rachna went over to the wall.

She took the calendar down from the iron nail.

Behind it, the paint on the wall was darker—where dust and sunlight had not reached for years.

Below the nail were also two old pencil marks from childhood—Saurabh's height had once been measured there.

Rachna tried to fold the calendar, but the thick stack of pages would not bend.

She put it into a cloth bag just as it was.

Nilmani Jha placed the keys in Chaudharyji's hand.

As she stepped out through the gate, Padma Devi turned back once to look at the courtyard.

The empty tulsi platform, the sunlight on the veranda, the open window.

Then she came out.

At the new house everyone immediately became busy.

Where the trunks should go, where the cot should stand, which shelf should hold the kitchen utensils, against which wall the books should be placed.

The bag containing the calendar lay in a corner of the sitting room.

No one opened it that night.

On the morning of 8 October, Padma Devi made tea.

Out of habit, Nilmani Jha looked toward the wall.

There was no calendar there.

“Where is the calendar?”

Rachna brought the bag.

Once again the four of them gathered in one place.

Rachna took out the calendar.

The moment he saw the top page, Saurabh said, “But this is...”

At the top was 8 October.

An ordinary 8 October.

Below it, 9 October.

Then 10.

Rachna began turning the pages quickly.

From 1 October through 7 October, everything was in normal order.

Nilmani Jha’s red circle was still there on 7 October.

No 31 September.

No 32.

No pages at all through 37.

“We had torn those pages off,” Saurabh said.

Rachna searched the small bag of papers meant to be thrown away, which had accidentally come with them from the old house.

Inside were electricity bills, cancelled receipts, scraps of newspaper.

At the bottom she found two small calendar pages.

31 September.

32 September.

Only those two.

No 33, 34, 35, 36 or 37.

“The rest?” Saurabh asked.

No one knew.

Nilmani Jha picked up the page for the thirty-first.

On the back was Padma Devi's list—cumin, soap, thread.

On the back of the thirty-second was Saurabh's writing: "Outside: 2 October."

It was evidence enough, but evidence of what was not clear.

Padma Devi placed both pages on the table.

"Throw them away?" Nilmani Jha asked.

"Why?" Padma Devi said.

In the same tone in which she had once asked why they should remove the extra pages.

The two pages were not thrown away.

Rachna tucked them behind the calendar in the new house.

The days began to pass.

In the new house came 9 October, then 10, then 11.

The calendar was normal.

The stack of pages kept shrinking.

The belongings found their places one by one.

Padma Devi's spices were arranged on a shelf.

Nilmani Jha's files went into the new cupboard.

Saurabh's kite went onto the upper shelf.

The tulsi took root in the new courtyard.

A few weeks later, one day Rachna was looking at photographs of the old house.

One photograph had been taken on 30 September.

The calendar on the wall was clearly visible.

Rachna enlarged the photograph.

At the top was 30 September.

The edge of the page beneath it projected slightly beyond it.

Only half of a red numeral could be seen.

It could have been a 1.

It could also have been a 3.

Rachna closed the photograph.

That evening Nilmani Jha sat in the sitting room of the new house and tore off the calendar page.

The date was normal.

He put the page in the basket.

Rachna looked at the calendar.

The two impossible pages tucked behind it could not be seen from the front.

After everyone had gone to sleep that night, the wind began to blow.

The lower corner of the calendar trembled lightly.

The page for 31 September tucked behind it slid halfway out.

There was no new date on its blank front.

Only the reverse impression of Padma Devi's old list showed faintly through the paper.

In the morning, Nilmani Jha tore off that day's page.

One day was gone.

The two impossible pages tucked behind it remained exactly as they were.

The Air in the Locked Room

It was the last week of Kartik.

In Darbhanga's Balbhadrapur neighbourhood, the days had begun to shorten, but winter had not yet fully arrived.

There was still a little warmth in the midday sun, though by evening one felt like drawing a gamchha over one's shoulders.

The inner room of Shivkant Jha's house seemed to have nothing to do with this season.

That room had been locked for three months.

After the roof had leaked, the plaster on the inner wall had flaked away, so Bhola the mason had said it should be allowed to dry completely.

Two trunks of old books, a bamboo stool, a broken brass lamp, and a few utensils left over from a wedding were kept in the room.

There was no window.

There was a small ventilator opening to the outside, but it had already been bricked up before the rains.

The door was made of thick wood.

During the day no one paid it any attention.

Meera noticed the first thing.

Meera was Shivkant's seventeen-year-old daughter.

Early one morning, while she was sweeping the courtyard, the dust lying beneath the locked door suddenly slid towards her.

She stopped short.

A scent came with the dust as well.

Like fresh mango blossom.

Meera bent down and placed her palm beneath the door.

The air was mild.

Neither cold nor warm.

It held the soft dryness of Phagun.

It was Kartik in the courtyard.

Phagun was blowing from beneath the door.

At first Meera did not trust her own nose.

She called her mother.

Malti Jha was washing rice in the kitchen.

She came out and laughed.

“Someone must have pressed flowers inside one of those old books.”

Meera placed her palm beneath the door again.

The air was still there.

Malti bent down too.

The smile slowly left her face.

“It is coming from inside.”

Shivkant was called.

Since retiring from his government office, he spent much of his time at home going through old ledgers and papers.

He examined the doorframe, the latch, the gap below the door, and all the walls.

“The ventilator at the back must not have been sealed properly.”

“But the neighbour’s wall is right against the back,” Malti said.

“Air can find its way through a crack.”

Shivkant’s explanation sounded reasonable.

By noon, the mystery of the morning had become a household repair problem.

But the next day the problem changed again.

In the morning Meera deliberately went to the door.

This time a hot gust came out from underneath it.

It was so hot that she pulled her hand away at once.

The smell carried dust, dry grass, and the acridness of bricks baked in the sun.

“Jeth,” Meera said softly.

Malti stood in the courtyard wrapped in a shawl.

There was dew on the neem tree outside.

The hot wind of Jeth was blowing beneath the locked door.

This time Shivkant did not laugh.

He cut three thin strips of paper and hung them by thread beneath the door.

All three strips kept trembling outward.

He proposed opening the door.

Malti stopped him.

“The plaster has fallen. Dust will rise inside.”

Meera said, “Let us watch the air first.”

They all sat outside.

For half an hour the hot air kept bending the thin strips of paper outward.

Then it stopped all at once.

No sound.

No smell.

The paper strips hung straight down.

On the third morning, the ground beneath the door was wet.

It had not rained.

The courtyard was dry.

Dust crunched beneath Malti's feet.

But beside the gap under the door, a strip two fingers wide was damp.

The air was cold and heavy.

With it came the smell of raw earth, wet leaves, and the distant night-call of frogs.

Malti shivered.

"This is Sawan."

This time Shivkant did not name any season.

He merely accepted that the air inside was different from the air outside.

At noon Bhola the mason was called.

Bhola put his ear to the doorframe.

Nothing.

He placed his palm beneath it.

There was a faintly damp breeze.

"The wall must be hollow inside."

He tapped the wall with the handle of his hammer.

The same sound came from every part of it.

They reached the bricked-up ventilator from outside.

The joints between the bricks were firm.

Bhola plastered clay around the entire doorframe once more.

He stuffed a thick cloth into the gap at the bottom.

"Now let us see."

No air came until night.

On the fourth morning, Meera woke to find the cloth bulging outward.

As though someone inside were gently blowing against it.

She pulled the cloth out.

Cold air touched her fingers.

So cold that pain rose beneath her fingernails.

With it came the smell of smoke, mustard oil, and ash from a fire.

Paus.

This time Meera did not call her mother.

She filled a brass bowl with water and placed it directly in front of the door.

Ten minutes later, a fine mist had gathered over the surface of the water.

When Shivkant woke, he found his daughter sitting beside the bowl.

“Have you been doing this since last night?”

“Not me. The air.”

Shivkant decided to open the door.

Bhola was called again.

Everything nearby was moved away.

Malti held the end of her sari over her mouth.

Meera stood an arm’s length back from the door.

Shivkant lifted the latch.

The swollen wood made the door stick.

Bhola put his shoulder against it.

With one shove, the panel opened.

No cold air came out from inside.

Only the stale smell of a room shut for three months.

Dust.

Lime.

Old paper.

And, in one corner, the dry trace of damp.

Meera went inside.

She stretched out her hand, feeling the air.

The room felt like the courtyard.

No Paus.

No Sawan.

No Jeth.

No Phagun.

“You see?” Shivkant said, but there was no triumph in his voice.

Bhola ran his hand over the bricks sealing the ventilator.

“Nothing can come through here.”

The room was not emptied completely.

They merely swept away the dust, gathered the fallen plaster, and carried the two trunks outside.

The door remained open all day.

No unusual air came that day.

The door remained open the next day as well.

Nothing.

On the third day Malti said, "Close it. A cat will get in."

The door was closed in the evening.

In the morning, the strip of paper below it was covered with fine yellow pollen-dust.

The air was gentle and sweet.

Phagun had returned.

This time Meera was not pleased.

Her faith had been shaken more than anyone else's.

While the room remained open, it was ordinary.

The moment it was closed, the season inside it changed.

Shivkant kept avoiding putting this into words.

He would say, "The temperature in the gap must be different."

He would say, "The wall must be holding the day's heat."

He would say, "Smell is a trick of the nose."

But on the fifth morning, a hot wind blew from beneath the door and softened a small piece of wax left there the night before.

After that he did not call it "a trick of the nose."

Meera began a register.

The first column was for the date.

The second for the air outside the house.

The third for the air from the locked room.

The fourth for the smell.

The fifth for some small piece of evidence.

Kartik 27 — Phagun — mango blossom — paper bent outward.

Kartik 28 — Jeth — sun-baked dust — palm warmed.

Kartik 29 — Sawan — wet earth — threshold damp.

Kartik 30 — Paus — fire ash — mist on bowl.

Phagun did not come again the next day.

This time the air was that of Sharad.

Clear, dry, light.

It brought to mind kans grass in flower, though the kans fields were far from the house.

Meera wrote in the register: "No sequence."

Malti asked, "Why must there be a sequence?"

Meera did not answer.

Slowly, separate rules for this air took shape in the household.

Whoever woke first in the morning placed a palm beneath the door.

If the air was wintry, Malti tightened her shawl before watering the tulsi, even though the courtyard might be warm.

If the air was from Jeth, Shivkant set his chair two arm's lengths away from the door.

If it was rainy-season air, Meera gathered up her notebooks, though not a drop fell from the roof.

The family themselves sometimes laughed at all this behaviour.

"Which weather do we believe in—the one inside the house or the one outside?" Shivkant said one day.

Malti replied, "If there are two, believe in both."

Hearing this, Meera thought of writing something in the register, then did not.

One Sunday Shivkant's younger brother Pramod came to visit.

He lived in Delhi and had laughed heartily when he heard about the room over the phone.

Now he wanted to see for himself.

There was a mild sun outside that day.

Cold, damp monsoon air was coming from the locked room.

Pramod placed his palm against the gap.

The smile on his face was the first thing to change.

Then he immediately said the door should be opened.

The door was opened.

The air vanished.

Pramod went inside.

He inspected the ceiling.

He tapped the walls.

He put his ear to the floor.

Nothing.

"It must be a matter of pressure," he said.

"Whose pressure?" Meera asked.

Pramod laughed. "That is what I would need to be an expert in air and wind to explain."

The door remained open until evening.

At night Pramod insisted on closing it himself.

He pressed a thick flexible strip along the bottom.
He stuffed cotton into the keyhole.
He pasted paper over the joints of the frame.
“Now where will the air come out from?”
In the morning, no air came from underneath.
The paper did not tremble either.
Pramod came into the courtyard wearing a victorious look.
Then Malti said, “Come here and see.”
The old spiderweb hanging near the top of the frame was fluttering outward.
The air was coming from above.
It was not warm.
Nor was it cold.
It smelled of new rice, drying straw, and earth warmed by the sun.
Aghan.
Pramod stared upward for a long time.
Then, without saying anything, he removed the flexible strip.
That evening he returned to Delhi.
As he was leaving, he said to Meera, “Keep writing in the register.”
Meera asked, “Why?”
“The day this stops, we will know it was truly happening.”
Meera did not like that answer.
She thought: why should the ending of something be the proof that it had been real while it lasted?
As December approached, Bhola fixed a date to begin the repairs.
The damp in the ceiling had dried.
The plaster would be redone.
The doorframe would be replaced.
The bricks sealing the ventilator would also be removed and checked again.
What frightened Meera most was the replacement of the doorframe.
She said, “If the door is changed, the air may stop.”
Shivkant said, “The air cannot be inside the door itself.”
Malti remained silent.
Bhola first removed the old door panel.
Then he took out the frame.
There was no longer any boundary between the room and the passage.
The masons worked for three days.

For three days no separate air appeared.

Meera left three lines blank in the register.

On the fourth day the new frame was fitted, but the panel had not yet been hung.

The air was normal.

On the fifth day the new wooden panel was fitted.

It remained open all day.

The air was normal.

In the evening, after the paint had dried, Bhola closed the panel.

The new latch gleamed.

The gap at the bottom was much narrower than before.

Meera got up three times during the night to look.

Nothing.

She fell asleep before dawn.

Malti was the first to wake.

On her way to the kitchen, she stopped beside the new door.

No air was coming from underneath.

She placed her palm there.

Nothing.

She did not call Meera.

She put water on the stove.

The sun rose.

Meera woke and went straight to the door.

She bent down.

Nothing.

“Finished?” she asked her mother.

Before answering, Malti looked upward.

In the middle of the new panel, the grain of the wood had naturally left a hairline seam.

A very faint breath of air was coming through it.

So faint that one could not feel it without putting a cheek close to the wood.

Meera pulled over a chair and brought her face near the seam in the panel.

The air was cool.

It carried the soft scent of silk-cotton fluff, new leaves, and something like the imagined call of a distant cuckoo.

Malti smiled.

“This time?”

Meera said, “Spring.”

Shivkant had come over too.

He looked at the new door.

“Not from below—from the middle?”

Meera nodded.

She brought the register.

After the three blank lines she wrote: “New door. Boundary made again. Air returned.”

Shivkant read what she had written.

“Boundary?”

Meera said, “While the room is open, nothing happens. The moment it is closed, the air changes.”

Shivkant looked at the door for a while.

Then he lifted the latch.

The panel opened.

The spring air stopped at once.

The room was ordinary.

New plaster, two trunks, a bamboo stool.

Meera went inside.

There was only the ordinary chill of the season between Kartik and Paus, the same as outside.

She came out.

Shivkant closed the panel again.

The three of them stood there for a while.

At first, nothing.

Then the corner of Malti’s sari near the hairline seam in the panel stirred.

The air had returned.

This time Meera could not identify its smell at once.

The earth was not warm.

The leaves were not wet.

There was no ash from a fire.

No sweetness of mango blossom.

It was simply different.

Meera left the season column blank in the register.

She left the smell column blank as well.

Only in the evidence column did she write: “Door closed.”

From that day on, no new rule was made in the house for the air from the room.

Some mornings someone placed a palm beneath the door; some mornings no one did.

Sometimes it was Jeth, sometimes Sawan, sometimes winter, and sometimes an air for which no one in the house had a name.

The moment the room was opened, everything stopped.

A little while after it was closed, it began again.

Bhola took his payment for the repairs and left.

Pramod called from Delhi and asked, "Did the air survive?"

Meera told him, "The door survived."

Whether Pramod laughed or not was impossible to tell clearly over the phone.

One night in Paus, Malti was putting the kitchen in order late. Everyone else had gone to sleep. As she passed the locked room, warm air was coming through the hairline seam in the panel. She stopped.

This time the air carried no smell of earth, flowers, or dust. Only warmth. Malti placed her palm against the panel. The wood was cold. The air coming through the seam was warm. She reached for the latch to open the door. Then she stopped her hand. The door remained closed.

It was winter in the courtyard. To know what season lay inside the locked room, one had to open it. But the moment it was opened, that season ceased to exist. Malti quietly switched off the kitchen light. In the darkness, the hairline seam in the door could no longer be seen. Only the air continued to touch her cheek.

The Ownerless Shadow

At noon, Madhubani's old market became almost another place altogether.

The morning commotion subsided.

Wet sacks were laid over the vegetable baskets.

The saris hanging outside the cloth shops grew still.

The tea seller lowered the flame under his stove.

And people drew themselves in beneath awnings, umbrellas, tarpaulins, and leafy shade.

That day in Jeth was just such a day.

The sun was almost directly overhead.

The shadows were all small, dense, and pressed close to the feet.

Sulochana Devi was inside her stationery shop counting the ledger entries.

The shop was called "Vidyapati Writing Store."

Her late father-in-law had given it that name.

Now Sulochana ran the shop.

At that moment she saw a black shape in the middle of the road.

At first she thought someone was walking through the noonday sun.

But no person was visible.

There was only a shadow.

It was shaped like a human being—a head, shoulders, two arms, two legs.

It was moving slowly from east to west.

Sulochana narrowed her eyes.

The road was empty.

A rickshaw stood far off at the bend.

Two dogs lay drowsing beside a water trough.

And in the middle of the road the shadow kept walking.

Its pace was so ordinary that it took Sulochana a few moments to grasp what was extraordinary about it.

The shadow put one foot forward.

The other lifted from behind.

Its arms swung lightly.
But there was nothing above it.
Sulochana came to the threshold of the shop.
“Sattar bhai!” she called to the key-maker across the road.
Sattar Mian came out from inside.
“What happened?”
Sulochana pointed toward the road.
Sattar first looked at the sunlight.
Then at the shadow.
“Whose is it?”
“That is my question too.”
Both of them looked upward.
There was no one on any rooftop.
There were electric wires, but their shadows fell in another direction.
There was a bamboo pole, but it stood still.
The sky was perfectly clear.
By then the shadow had reached the front of Sattar’s shop.
Sattar stepped into the road.
He placed his foot near the shadow.
His own shadow was a small black patch to the right of his feet.
The two shadows came close to each other.
But they did not meet.
The ownerless shadow suddenly turned left.
Sattar also moved left.
The shadow straightened again.
Sattar laughed.
“It got frightened of me.”
“Not of you,” Sulochana said.
She was looking at Sattar’s feet.
“Of your shadow.”
Sattar looked down.
It had turned not before his body, but before his shadow.
That could not be tested at once.
First five people gathered.
Then ten.
Parvati Devi, the vegetable seller, left her basket and came over.
Ramlochan Babu, who repaired watches, kept wiping his spectacles
and peering.

A schoolboy stopped his bicycle.
Everyone's first question was the same—"Whose shadow is it?"
People began looking at one another's feet.
No one's shadow was missing.
No one's shadow matched it.
Meanwhile, the ownerless shadow did not stop walking.
It kept moving ahead down the middle of the road, making small turns to left and right.
Then Parvati Devi noticed that the shadow went around the shadow of her weighing scale.
The scale stood at the roadside.
Its body was not in the shadow's path.
Only the scale's thin shadow lay ahead.
"Did you see that?" Parvati said.
No one had seen it clearly.
Sattar Mian brought a long bamboo pole from his shop.
He laid the bamboo on the ground.
The ownerless shadow crossed over it.
Nothing happened.
Sattar lifted the bamboo.
He rested one end on his shoulder and extended the other over the road.
The bamboo itself was in the air.
Its thin shadow made a black line on the ground.
The ownerless shadow reached that line and stopped.
It had stopped for the first time.
It seemed as though the market too had stopped.
Sattar raised the bamboo a little.
The black line shifted.
The ownerless shadow took one step forward.
Sattar lowered the bamboo.
The line came before it again.
The shadow stopped again.
"It does not heed the body," Sulochana said softly.
"It heeds the shadow."
The schoolboy grew excited.
He laid the bicycle down on the ground.
The shadows of the wheels and frame fell across the road like a lattice.

The ownerless shadow did not go straight through.

It went around the edge of the wheel's circular shadow and came out on the other side.

Its foot did not strike the iron wheel.

For the iron wheel itself was not in its path at all.

It avoided only the black circle drawn on the ground.

There was no laughter in the crowd now.

People began looking at their own shadows.

What until then had been merely an effect of light had suddenly become an obstacle in a road.

Ramlochan Babu said, "It can be stopped."

"Why should we stop it?" Sulochana asked.

"For an experiment."

Ramlochan brought two old white sheets from inside his shop.

Four people stretched them on bamboo poles and held them over the road.

The shade of the sheets made a broad black band on the ground.

The ownerless shadow came to that band and halted.

It turned right.

There Sattar stood making a shadow with the bamboo pole.

It turned left.

There the schoolboy stood the bicycle upright.

There was shadow on three sides.

The way behind was open.

The ownerless shadow turned around.

It began walking back the way it had come.

"It does not get trapped," Sulochana said.

"It changes its route."

Ramlochan said, "Close the way behind too."

Sulochana stopped him.

"First let us see what it does."

The sheets were lifted away.

The bicycle was moved.

The bamboo was lowered.

The black bands broke apart.

The ownerless shadow turned again.

It resumed its original direction and walked westward.

That day it went as far as the end of the market.

At the end stood a peepal tree.
 The peepal's dense shade covered much of the road.
 The ownerless shadow reached the tree's shade and stopped.
 The people had followed behind it.
 The shadow went around to the right.
 The peepal's shade spread all the way to the right.
 It went around to the left.
 There too was dark shade.
 For a few moments it paced back and forth inside a small patch of light.
 Then a wind blew.
 The peepal leaves stirred.
 A thin crack of light opened within the shade.
 The ownerless shadow entered that bright crack.
 The crack moved with the leaves.
 The shadow too moved crookedly with it.
 Once, its head fell beneath the dark leaf-shadow.
 That part vanished from sight.
 The rest of the body remained visible on the bright patch.
 The next moment the head came back into the light.
 The shadow became whole again.
 In this way, breaking into pieces, it crossed the peepal's shade.
 Then it turned into the lane behind the market and disappeared from sight.
 By evening, word of the first day's event had spread through the market.
 Someone said it must be some trick with a mirror on a rooftop.
 Someone said it was an illusion caused by the heat.
 Someone said such a thing might have happened before in the old market, only no one had written it down.
 Sulochana offered no conclusion.
 On the last page of her ledger she wrote only: "12:17 p.m. East to west. No obstacle from bodies. Obstacle from shadows."
 Before noon the next day, people began to wait.
 Sulochana did not like that.
 "This is a market, not a playhouse," she said.
 Yet she herself placed a chair at the threshold.
 At twelve ten, nothing happened.

At twelve fifteen, nothing happened.

Ramlochan held his watch to his ear and checked it.

Sattar stood holding the bamboo pole.

At twelve seventeen, the black shape appeared near the eastern bend.

The same gait.

The same head.

The same shoulders.

The same two swinging arms.

A single sound rose through the crowd like a breath.

“It has come.”

This time Sulochana stepped into the road carrying a piece of chalk.

She made a small mark beside the shadow where it had first appeared.

Then, every ten cubits, she drew a small line at the side of the road.

The shadow kept walking at the same pace.

Ramlochan kept noting the time.

From time to time Sattar placed the shadows of different objects in its path.

A bamboo pole.

An umbrella.

A wooden frame.

Even the shadow of an empty rope.

The ownerless shadow avoided them all.

But bricks, rope, baskets, and wood lying on the ground could not stop it.

At one spot three bricks lay on the road.

The shadow went straight over them.

Its black foot did not rise onto the surface of the bricks.

Wherever it had been visible on the road, that part vanished for a moment because of the bricks, then appeared again on the other side.

Seeing this, Sulochana wrote: “A change of surface makes no difference.”

On the third day the sky was overcast.

People waited.

There was no sunlight until afternoon.

No shadow was distinct.

The ownerless shadow did not come either.

On the fourth day, half the sky was clear.

At twelve seventeen, it came again.

This time, as it reached the middle of the market, a cloud passed over the sun.

All the shadows on the road began to fade at once.

Sattar's shadow turned grey first.

The umbrella's shadow grew pale.

The peepal's shade began to dissolve into the earth.

The ownerless shadow too grew thin.

It was one step ahead.

The next step appeared only halfway.

Before it could lift the third step, it vanished completely.

People kept staring at the spot.

Five minutes later the sunlight grew strong again.

Sattar's shadow returned beside his feet.

The shop awnings cast clear shadows on the road again.

And the ownerless shadow reappeared at the very place where it had vanished.

One of its feet was still halfway forward.

As though those five minutes had not passed for it at all.

It completed the step and walked on.

Sulochana wrote in the ledger: "It does not move in darkness. When light returns, it resumes from the same place."

Sattar read it and said, "The shadow is afraid of the dark."

Sulochana said, "Where does a shadow exist in darkness anyway?"

"Then why call this a shadow?"

No one had an answer to that question.

On the fifth day, the boys in the market decided to conduct an experiment.

They gathered four old umbrellas, two sheets, and three bamboo poles.

They made shade all around the road, leaving only a narrow corridor of light.

The ownerless shadow entered that corridor.

It took the winding path.

Where the light bent left, it turned left.

Where it bent right, it turned right.

At one point the corridor was so narrow that half its shoulder fell into shade.

That half vanished.

The remaining half of the black figure moved forward.

The corridor widened again.

The shoulder became whole again.

The boys applauded.

Sulochana scolded them.

“Make a path for it, not a game of tormenting it.”

“Does it feel pain?” one boy asked.

Sulochana fell silent.

That was not a question for the ledger.

Over the next few days, a new custom took hold in the market.

Around twelve seventeen, shopkeepers made sure not to cast unnecessary shade across the middle of the road.

If an umbrella jutted out too far, they pulled it inward.

Sattar would joke, “Keep the road clear. The noonday traveller is coming.”

Ramlochan had already measured its pace.

It was like the slow walk of an ordinary person.

Neither hurried.

Nor sluggish.

It never stopped in front of any shop.

It never followed anyone.

It never turned its head toward anything.

There were no features on its shadow-face.

There was only the gait.

After two weeks, people's curiosity began to wane.

The market returned to its work.

The shadow did not come every day, but on clear afternoons it appeared often.

Some people watched it.

Some did not.

Sulochana kept recording the dates in her ledger.

One day she noticed that the shadow was not always the same size.

Under Jeth's fierce overhead sun, it was short and dark.

As Ashadh approached and the sun angled slightly, its body grew longer.

That would have been natural, if it had had a body.

But where was the body?

Sattar said of this, “Perhaps its owner is not here, but somewhere else.”

“Why would the shadow of a body elsewhere fall here?”

“Not everything in this market has an explanation.”

Sulochana smiled.

She did not write the word “owner” in the ledger.

It seemed to her that insisting on finding an owner turned the sight into the wrong question.

One day the municipality began installing a new cloth canopy over the middle of the market.

The heat had been severe.

For months the shopkeepers had been asking for shade.

Long bamboo poles were planted.

Thick cloth was stretched from east to west.

Almost the entire middle of the road came under shade.

Everyone was pleased.

The afternoons became somewhat bearable.

But on the first clear day, at twelve seventeen, Sulochana looked eastward.

The ownerless shadow appeared at the bend.

It walked through the light until it reached the first edge of the canopy.

And stopped.

This time there was not a strip of shade merely a few cubits wide before it.

Almost the whole market lay ahead like a long black river.

There was canopy over the mouth of the lane to the right as well.

To the left were the fruit sellers' umbrellas.

Behind it lay open sunlight.

The shadow turned back.

Sulochana thought it would return the way it had come.

But it did not.

It began moving north along the edge of the canopy.

Where the cloth ended, there was a strip of sunlight two cubits wide.

The shadow took that thin band of light.

Leaving the market's main road, it began moving close along the shop thresholds.

People stopped their work and watched.

It had never taken this route before.

It came in front of Sulochana's shop.

The awning's shadow fell near the threshold.

Only half a cubit of sunlight remained between them.

The ownerless shadow tried to pass through that half-cubit strip.
Most of its body vanished.

Only a thin black streak could be seen moving.

Without thinking, Sulochana raised the bamboo support of the awning a little.

The strip of sunlight widened.

The shadow became whole again.

Without stopping, it moved on.

Sattar too tied up the hanging mat outside his shop.

Parvati pulled the vegetable sacks inward so their shadows would not fall across the path.

No one gave anyone an order.

Only a narrow path of light began opening along the edge of the market.

The shadow followed that path and reached the western peepal tree.

The peepal's shade was still there.

This time there were very few patches of light between the leaves.

The shadow moved along the edge for a while.

Then it found a bright slit.

It passed through it.

In the evening a municipal worker came and asked, "Why have you left so many gaps along the sides of the canopy?"

"For air," Sattar said.

Sulochana said nothing.

After Ashadh, the rains began.

The sky remained overcast for days at a time.

For many weeks the ownerless shadow did not appear.

The lines for dates in the ledger remained empty.

Rainwater came through the gaps in the canopy, so the shopkeepers gradually covered them again.

The market returned to its normal routine.

The schoolboy now came only occasionally.

Ramlochan stopped looking at the clock.

Sattar's bamboo pole went back to resting above the key shop.

Sulochana put the ledger away in the cupboard.

At the end of Bhadav, one day the sky cleared as though it had been washed.

The afternoon sun was fierce again.

Sulochana did not think of the ledger.

She was tying a bundle of notebooks for a customer.
 Then a stranger's voice came from outside: "Whose shadow is this?"
 Sulochana's hands stopped.
 She came outside.
 A man who looked like a traveller stood in the middle of the road.
 A cloth bag hung from his shoulder.
 He was looking down.
 The ownerless shadow was approaching him.
 The traveller was perhaps seeing it for the first time.
 He stepped back twice.
 The shadow did not change its pace.
 "Whose is it?" he asked again.
 No one answered.
 Sattar Mian kept filing a key.
 Parvati went on weighing okra on her scale.
 Ramlochan was wiping the lenses of his spectacles.
 The traveller remained standing in the middle of the path.
 The ownerless shadow reached directly in front of his body.
 The traveller thought of moving aside, but it was too late.
 The shadow did not collide with his body.
 It did not heed bodies at all.
 But the traveller's own shadow fell to the left of his feet.
 The ownerless shadow reached that black shape and turned.
 It passed so close to the traveller's body that its black shoulder seemed to go beneath the bag.
 Even so, it kept an inch of distance from the traveller's shadow.
 Then it straightened and moved on.
 For a long while the traveller kept looking down.
 His own shadow remained just as it was beside his feet.
 He raised his head and looked at Sulochana.
 "Are none of you afraid?"
 Sulochana watched the black figure moving westward along the side of the market.
 "At first there were more questions," she said.
 "And now?"
 Before answering, Sulochana noticed that the mat outside Sattar's shop was hanging out again.
 Its shadow lay across the path.

Without saying anything, Sattar tied the mat up.
A narrow strip of sunlight opened.
The ownerless shadow took that strip and moved ahead.
Sulochana said, "Now we simply know its way."
The traveller turned again and looked at his own shadow.
It was moving with his body.
The market's other shadows too were with their own bodies.
Only one shadow belonged to no one, yet little by little everyone in
the market had learned its path.

The Station Not on the Map

For Prabhakar Mishra, a train journey was not something to look at but something to count.

The time he left home at dawn, the time the train arrived at the little station, the time it crossed the bridge after Sakri, the time he reached Darbhanga and marked his attendance at the office—everything sat inside him like the hands of a clock.

He was a clerk in the district archives. He spent his days among old files, torn maps, and dates. So whenever something new appeared along the way, his eyes tried to place it, in his mind, somewhere within the old order.

He first saw Kadambbari station on a Monday.

He wrote the name in his notebook later. In that first instant, there had not even been time enough to read it.

The train was running at full speed between two familiar stations. Outside the window, paddy fields, two ponds, electric poles, and a small brick kiln went past in turn. Then, all at once, a platform with a yellow signboard filled the frame of the window.

In the middle of the platform, black letters on the yellow board read—Kadambbari.

A blue bench. An iron hand-pump. A small tin shelter. Beneath the shelter, an old man with a red gamchha over his shoulder.

The train did not slow down. No whistle sounded. No door opened.

Within eighteen or twenty seconds, everything had fallen behind.

Prabhakar looked at Shekhar Thakur, who was sitting beside him. Shekhar was reading a newspaper.

“Has a new station been built here?” Prabhakar asked.

Shekhar did not lift his eyes from the paper. “Where?”

“The one we just passed—Kadambbari.”

This time Shekhar looked outside. There were fields.

“You have spent so long looking through old files that now you have begun looking for files even on the railway tracks,” he said with a laugh.

Prabhakar laughed too. The matter ended there.

The next day Prabhakar deliberately took a seat by the window. His coach was almost the same one—the third general coach from the front, the fourth window on the left.

Between the two familiar stations he began counting electric poles. After the fourteenth pole came the pond, then the thicket, then the little culvert.

And then the yellow board again.

Kadambbari.

This time he read the name clearly. The old man from the previous day was not on the platform. A girl was working the handle of the hand-pump up and down. Three yellow canisters stood beside the bench.

Again the train went on without changing speed.

Prabhakar immediately took out his notebook and wrote: ‘Between two stations. Pond after the fourteenth pole. Name: Kadambbari. Train does not stop.’

On reaching the office, he found his archival habits useful for the first time. During lunch he searched for old district maps of the railway line. The archives did not hold every railway department file, but they did have old land-acquisition maps.

A straight line ran between the two stations. The little culvert was marked midway. Kadambbari was not marked.

He thought—it must be a new station. How could it appear on an old map?

That evening, at the enquiry window of his own station, he asked about the name.

The clerk turned the pages of the timetable. “Kadambbari?”

“Yes, in between.”

The clerk turned more pages. “There is no station by that name on this line.”

“A new halt?”

“No.”

“An old station that was closed?”

“Not that either.”

Prabhakar did not argue. It was not in his nature to argue with records about something that could not be found in the records.

On the third day he asked Shekhar to fold away his newspaper.

“Today just look out of the window. When I tell you.”

Shekhar smiled, but agreed.

As soon as the pond slipped behind them, Prabhakar said, “Now.”

Shekhar looked out through the fourth window.

The yellow board was in front of them.

“Kadambbari,” Shekhar said softly.

This time a goat was tethered on the platform. A thin strip of sunlight fell from the edge of the tin shelter. A woman in a green sari sat on the bench with a bundle of clothes in her lap.

After the station had gone by, Shekhar did not reopen his newspaper.

“I have travelled on this line for eight years,” he said. “I have never heard of a station by this name.”

“Neither had the enquiry clerk yesterday.”

“Then what is this?”

Prabhakar did not answer. In his notebook he wrote a third line: ‘Shekhar saw it too.’

The investigation began the next day.

Prabhakar left the fourth window and sat at the fifth. The same pond, the same thicket, the same culvert came into view. But Kadambbari did not. The fields continued without interruption.

He got up and moved toward the fourth window, but by then the train had already passed that stretch.

On the fifth day he sat at the fourth window again. Kadambbari was there.

On the sixth day he kept shifting his gaze between the three gaps formed by the iron bars of the window.

That was when he noticed the most unsettling thing of all.

Seen through the middle gap of the fourth window, the station was there. At the very same moment, if he moved his head two inches to the right and looked through the side gap, there was no station—only paddy fields.

Back to the middle gap—the yellow board, the pump, the bench.

Back to the side gap—the fields.

Both views existed at the same time in the same direction.

For the first time, a faint shiver ran through Prabhakar. More than fear, it was the kind of unease he felt when two different owners appeared against the same plot number in a file.

With his fingernail he made a small scratch on the window frame.

On the seventh day Shekhar was absent. Facing Prabhakar sat Manjula Kumari, a college student he often saw on this train.

For a long time Prabhakar said nothing. As the station drew near, he gave up his seat and said, “Would you look out through this window?”

Manjula looked at him questioningly, but changed places.

A few moments later she read the name herself. “Kadambbari?”

“What do you see?” Prabhakar asked.

“A small station. A child is peeping from behind the signboard.”

Prabhakar looked through the middle gap. The child was indeed there.

“And through the side gap?”

Manjula shifted her head. Her brows drew together.

“Fields.”

The station fell behind. Manjula remained silent for a long time.

“Will you tell anyone?” she asked.

Prabhakar closed his notebook. “Let me first understand it myself.”

He could not understand it.

Through a clerk he knew in the railway office, he informally examined the records for the distance between the two stations. Distance posts, culverts, bends in the track, land acquisition—everything was recorded. The name Kadambbari was nowhere.

“There is hardly room for a station here either,” the clerk said, running a finger over the map. “Fields on one side, low-lying land on the other. There was never even an old proposal.”

Prabhakar asked, “Any temporary halt? During a fair?”

The clerk shook his head. “No. Where did you come across the name?”

“I heard it from someone.”

As he gave that answer, Prabhakar felt that for the first time he was lying about Kadambbari.

On the eighth day he tried to take a photograph with his phone.

With his eye at the middle gap, the station was perfectly clear. When he held the phone screen in the same direction, there were only fields. He took the photograph. Later, when he looked at it, he saw paddy, a white egret, and a distant palm tree.

That day, after reaching home, he drew a small sketch of the station from memory: the yellow board, the blue bench, the hand-pump, the tin shelter. The drawing was still the same the next day.

On the ninth day the hand-pump was gone from the station. In its place, two labourers were digging the earth.

On the tenth day a new pump stood half-buried in the ground.

On the eleventh day the earth around it was wet.

Prabhakar understood that this was not some fixed image. Days passed there.

But he could not tell how much time passed there.

A week later the order of the coaches changed. The third coach from the front was new. The old fourth window was gone.

Prabhakar sat in the corresponding place. Between the two stations he saw the fields, the pond, the thicket, the culvert. Kadambbari did not appear.

That day he felt emptiness more than surprise. He could not prove that the place existed, yet its absence began to trouble him as well.

For three days the station did not appear.

On the fourth day Shekhar asked, "Where has your station gone?"

Prabhakar said, "Perhaps with the coach."

Shekhar tried to laugh, but the laugh did not quite come.

That evening, returning from the office, Prabhakar was crossing the footbridge beside the Darbhanga railway yard at a slow pace. Below him, several old coaches stood on separate tracks.

On the frame of one coach he saw the small scratch he had made with his fingernail.

He stopped.

It was the same coach.

In the railway yard, there should have been the wall of the goods shed behind that coach. From the bridge above, Prabhakar looked toward the middle gap of the fourth window.

There was no wall.

There was Kadambbari.

The yellow board stood in the sunlight. The earth beneath the new pump had dried now. On the blue bench sat not the same woman in the green sari, but an old man. A child was drawing a circle in chalk along the edge of the platform.

Prabhakar stood motionless on the bridge. The coach below was motionless too. Yet inside the station small movements continued—cloth fluttered, the child's hand rose and fell, a goat's ear twitched.

He took two steps to the right and looked through the next window of the same coach. The wall of the goods shed. Then through the middle gap of the fourth window—Kadambbari. This time a boy standing beside the yellow board raised his head and looked toward the bridge.

Prabhakar felt like raising his hand. He did not. He placed his notebook on the iron railing of the bridge and opened the page with the map. Between the two stations, where he had earlier made a dot for Kadambbari, he struck the dot out.

Instead, in the margin of the page, he drew a small rectangle—the shape of a window. Inside it he wrote: 'Kadambbari.' Below, in the railway yard, the coach stood perfectly still. There was still no place for the station on the map; but there was a place for the window.

The Clock That Struck Half

In the drawing room of Devanand Mishra's house in an old Laheriasarai neighbourhood, a wall clock had hung for eighteen years. It had a square wooden case, a white round face, black numerals, and below, behind glass, a brass pendulum. One corner of the glass had long been cracked, but that had never affected the clock's running.

Many things in the house changed. The radio went, the table was replaced, a cupboard took the place of the tin trunk, and the children grew up. But the clock remained where it was.

When it came to time, Devanand Babu trusted the clock. A phone might be five minutes fast or slow, a neighbour's clock might stop, the electricity might fail—the drawing-room clock kept moving in its own rhythm.

His wife Kumud would say, "This clock is more regular than the people in this house."

Their daughter Vaidehi would laugh and say, "Then give it food too."

Devanand Babu would reply, "It gets wound once every seven days. That is all."

Everyone would laugh at that.

One evening in Bhadau, before dinner, the clock told a time no one had ever known before.

Kumud was heating milk. Devanand Babu was checking old accounts of the cooperative store at the drawing-room table. Vaidehi sat by the window writing an essay. Bhubaneswari Devi, Devanand Babu's mother, was mending a torn seam in a pillowcase.

The clock reached nine twenty-six. The pendulum swung right, then left. The minute hand left the mark for twenty-six and moved forward.

But before it reached the mark for twenty-seven, it stopped midway.

Not stopped—stood still. Vaidehi was the first to notice the distinction.

The pendulum kept moving. Tick. Tock. Tick. Tock.

The short hour hand was where it ought to be, between nine and ten. The long minute hand stood between two fine marks, at a place where there was no line at all on the clock face.

Vaidehi stopped writing. "Babu, has the clock got stuck?"

Devanand Babu looked up. "The pendulum is moving. Why has the hand stopped?"

He rose and went beneath the clock.

Just then a very faint metallic sound came from behind the glass—ting—

The sound did not ring out fully. It was as though a bell had been struck and someone had caught its echo halfway.

Bhubaneswari Devi stopped sewing. "What time did that strike?"

From the kitchen Kumud said, "Why would it strike again after nine?"

Devanand Babu took out his phone and looked. Nine twenty-six.

Vaidehi checked hers. It too said nine twenty-six.

The pendulum kept moving.

Devanand Babu began counting—one, two, three...

At the twentieth tick the phone still showed nine twenty-six. At the fiftieth tick, the same. At the eightieth too.

Suddenly Kumud called from the kitchen, "The milk!"

Everyone ran in.

The milk had risen to the lip of the pot. White froth pressed right against the rim, yet did not spill over. The flame was burning. The surface of the milk trembled, trying to rise, yet remained poised at that fine boundary.

Kumud quickly turned down the flame. The stove knob turned, but the flame did not immediately grow smaller.

"What is this?" she exclaimed.

Vaidehi bent over the pot. One bubble in the froth was on the verge of bursting, but did not burst.

Just then a full chime sounded from the drawing room—ting.

The kitchen flame diminished. The bubble burst. A drop of milk slipped over the rim and fell on the stove.

Vaidehi ran to the drawing room.

The minute hand stood on the mark for twenty-seven.

The phone showed nine twenty-seven.

For a while no one in the house spoke.

Devanand Babu was the first to say, "The clock is faulty."

Bhubaneswari Devi asked, "The phone too?"

He had no answer to that.

The next morning everything was normal. Devanand Babu opened the clock's glass and gently moved the hands. Nothing caught. He wound the clock and listened to the movement of the pendulum.

Nothing happened that afternoon. Nothing that evening either.

At around half past ten that night, Kumud was fastening the inner bolt of the door. Vaidehi was gathering up her notebooks. Devanand Babu was taking his medicine.

The clock showed ten forty-two.

Then came the same half-chime.

Kumud's hand did not stop on the bolt. She pushed it upward, but the iron piece would not go all the way into its slot. She pressed harder. The bolt reached the mouth of the slot and no farther.

"Has it jammed?" Devanand Babu asked.

"No. Something is stopping it."

He went over himself. He pushed with both hands. The bolt did not move even a fraction farther into the slot.

Vaidehi looked towards the drawing-room clock. The long hand stood between forty-two and forty-three.

"It's in between again," she said.

Bhubaneswari Devi was tying a knot in the thread at the pillow. She pulled both ends, but the knot would not tighten. However hard she pulled, the knot took shape and then remained loose.

Vaidehi tried to laugh. No laugh came.

"This time it isn't the milk," she said softly.

Devanand Babu checked his phone. Ten forty-two.

He began counting. Thirty-one ticks. Thirty-two. Thirty-three.

Kumud let go of the bolt. "Leave it."

Bhubaneswari Devi set the thread down in her lap.

Vaidehi wrote on a page of her notebook—"The second time today."

She touched her pen to the page to put a full stop. A small dot of ink appeared, but it did not become round; it was as though half the dot remained caught inside the paper.

At the fifty-seventh tick the clock chimed fully.

The bolt slid straight into the slot—though Kumud was not even touching it.

The knot in the thread lying in Bhubaneswari Devi's lap did not tighten by itself, but when she pulled it once more, it tightened at once.

Vaidehi's full stop became round.

The phone showed ten forty-three.

This time Devanand Babu did not say, "The clock is faulty."

From the third day onward, Vaidehi kept a separate page. At the top she wrote—"The Time Between."

Devanand Babu felt like striking out the heading, but he did not.

For three days nothing happened.

On the fourth morning, at six eleven, the half-chime sounded. Kumud was closing the lid of the rice tin. The lid turned and turned until it reached the final thread, but would not tighten. Devanand Babu was tying his shoelaces; the knot formed, but loosened at the last pull.

Vaidehi opened the page at once.

She wrote—‘A task continues, but does not finish.’

Devanand Babu said, “Don’t make a rule so quickly.”

Vaidehi replied, “Then tie your shoe.”

Devanand Babu tried again. The lace would not tie.

When the half-time ended, the lid tightened in a single turn and the shoelace tied.

After that incident the family began observing it not as a game, but as an investigation.

On a sheet of paper Devanand Babu made two columns—‘Begun In Between’ and ‘Completed In Between’.

The ‘Completed In Between’ column remained empty for many days.

Once Bhubaneswari Devi folded a betel leaf. The leaf folded, the lime and catechu stayed inside, but she could not pierce it with a clove and close it.

Once Vaidehi wrote a letter and folded the envelope; the gum stuck, but the final corner of the flap remained raised.

Once Kumud turned on the tap to fill a bucket. The water rose until it was half an inch below the rim, then trembled at that level. The tap was open, water was still coming, yet the bucket would not fill.

Devanand Babu turned off the tap. The knob turned, the stream grew thin, but it would not stop completely.

The moment the full chime sounded, the stream stopped and the surface of the bucket stirred once and became still.

“So a task can be begun during the time between,” Vaidehi said, “but it cannot be completed.”

Devanand Babu said, “If it is time, why can there be no completion?”

Bhubaneswari Devi put the betel leaf in her mouth and said, “Perhaps the time itself is not complete.”

It was the simplest sentence of all, and so everyone fell silent.

That day Devanand Babu took the clock down.

“Now we’ll see,” he said. “If the clock isn’t here, where will this half-time come from?”

The clock repairer Brijmohan had a shop near the tower. He opened the case and examined the wheels, spring, hammer, bell—everything.

"The hand stops in between?" Brijmohan asked.

"Yes."

"The pendulum?"

"Keeps moving."

"The bell rings only halfway?"

Devanand Babu looked at him closely. "Why did you ask that?"

Brijmohan laughed. "In a clock that catches, the hammer can rise halfway and slip. Quite ordinary."

Devanand Babu felt relieved.

Brijmohan said, "Leave it with me for a night."

Without the clock the drawing-room wall looked strangely empty. A pale circular mark remained where dust had not settled for years.

At dinner Kumud said, "At least we won't hear the half-bell now."

Vaidehi folded the page and put it inside a book.

At eleven five that night, Bhubaneswari Devi was threading a needle. Kumud was turning off the kitchen tap. Devanand Babu was pulling the window shutter closed.

No clock chimed.

But the window shutter came to a halt as though caught, one inch before the frame.

The stream from the tap thinned to a thread and kept falling; it did not stop.

Bhubaneswari Devi's thread passed halfway through the tiny eye of the needle, but however much she pulled, the other end stayed where it was.

Devanand Babu looked at his phone. Eleven five.

He said nothing.

Vaidehi came running from her room. She glanced at the window, the tap, the needle. Then at the empty wall.

"The clock isn't here," she whispered.

No one answered.

After a while the tap suddenly stopped. The window shutter settled against the frame. The thread came all the way through the needle.

The phone showed eleven six.

The next day Devanand Babu went to Brijmohan's shop.

Brijmohan had the clock on the table. "I found nothing wrong. It ran all night. Kept correct time too."

Devanand Babu asked, "The bell?"

"Rang properly on the hour."

"Halfway?"

Brijmohan laughed. "What clock rings half a bell?"

Devanand Babu picked up the clock.

Back home, he hung it on the wall again himself. Vaidehi asked, "If it isn't the cause, why put it back?"

Straightening the clock, he said, "At least it tells us when the in-between has begun."

After that, the family stopped trying to prevent it.

The time between did not come every day. Sometimes after two days, sometimes after seven. Sometimes in the morning, sometimes at midnight. Its duration was not fixed either—sometimes twenty-three ticks, sometimes more than a hundred.

Once Devanand Babu thought he could use that time to make considerable progress on unfinished accounts. He kept paper, calculations and pen ready. The moment the half-chime sounded, he sat down to write.

He added line after line. Everything was fine until the final total. But when he reached the last digit, his pen kept touching the paper and no numeral would form.

The clock chimed fully. The numeral appeared.

After that day he no longer regarded the time between as saved time.

Once Vaidehi thought of using it for study. At the half-chime she read three pages of a lesson. Her eyes kept going over the final line of the fourth page, but the meaning would not become complete. After the full chime, one reading was enough for the sentence to make sense.

Kumud said, "This time completes no one's work."

Bhubaneswari Devi replied, "Why only the work? Perhaps it has not itself become complete."

One night in Ashwin, rain fell heavily. The electricity was out. A lantern burned in the house. In the darkness, the wall clock showed only the faint glimmer of its swinging pendulum.

A little before twelve, the half-chime sounded.

This time no one was alarmed.

Kumud was folding a cloth and placing it along the threshold so that rainwater from the veranda would not come inside. The cloth reached one end of the threshold, but its other end would not lie flat.

Devanand Babu stood by the window. Vaidehi came beside him.

Outside, a drop was swelling at the edge of the roof. As water gathered, the drop had grown heavy, but it did not fall. Inside it the courtyard lantern shone upside down.

Vaidehi asked, "Babu, what time is it now?"

Devanand Babu looked at the clock. In the darkness the minute hand stood between two marks.

He said, "A time no clock has struck."

Vaidehi smiled.

The drop still hung from the edge of the roof. The tiny inverted house of lantern-light trembled inside it.

A few ticks later the wall clock chimed fully.

The drop fell. The cloth at the threshold lay flat. Outside, the rain could once again be heard in its ordinary sound.

Vaidehi opened her page titled 'The Time Between'. It held dates, times, numbers of ticks, and a long list of unfinished tasks.

She placed her pen on the final line.

First she wrote—'Before twelve struck.'

Then she thought, and struck it out.

Beneath it she wrote only—'Half struck.'

The Second Door

A little way in from Benta Chowk in Darbhanga, in a narrow lane, stood a new four-storey building. Mahendra Jha had lived with his family in a rented flat on the third floor for five years.

The flat was not large—a drawing room, two bedrooms, a kitchen, a bathroom, and a narrow veranda. But Aarti liked the house. From the window she could see the crown of a peepal tree; in the morning the milkman rang his bell below, and in the evening clothes fluttered on the terrace opposite.

Mahendra Babu would say, “It may not be our own house, but the way we live in it has become our own.”

Their daughter Mrinal was in Class Eight. Their son Anshuman was in Class Five. Mahendra Babu’s elderly mother, Shyama Devi, came from the village to stay with them for two or three months each year.

The west wall of the drawing room was bare. No window, no cupboard, no picture. Aarti had once thought of hanging a Madhubani painting there, but after noticing a faint damp patch on the wall, she had let the idea drop.

According to the landlord’s plan, the drawing room of the neighbouring flat lay behind that wall.

One night in Katik, after midnight, the electricity went out.

Aarti came into the drawing room carrying a candle. Anshuman had got up for a drink of water. Mahendra Babu stood by the window because, in the darkness, the lane outside seemed unusually quiet.

The candle flame trembled against the west wall.

At first Aarti thought the damp patch had grown. Then the flame steadied, and the outline of a frame became clearly visible on all four sides.

There was a door in the wall.

Its wood was neither old nor new. A pale grey. A small brass handle on the right. At the bottom, the frame met the floor so neatly that it looked as though the door had been there since the house was built.

Mahendra Babu remained silent for a while.

Then he said, “Was this here yesterday?”

Aarti looked at him. “Are you asking me?”

Anshuman said, "I bounce my ball against this wall. If there had been a door, the ball would have gone through it."

Mrinal too came out of her room. She raised the candle and examined the frame.

"Sharmaji's house is behind this wall," she said.

Mahendra Babu placed his hand on the handle.

Aarti said at once, "Not now."

"Why?"

"It is midnight. A door grows out of the wall by itself, and you want to open it at once?"

Anshuman laughed softly, but Shyama Devi's voice came from behind them—"This is no laughing matter."

She came past them to the frame and touched the wood with her fingers.

"The wood is cold," she said.

Mahendra Babu turned the handle again. This time Aarti did not stop him.

The door opened inward without a creak.

Behind it was not Sharmaji's drawing room.

It was their own kitchen.

The stove was out. A brass ladle hung from a hook on the wall. On the kitchen platform stood the bowl used for kneading flour. A small blue mat lay on the floor.

The candle trembled in Aarti's hand.

"This kitchen..." Mrinal whispered.

The kitchen was ten steps away, reached by turning left from the drawing room. There was no possible way it could lie behind this wall.

Anshuman began to lean his head through the doorway. Mahendra Babu caught him by the shoulder and pulled him back.

"Let us look first."

Everyone ran to the kitchen's actual door.

The kitchen was there.

Aarti went inside. She looked towards the new door in the drawing room. There was no second door in that kitchen wall—only a shelf holding three spice tins.

Mahendra Babu stood at the new doorway in the drawing room. Before he could ask whether Aarti could see him clearly from there, the door closed by itself.

Mahendra Babu pulled at the handle. It would not open.

Aarti came out of the kitchen.

The moment she reached the drawing room, the handle turned easily again.

The door opened.

This time, beyond it, was Mrinal's room.

Mrinal started. "My room?"

Her open book lay on the bed, a green pen beside the pillow, her schoolbag on the chair.

Mrinal immediately ran towards her room. The moment she entered it, the new door closed again.

After a little while Mrinal came out. Mahendra Babu opened the door.

Once again, Mrinal's room lay beyond it.

Mahendra Babu said slowly, "Whichever room is empty..."

Aarti completed the sentence. "It opens there?"

No one slept properly until four that night.

By morning the door was still there. In daylight it looked even more ordinary—so ordinary that the fear of the previous night seemed almost ridiculous.

Mahendra Babu telephoned the landlord, Krishnakant Chaudhary.

Chaudhary Babu arrived at ten. At first he thought his tenants were playing a joke on him. The moment he saw the west wall, his face changed.

"There was no door here," he said.

"I know that too," Mahendra Babu replied.

Chaudhary Babu went to the neighbouring Sharma family's flat. There he found the wall completely smooth. When he knocked on it, it gave the ordinary solid thud of brick.

The distance between the two flats was measured. The thickness of the wall came out exactly as shown in the original plan.

Chaudhary Babu returned to Mahendra Babu's drawing room and opened the door.

Shyama Devi's room appeared beyond it.

At that moment Shyama Devi was sitting in the veranda, warming herself in the sun.

Chaudhary Babu stood with his mouth open.

"How can this room be here?"

Anshuman said proudly, "The door goes to whichever room is empty."

"Every empty room?"

Mahendra Babu said, "Perhaps the one that most recently became empty."

That day they understood the rule completely.

Aarti came out of the kitchen—the door began to show the kitchen. Mrinal came out of her room—the door began to show Mrinal's room. Shyama Devi came out of the bathroom—the door opened there.

If someone entered that room again, the door closed. It waited for the next room to become empty.

“So it is a door of emptiness,” Shyama Devi said.

Chaudhary Babu did not like the phrase.

He called a carpenter. The carpenter tapped the frame and examined it. The wood was real. Nails went into it. The paint could be scraped. But when he chipped the plaster away from the edge of the frame, he found not brick underneath, but more wood.

“Shall I cut it out?” the carpenter asked.

Aarti said at once, “No.”

Mahendra Babu stopped him too. “Let us understand it first.”

The attempt to understand it continued for several days.

Anshuman was the most excited. He would slide a small toy counter through the doorway into the empty room. The counter really did turn up on that room's floor.

One day he tried to put his foot through.

The moment the front of his slipper crossed the frame, the view beyond blurred. The handle went rigid.

Mahendra Babu pulled him sharply back.

The door closed.

“People cannot cross through it,” Mrinal said.

Anshuman protested, “But the toy goes through.”

Shyama Devi said, “A room does not become occupied because a toy enters it. It does when a person enters.”

That seemed natural to everyone, as though the door's rules were old rules of the house.

After a few days, the fear diminished.

The new door became part of the household's daily life.

Sometimes Aarti would leave the kitchen empty and look in from the drawing room to check whether she had turned off the stove. After leaving his room, Mahendra Babu would look through the door to see whether he had left his spectacles on the table. Anshuman had turned it into a game.

Mrinal did not like the game.

One evening she came out of her room. At once the drawing-room door began to show her room.

Aarti looked inside without thinking.

An open notebook lay on Mrinal's bed. Across the top, in large letters, she had written—"Things I Cannot Say."

Aarti looked away.

Mrinal saw that her mother had already looked. She immediately shut the door.

"Just because my room is empty does not make everything in it everyone's," she said.

The drawing room fell silent.

Aarti answered softly, "You are right."

From that day a rule was made: if the door showed someone's private room, no one would look inside without need.

Mahendra Babu said with a laugh, "The door does not know its own rules. We have to know them."

Mrinal did not laugh, but her face softened.

The new door continued to do its work all the same.

Sometimes it showed Shyama Devi's empty bed, her spectacles resting on the edge of the pillow. Sometimes the wet floor of the bathroom. Sometimes a half-cut sponge gourd in the kitchen. Sometimes the marbles scattered on the floor of Anshuman's room.

Gradually, the people of the house began to understand that an empty room was not empty. It retained the trace of a body that had only just risen, unfinished work, a smell, a fold, a scattering of things.

One day Mrinal said, "This door does not show people. It shows what remains after people."

Shyama Devi replied, "Sometimes that shows a person more clearly."

At the end of Margashirsha, Shyama Devi returned to the village.

Her room became empty. All day the new door opened onto it, unless someone happened to leave another room empty in between. One corner of the bed remained pressed down, a bottle of oil stood by the wall, and a dried tulsi leaf lay in the window.

That day Aarti opened the door less often.

By Phagun, the family had grown accustomed to its presence.

Then the landlord informed them that the flat was to be sold. Within three months Mahendra's family would have to move elsewhere.

Mahendra Babu was angry at first. Then began the rush to find another house.

The door, as though unaware of the change, continued to follow its rule.

Packing began. First the boxes of books were filled, then the clothes, then the pots and utensils. As the rooms emptied, they looked barer and barer through the new door.

There had once been a map on the wall of Mrinal's room. When it was taken down, a rectangular pale patch remained. The door showed that mark so clearly that Mrinal said, "The house is showing its real colour now."

Anshuman asked, "Will this door work in the new house?"

No one had an answer.

Moving day was a hot morning in Baisakh.

The labourers carried the boxes downstairs. The kitchen was emptied first. The new door showed the kitchen—only the darkened wall, a faint stain of smoke from the stove, and a yellowed corner by the tap.

Then Anshuman's room became empty. The door began to show it.

Then Mrinal's.

Then Mahendra and Aarti's.

Each time, stripped of its belongings, a part of the house looked strangely larger through the door.

Aarti swept the kitchen one last time. Mrinal closed the window. Anshuman checked three times that none of his red marbles had been left in a corner.

By noon, every room except the drawing room was empty.

Only two stools, a bag, and a bunch of keys remained in the drawing room.

The new door was opened. Beyond it lay Mahendra and Aarti's empty room.

Anshuman asked, "When all of us go outside, which room will it show?"

Mahendra Babu said, "It will show something only if there is someone here to open it."

"Can the door open by itself?"

Mahendra Babu laughed. "It has not opened by itself all these days."

Even after giving that answer, he himself did not like it.

Everyone went downstairs.

Halfway down the stairs Aarti said, "The file with the old gas receipts is still on the upper shelf in the drawing room."

Mahendra Babu said, "I'll get it."

He climbed back to the third floor and opened the main door.

For the first time, the flat was almost completely empty.

An empty house has a different sound. The thud of a foot goes around all the walls and comes back. Even the traffic outside the window sounds like a noise from within.

Mahendra Babu entered the drawing room.

The second door in the west wall was closed.

He took the file down from the shelf and put it in the bag. Then, almost despite himself, he looked towards the door.

The thought came to him—let me open it one last time.

He turned the handle.

The door opened.

Beyond it was the drawing room.

Mahendra Babu stopped dead.

On the other side was exactly the same drawing room—empty. No two stools. No bag. No Mahendra Babu himself. And on the west wall, no second door either. Only a flat wall with the faint old damp patch.

Afternoon light fell through the window. On the floor was the square outline in the dust where a trunk had stood for five years.

Mahendra Babu turned and looked back at the real drawing room.

Here the two stools remained. The shelf stood open. The bag lay by his feet.

He looked through the doorway again. Everything on the other side was empty.

He remembered Anshuman's question—when all of us go out, which room will it show?

Mahendra Babu placed his hand on the doorframe.

For the first time, the wood was not cold. It was warm, like the wall of the house.

He did not step forward.

He slowly closed the door.

The labourers came upstairs again to carry down the two stools. Mahendra Babu sent all the remaining things out with them.

At the end, before closing the main door, he looked once towards the west wall.

The second door was still there.

He stepped outside and locked the main door.

As he went down the stairs, the empty third-floor corridor remained above him.

By the time he reached the second floor, he heard a very faint sound from above—as though a wooden handle had turned once.

He did not stop.

Downstairs, Aarti asked, "Did you find the file?"

Mahendra Babu patted the bag. "Found it."

Anshuman asked, "Did you open the door one last time?"

Mahendra Babu looked at him.

Before he could say anything, the driver of the vehicle taking them to the new house called out.

Mahendra Babu said, "The house is empty now."

They all got into the vehicle.

As it turned out of the lane, the third-floor window was visible for a moment.

The west wall could not be seen from outside.

Mahendra Babu wondered—how, after all, would a door that showed an empty room see an empty house?

The vehicle turned the corner. The question remained behind in the old flat, perhaps beyond that second door, where now no one stood in the drawing room.

The Lane That Changed Its Name

That lane in Madhubani's old quarter was not very wide. If two bicycles passed each other face to face, a third person had to press against the wall.

At the eastern entrance to the lane hung a blue tin name-board. Beneath it, in white letters, were written the municipal block number and the sequence of the houses.

Ira Jha had lived in that lane since childhood. More than the lane's name, she remembered the triangular patch of rust at one corner of the board.

One morning, when she stepped out to buy milk, the board read: "Neem Lane."

Ira read it once, then held out her bucket.

The milkman, Jagdish, asked, "Since when has this been its name?"

Ira was surprised. "Its name? Neem Lane is its name."

Jagdish looked toward the board. "I remember another name."

"Which one?"

Jagdish scratched his head. "Wait... Barki Pokhar... yes, Barki Pokhar Lane."

Ira laughed. "There must be a lane by that name somewhere else."

Jagdish said nothing. He measured out the milk and moved on.

At noon the postman delivered an envelope. Ira's house number was correct, but the address read: "Barki Pokhar Lane."

Ira showed the envelope to her father, Devnarayan Jha.

Devnarayan Babu cleaned his spectacles and said, "The post office must have copied it from an old file."

"Was the old name Barki Pokhar Lane?"

Devnarayan Babu answered at once, "No. I remember no such name."

Her mother, Pushpa Devi, shook her head as well. Their neighbour Salma Khatoon said, "I have lived here for thirty years. I have never heard any name other than Neem Lane."

That evening Ira brought out a bundle of old electricity receipts. On a receipt from five years earlier, the address was clearly written: "Barki Pokhar Lane, House 17."

A receipt from three years earlier said the same.

So did a file from one year earlier.

After looking at the receipts, Devnarayan Babu said, "The municipal people must have kept printing the wrong name."

Ira asked, "The same wrong name for five years?"

No one answered.

That night Ira wrote in her notebook: "12 June. Today the name-board says Neem Lane. The old receipts say Barki Pokhar Lane. Everyone in the lane believes Neem Lane to be the old name."

Below it she had Devnarayan Babu, Pushpa Devi, and Salma Khatoon sign their names.

The next morning Ira stepped outside. The board read: "Kaner Path."

As soon as she read it, she thought quite naturally: yes, Kaner Path.

After walking two steps, she remembered the notebook from the previous night. She ran back inside.

She opened it. "Today the name-board says Neem Lane..."

Ira read "Neem Lane" twice. She understood the words, but they did not feel like the name of her own lane.

Devnarayan Babu recognized his signature. "Why did you make me write this?"

"Yesterday we all wrote down the name together."

"Neem Lane?" He laughed. "There is no lane by that name in this neighbourhood."

Ira took him to the name-board. "And this?"

"Kaner Path. That is the name of our lane."

Salma Khatoon said the same. She accepted yesterday's signature as her own, but not yesterday's name.

When Jagdish the milkman arrived, he called out from a distance, "It has changed again today!"

Ira caught hold of his arm. "Do you remember Neem Lane?"

"Neem Lane was yesterday. Before that it was Barki Pokhar. I leave the dairy at three every day; I read the name as I pass."

For the first time Ira listened carefully to someone who came from outside the lane.

From that day Ira began keeping a register of names. She wrote the date, the name on the board, and below it three things—the weather, the first sound heard in the lane, and the rust mark on the board.

13 June—Kaner Path.

14 June—Matikuan Lane.

15 June—Sonbarsa Way.

16 June—Champa Lane.

Every morning the residents spoke the new name as though it were the old one. Every evening they wrote down the previous name and signed beneath it. The next morning they recognized their signatures but refused to believe the name.

Ira made a test. She scratched a red mark on the back of the board.

In the morning the name had changed to “Harsingar Path,” but the red scratch was still there.

So no new board was being put up. The letters themselves were changing on the same sheet of tin.

Salma Khatoon said, “The painter must come at night.”

Ira asked, “Then why does none of us remember yesterday’s name?”

Salma Khatoon fell silent.

One night they tied a thick cloth over the board. Devnarayan Babu dripped wax onto the knot and pressed his seal into it.

In the morning the cloth was exactly as they had left it. The seal was unbroken.

They removed the cloth. The board read: “Kamla Path.”

Pushpa Devi said at once, “Why, that is its name.”

Ira asked, “The board was covered all night. How do you know the name?”

Pushpa Devi stood with her mouth open.

That day Jagdish the milkman recited the six earlier names. Everyone inside the lane looked at him as though he had spoken the names of six unknown places in a single breath.

The municipal office was informed. Three days later, a municipal surveyor named Nakul Mandal arrived.

Nakul carried a thick file and an old map. He read the board—“Kamla Path”—and opened the file.

“The official name is Barki Pokhar Lane. It has not changed for thirty-eight years.”

Devnarayan Babu said, “There is no place called Barki Pokhar Lane here.”

Nakul looked at him for a long time.

He went from house to house asking questions. Every resident gave the current name in one voice. No one could tell him the name from the day before.

Nakul read Ira’s register of names. “You wrote all this?”

“Yes. But even to me, when I read it, it looks like a list of different lanes.”

“Then why do you keep writing them down?”

Ira said, "Because the signatures are ours."

Nakul did not laugh. In his own notebook he wrote down the current name, photographed the board, and recorded the measurement of the red scratch.

He returned the next day. The board read: "Piyari Lane."

Nakul said at once, "Yesterday it was Kamla Path."

Everyone in the lane was silent.

On the third day it became "Bel Path." Without looking at his notebook, Nakul recited both yesterday's and the day before yesterday's names.

On the fourth day he tried to remove the board. The four screws turned, the sheet of tin came away, and a faded blue mark of the same shape remained on the wall.

Nakul took the board to the municipal office. The entrance to the lane was left bare.

In the morning, when the residents woke, they all said quite naturally, "There is a lot of sunshine in Madhukunj Lane today."

There was no name-board on the wall.

Jagdish the milkman arrived and stopped short. "Where is the name-board?"

Pushpa Devi said, "It has gone for repairs."

"And the name?"

"Madhukunj Lane."

Jagdish shook his head. "Yesterday it was Bel Path."

Pushpa Devi said, "Your memory is badly muddled."

That evening Nakul brought the board back. The tin now bore the municipal office seal. Even there, during the day, its lettering had changed to "Madhukunj Lane."

Nakul said, "I kept the board on my desk all day. Until noon it said Bel Path. When I looked at one o'clock, it said Madhukunj Lane. No one had touched it."

Ira asked, "Do you remember Bel Path?"

"I remember."

"Why?"

Nakul gave no answer.

That night Nakul decided to stay in the lane and watch until dawn. A mat was spread for him in the vacant upstairs room of Salma Khatoon's house.

Until eleven at night Nakul sat on a chair facing the board. Ira, too, stood there for a while with her notebook.

The board read: "Madhukunj Lane."

At midnight it was the same. At one it was the same. At two, Nakul told Ira to go inside and sleep.

"Will you stay awake?"

"Yes."

At five in the morning Ira came outside. Nakul was sitting in the chair, his eyes red. The board read: "Sheetal Lane."

Ira asked, "When did it change?"

Nakul looked at the board. "What changed?"

The notebook in Ira's hand suddenly felt heavy.

"What was the name yesterday?"

Nakul narrowed his eyes and thought. "Sheetal Lane... the name is Sheetal Lane."

Ira opened his notebook. Four days of names, times, photograph numbers, and measurements of the red scratch—all in Nakul's handwriting.

Nakul read each line. His face slowly drained of colour.

"This is my handwriting."

"Yes."

"Bel Path..." He read the words, then shook his head. "Where is that?"

Ira said, "Until yesterday, you knew."

Nakul stood holding the veranda pillar. The first smoke from cooking fires was rising in the lane.

That day one of Nakul's colleagues came from the municipal office. Nakul could not tell him yesterday's name, but he showed him his file.

The colleague asked, "You spent a night here?"

Nakul silently nodded.

From that day a note was added to the municipal file: "Verify addresses by house number and municipal block; the lane name has been observed to be variable."

The residents did not stop preserving the names, but they changed how they used them.

At Ira's suggestion a second, smaller board was fixed below the name-board: "Municipal Block 12 · House Nos. 1-36."

The small board did not change the next day.

It did not change the day after that either.

The postman now looked at the house numbers. Jagdish the milkman read the name and smiled, but did not argue.

Ira continued writing in the register of names. The only difference was that beside each name she now made a small sketch—the awning of

the betel shop, the crack in the red wall, the handle of the public tap, the grille of her own house.

The names kept changing. The things in the place slowly grew old.

One morning the board read: "Chandni Lane." Nakul, who had by then rented Salma Khatoon's upstairs room for a month or two, came outside.

He looked at Ira's register. On the previous page was written "Sheetal Lane," beneath his own signature.

Nakul said, "Where is this Sheetal Lane?"

Ira placed a finger on the page. "The record says—it was here yesterday."

For a while both of them kept looking toward the mouth of the lane.

On the blue board, "Chandni Lane" gleamed. Directly beneath it, the small permanent board carried only numbers.

Jagdish the milkman stopped his bicycle and asked, "A new name again today?"

Nakul opened his mouth to answer, then looked at the register.

Ira said nothing.

Jagdish pedalled on. The blue board shone in the sunlight. When the wind blew, its rusted corner trembled lightly, but the smaller board beneath it—"Municipal Block 12 · House Nos. 1-36"—remained exactly as it was. On the open page of Ira's register, yesterday's name was written clearly, but she could no longer remember the sound of it.

An Extra Window

The talk of selling the house began inside it, but the first trouble appeared on the outer wall.

Vaidehi and Neelabh's house in Allalpatti, Darbhanga, was not very large. Seen from the front, three windows were clearly visible—the sitting-room window on the left, the small room's in the middle, and the kitchen window on the right. The woodwork of all three had been replaced in the same year, and all three bore the same shade of green.

Neelabh had retired from his job. Vaidehi's knees could no longer manage the stairs to the upper floor. Their son Nachiketa lived in Bengaluru and their daughter Aparna in Madhubani. After much thought, the two had decided to sell this house and buy a smaller, single-storey one.

The broker, Rakesh, came for the first time on Tuesday afternoon. He went from room to room, wrote down measurements, turned on the taps, counted the cracks in the roof, and at last crossed the road to take a photograph of the front.

"This front photograph is what everyone will see first," he said. "The house looks good."

Vaidehi laughed. "Don't erase the stain on the wall."

"No, no. It will stay as it is."

That evening Rakesh sent a draft of the sale listing to Vaidehi's phone. Vaidehi first read the price, then the number of rooms, then looked at the photograph of the front.

Her finger stopped on the photograph.

"Neelabh, how are there four windows here?"

Neelabh put on his glasses. There really were four: four identical green windows from left to right, all spaced at almost equal intervals.

He went outside and counted the windows on the wall. Three. He came back in and looked again at the windows of all three rooms. Three.

Rakesh was called.

"Did you make any changes?" Neelabh asked.

"Only brightened it a little, that's all. Why would I add a window?"

"There are four in the photograph."

There was silence for a few moments. Then Rakesh laughed. "Phone cameras sometimes make mistakes when they stitch a wide photograph together. I'll take it again tomorrow."

The next day Rakesh came with an ordinary camera. This time Vaidehi stood in front and watched. He took the photograph with all three windows in view. On the camera screen, the image that appeared at once showed three.

"See?" Rakesh said.

He uploaded that same image to the sale page that evening. Five minutes later Vaidehi opened it and looked—four windows.

This time Neelabh did not laugh.

Rakesh sent the original photograph again. The original had three. The image on the sale page had four.

"It must be some sort of glitch," Neelabh said, but there was little confidence in his voice.

Aparna came on her day off. She opened the two images separately and studied them for a long time.

"It hasn't merely added one new window," she said.

"Then what?"

Aparna brought a ruler. She measured the width of the house on the screen. In the original photograph with three windows, the spaces between the windows were wider. In the four-window image, the entire wall was exactly as wide, but the gaps between all four windows had somehow narrowed on their own.

In other words, the fourth window had not been inserted into one fixed empty patch of wall. The whole front wall had rearranged itself in the photograph.

"So there is no need to look for a fourth room inside," Aparna said. "None of the window positions here exactly matches its real position."

This did not reassure Vaidehi.

That night she opened and shut the shutters of all three windows from inside. The sitting-room window opened. The small room's opened. The kitchen window opened. There was no fourth.

The next day Rakesh took down the sale page.

Neelabh opened the saved image from that sale page again. It now showed three windows.

They looked at one another.

"Put it up again," Aparna said.

Rakesh made the sale page again. He entered the price, wrote the address, and selected the original photograph of the front.

The moment the page went public, there were four windows.

This time Rakesh did not laugh on the phone.

Over the next two days, they began testing it. The same original photograph was sent to a private family group—three. Neelabh sent it to an old friend with the words “our house”—three. Rakesh attached the same image to his office’s sales listing—four.

Aparna had the image printed. On paper there were three windows.

Under the image, in red ink, she wrote only: “For sale · Price 58 lakh.”

Nothing happened. It remained three.

“Paper doesn’t understand what is written on it,” Neelabh said.

Rakesh had the image and the price printed together on a one-page sales brochure. There were four windows on it.

Vaidehi took the brochure in her hand and went outside. Three on the actual house. Four on the paper. The afternoon sun fell on both at the same angle.

“Buyers will see this and ask questions,” she said.

The question came on the third day. A family from Samastipur came to see the house. The man stood in front with the brochure in his hand.

“Which room is the fourth window for?”

Rakesh looked at Vaidehi for a moment.

Neelabh said, “The house has only three windows.”

The man looked again at the brochure, then at the house. “There are four in the photograph.”

“Yes.”

“Then the photograph is wrong?”

Before Neelabh could answer, Vaidehi said, “The sale photograph is wrong. The house isn’t.”

The family walked through the house, but their attention stayed on the windows more than on the rooms. When they had left, Rakesh said quietly, “Selling it this way will be difficult.”

Neelabh grew irritated. “I can’t add a window just to make the photograph correct.”

Rakesh said, “Shall I remove the front image?”

They removed it. Only the rooms inside, the courtyard, the kitchen and the roof remained.

The sale page looked normal.

But two days later a buyer asked, “Why is there no photograph of the front?”

Rakesh lied. “The lane is too narrow to get the whole house into the camera.”

The lie bothered Vaidehi.

“Why hide something just because we don’t understand it?” she said.

In a tired voice Rakesh said, “Not every mystery is written into a property listing.”

“This isn’t a mystery. It’s four windows.”

Aparna suggested tying different-coloured cloths to the three real windows and taking another photograph.

A red strip on the sitting-room window, yellow on the middle one, blue on the kitchen window.

In the private photograph: red, yellow, blue—three windows.

Rakesh uploaded that same image to the sale page.

Four windows. Red. Yellow. No strip. Blue.

The fourth window stood in the middle, but the wall of the house had not grown to make room for it. The other three windows had shifted slightly.

“At least now it’s clear that the fourth isn’t real,” Aparna said.

Rakesh shook his head. “Are we going to tell buyers this?”

“We’ll tell them the truth,” Vaidehi said.

The next buyer was a retired school headmaster. He looked at the brochure with four windows, counted three on the house, and then listened to the story of the coloured-strip test.

He stood outside for a long time.

“Are the house papers in order?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“The measurements?”

“They match.”

“The wall?”

“Three windows.”

The headmaster looked again at the brochure. “Then I’m buying the house, not the photograph.”

For the first time that day, Rakesh’s face relaxed.

Bargaining began, but the sale was not settled at once. Verification of the house papers, municipal tax, the old map, the lending institution’s valuation—all proceeded in their own order.

When the lending institution’s valuer came, he too saw the sale photograph of the front.

“Four?”

Aparna burst out laughing. “Count them yourself.”

He counted three. He measured. In his report he wrote: “Actual front windows: 3. Visual discrepancy in promotional image.”

“Have you ever written a sentence like that before?” Vaidehi asked.

He said, "No. But I write what the measurements show."

The day of the sale drew near. The house slowly began to empty. The sitting-room cupboard was taken away. The bed in the small room was dismantled. The brass utensils from the kitchen went into boxes.

The strange thing was that as the house emptied, the number of windows did not change. There were still three.

In the final week Rakesh asked for a new photograph. "The house is clean now. We'll keep this image with the papers."

Vaidehi said, "Take it."

Rakesh crossed the road. Vaidehi, Neelabh and Aparna stood on the veranda. The camera was raised.

At that moment there were three windows on the house.

There were three on the camera screen as well.

Rakesh sent the image to Neelabh. Three.

Then he added the price and the words "Agreement Finalised" to the final sale page and attached the same image.

Four.

This time there was no strip on the fourth window. The strips had already been removed from the three real windows, but the green shutters of the fourth looked so fresh that they seemed to have been painted only yesterday.

Aparna stared at the image for a long time. "This window doesn't belong to any room," she said softly.

"Then whose is it?" Vaidehi asked.

Aparna did not answer.

On the day of the sale registration, the headmaster came with his wife. The papers were signed. The keys were counted—the main gate, the back door, the roof, the cupboard. There was no key for any window.

Before handing over the house, Vaidehi walked through it once more. She opened all three windows. Air from outside came in. Then she shut them one by one.

She stepped outside. The headmaster's wife was standing on the veranda.

"I want to ask you something," she said. "Was that story about the fourth window true?"

Vaidehi smiled. "It was true in the photograph."

"In the house?"

"Three in the house."

For a few moments the two women stood looking at the front wall.

The day after the registration, Rakesh closed the sale page.

Out of curiosity, Aparna opened the saved copy of the old sale page. The image now showed three windows.

She called Rakesh at once.

“Look at the old brochure.”

Rakesh took the sales brochure from an office drawer. The four windows were still there, exactly as before.

Three on the web page, four in the printed sales brochure.

“Has the rule changed?” Rakesh asked.

Aparna said, “The house isn’t for sale anymore.”

Her voice sounded like a question, not an answer.

Three weeks later the headmaster’s wife sent Vaidehi a photograph. The whole family stood in front of their new house—flowerpots on the veranda, a ball by the gate, pale curtains at the windows.

Three windows.

Vaidehi sent the image to Aparna.

Aparna had a print made of it. She placed it beside the old sales brochure’s image with four windows.

In both images, the wall was exactly as wide. The crack in the eaves was in the same place. The bend in the drainpipe was in the same place.

Three windows in one. Four in the other.

Aparna left a blank strip of paper between the two images. She wrote nothing on that empty strip.

Outside, Vaidehi’s new little house had two windows. They remained open all afternoon.

The Room of Voices

The front room of the old house in Laheriasarai had stood completely empty for three days.

Bipin Babu had lived there before as a tenant. His iron cot, two chairs, a trunk, a clothesline, and the little stove kept in one corner had filled the room so completely that the true colour of the walls could hardly be seen. When Bipin Babu moved to Samastipur, Raghunath Jha had the room cleared and whitewashed, and said they should let the air into it for a few days before looking for a new tenant.

On the first night, Kamla Devi was folding up the bedding on the veranda. The inner door stood open. No electric light was burning in the empty room, but the yellow glow from the street fell inside through the bars of the window.

Just then a woman's voice came from inside the room, very clear, as though someone were standing close to the wall and saying, "No more than ten children will sit here."

The sheet in Kamla Devi's hands went still.

At once another, younger voice said, "Put the table near the window. The afternoon light will fall nicely there."

Then came a little laughter, very faint. After that, silence.

Kamla Devi went to the door. The room was empty. The smell of fresh lime. A fine layer of dust. The window was shut. There was no crack in the rear wall.

She called Raghunath Jha. At that moment he was turning off the tap in the courtyard.

"Someone spoke in the room."

"Who?"

"A woman. Then some girl."

Raghunath went inside. He inspected all four corners. He opened the window and looked out. The tea stall across the road had already closed. The roof of the neighbouring house was empty.

"The sound must have come round from outside," he said.

Kamla Devi did not answer. She remembered the direction of the voice clearly: not from the street, but from the very place where Bipin Babu's cot had stood.

On the second night, Raghunath Jha deliberately remained seated on the veranda. Kamla Devi was in the kitchen inside. Their daughter Meenakshi was reading in her room.

At around half past ten, the voice came again. This time it was a man's: "If I pay before the fifth of every month, that will be all right."

Raghunath rose and went to the doorway. The voice did not stop.

A woman said, "Look at the room first. We will discuss the money afterwards."

Raghunath stepped inside.

At that very instant all the voices were cut off. They did not fade away gradually; it was as though a cord had been snipped with scissors.

He stepped back and returned to the veranda. Ten or fifteen moments later, the same woman's voice came again: "We won't hang a clock on the wall. The ticking will echo too much here."

A shiver ran down Raghunath's back.

He called Kamla Devi. The two of them stood outside the doorway. No one was inside. Yet now and then short fragments of conversation kept coming: sometimes a child's laughter, sometimes a sound like a chair being dragged, sometimes a woman saying, "Open the page."

Meenakshi came as well. She listened carefully.

"I can't hear anything," she said.

At that very moment, both Kamla Devi and Raghunath heard a child's voice say, "Give me the red pencil."

Meenakshi said again, "Nothing at all."

The three of them stood silently for a while.

Raghunath brought an old bamboo stool and placed it in the middle of the room.

No more voices came that night.

In the morning the stool was taken outside. Nothing happened until afternoon. As soon as evening fell, two unknown voices came again.

Kamla Devi put the stool back inside. The voices stopped. She took it out. After some time, the voices returned.

"It speaks only when it is empty," Meenakshi said.

Raghunath looked at her. "But you cannot even hear it."

"You two say you can. And the moment the stool is put in, both of you fall silent."

Meenakshi laughed, but there was less mockery than curiosity in her laughter.

From that day, the three of them told no one about the room. Raghunath made a small ledger. Whenever a sentence was clearly audible, he wrote it down, adding the time beside the date.

In the first three days, twelve fragments were recorded: "No more than ten children will sit here." "Put the table near the window." "I will pay before the fifth of every month." "We won't hang a clock on the wall." "Give me the red pencil." "Open the window; the dust is flying."

Meenakshi said, "These must be conversations that happened here before. The sounds have somehow got trapped in the walls."

Kamla Devi objected at once. "Bipin Babu never taught children. Where would a red pencil come into it?"

Raghunath said, "And if these are old voices, why did we never hear them before?"

The question remained.

On the fourth afternoon, a young woman named Supriya Karn came to see the room. She taught at a nearby school and was thinking of teaching eight or ten children separately in the evenings somewhere outside her home.

Meenakshi had gone to the market at the time. Kamla Devi and Raghunath showed Supriya the room.

Supriya stood at the doorway and looked inside. She measured the window. She examined the width of the wall. Then she said -

Her lips moved. No sound came.

Kamla Devi looked at Raghunath.

At the same instant, both understood where the silence had fallen. From the movement of her lips, they could recognise the sentence: No more than ten children will sit here.

Without pausing, Supriya spoke a second sentence, this time clearly audible: "With ten, there will still be enough air and space."

Raghunath's palm turned cold.

Supriya did not seem to notice that her voice had vanished. She continued measuring the room as naturally as before.

Kamla Devi asked softly, "That first thing you just said...?"

"No more than ten children will sit here?" Supriya repeated casually. This time the sentence was perfectly clear.

Kamla Devi gripped the back of a chair.

When Meenakshi returned in the evening and heard what had happened, she laughed at first. Then she looked at the first sentence in the ledger.

"So you two had heard this sentence four days ago. Today, when Supriya Didi actually said it, you two couldn't hear it. I wasn't even there then."

"Yes."

"If I had been there, perhaps I would have heard it."

Raghunath closed the ledger. This was no longer a matter of old voices.

That night Meenakshi insisted that they listen separately once. It was the only way to understand the rule.

Kamla Devi did not agree. "It isn't right to sit listening for something from someone's future."

Meenakshi said, "We don't even fully know yet whether it is from the future."

At last Raghunath sat alone on the veranda. The stool was outside. Kamla Devi and Meenakshi stayed in the inner courtyard.

Half an hour later, Supriya's voice came from inside the room: "Not this yellow curtain. Put up a white one."

Raghunath wrote it in the ledger. No one else heard the sentence.

Six days later, Supriya decided to take the room. While choosing curtains, Kamla Devi, Meenakshi, and Raghunath were all present. Supriya looked at two pieces of cloth and said -

For Raghunath, there was again a moment of silence.

Kamla Devi answered at once, "If you put up a white one, the room will feel more open."

Meenakshi heard it too. Only Raghunath did not.

Raghunath understood. The sentence he had heard in advance had already given him its sound; when that future moment arrived, there was none left for him to hear. Everyone else could still hear it.

That night the three of them discussed it for a long time.

Meenakshi said, "The room isn't playing voices from the future. It gives our ears their share of those voices in advance."

Kamla Devi said, "Then hearing them beforehand is not a gain but a loss. When the real moment comes later, you will not hear that part of it."

Raghunath opened the ledger. He looked at the twelve sentences. Suddenly he understood: whenever those sentences were spoken in the future, small gaps would open in what he and Kamla Devi heard.

The next day he placed the stool permanently in the middle of the room.

Supriya settled the rent. The question of paying before the fifth of every month came up. The sentence returned - and for Kamla Devi and Raghunath, silence fell in the middle. Meenakshi heard it normally.

"Enough now," Kamla Devi said. "What we have already heard is more than enough."

Two days later, Supriya moved in her things: one table, ten small stools, two bookracks, and a white curtain. The room was no longer empty. The voices stopped.

During the first month, five sentences from the ledger appeared one by one in real conversations. For whichever listener had heard a sentence at night, that sentence fell silent for that person when its later moment arrived. Everyone else heard it normally.

At first Raghunath was alarmed each time. Later he began to recognise those small patches of silence. Supriya would go on speaking, and for half a moment her lips would move without sound for Raghunath; then the next words would become clear again.

It felt as though the future had already cut a small notch out of his hearing.

A month passed. Supriya's classes continued. The room filled with children's voices, the rustle of turning pages, questions, laughter, and sometimes quarrels. It had become an ordinary room now.

Kamla Devi put the ledger away in the cupboard.

A year later, Supriya was given more evening work at the school. She decided to close the tuition class. Her things were removed. The white curtain came down. The table, stools, and racks all went out.

The room was empty again.

That evening Raghunath reached the doorway, but the moment the first whisper rose from inside, he covered his ears and stepped back.

Kamla Devi immediately placed the old stool in the middle. The voice stopped.

"Not this time," she said.

Meenakshi smiled. "Now we understand the rule."

Raghunath did not take out the ledger.

For several days the room remained empty, but silent because of the stool. No one sat on it. It was like a small guard: it stopped neither future nor present, only the exchange of sound between the two.

One day one leg of the stool cracked. It was sent to the carpenter. Kamla Devi went to the market. Meenakshi was at school. Raghunath was alone at home.

At noon, the room became completely empty again.

Raghunath was crossing the veranda when an unfamiliar child's voice came from inside: "Ma, here..."

He stopped.

Before he could hear the rest of the sentence, Raghunath took two steps back and went towards the courtyard. He was curious, but by now he knew something that mattered more than curiosity: whatever sentence

he heard today, his ears would not receive that part again when its real moment came tomorrow.

He picked up an empty earthen water pitcher from inside the house and placed it in the middle of the room.

The voice stopped.

That evening, when Kamla Devi returned, Raghunath told her about the child's half-sentence.

"Whose child?"

"I don't know."

Kamla Devi looked at the pitcher. "Perhaps the next tenant's."

Raghunath said, "Perhaps someone who will live here after us."

At that sentence, both fell silent. For the first time it occurred to them that the room's future stretched far beyond the house's present owners.

Two months later, Raghunath and Kamla Devi decided to sell the house. They were growing older, its upkeep was becoming difficult, and Meenakshi had found a smaller house near the school.

The buyers were Arun Mishra, his wife Vibha, and their eight-year-old daughter Nupur.

On the day they came to see the house, the pitcher stood in the middle of the room. Nupur went inside and spun around. "Will you give me this room?" she asked.

Vibha laughed. "Let us buy the house first."

The unfinished voice from that afternoon flashed through Raghunath's mind: "Ma, here..."

He did not wait for Nupur's next sentence. He changed the subject.

The house was sold. Their belongings were moved out little by little. On the last day, the cupboard, cot, utensils, ledger, everything went. Only the earthen pitcher remained in the front room.

Just before handing over the keys, Kamla Devi asked, "Shall we take the pitcher or leave it?"

Raghunath thought for a moment. "Take it. We should leave the house empty."

He picked up the pitcher.

The room became completely empty.

At once the air inside seemed to tremble lightly. Raghunath was near the doorway. An unfamiliar woman's voice rose: "Put the table here..."

Raghunath stepped away from the door without hearing the rest.

He crossed the veranda and reached the gate, where Arun Mishra's family was arriving to take the keys. Nupur came running in front.

"My room!" she cried, and ran inside.

Kamla Devi looked at Raghunath. "Did a voice come?"

Raghunath nodded. "Half of one."

"The rest?"

"I didn't listen."

Nupur said something from inside. Kamla Devi heard it clearly. Raghunath heard it too, because this was a sentence he had not heard beforehand.

"Ma, what you say here echoes a lot."

That unfinished "Ma, here..." from the afternoon rose again in Raghunath's mind. He understood that if he had heard the whole sentence then, part of this child's voice would have been silent for him now.

He placed the gate key in Arun Mishra's hand.

The room behind them was no longer empty. Nupur was running about inside, Vibha was opening the window, and Arun was measuring the wall.

The voices were arriving at their proper time.

Raghunath stepped out onto the road. There was no future in his ears, only the whole conversation of the present.

Bus Number Zero

It was a quarter to midnight. The iron gate of the old bus stand had already been lowered halfway, the tea seller was turning his glass tumblers upside down and putting them into a tin box, and five or seven people were still waiting beneath the veranda for their respective rides.

Ishani Mishra had a cloth bag, a small case, and a brown file folder in her hands. All day she had been handing over the school's old accounts. Today was the last day of her temporary appointment; she had also vacated her rented room that evening.

The question was only where she should go now, at this hour of the night. But it was not a small question.

For three days her mother had been saying, "The work is over. Come home now." Her colleague Kusum had said, "Stay with me until your next appointment." And in Ishani's bag lay an appointment letter from a new school in Purnea, to which she had to reply by the day after tomorrow.

If she went home, her mother would take it to mean that all these wandering jobs were over now. If she went to Kusum's, the possibility of accepting the next appointment would remain open. If she went to the railway station, she could catch the morning train and postpone the decision for a while.

She knew the roads to all three places. It was the destination that was not one.

The clock at the stand showed 11:47. The last regular bus had left ten minutes earlier. The rickshaws were beginning to thin out.

Just then an old yellow-and-green bus came out of the dark end of the road and stopped. Where its route number should have been, a single black digit appeared on a white rectangular plate: "0".

The sound of the engine was ordinary. There was mud on the wheels. Drops from the previous day's rain had dried on the windscreen. Only the number was unusual.

An elderly man standing beneath the veranda stepped forward first. The conductor opened the rear door.

"Where to?" the conductor asked.

"Laheriasarai Chowk."

The conductor shook his head. "Not this bus."

The old man grew irritated. "Then what is the point of writing zero?"

The conductor pulled the door shut. "Your destination is already decided."

The bus moved a few feet forward and stopped again. This time two college students came running. The first said, "Railway station." The second said, "Donar." Neither was allowed to board.

Ishani kept watching this oddity. It seemed to her some complicated rule of a private bus.

The conductor looked at her. "You?"

Ishani opened her mouth. "I..."

She could have said Laheriasarai. She could have said the railway station. She could have named Kusum's neighbourhood. No word came out.

The conductor asked again, "Where to?"

Ishani said softly, "I don't know yet."

The door opened all the way. "Get on."

There were eleven people inside the bus. No row of seats was full, yet everyone sat in a different row, as though even one another's uncertainty required distance.

Ishani sat by a window. The conductor tore off a small paper ticket and gave it to her. It bore the boarding time, 11:51, and the words "Old Bus Stand." The space for the destination was blank.

"The fare?" Ishani asked.

"When you get off."

"How much?"

"Not how far. How long."

Ishani did not understand. The conductor moved on.

The bus started. The first turn was familiar: the chemist's shop, the closed sweet shop, the peepal tree beside the pond. The second turn was familiar too. Nowhere had the city changed.

There was no route list on the wall inside the bus. A small clock above the driver's head showed 11:55.

Opposite Ishani, a thin young man held a small iron box on his knees. He kept opening and closing his ticket.

"Is the destination blank on your ticket too?" Ishani asked.

The young man smiled. "Everyone's is, on this bus."

"Where are you going?"

The young man looked out of the window. "If I knew, it wouldn't let me board."

His name was Neeraj. The printing press where he had worked for three months had shut down that day. The owner had told him not to come from tomorrow. Neeraj was two months behind on the rent for his room. He had not found the courage to tell his family.

“Have you ridden this bus before?” Ishani asked.

“Once.”

“Then where did you get off?”

Neeraj was about to answer when the conductor called from behind, “That is not spoken of on this bus.”

Neeraj laughed, but did not answer.

At the next stop three people signalled the bus. The conductor got down and asked each the same question. One woman said, “Sadar Hospital.” A young man said, “Kadirabad.” Neither was allowed to board. The third, an elderly woman, remained silent for a long time.

“Where to?”

The old woman tightened her grip on her bundle. “Far from here.”

The conductor let her board.

The bus moved on again.

Ishani noticed that the bus was following no fixed route, but neither was it taking any impossible road. Sometimes it left the main road through a narrow lane; sometimes it returned to the same road from another end.

Neeraj said, “Have you understood one thing?”

“What?”

“This bus does not take you anywhere.”

Ishani looked at him.

“The first time, I thought that if someone didn’t know where to go, the bus would find the place for them. But it isn’t like that.”

“Then?”

Neeraj fell silent before answering. Perhaps because of the rule that one could not speak of a previous journey on this bus, or perhaps because he did not fully understand it himself.

A man sitting at the back suddenly called the conductor. “I’ve decided.”

Several heads inside the bus turned toward him.

“Where to?” the conductor asked.

“My maternal uncle’s house. Belwaganj.”

The conductor pulled the bell cord once. The bus stopped at the next ordinary stop. A sign outside read, “Municipal Library Turn.” Belwaganj was about three kos from there.

The man stared in surprise. "Here? I said Belwaganj."

"Now you know your destination," the conductor said. "The rest of the journey is yours."

"The fare?"

The conductor looked at his ticket. "Four rupees."

The man got off. The bus had not taken him to Belwaganj. It had merely put him off the bus.

For the first time, a line of the bus's rule took shape in Ishani's mind. As long as there was no answer, the bus would keep moving. The moment an answer was found, the journey ended, however far away that answer might be.

The elderly woman sat silently with her bundle in her lap. After a while she spoke on her own. "I'll go to my sister."

"Where to?" the conductor asked.

"Mirzapur, behind the Durga temple."

The next stop was the milk market. The old woman got off without protest. The moment she stepped down, her gait seemed quicker than before.

There were now nine people inside the bus.

Midnight had passed. The city's shops were dark, but a few cooking fires, chemist's shops, and watchmen's lanterns were still awake. The bus number "o" appeared reversed on the inside of the glass.

Ishani opened her file. In red ink at the top of the Purnea appointment letter were the words: "Acceptance due by the day after tomorrow." She closed the paper again.

An old letter from her mother was in the bag: "This time come home on a long leave." On a small slip Kusum had given her were the name of her lane and the watchman's name.

The three papers seemed like three separate stops.

Neeraj asked, "Is any name coming to your mind?"

"Three."

"Then it is difficult."

"And yours?"

Neeraj ran his palm over the iron box. "There were two. Now only one is left, but I don't have the courage to say it."

"Why?"

"If I say it, the bus will put me off."

Ishani asked with a smile, "Is staying inside the bus so pleasant?"

Neeraj looked into the darkness outside. "No. But the moment I step outside, the answer will become true."

The sentence stayed in Ishani's mind.

Over the next half hour three passengers got off. One student said, "My uncle's house"; a seamstress said, "To the superintendent of the women's hostel"; an elderly man said, "The railway-station waiting room." The bus did not leave any of them at those places. It put each of them off at the next stop.

There was no happiness on anyone's face. But as they got off, every hand seemed to hold its ticket less tightly.

Ishani noticed something new. When a passenger named a destination, the conductor wrote nothing in the blank space on the ticket. The blank remained blank.

"Then why is this blank space here?" Ishani asked.

"To remain blank," the conductor said.

"Even after the destination is found?"

"The ticket proves that you boarded the bus, not that you arrived."

After hearing this, Ishani thought the man seemed less like a bus conductor and more like a clerk in some old office. Yet there was nothing mysterious in his expression. In an ordinary way he kept counting coins, pulling the bell, and opening and closing the door.

At twenty-five past one the bus crossed the river bridge. Ishani realised that this route led neither toward home, nor toward Kusum's, nor toward the railway station.

"Where are you taking us around?" a young man who had just boarded asked irritably.

The conductor asked as before, "Where do you want to go?"

"That is what I'm asking you," the young man said.

"Then sit down."

The young man sat.

After a while he began listing many places: "Not home, not the office, not my uncle's, not the railway station..."

The conductor did not stop him.

Ishani understood: this bus was not affected by "where not." It wanted only "where."

At two o'clock Neeraj suddenly lifted his box.

"I'm ready," he said.

The conductor came over to him.

Neeraj took a deep breath. "I'll go to Madhubani. To my younger uncle's printing press. Tomorrow morning I'll stand before him."

The bell rang. The next stop was the old post office.

Before getting off, Neeraj showed Ishani his iron box. "The first time, I got off leaving this box behind. When I tried to board again, the bus would not take me, because I already knew where I had to go to pick up the box. This time the box is with me."

Ishani did not fully understand the rule, but she understood this much: the bus carried a person only as far as the decision, not through its consequences.

Neeraj got off. He still had to find transport to Madhubani at dawn.

There were now five passengers left on the bus, including Ishani.

The silence of the night deepened. The driver coughed once, and the conductor sat on the front seat counting the tickets. The air flowing through the windows grew cold.

Ishani counted her three options again. Home. Kusum. Railway station.

The railway station was not really a destination; it was a place for postponement. This was clear to her now.

Home was a destination, but once she reached it she would have to say the first sentence: "I'll give my answer about going to Purnea the day after tomorrow." Her mother might fall silent.

Kusum's house was also a destination, but going there would be almost the same as having made the decision already.

The bus passed a closed cinema hall. An old poster on the wall was torn. Ishani remembered the empty classroom at the school: today, for the last time, she had straightened the chairs before walking out and had left the key on the headmaster's desk.

At that moment she understood for the first time that the real question was not "Where will I stay?" but "Where will I say tomorrow's first sentence?"

She called the conductor.

"Where to?"

Before answering, Ishani looked out of the window. The bus was not on an unfamiliar road; it was near the same old oil depot from where one could also get the morning bus toward home.

"Home," she said. Then immediately added, "Piprahi, beside the Madhubani road. But when I reach at dawn, the first thing I'll tell Ma is that I will accept the Purnea appointment."

Whether the conductor heard only the first word or the whole sentence, Ishani could not tell. The bell rang.

The next stop was "Kachahari Turn." Piprahi was very far from there.

"Do I get off here?" Ishani asked.

"Now you know your destination."

“But the bus home comes in the morning...”

“Then wait until morning.”

The conductor took the ticket and said five rupees. Ishani gave him the coins. She asked for the ticket back.

The conductor showed no surprise. “Keep it.”

Ishani got down. The road was deserted. The court gate was closed, and the shutters of the paan shop were down. In the distance a tea seller was arranging coal for the dawn fire.

The bus moved off. Ishani turned to look back. The number “o” was clear in the dim yellow light.

The bus had reached the next turn when a young man by the roadside raised his hand. The bus stopped.

The conductor got down and asked the same question: “Where to?”

The young man remained silent for a long time. Ishani was too far away to hear his answer. But the door opened.

The young man got on.

The bus moved again.

The ticket in Ishani’s hand was still blank. Apart from the boarding time and the words “Old Bus Stand,” the destination box remained empty. She no longer felt any wish to fill that empty space.

There was still an hour and a half before the first ordinary bus arrived at Kachahari Turn. Ishani sat down on her case.

The first milkman’s bicycle passed along the road. A little later came a bundle of newspapers. The city began waking again into its everyday route numbers, stops, and fixed places.

Ishani took the Purnea appointment letter out of her bag. She placed the paper for her reply on top of it. She did not write yet.

First she had to reach home. First she had to say the first sentence. Then she would write.

Far, very far away, from behind some turn, the engine of Bus Number Zero was heard once more—or perhaps it was only the sound of the first freight vehicle of the morning. Ishani could not be certain.

A Rain of Paper

It was the first thunder-laden day of Ashadh. By afternoon the sky had closed in so heavily that the shopkeepers of Laheriasarai lowered their awnings halfway. People thought—this time the rain would come properly.

The first thing to strike the tin roof of Vibha Chaudhary's printing press was not a raindrop.

There was a rustle. Then another. Then a sound as though a swarm of dry leaves were falling on the roof.

Vibha came outside. The sky was grey, the air heavy. But not a drop of rain lay in the lane. Instead, white, yellowish, blue sheets of paper—some thick, some very thin—were wheeling and drifting down.

Some papers caught on roofs, some on electric wires, some over the drains, some on people's heads. One sheet landed on Vibha's shoulder.

She picked it up and looked. In the middle of the page only one line was written—

“The wedding procession will leave at seven in the evening.”

Vibha stared at the line for a long time.

That morning the proof of Shyamsundar Jha's daughter's wedding invitation had come to this very press. The first draft had said “seven in the evening.” Shyamsundar himself had struck it out in red ink and written “half past five,” because the time had been brought forward after seeing the rain and the condition of the roads.

There was no trace of seven o'clock in the final invitation.

“How can this be?” the pressman Nandu asked.

Vibha turned the paper over. There was nothing on the back. No printer's mark, no paper merchant's stamp. The handwriting was not Shyamsundar's, but the sentence was exactly the line that had been struck out.

The commotion in the lane grew.

Bhola, the paan seller, came running with a sheet in his hand. On his page was written: “Ramnath's account—three hundred and twenty.”

“I struck out three hundred and twenty and wrote two hundred and eighty,” he said. “Yesterday I made a mistake while adding up the oil account.”

Two children ran over from the school opposite. On one sheet was written: "The Ganga flows westward." Laughing, one child said, "I made a mistake. Teacher crossed it out and wrote east."

Within ten minutes the lane was covered with sentences that were no longer anyone's present truth, but each of them had at some time been written.

The rain of paper lasted half an hour. No water fell. When the clouds cleared, sunlight came out, and people took brooms to their roofs, courtyards and drains.

Vibha set five sheets aside.

The next day the clouds came again.

This time people were waiting in advance. Some children climbed onto roofs with baskets. A few old men carried cots into the lane and sat there. When the first sheet fell, everyone ran towards it.

This time Vibha had decided to test it.

In the morning she had written on a blank sheet: "The printing press will remain closed for seven days from tomorrow." Beneath it she drew a thick line through the entire sentence. Then she wrote: "The printing press will open at its usual hours."

At two o'clock the clouds closed in.

At twenty-seven minutes past two, Nandu picked up a sheet from beside the roof and brought it in.

It said: "The printing press will remain closed for seven days from tomorrow."

Not the final sentence. Only the one that had been crossed out.

"So the sky reads proofs?" Nandu asked, half laughing.

Vibha did not answer. She made another test. This time she wrote on a page: "Nandu will eat five kilos of jalebi today." She left the page on the table without striking the sentence out.

By evening no such sheet had fallen.

Then Nandu himself wrote: "I am the owner of the printing press." He ran his pen over the line three times and crossed it out.

A little later came a rustle on the roof. A sheet fell: "I am the owner of the printing press."

Nandu became so solemn when he saw it that everyone burst out laughing.

For the first time the rule became clear: whatever was written and then struck out, the clouds preserved. The marks of cancellation vanished; only the sentence rained down.

By the third day the news had spread through the whole neighbourhood. On the fourth day reports began coming from other parts of the town as well.

Someone's old crossed-out account figure fell. Someone's wrong school answer. Someone's changed invitation date. Someone's cancelled price on a shop list. Half a sentence from someone's letter.

The greatest difficulty was that the sky did not say the sentence had been cancelled.

A sheet that fell to the ground looked cleanly written. No line through it, no "cancelled," no mark of correction.

On the fifth day the crisis reached the school.

In the first draft of the examination notice at the Town Girls' School, the mathematics examination had been written for the 18th. The headmistress crossed it out and changed it to the 19th. The final notice posted on the board showed the 19th. But in the evening paper-rain, sheets reading "Mathematics examination on the 18th" fell in the school field, the road, the tea shop, the hostel roof—everywhere.

The next day half the students sat convinced that the 18th was correct.

The headmistress came to the printing press.

"Did all this get out from your proofs?"

Vibha showed her the sheets she had collected over five days.

"There are lines here that were written in my press, but this paper is not mine. And three of the school sheets never came here at all. The clouds are not reading only my shop."

The municipal council held a meeting about it.

After the meeting a notice was issued: "Avoid unnecessary crossings-out on overcast days."

That sentence itself had been revised three times. The first draft said "during rain," then "during paper-rain," and finally "on overcast days."

That evening three versions of the notice rained over the town.

"Avoid unnecessary crossings-out during rain."

"Avoid unnecessary crossings-out during paper-rain."

And the final, correct notice remained posted on the municipal wall—the sky did not rain it down.

People laughed at the irony for two days, but the problem was not small.

Shopkeepers began to stop correcting accounts by striking figures out. Children began taking a new sheet instead of drawing a line through a mistake. In offices, clerks, afraid to cancel an old sentence, began tearing off the whole page and setting it aside.

But tearing off a page did not break the rule. If the sentence remained untouched on the torn page, the sky stayed silent. If a line had been drawn through the sentence, it rained down.

Instead of striking out words, people began circling them and writing “no” around them.

Two days later the clouds rained the entire line, “no” included.

Writing in the town gradually became inconvenient.

Vibha’s work at the printing press changed more than anyone’s. Proofreading meant finding an error, striking it out, changing it. Now clients said, “Leave the mistake, but don’t cross it out.”

Vibha would answer, “If we leave the mistake, then the printed thing itself will become wrong.”

On one wedding invitation, the groom’s father’s name had come out as “Jagdip” instead of “Jagdish.” The client said, “Leave it this time. Let his father’s name not rain from the clouds.”

Vibha lifted her red pen and crossed the name out.

“The name has to be corrected.”

That evening a dozen sheets bearing “Jagdip” fell over the neighbourhood. Jagdish Babu himself picked one up and laughed.

“That name belongs to the sky now,” he said. “As long as the wedding invitation has the right one.”

Not everyone took it so lightly.

On the sixth day one of Vibha’s own crossed-out sentences rained down.

At noon a sheet came to rest against the threshold of the press. Nandu picked it up. His face changed as soon as he read it.

The sheet said: “I am thinking of selling this printing press.”

Nandu said nothing. Vibha took the sheet from his hand.

That sentence had been written three months earlier. One night, after adding up the loan instalments, the repair of the printing machine, and the rising price of paper, Vibha had written it on the back of an account sheet. Ten minutes later she crossed it out. On the next line she had written: “I will not sell it; I will get rid of the small printing machine.”

The small printing machine really had been sold. The press had not.

But the sky did not rain down the final decision.

Nandu asked quietly, “Then this...?”

“It was considered. It was not decided.”

“But on the sheet it reads as if, even now...”

“That is why it was crossed out.”

That day, for the first time, Vibha understood that the true nuisance of the paper-rain was not litter but time. A sentence that for one moment had been truth, fear, conjecture, error or an option fell from the sky and became the present.

A crossed-out sentence came down to earth stripped of the mark that had cancelled it.

On the seventh day the municipal council summoned Vibha.

The proposal before the meeting was that crossings-out in official work should be forbidden whenever clouds were present.

Vibha asked, "Then what if there is a mistake?"

"We will write a new page."

"The old page?"

"Destroyed."

"What does destroyed mean?"

No one had an answer.

Vibha placed on the table the municipal notices from the previous five days. One had the wrong date, another the ward number, a third the name of the lane to be cleaned. All had been made correct in their final form because something had been struck out along the way.

"If we stop crossing things out, the sky will stay clean. The paper will stay dirty."

The meeting remained silent for a while.

In the end no prohibition was imposed. Instead the council made a new rule: in every public document, a small number was to be written after each cancelled sentence, and a correction register was to be kept with the final copy, so that if a sheet fell from the sky people could tell that it was discarded text.

The rule was practical, but the sky did not rain the number.

It rained only the sentence.

People laughed again.

On the eighth day the clouds grew very thick. The air was completely still. Vibha placed a bucket outside the shop—perhaps this time water would fall.

First one sheet fell. Then another. Then a thousand.

Such a rain of paper fell over the town that the eaves turned white, the leaves of the peepal were covered, and bicycle wheels began crushing sheets under them.

Some pages were funny—wrong addition, wrong spelling, half a poem. Some held someone's old anger. Some were lines from letters that had never been sent.

People no longer ran to read every sheet as they had at first.

Many simply took brooms and kept their own thresholds clear.

Vibha picked up one sheet. It said: "I will never speak to you again."

Whose sentence it was, she did not know.

She turned the page face down.

A little farther away lay another sheet: "Five kilos of potatoes."

A third: "Monday holiday."

A fourth: "I am afraid."

A fifth: "Two hundred and twenty-seven."

All had fallen from the same sky.

By evening the paper in the lane was not knee-deep, but had gathered thick enough to brush the ankles. Municipal cleaners began carrying it away sack after sack.

Then the first drop of water fell.

An entirely ordinary drop.

Onto Vibha's palm.

Then another.

The sheets of paper began to get wet. The written lines bled and blurred. Some letters ran into one another. Some disappeared altogether.

People ran under the eaves. Children began stamping on the wet papers and splashing water.

Nandu came out of the press carrying a proof. It was the cover of the school booklet for the next day. In the date he had written "29 June," while the correct date was "30 June."

He stood there holding the red pen.

"Shall I cross it out?"

Outside, the rain was growing heavier. On the wet road, old discarded sentences were running away in blue-black streams.

Vibha looked at the page.

"Cross it out."

Nandu drew a line through "29 June" and wrote "30 June" beside it.

A few moments later there was a light rustle of paper on the roof.

Nandu did not run outside. Neither did Vibha.

Rain kept beating steadily on the tin roof.

A small sheet fell near the threshold. It probably said "29 June," but as soon as the drops touched it, the ink spread.

Water in the drain folded it, soaked it halfway, and slowly carried it off with the other wet sheets in the lane.

Inside the printing press, the correct date was still clear.

The Pond on the Map

At the land-records office in Madhubani town, opening an old map was almost a small ceremony in itself. First the table had to be cleared, then brass weights placed on all four corners, and finally the paper, folded year after year, had to be eased slowly flat.

Mridula Karn was the most patient of them all at this work.

In the last seven days of Jeth, the municipal council drew up a plan to lay a drain towards the old southern quarter. The new survey sheet showed roads, houses, shops, and the school, but to understand which way the water had once run along the old gradient, the original map of 1934 was called for.

As soon as the map was opened, Mridula's eyes fell on a blue patch near its centre.

A fine black line ran around the blue. Inside, in small letters, was written: "Matiyahi Pond."

Plot numbers surrounded it, but there was no number within the pond itself.

Mridula called the survey worker Ramlochan.

"Was there a pond here?"

Ramlochan bent over the map.

"On paper, there is."

"On the ground?"

"On the ground there is the old market. Half paved, half earth. I have never even heard the pond's name."

Before evening, the two of them went there with a long measuring rope, a copy of the old map, and the plot register.

Where Matiyahi Pond was shown, there were now the awnings of vegetable sellers, two betel shops, a public hand pump, an open space for bicycles, and, in the middle, a broad dusty ground.

On the southern edge of the map, where a small notch like a bathing ghat had been drawn, there now stood Jagdish Mahto's tea stall of matting and sheet metal.

Mridula asked, "Babu, was there once a pond here?"

Filtering tea as he spoke, Jagdish said, "My father used to say there was water here long ago. Ever since I came to my senses, I have seen only dust."

"How long ago?"

"He used to say it was being filled in when he was a child. How old it was before that, I don't know."

Ramlochan stretched the rope across the ground. By the scale of the map, the outer line of the blue patch fell across the field, two lanes, the rear of the tea stall, and towards the school's southern wall.

Mridula laughed.

"If the pond were still here now, half the town would be swimming."

Ramlochan said, "The map is old. The land changes."

That day, the remark sounded ordinary.

It did not rain that night. No clouds came either.

At dawn, when Jagdish arrived to open the tea stall, he lifted the matting and for the first time heard his own feet splash.

He thought the hand-pump pipe must have burst.

But the ground near the hand pump was dry.

The water began from the middle of the field and spread as far as the bend in the lane. In some places it was ankle-deep, in others knee-deep. Its surface was perfectly still, as though not even a breath of wind had moved all night.

By the time the sun was high, people had gathered.

No water had entered any house, but it had come up to the thresholds and stopped. Whether the floor was paved brick or an earthen courtyard, the water stopped precisely along the edge of an invisible curve.

The moment Ramlochan reached the office, he heard the news.

Mridula ran there with the map.

Standing at the edge of the field, she opened the copy. The blue patch and the water on the ground fell, more or less, in the same place.

"Matiyahi Pond," Jagdish said softly.

No one laughed.

Municipal workers came. The drains were checked. The hand-pump pipe was checked. The tanks of the neighbouring houses were checked.

Nowhere was there a source capable of supplying that much water.

The water had no smell. When someone suggested tasting it, everyone looked at one another; finally Jagdish took a little in his palm and smelled it.

"It is like pond water."

"How do you know what pond water is like?" Mridula asked.

Jagdish laughed. "That I don't know either."

By noon it was decided that the water should be pumped out towards the drain.

A pump arrived. A thick hose was laid into the field. The machine roared, and the water began to fall.

Mridula returned to the office, because it was not wise to leave the original map in the sun for too long.

She opened it and spread it across the table to compare it.

The blue patch was gone.

At first Mridula thought the colour had faded in the sunlight.

But the name was still there—"Matiyahi Pond."

The black outer line was there too. Only the inside had the faded yellow of old paper.

She opened the copy. On the copy, the blue pond remained exactly as before.

She looked again at the original map. No blue.

Ramlochan came in the evening.

"We have lowered the water by half," he said. "By night we will dry it out."

Without saying anything, Mridula slid the map towards him.

Ramlochan blinked twice.

"Where has the colour gone?"

"I was about to ask you."

For some time, both of them stared at the empty pond inside the paper.

Mridula searched the old photographic register beside the table. A month earlier, photographs had been made of all the original papers for conservation. In that photograph, Matiyahi Pond was a deep blue.

"Can paper change?" Ramlochan asked.

"The paper is here. The copy is here. What has changed?"

There was no answer.

The pump ran through the night. By dawn, the field had been almost completely dried out.

The next morning, the moment the office opened, Mridula unfolded the original map.

The blue colour had returned.

Thin first along the edges. Darker in the middle.

As though the paper had drunk water all night.

She called Ramlochan at once.

Ramlochan came from the field. The edge of his dhoti was dry.

"Has the ground dried?"

"Yes. Only three or four hollows are still damp."

Mridula showed him the map.

This time Ramlochan did not laugh.

That day, the two decided to conduct a small test.

The original map was left open under glass in the office. The copy was kept at the field. The pump was not removed.

By afternoon, water began seeping again into a low patch of the field.

First as large as a plate. Then as large as a mat. Then as large as the floor of two rooms.

At that moment Ramlochan sent word to the office.

Mridula looked at the map.

A pale mark had appeared at the exact centre of the blue patch.

As the water rose in the field towards evening, the blue on the map grew lighter.

By night, the water had again spread as far as the old boundary.

The next morning, the pond on the map was once more almost white.

Mridula wrote the date in pencil: "12 Jeth—water at full extent on the ground; colour nearly zero on the original map."

Beside it Ramlochan wrote: "13 Jeth—half the water pumped out; colour half as deep on the map."

"How did you measure half?" Mridula asked.

"With my eyes."

"That is not measurement."

So they began laying a transparent grid sheet over the blue patch to mark the depth of colour. In the field, small bamboo stakes were driven in to measure the water's edge.

Three days of testing made one strange fact clear.

When the water increased on the ground, the blue colour on the map decreased.

When the water decreased on the ground, the blue colour on the map increased.

But this happened only on the original map. Its copy, photograph, and duplicate—all showed the pond unchanged in blue.

"Then is this map a reservoir for the water?" Ramlochan said once.

Mridula immediately shook her head.

"It is too soon to say that. Shall we tear the map and see?"

Ramlochan was alarmed.

“No, no. It is an original government map.”

They both burst out laughing.

But the question remained.

The municipal council was told about the changing colour on the map. At first, the officer did not believe it.

So he was summoned to the office in the morning. The pond on the map was deep blue. The field was dry.

In front of him, the pumping hose was left switched off. By afternoon water began rising from the ground. By evening, half the blue colour on the map had faded.

The officer remained silent for a long time.

“This could be a chemical property of the paper.”

Mridula said, “Then why does it keep time with the water in the field?”

“Coincidence.”

The next day, the officer came again.

The coincidence repeated itself.

On the third day as well.

The story spread through the town.

People began coming to see the pond. Some said the old body of water was reclaiming its place. Some said groundwater had risen. Some said there was a spell in the map.

Serving tea, Jagdish would say, “For me, it is water. Whatever the reason.”

The schoolchildren wanted to float paper boats, but the municipal council stopped them, because no one knew exactly how deep the water was.

The second part of the wonder appeared a week later.

A paved road ran through the middle of the pond. The road had been built thirty years before. Water covered it too, but only to a depth of two fingers. On both sides of the road, it reached the knees.

Where the old map showed the mark of a ghat, the ground was now level; even so, the water grew gradually shallower there and ended.

As though the water obeyed the present height of the land, yet had not forgotten its old shore.

Mridula wrote this sentence in the register and then crossed it out.

The crossed-out sentence did not remind her of the rain of paper in Story 295; in this world, that story did not exist. She was afraid only of writing conjecture as though it were fact.

She wrote: "The outer boundary of the water corresponds approximately with the boundary on the old map; the depth varies according to the present ground level."

This time she did not cross out the sentence.

The municipal council's chief concern was not the cause, but access. The market remained closed. Water reached the thresholds of two shops. The southern lane used by the schoolchildren was blocked.

The water was pumped out again.

In two days, the pond had almost vanished from the ground.

The original map turned blue again.

The market reopened.

People breathed in relief.

On the fourth morning, the water returned.

The cycle repeated three times.

At last, the council left the pumping machine permanently beside the field.

The machine ran all day. All day, the map grew bluer. At night the machine was switched off, the water slowly returned, and the map grew pale.

Jagdish would say, "By day the pond lives on paper; by night it lives on the ground."

Everyone laughed when they heard this, but little by little people began arranging their lives according to the rule.

The vegetable sellers removed their goods before dawn. The children went to school along the dry path at noon. The bamboo platform of the tea stall was raised by half a cubit.

Every morning Mridula opened the map.

One day, she noticed something new.

The blue did not return evenly across the whole pond.

Where the water dried first on the ground, that part of the map turned blue first.

Where the last of the water remained in the field, that part of the map stayed pale until the end.

It was not merely an inverted image. It was as though there were an accounting of water between the two places.

This time Mridula wrote nothing.

The rains came.

In the first heavy rain of Sawan, the whole town was drenched. The real rainwater mingled with the water of Matiyahi Pond.

That day, the rule became difficult to read. The map was half blue, half pale. There was rainwater in the field as well.

Ramlochan said, "Now which water belongs to the map, and which to the sky?"

Mridula said, "Perhaps water does not make that distinction."

When the rains passed, the old rule became clear again.

At the end of Bhadon, the municipal council built a permanent drain so that the pond water could be removed more quickly.

On the day the work was completed, the officer said proudly, "Now the problem is over."

The next morning, there was less water.

The map was bluer.

On the third day, the field was completely dry.

On the map, Matiyahi Pond had become such a deep blue that it seemed darker even than the original colour of 1934.

Mridula was startled.

She checked the conservation register. The earlier colour had been recorded as pale sky-blue. Now it had deepened almost to indigo.

"The more water we drain away, the more the paper will drink?" Ramlochan asked.

Mridula did not answer.

In the dry market, life returned to normal: heaps of vegetables, bicycles, running children, tea, dust.

The pond survived only on the map.

Jeth returned the following year.

This time the heat was severe. The water level at the hand pumps fell. Many wells in the town dried up. Matiyahi market too filled with dust.

One afternoon, Mridula opened the original map.

In the southern corner of the blue patch, she saw a thin white line.

She bent close to look. The colour had indeed begun to recede there.

Taking Ramlochan with her, she went to the field.

At the southern corner—where the old map showed the ghat and where there was now bare earth behind Jagdish's tea stall—a narrow crack in the ground was damp from within.

A few minutes later, a glint appeared in the middle of the crack.

No pipe had burst. The sky was perfectly clear.

Mridula bent down and placed her palm on the ground.

The earth was cool.

That evening, only a palm-sized patch of water appeared on the ground.

On the office map, the same-sized patch in the pond's southern blue corner had turned pale.

Mridula did not write a cause in the register that day.

She wrote only two things: "Original map: southern corner pale."

And beneath it: "Ground: southern corner damp."

When she closed the office that night, she did not fold the map. She left it open beneath the glass.

At dawn the next morning, as Jagdish put the tea on to boil, he saw that a small round pool of water had gathered in the earth behind his stall.

At that same moment in the office, beneath the glass, the southern corner of Matiyahi Pond's blue colour was quietly turning white.

The Reversed Reflection

In the old lane that ran inward from Benta Chowk in Darbhanga, a long mirror hung on the veranda of Shashank Jha's two-storey house. It was not a new mirror; beneath the worn sheen of its wooden frame, old scratches showed through, and in the left-hand corner the silvering had gone slightly dim.

No one in the house regarded it as anything special. It was simply something in which to check, before stepping out, whether one's hair was in place, one's sari-end straight, or the mark on one's forehead had slipped to one side.

Meera stood before that mirror most often in the mornings.

That day too, before leaving for college, she was tying up her hair. A comb was in her right hand. She raised it toward her head.

In the mirror, the hand stayed down.

Meera froze.

A moment later she moved a lock away from her forehead with her fingers.

Only then did the Meera in the mirror raise the comb toward her head.

Meera lowered the comb.

In the mirror, the reflection moved the lock away from her forehead. She stood bolt upright.

The Meera in the mirror lowered the comb.

The real Meera did nothing now.

The reflection too stood still.

Meera thought: an illusion of the eyes.

She moved her right hand sharply up and down three times. The mirror moved too, but not exactly with her. The first movement came as Meera began the second. The second came with the third. The third remained suspended until Meera made a fourth movement.

Meera stepped back.

Only then did the reflection complete the third movement.

She ran from the veranda toward the kitchen.

"Ma!"

Kiran Devi turned after lowering the flame under the stove.

“What happened?”

“Come and look at the mirror.”

“What new thing has sprouted in the mirror this early in the morning?”

Meera took her by the hand and brought her to the veranda.

“Raise your hand.”

Kiran Devi laughed. “What sort of game is this?”

“Just raise it.”

Kiran Devi raised her left hand. In the mirror, her hand stayed down.

Her laughter stopped.

“Do something else.”

She adjusted the end of her sari on her shoulder.

In the mirror, the reflection raised its left hand.

Kiran Devi remained there holding the sari-end.

“Has it gone bad?”

“If a mirror went bad, the face would look distorted. This one is moving behind us.”

“How far behind?”

Instead of answering, Meera looked at the clock on the wall.

The two of them began testing it.

Kiran Devi counted to five. She raised her hand. One, two, three, four, five—the reflection did not raise its hand.

She counted to ten. No.

Not even after a long while.

Then Kiran Devi scratched her nose.

At that instant the reflection raised its hand.

Meera said softly, “It isn’t behind in time.”

“Then?”

“It is one action behind.”

Kiran Devi scratched her nose again. The reflection repeated the first nose-scratching movement.

“When we do a second thing, it does the first,” Meera said.

Kiran Devi took two steps back. The reflection scratched its nose, then moved backward after a delay.

Just then Nayan came onto the veranda rubbing his sleep-heavy eyes.

“What spectacle is going on?”

Meera said, “Look into the mirror and blink once.”

Nayan blinked.

The reflection blinked at the same instant.

All three fell silent.

“Now raise your hand,” Meera said.

Nayan raised his hand. The reflection stayed still.

Startled, he turned his head. The reflection raised its hand.

Kiran Devi pulled over a chair and sat down.

Nayan grew excited. “Blinking follows a different rule!”

Because of this discovery they were late getting to college that morning. But a list of rules took shape in the house.

Blinking—together.

Sneezing—together.

Coughing—together.

Swatting away a mosquito that had landed unexpectedly on the face—sometimes together, sometimes behind; it was hard to know whether awareness arrived before the hand rose.

Deliberately raising a hand—on the next deliberate action.

Deliberately smiling—on the next action.

Deliberately closing the eyes—on the next action.

Meera wrote on a sheet of paper: “The mirror is not one step behind in time, but in decision.”

Nayan wanted to strike out “decision” and write “desire.”

Meera pulled the sheet away. “Understand it first. Name it afterward.”

When Shashank Jha returned from the office in the afternoon, the three of them showed him the mirror.

At first Shashank did not believe them.

He raised his left hand, then immediately his right. The reflection raised the left first. The third time, he brought both hands together at once; the reflection raised the right hand.

He remained still with both hands joined.

The reflection stayed suspended without joining both hands.

There was sweat on Shashank’s forehead. Without thinking, he wiped it with his palm.

At once the reflection joined both hands.

“Take this mirror down,” he said.

Nayan protested immediately. “Why? What does it do?”

“Why keep something in the house that does not follow the rules?”

Meera said, “There is a rule. It just isn’t our rule.”

Shashank Jha looked at his daughter. "There is no need to search for profound meaning in this."

Kiran Devi intervened. "Let us cover it for one night first."

That evening an old sheet was hung over the mirror.

The next morning the sheet was removed.

Kiran Devi was the first to stand before it. She remembered her last deliberate action before the mirror had been covered the previous night—pointing a finger toward it and telling Nayan, "Enough now."

As soon as the sheet came off, the reflection stood there normally.

Kiran Devi deliberately drew the end of her sari over her head.

The Kiran Devi in the mirror raised a finger and made the old "Enough now" gesture.

Only on the next action did the sari-end go over her head.

Nayan cried out with delight, "It remembered all night!"

There was no delight on Kiran Devi's face.

"What do you call remembering? I still remember doing it myself."

"But the mirror does too."

"Does the mirror remember, or does it simply remain stuck?"

No one had an answer to that question.

Over the next few days, the people in the house began changing the way they behaved in front of the mirror.

After every deliberate movement, Nayan would snap his fingers once so that the reflection could finish the previous movement. In the mirror, his life went on as though every sentence required a punctuation mark at the end.

Shashank Jha stopped looking at the mirror altogether. He crossed the veranda with his eyes lowered to the floor.

Kiran Devi still adjusted her sari-end as before, but immediately afterward she would give her head a small shake so that the reflection's pending action could be cleared.

Meera did not do that.

She wanted to see how many days a single action could remain suspended.

One Monday morning, standing before the mirror, she tucked her hair behind her right ear. Then she left the veranda without making another deliberate movement.

For two days she did not go in front of the mirror.

On Wednesday evening she quietly came back before it.

The reflection stood there normally.

Meera deliberately slipped the bag from her left shoulder.

The Meera in the mirror tucked her hair behind her right ear.

The two-day-old action had remained exactly as it was.

For the first time, Meera felt a little afraid.

Not because the reflection was independent. On the contrary, it was utterly obedient.

It did nothing of its own accord.

The problem was that it did not forget.

Then another thing came to light.

One day Meera and Nayan were standing together in front of the mirror. Meera raised her hand. Nayan bowed his head.

Both reflections remained still.

Nayan snapped his fingers again. Only Nayan's reflection bowed its head.

Meera remained still.

Then Meera smiled. Only her reflection raised its hand.

So the mirror did not keep the family's actions in a single sequence.

Each person had a separate backlog.

"My account is separate, yours is separate," Nayan said.

Meera said, "Not an account. A queue."

"In a queue, when the person behind arrives, the one in front moves forward."

Kiran Devi did not like the comparison.

"Do not turn people's actions into bookkeeping," she said.

But little by little, the word "pending" came into use in the house.

"Ma, do you have anything pending in the mirror?"

"Nayan, finish your studies first."

"Babuji must have days and days of pending actions by now."

Shashank Jha would grow irritated whenever he heard it.

A month later, Meera received a selection letter for six months of training at the Book Conservation Centre in Patna.

There was happiness in the house, and worry too.

Kiran Devi began setting clothes aside. Nayan made a list. Shashank Jha kept asking again and again about the journey, the place where she would stay, and the arrangements for food.

Meera was excited, but it would be the first long stretch she had ever spent away from home.

Two days before she was to leave, the mirror on the veranda came up in conversation again.

Kiran Devi said, "Once you are gone, we will cover it."

Meera asked, "Why?"

"Just because. I do not feel like looking at it."

"Because of me?"

Kiran Devi did not answer.

Meera understood.

By then the mirror was no longer a game for the people in the house. It could preserve an unfinished movement belonging to any one of them. If someone did not come before it again, that pending action could remain for a day, seven days, a whole month.

Kiran Devi was now troubled by the thought that after her daughter left, some movement of hers might remain suspended in the mirror.

Meera said, "I will clear it before I go."

"How?"

"A small movement after the final movement. And then after that one too?"

Meera herself laughed.

Nayan said, "The final action will still remain pending."

No one could step away from the mirror with every action completed.

The final deliberate action would always wait for the next one.

It was raining on the morning of her departure.

Meera stood ready with her bag. Kiran Devi kept asking, "Have you packed the ticket? The papers? Your shawl?"

Shashank Jha had gone outside to check the car. Nayan was impatient to carry the bag downstairs.

Meera paused for a moment before the mirror on the veranda.

Her reflection paused too.

Meera tucked her hair behind her ear.

The reflection stayed still.

Meera smiled faintly.

The reflection tucked its hair behind its ear.

Then Meera raised her right hand and waved to her own face inside the mirror as though saying goodbye.

The reflection merely smiled.

Meera did not lower her hand.

She understood—if she lowered it now, the reflection would make the farewell wave.

Deliberately keeping her hand raised, she took one step back and then left the veranda.

From behind her, Nayan called out, “Didi, you left something pending!”

Meera turned and laughed, but she was no longer in front of the mirror.

Kiran Devi kept looking at it.

After Meera left, the mirror was not covered that day.

Kiran Devi thought several times of hanging the sheet over it. But she did not.

Days passed. Nayan’s pending action changed every day. So did Kiran Devi’s. Shashank Jha usually crossed the veranda without looking at the mirror.

Meera did not appear in it.

Over six months, many small things changed in the house. The veranda wall was painted again. The old yellow light was replaced with a white one. The nail in the frame was replaced.

The mirror stayed where it was.

Once Kiran Devi asked Nayan, “When Meera comes back, what will it show first?”

Nayan had no answer ready.

“Her hand,” he said at last. “That farewell wave.”

Kiran Devi said nothing.

Meera returned at the end of Magh.

That day too there was a light drizzle.

As soon as the door opened, Kiran Devi embraced her. Nayan took the bag from her. Shashank Jha kept asking, “The journey was not too difficult, was it?”

Meera came inside the house.

At the turn of the veranda, the mirror came into view.

She stopped.

The same frame as six months before, the same dim left-hand corner.

In the reflection Meera now looked a little thinner. The way she tied her hair had changed. A new bag hung from her shoulder.

Kiran Devi came to stand behind her. Nayan did too.

Meera deliberately made her first movement before the mirror—she wiped two drops of drizzle from her forehead with her right hand.

The Meera in the mirror did not wipe away the drops.

She raised her right hand.

Just as she had six months before.

And slowly waved goodbye.

Kiran Devi caught her breath.

Nayan fell completely silent.

The real Meera stood there now with her forehead already wiped.

The reflection was finishing a six-month-old farewell.

The waving stopped.

Meera then deliberately slipped the bag from her shoulder.

The reflection wiped the drops from its forehead.

Nayan said softly, "Is the pending action cleared now?"

Meera looked into the mirror.

The reflection still had the bag on its shoulder.

She smiled.

"No."

The reflection then took the bag off its shoulder.

Meera left her smile unfinished and walked from the veranda into the house.

In the mirror, the smile was still pending.

The Missing Wednesday

The first time Wednesday disappeared, no one in the house believed it at once.

On Tuesday night, sitting at the dining table, Sudhanshu Jha had said, “Tomorrow morning I have to go to the university records office. I’ll leave before ten.”

His wife, Malati, had said, “I have a women’s group meeting too.”

Their daughter Richa reminded them, “I have an oral examination in the first period at college on Wednesday.”

Their younger son Nachiketa laughed and said, “And I have nothing. I’ll sleep.”

Chandrakala Devi, seated at the head of the table, scolded him. “Your mathematics tutor comes on Wednesday.”

All five ate together. That in itself was a little unusual. For several months now, sometimes Sudhanshu came home late, sometimes Richa stayed at the library, sometimes Nachiketa ate at a friend’s house. That night it was raining, so everyone was at home.

There were five wooden chairs around the table. Everyone sat in their old places. Chandrakala Devi to the east, Sudhanshu to the south, Malati to the west, with Richa and Nachiketa facing each other.

After dinner, Richa put the papers for Wednesday’s oral examination into her bag. Sudhanshu hung a dhoti and kurta separately. Malati left the accounts register for the meeting on the kitchen platform.

That night everyone went to sleep as usual.

When Malati opened her eyes in the morning, sunlight was already in the courtyard.

She thought—such brightness after the rain! Then she looked at the wall clock. Seven twenty.

“Richa! Get up! Your exam!”

All at once the house was in a rush.

Richa got up, looked at the calendar, and stood still.

The page showed Thursday’s date.

She turned the page back. Wednesday’s page had already been folded over, as though it had passed the day before.

“Ma, who did this?”

Malati grew irritated. “I don’t have time for jokes now.”

Sudhanshu opened the outer door. Two packets of milk lay on the threshold. One had swollen in the heat, the other was cold.

There were also two newspapers—one for Wednesday, one for Thursday.

Sudhanshu picked up the first paper. Wednesday’s date was printed clearly on it.

He came back into the house.

“Today is Thursday.”

Richa said, “Last night was Tuesday.”

“Yes.”

“Then where did Wednesday go?”

No one had an answer.

The first half hour was spent trying to prove that someone was reading the date wrongly.

Sudhanshu called their neighbour, Baijnath Babu. Baijnath said casually, “Yesterday was Wednesday, wasn’t it? Your door was shut all day. I thought you had all gone somewhere.”

“We were at home.”

“Then why didn’t you answer the bell? I called out twice in the afternoon.”

Sudhanshu fell silent.

When Richa reached college, the oral examination was already over. In the register, “absent” had been written against her name for Wednesday. Her friend Kaveri said, “I sent you three messages yesterday. You didn’t reply.”

Richa said, “I never even saw yesterday.”

Kaveri laughed, then saw Richa’s face and stopped.

Sudhanshu reached the university records office. The work he had meant to do on Wednesday had been postponed for another seven days.

Malati had been marked absent from her women’s group meeting.

Nachiketa’s mathematics tutor had knocked on the door and gone away.

Only Chandrakala Devi remained silent for a long time.

In the evening she said, “My body does not carry the fatigue of an entire day.”

Sudhanshu asked, “What do you mean?”

“If I had slept in the house all day yesterday, I would have drunk water, risen and sat down, felt heaviness in my body. It feels to me as if Tuesday night went straight into this morning.”

Malati objected, “But Wednesday happened outside.”

Chandrakala Devi said, “Outside, yes. Not inside.”

At that sentence, silence settled over the house again.

That night everyone read Wednesday’s newspaper. The world had gone on normally. It had rained, the Legislative Assembly had sat, schools had opened, trains had run. Only in the home of these five people was there no memory of Wednesday.

As Sudhanshu threw away the swollen packet of Wednesday’s milk, he saw that the milk inside had gone sour.

“A day passed for the milk,” he said.

Richa replied, “Not for us.”

For the next seven days, Wednesday remained the subject of conversation in the house.

Sudhanshu said perhaps some contaminated air had affected all of them at once.

Malati said that if it had been contaminated air, something from the middle of Wednesday would have remained in their memory.

Richa said that five people forgetting an entire twenty-four hours at exactly the same time was not ordinary.

Now and then Nachiketa laughed and said, “If next Wednesday disappears too, I’ll escape my mathematics lesson again.”

The moment Chandrakala Devi heard him, she scolded him.

The following Tuesday, Sudhanshu decided to conduct a test.

After dinner, dry flour was spread over the courtyard threshold. If anyone went out during the night or on Wednesday, their footprints would remain.

A scratch was made inside a brass lota filled with water to mark the level.

A raw banana was placed on the kitchen table so that any change in colour could be seen.

The mechanical wall clock was set exactly right.

Richa opened her notebook and wrote the heading “Wednesday”—“The moment I wake, I’ll write the first sentence here.”

Nachiketa said, “I’m going to stay awake.”

He really did stay awake until eleven.

What happened after that, he did not know.

When his eyes opened, it was Thursday morning.

Not a single letter had been added beneath “Wednesday” in the notebook.

The flour was exactly as it had been.

The water level in the lota had fallen slightly.

The banana had grown yellower.

The wall clock had advanced to the correct date.

Wednesday’s packet of milk on the threshold had gone sour again.

For all five people in the house, Wednesday had not happened, but for the water, the fruit, the milk, and the clock, it had.

This time fear became unmistakable for the first time.

Malati said, “This isn’t sleep either. A sleeping person turns over. There isn’t a single mark in the flour.”

Richa took Chandrakala Devi’s hand and felt her pulse. “The body is normal.”

Nachiketa tried to laugh, but no sound came out.

On Thursday evening, the family held a meeting.

Sudhanshu said, “Next Tuesday, none of us will stay in the house.”

Malati objected at once. “Where will we take Ma at night?”

Chandrakala Devi herself said, “I’ll go to my younger sister’s house. We’ll see whether Wednesday happens there or not.”

The following Tuesday evening, Chandrakala Devi took a rickshaw to her younger sister’s house in Laheriasarai.

For the first time, her chair at the dining table remained empty.

Sudhanshu, Malati, Richa, and Nachiketa—the four of them ate together.

Everyone went to bed tense.

Malati’s eyes opened at five in the morning.

The calendar on the wall showed Wednesday.

She called out loudly, “Get up! It’s Wednesday!”

Never before had there been such joy in the house over a Wednesday.

Laughing, Richa went out into the courtyard. Nachiketa kept looking at the clock. Sudhanshu immediately said they should check on Chandrakala Devi.

Wednesday was normal at Chandrakala Devi’s sister’s house too.

She returned home in the afternoon.

“So it has something to do with all five people being in the house,” Sudhanshu concluded.

Richa said at once, “Don’t draw a conclusion so quickly.”

The next Tuesday, all five decided to remain in the house, but because of a toothache Chandrakala Devi ate early in the evening and went to her room.

The other four sat down at the table later. Her chair remained empty.

In the morning, Wednesday was present.

This time Chandrakala Devi had been in the house too.

Richa looked at the table.

“Five people being in the house is not the cause.”

Nachiketa asked, “Then?”

Richa put a hand on Chandrakala Devi’s empty chair.

“Maybe this is.”

Sudhanshu disagreed.

“A chair makes a day disappear?”

“Not the chair. Maybe every place being occupied?”

Malati said, “Who has ever heard of such a thing?”

Richa smiled. “Had we ever heard of Wednesday disappearing?”

The next Tuesday, the family deliberately tested it.

All five were at home. All five ate together. But Nachiketa did not sit in his chair; he brought a small low stool from the kitchen and sat on it beside the table.

His wooden chair remained empty.

Sudhanshu said, “Don’t let this performance make you late for university tomorrow.”

Richa tied a red thread around the back of the empty chair.

The night passed.

In the morning, Wednesday was there.

The red thread was exactly as it had been.

Nachiketa announced, “The chair eats Wednesday.”

Malati gave him a light tap on the head.

But now everyone’s eyes were on the table.

For the next seven days, the house had a rule: at Tuesday night’s dinner, one of the five wooden chairs would remain empty. Someone would sit on the low stool.

In the first week, Malati sat on the low stool. Wednesday came.

In the second week, Sudhanshu did. Wednesday came.

In the third week, Richa. Wednesday came.

For an entire month, not a single Wednesday disappeared.

Gradually, the fear diminished.

One empty chair at the table became a regular sight in the family. No one called it inauspicious. No one worshipped it. On Tuesday nights, one person simply pulled over the low stool.

The problem arose on the day Malati's maternal uncle's son Manoj arrived unexpectedly in the evening.

He had come to Darbhanga on business and said he would stay the night.

Malati happily served dinner.

There were five chairs at the table. Of the five family members, that week Sudhanshu was sitting on the low stool, leaving one chair empty.

Manoj naturally sat down in that empty chair.

Richa became instantly alert.

She looked at Malati.

Malati understood too, but the words—"Don't sit on this chair, or tomorrow Wednesday will not happen"—would not come out of her mouth to a guest.

Sudhanshu said softly, "Manoj, I'm sitting on the stool. You sit comfortably."

Richa cut in. "I'll bring another chair."

"Why?" Manoj laughed. "There's room."

Nachiketa kept looking at Richa.

The meal began.

All five wooden chairs were occupied. Sudhanshu sat on the low stool. Six people in all were around the table.

That night Richa stayed awake for a long time.

She could have emptied a chair after dinner if she had wanted to. But did the rule apply at mealtime, or through the night? No one knew.

She tied the red thread around the back of one chair again, but now the chair was not empty.

When she woke in the morning, Manoj was opening the window and saying, "Oh, everyone has slept so late?"

Richa looked at the calendar.

Thursday.

Manoj laughed and said, "But yesterday I had work at the deposit office!"

Then his face changed.

"Yesterday was Wednesday, wasn't it?"

No one answered.

Manoj too had forgotten Wednesday.

This time the rule became clearer—when all five wooden chairs at the table were occupied, Wednesday could disappear for anyone who had taken part in that meal. They did not have to be a member of the family.

At first Manoj did not believe it.

On Thursday afternoon, when the deposit office told him that he had not come in on Wednesday, his laughter ended.

He had slept in another house that night, but it had made no difference. Whether Wednesday would still have disappeared if he had left the house immediately after dinner remained unanswered. No one had the courage to test it again.

After that, the family became more careful.

Before dinner began on Tuesday night, one wooden chair was moved two handspans away from the table. No plate was placed before it.

Whoever's turn it was sat on the low stool.

If there was a guest, a woven stool was brought in from outside.

Wednesday became regular again.

Months passed.

Richa's oral examination was held again, and she passed. Sudhanshu's work at the office returned to its routine. Wednesday meetings were no longer a problem for Malati's women's group. Nachiketa began looking for some other excuse to escape his mathematics tutor.

Now and then Chandrakala Devi kept looking at the empty chair.

One day Richa asked, "Dadi, what are you thinking?"

She said, "Earlier, whenever I saw an empty chair in the house, I used to think—who hasn't come? Now I think—it is necessary for this to remain empty."

Richa said, "Does it frighten you?"

"At first it did. Not now. We understand the rule."

"Do we understand the whole rule?"

Chandrakala Devi laughed. "When does a human being ever understand the whole rule?"

Autumn came.

One Tuesday evening, there was no electricity. An oil lamp burned in the courtyard. A light breeze stirred outside.

Malati was serving dinner.

That week it was Nachiketa's turn to sit on the low stool.

Nachiketa pulled it over, but one of its legs was loose. The moment he sat down, it wobbled.

"If I sit on this, I'll fall," he said.

Sudhanshu said, "Bring the other stool from the veranda."

Nachiketa got up.

Just then Baijnath Babu called from outside, “Sudhanshuji!”

Sudhanshu went out.

Malati was taking rotis off the griddle. Richa was pouring water. Chandrakala Devi was in her chair.

Nachiketa took time searching for the other stool.

Sudhanshu remained outside talking to the neighbour.

Three chairs at the table were occupied, two empty.

The meal was delayed.

At last Nachiketa returned with the stool. Sudhanshu came back too.

Everyone sat down.

Suddenly Richa noticed that in her tiredness Malati had forgotten and placed Sudhanshu’s plate in front of his wooden chair. Sudhanshu had naturally sat down in it.

Nachiketa was on the low stool.

One wooden chair was still empty—Nachiketa’s.

Richa breathed with relief.

Halfway through the meal, Baijnath Babu called again. Sudhanshu got up and went outside.

Nachiketa said, “Babuji’s chair is empty now. Can I sit there?”

Richa said at once, “No.”

“Why? We weren’t all five sitting together anyway.”

Richa stopped.

He was right. Did the rule apply at the beginning of the meal? What if all five chairs were occupied at some point in the middle? How long did they have to remain occupied?

Chandrakala Devi said, “Don’t test it.”

Nachiketa stayed on the low stool.

That night, for the first time, Richa understood that the family was not saving Wednesday; they were only avoiding a boundary whose exact shape was still unknown.

Even so, Wednesday came in the morning.

After this incident, the empty-chair rule became stricter. From six on Tuesday evening until Wednesday morning, one wooden chair would remain separate from the table.

No one touched it.

A full year passed.

Not a single Wednesday disappeared again.

On the final Tuesday of the year, there was talk in the family about Richa's marriage. The prospective groom's family was to come the following month. Painting the house, cleaning rooms, and removing old things had begun.

Malati said, "After the wedding, there will be only four people left at the table."

Nachiketa said at once, "Then one chair will stay empty by itself. We won't have to worry about Wednesday."

Richa glared at him.

Chandrakala Devi said softly, "Who knows whether the rule counts people or places?"

Everyone fell silent again.

The wedding took place. Richa went to Patna.

On the first Tuesday, there were indeed only four people in the house. The fifth wooden chair was empty. No one needed to pull over the low stool.

Wednesday was normal in the morning.

The second week too. The third as well.

Gradually, the empty fifth chair came to be called Richa's chair.

Malati never used it to pile clothes on. Nachiketa did not throw his bag there either.

A month later, Richa came to her parents' home.

It was a Tuesday.

Dinner was served in the evening.

Richa moved toward her old chair.

All four of them looked at her at once.

Richa stopped.

Trying to laugh, Nachiketa said, "Didi, welcome to the low stool."

Malati grew irritated. "Has she become a guest now?"

Richa said, "Not a guest. The keeper of Wednesday."

She pulled over the low stool and sat down.

The fifth wooden chair remained empty.

In the middle of the meal, no one said whose chair it was.

That night Richa slept in her old room.

At dawn, light came through the window. Outside, a vegetable seller called out. In the kitchen, Malati's utensils clattered.

Richa opened the calendar.

Wednesday.

She came out onto the veranda. The dining table was empty now. All five wooden chairs had been pushed back into their usual places—after the night's meal, Malati had cleaned and set them all evenly.

Richa stopped for a moment.

All five chairs were empty now.

Then she smiled.

The problem was not five empty chairs.

The problem was when, on Tuesday night, not a single one remained empty.

She ran a hand over the back of her old chair, then moved it a little away from the table.

The people in the house were waking.

Wednesday had begun normally, outside and inside alike.

The Fifth Corner

From outside, Saroj Mishra's ancestral house in an old neighbourhood of Madhubani still looked square.

A veranda ran around all four sides of the courtyard, rooms lay behind the veranda, and in the north-west corner stood a small room that everyone in the house called "the paper room."

It had acquired that name because, for thirty years, anything no one had the courage to throw away was stored there.

Old land records, school certificates, wedding invitations, medicine receipts, Babuji's service book, the brass handle from a broken doorframe, two empty trunks—all of it was in that room.

After Saroj's father died, the question of dividing the house arose.

Her two brothers had settled elsewhere. Saroj lived in Madhubani, and the care of the house was largely her responsibility.

When the roof leaked during the last rains, her younger brother Naveen said, "Sell the part no one uses. Why pour money into repairs?"

Saroj did not answer.

She postponed the decision, but resolved to clear out the room in the north-west corner.

Her plan was to sort the old papers, keep what was necessary, remove the rest, and turn the room into a place for reading.

On the first day, the carpenter Kedar came.

Kedar was an old hand around the house. Since Saroj's father's time, he had been the one to repair its doorframes, cupboards and windows.

He stood in the middle of the room and looked around.

"Twelve cubits by twelve?"

Saroj said, "About that."

Kedar took out his measuring tape.

The eastern wall measured twelve cubits and two finger-widths.

The southern wall measured twelve cubits and two finger-widths.

The western wall measured twelve cubits and two finger-widths.

The northern wall was the same.

Kedar smiled. "Not about. It is exactly square."

Saroj felt lighter. The work of clearing the room now seemed straightforward.

Within two days, the old trunks had been taken out, the papers divided into bundles, and the walls had come into view.

On the third day, Kedar placed a long bamboo pole against the northern wall to brush off the limewash.

The pole did not sit flush against the wall.

A gap a finger's width wide remained in the middle.

"The wall has developed a belly," Kedar said.

Saroj ran her hand over the wall.

Beneath the limewash there truly was a slight curve that had earlier been hidden behind bundles of paper.

"It is an old house," Saroj said. "Walls bend."

Kedar went outside on the northern side.

He stretched a string along the outer wall.

Outside, the wall was perfectly straight.

"A curve inside, straight outside?"

Saroj laughed. "The limewash must be thick."

Kedar tapped it gently with the flat back of his hammer.

The sound was equally solid everywhere.

They did not stop work that day.

The northern wall was whitewashed. Beneath the fresh whitewash, the curve remained like a faint shadow.

The next morning, when Saroj went into the room with a broom, the shadow seemed larger.

The curve that had been a finger's width deep the previous day now projected inward by about two finger-widths.

She telephoned Kedar.

Kedar came, set the tape against the wall, then measured the corners.

The north-eastern corner was ninety degrees. The north-western corner was ninety degrees.

But midway along the northern wall, a small angle was now taking shape—like two straight lines meeting at a point.

"It is turning into a corner," Kedar said softly.

Saroj looked at him.

"Not a bulge in the wall?"

"A bulge is round. This is forming an edge."

With a pencil, Kedar made two small marks on the limewash, one on either side of the bend.

Then he drew a line on the floor up to the point the bend had reached.
“We’ll see tomorrow.”

By the next day, the bend had moved half a finger-width beyond the line.

The distance between the two marks had increased as well.

From outside, the room had not changed.

Saroj and Kedar measured the northern outer wall again.

Twelve cubits and two finger-widths.

Inside, the two sections of the northern wall were measured together—more than twelve cubits and three finger-widths.

Kedar set the tape again.

Again.

A third time.

“How has the inside wall become longer than the outside wall?”

Saroj had no answer.

She called her brother Naveen.

When Naveen came from Patna, he laughed when he first heard the matter.

“Walls do not grow. The measurement is wrong.”

He brought his own steel tape.

He measured outside.

He measured inside.

Then he fell silent.

“The plaster has swollen,” he said at last.

“And this edge inside?” Saroj asked.

“Break it open and see.”

Kedar was not willing.

“It is an old load-bearing wall. Not without an engineer.”

The next day, Shashank, an engineer from town, came.

He tapped the wall, checked for damp, went up to the roof, and looked for cracks outside.

Nothing.

“Structurally, this wall should not be moving inward like this,” he said.

Naveen grew irritated. “What do you mean should or shouldn’t? It is moving.”

Shashank drew the outline of the entire room on the floor with chalk.

All four old corners were clear. In the middle of the northern wall was the new edge.

“Technically,” he said, trying to laugh, “this is now a five-cornered room.”

No one laughed.

That day, the fifth corner projected three finger-widths inward from the wall.

Four days later, seven finger-widths.

Seven days later, nearly a handspan.

The corner did not slowly grow sharper; it grew deeper. The northern wall divided into two sections, both inclining toward the new point.

The floor area was shrinking, though very slowly.

Every morning Saroj drew a new chalk line.

Seven parallel marks appeared on the floor, each a little farther forward than the one from the day before.

Meanwhile, another strange thing came to light.

Saroj had left an old trunk beside the northern wall as a test.

The wall advanced, but it did not push the trunk.

In the morning, the trunk stood two finger-widths farther south than it had the previous day.

Its old square mark in the dust remained behind on the floor.

“Did someone move it?” Naveen asked.

At night the room had been locked. Saroj had the key.

The following night, they drew a chalk outline around all four feet of the trunk.

In the morning, the trunk stood outside the outline.

All four feet had shifted an equal distance south.

There was no drag mark, and the chalk was undisturbed.

It was as if the trunk had left its place during the night and been set down elsewhere in a single movement.

Kedar no longer wanted to enter the room alone.

Saroj wanted to understand the rate at which the corner was advancing.

Near the northern wall, she placed different objects—an earthen water jar, a wooden low stool, and an empty iron trunk.

In the morning, all three had shifted south by exactly as much as the wall had advanced.

The wall did not crush the objects.

The empty space in front of it simply diminished, and the objects moved along with that diminishing space.

“If this goes on,” Naveen said, “one day it will eat the whole room.”

Saroj kept looking at the northern corner.

"In how many days?"

Shashank calculated. The rate was not constant. Sometimes half a finger-width, sometimes one and a half.

"No calculation can be trusted."

Naveen raised the matter of selling the house again.

"Sell it now?" Saroj's voice hardened.

"Now it is all the more necessary."

"What will we tell the buyer?"

Naveen fell silent.

For the first time, the thought came to Saroj that perhaps the house itself was changing its measurements, but she did not say the sentence aloud.

That night she opened the old bundles from the paper room again.

Her father used to record the measurements of every repair.

In an old notebook she found the dimensions of the rooms: "North-west paper room: 12 cubits 2 finger-widths $\times$ 12 cubits 2 finger-widths."

It was dated thirty-two years earlier.

Below it, measurements from repairs two years later were the same.

On the last page of the notebook was a small sketch.

A square room.

Four corners.

Saroj placed the page before Naveen.

"It used to be like this."

Naveen said, "From outside, it is still like this."

Brother and sister looked together toward the northern wall.

The fifth corner had now come so far inward that a separate little space had formed around it—not a room, not a cupboard recess, only a pointed emptiness between two slanting walls.

Saroj put her father's old chair there.

Naveen asked, "Why?"

"To see whether this moves too."

In the morning, the chair had shifted south.

But one thing was different.

The corner had not advanced even a finger-width from the previous day.

Saroj looked at the chalk line. It was exactly where it had been.

On the second night, the chair was put there again.

In the morning, the corner had not advanced.

Nor on the third night.

Naveen said with delight, "That's it! We've found the answer. The chair has stopped the corner."

Kedar narrowed his eyes.

"The chair moved like the trunk at first. Then why did the corner stop?"

Saroj sat down in the chair.

It had been her father's reading chair—a palm-sized patch worn smooth on the back, an old ink stain on the right armrest.

She sat there for a while.

The two walls of the fifth corner slanted on either side of her.

The place was not uncomfortable; on the contrary, it seemed to invite concentration.

That day Saroj spent two hours there reading old papers.

The chair was not removed that evening.

For a week, the corner remained still.

The family's fear slowly dissolved into routine.

Saroj changed her plan for the reading room.

Inside the fifth corner she placed her father's chair, a small lamp beside it, and a narrow plank in front.

"An odd corner, but useful," Naveen said.

Saroj did not answer.

Ten days later, Naveen returned to Patna with his family.

That night Saroj was tired. Instead of sitting in her father's chair, she went straight to sleep in her own room.

In the morning, the fifth corner had advanced another half finger-width.

The chair too had shifted half a finger-width south.

For a long time Saroj stared at the new distance beyond the chalk line.

That night she sat in the chair again.

For an hour.

In the morning, the corner was still.

The next night she sat there for only five minutes.

In the morning, the corner was still.

On the third night, she left a book on the chair but did not sit there herself.

In the morning, the corner had advanced.

A shiver ran through Saroj.

An object was not enough.

The use of the place—perhaps.

She did not write down a rule. She simply kept experimenting.

One night Kedar sat in the chair for half an hour.

In the morning, the corner was still.

One night Saroj placed a low stool on the floor and sat inside the corner, leaving the chair outside.

In the morning, the corner was still then too.

One night she left the lamp burning inside the corner, but no one sat there.

In the morning, the corner had advanced.

“A living person?” Kedar whispered.

Saroj said, “Do not name it so quickly.”

They did not fully understand the rule.

How long one had to sit there, whether one had to stay awake, whether one person or several were needed—nothing was certain.

But one thing appeared again and again: if someone spent some time inside the fifth corner after dusk, the next morning the wall generally remained still.

If the corner was left untouched all night, it advanced.

Hearing this, Naveen devised a practical plan.

“Make a roster. Someone from the house will sit there for half an hour every day.”

“Standing guard over a corner?” Saroj laughed.

“The house will be saved.”

The arrangement began.

Monday Saroj, Tuesday Kedar, Wednesday the neighbouring aunt who came to chat in the evening, Thursday Saroj again.

For several days, everything went well.

Then one night there was heavy rain.

Kedar could not come. Saroj had a fever.

The corner remained empty.

In the morning, they found that it had advanced three finger-widths in a single night.

For the first time, the pace had been so great.

The distances between the old chalk lines on the northern floor looked uneven.

Along with fear, anger rose in Saroj.

“This is not a house anymore. It has become something that makes demands.”

Kedar said softly, "Call it a demand or a rule."

Saroj did not sit in the corner that day.

"Let us see how far it goes."

Naveen tried hard to stop her over the telephone.

"Do not be stubborn."

Saroj said, "I am not the servant of this house."

The second morning, the corner had advanced another two finger-widths.

The third morning, one.

The fourth morning, half.

The fifth morning, two again.

The room now clearly looked like an irregular pentagon—four old right angles and, on the northern side, one new edge thrust inward.

Outside, the wall was still straight. Its outer measurement was still twelve cubits and two finger-widths.

After five days, Saroj did not admit defeat; she simply grew tired.

She sat inside the fifth corner.

The wall stopped again.

This time she understood that her fear was not only of the advancing wall. It was the fear that one part of the house had become dependent on her presence.

She opened her father's notebook again.

On the back of the square sketch on the last page was something written that she had not noticed before.

The ink had faded.

"Do not leave the north-west room empty."

That was all.

No reason. No date.

Saroj's hand became still.

Naveen came the next day. He looked at the page.

"Babuji knew?"

"Perhaps."

"Then why did he never tell us?"

Saroj looked toward the fifth corner.

"Perhaps for him this was never a corner. Because he never left the room empty."

Her father had spent almost every evening there, sorting old papers, writing accounts or reading the newspaper.

The family had always thought it was merely a habit.

Perhaps the habit had not been merely a habit.

A few days later, Saroj decided that for now, all talk of selling the room was over.

But she also ended the guard roster.

She truly turned the room into a reading room.

Children from the neighbourhood began coming there to study in the evenings.

One sat on the chair inside the fifth corner, another on the floor, another beside the plank.

The corner remained still for three weeks.

The children quickly made the strangeness of the place ordinary.

"This fifth corner is mine," little Ruchi would say, because the breeze reached it less strongly.

Another child would say, "No, tomorrow is my turn."

Saroj did not explain the rule to them. She only said, "There is no need to leave the place empty."

A month later, Naveen came again.

He looked into the room. Two children were bent over the same book inside the fifth corner.

"Have you measured it lately?"

Saroj said, "No."

"Why not?"

"Measurement mattered while it was growing. Now it is being used."

Naveen looked at the old chalk lines on the floor.

He put a hand into his pocket to take out the tape, then stopped.

In the evening, the children left.

Saroj came to close the room.

Ruchi's small pencil had fallen inside the fifth corner.

Saroj bent and picked it up.

At the foot of the wall she found the first chalk line, where the corner had reached a month earlier.

The line now lay far behind.

She picked up the chalk to draw a new line.

Her hand stopped halfway.

The room now had five corners inside.

From outside, the house was still square.

And Saroj could no longer see any use in measuring the difference between those two facts.

She set the chalk down on the plank.

Then she pulled the small low stool into the fifth corner and sat down herself.

Night air was coming in from the veranda.

She did not stay awake until dawn to see whether the wall remained still.

She simply opened her book and began to read.

An Unfamiliar Home of One's Own

Vinay Jha returned to his home in Darbhanga at half past nine at night after a three-day journey.

The lock on the main gate was the same.

The brass key caught in the same old notch and turned.

The veranda bulb gave the same flickering light, for which he had been meaning to call an electrician for three months.

Everything seemed his own.

As soon as he opened the door, the first thing that felt unfamiliar was not a smell, not a sound, not some strange object.

It was the arrangement.

The large table in the sitting room had moved over to the window.

Two cane chairs, which had always stood on either side of the table, now faced one another, with a small round stool between them.

The bookcase had moved from the western wall to the northern wall.

The radio, which always bore a layer of dust, had not been cleaned; but its place had changed.

It was now on the three-legged stand below the window.

Vinay did not go farther in.

First he looked at the whole room from the doorway.

Nothing seemed to have been stolen.

On the contrary, the idea that a thief would patiently move an old bookcase, books and all, was absurd.

He set his travel bag on the floor and went straight to the bookcase.

It was not locked; the bookcase was never locked.

History books on the top shelf.

Magazines on the second.

Old files below.

All of them were his.

He took out a book and examined it.

On the back cover was the same small blot of blue ink left when a pen had burst five years earlier.

It was his book.

He picked up the brass bell from the right-hand corner of the table.
That too was his.

When he rang it, the cracked sound inside gave the same ordinary rasp.

No one had replaced any of the objects.

Only all the objects were arranged differently.

Vinay's first thought was that Mira must have come.

Mira was his younger sister, who lived in Laheriasarai and had the second key to the house.

He took out his mobile phone and called her.

"Did you come to the house?"

Mira was startled.

"No. Why?"

"Nothing. The table has moved."

"Did the table walk there by itself?"

"Maybe the cleaner came."

"But you gave Budhiya Kaki leave for the whole trip."

Vinay remembered.

That was true.

"All right. I'll see tomorrow."

He ended the call and went toward the kitchen.

There the strangeness was more obvious.

The wooden spice box was not beside the stove but on the window ledge.

The plates were on the upper shelf, the bowls below.

The rice tin was in the left corner instead of the right.

The water pitcher stood by the door.

For a moment Vinay felt that he was not in his own house, but in some house where everything had been borrowed from his.

He opened every tin in the kitchen and looked inside.

The turmeric was the same.

The lid of the salt tin had the same small bend in it.

The back of the brass plate bore the same scratch.

The rim of an old glass had the same nick that made him always keep it away from guests.

Everything was his.

But the kitchen was arranged as though someone lived there whose hand naturally went to the left.

Vinay worked with his right hand.

So had his wife, Lata.

Lata had been gone for seven years.

Vinay's hand suddenly stopped on the rice tin.

When Lata was alive, she had once suggested rearranging the kitchen.

"Keep the tins on the left," she had said. "There is too much smoke by the stove."

Vinay had replied then, "Things are fine where they have stood for years."

The matter had ended there.

Now the tin was on the left.

That night Vinay began putting everything back in its old place.

The bookcase was hard to move.

He could not move it all the way by himself.

The table, chairs, radio, kitchen tins, plates—whatever he could, he restored to the old arrangement.

He left the bookcase alone.

"Tomorrow I'll call Ramsevak," he said to himself.

When he reached the bedroom, he saw that the head of the bed had also been changed.

The bed had formerly stood against the southern wall.

Now it faced east, where the morning light fell directly on the pillow.

Lata had liked the morning light.

Vinay did not.

For seven years he had kept the bed to the south.

Now he was tired.

Instead of moving the bed, he lay down facing east.

When he opened his eyes in the morning, the light was falling straight on his face.

For the first moment he wanted to blame Lata.

Then he remembered at once—Lata was not there.

He got up and went into the sitting room.

The table he had returned to its old place the night before was once again by the window.

The chairs were once again facing each other.

The radio was once again on the stand.

This time Vinay stood still in the middle of the room.

If anyone had come in during the night, the main door had been bolted from inside.

The back door was latched from inside.

The windows had iron bars.

And the bookcase, which he himself had not been able to move, was no longer against the northern wall.

It stood diagonally in the eastern corner.

That meant its place too had changed during the night.

Vinay went outside and looked around the house on all four sides.

The wall was intact.

The gate was intact.

There was no scratch anywhere.

There were no fresh drag marks in the earth.

Ramsevak the carpenter was called.

The moment Ramsevak saw the bookcase, he said, "How did this move by itself?"

"That is what I called you to ask."

"It would take four men."

Two labourers were brought.

The bookcase was put back against the western wall.

With chalk, Vinay made small marks around all four feet.

He did the same around the table legs.

And around the radio stand.

Ramsevak laughed.

"Getting ready to catch a thief?"

"To catch the objects."

Ramsevak looked at Vinay's face and stopped laughing.

Vinay did not leave the house that day.

Everything remained still until noon.

Until evening too.

After dinner, he sat in the sitting room reading a book.

At ten he turned off the light and went to the bedroom.

In the morning, all the chalk marks stood empty.

The bookcase had moved again.

This time it was not against the northern wall but to the left of the doorway.

The table was in the middle, with four chairs around it.

The radio was not on the stand.

It was in the small corner outside the kitchen where Lata used to cut vegetables in the evening.

Vinay touched the radio.

The same dust.

The same rasp.

But this time the arrangement was not like Lata's old proposal.

It was entirely different.

The four chairs around the table immediately brought one thing to Vinay's mind.

When his son Anshuman was small, meals in the house were always eaten on the kitchen floor.

Once Anshuman had said, "Why don't we all eat at the table?"

Vinay had answered, "That isn't the custom here."

Lata had laughed and said, "Customs are made."

But the table had never become a dining table.

Now the four chairs stood as though the family had been eating there for years.

Vinay examined the surface of the table.

In one corner was an old yellow stain, like turmeric.

He could not say for certain whether the stain had been there before.

He was about to take an old photograph from the bookcase, then stopped.

A photograph would not prove the arrangement.

The objects were all the same.

The question was not where the objects had come from.

The question was why they had been arranged this way.

He started a file.

On the first page he wrote, "Arrangement of the House."

The date.

Measurements of the sitting room.

The position of the table.

The direction of the chairs.

The wall against which the bookcase stood.

The order of the kitchen tins.

The head of the bed.

Day by day he began recording the measurements.

Gradually, certain rules began to emerge.

No new object ever appeared.

No old object disappeared.

Even the contents of closed boxes did not change.

Only the arrangement of objects left out in the open changed.

The walls, doors, windows and dimensions of the rooms remained fixed.

The changes took place at night.

But night alone was not enough.

One night Vinay stayed awake in the sitting room until dawn.

Nothing changed.

Another night he went to the bedroom but left the door open.

By morning, there had been a change.

So being watched was not the cause.

One night he locked all the small objects inside a box.

By morning the heavy furniture had moved, while the box remained exactly as it was.

That meant the house did not add objects; it made new arrangements out of whatever was available.

On the seventh day Mira came.

The moment she saw the sitting room she said, "So you finally moved the table?"

Vinay looked at her.

"Does this look right to you?"

"It's fine. The light is better by the window."

"How was it before?"

Mira answered readily, "Against the wall."

"And what about the way it is now?"

"You must have moved it."

"I didn't."

Mira was about to laugh again, but then she saw Vinay's file.

Ten pages of measurements, dates and diagrams.

She fell silent.

"Does someone get in at night?"

"Then why doesn't anything get stolen?"

"Aren't you frightened?"

Vinay thought for a moment and said, "At first I was. Now I'm more curious."

Mira went into the kitchen.

The spice box was now on the low wooden stool.

"Sister-in-law wanted to keep it this way," Mira said softly.

Vinay turned toward her at once.

"You remember?"

"She said it once. You wouldn't agree."

"And this table?"

Mira looked at the table.

"Wasn't this Anshuman's insistence? That everyone should eat together at the table."

Vinay's hand tightened sharply around the file.

"The bookcase by the doorway?"

Mira shook her head.

"No. I don't remember that."

No immediate conclusion emerged.

But from that night on, Vinay stopped merely measuring the arrangements and began writing down their possible causes.

One night the study desk moved into the bedroom.

He remembered that twenty years earlier he had considered leaving his job and writing from home.

Lata had said, "Put the desk inside. It will make a separate corner for work."

Vinay had not left his job.

The desk had never gone inside.

Another night the sewing machine stood in the well-lit part of the sitting room, with the clothes trunk beside it.

After their marriage, Lata had spoken of wanting to teach sewing to the girls of the neighbourhood.

Vinay had said, "The house will turn into a school."

The classes had never begun.

On the third night, Anshuman's old study board was on the veranda, with flowerpots around it and the radio nearby.

Before leaving for college, Anshuman had said, "Let's make the veranda an open place to study."

Vinay had answered, "Everything will get wet in the rain."

That too had never happened.

The arrangements the house created all resembled proposals from Vinay's life that had never been fulfilled.

But not all of them.

Some arrangements were things Vinay had no memory of at all.

One night two cane chairs stood outside the bedroom as though two people had sat there talking late into the night.

Vinay could remember no such proposal.

One day the books were arranged not by subject but in the order in which they had been read.

Vinay had never used such an order.

And yet, from the wear on the books, the sequence looked natural.

One night the dinner plates were arranged as though the table had been set for only two people—the plates had not actually been taken out of the cupboard; just two plates had been shifted to one side at the top of the stack.

Which two people?

Vinay could find no answer.

From this point on, the labels “Lata’s proposal,” “Anshuman’s proposal,” and “my unfinished idea” appeared less often in the file.

He made a new heading: “Unfamiliar Possibility.”

Mira said, “Don’t think about it so much. The things in the house move; let them move.”

Vinay asked, “What if all these are arrangements from lives I never lived?”

Mira did not answer at once.

Then she said, “In that case, why would those lives arrange your house?”

Vinay did not write that question in the file.

It stayed in his mind.

A week later Anshuman came from Delhi.

The moment he saw his old room, he laughed.

“Babu, you finally put my desk by the window!”

Vinay was startled.

“You wanted it this way?”

“When I was at school. You used to say the sunlight would ruin the books.”

Vinay could not remember.

Anshuman opened the desk drawer.

Inside were his old compass, two tickets, an unfinished letter, and a small wooden whistle.

All old things.

“Were all these already here?” Vinay asked.

“They were in the drawer. I don’t remember the order.”

Vinay understood that the house was not merely reading the catalogue of his memories.

At least some of its arrangements also matched the forgotten wishes of other people.

That night father and son stayed awake for a long time.

Anshuman was told all the rules.

"Shall I try an experiment?" he asked.

"What?"

"Today let's not touch anything. Let's see what happens by morning."

"I hardly touch anything now."

"No, I mean—let's accept things where they are. Don't put anything back in its old place."

Vinay agreed.

In the morning the sitting room had not changed.

The kitchen had not changed.

Anshuman's room had not changed either.

Vinay grew excited.

"See? If we don't change things, it stays still."

Before answering, Anshuman went into the bedroom.

There, the small bedside table had moved to the window.

Only one object had changed.

Anshuman said, "Not still. Slower."

For the next four days they did not return anything to its old place.

The changes in the house diminished.

Earlier, an entire room would change in a single night.

Now, one or two objects changed in a night.

Sometimes only the direction of a chair.

Sometimes a single flowerpot.

Sometimes the position of the clock.

Vinay felt as though the house were merely searching for whatever empty space was available.

On the fifth day Anshuman left for Delhi again.

Before leaving, he asked his father, "Why did you keep returning everything to its first place?"

"Because that was where it was."

"That answers where it was before. It doesn't answer why it was there."

Vinay grew irritated.

"You don't need to philosophize."

Anshuman laughed.

"All right. But the things in the house philosophize more than you do."

There was a train to catch. The matter ended in laughter.

After Anshuman left, the house grew quiet again.

Vinay read the file.

Thirty-three days.

Thirty-three arrangements.

Some familiar possibilities.

Some unfamiliar.

One thing had remained constant so far—no arrangement had repeated Vinay's actual present arrangement.

It was as though the house ignored "what is" and moved only among "what might have been."

As soon as he wrote that conclusion, Vinay stopped his pen.

"What might have been"—the phrase was too easy.

There was too little evidence.

He put a question mark on the page.

That night, for the first time, Vinay deliberately made a change that was not meant to restore an old arrangement.

He picked up one of the cane chairs in the sitting room and placed it in the eastern corner of the veranda.

A chair had never stood there.

Nor could he remember any old proposal to put one there.

He placed it there only for the evening breeze.

On the small stool beside the chair, he set the radio.

He had never before even thought of putting the radio there.

Then, deliberately, he took a stack of books and placed it behind the chair.

In the file he recorded this arrangement as: "Today's."

"Not old."

"Not anyone's unfinished proposal."

"I made it just now."

In the morning Vinay went straight to the veranda.

The chair was still there.

The radio was still there.

The stack of books was still there.

He was ready to smile.

Then he saw that opposite the chair, in the other corner of the veranda, a second chair had come from inside the house.

The same cane chair that had been in the sitting room the day before.

The two chairs faced each other.

A small empty space lay between them.

Vinay stood there for a long time.
He had not made this arrangement.
But it did not feel entirely old either.
One chair was his present decision.
The other was the house's answer.

That day, for the first time, he crossed out the words "Unfamiliar Possibility" in the file.

In their place he wrote, "Incomplete Arrangement."

Mira came that evening.

The moment she saw the two chairs on the veranda, she sat down on one of them.

"This was a good idea," she said.

Vinay sat in the other chair.

The radio was switched on.

After the old static, a Maithili song began on All India Radio.

Mira said, "If Sister-in-law were here, she would have liked sitting here."

Vinay did not answer.

After a while he got up and went inside.

He brought the file.

On the last page he drew a diagram of the veranda.

Two chairs.

The stool between them.

The radio.

He wrote the date.

He left the space for the reason blank.

At night Mira left.

Vinay locked the main door.

He did not draw chalk lines around the feet as before.

He took no measurements.

He returned no object to its old place.

In the morning the bookcase in the sitting room was against a third wall.

The order of the plates in the kitchen had changed.

In the bedroom, the bed had turned to face east.

The house was unfamiliar again.

Vinay looked at each object one by one.

Everything was his.

He placed the file on the table in the sitting room.
He turned the pages.
The measurements from the first day.
The diagram from the second.
Lata's possibility.
Anshuman's forgotten wish.
An unfamiliar order.
An incomplete arrangement.
The last page was blank.
Vinay picked up his pen.
His hand moved to write, "Today the house changed again."
Then it stopped.
He went out to the veranda.
The two cane chairs were still facing each other.
One chair was the one he himself had placed there the day before.
The other had been brought by the house.
Vinay sat not in the first chair, but in the second.
The chair opposite him remained empty.
The light of dawn was slowly falling across his back.
Inside the house, every object was his own.
He still did not know to which life the arrangement belonged.
But for the first time, he was in no hurry to decide how the house had stood before.
The radio was off.
On the veranda there was only the sound of birds.
After a while Vinay rose, moved the empty chair one finger's breadth forward, and sat down again.

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